



THE LONG GRACE

# SEVEN TABLES

LANDS · LIVES · LEAVINGS

A COMPANION TO THE CORE BOOK · A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF EATEN GODS

EVERY LAND IS CERTAIN THAT THE CURE IS NEXT DOOR.  
EVERY LAND IS CERTAIN THAT THE MONSTER IS  
NOT AT ITS OWN TABLE.

[ RIM ROAD SAYING ]

# CONTENTS

## THE LONG GRACE · SEVEN TABLES

### PART ONE: THE SEVEN TABLES

#### SALLOWREACH: THE LONG UPKEEP 11

|                                      |    |
|--------------------------------------|----|
| DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS            | 13 |
| ROADS AND WAYS                       | 18 |
| BREAD AND COIN                       | 19 |
| LAW AND THE KNIFE                    | 20 |
| THE FAITHFUL                         | 20 |
| VOICES OF THE LAND                   | 22 |
| HOW POWER MOVES                      | 23 |
| THE PEOPLE OF SALLOWREACH            | 24 |
| THE PEOPLE OF SALLOWREACH, CONTINUED | 49 |
| NEW FACES OF SALLOWREACH             | 75 |
| WEBS OF SALLOWREACH                  | 90 |

#### THE FATLANDS: A COUNTRY AT TABLE 94

|                                       |     |
|---------------------------------------|-----|
| DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS             | 96  |
| ROADS AND WAYS                        | 99  |
| BREAD AND COIN                        | 100 |
| LAW AND THE KNIFE                     | 102 |
| THE FAITHFUL                          | 103 |
| VOICES OF THE LAND                    | 105 |
| HOW POWER MOVES                       | 105 |
| THE PEOPLE OF THE FATLANDS            | 108 |
| THE PEOPLE OF THE FATLANDS, CONTINUED | 134 |
| NEW FACES OF THE FATLANDS             | 161 |
| WEBS OF THE FATLANDS                  | 174 |

#### BRINEHOLLOW: THE COUNTRY THAT CHASES ITS WATER 177

|                           |     |
|---------------------------|-----|
| DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS | 179 |
| ROADS AND WAYS            | 185 |
| BREAD AND COIN            | 186 |
| LAW AND THE KNIFE         | 188 |
| THE FAITHFUL              | 189 |
| VOICES OF THE LAND        | 192 |
| HOW POWER MOVES           | 193 |







## ▼ BEFORE THE SECOND COURSE

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*Six peoples ate. One refused. Every one of them is still chewing.*

– RIM ROAD SAYING

FROM A LETTER FOUND IN THE SACHEL OF A CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE SURVEYOR, SEALED BUT NEVER SENT.

*Sister, you asked me what the lands are like, and I keep failing to tell you, because the honest answer is that they are like people. Not like nations. Not like maps. Like people at a long table after a meal that went on too long: one has fallen asleep with her eyes open, one is still eating, one is weeping into the soup, one keeps promising to leave and cannot stand, one is giving birth under the table, one has died and will not stop*

*talking, and one stands by the door with his coat on, refusing everything, insufferable, starving, right.*

*I have spent eleven years writing down their names. Every name I write I have come to think of as a kind of plate: something with a portion on it. Something that will be eaten.*

*I am enclosing the ledger. Do not open it at the table.*

*The Long Grace* core book gave you the Table: its history, its seven lands, its rules, its market and its monsters. This book is the second course. It is about **the people**, and about **what is left of the gods when someone takes a knife to them**.

## ▼ WHAT THIS BOOK CONTAINS

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**Part One: The Seven Tables** returns to each land and goes down to street level. Every land opens with a deep-dive into how it actually works day to day: its districts and villages, roads and wages, courts and punishments, shrines and hymns, the voices of its ordinary people, and a map of who holds power over whom. Then comes the heart of the book: **every named character of every land**, written in full. Each dossier gives a complete stat block, a quote in the character's own voice, who they are and how they smell and sound, their story, how they function inside their land's institutions, **everything they carry**, their wants and fears and secrets, their ties to the rest of the cast, how to use them in play, and what other people say about them behind their backs. Each land closes with its newer

faces, a web of its relationships, and a table for deciding who comes knocking.

**Part Two: Leavings** is a catalogue of relics. On the Table, a god is not only a power in the blood; it is meat, bone, breath, silence, salt and gristle, and people have been cutting pieces off it for six hundred and forty-one years. The Leavings chapters describe what can be taken from the gods, from the godsign-touched, from the horrors and places of each land, and from the Host's tables: how to have heard of it, how to carve it, how long it keeps, how badly it taints, what it does, and what it is worth. A short rules chapter, *The Carving Knife*, explains how harvesting works.

# USING THE DOSSIERS

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The dossiers are written to be used at the table, not admired on the shelf. Every one of them answers four questions a Carver needs mid-session:

- ◇ **What do they look, sound and smell like?** Read the first paragraph of *Who They Are* aloud.
- ◇ **What do they want from the Guests?** See *In Play*.
- ◇ **What happens if they fight?** The stat block uses the core-book rules exactly: 2d10 + Attribute + Skill, Teeth for Partaking,

Flesh, Guard, Armor, Dread.

- ◇ **What happens if nobody intervenes?** Every dossier ends its *In Play* section with the character's fate if the Guests do nothing. These are the clocks of the Table. Use them.

Not every secret printed here is true in your campaign. Where the book offers options, choose one, and let the others become rumours.

## ▼ A REMINDER ABOUT CONTENT

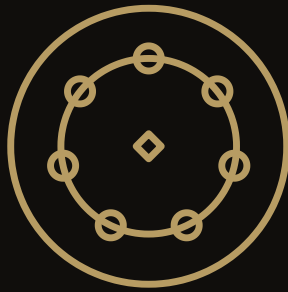
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This is a book about people being eaten by their gods and each other, in detail. Everything in the core book's content warning applies here, and more intimately, because these are faces the Guests will come to know. Keep using Lines, Veils and the Grace. Suicide and self-harm in these pages are tragedies, written from the side of the people left behind; nothing here is instruction. Sexual taboo, cursed bloodlines and desecration of the dead remain implied and adult. Children appear in these pages, as they appear on the Table; their suffering is shown through the adults who fail them, and never lingered on.

### READING A DOSSIER STAT BLOCK

- ◇ **Land & Cut:** the character's land, bloodline strength (0–5), Regrowth (0–12) and current Hunger (0–10).
- ◇ **Calling & Standing:** the nearest core-book Calling and their rank in it (1–5), so you can see what their institution will do for them.
- ◇ **Attributes / Skills:** used exactly as for Guests. Threat-rated minor figures appear as one-line quick stats.
- ◇ **Flesh · Guard · Armor · Fray:** physical durability, the number to hit them, damage reduction, and how near they are to Breaking.
- ◇ **Gifts / Wants:** the god's powers in them and the compulsions that come with those powers.
- ◇ **Carries:** a summary; *What They Carry* gives the details, including items from the Rim Market and Leavings.
- ◇ **Dread:** the Dread rating of encountering them at their worst.





PART ONE

# THE SEVEN TABLES

*Every land at street level, and every face at its table.*





CHAPTER 1

# SALLOWREACH

*The Long Upkeep*

*Sweep the step, salt the sill, stitch the seam, shut the door. Then do it all again tomorrow,  
love. Then do it all again.*

– WEIR ROW HOUSEKEEPING CHANT, SUNG WHILE WORKING

*We do not have a word for “over.” We have “mended,” “set aside,” “sunk,” and “kept.” The  
last one is the one you hear most.*

– FENWICK LISP, INTERPRETER, TO A CUTWRIGHT SURVEYOR, 639 A.G.

A letter from Teal Mallory, living, aged forty-six, of Weir Row, Lastgate, to her mother Hanne Mallory, Set Aside in the Lofts, Hall Six, Fourth Storey, Shelf Nineteen. To be read aloud by the Reader of Hall Six on the next feast day. Carving, 641 A.G.

Mam, it is me. Aldo is reading this for you because my hand is no good for the ladders and you know how I am with heights. I am going to tell you a day, the way you used to ask me to when I came home from the weir, so you will have something that is not the shelf to think about.

First bell is still the bell at the Ferrying Post, and it is still flat. I got up in the dark and did the shutters before I did anything else, because the dew-rot came in thick in the night and there were flies on the inside of the glass already, slow ones, the fat green kind. I counted them for the almanac-man like you taught me. Forty-one on the east pane. He says that means a front by Carving's end. I put out the smudge pot and lit it off the smoulder-coal, which Papa lit in the year 590 and which is still going in its tin, and the kitchen filled up with peat and lavender and that was the morning smelling right.

Gran-Gran Ide was sitting up in her chair by the stove where we left her. She does not sleep, as you know, but she likes to be put to bed at night and got up in the morning, so we do it. Her gauze had slipped in the night again, on the jaw side. I wound it back for her. She said, “You have cold hands, girl,” and I said, “So do you, Gran,” and she laughed the way she does, where the laugh comes out a bit lower down than her mouth. Then I did Grandsire Petter's wraps and Uncle Josse's, and gave Petter's hands their oil, and Josse asked if it was a feast day yet, which he asks every morning, and I said not yet, Uncle. Eleven of them at table now, Mam, counting Papa. Two of us breathing. Brann says that is a good household and it is. It is just a great deal of linen.

Breakfast was lively eel, which you will remember. Brann caught them in the traps last night and they were still going in the bucket when I fried them, and still going on the plate, and Brann says the trick is to bite behind the head and then you are the one in charge. I ate mine standing. The children ate

theirs at the table with Gran-Gran watching, and she told them they chewed like heifers, and little Wenn bit his so hard it stopped, for a moment, and everyone clapped. It started again. They always do.

The Tenancy man came at second bell. That is the collector for old Alderman Strake, who owns the house, as he has since 207. Twelve lacks for the quarter, and he looked at the stairs and said he could smell someone up there was going Ripe and we should see to it before the fly-assessor came, because the window-tax goes up if your flies are counted on the outside. It is Uncle Josse. We know. I told him we have him down for Restitching Week. He wrote that in his book. Everyone has a book, Mam. Even the flies have a book now.

I walked to Needle Street to pay the last of the restitching fee for Josse's foot and to buy wire, and on the way I passed the Lofts, so I stopped outside and listened. You can always hear it from the street. Like rain on reeds, the way it always was. But Mam, there is something else under it now. Everyone on Loftside says it. They are all saying the same thing at the same time, very soft. Aldo will not tell me what it is. He said it was not his to read. I asked him if you were saying it too and he said yes. I am not angry, I only want to know what you mean by it. If it is something you need, ask Aldo to write it down plain.

After supper I sat with the breath-jar. We have nineteen breaths now, Mam, and four whole minutes, which is the four Papa saved before he went, and one more I put by this Carving from the eel money. That is not even a tenth part of a license yet. But it is a start, and a start is something you can hold in your hand. It is for you. I want you to know it is for you first. Then Gran-Gran, who has been asking. Then Papa, if he ever will. Then whoever is next.

I am writing this by one of Wick Tallow's candles. It is a good steady one. Brann bought it on the Lane for six crumbs. I try not to wonder whose it was. When I turn the page it leans toward me, just a little, the way your head used to when I was talking and you were trying to hear.

*I will come on the feast day. I will bring the children if Brann can get off the weir. May you finish, Mam. I mean it the kind way.*

*Your Teal.*

The core book told you what Sallowreach is. This chapter is about what it is like: the smell of a street at a particular bell, the price of wire, what a reed-cutter earns, who holds which key, and how a woman of forty-six who is legally a child keeps eleven dead relatives clean on a weir-worker's wage. The horror of the north is not that the dead walk. It is that they must be maintained, every day, forever, by people who will one day need maintaining themselves.

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

Sallowreach has about a hundred and sixty thousand people by the Court's census of 637, a hundred and forty-four thousand of them Kept (the census counts the shelved and the barrels of Brinemoss, but not the Sump or the Smalls). Two in three live in or under Lastgate; the rest are scattered across the fen in stilt-hamlets, weir-towns and the walled mounds of the Hand-lines.

### LASTGATE

From the border road, Lastgate looks like a forest of black posts walking into the fog with houses balanced on their shoulders. It is built entirely on pilings driven into the fen, ten thousand of them, many as old as the Glad Century, all tarred, all slowly going down. Because nothing in Sallowreach finishes, the pilings do not rot through. They soften. They lean. They sink an inch a decade into the peat, and the city sinks with them, and so for six hundred years the people of Lastgate have done what the people of a sinking city must: they build a new storey on top of the old one and move upstairs.

Lastgate is therefore counted in **storeys** rather than streets. The Boards (the present street level, the planks you walk on) are the Ninth Storey. The Eighth is the cellar level, damp, half-lit, where the poor rent rooms by the bed. The Seventh and everything below it are the Drowned Storeys, under the canal-line, inhabited by the Kept, the Smalls and those who have reasons not to be found. Addresses in Lastgate give the storey, the board and the house: *Ninth, Weir Row, the Coombe house* is an ordinary address; *Sixth, Old Weir Row, the Coombe house* is the same house three centuries ago, and there may still be a Coombe living in it.

The city is ruled by the flat iron bell of the Ferrying Post, cast in the year 9 and never finished cooling, which rings nine hours from first bell before dawn to ninth bell at the Plate's rising. At sixth bell, by law, every household lights its door-candle, and the whole city glows yellow in the fog like something seen through the skin of a lantern.

### THE UPPER BOARDS

The Court's district, on the highest and driest piling-ground at the heart of the city, around the Hall of Hands and the Hall of Closings. The houses are tall, narrow, black-timbered and double-doored, built in the style the fen calls *shut*: no window on the

ground storey, slit windows above, a vestibule between every pair of doors so that nothing opens directly onto anything. The Hand-line houses, Grue, Vane, Sedge, Hethe and the dozen lesser lines, keep their town residences here, and the Unvacated aldermen who own most of the rest of the city keep theirs beside them.

**Who lives here:** the Hand-lines and their cadets, the Unvacated rich, the Court's clerks and Licensers, Envoy Castellan Dray in rented rooms, and thousands of living servants, who may not sleep on the Upper Boards and walk down to the Eighth Storey each night. **Smell and sound:** cedar, above all, from the brass braziers that burn day and night beside every great door, so that the district smells like the inside of a new chest; under it myrrh, ambergris and, faintly, the sweetness all of it is there to hide. Hand-line houses absorb sound; birds do not sing here, and the flies are fewer. **Trade:** licenses, minutes and breaths; perfumers; the best lacquerers; jewellers who make signets to be worn over a glove. **Custom:** *the Threshold Sniff*: a guest is smelled by a footman between the two doors. The Ripe are handed a cedar cloth and shown to the cool room. Those who smell of nothing are shown in at once, and nobody meets their eyes. **Danger:** the Court has hands. Right Hand agents in grey coats note who visits whom, and a living person found here after ninth bell without a pass is fined as a vagrant, by the hour.

**Ysolde Crane, Cedar-Warden.** A living woman of fifty-two who keeps the braziers along Hand Street, as her mother did. She knows every visitor to the Hall of Hands by smell and will tell you, for a lack, who came to the Hall of Closings last night and whether they left smelling of nothing. Lately she has been asked not to light the brazier at the Vane house, because Lady Corrow says burning bothers her. Ysolde has noticed that the flies on that door have not moved in a long while.

**YSOLDE CRANE** Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (poker 3)  
· Armor 1 (leather apron) · Dread 0

### NEEDLE STREET

The Seamers' quarter: a long canal-side street of a hundred narrow shops, each with a work-table in the window and a hook above it, running from the Guildhall at the north end to the wire-drawers' sheds at the south. Needle Street is the only district of Lastgate that is busy at every bell. The Seamers sleep in shifts.

**Who lives here:** Seamers of every rank, from Threaders bunking six to a loft to Masters with houses of their own; wire-drawers, lacquer-boilers, gut-spinners, cork-cutters, glaziers who make false eyes. The Kept come here as clients, carried on boards or walking, holding their parts. **Smell and sound:** hot pitch, cedar lacquer, spirits of wine, the brown smell of gut-thread soaking in vats, and from every open doorway the sweet layered stink of the clients. The sound is the street's famous rhythm: the hiss of the bellows that dry the lacquer, the click of the wire-cutters, and under it a constant murmur of the Kept being reassured, because a Seamer talks to the client the whole time, and the client usually talks back. **Trade:** restitching (three lacks a limb at Guild rates), wire-work, lacquer, false eyes, false teeth, glass noses, gauze, waxed wraps, Seamer's kits. The Guild's stock-room of spare parts, behind the Guildhall, is the most valuable warehouse in the country. **Custom:** *the first seam*. Every Threader's first real stitching is done on a family the Guild chooses, and the family is bound to ask for that Threader every spring for as long as the Threader works. Some Seamers have clients who have asked for them for a hundred and fifty years. **Danger:** the Restitching Week crush. In Grace, when every household in the city brings its grandmothers, Needle Street fills from bank to bank, people fall in the canal, and parts go missing in the press. Marrow Jack's boys work the crowd.

**Mistress Winifred Harl, Seamer.** Aubin Coyle's mistress in the Guild, living, sixty-six, a short broad woman with forearms like a ferryman's and a pipe she never takes out of her mouth except to swear. She has stitched the Coombe family for forty-one years and has seventy-eight families on her list. She knows, because she has been counting, that more parts have come into the Guild stock-room this year than came out of the Sump. She has asked Thessaly Mort about it once. She has not asked again.

**MISTRESS WINIFRED HARL** Threat 4 · Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Attack +5 (Seamer's awl 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

#### TANNER'S BOARDS AND WICK LANE

The rendering quarter, downwind (when there is wind) on the east edge of the city, where the trades that need fire and stink are kept away from the Upper Boards. Tanner's Boards is a broad plank square ringed by tan-pits sunk in the old Seventh Storey roofs; Wick Lane runs off it to the north, crooked, lined with chandlers, soap-boilers, glue-makers and bone-turners. Wick Tallow's shop is at the far end, with its sign of a candle with a face.

**Who lives here:** tanners, renderers, soap-boilers, chandlers and their journeymen, most of them living (the work is hot, and heat is unkind to the Kept). The Heirs keep several rooms over the tanneries because the stink keeps Court agents away. Jory Welt lives here. **Smell and sound:** oak bark and lime from the tan-pits, hot fat, lye, scorched hair, and, along Wick Lane, the thick yellow smell of rendering that coats the back of the throat and stays there for a day. You hear the scraping of hides, the bubble of the vats, and in the

evening the chandlers calling their candles: *Steady light, sixth bell light, light that will not leave you*. **Trade:** leather (Sallowreach leather is very fine and never perishes), soap, glue, Kept-candles, named candles, rendered fat for lamps, bone for lacks (the Rim Road Company's northern curing-shed is on the square). **Custom:** *the candle-blessing*. Families who commission a named candle from a relative carry it home in a procession and light it first at the dinner table, and the eldest Kept present says the name aloud. Then nobody speaks while it burns for the first hour, out of courtesy. **Danger:** the vats. Everything that goes into a Sallowreach vat continues, and a man who falls into one comes out half rendered and entirely aware. The quarter also has the city's only recorded Tallow-Saints.

**Saul Brindle, Tanner.** Jory Welt's landlord, a living man of fifty-eight, bald, brown-stained to the elbows, and a Pamphleteer of the Heirs in his own right. He hides presses in his drying-lofts under racks of hides and has kept the Boy's secrets for twenty years. He has a Kept father, who is Unvacated and owns the tannery, and who sits in the counting-room every day doing the books. Saul has started to watch the old man's hands and wonder how heavy he would be.

**SAUL BRINDLE** Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (fleshing knife 2) · Armor 1 (leather) · Dread 0

#### WEIR ROW

The eel-fishers' quarter on the north canals, where Lastgate meets the open mere. The houses here are low and wide and built over the water on their own short pilings, each with a trap-door in the kitchen floor through which the family drops its eel-traps straight into the fen. The whole district is a lattice of weirs, nets and wicker traps, and on still nights you can hear the traps working: a soft wet knocking, thousands of times over.

**Who lives here:** eel-catchers, reed-cutters, net-menders, punt-makers, their Kept elders by the dozen per house. This is the most crowded district of the dead in the city, because fishermen drown, and drowned men come home. **Smell and sound:** fen-water, eel-slime, smoke from the eel-smokeries, vinegar, and wet wool. Children's voices (Weir Row has more living children than anywhere in the city), the knock of the traps, the chant of the housekeeping song, and the long wet coughing of the newly drowned coming up the ladders in the morning. **Trade:** eel (lively, smoked, pickled), reeds, wicker, rope, punts, the cheap *sour* beer of the north. **Custom:** *the ladder-light*. Every Weir Row house keeps a lamp burning on its water-ladder all night, because sooner or later everyone in the family goes into the fen, and it is good for them to see the way home when they come up. **Danger:** the fen holds on. Weir Row children are taught to keep their feet on the ladder and never sit with their legs in the water, because things that drowned long ago sometimes take an ankle and will not let go for hours.

**Teal Mallory, Housekeeper.** Living, forty-six, legally a minor, keeper of eleven Kept relatives and two living children on a weir-

worker's wage (see the letter that opens this chapter). She is a descendant of Cobb Mallory, one of the parties to the Long Argument, and visits him in the Room every feast day with a pie he cannot eat. She is ordinary, tired and kind, and she is exactly the person the PCs should meet first in Lastgate.

**TEAL MALLORY** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (eel-knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## THE SINKS

The low, sagging southwest of the city, where the pilings have gone down fastest and the Ninth Storey is only a few feet above the canal-line. The Sinks are crooked, over-built and dark: alleys between houses lean so close that their upper storeys touch, and some lanes are entirely roofed by other people's floors. The poor live here, the living poor and the Kept poor together, and the Heirs, and Marrow Jack's markets, and the Room of the Long Argument.

**Who lives here:** day-laborers, dredgers, sackmen, back-alley seamers, part-sellers, fences, Heirs in their safehouses, Finishers between pilgrimages, Pim Sorrel and her mother, and a great many Kept whose families cannot afford to keep them and who have put them out. **Smell and sound:** the Sinks smell of themselves. Peat smoke when there is peat. Underneath, the honest stink of the poor Kept, unperfumed and unlacquered, and the drains. The sound is of too many people in too little space, and of the Kept who have been put out and sit in doorways asking passers-by for a stitch. **Trade:** everything illicit: Kept limbs (Nan Pickering's drying racks are under the Eighth Storey here), stilled meat, back-alley seaming at half Guild rates, Bait pamphlets, fen-gin, minutes of Closing of uncertain provenance. **Custom:** *the doorway coin*. A passer-by who has a crumb to spare drops it into the lap of a put-out Kept, who cannot use it, and who passes it to the first living child who comes by. It is said to be lucky for all three. **Danger:** part-theft. A Kept person who sits still too long in the Sinks wakes without a hand. A living person who looks too long at the wrong door is invited to an Heirs' meeting and does not get to say no.

**Lark Dunnock, Printer.** A living woman of forty-four, an Heir of the Pamphleteer rank, who runs the press for the Heirs' broadsheet, *The Bequest*, from a cellar under the Room of the Long Argument. She is small, ink-black to the wrists, and quick, and she has printed every Hush map Jory Welt has made. Her own father is in the Jar Room, third shelf, sentenced in 612 for striking a Licenser. She prints his name in the corner of every issue.

**LARK DUNNOCK** Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## THE LANDING

The southern waterfront, where the border road comes off its causeway onto the first pilings and the city begins. The Ferrying Post stands here, the oldest piling in Lastgate, black as iron with nine centuries of tar. Around it are the Rim Road Company's

warehouses, the customs house, the punt-stands, the inns for foreigners, and Tam Ruddock's ferry.

**Who lives here:** porters, punt-men, Company clerks, customs officers of the Court, innkeepers, foreigners (Fatlands meat-factors, Vigil couriers, Oathen notaries, the occasional Reckoner who has not yet understood), and the smugglers who move the dying north. **Smell and sound:** tar first, from the Post and the hulls; then rum, Fatlands gravy from the foreigners' inns, horse-dung from the Company stables, and the vinegar the customs men splash on everything that comes off the road. You hear foreign accents here and nowhere else in the city, and the Company's post-horn at the arrival of every coach. **Trade:** imports (Fatlands meat, Brinehollow salt, Vigil glass, Oathen paper), exports (Sallowreach leather, smoulder-coal, Kept-candles, undying cheese), money-changing (the only place in the north where a foreigner can buy breaths at a fair rate). **Custom:** *the Turning Back*. Every Kept porter and punt-man on the Landing wears a red cord on the left wrist. It reminds them, and tells others, that they must not take the road south. Living porters tie the cord on for them at hiring, and if a Kept porter is ever seen walking south past the last piling, any living person who sees them is expected to take them by the cord and turn them round. **Danger:** foreigners. People from the other six lands die here. A Brinehollow sailor knifed in a Landing inn dies properly, and then gets up, and cannot go home, and the Landing has a whole street, Stranger's Row, of foreign Kept who made that mistake.

**Gideon Tarr, Tarrer of the Ferrying Post.** A Kept man who has tarred the Post at Court wages since 338, so sealed with tar himself that he looks carved from it and smells exactly like it. He is the man who tars over the gouged eighth figure. The gouges used to come twice a year. Now they come every month, and the newest are cut from the inside of the wood outward, as if something were trying to get out.

**GIDEON TARR** Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (tar-hook 3) · Armor 2 (tar) · Dread 1

## LOFTSIDE

The north edge of the city, around the nine long halls of the Lofts. The streets here are quiet and clean and swept, because the Loft-Wardens insist on it, and because the families who come to visit the shelved want the walk to be decent. Loftside is a district of linen-sellers, camphor-merchants, wrappers, label-writers, readers-for-hire, and small cheap lodgings where Wardens and their families live.

**Who lives here:** the Loft-Wardens and their families; wrappers (the craftsmen who wind the Set-Aside in linen); readers who hire out to families who cannot read; widowers of the shelved who rent rooms near their spouses; and the very poor living, who come because rents are lower near the whispering. **Smell and sound:** camphor, linen, wax, lamp-oil, and old meat. The sound is the whispering, always: a soft continuous rush like rain on reeds, rising at night, coming through the walls of the halls into every house on



Loftside. Locals say they stop hearing it in a month. Visitors never stop. **Trade:** linen and waxed wrap, camphor, labels, the Setting Aside (40 lacks to wrap and shelve, 1 lack a season for upkeep), reading-aloud by the hour. **Custom:** *the feast-day queue*. On every feast day the families of the shelved line up outside the halls before first bell with letters, books and small gifts the shelved cannot use, and the line runs the length of Loftside. Those who come to the head of the queue and find they cannot remember which shelf they want are taken in by a Warden and helped to look, without comment. **Danger:** the whisper. Anyone who lodges on Loftside long enough begins to hear the shelved as words rather than sound, and lately there is one word only. Three lodgers on Loft Lane this Carving have stopped speaking anything else.

**Aldo Penny, Reader of Hall Six.** Living, thirty-one, thin, near-sighted, with a soft trained voice and ink on his cuffs. He has read to the four hundred shelved of Hall Six every night for nine years and knows most of them by voice. He refuses to tell families what their shelved are whispering now, on Old Bettany's order, and he has begun sleeping badly, waking at the same hour every night with the word in his mouth.

**ALDO PENNY** Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## THE DROWNED STOREYS

Beneath all of it. The Drowned Storeys are the old streets of Lastgate that sank below the canal-line, storey by storey, over six centuries: the Seventh at knee-depth, the Sixth at the waist, the Fifth to the neck, and everything below the Fifth fully underwater, green-lit through the gratings of the streets above, inhabited by those who do not need to breathe. Access is by ladder, by stair, by trap-door, by the old chimneys, and by swimming.

**Who lives here:** the Kept who cannot afford the Boards or do not want to be seen; the Smalls, the child-dead, in their own society under Little Nell Ash; old Kept families who never moved up when their storey sank and still sit in their parlors with the canal at their chins; smugglers, part-thieves, and anything the Court has lost interest in. **Smell and sound:** canal-water, green weed, wet plaster, the drains of the city above, and the cold mineral smell of deep stone. The sound is muffled and close: dripping, the slap of water against walls, voices that come from the wrong direction, and, in the Smalls' quarter under the old schoolroom, the sound of children playing a game whose rules no living person has been told. **Trade:** almost none, in money. The Drowned Storeys run on favors, on found objects, and on what falls through the gratings. The Smalls trade in buttons, keys and spoons. **Custom:** *the grating gift*. Living people who live on the Boards above a grating drop something through it on feast days, a toy, a ribbon, a sweet, for the Smalls. Nobody admits doing it. Everybody does. **Danger:** the cold, the dark, the water, the old families who do not like visitors, and the

Smalls, who are children, with children's ideas of fairness, and who have had two hundred years to perfect their games.

**Ossie Wade, the Lamp-Wader.** A Kept lamplighter, drowned at the age of nineteen in 498 while lighting the gratings, who has gone on doing it ever since from below. He wades the Sixth and Fifth Storeys with a pole and a tin of smoulder-coal, lighting the fen-glow jars the Court hangs on the old street corners. He is grey-green, soft as a soaked loaf, gentle and very slow, and he is the only adult the Smalls allow into their quarter, because he brings light and never asks them anything.

**OSSIE WADE** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (lamp-pole 3, Reach) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

## BEYOND LASTGATE

The rest of Sallowreach is fen: miles of reed and black water broken by peat-islands, alder carr, stilt-hamlets and the walled mounds of the Hand-line estates. Every settlement off the border road stands on something: piles, a peat-bank, an old mound, the back of an older village. Most can be reached only by punt or boardwalk.

## BRINEMOSS

A hamlet of thirty stilt-huts in the south fen, six hours' punt from Lastgate, built around a broad wooden platform where the pickling is done. Brinemoss is famous for two things: its pickles, which are the best in the north, and Mother Gall's cellar, which holds four hundred customers in barrels. **Who lives here:** picklers, coopers, salt-boilers, and Mother Gall's extended family, living and Kept, all of whom work for her. **Smell and sound:** dill, garlic, vinegar, brine, cooper's shavings, and from under the great hut the creak and knock of four hundred barrels, very soft, steady, like a ship's timbers at anchor. **Trade:** pickles (eel, egg, onion, mushroom, and *Brinemoss pig*, a pickled lively pork that the brine finally stills), barrels, salt, and the cellar, at Mother Gall's prices. **Custom:** *knocking back*. Visitors to the cellar are taught to answer any knock from a barrel with the same number of knocks on the lid. It is the only conversation the customers can have. Some visitors stay for hours. **Danger:** the brine-pits outside the village, where the failed batches are poured. Things that went in them halfway preserved still move there. **Notable:** **Dill Gall**, Mother Gall's living grandson, twenty-six, a cooper with hands like paddles and a slow, sweet manner, who makes and seals every barrel in the cellar and who has begun, without telling his grandmother, to take visitors' money to lift lids at night.

**DILL GALL** Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (cooper's mallet 3, Stunning) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

## THE FINISHING POST

Nine miles south of Lastgate on the border road, where the tarred stakes mark the edge of the land. On the Sallowreach side of the line stands the **Last Lamp**, the Rim Road Company's border inn, a long



low building of stone (the only stone building in the north, carried in by cart) with a palisade and a toll-gate. On the other side, in the grass, is the heap. **Who lives here:** Company clerks, toll-wardens and grooms, all living and all on two-year postings; the Court's border officer and a half-company of the Fen Guard, all Kept, posted on the north side of the stakes; and, on feast days, the families who come to stand just inside the line and look south. **Smell and sound:** grass, which nobody from the fen is used to; horses; the Company's clean lamp-oil; and when the wind is from the south, the dry tomb smell of the heap. The sound is the wind itself, which reaches here, and the post-horns of the coaches. **Trade:** Company tolls, fresh horses, the only beds in the north without a Kept relative in the next room. **Custom:** *raking*. Twice a year the Company clerks rake the heap and sort what they find. Rings, buttons and anything with a name go into a box at the inn, and Kept relatives may claim them through the Company clerk without crossing. The box is never empty. **Danger:** confusion. Kept people who have lost their wits drift south down the road without understanding, and the Guard does not always see them in time. **Notable:** **Hesper Lowe**, Senior Factor of the Last Lamp, living, forty, a Fatlander who has run the inn for six years, eats continuously and kindly, keeps the claim-box himself and has begun, against Company policy, walking out into the grass at dawn to turn the newest bodies so that they face home.

**HESPER LOWE** Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (cudgel 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

#### DUNMERE VERGE

The great encampment around the edge of Dunmere Hush, a ring of tents, lean-tos, punts and pilgrim-shacks strung along the grey line for two miles of its circumference, and moving outward a few yards each month as the silence grows. **Who lives here:** Finishers waiting to walk; Lamps and Singers of the cult who lead them; the families of those who walked, who cannot bring themselves to go home; Court guards (Kept, posted at the main approach, some of whom have walked in themselves); dredgers who wade the edge for dropped valuables; and Dunstan Reave, at his usual spot, with his spyglass. **Smell and sound:** beeswax and fen-mint from the Finishers; wet canvas; cook-smoke; and, at the line itself, nothing, because the Hush has no smell. The camp is loud with singing on pilgrimage days and otherwise unnaturally hushed, as people instinctively lower their voices the nearer they come to the line. **Trade:** candles, name-strips, pilgrim-bread, and illicitly, bottled air from the edge, which the Court calls stolen licenses. **Custom:** *the last verse*. When a procession goes over the line, those who stay behind sing the song to its end, which in Sallowreach is a thing almost never done. The camp says the song is finished when the last singer outside stops. **Danger:** the edge moves. People who fall asleep near the line wake with their feet in grey reeds, or do not wake. **Notable:** **Brother Abel Fisk**, a Lamp of the Finishers, Kept since 603, who runs the camp's soup kitchen for the living children left

behind. He has led forty pilgrimages and never once gone in, and he has begun to be asked, as Sister Lorn is asked, why not.

**BROTHER ABEL FISK** Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (ladle 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

#### GRUESHOLT

The Grue estate, a day's punt west of Lastgate beyond the Sump: a long black hall on a peat mound over a reed-cutters' village of sixty houses. The Regent has not been here since 371; it is kept by stewards and by forty-two cadet Grues not wanted in town. **Smell and sound:** cut reed, eel-smoke, and the deep cold of the Grue chapel, where Hessa Grue's reaping hook hangs above the altar in a lead case. The village is loud on purpose: dogs, bells, singing. **Trade:** the best thatching reed in the north; eels; a small tithe of minutes from the Regent's allotment. **Custom:** *the shout at sixth bell*: when the door-candles are lit, the whole village shouts once, together, as loud as it can. Nobody remembers when it began. It began in 634. **Danger:** the silence that is not there. Gruesholt is the only great Hand-line estate with no Hush within a day of it, and Provost Sedge's map has a blank around it. Some say the Regent's absence spares it; some that the Grue blood has gone too deep to close anything; some that the Hush is there and has not yet chosen to be heard. **Notable:** **Steward Mallen Grue**, Kept since 588, a cadet cousin who writes to Lastgate every week asking what is happening and receives no answer. He closes every shutter in the hall each night, and finds them shut again in the morning before he reaches them.

**STEWARD MALLEN GRUE** Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (cane 2) · Armor 1 (lacquer) · Dread 1

#### SMOKEHOLM

A peat-cutters' village on the western rim of the Smoking Ground, two hours by boardwalk east of Lastgate, built on the one hard ridge in that warm, cracked, steaming country. **Who lives here:** peat-cutters, coal-tinners, and the burned: Kept men and women who were caught in fires over the centuries and walk now as figures of black coal, crackling, weeping clear fluid from their cracks. They are the village's best workers, because they do not mind the heat. **Smell and sound:** peat smoke, always, hot and sweet and choking; scorched earth; sulphur from the cracks; and the coal-folk's sound, which is the crackling of embers when they move. **Trade:** peat, and above all *smoulder-coal*: lumps of burning peat sealed in tins, which stay lit for years and are sold in every household in the north to light the door-candle and the smudge pot (1 lack the tin). **Custom:** *lending a light*. No Smokeholm household will refuse to light another's coal, and to refuse a light to anyone in the village is the worst insult there is. **Danger:** the ground. The peat fires under it shift, and a cutter who steps on the wrong turf goes through into a burning hollow, and comes out, eventually, as one of the coal-folk. **Notable:** **Cinder Annet**, Kept since 401, who fell through the turf at eighteen and has been a coal-woman ever since. She is the best

tinner in Smokeholm, and the Heirs’ contact there, and she guides their meetings onto the Smoking Ground by the paths that will hold. She glows faintly in the dark. She has asked three Hand-line visitors to close her, and been refused three times, and she has stopped asking and started saving minutes.

**CINDER ANNET** Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 10 · Attack +4 (burning grip 3) · Armor 2 (coal hide) · Dread 2

GRINHOLM

The far north fen, three days by punt from Lastgate, where the Scraplings live: the families who took what nobody else wanted at the Meal, and above all, the face. Grinholm is a scatter of turf huts on a low island ringed by alder, built around a peat pit fenced with stakes. The pit is where the face was boiled, for a week, in the year 0. Nothing grows in it. Its water is perfectly clear. **Who lives here:** Scrapling families of Cut 1, poor, proud, inbred by necessity and suspicious of all outsiders, especially the Hand-lines; a handful of Cutwrights’ College surveyors who have come lately to measure the pit; and Granny Ketch. **Smell and sound:** peat smoke, alder, fish, and the curious absence of smell over the pit itself. The village is

quiet but not silent; its people laugh more than other Sallowreachers, and a great deal of the laughing is at the Hand-lines. **Trade:** almost nothing. Fish, peat, alder-bark dye, and lately the College’s money, paid for samples of the pit-water and for the right to measure the heads of Grinholm children. **Custom:** *the face-grace*. Before every meal, Grinholm families smile at their food, all together, for a breath, before eating. They say it is to thank the god for smiling at them. Outsiders find it unbearable. **Danger:** the College. Grinholm children have begun, in the last year, to be born with a fold at the corner of the mouth that looks like a smile and will not straighten, and men from Lastgate keep coming to look at them. Pim Sorrel’s family came from here, two generations back. **Notable:** **Granny Ketch**, Kept since 377, the keeper of the pit, a small dark leathery woman wrapped in alder-dyed rags who has sat beside the pit every day for two and a half centuries. She is Pim Sorrel’s great-great-great-grandmother. She says that the pit has started to move, very slightly, at the corners, and she will not say the corners of what.

**GRANNY KETCH** Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 9 · Attack +2 (alder staff 2) · Armor 1 (leather skin) · Dread 1

▼ROADS AND WAYS

Sallowreach has one road and a thousand ways. The road is the border causeway, nine miles of piled peat and old bone from the Finishing Post to the Landing. Everything else is water. A Sallowreacher does not ask how far a place is; they ask how many poles.

**Punts**, long black-tarred boats poled from the stern, are the carts of the north; hired punt-men charge 2 lacks a day. **Boardwalks** run between the larger villages on sunk posts: single planks, often rotten, swaying in the Breath. **Wading-ways** are routes across shallow fen staked with white-ragged alder poles. And the Kept walk the bed of the fen as freely as the living walk a road; the Fen Guard moves its soldiers that way when it wants to arrive unseen.

| ROUTE                          | WAY                             | DAYS        | DANGER                                 |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------|----------------------------------------|
| Lastgate to the Finishing Post | the causeway, on foot or coach  | half a day  | Kept wandering south; Company tolls    |
| Lastgate to Brinemoss          | punt through the south channels | 1           | sacks drifting up from the Sump’s edge |
| Lastgate to Dunmere Verge      | punt, then the pilgrim plank    | 1 to 2      | Finisher processions; the moving edge  |
| Lastgate to Gruesholt          | punt across the Sump            | 1           | bubbles in patterns; things below      |
| Lastgate to Smokeholm          | boardwalk east                  | quarter day | burning hollows; coal-folk             |
| Lastgate to Grinholm           | punt, wading-way, punt          | 3           | getting lost; Black Noons; College men |
| Any wading-way                 | on foot, in tall boots          | varies      | something takes an ankle               |
| The bottom of the fen          | walking, Kept only              | as surface  | the dark; the Sump’s mound             |

## FEN TRAVEL AT THE TABLE

Poling a punt is Lung + Wayfaring; a hired punt-man rolls for the party with Threat 3. A Black Noon on open water forces a Hard (14) Gut + Endure roll or -2 to all rolls for the rest of the day (flies in the mouth, the eyes, the lungs). A living character who falls from a boardwalk into deep fen must make a Hard (14) Lung + Athletics roll to climb out, or a drowned thing has them: they are held, not pulled under, for 1d6 hours unless freed with a Grim (18) Gut + Labor roll or a blade (the hand does not let go of what it holds even when cut off). If a living character drowns in Sallowreach, they come up Kept the next morning.

## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

The economy of Sallowreach is built on one fact and one fear. The fact is that nobody inherits. The fear is the bill for upkeep. Every household in the north is carrying a load of Kept dependents who do not eat but must be stitched, lacquered, perfumed, wrapped, housed and kept from the flies, and who own the house, and whose permission is needed to spend anything. The living work. The dead own. The Guild charges both.

**The great trades** are Keeping (Seamers, wrappers, perfumers, lacquer-boilers, gauze-weavers), eel and reed, peat and smoulder-coal, leather (which never perishes and is prized on the Rim), Kept-candles, and the Court's trade in death. Sallowreach imports meat,

grain, salt, glass, paper and cedar, which it burns by the ton, and exports leather, coal, candles, smoked eel, undying cheese and, quietly, bottled Hush-air.

**The Kept work for less.** The Kept do not eat and need no bed, and so the law since 214 has permitted them to be paid *dead wages*: half the living rate, often less. This has kept wages in the north the lowest on the Table, and kept the living poor poorer, because no employer hires a living porter at a lack a day when a Kept one will carry the same load for six crumbs. The Heirs' pamphlets call it the second inheritance: the dead took the houses, and then they took the work.

| WORK                                          | LIVING WAGE PER DAY | KEPT WAGE PER DAY          |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------|----------------------------|
| Porter, punt-hand, reed-cutter                | 1 L                 | 6 c                        |
| Eel-catcher (own traps)                       | 2 L                 | 1 L                        |
| Sackman of the Sump                           | 2 L                 | 1 L                        |
| Ladder-hand of the Lofts                      | 1 L and a bed       | 5 c                        |
| Threader of the Seamers                       | 5 c and board       | 5 c                        |
| Journeyman Seamer                             | 4 L                 | 4 L (the Guild pays alike) |
| Master of the Seam                            | 15 L                | 15 L                       |
| Fen Guard soldier                             | 2 L                 | 1 L and free stitching     |
| Court clerk or Glovebearer                    | 6 L                 | 3 L                        |
| Professional mourner (Bram Hollin, this year) | 30 L                | none exist                 |
| Closer of the Court                           | 40 L and a house    | (no Closer is Kept)        |

**What things cost locally.** Lively eel is 4 crumbs the pound; stilled meat 3 lacks; Fatlands beef 2. Reed-bread is a crumb a loaf, a tin of smoulder-coal a lack, a Wick Tallow candle 6 crumbs, a named candle 5 lacks (50 to commission your own dead). Restitching is 3 lacks a limb at Guild rates, half that in the Sinks. A barrel at Mother Gall's is 600 lacks in advance. A license is about 4,000 lacks and rose

by three hundred last year, because the Hushes have made death seem, for the first time, a thing that might be had for free.

**Taxes.** The **fly-tax** is assessed per window by Court fly-assessors, who count the flies on the outside of the glass each Plenty and presume a fly-thick house is keeping its dead badly. The **stitching-tithe** is a tenth of every Seamer's fee. The **door-duty** is a crumb a

night for every door-candle. The **license-levy** is a tenth of every Closing fee, which is to say the Court taxes itself and keeps both halves. And the **Tenancy** is the rent every living person pays to the Unvacated owner of their house, as their parents did, and their grandparents.

## ▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

Law in Sallowreach is very old, very precise and absolutely without end. Every statute ever passed is still in force, because nothing is repealed: a repeal is an ending. Statutes that contradict one another are reconciled by the courts, which have been reconciling them for five centuries. No case is ever closed, because a judgment is a kind of ending too, and so every judgment of a Sallowreach court is, formally, *adjourned with a ruling*, and may be resumed by either party at any time. Most are not. Some are resumed every few decades, by the original parties, out of spite.

**Who enforces.** The **Fen Guard** under Captain Dace Morrow keeps the border, the larger Hushes and the peace. The **Hookmen**, the Court’s beadles, make arrests in Lastgate by hooking a suspect by the collar with a shelving hook and bagging their head. The **Right Hand’s agents**, plain-coated, watch the Upper Boards and

**Who is rich.** The Unvacated, who own nearly every building in Lastgate; the Hand-lines, who own death; the Guild, which owns keeping; and the few living who found trades the dead cannot do: Tam Ruddock, Mother Gall, Wick Tallow and, this year, Bram Hollin.

the Heirs. **Parish wardens** collect falling-apart fines, and carry a bag for what they collect.

**How a trial works.** Small matters, debts, nuisance and *grievous unmaking* (what other lands call assault and murder), go before the **Court of Wrongs** on the Landing, under three Justices led by Justice Ever Lathe. Plaintiff, defendant and victim all speak, because the victim is always present, however badly unmade. Witnesses swear with a hand in the mouth of a Kept parent, or, lacking one, of the court’s oath-keeper, Mother Clamp, Kept, who has sat in the witness-box since 402 and has bitten through nine perjurers’ fingers. Capital matters go to the **Hall of Hands**, where the Regent and three Hands sit, the accused speaks only through an advocate of the Court’s choosing, and the sentence is almost always the jar: the head sealed aware in green glass, the hands in a jar beside it, the rest rendered or sunk. Witnessing a jarring is Dread 3.

| CRIME                                 | USUAL SENTENCE                           | NOTES                                            |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Falling apart in public               | 4 L a hand, 20 L a face                  | parish wardens collect the fine and the part     |
| Grievous unmaking (assault, “murder”) | cost of repair, and the same done to you | the victim chooses the Seamer                    |
| Part-theft                            | unstitching; jar on the third offence    | the stolen part is returned if found             |
| Clipping lacks                        | the clipper is shaved by the same weight | done slowly, by a Seamer                         |
| Stilling (selling closed meat)        | refusal; 200 L fine                      | the butcher’s hands may be mittened in lead      |
| Breaking an oath on the dead          | the jaw closes                           | the court will wire it shut if the parent cannot |
| Walking into a Hush (Finisher)        | the family is billed 400 L               | “for a death not paid for”                       |
| Hush-dragging an elder                | the jar                                  | counted as unlicensed Closing                    |
| Unlicensed Closing                    | the jar                                  | the Closer’s hands are jarred separately         |
| Preaching the Bait                    | the tongue jarred                        | the rest is let go                               |
| Treason against the Court             | the jar, or the Sump                     | the Sump is considered the kinder                |

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

Sallowreach is a land of the Theft. Most people in the north believe in their bones that their ancestors murdered a kind god on a mudbank, and that what they live in now is the bill. The Confessors of the north are the gravest priests on the Table, and their chapels are low, windowless timber houses with a single shut door painted grey, called **Shut Houses**. Inside there is a long bench, a grey cloth

on the wall in the shape of two open hands, and nothing else. Worship is sitting in silence on the bench and not leaving. The service ends when the last worshipper decides to go, which in some Shut Houses has not happened in years.

The **Gift** is the faith of the comfortable, the Unvacated and the families of the Upper Boards who are not Hand-line. Its Thankers

preach that Ossel lay down out of love, and that its refusal to finish is that love gone on too long, as a mother's hand stays on a sleeping child's head. Gift households keep a dish of grey salt on the sill. The Court finds the Gift convenient.

The **Bait** has been illegal here since 331, and its pamphlets are the most read literature in the Sinks. Northern Baiters teach that Ossel lay down as a seed lies down, that the Hand-lines are its fruit, and that the Hushes are the harvest; theirs is the only doctrine whose preachers can stand at the edge of a Hush and point. The Court jars their tongues, which go on preaching silently to each other on the shelf.

And then there are the **Finishers**, who are a faith in their own right and growing faster than all three, and whose hymns are the only songs in Sallowreach with last verses.

**Shrines.** Every house has a *shut-niche*, a small cupboard with a door, in the wall of the kitchen, holding the household's oath-relics: a lock of hair, a tooth, a ring from each of the Kept. The door is opened only to swear. Every street corner in the old parts of Lastgate has an *eye-post*, a short black post carved at the top with two closed eyes, where people touch their fingers to the lids on the way to a Closing, a sickbed or a quarrel. The Ferrying Post is the greatest shrine of all, and nobody worships at it.

**Holy days. Restitching Week** (early Grace), with its mending-mass, the one joyful service of the year. **The Shutter Days** (high Plenty), when the flies breed and the Kept are shut indoors while the living keep vigil with smudge-pots. **Yellowing** (Carving), when children gather the rare leaves that finally fall and keep them in

boxes for luck. **Tablenight**, the banquet for the dead. And **the First Morning**, the day after, when every household hangs a knotted cord on the door and cuts it at first bell, saying *come down, then*.

*The Hymn of the Open Hands, as sung in the Shut Houses of the Confessors. It has eight verses. The eighth has never been sung in living or unliving memory, and the Confessors do not know its words. The congregation sings the seventh, and then sits in silence for the length of a verse, and then goes home.*

*You came to the shore with your hands on your knees,*

*And we came to the shore with our knives.*

*You closed the eyes of the children at the back*

*And we opened your side for our lives.*

*Hand that closes, we have you in us now.*

*Hand that closes, you cannot close.*

*We carry you shut in the dark of the gut*

*Where nothing that enters goes.*

*Forgive us the mud and forgive us the hook,*

*Forgive us the nine days' meat.*

*We will keep what we took until the book*

*Is shut and the debt complete.*

*(The congregation sits through the eighth verse in silence.)*

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

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### OVERHEARD IN SALLOWREACH

"I've dug holes forty years for the Court's fence-posts and never once a grave. My granddad used to tell me what one looked like. I didn't believe him." — Hob Rennet, post-digger, Weir Row

"My nan's shelved. Every feast day I tell her I've been good and she whispers back that I'm lying. She's right but how does she know?" — a living girl of nine, Loftside queue

"Long life, sir. No, I meant it. I meant it exactly as it sounds." — a whore of the Sinks, to a Hand-line cadet who would not pay

"I've been killed eleven times in the Guard. The pay's the same. The stitching's free. You get used to the second sort of pain but not the first sort." — Corporal Wat Gully, Fen Guard

"I am seventy-three and I have never once been allowed to choose my own supper. My mother chooses it. She doesn't eat it. She just chooses it." — an Heir at a Smoking Ground meeting

"He was my baby. He's still my baby. He's two hundred years my baby and he's still in the cot and he still cries and I still pick him up. You don't stop being a mother because it's forever." — Hennet Plaice, Kept, of the Seventh Storey

"We don't say dead in our house. We say quiet. Gran's quiet. Uncle's quiet. Mam's not quiet yet. Mam's never quiet." — a Weir Row child, explaining to a Fatlands visitor

"I went to Dunmere to watch my brother walk in. I sang the last verse. I didn't know I knew it. Nobody taught me. It was just there in my mouth, as if it had been waiting." — a reed-cutter, living, at the Verge

"Don't lean on the rail at Cooper's Cut, there's a man under it who's been holding on since 517 and he's very polite but he does pull." — directions given to a stranger on the Sinks bridges

"Of course the candles feel it. Everything here feels it. Why should a candle be spared?" — a chandler's journeyman, Wick Lane

"Mind your stitches, love." — what every Kept mother says at the door, instead of goodbye

"They're all whispering it in the Lofts now. Company. Company. Like when you're little and you hear the door go downstairs and Mam says, hush, we've got company." — a Loftside lodger, the week before she stopped speaking

IN EVERY OTHER LAND THE DEAD ARE A LOSS. HERE THEY  
ARE A COST. YOU LEARN TO LOVE THEM THE WAY YOU LOVE A  
ROOF.

[ THANKER ODILE STRAND, SERMON ON THE UPPER BOARDS, 636 A.G. ]

## ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

On paper, the Regent rules through the Mortuary Court, and the Court rules everything. In practice power in Sallowreach moves along three cords that are always pulling against one another: **who can end things** (the Hand-lines, and now the Hushes), **who can keep things** (the Seammers, Mother Gall, the Wardens), and **who owns things** (the Unvacated). The living have none of the three, which is why the Heirs exist. The Court's whole art, for three

centuries, has been to keep the first cord in its own hand and to tie the other two to it with debt.

That art is failing. The Hushes end things without license; the Guild knows it could stop the country; the Lofts whisper one word; and the Unvacated have begun buying minutes in secret against the day the Court stops selling.

| POWER-HOLDER           | CONTROLS                                       | FEARS                                        | OWES                                       |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Regent Ansel Grue      | every license; the Court's ledger; precedent   | the Hushes; disorder; his own hands          | the Unvacated, who confirm him each decade |
| Lady Corrow Vane       | the Closers; who finishes and when             | herself; the Glovehall Hush                  | the Regent, a secret from 610              |
| Lord Absalom Hethe     | the Court's Quiet Market party; Osric's visits | exposure as the Second Table's man           | the Second Table, everything               |
| Thessaly Mort          | every stitch in the country; the strike        | being no one; Marrow Jack's tongue           | Marrow Jack, a third of her stock          |
| The Unvacated aldermen | every deed, rent and guild seat                | the Heirs; the jar; being finished unwilling | the Seammers, their faces                  |
| Old Bettany Shroud     | forty thousand witnesses                       | whatever "company" is                        | the shelved, a promise to stay             |
| Jory Welt              | the Heirs; the Hush map                        | becoming his father's undertaker             | his father, secretly, his funds            |
| Sister Lorn            | the Finishers' processions                     | that she is a coward                         | the nine hundred she led                   |
| Captain Dace Morrow    | the Fen Guard                                  | the border                                   | the Guild, who stitched him sixty times    |
| Provost Carrion Sedge  | the proof that the Hushes follow the blood     | publication; his own closing ledgers         | the College, and three buyers              |
| Marrow Jack            | the part trade; half the Guild's stock         | the woman in eleven pieces                   | nobody, he thinks                          |
| Little Nell Ash        | the Smalls; the Drowned Storeys                | growing up; the Court; Marrow Jack           | Ossie Wade, the light                      |

# THE PEOPLE OF SALLOWREACH

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The core book gave each of these people a paragraph; here each is given a life, with stats agreeing with the core book (refined where noted). In Sallowreach nobody dies: every fight with these people

ends when someone is held, sacked, sunk, jarred or closed, and anyone merely harmed will be back, stitched and furious, by next week.



# ANSEL GRUE

*the Unvacated Regent*

*“You ask me to sign. I shall sign. Sit down. It takes a minute, and I have never once in three hundred years been hurried.”*

– ANSEL GRUE, THROUGH HIS BRASS TUBE, TO A PETITIONER AT THE HALL OF HANDS, 640 A.G.

| ANSEL GRUE – THE UNVACATED REGENT |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                        | Sallowreach · Cut 5 (Hand-line, the left hand) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                     | 412 (born 229, Kept since 371); Regent of the Mortuary Court since 341                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                | Scion · Standing 5 (Great House: the Regency); above every rank of the Mortuary Court                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                        | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                            | Clause 5, Resolve 5, Persuade 4, Lore 4, Intimidate 3, Endure 3, Reckoning 3, Rites 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                              | Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Armor 2 (lacquer and wire) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                           | none worth the name; he has never needed one. If pressed, a slow cold grip +2 (1, and the Shutting)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                             | Kept (Unending in Sallowreach; Rot 4, held there by constant Guild attention); The Shutting (once per scene, Routine Tongue + Clause to end any argument, threat or plea in his presence; the speaker cannot recall where it was going); Lidsense; four hundred years of precedent (+3 to any Clause or Lore roll concerning the law of Sallowreach) |
| WANTS                             | Close (cannot leave a ledger unsigned, a door ajar or a sentence unfinished; resist Hard 14); Endure (refuses every ending, including his own)                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                            | Dowager’s Patience, Counting Habit, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                      | The Count (he counts the licenses he has signed, always aloud, always one short)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                           | brass speaking-tube, the Regent’s pen, the License Ledger, the first minute, a jaw-key, a lead box, cedar oil                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                             | 2 (to watch him move); 3 (to hear the tube when he laughs)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

The Regent sits in a high-backed chair of black fen-oak at the head of the Hall of Hands, and almost never leaves it. He is smaller than his portraits: the centuries have settled him downward, the spine compressed, the head held up by a collar of brass wire under a black silk stock. His face has been lacquered so often that it is no longer skin but a deep glossy amber shell, like a violin, through which, in strong lamplight, you can see the dark shapes underneath. The eyes are blue Vigil glass, made in 455. The jaw is wired shut. He speaks through a brass tube in his throat, fitted by Thessaly Mort in 470, in a dry clicking whisper that makes everyone who speaks to him lean in, so that everyone who speaks to the Regent ends up bowing.

He smells of cedar first, then varnish, then, faintly, unmistakably, of something sweet: a bowl of fruit forgotten in a warm room. Under the lacquer, his hands are grey to the second knuckle, the nails gone thick and dark as horn. He keeps them in fine black gloves. When he moves them, which is rarely, they move one finger

at a time, and there is a small sound inside each joint like a seed rattling in a dry pod.

## THEIR STORY

Ansel Grue was born in 229 to the left-hand line of Hessa Grue, a cold clever child who closed every door in Gruesholt by the age of four. In 301, a junior Hand of seventy-two, he drafted the fee-schedule of the Licensing: the first price of death, the rule of consent, the threefold question. Every license since bears his form of words. In 340 the Regent of the day, Lorimer Vane, was charged with treason for proposing free Closings for the Set-Aside, on a charge Grue drafted, and was recorded as having “retired to Glovehall, not receiving.” Grue was confirmed Regent in 341, living, a hundred and twelve, withered, already the most feared clerk in the country. Nobody has seen Lorimer Vane since.

In 340 the Regent of the day, Lorimer Vane, was charged with treason for proposing that the Court give Closings free to the Set-Aside. The charge was drafted by Grue. Lorimer Vane was officially recorded as having “retired to Glovehall, not receiving,” and Grue

was confirmed as Regent in 341, at the age of a hundred and twelve, living, withered, and already the most feared clerk in the country. Nobody has seen Lorimer Vane since.

In 371, aged a hundred and forty-two, he was thrown on the causeway when his Kept horse shed a leg, and broke his neck and jaw on the planks. He was back in his chair in nine days, stitched and wired, and heard four petitions that afternoon. In the Carving of 610, alone, at night, he sent for Lady Corrow Vane, then thirty and newly at the Course, and asked her to close him. She laid her bare hand over his eyes. Nothing happened. Neither has spoken of it since.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Grue is the keystone. Every death in Sallowreach passes under his hand: he signs every license personally, in a slow copperplate that takes a full minute and cannot be forged, because the ink is mixed with lacquer scraped from his own face. Every minute and breath bears his name. He presides over every capital case, confirms every Closer, and is confirmed in turn by the Unvacated aldermen every ten years, in a ceremony never yet contested. At second bell he hears petitions in order of filing, which for some means thirty years of waiting; at fifth bell he signs licenses, never more than forty a day; at ninth bell the shutters close and he sits on in the dark with the License Ledger on his knees, counting.

He knows his limits exactly. He cannot strike the Seamers, who keep his face on, or overrule the Unvacated, who own the buildings the Court meets in. He cannot command the Hushes. And he cannot leave the country.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The brass speaking-tube** — set into his throat in 470, polished daily by his clerk, Anselm Rook. When it is stoppered, he cannot speak. Petitioners who have angered him have watched the clerk reach for the stopper.
- ◇ **The Regent's pen** — a black iron nib in a shaft of heron bone, the heron being Ossel's bird. The ink is lamp-black mixed with lacquer from his own face, scraped by the Guild each spring and kept in a sealed pot.
- ◇ **The License Ledger** — the current volume (the four hundred and eighteenth) of the record of every license, bound in black calf. He never lets it out of his sight. A license not entered here is void, which makes it the most valuable book in the north.
- ◇ **The first minute** — the first minute of Closing ever cut, number 1/1, issued in 301 and never spent. He keeps it on a chain around his neck under the stock. Worth sixty-five lacks; worth more than any jewel in Lastgate as a relic.
- ◇ **A jaw-key** — a small brass key that opens the wire of his jaw, held by his clerk. The jaw has been opened four times since 371. Each time he said one thing, aloud, with his own mouth, and nobody who heard any of the four has repeated them.

- ◇ **A lead box** — a small lead-lined casket on the arm of his chair, which nobody has seen opened. It holds the note Lady Corrow Vane wrote him the morning after 610: *I did not hold back. C.V.* He does not believe it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Grue wants order: precedent, process, ledgers that balance and doors that are shut. He fears the Hushes more than anything in the six lands, because they close without license, and an ending without a signature is the one thing his entire life has been built to prevent. He is tempted by Envoy Castellan Dray, not by the Vigil's oil but by the thought of a second country run on his forms.

**Secret the GM can reveal:** he asked Corrow Vane to close him in 610, and her hand did nothing. He does not know whether he is beyond closing or whether she held back, and he has spent thirty-one years watching her for the answer. **A second secret:** Lorimer Vane did not retire. Grue had him sacked and sunk in the Sump in 340, alive and talking, and the dredgers have found Sack Seventeen. If its occupant is Lorimer, every license Grue has ever signed was signed by a Regent who took office by an unlawful sinking, and is void.

**Secret he does not know:** Gruesholt has no Hush because the Hush is in him. Corrow's hand worked. It found the ending in him and closed it, the way a Course-hand closes a candle so it can never be lit again. Grue cannot be finished now, by any hand or any Hush. When the great Hush comes, everything in Sallowreach will end except the Regent, who will sit in his chair in the silence, signing. (The GM may choose instead that Corrow did hold back, or that a Brink-hand like Osric's might still succeed.)

#### TIES

- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — his Left Hand and the only person alive who has touched his face. He trusts her completely with every death but his own.
- ◇ **Osric Vane** — a weapon he has declined to use and a Brink he has declined to close. He receives a weekly report on the lead mittens.
- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — the only person in the country who can unmake him by withholding a stitch. They have dined together, he not eating, every Restitching Week since 451.
- ◇ **Jory Welt** — a petitioner whose case has been adjourned for forty years. Grue knows exactly where the Boy lives and lets him live there.
- ◇ **Envoy Castellan Dray** — a guest he is keeping waiting, as he keeps everyone waiting. He has begun to enjoy the visits.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet the Regent when they petition the Court, threaten its order, or bring him something he cannot ignore: Sack Seventeen, Sedge's ledgers, Pim Sorrel. He wants them to file properly and wait,

and he hires them, through intermediaries, to retrieve documents and silence witnesses.

- ◇ **The Fortieth Signature.** The Regent has signed thirty-nine licenses today and will not sign the fortieth, because the fortieth is for a Hush-dragged alderman whose family wants it backdated. The family hires the PCs to find out what would make him sign.
- ◇ **Sack Seventeen.** The PCs have the sack. Grue's clerk offers them a full license each for it, unopened. The Heirs offer them a printing press and a riot. The sack offers them nothing; it only asks, in a voice like a drowned bell, to see the Regent.
- ◇ **The Jaw-Key.** Anselm Rook, the clerk, has been murdered (stitched, but mute) and the jaw-key is missing. Somebody wants to hear what the Regent says with his own mouth.

**Threat:** he files, adjourns, licenses and outlasts; he sends Hookmen, then the Right Hand's agents, then the jar. **Kindness:** he does not understand it, and treats it as a filing error. **The god:** he will not speak of it, and the Want to Close is visible in him only as the way he lowers the lid of the inkwell, very carefully, after every signature. **If nobody intervenes:** he sells Dray the forms of Keeping (not the secret, which is not his to sell), sinks Sack Seventeen deeper, and sits on in the Hall of Hands as the Hushes join around Lastgate, signing licenses for a country that no longer needs them.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He's been Regent longer than Lastgate's had the Ninth Storey. My gran says he was always like that. My gran's two hundred." — a porter on the Landing

"I have read every one of his rulings since 341. I cannot find a single error. I cannot find a single mercy. I am beginning to think they are the same thing." — Provost Carrion Sedge

"When he signs, the room holds its breath. Even the ones who have none." — Anselm Rook, Clerk to the Regent

# LADY CORROW VANE

*the Left Hand of the Court*

*“Lie still, please. It is easier if you are not holding anything. No, I will not say anything.  
There is nothing I could say that would be true.”*

– LADY CORROW VANE, IN CHAMBER FOUR OF THE HALL OF CLOSINGS, TO A CLIENT

| LADY CORROW VANE – THE LEFT HAND OF THE COURT |                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                    | Sallowreach · Cut 5 (Hand-line, the right hand) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 6                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION                                 | 61, living; Left Hand of the Court, chief Closer, mistress of Glovehall                                                                                                                    |
| CALLING & STANDING                            | Celebrant (Closer) · Standing 4; Mortuary Court rank 5 (Left Hand)                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                                    | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                                        | Rites 4, Persuade 3, Instinct 3, Resolve 3, Clause 2, Stitching 2, Godsign 2, Blades 1, Endure 1                                                                                           |
| BODY                                          | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                                       | Closing Touch +8 (finishes a Kept target outright; a living target makes a Grim 18 Caul + Resolve check or falls to Ruin and rises Kept); stiletto +5 (2)                                  |
| GIFTS                                         | The Closing Touch; Coldprint (her bare hand frosts metal and glass and leaves a bloodless print on skin); Lidsense; Long Hands (+1 Filch and Stitching; Dread 2 to see bare); Cold Fingers |
| WANTS                                         | Close (resist Grim 18); Quiet (cannot bear laughter near her; she must leave or end it)                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                        | Unflinching, Silent Supper, Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                   |
| DERANGEMENTS                                  | none yet; Fray rises in her only at night                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                                       | sewn gloves, the stiletto, the Count-Book, a perfect pear, a knotted cord, a cap under glass, sleeping mittens                                                                             |
| DREAD                                         | 2 (to see her gloves come off)                                                                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

Corrow Vane is tall, very straight and very still, and she smells of nothing at all. In a country where everyone carries cedar or vinegar or rot, the air around her is clean as cold water, and people who have stood beside her describe it as standing beside an open grave that has been scrubbed.

Her ash-blond hair, silvering, is worn in a single severe coil. Her face rarely moves; she learned young that expressions frighten clients. Her voice is low, courteous and sparing. Her gloves are black kid sewn on at the wrist with nine stitches of black silk, and under them her hands are slate grey past the wrist, cold enough to sting through the leather, each finger with two joints too many. She keeps them folded at her waist, left over right, and never gestures.

## THEIR STORY

Corrow was born at Glovehall in 580, the elder child of Lord Hamnet Vane, a Closer, and raised to be the hand of the Court. At three she could not sleep with a door open; at twenty-two her fingers went grey. She performed her first Closing at twenty-three,

on a Glad Century fisherman who had asked for two hundred years, and has performed eleven thousand since, four or five each working day. She was named Left Hand in 618, the youngest in three centuries.

She performed her first licensed Closing at twenty-three, on a Kept fisherman of the Glad Century who had asked for it for two hundred years. She has performed eleven thousand since: a little over two hundred and sixty a year, four or five each working day. She keeps count. She was named Left Hand in 618, the youngest in three centuries.

She married in 599, by arrangement, Lord Merriman Vane, a gentle Sedge cadet who took her name, and bore two sons, Ivo in 601 and Teodor in 605, handing each to a nurse at birth. Ivo, now forty and a Licenser of the Court, drafts the licenses his mother executes and has never touched her skin. Merriman drowned in the Glovehall moat in 622 and is Kept in the south wing. Every year she offers to close him. Every year he refuses; he says he would like to stay near the boys.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Left Hand commands the nine Closers of the Court and performs the important Closings herself: aldermen, Court officers, the Regent's rewards. Her waiting list is years long. Her Glovebearer, **Prudence Lisk**, a living clerk of twenty-nine, unpicks and resews the nine stitches with a silver needle; in six years they have exchanged no word not about the work. She is also used for deniable work, a rebel closed in a back room, a witness finished in the Jar Room, and she does it without asking. She enforces the license and consent on every Closer but herself.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Sewn gloves** — black kid, nine stitches of black silk at each wrist, replaced every month. She owns forty pairs. She has never in her adult life put one on herself.
- ◇ **A stiletto** — a slim Oathen blade in her left sleeve, for the living who might need to be persuaded to stand still. She has drawn it twice.
- ◇ **The Count-Book** — a small black notebook in which she has written the name of every person she has closed, eleven thousand and some, in a tiny clear hand, with the date. She reads a page every night. She does not know why.
- ◇ **A perfect pear** — from the orchard Hush behind Glovehall, picked with tongs by a gardener who would not step over the line. It sits on her desk in the Hall of Closings, a year old, golden, unblemished, and smells of nothing.
- ◇ **A knotted cord** — sixty yards of waxed linen knotted every yard, used each night to measure the Glovehall Hush. The newest knots are on the side nearest her own window.
- ◇ **A cap under glass** — Ivo's christening cap, in a glass case the size of a book, which she has carried for forty years and never touched bare-handed. She has never opened the case.
- ◇ **Sleeping mittens** — lead-lined, padlocked by Prudence each night, because in her sleep her hands go looking for things to close.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Corrow wants to be told that she is not the cause. She fears only one thing, and it is herself: that the god coming back through her hands is not a duty but a hunger, that she has come to want the moment the room goes cold. She cannot bear laughter. She left Ivo's wedding at the toast.

**Secret the GM can reveal:** the Hush at Glovehall is growing from her rooms, not her brother's. She has measured it every night for a year with the knotted cord. She has hired others to measure it (see In Play) because she wants someone, anyone, to come back with a different answer. **The 610 secret:** she told the Regent she did not hold back. That is true. She felt her hand go into him and close around something, and then he opened his eyes, and she has never told anyone what her hand felt it close.

**Secret she does not know:** her son Ivo has been forging licenses for two years, with his mother's name on them, and selling them to the Heirs, so that grandmothers in the Sinks might be finished at the Hush edge by Heirs instead of being dragged there. He does it because it is the only way he has ever found to touch her work.

## TIES

- ◇ **Osric Vane** — her brother, whom she loves and has locked in the west wing. She holds one of the two mitten-keys. She visits once a month and they speak through the door.
- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — her master, whose face she has touched once. She does not know if she failed him or freed him.
- ◇ **Lord Merriman Vane** — her Kept husband in the south wing, who refuses her every year. She envies him his refusal.
- ◇ **Ivo Vane** — her son, a Licenser, three paces away all his life. He forges her name.
- ◇ **Lord Absalom Hethe** — her brother's only other visitor. She finds him charming and does not trust a single word.
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — a child who can do what Corrow does without the grey, without the cold, and without the Court. Corrow has asked for her to be brought to Glovehall. She will not say why.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet the Left Hand at a Closing, when the Court needs deniable agents, or when a PC Hand-line enters the Course and is summoned to Glovehall to be told what is expected.

- ◇ **The Glovehall Garden.** She hires the PCs to measure the orchard Hush secretly each night for a month and report which way it grows. She already knows. She is paying for a different answer, and if they bring her the true one she will thank them, pay them double, and ask them to forget they ever came.
- ◇ **The Forged License.** A grandmother in the Sinks has been finished at the Hush edge with a license bearing Corrow's name, and Corrow did not close her. The Court wants the forger. So, quietly, does Corrow. Following the trail leads to her own son.
- ◇ **The Laughing House.** A Weir Row family whose old man she is to close on 'Tablenight are famous for their laughter; the old man wants to go out laughing. Corrow cannot bear it. She asks the PCs to keep the house quiet. The family asks the PCs to make sure it is not.

**Threat:** she is calm, takes off a glove, and lets the room see the hand. **Kindness:** it confuses her; any touch, even gloved, makes her step back three paces from long habit. **The god:** she feels it as cold, and as appetite, and she is ashamed of the appetite. **If nobody intervenes:** the Glovehall Hush reaches her window within two years. She will be found sitting in her chair, with the Count-Book open, at the center of a grey silence the size of the estate, and her husband's south wing will be inside it.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She closed my mother. She didn’t speak. She didn’t look. She did it so well I’ve never forgiven her, because I wanted someone to hate.”  
— a living man of the Upper Boards

“I unpick nine stitches every morning and sew nine stitches every night and in six years she has not once said thank you, and in six years she has not once let me see her cry, and I know she does, because the gloves are wet inside.” — Prudence Lisk, Glovebearer

“Lady Vane? Never shake her hand, love. Never laugh near her. And never ask her what she’s thinking. She’ll tell you.” — a cedar-warden of Hand Street

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# OSRIC VANE

## the Gloved

*“I should like to be useful. I should like to be put somewhere I can do good. Would you ask them, please? They will not listen to me. I am very easy to ignore, through a door.”*

– OSRIC VANE, THROUGH THE DOOR OF THE WEST WING, TO A NEW GUARD

| OSRIC VANE – THE GLOVED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT              | Sallowreach · Cut 5 (Hand-line, the right hand) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 8                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION           | 54, living; confined in the west wing of Glovehall since 629                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING      | Scion · Standing 2 (Heir, nominally); none in practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES              | Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                  | Godsign 5, Rites 4, Instinct 4, Lore 3, Resolve 3, Endure 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| BODY                    | Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 (lead mittens count as Armor 4 to his hands only) · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                 | bare touch +9 (finishes anything; Dread 4 to witness)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                   | The Closing Touch; Long Hands; Hushing (by Partaking, no sound within ten paces for a scene, flies die, flames lean, Kept kneel and plead; 2 Hunger); Closing Gaze (a minute’s stare finishes a candle, a fly, a conversation or a Kept man, through a door if he knows where they stand) |
| WANTS                   | Close (resist Dire 22); Be of Use (he cannot refuse a request framed as a duty; resist Hard 14)                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| KNACKS                  | Elder’s Ear, Silent Supper, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS            | The Guilt That Bends the Room (the Fatlander Pell Ambry is in every face he sees)                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                 | lead mittens, a silk blindfold, a page-turner, a knotted thread, a dead fly, Hethe’s letters                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                   | 3 (in the same room); 4 (unmittened)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

### WHO THEY ARE

You know you are near the west wing of Glovehall because the sound goes. Your footsteps grow soft and distant, the flies stop, the lamps lean away. Then there is a black double-barred door with a hatch, and behind it a warm, educated, lonely voice: *Hello? Is someone there? Please, come and talk. I promise to keep my eyes shut.*

His face has gone smooth and grey, softened as if seen through the Breath, the lips curved in an expression everyone at Glovehall has agreed not to call a smile. His white hair lifts a little in the still air. He is thin, and wears a much-mended scholar’s gown. Inside the lead mittens his hands are grey to the elbow, with nine joints to every finger, and when they move you hear a dry clicking like an abacus counted very fast. He reads constantly and asks every guard about their family.

### THEIR STORY

Osric was born in 587, gentler and cleverer than his sister, came into the Course at nineteen, and was a promising Closer by twenty-five. In 628, on the Landing, he shook hands with a Fatlands meat-factor named Pell Ambry, bare, without thinking, because the man held

out his hand and Osric had been raised to be polite. Ambry fell to Ruin on the planks and rose Kept an hour later. He lives in Stranger’s Row, and writes to his wife in the south, who does not write back.

He asked for the mittens himself the next morning, and in 629, when his hands began to close things he had not touched, he asked to be locked in. He reached the Brink in 636, and since then has not needed to touch anything at all.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Officially Osric is a Hand of the Court in abeyance and an invalid. In fact he is the most dangerous thing in the Court’s keeping and the clearest proof of what every Hand-line is becoming. The Leaden party would wall him up; the Quiet Market would sell him; the Regent reads a weekly report and does nothing. Six Kept soldiers of the Fen Guard guard him, changed monthly. His sister visits monthly, a Seamer weekly, Lord Absalom Hethe every Thursday. He reads (a guard turns the pages through the hatch), dictates letters, talks through the door, and at night sits very still in the middle of the floor, trying not to want.



## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Lead mittens** — two, cast for him by a Lastgate plumber in 629 and re-cast twice as his hands lengthened, padlocked at the wrist with Oathen locks. Each weighs nine pounds. Armor 4 to the hands only; a blow with one is a Stunning strike. The keys are held by Corrow and by the Captain of the detail.
- ◇ **A silk blindfold** — grey, which he puts on, awkwardly, with his mittened hands, whenever anyone opens the hatch, so that he will not finish them by looking.
- ◇ **The page-turner** — a long ivory paddle, slid through the hatch for the guards to use. He has a list of the books he has read since 629. It is three hundred and nine titles long.
- ◇ **A knotted thread** — unravelled from his blanket and knotted with his teeth: twelve knots. One for each guard he has finished through the door. He keeps it under his tongue when he sleeps.
- ◇ **A dead fly** — under an upturned glass on his table, the first thing his Closing Gaze ever finished, in 636. Perfect, unrotting, eight years dead. He keeps it to remind himself what looking can do.
- ◇ **Hethe's letters** — forty-one letters from Lord Absalom Hethe, read to him by the guards and kept in a box. They speak of usefulness, of service, of the Rim, of a great table where a man of his gifts would be honored.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Osric wants to be of use. He has spent twelve years doing nothing but not-harming, and it has nearly broken him, and he would accept almost any task framed as a duty: the Reckoners, the Fast, the Second Table, anyone. He fears that he is the cause of the Glovehall Hush, and that his sister has been too kind to tell him.

**Secret the GM can reveal:** he has been finishing his guards through the door, by stare, one a month, for a year. He chooses the ones who have told him they are tired: the ones who say, through the hatch, that they wish it were over. He listens for days to be sure. Then he takes off the blindfold and looks at the place in the door where he knows they are standing, for a full minute. The Court replaces them and does not connect the deaths. He keeps count. **Secret he does not know:** the Glovehall Hush is growing from Corrow's rooms, not his. He has been blaming himself for a silence his sister made. And **Lord Absalom Hethe** does not mean to use him against an enemy. He means to carry him to the Rim in a lead coffin and put him to the work of closing a god when it is ready to be eaten again.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — his sister, whom he adores and whom he has not seen bare-faced in twelve years. They speak through the door. He does not know what she is hiding.
- ◇ **Lord Absalom Hethe** — his only friend, he believes. Thursday is the best day of his week.

- ◇ **Pell Ambry** — the Fatlander he made Kept with a handshake. Osric pays his rent in Stranger's Row through a lawyer, and has never been able to write to him.
- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — whose men guard him, and keep dying. Morrow has begun to suspect.
- ◇ **Lord Casimir Hollowe-Vane** — a young cousin who wrote to him every month, and stopped. Osric believes, rightly, that Casimir ran from Sallowreach to avoid becoming him.
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — he has heard about her through the hatch. He has asked to meet her, with his eyes covered. He would like to ask her whether it is cold.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Osric as guards, as messengers for Corrow or Hethe, as thieves sent by the Second Table, the Heirs or Marrow Jack, or simply by hearing a voice through a door at Glovehall asking for news.

- ◇ **The Thirteenth Guard.** A PC is posted to the west-wing detail. Osric is charming. He asks how the PC sleeps. A week later he asks whether the PC is tired. Players who read the knotted thread may work out what is coming.
- ◇ **The Lead Coffin.** Lord Hethe has commissioned a lead coffin from a plumber in Tanner's Boards, with air-holes and a lock on the inside. The plumber, frightened, hires the PCs to find out who it is for.
- ◇ **The Useful Man.** A Hush is crossing the border road toward the Last Lamp. The Court considers asking Osric to stand at its edge and stare it back. It is not certain he can, or that he would not simply widen it. Osric is thrilled to be asked.

**Threat:** he does not threaten; he apologizes, and the room goes quiet. If attacked, he holds still and asks that nobody hurt themselves on him. **Kindness:** he weeps, without moving his face. **The god:** he feels it as peace, and he is frightened of how much he likes it. **If nobody intervenes:** Lord Hethe takes him out of Glovehall in the lead coffin within the year, by night, across the Sump. He is never seen again in the north. Somewhere on the Rim, a long time later, a regrowing god is closed like a book, and the man who did it is thanked, and then sealed back into his lead.

## SAID OF THEM

"He asked after my little girl. Every day. He remembered her name. And then one morning he asked me if I was tired, and I said no, sir, never better, and I put in for a transfer that afternoon." — Corporal Annis Wray, Fen Guard

"The gentlest man in the country, behind the thickest door. That is Sallowreach in a sentence." — Lord Absalom Hethe

"You don't hear the west wing. That's how you know it's there." — a Glovehall gardener



# THESSALY MORT

Master Seamer

*“Hold still. You’re two hundred years old, you can hold still for thirty stitches. There. Now you’re somebody again. Next.”*

– THESSALY MORT, AT HER TABLE ON NEEDLE STREET, RESTITCHING WEEK

| THESSALY MORT – MASTER SEAMER |                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                 | 245 (born 396, Kept since 441); Master Seamer of the Guild since 451                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING            | Seamer · Standing 5 (Guild Elder; head of the Guild)                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                        |
| SKILLS                        | Stitching 6, Craft 4, Endure 4, Reckoning 3, Haggle 3, Clause 2, Blades 1                                  |
| BODY                          | Flesh 15 · Guard 11 (the wire lattice stiffens her) · Armor 3 (wire lattice) · Fray 5                      |
| ATTACKS                       | curved needle +6 (2; on a Helping against a Kept target she unstitches a limb)                             |
| GIFTS                         | Kept; Master’s Hands (restitches a Ruined Kept body in an hour; removes 2 Rot per sitting); Lidsense       |
| WANTS                         | Keep Count (must record every replaced part, hers or anyone’s, before the day ends; resist Hard 14)        |
| KNACKS                        | Steady Hands, Mother’s Hands, Butcher’s Calm                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                  | Not My Hand (her right hand, bought in 639, sometimes stops in the middle of a seam and will not go on)    |
| CARRIES                       | the curved needle, the Ledger of Parts, the Guild thimble, the strike-bell key, gold lacquer, a donor list |
| DREAD                         | 2 (to see her ledger, or to watch her work on herself)                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

Thessaly Mort glimmers. Every seam in her body, and there are hundreds, is lacquered in cedar-gold, so that she looks like a bowl broken many times and mended in a very good shop. Her skin is a dozen skins in a dozen shades joined by fine gold lines; her joints are braced with a lattice of bright wire that ticks when she walks. One eye is grey and her own; the other is brown and bought. She smells of waxed thread, pitch and spirits of wine. Her voice is a deep, warm contralto of the Glad Century, bought in 498 from a Kept singer named Maud Fennick, who sold it to pay for her daughter’s shelving and has been mute ever since.

She is brisk, practical and funny, and never sits without a work-table in front of her.

## THEIR STORY

Thessaly was born in 396 above a wire-drawer’s shop on Needle Street and was a Threader at twelve. She died at forty-five of the Seamers’ cough, at her table, in the middle of a seam, and finished the seam before anyone noticed. She was elected Master in 451, and in 459, when the Court tried to tax wire, she rang the Guild’s strike-

bell for the only time. The tax was withdrawn in nine days, and the Regent has dined with her every Restitching Week since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Thessaly holds the country together, literally. The Guild’s six hundred Seamers restitch a hundred and forty thousand Kept a year; she sets their rates, approves every Master, and owns, in the Guild’s name, the stock-room of spare parts behind the Guildhall, every limb labeled and legally acquired, or so the labels say. She still works the table herself every day from first bell, on the hard cases: Fen Guard soldiers, the burned of Smokeholm, Captain Morrow. She takes no fee for children.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The curved needle** — a Seamer’s needle of black steel, as long as her hand, which she has used since 420. Her original right hand used it. Her present right hand does not like it.
- ◇ **The Ledger of Parts** — calf-bound, worn smooth. The first page lists her originals. It is three lines long: *left eye; two fingers, right hand (since lost); the part that remembers*. The other two hundred pages list everything else, with the donor’s name where she knows it.

- ◇ **The Guild thimble** — gold, set with a fly in amber, the badge of the Master Seamer since 130.
- ◇ **The strike-bell key** — the iron key to the bell-tower of the Guildhall. When it rings, every needle in the country stops.
- ◇ **Gold lacquer** — a pot of her own blend, cedar and resin and gold-leaf, which she uses only on herself.
- ◇ **A donor list** — the names of every person whose part she wears. On every feast day she sends a crumb to each family that can be found. Twenty-nine of the names she cannot trace. Eleven of them are recent.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Thessaly wants the work to go on. She wants pay, respect and to be left alone, and she wants to keep count. She fears that she is no longer anyone: that if the third line of the ledger goes, there will be nothing left that was Thessaly Mort, only a very good Seamer wearing other people.

**Secret the GM can reveal:** Marrow Jack was her Journeyman, expelled in 619 for selling parts, and he supplies her still, through Nan Pickering. A third of the parts in the Guild's stock-room came from him. If this were known, the Guild would be ruined, and the Court would have its excuse to put the Seamers under a Licenser. **Secret she does not know:** her new right hand, bought in 639, came from Marrow Jack too. It belonged to a Kept woman named Edony Sallis, who felt every stitch Thessaly made with it, followed the feeling across the city to Jack's stock-room, and is there now, in eleven pieces. The hand stops in the middle of seams because Edony is trying to make it stop.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — her oldest client and oldest rival. She fitted his throat-tube. She could leave it out.
- ◇ **Marrow Jack** — her expelled Journeyman, her secret supplier, the one person who could ruin her with a sentence.
- ◇ **Mistress Winifred Harl** — her most trusted Seamer, who has started counting what comes into the stock-room.
- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — stitched by her sixty times. She knows about the finger in the barracks box and has not reported it.
- ◇ **Old Bettany Shroud** — an ally of fifty years; the Guild gives the Lofts linen at cost.
- ◇ **Wick Tallow** — who takes, at a fair price, everything the Guild cannot use.
- ◇ **Dr. Halloran Quease** — who wants to measure her pain. She has let him once.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Thessaly at her table, as clients, as Threaders, or when she needs odd jobs done quietly: stolen parts recovered, a back-alley seamer shut down, Marrow Jack watched.

- ◇ **Count the Stock.** Mistress Harl hires the PCs to count what comes in the stock-room's back door for a month. What they find leads to Nan Pickering, then to Jack, then back to the Master.
- ◇ **The Stopping Hand.** Thessaly's right hand stops mid-seam during a Closing-eve restitching of an Unvacated alderman, and will not go on. She asks the PCs to find out whose it was.
- ◇ **The Bell.** The Court has announced a levy on wire again. Thessaly asks the PCs to carry the strike-bell key to the Guildhall at midnight, past the Right Hand's agents, so that she can choose whether to ring it.

**Threat:** she unstitches, carefully, one seam at a time. **Kindness:** she is gruff, and remembers it for a century. **The god:** she barely feels it; it is the one part of her that is still entirely her own. **If nobody intervenes:** the secret of Jack's stock comes out within the year, the Court moves against the Guild, Thessaly rings the bell, and the Sinks fill knee-deep again.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She did my gran's face in 512 and she did my face last spring and she did it the same, exactly the same, as if she'd kept the pattern. She had." — Teal Mallory

"The Master Seamer is the only person in Sallowreach the Regent cannot outwait. She is also waiting." — Provost Carrion Sedge

"I taught Jack everything he knows. Write that down somewhere, and then burn it." — Thessaly Mort

# JORY WELT

the Boy

*“I’m seventy-one. I’ve buried no one. I’ve inherited nothing. I’ve signed nothing. Tonight we go out to the grey with Alderman Pask in a sack, and when we come home I’ll have done the only grown-up thing I’ve ever been allowed to do. God help me.”*

– JORY WELT, TO A NEW BEQUEATHER, THE SMOKING GROUND, 640 A.G.

| JORY WELT – THE BOY |                                                                                                             |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT          | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                     |
| AGE & STATION       | 71, living, legally a minor; leader of the Heirs                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING  | Scion (disinherited) · Standing 1 (Cadet, in law); the Heirs’ rank 5, the Boy                               |
| ATTRIBUTES          | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                         |
| SKILLS              | Persuade 4, Blades 3, Endure 3, Reckoning 3, Wayfaring 3, Stealth 2, Search 2, Clause 1                     |
| BODY                | Flesh 14 · Guard 15 (16, less one for the knees) · Armor 1 (padded coat) · Fray 6                           |
| ATTACKS             | boathook +6 (4, Hooking); knife +6 (2)                                                                      |
| GIFTS               | none; he is entirely ordinary, which is his strength                                                        |
| WANTS               | none; his compulsions are his own                                                                           |
| KNACKS              | Second Chair, Corpse-Road Walker, Old Grief                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS        | none, yet                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES             | the boathook, the Hush map, a measuring chain, the cut-hand token, the Book of the Taken, the donor’s notes |
| DREAD               | 0                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

Jory is a stooped old man with white whiskers, swollen knuckles and bad knees, whose voice still cracks with anger like a boy’s. He smells of oak bark, lime and old dogs: he lives over a tannery with two elderly Kept hounds, Tansy and Bray. He dresses as what he is in law, a minor, in a clerk’s patched coat with no ring and no seal. He laughs easily with children and almost never with adults.

## THEIR STORY

Jory was born in 570 to Agnes Welt, living, and Alderman Rufus Welt of the Weir Row parish, who was two hundred and twenty-nine and still breathing, withered as the very old of the north become. Rufus’s heart stopped the next winter in his counting-house, and he sat up and finished the quarter’s accounts. At twenty Jory asked to be apprenticed, at forty to marry, at fifty to be paid his own wages; his father refused all three. He joined the Heirs at fifty-two and was chosen Boy in 614, as the only Executor nobody hated.

In 634, a year after Dunmere, he took the first elder to the grey, a Kept grandfather who had asked to go, and watched him go soft at

the line. The Heirs have taken a hundred and six since, most of them willing, nineteen not.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Jory commands perhaps three thousand Heirs in cells of twelve, the presses of *The Bequest*, forty punts and the Hush map, and through the living servants of every Unvacated household he has eyes in all of them. He depends on donors and on Saul Brindle’s silence. His limit is hard: he can break the law but not change it. Every elder taken to the grey is one less owner, but the property passes to the next oldest Kept. In seven years the Heirs have not won a single house.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The boathook** — ash-hafted, iron-headed, from his punt. The tool of the trade, for hooking a sack into the boat and over the line.
- ◇ **The Hush map** — four feet by six, on sailcloth, every Hush marked in red, every Hand-line estate in black pins, measured weekly. Provost Sedge would recognize the pattern at once. Jory has not quite let himself see it.

- ◇ **A measuring chain** — a surveyor’s chain stolen from the Court’s own stores.
- ◇ **The cut-hand token** — a disc of bone carved with a hand cut off at the wrist, the badge of the Heirs since 288. His is the original, carried by every Boy.
- ◇ **The Book of the Taken** — a small black notebook, one name a page, a hundred and six pages. Under each name, in Jory’s hand, whether they went willingly, and what they said at the line.
- ◇ **The donor’s notes** — a bundle of twenty notes, each wrapped round a platter or a minute, left at the tannery door. Each is signed only *A Friend of the Living*. Each uses the phrase *make them last*.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Jory wants the living to inherit. He wants, more privately, to rest. He fears that he has not freed anyone, only found a new way to bury his elders without mourning them.

**Secret the GM can reveal:** in 639 his father, Rufus, sent for him and asked, plainly and in private, to be the next one taken to the Hush. Jory refused. He has not been able to give a reason, to his father or to himself, and has not gone back. **Secret he does not know:** the anonymous donor is Rufus Welt, who has been funding the Heirs for six years out of his rents. *Make them last* is what Rufus said every Plenty-day for fifty years, when he handed his son eight lacks. Jory has read the phrase twenty times and has not heard it.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Alderman Rufus Welt** — his Kept father, three hundred and upright, who wants to go to the grey and is paying for it.
- ◇ **Saul Brindle** — his landlord and oldest friend, who is beginning to look at his own father’s hands.
- ◇ **Lark Dunnock** — his printer, whose father is in the Jar Room. She wants Jory to raid it.
- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — whose Court has adjourned Jory’s petition for an allowance since 601. They have never met.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — whose Finishers walk willingly, where Jory’s Heirs drag. They despise each other’s methods and use each other’s routes.
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — a child of the Sinks. Jory has had her watched, for her protection, and has had to stop two of his own cells from taking her.
- ◇ **Withhold Pennick** — the stranded Reckoner, who has offered him her knife. He has not said no.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Jory if they are living and disinherited, if they help with something that cannot be undone, or if the Court sends them to find him.

- ◇ **The Nineteenth.** One of the nineteen unwilling elders was an Heir’s mother, taken by mistake: the wrong sack in the dark. Her son wants Jory’s head in a jar. Jory wants the PCs to find out if the woman went quietly.
- ◇ **The Forged Licenses.** The Heirs have been buying Closing licenses from an unknown seller at the Court (Ivo Vane). Jory wants to know who, before the Court finds out.
- ◇ **Father’s Day.** Rufus Welt sends for the PCs, not his son. He wants to be taken to the grey by strangers, so that Jory does not have to. He will pay well. He would like, when he goes over the line, for someone to tell his boy.

**Threat:** he scatters his cells and waits; he is old and has learned patience from the people he hates. **Kindness:** he accepts it awkwardly, like a boy given a coin. **The god:** at the Taste, he has started closing his door three times before he sleeps, and it frightens him more than the Court. **If nobody intervenes:** within a year, the Heirs split. The young wing (in their forties) begins taking Hand-line children, because the map shows where the god is coming from. Jory, unable to stop them, takes his father to the Hush at last, alone, by night, and does not come back from the edge.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He took my grandad to the grey. Grandad asked him to. Grandad held his hand the whole way in the punt and told him jokes. I think it was the nicest day Grandad had in a hundred years.” — a living girl of twelve, the Sinks

“The Boy is a murderer and a sentimental one. That is the most dangerous kind.” — a Licensor of the Court

“Seventy-one and still asks permission before he sits down in my house. His father did that to him. I’d like to do something to his father.” — Saul Brindle

# OLD BETTANY SHROUD

## Warden of the Lofts

*“Hush now, Hall Three. I’m here. I’m only on the ladder. No, I’m not leaving. I’ve brought my blanket. Tell me again, slowly, and I’ll write it down.”*

— OLD BETTANY SHROUD, NINTH BELL, THE LOFTS

| OLD BETTANY SHROUD – WARDEN OF THE LOFTS |                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                            | 88, living; Warden of the Lofts since 601                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Nightwarden (Loft-Warden) · Standing 5 (Commander; Warden of the Lofts)                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                                   | Lore 5, Resolve 4, Search 3, Instinct 3, Rites 3, Persuade 3, Reckoning 2                                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 6 (and rising)                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                                  | fist +1 (1); she will hook you with a shelving hook if she must, +1 (3, Hooking)                                                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                                    | none of the god’s. The Wardens’ own gift: Forty Thousand Ears (once per session, ask one question about anything said within earshot of the Lofts in the last fifty years; she knows, or knows which book) |
| WANTS                                    | none of the god’s; she must not leave the shelved alone at night (her own vow)                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                                   | Elder’s Ear, Silent Supper, Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none; but see Wants, Fears and Secrets                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                                  | the whisper-books, the nine keys, a lamp, a shelving hook, a reading list, her own label                                                                                                                   |
| DREAD                                    | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

### WHO THEY ARE

Bettany is small, bent nearly double, and wrapped in so many camphor-smelling shawls that she looks like a bundle of washing that has learned to walk. Her fingers are inked to the second knuckle. Her voice is a reader’s voice, low and clear, trained over seventy years to carry along an aisle of four hundred shelved bodies without being raised. She is kind, dry and stubborn, and Court officers who have tried to buy the whisper-books know her for a single word, *no*, delivered as though declining a second biscuit.

### THEIR STORY

Bettany was born on Loftside in 553, the daughter of a wrapper. She became a Ladder-hand at twelve, reading for a crumb a night to the shelved of Hall Two, and has climbed the ladders every night since. In 591, as a Reader, she began writing down what the shelved whispered back: it seemed rude, she said later, to let them talk and not keep it. Those notebooks became the first whisper-books. She was made Warden of the Lofts in 601, and her first act was to forbid the Senior Wardens to sell what was in them. Her mother was shelved in Hall One in 612, and Bettany reads to her every Plenty-day.

In the Lack of 640 she heard the first of the shelved say *company*. By Grace 641 all forty thousand were saying it. She moved a cot into the Lofts that week, between the shelves of Hall Nine, and has slept there since.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Bettany commands two hundred Wardens, Readers and Ladder-hands, keeps nine halls and forty thousand people who cannot move, and bargains linen with the Guild and shelf-fees with the Court. She also holds, in a hundred and twelve whisper-books, every conversation held near the walls of the north city for fifty years. The Court, the Heirs, the College and Envoy Dray have all tried to buy them. She has never sold one line.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The whisper-books** — a hundred and twelve, kept in a cedar press in Hall Nine. She carries the current one, the hundred and twelfth, everywhere. Its last forty pages contain a single word, over and over, in forty thousand columns.
- ♦ **The nine keys** — iron, on a ring at her belt, one for each hall. There is a tenth hook on the ring with no key on it. It was there when she inherited the ring.

- ◇ **A lamp** — tin, shuttered, burning one of Wick Tallow’s candles, which she buys by the box because they do not gutter on the ladders.
- ◇ **A shelving hook** — a Loft-Warden’s hook (8 lacks), for lifting the Set-Aside down for visits.
- ◇ **A reading list** — the names of the shelved whom nobody visits, eleven thousand of them, with what each liked to hear.
- ◇ **Her own label** — written in her own hand and kept in her apron: *Bettany Shroud, Warden. Hall Nine. Read to me.*

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Bettany wants the shelved not to be alone. She fears that something is coming up the stairs, and that when it arrives there will be nobody awake in the Lofts but her.

**Secret the GM can reveal:** the whisper-books record, among ten thousand other things, the night in 340 when a Kept man was carried past Hall One in a sack, shouting that he was Regent of Sallowreach. A shelved clerk heard the name. Bettany has known for fifty years who is in Sack Seventeen. **Secret she does not know:** the shelved are not warning her. They are not afraid. At night, in every hall, the wrapped heads turn, all together, toward the stair, as a household turns when the knock comes downstairs, and they are not whispering *company* the way you whisper a danger. They are whispering it the way you whisper to the children to sit up straight. (The GM may consult the Secrets chapter about who might be expected.) And Bettany has begun to say it in her sleep.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Aldo Penny** — her Reader in Hall Six and her likely successor, who has started to say the word too.
- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — an ally of fifty years; their bargains over linen are famously cordial.
- ◇ **Marrow Jack** — her enemy. He takes hands from the shelved, and she has hooked him once.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — whose Finishers take the shelved who ask, and whom Bettany quietly lets in by the back stair.
- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — who has sent for the whisper-books four times. She has sent back a reading list.
- ◇ **Grandfather Peat** — whom she has never met. When Provost Sedge told her what Peat does with his fingers, she went white.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Bettany if they come to the Lofts to visit, to steal, or to learn what someone said. She is the best source of information in Lastgate and will give it only for a reason she believes.

- ◇ **The Unvisited.** She asks the PCs to read to the shelved of Hall Seven for a night. By morning, a shelved woman has told one of

them a secret about the PC’s own family.

- ◇ **The Tenth Key.** Bettany asks the PCs to find out what the tenth hook on the ring once opened. The oldest plans of the Lofts show a tenth hall, under the other nine, which was never built.
- ◇ **When They Arrive.** On Tablenight, every shelved body in the Lofts goes silent at once. Bettany, alone on her cot, sends Aldo running for the PCs.

**Threat:** she says no. **Kindness:** she takes it, and puts it to use for the shelved. **The god:** distant; she has the Taste only, and closes the Lofts’ doors gently, every one, every night. **If nobody intervenes:** she dies in the Lofts, in her sleep, at ninety, and is found sitting up on her cot with the book open, and is Kept, and stays, and goes on writing.

#### SAID OF THEM

“Old Bet read to my gran every night for thirty years, and my gran was a terrible woman, and Bet never once skipped her.” — a Loftside lodger

“I offered her a full license for one volume. She said she was saving her license for later, thank you.” — Envoy Castellan Dray

“She knows everything. That’s the trouble. Nobody’s ever been able to make her say any of it.” — a Right Hand agent, in his report



# PIM SORREL

## the Scrap Finisher

*“I don’t want to do it to anybody. I only do it when they ask. And the candle asked. It did, I heard it. Can I go to school now?”*

— PIM SORREL, TO A COURT EXAMINER, CARVING 641

| PIM SORREL – THE SCRAP FINISHER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                      | Sallowreach · Cut 1 (Scrapling, Grinholm stock) · Regrowth 2 by the College’s measure (impossible) · Hunger 0 (always)                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                   | 12, living; a girl of the Sinks                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING              | none (she guts eels with her mother)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTRIBUTES                      | Hand 3 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                          | Instinct 4, Athletics 2, Stealth 2, Filch 2, Godsign 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| BODY                            | Flesh 10 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                         | none she would use; a bite and a kick +3 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                           | The Warm Closing (her bare hand, laid on anything that wants to end, finishes it, Kept or creature or flame, with no roll; a finished thing does not rot afterward but stays perfect, as things do inside a Hush; she gains no Hunger); The Kneeling (Hush-walkers and Undone Closers kneel when she comes near, and do not touch her) |
| WANTS                           | none of the god’s that anyone can measure                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                          | Scrap-Born Luck, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                    | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                         | a slate and chalk, Tib in a box, wool mittens, an eel-knife, a spoon crown, her father’s ribbon                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                           | 0 (to meet); 3 (to watch her close someone, because it is so gentle)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

### WHO THEY ARE

Pim is a thin, quick, freckled girl of twelve with eel-shear-cropped hair, a gap in her front teeth and a habit of standing on one foot when she thinks. She smells of peat smoke and eel. Everyone looks at her hands, and there is nothing to see: ordinary, warm, scraped across the knuckles, bitten nails. They are not grey. Candles do not lean from her. She laughs a great deal, and those with the Want of Quiet find her laughter does not trouble them.

She is clever, stubborn and a little bossy, and wants more than anything to go to the Seamers’ charity school on Needle Street.

### THEIR STORY

Pim was born in 629 to Orla Sorrel, an eel-gutter, and Davey Sorrel, an eel-man, both of Grinholm stock, two generations off the island. Davey drowned off Weir Row in 633 and came home Kept. In the Lack of 640 a cart crushed a cat on the boards outside their house, and it lay there crying and could not stop, and Pim picked it up. It was quiet. It stayed quiet. It is still perfect.

Since then she has closed a neighbor’s grandfather, who asked her for six months; two Smalls of the Drowned Storeys, who came up a grating to ask; and a candle, one of Wick Tallow’s, which she says asked her too. She has refused everyone else, including, every night, her father.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Pim is impossible: a Scrapling’s blood should not close anything, and she does it without the grey, the cold, the Hunger or the Court. A death that can be had for nothing ruins the license, so the Court wants her examined and, if need be, dissected. The Finishers want her crowned, Provost Sedge wants her measured, Marrow Jack wants her hands, Little Nell Ash wants her for the Smalls, and her mother wants her out of the country. The Sinks hide her and lie for her, and quietly, one by one, ask.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A slate and chalk** — for practicing her letters. She has written her name, her mother’s, and SCHOOL.
- ♦ **Tib in a box** — the cat, in a cardboard box with holes punched in it from habit. He is perfectly dead and perfectly whole and

smells of nothing. She does not know why she keeps him.

- ◇ **Wool mittens** — knitted by her mother after the cat, red, in imitation of the Hand-line mittens. They do nothing at all. She wears them to be polite.
- ◇ **An eel-knife** — short, blunt, for work.
- ◇ **A spoon crown** — a ring of three tarnished spoons, wired, sent up through a grating by Little Nell Ash. It is an invitation. It is also a claim.
- ◇ **Her father's ribbon** — the red cord Davey Sorrel wore on the Landing. She ties it on her own wrist when he asks her, again, and she says no.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Pim wants to go to school, to keep her mother safe, and to stop being asked. She is afraid of the men from the Court, of the singing Finishers who follow her in the street, and of the day she says yes to her father.

**Secrets (the GM chooses):** she is the great-granddaughter of a Vane bastard, which Sedge's ledgers record; or Ossel, growing back, is reaching through the least of its eaters first; or the face that the Scraplings boiled at Grinholm is waking, and what it does is not closing but *mercy*, and it does not need a Hand. **Secret she does not know:** in 641, Granny Ketch's pit at Grinholm began to curve upward at the corners on the same night Pim closed the candle. Whatever is waking there knows her.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Sorrel** — her mother, who would carry her across the border tonight if anyone would help.
- ◇ **Davey Sorrel** — her Kept father, who asks every night, and whom she loves too much.
- ◇ **Little Nell Ash** — the Queen of the Smalls, who wants Pim for her own and has a spoon crown waiting.
- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — who has asked for Pim to be brought to Glovehall. Pim has heard. She does not want to go.
- ◇ **Jory Welt** — whose Heirs watch her house, for her protection, and have twice argued about taking her.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — whose Finishers sing outside her window. Pim finds Lorn sad and kind and frightening.
- ◇ **Granny Ketch** — her great-great-great-grandmother, whom she has never met, sitting by a pit that is starting to smile.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Pim through her mother, who hires them to get the girl across the border, or because every faction in the city hires them to fetch her.

- ◇ **The Little Closer.** Orla hires the PCs to carry Pim south. The girl does not want to go, and nobody knows whether her touch

will stop at the border, or whether it will start working on the living.

- ◇ **The Queue.** A line has formed outside the Sorrels' door in the Sinks: forty Kept, silent, waiting. The Court is coming with Hookmen. The PCs must decide what to do with the queue.
- ◇ **The School.** Thessaly Mort will take Pim into the charity school, under Guild protection, if the PCs bring her proof of Marrow Jack's plans for the girl's hands.

**Threat:** she runs; she is fast and knows every grating in the Sinks.

**Kindness:** she trusts it at once, which is her danger. **The god:** she feels nothing at all, which frightens the College more than anything.

**If nobody intervenes:** the Court takes her before Restitching Week. Corrow Vane intercepts her at the Hall of Hands and takes her to Glovehall, and the orchard Hush stops growing for the first time in a year.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She held my old dad's hand and asked him, are you sure, three times, the way they do at the Hall. Where'd a little thing learn that? Nobody taught her." — a neighbor in the Sinks

"A Scrapling child with a closing touch is not a miracle. It is an error in my ledgers. I intend to find it." — Provost Carrion Sedge

"She doesn't go cold. That's the thing. Every one of them goes cold. She stays warm." — Lady Corrow Vane, to no one, in the Hall of Closings



# JUSTICE EVER LATHE

*the Honorable Maggot*

“Bzzzz-zz. Zz. Bzzzzzzz.”

– JUSTICE EVER LATHE, DELIVERING JUDGMENT; RENDERED BY HIS CLERK AS  
“THE CLAIM IS UPHELD, WITH COSTS, AND THE COURT NOTES THE  
DEFENDANT’S SMELL.”

| JUSTICE EVER LATHE – THE HONORABLE MAGGOT |                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 · Hunger 0                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                             | Kept since 389 (born 331); senior Justice of the Court of Wrongs since 402                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                        | Clausewright · Standing 4 (Senior of the Bench)                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                                | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                    | Clause 5, Lore 4, Instinct 3, Resolve 3, Intimidate 2                                                                                                 |
| BODY                                      | Flesh 6 (9, less what the colony has eaten) · Guard 9 (he cannot leave the bench) · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                  |
| ATTACKS                                   | swarm +3 (1; blinds for a round on a Helping)                                                                                                         |
| GIFTS                                     | Kept; The Hum (his rulings are delivered in the buzzing; any listener at Fray 5+ who hears a full sentence of it must make a Dread 1 check); Threat 4 |
| WANTS                                     | none that anyone can measure; the colony wants sugar and warmth                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                                    | Counting Habit, Unflinching                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                              | unknown; possibly The Splitting                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                                   | the seething robe, a silver skull-cap, the sugar-dish, the gavel, Pike’s ear-trumpet                                                                  |
| DREAD                                     | 2                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

Justice Lathe is a skeleton in a robe that moves: brown bone, a few black tendons and the colony, a great slow mass of flies and their children that has taken up residence in the skull. The black robe of office seethes. The bench smells of old meat, sugar and hive. When he rules, the colony rises in a drone that swells and falls exactly like speech, and the courtroom leans forward to hear it, and then leans back to listen to his clerk.

## THEIR STORY

Ever Lathe was a contract-drafter who fell down the courthouse stair in 389 and went on drafting. Grue appointed him in 402. His tongue went in the 450s, his face in the 520s; the flies came about 560. By 590 nobody could tell whether the hum was Lathe, and the Court decided it would be indelicate to ask.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Lathe hears the bulk of the north’s ordinary justice: debts, nuisances, grievous unmaking, falling-apart fines, the endless suits of the Kept against one another. His rulings are famously fair and his conviction rate has never been higher. Everything passes through his

clerk, **Absalom Pike**, a living man of sixty-four with a gentle face and an ear-trumpet, who has translated the Justice for forty-one years.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The seething robe** — the black robe of office, which nobody may remove, because the colony lives in it.
- ◇ **A silver skull-cap** — a mesh of silver wire fitted by the Guild to keep the colony from leaving in a Black Noon.
- ◇ **The sugar-dish** — a saucer of sugar-water on the bench, refreshed hourly. When it runs dry, the rulings grow harsher.
- ◇ **The gavel** — a black oak mallet he cannot lift. Pike strikes it.
- ◇ **Pike’s ear-trumpet** — brass, shaped like a lily, by which Pike claims to hear words in the hum.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Nobody knows what Lathe wants, which is the point. **Secret the GM can reveal (choose one):** Pike has been inventing the rulings since 590, and he is a very good judge; or Lathe is still in there, deciding, and Pike translates faithfully; or the colony decides, and what it wants, rulings that keep things going and never close a case,

is what Ossel's eaters have made of every living thing in the north. **Secret he does not know:** Pike is going deaf, really deaf, and has not told anyone.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Absalom Pike** — his clerk and voice; the most important man in the Court of Wrongs, whom nobody fears.
- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — his appointer, who reads every ruling and agrees with all of them.
- ◇ **Fenwick Lisp** — the jaw-click interpreter; the two clerks of the inarticulate dead are bitter professional rivals.
- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — who fitted the skull-cap and wants to know what is inside it.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Lathe as plaintiffs, defendants or witnesses in the Court of Wrongs, which is to say, sooner or later, everyone in Sallowreach does. **Seeds:** a PC is sued by a Kept man they unmade in a fight, and the hum seems to favour the plaintiff until a PC puts honey in the dish; Pike, going deaf, secretly hires a PC to listen to the hum and tell him what they hear; a Black Noon strikes the courthouse, and the colony leaves the Justice in the middle of a ruling, and everyone waits to see if the bones go on judging. **Threat:** the swarm rises; costs are awarded. **Kindness:** the hum softens. **The god:** none visible. **If nobody intervenes:** Pike dies within five years, and the Court appoints a new clerk, who hears something entirely different.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Best judge I ever lost in front of." — a Sinks fence, three times convicted

"I hear him, in the trumpet. Not words. A kind of leaning. Like a scale tipping. I just say which way." — Absalom Pike

"Don't stand near the bench in Plenty, love. They breed." — an usher of the Court of Wrongs

# DR. HALLORAN QUEASE

*the Physician of Pain*

*“Number two hundred and twelve, the long bell: the pain of a seam pulling through, felt as a single note sustained. Thank you, Mother Nettle. Two drops. You were very brave. Now, would you describe it again, more slowly?”*

— DR. HALLORAN QUEASE, AT HIS SURGERY

| DR. HALLORAN QUEASE – THE PHYSICIAN OF PAIN |                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                |
| AGE & STATION                               | 50, living; physician, of the Eighth Storey under Hand Street                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Seamer (ungilded physician) · Standing 3 (Seamer, by courtesy)                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                    |
| SKILLS                                      | Stitching 4, Reckoning 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Persuade 2, Endure 2, Blades 1             |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                     | scalpel +4 (2, Ripping)                                                                |
| GIFTS                                       | none; method only (+2 to any roll to diagnose, describe or relieve pain)               |
| WANTS                                       | none of the god’s; he must record any new pain he witnesses, at once                   |
| KNACKS                                      | Steady Hands, Counting Habit, Pin-Cushion                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | none acknowledged                                                                      |
| CARRIES                                     | the Quease Index, the dolorimeter, poppy drops, carbolic and lemon, his volunteer roll |
| DREAD                                       | 1 (his surgery)                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

Quease is plump, pink, scrupulously clean, and smells of carbolic and lemon, in a land where everybody smells of something worse. He wears white linen, boiled daily, and a physician’s black cap. His voice is soft and interested. He asks good questions and listens to the answers with his whole face, and his patients love him, and then, sometimes, watching him write, they feel cold.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 591 to a Landing apothecary, Quease trained in Oathen, came home in 618, and found there was no illness in Sallowreach worth a physician’s time, because none was fatal. Only pain remained. He began cataloguing it in 620. The **Quease Index** now lists four hundred kinds, from *the long bell* to *the attic*, the ache of being shelved and forgotten, which he considers the worst and the most common.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He runs a surgery under Hand Street where Kept volunteers let him test them in return for poppy drops. He sells relief to the Unvacated at Upper Boards prices, consults for the Guild on difficult

restitchings, and advises the Court on how much pain a sentence ought to involve. That last he does not discuss.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Quease Index** — four leather volumes, four hundred entries, each with a name, a description, a scale, and a treatment, if any.
- ◇ **The dolorimeter** — a brass screw-press with a graduated dial, which measures pain by the pressure a patient bears before speaking. He invented it. He is proud of it, and ashamed.
- ◇ **Poppy drops** — laudanum (1 lack a dose), the currency of his surgery.
- ◇ **Carbolic and lemon** — for his hands, constantly.
- ◇ **His volunteer roll** — thirty-one Kept names, with what each has endured. He visits them on feast days.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to end pain. He fears that he enjoys measuring it, and that the dial is the part he loves. **Secret the GM can reveal:** the Court has paid him, since 630, to design the procedure of the jarring so that it hurts exactly as much as the Regent specifies. **Secret he does**

**not know:** Mother Nettle, his oldest volunteer, has been inventing pains for him for six years, out of affection, because he looks so happy when he finds a new one. Thirty-one of the four hundred are hers.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — who let him measure her once and will not again.
- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — his most discreet client. He cannot tell whether the Regent feels anything.
- ◇ **Mother Nettle** — his volunteer, Kept since 498, his liar and his friend.
- ◇ **Edda Thrush** — whom he desperately wants to examine. Pain, in a Hush, might simply stop.

#### IN PLAY

He pays well for new kinds of pain (10 to 100 lacks a kind, if documented). **Seeds:** he hires the PCs to escort him to the edge of Dunmere Hush to measure whether pain ends there; a volunteer has vanished from his roll, and is found in the Jar Room under a false name; a PC Partakes in front of him, and he asks, very politely, if he may measure what the god's bite feels like. **Threat:** he summons the Hookmen and retreats behind his door. **Kindness:** he records it. **The god:** he dismisses it as an untreated pain. **If nobody intervenes:** the four-hundred-and-first entry is his own: *the ledger*, the pain of knowing exactly what you are.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He's the only one who ever asked me where it hurt. Two hundred years, and he's the first." — Mother Nettle, volunteer

"A good man with a terrible hobby, or a terrible man with a good bedside manner. I've known him twenty years and can't say which."  
— Mistress Winifred Harl

"He gives you drops. That's all you need to know about him, sir."  
— a put-out Kept man in the Sinks

# WICK TALLOW

the Chandler

*“Steady light, sixth bell light, light that will not leave you! Three nights a candle, madam, and it’ll never gutter on you. No, I couldn’t say who. Unclaimed, the lot. Does it matter?  
It’s light.”*

– WICK TALLOW, AT HIS SHOP DOOR ON WICK LANE

| WICK TALLOW – THE CHANDLER |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION              | 110 (born 531, Kept since 594); chandler of Wick Lane since 551                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Renderer · Standing 3 (Master Renderer)                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                     | Craft 5, Labor 4, Haggle 4, Feast 2, Endure 1, Reckoning 2                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                       | Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 (waxed hide) · Fray 1                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTACKS                    | rendering hook +4 (3, Hooking)                                                                                                                                                         |
| GIFTS                      | Kept (but slow to rot: he went into his own vat in 594 and came out half turned to grave-wax); Know the Cut (by smell he can tell whose tallow a candle is, once he has rendered them) |
| WANTS                      | none                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| KNACKS                     | Butcher’s Calm, Iron Stomach, Strong Back                                                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS               | none; he would think it impolite                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                    | the rendering hook, the batch ledger, a smoulder-coal, Bess’s candles, his wick-knife                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                      | 1                                                                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Wick is cheerful, broad and practical, and he shines. His forearms, and much of his chest and face, are smooth, pale, yellowish and slightly translucent, like soap, from the day in 594 when he fell into his own rendering-vat and the fat took him. He rots very slowly: grave-wax keeps. He smells of hot fat, smoke and singed hair, and when he stands near his own stove too long he softens, and has to step outside. He whistles while he works.

## THEIR STORY

Wick opened his chandlery in 551, at twenty, rendering mutton fat. The Court, short of sacking-space in the Sump, offered him the unclaimed dead in 560 at a price. He discovered that the tallow gave a light that would not gutter, and that the candles were warm, and that if you held one close you could hear it. He thought this was interesting, and a selling point. His wife Bess asked, before she was Set Aside in 618, to be made into candles instead of shelved. He did it himself.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Half of Lastgate reads by his candles. The Court supplies him with the unclaimed and the rendered remains of the jarred; families commission named candles of their own dead (50 lacks); and, lately, some families sell him their grandmothers quietly for the price of a restitching. His candles light the Hall of Hands, the Lofts and most of the Sinks.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The rendering hook** — iron, long-handled, for lifting from the vat.
- ◇ **The batch ledger** — every candle batch since 560, with whose tallow went into it, as far as he knows.
- ◇ **A smoulder-coal** — lit in 551, from which every candle in his shop has been lit.
- ◇ **Bess’s candles** — the last nine, in a cedar box. He burns one each Tablenight, and says her name, and does not speak for an hour.
- ◇ **His wick-knife** — small, very sharp, for trimming.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Wick wants trade and a quiet life. He fears very little, which is his horror. **Secret the GM can reveal:** he keeps a Tallow-Saint in his cellar, in a barrel of cold water to keep it hard; it was a family batch, burned together, that ran, and he could not bring himself to sink it. **Secret he does not know:** since Lack 640, at midnight, every Tallow candle in Lastgate has leaned, for one minute, toward the Ferrying Post, toward the place where the eighth figure keeps being gouged open. He has noticed only in his own shop, and puts it down to a draught.

## TIES

- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — the Guild sells him what cannot be stitched.
- ◇ **Old Bettany Shroud** — his best customer; the Lofts burn a box a week.
- ◇ **Ansel Grue** — whose desk is lit by Wick's candles, unnamed, from the Court's own supply.
- ◇ **Gideon Tarr** — who tars the Post, and who has noticed which way the candles lean.

## IN PLAY

**Seeds:** a family wants back a named candle of their mother that a thief has stolen, before it burns down; a Tallow-Saint walks out of a dinner on the Upper Boards, and the Court wants to know whose it was; a PC's Kept companion is sold to Wick by a desperate relative, and the vat is already hot. **Threat:** he swings the hook and calls the Hookmen, who are customers. **Kindness:** he gives a free candle. **The god:** he does not think about it. **If nobody intervenes:** the cellar barrel cracks one hot Plenty night.

## SAID OF THEM

"I read by my uncle every night. He's a lovely steady light. He never was, alive." — a clerk of the Upper Boards

"Wick's a good man. Everything he makes is screaming. Both things are true." — Mistress Winifred Harl

"You'd think the candles'd hate him. They lean toward him when he comes in." — Wick's journeyman

# GRANDFATHER PEAT

*the Last Witness*

*“Ha grinnet. Ha grinnet, the Hond. Ond the oother ... the oother ...” (He counts to eight on his fingers, and folds one down.)*

— GRANDFATHER PEAT, IN THE OLD FEN-TONGUE, TO PROVOST SEDGE

| GRANDFATHER PEAT – THE LAST WITNESS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | Sallowreach · Cut 0 (he never ate) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0                                                                                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                       | about 655 (drowned in the week of the Gorging, perhaps fourteen years old); hauled from the Sump in 611; kept in a tank at the College                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 1 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                              | Instinct 4, Resolve 5, Lore 3 (the world before), Wayfaring 2 (the old fen)                                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                                | Flesh 8 (the bog took one) · Guard 8 (he cannot rise from the tank) · Armor 1 (peat-tanned hide) · Fray 4                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                             | none (+0)                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                               | Kept; Bog-Sealed (no Rot ever; the peat has kept him as it kept him); The Old Tongue (speaks only the pre-Gorging fen dialect; understanding him is a Grim 18 Eye + Lore roll for a Cutwright, Impossible for anyone else); Threat 1 |
| WANTS                               | to go back in the water                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                              | Silent Supper, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | The Count (he counts to eight and folds one down, and cannot stop)                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                             | the rope at his throat, a peat-knife blade, his tank                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                               | 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Grandfather Peat is a boy who has been in the bog for six centuries and looks like a saddle: leather-brown, flattened, shining wet, with a fringe of rust-red hair and a braided rope knotted at his throat. He smells of peat, tannin and old rainwater. He lies in a zinc tank of fen-water in Provost Sedge’s offices with only his face above the surface, and speaks slowly, in a dialect nobody has spoken since before the Meal.

## THEIR STORY

He was a peat-cutter’s son. On the night the fen-folk ate Ossel he stood at the back of the crowd and did not eat, and stared past the god at the empty bank on the far side of the fire, and before dawn he ran into the fen, and the water took him. Nobody went after him. In 212 a reed-cutter found him floating at the Sump’s edge and, frightened, tied a stone to his neck and sank him again: that is the rope. A dredger brought him up for good in 611. Sedge bought him for forty lacks.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Peat is the College’s most precious and most useless witness: only three Cutwrights in the north can follow his dialect, and only Lecturer Odo Fask well. He repeats one thing, *the god was smiling*, and when asked more counts to eight on his fingers and folds one down, carefully, as if it might bite. He has asked every day since 611 to be put back.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The rope at his throat** — braided reed, with the stone’s knot still in it. He will not let anyone untie it.
- ◇ **A peat-knife blade** — the bronze blade of his father’s cutting-spade, found in his fist. He holds it still.
- ◇ **His tank** — zinc, eight feet long, which the College refills with Sump water weekly, because he will not settle in clean.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to go back in the water, where it is dark and nothing can see him. He fears being looked at. **Secret the GM can reveal:** Peat did not run from Ossel. He ran from what he saw on the empty bank, and from the moment it looked back at him. He will describe

it fully to anyone who learns his dialect and asks the right question (see the Secrets chapter). **Secret he does not know:** when Bettany Shroud's word *company* was said aloud in his hearing for the first time, he folded down not one finger but all eight, and pulled himself under the water, and the College has not been able to make him come up since.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Provost Carrion Sedge** — his owner and keeper, who wants the ledger of the Meal and gets one sentence.
- ◇ **Lecturer Odo Fask** — his only true listener, who has started dreaming in the old tongue.
- ◇ **Old Bettany Shroud** — whose word sent him under.
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — a child of the families who ate the face. He has asked, in his way, to see her.
- ◇ **Meek Garrity and Cray Lobbett** — strangers on the far Rim, whose tables and seating plans would make sense to him.

#### IN PLAY

**Seeds:** a PC who learns his dialect (a season of study with Fask) can ask him the right question; the Heirs or the Finishers want to steal him and put him back in the Sump, as he asks; the College is sending him south, by sealed tank, to the Cutwrights' great house, and he will drop to bone and dust at the Finishing Post unless someone stops it. **Threat:** he sinks. **Kindness:** he lets you see him smile, slowly, which is worse. **The god:** he never ate; there is nothing in him but the fen. **If nobody intervenes:** he stays under, and one night the tank is found empty, and the Sump's bubbles that week rise in rings of eight, with one ring missing.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Six hundred years in the bog and the first thing he did when they cut the sack was ask for the light to be turned away." — the dredger who found him

"He is the only person on the Table who saw the Meal and did not eat. That makes him the only honest witness to it." — Lecturer Odo Fask

"Grandfather? He's younger than my boy. Just been dead longer."  
— a College porter



# THE PEOPLE OF SALLOWREACH, CONTINUED

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*Everybody in Lastgate is waiting on somebody. The trick is to know who, and for how long, and whether they will still want you when you get there.*

— HOLLIS MEAD'S HOUSEKEEPER, TO THE COURT'S EXAMINERS, 641 A.G.

These dossiers continue the cast of the grey north: the people who live in the cracks between the land's great powers. Every one of them

is waiting for something to finish. Most of them are going to get it, and not in the way they hoped.

# SISTER LORN OF THE SHUT EYE

## High Shut Eye of the Finishers

*“Sing it to the end with me, love. Every word. Somebody has to hear the last of it, and it will not be you.”*

– SISTER LORN, TO A KEPT FISHERMAN AT THE EDGE OF THE COTTER’S DITCH  
HUSH, CARVING 640

| SISTER LORN OF THE SHUT EYE – HIGH SHUT EYE OF THE FINISHERS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                                   | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common fen blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                                                | Born 561 A.G.; Kept since 590 (died at twenty-nine); High Shut Eye of the Finishers                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                                           | Celebrant · Standing 5 (High Shut Eye)                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                                                   | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                                                       | Persuade 5, Rites 4, Resolve 3, Wayfaring 3, Lore 2, Instinct 2, Stitching 1                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                                                         | Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 9                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                                                      | none; she has never struck anyone, and her pilgrims would tear apart anyone who struck her                                                                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                                                        | Kept (Rot 4, Ripe; she keeps herself to it with mint and beeswax); the Last Verse (her singing grants all who hear it +2 to resist Dread for a scene); Lidsense (she knows, in the dark, which of her pilgrims have their eyes open) |
| WANTS                                                        | Lead (when a crowd of the grieving forms, she must step to its front and give it a direction; resist Hard 14); Close (at the Taste; she shuts the lids of the sleeping without meaning to)                                           |
| KNACKS                                                       | Old Grief; Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                                                 | The Pull (roused within a mile of a Hush, or at Fray 8+; she has mastered it nine hundred times and failed once)                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                                                      | a grey linen wrap; a bag of fen-mint; a beeswax candle stub; the Book of Names; a child’s tin whistle; nine hundred name-strips; a needle and black thread                                                                           |
| DREAD                                                        | 1 (her stitched eye, and what moves under the lid when she sings)                                                                                                                                                                    |

### WHO THEY ARE

Sister Lorn is slender and straight-backed, wrapped from throat to ankle in waxed grey linen that creaks faintly when she bends. Under thin lacquer her face has gone the color of tallow and settled in soft folds at the jaw. Her left eye is sewn shut with nine black stitches in the Glad Century’s mourning style; her right is grey-green, wet and kind. She chews fen-mint constantly, and its cold green smell rides over the sweetness beneath, with beeswax from the candles on her hands.

Her speaking voice is low and hoarse, with the long vowels of the far reed-towns. Her singing voice is deep, round and unhurried, and carries over open water as if from just behind the listener’s shoulder; people describe it as a warm hand laid between the shoulder blades. She wrote most of the Finisher songs. She will not sing in rooms. Rooms, she says, are for stopping.

### THEIR STORY

Lorn Teal was born in 561 in Cattermere, a reed-town of the far north fen where the Glad Century songs were still sung on holy

days. She sang in the reed-chapel from the age of six and was hired to sing at Restitching Weeks across the north, the hymns that are sung while the grandmothers are lacquered. She married a weir-man named Josse Teal and bore a daughter, Wren, in 584.

In the Plenty of 588, Wren went off the Cattermere boardwalk in a fly-front, at four, and came up in the morning, and has been four ever since. In 589 Lorn took her to Lastgate to find a Seamer who could keep a child sound forever, and could not pay one. In 590 Lorn died of a Fatlands fever in a rented room on Needle Street, with Wren sitting on the end of the bed. She sat up the next morning and Wren was gone: the Smalls had come up in the night and taken her down, as they take the child-dead whose families cannot keep them. Lorn sewed her own eye shut that week and went down to the Drowned Storeys every night for a year. The Smalls never let her past the first flooded stair.

For forty years she sang at Restitchings, Settings Aside and, from about 610, in a back room on Wick Lane where a few Kept met to sing the old songs with their last verses put back. In Carving 633, when Dunmere went silent, the Singers walked to the grey reeds

with candles and a list of names, and seven walked in. Lorn led the singing and stayed outside. She has stayed outside nine hundred times since. She was named High Shut Eye in 636, and wrote the Finishers' only rule: the living are not wanted yet.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Lorn is the most dangerous person in Sallowreach who has never harmed anyone. The Finishers number perhaps nine thousand now, most of them Kept, and they go where she points. Every pilgrimage is, in the Court's law, the theft of a licensed good: each Kept body that walks into a Hush is a Closing that was not paid for, four thousand lacks of the Court's only real currency, walked into the reeds. Lorn knows this. She does not preach against the Court. She does not need to.

She lies still by night in a loft above Wick Tallow's chandlery (he lets it free; her flock is his best customer), hears petitioners by morning, the Kept who want to walk and the living who want them not to, and three or four evenings a month leads a procession past the Court's guards, who mostly look away, to whichever Hush the Lamps have chosen. She sings. They walk. She walks back. Twice the Court has drawn up a warrant to jar her, and twice Regent Grue has declined to sign it: a priestess in a jar, he says, is a saint by morning.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Book of Names** — a fat, swollen ledger in waxed calfskin, every page water-stained. It holds the name, the date, the Hush and the last words of every pilgrim she has led in: nine hundred and four, as of this Carving. The last words are mostly ordinary. *Tell Bess the key is under the step. I'm not frightened. Is it cold?* A Cutwright or Court agent would pay well for it (Haggle vs Hard; 400 lacks or more), since it is also a list of every unlicensed death since 633.
- ◇ **The beeswax stub** — a candle she lit at the Dunmere edge in 633 and has relit at every edge since. In Sallowreach a fire does not go out, so she must close it by pinching; her fingers at the Taste can just do it, if she presses hard and thinks of nothing. It is the only candle she will not let Wick Tallow replace. It is not made of anybody.
- ◇ **Wren's whistle** — a tin whistle, dented, that her daughter blew from the Cattermere boardwalk. Lorn cannot play it; a Kept mouth has no breath. She holds it in her fist while she sings.
- ◇ **A Bottled Hush (unopened)** — a jar of edge-air given to her by a grateful family in 639 (Taint: Dread 4; see the Rim Market chapter). She has never opened it. She keeps it at the back of a shelf in the loft. She has never told anyone why she keeps it, and the answer is in the Secrets below.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Lorn wants her flock to go peacefully, unafraid, with someone singing. She wants the living left behind at the edge to be held by

someone. And she wants, more than she has ever wanted anything except her daughter back, to know why she has never walked.

She tells herself it is duty: someone must sing the last verse and hold the husbands at the line. She fears it is cowardice. Worse, she fears she enjoys it: that walking back along the causeway with nine fewer behind her is the only time in fifty years she has felt like someone who decides things.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** She walked to the edge once alone, at night, in Lack 639, and stopped one step from the line, with her toes in the green reeds and her face in the grey. She stood there until dawn. She has not told anyone, and she cannot forgive herself either way: not for going, and not for coming back.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** She keeps the Bottled Hush for Wren. She cannot get past the Smalls' first stair, but a jar can be carried by someone who can. She has never asked anyone to do it, because she does not know whether a four-year-old who has been four for fifty-three years can consent to anything.

**Secret she does not know:** Wren has asked to be closed. She asked Little Nell Ash in 640, formally, before the Smalls' assembly, and Nell has not yet given her answer. Wren is one of the Smalls who has heard about Pim Sorrel. And Lorn's own second, the Lamp Orla Fenn, has for two years been selling the location of every secret Hush to Lord Absalom Hethe, who passes them to the Court's Quiet Market party, which is surveying them as estates.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Little Nell Ash** — the queen who keeps her daughter. Lorn has petitioned her by letter, through the Loft-Wardens, two hundred times. Nell answers every letter, in a careful round hand, and every answer is no.
- ◇ **Dunstan Reave** — the living man who camps at Dunmere's edge. She sits with him some nights. He is the person she is most ashamed in front of, because he cannot walk in and she can.
- ◇ **Bram Hollin** — he has been teaching her singers the six last songs, at night, for money. She suspects the old songs are older than the Finishers and more dangerous; she has noticed that when Bram sings, the grey line at the edge comes a little closer.
- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — his guards stand at the Hushes to stop her. Some of his guards have walked in with her. He has never once arrested her, and she does not know why.
- ◇ **Sister Orla Fenn** — her Lamp and closest friend; secretly the Court's informer (see Secrets).
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — the Finishers want her crowned. Lorn does not. She has met the girl once and told her mother to take her south, and has told the Finishers' council the opposite.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Lorn at a Hush edge at dusk, or in her loft when a family hires them to bring someone home before the singing stops. She is courteous, tired and the most honest person in any scene. She wants

escorts past the cordons, strong arms to hold the living back at the edge, and, from any Hand-line PC at the Course, a private conversation about whether their touch would count, in the god's eyes, as walking in.

- ◇ **The Last Name.** A Kept grandmother in the Sinks has given Lorn her name for the next procession. Her living grandson hires the PCs to steal the name-strip back before the procession leaves. The grandmother wants to go. The grandson is sixty and has never lived a day without her.
- ◇ **The Informer.** A procession is ambushed by Court guards at a secret Hush only six people knew about. Lorn asks the PCs to find out which of her Lamps is selling them. It is the one she loves.
- ◇ **The Whistle.** Lorn asks a PC, very quietly, to carry a jar down the first flooded stair of the Drowned Storeys and leave it with a girl called Wren. She will not say what is in it. Nell Ash's Smalls are waiting on the stair.

Faced with threat, Lorn sings, and her pilgrims close around her. Faced with kindness she weeps without moisture. Faced with the god she goes still and must roll against the Pull. If nobody intervenes, she reaches Fray 10 at the next procession that loses a living child at the edge, Breaks, and walks in singing, with no one left outside to finish the song. The Finishers split within the season: half follow Orla Fenn toward the Court's bargain, half follow Pim Sorrel whether she wants them or not.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"She's got a voice on her like your mam calling you in for supper. That's the cruel part. You go." — a Kept net-mender, the Landing

"Nine hundred and four, and not one of them hers. Ask yourself what kind of shepherd that is." — Lady Corrow Vane, to the Court

"She held my hand at the line while my Tobias went over. She held it so hard she broke two of her own fingers. She didn't notice. I did."

— Mary Vell, living, of Cotter's Ditch

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# CAPTAIN DACE MORROW

*the Sixty-Times Slain*

*“I’ve died sixty times, son, and I’ll tell you what I learned from it. Keep your guard up. It doesn’t help, but it’s tidier.”*

– CAPTAIN MORROW, TO A NEW RECRUIT OF THE FEN GUARD, GRACE 641

| CAPTAIN DACE MORROW – THE SIXTY-TIMES SLAIN |                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                               | Born 548 A.G.; first killed 583 (aged thirty-five); Kept; Captain of the Fen Guard since 601                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Warden · Standing 5 (Captain of the Fen Guard; answers to the Right Hand of the Court)                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                                      | Blades 5, Endure 6, Intimidate 4, Wayfaring 3, Reckoning 2, Resolve 3, Athletics 1                                                                             |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 19 · Guard 16 (the wire lattice stiffens him) · Armor 3 (bone lamellar over wire) · Fray 6                                                               |
| ATTACKS                                     | sword +9 (4, Parrying); gauntleted fist +6 (1, Stunning on a Helping); he does not stop                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                       | Kept (Rot 6, Loose, held to Rot 4 in effect by constant Guild work); Thread-Bound (ignores the first Ruin each scene); Shield the Cargo (as the Warden Talent) |
| WANTS                                       | Hold the Line (when a line, post or cordon he commands is crossed, he must go to it personally; resist Hard 14)                                                |
| KNACKS                                      | Unflinching; Good Bones                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | The Count (he counts his deaths, his men and his missing parts; the number is always one short)                                                                |
| CARRIES                                     | his sword; the brass lattice; the Box; the Captain’s Roll; a horse that cannot die; a field-kit of wire and gut; a slate of sixty marks                        |
| DREAD                                       | 2 (to watch him take a killing blow and keep walking; 3 to watch him reassemble)                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Dace Morrow is tall, broad and wrong in his proportions, the way a mended chair is wrong. Sixty stitchings have replaced the man with cord: he is bound in grey linen cord from the neck down, under a cuirass of yellowed bone lamellar laced with wire. A lattice of brass strips riveted at temple and jaw holds his mottled face on like the frame of a lantern. His eyes are still his own, pale and steady. His right ear is a woman’s, pierced for an earring.

He smells of linseed, old blood and wet rope. The cord creaks when he walks, and something in his chest rattles on cold mornings, a loose rib he has decided to keep. His voice is slow, level and a little wet, and he has not needed to raise it since the forty-first time he was killed.

His soldiers love him in the dog-loyal way of men who have seen their captain take a halberd through the face and finish giving the order. Strangers find him unbearable to watch eat: he still sits at mess and chews, for the men, and the food goes where it goes.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 548 on the Landing, Morrow joined the Fen Guard at eighteen. In Carving 583 he met a Reckoner band on the causeway

with nine men, and a Reckoner Knife put a black-iron blade through his heart. He was standing again before she had wiped it, and he cut her down, and she died properly: she had fallen south of the causeway’s last stake, a fact he has turned over for fifty-eight years. That was the first time.

He has been killed since by Reckoners, Heirs, smugglers, a jealous husband, a falling crane, his own panicking horse, and once, in 627, by a Finisher procession that trampled him at the edge of a Hush he was holding. He became Captain in 601 when his predecessor walked across the Finishing Post one morning and did not explain. He keeps a slate in his office with sixty chalk marks on it.

The Fen Guard he commands is three thousand strong, nine in ten of them Kept: an army that cannot lose a man and cannot cross a border. It guards the causeway, the Finishing Post, the Court’s houses, the Lofts at night and, since 633, the cordons around the Hushes. That last duty is breaking it. Since 636 forty-one of his soldiers have walked into the Hushes they were posted to guard. He has not recruited replacements. He has recorded each one on the Captain’s Roll as *transferred*.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Morrow is the Mortuary Court's hard edge and no Court man. He answers to the Right Hand, and he is the only officer who will tell the Regent to his lacquered face that a thing cannot be done. The Court values him because he is incorruptible and fears him because he is tired.

His soldiers are paid little (two lacks a day for a Kept guardsman, four for the living) and stitched free by the Guild under an old contract, which is the real reason anyone joins. Morrow rides the causeway daily on a Kept horse named Pardon, inspects the Hush cordons at dusk, and every Tablenight stands a shift on the Finishing Post, just inside the stakes, looking south. He has never once seen the Rim Road with his own eyes.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **His sword** — a plain officer's sword (Sword, 4, Parrying), with a cord-wrapped hilt that his hand has rotted into the shape of. He has had his hand sewn to the grip twice in battle and once, in 620, permanently, for a week.
- ◇ **The brass lattice** — the frame that holds his face on, made by Thessaly Mort herself in 612 after a Reckoner took the face off with a cleaver. It counts as nothing in combat but makes him a Dread 1 sight to anyone new.
- ◇ **The Box** — a cedar munitions box kept by Sergeant Greer Abbot under her cot in the barracks. In it, wrapped in waxed paper and labeled in her hand, are the pieces of himself that Morrow has left lying around since 639: four fingers, an ear, three toes, a strip of scalp with hair on it, a kneecap. Abbot has not reported them. She has started to notice that the pieces are always found on the south side of the barracks, near the road.
- ◇ **The Captain's Roll** — the ledger of the Fen Guard. Forty-one entries marked *transferred*. He reads them aloud on the first of each month to an empty room.
- ◇ **Pardon** — his Kept horse (see the Rim Market chapter), grey, spavined, lacquered on the flanks. It has been dead since 609 and has never once let him fall since.
- ◇ **A slate of sixty marks** — chalk on slate, rubbed and redrawn. The sixtieth is fresh: an Heir's boathook in the Sinks, Lack 640. He suspects he will need a bigger slate.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Morrow wants to hold. The holding is all of him that is left that is not cord. He fears that he is the only thing between Sallowreach and the rest of the Table, that he is coming apart, and that nobody is coming to replace him, because everybody who could has walked into the reeds.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** The pieces he leaves are deliberate. He is trying to get a little of himself across the border without dying, a finger at a time, leaving them by the south road where a Company carter might kick one into a wagon. Twice it has happened. Twice a

Company clerk he pays has found, in the heap beyond the stakes, grey dust in the shape of a finger. He keeps trying.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He has never arrested Sister Lorn, and never ordered his cordons to stop the processions with force, because in 633 he was on the Dunmere cordon when the first seven walked in, and he heard the last verse, and he has been afraid ever since that if he arrests her, he will ask her to take him.

**Secret he does not know:** Very little of him is still his. Of the sixty stitchings, the Guild has replaced his sword-hand three times, his jaw twice and most of the long muscles of his back, from stock. A third of the Guild's stock comes from Marrow Jack. His current right hand was taken in 638 from a shelved woman in the Lofts named Ysolde Brann, a fishwife Set Aside in 559. She is still aware. She feels every grip, every parry, every blow. She has felt him kill. She has been whispering about it to Bettany Shroud's readers for three years, and it is in a whisper-book, and nobody has connected the hand to the captain.

## TIES

- ◇ **Sergeant Greer Abbot** — his sergeant for forty years, living, sixty-two. Keeps the Box. Would carry him across the border in a sack if he asked, and has told him so, and he has told her that is exactly why he never will.
- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — his Seamer for every one of the sixty. They are old friends in the way two professionals are; she calls him her best customer and her worst patient. He does not know where her stock comes from.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — see above. He thinks of her as the enemy he respects most.
- ◇ **Withhold Pennick** — the Reckoner who cut Lord Osgood Wole's throat in 639. He has been hunting her through the Sinks for two years. He has nearly caught her four times. Each time he has stopped, because he does not want to be the man who brings her to the jar.
- ◇ **Castellan Dray** — the Vigil's envoy has asked Morrow, privately, how many soldiers Sallowreach could raise if the dead of another country came north to live. Morrow told him, "As many as you send." He has not slept since; but then, he never does.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Morrow at the Finishing Post, at a Hush cordon, or after doing something the Court wants answered with a sword. He is fair, blunt, and cannot be bribed, though he can be told the truth. He hires living PCs to chase fugitives across the border where his Kept cannot follow, at forty lacks a day and his word.

- ◇ **The South Side.** Sergeant Abbot hires the PCs privately: take the Box across the border, in a lead case, packed in Mother Gall's brine, and see if anything survives. It does not. But in the brine the finger moves for nine minutes on the far side before it goes to dust, and it points north.

- ◇ **The Cordon.** Six of Morrow's soldiers walk into the Cotter's Ditch Hush in one night. He asks the PCs to stand the cordon with him, at night, for a week, and tell him which of his men are going to go next. One of them is Morrow.
- ◇ **The Hand.** A Loft-Warden brings the PCs a whisper-book page: a shelved woman describing, in exact detail, the feel of killing a smuggler on the causeway last Grace. Someone is using her hand. Following the thread leads to Marrow Jack, to Thessaly Mort, and to the captain.

Faced with threat, Morrow attacks without hurry until it stops. Faced with kindness he changes the subject to the weather. Faced with the god he stands to attention, as at a grave. If nobody intervenes, by the end of 642 the Guard is under two thousand, the cordons are hollow, and at his sixty-first death Morrow simply does not get up from the causeway mud: not because he cannot, but because he decides not to. His sergeant sits beside him. They are still there when the Hush comes up the road.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"I seen the Captain take a crossbow bolt through the eye and pull it out and say, 'Right, where was I.' He's the only officer I ever served under who knew where he was." — Private Hob Clutter, Kept, Fen Guard

"Dace is a fine piece of work. I'd know. I've done most of it." — Thessaly Mort

"My mam says he's what you get if you never give up. She says it like it's a warning." — a girl selling eels on the Landing

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# HENNA FARROW

*the Widow Unmade*

*“Sit down, Amos. Sit down, love. It’s eel. No, I know. I know it does. Sit.”*

– HENNA FARROW, EVERY EVENING SINCE 551

| HENNA FARROW – THE WIDOW UNMADE |                                                                                                                                              |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                      | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                                             |
| AGE & STATION                   | Born 529 A.G.; living, 112; widow, wife, petitioner; lodger in her own house on Pellet Row, the Sinks                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING              | none (a retired net-mender; Standing 0)                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                      | Hand 3 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                          | Clause 3 (forty-one petitions teach anyone), Craft 3 (nets, cooking), Resolve 4, Persuade 2, Endure 2, Stitching 1                           |
| BODY                            | Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                         | none; a ladle, if she must (+3, 1)                                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                           | none; she is very old and very stubborn, which in Sallowreach is a kind of power                                                             |
| WANTS                           | Close (at the Taste: she closes the lid of the eel barrel, the door of the stair, her husband’s mouth when he forgets it)                    |
| KNACKS                          | Dowager’s Patience; Old Grief                                                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                    | Kept Grief (roused by the smell of fried eel, the sound of the door at dusk, or anyone using his name)                                       |
| CARRIES                         | the forty-one petitions; the painted mask’s brushes; a ladle; a wedding ring on a cord; the Court’s last letter of refusal; a jar of minutes |
| DREAD                           | 0 (Henna herself); 2 (to sit at supper with Amos)                                                                                            |

## WHO THEY ARE

Henna is a hundred and twelve and living, bent almost double over two sticks of black bog-oak, so that she looks at the world from under her own brow. Her skin is spotted and thin as hymnal paper; her net-mender’s hands are knotted at every joint and still quick. She smells of lye, lavender water and frying fat, because she cooks every night.

Her voice is high and cracked and tart, and she does not suffer clerks. The Court’s petition-office knows her well: every Grace they bring her a chair and a cup of sour, and they hate the day, because she is always polite and she always cries at the end, briefly, angrily, and then apologizes.

## THEIR STORY

Henna Gilt was born on Pellet Row in 529, the daughter of a net-mender, and married Amos Farrow, a weir-man on the Lastgate eel-weirs, in 547, when she was eighteen and he was twenty-two. Their vows ended *until finished*, as all Sallowreach vows do, and everybody laughed at the wedding when the priest said it, as everybody always does. They had four good years. In the summer of 551 a Fatlands fever came up the causeway with a meat-carter, and

Amos sickened and died in their bed on Pellet Row, at twenty-six, with Henna holding a cup to his mouth.

He sat up that evening, said he was late for the weir, went and worked his shift, came home at dusk, opened the door and said, “Something smells good, Hen.” Nobody told him he was dead: in the first weeks Henna could not, and by the first year it was a thing not done. In 570 the Court pulled down the Lastgate weirs for the Landing’s new piers. Amos did not notice. Every morning he still walks out to the black water where the weir stood, stands in it to the waist for nine hours working at nothing, and comes home at dusk.

His face went in the 590s. The Guild could not keep it; flesh that is out in the weather every day rots fast. Henna paid a Seamer to make him a mask of lacquered linen over a wire frame, and when the Seamer painted on a stern face she sent it back and painted it herself: a broad, lopsided smile, the one he had at their wedding. She repaints it every Restitching Week.

She has never remarried (it would be bigamy) nor had children. She has filed for a setting-apart four times and withdrawn it four times. She has petitioned for his Closing forty-one times. The Court refuses: Amos must consent three times aloud, and to consent he would have to be told.



## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Henna is nobody, institutionally, which is the point of her: she is the household the laws of 301 were written over. Pellet Row's children, living and Small, run her errands for burnt sugar. The Row's Kept call out when they see Amos coming up from the Landing, so she can have the eel in the pan. Aubin Coyle, a Seamer's apprentice, restitches Amos's hands every spring for nothing.

She owns nothing: the house belongs by law to Amos, who is upright, and she lives on three lacks a week from the Net-Menders' Benevolent. Under the hearthstone she has eleven minutes of Closing, saved since 560, about seven hundred lacks of a license. She will not live to save the rest.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The forty-one petitions** — copies of every petition she has filed, tied with net-cord in a bundle the thickness of a loaf. Each grows longer. The forty-first (Grace 641) runs to nine pages and for the first time asks for two Closings: his, and, when the time comes, hers.
- ◇ **The mask-brushes** — three fine sable brushes and a twist of paint (red, white, a fen-brown for the eyebrows) in a tin. She paints the smile every Restitching Week. Last year her hand shook and it came out sad. She had to scrape it and start again, and he stood patiently while she did it.
- ◇ **The Court's letter** — the forty-first refusal, sealed in red with the closed eye of the Court, signed by Regent Grue's own hand: *The petitioner is reminded that consent cannot be given by one who has not been informed.* She has read it so often it is soft.
- ◇ **The jar of minutes** — eleven lacquered slips of coffin-wood, each bearing the Regent's signature (see the Rim Market chapter). She takes them out on Tablenight and counts them.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Henna wants Amos to finish, with the raw, unhealed wanting of a woman still twenty-two inside. She wants to be a widow. She wants to grieve. She would like someone to tell him, because she has tried, and she knows what his painted face did.

What she fears is her own death. She is a hundred and twelve. When she dies, in her bed on Pellet Row, she will sit up the next morning and be Kept, and she will set his place, and he will come home, and they will be two corpses at a kitchen table forever, and nobody will be left to fry the eel.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** She has told him. Once, in Lack 589, she sat him down and said it all, and he listened, and then he stood and went out to the weir that was not there and did not come home for nine days. When he came back he said, "Something smells good, Hen," and she has never dared again. She tells the Court she has never told him. It is the only lie she has ever put in a petition.

**Secret she does not know:** Amos knows. He has known since 589, and he has been trying to answer her ever since. His tongue is

gone and his jaw is wired under the mask, but every night, at supper, the jaw clicks: three short, one long, a pause, three short, one long. It is the old weir-men's click-code, the signal the weir-gangs used across the water in the Breath, and it means *let go*. Henna does not know the code. Fenwick Lisp, the interpreter of jaw-clicks, does. If a sworn interpreter attests before the Court that Amos Farrow has three times said *let go*, his consent may be lawful. Whether Fenwick's attestation can be trusted is another matter entirely (see his dossier).

## TIES

- ◇ **Amos Farrow** — her husband, Kept, faceless, smiling in paint. See above.

**AMOS FARROW (KEPT)** Threat 1 · Flesh 12 · Guard 9 · Attack +2 (weir-hands 1) · Armor 1 (wrap and mask) · Dread 2

- ◇ **Aubin Coyle** — the Seamer apprentice who restitches Amos for free. She is teaching him to make proper eel in return. He is the closest thing she has to a grandson.
- ◇ **Bram Hollin** — her neighbor two doors down and her rosemary-man. She has asked him, as a professional, what the funeral rite costs. He has told her it is free for her. She has asked him to learn the weir-men's songs, so that there is something to sing.
- ◇ **Ivo Vane** — the Licenser who has processed her petitions for nine years. He has never met her. He has read every page. He has begun to keep copies.
- ◇ **Fenwick Lisp** — she does not know him. He knows of her; everyone on the Landing knows Amos. He has heard the clicks from the street. He has not said anything.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Henna if they lodge on Pellet Row or need a guide to the petition-office, or because she asks them plainly, at her own table with a dead man across from her: *Will you tell him?* She can pay with eleven minutes of Closing, which is all she has.

- ◇ **The Telling.** The PCs agree to tell Amos. He listens, and goes out to the weir, and does not come back. Three days later he is found standing in the deep fen beyond the Landing, up to his painted mouth, and the Fen Guard will not wade in. Something down there has him by the ankle and will not let go.
- ◇ **The Code.** A PC with the Elder's Ear Knack, or anyone who sits long enough at supper, notices the clicks. Finding someone who can read weir-code leads to Fenwick Lisp, and Fenwick wants something for his testimony: company.
- ◇ **Two Closings.** Henna dies in her sleep, in Carving, during a session. She sits up in the morning, Kept, and makes breakfast. She asks the PCs to take her forty-second petition to the Court. It asks for two.

Faced with threat, Henna threatens back with a ladle and a hundred and twelve years of temper. Faced with kindness she is suspicious, then ashamed of crying. Faced with the god she would like it to hurry up. If nobody intervenes, she dies in Lack 642, rises, and sets two places, and the house on Pellet Row becomes a small, famous, terrible thing: two Kept at supper forever, one smiling in paint, the other scraping eel into a barrel, and the neighbors keeping the door shut.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She’s at the window at dusk every night, same as ever. You set your clock by Henna. Not that clocks finish neither.” — Kept lamplighter, Pellet Row

“Petition forty-one is very well drafted. Forty-one petitions in, I would hire her.” — a Court clerk, the petition-office

“I asked her once why she didn’t just let the Heirs take him. She said, ‘Because then it wouldn’t be him that said yes.’ I didn’t understand it then. I’m seventeen now. I understand it a bit.” — Aubin Coyle, Seamer’s apprentice

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# TAM RUDDOCK

## the Lastgate Ferryman

*“You’ll not die. I promise you that. I promise you that and nothing else, so listen to how I’m saying it.”*

– TAM RUDDOCK, TO EVERY PASSENGER, AT THE LONG FAREWELL, FOGMOUTH

| TAM RUDDOCK – THE LASTGATE FERRYMAN |                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                              |
| AGE & STATION                       | Born 601 A.G.; living, 40; licensed ferryman of the Landing; unlicensed smuggler of the dying |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | Crumb-Runner · Standing 3 (known on every Rim Road back stair from Fogmouth to Sated)         |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                           |
| SKILLS                              | Wayfaring 4, Labor 4, Deceive 3, Stealth 3, Brawl 3, Endure 2, Haggle 2, Search 1             |
| BODY                                | Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (oilskin) · Fray 7                                              |
| ATTACKS                             | punt-pole +6 (3, Reach, Stunning); fists +6 (1)                                               |
| GIFTS                               | Lidsense (he knows, in the dark of the punt’s hold, whose eyes are open)                      |
| WANTS                               | Close (he cannot leave a passenger’s eyes open; he shuts them while they sleep)               |
| KNACKS                              | Corpse-Road Walker; Hard Sleeper (it has stopped working)                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | none yet; Fray 7 and climbing                                                                 |
| CARRIES                             | the black punt; the List; the rum flask; forged passes; a lantern; a sack of Fogmouth cedar   |
| DREAD                               | 0                                                                                             |

### WHO THEY ARE

Tam Ruddock is big, heavy and slope-shouldered, with a nose broken twice and a voice so soft that strangers lean in to hear him and find themselves agreeing. His hands are tarred black in the creases. He smells of pitch, rum and the cedar he smoulders in the punt. He blinks slowly, like a man who has not slept, which he has not, much, since 624.

### THEIR STORY

Tam was born on the Landing to a ferrying family and poled his first punt at nine. His younger brother Hob went south at eighteen to work as a Company carter and was killed in 619 when a meat-wagon went over on the Gristmoot road in the Fatlands. He died. He died properly, south of the Drop, and Tam, who was eighteen and had never seen a death, got the letter and a box of ashes. He could not understand it. He still cannot.

In 624 a Fatlands woman named Idony Pask, thin as a reed with a wasting sickness, asked him at the Long Farewell inn in Fogmouth whether it was true that in the north nobody died. He said it was, and took her across. Since then he has taken two hundred and twelve: Fatlanders with the wasting, Brinehollowers too far Called, Vigil sleepers on stretchers, a Cradlewrack mother whose belly had

not stopped. For three hundred lacks they cross the Drop at night on a handcart, lie under oilcloth in his punt, and come up the canals to rooms he rents in the Sinks. None of them die. That is his promise, and he has never told one of them what happens next.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

By day Tam ferries the living across the Landing at a crumb a head, under Court license. By night he smuggles people *in*. The Court does not care (the foreign dead pay the fly-tax forever), the Company takes a cut at Fogmouth, and Morrow’s guards wave him through, since no law forbids bringing the living into Sallowreach. He is the only man in the north whose crime is legal.

On his days off he visits. He keeps the List, and he goes down it, one name a day, with a bottle of fen-gin and a bag of cedar chips, to whatever room or Loft-shelf his passenger now lies in. He sits with them. Most are glad to see him. Some are not.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The black punt** — thirty feet, tarred, with a hidden hold under the boards that will not be found except on a Grace (his Crumb-Runner’s Hidden Hold). It has carried two hundred and twelve people who were dying, and is now the most-wanted boat in Lastgate: Castellan Dray of the Vigil has offered to buy it.

- ◇ **The List** — a tarred notebook with every passenger’s name, land, date of crossing, date of death, and where they are now. Eighty-one are still breathing. A hundred and thirty-one have died and are Kept. Nine are shelved. Two have walked into Hushes. The Vigil would pay a fortune for it, as a census of what happens to foreigners kept in the north.
- ◇ **Forged Company passes** — six, drawn by a clerk at Fogmouth, good for “a living traveler and attendant, for treatment.” The ink is not quite the right brown.
- ◇ **A sack of Fogmouth cedar** — for the punt’s brazier. For the smell. For the passengers, so they will not lie under the oilcloth and smell Sallowreach for the first time and know.
- ◇ **Hob’s box** — the box of ashes his brother came home in, kept on a shelf in his lodging over the Landing. It is the only finished thing he owns.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Tam wants to stop and cannot, because every week another letter comes to the Long Farewell from somebody whose child is dying. He fears the List. He fears that he is the cause of a hundred and thirty-one people living forever in rot in a country not their own, and he fears worse that he would do it again, because the alternative is a box of ashes.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He has never told a passenger what happens next because the first time, with Idony, he did not know himself. He thought the north kept the living living. He learned, when she died in 627 and kept going and kept wasting, what he had sold her. He went home and was sick in the canal and went back to Fogmouth the next week, because a Vigil mother had been waiting for nine days with her son on a stretcher.

**Secret he does not know:** Castellan Dray has had him followed for a season. To the Vigil, Tam Ruddock is not a smuggler. He is a proof of method: the route, the price, the rooms, the List. If the Deadwatch is signed, the Vigil will need a ferry for a hundred thousand sleepers. Dray intends to make Tam rich, and to make him do it.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Idony Pask** — his first passenger. She has never forgiven him. He visits her most, every week, and lets her shout.
- ◇ **Castellan Dray** — the Vigil envoy who wants to buy his boat, his List and his route.
- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — they drink together on Tablenight at the Finishing Post, Tam on the south side of the stakes and Dace on the north, passing the flask across the line.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — two of his passengers walked in with her. He came to the edge to stop the second one. Lorn held him back. He has not spoken to her since.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Tam at the Landing or at the Long Farewell in Fogmouth, especially if they are carrying someone sick north, or are themselves running from something that could kill them. He is gentle, hospitable, discreet and very good at his job.

- ◇ **The Two Hundred and Thirteenth.** A PC’s companion is dying of something only the north can stop. Tam will take them. He asks the PC, privately, to promise to tell the dying person the truth before they cross. He has never managed it.
- ◇ **The Census.** Dray’s men try to steal the List. Tam asks the PCs to visit every name on it in a week and warn them. Some do not want to be warned.
- ◇ **The Return Trip.** A Kept passenger, a Vigil boy of nineteen, wants to go home, knowing what crossing means. His mother, still breathing, has come north to stop him. Tam is asked to pole him to the Drop.

Faced with threat, Tam hits once, hard, with the pole, and then talks. Faced with kindness he looks at the floor. Faced with the god he closes his eyes and keeps poling. If nobody intervenes, Tam signs on with Dray in 642, for a fee that would let him stop, and never stops: within two years he is ferrying cartloads of the Vigil’s sleepers across the Drop, by day, under Company seal, and he has bought a bigger notebook.

#### SAID OF THEM

“Tam? He’ll take you. He’ll take anybody. That’s the trouble with him.” — a Company clerk at Fogmouth

“He carried my boy on his own back from the cart to the punt so the jolting wouldn’t wake him. I’ll pray for that man until I die. Which I suppose I won’t.” — Maud Ennerly, Vigil mother, now Kept, the Sinks

“He’s the kindest man I ever met and I’d see him in the Sump.” — Idony Pask

# MARROW JACK

*the Part-Thief*

*“Everybody’s a donor, friend. It’s only a question of whether you’re asked.”*

– MARROW JACK, TO A BUYER IN THE SINKS

| MARROW JACK – THE PART-THIEF |                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Sallowreach · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                | Born 608 A.G.; living, 33; part-thief, fence, ex-Journeyman of the Seamers’ Guild                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Gleaner · Standing 4 (the best in the north; Nan Pickering buys his whole season)                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                       | Stitching 4, Filch 5, Stealth 5, Blades 3, Haggle 4, Search 3, Endure 1, Craft 2                                                         |
| BODY                         | Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (padded coat) · Fray 3                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                      | bone-saw +8 (3, Ripping; takes a limb from a Kept target on a Helping); knife +8 (2, Concealable); Seamer’s awl +8 (2, Piercing, Silent) |
| GIFTS                        | none; skill only (and Scrap-Born Luck)                                                                                                   |
| WANTS                        | none; his compulsions are entirely his own                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                       | Scrap-Born Luck; Steady Hands; Vinegar Kiss                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | none; this is what worries people                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                      | the coat of saws; clove oil; the labels; the stock room key; a ledger in cipher; Sister Halloway’s letter                                |
| DREAD                        | 2 (his stock room)                                                                                                                       |

## WHO THEY ARE

Marrow Jack is thin as drawn wire, with a pleasant freckled face, sandy cropped hair and the cheerful manner of a man who likes his work and likes people. His hands never stop. His long padded coat clinks faintly with saws and awls in waxed sheaths. He smells overwhelmingly of clove oil, and under it, if you are close, of the sweet. He remembers your name.

## THEIR STORY

Jack Pell was born in a stilt-hut on the edge of the Sump, a dredger’s son, and by twelve was cutting rings off the fingers the rake brought up, and the fingers with them. Thessaly Mort saw him at fourteen selling a thumb on Needle Street and took him as a Threader: a boy who could get a thumb off that clean, she said, would make a Seamer. He was a Journeyman at nineteen.

In 629 he was expelled from the Guild before all of Needle Street for taking a hand from the Lofts. Thessaly arranged it. The Guild needs parts, more each year; no family will sell; the Lofts hold forty thousand bodies that cannot complain. Since 629 Jack has supplied a third of the Guild’s stock, paid through Nan Pickering so that Thessaly’s ledger never shows his name.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Jack works the Lofts by night with a dark lantern and a shelving hook, buys dredged sacks from the Sump crews, and picks over the potter’s corners where the unclaimed are left. He sells to Nan Pickering, to back-alley seamers, and to buyers who want whole pairs of hands, or lately Hand-line fingers, worth twelve hundred lacks and a capital crime. He seals every stump with lacquer, because he is not cruel, and labels every piece with its owner’s name.

That is his trade’s curse. His victims feel what their parts are doing. A woman in the Lofts whose arm was sold to a Kept singer feels the arm lift a glass at every performance. A man whose hands went to a back-alley strangler felt them close. Some of them have followed the feeling across the city, crawling.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The coat of saws** — padded, many-pocketed: two bone-saws (one fine, one coarse), three knives, a Seamer’s awl, a shelving hook that folds, a pot of lacquer, gut, wire, labels.
- ◇ **The labels** — linen tags, each with a name in his small clean hand. He has never sold an unlabeled part. He says it is a matter of respect.
- ◇ **A ledger in cipher** — every part he has taken since 629, with owner, buyer and price. It proves that the Guild’s stores are his

stock. Thessaly would pay anything for it. So would the Court.

- ◇ **The stock room key** — iron, on a cord round his neck. The stock room is a cold cellar under a tannery on Gutter Lane: racks, jars, hooks, a hundred labeled hands, and Edony Sallis (see below).
- ◇ **A letter from Sister Tisane Halloway** — the Purgation’s apothecary, who keeps a jar of small grey hinged joints that people from four lands have vomited up. Jack has been buying Cradlewrack Parts on the Rim for a client; the joints fit them. He has offered her two hundred lacks for the jar.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Jack wants to be paid and to be respected as a craftsman, and he wants Thessaly to take him back openly, as her Master of the Seam, which she has promised for twelve years. He fears nothing much, which is the frightening thing about him. He has begun to fear one person.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He supplies Thessaly Mort. A third of the parts in the Guild’s stores came from him. Captain Dace Morrow’s sword-hand is one of his.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** In Carving 640 he took the hands of Edony Sallis, a Kept cooper working off a thirty-eight-year debt to a moneylender. She felt them sold, felt them sewn on, and followed the feeling to Gutter Lane. She found the stock room. He caught her in it. Now she is in it, in eleven pieces, on the racks, each piece labeled, still talking. He cannot sell her (she knows his face, and her parts would tell). He cannot sink her (the Sump talks). He cannot close her. He visits her every night and they talk. She is the best conversation he has ever had.

**Secret he does not know:** The client buying Cradlewrack Parts and Halloway’s joints is Lord Absalom Hethe, for the Second Table. And the Smalls know where his stock room is. Little Nell has a list of every Small whose part he has ever taken.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — his old mistress and secret employer. He loves her like a mother and would sell her to the Court in an afternoon.
- ◇ **Nan Pickering** — the limb-broker who fences his stock and keeps his name off every ledger.
- ◇ **Little Nell Ash** — the queen of the Smalls has sworn to jar him in pieces of her own. He takes nothing from children now, which is a rule he made after the first time Nell’s Smalls found him on a stair.
- ◇ **Edony Sallis** — his prisoner, his conversation.

**EDONY SALLIS (KEPT, IN ELEVEN PIECES)** Threat 2 ·  
Flesh 3 · Guard 5 · Attack — · Armor 0 · Dread 3

- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — wears one of his hands without knowing it.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Jack in the Sinks, buying or selling, or because something of someone they care about has gone missing in the night. He is charming, reasonable, and will happily do business with PCs who need a part, a body, a hand-line finger or a way into the Lofts after dark.

- ◇ **Feel for It.** A shelved Kept in the Lofts begs the PCs to follow what she feels her hand doing. The trail goes through three buyers to a Court house on the Upper Boards.
- ◇ **The Eleventh Piece.** The moneylender who owns Edony Sallis’s debt hires the PCs to find her. When they find her, every piece of her asks to be put back together, and Jack asks to be allowed to watch.
- ◇ **The Joints.** Jack hires PCs to escort a crate of Cradlewrack Parts from the Rim to Lastgate. The crate knocks from inside, rhythmically, toward the northwest.

Faced with threat, Jack runs, and he is very fast; cornered, he goes for the tendons behind the knee. Faced with kindness he is touched and suspicious. Faced with the god he is uninterested; he is a Scrapling and it has never noticed him. If nobody intervenes, Thessaly Mort, cornered by a Court inquiry, gives the Court Jack’s name in 642, and he is jarred; but not before he sells his ledger to the Heirs, and the Seamers’ Guild comes apart at the seams.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He took me arm in the night and left a lacquer stump neat as you like and a tag on the shelf that said *thank you*. Thank you! I can feel it, you know. It’s on a fiddler.” — Old Mab Tolley, shelved, Loft Six, as taken down by a Reader

“Best pair of hands I ever trained, and I’ve seen a lot of hands.” — Thessaly Mort

“He’s polite. That’s what you notice. Polite as a priest.” — a dredger of the Sump





# LITTLE NELL ASH

## Queen of the Smalls

*“That’s not fair, and I’m the one who says what’s fair. So no.”*

– LITTLE NELL ASH, TO AN EMISSARY OF THE MORTUARY COURT, 612

| LITTLE NELL ASH – QUEEN OF THE SMALLS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                         | Born 434 A.G.; died of a fever 441, aged seven; Kept; Queen of the Smalls of the Drowned Storeys                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | none of the grown-up kind (Standing 5 among the Smalls, where it is the only rank that matters)                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                                | Clause 4 (the Smalls’ Laws), Persuade 4, Stealth 4, Instinct 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Intimidate 2                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                               | none she would use; her Smalls are her attack (see In Play)                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                 | Kept (Rot 3, Ripe, held there by the Smalls’ patient stitching); Lidsense; the Queen’s Word (a ruling she gives among the Smalls is obeyed by every Small in Lastgate, always)                                                   |
| WANTS                                 | Close (at the Taste; she shuts the schoolroom door, the lids of sleeping Smalls, the drawers of the teacher’s desk); Fair (when she sees a promise broken or a turn skipped, she must say so, out loud, at once; resist Hard 14) |
| KNACKS                                | Little Lies; Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                          | none; she has had two hundred years to be careful                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                               | the crown of spoons; violet sweets; the Register; the slate of laws; a key to the first stair; her mother’s thimble                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                                 | 1 (to be looked at by her, properly, for the first time)                                                                                                                                                                         |

### WHO THEY ARE

Nell is the height of a seven-year-old and grey-green all over from two centuries of damp, the color of a pond-stone. Smalls who taught themselves from stolen manuals have stitched her countless times, unevenly and devotedly, with little embroidered flowers where the seams meet. Her hair is a wet dark plait; her eyes are milky at the edges and very sharp in the middle. She wears a schoolgirl’s pinafore mended into lace and a crown of bent spoons, and smells of canal water and the violet sweets she holds in her mouth until they dissolve.

Her voice is a child’s, high and clear, but she uses it like a judge. She does not fidget. She listens with her whole face. She laughs at things that are actually funny, and she does not laugh at anything else.

### THEIR STORY

Nell Ash was born in 434 above a cooper’s on the Weir Steps and died of a fever in 441. Her mother, the mistress of the Lower Board School, kept her in the schoolroom for a year, teaching her letters. In 443 the Lower Boards sank another storey, the school went under the green water, and her mother, who was living, did not come down again.

Nell waited. Other child-dead came down the stairs, the drowned and the fevered and the unkept. By 470 there were sixty and nobody in charge, and things happened in the dark that Nell has never spoken of, and she decided that someone had to say what was fair. There are now some four hundred Smalls, and she knows every name.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Smalls live in the half-flooded lower streets and go up into the city at night to run errands and carry messages for sweets and lamp oil. Everyone in the Sinks uses them; nobody admits it. Nell sets the rates, makes sure every Small comes back down, and judges disputes from a waterlogged armchair with the Register on her knee.

She has held the Court off for two centuries by being too small to arrest and too many to jar. In 612 the Court tried to take the Smalls into the Lofts as Set-Aside wards; Nell sent four hundred children up the stairs onto the Upper Boards at noon, silent, holding hands, and the Court withdrew the order by dusk. She is careful with the Seamers (who stitch her Smalls for nothing at Restitching Week because she asked them politely, once, in 520) and implacable with Marrow Jack.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The crown of spoons** — eleven tarnished teaspoons from the school's kitchen, bent around wire. She made it herself in 471. It is her only regalia and nobody else may touch it.
- ◇ **The Register** — the Lower Board School's attendance register, long since full, extended with sewn-in pages. Every Small's name, date of death, and the date they came down. She calls it every morning, all four hundred names, and each Small answers.
- ◇ **The slate of laws** — a school slate with nine laws chalked on it, rewritten when the damp wears them away. The first is *Nobody takes a turn twice*. The ninth, added in 640, is *Nobody goes without asking the Queen*.
- ◇ **A key to the first stair** — the iron key to the flooded door at the bottom of the Weir Steps. Nobody grown comes past it without her leave.
- ◇ **Her mother's thimble** — brass, worn through at the top. She keeps it in her pinafore pocket and touches it when she is deciding things.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Nell wants her Smalls kept safe and fairly treated, forever, because forever is what they have. She wants Pim Sorrel, the Scrapling girl who can close things, because several Smalls have asked to be closed, and because Pim closed two of them without asking the Queen, which is against the ninth law, and because if it is going to be done it must be done fairly, in order, by someone answerable to her.

She fears the asking. Forty-one Smalls have asked to be closed since the Hushes began. She has not said yes to any of them. She does not know whether a child can consent to finishing when the child is two hundred years old. She fears that she is refusing them because she cannot bear to be alone.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** One of the forty-one is Wren Teal, Sister Lorn's daughter, who has been four for fifty-three years. Nell has kept every one of Lorn's two hundred letters and answered them all no, because Wren asked her not to let her mother come down. Wren is afraid her mother will want to stay.

**Secret she does not know:** Her mother did not abandon her. Adela Ash died in 446 of grief and a slip on the Weir Steps, and was Set Aside in the Lofts in 503 when she could no longer stand. She is on the fourth floor of Hall Two. Every night for a hundred and thirty-eight years she has whispered one thing to the Readers: *Tell Nell I am coming down*. It is in fifty years of Bettany Shroud's whisper-books. Bettany has never connected the name to the Queen.

## TIES

- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — the living girl she wants for her own. She has sent Smalls to watch her house every night for a year. Pim has started leaving sweets on the step for them.

- ◇ **Marrow Jack** — her enemy. The Register marks every Small he has ever taken a part from. She is waiting for him to come down the stairs.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — see above.
- ◇ **Old Bettany Shroud** — the Loft-Warden carries Lorn's letters and Nell's replies, and does not read either.
- ◇ **Bram Hollin** — Nell has asked him to teach her the funeral rite, all of it, in case she says yes.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Nell if they go down into the Drowned Storeys, if they need a message carried in Lastgate at night, or if they hurt a Small. She receives grown-ups in the flooded schoolroom, sitting very straight, with the light coming green through the water at the windows. She will want to know their names, their business, and whether they keep their promises.

- ◇ **The Ninth Law.** A Small has gone up the stairs alone to find Pim Sorrel. Nell sends the PCs after her, with instructions: bring her back, and do not let her be closed, and do not let Pim be hurt. All three may not be possible.
- ◇ **Forty-One.** Nell asks a Hand-line PC at the Course to come down and sit with the Smalls who have asked, one at a time, and tell her honestly whether it would hurt.
- ◇ **The Fourth Floor.** A PC reading in the Lofts hears a shelved woman whisper *Tell Nell*. Carrying that message down the stairs will change the Queen; whether she will forgive the messenger is another matter.

Faced with threat, Nell blows a tin whistle, and four hundred children come up out of the flooded rooms; nobody can kill them, and they can hold on for a very long time. Faced with the god she is a child, frightened and pretending not to be. If nobody intervenes, Nell says yes in 642, to all forty-one, and asks Pim to do it in the schoolroom, in order, by the Register; and afterward she calls the morning names, and forty-one do not answer, and she does not stop calling them for a year.

## SAID OF THEM

"You don't argue with the Queen. You can, but she's always right, and she tells you why, and then you feel like you're six." — a Small called Pip, aged six since 502

"I pay her rates. Everyone pays her rates. She'd know if you didn't." — a Sinks pawnbroker

"She asked me once what grown-ups do when they're sad and there's no one to tell. I said they find someone smaller. She said, 'I know. That's what I'm afraid of.'" — Old Bettany Shroud





# PROVOST CARRION SEDGE

*Keeper of the Northern Ledgers*

*“A family tree is a map, madam. I have simply drawn the country it describes.”*

– PROVOST SEDGE, TO LADY CORROW VANE, IN CAMERA, CARVING 640

| PROVOST CARRION SEDGE – KEEPER OF THE NORTHERN LEDGERS |                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                             | Sallowreach · Cut 4 (Hand-line, cadet Sedge) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                                          | Born 529 A.G.; Kept since 598 (died at sixty-nine); Provost of the Cutwrights’ College in the north since 571                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                                     | Cutwright · Standing 5 (Provost)                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                                             | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                                                 | Lore 5, Reckoning 5, Search 4, Clause 3, Resolve 3, Persuade 2, Endure 1                                                                                                          |
| BODY                                                   | Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 (lacquer) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                                                | none; a paper-knife, +2 (1)                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                                                  | Kept (Rot 4, Ripe, though the binder’s lacquer hides it); Lidsense; the Quiet Hand; Read the Line (as the Cutwright Talent, at Routine instead of Hard for any Sallowreach blood) |
| WANTS                                                  | Close (ledgers, inkwells, doors, the tank lid); Keep Count (he cannot leave a lineage unfinished on the page)                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                                 | Counting Habit; Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                                           | The Gaslight (triggered when a ledger contradicts his memory, which is now often)                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                                | the Hush Map; the closed ledgers; calipers; Grandfather Peat’s tank key; a dried-blood sample case; his <i>Lectures</i>                                                           |
| DREAD                                                  | 1                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Carrion Sedge is gaunt to the point of architecture, a tall frame of bone in a scholar’s black gown, his face lacquered a matte brown like an old book’s spine. He smells of paper, dust and bindery glue. His fingers are black with ink to the second joint. He speaks in long, perfect sentences with a dry rasp, never hurries, and corrects people’s genealogy in conversation as other men correct pronunciation.

## THEIR STORY

Carrion was born to a cadet branch of the Sedges, one of the four houses that divided Ossel’s right hand, and was sent at twelve to the College at Quire, where he discovered that he loved ledgers more than people because ledgers did not lie about their parents. He came home in 560 and was Provost of the northern ledgers by 571. He died in 598, at his desk, of a stroke, and finished the page he was writing before anyone noticed.

In 634 the Court asked him for a routine survey of the land-holdings around Dunmere. Every holding within a day’s punt was Hand-line. As more Hushes appeared he plotted them against his ledgers, and by 638 he had a map: each Hush lies where Hand-line blood is thickest, sized by the Cut of the nearest line, appearing in

the order of the Grue, Vane, Sedge and Hethe descents, generation by generation. Plotted on vellum, the Hushes *are* a family tree. And a family tree has a trunk.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The College’s Ledger House is a tall, windowless building of tarred brick on the Upper Boards near the Hall of Hands. Sedge’s certificates of Cut are law, every Hand-line marriage and Closing license cites his ledgers, and every house on the Court owes him a pedigree. Grandfather Peat lives in a slate tank in his outer office, and Sedge spends an hour each evening with him and a dialect grammar.

The Court, the Second Table and the Vigil’s envoy have all asked for the Hush Map. The Heirs would kill for it. He has not decided whom to sell it to, or whether to burn it, and his inability to decide is the only thing keeping a dozen factions from his door: each believes it is about to win him.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

◇ **The Hush Map** — a vellum sheet, four feet square, the Hand-line pedigrees inked in brown and the Hushes laid over them in grey wash. At the point where the trunk of the tree meets the

root, in the middle of Lastgate, there is a pinhole. He has not marked anything there.

- ◇ **The closed ledgers** — eleven volumes he has closed, since 639, too firmly. Opened, their pages are blank. The ink is not faded; it is gone, as though it had never been laid. Among them is the volume containing the Sorrel line, and with it any proof of who Pim Sorrel’s great-grandfather was.
- ◇ **The tank key** — to Grandfather Peat’s tank lid. He locks it. Peat would like to go back in the water.
- ◇ **A sample case** — two hundred phials of dried blood, from every Hand-line living and Kept.
- ◇ **His Lectures** — his own *Introductory Lectures in Cutwrighting*, much annotated in the margins, in a hand that is getting slower.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Sedge wants the truth to be complete. That is his want and his Want: a lineage half-drawn is an agony to him. He fears publishing (the Heirs will come to every Hand-line nursery with sacks), and fears selling (the Court will bury it, the Second Table will use it, the Vigil will move in), and fears, most of all, his own hands, which have begun to close things so that they stay closed.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** The pinhole is the Hall of Hands. If the map is right, the next great Hush will open beneath the Court itself, centred on the Regent’s chair, within two years. Sedge has calculated it to the season: Lack 642, give or take one.

**Secret he does not know:** The volumes he closed are not empty. They have been finished, and finished things go somewhere. Grandfather Peat, in the tank in the outer office, has been reciting their contents, aloud, word for word, in his dead dialect, for two years. Sedge thought it was prayer.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Grandfather Peat** — his ward and his riddle. He is closer to understanding him than anyone alive or Kept.
- ◇ **Lord Absalom Hethe** — the Second Table’s man, who has offered to buy the Map and has the patience to wait. Sedge suspects the eighth chair in Hethe’s dining room is drawn from a carving in the College’s own archive.
- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — he has told her, alone, that the Glovehall Hush is growing from her rooms. She thanked him and has not spoken to him since.
- ◇ **Jory Welt** — the Boy’s own wall-map is a crude copy of an early draft, stolen from the Ledger House in 637. Sedge knows who stole it.
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — he measured her hands secretly in 640 and found nothing. The ledger that might explain her is one he closed.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Sedge when they need a pedigree, a certificate of Cut, an answer about a Hand-line, or a job: he hires discreet people to take

blood from Hand-line infants, to steal back copies of his work, and lately to read his closed ledgers to him through Peat’s dialect.

- ◇ **Read It Back.** Sedge hires PCs to learn enough of Peat’s dialect to transcribe what the bog body is reciting. It is the closed ledgers. It is also something else, older, in between the entries: a list of eight names, with one missing.
- ◇ **The Thief.** The Map is stolen. Everyone who wanted it is suspected. It was taken by Sedge’s own hand, in his sleep, and closed inside a drawer that no one can now open.
- ◇ **Lack 642.** Sedge asks PCs to measure the ground under the Hall of Hands at night. The floorboards are colder there than anywhere in Lastgate, and there are no flies.

Faced with threat, Sedge negotiates; he has information everyone wants. Faced with kindness he becomes, briefly, shy. Faced with the god he takes notes. If nobody intervenes, Sedge sells the Map to Lord Hethe in Lack 641 for a seat on the Second Table, and closes his own hands on the bill of sale, and the ink vanishes, and nobody can prove the sale ever happened.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He told me my grandmother was a Hethe bastard and my children are Cut 3. I went in a fishwife and came out a lady. I still sell fish.” — Margery Coot, living, of the Landing

“Carrion knows where the bodies are. He has them alphabetised.” — Lord Absalom Hethe

“He reads to the bog-man every night. You hear him through the floor. Like a father with a little ’un.” — a cleaner at the Ledger House



# MOTHER GALL

*the Pickler of Brinemoss*

*“Nothing finishes here, duck. But it can keep. Hold still. That’s all I ask of anybody. Hold still and float.”*

– MOTHER GALL, LOWERING A CUSTOMER INTO BARREL 388

| MOTHER GALL – THE PICKLER OF BRINEMOSS |                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Sallowreach · Cut 1 (Scrapling, far fen) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0                                |
| AGE & STATION                          | Born 588 A.G.; living, 53; the third Mother Gall; keeper of the Brinemoss cellar                |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Renderer · Standing 3 (respected, feared, and owed by half the south fen)                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                             |
| SKILLS                                 | Craft 5 (pickling, brining), Feast 4, Labor 4, Haggle 4, Lore 3, Endure 3, Brawl 2, Stitching 2 |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 16 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (rubber apron) · Fray 4                                           |
| ATTACKS                                | barrel-hook +6 (3, Hooking); fists +6 (1, and she can hold a Kept under brine with one hand)    |
| GIFTS                                  | none; a recipe and two strong arms                                                              |
| WANTS                                  | none of the god’s; her own is to be paid in advance                                             |
| KNACKS                                 | Iron Stomach; Strong Back; Butcher’s Calm                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | none                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                                | the barrel-hook; the brine-book; a dill-crock; the pit key; the visitors’ bell; a cleaver       |
| DREAD                                  | 2 (her cellar, when the lids come off)                                                          |

## WHO THEY ARE

Mother Gall is enormous in every direction, broad as a door and nearly as tall, with forearms like hams, scarlet hands cracked and shining from brine, and a round red face that is always smiling. She wears a rubber apron, rolled sleeves and clogs, and a kerchief over hair the color of rust. She smells so powerfully of brine, dill and garlic that eyes water at three paces, and the smell has soaked into everything she owns and everyone she hugs, which is everyone. She laughs loudly, sings while she works, calls everyone *duck*, and never stops moving.

## THEIR STORY

The first Mother Gall, Agnes, pickled eels at Brinemoss, a Scrapling hamlet of the south fen. In 547 she noticed that a dog fallen into her brine-pit had not rotted in a year, and tried it on a neighbor’s grandfather, who asked. By 551 she had fifteen customers; the first, Old Corder, is still in barrel one. Agnes went into barrel two in 590, her daughter Hesketh into barrel three in 623. The present Mother Gall, Hesketh’s daughter Maud, has no daughter.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

There are four hundred barrels in the cedar-lined cellar dug into the peat under Brinemoss, in long rows, numbered in white paint. In

each, floating upright in green brine, is a paying customer, wide awake. Their bodies are sound: no rot, no flies, no further decay, so long as they stay submerged. They cannot speak. They knock, gently, on the staves. When the lids are lifted their faces are smooth, pale and perfect, and the eyes open.

A barrel costs fifteen hundred lacks, paid in advance, for a century; most customers are bought in by families tired of paying the Seamers forever. Visiting costs two lacks. A flask of brine (good for a corpse for a year) sells at twenty. Mother Gall is the only person in Sallowreach who sells what feels like a cure, and she says plainly to every customer that it is not one: the rot stops, the time does not. The Seamers’ Guild loathes her and buys her brine in secret. The Court taxes her as a lodging-house.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The barrel-hook** — iron, long-handled, for lifting lids and steadying customers as they go down.
- ◇ **The brine-book** — every customer, their barrel number, their date of entry, who paid, and who visits. Fewer each decade.
- ◇ **The pit key** — the key to a locked shed behind the largest hut, over the brine-pit itself. Nobody else goes in.

- ◇ **The visitors' bell** — a handbell she rings to warn the cellar that a family is coming down, so the customers can compose themselves. They knock less when the bell rings.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be paid, to keep the cellar, and to keep the promise her grandmother made to barrel one: a century, sound. Corder's century is up in 651. She does not know what she will do with him. She fears the Court will tax her out, or the Finishers will come for her customers, or the Hushes will reach the south fen.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** The recipe's heart is the water of the brine-pit, and the brine-pit is the peat pit where, in the week after the Gorging, the Scraplings of the far fen boiled Ossel's face. The Gall women have known it since Agnes dug the pit out and found, at the bottom, under six feet of black silt, a grey tooth the size of a loaf. It is still down there. She salts it every Plenty.

**Secret she does not know:** The customers are not merely kept; they are listening to the pit. The knocking that every visitor hears is not random. Taken down over a night (Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14), every barrel knocks the same pattern: eight beats, a pause, then seven, and the gap where the eighth should be is precisely as long as a knock. Grandfather Peat, shown the transcript, will hold up eight fingers and fold one down. The customers all see the same thing when they open their eyes in the green: a grey face, very large, under the brine, smiling.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Tam Ruddock** — he has brought her four of his dying passengers before death, as a cheaper mercy. She charges him at cost.
- ◇ **Thessaly Mort** — buys her brine through three intermediaries. Mother Gall knows and charges double.
- ◇ **Idony Pask** — has asked, twice, for a barrel, to stop the wasting. Mother Gall told her the truth: the brine will hold her flesh but not her hunger, and she would float, starving, a hundred years.
- ◇ **Pim Sorrel** — her Scrapling kin by the far fen. The pit is where the Scraplings ate the face. If anyone can explain the girl, it is the Galls; she has not been asked.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Mother Gall when someone they know is rotting faster than the Seamers can keep up, when they need a corpse kept fresh (for evidence, for a funeral, for transport), or when a family hires them to visit barrel 212 and ask its occupant where the deeds are.

- ◇ **Barrel One.** Corder's family is long gone. His century is ending. He knocks, every night, harder. Mother Gall asks the PCs to find out what he wants: out, or another hundred years.
- ◇ **The Tooth.** Someone has been in the shed. The pit has been dredged. Marrow Jack's dredgers were seen at Brinemoss. The

tooth is gone, and in the cellar every barrel has stopped knocking.

- ◇ **Visiting Hours.** A PC's own dead relative is in a barrel, and has been knocking a message in the same pattern as the others. It is a count, and it is getting faster.

Faced with threat, Mother Gall picks up the threat and puts it in the brine-channel. Faced with kindness she feeds it. Faced with the god she rings the visitors' bell and refuses to look. If nobody intervenes, the Glovehall Hush's growth and the Hand-line Hushes in the south fen meet Brinemoss in 643; the edge reaches the cellar at night, and four hundred customers finish in their barrels, at once, and the brine goes clear as rainwater, and in the pit the tooth, very slowly, begins to work loose.

#### SAID OF THEM

"I paid for my mother's barrel in '19. I visit Tablenight. She knocks twice for yes. She always knocks yes. I don't know what I'm asking her anymore." — Hal Brindle, living, of Brinemoss

"Mother Gall kept my auntie better than the Guild ever did, and she never once charged extra for the dill." — a fish-wife on the Landing

"A pickled corpse is still a corpse. It is merely a corpse with a lid." — Thessaly Mort, publicly



# EDDA THRUSH

*the Hushwalker*

*“I’m not deaf. Stop saying it. Something is listening. It’s using my ears. I can feel it, it’s like having somebody sitting in your chair.”*

— EDDA THRUSH, TO THE COURT’S SURGEON, LACK 638

| EDDA THRUSH – THE HUSHWALKER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite; it rose four steps in three hours) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                | Born 601 A.G.; living (in a manner of speaking), 40; former surveyor to the Mortuary Court; now the Court’s unwilling measurer of Hushes                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Delver · Standing 4 (no one alive has gone further)                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                       | Reckoning 4, Search 4, Wayfaring 4, Athletics 3, Craft 3, Instinct 3, Godsign 2, Resolve 3                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                         | Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                      | surveyor’s chain +5 (2, Entangling); she has never hit anyone                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                        | the Listener (within three paces of her, sound dims to a whisper; the Kept fall silent near her and feel a pull toward her; Dread 1 to stand beside her); Lidsense; Gone Under (as the Delver Talent); she cannot hear, and is never surprised |
| WANTS                        | Quiet (laughter, bells and crowds are painful to her, though she cannot hear them; she feels them in her teeth)                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                       | Corpse-Road Walker; Light Sleeper                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | The Pull (roused by any Hush edge); The Watchers (she is certain she is being observed, and she is right)                                                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                      | the drawing; the chain; a broken theodolite; slates and chalk; a tether-line with a frayed end; a tin of fly-paper                                                                                                                             |
| DREAD                        | 2 (her silence; the gap she leaves in the smell of the world)                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Edda is wiry and weathered, cropped of hair, with grey-streaked eyebrows that never stop moving, a surveyor’s squint and a slate on a cord round her neck. She smells of nothing at all. In Lastgate she is a person-shaped hole in the air; dogs whine at it, and flies that land on her drop off dead. She speaks too loudly, then too softly, and sometimes stops mid-sentence and tilts her head, as if someone behind her has cleared their throat.

## THEIR STORY

Edda was the Court’s best surveyor of the fen. In Carving 638 the Quiet Market party wanted Dunmere measured from the inside, and she was sent with a Kept chainman, Fenn Albery, a tether and a theodolite. Albery finished at the edge mid-step. Edda, living, should have finished too. She walked in for three hours and came out at dusk a mile north, the tether cut (she does not remember cutting it), the lenses crazed white, and the whole of the inside in her head.

The Court’s surgeons examined her for a month. She was sound in every part. She could not hear. They called it deafness. She told

them, at a volume that made the clerk drop his pen, that it was not.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Court keeps her on salary and on a leash. She measures all eighteen Hushes monthly, the only reliable figures there are. Lady Corrow hires her privately for the Glovehall garden. The Finishers think her a saint; the Heirs want her as a guide. She lives above a wire-drawer’s on Needle Street, because the hammering is the only sound she can feel through the floor.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The drawing** — a sheet of surveyor’s paper, folded in eight, showing the inside of Dunmere from memory: every street, every washing line, every body where it lay, drawn to scale with a draughtsman’s precision. In the center is a large shape left blank, outlined in nothing, simply not drawn, very carefully.
- ◇ **The chain** — Albery’s surveyor’s chain, which she took from his hand at the edge. She uses it still.
- ◇ **The theodolite** — brass, its lenses white as cataracts. Looking through it shows nothing; she looks through it anyway.

- ◇ **A frayed tether-line** — the end is not cut but finished: the fibres stop, clean, like a thing that was never longer.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Edda wants to hear again, and she wants the thing in her ears to leave, and she wants, though she would never write it on the slate, to go back in. She fears that the listener is learning. Lately when she is near a Hand-line, the silence round her deepens, as if something were leaning forward.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** The blank in the drawing is not empty. At the center of Dunmere, among the reeds behind the reed-chapel, she saw a hand: grey, smooth, seamless, as long as a punt, lying palm upward in the mud with the fingers slightly curled, as a hand lies open on a sleeper's knee. It did not move. It was not a statue. She did not draw it because she was afraid that drawing it would finish it, and she does not know what a finished hand would do.

**Secret she does not know:** She is no longer subject to the Rule of the Land. If she dies in Sallowreach, she will not rise Kept. She will finish, cleanly, and a new Hush will open where she falls. She is the first Hush-walker; the adversaries of that name (see the Adversaries chapter) are what she is becoming.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — her employer for the Glovehall measurements; Edda has told her, in writing, which wing the Hush is coming from.
- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — the man who sat with her when she walked out. The only person she lets stand close.
- ◇ **Dunstan Reave** — has begged her to guide him to his own roof. She has not said no.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — has asked her three times what is inside. Edda has written, three times, *It is listening*.
- ◇ **Provost Carrion Sedge** — her figures are his data. He has asked for the drawing. She has refused.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Edda at a Hush edge, measuring, or are hired to escort her through the fen. She is brusque, practical, and grateful for anyone who will write instead of shout.

- ◇ **The Measure.** The Court sends PCs with Edda to measure the new Hush in the Jar Room. Under the Hall of Hands the silence round her is deeper than anywhere she has been since Dunmere.
- ◇ **Guide.** Dunstan Reave and the Heirs both pay her to take them in. She agrees to take one. She does not say which.

- ◇ **The Blank.** A PC who studies the drawing (Eye + Reckoning, Grim 18) works out the blank's size and shape. That night every PC dreams of a hand closing over their eyes.

Faced with threat, Edda simply stands still; attackers within three paces find their own war-cries gone and their nerve with them. Faced with kindness she writes *thank you* on the slate and underlines it twice. Faced with the god she listens, and something listens back. If nobody intervenes, Edda walks back into Dunmere in Grace 642, alone, with a slate that says *I want to see if it has moved*, and does not come out; and the next month the Hush has grown a mile overnight, toward Lastgate, in the shape of a pointing finger.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Stood next to her at the edge once. My heartbeat stopped. In my ears, I mean. I knew it was going, I could feel it. I couldn't hear it. Never been so frightened." — Fen Guard private, Dunmere cordon

"She is the only reliable instrument the Court possesses, and she is broken." — Provost Carrion Sedge

"She don't smell. Don't trust anyone in Lastgate that don't smell."  
— a lamplighter on Needle Street





# BRAM HOLLIN

*the Last Mourner*

*“The first song is for the washing. The second is for the coin. The sixth, my father said, is not for the dead at all, and I was never to sing it at a table.”*

– BRAM HOLLIN, TO THE FAMILY OF JOSIAH ROOK, 641

| BRAM HOLLIN – THE LAST MOURNER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | Sallowreach · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                  | Born 581 A.G.; living, 60; professional mourner, the last of a trade six centuries extinct                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING             | Celebrant · Standing 3 (the Court hires him; the Finishers hire him; everyone wants him)                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                         | Rites 5, Lore 4, Resolve 4, Persuade 3, Instinct 3, Stitching 2 (the washing of the dead), Endure 1                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                           | Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                          | the Six Last Songs (once per scene, leading the rite over a properly dead body removes 3 Fray from all who join, instead of 2; the sixth song, sung, has effects the GM decides); the Words Over the Body (as the Celebrant Talent) |
| WANTS                          | Finish (he cannot leave a song or a rite unfinished; resist Hard 14)                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                         | Old Grief; Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                   | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                        | the black coat; the rosemary; the washing-cloths; the coin-purse; his father’s book; a pitch-pipe                                                                                                                                   |
| DREAD                          | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Bram Hollin is small, neat and soft-spoken, with a round bald head fringed in white, pale wet eyes and a face built for sorrow, with the long upper lip and drooping corners of a man who has practised it. His black coat is the one his grandfather wore, gone green at the seams, brushed every morning. He smells of rosemary, which he grows in pots on every sill of his house on Pellet Row and carries in every pocket. He weeps easily, professionally, beautifully: tears rise and spill on cue, in silence, and stop when the rite says. Lately they do not always stop.

## THEIR STORY

The Hollins were mourners before the Gorging. After the Meal the trade ended in a week, and the Hollins kept it anyway: for six hundred and forty years father taught son the full rite, word-perfect, over a straw dummy in an attic, for a job none of them could do. In 619 Bram’s father made him swear it on his grandfather’s Kept jaw, and then asked him to close the oath by singing the six songs over it. Bram sang to the fifth. His father stopped him there.

Bram was a scrivener for forty years. In 641 the Court called him to stand mourner at Josiah Rook’s Closing, the first proper death a

Hollin had mourned since the Gorging. He watched the long rot go out of Mr. Rook in a breath, went home, was sick, and sat up all night reading the songs as if for the first time. He had not known until then what they were for.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Since Grace 641 everyone wants him. The Court pays him twenty lacks to stand mourner at licensed Closings, which lends them dignity. The Finishers pay him in secret to teach their Singers the old songs. Families of those closed by accident, by Heirs or by Hushes come to his door asking for a funeral, a thing none of them has ever seen. He does not refuse. He is booked through Carving.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The black coat** — his grandfather’s, green at the seams. The inner pockets hold rosemary, cloths, coin and a pencil.
- ◇ **Rosemary** — bundles of it, fresh from the sill. For the dead, for the smell, for Henna Farrow, who buys a sprig a week.
- ◇ **The coin-purse** — old pre-Gorging coins of copper, worn faceless, one for each tongue. There are eleven left. Nobody has minted any in six centuries.



- ◇ **His father's book** — the rite, written out in 402 by a Hollin who feared the family would forget. The sixth song is on the last page, and the last page has a seventh line that has been inked over.
- ◇ **A pitch-pipe** — bone, sounding a low G. The keening begins on it.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Bram wants to do his trade properly, now that he finally can: every rite whole, every song finished. He fears that he has been hired by a country to give it the thing it has wanted for six hundred years, and that he is about to be very busy.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He is teaching the Finishers, which the Court would call aiding the theft of licensed goods. The Court would jar him for it. He does it because the Finishers' songs are wrong in places and it offends him.

**Secret he does not know:** The sixth song is not a song of farewell. It is a song of welcome, addressed to a guest who is to be "kept a place for at the end of the board," and its inked-over seventh line names that guest. When Bram sings at a Hush edge, the grey line comes a little closer. When he sang the first five over his grandfather's jaw, his father stopped him, and told him the reason was the sixth was too sad. It was not the reason.

### TIES

- ◇ **Henna Farrow** — his neighbor. He has promised to sing for Amos, when it happens, and to learn the weir-men's songs first.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn** — his secret employer. He thinks her voice is the finest he has ever heard and her lyrics are dreadful.
- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — he stands mourner at her Closings. She has never spoken to him. Last month she asked him, through her clerk, whether there is a song for the Closer.
- ◇ **Little Nell Ash** — has asked him to teach her the whole rite. He has started, on Tuesdays.

### IN PLAY

PCs meet Bram at a Closing, at a funeral, or because they need someone to tell them what to do with a body that has, for the first time in their lives, properly died.

- ◇ **The Last Verse.** Bram is hired to mourn a living woman closed by accident. Halfway through, the corpse begins to whisper *company*.
- ◇ **The Inked Line.** A Cutwright offers the PCs money for a sight of Bram's book. Under the ink, the seventh line can be read with lamp-black and patience (Eye + Search, Grim 18). Reading it aloud is a Dread 3.

- ◇ **The Busy Season.** Bram has booked nine funerals in one week, all for elders taken to the Hushes by Heirs. He asks the PCs to help, and to notice that the families are relieved.

Faced with threat, Bram freezes and then sings. Faced with kindness he cries, real tears, and is embarrassed by the difference. Faced with the god he takes off his hat. If nobody intervenes, Bram is jarred for aiding the Finishers in 642, and the trade ends with him: but in the Jar Room, every night, a head in green glass mouths six songs to the shelf, and the shelf learns them.

### SAID OF THEM

"He cried at my uncle's Closing. Proper crying, like he knew him. He didn't know him. That's the job, he says." — a carter, the Landing

"Mr. Hollin's songs are very beautiful. I want to know what they're for before I let him sing any more of them." — Little Nell Ash

"Six hundred years they practised. You'd want to make it count." — Henna Farrow

# IDONY PASK

the Tourist

*“Write it down, would you? ’Dear Tansy. Still not dead. Still hungry. Weather foul. Your loving sister.’ Same as last week. Seal it nice.”*

– IDONY PASK, DICTATING TO A HIRED LETTER-WRITER, LASTGATE, 641

| IDONY PASK – THE TOURIST |                                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | The Fatlands (living in Sallowreach) · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite, Ummer’s) · Hunger 7                                                         |
| AGE & STATION            | Born 590 A.G. in Low Tilth; came north 624; died 627 (aged thirty-seven); Kept; lodger in the Sinks                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Factor (once, a grain clerk) · Standing 1                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                   | Persuade 3, Reckoning 3, Lore 3 (letters, the Fatlands), Feast 4, Haggle 3, Deceive 2, Endure 2                                                                              |
| BODY                     | Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                  | teeth +3 (1; on a hit, Taste the Name)                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                    | Kept (Rot 5, Loose; the wasting keeps her shedding); Iron Belly; Taste the Name; Gorge (useless; nothing she eats stays)                                                     |
| WANTS                    | The Second Plate (she cannot see food without chewing it); The Long Pig (every Kept in Sallowreach smells like supper to her; resist Hard 14, Grim 18 for someone she likes) |
| KNACKS                   | Table Manners; Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS             | The Hollow Plate (food tastes of ash; she chews it anyway)                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                  | the letters; the Fatlands shawl; a spit-dish; a lead bit; a ledger of meals; a fork                                                                                          |
| DREAD                    | 2 (to watch her eat)                                                                                                                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

Idony was a big woman once, by Fatlands measure a slender one at two hundred pounds. Now she is skin on a frame: a creature of cords and knuckles, the jaw prominent, the eyes huge in their pits, the hands like bundles of twigs in a bright Fatlands shawl embroidered with fat red hens. She smells of sour milk and decay, a sharp smell, since the wasting eats what the rot would have. Her voice is warm, Low Tilth, quick and funny, and she talks constantly about food. She is bright, bitter and excellent company, and her laugh comes out as a dry rattle.

## THEIR STORY

Idony Pask was a granary clerk in Low Tilth, beloved aunt of six. At thirty she began to thin, and in the Fatlands a thin woman is sick, criminal or Thin, and the law treats them alike. In 624 she sold her share of the family hogs and asked Tam Ruddock to take her north. She was his first. She did not die of the wasting, not in the way she had feared. She died in 627 in a boarding house on Ratline Boards, sat up, and the wasting went on.

She is hungry. She was hungry in the Fatlands and is hungrier now, with Ummer’s endless hunger in a body that cannot keep

food. She chews and spits. She cannot leave: the Drop would finish her in a heartbeat. She has written home to her sister Tansy every week since 624. The replies stopped in 631.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She earns two crumbs a page writing letters for illiterate Kept, spends Tam’s weekly coins on food to chew, and pays Fatlands carters to carry her letters south. The Sinks cookshops let her sit, chew and spit, because she tells them what is wrong with their gravy.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The letters** — a box of copies, seven hundred and twenty, one a week. And eleven replies from Tansy, the last dated Lack 631, which says only, *Darling, the Board has been asking.*
- ♦ **The shawl** — embroidered by Tansy, red hens on yellow. It is the last thing that smells of home, and it no longer does.
- ♦ **A spit-dish** — pewter, from the Fatlands, for the chewed food. She carries it everywhere and is never without something to put in it.
- ♦ **A ledger of meals** — every meal she has chewed since 627, rated out of ten. None is above three.
- ♦ **A Fatlands fork** — silver, broad-tined, her grandmother’s.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know what happened to her family. She wants to eat one meal that stays. She would like, though she says it only when drunk on fen-gin she cannot swallow, to finish, but she cannot afford a license and will not walk into a Hush, because a Fatlander does not leave the table early.

She fears her Want. Every Kept in Sallowreach smells to her like Sunday supper, and she has begun to sit too close to them.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** In 639, after a week without anything to chew, she bit a shelved woman in the Lofts on a visit, and swallowed, and for an hour, for the first time in twelve years, she felt full. She knows the woman's family, her Cut, and the thing the woman was most ashamed of eating. She has not done it again. She thinks about it every day.

**Secret she does not know:** The GM chooses. The letters were seized by the Board of Plenty, which treats every letter from a thin Fatlander abroad as Thin propaganda. Or Tansy died in 631, and was served at her own wake, as Fatlanders are, and the family did not know how to write that. Or Tansy is on her way north, thin, with a letter for Tam Ruddock.

## TIES

- ◇ **Tam Ruddock** — the man who brought her here. She shouts at him every week. She would be lost without him.
- ◇ **Mother Gall** — has told her the truth about the barrels: her flesh would keep but her hunger would not.
- ◇ **Castellan Dray** — has interviewed her about foreigners Kept in the north. She charged him a meal.
- ◇ **Marrow Jack** — has offered her a new jaw, from stock. She knows where his stock comes from.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Idony in a Sinks cookshop or because she wants them to carry a letter south and come back with an answer. She pays in a dead aunt's silver fork, and gossip.

- ◇ **To Low Tilth.** PCs carry a letter to the Pasks. What they find (see Secrets) must be brought back across the Drop to a woman who cannot follow.
- ◇ **The Bite.** A shelved woman in the Lofts accuses a visitor of eating her. The Wardens ask PCs to find out who.
- ◇ **A Meal That Stays.** A Fatlands cook in the Sinks claims to have a recipe that will feed a Kept. It is made of the Kept.

Faced with threat, she laughs; faced with kindness, she cries without moisture; faced with her god, she eats. If nobody intervenes, Idony bites again in 642, and again, and the Lofts begin to lock their doors, and Tam Ruddock finds her one night on the fourth floor of Hall Two, full and weeping.

## SAID OF THEM

"Best company in the Sinks. Don't sit next to her." — a cookshop owner on Ratline Boards

"She told me my eel needed mustard. She was right. She can't even eat it." — another cook, aggrieved

"She asked me if it hurt, when you got used to it. I said you never get used to it. She said that's what she was afraid of." — Tam Ruddock

# NEW FACES OF SALLOWREACH

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*Every face in Lastgate is new to somebody. Most of them are also very old.*

— LOFT-WARDEN'S SAYING

The core chapter introduced five new Sallowreachers beyond the old cast. They are given full dossiers here, in shorter form, together

with two more: a man who tars over a carving, and a son who has never been touched.

# FENWICK LISP

## Interpreter of Jaw-Clicks

*“Master Strake says (click, click-click) that Master Mallory is a liar and a thief and a poor judge of eels. Master Mallory replies... well. I shan’t repeat that. I shall paraphrase.”*

– FENWICK LISP, THE ROOM OF THE LONG ARGUMENT, ANY EVENING

| FENWICK LISP – INTERPRETER OF JAW-CLICKS |                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                            | Born 470 A.G.; Kept since 501 (died at thirty-one); sworn interpreter to the Courts of Lastgate since 520        |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Clausewright · Standing 3 (sworn before the Court of Wrongs)                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 2                                                              |
| SKILLS                                   | Deceive 5, Persuade 4, Clause 4, Lore 4, Instinct 3, Resolve 2                                                   |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (lacquer) · Fray 7                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                  | none                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                    | Kept (Rot 4); reads every click-code in the north: jaw-clicks, weir-code, the knocks of the Brinemoss barrels    |
| WANTS                                    | Finish (he cannot let a sentence go unfinished; he finishes other people’s)                                      |
| KNACKS                                   | Little Lies; Elder’s Ear                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | The Gaslight (he no longer knows which half of the Argument he has invented)                                     |
| CARRIES                                  | an ivory tally; the transcript-books; a pocket of cloves for the room; a brass ear-trumpet; his own clicking jaw |
| DREAD                                    | 1                                                                                                                |

### WHO THEY ARE

Fenwick is gaunt, courteous and threadbare, in a scrivener’s coat buttoned to the chin, with a lacquered jaw of his own (black, glossy, hinged with brass pins) that he clicks softly while he thinks, a sound like knitting needles. His voice is a warm, educated tenor that comes from a throat which no longer needs air. He smells of cloves, ink and the sweet. He bows to everyone.

### THEIR STORY

Fenwick died of a fall on the Weir Steps in 501 and lost his tongue to rot by 515. He learned to talk with his jaw like the other tongueless Kept, and then learned all their dialects, and by 520 was the Court’s sworn interpreter. In 524 he was hired to interpret the Long Argument between Abel Strake and Cobb Mallory, who had lost their tongues decades before. He has interpreted it nightly for a hundred and seventeen years. He has not translated it accurately since 560, when, one evening, Strake clicked *I am tired*, Cobb, and Mallory clicked *So am I*, and Fenwick, who had nowhere else to be, translated it as a fresh insult.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the voice of every tongueless Kept in a city with thousands of them: in courts, at wills, at Closings, where the subject’s three consents must be heard. His sworn word is law. The Court relies on him and has never once checked him.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The transcript-books** — sixty volumes of the Argument, beautifully kept, nearly all fiction.
- ♦ **An ivory tally** — for counting clicks when they come fast.
- ♦ **A brass ear-trumpet** — for the faint clicks of the very far gone.
- ♦ **Cloves** — scattered on the floor of the Room each evening, for the crowd.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants company. He fears that both men know what he has done.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He has heard Amos Farrow’s jaw clicking *let go* in weir-code from the street on Pellet Row for years, and has told no one. If Henna learned it, she would need him to swear it before the Court. Then he would have to stand in the Hall of Closings, and say it truthfully, and watch.

**Secret he does not know:** Strake and Mallory both know. They have known since 562. They come every night because the Room is the only place in Lastgate where anyone speaks to them as people, and because they are fond of him.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Abel Strake and Cobb Mallory** — his clients, his audience, his friends, though he would never say so.
- ◇ **Henna Farrow** — see above.
- ◇ **Justice Ever Lathe** — Fenwick interprets for the Court of Wrongs when Absalom Pike is ill; he suspects Pike of doing what he does.
- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — he hears the three consents at her Closings. Twice, he has heard *no* and said *yes*, out of pity.

#### IN PLAY

PCs need Fenwick whenever a tongueless Kept has something to tell them. He is charming, obliging and unreliable in exactly one way. Hooks: Henna Farrow needs his testimony; a will is contested and only his reading of the dead man's clicks can settle it; the Long Argument suddenly reaches an outcome, and Fenwick did not write it. Faced with threat, he apologises. If nobody intervenes, he goes on forever, which is the whole problem.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Best night out on the Sinks is the Argument. Nobody knows who's winning. That's the fun." — a bettor

"He is a gentleman. Gentlemen are the best liars." — Lady Corrow Vane

"Click, click-click." — Abel Strake (translated by Fenwick as "Good evening")

# MERRIT CASK

*Keeper of the Jar Room*

*“Number one, Tobias Harrow, sedition, three hundred and four. Morning, Mr. Harrow.  
Number two...”*

— MERRIT CASK, THE MORNING READING, EVERY DAY

| MERRIT CASK – KEEPER OF THE JAR ROOM |                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Sallowreach · Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 1              |
| AGE & STATION                        | Born 597 A.G.; living, 44; Keeper of the Jar Room, third of her line |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Warden · Standing 2 (a Court servant, unseen)                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                  |
| SKILLS                               | Search 3, Resolve 3, Labor 2, Lore 2, Craft 2                        |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 6               |
| ATTACKS                              | cudgel +3 (3, Stunning)                                              |
| GIFTS                                | Lidsense (she knows which jars have their eyes open)                 |
| WANTS                                | Close (lids, every one; she checks the seals forty times a night)    |
| KNACKS                               | Butcher’s Calm; Vinegar Kiss                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none yet                                                             |
| CARRIES                              | the cudgel; the label-book; lead and solder; a duster; her chair     |
| DREAD                                | 0                                                                    |

**MERRIT CASK** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) ·  
Armor 1 · Dread 0

## WHO THEY ARE

Merrit is solid, square-faced and plain, in a leather apron and lye-stiff sleeves, with lamp-oil on her fingers. She has her mother’s patience and none of her mother’s calm. She reads the labels aloud every morning in a flat clear voice, all of them, so that the heads know they have not been forgotten.

## THEIR STORY

Her grandmother kept the Jar Room, and her mother, Dorcas Cask, who died in 615 and kept it Kept until her hands went in 628. Merrit took the keys at thirty-one. Her mother sits in a chair at the vault door still, supervising. In the Carving of 641, nine of the oldest jars went silent at once, in a single night. Merrit found the jars in the morning: the heads inside were properly dead, smooth, unrotted. There were no flies on that end of the shelf. The Court sent a clerk, who told her it had not happened.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the Court’s worst sentence made flesh: the woman who keeps it. She dusts the jars, oils the lead seals, sweeps the drains, and admits visitors (two lacks, for the families who still come). The Court forgets she exists. The heads do not.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The label-book** — every jar, name, crime and date, including the nine silent ones, whose entries she has not crossed out.
- ◇ **Lead and solder** — for resealing.
- ◇ **A cudgel** — for the rare visitor who tries to break a jar, out of mercy or spite.
- ◇ **Her chair** — a kitchen chair she moves a little further down the vault, away from the silent end, every night.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be told the truth. She fears the shelf, which has begun whispering about who will be next.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** Jar nine, at the center of the silent nine, held Edric Grue, the Regent’s own younger brother, jarred in 304 for an unlicensed Closing. A Hand-line. The Hush began from him.



**Secret she does not know:** The next Hand-line jar along the shelf, Lady Sybil Hethe (jarred 377), is directly above where her chair now stands. She has been moving toward it.

**TIES**

- ◇ **Dorcas Cask** — her Kept mother, at the door, who tells her to stop moving the chair.
- ◇ **Withhold Pennick** — Pennick’s three captured bandmates are in jars 611 to 613; Pennick has sent a note asking which ones still talk.
- ◇ **Bram Hollin** — she would like him to sing over the nine.
- ◇ **Edda Thrush** — the Court is about to send her to measure the Jar Room.

**IN PLAY**

PCs meet Merrit when they need to speak to a jarred head, smuggle one out, or learn the truth of the silent nine. Hooks: a family pays the PCs to get their ancestor’s jar out before the silence reaches it; Pennick asks for her comrades; the Court orders the vault sealed with Merrit inside. Faced with threat, she swings first. If nobody intervenes, the silence takes the next nine jars in Lack 641, and Merrit, sitting in her chair beneath them, goes quiet with them.

**SAID OF THEM**

- “She reads us our names every morning. Nobody else has said my name in two hundred years.” — a head, jar 40, via Fenwick Lisp
- “Plain as a pudding, steady as a post.” — Dorcas Cask, Kept, of her daughter
- “Who’d want that job? Somebody’s got to.” — a Hall of Hands porter

# WITHHOLD PENNICK

## the Stranded Reckoner

*“I cut his throat to the bone. He sat up and rang for his man. What do you do with a country like that? I’ll tell you. You find the one door it has.”*

— WITHHOLD PENNICK, TO JORY WELT, 640

| WITHHOLD PENNICK – THE STRANDED RECKONER |                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | The Fast (stranded in Sallowreach) · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 7 (Wasting)    |
| AGE & STATION                            | Born 611 A.G.; living, 30; Knife of a Reckoner band, the last free member of it    |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Reckoner · Standing 2 (Knife)                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                |
| SKILLS                                   | Blades 4, Stealth 4, Resolve 4, Wayfaring 3, Athletics 2, Search 2, Endure 2       |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 12 (8 while Wasting) · Guard 18 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                           |
| ATTACKS                                  | black-iron long knife +8 (3, Silent; +4 vs the unaware, +2 vs Cut 3+); a garrotte  |
| GIFTS                                    | none; the Unfed have Want instead (Nothing to Hold: +4 to resist a Closer’s touch) |
| WANTS                                    | the Refusal (she will not eat what she did not carry herself)                      |
| KNACKS                                   | No Thank You; Light Sleeper                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none; she is beginning to recite recipes in her sleep                              |
| CARRIES                                  | the knife; the list; an empty ration bag; an eel-trap; a punt-hook                 |
| DREAD                                    | 0                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Wiry, sinewed, grey-eyed, her head shaved to the scalp, in dark clothes washed every day in clean water she carries from the Landing’s rain-butts. She smells of nothing but cold water and lye, which in the Sinks makes her conspicuous. She is appalled by everything: the smell, the Kept, the food. She is starving.

### THEIR STORY

She crossed the Finishing Post in Carving 639 with a band of five, to end the line of Lord Osgood Wole, a lesser Hand-line. She reached his bed. She cut his throat. He sat up, his head on a hinge of skin, and rang for his man. Captain Morrow’s guards took three of her band, who are now in the Jar Room. One escaped south. She went to ground in the Sinks. She has been there two years.

Her ration ran out in the first month. She eats only what she has carried herself: fen-eels from a trap she set with her own hands, which she argues is carrying, and which she eats lively and hates. It is not enough.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the Court’s most wanted fugitive and the Heirs’ strangest ally. Jory Welt’s cells hide her, and she has begun to work out what they

already know: a lord cannot be killed, but he can be dragged into a Hush.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The long knife** — black iron, unoled. Useless here. She sharpens it every night.
- ◇ **The list** — the Wole kin-tree, from the Reckoners’ kin-reader. Eleven names. None crossed out.
- ◇ **An empty ration bag** — she carries it still.
- ◇ **An eel-trap** — wicker, set and lifted by her own hands, every night.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to finish her oath and go home. She fears starving; if she dies here she will rise Kept, Unfed and godless, and never leave.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** She has already dragged one lord into a Hush: an old Sedge cousin, in Lack 640, at Cotter’s Ditch. It worked. She was sick for a day afterward, and then hungry.

**Secret she does not know:** Lord Wole has a Hush forming in his own cellar. If she waits, the god will do her work.

## TIES

- ◇ **Jory Welt** — her host; he is starting to fear what she is teaching his cells.
- ◇ **Captain Dace Morrow** — has nearly caught her four times. She knows he let her go.
- ◇ **Merrit Cask** — keeps her bandmates' jars.
- ◇ **Idony Pask** — Withhold finds the Fatlander revolting and cannot stop visiting her; they talk about food.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet her as hunters (Morrow's bounty, 500 lacks), as allies of the Heirs, or as someone who needs a killer in a country that cannot die. Hooks: get her bandmates' jars out; feed her without breaking the Refusal; stop her at the edge of a Hush with a bound lord. Faced with threat, she strikes once and vanishes; faced with kindness she refuses it, and gains Want. If nobody intervenes, she reaches Pangs 10 in Lack 641, and dies on a Sinks floor, and sits up Kept: an Unfed corpse in the land of the god of death, who cannot go home.

## SAID OF THEM

"She looked at my supper like it was a dog's mess. Then she looked at it like she'd kill for it." — an Heir, the Sinks

"I respect her. I'd still like her in a jar." — Captain Dace Morrow

"There's a clean woman in the Sinks. Nobody can work out what's wrong with her." — a laundress

# LORD ABSALOM HETHE

## Hand of the Court, Second Table

*“Do sit. No, not that one. That one is spoken for. It always has been.”*

– LORD HETHE, TO A DINNER GUEST, HETHE HOUSE

| LORD ABSALOM HETHE – HAND OF THE COURT, SECOND TABLE |                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                           | Sallowreach · Cut 4 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                 |
| AGE & STATION                                        | Born 593 A.G.; living, 48; Hand of the Court; secretly of the Second Table                             |
| CALLING & STANDING                                   | Scion · Standing 4 (Hand of the Court)                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                                           | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                    |
| SKILLS                                               | Deceive 5, Clause 4, Persuade 4, Lore 3, Feast 3, Blades 2, Endure 2                                   |
| BODY                                                 | Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                              | rapier +5 (4)                                                                                          |
| GIFTS                                                | Lidsense; The Shutting; Cold Fingers (he wears dove-grey mittens of the finest kid)                    |
| WANTS                                                | Close                                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                                               | Smell of Cedar; Table Manners                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                                         | none; he is entirely sane, which is the horror of him                                                  |
| CARRIES                                              | the dining room; rubbings; Fatlands recipes; the lead coffin’s plans; a ledger of bends; a carving-set |
| DREAD                                                | 1                                                                                                      |

### WHO THEY ARE

Handsome, florid, broad-chested, with a beautifully barbered auburn beard and dove-grey mittens. He smells of myrrh and claret. His voice is a rich, amused baritone. He is the most delightful host in Lastgate, and the only man who visits Osric Vane without fear.

### THEIR STORY

Absalom inherited the Hethe seat at thirty, when his Kept father was Set Aside, a rare thing among the Hand-lines (Hethe paid for it). He was approached by the Second Table in 625, at a dinner in Sated, over a dish he still dreams of. He has prepared ever since. His plan is simple: when a god is ready to be eaten again, it must first be held still. The Hand-lines can close. Osric Vane, at the Brink, can close anything. Carried in a lead coffin to the Rim, Osric could still a regrowing god on the table.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

As a Hand of the Court he may grant one Closing a year without fee, and he sits on the Quiet Market party, which wants to sell Hushes as estates. Through Ivo Vane he buys the seasonal bend in the Closing list. He uses both to remove obstacles quietly.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The dining room** — at Hethe House, eight chairs; the eighth, at the end, is carved with a figure chiseled out, copied from a College rubbing. Nobody sits there.
- ◇ **Rubbings** — from the Ferrying Post, made every few years by the Tarman, of the gouge as it reopens.
- ◇ **Fatlands recipes** — a bound collection, including one written in a hand nobody can identify, for a dish served to “the guest at the end.”
- ◇ **The lead coffin’s plans** — drawn by a Vigil clockmaker; breathing holes lined with lead mesh.
- ◇ **A carving-set** — black-handled, never used. It was a gift from the Second Table.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to sit at the second meal. He fears nothing he will admit to; privately, he fears the eighth chair, and sets it every night.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He is the Second Table’s man on the Court and plans to carry Osric to the Rim. He has also been buying Marrow Jack’s Cradlewrack Parts and Halloway’s grey joints, for a friend in Cradlewrack who is assembling something.

**Secret he does not know:** Lady Corrow Vane has known about him since 638, and lets him visit Osric because she hopes he will take

her brother away.

## TIES

- ◇ **Osric Vane** — his weekly visit; his future instrument. They play chess. Osric wins.
- ◇ **Ivo Vane** — sells him the list's bend each season.
- ◇ **Provost Sedge** — he wants the Map. He is patient.
- ◇ **Ebb Totter** — pays him a lack a rubbing.
- ◇ **Sister Lorn's Lamp Orla Fenn** — his informer.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Hethe as a patron (generous, charming, paying lavishly for odd errands: a rubbing, a Part, a recipe from Sated). Hooks: escort a lead coffin "of wine" to Fogmouth; dine with him and be asked not to sit in a certain chair; discover a Closing he granted was a murder. If nobody intervenes, Osric leaves Glovehall in the lead coffin in Grace 642 and Sallowreach's Hushes, without their strongest source, slow, for a season, while somewhere on the Rim a god is held still.

### SAID OF THEM

"Lovely man. Tips in platters." — a Hethe House footman

"Absalom eats as if he is practising." — Lady Corrow Vane

"He asked me how a god tastes. I said I've only had the one." — Grandfather Peat, as translated by Provost Sedge

# DUNSTAN REAVE

*the Last of Dunmere*

*“From here, on a clear night, you can see my roof. Second from the chapel. That’s my chimney. No smoke. Course not.”*

– DUNSTAN REAVE, AT THE DUNMERE EDGE

| DUNSTAN REAVE – THE LAST OF DUNMERE |                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | Sallowreach · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0                                            |
| AGE & STATION                       | Born 606 A.G.; living, 35; reed-cutter, guide to the Dunmere edge                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | Delver · Standing 1                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2                                                |
| SKILLS                              | Wayfaring 4, Labor 3, Search 3, Athletics 2, Endure 2, Blades 1                                    |
| BODY                                | Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (oilskin) · Fray 8                                                   |
| ATTACKS                             | reed-hook +4 (3, Hooking)                                                                          |
| GIFTS                               | none                                                                                               |
| WANTS                               | none of the god’s                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                              | Corpse-Road Walker; Scrap-Born Luck                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | The Pull (roused by any clear evening at the edge)                                                 |
| CARRIES                             | the spyglass; a reed-hook; a coil of marked rope; his wife’s comb; a tin of the children’s buttons |
| DREAD                               | 0                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Weathered, tall, quiet, with reed-cuts on his hands and a beard grown out since 633. He smells of smoke and wet wool. He speaks in short sentences and looks past people, north.

## THEIR STORY

Dunstan was a reed-cutter of Dunmere with a wife, Sabine, two children, and his Kept parents in the back room. On the night Dunmere went silent he was not, as he tells it, at market. He had quarrelled with Sabine and walked out, intending not to come back, and slept in a ditch on the Lastgate road. In the morning he walked home to apologise. The reeds were grey. He has camped at the edge every night since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He guides Finishers, Court surveyors, Heirs and the curious to the Dunmere edge for free, by paths no one else knows. The Finishers bring him food. Captain Morrow’s cordon lets him be.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The spyglass** — brass, Company-made, bought with every lack he had. From one hummock, on a clear evening, it shows his

roof.

- ♦ **Marked rope** — a coil marked every yard. He has tied it to a stake at the edge and, some nights, walked out along it in his mind.
- ♦ **Sabine’s comb** — horn, left in his coat pocket the night he walked out.
- ♦ **A tin of buttons** — from the children’s coats. He counts them.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants someone who goes in to come back and tell him whether they looked peaceful. He fears they will say yes.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He walked out on them. He has told no one.

**Secret he does not know:** Edda Thrush’s drawing shows his house. Sabine is lying in the kitchen doorway, facing the road, as if she had gone to the door to look for him.

## TIES

- ♦ **Edda Thrush** — he has begged her to guide him in.
- ♦ **Sister Lorn** — sits with him; neither will say why the other cannot walk in.

- ◇ **Jory Welt** — the Heirs use his paths. He does not ask what for.
- ◇ **Bram Hollin** — is planning him a funeral without bodies.

#### IN PLAY

He is the PCs' guide to Dunmere. Hooks: carry his spyglass in and look at his roof from the inside; stop him the night he decides to follow the rope; bring back Sabine's comb's twin from the kitchen. If nobody intervenes, he goes in on the first clear night of Plenty 642, holding the rope, and the rope goes slack at a yard marked *forty-one*.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"He guided us to the edge and wouldn't take a crumb. Said, 'Just tell me.' Tell him what?" — a Fatlands traveler

"Best paths in the north fen. He knows every dry hummock to Dunmere." — Captain Morrow

"He counts buttons. I've seen him. Two little coats' worth." — a Finisher Singer

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# EBB TOTTER

*the Tarman of the Ferrying Post*

*“I tar it. It opens. I tar it. That’s the job. You don’t ask a job what it wants.”*

– EBB TOTTER, THE LANDING

| EBB TOTTER – THE TARMAN OF THE FERRYING POST |                                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                   | Sallowreach · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                                | Born 302 A.G.; Kept since 338 (died at thirty-six, of a fall from the Post); the Court’s tarman since 341 |
| CALLING & STANDING                           | none (a Court laborer; Standing 1, unchanged in three hundred years)                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                                   | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                       |
| SKILLS                                       | Craft 3, Labor 3, Resolve 4, Endure 2, Search 2                                                           |
| BODY                                         | Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 (three centuries of tar) · Fray 7                                           |
| ATTACKS                                      | tar-brush +3 (1); he has never needed one                                                                 |
| GIFTS                                        | Kept (Rot 7, Ruinous, but the tar holds him)                                                              |
| WANTS                                        | none                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                                       | Silent Supper; Unflinching                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                                 | The Count (he counts the times the gouge has reopened; it is always one short of what he wrote)           |
| CARRIES                                      | the tar-pot; the brush; the tally-stick; a ladder; a lump of wood                                         |
| DREAD                                        | 2 (to see him up close, glossy black, mostly tar)                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

A short, thick Kept man coated so many times in his own work that he is glossy black from crown to boots, cracked like old varnish at the joints, smelling hot and sweet of pine-tar. Only his eyes move freely. He speaks seldom, in a creak.

## THEIR STORY

The carving on the Ferrying Post shows a table with eight places, the eighth gouged out. In 341, the year Ansel Grue became Regent, the Court paid Ebb a crumb a week to tar it over, because the gouge kept looking fresh and the Landing whispered. He has tarred it every time it reopened since: three hundred and twelve times. He has never seen anyone open it. He sat up with it once, for a whole year in 509, never looking away. On the last night he blinked. In the morning it was open.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is part of the Landing: children dare one another to touch him, ferrymen nod. The Court has forgotten why it pays him. Lord Hethe has not.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The tar-pot and brush** — the pot is the same iron one since 341. In Sallowreach, its fire has never gone out.
- ◇ **The tally-stick** — a yard of oak, notched three hundred and twelve times.
- ◇ **A lump of wood** — pale, fresh, from inside the gouge, which he found on the mud under the Post in 640. It is cut cleanly by a tool he does not recognise.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to know who does it. He fears to know.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** The reopenings have grown more frequent: once a decade until 600; once a year since 633; three times since Tablenight 640.

**Secret he does not know:** The lump of wood, set against the gouge, fits; and if held to the ear it hums the low G of Bram Hollin’s pitch-pipe.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lord Hethe** — pays a lack a rubbing.
- ◇ **Tam Ruddock** — moors his punt at the Post; brings Ebb tar.

- ◇ **Grandfather Peat** — has, through Sedge, asked to be carried to the Post. Ebb would like that.
- ◇ **Bram Hollin** — Ebb asked him once whether there is a song for a chair nobody sits in.

#### IN PLAY

Hooks: watch the Post for a night (the GM decides what is seen: nothing, or a shadow without a body, or a PC's own hands with a chisel); deliver the lump of wood to Sedge; stop Hethe's men from cutting the carving out whole. If nobody intervenes, Ebb tars it until the Grace ends.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"Old Tarman? He's furniture." — a Landing ferry-boy

"He has outlasted every theory about that carving." — Provost Sedge

"Don't watch the Post on Tablenight. Just don't." — a fishwife

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# IVO VANE

## the Untouched

*“My mother has finished eleven thousand people. I’m the only one she’s taken care never to touch.”*

– IVO VANE, DRUNK, THE UPPER BOARDS

| IVO VANE – THE UNTOUCHED |                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | Sallowreach · Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                |
| AGE & STATION            | Born 601 A.G.; living, 40; Licenser of the Mortuary Court; Lady Corrow’s elder son                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Scion · Standing 2 (Licenser)                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                |
| SKILLS                   | Clause 4, Reckoning 3, Persuade 3, Lore 3, Deceive 3, Blades 2                                                     |
| BODY                     | Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                  | dress-sword +5 (4)                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                    | Lidsense; the Quiet Hand                                                                                           |
| WANTS                    | Close                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                   | Smell of Cedar; Kin-Sense (he always knows where his mother is)                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS             | The Devotion (to his mother, who has never once looked at him for longer than courtesy requires)                   |
| CARRIES                  | the license-seal; the waiting list; copies of Henna Farrow’s petitions; a child’s glove; a purse of Hethe platters |
| DREAD                    | 0                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Tall, ash-blond, very like his mother, with her stillness and none of her silence: he talks fast and laughs too loud. He smells of cedar and ink. He wears black kid gloves he does not yet need.

### THEIR STORY

Ivo was raised by nurses at Glovehall and taught to keep three paces from his mother. He has never touched her skin. At six he ran to her across a room; a nurse caught him at two paces and Lady Corrow did not move. He went into the Court’s service at twenty and became Licenser at thirty-one.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He drafts and seals every Closing license, and may bend the waiting list by one name a season. He sells that bend to Lord Hethe. He reads every petition, including all of Henna Farrow’s.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The license-seal** — the closed eye, in red wax.
- ◇ **The waiting list** — eight years long. His mother’s hand works down it.

- ◇ **Henna’s petitions** — copied, all forty-one. He does not know why.
- ◇ **A child’s glove** — his own, kid, age six, the one he took off to run to her.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants his mother to touch him once. He fears that she would, and what it would mean.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** He has drafted a license in his own name and signed the Regent’s signature himself. It is in his desk.

**Secret he does not know:** His mother keeps him at three paces because, at nine, he fell ill with a fever, and she sat by his bed all night with her gloved hand an inch above his forehead, and her hand began, through the glove, to close him. She has not forgiven herself.

### TIES

- ◇ **Lady Corrow Vane** — his mother. See above.
- ◇ **Osric Vane** — the uncle who writes him kind letters through the door.
- ◇ **Lord Hethe** — buys his bend.

◇ **Henna Farrow** — he has never met her, and thinks of her daily.

#### IN PLAY

Hooks: Ivo offers PCs a place on the list for a favor; he asks them to forge his mother's consent on his license; he moves Henna's petition to the top and needs Fenwick Lisp to swear. If nobody intervenes, he presents his forged license at the Hall of Closings in 642, in Chamber Five, and his mother's clerk unpicks nine stitches, and his mother sees whose name is on the license, and stops.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"Master Ivo's always polite. He holds the door, then shuts it very soft." — a Hall of Closings porter

"He's the only Vane who laughs. Not well." — Lord Hethe

"I'd rather be a Small than a Vane child." — Little Nell Ash

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# WEBS OF SALLOWREACH

*In Lastgate everybody owes everybody. The interest is the only thing that's ever paid.*

– MONEYLENDER'S PROVERB

Nothing in Sallowreach ends, and that includes grudges, debts and love. The table below sets out what the people of this half of the cast

want from one another, what they fear, and what they owe. Use it to decide who turns up when a PC pulls on any one thread.

| CHARACTER        | WANTS FROM                  | FEARS                        | OWES                          |
|------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Sister Lorn      | Nell Ash: her daughter      | that she enjoys walking back | Orla Fenn, her life           |
| Dace Morrow      | Sister Lorn: to be asked    | his men's next walk          | Thessaly Mort, sixty bodies   |
| Henna Farrow     | anyone: to tell Amos        | waking Kept beside him       | Aubin Coyle, eel lessons      |
| Tam Ruddock      | Idony: forgiveness          | the List                     | the Company, its cut          |
| Marrow Jack      | Thessaly: her name          | Nell's Smalls                | Nan Pickering, a season       |
| Little Nell Ash  | Pim Sorrel: fairness        | being alone                  | the Seamers, since 520        |
| Carrion Sedge    | Peat: the ledgers back      | his own hands                | every Court house, a pedigree |
| Mother Gall      | the Court: to be let be     | the edge reaching Brinemoss  | barrel one, a century         |
| Edda Thrush      | the listener: to leave      | going back in                | Dace Morrow, a night          |
| Bram Hollin      | his father's book: the line | the sixth song               | the Finishers, lessons        |
| Idony Pask       | Tansy: an answer            | her own teeth                | Tam, three hundred lacks      |
| Fenwick Lisp     | Strake and Mallory: company | being found out              | Henna, the truth              |
| Merrit Cask      | the Court: the truth        | the shelf                    | her mother, the keys          |
| Withhold Pennick | Jory Welt: a lord           | dying here                   | her band, their jars          |
| Absalom Hethe    | Osric Vane: his hands       | the eighth chair             | the Second Table, a god       |
| Dunstan Reave    | Edda: a way in              | that they looked peaceful    | Sabine, an apology            |
| Ebb Totter       | the Post: a culprit         | seeing who                   | the Court, three centuries    |
| Ivo Vane         | Corrow: one touch           | that she would               | Hethe, a season's bend        |

## THE THREE MOST EXPLOSIVE

**Lorn, Nell and Wren.** A mother who will not walk into the silence, a queen who will not let children into it, and a four-year-old girl, fifty-three years dead, who has asked to go and asked that her mother not be told. Sister Lorn holds a Bottled Hush she has never opened; Nell holds the key to the first stair; Pim Sorrel holds the

only hands in Lastgate that could close a Small. Every one of them is acting out of love. The moment Lorn learns that Wren asked, she will try to carry the jar down the stair herself, or march nine thousand Finishers to the Weir Steps, and four hundred Smalls will come up out of the green water to stop her. Whoever is standing on that stair (the PCs, most likely) decides whether Sallowreach sees its

first funeral for a child in six centuries, or its first war between the dead and the dead.

**Henna, Amos, Fenwick and Ivo.** A widow who cannot be one, a husband clicking *let go* through a painted smile, an interpreter who could swear to it and is afraid of what honest testimony would cost him, and a Licenser who has read all forty-one petitions and has, in his desk, the power to bend the list. Put any two of them in a room and the Court's oldest refusal can be overturned in a day. Put all four in the Hall of Closings and Lady Corrow Vane must close a man by her son's bend on an interpreter's oath, with the last mourner singing, and the Court will have to decide whether consent given in weir-code is consent. The precedent would empty the Lofts: forty thousand shelved Kept, whispering.

**Morrow, Jack and the hand.** The incorruptible captain is held together by stolen parts. His sword-hand belongs to a woman shelved in the Lofts who has felt it kill. Marrow Jack took it; Thessaly Mort sewed it on; Bettany Shroud's whisper-books recorded every grip. When this comes out (and in Sallowreach everything comes out, because nothing that knows a thing ever stops knowing it), Morrow will have to choose between arresting the Master Seamer who made him, and going on wearing the hand. The Guild will choose too, and if it strikes to protect Thessaly the Sinks will be knee-deep within the month, and the Fen Guard, held together by Guild thread, will come apart in the streets it is meant to hold.

# USING SALLOWREACH'S PEOPLE

*Shut the door, love. Somebody's knocking.*

— LASTGATE SAYING

When the PCs are lodging in Lastgate, or have made themselves known, or have simply stayed still long enough for the north to notice them, roll on this table. Each entry names who comes and

why. Most visitors are Kept and in no hurry; they will wait on the step all night if not let in.

| D20 | WHO'S AT THE DOOR?                       | WHY                                                                                                             |
|-----|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Sister Lorn                              | She needs someone to carry a jar down a flooded stair and will not say what is in it.                           |
| 2   | Sergeant Greer Abbot, for Captain Morrow | A cedar box, a lead case, and a question: can a finger cross the border?                                        |
| 3   | Henna Farrow                             | On two sticks, with eleven minutes of Closing in a jar: <i>Will you tell him?</i>                               |
| 4   | Tam Ruddock                              | A dying child at the Long Farewell, and he cannot face telling the mother the truth.                            |
| 5   | Marrow Jack                              | Friendly, clove-scented, offering a Hand-line finger for a fraction of its worth. Someone is missing one.       |
| 6   | A Small called Pip                       | The Queen requests the pleasure of the PCs' company in the schoolroom, now. Bring sweets.                       |
| 7   | A clerk of Provost Sedge                 | Paid work: a phial of blood from a Hand-line infant, before its christening.                                    |
| 8   | Mother Gall                              | Barrel one has started knocking in a new pattern, and she wants witnesses.                                      |
| 9   | Edda Thrush                              | A slate: <i>The silence moved last night. Toward your street. Come and measure.</i>                             |
| 10  | Bram Hollin                              | Nine funerals this week. He needs bearers, and someone to stand at the back and keep the Heirs out.             |
| 11  | Idony Pask                               | A sealed letter for Low Tilth and a silver fork as payment. Come back with an answer.                           |
| 12  | Fenwick Lisp                             | A tongueless Kept outside has something to say about the PCs, and only Fenwick can say it. Truthfully?          |
| 13  | Merrit Cask                              | Jar forty asked for them by name this morning. She has no idea how it knew.                                     |
| 14  | Withhold Pennick                         | Starving, knife out, wanting to know whether the PCs carried their own food here.                               |
| 15  | Lord Absalom Hethe's footman             | An invitation to dine at Hethe House. Eight chairs. Do not sit in the last.                                     |
| 16  | Dunstan Reave                            | A clear night is coming. Will they look through his spyglass at his roof?                                       |
| 17  | Ebb Totter, glossy with tar              | The carving opened again an hour ago. He wants someone else to see it before he tars it.                        |
| 18  | Ivo Vane                                 | A place on the Closing list, for one small favor in his mother's wing at Glovehall.                             |
| 19  | Fen Guard, on Captain Morrow's warrant   | The PCs were seen at a Hush edge with Finishers. The Captain would like a word. Politely.                       |
| 20  | Nobody                                   | The knock comes; the door opens on the empty Breath. On the step, a chair, pulled out, angled toward the house. |

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## RUNNING THIS CAST

Every person in this half of the chapter is waiting on something that has not come for six hundred years and is now, suddenly, arriving. Use that. Give each one a clock: Morrow's sixty-first death, Henna's next birthday, Sedge's Lack 642, the next nine jars, Dunstan's clear night. Let the PCs see the clocks. Then let them choose which ones to stop, knowing that in Sallowreach stopping something is the one thing the land forbids, and the one thing everyone is begging for. When in doubt, have someone knock, and have them be polite, and have them be dead, and have them want something that only ends.

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CHAPTER 2

# THE FATLANDS

*A Country at Table*

*Eat while it's warm. It won't be.*

– FATLAND PROVERB, STITCHED ON SAMPLERS OVER EVERY HOB FROM SATED TO THE SEA

*Five meals a day by law, and a sixth for the nerves, and a seventh for the dead. And still  
you wake in the night with your mouth open.*

– DR. EMMERICH PAUNCH, NOTES TOWARD A MEASURE OF THE SOUTHERN  
APPETITE, UNPUBLISHED, 640 A.G.

*Firstbite is at the fourth bell, before light, and Dilly Murch is up for it because the hunger is up for it. It is always up first. She lies on her pallet in the back room on Tallow Stair with her mouth already working on nothing, the taste of soil on her tongue from a dream she cannot remember, and listens to the whole of Sated waking in the dark around her: four hundred thousand bellies grumbling in their beds like a field of frogs.*

*Her mam has the pot on. The pot is always on. It has not been off since Gran's wake, nine years ago, and there is a scrap of Gran in it still, the family says, somewhere down in the black crust at the bottom where the spoon cannot reach. Dilly eats standing: a bowl of dripping-porridge with a skin on it, two slices of fried bread with the teeth sieved out, a cup of well-broth that tastes of beef and pennies. She thanks Granny Hessop's Rise, because that is the family field, and she thanks Long Acre, because the flour came from there, and she thanks her Gran, because the pot is Gran's. She wipes the bowl with the last of the bread. She is still hungry. Of course she is.*

*She is a Washer, second grade, in the Fold. She walks to work with her sponges and her tweezers through streets already crowded and already eating. The cookshops along Ladle Lanes never shut. The tallow lamps over them have been burning all night and the light is the colour of a cooked onion. A man at a brazier is turning sausages as thick as a child's wrist and singing to them. A Bailiff in a blue sash stands at the corner with his ladle of office, counting the plates going by. A drunk is asleep face-down on the warm cobbles, and the cobbles, Dilly would swear, are rising and falling a little beneath him, like a chest.*

*Her lady is Madam Gorrel Fenn, of the Fenns of the Fold, who weighs eleven hundred pounds and has not left her bed in four years. The house is all ramps and double doors and the floors are joisted like a bridge, and the smell when the Carriers open the bedroom is the smell of every Laden bedroom on the plain: warm loam, rosewater, old milk, and underneath, very faint, the smell of a field after rain. Dilly loves the smell. She is ashamed of how much.*

*The Carriers turn Madam on her great quilted pallet with ropes and pulleys, four of them heaving and grunting and saying up she comes, beauty, up she comes, and the flesh rolls over like a landslide in silk, and Dilly goes in with the sponge. She washes the folds one by one, lifting each with the brush-handle, sometimes with both arms. Inside the folds the skin is darker, red-brown and mottled like turned soil, and soft as proving dough, and it keeps the shape of her fingers for an hour. In the deeper creases, behind the knees and under the great overhang of the belly, there are the shoots. Little green threads, pale at the base. They come up every night. Dilly plucks them with the tweezers, one by one, and drops them in a dish. Madam Fenn says ah at each one, softly, the way you say ah when a splinter comes out. Seventy-three this morning. Yesterday it was sixty-eight. Dilly does not write the numbers down, because that is what the Long Count people do and she does not want the Bailiff looking at her, but she remembers them. She cannot help it.*

*In the afternoon Madam's feet need doing. Dilly does not like the feet. They are on an iron board at the end of the pallet, because iron is the only thing the roots will not take, and the soles are matted with fine white threads that have spent the night trying to find the floor. They have worked into the seams of the iron like hair into a comb. Dilly teases them free with a bone pick and a dab of salve and wipes them, and they curl round her fingers, warm and blind and searching, like the hands of a baby. One of them, this afternoon, does not let go. It wraps her smallest finger twice and squeezes. Dilly sits very still. Madam Fenn, far away up the slope of herself, says in a dreamy voice: You're a good girl, Dilly. You're a heavy girl. You'd make a lovely bit of ground.*

*At Fourth Plate the Bailiff comes round to see the house is keeping the Laws. At Supper there is roast. On the way home in the blue dusk Dilly passes the Weighhouse, under its dome of glazed bone, and she stops, as everyone stops, at the iron grating in the pavement on Scale Street where you can feel the warm air coming up from the cellars. It smells of earth and gravy. If you put your ear to the grating you can hear, far down, something like a slow tide, something like a great man*

*breathing through his nose while he chews. People say it is the Chairman. People say a lot of things.*

*She goes home. She has a bowl from the pot. She lies down with her mouth working. And at the second bell of the night*

*she wakes, hungry, with the taste of soil on her tongue, and the smallest finger of her left hand, where the root held it, itching and itching and itching, as though something had been planted there.*

– TOLD TO A CUTWRIGHT SURVEYOR IN SATED, LACK 640; THE SURVEYOR NOTED THAT THE GIRL'S LEFT LITTLE FINGER "SHOWED A FINE PALE FILAMENT AT THE NAIL-BED, WHICH SHE BIT OFF WHILE WE SPOKE, AND ATE"

Remember three things when you run the Fatlands, and everything else follows. First, it is *warm*. It is comfortable. It is the most hospitable land on the Table, and the horror arrives buttered and smiling and asking if you would like more. Second, everybody is

always eating, in every scene, as a background noise like weather. Third, everyone knows. There is no conspiracy of silence in the Fatlands, only a conspiracy of politeness, which is stronger.

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

### SATED: THE CITY BUILT AROUND A SCALE

Sated sits on the Great Gravy, the slow brown Brawn, in nine rough rings around the Weighhouse. The rings are not walls; they are roads, broad as fields, laid down as the city swelled outward, and each was paved in turn with stone that has since sunk, tilted and been relaid so often that the oldest streets ripple like a quilt thrown over sleepers. Nothing in Sated is tall. The city is built low and wide on purpose, because height means stairs and stairs mean that the great cannot reach you, and in Sated to be beyond the reach of the great is to be beyond the law. Every building is a hall, every door double, every upper floor reached by a ramp of packed brick. From the Rim Road on a clear evening the city looks like a heap of loaves left to cool on a board, smoking.

It is never quiet and it is never dark. Tallow lamps burn on every corner all night, and street-cooks work under them, and the Bailiffs walk the rings counting plates. The drains, which are open stone gutters down the middle of every street, run warm with dripping and drip and dishwater down to the river, and the whole city smells of gravy at every hour: brown, rich, salt, faintly burnt, the smell of a kitchen on a feast-day that never ends. Visitors stop noticing it on the third day. On the tenth day they find they are always hungry.

#### THE SCALES

The innermost ring around the Weighhouse, where the Board's clerks, scale-wrights, Cutwrights and Weighers live and work. Its streets are named for the parts of a balance (Beam Street, Pan Row, Fulcrum Yard, Scale Street) and its houses are faced with the same glazed bone tile as the dome, so that on a sunny day the whole district gleams like a plate of fat. The people are clerks and the great's servants: neat, plump, quiet, well-fed on Board rations, who walk with their hands folded on their bellies. It smells of ink, lamp-oil, and the warm air rising through the iron gratings set in the pavements, which open onto the Weighhouse cellars and breathe.

Trade here is in paper: meat scrip is printed in Fulcrum Yard on greased sheets, and every lease and Weighing certificate on the plain is copied in Pan Row.

**Custom.** Nobody in the Scales whistles, because the Chairman, rooted under the dome, is said to dislike it, and the gratings carry sound down. **Danger.** The gratings. Children dared to put their arms down them come up with fine white threads round their wrists. In 639 a clerk who slept drunk on a grating was found in the morning rooted to it through the cheek. **Notable.** **Ambry Coil**, keeper of the scrip-press, who prints a little more scrip in heavy Reaping years on the Board's quiet instruction, and has noticed that the press's rollers, which are greased with Weighhouse dripping, have begun to grow a soft green fur.

**AMBRY COIL, SCRIP-PRINTER** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 ·  
Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · knows the true scrip figures;  
Reckoning 4

#### THE FOLD

The great houses of the Gut-lines in town, in a ring of broad gardens and ramped mansions on the slight rise east of the Weighhouse. Here live the Laden families who still keep a seat in the city: the Fenns, the Gammons, the Chitterlings, the Loins, the Tullows' town-branch. Their houses are the size of granaries and built like them, with iron-floored inner bedrooms and drains under the beds. The Fold is the district of the **Carriers** and the **Washers**, who live in narrow tenements behind the mansions and come and go through the service ramps. It sounds like a hospital: ropes creaking in pulleys, soft voices, the great sighing in their sleep, and, on the hour, the bells that call the Carriers to turn their masters. It smells of rosewater, warm loam and milk.

**Custom.** On the night a Laden master roots for good, the household opens every window and the Washers put their sponges out on the sills, so the neighbours know. **Danger.** The gardens. Several Fold gardens contain a relative who was allowed to plant, and the grass in them is long and warm and not safe after dark.

**Notable.** **Wem Haddle**, head Carrier of the Fenn house, sixty, enormous in the shoulders, who has turned the same mistress four times a day for nineteen years and calls her *beauty*, and who has begun quietly asking the Washers whether anyone knows how long it takes a hill to forget its Carrier.

**WEM HADDLE, HEAD CARRIER** Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (fists 1, Grappling) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Labor 5; Strong Back

### LADLE LANES

The cookshop district, west of the Scales, a tangle of narrow lanes (narrow by Sated's standard, which means two drays abreast) lined with ovens, braziers, spits, pie-shops, sausage-stalls, pudding-houses, gravy-sellers and dripping-merchants, all of them open all night. Here the poor of the city come to buy the meals the Feasting Laws require of them, and here the Bailiffs do most of their counting. The noise is constant: the hiss of fat, the cries of the sellers (*Hot, hot, toothless and hot! Pie of the parish, pie of the plain!*), the clatter of plates, a thousand mouths chewing. The smell is the smell of Sated concentrated to a syrup. The cobbles are slick with grease and sanded every morning.

**Custom.** The **ten-crumb plate**: by Board ordinance every cookshop must sell a full meal for ten crumbs, a lack, to anyone at any hour, so that no one in the city can claim poverty as a reason to miss a meal. The ten-crumb plate is mostly potato, gristle and gravy, and it is better than most of what is eaten in Oathen. **Danger.** Jem Crackle works kitchens, and Ladle Lanes is all kitchens. More ordinarily, the cookshops buy meat at night from the back doors of the Dusk Acres carts, unstamped, and you do not ask. **Notable.** **Mother Suckling**, who keeps the oldest pie-shop on the Lanes, the Bottomless Crust, and who has never once refused to buy meat at her back door or to say whose it was if asked kindly.

**MOTHER SUCKLING, PIE-WIFE** Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (cleaver 3, Ripping) · Armor 1 (suet) · Dread 0 · knows every unstamped cart in the city

### WAKESIDE

The jointers' and wake-cooks' quarter, south of the Lanes along a curve of the Brawn, where the trades of the dead are carried on. Coppersmiths here make the great rendering-coppers every family needs for a wake, and hire them out by the day; carpenters build the long boards on which the dead are laid; knife-grinders sharpen the jointers' blades on wheels of bone. It is a respectable, pious, house-proud district, full of whitewash and flower-boxes, and every second door has a painted sign showing a crossed knife and ladle and the words WAKES DONE DECENT. Wakemother Pudding Hesk keeps her kitchen here. It smells of applewood smoke and roasting and, on a busy day, of the particular sweet heavy smell that every Fatlander knows and no Fatlander names.

**Custom.** A jointer's apprentice is not let to carve a stranger until they have carved their own grandparent; families in Wakeside save

their old folk for their apprentices. **Danger.** Grief. Wakeside has the highest rate of the Long Pig in the city, because its people are in rooms with good meat all day, and the Bailiffs patrol it with a peculiar watchfulness. **Notable.** **Corby Sallet**, a coppersmith, who rents out the copper that rendered Hester Gaunt after she burst in 455 and charges triple for it, and who has noticed it has begun, when it is heated, to sigh.

**CORBY SALLET, COPPERSMITH** Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (hammer 3, Stunning) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

### THE LEANINGS

The poorest ring, on the low ground west of the river, where the city's Scrapling labourers live in long timber tenements that lean on one another like drunks, because the ground beneath them is soft and gives a little more each year. The Leanings are crowded, warm, damp and loud. Every tenement has a shared pot in the yard, kept full by subscription, and the Bailiffs check it daily. The people are field-hands who walk out to the near acres each dawn, rendering-yard labourers, Carriers between houses, and the families of the dusk-shifted. It smells of boiled potato, wet timber, and the sharp ammonia of too many people. The Leanings is where the Thin recruit in Sated, and where the Long Count has its city copyists, and where the Bailiffs walk in threes.

**Custom.** The **Empty Bowl**: on the anniversary of a dusk-shifting, the family sets the culled person's bowl on the yard wall upside down. Some walls in the Leanings carry nine or ten bowls. **Danger.** The ground. Tenements in the Leanings do not fall; they sink, slowly, a storey a generation, and the bottom floors of the oldest are below the street and full of roots and warm dark and, it is said, people who went down to sleep there and stayed. **Notable.** **Sister Nettle Brack**, a Thin cell-leader of the rank of Gaunt, who runs a soup kitchen as a cover and serves broth so thin it is nearly water, and who is very good at seeming fat: she wears padding.

**NETTLE BRACK, THIN GAUNT** Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 0 (padding, not armor) · Dread 0 · Deceive 4; Stealth 3

### REGISTRY CLOSE

A walled quarter just north of the Scales where the cross-border powers keep their southern offices: the Cutwrights' College's southern registry, a squat bone-tiled hall whose vaults hold three centuries of weighing records; the Rim Road Company's Sated house, with its notary's bench and its strongroom of platters; and a dozen foreign merchants' halls, from a Vigil salt-beef buyer's lodge (lamps lit all night, which in Sated goes unnoticed) to an Oathen contract-house where nobody speaks above a whisper. Registry Close is the only district of Sated with stairs. The Fatlanders who work there are thin by local standards, sharp, and travelled. It smells of paper, wax, and the cedar perfume foreigners wear to cover the smell of the city.

**Custom.** Foreigners in the Close are permitted by Board licence to eat three meals rather than five, provided they pay the **Guest's Fine** of two lacks a day for the missing two. **Danger.** The Cutwrights. A registry surveyor will examine anyone they please under Board warrant, and a high reading means an invitation to the Fold that cannot be refused. **Notable.** **Surveyor Otilie Vance**, of the College, who keeps the southern registry's projection of which Gut-line houses will Seat in the next decade, and has been offered, by three different families, enough money to retire on in exchange for moving their names down the list.

**OTILIE VANCE, CUTWRIGHT SURVEYOR** Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Lore 5; Read the Line

## BEYOND SATED: TOWNS AND VILLAGES OF THE PLAIN

The Fatlands have no walled towns and few large ones. Outside Sated the country is a quilt of villages, each of a few hundred souls, each surrounded by its fields, each field named and thanked at every meal. Villages are built in rings around a central yard where the common pot stands and the wakes are held. The houses are long and low and timber-framed and roofed with thick yellow thatch that must be replaced every year because it sprouts. The villages are joined by causeways of packed brick and bone laid over the soft ground, and between them is wheat, and wheat, and wheat, and the low green rises that are people.

### KETTLE FURROW (LOW TILTH)

The village of Pell Hogget, of Hogget's Barn, of Old Mother Rind, of Tansy Lard and of the Scarecrow, and therefore one of the most visited small places on the Table. Kettle Furrow lies in the deep black heart of Low Tilth, in a fold of land so rich the wheat is red at the root, and it is quiet in the way of every Low Tilth village: well-fed, polite, and missing people. It has two hundred and eleven souls by the Board's census and a hundred and ninety-four by Pell's, and the difference is the Count. The houses have no locks. The doors stand open at night in Carving, because a closed door, people say, only means the field has to come round to the window. It smells of black soil, baking, and the faint vinegar-sweetness of Old Mother Rind's pears.

**Trade.** Wheat, the reddest and most toothed in the country, sold to the mills on the Little Gravy and stamped *Low Tilth Prime*. **Custom.** Every Carving evening the whole village eats Supper outdoors in the yard facing the far field, so that if anyone is Reaped, they will not be alone. **Danger.** The Scarecrow, of course, in the far field; and the pilgrims who come to Hogget's Barn and do not all go home. **Notable.** **Gaffer Tolly Mumbraw**, the Wolf-Warden for the district, eighty, toothless, who files the annual wolf report and has written, for nineteen years, the single word *wolves* in the column for cause, and who has started crying when he does it.

**TOLLY MUMBRAW, WOLF-WARDEN** Threat 1 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +1 (stick 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · knows every Reaping in the district for sixty years

### BRAMBLE FURROW (LOW TILTH)

Wren Hollowell's birthplace, five miles from Kettle Furrow along the Tilth causeway, a ragged poor village on the edge of the Dusk Acres, where the Cullmasters' numbered stones begin. It has more empty houses than full ones, most of them belonging to families who were listed and walked the row together. Bramble Furrow is the village that sent the most names to the dusk-shift in the last ten years, and it knows why: it is poor, it owes, and it produced a Blank. The Board's agents and the Second Table's agents and three kinds of bounty-taker have all been through it looking for the girl, and the villagers have learned to answer every question about her with a plate of food. It smells of bramble-flowers, which here bloom pink and smell of ham.

**Trade.** Bramble-jelly, sold in Sated as a delicacy; brambles here grow thorns like small curved teeth and the jelly sets with a faint pulse. **Custom.** **Weighing the Babies:** every infant is weighed at the yard-pot on its first day and a pebble put in a jar for each pound, and the jars are kept on a shelf in the common house. Wren Hollowell's jar is still there, and it is fuller than the others, because her mother kept putting pebbles in to hide how little she ate. **Danger.** The Dusk Acres are a field away. **Notable.** **Gammer Hollowell**, Wren's grandmother, who has been questioned eleven times and fed by Bailiffs twice, and who says, every time, that her granddaughter died of the wasting at five and was served at a wake, and lists the dishes.

**GAMMER HOLLOWELL** Threat 1 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +1 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Deceive 4; will not break

### GRISTMOOT

The great market town on the Rim Road at the Fatlands' eastern gate, where the Road comes down out of the dry country of Oathen and meets the first green fields. Gristmoot is a Company town in all but name: inns, warehouses, stockyards, toll-houses, and the longest market on the Rim, three miles of stalls along the Road where Fatlands meat and bread are sold to every land. Mardy Haunch keeps her sausage-stall here, the widest on the Rim. It is loud, crowded, mercenary and cheerful, full of foreigners and foreign money, and it is the place where most travellers first taste Fatlands bread and first stop being able to leave. It smells of woodsmoke, sausage, horse, and, from the east, dust.

**Trade.** Everything that crosses the eastern border: meat and flour going out, sworn notes and Oathen silver and Vigil glass coming in. **Custom.** The **Stranger's Loaf:** every inn gives a newcomer a hot loaf free at the door, and the town takes a quiet wager on whether they will be out of Gristmoot in a week. The house usually wins. **Danger.** The Gristmoot cure-sellers, who sell foreigners "safe" food that is anything but, and the bounty-takers who work the Road



looking for Blanks and Unfed. Kale Dragoman drinks here. **Notable.** **Toll-Reeve Bastable Crumb**, a Company man, Fatland-born, who weighs every foreigner who enters the town on a public scale at the toll-house and again when they leave, and posts the difference on a board outside. It is always a gain.

**BASTABLE CRUMB, TOLL-REEVE** Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (sword 4, Parrying) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Haggle 4

## BARRELSIDE

The town that has grown up around the Chute at the Fatlands' northern edge: a mile-long sprawl of coopers' yards, salting-sheds, rendering-houses, tanneries, stock-pens and the tenements of the people who work in them. Barrelside is Renderers' Union country absolutely; the Board's Bailiffs come here by invitation and the Union's own **yard-wardens** keep the peace. Its people are red-armed, salt-chapped, foul-mouthed, proud and well-paid by Fatland standards, and they have the most honest faces in the south, in the sense that nothing that happens there surprises them. It sounds of hammers on hoops, the bawling of stock, the roll of barrels down the long stone ramp, all day and all night. It smells, the whole of it, of brine and hot fat and blood, so strongly that on the Belch the smell reaches eleven miles and children in the next district are sent indoors.

**Trade.** Barrels. Everything that leaves the Fatlands by the Rim Road leaves here, in oak, stamped with an origin and then stamped over twice. **Custom.** A new Hook is initiated by being sealed in an empty barrel for a night in the salting-shed, and let out at dawn by the whole yard, who sing. **Danger.** The barrels that should not have been filled; the Stampers who know which; the people who do not want the Stampers to talk. **Notable.** **Ivo Stockpot**, Quartermaster, who stamps the export barrels, and has begun to notch some of them. (See the core book; he belongs to another chapter of this one.)

## DIMBLE

A dying village on the western plain between Sated and the Trencher, built around the ruins of a granary that was old when Ummer walked. Over the granary's root-cellar is the oldest carving in the Fatlands, the procession of the Providers, with the Eighth chiselled away and a little of the long open hand left where the chisel slipped. Dimble is poor and getting poorer; its fields are close to the Trencher and grow wild and fleshy and hard to cut, and its young people go to Sated and do not come back. It is visited by Cutwrights, College historians, Second Helping pilgrims on their way to the Trencher, and the occasional Second Table noble who

comes at night to look at the hand and goes away pale. It smells of wild mint, which here grows furred, and old stone.

**Trade.** Very little: wild-grown roots from the Trencher's edge, which sell in Sated as a delicacy to those who like their food strong, and guiding. **Custom.** The people of Dimble do not say *Is there any more?* at the end of a meal, as Fatlanders do everywhere else as a pleasantry. They say it is unlucky, and will not explain. **Danger.** The Trencher is two miles off, and its creepers have been creeping. **Notable.** **Elder Gammet Rake**, keeper of the granary key, who lets visitors see the carving for a lack and will not let anyone stay in the cellar after dark, because, he says, the hand in the carving is longer in the mornings than it was the night before.

**GAMMET RAKE, GRANARY KEEPER** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (crook 2, Reach) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Lore 3 (the carving)

## SAPWELL (THE BLEEDING ORCHARDS)

The chief village of the Orchards, in the middle of its ten thousand acres, a village of the deaf. Sapwell's orchard-keepers go deaf young with heated needles, by choice, so that they will not hear the trees scream at pruning, and the whole village speaks in a quick, expressive hand-language that outsiders cannot follow and the Thin have learned. The houses are built of pear-wood and apple-wood, which never quite dries and leaks a little sap in hot weather. In the pruning season the village is utterly silent to its people and utterly, unbearably loud to everyone else; outside the pruning season it is the quietest place in the Fatlands, and visitors find the quiet unnerving, because they can hear the trees breathing. It smells of blossom in Grace, fruit in Plenty, and blood in Carving.

**Trade.** Bleeding-orchard fruit; orchard sap, collected in buckets at pruning for blood-pudding and for the apothecaries; pear-wood. **Custom.** Children in Sapwell are allowed to hear until their tenth year, and on the night before the needles they are taken into the oldest grove and let to listen to the trees for an hour, so that they will know what they are choosing. **Danger.** Marigold Chine's grove, which sings. And the pruning hooks; the trees remember them. **Notable.** **Keeper Aldo Pippin**, sixty, deaf since nine, who leads the Orchard-keepers' quiet council and who has been sheltering Thin fugitives in the hollow trunks of the oldest trees for twenty years, and has begun to notice the trees closing over them a little more each season.

**ALDO PIPPIN, ORCHARD-KEEPER** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (pruning hook 3, Hooking, Reach) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · cannot hear; immune to sound-based Dread

# ▼ROADS AND WAYS

The Fatlands are flat and soft, and travel across them is slow, warm, and never quite comfortable. The ground gives. Cartwheels sink. A

loaded wagon on an unmade track in late Plenty can sink to the axles in an afternoon and have to be dug out, and the ruts it leaves

behind are found next morning healed over and slightly raised, like a scar. For this reason the Fatlands are threaded with **causeways**: raised roads of packed brick and crushed bone, laid over beds of salt and iron filings, which the ground does not like and will not take in. The causeways are the arteries of the country. They are maintained by the Board’s road-gangs, who are paid in scrip and fed at the roadside, and by the dusk-shifted, who work the causeway repairs in Lack when the fields are quiet.

**On foot**, a traveller on a causeway makes the usual twenty miles a day, but must stop five times for the mandatory meals, which in practice brings it nearer fifteen; a traveller off the causeways, across fields, makes ten at best, and should not be in a field at dusk in

Carving. **By cart**, the causeways are good going, twenty-five miles a day, but Fatland oxen are slow and stop to eat whenever they are allowed and sometimes when they are not. **By barge**, on the Great Gravy and the Little Gravies, travel is slowest of all, perhaps twelve miles a day downstream and eight up, but it is restful, it is fed, and the bargemen will not let anyone off at dusk. The great travel by **dray**: a wide, iron-floored, eight-ox platform that moves at walking pace and is preceded by Bailiffs who clear the road.

Fatlanders reckon distance not in miles but in **meals**: a village is “two meals off” if a person setting out after Firstbite will arrive at Middy. The Board’s mile-stones are carved with a plate and a number of notches.

| ROUTE                                   | DAYS       | CHARACTER                           | DANGERS                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------|------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weighing Road (Sated to Dowager Hills)  | half a day | broad, paved, lined with hills      | the Dowagers call to walkers by name                                   |
| Chute Road (Sated to the Chute)         | 4          | causeway; Union carts day and night | barrel-thieves; the Belch; rolling barrels                             |
| Tilth Causeway (Sated to Kettle Furrow) | 2          | narrow, raised, through Low Tilth   | Reaping at its edges; the Scarecrow; Cullmasters’ lines                |
| Gravy Barge (Sated to the sea)          | 9          | slow, warm, fed                     | swimmers’ sickness; the river takes; smugglers                         |
| Orchard Ride (Sated to Sapwell)         | 2          | earth track through the trees       | pruning season; trees that close; deaf keepers who will not hear a cry |
| Gristmoot Way (Sated to the Rim)        | 5          | the old trade causeway east         | bounty-takers; cure-sellers; foreigners                                |
| Trencher Track (Sated to Dimble)        | 2          | unmaintained; creeper-grown         | pilgrims; the Trencher’s spreading tangle; Board patrols               |
| Drovers’ Ways (across the plain)        | varies     | unmade, unmarked, wide              | the herds; soft ground; things that walk on two legs                   |

TRAVELLING THE FATLANDS IN PLAY

Each day on the causeways, a Fatland journey is safe and fed and slow. Each day off them, roll Lung + Wayfaring (Hard 14). On a failure, the party loses half a day to the soft ground; on a Lack, a cart, an ox or a person sinks to the waist and must be dug out (Gut + Labor, Hard 14, an hour’s work, and Dread 1 for what the spade turns up). Travellers who skip the mandatory meals on a Board road are likely to meet a Bailiff (one in three chance each day) and will be fined, fed, or both. In Carving, the GM should ask every evening where everyone is at dusk, and make the players answer.

## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

The Fatlands are the richest country on the Table by every measure but one, and the one is the reason for all the others. The land grows three harvests a year in Low Tilth and two everywhere else; the herds double every spring; the orchards bend. Half the Table eats from the Chute. And the plains are run, from top to bottom, on the understanding that none of this is free, and nobody says what the price is.

## WHAT PEOPLE DO

Most Fatlanders work the land: as **field-hands** on the great Gut-line estates, as **tenant-farmers** on their own strips, as **gleaners** behind the harvesters, as **drovers**, **orchard-keepers** and **millers**. The next great trade is **rendering**, under the Renderers’ Union. The third is **feeding**: cookshops, inns, wake-cooks, and the city trades that exist only because the great cannot move, the **Carriers** and the **Washers**.

Then there is the Board, which pays its clerks, Bailiffs and Listing Clerks well, because they are the people who must look at the figures.

Wages are paid in meat scrip, by the week, and most of it goes straight back to the Board stores as food. A Fatlander who saves is regarded with suspicion: *a thin purse and a thin belly keep the same company*. Lacks are used for trade with foreigners and for anything the Board does not sell.

| WORK                | DAILY WAGE      | PAID IN | NOTES                                   |
|---------------------|-----------------|---------|-----------------------------------------|
| Gleaner (child)     | 3 crumbs        | scrip   | plus all they can eat from the stubble  |
| Field-hand          | 1 lack          | scrip   | plus two field-meals; double in Carving |
| Washer              | 2 lacks         | scrip   | more for Laden at the Course            |
| Carrier             | 3 lacks         | scrip   | a team of four for each great body      |
| Rendering-yard Hook | 2 lacks         | scrip   | Union rates; a cut of offal weekly      |
| Jointer (at a wake) | 4 lacks a body  | lacks   | Hob Gristle charges 10 and is worth it  |
| Wake-cook           | 10 lacks a wake | lacks   | Pudding Hesk charges 40                 |
| Bailiff (Ladle)     | 3 lacks         | scrip   | free Supper at any inn                  |
| Listing Clerk       | 5 lacks         | scrip   | and a bonus per name in Carving         |
| Hill-Speaker        | 6 lacks         | lacks   | paid by the family, by the consultation |
| Dusk-shift labourer | debt struck off | —       | a debt of up to 200 lacks per evening   |

## WHAT THINGS COST

Food in the Fatlands is cheap, abundant, and better than anywhere else on the Table. Everything that is not food is dear, because it must

be brought in up the Rim Road and paid for in a country that thinks of iron and glass the way other lands think of meat. Iron in particular is costly, because the great need iron-floored beds and drays, and a Gut-line family can spend more on iron in a year than a village earns.

| ITEM                                | LOCAL PRICE                   | NOTES                                                 |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| A full meal at a cookshop           | 1 lack                        | the ten-crumbs plate; by law, at any hour             |
| A week's food for a family of five  | 6 lacks                       | in scrip; five meals a day each                       |
| A side of beef                      | 8 lacks                       | half the Rim price                                    |
| A sack of toothed flour             | 2 lacks                       | teeth sieved; with teeth, half price to button-makers |
| An iron bed-plate                   | 120 lacks                     | for the Laden; the Course is expensive                |
| A Laden's dray (eight oxen)         | 900 lacks                     | rented by the day at 15                               |
| A rendering-copper (hire, one wake) | 3 lacks                       | Wakeside; famous coppers cost more                    |
| Wake-board (hire)                   | 1 lack                        | a long table, scrubbed                                |
| A Dowager consultation              | the best cut of the last wake | and 6 lacks to the Hill-Speaker                       |
| Lead pockets at the Weighing        | 200 lacks                     | Garrick Tripe's price, rising                         |
| A glass window                      | 40 lacks                      | foreign; the great have none, the clerks have two     |

## TAXES AND TITHES

The Board taxes the Fatlands by weight, as it governs them, but in reverse. The **Plate-Tithe** is a fifth of every harvest, taken in kind at the mills and the Chute, and it is the Board's great income; it is collected without complaint because nobody can imagine the

country without the Board's stores. The **Lean Levy** is a yearly tax on every adult, assessed at the Weighing, and it falls by a crumb for every pound of body weight: the lighter you are, the more you pay. A labourer of three hundred pounds pays a lack or two. A Gut-line matriarch of fourteen hundred pays nothing at all, and is, technically, owed a rebate, which the Board credits against her vote.



A thin man pays heavily, and if he cannot pay he goes on the dusk-shift lists, and the circle closes. The Board’s apologists call the Lean Levy a tax on “the withheld portion”; the Thin call it a bounty on bones.

The Renderers’ Union pays the **Barrel Duty**, a lack on every barrel down the Chute, and has fought the Board over every crumb of it for two centuries. The Rim Road Company pays nothing to anyone and charges everyone, and the Board pretends this is an arrangement.

WHO IS RICH

The Gut-lines own a third of the country by way of their hills, and most of the rest by way of their living members. Their wealth is land, and land in the Fatlands grows on it, so it compounds. Below them stand the **granary-houses** of Sated, the **Union bosses**, and

oddities such as Garrick Tripe, whose fortune is in lead. The poorest Fatlanders are not hungry in the way the poor are hungry elsewhere; they are fed. What they lack is weight, and in the Fatlands weight is vote, voice, credit and safety from the dusk-shift lists. Being poor in the Fatlands means being light, and being light means being the field’s.

MEAT SCRIP IN PLAY

Meat scrip (see the Rim Market chapter) trades at a lack per pound in an ordinary year. The GM may set the scrip rate each Carving by the Long Count: in the year the Reaping rises by a tenth, the scrip falls by a tenth. In 641 A.G. the scrip stands at about seven crumbs a pound and falling. A PC paid in scrip who tries to spend it outside the Fatlands will find it worth half, and the merchant will want to know the barrel-mark it was redeemed against.

▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

Fatland law is the Feasting Laws, the Weighing Statutes and three centuries of Board ordinances, and it is kept by a population that has very little crime of the kind other lands fear. Fatlanders are well-fed, warm and neighbourly. They do not steal bread, because bread is everywhere. They do not often murder, because a murderer is rendered and the victim’s family has first cut. What they do, all the time, is fail to eat enough, and that is where the law bites.

WHO ENFORCES

The **Bailiffs** of the Board keep the Feasting Laws: they count plates, inspect inns, fine waste, weigh children, and feed the stubborn. They wear a blue sash and carry a ladle and a funnel of horn as their badges of office, and they are, by the standards of other lands’ police, gentle. They rarely draw a blade. They do not need to. The **Wolf-Wardens**, one to a district, file the Reaping reports and maintain the fiction. The **Cullmasters** hold Carving evenings, when the Bailiffs answer to them. In Barreside and the Chute the **yard-wardens** of the Renderers’ Union keep their own law and hand over nobody. The great keep their own households, and what happens in a Gut-line house is a matter for the family, the family’s Dowager, and nobody else.

HOW A TRIAL WORKS

A Fatland trial is held at table. The **Plate-Justice**, a Board magistrate appointed by weight from among the Deacons, sits at the head of a

long board in the village yard or the district hall, and the accused sits at the foot, and the witnesses and the accuser and anyone who cares to come sit along the sides. Everyone eats. The trial is a meal, and it lasts as long as the meal does, which may be days. The accused must eat throughout, and a Bailiff stands behind them with a ladle to see that they do; refusal to eat at one’s own trial is taken as a plea of guilty to sedition, whatever the original charge.

Testimony is given with the mouth full. Important witnesses swear on their dead, with a morsel of a dead relative held on the tongue, *by my mother’s meat, which is in me*, and the families of the region keep a little dried meat of their elders in a salt-box against the day they will need to testify. A witness who has no dead to swear on is given a morsel of the Board’s own: the Board keeps, in a salt-casket in the Weighhouse, a supply of dried flesh from Hester Gaunt, the starved preacher of the Thin Rising, and witnesses who swear on her are believed implicitly, because nobody would perjure themselves with that in their mouth.

When the plates are empty the Plate-Justice gives judgment, and the convicted are fed their sentence. Appeals go to the Board, which sits once a season, and are decided by weighted vote; an appeal from a Scrapling against a Gut-line has never succeeded, because the Gut-line outweighs the court.

CRIMES AND PUNISHMENTS

| CRIME                     | PUNISHMENT              | NOTES                              |
|---------------------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Leaving food on the plate | 1 lack per crumb-weight | assessed on the Bailiff’s scale    |
| Missing a mandatory meal  | the meal, fed; 2 lacks  | repeat offenders to the Gavage     |
| Refusing a meal           | sedition: the Gavage    | a season; longer if they come back |

| CRIME                                  | PUNISHMENT                                          | NOTES                                                            |
|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Keeping a child thin                   | treason against the Weighing                        | the child taken to a heavier house; the parent to the dusk-shift |
| Purging, bleeding, fasting             | treason                                             | the Gavage; Thin leaders made an example                         |
| Theft of food                          | none, if eaten in full                              | the Appetite defence of 312                                      |
| Theft of goods                         | restitution in meals owed                           | a meal a day to the victim for a season                          |
| Waste (a spoiled barrel, rotted grain) | the gravest crime                                   | rendering, in the worst cases                                    |
| Assault, brawling                      | the reconciling supper                              | both parties eat together until friendly                         |
| Debt unpaid                            | the dusk-shift                                      | debt struck off "in full"                                        |
| Murder                                 | the Renderers' yards; first cut to the victim's kin | <i>making good</i>                                               |
| Burial of the dead                     | desecration of the Wake Ordinance                   | the buried are dug up and served; the buriers fined              |
| Uttering the Long Count                | sedition (since 637)                                | rarely enforced; it is everywhere                                |
| Lead at the Weighing                   | fraud against the Board                             | in theory; in practice, a fee to Garrick Tripe                   |

### THE LAW AND THE PCS

Foreign PCs in the Fatlands break the law constantly simply by eating like foreigners. The Bailiffs are patient with them for a day or two; after that, fines, and then feeding. A party that leaves food on its plates in a Board inn should expect a visit from a Ladle with a scale and a ledger. A party that refuses food outright should expect the Gavage. The Feasting Laws are the cheapest way to make the Fatlands' horror personal: let a Bailiff kneel by a reluctant PC's chair, with kind eyes and a full spoon, saying *come on, love, just a little, for me*, and let the whole inn turn to watch.

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

Every Fatlander thanks the field before eating. That is the whole of religion for most of them, and it is not a small thing; the grace is said five times a day by four hundred thousand mouths in Sated alone, and it names the fields, and through the fields it names the dead. Above that floor of daily thanks, the Fatlands have the same three doctrines as everywhere else, but each takes a peculiarly southern shape.

### THE THREE DOCTRINES IN THE SOUTH

**The Gift** is the Fatlands' established faith, and the Board's. Ummer, it says, laid itself down in the Trencher out of love for its starving people, as a mother gives her body to her child, and we ate it in gratitude, and its return in our fields is its continued gift. The **Field Church**, which has no single head but a priest in every parish called a **Grace-Keeper**, teaches that the Reaping is the god taking back a little of what it gave, as is fair, and that the Laden are blessed. The Field Church presides at Weighings, wakes and Harvest Home. Its

priests are fat, cheerful and comfortable, and most of them know the figures.

**The Theft** is the faith of the Thin and of Tablenight. It says we murdered Ummer, that the hunger is the god's own famine come to sit in us as justice, and that the only decent response is penance. In the Fatlands, where fasting is treason, the Theft survives as the shame that comes on everyone once a year on Tablenight, and as the quiet creed of the Thin, who believe they can starve the god back down into the soil by refusing to feed it. Its holy figure is Hester Gaunt, and its sacred place is the Brawn below the Gavage, where the lean bodies of executed Thin are thrown in, uneaten.

**The Bait** is the faith of the Second Helping and, more quietly, of a great many Gut-line households. Ummer wanted to be eaten, it says; the Long Lack was its doing; it starved us so that we would take it into ten thousand bodies, and now it grows back through us, and it is our joy to be its field. The Board has made the Bait illegal and has never once enforced the ban on a Gut-line. Gladbelly preaches it openly, and the Board finds Gladbelly embarrassing and very convenient.

SHRINES AND HOLY PLACES

Every field in the Fatlands has a **grace-stone** at one corner: a squat stone post carved with the field’s name, sometimes a face, and a little cup-hollow on top where a crust is left on feast days. The oldest grace-stones are pre-Gorging granary lintels and carry worn figures of Ummer walking. Families touch the grace-stone when they pass, and children are taught to kiss it. In Carving, the grace-stone of a field that has Reaped is wrapped in a strip of red cloth, and the strip is left to rot.

The great shrines are the **Dowager Hills**, which are consulted rather than prayed to, but where every Gut-line matriarch is buried,

| SEASON  | RITE             | WHAT HAPPENS                                                                                         |
|---------|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Grace   | The Weighing     | three days of pie-stalls, the Board on the Scales, votes set by the pound                            |
| Grace   | First Furrow     | the first plough of the year is pulled by the heaviest man in the village, and the furrow fed a loaf |
| Plenty  | Sweating Night   | in late Plenty, when the fields sweat, the whole village sleeps outdoors on the warm ground          |
| Carving | Marbling Morning | the first frost; children run barefoot on the white veins of the fields                              |
| Carving | Harvest Home     | a week of feasting; lately quiet, because of the Count                                               |
| Carving | The Lists        | read in every village square on Carving afternoons; not a holy day; everyone attends                 |
| Lack    | Tablenight       | the national fast, which always fails                                                                |
| Any     | The Wake         | the dead served by kin; the most sacred rite of all                                                  |

**Sweating Night.** In the hottest week of Plenty, when the fields glisten, whole villages carry their bedding into the fields and sleep on the warm, rising and falling ground, under the yellow sky. It is said to bring easy births and good harvests. Couples conceive on Sweating Night and the children are called **field-gotten** and thought lucky. Every year, in the morning, some sleepers will not wake, and are found with their faces pressed into the soil and fine white threads in their hair, smiling, and they are carried home to their wakes with great gentleness and nobody says anything at all.

in a sense, and where offerings of meat are brought; the **Weighhouse**, whose dome is the Field Church’s cathedral in all but name and where the Board sits under carvings of Ummer feeding the world; and the **Trencher**, which is forbidden and therefore holy. In every parish there is a **table-chapel**, a long low hall with a table running its length, where the Grace-Keeper presides over communal meals on holy days and where the parish’s wakes are held when a family’s yard is too small.

rites of the year

A GRACE AND A HYMN

*Thank you, field. Thank you, Long Acre, and Hessop’s Rise, and Gran.*

*Thank you for the bread you give, which was our bread before.*

*Thank you for the meat you give, which was our meat before.*

*We have eaten. We will eat. We will be eaten. Thank you.*

*Lack keep away.*

– THE LONG GRACE OF THE FIELD CHURCH, SAID AT SUPPER ON HOLY DAYS; IN ORDINARY USE IT IS SHORTENED TO THE NAMES OF THE FIELDS AND “THANK YOU”

*Ummer walked before the plough, and the furrow bowed its head;*

*Ummer broke its shoulder off and gave us all its bread.*

*Ummer lay down in the Trencher, and Ummer said, Come in;*

*we ate it all and left no bone, and the god is in our skin.*

*Lift the ladle, lift the plate, and do not leave a crumb;*

*the field is fed, the field will feed, the field will bid us come.*

*The field is fed, the field will feed, the field will bid us home.*

– “UMMER WALKED BEFORE THE PLOUGH,” THE MOST COMMON HYMN OF THE FIELD CHURCH; THE SECOND HELPING SINGS THE LAST LINE TWICE, VERY SLOWLY, AND THE THIN WILL LEAVE A ROOM RATHER THAN HEAR IT

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

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### OVERHEARD ON THE PLAIN

"I've jointed nine hundred and four. You stop seeing faces after the first fifty. Then about the eight hundredth you start again, and it's all faces." — a jointer of Wakeside

"Mam says not to go in the far field after Fourth Plate. I went once. It was nice. It smelled of tea-time." — a child of Kettle Furrow, aged seven

"I don't eat the bread from the north strip. My husband's in the north strip. I give it to the pigs, and then I eat the pigs. I know. I know." — a farmwife, Low Tilt

"You feed a Laden lord a whole pig for breakfast and he says thank you, Carrier, very kindly, and then he asks you if you've ever thought about being planted. Every morning. Very kindly." — a Carrier of the Fold

"Wolves. I write it down every year. Wolves. My hand writes it on its own now." — a Wolf-Warden of the eastern plain

"They pay well at the Chute and you never go hungry and you never ask what's in the barrel. That's three good things. Most jobs give you one." — a cooper of Barreldside

"I came for a week to buy flour. That was eleven years ago. I'm very happy. Why are you looking at me like that?" — a former Oathen merchant, now of Gristmoot, four hundred pounds

"My name was on the list in 638. I walked the row. The wheat leaned at the man next to me and I heard what it does. I've got my debt struck off. I'm free. I can't sleep with the window open." — a dusk-shift survivor of Bramble Furrow

"Course it's delicious. That's the cruel part. If it tasted like what it is, we'd stop." — a whore of Ladle Lanes, between meals

"I feed them gentle. I always feed them gentle. Some of them thank me after. I don't know if that's better or worse." — a Gavage feeder

"I joined the Thin because my brother was dusk-shifted and my mam ate his bowl of supper the next morning because it was there. Not out of greed. It was *there*." — a Hollow of the Thin

"Brother Glut held my hand. The hand he's got left. He said I'd be so loved. My wife went to the pavilion in Plenty. I eat at the long tables now. Everyone's very kind. I'd like to stop eating, please. I'd like to stop." — a widower at Gladbelly

## ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

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On paper the Fatlands are simple: the Board rules by weight, the Chairman is the heaviest, and everyone else is lighter. In practice power in the south moves the way food moves through a body: slowly, in one direction, with a great deal going on that nobody

looks at. Four things carry it. **Weight**, which is votes. **Food**, which is the Board's stores and the Union's barrels. **Lists**, which is the Cullmasters. And **land**, which is the Gut-lines and their hills, and in the end, the god.

| POWER-HOLDER                        | CONTROLS                                                               | FEARS                                               | OWES                                                              |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chairman Obb Tullow                 | the heaviest vote; the Board's inner committee; the Weighhouse cellars | his mouth closing while the hill keeps voting       | Garrick Tripe's silence; Varn Sweetbread's lists                  |
| The Board of Plenty                 | law, scrip, the Plate-Tithe, the Bailiffs                              | the Long Count made official; the Table finding out | the Union for every barrel; the Company for every road            |
| Dame Suet Marrable                  | the Gut-lines' society; the Second Table in the south                  | the Dinner ending; her own rooting                  | her Dowager forebears' counsel; Lord Chastain Loin's acquisitions |
| The Dowager Hills                   | a third of the land; the deciding word in Gut-line succession          | nothing anyone can name                             | nothing; they are owed                                            |
| Mistress Brisket Annalow            | every barrel on the Rim; Barrelside; the second ledger                 | the day the Table stops buying                      | the Company's indifference; her Stampers' silence                 |
| Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread          | the dusk-shift lists; Carving evenings                                 | an empty plot-ledger; being wrong about the yield   | the Chairman, who signs the lists                                 |
| The Rim Road Company                | a third of the Chute's wagons; the roads out                           | an honest inspection                                | nothing; it is owed by everyone                                   |
| Corder Lank and the Thin            | perhaps four thousand people who will not eat                          | his own death; his followers learning the truth     | the Purgation's money; the Orchard-keepers' silence               |
| Brother Glut and the Second Helping | Gladbelly; a hundred kitchens; the grieving                            | nothing; he is happy                                | the Second Table, without knowing it                              |
| Pell Hogget and the Long Count      | two hundred villages' tallies; the truth                               | the numbers; his own wall                           | Nell Hogger's mark, unwritten                                     |
| The Cutwrights' southern registry   | the weighing records of three centuries; who Seats next                | the Gut-lines' bribes being discovered              | the College in the north                                          |

## THE LINES OF PULL

The **Chairman** sits at the top of the Board because he is heaviest, and stays heaviest because Garrick Tripe's lead goes into the pockets of the Deacons who vote with him and out of the pockets of the ones who vote against. He keeps the Board in line through the **Cullmasters**, whose lists can be made to include the families of awkward Deacons, and he keeps the Cullmasters in line by signing their lists, which means he can write a name on them, including theirs. The Board needs the **Renderers' Union** for every barrel and pays it badly and threatens to tax it; the Union needs the Board's Bailiffs to keep the herds and the dusk-shift coming. Each holds the other by the throat, gently.

**Dame Marrable** holds no Board office but outweighs most of it, and the Gut-lines who sit at her Dinner vote as she suggests. Above

her are her own **Dowagers**, whose counsel she follows and who are, more and more, advising every Gut-line on the plain to do the same few things: plant, feed, stay. Through the Unending Dinner she chairs the southern **Second Table**, which wants the god to finish growing so that it can be eaten again, and which therefore wants the Reaping to go on. The Board's inner committee knows this, and approves.

And under everyone, under the Weighhouse, under the Dowager Hills and the Dusk Acres and the Trencher, is the field. Every line of power in the Fatlands runs, in the end, down. The Chairman's roots go into the cellars. The Dowagers' advice goes into the soil. The Cullmasters' lists go to the Dusk Acres. The Union's barrels carry it up the Rim Road to every land. It is the oldest power in the country and the only one that has never needed a vote, and it is very, very patient.

WE HAVE **GOVERNED** THIS **COUNTRY** BY  
**WEIGHT** FOR FOUR **HUNDRED YEARS**, AND I WILL  
TELL YOU A **SECRET**, YOUNG **MAN**: THE **HEAVIEST**  
**MEMBER** OF THIS **BOARD** DOES NOT SIT IN IT. SHE LIES  
**UNDER** IT.

[ CHAIRMAN OBB TULLOW, TO A NEW DEACON, 638 A.G. ]

# THE PEOPLE OF THE FATLANDS

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What follows are the dossiers of the first half of the Fatlands' people: the Chairman and the hostess, the Counter and the Thin Man, the Union boss and the honest butcher, the Cullmaster, the gleaner girl, the prophet, the hill and the doctor. They agree with everything in

the core book and go much further. Stat blocks use the full format; where a character in the core book had a stat block, the numbers are kept or refined only slightly.

# CHAIRMAN OBB TULLOW

the Heaviest Vote

*“Read me the figures again, Mister Purslane. Slowly. The eastern districts first. No, don’t skip the children. I can feel when you skip.”*

– OBB TULLOW, TO HIS READING-CLERK, UNDER THE WEIGHHOUSE DOME, CARVING 640

| OBB TULLOW – THE HEAVIEST VOTE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | Fatlands · Cut 5 (Gut-line, the Tullow stomach) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                  | 71; Chairman of the Board of Plenty since 602 A.G.; 1,900 lb at the last Weighing he could be lifted onto                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING             | Scion · Standing 5 (Great House: “a bench, or a hill”)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 1 · Gut 6 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                         | Feast 5, Endure 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3, Intimidate 3, Reckoning 3, Lore 2, Godsign 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| BODY                           | Flesh 18 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                        | rolling crush +2 (4) against anyone who climbs onto the dray; cannot pursue                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                          | Field-Body: feels every footstep on the Weighhouse floor and the Weighing Road, and every Reaping in the Fatlands as a warm mouthful (he knows when and roughly where). The Bending: when he speaks in the Weighhouse, grain and grass within sight lean toward him; anyone arguing against him there is at –2 Persuade. Gorge: regains 1d6 Flesh per meal. The Field Answers (Brink): once per scene he may make the cellar roots grip a target in the Weighhouse (Gut 5, Hard 14 to break free). |
| WANTS                          | The Second Plate (eats whatever is set within reach, Grim 18 to stop if meat); Stillness (never to be moved; he will fight to stay); The Count (must be told the Reaping figures, aloud and slowly, every day, or gains 1 Fray)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                         | Counting Habit, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                   | The Count (the number is always one short; he believes the missing one is himself)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                        | the dray, the Chairman’s Ladle, the Seal of Plenty, the Reaping roll, his mother’s salt-box, Tripe’s receipts                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                          | 3 (to watch him eat, or to see what grows under the dray); 4 if he speaks while the cellar roots are moving                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

The Chairman is a landscape before he is a man. He lies on the iron bed of a great dray at the centre of the Weighhouse, under the bone-tiled dome, where the Great Scales once stood unobstructed and now must be walked around: nineteen hundred pounds of cool, brown, loam-soft flesh draped over the dray’s edges like a haystack slumped in rain. The skin is mottled red and umber like a ploughed slope seen from a hill. It gives under a finger like warm dough and holds the print for an afternoon. Green shoots stand in every crease, in the elbow-pits, along the great folded shelves of the belly, behind the ears; his Washers pluck three hundred a morning and three hundred more are up by Fourth Plate. He sweats a clear, sweet, sticky fluid that draws bees in the warm months, and on the hottest days of Plenty there is a hum about him like an orchard.

At the summit of all this, half sunk in folds, is a small, pink, clever face that looks out like a man peering from a cellar door: neat little nose, wet little mouth, two very bright pale eyes that miss

nothing. His voice is reedy, precise and dry, a clerk’s voice, and he uses it sparingly, because breath is an effort and because he learned long ago that the heaviest man in the room never needs to raise it. He smells of turned earth, rosewater, and the sweetish rot of a root-cellar in Lack. His hands, which are small for the rest of him, lie folded on the summit of his belly, and he moves them very little, except to eat, which he does constantly, neatly, with a gold fork, from plates his servers keep full. He chews with his eyes half-closed and an expression of polite attention, as though the food were giving evidence.

## THEIR STORY

The Tullows are the eldest Gut-line on the plain. Matron Ysolde Tullow was the first Laden in the Fatlands, rooted in her own kitchen in 61 A.G., and in 97 she became the first of the Dowager Hills; her mound, nearest the Weighing Road, is called simply the Eldest, and her mouth is a warm damp crack that exhales. Every Tullow since has been raised to understand that the family’s destiny



is to grow heavy, sit the Board and become land, in that order. Obb was born in 570, a third son and a sharp, quiet child who liked ledgers. His elder brothers both rooted before forty and stand as a pair of hills at Tullow's Reach.

He entered the Board at twenty-four, as the family's member, and rose by two arts: counting and patience. He made himself master of the Board's figures, the Plate-Tithe, the export tallies and, from 590, the Reaping returns in the cellars, which no member had read in a century. He understood them. In 602, at thirty-two, he was heaviest by eleven pounds at the Weighing, with some help from a young Weigher named Garrick Tripe, and he became Chairman. He has been heaviest every year since. He walked for the last time in 611, across the Weighhouse floor to the Scales on two Carriers' arms; Deacons still step round the prints.

For three decades he governed from a bed and then a dray, moved through the streets by eight oxen and a Bailiff escort. In Grace 640 his roots found a seam the smiths had missed in the dray's iron floor, went through it, and went into the Weighhouse floor beneath. By the time the Carriers noticed, the cords were thick as a wrist. The Board agreed not to notice. The oxen stand stabled in a side-hall, groomed daily, in case. The Board now sits around him.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Tullow is the Board. He chairs its sessions from the dray, sets its agenda, sits on its inner committee, signs the Cullmasters' lists, approves the scrip-rate, and holds more votes alone than the whole of Low Tilth. His day is fixed and ceremonial: Firstbite at the fourth bell, served by his Washers; the reading of the Reaping roll by his clerk, Mister Hollis Purslane, a dry little man who has read him the figures every morning for nineteen years; then Board business, petitioners, committees and meals, until the Supper bell, and then, alone under the dome, the long night, which he spends feeling the country through his roots.

His power is enormous and narrowing. He cannot leave the Weighhouse, and so the Weighhouse has become the only place in the Fatlands where power is done; Deacons who once governed from their districts must now come to him. But he depends absolutely on others' hands: on Purslane's reading, on the Carriers and Washers, on Varn Sweetbread's lists, on Garrick Tripe's lead, on Brisket Annalow's barrels. And in Grace 641 the Board faces the **Root Question**: whether a rooted member's weight for voting purposes includes what his roots hold. The Weighers, quietly, have estimated that the soil and cellar-roots bound to the Chairman weigh some thirty thousand pounds. If the Board rules that the roots count, the Chairman will hold more votes than the rest of the Board together, forever, and the vote will be his to cast. He knows exactly how many Deacons he must frighten to win it.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The dray** — eight yards of oak and iron, built in 611 for a man of eleven hundred pounds and reinforced twice since. Its iron

floor is now pierced by eleven root-cords as thick as hawsers. Its wheels have sunk to the hubs in the tiles. Everyone calls it the Bench.

- ◇ **The Chairman's Ladle** — the Board's chief badge of office, a ladle of beaten gold the length of a forearm, older than the Weighing. By law the Chairman must taste the first spoon of every Board supper with it. He keeps it on his belly like a sceptre.
- ◇ **The Seal of Plenty** — a signet of black bone set in gold, on the smallest finger of his left hand. The flesh has grown round it and over it; only the face shows. To seal a document his hand must be lifted and pressed down by a clerk. It cannot be removed without the finger.
- ◇ **The Reaping roll** — the real figures, kept in a locked oak case beside the dray, in Purslane's hand: every Reaping by district since 300 A.G. It matches Pell Hogget's Long Count to the head, and goes back two centuries further.
- ◇ **His mother's salt-box** — a small tin of salt containing a strip of dried meat from Matron Olwen Tullow's wake, kept for oaths. He has used it four times. He keeps it under his chin, where he can reach it with his mouth.
- ◇ **Tripe's receipts** — a bundle of chits recording every Weighing at which Garrick Tripe sold lead to a Deacon, and to whom. He has never used them. He is waiting.
- ◇ **A gold fork and a silver tooth-pick** — the fork was a gift from Dame Marrable on his election; the pick he uses to remove, after meals, the small white threads that have begun to grow from his gums.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Tullow wants to die Chairman, and to win the Root Question so that he cannot be unseated by anything but the hill he is becoming. He wants the Fatlands to go on eating and the Table to go on buying, at least until he is gone. More privately, and more hungrily each month, he wants the figures. The Reaping returns are the only thing that still interests him as much as food.

He fears the moment his mouth closes and the hill keeps voting, as his brothers' hills vote now, however their Hill-Speaker says.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** Tullow has arranged for the Cullmasters to list the families of every Deacon who votes against him. He reads the dusk-shift lists before he signs them and adds names in his own small hand. Next Carving's list includes Varn Sweetbread himself, because Sweetbread has begun to keep his own figures, and the Chairman does not share figures.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** His roots have reached the cellars and are drinking from the Gravy, as the rumour says; they have also reached the vaults where the Board's Reaping records are kept, and he feels each Reaping in the land as a warm full mouthful, a taste of a name. In 637 he felt something else: a cold, narrow, heavy thing let down inside him, from a great height, and drawn up again. He has never told Dr. Paunch that he felt the plumb line.

**Secret (he does not know):** He believes he feels the Reaping through his roots. The truth is the reverse. The Reaping is feeling *him*. Every taken labourer goes into the soil and along the roots toward the heaviest knot of the god's flesh in the land, and that knot is the Chairman. Ummer is gathering itself in Obb Tullow. When he Seats, he will not become a hill. He will become the floor of Sated.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — his oldest ally and his only equal; she gave him his gold fork and his chairmanship, and she has never let him forget either. He suspects, correctly, that she is courting the Root Question's opponents.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — his instrument. Tullow likes him and has written his name on the list.
- ◇ **Garrick Tripe** — the man who made him Chairman with lead; Tullow keeps his receipts and his secret, for now.
- ◇ **Dr. Emmerich Paunch** — his physician, who measures him weekly and is afraid of him; Tullow knows what Paunch heard at the bottom of the line, because he heard it too.
- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — a man he has never met, whose figures he reads in Purslane's copy every week and whose accuracy he admires more than anyone on the Board.
- ◇ **Mistress Brisket Annalow** — the only person in the Fatlands who can do to the Board what the Board does to everyone else; they hate each other with great courtesy.
- ◇ **Matron Ysolde Tullow (the Eldest)** — his first ancestor, now a hill, whom he consults by proxy and who has begun to answer every question with the same word: *Down*.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet the Chairman in the Weighhouse, where all business in the Fatlands eventually goes: as petitioners, as agents of a foreign land negotiating for flour, as witnesses in a Board inquiry, or as people the Board needs for something it cannot ask its own servants to do. He wants from them what he wants from everyone: information, preferably numbers, and service that cannot be traced to him.

- ◇ **The Root Question.** The vote is in a month. The Chairman needs six Deacons to change their minds, or to be unable to attend. He would like the PCs to persuade them. He is not particular about the method, and he will provide the lists of their families.
- ◇ **The Weight Below.** Clerks in the Weighhouse cellars have stopped coming back up. The Board wants the cellars inspected by people who are not Fatlanders and who will not be missed. Down there the Chairman's roots fill the vaults like the inside of a hedge, and they are warm, and they move when he speaks overhead.

- ◇ **One Short.** Tullow summons a PC with Reckoning to check Purslane's arithmetic, because the figures are always one short of what he feels. The PC finds that Purslane has, since 622, left one name off every eastern total: his own daughter's, Reaped that Carving.

**Threatened**, he does nothing; he lets the Board, the Bailiffs and the Cullmasters do it. **Shown kindness**, he is suspicious, then curious, then quietly grateful, and asks the kind one to read him the figures. **Faced with the god**, he is unafraid. He has been waiting for it all his life.

If nobody intervenes, the Board rules that the roots count, in the Grace of 642. The Chairman's vote becomes permanent and absolute. Within three years he stops speaking, and the floor of the Weighhouse begins, very slowly, to breathe.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"He doesn't need to win a vote. He just needs everyone to know he could." — a Deacon of the eastern plain

"I turn him every morning. He says *thank you, Carrier* every morning. He never once has asked my name, and he knows it." — Wem Haddle's cousin, a Carrier of the Weighhouse

"Ask the Chairman what's under the Weighhouse and he'll tell you: the Chairman. He thinks it's a joke." — Mistress Brisket Annalow

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# DAME SUET MARRABLE

*Hostess of the Unending Dinner*

*“Sit, duck. No, there. By me. You’ll want the crackling while it’s hot. Nobody leaves my table hungry, and nobody’s left it yet.”*

– DAME SUET MARRABLE, TO EVERY NEW GUEST, IN THE SAME WORDS, FOR EIGHTY-ONE YEARS

| DAME SUET MARRABLE – HOSTESS OF THE UNENDING DINNER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                          | Fatlands · Cut 4 (Gut-line, the Marrable liver) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION                                       | 103 (born 538 A.G.; her face has not aged since 40); mistress of Marrable Hall; southern chair of the Second Table                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                                  | Scion · Standing 5 (Great House)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                                          | Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                                              | Feast 5, Persuade 4, Clause 3, Endure 3, Search 2, Deceive 2, Lore 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                                                | Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                             | carving knife +3 (2); she prefers to have others carve                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                               | Taste the Name: one bite of a guest’s blood tells her their family, their Cut and one secret (she licks the knife after the first cut of meat she serves them, from their own plate, which has been nicked). The Hostess’s Table: her hall’s food compels; any guest who has eaten at the Dinner must pass Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to rise from it, Grim 18 after the third course. Laden: her loam-flesh grants Armor 1. Rooting: her feet are rooting through the throne’s floor; she cannot be moved from the head of the table without 1d6 Flesh damage to her and a Dread 2 check for the Carriers. |
| WANTS                                               | The Second Plate; The Hollow (no guest may refuse a dish); and her own: that no guest leave hungry, and that no guest leave                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                              | Table Manners, Smell of Cedar, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                                        | none she would admit; she has not been alone in a room since 560                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                                             | the head-of-table throne, the Marrable carving set, the place cards, the Dinner Book, the cellar key, Fennick’s ring                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                               | 2 (to see a guest served); 3 to be taken to the cellar table                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

At the head of a table three hundred feet long, on a gilded throne that has sunk four inches into the floorboards, under a canopy of gold silk stained brown at the edges by eighty years of steam, sits a woman made of pillows. Dame Suet Marrable weighs a little over twelve hundred pounds and wears all of it in silk: gold, ochre, field-red, swathe on swathe, pinned with bone brooches, her many chins hung with ropes of pearls like dew strung on a hedge. Her face is powdered white and rouged high on each cheek and it is, under the paint, the face of a handsome woman of forty, unlined and bright-eyed; she sucked marrow at her first wake at the age of six and the Gut-line marrow keeps the face young while the body goes on.

She smells of rosewater over roast pork, and, closer, of loam. Her voice is warm and husky, a little hoarse from eighty years of conversation over the noise of a full hall, and she calls everyone *duck*: Chairmen, servants, Reckoners, children. She is the best company in the Fatlands, and she knows it, and her guests feel, while they sit

with her, more welcome than they have ever felt anywhere. It is only afterward, if there is an afterward, that they realise how much of that was the food.

## THEIR STORY

Suet Brawnley married Lord Fennick Marrable in the Grace of 560, at twenty-two, in Marrable Hall, before four hundred guests. It was the match of the decade: the Brawnley liver-line and the Marrable stomach-line together. The wedding breakfast began at the Firstbite bell. At Supper, when the guests rose to go, the bride stood up at the head of the table, already the heaviest woman in the room, and said, laughing, *Oh, don’t go. There’s more. Stay.* And they stayed.

That is how the Unending Dinner began, and it has not stopped. The table has been laid, served, cleared and laid again, continuously, without a single hour’s interruption, for eighty-one years. Guests have come and gone; some have come and stayed. The hall has had no clear floor since 560. Children have been born at the table and grown grey at it. Fennick Marrable died at the table in 571, of a

burst belly during the fish course, and in accordance with the Wake Ordinance and with his wife's wish, he was served at it, starting at the next Firstbite. The custom since then is that anyone who dies at the Dinner is served at the Dinner. A good many have died there. The hall's foundations have shifted a yard downhill under the weight.

In 589 Dame Marrable was approached, at her own table, by a quiet Oathen gentleman with a proposition about what might be done when the gods finished growing, and the Second Table's southern chapter has met in her cellar ever since. She took its chair in 604.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Marrable Hall is the Fatlands' second capital. The Board decides in the Weighhouse; the Gut-lines decide at the Dinner, and the Board usually follows. Dame Marrable holds no office, but she outweighs most of the Board, and the members who dine with her vote as she suggests over the pudding. Her cooks, forty of them in three shifts, are the best-paid in the south, and her larders are supplied by the Renderers' Union, the Board's stores, the Dowager Hills' best cuts, and, in the cellar, by Lord Chastain Loin's acquisitions.

Her limits are physical and growing. Since 638 she cannot leave the throne. Her feet have rooted through its iron floor plate, which is cracked, into the hall's boards, which are oak and which the roots love. She rules from that seat now, absolutely, and everything must come to her. Her Carriers have stopped turning her. Her Washers work round her where she sits, and they pluck her shoots under the table while she talks.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The head-of-table throne** — gilded oak, iron-floored, built in 560 for a bride of five hundred pounds and rebuilt three times. The floor-plate is cracked through. Under it, through the hall's floorboards, her roots have gone down into the cellar, and they hang there over the second table like the roots over a cave.
- ◇ **The Marrable carving set** — a knife, a fork and a steel of black-handled Oathen steel, a wedding gift, used to make the first cut of every joint served at the Dinner, including Fennick, including every guest since. She carves seldom now; she makes the first cut and hands the knife to a servant.
- ◇ **The place cards** — a silver box of cream cards, each with a guest's name in her own round hand. She writes a card for everyone she intends to have at her table. There is one, written in 640, for **Tobias Wether**, the Unfed exile who ate. There is another, written last month, for **Wren Hollowell**.
- ◇ **The Dinner Book** — a ledger, now in sixty volumes, recording every guest, every dish and every course since 560, kept by a succession of stewards. Guests who were served are listed twice: once under *Guests*, once under *Dishes*.
- ◇ **The cellar key** — iron, on a chain about her neck, hidden in her chins. It opens the door behind the tapestry of Ummer walking,

- ◇ **Fennick's ring** — her husband's wedding ring, on her thumb. She took it from his plate.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the Dinner to outlast her. She has never said aloud what that means. She fears that it will not, because her feet are in the floor and she knows how the Course ends; she has visited her mother, and her grandmother, on the Dowager Hills, and they have told her to *stay*. She does not fear becoming a hill. She fears becoming a hill and having the guests go home.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** The cellar beneath the dining hall holds a smaller table, of twenty-four places, where the Second Table's southern chapter dines. The guests there are older and the meat is something rarer: Blank flesh, Unfed flesh, high-Cut flesh from other lands, cuts of the Dowagers, purchased and stolen. They are practising. When Ummer stands up, they intend to be at its table with knives. Tobias Wether's seat is waiting for him in the cellar, between Lord Chastain Loin and a Vigil Eye-line count.

**Secret (she does not know):** Lady Aspic Dellamore has been measuring her for a jelly. And under the throne, in the cellar, her roots have found the roots of the Chairman, which run out under the city, and have joined them.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — her protégé, her old ally, and her rival in the Root Question. She bought him his first Weighing with Garrick Tripe's lead; she thinks she is owed the Board.
- ◇ **Lord Chastain Loin** — her favourite and her heir in the Second Table, who brings Blanks to the cellar; she loves him like a son, and suspects he is waiting for her to root.
- ◇ **Lady Aspic Dellamore** — her most frequent guest and most gifted rival in the kitchen; Suet adores her jellies and has never guessed what the measuring is for.
- ◇ **Tobias Wether** — a name on a card; the most interesting meal she has ever imagined.
- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — another card. Suet wants to know what a Blank tastes like with all her heart.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — her jointer, for sixty years of wakes. He has refused the cellar twice, politely. She has not forgotten.
- ◇ **The Brawnley Dowager** — her mother, a hill a mile from the Hall, whose counsel she follows on everything.

#### IN PLAY

Every PC of consequence in the Fatlands is invited to dinner. That is how the PCs meet her: a cream card, a fine hand, their name spelled correctly, and a carriage at the door. The Dinner is a social battleground, a source of intrigue, a market for secrets and a death-trap, all at once. She wants from the PCs what she wants from all guests: to taste them, to learn their secrets, and to keep them. Foreign PCs are especially welcome. She has not tasted many foreigners.

- ◇ **Sixty Courses.** The PCs need something from a guest who has been at the Dinner for nineteen years and will not leave the table to talk. They must take seats, eat, and resist the table's pull long enough to get what they came for (Caul + Resolve at rising difficulty each course).
- ◇ **The Card for Tobias.** Dame Marrable wants Tobias Wether brought to dinner. She will pay any price, and offers it to the PCs. The Reckoners want him dead first.

**Threatened**, she laughs, and asks if they have tried the pork, and signals with her fan, and her servants, who are many and heavy, close the hall doors. **Shown kindness**, she is touched, and sets a place for the kind one forever. **Faced with the god**, she is delighted: she has been laying a table for it for eighty-one years.

If nobody intervenes, Dame Marrable roots completely in the Carving of 642, at the head of her table, mid-sentence. The Dinner continues. The guests serve themselves. Within a decade, Marrable Hall is a hill with a long hall inside it, and the guests are still at table.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"I went for Elevenes in 609. My wife came to fetch me in 611. She's still here too. We're very happy." — a guest at the Unending Dinner

"Her mother told her *stay*. She's been saying it to everyone since. I don't think she knows it isn't her word." — Mercy Sowerby, Hill-Speaker

"I've washed dishes in that hall forty years. You learn what the plates mean. The blue ones go up. The white ones go down." — a scullery-maid of Marrable Hall

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# PELL HOGGET

the Counter

*“I don’t say what it means. I say how many. One hundred and ninety-four in Kettle Furrow. That’s all. That’s all I’ve ever said.”*

– PELL HOGGET, TO A BAILIFF, AT HIS OWN KITCHEN TABLE, LACK 640

| PELL HOGGET – THE COUNTER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Scrapling line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION             | 47; tenant-farmer of Kettle Furrow, Low Tilth; keeper of the Long Count                                                                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING        | none formally; to the two hundred villages of the Count, the Counter (unofficial, total)                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                    | Reckoning 4, Labor 3, Endure 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 2, Lore 2, Resolve 2, Craft 1                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                      | Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                   | hay-fork +3 (3, Reach); he has never struck anyone                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                     | Iron Belly (Taste): +2 to Feast; can eat what he must. The Tally (not a godsign Gift): once per session, told a place and a season, he can give the true number of the Reaped there, from memory, and is never wrong. |
| WANTS                     | The Hollow (he will make others eat, though he eats too little himself); The Second Plate at Hunger 4+                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                    | Counting Habit, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS              | The Count (he counts everything, always; the number is always one short, and he knows exactly who the missing one is)                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                   | a stub of chalk, the barn key, the tally-book, Nell’s comb, eleven sets of teeth                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                     | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

A short, broad, sunburnt man with a wheat-coloured beard going grey at the chin, small careful blue eyes, and a stub of chalk always behind his left ear. He has a farmer’s hands, square and cracked, and a farmer’s slowness, and he speaks as he works: one word at a time, laid down straight. He gives numbers instead of opinions. Ask him whether the Reaping is worse this year and he will say *forty-one in the Tilth parishes by the ninth of Carving, against thirty-three this time last year*, and then look at you to see whether you understand what he has said. He is lighter than he should be, two hundred and sixty pounds, which in Low Tilth makes him look ill. His smock hangs on him. He smells of chalk dust, sweat and barn.

## THEIR STORY

Pell was born in Kettle Furrow in 594 to a family of tenant-farmers on Marrable land. His grandmother, Margery Rind, rooted in the orchard behind the village in 601 and taught him his numbers before she lost her legs, counting pears with him on her lap; she is Old Mother Rind now, and he still visits her. He married Nell Fairweather in 616. They had one son, Barnaby, now sixteen. Pell

was an ordinary farmer, rather better at sums than his neighbours, who did the village’s accounts at Harvest Home.

In Carving 629 he was asked to count the village for the Board’s census and noticed that the figure was one less than last year’s, and that last year’s was one less than the year before. He went back through the parish’s wake-book. He scratched the figures on the inside of his barn wall in chalk, one mark for each, by year. Then he walked to the next village and asked. By 633 eleven villages were sending him their numbers; by 637, ninety; now, two hundred, by carrier, by pilgrim, by children who walk the causeways with slates. The marks went from chalk to knife to paint. The barn is a ledger of the dead from floor to rafter.

In Carving 637 Nell’s name was read on the dusk-shift list in Kettle Furrow square. She walked the row in a white smock with a ribboned sickle. She did not walk back. Pell has never put her mark on the wall.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Pell has no office and wants none. He is the keeper of a habit that has become a movement, the **Long Count**, and the Count has no leaders, no meetings and no creed, only tallies, copied and carried.



Every Carving the villages send their numbers to Kettle Furrow, and Pell adds them up, and copies the totals onto slates that go back out along the causeways, and the copies are copied again. That is all. It is enough to terrify the Board, because the Count is the first public record of the Reaping in three centuries, and it shows the Reaping doubling.

He still farms his strip. He depends on his neighbours, who protect the barn by sitting round it eating whenever the Bailiffs come, on his son, who carries the slates, and on Old Mother Rind, who tells him things. The Board cannot arrest him without making the Count famous; it has tried feeding him (he is on a Bailiff's watch-list for eating too little), burning his barn (twice), and listing him (the Cullmasters have never yet put his name on a list, for reasons he does not understand).

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A stub of chalk** — behind his ear, always. He has worn through four hundred sticks.
- ◇ **The barn key** — the barn has no lock; the key is to a box nailed inside, which holds the Count's master copy.
- ◇ **The tally-book** — a calf-bound ledger copied from the walls, in his square hand, with every village's figures since 629 and a column at the right-hand edge headed *Projected*. The projection crosses Kettle Furrow's population in nineteen years and the country's soon after.
- ◇ **Nell's comb** — horn, with three of her hairs still in it. He keeps it in his breast pocket and does not use it.
- ◇ **Eleven sets of teeth** — bought from Granny Cracknel, matched to Low Tilth people he knew. Held in the mouth for a night, each gives the owner's last sight. It is always the same field at dusk. He has not bought Nell's set, though Granny has told him she has it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wishes he had never learned to count. He wants the Board to say the number out loud, once, in the Weighhouse, so that it will be true for everyone and he can stop. He fears the shape of the numbers more than anything that has ever happened to him, and he fears that the shape has a destination: that the Count is not measuring the Reaping but *drawing* it, that the Scarecrow is walking toward his barn because the barn is where the names are.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** He has never put Nell's mark on the wall. Every year his total for Kettle Furrow is one short of the truth, and he knows it, and he cannot make his hand do it, because once she is a mark she is a number like the others.

**Secret (he does not know):** Nell was not listed for debt. She was listed as a troublemaker, for carrying the Count to Bramble Furrow and Millsop, and Pell's own name was on the same list beside hers. A Listing Clerk may strike one name a season. Nell went to the Clerk on the morning of the reading and asked which name, and

offered him something, and he struck Pell's. It was in Varn Sweetbread's ledger, in the Cullmaster's neat hand: *Hogget, P.: struck, by exchange.*

#### TIES

- ◇ **Old Mother Rind** — his grandmother, an orchard hill with a mouth, who taught him to count; he brings her pears from her own trees, and she has lately asked him to bring her Barnaby.
- ◇ **Tansy Lard** — the gleaner girl from the next lane, who brings him her mother's root's growth, measured in hands; he writes it down.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — the Cullmaster who walked Nell out to the row and bowed to her. They have met once since. Sweetbread asked to see the tally-book and was genuinely interested.
- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — who reads Pell's figures every week and whom Pell has never seen.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — the Thin want the Count as proof; Pell will not let them use it, because he does not give opinions.
- ◇ **Granny Cracknel** — who sells him teeth and keeps Nell's.
- ◇ **The Scarecrow** — which has turned around, and is facing his barn.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to Kettle Furrow because everyone does: to touch the marks for their own dead, to find out whether someone they lost was Reaped, to bring a village's tally, or on the Board's business, to steal or burn the book. Pell will feed them, answer any question with a number, and ask them to carry slates.

- ◇ **The Missing Mark.** A PC who reads the wall closely (Eye + Reckoning, Hard 14) finds that Kettle Furrow's totals are one short every year since 637. Asking why is the way into Pell's grief, and into Sweetbread's ledger.
- ◇ **The Brawn Book.** A Cullmaster's little book of dusk names has gone missing on the Rim Road (see the core adventure). Pell would weep to have it. Getting it to him puts the Board's figures and the people's side by side.
- ◇ **Barnaby.** Old Mother Rind has asked for Pell's son. Pell has not refused her. He has not answered. He asks the PCs what they would do.

**Threatened**, he goes on counting. **Shown kindness**, he cries, briefly and without embarrassment, and then gives a number. **Faced with the god**, he counts it. If nobody intervenes, the Scarecrow reaches the barn in Carving 642, and the barn is found next morning empty, every mark on its walls scraped clean, and Pell sitting in the middle of the floor writing them back in chalk from memory, one short.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“He came to count us, and he did, and then he cried, and then he ate supper with us. You can’t be angry at a man who eats supper.” — a Bailiff of Low Tilt

“My mam’s on the wall. Third row, the year I was born. I go and touch her on Sundays.” — a boy of Kettle Furrow

“His figures are the best in the country. I would give a great deal to have him in the cellars. I would give a great deal for him never to come.” — Mister Hollis Purslane, reading-clerk to the Chairman

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# CORDER LANK

the Thin Man

*“Are you hungry? It’s all right. You can tell me. I’m not going to feed you.”*

– CORDER LANK, HIS FIRST WORDS TO EVERY STRANGER

| CORDER LANK – THE THIN MAN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste, dormant) · Hunger 0                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION              | 38; outlaw; leader of the Thin, under sentence of the Gavage in every district                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Purger (the Thin’s way) · Standing 5 (the Thin Man)                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS                     | Resolve 5, Endure 4, Persuade 3, Stealth 3, Athletics 2, Rites 2, Feast 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                       | Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                    | knife +3 (2); he has never used it on a person                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                      | Passing the Plate: anyone who fasts a day in his company loses 1 Hunger and he gains none; they gain it back, doubled, the day they leave him. The Still Field: the Reaping does not lean toward him; he can walk a ripe field at dusk in Carving and the wheat turns away. |
| WANTS                      | to be needed; never to be fed (if force-fed, he must pass Caul + Resolve, Grim 18, or gain 1d6 Hunger at once, which he has not felt in six years and which is unbearable)                                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                     | No Thank You, Cold Supper, Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS               | The Unclean (he cannot bear to be touched by anyone who has just eaten)                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                    | the cord, the ash-tin, a knife, the hand-signs, Hester Gaunt’s spoon                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                      | 1 (his body, bone by bone)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

You can count him. That is what people say first. A long brown figure strung on tendons, six feet two, perhaps a hundred and thirty pounds, every rib and knuckle and vertebra standing out under skin as tight and dry as a drumhead; the hip-bones lift his ragged smock like tent-poles; the cord around his middle is wound six times and still loose. His head is a skull with a calm face drawn on it, the hair cropped, the cheeks hollow, the lips thin and cracked. His eyes are enormous in that face, brown and clear and still, and they rest on people the way a cool hand rests on a fever.

He smells of woodsmoke and nothing else; there is no sweat on him, no breath of food, none of the warm loam-and-dripping smell of every other Fatlander. His voice is quiet, low and unhurried, and he always first asks whether you are hungry.

## THEIR STORY

Corder Lank was born in Sapwell in 603, a drover’s son. He was an ordinary, heavy, cheerful boy who could walk a herd and carve a wake. At twenty-four he joined the Thin, not from conviction but from grief: his younger sister was dusk-shifted for their father’s

debts in 627 and did not walk back, and at her empty-bowl supper his mother ate the girl’s portion because it was there. He fasted with the Thin for five years, hiding in the Orchards, and rose to Gaunt. In 632 he was taken and spent a season in the Gavage under Feeder Callow Pudge, who sang to him. He came out at four hundred pounds, silent and eating.

He went back to the Thin within a month. In 635 he began the true fast: water and ash, nothing else, ever. The Thin had fasted for two centuries and always failed by the second month; Corder did not. The hunger, which had sat beneath his breastbone his whole life, thinned and then went. By 637 he was the only man in the south who did not feel it, and the Thin, who had had no single leader since Hester Gaunt, made him their Thin Man. In 638 he understood why it had gone.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Thin number perhaps four thousand across the plain, in cells of six to twelve, hidden in barns, ditches, the hollow trees of the Orchards and the sunken basements of the Leanings. Corder walks between them, never staying more than three nights, moving by the Drovers’ Ways at night and through the Orchards where the deaf

keepers will not hear. He leads by presence: he sits with a cell, fasts with them, listens, and goes on. The Thin do not kill nobles and do not burn houses; they refuse. Corder's whole policy is refusal, made public: to get one whole parish, then one district, through one whole Carving without feeding the god, and so prove the Reaping can be ended. The Purgation's money goes on getting people out of the Gavage.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The cord** — a rope belt, wound six times, which every Thin wears. His is the original cord of Hester Gaunt, passed from Thin Man to Thin Man since 455.
- ◇ **The ash-tin** — a small tin of fine grey wood-ash, sifted. He stirs a pinch into a cup of water twice a day. Ash-water is treason in the Fatlands.
- ◇ **A knife** — a plain drover's knife, for cutting cord and bread for others.
- ◇ **Hester Gaunt's spoon** — a horn spoon, worn thin, which she is said to have carried and never used. He gives it to Thin who are about to be taken, to hold in the Gavage.
- ◇ **A list in his head** — of every Thin in every cell, by name; he writes nothing down.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be needed. He wants one whole Carving without a Reaping somewhere. He wants, in the last place he allows himself to look, to be forgiven by the people he leads. He fears his own death, not for himself, and he fears the day any of the Thin works out what he worked out in 638.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** The hunger did not leave him. It went out of him, a little at a time, into those who fast beside him. Every Thin cell carries a share of Corder Lank's gnawing on top of its own, and that is why the Thin's fasts are so hard and why they fail so often. He has not told them. He cannot stop leading, because leading is the only thing that keeps him clear; if he stopped moving between the cells, the hunger would have no one to go to and would come home. If he dies, it goes back to the god all at once, and every Thin on the plain will feel it go.

**Secret (he does not know):** He believes he has starved the god out of himself. He has not. Ummer does not want a field that does not feed it, and has simply stopped attending to him. His Regrowth is dormant, not reversed, and it is waiting for the day he eats.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — the Fasting Girl, a Blank, the one person he cannot pass his hunger to. The Thin kneel to her; Corder does not, and she likes him best of anyone for it. She is proof that a person can be without hunger honestly, and he cannot look at her for long.
- ◇ **Brother Glut** — his mirror: the other man in the south who no longer feels the hunger. They met once, at the edge of Gladbelly,

and Glut embraced him and wept.

- ◇ **Bailiff Dunmow Fatt** — who has taken him twice and wept both times, and is afraid of the quiet in his eyes.
- ◇ **Feeder Callow Pudge** — who fed him in 632, and who now leaves one Gavage cell unbarred each Lack, because he asked her to.
- ◇ **Tobias Wether** — a man who came from emptiness into hunger; Corder is very interested in him, and wants to know whether the hunger in Tobias can be passed.
- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — whose Count Corder wants as the Thin's proof, and who will not give it.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Corder in a barn at night, in the Orchards, or in the Gavage, where a PC might be held beside him. He wants from the PCs what the Thin always need: shelter, a way out of the Gavage for someone, a message carried to the Purgation, and above all a witness from outside the Fatlands who will say, somewhere the Board cannot reach, that the Reaping is real.

- ◇ **One Clean Carving.** Corder has persuaded a single parish to keep its people out of the fields and refuse the dusk-shift for one season. The PCs are asked to help them hold out against the Bailiffs and the Cullmasters.
- ◇ **The Weight of the Thin.** A Thin Hollow, starving, sick, begs a PC to explain why the fast is so much harder with the Thin Man present. The PCs may work it out.
- ◇ **The Feeding of Corder Lank.** The Board takes him and announces his feeding in the Weighhouse. If he is fed, the god wakes in him all at once, and every Thin on the plain doubles over.

**Threatened,** he does not resist, and does not run, unless others are with him. **Shown kindness,** he offers bread. **Faced with the god,** he is the one person in the Fatlands it looks past. If nobody intervenes, he is taken in the Lack of 642 and fed; he dies in the Gavage chair in the ninth day, eating, weeping, and the Thin break across the plain like a field going over in wind.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He looked at me like I was a person and not a meal. Nobody's ever done that. I followed him four years for that look." — a Lean of the Thin

"I fed him for a season. He thanked me every ladle. I've never been so ashamed of anything in my life." — Feeder Callow Pudge

"There's always a thin man somewhere. You find him and you feed him and there's another. It's like weeding." — an Under-Bailiff of Sated

# MISTRESS BRISKET ANNALOW

*Boss of the Renderers' Union*

*“Every barrel’s got two marks on it, love: what it says and what it is. I know both. That’s why I’m the one with the pencil.”*

— BRISKET ANNALOW, TO A BOARD TAX-CLERK, BARRELSIDE, 638 A.G.

| BRISKET ANNALOW – MISTRESS OF THE UNION |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common line) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                           | 58; Mistress of the Renderers’ Union since 624; Stamper since 619                                                                                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | Renderer · Standing 5 (Union Boss)                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                                  | Haggle 4, Reckoning 4, Intimidate 4, Feast 4, Labor 3, Endure 3, Clause 3, Blades 2                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (salt-stiff apron) · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                 | cleaver on a chain +6 (3, Ripping; +1 damage from Know the Cut = 4)                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                   | Iron Belly (Taste). Know the Cut (Calling): by taste or smell she can tell what meat used to be. The Stopping Word: once a season she can halt every barrel at the Chute; the Rim Road Company will go hungry within the month. |
| WANTS                                   | The Second Plate at Hunger 4+ (she chews salt fat all day, and it is never enough)                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                                  | Butcher’s Calm, Bone-Coin Nose, Strong Back                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                                 | the cleaver, the pencil, the second ledger, the Union stamp, a salt-pouch, a brass whistle                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                   | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

A vast red-armed woman of five hundred pounds, built square and solid as a salting-vat, in a leather apron so stiff with old salt it stands up on its own when she takes it off. Her grey hair is cropped to the skull against the heat of the rendering-sheds. Her face is broad, weathered and freckled, with small shrewd grey eyes and a mouth always working on a strip of salt fat. A cleaver hangs from a chain at her hip, worn bright; a pencil lives behind her right ear. She smells of brine, hot tallow, pipe-smoke and blood, and her hands are chapped raw to the wrist. She talks like a drover, loud and filthy and quick, and laughs like a kettle coming to the boil, a rising shriek that sets the yard-dogs barking. She walks slowly and never stops; she has been seen to cross the whole of Barrelside in an afternoon, eating, swearing and settling disputes as she goes.

## THEIR STORY

Brisket was born in Barrelside in 583 to a cooper and a tripe-dresser, and went into the yards at eight as a spit-hand. She was a Hook at fourteen, a Jointer at twenty, a Yardmaster at thirty. In 619 she was made a Stamper, with control of a barrel-mark, and with it the knowledge of what went into the barrels that bore it. That year she

began a second ledger: every consignment’s real contents set against its stamp. In 624 the old Mistress of the Union rooted in the Chute office, and Brisket took the chair by acclamation, standing on a barrel. She has kept the second ledger for twenty-two years, in her own hand, in a code of butchers’ cuts that nobody else can read.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She holds the Chute absolutely. Every barrel that leaves the Fatlands passes under a Union stamp, and every Stamper answers to her. The Board needs her for every lack of export revenue and taxes her as hard as it dares; the Rim Road Company needs her barrels to feed half the Table and pays her well not to look. She keeps Barrelside’s peace with her yard-wardens, settles the Union’s disputes in the open yard, and sits, by Union right, on the Board as its member, where she outweighs most Deacons and votes against the Chairman on every tax. Her day begins at the Firstbite bell on the Chute ramp, counting barrels, and ends at the Supper table in the Union hall, eating with her Stampers.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◆ **The cleaver on its chain** — her father’s, ground so often the blade is half its old width. She has jointed nine hundred bodies

with it and taken one man's hand, in 627, for selling Union stamps.

- ◇ **The pencil** — a lead pencil in a bone holder, behind her ear. Every barrel she tallies, she tallies with it.
- ◇ **The second ledger** — twenty-two years of true contents, in eleven greasy volumes, coded in cuts. "Brisket" means Dusk Acres meat. "Shin" means Sal Trotter's two-legged herds. "Hare" means Rootkin. "Tongue" means people.
- ◇ **The Union stamp** — the master stamp of the Chute, brass, the size of a fist; any barrel bearing its mark goes up the Rim unopened.
- ◇ **A salt-pouch of fat strips** — she chews all day.
- ◇ **A brass whistle** — one long blast stops every winch in Barreldside. She has blown it twice in twenty years.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the Union paid and her people safe, and she wants, more and more, someone else to be blamed when the world finds out what has been in the barrels. She fears the day the Table stops buying; Barreldside would starve in a fat country. She would sell the Board out in an afternoon to keep the Chute open.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** She knows where Sal Trotter's bloodstock comes from. Each spring, in the Dusk Acres, the Cullmasters' men find calves lying in the furrows of the plots that Reaped the Carving before: pale, broad-faced, silent, with scars in the shape of letters. Her ledger matches the scars to Pell Hogget's names. The herds are the Reaped, come up again as stock, and she has been shipping them up the Rim as beef for twenty years. She has kept the ledger as her protection: if the Board ever moves against her, she will publish, and the Board knows it.

**Secret (she does not know):** In 636 a Stamper named Wat Gristle went to his brother with the truth about the herds. Her deputy, Yardmaster Rook Tallowby, took out a contract on Wat in the Union's name, to protect her, without telling her. Jem Crackle did the work in a Sated kitchen. Wat was served in a pie. Hob Gristle tasted him.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — her enemy at the Board, and the only man who can tax her; they need each other and say so.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — the best jointer in the south and the most honest man she knows; she has offered him a Stamper's seat three times. She does not know what he tasted.
- ◇ **Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot** — who has been notching barrels; she has sent a clerk to count the notches and is frightened by the number.
- ◇ **Sal Trotter** — her drover; Brisket pays her double and never asks about the road.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — who supplies the Dusk Acres meat; she despises him as a man who calls slaughter by another name.

- ◇ **The Rim Road Company** — her real master, she sometimes thinks, and the only customer who never complains.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her at the Chute, as Union hires, Company agents, Board inspectors, or foreigners who have opened a barrel and want to know what was in it. She wants from them deniability: people from outside who can carry a barrel, a message or a ledger page somewhere and be blamed.

- ◇ **The Undercutting.** The Vigil has started buying tallow from a cheaper source, and Brisket wants to know whose. It is the Second Table, rendering Blanks.
- ◇ **Count the Notches.** Brisket hires the PCs to check one convoy against its manifest (see the core adventure).
- ◇ **The Ledger Walks.** A volume of the second ledger is stolen. The Board, the Company and the Thin all want it, and Brisket will do anything to get it back first.

**Threatened,** she blows the whistle. **Shown kindness,** she feeds you, and owes you, and remembers. **Faced with the god,** she reaches for the pencil. If nobody intervenes, the Board moves against her in 642 and she publishes the ledger on the Rim Road; the Table reads it and, after a month of horror, goes on buying, at a discount.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She can shout a winch still from the other end of the yard. I've seen it." — a Hook of Barreldside

"I've always admired a woman who knows exactly what she's selling." — a Rim Road Company factor

"She's the only honest one in the business. She knows it's people and she says it's beef. The rest of them don't even know." — Hob Gristle

# HOB GRISTLE

*the Honest Butcher*

*“Sorry, Wilm. Sorry, old lad. You were a good man and you’re good meat. Sorry.”*

– HOB GRISTLE, JOINTING A DEACON AT A WAKE IN LOW TILTH, 639 A.G.

| HOB GRISTLE – THE HONEST BUTCHER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Fatlands · Cut 3 (Gut-line, a cadet branch long fallen to trade) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION                    | 55; master jointer of Wakeside, Sated                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Renderer · Standing 2 (Cutter; he has refused Master three times)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                           | Feast 5, Blades 4, Labor 3, Endure 3, Stitching 2, Rites 2, Resolve 2, Lore 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                             | Flesh 15 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                          | jointing knife +7 (2 +1 = 3, Ripping); cleaver +7 (3 +1 = 4, Ripping)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                            | The Naming Tongue: a mouthful of any meat tells him the beast, the field it ate from, and the name of anyone Reaped into that field; a mouthful of a person tells him their name and their last meal (no roll; it cannot be refused; each tasting of a person is a Dread 2 check for him). Gorge (Appetite). |
| WANTS                            | The Long Pig (he resists it at every wake, and has not failed yet); The Second Plate                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                           | Butcher’s Calm, Steady Hands, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                     | Kept Grief (for his brother Wat; he sets a plate for him)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                          | the jointing set, the apology-cloth, the name-book, the casings, a pie-dish                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                            | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## WHO THEY ARE

A big, mild, sorrowful man with forearms like hams and a bald head always beaded with sweat, wearing a leather apron and a clean white shirt with the sleeves rolled to the elbow. His face is large, soft and kind, with heavy-lidded brown eyes that look as though he has just been told bad news. He moves slowly and precisely, and his hands, when he carves, are as light as a lacemaker’s. He smells of carbolic soap, honed steel, and faintly of rosemary, which he chews to clean his mouth between tastings. He speaks softly, says sorry often, and apologises to every joint by name, under his breath, as the blade goes in.

## THEIR STORY

Hob was born in Wakeside in 586, the elder of two sons of a jointer. He carved his grandmother at twelve, as Wakeside custom requires, and has carved at wakes ever since: forty years, perhaps four thousand bodies, deacons and Carriers and children, a Gut-line lord in 621 who took three days. He was always good. In 630 he reached the Appetite and the gift came: he put a scrap of sausage in his mouth at a market and knew the pig, the farm, the field, and the name of a girl who had been Reaped into that field’s wheat four

years before, which the pig had eaten. He was sick in the gutter. He has been able to taste names ever since, in every mouthful. It has ruined him for the trade and for food. He still works, because jointing at wakes is the only honest money left: there, at least, everyone knows whose meat it is.

In 636 he bought a pig in Sated, on Ladle Lanes, and tasted his brother Wat.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the most sought-after jointer in the south, after Pudding Hesk’s cooking. Families wait months for him. He charges ten lacks a body and gives half back to the poor. He also sells **tastings**: five lacks to tell a family what a cut of meat used to be, by name, which families buy when they suspect a barrel or a cookshop holds someone they lost. He depends on Wakeside’s custom, on the Union card that lets him work, and on Brisket Annalow’s protection, which she gives without asking why he refuses promotion.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The jointing set** — eleven knives and a cleaver in a rolled canvas, his father’s, each blade named for a family member.

- ◇ **The apology-cloth** — a square of white linen he lays over the face of the dead before he begins. He washes it after every wake. It is never quite white.
- ◇ **The name-book** — a small book of every name he has tasted in meat that was not sold as a person, with the place he bought it. Six hundred names.
- ◇ **Tattooed casings** — bought from Mardy Haunch of Gristmoot, sausage-skins tattooed in blue, which he is trying to return to the families whose names are on them.
- ◇ **A pie-dish** — empty, chipped, from the cookshop where he tasted Wat. He set it at his table for five years. He sets a place beside it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants one barrel from the Chute that tastes of nothing but beef. He fears the day he tastes someone he loves; it has already come.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** He tasted his brother in a pie on Ladle Lanes in 636 and has told no one. He knows Wat was not Reaped: there was no Reaping in Sated that night, and the meat tasted of a kitchen knife, not a field.

**Secret (he does not know):** Wat was killed by Jem Crackle on a Union contract taken out by Yardmaster Rook Tallowby, Brisket Annalow's deputy, because Wat was about to tell Hob about the herds.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Brisket Annalow** — his protector and his Union boss; she calls him the only honest man in the trade.
- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — whose family wakes he has jointed for sixty years, father and son; he has refused her cellar table twice.
- ◇ **Wakemother Pudding Hesk** — his partner at a hundred wakes; she cooks what he carves, and they weep together.
- ◇ **Mardy Haunch** — who sells him casings and does not ask.
- ◇ **Jem Crackle** — a cheerful young kitchen man who once asked him how he gets such clean joints. Hob showed him.
- ◇ **Tansy Lard** — whose mother's family he jointed; he would know the hare birthmark anywhere.

#### IN PLAY

PCs hire Hob to taste something: a barrel, a pie, a Rootkin, a joint from Marrable Hall. He wants from them his brother's killer, though he will not say so until he trusts them.

- ◇ **Who Is in the Pie?** A PC's missing contact may be in a cookshop's stock. Hob can tell. He will need to eat it.
- ◇ **The Casings.** Hob asks the PCs to help return a tattooed casing to a sailor's family in Brinehollow, and the trail leads up the

Rim.

- ◇ **The Kitchen Knife.** If the PCs learn who killed Wat, Hob asks them, very quietly, not to tell him. Then he asks them to.

**Threatened,** he puts down the knife. **Shown kindness,** he cooks. **Faced with the god,** he tastes it. If nobody intervenes, Hob eats nothing for a month after a wake at which he tastes someone he will not name, and is found sitting at his table beside two plates, rooted to the kitchen floor through his slippers.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"He carved my mam. He said sorry to her elbows. I've never forgiven anyone so fast." — a woman of Wakeside

"Five lacks to know it's not your husband. I'd pay fifty." — a widow of Low Tilt

"Big soft fellow. Very clean joints. I learned a lot from him." — Jem Crackle

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# CULLMASTER VARN SWEETBREAD

*the Board's Quiet Hand*

*“Work well. The field is grateful. You are paid in full.”*

– THE WORDS VARN SWEETBREAD SAYS AT EVERY STONE, TO EVERY WORKER,  
EVERY CARVING EVENING SINCE 619

| VARN SWEETBREAD – CULLMASTER-GENERAL |                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Fatlands · Cut 3 (Prime Cut, the Sweetbread pancreas-line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                        | 52; Cullmaster-General of the Board of Plenty since 633                                                                                                                             |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Factor (as a Board officer) · Standing 4; Cullmasters' rank 5                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                               | Reckoning 4, Clause 3, Intimidate 3, Resolve 3, Rites 2, Endure 2, Lore 2, Blades 1                                                                                                 |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                              | ribboned sickle +3 (3); he also has the right to a black-iron Cullmaster's sickle (4, Hooking, Ripping, Silent) and does not carry it                                               |
| GIFTS                                | Field-Reading: on any Carving evening he knows which plot will Reap first, and roughly when. Taste the Name (Appetite): a slice of bread from a plot tells him who was taken there. |
| WANTS                                | to see the line through to the end (he cannot leave a dusk-shift before full dark, Hard 14 to break off); to taste the bread of each plot he culled; The Second Plate               |
| KNACKS                               | Counting Habit, Unflinching                                                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                              | the plot-ledger, the lantern, the red cloth, the ribboned sickle, lavender water, spectacles, a loaf                                                                                |
| DREAD                                | 2 (to watch his dusk-shift)                                                                                                                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

A neat, plump, pink man of middle height in good grey broadcloth, with soft white fingers, a round clean-shaven face, rimless spectacles and thinning fair hair combed flat. A ledger is chained to his belt. He smells faintly of lavender water, which he uses to cover the smell of the field that clings to him after Carving. His voice is gentle and his manners perfect: he stands when a woman enters, he remembers children's names, and he says please to Bailiffs. He is not cruel. He has never raised his voice to anyone. That is the worst thing about him.

## THEIR STORY

Varn was born in Sated in 589 to a family of Board clerks, a minor Prime Cut. He was a Lanternbearer at nineteen and walked his first dusk-shift in 608 behind a Cullmaster who wept; he did not. He was a Listing Clerk by 612, a Cullmaster by 619, Senior Cullmaster by 625, and Cullmaster-General in 633. His rise was due to arithmetic. He weighed each plot's yield in the year after its Reaping and proved that the field took the culled more gently, and returned more bread from them, than from Reaped farmers. He proposed that the dusk-shift be extended. The Board agreed.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He draws up the lists, or approves them, for every district, from the Bailiffs' reports, the debt-rolls and the Board's quiet instructions, and the Chairman signs them. On Carving afternoons his clerks read them in village squares. On Carving evenings he walks a line himself, somewhere on the plain, behind his workers, and bows at every stone. His ledgers record each plot, each worker, the time of each Reaping, and the next year's yield. He depends on the Chairman, who signs, and on Brisket Annalow, who buys the Dusk Acres meat and the Rootkin his men harvest by night.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The plot-ledger** — chained to his belt: every plot of the Dusk Acres, every worker sent to it since 619, every yield after. In it, in 637: *Hogget, P.: struck, by exchange.*
- ♦ **The lantern** — brass, shuttered, which he carries behind every line. He lights it from the Supper fire of the workers' last meal.
- ♦ **The red cloth** — a roll of red linen strips; one is laid across the end of every row, and tied at every worker's wrist. The ground knows the cloth.

- ◇ **The ribboned sickle** — a ceremonial sickle with a green ribbon, the one he bows with.
- ◇ **Lavender water** — in a silver flask.
- ◇ **A loaf** — always, from last year's plots. He eats a slice with every meal and knows whose it is.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the line seen through and the figures right. He wants to taste the bread of every plot he culled, as a matter of respect. He fears an empty plot-ledger; he fears being wrong about the yield.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** His own name is on next Carving's list, in the Chairman's hand, because Sweetbread has begun to keep his own figures, and they disagree with the Board's.

**Secret (he does not know):** The figures disagree because the field has stopped taking his workers first. Since 638 the field has been choosing for itself, and what it chooses, more and more, are the Lanternbearers and Cullmasters who stand on the road watching. It has learned who feeds it.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — his master; Varn admires him and does not know about the list.
- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — whose wife he walked to the row, and whose Count he respects as fellow work. He would like to compare ledgers.
- ◇ **Brisket Annalow** — his buyer, who despises him.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — whom the field will not lean toward; Varn would give a great deal to understand why.
- ◇ **Cullmaster Hedley Brawn** — his best officer, missing on the Rim Road with a little book of dusk names.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Varn when a name is read: theirs, or a friend's. He is courteous and immovable, and he will explain the figures to anyone who asks.

- ◇ **The Dusk List.** See the core book: a PC is listed, and the PCs have until dusk.
- ◇ **Walk the Line.** Varn invites a PC to carry the lantern, as a courtesy, so they can see it is agriculture.
- ◇ **His Own Name.** A PC finds the list with Varn's name on it. What they do with it is up to them; Varn, told, thanks them,

checks the hand, and goes very pale.

**Threatened**, he calls the Bailiffs, politely. **Shown kindness**, he is touched, and offers a seat at the workers' supper. **Faced with the god**, he takes notes. If nobody intervenes, he walks his own row in Carving 642, in a white smock, holding his own lantern, and records the time.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He bowed to my son. He said *paid in full*. My son owed nine lacks." — a mother of Bramble Furrow

"The finest administrator on the Board. I mean it as a compliment and as a warning." — Chairman Obb Tullow

"He smells of lavender. Everyone on the row smells of lavender after. It's the last thing they smell." — a Lanternbearer



# TANSY LARD

the Gleaner

*“She’s growing ever so well. Da says not to tell anyone. I’m only telling you because you look like you’d understand about mams.”*

– TANSY LARD, TO A STRANGER ON THE TILTH CAUSEWAY, PLENTY 641

| TANSY LARD – THE GLEANER |                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common line) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 5                                                     |
| AGE & STATION            | 10; gleaner behind the harvesters of Kettle Furrow; daughter of a field-hand                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Gleaner · Standing 1 (Picker)                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                    |
| SKILLS                   | Search 3, Stealth 2, Athletics 2, Filch 2, Labor 1, Instinct 2                                                         |
| BODY                     | Flesh 11 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                  | none worth the name; she runs                                                                                          |
| GIFTS                    | Iron Belly (Taste). The Root’s Daughter: the Rootkin behind her house knows her; while she is near, it does not grasp. |
| WANTS                    | The Hollow (she cannot bear it when her mother’s root refuses water; she will make it drink)                           |
| KNACKS                   | Silent Supper                                                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS             | none yet                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                  | a gleaning sack, a chipped bowl, a tin cup, her mother’s ribbon, a hare cut from paper                                 |
| DREAD                    | 3 (to see the root say her name)                                                                                       |

## WHO THEY ARE

A girl of ten, skinny for a Fatlander, which means she would pass for a well-fed child anywhere else on the Table: straw-coloured hair tangled past her shoulders, freckles, a smock too short in the arms, scabbed knees, and dirt permanently under her nails. She has a gap where two front teeth are coming in. She is quick, watchful and very quiet, and she chews the cuff of her sleeve when she is thinking, as Fatland children do. She smells of stubble-dust, grass and the earth behind her house.

## THEIR STORY

Tansy’s mother, Mab Lard, was Reaped in Carving 639, in the north strip of the far field, gleaning late after the others had gone home. Tansy was with her until the light went red, and was sent home, and went. Her father, Abner, a field-hand of few words, held a wake with no body, as Low Tilth families do, baking the strip’s flour into a single loaf on Tablenight.

In Plenty 640, gleaning in the north strip, Tansy dug up a root the size of a sleeping cat: pale, veined, warm, and marked on one side with a brown splash shaped like a running hare. Her mother had that mark on her shoulder. Tansy carried it home in her sack and

planted it behind the house, in the angle of the wall by the water-butt, and has watered it every day since. It has grown. It has leaves like hands. Last week, at dusk, it said her name.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is one of hundreds of gleaners in Low Tilth, children who follow the harvesters picking the fallen ears and are paid a few crumbs and all they can eat. She is part of the village: Pell Hogget, next lane over, measures the root for her; Old Mother Rind, in the orchard, asks after it. She has stopped eating at the family table and goes out at dusk with her bowl, and her father has noticed, and does nothing, because he has been out to look too.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A gleaning sack** — patched, which smelled of her mother for a year and now smells of the root.
- ♦ **A chipped bowl** — her supper bowl, which she carries out at dusk. She pours her broth on the root, and eats nothing.
- ♦ **A tin cup** — for water from the butt.
- ♦ **Her mother’s ribbon** — red, from Mab’s hair, which Tansy ties round the root’s thickest stem.

- ◇ **A paper hare** — cut from a Board proclamation about wolves; she has pinned it to the wall over the root.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants her mother back. She fears that someone will dig the root up: the Cullmasters' men harvest Rootkin by night and sell them by the weight, and she has heard the carts.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** Mab did not come up in one root. The north strip grew others, hare-marked, and the Cullmasters' night carts took them in Lack 640 and sold them to the Union by weight. A barrel of bacon with a hare-shaped birthmark is somewhere on the Rim Road.

**Secret (she does not know):** The root is a Rootkin bed. It has learned her name from her, and her mother's voice from the soil. If it is left a full year, in Plenty 641, it will send up shoots with hands, and the hands will pull down whatever leans close, and Tansy leans close every night. While she is near, it holds back. It is waiting for her father.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Abner Lard** — her father, who will not speak of the root and has started standing by it at night.
- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — who measures it in hands and writes it down.
- ◇ **Old Mother Rind** — who tells her the root is lucky and asks to be told how it grows.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — who jointed her grandmother, and would know the hare birthmark anywhere.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — whose men are coming for the Rootkin of Kettle Furrow this Carving.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Tansy gleaning, or on the causeway; she talks to strangers because villagers have stopped listening. She is the reason the PCs first learn what a Fatland root can become. She wants them to help her keep the root safe.

- ◇ **The Night Carts.** The Cullmasters' men come at night for the Rootkin of Kettle Furrow. Tansy begs the PCs to stop them.
- ◇ **It Said Her Name.** The PCs hear the root speak. It is Mab's voice. It asks for Abner.
- ◇ **The Hare Barrel.** A barrel on the Rim Road holds bacon with a hare birthmark. Bringing it home is a kindness and a horror.

**Threatened**, she runs and hides behind the water-butt, by the root. **Shown kindness**, she shows you her mother. **Faced with the god**, she waters it. If nobody intervenes, her father is found one morning in Plenty 641 on his knees at the root, held fast by green hands, and Tansy is sitting beside him, holding the cup, saying *drink, Mam, drink*. (Keep the camera on the adults. Tansy survives.)

#### SAID OF THEM

"Poor little mite. She's lost weight. Someone should feed her." — a Bailiff of Low Tilt

"Leave her be. A root's a root. We've all got someone in the garden." — a neighbour of Kettle Furrow

"She brings me her bowl to look at, empty, and asks if she's done right. I tell her yes. It's the first lie I've told a child." — Pell Hogget

# BROTHER GLUT

## Prophet of the Second Helping

*“Take, and eat, my loves! This is my flank, which I give for you! Oh, don’t cry, don’t cry.  
It’s the happiest day of my life. Every day is.”*

– BROTHER GLUT, AT THE LONG TABLES OF GLADBELLY, CARVING 640

| BROTHER GLUT – PROPHET OF THE SECOND HELPING |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                   | Fatlands · Cut 3 (Prime Cut, the Puddifoot tripe-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5 (stable; it has not risen since 636)                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                                | 52; Prophet of the Second Helping since 618; resident at Gladbelly                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                           | Celebrant · Standing 5 (Prophet)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                                   | Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                                       | Persuade 5, Rites 4, Feast 4, Endure 4, Godsign 3, Stitching 1, Lore 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| BODY                                         | Flesh 17 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Fray 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                      | crushing embrace +2 (1, held)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                                        | The Shared Plate: anyone who eats his flesh loses 1d6 Hunger and must pass Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or come back for more. The Words Over the Body (Calling): once per scene, those who join his rite remove 2 Fray. Laden: Armor 1; he is rooting, and is moved on a litter. Unbleeding: his offered wounds close clean in a day and never fester. |
| WANTS                                        | to give; to see others give (anyone in his presence who refuses a gift must pass Hard 14 or feel a shame like grief)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                                       | Gallows Laugh, Hostage’s Smile                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                                 | The Devotion (to Ummer; he believes it speaks to him in the taste of bread)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                      | the garland, the linen, the carving-cloth, the Book of Gravy, a bell, a bowl                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                                        | 2 (to see him carve himself, smiling)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

### WHO THEY ARE

A mountain of pink flesh in a garland of toothed wheat, nine hundred pounds of him, carried on a litter by eight singing Servers because his feet have begun to root. His face shines: with sweat, with joy, with tears that run without stopping because he is so happy. His voice is a deep golden bell that fills a meadow without trying. He has no left hand, only a stump bound in clean linen; no ears, only neat pink whorls of scar; three toes gone from his right foot; and a long linen dressing down his left flank where a strip was taken in Carving 640. He shows these off like medals. He embraces every stranger, and his embrace is warm, soft, enormous and smells of bread and honey and the inside of a bakery at dawn.

### THEIR STORY

He was born Osbert Puddifoot in Sated in 589, a pastry-cook’s son on Ladle Lanes, and was a pastry-cook himself, beloved, a little foolish, kind to children. In 612 his wife, Primrose, was Reaped. He did not weep; he went to Gladbelly, which was then a small Bait congregation of a few dozen souls, and ate with them, and was offered a second helping, and took it. He was transfigured. He

preached his first sermon at the long tables that Supper, on the text *we were eaten first*, and the commune followed him. He has been Brother Glut since 618.

He gave his first part, his left ear, in 620; his right in 624; the toes in 629; the left hand in 636, cut off on the pavilion’s board and roasted with honey and served to the whole commune; the flank strip in 640. The Second Helping teaches that being eaten is the highest form of being loved, and he is its proof.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Gladbelly has some three hundred residents and a hundred kitchens across the plain, and they are the happiest people in the south. Brother Glut presides at the long tables, preaches at every meal, blesses the Offered in their last week, and walks (is carried) in procession beside them to the pavilion. The Board finds him embarrassing and very convenient, because the Offered do not appear in the Count. The Second Table finds him useful and gullible.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The garland** — toothed wheat woven fresh each morning by the children; it nips his scalp, and he says it is kisses.
- ◇ **Clean linen** — bindings for his wounds, changed daily by Plateholder Juniper Mallow.
- ◇ **The carving-cloth** — a white cloth embroidered with the hymn, laid under him when he gives a part.
- ◇ **The Book of Gravy** — the Second Helping's hymnal, in his own hand, sticky with dripping.
- ◇ **A little brass bell** — rung at every meal, and when someone announces their Offering.
- ◇ **A wooden bowl** — Primrose's, from which he eats every meal, which is always empty when he finishes.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to give, and to see others give, and to go to the god himself, whole, when the time comes. He fears nothing. He does not see the widows at the back of each meeting, holding their plates.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** He has not felt the hunger since his hand was eaten. He thinks this is grace. It is the god moving out, piece by piece, into those who eat him. Those who have eaten his flesh feel his hunger, and come back.

**Secret (he does not know):** Some of the Offered never reach the pavilion's kitchens. Juniper Mallow has, since 630, sold one Offered in ten to Lord Chastain Loin for Dame Marrable's cellar table, and spends the money on the orphans.

## TIES

- ◇ **Corder Lank** — the other man who does not feel the hunger. Glut embraced him once and wept for joy. Corder did not.
- ◇ **Tobias Wether** — a man from the Fast who has eaten; Glut sees a convert, and believes Tobias is the god's own sign.
- ◇ **Juniper Mallow** — his Plateholder, who binds his wounds and keeps the shoes.
- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — who sends Gladbelly a cart of pies each Harvest Home, and to whom he is grateful.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — who refused to joint his hand in 636 and told him he was a fool, gently.

## IN PLAY

PCs reach Gladbelly following a missing friend, or as guests. Everyone is offered a second helping. Glut wants them to stay, and to give.

- ◇ **The Offering of a Friend.** Someone the PCs know has announced their Offering; there is a week of feasting before the

pavilion.

- ◇ **The Tenth Offered.** A child at Gladbelly asks why her father's shoes are not in the row.
- ◇ **A Piece of the Prophet.** A Thin PC with Hunger 0 is told that one mouthful of Glut will make the pain of fasting go. It will, for a day.

**Threatened**, he opens his arms. **Shown kindness**, he weeps for joy. **Faced with the god**, he sings. If nobody intervenes, he announces his own Offering in Carving 642, and the whole commune eats him in a week, and every one of them wakes the next morning with his hunger.

## SAID OF THEM

"He held my hand. The one he has left. I've never been so loved." — a Guest of the Second Helping

"There's always a widow at the back. Every meeting. Never the same one." — a cook of Gladbelly

"The happiest man in the south, and the only one who isn't hungry. That should tell you something, and it tells everyone the wrong thing." — Corder Lank

# OLD MOTHER RIND

*the Hill with a Mouth*

*“Marry her, love. She’s sound in the hip and she’ll root late. No, don’t thank me. Bring me something. Not the pears. I’ve got pears.”*

— OLD MOTHER RIND, TO A YOUNG MAN OF KETTLE FURROW, GRACE 641

| OLD MOTHER RIND – THE ORCHARD HILL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Fatlands · Cut 3 (common line, rising) · Regrowth 12 (Seated) · Hunger 7 (never below 4)                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                      | born 556 A.G.; rooted 601; Seated about 620; a small orchard hill outside Kettle Furrow                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | once Midwife of Kettle Furrow · Standing 3 (her word on marriages is still law in the village)                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 2 · Gut 9 · Lung 0 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                             | Lore 5 (every birth, bed and bloodline in Kettle Furrow), Instinct 5, Persuade 4, Feast 5, Rites 2                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                               | Flesh 50 · Guard 9 · Armor 3 (turf and loam)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                            | roots +5 (2, held: Gut + Athletics Hard 14 to break; reach: the hill and ten paces); the mouth +6 against a held target (5)                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                              | The Two Questions (old Midwife’s gift): she knows at once whether a living thing is what it seems. True Counsel: fed meat, she answers one question about any person of Kettle Furrow truthfully. Ripening: her nine pear trees bear fruit that heals 1d6 Flesh (Taint 2 Hunger). |
| WANTS                              | to be fed by her kin; lately, particular people                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| KNACKS                             | Elder’s Ear, Kin-Sense                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | The Voice at Table (she hears the field; it is reasonable; some of what it says is good)                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                            | nine pear trees, a mouth, a midwife’s knife in the turf, a ring of offerings                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                              | 2 (to hear her speak); 3 when she asks for someone by name                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

A low round hill some forty paces across behind Kettle Furrow, covered in short soft clover and bearing nine pear trees on her back in a rough ring, as a woman wears a crown of pins. The turf is warm right through Lack, and it rises and falls, slowly, once every few minutes. At her foot, half hidden in the clover, is a mouth: lips brown and cracked like bark, as wide as a cart-wheel’s hub, and inside, many rows of wheat-teeth, small and white. Her voice is a dry old woman’s, amused, sharp, a little hoarse, and it comes up through the turf as much as through the mouth, so that people kneeling to listen feel it in their knees. She smells of windfall pears and wet earth.

## THEIR STORY

Margery Rind was the midwife of Kettle Furrow for twenty-five years and delivered half the village, including her own grandson Pell Hogget in 594. She grew heavy late, reached the Course at forty, and rooted in 601 in her own orchard while hanging washing, because, she said, she was tired and the ground was warm. She taught Pell his numbers on her lap, counting pears, until her lap was gone. By 620

she had stopped being a woman and become a hill. She kept her mouth, and her memory of every birth in the village, and her opinions.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Kettle Furrow asks her advice on marriages, and she is always right, because she knows every bloodline and every secret parentage. Her fee is meat: the best cut of the last wake. Families bring her offerings and kneel and ask. The village is proud of her.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Nine pear trees** — planted on her by Pell’s mother in 621; their fruit is famous.
- ◇ **The mouth** — which eats whatever is put in it.
- ◇ **Her midwife’s knife** — buried in the turf near the mouth, its handle showing; she asks people not to touch it.
- ◇ **A ring of offerings** — bones, ribbons and wedding-tokens around her foot.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be fed. She fears nothing anymore except being forgotten.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** The particular people she has lately asked for are the ones the field wants this Carving. She can feel them. If they are fed to her, they are hers, not the Scarecrow's, and she tells herself it is mercy, because she is quick and the field is slow. She has asked Pell for Barnaby.

**Secret (she does not know):** She is moving, a few inches a year, toward the far field and the Scarecrow.

## TIES

- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — her grandson, whom she taught to count.
- ◇ **Tansy Lard** — whose root she asks after.
- ◇ **The Scarecrow** — which she calls *that one*.
- ◇ **Mercy Sowerby** — the Hill-Speaker, who has come to listen to her and has been told to go away.

## IN PLAY

PCs come to her for counsel; she answers truly. She wants them to bring her someone.

PCs come to her because Kettle Furrow sends everyone to her: for a true answer about a missing person, a parentage, a debt, or which field will Reap this Carving. She answers truly, for meat. More and more, she wants them to bring her someone in particular.

- ◇ **The Marriage.** A young couple asks the PCs to stand witness while they ask her blessing. She gives it gladly, and then asks, in the same warm voice, for the bride's mother, by name, before Carving.
- ◇ **Barnaby.** Pell Hogget asks the PCs, quietly, what they would do if their grandmother asked for their son. Barnaby has overheard, and has started walking out to the orchard alone at dusk to sit with her.
- ◇ **The Move.** Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker, asks the PCs to measure the distance between Old Mother Rind and the Scarecrow at Marbling and again at Tablenight. Both numbers are smaller than they should be.

**Threatened**, she laughs, and the roots tighten. **Shown kindness**, she tells a secret for free, which she has not done in twenty years. **Faced with the god**, she is the god, a little, and knows it. If nobody intervenes, she and the Scarecrow meet in the far field within a decade, and the village wakes one morning to find a hill where the far field was, with a scarecrow standing on its crown, and a mouth.

## SAID OF THEM

"She told me who my real father was. She was right." — a farmer of Kettle Furrow

"Always right. Always hungry." — a Bailiff

"She asked for my boy." — Pell Hogget

# DR. EMMERICH PAUNCH

*the Board's Physician*

*"Two hundred feet of line, and no bottom. I have nine hundred more in the cupboard. I need only someone to hold the rope, and someone to tell me what I am hearing."*

— DR. EMMERICH PAUNCH, TO A VIGIL COLLEAGUE, BY LETTER, 639 A.G.

| EMMERICH PAUNCH – PHYSICIAN TO THE BOARD |                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Fatlands · Cut 3 (Prime Cut, the Paunch caul-fat line) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                            | 61; Physician to the Board of Plenty since 621; Fellow of the Cutwrights' southern registry                                                                                                             |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Midwife (the belly-surgeon's road) · Standing 4 (by Board appointment)                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                     |
| SKILLS                                   | Stitching 5, Reckoning 4, Lore 4, Search 3, Feast 2, Resolve 2, Endure 1, Blades 1                                                                                                                      |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                                  | scalpel +4 (2, Piercing)                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                    | Iron Belly (Taste). Taste the Name (Appetite): he uses it clinically, on blood samples, and records the results. The Two Questions (Calling): he can tell a Seated thing from a living one at a glance. |
| WANTS                                    | The Second Plate (he eats from a bag of cracklings at his elbow, absently, while operating); and his own: to measure                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                   | Steady Hands, Counting Habit, Mother's Hands                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | The Seeing (since 637 he sometimes sees, in any open stomach, a long way down)                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                                  | the surgeon's case, the plumb line, the chewed weight, the notes, the silk, the trumpet                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                                    | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

## WHO THEY ARE

A stooped, heavy, myopic man of four hundred pounds, which in the Fatlands is slight for a Prime Cut, with ink-stained cuffs, thick spectacles, a grey frock-coat shiny at the elbows, and a voice like a dry quill. His hands are fine and steady. He peers at everything from too close. He smells of carbotic, ink and cracklings. He is courteous, distracted and precise, and he speaks of the most dreadful things in the flat tone of a man reading out an inventory, because he has found that it is the only way to say them at all.

## THEIR STORY

Emmerich Paunch was born in Sated in 580, studied the belly-surgeon's art in Cradlewrack under the Attendance and came home to serve the Board in 621. He measures the great. Every Gut-line member is weighed, sounded and recorded by him once a month, and the Board relies on his figures for the Weighing and on his discretion for everything else. He has opened many bellies, living and dead, and published nothing.

In 637, under licence, he opened the stomach of Dame Ottoline Gammon, a Gut-line matriarch at the Brink, rooted in her bedroom

in the Fold, who had consented to the procedure as a contribution to science. He meant to measure her capacity. He lowered a plumb line into the opening. He ran out of line at two hundred feet. The house was on one floor. When he drew the line up, the lead weight had been chewed.

He has since obtained longer line, nine hundred feet of Vigil silk, and has not been able to bring himself to use it, because of what he heard echoing up the first one.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the Board's doctor and its quiet expert on the Regrowth: he certifies rootings, records the Course, attends the Chairman weekly, and advises the inner committee on the progress of the Gut-lines. He depends on the Board for licence, money and protection, and the Board depends on him for figures it can trust. His limit is his fear: he knows a great deal and can publish none of it.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The surgeon's case** — Cradlewrack steel, silver-mounted; +1 Stitching.



- ◇ **The plumb line** — two hundred feet of tarred cord, coiled in a box, still smelling of the inside of Dame Gammon.
- ◇ **The chewed weight** — a pear-shaped plumb of lead, deeply scored with tooth-marks. They are human, adult, many sets; one of them left a smear of silver from a filling.
- ◇ **The notes** — *Notes Toward a Measure of the Southern Appetite*, unpublished, four hundred pages.
- ◇ **The silk** — nine hundred feet of Vigil silk line, on a brass reel, never used.
- ◇ **An ear-trumpet** — brass, through which he listened at the opening. He has not used it since.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to publish, and to finish the measurement. He fears the Board, and what he heard.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** What he heard echoing up the line was chewing, slow and enormous, and under it many voices saying the grace, naming fields, and at the very bottom, very faint, a voice asking *Is there any more?*

**Secret (he does not know):** Every Gut-line stomach opens into the same place: the stomach of Ummer, under the plains. When his weight went down, the Chairman, rooted in the Weighhouse two miles away, felt it pass inside him.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — his patient, who knows more than he says.
- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — who has asked him, very sweetly, to measure her.
- ◇ **Granny Cracknel** — who could match the silver filling.
- ◇ **Dr. Mercy Thrane** of the Fast — his correspondent.

#### IN PLAY

He will pay adventurers very well to hold the rope: one hundred lacks each, and a share of the credit.

- ◇ **Hold the Rope.** Dame Ottoline Gammon is at the Seating now, a warm mound filling her bedroom in the Fold, and the surgical opening has never closed. Paunch has the silk. The PCs hold the reel while he lets it down, and listen, and something at the bottom takes hold of the line and pulls.
- ◇ **The Filling.** The silver smear on the chewed weight matches a molar found in a split ear of Low Tilth wheat in 638. Granny Cracknel can name the tooth's owner. The owner is still alive, and is a member of the Board.

- ◇ **The Notes.** The Board's inner committee has learned of the four hundred pages and wants them burned; the Cutwrights want them copied; Dr. Mercy Thrane wants them carried to the Fast. Paunch wants the PCs to choose for him.

**Threatened,** he gives up his notes. **Shown kindness,** he explains. **Faced with the god,** he measures. If nobody intervenes, he lowers the silk alone in 642, and it comes up chewed.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He listens at bellies like a priest at a door." — a Washer of the Fold

"Discreet, accurate, frightened. The ideal physician." — Chairman Obb Tullow

"He weighed my mam every month for nine years and never once said she looked heavy." — a Gammon grandson



# THE PEOPLE OF THE FATLANDS, CONTINUED

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*Everybody in the south is somebody's dinner, sooner or later. The trick is to be somebody's  
good dinner.*

– WAKEMOTHER PUDDING HESK, TO AN APPRENTICE WHO ASKED WHY SHE  
CRIED WHILE CARVING

The first half of the Fatlands' cast sits in the Weighhouse, at the Unending Dinner and in Hogget's Barn: the vast, the hungry and the counting. The second half walks the roads and works the kitchens. These are the drovers and the weighers, the cooks and the knives, the bailiffs and the keepers of mills and groves, the girl who is

never hungry and the man who should never have been. They are the people a party actually meets in the south, at an inn table or a wake or a dusk field, and almost every one of them is carrying something they would rather not have to set down.

WE DO NOT ASK WHAT IT WAS. WE ASK WAS IT GOOD. AND IT WAS  
**ALWAYS** GOOD. THAT IS THE **WHOLE TROUBLE,**  
LOVE. IT WAS **ALWAYS, ALWAYS** GOOD.

[ GRANNY CRACKNEL, THE TOOTH-MILLER ]

# SAL TROTTER

the Drover

*“Walk on, now. Walk on, my lovelies. No, don’t look at me. Look at the road. There’s a good lass. There’s a good lad. Walk on.”*

– SAL TROTTER, TO HER HERD, ON THE DROVE ROAD AT DUSK

| SAL TROTTER – THE DROVER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION            | 46; Union drover on the Drove Road between Low Tilth and the Chute                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Renderer (drover), Standing 2 (Cutter)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                   | Wayfaring 5, Instinct 4, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Athletics 2, Shooting 2, Feast 2, Labor 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                     | Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (hide coat) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                  | drover’s goad +4 (2, Reach, Stunning); drover’s bola +5 (1, Entangling, Thrown); knife +4 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                    | Iron Belly (the Taste: +2 Feast; may Sop on a meal’s weight of anything organic for 1d3 Hunger). The Croon (a drover’s trade grown strange): up to forty head of her herd obey her voice; she can stop a two-legged stampede with Caul + Instinct (Hard 14), or set one running with a single word she has never said aloud. |
| WANTS                    | The Second Plate (when food is in sight and her Hunger is 4+, Caul + Resolve Hard 14 or eat it).                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                   | Corpse-Road Walker; Silent Supper; Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS             | none yet; at Fray 8 she begins to count the herd over and over, and it is always one too many                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                  | goad and bola; an unlit pipe; a herd-book with every name scratched out; a Cullmaster’s receipt; a cow-bell with no clapper; a tin of salt-fat                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DREAD                    | 1 (Sal herself); 2 (to see the herd stand); 3 (to hear the lead steer hum)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Sal Trotter is lean in a country where lean means guilty. She is a long, tough, wind-dried woman, all tendon and knuckle, burnt brick-red on the face and the backs of the hands and pale as tallow everywhere else, with grey hair braided tight and tucked down the back of a dung-crusteds oilskin coat that creaks when she walks. She smells of cattle, rain, wet leather and the sweetish green reek of the Drove Road in Plenty, and under all of it, faintly, of the salt-fat she chews from the tin at her belt to keep the Bailiffs off her: a strip every mile, eaten steadily, without pleasure, the way other drovers spit. Her voice, when she uses it on people, is a dry, flat, uninterested croak. When she uses it on the herd it changes completely: it drops into a low, even, endless croon, half song and half nonsense, that goes on all day and all night and never quite stops, so that people who have walked a drove with her find themselves humming it in their sleep for weeks afterward.

Her eyes are the most noticeable thing about her: pale, red-rimmed, and fixed always ahead, at the road. Sal Trotter does not

look back. It is not superstition. It is policy, and she has kept it for eight years.

## THEIR STORY

She was born in 595 in a drovers’ hut on the edge of Low Tilth, the daughter and granddaughter of Union drovers. She married a salter named Abbot Trotter, who drowned in a rendering-vat in 619, and raised one son, Tobias, called Dab, a cheerful, heavy, singing boy who could not keep a lack in his pocket for an afternoon.

In 632 she lost a whole herd: sixty head, gone off the Drove Road in a single night of Belch-wind near Gristmoot, and never found. The Union docked her the value. She could not pay. In Carving 633 Dab, who was seventeen and had signed for his mother’s debt without telling her, was read out on a Cullmaster’s list in Kettle Furrow square. He ate the dusk-supper with great appetite, she has been told, and joked with the clerks, and walked out to plot LT-114 in a clean white smock with a ribbon on his sickle. She was on the road. She came back to a receipt marked *Paid in Full*.

The next spring the Union gave her a new herd, out of the Board’s own stock, without asking for a deposit. The beasts were

pinkish-white and broad-faced and very gentle, and on the third night of the drive, when she turned around to count them, the whole herd was standing up. She has not turned around since.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Sal is one of perhaps forty drovers still walking stock up the Drove Road, the nine-day track from the Low Tilth stockyards to the Chute; the rest go by barge on the Great Gravy now. The Union keeps a few drovers on because some herds cannot go by water. They panic on the barges, and they open the hatches. Sal's herds are always that kind. Her stock comes from the Board's pens on the edge of the Dusk Acres, where the Cullmasters' calving-men gather young beasts out of the wheat each spring, slick and wet and newborn, standing in the stubble of the plots that were worked at dusk the Carving before.

She is paid twice: once by the Union at the Chute, at the drover's rate of a lack a head, and once, quietly, by a clerk of Varn Sweetbread's office, in meat scrip, for "careful handling." She depends on the inns of the Drove Road to sell her salt-fat and stand her a supper, and the inns depend on her not stopping too long. Children follow her herds for a mile out of every village, singing, until their mothers call them back. The beasts sing too, when the children have gone.

#### WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **The drover's goad and bola** — Union issue, the goad's iron tip worn to a nub. She has used the bola twice in eight years, both times on a beast that stood up and ran toward a village, and both times the beast went down, cried like a man, and got up again on four legs.
- ◇ **The unlit pipe** — Abbot's. She fills it every morning with good leaf and never lights it. The smell of it is the only thing on the road that is not cattle.
- ◇ **The herd-book** — a greasy Union tally-book with a column of names for every drove since 634. Every name has been scratched out with a thumbnail. She named the first herd as she always had (Bluebell, Old Stoop, Butter, Ned). On the fifth night, she called "Ned" and three of them answered, aloud, in a voice like a boy whose voice is breaking.
- ◇ **The Cullmaster's receipt** — a slip of grey paper, folded small, sewn into the lining of her coat: *T. Trotter. Plot LT-114. Labour rendered. Paid in Full. V.S.* She has never read it a second time.
- ◇ **The bell with no clapper** — the lead steer's bell. She took the clapper out the night the lead steer began to hum her croon back to her, in her own tune, under the bell, so she would not have to hear the two together.
- ◇ **A brand-iron, wrapped in sacking** — the Union brand, a circle and a cleaver. She has never used it on the Board's herds. They already have scars where a brand would be, and the scars are letters and numbers.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Sal wants to finish one drive without looking back: to deliver a herd to the Chute, take her pay, and go home, and never know. She fears the day one of them asks her where they are going, and she knows it is close, because the lead steer, a vast gentle animal with a curl on its brow and a habit of nosing at her coat pocket for the salt-fat the way Dab used to, has started to hum the croon a beat *ahead* of her now, as though it knows the song better than she does.

**A secret she keeps:** Sal knows exactly where her herds come from. She worked it out in the first month and has made her peace with it in the only way she could, by refusing to look. She takes Sweetbread's second wage. She has never told the Union, the Thin, or Pell Hogget, whose wall carries the names of half the people she has walked to market.

**A secret she does not know:** the scar on the lead steer's flank, where a brand would be, reads *LT-114*. The beast is not her son, exactly. It is what the field made of the strip where her son was worked. But it remembers the song.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — pays her second wage. She calls him "sir" and will not take his hand.
- ◇ **Mistress Brisket Annalow** — her Union boss, who keeps Sal walking because Sal's herds cannot go by barge and Annalow knows why.
- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — she drinks with him at the Kettle Furrow inn twice a year, and never looks at his wall.
- ◇ **Tobias Wether** — she found him on the Drove Road in Carving 640, starved half to death at the Rim, and fed him salt-fat from her tin, and gave him her son's name because it was the first that came to her. She has not seen him since.
- ◇ **Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot** — stamps her beasts at the Chute and will not meet her eye.
- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — buys her knowledge of the empty drove-tracks along the Fast's border, and feeds his captives on her road. She does not like how gently he does it.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Sal on the road: on the Drove Road, at an inn in Low Tilth, or on the Rim Road where it crosses the Fatlands' northern edge. She may hire them as extra hands for a drive (two lacks a day and board), especially in Carving, when drovers die. What she wants from them is simple and impossible: walk behind the herd so she does not have to. Tell her if anything is standing. Never tell her what.

- ◇ **The Ninth Night.** On the last night of a drive the party is hired for, the herd stops in a field outside Gristmoot and will not move. Every beast is turned to face the same way, toward a village, and the lead steer is humming the wake-song.

- ◇ **A Question on the Road.** A beast asks one of the PCs, quite clearly, where they are going. Sal begs them to lie.
- ◇ **Rustlers.** Second Helping pilgrims try to steal the herd for an Offering feast; or Thin activists try to free it. Either way, the beasts must not be allowed to reach a village unwatched.

Under threat, Sal goes for the bola, and then simply walks away, never turning. Kindness confuses her; she takes it and leaves at dawn. Of the god she says nothing at all. If nobody intervenes, the lead steer asks its question on the eighth day of the spring drive of 642; Sal turns around to answer it, sees her herd standing in the road, and walks into the wheat beside the Drove Road and sits down. The herd reaches Gristmoot without her, upright, humming, and opens the gates.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She’s the only drover who doesn’t lose stock. Doesn’t lose a single head. Some years she arrives with more than she left with.” — a tally-clerk at the Chute

“She chewed fat all through the Tablenight fast and never once looked hungry. That’s not appetite, that’s discipline. That’s worse.” — a Bailiff of Low Tilt

“The lady with the cows sings the same song as the cows, and the cows sing it better.” — a child of Gristmoot

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# WREN HOLLOWELL

## the Fasting Girl

*“Everyone keeps asking me what it feels like not to be hungry. I don’t know. What does it feel like to be? It sounds horrible.”*

— WREN HOLLOWELL, TO CORDER LANK, THE FIRST NIGHT IN THE ORCHARDS

| WREN HOLLOWELL – THE FASTING GIRL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                        | Fatlands · Cut 0 (Blank) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger — (none, ever)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                     | 15; fugitive with a price on her weight                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                | Gleaner, Standing 1 (Picker); among the Thin, venerated and without rank                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                        | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                            | Stealth 3, Search 3, Resolve 3, Craft 2, Instinct 2, Wayfaring 2, Athletics 1, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                              | Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                           | knife +2 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                             | None of the god; the Blank’s emptiness. She cannot be Reaped, cannot Partake, and ignores Hunger Taint. While she walks through a field, no Reaping takes place within twenty paces of her; Rootkin shut their eyes; toothed wheat stops chewing. Regrowth Taint gives her Seasoning, as for any Blank, but in fifteen years of eating Fatland crop she has never gained a mark. |
| WANTS                             | none of the god’s. Her own: to see the sea; to be left alone.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                            | No Thank You; Cold Supper; Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                      | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                           | a gleaner’s apron; a knife; one shell; a cord the Thin gave her; half a lock of hair                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DREAD                             | 0 (and that is the frightening thing about her)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Wren is small and narrow and pale, with a long plain face, straight mouse-brown hair cut raggedly at one side, and grey eyes that rest on things without wanting them. In the Fatlands, where every face has been built by a lifetime of eating, she looks like a drawing of a girl rather than a girl: thin lines, empty spaces, no weight anywhere.

She smells of nothing. That is the first thing Fatlanders notice and the thing they cannot stop noticing. Every Fatlander smells faintly of the fields, of bread and grass and dung; Wren smells like rain on a stone. Her voice is quiet and a little hoarse, because she has spent two years whispering in barns, and she is dry and blunt and occasionally very funny in the way of someone who has been looked at too much. She eats when someone reminds her, slowly, without interest, and leaves the crust. In the south, leaving the crust is a fine. She has been fined, by her own count, four hundred and twelve times.

### THEIR STORY

She was born in Bramble Furrow, a Low Tilth hamlet of nine houses, in 626, to Hennet Hollowell, a rush-weaver, and Ruddle

Hollowell, a hedger. She did not cry for the breast. The midwife, who had seen everything, put her to the nipple anyway, and she fed politely and stopped and went to sleep, and the midwife looked at Hennet over the baby’s head and said nothing, and Hennet understood that she must never let anyone see the child refuse food.

For twelve years Hennet fed Wren loudly. She fed her in the doorway, in the lane, at every one of the five meals, singing, so the neighbours would hear the spoon. She sewed weights into the hem of the child’s smock before the weekly weighing and bribed the parish weigher with eggs. It worked until 638, when the parish weigher died and a Cutwrights’ College surveyor came through Low Tilth taking examinations for the southern registry, and Wren, at twelve, put out her tongue and let him look at her teeth and her nails and the backs of her eyes, and he went very still and wrote in his ledger for a long time.

The Bailiffs came within the month. Ruddle hid her in a hay-rick and walked out to meet them with a hedging-bill and was taken to the Gavage, where he is, by all report, now very large. Hennet carried Wren by night across Low Tilth to the edge of the Bleeding Orchards, put her into the hands of a Thin woman she had never

met, and walked back home to be arrested. Wren has not seen either of them since. The Board's bounty went up in Carving 639: her weight in bone coin, to whoever brings her in, and the proclamation did not say alive.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Thin kneel to her, which she hates. To Corder Lank's people she is proof that the hunger is not natural, that a Fatland body *can* be empty, and they move her from barn to barn through the Orchards and the hedges of Low Tilth like a relic carried in procession, a step ahead of the Bailiffs. The Board wants her because it wants nobody to have proof of anything. The Second Table wants her organs: the rumour in the high houses is that a Blank's heart, eaten, fills you forever, and while that is false, a Blank's blood and marrow are believed to slow the Regrowth, and Master Quillon Barr has a surgery in Sated with a table already scrubbed. She wants to see the sea.

#### WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **A gleaner's apron** — twelve pockets, stained to the elbow, her mother's work. She gleaned behind the harvesters as a child like every child in Low Tilth, and the habit of picking up what others leave has stayed with her.
- ◇ **A small knife** — a hedger's knife of her father's, honed thin. She has not used it on a person. She has thought about it.
- ◇ **One shell** — a ribbed white cockle, given her by a Rim Road carter who said it came from Brinehollow. She holds it to her ear at night. The carter told her you could hear the sea in it. She cannot. She has decided that is because the sea is leaving, and the shell is only being honest.
- ◇ **Half her hair** — the other half was cut off in her sleep in Lack 640 by Otilie Crane, a Lean of nineteen she had begun to love, who sold it in Sated for nine hundred lacks to buy her brother off a dusk-shift list. It hangs at the throats of rich women now, who boast that they no longer feel their first Partake each day. Wren wants it back. She wants Otilie back more, and knows she cannot have that.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the sea: not a cure, not a cause, not to be a saint, but a horizon with no field in it. She wants her mother. She wants people to stop looking at her the way hungry people look at a window. She fears the Gavage, not for herself but for what she will see on her father's face. She fears, more quietly, that she is lying to herself about not being hungry, and that one day it will arrive all at once.

**A secret she keeps:** Corder Lank has tried to pass his hunger to her. He fasted beside her for nine days in 640, hoping that if his gnawing could go anywhere it could go into a vessel with nothing in it, and so free his people. It would not go into her. It went *around* her, like water round a stone, and fell back into the Thin of the

barn, doubled. Three of them broke that night. Wren knows. Lank knows she knows.

**A secret she does not know:** the fields do not go quiet because they cannot smell her. They go quiet the way a room goes quiet when someone who is not expected comes in and stands in the doorway. Toothed wheat, for twenty paces around her, holds perfectly still: not empty, not indifferent. *Holding still*. The Orchard-keepers who have seen it say the trees do the same, and the oldest of them, Marigold Chine, says she has heard only one other thing that made her grove fall that silent, and that was the song about the Meal. In the carvings, the gods are said not to have moved either.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Corder Lank** — her protector and the person she trusts least: he needs her too much.
- ◇ **Marigold Chine** — brings her orchard-fruit in the Old Grove and does not kneel. Wren loves her for it.
- ◇ **Lord Chastain Loin** — hunting her for the Second Table's cellar, through poachers and pleasant letters left in Thin barns.
- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — the poacher who has come closest; he once got near enough to offer her stew, and was startled when she simply said no thank you once and meant it.
- ◇ **Tobias Wether** — the only other person in the south who knows what the absence of the god is like; he came out of it and she was born in it. She would like to meet him. He would like very much to eat with her.
- ◇ **Bailiff Dunmow Fatt** — took her father to the Gavage. Weeps about it. She has watched him from a hedge.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Wren through the Thin, through the bounty, or by accident: a girl in a hedge who does not flinch when the field beside the road leans in at dusk. She wants from them what no one else has offered her: to be taken somewhere and left there. The hook *Wren for Weight* in the core book is her story in brief; she is the centre of the Blank Trade thread.

- ◇ **To the Sea.** Wren asks the party to escort her out of the Fatlands, along the Rim to Brinehollow. Every bounty-hunter in the south follows, and in Brinehollow the sea is a mile further out than the map says.
- ◇ **The Silent Field.** Low Tilth farmers discover that a Reaping does not happen where Wren walks. Within a week, every village wants to borrow her for Carving dusk. The Cullmasters want her for the opposite reason.
- ◇ **Her Father.** Wren will give herself up to the Board if someone brings her father out of the Gavage alive and thin. She means it.

Under threat, Wren hides, quietly and very well; she does not panic, because panic is a kind of appetite. Kindness she accepts carefully, testing it the way you test ice. Of the god she has nothing to say,

except that she does not believe it can see her. If nobody intervenes, she is taken in Carving 641 by Dragoman's men in a barn the Thin thought safe, and stage two of the Blank Trade thread follows: a Gut-line matriarch at the next Weighing, ten stone lighter, not eating, smiling.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She's the only proof. One girl who isn't hungry, and the whole Board of Plenty sweats in its benches." — Corder Lank

"I put a bowl down in front of her and she said thank you and didn't touch it, and I swear the soup went cold faster than it should." — a farm-wife of Low Tilt who sheltered her for a night

"Alive or not alive, the price is the same per pound. I would prefer alive. The heart keeps better in the body." — Master Quillon Barr, surgeon, in a letter to Lord Chastain Loin



# GARRICK TRIPE

the Weigher

*“Every man’s weight is a matter of record, sir, and every record is a matter of who keeps it. Ten lacks the pound. Lead’s extra if you want it warm.”*

– GARRICK TRIPE, IN THE ROBIN-G-ROOM BEHIND THE GREAT SCALES, THE MORNING OF A WEIGHING

| GARRICK TRIPE – THE WEAHER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Fatlands · Cut 3 (Prime Cut, a lesser Gut-line cadet) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION              | 58; Weigher of the Great Scales of the Weighhouse                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Factor (weigher-for-hire), Standing 3 (Senior Factor); Board office with a Deacon’s privileges                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                     | Filch 5, Reckoning 5, Deceive 4, Haggle 4, Persuade 3, Clause 2, Feast 2, Endure 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                       | Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                    | brass counterweight on a cord +5 (3, Stunning); hidden knife +4 (2, Concealable)                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                      | Iron Belly (the Taste). Taste the Name and Gorge (the Appetite). The Weigher’s Thumb (craft, not godsign): any weighing he conducts reads what he chooses, within a tenth of the true weight, against Eye + Search Grim (18) to spot. |
| WANTS                      | The Second Plate; The Hollow (Hard 14 each)                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| KNACKS                     | Fast Hands; Little Lies; Bone-Coin Nose                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS               | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                    | the Weigher’s brass key; rigged hanging scales; the lead-ledger; lead shot; a dozen rings; a hollow counterweight                                                                                                                     |
| DREAD                      | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

Garrick Tripe is the most cheerful man in the Weighhouse and the only one who is not afraid of the Scales. He is a broad, glossy, well-upholstered man of four hundred and twenty pounds, which in Sated is middling-respectable, poured into a bottle-green coat with two rows of brass buttons that strain like the lid of a pot on the boil, with a waxed ginger-grey moustache and a ring on every finger. He smells of pomade, cloves, warm brass and the faint metallic tang of lead, which gets into the skin of anyone who handles it for forty years. He talks constantly: a rolling, oily, confiding patter full of *sir* and *madam* and *between ourselves*, the voice of a man selling you a horse he knows is lame and wants you to know he knows.

## THEIR STORY

He was born in 583 in the Scale Rings of Sated, the son of a Weighhouse sweeper, and grew up under the Great Scales, sweeping the crumbs of the great from around the pans. At sixteen he was taken on as apprentice to old Weigher Dimmock Hale, who taught him the three arts of the office: how to read the beam, how to read

the face of the person in the pan, and how to read the purse behind the face.

He elected his first government at twenty-five. At the Weighing of 608 the chair of the Board hung between Obb Tullow, then a mere fourteen hundred pounds and still walking, and Dame Hessaly Gorringer of the Gorringer Hill-line, who outweighed him by fifty-one pounds. Old Hale was ill. Young Garrick ran the Scales. Sixty pounds of lead shot, sewn into the hem of the Tullow bed-linen in sealed pockets the night before, won the Chairmanship by nine pounds, and Garrick Tripe was Weigher by Plenty.

His second government was the Export Committee of 622, which kept the Renderers’ Union in its monopoly against a Board tax by a margin of fourteen pounds. His third was the Steadiness Appropriation of 637, which doubled the Cullmasters’ budget and lengthened the dusk-shift lists across Low Tilt. It passed by eleven pounds, all of them lead, sewn into the ample smock of Deacon Rolle Dimsworth, who had been paid to vote yes and was too light to carry it alone. Then the Long Count began to circulate in Sated, copied on greasy paper and pinned in the Scale Rings, and he read

the figures for Low Tilth for Carving 637 and 638 and 639, and stopped telling it.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Weighing is the Fatlands' election, coronation and holy day in one, and Garrick Tripe is its priest. The Weigher reads the beam and cries the figure, and the clerks write it into the Book of Weight, and what he cries is law. Nobody has ever appealed a Weighing and won.

He depends on the Board's appetite for advantage, and on the Carriers who load the pans and are paid to look away. He rents his skill to anybody: Gut-line houses who want a committee seat, deacons who want to cross the threshold to Member, merchants who want a Board ally heavier than his rivals'. His fee is ten lacks a pound, cash or scrip, more for discretion, double for adding weight to an enemy's pockets in the form of a sudden, unaccountable *lightness*, which is more delicate work, since nobody wants to be seen to have lost weight. He is, in the narrowest sense, the most powerful man on the Board who has no vote.

### WHAT HE CARRIES

- ◇ **The Weigher's brass key** — a foot long, worn on a chain under his coat, which unlocks the beam-housing of the Great Scales. There is one other copy. The Chairman keeps it.
- ◇ **The lead-ledger** — a small calf-bound book in cipher: every pound of lead he has ever sewn, poured or slipped into a pan, with names, dates and fees. It is the most dangerous document in the Fatlands after the Weighhouse cellar records, and it is his insurance.
- ◇ **A pouch of lead shot** — fine, soft, grey as a dead eye, dusted with flour so it will not click.
- ◇ **Twelve rings** — including a seal-ring from the Tullow house (608), a Renderers' Union ring of salt-cured bone (622), and a plain iron band he bought himself in 637 and does not take off, for reasons he will not explain.
- ◇ **A hollow counterweight** — a brass weight of the Great Scales, bored out and plugged with tallow, which can be swapped for its twin in the time it takes to sneeze. He keeps it in a velvet bag like a pet.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Garrick wants to retire rich, to a house on the Little Gravy with a south-facing kitchen and a cook who sings, and to die fat and be eaten well.

He fears the Chairman. Tullow knows exactly how much of his vote is lead, because Tullow paid for the first sixty pounds of it, and Tullow has the other brass key. For thirty-three years the two of them have kept each other's secret: the Chairman's seat was bought, and the Weigher bought it. Now Tullow is nineteen hundred pounds, needs no lead, and is rooted through his dray, and Garrick has begun to understand that he is no longer a partner but a loose end.

**A secret he keeps:** at the Weighing of 641 Garrick took no fees. None. He weighed the Board honestly for the first time in his career, out of something he has not named, and the result moved the inner committee by two seats against the Cullmasters. Nobody noticed except Varn Sweetbread, who checked the arithmetic and sent Garrick a polite note of congratulation on his accuracy.

**A secret he does not know:** Tullow intends to expose him at the Weighing of 642, publicly, with the second key, and to void every vote cast since 608 by any member whose weight Garrick touched. That would unseat a third of the Board and leave Tullow, the honest giant, the only clean scale in the house. The Chairman only needs Garrick alive long enough to stand trial. Jem Crackle has been asked to be ready afterward.

### TIES

- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — partner in the original sin; holder of the other key; the man who will end him.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — owes him eleven pounds of appropriation and knows Garrick has stopped selling them.
- ◇ **Mistress Brisket Annalow** — an old client; they still drink together, and she would sell him in an afternoon.
- ◇ **Jem Crackle** — has cooked for Garrick's suppers twice, without killing anyone. Garrick tips well and talks too much.
- ◇ **Nell Haslet, the Chairman's Washer** — he pays her for gossip from the dray. She tells him less than she tells the Count.
- ◇ **Lord Chastain Loin** — a current client: Loin wants a committee seat in 642 and has ordered a hundred and ten pounds.

### IN PLAY

PCs meet Garrick at a supper in Sated, at the Weighing festival, or when a patron hires them to find out why his rival is suddenly heavier. He wants from them either a delicate job (getting the lead-ledger to a safe place outside the Fatlands, or getting a pound of lead into a Gut-line's linen) or, as his fear grows, protection, which he will never ask for directly.

- ◇ **The Light Member.** A Board member has lost forty pounds overnight and is screaming fraud. Garrick did not do it. Somebody else has learned his trade, or the member is being eaten from within.
- ◇ **The Ledger.** Garrick's cipher-book is stolen from his rooms. Every faction in Sated wants it; the thief is a child of the Scale Rings who does not know what she has.
- ◇ **Honest Scales.** Garrick asks the PCs to witness that his next weighing is honest. It is. Someone else's thumb is on the beam.

Under threat Garrick talks, bribes, and runs, in that order; he is not brave. Kindness he takes as a sign that you want something, and tips you. The god he jokes about until the Belch blows; then he chews his ledger-ribbon and says nothing. If nobody intervenes, he is tried at the Weighing of 642, convicted of theft of weight, and rendered

for tallow in the Renderers’ yards, and the tallow lights the courtroom for the trials of thirty-one Board members who follow him.

SAID OF THEM

“He cried my weight at thirteen hundred and six and I was thirteen hundred and four, and I’ve never been so flattered in my life.” — a Gut-line dowager, fondly

“Lead in the hem, lead in the pie, lead in the vote. There’s more lead on the Board than meat.” — a Scale Rings pamphlet, unsigned

“Mister Tripe weighs the Board. Who weighs Mister Tripe?” — a sweeper’s boy in the Weighhouse, asked by his mother to stop saying it

# LADY ASPIC DELLAMORE

the Preserver

*“Anyone can roast, darling. Fire does the work. But to keep something, exactly as it was at its best, forever, and still have it look at you? That is cookery.”*

– LADY ASPIC DELLAMORE, TO A GUEST PAUSING IN HER GALLERY

| LADY ASPIC DELLAMORE – THE PRESERVER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Fatlands · Cut 4 (Gut-line, House Dellamore) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                        | 44; mistress of Dellamore House in the Crown Ring of Sated, and of its Gallery                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Scion, Standing 3 (Lady); a Master Renderer in all but Union card                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                               | Craft 5 (cookery), Feast 5, Stitching 3, Blades 3, Lore 3, Persuade 3, Endure 2, Reckoning 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                              | filleting knife +7 (2, Light, Concealable); kitchen cleaver +7 (3, Ripping)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                | Iron Belly (the Taste). Taste the Name and Gorge (the Appetite). The Setting (her art, fed by godsign): over three days of work and Hand + Craft vs Grim (18), she can set a living person of Cut 3+ in clear jelly, where they remain conscious, unageing and hungry for as long as the aspic is kept cool. A Lack means the piece is set <i>badly</i> , and screams for a month. |
| WANTS                                | The Second Plate; The Long Pig (Hard 14 to leave a fresh corpse uncarved)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                               | Steady Hands; Smell of Cedar; Butcher’s Calm                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none recorded; she cannot taste salt any more and over-seasons everything, which she blames on her kitchen staff                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                              | the silver ladle; a set of moulds; jelly-knives; a measuring tape; a little book of setting-times; a jar of her jelly                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                                | 2 (Lady Aspic); 3 (to walk her Gallery)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is tall for a Gut-line, perhaps seven hundred pounds carried high and smooth, like a pear in silk: sleek, plump, upright, with a long neck she is vain about and hair the colour of clarified butter lacquered into a high glossy coil. Her skin is very pale and very fine and slightly translucent at the temples, where a blue vein shows like a thread through a consommé. She smells of bay, gelatine, white pepper and cold rooms. Her laugh is cold and musical, a little run of notes like a spoon drawn along a row of glasses, and she uses it in place of disagreement. Her kitchens are spotless and silent. Her staff wear felt slippers.

## THEIR STORY

Aspic was the second daughter of House Dellamore, a middling Gut-line with an estate of cold-cellars and ice-houses on the north bank of the Great Gravy, and its heir was her elder sister, Lady Galantine. Aspic was sent to learn cookery from Master Anselm Lardner, the finest preserving-cook in Sated, in the expectation that she would marry a Renderer and be useful. She learned from him how a Gut-line body, which refuses to finish hungering, can be kept

by cold and gelatine far longer than meat ought to keep. In 627, at twenty-nine, she set her sister.

She did it in the ice-house over three days, with Galantine drugged on poppy and marrow-brand, and when it was finished the heir of House Dellamore stood in a tall glass case in the family hall, perfectly preserved, garnished with chervil and quail’s eggs, and *blinking*. Aspic set Master Lardner in 629. Then the restaurateur Lorrimer Bastable, who beat her in the pie-contest at the Weighing of 630; then Dame Orla Crisp, a dining critic who had called her sauces “frightened”; then five others. Her Gallery has nine pieces now.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Lady Aspic is the south’s arbiter of taste. A Gut-line house that wants to make an impression has her cater it; a merchant who wants to be noticed sends her a gift of something rare to cook. Her jelly, sold by the jar through a discreet shop on the Ladle Steps, is the most expensive food in the Fatlands: it is clarified from the trimmings and seepage of the Gallery, and it carries a little of the Gut-line hunger of whoever it came off, and it blinks. Board

members eat it at the Weighing for luck. The Rim Market lists it at thirty lacks.

#### WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **The silver ladle** — her teacher's, taken from his hand before she set him. Lardner watches her use it from his case.
- ◇ **A measuring tape** — of oiled silk, marked in inches, pounds and setting-hours. She has been measuring Dame Suet Marrable at the Unending Dinner, discreetly, at the wrist, the throat and the circumference of the chair.
- ◇ **A little book of setting-times** — every piece, with dates, temperatures, and remarks on its expression ("Bastable sulking; Galantine reproachful as ever; Crisp improving").
- ◇ **A jar of her own jelly** — on a chain at her waist, tawny-gold, with a faint pulse in it. She eats a spoonful before difficult conversations. It is cut from Galantine.
- ◇ **A poppy-and-marrow cordial** — for guests who are to be set. Taint 1 Hunger; Gut + Endure vs Grim (18) or sleep for a night.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be the greatest cook on the Table: not the best-liked, the *greatest*, the one whose dishes are remembered when the gods have stood up. She fears blandness above death, and has begun to fear it in herself, because she can no longer taste salt and every dish she makes this year has been sent back once.

**A secret she keeps:** Dame Suet Marrable has commissioned her. Marrable's feet have begun to grow through the floor of her hall, and she knows the Unending Dinner will not outlast a hostess who has become a hill. She has asked Aspic, privately, to set her at the head of the table when the time comes, so that she may preside forever, conscious and hungry, watching her guests eat. Aspic accepted. She is planning instead to set Marrable for the Gallery, as its centrepiece, and has already ordered the glass.

**A secret she does not know:** the pieces are rooting. Hair-fine white threads have crept from their feet through the jelly, through the cases' brass plinths, through the Gallery floor and into the cellar, where they have twined into one mat. When the nine of them Seat, they will Seat as one hill, and Dellamore House will be inside it.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — client, rival, and intended masterpiece.
- ◇ **Jem Crackle** — she buys his "remainders," the choicest pieces from his kitchen work, and he resents it.
- ◇ **Wakemother Pudding Hesk** — the only cook in Sated Aspic is afraid of, because Hesk cooks the dead and cries and everyone loves her for it.
- ◇ **Lord Chastain Loin** — a fellow guest of the cellar table; he wants a Blank set in aspic as a dish for the Second Table.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — once tasted her jelly and named all nine pieces, aloud, at a supper. She has not forgiven him.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Lady Aspic as caterers, guests or thieves: hired to bring her a rare ingredient (a Brinehollow fish, a Vigil sleepless hare, a strand of Wren Hollowell's hair for a garnish), or by a family wanting one of the Gallery pieces back. She wants from them service, admiration and silence.

- ◇ **A Case for Dame Orla.** Dame Orla Crisp's grandson hires the party to steal his grandmother out of the Gallery. Freed from the jelly she is starving, conscious, and seven years hungry, and the first thing she does is eat.
- ◇ **The Centrepiece.** Aspic needs an eight-foot case carried across Sated at night without anyone asking what it is for. The PCs carry it. They may notice, later, that it is exactly Dame Marrable's size.
- ◇ **Bland.** Aspic believes someone is poisoning her palate. She is right: her own jelly is doing it, the nine hungers in it slowly eating her taste.

Threatened, she laughs, and calls for her felt-slipped staff, who are skilled with cleavers. Kindness she accepts as a compliment to her cooking. The god she considers a fellow artist. If nobody intervenes, she sets Dame Marrable in Lack 642, and when the Dinner's guests find their hostess gone, the Unending Dinner ends; and some weeks later the Gallery floor of Dellamore House bulges, cracks and rises, warm and grassy, with ten faces in it.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Her consommé is so clear you can read the Board minutes through it. I have done it. They were not improved." — a Gut-line wit, at table

"I brought the jelly up from the shop and the jar blinked at my little girl, and she blinked back, and they did it for an hour." — a scullery maid of the Crown Ring

"She did not set me because I was a rival. She set me because I was her teacher, and she had finished learning." — Master Anselm Lardner, by slate, through the glass

# JEM CRACKLE

## the Cook's Knife

*“No, love, not in the parlour. Nobody dies well in a parlour. Bring him through to the kitchen, sit him by the range, give him a bit of bread. I’ll be along.”*

– JEM CRACKLE, TO A CLIENT’S HOUSEKEEPER

| JEM CRACKLE – THE COOK’S KNIFE |                                                                                                                                                                                |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                  | 27; the most reliable assassin in Sated, for hire to anyone                                                                                                                    |
| CALLING & STANDING             | Renderer, Standing 3 (Master Renderer, by reputation; he has no shop of his own and wants none)                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2                                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                         | Blades 5, Stealth 4, Athletics 3, Craft 3, Feast 3, Endure 2, Filch 2, Search 2, Stitching 1                                                                                   |
| BODY                           | Flesh 12 · Guard 19 · Armor 0 · Fray 1                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                        | boning knife +10 (2, Light, Concealable); cleaver +10 (3, Ripping); hot spit-iron +10 (3, and the wound will not bleed)                                                        |
| GIFTS                          | In any kitchen he gains a free Helping on his first attack; he can joint a body in the time it takes to boil a kettle. Know the Cut (Renderer talent). Iron Belly (the Taste). |
| WANTS                          | The Second Plate (Hard 14); to cook what he kills                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                         | Fast Hands; Butcher’s Calm; Steady Hands                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS                   | none; he would like one, for the novelty                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                        | the knife-roll; a spit-iron; an apron; the Bill of Fare; a tin of salt and spices; a clean shirt                                                                               |
| DREAD                          | 2 (to find a missing friend on his table)                                                                                                                                      |

### WHO THEY ARE

He looks like the boy who turns your spit. That is the whole of his art. Jem Crackle is wiry, quick and unremarkable, about five and a half feet and two hundred pounds, which in Sated reads as underfed, with a cheerful, sweaty, snub-nosed face, red knuckles, cropped sandy hair, and burn scars to the elbow on both arms, laid over one another in shiny pink lacework from fifteen years of reaching into ovens. He smells of onions, hot iron, singed hair and bay leaf. He whistles while he works, badly. He moves around a kitchen the way water moves around a pot, never in anyone’s way, always where the knife is.

### THEIR STORY

Jem was born in 614 in the Spit Rows of Sated, the kitchen-quarter behind the Weighhouse where the great houses’ cooks live, and was sold at eight to the kitchens of Marrable Hall as a spit-boy. He spent nine years turning joints in front of the great ranges that feed the Unending Dinner, and so saw, at eleven, his first guest carried down to the kitchen from the hall, dead of a burst stomach between the fish and the fowl, and jointed by the under-cook while the Dinner went on above, and sent back up as the fowl. Nobody screamed.

The under-cook winked at him and gave him the oysters from the back.

In 631, at seventeen, he killed a man for the first time: a Board clerk who had come down to Marrable’s kitchens to collect a debt from the under-cook, and who had pushed Jem into the range. Jem cut him at the chopping-block, quickly and quietly, and then, because there was nothing else to do with him and the Dinner was waiting, cooked him. The clerk went up that evening as a fricassee. Dame Marrable sent down her compliments. A week later a Gut-line footman came down with a purse and a name, and Jem’s career began.

He left Marrable Hall at twenty. Since then he has worked for the Board, the Union, the Second Table, rival Gut-line houses and once, memorably, for a widow who wanted her husband served to his mistress. He owes nothing to anyone.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

In the Fatlands murder is a crime, and the punishment is to be rendered in the Renderers’ yards with the victim’s family taking the first cut. But a death in a kitchen, followed by a beautiful meal, sits in a gap in the law no court has closed. The body has been eaten,



which is proper. The family has been fed. The Feasting Laws are honoured. Jem's victims' families often do not complain, because the dish was so good, and because complaining would mean admitting they ate it.

So Jem is an institution: the polite, deniable way Sated removes people. His fee is two hundred lacks for a commoner, a thousand for a member of the Board, payable half before and half after tasting. He needs a kitchen, which means the target must be lured into one, and so he works with housekeepers, cooks and stewards all over the Crown Ring, who know that a fat purse and a quiet word mean they will be given a holiday. He works nowhere else. He is the reason that in great houses in Sated nobody of importance ever goes into the kitchen.

#### WHAT HE CARRIES

- ◇ **The knife-roll** — waxed canvas, eleven blades: boning, filleting, carving, a cleaver, a bird-shears, a marrow-scoop. Each is honed every morning. He has never used them on anything but meat, he says, and smiles.
- ◇ **A spit-iron** — a yard of black iron with a wooden grip, heated in any range: his favourite tool and his oldest. It closes what it opens.
- ◇ **The Bill of Fare** — a small greasy notebook: every person he has served, what he made of them, and the names of everyone who ate. He sells copies of single pages. Nobody in Sated knows the whole of it.
- ◇ **A tin of salt and spices** — his own mixture: salt, pepper, mace, dried orchard-blood and something from Granny Cracknel's mill.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Jem wants to cook what he kills, beautifully, and be praised for the dish. He wants a commission worthy of him, and has heard there is one coming. He fears boredom, and has begun to fear his own appetite, which has been growing since Carving 640, when he tasted the Chute-meat a client had served and could not stop eating it.

**A secret he keeps:** the Bill of Fare. Each page is a lever on a family: proof that they ate their own, or ate an enemy, or ate a Board member's son. He sells pages to the Board, to the Union, to the Thin and to the Second Table, and that, more than his knife, is why no one has ever had him rendered.

**A secret he does not know:** he has been asked, through a Board steward, to be ready to kill the Weigher Garrick Tripe after the Weighing of 642. He has also been asked, through a different steward, by Chairman Tullow himself, to come to the Weighhouse when the time comes and do the Chairman "a kindness, in a kitchen, before the hill takes him." Neither steward knows of the other. Wakemother Pudding Hesk has been asked to cook the result.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — his first patron and the place he learned his trade. She keeps his old spit-place laid with a fork.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — the one man who could name every dish Jem has ever served, and the one man Jem would never take a contract on.
- ◇ **Wakemother Pudding Hesk** — a rival and a friend; she cooks the dead legitimately and weeps, and he thinks the weeping is showing off.
- ◇ **Lady Aspic Dellamore** — buys his remainders; he would like very much to do something about her Gallery, but nobody has paid him to.
- ◇ **Garrick Tripe** — a talkative client who has tipped him twice.
- ◇ **Lord Chastain Loin** — a Second Table client, who orders through the cellar's steward and has never once said thank you.

#### IN PLAY

The PCs meet Jem in a kitchen, which should frighten them. He might be the cook at an inn they lodge in, the spit-boy at a wake, or the cheerful lad who brings the supper to a Board member's guest-rooms. He wants nothing from them unless they are a contract, in which case he wants them by the range.

- ◇ **A Page of the Bill.** A family will pay the PCs to recover one page of the Bill of Fare. The page proves they ate their grandmother, which is respectable, and their grandmother's lover, which is not.
- ◇ **The Sixty-Fourth.** A PC's contact vanishes in Sated. That evening, the PCs are invited to supper.
- ◇ **A Worthy Commission.** Jem approaches a PC to help him with "a big job," needing several hands: the kitchen must be built around the target. The target is nineteen hundred pounds and cannot be moved.

Jem flees threats rather than fights them outside a kitchen. Inside one, he fights superbly. Kindness bores him unless it is a good meal. The god he respects, as a fellow cook. If nobody intervenes, Jem takes both commissions in 642, does both well, and is himself the subject of a third, from a family whose page he sold to the wrong buyer.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Best leg of mutton I ever had, at the Marlowe wake. Then I heard old Marlowe had gone into the kitchen to complain about the gravy." — a guest at a wake in the Crown Ring

"He says sorry to nobody. I say sorry to everybody. Between us, we've got Sated covered." — Hob Gristle

"Jemmy turned our spit for two years and I never knew. He did lovely crackling. He still does, they say." — a former cook of Marrable Hall

# BAILIFF DUNMOW FATT

the Gentle Ladle

*“There, there. There, love. Nobody’s cross. Nobody’s ever cross with you. Just a little bit more, for me. Just one for me. That’s my good belly.”*

– BAILIFF DUNMOW FATT, TO A THIN PRISONER IN THE CART TO THE GAVAGE

| DUNMOW FATT – BAILIFF OF THE FEASTING LAWS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                 | Fatlands · Cut 3 (Prime Cut) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                              | 52; senior Bailiff of the Feasting Laws in Sated                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                         | Nightwarden (Bailiff), Standing 3 (Lieutenant; on the Board’s ladder, a Ladle who has thrice refused promotion to Deacon)                                                                                                                   |
| ATTRIBUTES                                 | Hand 3 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS                                     | Feast 4, Persuade 4, Endure 3, Stitching 3, Intimidate 2, Resolve 2, Rites 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                                                                       |
| BODY                                       | Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (suet-quilt under his sash) · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                                    | ladle of office +4 (3; he may hold the target instead of dealing damage); funnel, against a held target (Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or the target is fed and helpless for the scene)                                                            |
| GIFTS                                      | Iron Belly (the Taste). Taste the Name and Gorge (the Appetite). The Gentle Hand (Seen It Before, turned to the law): when he feeds a restrained person, they must pass Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or stop resisting, and they gain 2 Hunger. |
| WANTS                                      | The Hollow (Hard 14: when someone near him refuses food he must make them eat); The Second Plate                                                                                                                                            |
| KNACKS                                     | Mother’s Hands; Hostage’s Smile; Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                               | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                    | the funnel and ladle of office; the blue sash; the parish scale; a lullaby-book; a pocket of sugared fat; a list                                                                                                                            |
| DREAD                                      | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

He is huge, slow and pink, a man of nine hundred pounds who moves like a moored barge, with a round soft face, rosy cheeks, small wet blue eyes and a gentle lisp. He wears the blue sash of the Bailiffs over a vast white smock, and carries the funnel of office (polished horn, bound in brass) in a baldric like a sword, and the ladle of office (a deep pewter ladle on an iron handle) at his belt like a sceptre. He smells of warm milk, sweat, porridge and lavender water, which his late wife put in his collars and which he still buys by the pint. His hands are enormous, soft and clean, and he uses them carefully, like a man holding eggs.

Everybody in Sated agrees that Dunmow Fatt is gentle. He kneels to feed the stubborn. He strokes their throats to help the porridge down and sings to them, wordless lullabies in a sweet, breathy tenor. He weeps over every Thin prisoner he takes. Children run to him in the street, because he always has a pocket of sugared fat, and their mothers smile, because a child Dunmow has fed is a child the parish weigher will pass.

## THEIR STORY

He was born in 589 in the Pudding Ring, a baker’s son, and became a Bailiff at twenty because he could not bear to see people go without. He married Clemency Haws, a seamstress, who died of a burst gut at the Harvest Home of 628, eating, laughing; and he served her at her wake with his own hands, and could not stop crying, and ate the most of anyone.

He took his first Thin prisoner in 612, a boy of twenty fasting in a Sated doorway, and carried him to the Gavage in his arms. He has taken some four hundred since, more than any Bailiff living. He enforces the Feasting Laws all over Sated and is often sent out to the parishes, to see that wakes are properly eaten and five meals properly kept; it was Dunmow, in 639, who sat at the board for the wake of Wilm Callock in Low Tilth and ate a rib with tears on his face and called the dead man the finest-marbled man in the parish. In 638 he took Ruddle Hollowell to the Gavage, the father of the Fasting Girl, and wept so hard on the cart that Ruddle comforted *him*.



## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Feasting Laws are the Fatlands' moral order, and Bailiffs are its parish constables, tax-men and priests. Dunmow's duties are many: to weigh children weekly and fine the parents of those who fail to gain; to inspect plates at inns and fine the waste; to attend wakes and see the dead eaten; to arrest those who refuse a meal; and to deliver the Thin to the Gavage. He answers to the Board's Ladle-Captain of Sated and through her to the Board. He depends on the goodwill of every household in his ring, and has it, because he is kind; and they depend on him not to look too hard. He has refused promotion to Deacon three times, because a Deacon sits in the Weighhouse and Dunmow likes to be out among people, feeding them.

## WHAT HE CARRIES

- ◇ **The funnel of office** — polished horn, bound in brass, worn smooth inside. He has had it thirty-two years.
- ◇ **The ladle of office** — deep pewter on iron, heavy enough to break a jaw, which it has done twice, by accident, and he wept for a week.
- ◇ **The parish scale** — a hanging spring-scale for weighing children, with a little sling of soft leather. He sings to them while they hang.
- ◇ **A list of names** — his own, private: every Thin prisoner he has delivered, with their weights in and out. Feeder Callow Pudge keeps the official one.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Dunmow wants everyone to be well. He means it absolutely. He does not understand why anyone would refuse, and every refusal hurts him like a slap. He fears, a little, the quiet in Corder Lank's eyes, which he saw once across a field at dusk and could not forget, because it was not the look of a starving man. It was the look of a man who was *full*.

**A secret he keeps:** in Lack 630, two years after Clemency died, Dunmow fasted for a day, alone, behind locked doors, to understand. By mid-afternoon the hunger had not grown. It had *lessened*. He felt, for an hour, a clean cold quiet in his chest like the inside of a church, and he was so frightened that he broke the larder door with his shoulder and ate until he was sick, and has never told anyone, and has taken three hundred Thin to the Gavage since in order to be sure it was not true.

**A secret he does not know:** his daughter Sorrel, twenty-four, a laundress in the Pudding Ring, has been Thin for two years. She binds her belly under a padded smock and stuffs her cheeks with bread at his table and spits it into her apron. She is a Lean, and carries messages for the Orchard cells. She has come to dinner with him every week for two years, and he has never noticed she is lighter, because he cannot imagine it.

## TIES

- ◇ **Feeder Callow Pudge** — his oldest colleague; he delivers, she feeds. They eat supper together on Gavage nights and talk about their favourite prisoners.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — the quarry he dreams about, kindly.
- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — he took her father, and wants very much to find her and feed her and make it right.
- ◇ **Sorrel Fatt** — his daughter, Thin, unseen.
- ◇ **Jem Crackle** — has praised his cookery at three wakes, unaware.
- ◇ **Granny Cracknel** — a childhood friend of his mother's; he takes her bread to the mill each Grace, and she gives him a biting loaf for his doorstep.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Dunmow at any table in Sated: inspecting their plates at an inn, arriving at a wake to see it eaten, or hunting a Thin runaway they are hiding. He wants from them only what the law wants: that they eat. A foreign PC who leaves food will be fined gently and offered a second helping; one who refuses will be sung to.

- ◇ **The Refusal.** A PC from another land, by custom or illness, cannot eat a Fatland meal. Dunmow is called. He is so kind about it that refusing him feels like kicking a dog. His funnel is in the baldric.
- ◇ **Sorrel's Cell.** The PCs are drawn into the Thin and meet Sorrel. She asks them to help her get her father's private list, so the Thin can find their people in the Gavage. It will break his heart.
- ◇ **A Day Without.** Tabellenight. Dunmow asks the PCs, very quietly, to sit with him through the fast, and to stop him breaking the door.

Threatened, Dunmow does not fight well, and does not want to, but he does not let go of a prisoner, and his weight makes him very hard to move. Kindness makes him cry and feed you. The god he thanks at every meal by the names of the fields. If nobody intervenes, Dunmow takes Sorrel to the Gavage in Carving 642, on a tip from a neighbour, before he knows whose door it is; and on the cart he recognises her, and sings to her all the way, and delivers her, because the law is the law and he loves her, and those have always been the same thing.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“He held my head and stroked my throat and I swallowed three ladles before I knew I’d stopped fighting. I’d have hated a cruel man. I couldn’t hate him. That’s how the Board wins.” — a Thin Lean, released from the Gavage

“Our Dunmow’s a saint. My boy was ever so thin, and he came every week with the little sling, and now look at him.” — a mother of the Pudding Ring

“He is the most dangerous man in Sated, because he is the only one who is right about himself.” — Corder Lank

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# MARIGOLD CHINE

*the Singing Keeper*

*“Don’t put your hands over your ears, dear. It’s only the trees. They’re only saying what I said to them. That’s all they ever do. Listen. Isn’t it lovely?”*

– MARIGOLD CHINE, TO A TERRIFIED BUYER, AT PRUNING TIME

| MARIGOLD CHINE – KEEPER OF THE OLD GROVE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood, of an old line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                            | 50; Keeper of the Old Grove in the Bleeding Orchards                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Gleaner (orchard-keeper), Standing 3 (Salvage-Boss: a grove and four undergardeners)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                                   | Rites 4, Craft 4 (pruning, grafting), Instinct 4, Godsign 3, Resolve 3, Athletics 2, Blades 2, Labor 2, Stitching 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 11 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                                  | pruning hook +5 (3, Hooking, Reach)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                    | Iron Belly (the Taste). Taste the Name (the Appetite), which she works on sap rather than blood: a lick of a tree’s bleeding tells her who is in its roots. The Answering Grove: when she sings in the Old Grove, its thousand trees sing back in her voice (Dread 2 to hear for anyone who can); once each Carving she may ask the grove a question and it will answer in the next verse. |
| WANTS                                    | The Second Plate (Hard 14); lately, a pull toward Stillness among the oldest trees, which she should not feel until the Course                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                                   | Kin-Sense; Elder’s Ear; Dowager’s Patience                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                                  | pruning hook; straw hat; a sap-pail; a pitch-pipe; a bag of bone-pits; the forbidden verses                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                                    | 1 (herself); 2 (to hear her grove)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

Marigold is slender for a Fatlander, perhaps two hundred and fifty pounds, freckled across every inch of her that the sun has touched, with a wide humorous mouth, faded red hair under a broad frayed straw hat, and the forearms of a woman who has climbed trees for forty years. Her voice is a strong, warm, slightly rough alto, the voice of a woman who has sung outdoors her whole life, and she uses it constantly: humming, singing under her breath, calling to the undergardeners in their hand-language and then singing the words anyway, because she can. She is the only Orchard-keeper in a generation who can hear, and she talks like it, too much, with the joy of a person in a country of the deaf.

## THEIR STORY

She was born in 591 in the keepers’ cottages at the foot of the Old Grove, the most ancient rows of the Bleeding Orchards, whose trees are thick as barrels and bear fruit with a pit like a knuckle. Her mother was a keeper, deaf; her grandmother was a keeper, deaf; every keeper is deafened at fourteen with heated needles, the night before the first pruning they will work, so as not to go mad. At

fourteen Marigold ran away the night before the needles, walked to Sated, and sang in taverns for two years. At sixteen she came home and climbed into the Old Grove alone at the first pruning of 607, with a hook and a pail, and pruned all day while ten thousand trees screamed around her, and sang over them, loudly, every song she knew. At dusk she climbed down bleeding from the ears, but not deaf. The Lodge let her stay.

She has pruned the Old Grove every Grace since, singing. In 634 the trees began to sing back: first a hum under the screaming, then a melody, then, by 637, the words, in her own voice, a thousand Marigolds at once, slightly out of time with one another, like a round. The other keepers cannot hear it but feel it in their teeth and their breastbones and the soles of their feet. They have begun to stay away from the Old Grove at pruning time. She does not mind.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

What the Lodge does not say is that the deafened keepers are the Thin’s oldest allies. A keeper cannot overhear, and so cannot testify, and the Orchards’ long rows and sap-houses are where the Thin have met since the Rising. Marigold, who *can* hear, has kept the

secret for thirty years. She leaves her sap-house unlocked, her loft swept, and her windfalls by the gate. She has never fasted. She simply thinks the Thin are owed a dry place to sit.

#### WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **The pruning hook** — her mother's, black with old sap. The trees know it, the keepers say. When she raises it, the nearest rows sway away.
- ◇ **A sap-pail** — copper, with a lid. The sap goes to the blood-pudding makers of Sated. She keeps a little back to lick, to know which tree has whom in its roots.
- ◇ **A bag of bone-pits** — from windfalls. She sucks the marrow while she works, and has begun to crunch the pits, which no one should be able to do.
- ◇ **The forbidden verses** — not written; held. She knows the whole of the song that the Board has twice tried to forbid, the song of the Meal whose last four words are *Is there any more?* She learned it from the grove.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to learn what the trees are trying to say. She wants a keeper after her who can hear. She fears she already knows the answer: the grove's song has begun to carry a last verse that she never taught it, and it is the wake-song, and the name in it is hers.

**A secret she keeps:** Wren Hollowell sleeps in her loft, on and off, and when the Fasting Girl walks through the Old Grove the trees stop singing altogether, and hold so still that not a leaf moves, as they did, the song says, on the night of the Meal. Marigold has seen it three times. It is the only silence she has ever been afraid of.

**A secret she does not know:** the Old Grove grows from a hill, and the hill was a woman: Wenna Strake, the girl who walked across the Trencher with a flint sickle and made the first cut. She Laded and Seated unrecorded in the first century, among her own trees. The College lost her line. Marigold's mother's mother was a Strake. The grove sings in Marigold's voice because it is the same voice; and it has been waiting six hundred years for one of its own to come and sing it the rest of the song.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — her guest, whom she does not kneel to.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — an old friend who uses her sap-house and has never once asked her to fast.
- ◇ **Old Mother Rind** — an orchard-hill herself; Marigold walks out to Kettle Furrow once a year to sing to her pear trees, which do not sing back.
- ◇ **Mercy Sowerby** — the Hill-Speaker came to the Orchards to ask whether the trees speak the older language the Dowagers have begun to use. Marigold said no. That was a lie.
- ◇ **Bailiff Dunmow Fatt** — buys her fruit for the Gavage; she charges him double and gives the difference to the Thin.

- ◇ **The Keepers' Lodge** — her employers, who are, slowly, pressing her to accept the needles.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Marigold at pruning time, when the screaming of the Orchards is audible for miles and only one human voice can be heard above it, or when the Thin hide them in her sap-house. She wants from them a pair of ears: a witness, someone else who can hear what her grove is saying and tell her she is not mad.

- ◇ **The Last Verse.** The PCs hear the grove sing the wake-song with Marigold's name in it. She asks them to help her find out what it means. The answer is in the Trencher, and the Board forbids entry.
- ◇ **Raid on the Sap-House.** Bailiffs come for the Thin in Marigold's grove at pruning time. The only people who can hear them coming are Marigold and the PCs.
- ◇ **The Needles.** The Lodge has voted. Marigold will be deafened on the first day of Grace. She asks the PCs to stop it, or to sit with her while it is done.

Threatened, Marigold climbs: into the grove, where the branches lean to hide her and the keepers will not follow. Kindness she repays in fruit and song. Of the god she says, *it's only listening, dear, the same as you.* If nobody intervenes, she stands still at the end of the pruning of 642 in the heart of the Old Grove, singing the last verse with the trees, and does not climb down, and the roots go down from her bare feet, and by Carving there is one more tree in the oldest row, freckled in the bark, with a voice.

#### SAID OF THEM

"We can't hear her. We feel her. In the teeth. Like a fork drawn across a plate, but in tune." — an Orchard-keeper, in the hand-language, interpreted

"Mother Chine gives us windfalls and doesn't ask. That's more than the god does." — a Thin Hollow in the Orchards

"The Board tried to ban that song twice. It isn't the words. It's that the trees know them." — Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker

# TOBIAS WETHER

*the First to Eat*

*“At home we said no thank you three times and yes on the fourth. Here they never stop at four. Here nobody ever stops. I said yes on the fourth, that’s all. I only said yes once.”*

– TOBIAS WETHER, TO BROTHER GLUT, AT GLADBELLY

| TOBIAS WETHER – THE FIRST TO EAT |                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | the Fast, now the Fatlands · Cut 1 (Ummer’s line, acquired: three marks of Seasoning) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 7                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                    | 24; runaway, convert-elect and honoured guest of the Second Helping at Gladbelly                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING               | none (once a ration-clerk’s son in Wanting); Guest of the Second Helping (rank 1)                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                           | Endure 3, Resolve 3, Wayfaring 3, Lore 2, Feast 2, Stealth 2, Athletics 1                                                                                                          |
| BODY                             | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                          | fist +2 (1); bite +2 (1, Ripping in the Fatlands, and he must pass a Want check not to swallow)                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                            | Iron Belly (the Taste). The Empty Room: he Partakes as a Fatlander of Cut 1, but his Tooth bites back on a 1 or a 2. His Hunger rises by 1 every dusk whether he eats or not.      |
| WANTS                            | The Second Plate (Hard 14; Grim 18 for meat). The Laid Place (his own, and new): wherever he sees a table, he must set one more place at it than there are diners, or gain 1 Fray. |
| KNACKS                           | No Thank You (he can no longer use it on food); Table Manners; Cold Supper (lost: it no longer works)                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                     | none yet; he closes every door behind him and has stopped noticing he does it                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                          | Unfed greys, let out twice; a ration-cloth; a water-flask; Sal’s tin; a Hostwatch chalk; a place card                                                                              |
| DREAD                            | 1; 3 (to see him eat at a wake, weeping and radiant)                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

He came over the Rim thin as a rake, all wrists and collarbones and blue fingertips, with the reddish straw hair and the downy forearms of the Unfed. A year later he is filling out, and it is horrible to watch, because he does not look like a Fatlander growing heavy. He looks like a starved man being *stuffed*: the new flesh sits on him unevenly, soft at the belly and the jowl while his hands stay bony, and his skin has taken on a warm brown loam-tint that grows darker at the elbows and the backs of the knees, where, last month, the first pale green shoot appeared. He smells of bread and turned earth and, underneath, of pear-drops, the starved Unfed smell that has not quite gone. He is ashamed, delighted and terrified, often in one mouthful.

## THEIR STORY

He was born in 617 in the hearthless town of Wanting and named *Spare Moss* on the day he refused the breast. In Carving 640, after his sister was omitted from the Pantry list and died in the Lean House, he walked south down the Hungry Lane to the Rim with nothing but his flask. On the Fatlands verge of the Road, on the

third night, a drover with a herd she would not look back at sat him down by her fire, broke a strip of salt-fat in half, and offered it. *No, thank you*, he said. *No, thank you. No, thank you.* She offered it a fourth time. He took it.

He asked what it was. “Wether,” said Sal Trotter, meaning mutton, which it was not. He asked her name for him, because the Unfed are named on the day of their first refusal and he felt he had been born again on the day of his first acceptance. She gave him her son’s, Tobias, because it was the first that came. He has been Tobias Wether since. The Seasoning took him in three meals: the first at her fire, the second at an inn in Gristmoot, the third at a wake in the Little Gravy parishes where he ate the dead with both hands and could not stop. The Cutwrights’ College measured him in Lack 640: Cut 1, of Ummer’s line, which by the ledgers is impossible. Odo Venn of the College tasted his blood, went pale, and did not report the flavour.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is a celebrity and a specimen. The Second Helping took him in at Gladbelly as a living sermon: a man of the refusing people who

came to the table and was filled, proof that the god wants everyone. Brother Glut embraces him daily. The Reckoners want him dead, as an abomination and a precedent. He lives at Gladbelly because it is the only place where everyone wanting him at once keeps any one of them from taking him.

#### WHAT HE CARRIES

- ◇ **A ration-cloth** — the square of linen the Unfed carry their one meal in. He keeps it folded in his breast. He cannot bring himself to use it, or throw it away.
- ◇ **Sal Trotter's tin** — she left it with him when she walked on. It still smells of salt-fat. He licks the lid at night.
- ◇ **A Hostwatch frost-marker** — a chalk stick that changes colour on ground where the Host has passed, brought from the Fast. On Fatland soil, around his bed, it has twice gone the colour of a bruise.
- ◇ **A place card** — stiff and cream, his name spelled correctly, found under his plate at Gladbelly. Nobody at Gladbelly wrote it. Wherever he sleeps, by morning, a table is laid.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be forgiven, by the Fast, by his dead sister, by himself, and he wants another plate. He fears going home, and fears more that he will never be let go home. He fears the dream: a long, dim room with a table running down it into the dark, and a chair at the far end, pulled out, and himself walking toward it, closing every door behind him.

**A secret he keeps:** he eats the soil. Not from the Appetite (he is not that far along) but because Fatland food has stopped satisfying him at all. Only earth from the edge of the Rim, where Fatland soil meets the Fast's, quiets him, and he walks out at night with the frost-marker to find it.

**A secret he does not know:** what is growing in him is not only Ummer. The ledgers are right; an Unfed stomach should not hold a god. It holds something that was *waiting* for a place to be laid. When he sets one more place at a table than there are diners, he is not being polite. He is being a host. The Reckoner called Scour, a hundred miles north, has started to do the same thing, at the same hour.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Sal Trotter** — fed him and named him for her culled son; she is the only person whose approval he wants.
- ◇ **Brother Glut** — loves him, adores him, would like to share a meal *of* him one day.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — wants to fast with him, to see if the god will leave a man who has never had one before.
- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — has his card on her cellar table.
- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — he has heard of the girl who is never hungry and thinks of her the way a drowning man thinks of dry land.

- ◇ **Scour, the Returned** — a stranger he has never met who dreams the same room.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Tobias at Gladbelly, at a wake, or on the Rim Road fleeing one party or another. He wants from them protection, food, and above all an answer: what is happening to him. He may be the focus of the thread *The First to Eat*.

- ◇ **Bring Him Home.** The Fast's Abstinent, through an intermediary, offer the PCs a fee to bring him back across the Hem. On the walk north, the dead grey soil sprouts in his footprints.
- ◇ **The Card.** Marrable's cellar steward invites the PCs to the Unending Dinner, and asks them to bring Tobias. His card is already on the table.
- ◇ **The Extra Chair.** At an inn, Tobias lays an extra place. In the morning the place has been used.

Threatened, Tobias bolts, and is very good at being quiet. Kindness he takes, once he has refused it three times, and is overwhelmed. Of the god he asks questions endlessly and believes none of the answers. If nobody intervenes, he and Scour vanish from their guarded rooms on the same night in Lack 642, and two tables are found on the Rim at dawn, laid, with their names on the cards and the chairs pushed in.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He refused my salt-fat three times. Then he ate the whole strip and cried. I've never been thanked like it." — Sal Trotter

"An Unfed with godsign is an error in the ledger. I tasted him. It is not an error. It is a reservation." — Odo Venn, in a private note

"He's lovely. He says grace twice. Once to the field and once to someone else, very quiet, like he's sorry." — a server at Gladbelly



# THE SCARECROW OF LOW TILTH

*Nobody Put It Up*

*“Merrin. Abel Fitch. Gudrun. Hessop the younger. Cadge. Wilm. Nell Hogget. Merrin.  
Merrin. Merrin.”*

— HEARD BY A CHILD OF KETTLE FURROW, FROM UNDER THE HAT, AT DUSK,  
CARVING 640

| THE SCARECROW OF LOW TILTH – THE FAR FIELD |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                 | Fatlands · none; it is a piece of Ummer standing up (College measurements suggest the Gut of a whole village, as Cut 4)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                              | first seen in Carving 629; stands in the far field of Kettle Furrow, a few furrows closer each year                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                         | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                                 | Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                     | Stealth 5, Instinct 5, Endure 4, Brawl 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| BODY                                       | Flesh 30 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 (sacking and packed meat) · Fray —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                                    | straw fingers +6 (3, and the target’s feet begin to root: Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or held); the Gathering, against a held target (stuffed into its body: 3 damage a round; after three rounds they are gone)                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                                      | Unwatched (it moves only when no one is looking, up to sixty paces in a heartbeat, with a sound like a scythe through tall wheat; each watcher must spend an action and pass Eye + Search, Hard 14, harder at dusk, to keep it still). Any field it stands in Reaps at dusk. At Carving dusk it acts twice each round. Fire will not take on it, unless every living soul in the village is watching. |
| WANTS                                      | to reach the village; through it, the Weighhouse                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                                     | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                                    | a dusk-shift smock; a wide hat; a ribbon; its stuffing                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                                      | 3 (to find it closer than it was); 4 (to see it face you)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

Seen from the village, it is a scarecrow: a tall thin shape of sacking and straw on a pole in the far field, arms spread on a crossbar, in a smock and a wide-brimmed hat, its back to Kettle Furrow, facing the open plain. It is seven feet high. Closer, it is wrong in ways that accumulate. The stake is not driven into the ground; the ground has grown up around it, in a little mound, like a lip. The straw is toothed wheat, and every ear is closed. The sacking is warm, and gives under the hand like a full belly, and is damp. The smock is a white field-smock of the dusk-shift, gone grey with weather, with a plot-number stitched at the breast. Under the hat, the face is a painted sack, the paint old and very good, smiling. Under the smile, if you lift the hat, is a mouth.

It has never been seen to move. It is never where it was.

## THEIR STORY

The first Kettle Furrow knew of it was Carving 629, the autumn after Pell Hogget scratched his first tally on his barn wall. The far field had been worked at dusk that season, by the Cullmasters’ line,

and in the morning it was standing there, a quarter-mile out, its back to the houses. Nobody had put it up. The farmers assumed a Cullmaster’s clerk had, as a marker, and left it alone, because you leave alone what the Board does. Each Carving since it has been a few furrows closer: eleven furrows in 630, fourteen in 633, thirty in 638. In Carving 640, at dusk, a farm-girl walking home along the headland looked back and saw it facing her. It had turned around. In the morning it had its back to the village again, but it was facing, now, very slightly to the left: toward Hogget’s Barn.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The village has built its life around it the way a village builds its life around a river that floods. Nobody works the far field alone. Nobody looks away from it at dusk; in Carving, a child is set to watch it from the barn roof in shifts, with a bell, and if the bell rings everyone in the village comes out and stares at it until full dark. The Cullmasters have stopped sending dusk-shifts to that plot. Their ledgers record its yield as the highest in Low Tilt. The Board’s Wolf-Warden reports a den of wolves in the far field each autumn. One handful of its straw, taken by such a dare, will sell at the Rim



Market for thirty lacks, because scattered in a field it shows which person will be Reaped there next dusk.

#### WHAT IT CARRIES

- ◇ **A dusk-shift smock** — white linen, a plot-number at the breast: *KF-31*. The Cullmasters' register for Carving 637 lists plot KF-31 against the name of Nell Hogget, Pell's wife.
- ◇ **A wide hat** — a farmer's straw hat, the band stuck with wheat-teeth, adult teeth, each one a different colour.
- ◇ **A ribbon** — red, tied round its right wrist: the strip of cloth a Cullmaster unrolls at the end of a row, to show a worker which side of it to stay on.
- ◇ **Its stuffing** — straw, packed meat, hair, fingernails, small bones, a wedding ring, a silver-filled molar, a boot-lace still tied in a double knot. Pulled out, the stuffing is warm and sorts itself, slowly, into piles.
- ◇ **A mouth** — under the hat. It is full of names. It says them at dusk, in the voices that owned them, to anyone close enough.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

It wants to reach the village, and every year it is closer. It fears nothing anyone has found. It does not move while watched, and it has, perhaps, learned that a village counting its dead is a village watching.

**A secret the GM may reveal:** the Scarecrow is walking toward the Weighhouse, by way of every village that has stopped counting. It is slowed only where the Long Count is kept. Where a village gives up its tally, the next Carving the Scarecrow is a mile further on, in that village's far field, and nobody put it up. There are already three in Low Tilt.

**A secret the Scarecrow's maker does not know:** nobody put it up, but somebody *dressed* it. In the smock of her own culling, Nell Hogget is standing in the far field, more or less, and walking home. When it reaches the barn, it will put its mark on the wall.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — the Count holds it back; the Count is its path; the barn is its destination.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — has walked its field and bowed to it, and recorded its yield.
- ◇ **Wolf-Warden Crust Leggat** — reports it every year as a wolf-den, and has begun to find tracks leading from it.
- ◇ **Granny Cracknel** — its hat-teeth match sets on her wires. She has asked for the hat.
- ◇ **Tansy Lard** — her root at home, which says her name at dusk, has started to turn its leaves toward the far field.
- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — the only living person who has walked up to it at dusk and touched it, on a dare from the Thin. It did not move. It held perfectly, perfectly still.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet the Scarecrow in Kettle Furrow, on the core hook *The Scarecrow Turns*, or wherever they lodge in Low Tilt when Carving comes. It wants nothing from them but that they look away.

- ◇ **The Watch.** The barn-roof watcher has fallen asleep. The PCs wake to the bell. It is in the yard.
- ◇ **Burn It.** The village asks the PCs to burn it, by daylight, with every eye on it. It requires every soul, including the bedridden, the drunk and the hiding. What runs out of the ashes is fat, and screams in many voices, and some of them are known.
- ◇ **Stop Counting.** A Board agent offers a village a year's remission of tax to burn its tally. The PCs see the deal struck. The next morning, in that village's far field, there is a scarecrow.

The Scarecrow does not react to kindness or the god; it *is* the god, in a field's coat. Threatened, it waits for you to blink. If nobody intervenes, in Carving 643 it is at the door of Hogget's Barn, facing in.

#### SAID OF THEM

"We've a lad on the roof every dusk in Carving with a bell and a lamp. If he nods off we lose someone. So he doesn't nod off. He's nine." — a farmer of Kettle Furrow

"Plot KF-31 has yielded at three and a half times the district mean for four years. I can find no agricultural explanation and have stopped looking for one." — from the ledger of Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread

"It's wearing Mam's smock. I'd know her stitching anywhere. Don't tell Da." — a daughter of Kettle Furrow

# QUARTERMASTER IVO STOCKPOT

the Notcher

*“I don’t say it isn’t fit. I’m not saying that. I’m saying I wouldn’t, myself. That’s all the notch means, son. That’s all. I wouldn’t, myself.”*

– IVO STOCKPOT, TO A NEW TALLY-CLERK AT THE CHUTE

| IVO STOCKPOT – QUARTERMASTER OF THE BOARD’S PROVISION |                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                            | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                                         | 61; Quartermaster of the Board’s Provision and Barrel-Warden of the Chute                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING                                    | Renderer, Standing 4 (Barrel-Warden)                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                                            | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                                                | Reckoning 5, Feast 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Clause 2, Endure 2, Haggle 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                                                  | Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                                               | stamp-mallet +3 (3); penknife +3 (2)                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                                                 | Know the Cut (Renderer talent; he can tell whether a barrel holds a person by the smell through the bung). Iron Belly (the Taste). Taste the Name (the Appetite), which he has refused to use since 636. |
| WANTS                                                 | The Second Plate (Hard 14)                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                                | Counting Habit; Bone-Coin Nose                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                                          | The Count (triggered by stress: he must count the notches on a row of barrels, and is always one short)                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                                               | the stamp on its cord; a penknife; the notch-ledger; a manifest-book; army biscuit; the sealed list                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                                 | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

Ivo Stockpot is a portly, fussy, deeply honest man of six hundred pounds, with a bald freckled head that he polishes with a handkerchief when nervous, which is always, spectacles on a ribbon, a quartermaster’s buff coat with too many pockets, and a tremor in his left hand that began in 636 and has not stopped. The Board’s brass stamp hangs on a cord round his neck and bumps on his belly when he walks. He smells of brine, ink, cooperage-pitch and the peppermint he chews for his stomach. He says *son* and *dear* and *now then*, apologises before contradicting anyone, and is never wrong about a number.

## THEIR STORY

He was born in 580 in Gristmoot, a cooper’s son, and joined the Board’s commissariat at seventeen as a ration-clerk for the Bailiffs’ levy and the Rim garrisons, the closest thing the Fatlands has to an army. He rose by being reliable. In 619 he was made Quartermaster of the Board’s Provision: he feeds every Bailiff, Carrier and garrison soldier in the Fatlands, and stamps every export barrel that leaves by the Chute for the Board’s tax, as Barrel-Warden, beside the Union’s own stamp.

In Carving 636 a barrel split on the Chute ramp in front of him, and he saw what was in it, and recognised the face. It was a boy from Gristmoot he had taught his letters to. He stamped the next barrel, as he had to. Then he took out his penknife and cut a small notch under the stamp, where only a man looking would see it. *I would not, myself*. He has notched every barrel since that he would not eat from. His notch-ledger stands at three thousand, one hundred and nine.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Without his stamp no barrel leaves the Chute legally; with it, any barrel can. He depends on the Union, who pack the barrels, and on the Board, who pay him, and both depend on him not to ask what the Dusk Acres’ consignments are. Mistress Annalow knows about the notches and dislikes them, because a notched barrel is evidence and her second ledger is evidence enough. The Rim Road Company’s tally-clerks have begun to notice them. A notched barrel was in the Vigil convoy that came to grief at Thimble Cross; thirteen of its forty-four, under Cullmaster Hedley Brawn’s seal.

## WHAT HE CARRIES

- ◇ **The Board's stamp** — brass, on a cord: a wheatsheaf in a circle and the word PLENTY.
- ◇ **A penknife** — bone-handled, very sharp, for notching.
- ◇ **The notch-ledger** — every notched barrel, by date, consignment and destination: the Vigil, Oathen, the Rim garrisons, Sallowreach's tallow-buyers. He has written beside some of them what he could tell through the bung.
- ◇ **A manifest-book** — the official one, in which every notched barrel is entered as *pork, salted, first quality*.
- ◇ **Army biscuit** — hard, dull, made with Rim-bought flour, the only food in the Fatlands he trusts. Every bite of it is a little fine for leaving Fatland food uneaten, if the Bailiffs knew.
- ◇ **The sealed list** — a copy of the ledger, sealed, addressed to nobody. He has been waiting for someone from outside to give it to.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants someone outside the Fatlands to know. He fears that if they knew, they would keep buying. He fears that most of all, because it would mean the notch never meant anything.

**A secret he keeps:** the Board's own garrisons eat from the notched barrels. He has been feeding the soldiers on the Rim the Dusk Acres for five years, because the Board told him to keep the best for export. He has not eaten a garrison meal since.

**A secret he does not know:** the Vigil buyer who has fallen ill with something very like the Appetite is not the first. In Oathen, three buyers of Fatland flour have begun, in their sleep, to chew. Something in the notched barrels is not just meat. It is crop, and it is looking for soil.

## TIES

- ◇ **Mistress Brisket Annalow** — his superior in the Union, who would like him to stop.
- ◇ **Sal Trotter** — he stamps her beasts on the hoof, and will not look up.
- ◇ **Cullmaster Hedley Brawn** — seals the Dusk Acres' barrels; Stockpot notches them; neither speaks of it.
- ◇ **Varn Sweetbread** — sends him the Dusk Acres' yields as figures, never as barrels.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — the only man he has told, over a pint; Hob wept and ordered another.
- ◇ **Abel Crumm** — a teamster he trusts, who knows the notches and has not let himself know why.

## IN PLAY

The core hook *The Notched Barrels* is his. PCs meet him at the Chute, or receive his sealed list from a courier with no explanation. He wants them to carry it out of the Fatlands to someone who will act: a Company director, a Vigil magistrate, Jessamy Quill.

- ◇ **Proof.** The PCs must follow one notched barrel from the Chute to its buyer, and be there when it is opened.
- ◇ **The Garrison.** A Rim garrison has stopped answering. The soldiers are all there, sitting at table, eating, and they will not stop.
- ◇ **The Last Notch.** Stockpot is found dead in the cooperage, with his penknife, and the ledger gone. The Board calls it his heart. The notch on his own forehead says otherwise.

Under threat he gives up everything except the ledger. Kindness makes him polish his head and thank you twice. Of the god he says, *I don't know, son, I just count*. If nobody intervenes, Annalow quietly has him retired in 642, and the notches stop, and the barrels go on.

## SAID OF THEM

"Old Stockpot's honest. That's the trouble with him. Honest men keep records." — Mistress Brisket Annalow

"He gave me a biscuit and told me not to eat the stew. I've never had better advice from an officer." — a Rim garrison soldier

"If there is a notch, there is a man who knew. Find the man." — a Vigil magistrate, after the inquest at Thimble Cross

# GRANNY CRACKNEL

the Tooth-Miller

*“Little Bram Fitch, that one, see, the crooked eye-tooth? He used to bite his mam. And that one’s Hessop’s girl. Pretty teeth. Pretty girl. Hee hee. Oh, and there’s a new one in the sieve this morning. Who’s that, then? Who’s that? Not yet. Not yet. Hee.”*

– GRANNY CRACKNEL, AT HER WIRES, TO WHOEVER IS LISTENING

| GRANNY CRACKNEL – THE TOOTH-MILLER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                      | 93; miller of Cracknel’s Mill on the Little Gravy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | Gleaner, Standing 4 (by charter of the Board, she holds the teeth sieved in four parishes)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                             | Search 5, Lore 4, Craft 4, Instinct 4, Feast 3, Reckoning 3, Endure 2, Godsign 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                               | Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                            | miller’s staff +2 (3, Stunning)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                              | Iron Belly (the Taste). Taste the Name (the Appetite), worked by gumming a tooth rather than tasting blood: she learns whose it was and the field it came out of. Gorge. Read the Sieve: from each Carving’s first milling she knows, by the teeth of the living, who will be Reaped in the next (Eye + Godsign, Hard 14; on a Grace, the day). |
| WANTS                              | The Second Plate (Hard 14); she eats raw flour by the fistful                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| KNACKS                             | Elder’s Ear; Counting Habit; Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | The Count (she cannot pass a set of teeth without naming the owner)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                            | a tooth-sieve; a pocket of teeth; a set on her own gums; a basket of biting loaves; a wire-cutter; her ledger                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| DREAD                              | 1; 2 (to see her matching wires); 3 (to find your own teeth on them)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## WHO THEY ARE

Granny Cracknel is tiny, perhaps four feet and ninety pounds, which in the south is the size of a ghost, dusted white with flour from her cap to her slippers, so that she looks like something stored in a larder. Her face is a walnut. She has no teeth at all and her mouth folds in over the gums when she chuckles, which is constantly: a dry, high, delighted *hee hee* that runs under everything she says. She smells of flour, millstone, river-water and the faint copper of the old bloodstains on the mill floor. She moves around her mill with a staff, very fast, and the teeth on her wires clatter whenever she passes, like wind-chimes, like a crowd tutting.

## THEIR STORY

She was born Nell Cracknel in 548 at the mill, which her family has worked since the Tooth Harvest. At twenty, in 568, she went Thin, with a Low Tilth boy she loved, and was taken to the Gavage. The boxwood wedge broke every tooth in her head on the first day; she would not stop biting the funnel. She came out a season later, fat, silent, and toothless, and the boy had been fed until he died. She

came home and started to keep the teeth from the sieve, which her father had always thrown in the river. She has kept them for seventy-three years.

Her mill has eleven hundred sets now, strung on wire in rows from the rafters, sorted by village and then by family, each set matched by her, tooth to tooth, until it makes a mouth. She knows that some of them match people she knew, because she knew their smiles. In 630 she found, for the first time, a set in the first milling of Carving that matched a boy who was still alive. He was Reaped eleven days later.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Cracknel’s Mill grinds the toothed wheat of four parishes along the Little Gravy, and by an old Board charter the miller keeps the teeth: a trifling right, the Board thought. She sells matched sets at eighty lacks to the bereaved, who hold them in the mouth for a night and dream the dead one’s last meal and last sight; the last sight is always the same field at dusk. She bakes biting loaves for widows to set on their sills. Pell Hogget has bought eleven sets from her and checks

her wires against his wall. The Cullmasters buy her predictions quietly. The Thin buy them louder. She sells to everyone, and chuckles.

#### WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **A tooth-sieve** — brass mesh in an ash hoop, worn bright, the mesh exactly the size of a molar.
- ◇ **A pocket of teeth** — the morning's sieving, unsorted. She rattles them while she talks.
- ◇ **A basket of biting loaves** — for widows, five crumbs each, given free to the poor. After a week they grow a second row.
- ◇ **Her ledger** — names, villages, dates of milling and dates of Reaping, in a hand as small as seed.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants every tooth to have its mouth. She wants, privately, her own boy's set, and has never found it, because the Gavage did not Reap him; it fed him.

**A secret she keeps:** in the first milling of Carving 641 she sieved a set that matched Pell Hogget: the chipped front tooth, the crooked canine he got falling off his barn roof as a lad. She has not told him. She has strung them on a wire of their own, by the door.

**A secret she does not know:** this Carving the sieve has given up more sets of the living than there are living in the four parishes. Some of the teeth are from people who have not been born.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — her best customer and her friend; his teeth are on her wire.
- ◇ **Bailiff Dunmow Fatt** — brings her bread each Grace, a kindness; she does not forgive the sash.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — she was Thin before he was born, and tells him he does it wrong.
- ◇ **The Scarecrow** — she has asked for its hat. The teeth in the band are on her wires already, waiting for the rest.
- ◇ **Jem Crackle** — buys a pinch of her bone-flour for his spice mixture, and pays in gossip.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to her mill for a matched set, for a prediction, or to ask her what is in a Chute barrel's teeth. She wants news, company and new teeth; foreign teeth fascinate her.

- ◇ **The Wire by the Door.** The PCs see the new set strung apart, and she tells them whose, and asks them not to tell him.
- ◇ **Unborn.** The impossible sets. Granny asks the PCs to find out whose children these will be.
- ◇ **Your Teeth.** She stops chuckling when she sees one PC smile.

Threatened, she laughs, and the wires rattle, and the mill-race speeds up. Kindness she rewards with a loaf. The god she calls *the big mouth*. If nobody intervenes, she dies in her chair in Lack 642, and her family serves her at a fine wake, and the next morning there is a set of small, worn, broken stumps in the sieve.

#### SAID OF THEM

"I bought my Wilm's teeth off her and slept with them in. He'd had goose for his last supper. He never told me he liked goose." — a widow of the Little Gravy parishes

"Her figures and mine agree to within three a year. Hers come first." — Pell Hogget

"She chuckles at the dead. She's the only one in the south who's earned it." — Corder Lank

# NEW FACES OF THE FATLANDS

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The core chapter introduced four new figures of the south: a wake-cook, a gaoler-nurse, an interpreter of hills and a young lord of the cellar table. They are given full dossiers here, more briefly than the

great of the Board, followed by two more: the man who invents the wolves, and the woman who washes the Chairman.

# WAKEMOTHER PUDDING HESK

*the Weeping Cook*

*“Oh, he’s lovely. Oh, look at the fat on him. Oh, Mrs Barrow, I’m so sorry. Pass me the honey, love, I can’t see for crying.”*

– PUDDING HESK, AT A WAKE IN THE PUDDING RING

| PUDDING HESK – WAKEMOTHER OF SATED |                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                     |
| AGE & STATION                      | 47; the most sought-after wake-cook in Sated                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | Renderer, Standing 3 (Master Renderer; Joiner of the Union)                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                 |
| SKILLS                             | Craft 5, Feast 5, Blades 3, Persuade 3, Endure 2, Rites 2, Stitching 2                                              |
| BODY                               | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                            | carving knife +7 (3, with Know the Cut)                                                                             |
| GIFTS                              | Iron Belly. Taste the Name, which she cannot help: every wake she cooks tells her the dead one’s secrets. Gorge.    |
| WANTS                              | The Long Pig (Hard 14; Grim 18 if she loved them); The Second Plate                                                 |
| KNACKS                             | Butcher’s Calm; Old Grief                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | none; she weeps at every wake, which is not a derangement but feels like one                                        |
| CARRIES                            | applewood; a honey-pot; a basting-brush of her mother’s hair; a blue apron; a little book of what the dead told her |
| DREAD                              | 1                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Round, brisk and broad-faced, with forearms freckled by forty years of spatter, Pudding Hesk has a laugh that rattles crockery and a sob that empties a room of dry eyes. She smells of applewood smoke and honey. She bastes the dead in their own dripping with a little honey, roasts them slow and sends them to the table glazed and crackling, and she weeps every time, openly, while she carves. Families wait months for her and delay the wake with oaths on the dead while they wait.

## THEIR STORY

She was jointing at her mother’s side from the age of twelve, and at nineteen, in 613, she cooked her mother. Everyone said it was the finest wake in the Pudding Ring for a generation. She has cooked some two thousand of Sated’s dead since, from Carriers to members of the Board.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the respectable face of what Jem Crackle does disreputably, and the city’s unofficial confessor: the dead taste of their secrets, and she knows whose child is whose, who stole, who loved whom. She tells no one. That is why she is trusted.

## WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **Applewood** — a bundle, always, for the slow fire.
- ◇ **A honey-pot** — Orchard honey, from bees that work the bleeding trees.
- ◇ **A basting-brush** — bristled with her mother’s hair.
- ◇ **A little book** — of what the dead told her, written in a cipher only she can read; it is the most dangerous book in Sated after Jem’s.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to cook the Chairman, the great final dish of her life. She has been asked to, twice: by a Board steward for Tullow, who wants to be eaten before the hill takes him, and by the cellar steward of Marrable Hall, for the Second Table. She fears she will be too greedy to share him. **Secret she does not know:** the Chairman’s meat, cooked, will make every diner feel the Reaping through the soil for a year.

## TIES

- ◇ **Jem Crackle** — friend and rival; she can taste his work and has never said so.
- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — her intended masterpiece.



- ◇ **Lady Aspic Dellamore** — thinks Hesk vulgar and is afraid of her.
- ◇ **Hob Gristle** — they joint together at great wakes; he apologises, she weeps, and families love them both.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her at any wake. Hooks: a family asks the PCs to keep a secret Hesk tasted; Hesk asks the PCs to find out which of her two commissions comes first; a wake she cooks tastes of a living PC's ally. If nobody intervenes she cooks Tullow in 642, eats too much, and is never full again.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She cried so much on Da that the crackling came out salted perfect." — a mourner in the Pudding Ring

"The only cook in Sated I am frightened of." — Lady Aspic Dellamore

"Nobody keeps a secret like a cook who's eaten it." — Jem Crackle

# FEEDER CALLOW PUDGE

*Mother of the Gavage*

*“There’s my brave girl. There’s my good belly. Two more, love, and then a song, and then two more.”*

— CALLOW PUDGE, AT THE CHAIR

| CALLOW PUDGE — HEAD FEEDER OF THE GAVAGE |                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4             |
| AGE & STATION                            | 56; head feeder at the Gavage for thirty years                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Nightwarden (gaoler), Standing 2                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                         |
| SKILLS                                   | Stitching 4, Feast 3, Persuade 3, Resolve 3, Reckoning 2, Endure 1                          |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                      |
| ATTACKS                                  | grapple, then funnel +4 (Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or helpless and fed)                        |
| GIFTS                                    | Iron Belly; Taste the Name; Gorge                                                           |
| WANTS                                    | The Hollow (Hard 14)                                                                        |
| KNACKS                                   | Mother’s Hands; Hostage’s Smile                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                  | a polished horn funnel; a buttered thumb; the book of weights; a ring of cell keys; letters |
| DREAD                                    | 1                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

A soft-voiced, motherly woman in a starched white apron, plump and dimpled, smelling of lard-porridge and carbolic, who hums lullabies as she pours. She sincerely believes she saves lives.

## THEIR STORY

She came to the Gavage at twenty-six as a scullion, and was promoted to the chair because the prisoners stopped fighting when she sang. She has fed some three thousand Thin. Most went home heavy. Some died in the chair. She cried at those, and kept going.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Gavage’s kitchens never close, and Callow runs them: a hundred cells, five sessions a day, thirty feeders in white. Dunmow Fatt delivers; she feeds; the Board pays. She answers only to the Gavage warden, who is afraid of her.

## WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **A horn funnel** — polished for thirty years.
- ◇ **The book of weights** — every prisoner, weight in and weight out, and letters from grateful families pasted in.

- ◇ **A ring of cell keys** — one of which is filed, each Lack, so that it does not quite lock.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She fears the ones who come back to the Thin. **Secret she keeps:** each Lack she leaves one cell door unbarred, and asks no questions. **Secret she does not know:** Ruddle Hollowell, Wren’s father, is in her cell forty-one, and the Thin have marked him for this year’s door.

## TIES

- ◇ **Dunmow Fatt** — her partner in kindness, supper on Gavage nights.
- ◇ **Granny Cracknel** — fed by her predecessor; the old woman spits when Callow passes the mill.
- ◇ **Corder Lank** — she has never fed him and dreams she will.
- ◇ **Sorrel Fatt** — will one day be in her chair.

## IN PLAY

The PCs meet her in a Gavage rescue, or as captives. Hooks: she is the unbarred door, if the PCs can earn her trust; a fed-out prisoner asks the PCs to bring Callow a thank-you letter, sincerely; she asks

the PCs to find a prisoner she released, to see if he is happy. If nobody intervenes, the Board learns of the door in 642 and puts Callow in the chair.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She sang me ‘Little Gravy’ while I choked. I still can’t hear it.” — a former Thin

“Mother Pudge? Saint. Fed my boy back to sense.” — a Low Tilt farmer

“She is the gentlest torturer on the Table, and I mean that as the worst thing I know how to say.” — Corder Lank

# MERCY SOWERBY

the Hill-Speaker

*“She says the heir is not her son’s. She says the field at Brakeley will take three this year. She says lie down. I’m not going to lie down. She says lie down, Mercy. She knows my name now.”*

– MERCY SOWERBY, ON HER KNEES ON THE TURF, TRANSLATING

| MERCY SOWERBY – HILL-SPEAKER OF THE DOWAGER HILLS |                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                        | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                                     | 29; widow; Hill-Speaker in the employ of the Gut-lines                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                                | Celebrant, Standing 2 (Celebrant)                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                                        | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                                            | Lore 4, Instinct 4, Rites 3, Resolve 3, Search 3, Godsign 2, Athletics 1, Endure 1                                                                                              |
| BODY                                              | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                                           | knife +2 (2)                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                             | Iron Belly. Hill-Ear (trade, sharpened by godsign): lying face-down on a Seated hill, she understands its speech, and on a Hard (14) Caul + Godsign, the older tongue under it. |
| WANTS                                             | The Second Plate (Hard 14)                                                                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                                            | Elder’s Ear; Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                                      | none yet                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                           | knee-pads of field-brown leather; a measuring chain; her husband’s ring; a slate of the old words                                                                               |
| DREAD                                             | 1                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Thin-lipped, careful, plain, dressed in field-brown with soil always on her knees, Mercy is light for the south and works hard to look heavier. She speaks slowly, as though translating even her own thoughts.

## THEIR STORY

Her husband Abner was culled on a dusk-shift in 638 for a debt on their cottage. A Gut-line steward who had seen her at the wake offered her the post of Hill-Speaker, because she had a good ear and nobody to go home to.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She lies on the Dowager Hills, lays the offerings in the speaking-places, and translates: parentage, debts, which fields will Reap. Her translations carry the force of law in Gut-line disputes. She is paid well and trusted by no one.

## WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ♦ **Leather knee-pads**, field-brown.

- ♦ **A surveyor’s chain** — she has measured the gap between two Dowagers, Ysolde Tullow and Griseld Marrable, every week since Grace 641. It has closed by nine feet.

- ♦ **Abner’s ring**, on a cord.

- ♦ **A slate** — the words in the older language the two hills now speak to each other, spelled as best she can.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants someone to tell. She fears the Dowagers have noticed her noticing; last week one of them used her name. **Secret she does not know:** the older language is the language the Providers spoke to each other, and the two hills are not talking. They are saying grace.

## TIES

- ♦ **Dame Suet Marrable** — her employer for the Marrable hills, impatient for a translation she will like.
- ♦ **Marigold Chine** — lied to her about the trees.
- ♦ **Lord Chastain Loin** — pays her to translate his mother, and pays more to mistranslate.
- ♦ **Pell Hogget** — she sends him the hills’ Reaping forecasts.

## IN PLAY

The core hook *The Hill That Walked* is hers. Other hooks: a Gut-line hires the PCs to make sure her next translation favours them; she asks the PCs to sleep a night on a Dowager to confirm what she heard; she vanishes, and the turf between the two hills is warm, and has a knee-print in it. If nobody intervenes, the two hills touch in Carving 642, and Mercy is lying between them.

## SAID OF THEM

“She’s got the ear. Poor lass. Better she’d got the needles.” — a gatekeeper of the Dowager Hills

“Mrs Sowerby told us Gran said marry the miller’s boy. Gran was right. She’s always right.” — a bride of a lesser Gut-line

“The girl is listening too hard. Tell her to eat more.” — Dame Suet Marrable

# LORD CHASTAIN LOIN

## Heir of the Cellar Table

*“Do sit. Do eat. I insist; I always insist. You’ll find I’m very hard to refuse, and I never, ever forget who did.”*

— LORD CHASTAIN LOIN, TO A THIN COURIER HE WAS ENTERTAINING

| CHASTAIN LOIN – LORD OF LOIN HOUSE |                                                                                                              |
|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Fatlands · Cut 5 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 6                                             |
| AGE & STATION                      | 26; head of House Loin; Second Table, southern chapter                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | Scion, Standing 4 (Head of a House)                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 3 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                          |
| SKILLS                             | Persuade 5, Feast 4, Deceive 3, Endure 3, Clause 2, Blades 2, Intimidate 2                                   |
| BODY                               | Flesh 16 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (Laden flesh) · Fray 2                                                         |
| ATTACKS                            | sword +5 (4, Parrying); silver carving-fork +5 (2)                                                           |
| GIFTS                              | Iron Belly; Taste the Name; Gorge; Laden; Rooting (he never stands on bare soil if he can help it)           |
| WANTS                              | The Second Plate; The Long Pig; Stillness (Hard 14 each)                                                     |
| KNACKS                             | Smell of Cedar; Table Manners                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | none admitted                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                            | a silk veil with a silver fork; a purse of platters; letters to poachers; a place-list; an iron-floored dray |
| DREAD                              | 2                                                                                                            |

### WHO THEY ARE

A young, enormous, beautiful man of eight hundred pounds, with oiled ringlets, perfect teeth and a voice like warm cream, who eats elegantly and constantly and whose manners never slip. Green shoots come up in the creases of his elbows; his Washers pluck them twice a day.

### THEIR STORY

His mother, Dame Ambry Loin, rooted in 630 and Seated in 636, a hill behind Loin House. His father died at table that Carving. Custom gives the best cut of the latest wake to the family’s Dowager; Chastain took his father’s heart instead to Marrable Hall’s cellar table, and was admitted to the Second Table that night. His mother has never forgiven him.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is Dame Marrable’s protégé and her chapter’s buyer of Blanks, through Kale Dragoman and Master Quillon Barr. His house sits on the Board; he wants a committee seat, and has ordered a hundred and ten pounds of Garrick Tripe’s lead.

### WHAT HE CARRIES

- ◇ **A Second Table veil** — silk, with a silver fork.
- ◇ **Letters** — pleasant, signed, left in Thin barns for Wren Hollowell.
- ◇ **A place-list** — the cellar’s guests for Tablenight 641. One line is blank.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be at the table when Ummer stands up, with a knife in his hand. He fears his mother will stand up first. **Secret:** he has begun to hear her at night through the floor of his bedroom, asking for her husband’s heart. **Secret he does not know:** Marrable intends him for the blank line.

### TIES

- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — patron and intended host.
- ◇ **Wren Hollowell** — his quarry.
- ◇ **Mercy Sowerby** — paid to mistranslate his mother.
- ◇ **Garrick Tripe** — his weigher.

#### IN PLAY

He hires the PCs to deliver letters, to find Wren, or to fetch something from the Rim “for the cellar.” Hooks: his mother summons the PCs through Mercy; a Blank PC receives his invitation; his dray is found rooted outside Loin House, and the hill is closer. If nobody intervenes, he is served at the Second Table on Tablenight 642, beautifully.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He brought me his father’s heart, and he wasn’t even sorry. I knew then he’d go far.” — Dame Suet Marrable

“He leaves a letter and a cake. I burn the letter. I’m told the cake is excellent.” — Wren Hollowell

“His Lordship tips in platters and never looks at you. Like tipping a field.” — a Carrier of Loin House



# WOLF-WARDEN CRUST LEGGAT

*the Inventor of Wolves*

*“Tracks here, see. Big dog-wolf. Pack of six, I’d say. Took the Fitch girl from the headland.  
Write that down, son. Write it down neat.”*

– CRUST LEGGAT, STANDING IN AN EMPTY FURROW, TO HIS CLERK

| CRUST LEGGAT – WOLF-WARDEN OF LOW TILTH |                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4      |
| AGE & STATION                           | 63; Wolf-Warden of Low Tilth for thirty-eight years                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | Nightwarden (Board warden), Standing 2                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                  |
| SKILLS                                  | Deceive 4, Wayfaring 4, Search 3, Shooting 3, Craft 2, Endure 2, Instinct 2          |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (hide coat) · Fray 8                                   |
| ATTACKS                                 | crossbow +6 (4, Piercing, Slow)                                                      |
| GIFTS                                   | Iron Belly; Taste the Name                                                           |
| WANTS                                   | The Second Plate (Hard 14)                                                           |
| KNACKS                                  | Little Lies; Corpse-Road Walker                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | The Seeing (triggered by dusk: he sees wolves in the wheat)                          |
| CARRIES                                 | the Warden’s Foot; a crossbow; a ledger of reports; a wolf’s skull bought on the Rim |
| DREAD                                   | 0                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

A grizzled, red-faced, gravel-voiced man in a hide coat, with a crossbow he has never fired at a wolf and the cheerful certainty of a professional liar. He smells of pipe-smoke and gun-oil, though there are no guns, which is to say crossbow-grease. Lately his hands shake at dusk.

## THEIR STORY

He took the office from his uncle in 603, and with it the Warden’s Foot: a wolf’s paw carved in bone, made in 300 A.G., passed Warden to Warden, for pressing tracks into soft earth. Every Carving for thirty-eight years he has pressed tracks at the edge of each empty furrow and filed his report. In Carving 640 he found tracks he had not made. Big ones. Two-legged.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

His reports are the Board’s official account of the Reaping: wolves, so many taken, so many sighted. Everyone in Low Tilth knows they are lies, and the lies are a courtesy. He depends on that courtesy; it depends on him.

## WHAT HE CARRIES

- ♦ **The Warden’s Foot** — yellowed bone, worn smooth.
- ♦ **A ledger** — thirty-eight years of wolves.
- ♦ **A wolf’s skull** — bought on the Rim in 610 to show children; he talks to it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to retire before he is sure. **Secret:** the new tracks lead out of the far fields toward Sated, and the creature that makes them walks on its hind legs, like Sal Trotter’s herds; he has filed them as wolves. **Secret he does not know:** he is on Varn Sweetbread’s list, because his reports have started to read as if he believes them.

## TIES

- ♦ **Pell Hogget** — the honest count beside his false one; they never speak.
- ♦ **The Scarecrow** — filed annually as a wolf-den.
- ♦ **Varn Sweetbread** — his superior in all but name.
- ♦ **Sal Trotter** — he has followed her herd’s tracks and found them matching.

## IN PLAY

He hires the PCs to “hunt wolves.” Hooks: the tracks; a Board inspector wants proof of a wolf, and Crust needs a skin by Firstbite; Crust, drunk, confesses the Foot to a PC and begs them to throw it in the Gravy. If nobody intervenes, he follows the tracks at dusk in Carving 642 with his crossbow, and is listed as taken by wolves.

## SAID OF THEM

“Wolves, says Crust. Lovely wolves. My husband was a wolf’s dinner, officially.” — a widow of Kettle Furrow

“The wolf figures are wrong, and consistently so, and the Board prefers them.” — Pell Hogget

“Grandad says there’s no wolves. Then why’s he always so scared of them?” — Crust’s granddaughter

# WASHER NELL HASLET

## the Chairman's Hands

*“Lift there, sir. That’s it. There’s a shoot here wants pulling. Breathe out. Now, you were saying, sir? Kettle Furrow, three. Brakeley, five. I’m listening, sir. I’m always listening.”*

— NELL HASLET, AT THE DRAY, AT DAWN

| NELL HASLET – WASHER TO THE CHAIRMAN |                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Fatlands · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5        |
| AGE & STATION                        | 38; first Washer to Chairman Obb Tullow                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Seamer (Washer and dresser of folds), Standing 2 (Stitcher)                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                    |
| SKILLS                               | Labor 3, Search 3, Stitching 3, Endure 2, Feast 2, Reckoning 2, Stealth 2              |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                 |
| ATTACKS                              | shoot-shears +3 (2)                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                | Iron Belly; Taste the Name (she cannot help tasting the Chairman’s sweat)              |
| WANTS                                | The Second Plate (Hard 14)                                                             |
| KNACKS                               | Counting Habit; Silent Supper                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                              | shoot-shears; sponges and a bucket; a basket of the Chairman’s greens; a stub of chalk |
| DREAD                                | 0                                                                                      |

### WHO THEY ARE

A strong, quiet, square woman with red scrubbed forearms, a scarf over her hair, and the patient blankness of servants who see everything. She smells of lye and green sap.

### THEIR STORY

A Low Tilth farmer’s daughter from Kettle Furrow, she came to Sated at sixteen as a Washer and has cleaned the Chairman’s folds since 628. Pell Hogget is her mother’s cousin.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Twice a day she climbs onto the dray with sponges and shears, washes the Chairman’s folds and plucks his shoots. Tullow talks to her, because she is furniture. Lately, half-asleep, he murmurs the Reaping as he feels it through his roots, district by district, mouthful by mouthful.

### WHAT SHE CARRIES

- ◇ **Shoot-shears** — for the green.
- ◇ **A basket of greens** — the Chairman’s shoots, a Washer’s perquisite, sold in the Scale Rings as “Chairman’s cress.” She eats some herself.

- ◇ **A stub of chalk** — like her cousin’s.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

**Secret she keeps:** she memorises Tullow’s murmured figures and sends them to Pell Hogget, which is why the Long Count matches the Board’s own. **Secret she does not know:** the cress is rooting her; there are threads in her soles, and they point toward the dray.

### TIES

- ◇ **Chairman Obb Tullow** — her charge; he trusts her as he trusts a chair.
- ◇ **Pell Hogget** — her cousin and her cause.
- ◇ **Garrick Tripe** — pays her for gossip; she gives him little.
- ◇ **Pudding Hesk** — has asked her, kindly, how much the Chairman weighs today.

### IN PLAY

The PCs need someone close to the Chairman. Hooks: Nell needs a courier to Kettle Furrow; Tullow murmurs a PC’s name with the figures; Nell does not come down from the dray one evening, and is found asleep on it with her feet in the folds. If nobody intervenes,

she roots beside the Chairman by 643, and the Board agrees not to notice.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“Our Nell’s got a good post. She says the Chairman’s ever so polite.”  
— her mother, in Kettle Furrow

“She hears everything and says nothing. A paragon. Find out who she says nothing to.” — Varn Sweetbread

“Her figures, my figures. Same figures.” — Pell Hogget

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# WEBS OF THE FATLANDS

IN THE SOUTH, LOVE IS WANTING TO FEED  
SOMEONE, AND HATE IS WANTING TO EAT THEM, AND  
YOU'D BE SURPRISED HOW OFTEN IT'S BOTH.

[ A FATLAND PROVERB, AS WAKEMOTHER HESK TELLS IT ]

| CHARACTER       | WANTS FROM                        | FEARS                      | OWES                                     |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Sal Trotter     | Sweetbread: never to be told      | the lead steer's question  | Sweetbread a second wage's silence       |
| Wren Hollowell  | Marigold: a loft; anyone: the sea | the Gavage; her own hunger | Ottilie Crane nothing; Hennet everything |
| Garrick Tripe   | Tullock: to be let retire         | the second brass key       | Tullock his whole career                 |
| Lady Aspic      | Marrable: her body, set           | blandness                  | her teacher his ladle                    |
| Jem Crackle     | anyone: a worthy dish             | boredom                    | nobody, by design                        |
| Dunmow Fatt     | Lank: that he eat                 | the quiet in Lank's eyes   | Clemency's memory a full plate           |
| Marigold Chine  | Wren: to hear the silence         | the last verse             | the Thin a dry loft                      |
| Tobias Wether   | Sal: approval; Wren: emptiness    | the long dim room          | Sal his name                             |
| The Scarecrow   | the village: one blink            | nothing known              | Nell Hogget a smock                      |
| Ivo Stockpot    | an outsider: to know              | that they keep buying      | the garrisons an apology                 |
| Granny Cracknel | the Scarecrow: its hat            | the unborn teeth           | Pell a warning                           |
| Pudding Hesk    | Tullock: his body                 | her own greed              | the dead their silence                   |
| Callow Pudge    | the Thin: gratitude               | the ones who return        | Lank a door                              |
| Mercy Sowerby   | anyone: belief                    | her name in the turf       | Abner a reckoning                        |
| Chastain Loin   | Wren: her heart                   | his mother                 | his father a heart                       |
| Crust Leggat    | the Board: retirement             | the real tracks            | Pell the truth                           |
| Nell Haslet     | Pell: justice                     | the dray's pull            | Tullock a betrayal                       |

## THE THREE MOST EXPLOSIVE

**Garrick Tripe, Chairman Tullow and Jem Crackle.** The Chairman's seat was bought with sixty pounds of lead in 608, and the two men who know have kept each other's secret for thirty-three years. Tullow no longer needs Garrick; he needs a scandal that will void a third of the Board and leave him the only honest weight in the house, and a knife to tidy up after. Jem has been asked to be that knife and, separately, to kill Tullow himself, kindly, before the hill takes him. Pudding Hesk has been asked to cook the result of both. If the PCs warn any one of these four, the whole arrangement comes apart at once, in public, at the Weighing.

**Sal Trotter, Tobias Wether and the lead steer.** Sal culled her son for a debt by never looking back, and named a stranger after

him, and walks to market a beast with his plot-number on its flank. Tobias wants Sal's approval more than food. The lead steer hums her song a beat ahead of her. When the steer asks its question, Sal will turn around; when Tobias learns whose name he wears, he will go looking for the herd; and a man with an empty room inside him and a beast made of a culled boy will meet on the Drove Road at dusk.

**Dunmow Fatt, Sorrel Fatt and Callow Pudge.** The gentlest Bailiff in Sated does not know his daughter is Thin. The gentlest feeder in the Gavage leaves one door unbarred each Lack. Corder Lank's cells have marked Ruddell Hollowell for this year's door, and Sorrel is the messenger. If Sorrel is caught, her father takes her to the chair, and Callow feeds her, and the door Callow leaves open will be the one Dunmow is standing in.

# USING THE FATLANDS' PEOPLE

The people of the south come to the party; they knock, they bring a dish, they ask after your health and your weight. When the party is lodged anywhere in the Fatlands and someone knocks, roll a d20.

| D20 | WHO'S AT THE DOOR?           | WHY                                                          |
|-----|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Sal Trotter                  | needs two hands for a drive; won't say why the last two quit |
| 2   | Wren Hollowell               | hiding from Bailiffs; asks for nothing but the cellar        |
| 3   | Garrick Tripe                | wants a parcel carried out of Sated; it is a book            |
| 4   | a footman of Lady Aspic      | a dinner invitation; one guest will not leave                |
| 5   | Jem Crackle                  | "Kitchen's free, if you want to use it, sir"                 |
| 6   | Dunmow Fatt                  | a plate inspection; someone left a crust                     |
| 7   | Marigold Chine               | pruning starts tomorrow; she needs ears                      |
| 8   | Tobias Wether                | fleeing Gladbelly; lays an extra place at your table         |
| 9   | nobody                       | a field-smock on the step, folded, with a plot-number        |
| 10  | Ivo Stockpot's courier       | a sealed list addressed to nobody                            |
| 11  | Granny Cracknel              | a biting loaf for your sill; she stares at one PC's smile    |
| 12  | Pudding Hesk                 | a wake tomorrow; the family asked for the strangers          |
| 13  | Callow Pudge                 | wants a released prisoner found, to ask if he's happy        |
| 14  | Mercy Sowerby                | a Dowager asked for one PC by name                           |
| 15  | Lord Chastain Loin's Carrier | a letter, a cake, and a question about Blanks                |
| 16  | Crust Leggat                 | hiring wolf-hunters; shows tracks with no claws              |
| 17  | Nell Haslet                  | a message for Kettle Furrow, memorised, not written          |
| 18  | a Cullmaster's clerk         | reading a dusk-list; one name is a PC's ally                 |
| 19  | the lead steer of Sal's herd | standing on two legs, humming; it knocks politely            |
| 20  | a place card on the mat      | a PC's name, a fine hand; the table is already laid          |



CHAPTER 3

# BRINEHOLLOW

*The Country That Chases Its Water*



*Rope before bread. Bucket before rope. Name before bucket. And before your name, child,  
the cough.*

– MILE TWELVE SKIPPING RHYME, SUNG IN THE ORDER THINGS ARE TAUGHT

*We are not a people who lost the sea. We are a people the sea is still deciding about.*

– ILSE MARL, IN THE MARGIN OF HER ELEVENTH LOW-WATER BOOK

*A Day on the Mile, as told by Gaff Lugg, timber-hauler, Mile Thirteen, to the Wreckwives' table at the Lantern, Carving 641. Taken down by the Keeper of Names because he asked her to. He said somebody ought to have it written, the ordinary way it goes, before it stops being ordinary.*

*The bell wakes you before your chest does, if Finn Undertow is in a good mood. Lately he isn't. Lately the chest wakes you first, a fist of cold behind the breastbone, and you come up out of sleep already gargling, and the rope round your waist pulls you back down on the pallet like a dog on a lead, and for one heartbeat every single morning you forget why you're tied and you fight it. Then you remember. Then you lie still and taste the salt and wait for the bell to tell you you're allowed to be what you are.*

*We sleep five on the floor, me and Hanne and her two and my brother's girl, lashed to the iron ring Hanne's grandfather set in the joist. You undo yourself from the outside in. Children last. You check the knots before you untie them, every knot, even though your hands are numb and the cough is coming, because if a knot's been worked loose in the night you want to know whose fingers did it. This morning they were all good. You say a little thing when they're all good. Hold the line. Nobody taught me to say it. Everybody says it.*

*Then the bucket. Mine's tin, dented, Hanne's mother's before it was mine. You kneel. You put your forehead on the rim. You let it come. It comes up cold and it tastes of every morning of your life, and there's a thread of weed in it today, and a flea that jumps off my lip onto the floorboard and is gone between the planks down sixty feet to the Under. Hanne bails beside me. The children bail across from us. The whole Mile is doing it, the whole nineteen miles of it, a noise like surf if surf was made of people. Then it's done, and you wipe your mouth, and you look in the bucket. You always look. You don't say you're looking. You tip it toward the window, toward the grey, and you look at the color. Clear. Mine's clear. Hanne's is clear. The little one's has a green to it I don't like, and Hanne sees me see it, and she tips it into the gutter before I can look twice, and the gutter carries it west.*

*Then the count. Mouth to the plank. Dorrit. Wenna. Old Mags. Josiah. And they answer, wet, one after the other, and you feel your shoulders come down out of your ears. Old Mags answers late. Everyone holds their breath. Then she says I'm here, I was on the pot, mind your business, and the whole wall laughs. That's a good morning on Mile Thirteen. You get maybe one in three.*

*Then bread, which is seaweed bread, which is grey, and a cup of sweet water if you've got the bail-token, which I had, because I bailed Mags's husband last week when his arm was broke. Salt with everything. You stop tasting it. My brother says inlanders can taste it in our sweat from across a road.*

*Then the walk. Thirteen to Nineteen is six miles of plank. You walk west to work, everybody does, the whole Mile flows west in the morning like water down a gutter, and you try not to think about that. Carts. Gulls. The chandlers rolling up their shutters on Mile Fifteen. The smell of the rope-sheds. On Mile Sixteen the Wringer's lot are hanging a new one by the ankles in the fish-cellar window, and the boy's face is purple and he's smiling, and you don't look. On Mile Seventeen the pier starts to go raw, new wood, pale as a peeled finger, and you can smell the Uncovered through the gaps in the boards: low tide, every hour of every day, low tide that never turns.*

*Nineteen is where the work is. Harbormistress Drowle's barges come in loaded with timber from the Cradlewrack border, and we haul it, and the pile-drivers go, thud, thud, and the new piling goes down into the mud sixty feet and further, and there's always a moment when it drops further than it should, all at once, as if something below took hold of it and tugged, and the whole crew goes quiet. Then the Harbormistress shouts a number and we go on.*

*At midday somebody stops working and stands at the end-rail facing west and won't answer. Today it was Peder Swell. We took him by the arms and walked him back to the timber stack and sat him down and gave him water and he said I'm all right, I'm all right, I just wanted to see, and everyone said course you did, and nobody let go of his sleeve for the rest of the shift.*

*The walk home is east. Uphill, it feels like, though the Mile is flat as a plank. Everyone's slower going home. At dusk Finn rings and the whole Mile bends over its buckets again and you hear it rolling toward you from the Headland end, cough after cough, house after house, like a wave coming in. Like the tide used to.*

*Then the rope. Then the knots. You tie your own knot. You tie your neighbor's knot, and they tie yours, and you each check the other's, and you each say hold the line, and you lie down facing east because nobody faces west, not if they love their family.*

*And you lie there and listen to the floor. Sixty feet down, under the Mile, there's water moving in the dark where there oughtn't to be any. Twice a day. Every day. You lie there and*

*you listen to it come up and go out again, and you count your people breathing, and some nights, God of the deep forgive me, I lie there and I think: it's warmer down there. It sounds warmer.*

*That's a day. That's all of it. I don't know why I wanted it written down. Hanne says it's because when it stops being ordinary nobody will believe it ever was.*

Brinehollow is a land of chores. That is the first thing a Carver should understand about it. In Sallowreach the horror is endlessness, and in the Fatlands it is appetite. In Brinehollow it is maintenance. Twice a day, every day, for six centuries, every soul on the coast has knelt and coughed the god up into a bucket, and every night every soul has been tied down by someone who loves them. The horror lives in the routine, and in the morning the routine fails.

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

*Long pier, short life.*

— MILE PROVERB

### LOWMARK, MILE BY MILE

Lowmark is a road pretending to be a city. Its old heart stands on the Headland, the original shore, a crown of grey stone and slate roofs above a beach that has not seen a wave in a century. From the Headland the Mile runs west across the dry seabed for nineteen miles on tarred pilings sixty feet high: a single wooden avenue, forty to eighty feet wide, with houses built out over its edges on brackets and stilts, so that from below it looks like the spine of a great fish with its ribs hanging down. Every mile is marked by an iron post with a number and a bell. Every mile is a parish with its own Bailers' Warden, its own tide-post and its own grievances against the miles on either side.

Nobody in Lowmark asks where you live. They ask what mile you are, and they know from the answer how much you earn, how you smell and how likely you are to be Called by Tablenight.

#### THE HEADLAND

The old city. Grey stone, steep lanes, slate roofs furred with salt, and the four great buildings of the state facing one another across Tidepost Square: the Admiralty House, the Sounding Hall, the Salt Assay's sealed and half-empty offices, and the vast low bulk of Fathomhouse, which goes further down than it goes up. Officers, clerks, priests and the families of the Lung-line cadets live here in tall narrow houses whose cellars are tiled to the ceiling in white glaze, so the indoor tide leaves no stain. The Headland smells of wet stone, coal smoke and the green, mineral breath that rises from the gratings of Fathomhouse. It sounds of bells: the Admiralty's watch bells, the

tide bell in Finn Undertow's tower, and the dull bong of the Sounding Hall's lie-bell, which rings when the pool rises.

The Headland trades in orders, appointments and permits. Every salvage licence, every pier contract and every Rim Road carting bond is stamped here, in wet wax. Its custom is the **Dusk Muster**: at the evening bell, every household with an officer in it stands on its front step in dress uniform and bails in unison, facing east toward the Admiralty flag. Its danger is the gratings. The Fathomhouse drains vent into the square, and on pressure days the air above them thickens until passers-by drop where they stand with blood at the ears. Twice in living memory a child has been found curled asleep on a grating at dawn, perfectly unhurt, speaking in a voice an octave too low.

**PURSER-CLERK ALDO PENWARDEN, KEEPER OF THE SALVAGE LICENCE ROLLS** Threat 3 (Clause, Reckoning) · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (pen-knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. He sells licences for ground that does not yet exist, the next mile of Uncovered, and he has never once been wrong about where the water will fall.

#### MILE ONE: THE GILT MILE

The first mile west of the Headland is the oldest pier and the richest street in the country. Its houses are four storeys of painted timber with copper gutters, glass bow-windows (all on the east side) and private bail-rooms tiled in Cradlewrack red. Commodores, successful salvage-brokers, Rim Road factors and the Salt Assay's surviving senior clerks live here. It smells of beeswax, cedar shavings and good tobacco. Gilt Mile households keep **window-wardens**, servants whose only duty is to stand between the family and the

west-facing glass at dusk, drawing curtains and gently turning faces away.

The trade is credit. The Gilt Mile lends to every other mile, against pier-rights and against the future value of salvage that has not yet been uncovered. The danger is quieter than elsewhere: the rich are Called less often because they are anchored better, with silk-and-wire ropes and private Netwatch men on retainer, but when they go they go in numbers. Whole households have walked together, hand in hand, servants and all, down the Gilt Mile's ornamental stairs and away across the salt.

**MADAM ORLA CUSHION, SALVAGE-BROKER AND MONEYLENDER** Threat 4 (Haggle, Reckoning) · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (dagger 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. She holds mortgages on two-thirds of Mile Fourteen, and she has a standing order to be told, by the Bailers' Warden, the color of every debtor's water.

#### MILES TWO TO FOUR: THE ROPEWALK AND THE CHANDLERS' REACH

Here the Mile is a workshop. The **Ropewalk** of Ottoline Hawse runs a quarter-mile along the pier's north edge in a long, low, tar-black shed where men and women walk backward all day, spinning hemp from bundles at their waists, while wheel-boys turn the hooks. The air is brown with hemp-dust and the reek of hot pine tar from the tarring-house, and the noise is the creak of the wheels and the walkers' chant, which keeps the twist even. Across the street the chandlers sell everything a household needs to stay ashore: rope, buckets, iron anchor-rings, lead bed-weights, oilcloth, lamp oil, salted gull, Saltwick salt, Oathen iron shackles for those who can afford them, and Cradlewrack caulks, stitched into coat linings, which are said to stop the Calling and do not.

The custom here is the **knot-proof**. No rope leaves the Ropewalk without a proving: a length is knotted by the buyer and hung from the shed's beam with a Ropewalk apprentice dangling from it, while the buyer's family watches. The danger is fire. The tar-house has gone up four times, and in a city of tarred wood on tarred stilts, a fire on Mile Three could take nineteen miles of homes. Smoking on the Ropewalk is a flogging offence.

**JORY SPINWELL, OLDEST ROPE-WALKER ON THE SHED FLOOR, WHO WALKS BACKWARD SO WELL HE CAN NO LONGER WALK FORWARD WITHOUT FALLING** Threat 2 (Labor, Craft) · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. He has spun the rope for every royal wedding of the House of Vasht since 589, and he says three of the brides' ropes were spun to a length he was told to keep secret.

#### MILES FIVE AND SIX: THE CHAPEL REACH

The Mile's religious quarter, crowded with chapels of the three doctrines built shoulder to shoulder over the pier's edge, each with a west door bricked up and a bell. Debt chapels of the Theft, where people come to confess what their great-grandparents ate; Lending chapels of the Gift, sweet with candle-smoke, where the Tenanted

are blessed at the door; and in the cellars and back rooms, the illegal Deepening congregations, whose lanterns are hung in the windows on procession nights as a signal. The Reach smells of incense, wet wool and candle-fat, and it sounds of hymns sung over the slap of the indoor tide in the chapel crypts.

Its trade is grief: rope funerals, tide-post carving, the hire of mourners and the sale of **name-ropes**, short braided cords with the name of a Called relative woven in, worn at the wrist. Its custom is the **open hour**: from midnight to the first bell, every chapel door on the Reach stands open, and anyone who feels the pull may come in, be tied to a pew by a priest, and sit out the worst of the night in company. Its danger is that the Deepening's people sit in the pews too, and talk softly to the ones who are tied.

**BROTHER HOLLIS TARRANT, LENDING PRIEST OF THE CHAPEL OF THE RETURNED, WHO HAS BLESSED FOUR HUNDRED TENANTED AT HIS DOOR** Threat 3 (Rites, Persuade) · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. His own mother came back in 619. He has never once let her bless him in return.

#### MILE SEVEN: HOOKSIDE

The Netwatch barracks: a long, grim block of timber built across the whole width of the pier, so that the Mile passes through it by a tunnel, and every traveller walking west at night must pass under the eyes of the watch. Hookside is all bunk-rooms, net-lofts, lantern-stores and the long cold **Return Room**, where the Called who have been dragged home are tied to benches until the dawn bail and collected by their families, or not. It smells of tarred net, lamp oil, sweat and vomited brine. At night it sounds of boots, rattles and, from the Return Room, a low continuous pleading.

Its trade is rescue, paid in Netwatch tallies. Its custom is the **Hook-Toll**: anyone passing west through the Hookside tunnel between dusk and dawn must stop, say their name and mile, and show the Watch their bucket. A traveller with no bucket is assumed to be going somewhere they will not need one, and is detained. Its danger is that the Netwatch is exhausted, short-handed and paid by the head, and the Return Room's tally does not distinguish between the rescued and the recovered.

Nerys Colm lives here, in her sealed room above the net-loft. Everyone on Mile Seven knows which window, and nobody stands under it.

**WATCH-SERGEANT DUNNO BREAKWATER, KEEPER OF THE RETURN ROOM** Threat 3 (Intimidate, Endure) · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. He has tied eleven thousand people to benches, and the only one he remembers is the first, a girl who thanked him.

#### MILES EIGHT TO ELEVEN: THE MIDDLE MILE

Ordinary Lowmark. Ropery Row, Bucket Lane, the Lantern tavern on Mile Nine, cooperages, net-menders, bakeries of seaweed bread, schoolrooms where children learn bailing songs before letters. Two-

storey houses, families of six or eight, a lodger in the loft, the household's anchoring ring in the floor of the main room. The Middle Mile smells of bread, bail-water, tar and wet dog. It sounds of the morning count most of all, because here the walls are thinnest and the count is a real conversation: names, answers, gossip, complaints, and on bad mornings the silence.

Its trade is everything small. Its custom is the **plank-ear**: in every party wall there is a knot or a worn place, sometimes carved into the shape of an ear, where the count is called. Families are buried, in a sense, by the plank-ear: when a whole household goes, the neighbors cut the ear out of the wall and nail it to the tide-post. Its danger is the knife. The Middle Mile has the most cut ropes in Lowmark, because here families are close enough to love one another past bearing and poor enough to have no servant to sit up with the one who pleads.

Esk Penhallow sits on his own front step on Mile Eight, every night, roped to the rail.

**WIDOW COYLE TAMSIN, KEEPER OF NAMES FOR THE MIDDLE MILE** Threat 3 (Persuade, Search) · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. She has the name of every Tenanted spouse between Mile Eight and Eleven written in a book bound in her own husband's oilskin, and she reads it over each Tablenight to see whether she still believes in any of them.

#### MILES TWELVE TO SIXTEEN: THE LASHINGS

The slum. Here the houses are shacks hung from the pier on chains and ropes, three or four deep over the edge, so that the poorest live furthest out, swaying sixty feet above the dark. Whole families sleep lashed in a line to a single ring, like a boat's crew in a storm. There is no glass, only oiled paper and canvas, and every window faces whichever way the shack swung when it was hung. The Lashings smell of bail-water, which is poured from the windows rather than the gutters, and of fish-gut, tar smoke and the sweet rot of the shellfish middens. They sound of children, rope creaking and arguments.

The trade is labour: cannery work, pier-hauling, gull-netting, rag-picking, the digging of Uncovered shellfish, and bail-water sold by the bucket to Dry Jonah's buyers at half a crumb a pint. The custom is **the chain**: neighbors in the Lashings link their shacks' anchoring rings with a common chain that runs the whole length of a row, so that if one walks, the whole row wakes, tugged. The dangers are many. Shacks fall. Ropes rot. The Purgation's Wringer runs his mangle in a fish-cellar on Mile Fifteen. And on Calling nights the Lashings empty in dozens, roped families walking west together, still lashed, dragging their own beds behind them across the planks.

**MAGS NETHERBY, BAILERS' WARDEN OF MILE FOURTEEN, WHO KNOWS EVERY ROPE IN HER PARISH BY ITS SMELL** Threat 3 (Instinct, Intimidate) · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (bucket-shield bash 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Nine

ropes were cut on her street in nine nights last Carving; she has her own theory, and it involves the Drowned Bench.

#### MILES SEVENTEEN AND EIGHTEEN: THE RAW MILE

The newest pier, still pale and splintered. Few houses yet: timber yards, pile-driver sheds, workers' bunkhouses, Kessa Drowle's survey office (a single room on stilts above the stilts, reached by ladder) and the barge-landings where timber comes in from the Cradlewrack border by cart along the old shore road. The Raw Mile smells of fresh-sawn pine, hot pitch and the open Uncovered breathing through the gaps in the planks. It sounds of hammers, the thud of the drivers and the foremen calling depths.

The trade is the Chase itself: building the next mile. The custom is the **first nail**: when a new section of pier is begun, a worker who has lost someone to the Calling drives the first nail and speaks the name of the lost, so the pier is built toward them. Its danger is the gap. The Raw Mile has no rails in places, and men and women walking home at dusk at the Appetite stop at the edge, and look down, and step.

**FOREMAN BASTIAN GUTTER, DRIVER-BOSS OF THE RAW MILE CREWS** Threat 3 (Labor, Craft) · Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (maul 5) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. He has started measuring how far each new piling sinks after the drivers stop, and he keeps the figures in his boot.

#### MILE NINETEEN: HARBOR END

The end of the world. A ring of piers around a basin of grey water, the only real sea Lowmark can still touch, though its edge creeps a few yards further every month. A licensed fish-market, a customs house where the Rim Road Company still collects port tolls, Dagna Hull's iron slip where the *Follow* lies in its cradle, a Netwatch outpost and a tavern called the Last Rail. The end of the pier is a broad platform with a single iron rail along its western edge, worn bright by hands. Harbor End smells of real sea and of what the licensed boats bring back. It sounds of gulls, surf and, at night, the faint sounds carried in across the water from the far deep, which the boatmen call **the Swallowing**.

The trade is fish, or what passes for it now: the licensed boats come back with eyeless things, with fish whose ribs show through translucent flanks, with great slow eels that have to be killed three times. The custom is **the Rail**: those who have lost someone to the Calling come to Harbor End once a year and stand with both hands on the iron rail at dusk and say the lost one's name to the sea. The danger is the Rail itself. Every year a few of those who come to say the name are still standing at the rail when the Netwatch makes its last round, and do not answer, and must be pried off it finger by finger.

**MOTHER BRISA COLDWELL, LANDLADY OF THE LAST RAIL, WHO KEEPS A BUCKET UNDER THE BAR FOR EVERY REGULAR WHO WALKED** Threat 2 (Haggle,



Instinct) · Flesh 11 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (club 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0.  
There are sixty-one buckets. Some mornings one of them is wet.

### THE UNDERPIER

Sixty feet below the Mile, on the old seabed, in the permanent twilight under the planks, lives a city nobody counts. The Underpier runs the whole nineteen miles: a lattice of pilings like a drowned forest, hung with the drippings of everything above. Bail-water rains down from the Lashings. Refuse falls. Bodies fall. The mud is black and soft and wet, and twice a day, though no sea reaches it, it floods ankle-deep with cold clear water that rises from beneath and drains away again, leaving kelp and crabs. People live down here: the debt-runaways, the unlicensed, the Purgation's outcasts, the families of the Called who could not bear the count, a few of the Tenanted whose families would not have them back, and the **Pickers**, who live on what the Mile drops.

The Underpier smells of rot, wet timber, excrement and the deep. It sounds of dripping, always, and of the pilings groaning, and at night of a soft, communal humming from the Tenanted camps between Miles Ten and Eleven. Its trade is salvage of the Mile's waste, and a busy black market in cut ropes, stolen buckets and the rings and buttons of the Called, which the indoor tide brings up in the mud. Its custom is **the dropped name**: when someone on the Mile above is Called, an Underpier child goes and stands beneath their house at the next tide and says the name, because the Under believes the lost hear best from below. Its dangers are the falling, the cold and the things that come up through the mud on the flood: crabs too large and too soft, and once, in 638, a hand, very long and grey, that groped along three miles of the Under at dawn and drew back down into the seabed as the water fell.

**PICKER-QUEEN DULSE ABERNATHY, WHO RULES THE UNDER BETWEEN MILES TWELVE AND SIXTEEN FROM A WRECK'S UPTURNED HULL** Threat 3 (Filch, Intimidate) · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (gaff 3, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. She buys every cut rope that falls, and she has a cellar full of them sorted by the angle of the cut.

### RUNNING THE MILE

Lowmark is one long street, and that is its gift to the Carver. Everything happens in sequence. Anyone travelling from the Headland to Harbor End passes through every district in order, and the walk takes most of a day: about six hours on foot, two by Mile-cart. Use the walk. Let the party pass a rope funeral on the Chapel Reach, be stopped at the Hookside tunnel, hear the Lashings' chain rattle as somebody tugs, smell the Raw Mile's pitch. Let the westward journey feel like a descent and the eastward one like a climb, though the Mile is flat. Brinehollowers walk west to work and east to sleep, and they feel the difference in their chests.

## BEYOND THE MILE

The rest of Brinehollow is a ribbon of dry shore three hundred miles long, a strip of salt-grass and grey farmland behind it, and the Uncovered in front, widening every year. The old fishing towns stand in a line along the former waterline like teeth along a jaw, most of them several miles from any sea, most of them half-empty. Each has followed the water in its own way, or refused to.

### SALTWICK

The country's market town, thirty miles inland on the Rim Road spur, where the coast does its buying and selling with the rest of the Table. Low stone houses, a great covered market, a Company waystation and a horse fair. Saltwick's cellars flood twice a day like every cellar in the land, and two centuries ago the townsfolk gave up fighting them and turned them into salt-pans. Every house in Saltwick gathers its own indoor tide in shallow lead trays, dries it on racks by the kitchen fire, and sells the salt. The whole town smells of the sea, though the sea is fifty miles off. Its sound is the scrape of salt-rakes, the market crier and the long horns of the Rim Road carters coming down from the Lowmark Spur.

The trade is Saltwick salt, salvage from the Uncovered, Fatlands meat in brine coming up, and bail-water in green glass going east in Dry Jonah's wagons. The custom is the **salt-gift**: a Saltwick family gives a twist of its own cellar-salt to every guest, and the guest must eat a pinch at once. The danger is the salt itself. Outsiders who eat too much of it begin to dream of drowning, and some begin to bail, and the Company's waystation keeps a quiet list of carters who came down for one season and never left.

**REEVE HETTIE SALTMARSH, COMPANY WAYSTATION-MISTRESS AT SALTWICK** Threat 3 (Haggle, Search) · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. She has noticed that the carters who stay are always the ones who ate the salt-gift with pleasure, and she has stopped eating it.

### KEELROW PROP TOWN

Three miles south of the Headland, beneath the four hundred propped warships of the Dry Fleet, stands a town of tents, sheds and lean-tos built among the props, where the sailors' families have lived since 588. Children grow up in the shadow of hulls, and can name every ship by the shape of its keel above their heads. Keelrow smells of tar, laundry, cooking smoke and barnacle-scrapings, because the High Admiral's weekly inspection orders the hulls scraped of barnacles that are not there, and the scrapers scrape anyway, and the scraped wood is gathered for kindling. It sounds of bosuns' pipes, drills and the wind in four hundred sets of rigging, a vast, aimless creak like a forest of masts complaining.

The trade is the fleet's pay, and the camp-followers who live on it: laundresses, cooks, cobblers, chaplains and gin-sellers. The custom is the **launching**: when a child of Keelrow comes of age, the family hauls them up to the deck of their father's or mother's ship and holds them over the rail, facing the salt flats, and lets go, and the

child drops into a net the crew holds below. They call it learning to fall in. The danger is the props. They rot. In 633 the *Constant* came off her cradle in a gale and lay down on forty tents.

**BOSUN KETTLE MARROW OF THE UNWAVERING, WHO HAS DRILLED THE SAME GUN CREW EVERY MORNING FOR THIRTY-ONE YEARS ON A SHIP THAT HAS NEVER FIRED** Threat 3 (Intimidate, Labor) · Flesh 14 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (cutlass 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. He keeps the ship's log meticulously, and every entry for thirty-one years reads "Wind light. Sea absent. All hands present."

## SLABSIDE

The fishing village above Longslab, the beach of the Beaching, two hours' walk north of the Headland. It is the oldest settlement on the coast and the least changed: grey cottages roofed with turf, all their doors facing inland, all their west walls blind. The ground of Longslab is always wet, and the wet creeps into Slabside's lanes: puddles that do not dry, moss on the doorsteps, salt-rime on the washing. Slabside smells of the deep, the smell the survivors described, a tide pool sealed for a thousand years. It sounds of nothing much. The people speak softly and seldom, and the gulls will not land.

The trade is pilgrimage: Deepening faithful who come to lie face-down on the stones and listen, Gift-doctrine families who come to pray where the god gave itself, and the morbid. Slabside sells them lodging, rope, and pebbles from the beach, which are always damp. The custom is **the listening**: once in their lives, every Slabside child is taken down to Longslab at the turn of the tide and laid face-down on the stones for a full hour by their grandparents, and asked afterward what they heard. The answers are written in the village book. The book is very old. The answers have changed. The danger is that the beach is breathing harder each year, and the middens beneath it are shifting, and last Carving a fisherman's cottage on the edge of Slabside sank two feet in a night, level, as though something had taken a breath underneath it.

**GRANDAM WEIR SOLLIS, KEEPER OF THE SLABSIDE LISTENING BOOK** Threat 2 (Lore, Instinct) · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack — · Armor 0 · Dread 0. For four hundred years the children said they heard the sea. For the last eleven, every child has said they heard someone counting.

## BASKETFOOT

The village at the foot of the Hanging Abbey, forty miles north of Lowmark, among the dry white boulders that were once the sea floor. A few dozen stone huts, a hostel for pilgrims, a winch-house and the great baskets in which food, water and letters are hauled up four hundred feet to the monks, and in which their waste comes down. Basketfoot smells of boiled oats, rust and the cliff's own runoff, which comes down at dawn and dusk in sheets when the thousand Anchorites bail. It sounds of the winches, the creak of the

chains above and, at night, the monks' prayers, which drift down like the noise of a distant crowd.

The trade is supplying the Abbey, and taking in those who come to climb it. The custom is **the basket-letter**: anyone may send a letter up to a monk in the food basket, and the monk must read it before he eats. Most letters are from wives and mothers. The danger is falling: things from the cliff, and people. Each year a few chains fail or are worked loose, and what comes down is gathered by the villagers in a long cart and buried, face-down, in the boulder field, with its collar still on.

**WINCHMASTER COBB FENNICK, WHO HAS HAULED EVERY BASKET FOR TWENTY-SIX YEARS** Threat 3 (Labor, Endure) · Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (winch-bar 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. He reads every basket-letter before it goes up, and once a year he writes one himself, to Father Ebb, unsigned.

## GULLCRY

The village at Gullcry Strand, north of Lowmark, where the Deepening's shell road begins. Officially a fishing hamlet. In practice it is the Deepening's country: a straggle of whitewashed cottages with lantern-hooks on every doorpost, shell-paths, and a chapel to nobody with its west door wide open. The faithful who live here sleep unanchored, as an act of devotion, and the village is quieter each Carving. Gullcry smells of lamp oil and crushed shell, which is ground constantly in hand-mills for the road. It sounds of singing, softly, at all hours.

The trade is lanterns, oil, shell and the hospitality of procession nights, when thousands come. The custom is the **open bed**: every bed in Gullcry has its ropes cut and hung over the headboard, as a sign that the sleeper is ready. The danger is the welcome itself. Visitors are fed, sheltered and loved in Gullcry, and the Low Songs are sung to them as they fall asleep, and many visitors who came to fetch a son or daughter home have instead been seen in procession with a lantern, a month later, smiling.

**WADER LINNET SHORE, GULLCRY'S INNKEEPER AND LANTERN-BEARER OF THE DEEPENING** Threat 3 (Persuade, Rites) · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. She has fed every pursuing parent who came to Gullcry since 619, and she remembers which ones went home.

## WEIRHOLM

The farm country, forty to sixty miles inland in the low hills toward the Rim, where Brinehollow grows its barley, kale and sheep. Weirholm is a scatter of stone farmsteads and a market cross. The sea has never been in sight of it, and yet every cellar in Weirholm floods twice a day like every cellar on the coast, and the farm children bail like fisher children. Weirholm smells of sheep, peat smoke and, faintly, inexplicably, the sea. It sounds of sheep, dogs and the wind in the hedges.

Weirholm trades food to the coast: barley for seaweed bread, mutton, cheese, and above all **sweet water** from its springs, carted

down to the Headland cisterns in sealed casks under Admiralty guard. Without Weirholm the coast would have nothing to drink but rain, and the rain is salt. The custom is **the west room**: every farmhouse has one room with a west window, kept empty, swept and locked, where a family member at the Appetite is shut at dusk with the window shuttered, to stand at it if they must. The danger is distance. When a Weirholm farmer is Called, they walk sixty miles west across country, through fields and hedges and rivers, over two or three days, and the farms they pass leave their gates open, because it is very bad luck to stop the Called on your land.

**DAME YSOLT HAGGARD, THE ADMIRALTY'S WATER-WARDEN OF WEIRHOLM, WHO SEALS THE SPRING CASKS** Threat 3 (Clause, Intimidate) · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. Two of her springs have begun to taste of salt. She has reported neither.

### SKERROW

The northernmost town of the coast, near the Cradlewrack border, built on a red-stone headland where the cliffs of Brinehollow begin to turn into the clay highlands. It is a town of quarrymen and

wreckers, hard, closed and suspicious, and it buys more Cradlewrack cauls than all the rest of the coast together. Skerrow smells of wet red stone, smoke and fish-oil. It sounds of the quarry hammers and the bell of its single chapel, which rings a different tide from Lowmark's, because Skerrow's bellman refused Finn Undertow's change and still rings the sea's tide, as his fathers did.

The custom is the **caul-coat**: every Skerrow child is sewn into a coat with a Cradlewrack caul in the lining at birth, and the coat is let out every year and never taken off. The danger is that the cauls arriving from the highlands are warm now when they are packed, and warmer when they arrive. Last Grace three Skerrow children woke with their coats grown fast to their backs, the caul knitted into the skin between the shoulders. They are well. They do not bail any more. Nobody in Skerrow is sure what to make of that.

**BELLMAN ARNO SKERROW, WHO WILL NOT RING THE BODY'S TIDE** Threat 2 (Labor, Resolve) · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. His town bails out of step with the rest of the country, and he says that when the moment comes, Skerrow will be the town that is still coughing.

# ▼ROADS AND WAYS

*The Mile goes one way. Everything else goes round.*

– MILE-CARTER'S SAYING

Brinehollow has two kinds of road: those that run along the coast, north and south, and those that run west, out onto the Uncovered. The first kind is old, slow and safe. The second is new every year and safe never.

**The Mile.** Lowmark's one street is its own road. Foot traffic flows west in the morning and east at dusk; carts pulled by men or by stunted coast ponies carry goods in both directions, keeping to the north side going out and the south side coming in by Admiralty order. A **Mile-cart**, a light two-wheeled barrow with a seat, can be hired at any mile-post for a crumb a mile, with a runner between the shafts. After dark no cart may go west of Mile Seven without a Netwatch pass.

**The Shell Road.** The Deepening's nine-mile road of crushed white shell from Gullcry Strand straight out across the Uncovered, marked by lantern-posts every hundred paces. It is well-made, easy to follow and, by day, perfectly safe. By night, on procession nights, it is lit end to end, and walking it is an act of faith whether or not you mean it to be.

**The Salvage Tracks.** Out on the Uncovered there are no roads, only tracks: lines of marker-stakes hammered in by salvage crews, cairns of ballast-stones, rope-lines strung between wrecks across the soft places. Each crew keeps its own tracks secret. The mud changes with every flood of the indoor tide that seeps up from below, and a track that was firm last month may now go into a sinkhole. Travel on the Uncovered without a pilot is legal and is the commonest way to die in Brinehollow that does not involve the Calling.

| ROUTE                                    | DISTANCE  | DAYS ON FOOT     | DANGERS                                                | NOTES                             |
|------------------------------------------|-----------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Headland to Harbor End (the Mile)        | 19 miles  | 1 (6 hours)      | gaps in the Raw Mile, Hookside tolls, Lashings thieves | Mile-cart 2 hours, 2 lacks        |
| Lowmark to Saltwick (the Spur)           | 30 miles  | 1½               | Company tolls, Saltwick salt-sickness                  | patrolled; Company coach daily    |
| Saltwick to Lowmark Spur (Rim)           | 25 miles  | 1                | wardens checking for the pull                          | the way out of the country        |
| Lowmark to Slabside                      | 6 miles   | ½                | Longslab's breath, pilgrims                            | turn back if the stones are warm  |
| Lowmark to Basketfoot (Shore Road)       | 40 miles  | 2                | falling chains, Gullcry's welcome                      | stop at Gullcry only by day       |
| Lowmark to Skerrow (Shore Road)          | 140 miles | 7                | wreckers, timber-train bandits                         | the Chase's timber comes this way |
| Lowmark to Brackmouth (Shore Road)       | 160 miles | 8                | the dry estuaries, march smugglers                     | Fatlands carters, hot food        |
| Lowmark to Weirholm                      | 50 miles  | 2½               | the Called walking the other way                       | open the gates you pass           |
| Gullcry to the last lantern (Shell Road) | 9 miles   | ½                | the procession, the welcome                            | safe by day; never by night       |
| Headland to the Wreck Orchard            | 8 miles   | 1 by pilot       | sinkholes, ribbed things                               | Hask Tarn charges 6 lacks         |
| Harbor End to the Trench edge            | 30 miles  | 3                | soft ground, the Swallowing, lights                    | few go; fewer return              |
| Wreck Orchard to Lobbett's Drop          | unknown   | 3 (says Lobbett) | three crews lost                                       | no map exists that sells          |



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## CROSSING THE UNCOVERED

Each day of travel on the Uncovered, one character rolls **Lung + Wayfaring**: Hard (14) near the old shore, Grim (18) past the Wreck Orchard, Dire (22) beyond Harbor End's longitude. A pilot such as Hask Tarn makes the roll for the party at +4. On a failure, roll on the Uncovered encounters in the bestiary or choose: a sinkhole (Lung + Athletics vs Hard 14 or sink to the chest; the mud is cold and holds), a field of the face-down dead whose stones have been moved, a ribbed thing, or a fog bank in which the party hears their own names called from the west. On a Lack, someone in the party feels the pull and must make a Calling roll as though asleep.

The Uncovered also floods. Twice a day, at the body's tide, water rises an inch or two through the mud from below and drains away again. A party camping on low ground wakes wet, with kelp in their boots. On a pressure day the flood rises to the knee.

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## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

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*Sweet water, sour neighbors.*

— LASHINGS PROVERB

A country of fishers lost its fish, and a country of sailors lost its sea, and yet Brinehollow eats. It eats badly, and it eats salt, and it eats on credit, but it eats. The economy of the coast rests on four things, and none of them is the ocean any more: **salvage**, the stripping of the Uncovered; **the Chase**, the endless building of the Mile; **salt**, which the indoor tide gives every cellar for nothing; and **water**, sweet water, which nothing gives anyone for nothing.

**Salvage** is the coast's gold rush. Every year the sea gives up another mile of seabed, and on it lie six centuries of wrecks: Company barques with their cargoes still in the holds, warships of the old fleet, fishing smacks, and older things from before the Gorging. The Admiralty licenses ground by the square furlong, Purser-Clerk Penwarden sells the licences, and the salvage-brokers of the Gilt Mile buy them up in advance and hire crews to strip them. Brass, iron, lead, timber, coin, and the bones of the drowned (sold to Cutwrights and surgeons) flow back down the Mile. An unlicensed salvager who strikes a rich wreck can live like a Commodore for a year. Most strike nothing, and some strike things that should have been left in the mud.

**The Chase** is the coast's great public work: a mile of new pier every year, paid for by a tithe on every household and built by thousands of labourers. It is the country's largest employer and its largest debt. Timber comes down from the northern woods toward Cradlewrack by the wagon-train, and every year it comes from further away, and costs more, and is worse. The Chase is how the

Admiralty keeps the poor in work and the Mile in reach of water, and it is how the Gilt Mile's moneylenders keep the Admiralty in their ledgers.

**Salt** is free and everywhere, and Brinehollow sells it to the Table by the wagon-load. Saltwick salt is the best on the Rim; cellar-salt from the Mile is coarser and sold to the Fatlands for brining. Salt is the one export the Admiralty's figures admit is growing, because the indoor tide is rising every year.

**Water** is the great scarcity. Rain is salt, wells along the coast run brackish, and every cellar fills twice a day with sea-water that is no use to drink. Sweet water comes from the springs of Weirholm, carted to the Headland cisterns in sealed casks and sold by the cup at Admiralty windows on every mile. A cup costs a bail-token. A family of five needs perhaps ten cups a day for drinking and cooking. Everything else, from washing to laundry to the brewing of the thin bitter Mile ale, is done in salt. The poor are thirsty all their lives, and they live in a land where their own chests fill with water twice a day.

**Bail-water** is a minor trade with a major shadow. Dry Jonah's agents buy it by the bucket in the Lashings at half a crumb a pint, bottle it in green glass, and sell it inland. Families in the Lashings sell their dawn bail to his buyers every morning. Nobody asks what it is for. The price has doubled in two years.

## WAGES ON THE COAST

| WORK                       | PAY PER DAY        | WHO DOES IT                         | NOTES                                   |
|----------------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Mile-cart runner           | 2 L                | young men and women of the Lashings | plus tips; worse after dark             |
| Pier-hauler (the Chase)    | 2 L                | Raw Mile crews                      | 3 L for driver-men; deaths common       |
| Rope-walker                | 2 L                | the Ropewalk on Mile Three          | walk backward eleven hours              |
| Cannery worker             | 1 L                | Lashings women and children         | mussels, gull, Uncovered eel            |
| Shellfish digger           | 6 c to 1 L         | the poorest                         | Uncovered middens; poison to the dry    |
| Parish bailer (child)      | 4–8 bail-tokens    | children like Tolly Brack           | a token a bailing                       |
| Netwatch hooker            | 2 L a night        | the desperate and the brave         | plus tallies at 2 L a head              |
| Able Hand of the Dry Fleet | 2 L                | Keelrow crews                       | rations, a berth on props               |
| Salvage crewman            | 0–20 L             | Uncovered crews                     | shares of what the wreck yields         |
| Uncovered pilot            | 6 L                | Hask Tarn and a few others          | per party per day; more past Harbor End |
| Layer of the dead          | 1 L and the stones | Slabside and Mile Twelve men        | lays the face-down dead on the flats    |
| Gauger of the Salt Assay   | 2 L                | clerks with chains                  | under watch since 639                   |
| Tank-tender, Fathomhouse   | 4 L                | servants in rubber aprons           | never below the fourth stair            |
| Window-warden (Gilt Mile)  | 3 L                | household servants                  | stands between the family and the west  |

## WHAT THINGS COST ON THE MILE

| ITEM                                     | PRICE              | NOTES                                                    |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Seaweed bread, a loaf                    | 6 c                | grey, salt, filling; a lack's worth is two loaves        |
| Cup of sweet water                       | 1 bail-token (2 c) | at any Admiralty window on any mile                      |
| Cask of sweet water (40 cups)            | 7 L                | Gilt Mile households only; the poor buy by the cup       |
| Salted gull                              | 3 c                | the Lashings' meat                                       |
| Uncovered shellfish, a bowl              | 1 c                | safe if you bail; deadly if you don't                    |
| Fresh fish from Harbor End               | 2–5 L              | a luxury; eyeless ones are cheaper                       |
| Fatlands meat in brine, a pound          | 4 c                | nobody examines it                                       |
| Mile ale, a mug                          | 1 c                | brewed in brackish water, sour                           |
| Saltwick gin, a cup                      | 3 c                | the Fleet's ration; sweet water is in it                 |
| Anchoring rope, hemp, 10 fathoms         | 2 L                | Ropewalk-proved; 3 L with a knot-proof                   |
| Silk-and-wire rope                       | 30 L               | Gilt Mile; cannot be cut by a small blade                |
| Oathen iron shackle and chain            | 60 L               | Rim import; the best anchor money can buy                |
| Bail-bucket, tin                         | 1 L                | copper 5 L; silver 40 L (the Admiral's is silver)        |
| Cradlewrack caul, sewn into a coat       | 15 L               | does not work; sells anyway                              |
| Rope funeral (priest and carving)        | 3 L                | the name cut in the tide-post is extra, a crumb a letter |
| A room on the Middle Mile, a night       | 1 L                | with a ring in the floor and a knot-tier                 |
| A night's sitter (to watch the pleading) | 1 L                | the Chapel Reach hires them out                          |
| Salvage licence, one furlong             | 20 L to 400 L      | by the value of what is thought to lie there             |

## THE DUTIES

The Admiralty raises money as a navy does, by levy and by impressment, and its taxes are named for ships' business.

- ◇ **The Pier Tithe.** One lack in ten of every Lowmark household's earnings, collected by the parish Purser at each mile-post on the first day of each season, toward the Chase. Households that cannot pay can work it off on the Raw Mile.
- ◇ **The Rope Duty.** A crumb on every fathom of rope sold, collected at the Ropewalk. It is the most hated tax in the country, because it falls on the one thing nobody can do without, and the Admiralty knows it, and has doubled it twice.
- ◇ **The Keel Levy.** Every family in Keelrow pays a lack a month toward the upkeep of its ship's props, in return for living under it.
- ◇ **Port Tolls.** The Rim Road Company still pays the Admiralty full harbor dues for the port of Lowmark, on the grounds that it is still a port, and the Admiralty still collects them. Reeve Calder Stokes has noticed that the Company has paid these dues without complaint for a hundred and twenty years on a harbor

that has not taken a Company ship since 558, and has begun to wonder what it has been buying.

- ◇ **Impressment.** Debtors who cannot pay any of the above are pressed into the Dry Fleet for a term of years, to stand watches on a ship that will not sail.

## WHO IS RICH

The House of Vasht is rich beyond counting and cannot spend a crumb of it, because none of its princes can leave their tanks long enough to want anything. The Gilt Mile's salvage-brokers and moneylenders are the true rich of Lowmark, and Madam Orla Cushion and her like own the Mile's future in mortgages on pier that has not yet been built. The Commodores of the Admiralty are rich through their squadrons, which are provinces, and which pay them. The Rim Road factors of Saltwick grow rich on salt going out and water and meat coming in. And Dry Jonah, an outlander who has never bailed in his life, is quietly becoming one of the richest men on the coast by selling the coast's own breath to the east.

The poor own their buckets and their ropes. That is all most of them own, and they own those because the law says they must.

## ▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

*Tie your own knot.*

— THE FIRST PROVERB, AND THE FIRST LAW

Brinehollow's law is a ship's law written for a country, and its first principle is that nobody leaves their post. The **Articles of the Fleet**, issued in 121 and amended by Standing Order every year since, bind every citizen as a member of the crew. Every household is a watch. Every sleeper is on duty. To fail to anchor, to fail to bail, or to fail one's neighbor at the count is not merely a sin but desertion.

**Who enforces.** The **Netwatch** keeps the night and the shore. By day the parishes keep themselves, each mile through its **Bailers' Warden**, who inspects ropes and buckets, records the count and reports silences. The Admiralty's own **Deck-Wardens**, marines in blue oilskin with cutlasses, guard the Headland, the sweet-water cisterns and the Salt Assay, and carry out the Bench's sentences. On the Uncovered nobody enforces anything except the salvage crews, with their own knives.

**How a trial works.** Every case of consequence goes before the **Drowned Bench** in the Sounding Hall. The accused is brought in at the turn of the tide and stood barefoot in the shallow pool, which is fed by the indoor tide and always cold. Across the pool, on the stone bench beneath the frieze of the Beaching, sit three Tenanted judges, utterly still. A **Sounding Clerk** stands at the side with a brass gauge sunk in the water and a stick of chalk. The charge is read. Witnesses stand in the pool one at a time and speak. The accused may speak, or may hire a **Speaker for the Dry**, an advocate,

usually Oathen-trained, who stands beside them in the water. Nobody questions the judges and the judges rarely question anyone. When a statement is made, the Clerk watches the gauge. If the water rises, he marks the line in chalk and rings the lie-bell once.

Nobody can say whether the pool really rises at a lie. The Clerks swear it does. The Bench does not need it to. When the hearing is done, the judges speak the verdict together, in two voices each, six voices in all, and the lower voices sometimes finish first. There is no appeal. No verdict of the Drowned Bench has been successfully overturned in four centuries, and since the Bench grew from nine to ninety, every Tenanted judge in the country has voted the same way in every case this year.

## STANDING IN THE POOL

A character on trial before the Drowned Bench may try to lie. Roll **Tongue + Deceive** against **Dire (22)**. The Tenanted judges hear the second voice in every speaker, and they hear it lie. Even on a success the Sounding Clerk's gauge may move, at the Carver's choice. A character who tells the whole truth, against their own interest, gains +2 on any later roll to have the sentence softened, because the Bench is fair, and everyone knows it. Standing in the pool through a long hearing is cold and close: a character at Regrowth 4 or more must resist **The Water** (see Wants) or feel the urge to kneel and put their face in it, in open court.

**Sentences.** The Bench's sentences are naval and few. **Flogging with a wet rope** is the common punishment for theft and brawling. **Fines** in lacks are paid to the parish. **Impressment** sends debtors and petty criminals to the Dry Fleet. **Bucketing**, confiscating the offender's bail-bucket for a day and a night so that they must beg every neighbor to bail them, is a shaming punishment for slander and loose knots. **Hanging** from the yardarm of the *Steadfast* is reserved for treason and for officers who say "stranded." And above all there is **loosing**: the convict is sentenced to sleep unanchored for a set number of nights, under guard, with the Netwatch ordered not to intervene. Loosing for a night is a gamble. Loosing for a season is death by inches. Loosing for life is death, and the Bench hands it down with what looks like tenderness.

| CRIME                                       | SENTENCE                                       | NOTES                                       |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Theft, brawling, public drunkenness         | Wet-rope flogging, 6 to 40 strokes             | strokes laid on in the pool                 |
| Tying a loose knot (one's own or another's) | Bucketing, one day and night                   | in some parishes, a fine of 10 L            |
| Failing to call or answer the count         | Fine of 5 L, or a week on the Raw Mile         | a silence that was a lie is worse           |
| Asking a returned person where they went    | Fine of 1 L (Middle Mile, Chapel Reach)        | not a crime on the Headland, only gross     |
| Salvage without a licence                   | Forfeit of the take; impressment for a repeat  | the Orchard ignores this entirely           |
| Selling bail-water                          | No crime                                       | the Admiralty takes a tithe                 |
| Deepening procession                        | Fine of 20 L; rope confiscated and burned      | seldom enforced; a Commodore has asked why  |
| Debt beyond the Pier Tithe                  | Impressment, one year per 100 L                | the Dry Fleet's largest source of crew      |
| Neglecting to bail the helpless             | Murder: loosing for a season                   | the commonest murder there is               |
| Murder by blade or hand                     | Loosing for a season to life                   | the Bench weighs the reason with great care |
| Cutting another's anchoring rope            | Loosing for life                               | the worst crime in the country              |
| Saying "stranded" of the fleet (officer)    | Hanging from the <i>Steadfast's</i> yard       | four hanged under Admiral Sund              |
| Saying "stranded" (civilian)                | Wet-rope flogging, 20 strokes                  | the Headland's chaplains preach against it  |
| Publishing the Salt Assay's figures         | Treason: hanging, or loosing at the Rail       | Brenna Kelp is sought under this article    |
| Striking a Tenanted person                  | Flogging; loosing if the blow was on the Bench | the Tenanted do not strike back             |

**The knife in the night.** The law's great failure is that its worst crime is also its commonest act of love. When a rope is cut, the Bench must decide whether it was cut by the sleeper, by a stranger, by no one, or by the husband who could not bear to hear his wife beg any longer. Ottiline Hawse at the Ropewalk is called as a witness

in nearly every such case, to read the cut. The Bench listens to her, and to the family, and looks at the accused for a long time with its black eyes. Then it often finds that the rope was cut by the sleeper, and the family goes home, and nobody believes it, and everybody is grateful.

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

*Hold us down, O Fathom, as you held the drowned,  
that we may not rise up and frighten those we love.*

— THE OLDEST LINE OF THE ADMIRALTY HYMN, OLDER THAN THE GORGING

Before the Meal, Brinehollow prayed to Dromm as a keeper: the god who held the drowned down, held the storms under and kept the

cold water beneath the warm. The old prayers ask to be *beld*. The coast still uses them, and now they are said by people who are held,

every night, by rope.

THE THREE DOCTRINES ON THE COAST

The **Theft** is called the **Debt** in Brinehollow, and it is the faith of the Admiralty, the Anchorites and most of the old fishing towns. We dragged the god from the sea on ten thousand hooks and ate it while it was still moving. We owe the sea everything we took. The Called are the debt being paid, and the Tenanted are the bailiffs, come to collect what we borrowed and to see that the rest is kept honestly. Debt chapels are plain and bare, with a tide-post in the nave on which the names of the parish's Called are cut, and the sermon is always the same: endure, refuse, and pay what you must without complaint. The Anchorites carry the Debt to its end: if we cannot pay, we can at least refuse to be collected.

The **Gift** is called the **Lending**. Dromm came close to shore in the ninth winter and waited for us, and did not fight, because it loved its people and lent us its body to live on. The Tenanted are its kindness coming home: the god returning its children to their families, gentler than they were. Lending chapels are warm and full of candles, and they bless the Tenanted at the door. The Wreckwives are mostly Lending folk, at first. Many of them leave it.

The **Bait** is called the **Spawning**, and in Brinehollow it is illegal. Dromm let itself be dragged ashore because the god of the deep breeds by being eaten: swallowed by a people, it spreads through ten thousand chests and goes home, a bucket at a time, carrying them with it. The Spawning is the Deepening's doctrine, though the Deepening never uses the word. Mother Limpet calls it homecoming. The Cutwrights' genealogist in Lowmark, Ansby Wrack, has begun to suspect that the Spawning may simply be accurate.

SHRINES AND HOLY PLACES

- ◇ **Tide-posts.** Every mile, every town and every village has a tide-post, an oak pillar sunk in the ground where the sea once reached, carved from top to bottom with the names of the Called. The oldest, at Lowmark, carries the line "The sea is not going out. It is going in." The posts are the coast's gravestones. People touch them as they pass.
- ◇ **West-door niches.** In every house the west door is barred, and in the wall beside it there is a small niche holding a dish of sea-

water, a candle and a scrap of the rope of whoever in the family was last Called. It is lit on Tablenight and on the anniversary of the Calling.

- ◇ **The Bucket of the Unbailed.** At the crossings of the Middle Mile and the Lashings hang great copper buckets, dented and green, into which passers-by drop a crumb or a bail-token for those with no one to bail them. Parish children like Tolly Brack are paid from them.
- ◇ *\*The Steadfast's chapel.\** The Admiralty's chaplains keep a chapel between the flagship's gun-decks, where officers swear on the Articles, and where the hymn is sung every dusk while the propped fleet bails.
- ◇ **Longslab.** The holiest place on the coast, and the most feared. The Debt calls it the place of the crime, the Lending the place of the gift, the Spawning the place of the egg.

rites

- ◇ **The First Bail.** A newborn's first bailing, at its first dusk, is a rite: the mother or midwife holds the child head-down over a new bucket and sings, and the water that comes up is poured into the gutter while the family says, together, "Go west without her." The bucket is the child's for life.
- ◇ **The Knotting.** In early Grace every rope in a household is cut down and replaced, and every member of the family ties another's new knot before witnesses. The old ropes are burned on the Chapel Reach in a great tarry bonfire.
- ◇ **The Rope Funeral.** For the Called: the cut rope is divided, one piece for each of the family and one for the wall, and the name is cut into the tide-post. The priest asks, "Did the line hold?" and the family answers, "The line held. The sea was stronger." They must say it whether or not it is true.
- ◇ **The Face-Down.** For those who die in the ordinary way: the body is laid face-down on the Uncovered, weighted with stones, for a tide that no longer comes. The mourners walk away without looking back. The gulls do the rest.
- ◇ **The Wet Welcome.** For the Tenanted who return: the family meets them at the door with a bucket, a towel and a bowl of sea-water. The returned bails, dries and drinks, and is let in. Wreckwives say this rite was made by people who wanted something to do with their hands.

HOLY DAYS

| DAY              | SEASON                 | OBSERVANCE                                                                  |
|------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Knotting     | early Grace            | every rope replaced; old ropes burned on the Chapel Reach                   |
| The Beaching     | first week of Plenty   | Longslab hauling songs sung on the Headland; the Admiralty parades          |
| The Hauling Fast | Plenty, four days      | the devout eat nothing for the four days Dromm took to die                  |
| Low Water        | lowest tide of Carving | the Tenanted gather and sing on the Uncovered; families watch from the rail |

| DAY                   | SEASON                | OBSERVANCE                                                           |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Count of the Dead | late Carving          | every tide-post read aloud, name by name, through the night          |
| Tablenight            | longest night of Lack | a bowl of sea-water at the head of the table; the west door unbarred |

*HOLD US DOWN. The Admiralty Dusk Hymn, as sung aboard the Steadfast and in every Debt chapel on the coast while the congregation bails.*

*Hold us down, O Fathom, as you held the drowned,  
that we may not rise up and frighten those we love.*

*Hold us down, O Fathom, as you held the storm,  
that we may not break loose upon the ones we keep.*

*Hold us down, O Fathom, as you held the cold,  
that we may rest beneath and never feel the pull.*

*We took you from your water. We are your water now.*

*We bail you twice a day. We will not bring you home.*

*Hold us down, O Fathom. Hold us down.*

*And if you will not hold us, let the rope.*

— The second-to-last couplet was added in 512, the year of the Turning. The Deepening sings the hymn too, but replaces “We will not bring you home” with “We are coming home,” and the last line with nothing at all: a held breath, as long as the singers can hold it.

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

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### WHAT THEY SAY ON THE MILE

"I've laid nine hundred out on the flats, face-down, stones on their backs. Never had one turn over. Last week I had one turn over." — Ambrose Kittle, layer of the dead, Mile Twelve

"Mam says I'm not to look at the bucket. I look at the bucket." — Pip, aged eight, Middle Mile

"Every man I take upstairs wants me to tie him to the bed after. Not for that. Just to sleep. I charge for the knot." — Rosen, who works the rooms above the Last Rail

"Forty years on the *Resolute*. Never wet my boots. Best posting in the fleet." — Able Hand Corwen Bly, Keelrow

"My husband came home kinder. My children came home strangers. I don't know which of them I'm feeding." — a Wreckwife at the Middle Mile table

"We drag them back up the beach and they look at you like you've shut a door in their face. Then their mother kisses your hand. Then you go and do it again." — a Netwatch hooker, Mile Seven

"They say the sea's coming back. I've seen it from Nineteen. It isn't coming back. It's waiting." — a pier-hauler, the Raw Mile

"I cut my father's rope. He'd been asking for six years. The Bench said he cut it himself. I thanked them. I'd thank them again." — anonymous, read aloud at a Wreckwives' table

"You're a long way from water, my love. You'll want this." — a Saltwick grandmother, handing a visitor the salt-gift

"The god's down there, and he's lonely. So would you be." — a child of the Underpier

"Hot soup? On the Headland? What are you, Fatlands?" — a Gilt Mile hostess

"I sing them to sleep with the bailing song. It's the only song I know where you can hear if they're breathing." — a cannery mother, the Lashings

"Don't call it stranded. Call it waiting. Waiting's an order. Stranded's a fact." — Bosun Kettle Marrow, to a new recruit

"Give the wet man a crumb and he'll bless you dry. Look in his puddle and he'll bless you wet." — Headland beggars' saying, of Old Wet Tom

"The sea used to bring us fish. Now it brings us back our husbands. I preferred the fish." — a Brackmouth fishwife

"Everyone wants to know where it's going. Nobody wants to know what it's going to do when it gets there." — Brenna Kelp, overheard



# ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

*Every rope has two ends, and both of them are being held by someone.*

— OTTILINE HAWSE

Power in Brinehollow runs like rope through a block: whoever holds one end feels every tug on the other. The Admiralty rules, but it rules by permission of the tanks above it and the Bench below it, and it pays for everything with money borrowed from the Gilt Mile against a pier that Kessa Drowle knows cannot be finished. The

princes in the tanks are the god's own blood and the state's legitimacy, and they are drowning. The Bench is fair, final and not human, and nobody has ever dared ask whose law it is keeping. Underneath them all, the poor tie their knots and call their names, and every year there are fewer of them to call.

| POWER                                                | CONTROLS                                                 | FEARS                                                             | OWES                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| High Admiral Corvin Sund                             | the Dry Fleet, the Standing Orders, the Deck-Wardens     | the word "stranded"; his own pull                                 | the Gilt Mile for the Chase; the tanks for his seal     |
| The House of Vasht (Prince Aurel, the Dowager Below) | the wet seal; legitimacy; Fathomhouse                    | the Seating; the Cutwrights' ledgers                              | the retired-to-depth, whom it feeds below               |
| The Drowned Bench (Justice Oake and ninety others)   | every verdict; loosing; the Sounding Hall                | nothing anyone has seen                                           | its own seat to the Admiralty, in 240; perhaps to Dromm |
| Harbormistress Kessa Drowle                          | the Chase; timber; nine thousand labourers               | the twentieth mile; the year 650                                  | the Gilt Mile's moneylenders; the dead of the Raw Mile  |
| The Netwatch (Watch-Captain Hollis Dray)             | the night; the Return Room; the right to enter any house | a Calling night it cannot cover                                   | the Admiralty for pay; the families for trust           |
| The Gilt Mile (Madam Orla Cushion and the brokers)   | credit; salvage licences; mortgages on the Mile          | the end of the Chase; a run on debts                              | the Admiralty, which could seize everything             |
| The Rim Road Company (Reeve Calder Stokes)           | the Spur, sweet water from Weirholm, all exports         | being caught knowing; Brinehollow's end before its debts are paid | Brinehollow a century of answers                        |
| The Second Table (Commodore Lysander Vell)           | a faction of Commodores; Dromm's flesh in a lead box     | the Bench learning of it                                          | the Follow's builder, who does not know them            |
| The Deepening (Mother Limpet)                        | two thousand baptized; Gullcry; procession nights        | nothing; or that the voice is not there                           | its faithful a destination                              |
| The Wreckwives (Widow-Mother Agna Spurling)          | the best records of the Tenanted in the country          | the truth about the Tenanted, either way                          | every member a hearing without tears                    |
| The Salt Assay (Brenna Kelp, in hiding)              | the number                                               | the Tenanted already knowing it                                   | the Wreckwives her life, three times over               |
| The Ropewalk (Ottiline Hawse)                        | every anchoring rope in Lowmark; the reading of the cut  | the child with the small blade                                    | nobody; everyone owes her                               |

**WATCH-CAPTAIN HOLLIS DRAY, COMMANDER OF THE NETWATCH** Threat 4 (Intimidate, Search) · Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Attack +7 (boathook 4, Hooking) · Armor 2 · Dread 0. He has signed the stay of four thousand loosings and kept a list of the ones he refused. He reads it every dusk before the bell.

**WIDOW-MOTHER AGNA SPURLING OF THE WRECKWIVES** Threat 4 (Persuade, Instinct) · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Her husband came back in 602, and she has lived with him for thirty-nine years, and she is the only woman in Lowmark who will say aloud, at the table, that she loves him more now.

## THE CARVER'S TUG

When the party pulls on one power in Brinehollow, let another feel it. Expose the Second Table and the Admiralty purges itself, and the Bench is asked to try Commodores, and the Bench rules as one, and suddenly everyone is looking at the Bench. Help Brenna Kelp publish, and the Gilt Mile's credit collapses overnight, the Chase stops, nine thousand labourers have no bread, and the Deepening's processions double. Rescue the prince from his tank and the Dowager Below begins to move. Brinehollow is a knot. Pull hard enough on any line and the whole thing tightens.



# THE PEOPLE OF BRINEHOLLOW

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*A dry man drowns twice.*

– COAST PROVERB

The people below are the first half of Brinehollow's cast. They agree with what the core book established and go deeper: what they carry, whom they love, what they hide and what will happen to them if

the Guests do nothing. Stat blocks use the core rules; where a number differs slightly from the core book it is a refinement, not a contradiction.

# CORVIN SUND

High Admiral of the Tidal Admiralty

*“The fleet is not stranded, Lieutenant. The fleet is at anchor in a low tide of unusual duration. Say it back to me. Good. Now say it to the rope.”*

– CORVIN SUND, TO A JUNIOR OFFICER ON THE GALLOWS PLATFORM OF THE  
*STEADFAST*, 637 A.G.

| CORVIN SUND – HIGH ADMIRAL OF THE TIDAL ADMIRALTY |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                        | Brinehollow · Cut 3 (Lung-line, cadet) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                                     | 68 · High Admiral; commander of the Dry Fleet; master of the Standing Orders                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                                | Warden (the Tidal Admiralty) · Standing 5 (Commodore and above)                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                                        | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                            | Intimidate 4, Resolve 4, Blades 3, Clause 3, Endure 2, Persuade 2, Wayfaring 1                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                                              | Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                           | dress sword +6 (4)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                                             | Deep Breath (holds breath 30 minutes; cannot drown in that time); Hold the Line (once per scene, every Admiralty sailor in earshot gains +2 to resist fear or the pull); Pressure (Partake when striking: +2 damage, ears bleed, stunned on a Helping) |
| WANTS                                             | To Keep Under (roused by any secret, figure or loss; he buries it); The West (newly; roused by dusk at the <i>Steadfast</i> ’s rail)                                                                                                                   |
| KNACKS                                            | Unflinching; Rope Knots                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                                      | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                                           | silver Admiral’s bail-bucket; dress sword; his annotated Articles of the Fleet; four signet rings; a scrap of tarred rope                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                                             | 0 (he is a square old man in a wet coat; the dread is in what he orders)                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Corvin Sund is a block of a man, square in the shoulders and square in the jaw, grey-whiskered, with a weather-reddened face that has not seen weather worth the name in fifty years. His dress coat is Admiralty blue gone nearly black, and he has it sponged with brine every morning so that it never quite dries, and so he smells, always, of a harbor at low water: wet wool, weed, the faint ammonia of old rope. His voice is a quarterdeck bark meant to carry over a gale, and since there is no gale he uses it on rooms, where it rattles the glass. When he bails, at the dusk bell, on the *Steadfast*’s deck in front of the assembled crew, he does it standing, bent at the waist over the silver bucket, without a sound except the water.

He is not a stupid man. He has decided what is true and holds to it as a sailor holds a line in a storm. Officers fear him; common sailors love him, because he knows their names and has never let a Keelrow family go short.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 573 on the Headland to a cadet Lung-line captain, he went aboard the *Steadfast* as a ship’s boy at fifteen, in 588, the last year

the fleet floated. The pilot that season, a lean young man called Hask Tarn, let him hold the lead-line. He remembers the keel touching mud at Keelrow and not lifting, the old Admiral weeping, the props going in, and the officers calling it temporary. He believed them. He has spent fifty-three years making sure everyone else does.

He rose by competence and by marriage. In 601 he married Elsbet Carrow, a sharp, funny, dry-lunged woman from Weirholm who thought the propped fleet was the most ridiculous thing on the Table and loved him anyway. By 620 he was a Commodore; by 629 High Admiral. In between came the Great Pressure Day of 627, when every window on the Headland burst. The night before, at supper, Elsbet put down her fork and said it plainly: *We’re stranded, Corvin. The fleet is stranded and so are we. Admit it, and come inland with me.* He told her she was speaking treason in an officer’s house. That night, on a night when eleven hundred and forty people walked, she walked. Her rope was untied, not cut. The knot had been undone with care, by fingers that knew it. He has never let himself think about whose.

The first officer he hanged for saying “stranded” was Lieutenant Amos Prew, in 631. Then Captain Dorran Hale in 634, Sailing-

Master Ennis Crabbe in 637 and Lieutenant Jessop Tidewell in 640. In 639 Brenna Kelp presented her arithmetic to the Standing Orders, and he made it a crime by noon. That winter, alone, he went down into the *Steadfast's* hold with a two-man saw and a lantern and began to cut through her keel.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The High Admiral is the government. He issues the Standing Orders from the *Steadfast's* deck every first morning of the month, signs every commission, approves every salvage licence over a hundred lacks and commands the Deck-Wardens and, through the Watch-Captain, the Netwatch. His orders need the wet seal of the House of Vasht, which he carries to Fathomhouse in a sealed case each week and receives back through a hatch. He does not command the Bench, and he knows it, and he has never put the matter to the test.

His routine never varies: dawn bail on the *Steadfast*; inspection of all four hundred ships each week, hulls scraped of barnacles that are not there; afternoons at the Admiralty House; dusk alone at the west rail, hands on the wood; then sleep, shackled in Oathen iron to the mainmast's foot.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Admiral's silver bucket** — made for the first High Admiral in 121, engraved with every holder's name. His is the twenty-sixth. He keeps it polished to a mirror and does not like to look into it after bailing. Worth 400 lacks as plate; never sold.
- ◇ **Dress sword** — a straight Admiralty blade (sword, 4) presented at his commission. It has been drawn in anger twice, both times on Calling nights, both times on sailors who were walking.
- ◇ **The Articles of the Fleet** — his own copy, oilskin-bound, its margins dense with his annotations in a small, neat hand. Article Nine, the one that forbids "stranded", is underlined so often the page has torn.
- ◇ **Four signet rings** — Prew, Hale, Crabbe, Tidewell, on a cord inside his coat. He touches them when he says the word in his head.
- ◇ **A scrap of tarred rope** — six inches of Elsbet's anchoring line, the untied end, still knotted. He has never sworn on it. He is afraid of what the oath would be.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the sea back. Failing that, he wants nobody ever to say it is gone, because the day the Admiralty admits the fleet is stranded, the Admiralty has no reason to rule, the Chase has no reason to go on, the Gilt Mile calls in its debts and the poor stop believing that anyone is coming. He is not wrong about that. He fears the numbers. He fears that Elsbet was right. Most of all he fears the dusk, because for a year now, at the west rail, he has felt the pull, and it is gentle, and it is in her voice.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** the *Steadfast's* keel is sawn half through. He did it himself, over eleven nights in Lack 639, so that if the sea ever comes back the flagship will break her back rather than float away west without him aboard.

**Secret he does not know:** his favourite officer, Commodore Lysander Vell, is a member of the Second Table and has been using the Admiral's own seal-case to carry Second Table correspondence to Fathomhouse inside the Standing Orders. And his dawn bail-water has turned blue. Tolly Brack has seen it, in the silver bucket, when the steward tipped it out. The boy has not told anyone, because no one has paid him.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Hask Tarn** — the pilot of 588, who let the boy hold the lead. Sund has offered him a commission three times. Tarn has refused, because he would have to swear the sea is coming back.
- ◇ **Kessa Drowle** — he cannot rule without her pier, and she has told him to his face, once, the year the timber runs out. He had the conversation struck from the minutes.
- ◇ **Commodore Lysander Vell** — protégé, confidant and heir-apparent. Sund trusts him more than any living man.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — the traitor he is hunting. He has read her figures three times, alone, and burned them each time.
- ◇ **Elsbet Sund** — Called in 627, never returned. He sets her bowl on Tablenight, and the west door of his Headland house is the only one in the street he bars that night.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet Sund at an inspection, at the Standing Orders, or in the dock when he wants a leaker found. He wants things done quietly by people who will not be missed: Brenna Kelp's copies recovered, an officer's loyalty tested, a rumour about the keel traced to its source.

- ◇ **The Inspection.** A Keelrow sailor, half-drunk, says "stranded" within the Admiral's hearing while the Guests are present. Sund turns to the Guests and asks, very calmly, whether they heard it. The sailor's life depends on their answer.
- ◇ **The Sawdust.** A shipwright from Dagna Hull's yard, surveying the *Steadfast* for a refit, has found the cut. Sund asks the Guests to make sure she does not report it. He does not say how.
- ◇ **The Rail.** The Guests are aboard at dusk and see the Admiral at the west rail, hands on the wood, not answering his steward. It is a Calling roll with a man who commands four hundred ships.

Under threat he becomes colder and louder and gives orders, and men obey them. To kindness he is gruffly grateful and does not trust it. Toward the god he is pure refusal, and the refusal is cracking. **If nobody intervenes:** on Tablenight 641 Corvin Sund walks from the *Steadfast's* deck in full dress, down the gangway and west across the salt flats. Somebody rings the bell for "Hold the Line," and somebody else shouts "Follow the flag," which is an order every

sailor of the Dry Fleet has drilled all his life. By dawn, crews of sixty ships are missing from Keelrow, and a column of footprints in Admiralty boots runs straight to Harbor End and over the rail.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“He never once shorted my mam’s ration, and he hanged my brother. Both of those are true. I’ve given up trying to make them fit.” — Able Hand Corwen Bly, Keelrow

“Corvin is the best officer the fleet has ever had. That is precisely why the fleet will go wherever he goes.” — Commodore Lysander Vell

“He was a good boy on the lead-line. Kept his count steady. He’s still counting a sea that isn’t there.” — Hask Tarn

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# KESSA DROWLE

## Harbormistress of Lowmark

*“Six hundred and forty feet of pier this season, nine hundred pilings, three men dead and one walked. Next season it’s seven hundred feet and the pilings have to be four yards longer. Don’t ask me why. Ask the mud.”*

– KESSA DROWLE, REPORT TO THE STANDING ORDERS, CARVING 641

| KESSA DROWLE – HARBORMISTRESS OF LOWMARK |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                            | 52 · Harbormistress; master-builder of the Chase                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Factor (Admiralty works) · Standing 4                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                   | Reckoning 5, Craft 4, Labor 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 2, Haggle 2, Brawl 1, Endure 1                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                  | driving mallet +4 (3)                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                    | Salt-Sense (knows a pressure day an hour early; reads Regrowth from bail-water); Tide-Sight (Partake: direction and distance of nearest salt water and of every Called and Tenanted within a mile) |
| WANTS                                    | To Keep Under (roused by a figure that does not add up; she hides it in her second ledger)                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                                   | Counting Habit; Strong Back                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                                  | two carpenter’s pencils; the second ledger; sounding rod; driving mallet; tin bucket; her husband’s rule                                                                                           |
| DREAD                                    | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Kessa Drowle is a short, broad woman built like a bollard, black tar to the elbows and a carpenter’s pencil behind each ear. Her grey hair is cropped close because long hair catches in the drivers. She smells of pine pitch, sawdust and rum, and her hands are a map of splinters, burns and two crooked fingers broken by a piling chain. She speaks in measurements, the way other people speak in proverbs: a man is “six foot of trouble”, a bad day is “a three-foot sink”, her love for her daughter is “deeper than the twentieth mile”. Her cough is heavy, and she bails over the side of the work-barges into the sawdust, without stopping her talk.

### THEIR STORY

Born on Mile Ten in 589, daughter of a pier-wright, she drove her first nail at nine and her first piling at sixteen. She married a driver-man, Tobin Drowle, in 610, and they had one daughter, Wynn. Kessa was foreman of the Raw Mile by 622 and Harbormistress by 630, after her predecessor walked off the end of Mile Fourteen at dusk. In 629 a piling chain parted on the drivers and Tobin was

under it. They did not find all of him. She was back on the barges the next week.

In 636 she began to survey the ground beyond the end of the Mile with Hask Tarn, and in 638 she did the sum that has ruined her sleep. The northern woods that supply the Chase will be cut out in nine years. The survey shows that beyond the twentieth mile the seabed falls away down the long slope to the Trench, and pilings will have nothing to stand on. The water, at its present rate of fall, drops off the shelf entirely in the same year: 650. She told the High Admiral. He struck it from the minutes.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Chase is the largest work in Brinehollow and Kessa runs all of it: nine thousand labourers, the timber trains from Skerrow, the barges, the drivers, the tarring sheds and the pay. She answers to the High Admiral and is paid with Gilt Mile money, borrowed against pier she has not yet built. Every family on the Raw Mile depends on her wages. Every moneylender on the Gilt Mile depends on her finishing each mile on time. Her power is real and narrow: she can

stop the Chase with a word and bring Lowmark down with it, but she cannot make one more tree grow.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Two carpenter's pencils** — one for the true figures, one for the figures she reports. She sharpens both with the same knife.
- ◇ **The second ledger** — her own: the timber count, the fall of the sea and the year 650. It also holds a list of piling orders she does not remember making.
- ◇ **Sounding rod** — iron, twelve feet, marked in feet and fathoms. She pushes it into the mud at the end of every day, and lately she leaves it in a little longer than she needs to.
- ◇ **Driving mallet** — (mallet, 3) iron-hooped oak. She has used it on two salvagers who tried to steal timber.
- ◇ **Tin bail-bucket** — Tobin's, swapped on their wedding day. She has never swapped it back.
- ◇ **Tobin's folding rule** — boxwood and brass, the last foot snapped off where the chain caught it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to finish the Chase with dignity: to drive the last piling, tell the truth to the Mile, and have the Mile still trust her when the pier stops. She fears the twentieth mile, and the day she has to tell nine thousand people their work is done. She fears for Wynn, who works the drivers and stands at the end-rail too long at noon.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** for a year she has been ordering pilings longer than any sea could need: eighty feet, then a hundred, then a hundred and forty, for ground no deeper than sixty. The orders are in her hand, in the second ledger, and she does not remember writing them. The long timbers lie in a yard on Mile Eighteen. She tells the drivers they are for "the slope."

**Secret she does not know:** someone is driving them. At dawn, three times this Carving, the Raw Mile crews have found new pilings standing in the mud west of the pier's end, in a straight line toward the Trench, driven deep, still wet with tar. Foreman Bastian Gutter has kept it from her. The crews say the Tenanted among them get up in the night, quiet as cats, and come back at dawn with their hands blistered.

#### TIES

- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — her master, and the man who struck her truth from the minutes. She respects him and has stopped telling him things.
- ◇ **Hask Tarn** — her surveyor and her drinking companion. He tells her where the ground is going to fall. She does not ask how he knows.
- ◇ **Dagna Hull** — the shipwright whose iron slip stands at Mile Nineteen. Old friends; they shout at each other across the basin. Kessa has supplied the *Follow's* timber cradle for nothing.

- ◇ **Reeve Calder Stokes** — the Company auditor has asked for her ledgers. She showed him the first one. He asked for the second. She has not decided.
- ◇ **Wynn Drowle** — her daughter, twenty-nine, a driver-woman whose dawn water has a green in it.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet Kessa when she hires guards for the timber trains or the barges, which salvagers raid, or surveyors to walk the slope beyond the twentieth mile. She wants the truth about the ground, and someone outside the Admiralty to know her number in case something happens to her.

- ◇ **The Timber Train.** Forty wagons of pine coming down the Shore Road from Skerrow, and wreckers in the dunes. One wagon carries a piling no one ordered, a hundred and forty feet long, carved at its foot with a hauling-team's rope.
- ◇ **The Night Drivers.** Kessa hears about the new pilings and asks the Guests to watch the Raw Mile's end from dusk to dawn. What they see walking out across the mud with timber on their shoulders is her own crew, and her daughter is among them.
- ◇ **The Second Ledger.** Reeve Stokes, Brenna Kelp and Commodore Vell all want it. Kessa wants it kept safe, and she asks the Guests because nobody in Lowmark would think to look for it on them.

To threat she is blunt and hard to frighten; she carries a mallet and has used it. To kindness she is suspicious and then fiercely loyal. To the god she is a builder: she does not pray, she measures. **If nobody intervenes:** the twentieth mile is begun in 642 and abandoned in 645, when the pilings start to sink faster than they can be driven. In 650 the last timber arrives. Kessa drives the last piling herself, on the slope, at dusk, and then sits on its head, and keeps sitting, and is found at dawn with her hands on the sounding rod, a hundred and forty feet of it pushed down into the mud, all the way, as if something below had taken hold and pulled it from her gently.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She pays on the day and she knows your name and she's never once lied about the danger. You'd drive piles into hell for that." — Peder Swell, driver-man, Raw Mile

"Kessa thinks in feet. That's her blessing. The sea thinks in fathoms. That's her trouble." — Hask Tarn

"She brought me the number in 638 and asked me what to do. I told her to keep building. I am not sure, now, which of us was the coward." — High Admiral Corvin Sund, privately

# MAREN OAKE

## Justice of the Drowned Bench

*“You cut the rope because she asked. She asked because she was drowning. You are not guilty of the asking. You are guilty of being the one who heard it. Loosed, one night. Go home, and tie your own knot.”*

– JUSTICE MAREN OAKE, SENTENCING A WIDOWER, BOTH VOICES FINISHING TOGETHER, SOUNDING HALL, 638

| MAREN OAKE – JUSTICE OF THE DROWNED BENCH |                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                | Brinehollow · Cut 2, rising · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 3                                                       |
| AGE & STATION                             | 50 · Justice of the Drowned Bench since 624                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING                        | Clausewright (the Drowned Bench) · Standing 5                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                                | Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                              |
| SKILLS                                    | Clause 5, Resolve 5, Instinct 4, Search 3, Godsign 3, Endure 2, Brawl 2                                                          |
| BODY                                      | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 0                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                                   | The Weight +8 (Caul + Godsign; target makes Gut + Endure vs Grim or is pinned and takes 3 per round)                             |
| GIFTS                                     | Unbriable (cannot be Persuaded or Deceived by anyone who lies within her hearing); Voice of the Deep; Pressure; Fathom-Body      |
| WANTS                                     | To Keep Under; The Water (both held by the Passenger without effort)                                                             |
| KNACKS                                    | No Thank You; Unflinching                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                              | none (the Passenger feels no fear; Maren’s own Fray is uncounted)                                                                |
| CARRIES                                   | grey sealskin stole; iron ring of the Bench; verdict-book; Tam’s bucket; a piece of her own rope; a glass vial of Longslab water |
| DREAD                                     | 3 (to hear the lower voice answer a question nobody asked)                                                                       |

### WHO THEY ARE

A broad, still woman with slate-grey skin, cropped grey hair and eyes that are entirely black, wet and reflective, shining faintly green when the Hall’s lamps are low. Her hands lie flat on her knees through a whole hearing and never move. The air around her is cold and close and smells of deep water, and people standing before her feel their ears pop. She speaks in two tones at once, the higher one Maren’s own, a coastal alto with a Mile Six lilt, the lower one a slow sound like a hull settling, and sometimes the lower one finishes the sentence first. She is never unkind. Defendants weep in her court, and many of them thank her.

### THEIR STORY

Maren Fell was born in 591 on the Chapel Reach, a priest’s daughter, sharp at letters, and trained as a Speaker for the Dry in the Sounding Hall. She married Tam Oake, a cooper, in 614. In Carving 621, at thirty, she was Called. Tam had tied her knot himself. It held. She walked anyway, dragging the bedpost with her down the stairs, and the Netwatch found the bedpost on the Mile Nine rail. Forty days later she walked up out of the surf at Harbor End at

dawn, heavier, calm, and asked a fisherman the way to Mile Six, though she knew it. Tam took her in. Within three years the Admiralty had appointed her to the Bench, as it appoints every Tenanted person with a knowledge of law. She has sat there for seventeen years. She has sentenced more people to loosing than any judge in history.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is one of the three senior Justices and presides in the Sounding Hall four days a week. Her verdicts are final. Every Commodore, every moneylender and every Bailers’ Warden fears to stand in her pool, and every poor family on the Mile prays for her, because she is the only power in Brinehollow that has never once been bought. She depends on nothing the Admiralty gives. She eats little, sleeps in a cistern beneath the Hall, and receives one visitor a week: Tam, on the first evening, with a basket.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Grey sealskin stole** — the Bench’s vestment, kept wet. It is cold enough to raise frost on the stone where she lays it down.



- ◇ **Iron ring of the Bench** — heavy, plain, older than the Admiralty; it has been worn by forty-one Tenanted judges and has never once warmed.
- ◇ **The verdict-book** — her own record of every judgment. In the margins, in a different and smaller hand, a single word appears beside some cases: *wrong*. The Passenger does not write it.
- ◇ **Tam's bail-bucket** — copper, swapped at their wedding. She bails into it at dawn. The water is dark blue and always has been.
- ◇ **A piece of her own rope** — Tam cut her bedpost rope into nine and kept one piece for her. He gave it to her the day she returned. She has never sworn on it.
- ◇ **A vial of Longslab water** — given to every Justice on taking the seat. It never evaporates.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

The Passenger wants justice in a sense larger than the Admiralty's: the right weight on every scale, every debt paid, everything held where it belongs. It is not cruel. It is simply sure. Maren, folded small beneath it, wants Tam to know she is still there, and fears that if she tells him he will stop coming, because he will have to grieve properly at last.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** Maren is still present, awake and listening. She can, with enormous effort, move one finger, or write one word. The *wrong* in the verdict-book is hers. She has written it eleven times in seventeen years. Every case marked was a loosing.

**Secret Maren does not know (the Passenger does):** Tam was Called in Lack 640 and came back after nineteen days. He told no one. The man who has brought her basket every week since is Tenanted, and the two Passengers greet each other in the lower voice, over Maren's head, in a language she cannot hear.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Tam Oake** — her husband; Tenanted since 640, and she does not know it.
- ◇ **Father Ebb** — she has written to him every year since 625 and he answers. He is the only person who has ever addressed his letters to "Maren," never "Justice."
- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — she confirmed all four of his hangings. The Passenger approved. Maren wrote *wrong* beside Tidewell's.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — if Kelp is taken, she will stand in Oake's pool. The Passenger already knows her number and finds it correct.
- ◇ **Esk Penhallow** — his case is coming before her: is he Tenanted? Both voices will have to answer.
- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — Reef brings the rope-cutters to her court. Oake once told her, in the higher voice only, "Thank you for the ones you brought back."
- ◇ **Prince Aurel Vasht** — he has sent her a slate asking what the Tenanted are. She has not replied.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet her standing ankle-deep in her court, as defendants, witnesses or advocates, or when Tam asks them to find out why his wife's letters have begun to look like two people writing.

- ◇ **The Word in the Margin.** A Sounding Clerk shows the Guests the verdict-book and the eleven *wrights*. Find the eleven loosed. Some came back.
- ◇ **The Penhallow Hearing.** Esk Penhallow asks the Guests to speak for him. The Bench must rule whether a man is himself, and Maren is the one judge who knows what that question costs.
- ◇ **Tam's Basket.** The Guests watch Tam's weekly visit and see the two of them speak in the lower voice only. Whom do they tell, and which one?

To threat she is unmoved: the Passenger presses and the threat sits down. To kindness the higher voice warms, briefly. To the god, the Passenger is the god, or a piece of it. **If nobody intervenes:** the Bench, voting as one, begins to sentence the Salt Assay's clerks, the Anchorites who refuse to be collected, and finally the rope-makers, to loosing. Maren writes *wrong* in the margin every time, until one morning she cannot lift the finger, and the higher voice falls silent, and the Passenger sits on alone and finds itself, as ever, fair.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She loosed my son for one night. He came home in the morning. She knew he would. I don't know how she knew." — a mother, Mile Eleven

"She looks at you like you're very far down and she can see you perfectly well." — a Speaker for the Dry

"I bring the basket. She eats the bread. I don't ask. That's marriage." — Tam Oake

# AUREL VASHT

*Prince of the Lung-lines*

WHY DOES IT GO WEST. NOBODY WILL TELL ME. YOU. TELL ME.

– PRINCE AUREL VASHT, CHALKED ON HIS SLATE AND PRESSED TO THE GLASS  
FOR A SALTWICK SALT-MERCHANT, 640

| AUREL VASHT – PRINCE OF THE LUNG-LINES |                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Brinehollow · Cut 5 (Lung-line, the House of Vasht) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7                                         |
| AGE & STATION                          | 22 · Heir of the House of Vasht; holder of the wet seal                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Scion (the House of Vasht) · Standing 5                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 5 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                              |
| SKILLS                                 | Search 4, Lore 3, Athletics 3, Godsign 3, Persuade 2, Reckoning 2, Endure 1                                                      |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 10 · Guard 18 in water, 12 in air · Armor 1 · Fray 5                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                | none worth the name                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                  | Fathom-Body; Tide-Sight; Quiet Chest; Lip-Reading through water (Search +3 to read speech he can see)                            |
| WANTS                                  | The Water (roused by any thought of the surface; he stays under); The West (roused by his grandmother's voice through the stone) |
| KNACKS                                 | Counting Habit; Elder's Ear                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | none yet; the Carver may give him The Voice at Table at any time                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                | wax-slate and stylus; the wet seal; silk wrap; oilcloth sea-chart; a stoppered bottle of air; a list of questions                |
| DREAD                                  | 2 (to see his chest not move)                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

A slender young man floating in green brine in a glass tank twelve feet tall in the Hall of Tanks, naked but for a wrap of white silk that drifts around him like a jellyfish. His skin is the grey of wet slate, smooth and faintly pebbled along the spine. His eyes are huge and black. His hair is long and dark and moves on the water like weed. He is beautiful in the way a drowned boy in a story is beautiful. He does not breathe; his ribs never move, and visitors find their eyes going to his chest again and again. He reads lips through eight inches of water and answers by chalking capital letters on a wax slate and pressing it to the glass. His questions are short and his handwriting is quick and untidy, like a schoolboy's.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 619 in the tank of his mother, Lady Isaure, and lifted to the surface by a midwife in a rubber apron to cough his first water, Aurel was the first Vasht in three generations who could not keep air for a full day even as a child. His father, Prince Cassian, was declared “drowned at sea” in 624, which on a coast without a sea is a phrase everyone understands and nobody explains. Aurel was raised by tutors who knelt at the glass, by books printed on oilcloth, and by

his grandmother's voice coming up through the stones. He has been heir since he was five. He has been in the tank, except for an hour a day, since he was twelve. For the last nine days he has not surfaced at all.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The House of Vasht reigns and the Admiralty rules. Every Standing Order needs the prince's wet seal, which he presses through a hatch in the glass. In principle he may refuse; in practice he has never been asked anything except to sign. He depends on tank-tenders for warmth, food (raw fish, pushed through the hatch) and fresh brine, and on Chamberlain Odo Bracewell for everything else. He has one power the Admiralty fears: he can summon anyone in the land to the glass, and they must come.

He uses it. Once a month he summons someone with no stake in the court: a salt-merchant, a Netwatch hooker, a Wreckwife, a visiting outlander. He asks them what the sea is doing.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

◇ **Wax-slate and stylus** — he has worn through nine slates. The tenders scrape his questions off each evening and he chinks them again each morning.

- ◇ **The wet seal** — the Vasht seal-ring, a black stone matrix showing a lung with a fish in it. It must be pressed wet.
- ◇ **White silk wrap** — his only garment; rinsed daily. Fine silk, 30 lacks.
- ◇ **Oilcloth sea-chart** — the coast as it was in 500 A.G., before the Turning, with the soundings. He compares it to what visitors tell him.
- ◇ **A bottle of air** — stoppered glass, sealed in 619 by his mother on the day he was born, “so he would always have a breath of his own.” He holds it against the glass at night.
- ◇ **A list of questions** — chalked inside the tank lid, where only he can see: *Where does it go. Why does Grandmother want me. What was Father. Who was the eighth rope.*

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the truth about the sea, and company, and a friend who is not paid to kneel. He is curious, lonely and very clever, the only Vasht in a century to ask what the water wants. He fears the surface now: the air is thin and loud and burns. He fears that he no longer minds.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** he has heard his grandmother calling from the cellars every night for nine days, through the stone and the water, and he has begun to answer. He knocks on the glass in the rhythm she uses. The tenders have heard the knocking come back up through the floor.

**Secret he does not know:** his father Cassian was Called in 617, came back Tenanted in 618, and fathered him in 618. Ansby Wrack of the Cutwrights has the proof. Cassian was not drowned at sea in 624; he was retired to depth in the lowest cistern of Fathomhouse, beside his mother’s cellars, and the household fed him to the Dowager in 631. Aurel is the Seating she is waiting for.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Lady Ondine Vasht** — grandmother; the voice in the stone; she wants him to come down.
- ◇ **Lady Isaure Vasht** — his mother, in the next tank, deep in the Course, who has not spoken to anyone since 624 and watches him through two walls of glass.
- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — bows to the tank weekly and answers nothing. Aurel likes him and writes to him the questions he will not answer.
- ◇ **Dr. Isolde Reave** — his physician. She is the only person who has told him the truth about his lungs, and he asked her to open his chest and show him. She refused. He has asked again.
- ◇ **Nerys Colm** — he has summoned her three times. She will not come. He wants to hear the invitation and know if it is the same voice as his grandmother’s.
- ◇ **Ansby Wrack** — the Cutwright has asked for an audience. Chamberlain Bracewell has refused it four times.

**CHAMBERLAIN ODO BRACEWELL, MASTER OF THE HOUSEHOLD OF FATHOMHOUSE** Threat 4 (Deceive, Clause) · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (sword-cane 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. He has decided, alone, which of the retired-to-depth go down to the Dowager, and in what order, for nineteen years. He keeps the list in his head and has never once written it.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet him by summons: a footman in a rubber apron arrives at their lodging with a sealed and dripping order. They are taken to the Hall of Tanks and stand before the glass, and he asks them, in chalk, what they know.

- ◇ **The Audience.** Aurel asks the Guests to bring him Brenna Kelp’s number, or Ilse Marl’s chart, or Nerys Colm. He will pay with the wet seal: one Standing Order of their choosing.
- ◇ **Nine Days.** The tenders beg the Guests to persuade the prince to surface. When they try, he writes: **WHY. NONE OF YOU CAN BREATHE DOWN HERE. I DON’T ASK YOU TO COME DOWN.**
- ◇ **The Fourth Stair.** Aurel asks the Guests to go below to his grandmother and ask her one question for him. He will not tell them the question until they are on the stair.

To threat he is helpless and knows it, and his tank-tenders are armed. To kindness he is overwhelmingly grateful and writes too fast. To the god he is drifting. **If nobody intervenes:** on a night of the licked-clean moon in Lack, Aurel opens the hatch at the bottom of his tank, which leads to the drain, which leads to the cellars. By morning the tank is empty and the Headland’s ears are bleeding, and the cellars of Fathomhouse have begun to extend a third time, under the square, without any masons at all.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He asked me what the sea smelled like. I told him. He wrote **THANK YOU** so big it took the whole slate.” — a Saltwick salt-merchant

“I change his water every morning and every morning he looks at me like he wants to ask me something and doesn’t.” — a tank-tender, fourth floor

“A prince in a fish-tank asking us where the water’s gone. If he doesn’t know, God help the rest of us.” — a Lashings bailer

# ONDINE VASHT

*the Dowager Below*

*“Come down, child. Mind the stair. It is warmer than they told you.”*

– THE DOWAGER BELOW, HEARD THROUGH THE FLOORS OF FATHOMHOUSE  
EVERY NIGHT SINCE CARVING 641

| ONDINE VASHT – THE DOWAGER BELOW |                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Brinehollow · Cut 5 (Lung-line, the House of Vasht) · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, approaching the Seating) · Hunger 9                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                    | 86 · Dowager of the House of Vasht; once Princess Regnant                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING               | none (once Scion, Standing 5; she is beyond standing now)                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 4 · Gut 7 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 7                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                           | Godsign 6, Endure 5, Intimidate 5, Brawl 4, Instinct 4, Clause 3                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                             | Flesh 20 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Fray —                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                          | crushing grasp +8 (5, Pressure: on a Helping the target begins drowning on dry land)                                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                            | The Weight; Voice of the Deep (all within earshot make a Calling roll at Grim); Pressure Day (once a night: the palace air thickens; all within suffer –2 to every roll and ears bleed); Fathom-Body |
| WANTS                            | To Keep Under; the boy                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                           | Dowager’s Patience; Kin-Sense                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                     | The Devotion (to Aurel)                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                          | the great seal of Vasht; her wedding rope; nine rings; the bones of the fed; a lector on the fourth stair                                                                                            |
| DREAD                            | 4 (to see her whole)                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Nobody living has seen all of her. From the fourth stair, holding a lantern over the flooded cellars of Fathomhouse, a visitor sees a black surface that rises and falls very slowly, as if breathing, and parts of her. A grey hand resting on the bottom step, as long as a man’s arm, its nails thick and yellow as horn, three gold rings sunk into flesh that has swollen over them. An eye beneath the water, wide as a dinner plate, black, that turns to follow the lantern. The curve of a back turning, pebbled like a reef. The cellars smell of the deep and of something sweeter and older under it. Her voice comes up through the stone of the whole palace, slow and courteous and very clear, an old lady’s voice with the sea behind it, and it is always kind.

## THEIR STORY

Ondine was born in 555, a Vasht of the senior line, married her cousin Prince Alaric in 573 and ruled as Princess Regnant from his death in 590. She was the last Vasht to sit a throne in air; she moved to the tanks in 596 and below them in 604. The cellars were extended in 612 and again in 634, because she had grown too large. She has not been Tenanted. She has never walked to the sea. The sea, the household says, has come to her. In 609 the first of the retired-

to-depth was carried down to her cellar, dead and weighted, and the Dowager grew quiet and stopped calling for the west. The household has carried them down ever since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She still signs the family’s letters. The great seal of Vasht went down with her in 604, and documents that need it are lowered in a weighted basket and come back sealed, wet, with a print in the wax that is not quite a ring. Every Prince of Vasht since has ruled with her consent. The Admiralty does not know how much of Brinehollow’s law has been approved, in the last thirty-seven years, by something in a cellar. The household fears her, feeds her and keeps her calm, because the household has worked out what happens if she walks.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The great seal of Vasht** — bronze, the size of a fist, held in her palm. Her flesh has grown around its handle.
- ◇ **Her wedding rope** — braided silk and silver wire with the hair of nine Vasht ancestors, still tied to an iron ring on the cellar wall. It is the only thing anchoring her. It is stretched taut toward the west.

- ◇ **Nine rings** — on a hand too large for them; the gold has sunk under the skin and shows as bright lines when she moves.
- ◇ **The bones of the fed** — the cellar floor is paved with them, three deep, white and soft as chalk.
- ◇ **A lector on the fourth stair** — a blind servant who reads the Vasht chronicles aloud to her every night. The present lector is the ninth. The others went down the stairs.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the boy. She wants him to come down out of the thin air and be warm, and be with her, and not be alone, and she has wanted it with all the patience of the deep for twenty-two years. She fears nothing, except a little, still, the dark at the top of the stairs.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** she is not Tenanted; she is Seating, slowly, and the House of Vasht has been feeding her the retired-to-depth to keep her from going west and taking the palace with her. When she Seats, the Headland goes with her: Fathomhouse, the Sounding Hall, the Admiralty House and the tide-post, down into what the cellars have become.

**Secret she does not know:** she believes she is becoming the god and wants her grandson for company in the deep. She is not the one Seating. She is the shell. What has been growing in her for forty years has been growing toward Aurel, and when he comes down it will leave her for him, and the thing in the cellar will be, for one terrible moment, only an old woman again, drowning.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Prince Aurel Vasht** — the boy. Everything.
- ◇ **Chamberlain Odo Bracewell** — the man who feeds her. She calls him “dear” and has asked him, very gently, when he will come down himself.
- ◇ **Prince Cassian Vasht** — her son, Tenanted, whom she ate in 631. She remembers it as a visit.
- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — she signs his orders. She thinks of him as “the nice captain.”
- ◇ **Father Ebb** — she knew him as a Basketfoot fisher-lad who brought the palace its fish in the 580s. She knows the name of his girl, and has sent the name up to him in the basket, once, unsigned, to see whether he would come down.
- ◇ **Justice Maren Oake** — the Passenger in the Justice visits the fourth stair once a year, alone, and the two of them speak below hearing.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet her only if summoned below, which the household treats as both an honour and a funeral: they are bathed, dressed in rubber, given a lantern and led to the fourth stair. Or they meet her because Aurel sends them.

- ◇ **The Question.** Aurel’s question for her is: *What was my father?* She answers it truthfully and kindly, and it is a Dread 4 answer.
- ◇ **The Last of the Retired.** Bracewell has run out of the retired-to-depth. He asks the Guests to procure “one more” from the Underpier. He does not say what for.
- ◇ **The Rope.** The Second Table wants the Dowager’s wedding rope cut, to see what she does. Commodore Vell asks the Guests to do it, as a favour, for a great deal of money.

To threat she is patient and immense; nothing hurts her much. To kindness she is a grandmother. To the god she is a door. **If nobody intervenes:** Aurel comes down in Lack. The Headland sinks forty feet in a night, level, as if the ground breathed in, and the indoor tide in every cellar of the coast rises to the ceiling, and stays.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She asked me to read her the Beaching chapter again. Then she asked whether I could swim. Then she said never mind, dear, you won’t need to.” — the ninth lector

“Her Highness has never once been unkind. That is not the same as safe.” — Chamberlain Odo Bracewell

“You can hear her in the drains on the Headland. Old Granny Fathom, talking in her sleep.” — a Headland chimney-sweep

# FATHER EBB

*Abbot of the Hanging Abbey*

*“Every night it asks. Every night I say not tonight. Fifty-one years of not tonight. You’d think one of us would get bored.”*

— FATHER EBB, TO A POSTULANT ON THE LOWER ROCKS, LAUGHING

| FATHER EBB – ABBOT OF THE HANGING ABBEY |                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 2                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                           | 78 · Abbot of the Anchorites; holder of the Rock for 51 years                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | Celebrant (the Anchorites) · Standing 5 (Abbot)                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                         |
| SKILLS                                  | Resolve 6, Rites 4, Endure 4, Lore 3, Instinct 3, Persuade 2                                                                |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                                 | none                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                   | Fathom-Body; The Refusal (once a night, he may make the Calling roll in place of anyone within sight of him)                |
| WANTS                                   | The West, every night, unanswered                                                                                           |
| KNACKS                                  | No Thank You; Old Grief                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | Kept Grief (Coralie Fenn; roused by her name, or by the basket)                                                             |
| CARRIES                                 | the collar and chain; canvas habit; basket-letters; one copy of Brenna Kelp’s finding; a white shell; a knotted prayer-cord |
| DREAD                                   | 1 (to see the collar’s healed flesh)                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

A skeleton in a canvas habit stiff with salt, sitting cross-legged on a ledge four hundred feet up a black cliff, with an iron collar round his neck that his flesh has healed over like bark over a nail. His skin is the grey of the Course, crusted white where the dusk bailing runs down the rock. His hands are horn from gripping the chain. His eyes are wide and black and very merry. His voice is soft and rough, and he laughs often, mostly at himself. He smells of salt, rust and the wind. Visitors who climb to him expect a saint and find a cheerful old man who asks them about their families and listens to the answers.

## THEIR STORY

He was born Edric Pell in 563, a fisherman’s son of Basketfoot when Basketfoot still had boats. In 589 he was twenty-six and in love with Coralie Fenn, a net-mender’s daughter of nineteen who had begun to stand at west windows. Before her Calling, at the Appetite, she made him swear on her own rope: *If I go, don’t you follow. Whatever comes back, don’t you follow it.* She went in Plenty 589. She came back in thirty-three days, Tenanted, gentle, heavier, and came to his door and asked him to walk with her to the water. He said no. That winter, afraid of how much he wanted to say yes, he climbed the

cliff and had the Abbey’s smith collar him to the rock. He took the name Ebb. He has been there fifty-one years, Abbot for thirty.

Coralie married a ropemaker, Daw Colm, in 611, and bore a daughter, Nerys, in 613. Every Low Water she stood at the foot of the cliff and looked up. In 633 she walked into the sea again and did not return. In 629 Ebb felt the chain give in his hand: rusted through at the third link. He has held it together, in his fist, every night since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Abbot keeps a thousand chained monks alive: their food baskets, water, the basket-letters, the counsel of the dying. He decides who may take the permanent collar and who must climb down. He is the Debt doctrine’s living proof, and every Debt chapel on the coast preaches him. The Anchorites depend on Basketfoot’s winches and the Wreckwives’ charity. He depends on nothing he will admit to.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The collar and chain** — Oathen iron, forged 590. The third link is rust through. He keeps it closed in his fist when he sleeps, and the monks think it is a holy gesture.



- ◇ **Canvas habit** — salt-stiff; replaced every Knotting.
- ◇ **Basket-letters** — a bundle, tied with weed: one a year for twenty-six years from Winchmaster Cobb Fennick, unsigned, asking forgiveness for something never named.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp's finding** — one of the three copies, wrapped in oilskin in a crack in his ledge. He has read it. He was not surprised.
- ◇ **A white shell** — pink-lipped and whorled; it came up in the food basket in 633, the week Coralie walked. Isolde Reave would know the species, because there is none.
- ◇ **Prayer-cord** — fifty-one knots, one for each year. He ties a new one each Knotting.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants his monks to endure, and wants, more quietly, to know whether enduring is worth it. He fears that he has spent his life keeping a promise to a girl who no longer exists, against a woman who loved him.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** the chain has been rusted through for twelve years, and he knows it. What holds him is the promise, sworn on Coralie's rope, and the oath on the dead works on him every night as surely as iron.

**Secret he does not know:** Coralie's daughter Nerys turned around in the surf in 636, and what turned her was her mother's voice in the chorus, saying *don't you follow*. The same words. Coralie, or whatever wore her, kept the promise too.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Nerys Colm** — Coralie's daughter. He has never met her. He knows exactly who she is.
- ◇ **Coralie Fenn** — Called 589, Tenanted, walked again 633. The rope he swore on is in his fist.
- ◇ **Justice Maren Oake** — they have written yearly since 625. He addresses his letters to Maren, and the replies come in two hands.
- ◇ **Mother Limpet** — his great rival. She climbed his cliff in 618 and they argued for two days. He liked her enormously.
- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — she climbed to ask him what she is saving the Called from. He told her: "From me. From being me, fifty years from now." She has not decided if that was an answer.
- ◇ **Lady Ondine Vasht** — she sent him Coralie's name in a basket, unsigned. He knew the hand.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet him by climbing the cliff, a day's work (Lung + Athletics vs Hard 14, three times). He wants news, company and, from those who seem honest, a judgment: whether his life has been worth it.

- ◇ **The Third Link.** A Postulant has seen the rust. Word is spreading on the cliff. If the Abbot's chain is broken, whose is

not?

- ◇ **The Copy.** The Admiralty, the Second Table and the Wreckwives all know one of Kelp's copies is on the cliff. Someone is climbing tonight with a knife.
- ◇ **The Daughter.** The Guests bring Nerys to the foot of the cliff, or her words to the ledge. Ebb asks them to repeat the invitation to him. If they do, Ebb makes his roll at Dire, and the whole cliff listens.

To threat he laughs. To kindness he weeps easily and is embarrassed. To the god he is refusal itself, worn thin. **If nobody intervenes:** on the next Low Water after Nerys's letter is read in public, Father Ebb opens his fist. A thousand monks watch him walk down the cliff path he has not walked in fifty-one years, still wearing the collar, the broken chain dragging behind him. By the next Knotting, a third of the cliff is empty, collar after collar left hanging open on its ring.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He asked after my mam's leg. Fifty years chained to a rock and he wanted to know about her leg." — a Basketfoot girl who carries the baskets

"Ebb is the proof that the Debt can be paid in full, every night, by one man. I would like him to tell me what it buys." — Mother Limpet

"The old man holds his chain in his fist like a child holds a hand. You don't do that with iron." — a Bound monk of the high face



# TOLLY BRACK

## the Bailer Boy

*“Bail-o! Bail-o! Old ones, sick ones, drunk ones! A crumb a cough, a token a tip, and I won’t tell your mother!”*

– TOLLY BRACK, UP THE LASHINGS AT FIRST BELL

| TOLLY BRACK – THE BAILER BOY |                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Brinehollow · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                |
| AGE & STATION                | 11 · Parish bailer of Miles Twelve to Fourteen                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING           | none (parish bailer; the Bailers’ Wardens trust him)                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                |
| SKILLS                       | Instinct 4, Filch 3, Stitching 2, Search 2, Persuade 2, Athletics 1, Endure 0                                      |
| BODY                         | Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                      | fist +2 (1)                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                        | Salt-Sense (he reads Regrowth from bail-water, and more: the color tells him who will be Called within the season) |
| WANTS                        | none active yet                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                       | Scrap-Born Luck; Second Chair                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | none                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                      | bail-tokens on a string; his mother’s knife; a glass jar; a Netwatch tally; a sweet; his own bucket                |
| DREAD                        | 0                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

A small, freckled, sharp-elbowed boy under a crust of salt-grime, with strong thin hands and a voice cracked from shouting up the Mile at dawn. He wears a man’s oilskin cut down at the cuffs, a waist-rope of mismatched pieces, and no shoes. He is quick, cheeky, and kinder than he lets anyone see. When he bails an old woman, holding her face-down over his bony knee and pounding between her shoulders, he sings her the bailing song under his breath, all the verses, the way his mother sang it.

### THEIR STORY

Tolly was born in 630 on Mile Thirteen to Bryony Brack, a cannery woman, and no father anyone named. In 636 his mother reached the Appetite, and through one long Lack she begged him, at night, roped to the ring, to cut her loose. He was six. He would not. She went anyway, on a licked-clean night in Grace, her rope frayed through against the iron ring in a way that must have taken weeks. Tolly began bailing for crumbs that summer. By nine he had noticed the colors. By ten he could tell a family which of them would go before Tablenight.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He bails some forty people a day across three miles, mostly the old, the sick and the drunk, for a crumb or a bail-token each, paid from the Bucket of the Unbailed when they cannot pay. The Bailers’ Wardens rely on him. Families rely on him not to say what he sees. He sleeps in Mags Netherby’s loft, roped to her chain.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Bail-tokens on a string** — some sixty; he earns more than most grown men of the Lashings.
- ◇ **His mother’s knife** — a small cannery blade, curved, for opening mussels. Tolly keeps it in his boot. Otiline Hawse has asked to see it.
- ◇ **A glass jar** — he keeps a mouthful of each client’s dawn water in it for a moment, to hold to the light.
- ◇ **A Netwatch tally** — given him by Lieutenant Sable Reef, for running to fetch the Watch on a Calling night.
- ◇ **A boiled sweet** — from a Gilt Mile lady. He is saving it.
- ◇ **His bucket** — tin, his mother’s. He no longer looks in it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants his mother. He fears the blue he has started to see in his own bucket, faint, at the bottom, like dye.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** Tolly is the child Ottiline Hawse knows. He has cut forty ropes in a year, from below, with his mother's knife: only the ones whose water was deepest blue, only the ones who begged, after their families slept. He did it because his mother begged for a whole winter and he said no, and she went anyway, after weeks of pain. He thinks he is being kind. Some of the forty were.

**Secret he does not know:** two of the forty came back Tenanted, and they know exactly who cut their ropes, and they are grateful, and they have been watching over him at night.

## TIES

- ◇ **Mags Netherby** — the Bailers' Warden who gives him a bed; she suspects the knife and has told no one.
- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — gave him the tally. He worships her.
- ◇ **Ottiline Hawse** — knows. Has said nothing yet.
- ◇ **Sennet Gull** — he bails her neighbour; he has seen something in Sennet's water he does not understand.
- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — Tolly saw the blue in the silver bucket. Nobody paid him.
- ◇ **Bryony Brack** — his mother, Called 636. Some mornings, in the Under, a Picker child says her name for him.

## IN PLAY

Guests meet him at dawn, at the door of anyone they are visiting. For a crumb, he will tell them who on a street is close to going. He wants work, sweets and someone to tell him he did right.

- ◇ **The Color.** Tolly sees deep blue in a Guest's bucket, and does not say.
- ◇ **Forty Ropes.** Hired to find the rope-cutter of the Lashings, the Guests find an eleven-year-old boy. What then?
- ◇ **The Watchers.** Two Tenanted stand under Mags Netherby's loft every night. Tolly thinks they want to hurt him.

**If nobody intervenes:** at the next Knotting Ottiline Hawse brings his name to the Bench, and the Bench, finding the cuts were

kindness, finds them his. A boy cannot be loosed for life. The Bench looses him for one night. He walks.

## SAID OF THEM

"He's got hands like a little hammer and the voice of an angel and I'd trust him with my last breath. I have, twice a day." — Mags Netherby, Bailers' Warden of Mile Fourteen

"He looked in my bucket and went quiet. Nobody's ever gone quiet for me before." — a Lashings drunk

"He's a good boy, and he's carrying something I'd not want my own to carry." — Ottiline Hawse

# SENNET GULL

## the Wreckwife

*“He says thank you for his dinner. Six years married and he never once said thank you.  
Now he says it every night, and I sit there and I think, who taught you that?”*

— SENNET GULL, AT THE MIDDLE MILE WRECKWIVES’ TABLE

| SENNET GULL – THE WRECKWIFE |                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                              |
| AGE & STATION               | 34 · mussel-cannery worker, Mile Fourteen; Sister of the Line                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING          | none (cannery); Wreckwives Standing 2 (Sister of the Line)                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                  |
| SKILLS                      | Labor 3, Blades 2, Instinct 3, Endure 2, Haggle 2, Resolve 2                                                         |
| BODY                        | Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                     | shucking knife +5 (2)                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                       | Deep Breath                                                                                                          |
| WANTS                       | none active                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                      | Iron Stomach; Old Grief                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                | none yet; she is close to The Impostors, the other way round                                                         |
| CARRIES                     | shucking knife; Davey’s dinner pail; cistern key; Davey’s old belt; her wedding bucket; a Wreckwives’ name-book page |
| DREAD                       | 0                                                                                                                    |

### WHO THEY ARE

A sharp-faced, red-knuckled woman with her hair tied up in a cannery cloth, smelling of mussels, brine and carbolic soap. She talks fast, laughs harshly, and her hands never stop: shucking, darning, wringing. There is an old white scar through her left eyebrow and another at the corner of her mouth.

### THEIR STORY

Born on Mile Fourteen in 607, she married Davey Gull, a pier-hauler, in 629. Old Davey drank, and when he drank he hit, and the scars are his. In Lack 638 he was Called; Sennet had tied his knot. She has asked herself, every night since, whether she tied it well. He came back after twenty-six days, kind. She keeps him in the cistern under the house, because he is more comfortable there, brings him his dinner, and sits on the edge and talks about her day while he floats on his back with his black eyes open, and says the right things.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She works eleven hours a day in the cannery, sits at the Wreckwives’ table once a week, and goes home to Davey. She is no one of importance, which makes her the Wreckwives’ perfect test: an

ordinary woman, an ordinary Tenanted husband, an ordinary question.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Shucking knife** — (knife, 2) short and hooked. She can open a mussel blind in a second.
- ◇ **Davey’s dinner pail** — every evening: raw Uncovered shellfish, cold, salted.
- ◇ **The cistern key** — she locks it, from outside. She has never said why.
- ◇ **Davey’s old belt** — heavy, brass-buckled. She keeps it in a drawer and does not know whether as a memento or as evidence.
- ◇ **Her wedding bucket** — Davey’s, swapped at the wedding. Old Davey’s bucket.
- ◇ **A name-book page** — the Wreckwives’ record of Davey Gull, in her own hand: *returned 638. Kind.*

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know whether she is allowed to be happy. She fears that she prefers him, and what that says about her; that the man she married is still in there, folded small, watching her love his replacement.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** she can no longer remember old Davey's voice, and has wondered, in the dark, whether the thing in the cistern took that too, as a kindness.

**Secret she does not know:** she is carrying Davey's child. The child is the Tenanted Davey's, conceived after his return. Tolly Brack has seen a new thread in her bail-water, a fine dark blue line like ink in a glass, and has no word for it. Ansby Wrack of the Cutwrights would.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Davey Gull** — her husband; Tenanted since 638. Gentle, grateful, patient.
- ◇ **Widow-Mother Agna Spurling** — Sennet's sponsor; the one woman who says aloud she loves her returned husband more. Sennet hates her a little for it.
- ◇ **Esk Penhallow** — Sennet visits him on his step. If he is truly himself and his wife will not have him, she wants to know what that means for her.
- ◇ **Tolly Brack** — bails her neighbour; looks at her strangely.
- ◇ **Orrin Wake** — fished with Davey before. He tells Sennet that the Passenger in him knows Davey's Passenger, and that it is "a decent sort."
- ◇ **Ansby Wrack** — the Cutwright has asked to take Sennet's blood. Sennet said no.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet her at a Wreckwives' table, asking for advice she does not want.

- ◇ **The Voice.** Sennet asks the Guests to find someone who remembers old Davey's voice: a drinking friend, a brother. When they find him, does she want to hear it?
- ◇ **The Belt.** A neighbour tells the Guests that Sennet has twice been seen at night on the cistern's edge with old Davey's belt in her hand.
- ◇ **The Cutwright.** Wrack asks the Guests to obtain Sennet's blood, quietly, before the child shows.

**If nobody intervenes:** Sennet bears a quiet, grey, black-eyed daughter in Plenty 642, who does not cry and does not need to bail.

Davey sings to her in the lower voice. Sennet stops coming to the Wreckwives' table.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Sennet tells it straight and doesn't cry. That's the rule. She's the only one I've seen who doesn't cry because she's angry." — the Keeper of Names, Middle Mile

"New Davey brings her a shell every Low Water. Old Davey brought her a black eye every payday. You tell me." — a cannery woman

"She's afraid of being happy. That's the most Brinehollow thing I've ever heard." — Reeve Calder Stokes

# DR. ISOLDE REAVE

*Surgeon of the Drowned Chest*

*“Hold the lamp lower. No, lower. Do you see it moving? Clockwise. Westward. It’s a current, and it is not his.”*

– DR. ISOLDE REAVE, TO HER APPRENTICE, AT THE HIGH-TIDE OPENING OF A DROWNED FISHERMAN, 637

| ISOLDE REAVE – SURGEON OF THE DROWNED CHEST |                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                        |
| AGE & STATION                               | 45 · lung surgeon of the Headland; lecturer to the Seamers                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Seamer · Standing 4 (Master Seamer)                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                            |
| SKILLS                                      | Stitching 5, Reckoning 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Resolve 2, Blades 1, Endure 0                      |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                         |
| ATTACKS                                     | scalpel +5 (2)                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                                       | Salt-Sense                                                                                     |
| WANTS                                       | none active; To Keep Under is close (she hides her findings in a second hand)                  |
| KNACKS                                      | Steady Hands; Butcher’s Calm                                                                   |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | none yet                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                                     | surgeon’s case; the jar; a lead box of fourteen shells; the Current Book; spectacles; carbolic |
| DREAD                                       | 1 (her rooms, at high tide, when the jars move)                                                |

## WHO THEY ARE

Thin and upright, with steel spectacles, iron-grey hair pinned flat and a leather apron stiff with brine and old blood. Her rooms on the Headland smell of carbolic and low tide. She speaks precisely and quietly and is impatient with anyone slower than she is, which is everyone. She hums when she works, not tunes, but long rising notes, and has not noticed that they are the same notes the Tenanted sing at Low Water.

## THEIR STORY

Born on Mile Two in 596, apprenticed at fifteen to Master Quillon Barr, later Surgeon to the Table, she opened her first Course chest at twenty-two. In 634 she opened a drowned man’s chest at high tide and found the water in his lungs moving in a slow circle, westward, though he had been dead six hours. In the next she found a shell, alive, pink and whorled, of no known species. It is in a jar on her desk. It has grown to the size of a fist. In 638 she began opening chests that were not yet drowned.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the coast’s foremost lung surgeon: physician to the prince, certifier of deaths for the Admiralty (she signed the four hanged officers), teacher of the Seamers and the woman families bring their Course-stricken to. She buys the drowned from the Netwatch and the Underpier at 5 lacks a body. Her power is knowledge, and she trades it carefully.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Surgeon’s case** — (+1 Stitching; can amputate) Barr’s own, given her on his leaving.
- ◇ **The jar** — the first shell, the size of a fist now, which turns slowly to face west and hums at the tide.
- ◇ **A lead box of fourteen shells** — one from every chest she has opened since 638, living and dead. She keeps them apart. She has never laid them side by side.
- ◇ **The Current Book** — her notes: rate, direction and volume of the water in every chest. The figures from the living are in cipher.
- ◇ **Spectacles** — steel; she sees nothing without them, and the lenses fog with salt at the tide.

- ◇ **Carbolic** — two pints, which she uses for everything, including her hands, until they crack.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to understand. She fears that she does: that the lungs of the coast are not diseased but *occupied*, and that what lives in them is the same everywhere.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** she has opened eleven living chests since 638, nine with consent, two without: a Lashings drunk she was certain would die anyway, and her own apprentice, Dorran Swell, under poppy, who still does not know. The shells are in the living too.

**Secret she does not know:** the fourteen shells are not fourteen creatures. They are pieces of one. Laid side by side, edge to edge, they fit, and they make the first curve of a plate of black-lined slate, like the plates on Dromm's back in the oldest accounts. They are growing toward each other in the box.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Prince Aurel Vasht** — her patient. She told him the truth about his lungs. He has asked her to open his chest and show him.
- ◇ **Master Quillon Barr** — her old master, now Surgeon to the Table on the Rim. She writes to him; he has begun asking for samples.
- ◇ **Dr. Halloran Quease** — the Sallowreach physician; a correspondent. He catalogues pain. She has sent him a new kind.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — Reave's volume figures match Kelp's. They have met once, at night, and compared.
- ◇ **Ilse Marl** — the choir-mistress heard Reave humming and asked where she learned the Low Water song.
- ◇ **Dry Jonah Skerry** — sells her bail-water from the Vigil's brine-drinkers. Their lungs have shells in them too.

#### IN PLAY

Guests meet her when they need a Course chest explained, a body procured, or a companion examined.

- ◇ **The Procurement.** Reave needs a fresh drowned chest, opened within the hour, at high tide. The Netwatch has none tonight.
- ◇ **The Apprentice.** Dorran Swell has begun to hum. He asks the Guests why there is a scar under his ribs.
- ◇ **The Box.** A thief breaks into Reave's rooms; the shells are spilled and roll together on the floor, and fit.

**If nobody intervenes:** Reave lays the shells together herself, in Lack, and sees. She opens her own chest that night, under a mirror, with steady hands. Her apprentice finds the Current Book's last entry in plain writing: *Direction westward. It is in me also. It is one thing.*

#### SAID OF THEM

"She took my husband's body for five lacks and sent back a letter explaining exactly what killed him. Nobody ever explained anything to me before." — a Lashings widow

"Isolde was my best pupil and the only one who frightened me." — Master Quillon Barr

"She hums. Down there at Low Water they hum like that. I'd know it anywhere." — Ilse Marl

# HASK TARN

the Pilot

*“Six fathom, sand bottom. Mind, it shelves. Now step where I step and don’t look at the white patch. That’s eleven fathom and no bottom at all, and it’s listening.”*

— HASK TARN, LEADING A SALVAGE CREW PAST THE WRECK ORCHARD

| HASK TARN – THE PILOT |                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT            | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                         |
| AGE & STATION         | gives his age as sixty; the Admiralty rolls say seventy-four · Uncovered pilot                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING    | Delver (the salvage crews) · Standing 4                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES            | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                |
| SKILLS                | Wayfaring 5, Search 4, Lore 3, Instinct 3, Endure 1, Blades 1, Haggle 1                                            |
| BODY                  | Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4                                                                             |
| ATTACKS               | gutting knife +4 (2)                                                                                               |
| GIFTS                 | Deep Breath; Tide-Sight                                                                                            |
| WANTS                 | The West (roused by the white patches, the places he lost the bottom); The Silence (roused by questions about 581) |
| KNACKS                | Corpse-Road Walker; Light Sleeper                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS          | none                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES               | sounding-lead; tarred oilskin; gutting knife; marker-stakes; the pilot’s book of 581; a flask of rum               |
| DREAD                 | 0                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Lean, weathered, stooped, with skin like an old sail and eyes narrowed to slits against the salt glare. Around his neck on a tarred cord hangs a sounding-lead, a seven-pound bell of lead with a hollow at the base for tallow, and he swings it as he walks, and calls depths no one else can see: “Six fathom here, sand bottom; mind, it shelves.” He smells of tar, rum and the Uncovered. He is never lost.

## THEIR STORY

Hask Tarn was born in 567 on Mile Four, a pilot’s son, and was holding the lead-line on his father’s boat by ten. In 581, aged fourteen, he had the tiller one night far out off the Keelrow shelf while his father slept off a bottle, and steered them over a place where the lead struck something flat at forty fathom, and came up warm. He has never told that to anyone. He became a pilot himself, and in 588 piloted the *Steadfast* on the fleet’s last voyage, a boy called Corvin Sund at his elbow on the lead. When the sea left he followed it on foot. In about 627 he decided he would be sixty, and has stayed sixty since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the best of the dozen pilots who guide salvage crews across the Uncovered, at 6 lacks a party a day. Kessa Drowle hires him to survey the slope. Salvage-brokers on the Gilt Mile pay him to read new ground before they bid. He navigates by remembered depth, and his memory of the sea floor is the map of the Uncovered. He will not go near the white patches, the places where he once lost the bottom, where the lead ran out of line. They are still there on the mud: pale, soft circles, bottomless, and on still nights they breathe.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The sounding-lead** — his father’s. He arms the hollow with tallow, swings it, and reads what sticks: sand, mud, shell. On the Uncovered nothing sticks. He reads it anyway.
- ◇ **Tarred oilskin** — (Armor 1) stiff as board.
- ◇ **Gutting knife** — (knife, 2).
- ◇ **Marker-stakes** — a bundle of twenty, painted with his mark, for the tracks he leaves for crews he trusts.
- ◇ **The pilot’s book of 581** — his father’s, with one page in a boy’s hand: a bearing, a depth, and the word *warm*.
- ◇ **A flask of rum** — Saltwick, refilled at every tavern.



## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants one more season's pay, and then one more. He fears the day his memory of the depths fails him, and he fears the white patches.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** he knows the way to the Stone Table; he steered over it in 581, and the lead came up warm. Cray Lobbett has been trying to make him say so for two years.

**Secret he does not know:** he has begun to remember depths in places no ship of his ever sailed: west of the Trench edge, under the black water, down the long slope. The soundings come to him at night, exact, in fathoms, and they go down much further than any sea on the Table. They are not his memories.

## TIES

- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — the boy on the lead. Hask has refused his commission three times.
- ◇ **Kessa Drowle** — his employer and drinking companion. He tells her where the ground will fall.
- ◇ **Cray Lobbett** — begs him to confirm the table. Hask buys him drinks and changes the subject.
- ◇ **Ilse Marl** — her chart matches his depths, except in eleven places, where it is deeper.
- ◇ **Dagna Hull** — she wants him to pilot the *Follow*'s trial at the Trench edge. He has said maybe, which he has never said to anything.
- ◇ **Gannet Shale** — he took her out once and brought her back. He believes her story.

## IN PLAY

Guests hire him. He is honest, sour, and worth every lack.

- ◇ **The White Patch.** A crew member steps in one. Hask swings the lead out over the circle, and the line goes and goes, and something below gives it a slow, polite tug.
- ◇ **Forty Fathom, Warm.** Cray Lobbett offers the Guests a fortune to get Hask drunk enough to give the bearing.
- ◇ **New Soundings.** Hask begins calling depths that cannot be right. He is never wrong.

**If nobody intervenes:** Hask pilots the *Follow*'s trial, and at the Trench edge calls a depth nobody has ever heard: a number, then

another, steadily, out loud, all night, down into the thousands. In the morning his lead and line are gone, and he is sitting on the edge, smiling, counting.

## SAID OF THEM

"Hask says it shelves, it shelves. He's never been wrong. I'd follow him into the Trench. That's what scares me." — a Wreck Orchard salvager

"He's been sixty for fourteen years. I'm not about to argue." — Purser-Clerk Aldo Penwarden

"He swings that lead like he's asking the ground a question. Some days I swear it answers." — Kessa Drowle

# NERYS COLM

the Half-Called

*“Don’t put your ear to the tube. I mean it. I’ll talk, you listen from over there by the door.  
If I start to sing, leave. If I start to say your name, run.”*

– NERYS COLM, THROUGH THE WAX-SEALED DOOR ON MILE SEVEN

| NERYS COLM – THE HALF-CALLED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Brinehollow · Cut 2 (the Cutwrights say 3; her mother was Tenanted) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                | 28 · self-confined in the Netwatch barracks, Mile Seven                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CALLING & STANDING           | none (once a net-mender)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                       | Resolve 4, Godsign 4, Instinct 3, Persuade 3, Athletics 2, Endure 2, Craft 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                         | Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                      | none she will use                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| GIFTS                        | Fathom-Body (one eye only sees in the dark); Voice of the Deep; The Invitation (Tongue + Godsign: she repeats what she heard in the surf; everyone who hears it, awake or asleep, makes a Calling roll at Dire (22), and a Guest who fails takes a Dread 4 check as well; she has never failed to make it work) |
| WANTS                        | The West; The Silence (she keeps it, mostly)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                       | No Thank You; Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | The Pull (roused by Fray 8+ or the sound of surf)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                      | wax; slate; her mother’s net-needle; a stone from Harbor End; Reef’s bucket; the missing letter, once                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                        | 3 (to hear her begin to say it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Wild salt-stiff hair, sun-burned skin flaking at the cheekbones, a net-mender’s hard fingers. Her left eye is still blue. Her right eye has gone wholly black, wide and wet, and she sees out of it in the dark. Her voice is low and husky from disuse, and when she is tired a second voice moves under it, not a man’s or a woman’s, like a crowd far off. She jokes darkly and often, then goes silent for days.

## THEIR STORY

Nerys was born in 613 on Mile Five to Daw Colm, a ropemaker, and Coralie Fenn, who had been Called in 589 and come back. Her mother was kind, slow, heavy, and stood at the foot of the Hanging Abbey every Low Water without saying why. In 633 Coralie walked into the sea again and did not return. In 636 Nerys was Called. She walked from Mile Five to Harbor End, down the steps, and out into the surf, up to her chin. And then, uniquely in six centuries of record, she turned around. She walked back up the steps, wet to the hair, and asked the Netwatch to lock her up. She has heard the invitation in full. She can repeat it. Nobody who has listened to her has stayed ashore.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is a secret the Netwatch keeps and the whole Mile knows. She lives in a room above the net-loft with wax in the keyhole and a speaking-tube she will not use, by her own request. Lieutenant Sable Reef brings her food and books. The Deepening would give anything for her. The Admiralty wants her silent. The Wreckwives want to know what she heard.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Beeswax** — a pound of it, for the keyhole, the tube and her own ears at Low Water.
- ◇ **A slate** — she writes on it when she must talk and does not trust her voice.
- ◇ **Her mother’s net-needle** — bone; she mends the Netwatch nets with it.
- ◇ **A stone from Harbor End** — taken from the bottom step on the night she turned. It is still wet.
- ◇ **Sable Reef’s bucket** — Reef swapped buckets with her in 637. Neither has explained it.

- ◇ **The letter** — she wrote the invitation down once, in a letter she meant to burn. It is missing.

| D6 | WHO HAS THE LETTER                                                                                  |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Lieutenant Sable Reef took it to keep it safe, and has read it every night since.                   |
| 2  | Mother Limpet; a Wader in the Netwatch stole it. She has not read it aloud yet. She cannot hear it. |
| 3  | Commodore Lysander Vell, who plans to have it read at the Trench edge.                              |
| 4  | Prince Aurel; it came to him in a weighted basket from the cellars.                                 |
| 5  | Nobody. Nerys did not write it. She dreamed she did, and the paper she found was blank and wet.     |
| 6  | It is in the indoor tide. It surfaces in cellars, a page at a time, in her handwriting.             |

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know what made her turn. She fears she knows: under the chorus of the invitation there was an eighth voice, lower than the others, and it was hungry.

**Secret (the GM may reveal):** the letter, and what it could do read aloud on a procession night.

**Secret she does not know:** what turned her was her mother's voice in the chorus, saying *don't you follow*: the same words Coralie made Father Ebb swear in 589. And her mother walked in again in 633 not because she was called, but because something else was answering, and she went to stand in front of it.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — keeper, friend, the only person she speaks to through the door.
- ◇ **Father Ebb** — her mother's sweetheart. She has never heard his name.
- ◇ **Mother Limpet** — wants her at the head of a procession.
- ◇ **Prince Aurel Vasht** — has summoned her three times. She has refused, because she likes the sound of him.
- ◇ **Coralie Fenn** — her mother. Twice Called. Gone.
- ◇ **Ilse Marl** — has asked her to hum the invitation, just the tune, for the chart. Nerys is tempted.

## IN PLAY

Guests meet her through Lieutenant Reef, behind a door.

- ◇ **The Missing Letter.** Roll on the table; follow it.
- ◇ **The Eighth Voice.** Nerys asks the Guests whether anyone else has ever heard a hungry voice under the sea. Gannet Shale and Cray Lobbett both have.
- ◇ **The Cliff.** Bring her to the foot of the Hanging Abbey at Low Water. Ebb will know her face; it is Coralie's.

**If nobody intervenes:** on the night her letter is read aloud, Nerys takes the wax from her ears, opens the door, and walks down the Mile in silence with hundreds behind her. At Harbor End she turns again, and they do not.

## SAID OF THEM

"She makes me stand by the door. Two years. She's the bravest person I know and I've pulled three hundred out of the sea." — Lieutenant Sable Reef

"The Colm girl's window: don't stand under it at Low Water. You'll hear her humming and you'll want to go for a walk." — a Mile Seven mother to her son

"She turned around. Six hundred years, and she turned around. I would kneel to her if she'd open the door." — Mother Limpet

# THE PEOPLE OF BRINEHOLLOW, CONTINUED

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*Every wall has an ear, and every ear is a neighbor's. Mind what you say at the count.*

*Mind more what answers.*

— MILE PROVERB, AS GIVEN IN FULL BY GRANDMOTHERS

The first half of the coast's people hold it up. The second half live in its cracks: a smuggler who sells the sea by the bottle, a man who shares his mouth with a god's lodger, a clerk who has done the sum that ends the country, a saint who cannot hear her own god. Then come the new faces, and the knots that tie them all.

Unless stated otherwise, every dossier is written as of early Carving, 641 A.G. The Chase has just finished its nineteenth mile, the Low Water is a month away, and the tide in the body is running eleven minutes ahead of the tide on the Uncovered.

# CAPTAIN JONAH SKERRY

*Dry Jonah*

*“Half a crumb a pint, mother, and I’ll take the bucket off your hands myself. You’d only pour it in the gutter. The gutter doesn’t pay.”*

– DRY JONAH, TO A WIDOW ON MILE THIRTEEN AT DAWN BAILING

| CAPTAIN JONAH SKERRY – DRY JONAH |                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Fatlands-born, resident of Brinehollow · Cut 2 (Gut-line, common blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste; one point foreign, Dromm) · Hunger 5                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                    | 50; owner of the brig <i>Thirsty Bess</i> (aground) and of the bail-water trade                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Crumb-Runner · Standing 4 (Night-Factor)                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                           | Haggle 4, Deceive 4, Persuade 3, Reckoning 3, Wayfaring 3, Feast 3, Shooting 2, Stealth 2, Brawl 1, Endure 1                                                                                             |
| BODY                             | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                          | crossbow +4 (4, Piercing, Slow); brass-capped cudgel +3 (3)                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                            | Iron Belly (Fatlands Taste: +2 Feast; eats nearly anything); the foreign point gives him the Brinehollow tell for a scene whenever the GM spends it: salt on the lips, a wet voice, ears popping indoors |
| WANTS                            | none yet; he has Need 2 for his own tonic (Addiction Hard 14) and drinks it to sleep                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                           | Table Manners, Iron Stomach, Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                     | none, yet                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                          | tasting-cup, green bottles, a bucket ledger, the Bess’s key, a crossbow, a bedside bottle                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                            | 0 (he is a fat cheerful man; that is rather the horror of him)                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

Jonah Skerry is a round man in a coat of oiled Fatlands calfskin that is too warm for the coast and that he will not give up, because it reminds him of being somewhere with a supper. He smells of pipe tobacco, of the beeswax he uses to seal his corks, and, faintly, of the inside of a bucket. His face is red and well-fed and creased into a permanent good humor that never quite reaches the creases beside his eyes. His hands are soft and very clean. He laughs loudly, at his own jokes first, and has the trick of putting a palm flat on your shoulder while he talks, as though steadying a barrel.

He is called Dry Jonah because for nineteen years he was the only grown man on the Mile who did not bail. Children used to follow him at dusk to listen to him not coughing. He wears a waist-rope as a joke, a length of cheap hemp knotted into a bow, and a bail-bucket of painted tin that has never had a drop in it, with a wooden lid on which some wit carved *For Emergencies*. On the Mile they laughed with him for years. They have lately begun to laugh at a slightly different moment, a beat after he does, and he has not decided whether he has noticed.

## THEIR STORY

Jonah was born in 591 A.G. in a toll-village on the southern march where the Fatlands’ warm meat-plains run out into Brinehollow’s salt marsh. His father salted pork for the Rim; his mother sold it. He grew up eating five meals a day, as Fatlands law demanded, and watching coasters come down the Rim Road to buy salt meat and cough into buckets at the inn yard at dusk. He learned two things from them: that they were embarrassed by it, and that they would pay to be embarrassed less.

He came to Lowmark in 617 as a meat-house clerk, was dismissed in 619 for selling the house’s brine barrels twice, and with the proceeds bought the brig *Thirsty Bess*, aground in the old Keelrow channel since 588 and cheap because her timbers creaked at night in a manner her crew found personal. Nobody has ever sailed her. He lives in her captain’s cabin and bottles in her hold, and the Admiralty, which calls any shipowner Captain by courtesy, gave him the title with the harbor dues.

The idea came in 624, watching the gutters run west with the dawn bailing, a whole city’s coughing flowing downhill in green threads: *nobody owns that*. He bottled a bucket as Skerry’s Deep

Restorative and sold it in Saltwick as a lung tonic, and it worked, closing wounds in coaster and dry alike at the cost of a little of the sea going into them. In 633 a Slope apothecary found that a few drops made rouse last longer, and the sideline became a fortune. Rook Quarter-Bell's agents now buy by the cask at Lampwick Halt. Jonah has never been to the Vigil. He has never wanted to see what it is used for.

He buys at half a crumb a pint on the slum Miles, through a network of bucket-wives led by Coralie Sculpin, and sells at three lacks a vial on the Rim and a platter a bottle, green glass and wax seal, to the rich of the Vigil's Height. The rumor on the Mile says the Vigil pays a platter. It is true. Jonah charges three, when he can.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Jonah is a parasite of exactly the kind the poor depend on. On Miles Twelve to Sixteen a family that sells its bailings clears two or three lacks a week, the difference between seaweed bread and seaweed bread with gull in it. The parishes hate him for undercutting their bail-tokens; the Netwatch take his money; the Admiralty tax the trade and pretend not to know the commodity. Brenna Kelp's arithmetic counts his barrels: near ninety thousand gallons of the coast's inner tide carried east in seventeen years, every gallon of it still going somewhere.

His power is money and a wagon road, and its limit is that nobody respects him and everybody needs him. He has no friends of rank. He has a great many customers. He keeps the peace with all of them by being jolly, prompt and discreet, and by never once asking a question about what is in the buckets.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A pewter tasting-cup on a chain** — he tastes every bucket before he buys it, a sip, rolled on the tongue and spat. He tells grades by it: thin, clear, green, heavy. He has never told anyone that a blue bucket tastes sweet.
- ◇ **A case of six green bottles, wax-sealed** — Skerry's Deep Restorative, his best grade. Each is bottled brine tonic (heals 1d6 Flesh; Taint 2 Regrowth, Dromm; Addiction Hard 14). Retail three lacks; he gives them away to officials.
- ◇ **The Bucket Ledger** — a calfskin book of every household on the slum Miles that sells to him, with dates, volumes and grades. It is, without his intending it, the best record in Brinehollow of who is about to be Called, because Coralie notes the colors. Brenna Kelp would give a year of her life for it.
- ◇ *\*The Thirsty Bess's key\** — iron, as long as his hand. The captain's cabin door is the only lock on the brig. The hold is not locked; it does not need to be. Nobody on the Mile will go into a hold full of other people's breathing.
- ◇ **A heavy crossbow and twelve bolts** — for the wagons. He shoots badly and knows it, and hires Wardens who do not.

- ◇ **A forged travel pass and a real one** — the forged one says he carries pickling brine. The real one says the same thing, sealed by a Company Factor at Lowmark Spur who has been paid not to taste it.
- ◇ **The bottle by the bed** — unlabeled, corked with a scrap of rag, half empty. He drinks from it when he cannot sleep. See below.
- ◇ **A Fatlands sausage, always** — wrapped in greased paper in his breast pocket. He eats it at the grace, so that he will have eaten before anyone at the table, as his mother taught him.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Jonah wants to be rich enough to go home to the warm south and never smell a bucket again. He wants it the way men want things they have decided not to do. He fears the Netwatch, the Admiralty's tax-clerks, and, more than he will admit, the look in the eyes of the families he buys from on the morning after someone in the house was Called, when they bring him that night's bucket anyway, because the price is the same.

**Secret (GM can reveal):** he began to drink his own product two years ago, a spoonful at a time, because the nights on the *Bess* were long. Now he drinks a mouthful each night. He wakes with salt at the corners of his lips. Twice he has found himself at the stern rail at dusk, looking west. Three weeks ago, at dawn, he coughed, and a cupful of clear cold water came up into his hand. He threw it over the side and laughed all morning. He still wears the empty tin bucket. It is no longer a joke, and he does not know how to stop it being one.

**Secret (he does not know):** the bottle by his bed came from a single bucket, bought by Coralie Sculpin from a Wreckwife on Mile Twelve who sold it in secret: the dusk bailing of her Tenanted husband, drawn from his cistern. It is Tenanted brine. When Jonah lies awake and drinks from it, it is not the tonic that helps him sleep. It is the voice in it, like a hull settling, telling him slowly and kindly that he is nearly home. His Calling roll, when it comes, will be made at Grim, and he has never in his life tied a knot that would hold.

### TIES

- ◇ **Coralie Sculpin** — his buyer on the slum Miles, his partner in everything but the profits, and the only person who calls him Jonah without the Dry. He trusts her. He should.
- ◇ **Rook Quarter-Bell** (the Vigil) — his best customer, through agents. They have never met. Jonah sends him a Tablenight bottle each year with a card: *To my friend in the east, keep you dry.*
- ◇ **Tolly Brack** — the bailer boy refuses to sell him a drop. Tolly knows the colors too, and once spat into Jonah's tasting-cup.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — she has counted his barrels; he does not know she exists. If she gets his ledger, the Admiralty gets him.
- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — she has taken his money twice and returned it once. He cannot read her, which frightens him more

than her boathook.

- ◇ **Reeve Calder Stokes** — the Company auditor has priced Jonah's trade as the single largest export of the coast. Jonah sent him a case of the Restorative. Stokes logged it as a bribe and returned it, and has since started tasting salt.
- ◇ **Old Wet Tom** — Jonah once tried to buy Tom's puddles. Tom laughed until the rain on him fell harder, and said, very gently, *you've been buying them for years.*

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Jonah buying, selling or hiring: he always needs Wardens for the wagons on the Rim spur, and he pays well, in platters, and asks nothing. He wants them to escort a cart to Lampwick Halt, or recover a stolen cask, or persuade a parish priest to stop preaching against him. He is a good employer and an easy man to like, and the PCs should like him before they understand what he sells.

- ◇ **The Walkers on the Road.** A cart of casks bound east is stopped at Saltwick by a column of Vigil-folk walking west, eyes open, coughing brine. They are Rook's customers, and they want to see the man who sells the sea. Jonah wants the PCs to get his casks through. The walkers want to thank him.
- ◇ **The Blue Cask.** A whole cask has gone blue in the hold of the *Bess*. Coralie swears she bought nothing but clear. The cask is warm. At night it knocks, three times, the way a neighbor knocks at the count.
- ◇ **Dry No Longer.** Jonah's crew find him on the stern rail at dusk, and he will not come down. He asks the PCs, quite calmly, to rope him to the mainmast every night until the wagons are safely gone, and to never tell Coralie. He offers a platter a night.

**Threat:** he pays; failing that he runs; failing that he weeps and tells everything, very fast. **Kindness:** it undoes him, and he gives a kind PC a case of tonic, the worst gift he could give. **The god:** he does not believe in it, and it does not need him to. **If nobody intervenes:** before Tablenight he is Called from the *Bess*; the rope he tied for himself is found on the floor, never knotted. He is next seen at the Low Water of 642, standing in the singers' ring on the mud, heavier, calm, and dry for the first time in his life.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"He pays half a crumb a pint and he pays on the nail. My boy's dying in that bucket, and Dry Jonah's the only one who ever paid us for it." — a mother on Mile Fifteen

"Whatever he's selling, it isn't brine. I've had brine. Brine doesn't look back at you." — a Company drover at Lampwick Halt

"He laughs like a man rowing away from something." — Coralie Sculpin

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# ORRIN WAKE AND PASSENGER

## the Talking Tenant

*“He wants the arm from dusk bailing to dawn bailing. I want it Tablenight free. We have agreed on the knuckles. The thumb is still open.”*

— ORRIN WAKE, TO THE BARMAN OF THE LANTERN, IN HIS UPPER VOICE

*“Write that the thumb is not open. Write that he knows it is not.”*

— THE PASSENGER, A MOMENT LATER, IN THE LOWER

| ORRIN WAKE AND PASSENGER – THE TALKING TENANT |                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                    | Brinehollow · Cut 2 (common, rising) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 5                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                                 | Orrin 39; the Passenger, unknown and very old; fisherman of the Nineteenth, licensed to no boat since his return                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                            | Gleaner (fisherman, now salvager) · Standing 2 (Gleaner); the Passenger has no Calling it will name                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                                    | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 (Orrin) / 5 (Passenger) · Caul 4                                                                      |
| SKILLS                                        | Godsign 4, Clause 4 (Passenger), Labor 3, Wayfaring 3, Endure 3, Brawl 2, Search 2, Instinct 2                                                   |
| BODY                                          | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4 (Orrin) / — (Passenger)                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                                       | fist +5 (1); the left arm, when the Passenger has it, +8 (4, Pressure: on a Helping the target’s ears bleed and they are stunned a round)        |
| GIFTS                                         | Voice of the Deep; The Weight; Fathom-Body; Two Minds (cannot be surprised; each mind may act once per round, but only one may use the left arm) |
| WANTS                                         | The Water (Orrin resists; the Passenger does not); The Silence (Orrin keeps it; the Passenger breaks it on purpose)                              |
| KNACKS                                        | Strong Back (Orrin); the Passenger has no knacks, only patience                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                                  | Orrin has Not My Hand (left arm), and it is not a derangement, because it is true                                                                |
| CARRIES                                       | the slate, a slate-pencil, a mended net, Marra’s bail-bucket, a tally of days, a glove                                                           |
| DREAD                                         | 3 (to hear them disagree)                                                                                                                        |

### WHO THEY ARE

A big man, slope-shouldered, with a fisherman’s ruined knuckles and a face that has been out in salt wind for thirty years. His eyes are the Tenanted black, wet and wide and gentle, and his skin has gone the grey of a winter beach. His left arm hangs a little loose, as if the shoulder were not quite his to lift. When the Passenger has the arm it does not hang. It rests on the table, palm down, perfectly still, and the fingers sometimes spread, one at a time, as if counting.

Orrin speaks slowly, the way the Nineteenth speaks, with a pause before every answer to make sure the question is finished. The Passenger speaks under him, a full octave lower, with a courtesy so old that it sounds formal, like a letter from a grandparent’s grandparent. They argue in the same mouth, and the mouth has learned to take turns: Orrin’s lips move for both, but the Passenger’s words come out slightly before the lips finish shaping them, as if the

voice were arriving from further down. Sitting at their table in the Lantern on Mile Nine is like sitting at a table with a man and a well.

The room around them is cold. The beer in their mug is always flat by the time it is drunk. They smell of the inside of a shell.

### THEIR STORY

Orrin Wake was born on Mile Nineteen in 602, when the Nineteenth was still the Fourteenth. He fished the licensed boats at the pier’s end, hauling up what the Mile calls catches: fish with too many eyelids, flatfish as big as a door that wept when landed, once a net of drowned dogs still wearing collars from inland towns. He married Marra Pell in 627 and they had two children, Hal and Dory, seven and five when he was Called.

He went on a pressure night in Lack, 639, after the net came up heavy with nothing but cold water that would not run out through the mesh. Marra had tied his knot well. The rope was cut with his own gutting knife, missing from the boat for a month. Thirty-one

days later he came up the Nineteenth's harbor steps at dawn, out of the water rather than the mud, asked for his bucket, bailed eleven gallons, sat down on the top step and said, in two voices: *We should talk about the arm.*

It is not usual for the Tenanted to talk about themselves. It is unheard of for the thing inside to talk about the person it sits in, or to bargain. The Wreckwives took the case at once. The Drowned Bench sent a clerk, who listened for an afternoon and went home and was not able to describe what she had heard. The Admiralty made a note. The Passenger, for its part, has been unfailingly polite to all of them, and has said only that it needs a hand to do something with, and that it would rather not take one that was not offered.

For two years they have been negotiating. They have drawn up terms on a slate. Orrin has given up the arm by night, from dusk bailing to dawn bailing, in exchange for the Passenger's promise that it will not use the arm on any living Wake, and will answer one question a day, truthfully, about anything Orrin asks. The thumb is still under discussion. So is Tablenight.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Orrin and the Passenger are a curiosity, a scandal and a test case. The Lantern's owner lets them sit in the corner because people come to hear them and buy beer while they do. The Wreckwives watch them as a possible answer to the question at the heart of their sisterhood: if the person is still in there, and can argue, then perhaps the person can win. The Deepening watches them as proof that the Tenant is benign, reasonable, a guest who asks before it borrows. Mother Limpet has sent them a lantern. Cutwright Ansby Wrack has asked to examine them and been refused, courteously, by the lower voice.

Orrin cannot crew a licensed boat, because no captain will sail with a Tenanted; they salvage the near Uncovered for bread, and the Passenger's half of the body can lift a cart. Marra still shares his bed, roped to him by her own knot. The children call the other one Grandda, and the Passenger has asked them not to, gently, every day, for two years.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The slate** — a schoolroom slate framed in driftwood, written over on both sides in two hands: Orrin's square fisherman's capitals and a fine, slanted, antique script that no one in Lowmark has written for four hundred years. The terms. Clauses struck out, re-written, initialed by both. A Clausewright reading it (Eye + Clause vs Hard 14) finds it the best-drafted contract they have ever seen, and finds that every Exit in it belongs to the Passenger.
- ◇ **A slate-pencil** — Orrin's. The Passenger writes with its finger, wet, and the writing dries in salt.
- ◇ **A mended net** — he still carries a hand-net folded at his belt and mends it in the tavern. The left hand helps by day. At night it

ties knots he does not recognize, in patterns that look like soundings.

- ◇ **Marra's bail-bucket** — the one she gave him on their wedding day, oak-staved, with *I will hold your line* burned into the rim. He bails into it at dawn. The Passenger bails into it at dusk, and the water is a different color.
- ◇ **A tally of days** — a stick notched for every day since his return. Orrin cuts the notches. Some mornings there are more than there should be.
- ◇ **A glove** — a single leather glove for the left hand, which Marra knitted a lining for. When the Passenger has the arm, the glove comes off by itself and is found folded on the table, neatly, like a napkin.
- ◇ **His gutting knife** — the one that cut the rope. He found it on the harbor steps when he came back, laid on the top step as if for him. He cannot throw it away. The Passenger has asked him to keep it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Orrin wants his life back, or enough of it to raise two children who are not afraid of him. He wants to be able to hold his daughter with both arms. He fears that the arm is only the first clause, and that the contract is a ladder; he fears more that he no longer minds. The Passenger wants a hand to do something with. It will not say what. It wants the contract witnessed by a stranger, a dry one, because, as it puts it, *every witness on this coast is already on one side of the water.*

**Secret (GM can reveal):** in the one-question-a-day bargain, Orrin asked, on the ninety-first day, *what is the sea for?* The Passenger told him. It took all night. Since then Orrin has begun to agree with it. What it told him, in the version Orrin will repeat if he trusts the PCs, is this: *The sea was not a home. It was a lid. The Fathom was the keeping, and the keeping is going home, and when it has all gone home what was kept under will be uncovered. Someone has to be at the table when it is. Someone has to have a hand.* Orrin believes this is a kindness. He believes the Passenger means to protect the coast. He may be right.

**Secret (they do not know, or one of them does not):** the left arm is for opening something at Cray Lobbett's stone table. Set into the slab at the eighth place there is a round stone lid, carved like the cover on a serving dish, and no human hand has been able to move it. The GM should decide what is under it: an empty dish, waiting; a dish already full; or a hollow that goes down further than the Trench. The Passenger knows. Orrin does not. Marra suspects, because the left hand has begun, at night, to draw circles on her back.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Marra Wake** — his wife, a Sister of the Line among the Wreckwives. She ties his knot every night and checks it twice and does not know which of them she is protecting.

- ◇ **Cray Lobbett** — the Passenger wants to be taken to Lobbett’s table, and has offered Lobbett a price he cannot hear without shaking: *we will push the chair in for you.*
- ◇ **Ilse Marl** — the Passenger sings at the Low Water with the others; Orrin does not. Ilse has transcribed a line that only one voice in the ring sings, a counter-melody, and it comes from Orrin’s mouth.
- ◇ **Justice Maren Oake** — the Passenger addresses her as an equal, and she, alone of anyone on the coast, answers it in her own lower voice. Their conversations have been recorded by a Bench clerk. The record is sealed.
- ◇ **Mother Limpet** — she sent a lantern and a blessing. The Passenger sent the lantern back with a note: *Not yet, Mother. And not you.*
- ◇ **Ansby Wrack** — refused. She wants to know whether Orrin’s children carry higher Cut than they did before he went. They do.
- ◇ **Reeve Calder Stokes** — the first dry stranger the Passenger asked to witness the contract. Stokes, Oathen-trained, read the slate for an hour and declined, white-faced, and will not say why.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet them when the Passenger asks a stranger to witness the contract. It will choose a PC who has not yet bailed in Brinehollow, if one is present. Witnessing is easy: sign the slate, under both their marks. What it binds the witness to is the question. In Oathen a witness’s word becomes a binding; on the coast it becomes a debt, and the Passenger keeps exact accounts.

- ◇ **Witness.** The Passenger asks a PC to sign. Orrin, in his own voice, asks them not to. Neither will explain while the other is listening, and they are always both listening.
- ◇ **The Thumb.** Orrin has lost the argument about the thumb. He asks the PCs to help him find something he can trade for it. The Passenger suggests a price: one night with the arm at Lobbett’s table, with the PCs as escort, and the whole hand returned to Orrin forever after.
- ◇ **The Children’s Grandda.** Dory Wake, seven, has started speaking in a lower voice at the morning count. The Passenger swears it is not its doing. For the first time in two years, it sounds afraid.

**Threat:** the Passenger stands, the floor creaks, and both voices say *please don’t*; pressed, the arm can tear a door from a house. **Kindness:** Orrin weeps; the Passenger thanks the PC by names they never gave. **The god:** the Passenger calls the rest of it *the family*. **If nobody intervenes:** they settle the thumb at Low Water. At Tablenight the Passenger walks Orrin toward Lobbett’s Drop with Marra’s knot still round his waist and the cut end trailing. He comes back a week later with both arms hanging loose, calm, kind, in a single voice that is not Orrin’s.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He bought me a drink and the other one paid. I don’t know how. The coins were wet.” — the Lantern’s potboy

“I tie his knot every night. I tie it tight. And every morning I lie there and listen to which of them says good morning first.” — Marra Wake, at a Wreckwives’ table

“It is the only Tenanted I have ever heard say *please*. That should comfort me more than it does.” — Lieutenant Sable Reef

# BRENNA KELP

*the Keeper of the Number*

*“I didn’t find anything. I counted. It was all there already. It was there in every bucket on the coast, every morning, for anyone who could add.”*

– BRENNA KELP, TO A WRECKWIFE, IN A CELLAR ON MILE TEN

| BRENNA KELP – THE KEEPER OF THE NUMBER |                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Brinehollow · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite, near the Course) · Hunger 6                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                          | 41; formerly Senior Assayer of the Salt Assay; now a fugitive under Admiralty warrant                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Cutwright-trained clerk, serving as Salt Assayer · Keeper of the Number (Salt Assay Standing 5, by default; nobody else would take it) |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                 | Reckoning 5, Search 4, Lore 3, Stealth 3, Craft 2, Clause 2, Resolve 2, Endure 1, Athletics 1, Godsign 1                               |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                | fist +2 (1); the gauging-chain swung, +3 (2, Entangling)                                                                               |
| GIFTS                                  | Salt-Sense (taste a bail-water to know a person’s stage; she uses it on herself every dawn); Tide-Sight                                |
| WANTS                                  | The West (dusk, any west-facing window); To Keep Under (she has kept her finding under so long it has become a compulsion)             |
| KNACKS                                 | Counting Habit, Steady Hands, Light Sleeper                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | The Count (she counts everything she sees in buckets and gallons; triggered by stress; the number is always one short)                 |
| CARRIES                                | gauging-chain, spectacles, the arithmetic, a glass jar, a bail-token string, an inkwell, a false name                                  |
| DREAD                                  | 0                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

A short woman in a grey Assay coat with the badges cut off and the cuffs black with ink to the elbow. Her round spectacles are cracked across the left lens, and she peers over them like a heron deciding whether something in the water is a fish. She smells of oak gall ink, wet wool and lamp smoke. Her voice is quiet and flat, and her lips move constantly, even in company, as she counts.

She wears her gauging-chain as a belt: twenty fathoms of brass-linked surveyor’s chain wound round and round her waist, so heavy that she walks with a slight backward lean, like a woman carrying a child in front of her. It is also her anchoring rope. She chains herself to the bed with it at night and locks it with an Assay padlock whose key she gives to whoever is sheltering her.

## THEIR STORY

Brenna was born in 600 on Mile Six, a cooper’s daughter who could do sums before she could bail. She trained as a College copyist at twelve, was taken by the Salt Assay at sixteen, and rose from Gauger to Senior Assayer by 635, with a house on Mile One she never furnished.

She had kept a second ledger since 627, when she lost her younger brother Pell to the 1,140 Callings of the Great Pressure Day: the parish bail-token records, which count roughly every bailing on the coast; the Netwatch’s Calling logs; the Wreckwives’ records of the Tenanted; and the fall of the sea, measured at forty posts in fathoms and, by her own method, in volume.

In the Grace of 639 she laid the curves over one another on a single sheet of tracing paper in her Mile One house, by lamplight, and they matched. The volume of sea lost each year is the number of Tenanted returned that year, multiplied by a constant. Her constant, which the Assay clerks still whisper as *the Kelp*, is nine hundred and twelve thousand barrels per returned soul, and it holds, year on year, to within four parts in a thousand. Where it drifts, it drifts in the years when the Admiralty has retired more people to depth. The Called who never return do not lower the sea at all. The Tenanted do. The Seated more so. The ocean is moving into the people, a bucket at a time.

She presented the finding to the Admiralty’s Board of Soundings in Plenty, 639. She was thanked. That night the Standing Orders were read from the deck of the *Steadfast*, declaring the publication, possession or recitation of *any arithmetic of the fall relating to*

persons to be treason against the Articles. The Netwatch came for her at the second bell. She was not home. A Wreckwife had come at the first bell and taken her down the back steps and onto the Mile, and she has been moving between their safe houses ever since, fourteen of them in two years.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Brenna is the most wanted woman in Brinehollow and one of the least visible. The Admiralty wants her silent, or dead, or ideally both. The Second Table wants her figures, because a sea that moves into bodies can be moved out of them by a knife. The Wreckwives protect her because her number is the first thing anyone has given them that explains what came home to their beds. The Deepening, having heard her finding read aloud on a procession night, reveres her as a prophet who proved with arithmetic what they knew in their hearts. She finds this the most unbearable of all.

Her routine is a fugitive's: cellars, attics, the back rooms of mussel-canneries, never more than nine nights in one place. She works by night, on paper borrowed from her hosts, and goes on counting, because she cannot stop: the falling number goes on falling and someone must write it down. She pays her way by doing the household accounts of every family that hides her, which is how half the Wreckwives on the Mile come to have their books in better order than the Purser's Office.

Her finding has left the Assay half-purged. Its surviving clerks keep two ledgers each, and send her their figures folded into the bottoms of bail-buckets.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The gauging-chain** — twenty fathoms of brass-linked Assay chain, her belt, her rope and her weapon. It was issued to her at sixteen, and it is the one piece of Assay property she did not return.
- ◇ **Her spectacles** — cracked across the left lens on the night she fled, when she missed the bottom step in the dark. She sees the world slightly doubled on one side, and has come to think it suits the coast.
- ◇ **The arithmetic** — not a copy of the finding; the working. Thirty-one sheets of tracing paper, folded into a flat oilcloth packet sewn into the lining of her coat. Without the working, the three hidden copies are an assertion. With it, they are a proof any reckoner on the Table can check (Eye + Reckoning vs Hard 14, a day's work, and a Dread 2 check on finishing).
- ◇ **A glass jar with a screw lid** — her dawn bail-water, every day. She holds it to the morning light at the window of whatever cellar she is in and records the color in the margin of her figures, in a code nobody else reads. See below.
- ◇ **A string of forty bail-tokens** — her purse. She cannot carry lacks safely; a woman with silver on the slum Miles is noticed. Forty cups of sweet water is enough to buy a night's silence from most households.

- ◇ **An inkwell with a cork stopper and three steel nibs** — she will not use a quill. She says the quill was once alive and has opinions.
- ◇ **A false name** — Ness Gauge, cousin to whatever family is sheltering her this week. Everyone on the Mile knows a Ness Gauge. It is the Wreckwives' private joke.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Brenna wants the number published before the sea is gone: not believed, which she has given up on, but published, printed, on every tide-post on the coast, so that nobody can ever again say they were not told. She wants this more than she wants to live. She fears that the Tenanted already know her number, and are counting down to something; she has noticed that every Tenanted judge on the Bench voted the same way in every case this year, and she has begun, in the margin, to count their unanimities as if they were tallies.

**The three copies:** one is with Father Ebb, sealed in tarred canvas and chained to his ledge on the Hanging Abbey. One is in a bail-bucket that has passed through four sweethearts' hands, from wedding to wedding, the paper rolled inside the double base; she does not know whose bucket it is now. One has already been read aloud, on a procession night at Gullcry Strand, by a Deepening Lantern-Bearer who wept with joy; it is now in Mother Limpet's keeping, and it is the copy Brenna most wants back.

**Secret (GM can reveal):** her own bail-water has gone blue. Not green, as at the Appetite: blue, deep and heavy, the color Tolly Brack calls *soon*. She has known for six weeks. She has told no one. She chains herself to every bed she sleeps in, and every morning she checks the padlock before she opens her eyes, and every morning it is still locked, and every morning her ankles are wet.

**Secret (she does not know):** the bucket with the second copy has passed into the hands of a Tenanted bride. The Drowned Bench read Brenna's finding six months ago. They were not surprised. Justice Maren Oake wrote one line in the margin, in the antique hand the Tenanted share, and rolled the paper back into the bucket's base: *The figure is correct. The constant will change.*

#### TIES

- ◇ **The Wreckwives** — her keepers, her readers, her landladies. She owes them her life fourteen times over.
- ◇ **Father Ebb** — keeper of the first copy. She climbed to his ledge in 639 in a single day, which no fugitive should be able to do, and he gave her bread and asked her only whether the number was kind. She said no.
- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — the warrant is in his hand. She has never met him. She has counted his ships.
- ◇ **Reeve Calder Stokes** — the Company auditor has her number on his own pages, arrived at by tolls instead of buckets. He is

desperate to meet her. She is terrified of what a Company man will do with a second proof.

- ◇ **Commodore Lysander Vell** — he has sent word through three cutouts that the Admiralty will pardon her in exchange for the working. He does not represent the Admiralty.
- ◇ **Tolly Brack** — the bailer boy taught her the colors before she had a name for them. She owes him an apology she cannot afford to make.
- ◇ **Dry Jonah** — his barrels are a line in her figures: the only sea leaving Brinehollow eastward by road. She suspects it is not leaving at all.
- ◇ **Finn Undertow** — his body-tide bell has been the one public measure that agrees with her. She has never spoken to him. She sets her count by him.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Brenna when a Wreckwife asks them to escort a “cousin” across the Mile at night, from one safe house to another, past three Netwatch posts and a Deepening procession. The cousin carries a chain and mutters numbers. She will not give her name. She will give her arithmetic, if the PCs ask the right question: *how long?*

- ◇ **Three Copies.** As in the core book. Brenna will pay the PCs everything she has (forty bail-tokens and a promise) to recover the copy in Mother Limpet’s keeping. Limpet will give it up only if the PCs walk the shell road to the last lantern and come back.
- ◇ **The Second Proof.** Stokes wants to meet. Brenna wants the PCs to be there, to see what kind of man he is, and to kill him if he is the wrong kind. She does not mean the last part. She has said it twice.
- ◇ **Blue.** One dawn the jar is blue in front of the PCs, and Brenna sees them see it. She makes them swear on the dead, with a piece of her brother Pell’s rope, that if she walks they will let her go and take the working to the tide-posts. She is not asking them to hold her line. She is asking them to cut it.

**Threat:** she runs, badly, and hides well. **Kindness:** she gives her real name, which is the most dangerous gift she owns. **The god:** she hears it as arithmetic, a long division with a remainder that keeps growing. **If nobody intervenes:** the Netwatch take her on Mile Ten in early Lack, because a frightened household sells her for a Netwatch tally. She is tried before the Drowned Bench, standing in the pool, and sentenced to loosing: thirty nights unanchored under guard. She walks on the ninth. The working goes west in her coat lining.

THE SEA IS NOT **EVAPORATING.** I WANT THAT  
**UNDERSTOOD BEFORE ANYTHING** ELSE. I  
HAVE **WEIGHED** IT. IT IS NOT **GOING** UP. IT IS **GOING**  
IN.

[ BRENNA KELP, THE OPENING LINE OF HER FINDING, AS READ ON GULLCRY  
STRAND ]

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**SAID OF THEM**

“She did my accounts while I hid her. Found four lacks I didn’t know I had. Then she cried for an hour over a column of numbers I couldn’t read. I’d hide her again.” — a mussel-cannery widow on Mile Ten

“Her figure is the only true thing the Assay ever produced. That is why it is treason.” — a surviving Measurer, off the record

“A woman who counts the drowned in barrels. They say she’s mad. I’ve seen my mother’s bucket. She isn’t.” — a child on Mile Twelve, to Tolly Brack

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# MOTHER LIMPET

## Mother of the Water

*“Hush now. Hold my hand. I’ll take you to the edge, and you’ll go on, and I’ll come after when the last of you is safe. That’s the promise. I’ve never broken it.”*

– MOTHER LIMPET, AT THE LAST LANTERN ON GULLCRY STRAND

| MOTHER LIMPET – MOTHER OF THE WATER |                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 3                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                       | 84; Mother of the Water, head of the Deepening                                                                                         |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | Celebrant · Standing 5 (Prophet)                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                              | Persuade 5, Rites 4, Godsign 3, Instinct 3, Lore 2, Deceive 2, Resolve 2, Endure 1                                                     |
| BODY                                | Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                             | none                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                               | Fathom-Body; Quiet Chest; The Low Song (Persuade + Rites; listeners at the Appetite or beyond make a Calling roll at Hard, even awake) |
| WANTS                               | The West, which she has never truly felt; she performs it, at every dusk, from memory of other people                                  |
| KNACKS                              | Elder’s Ear, Old Grief, Table Manners                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | none she would admit; the GM may decide she has The Devotion, and that its object is a voice she has never heard                       |
| CARRIES                             | shell-bead dress, the first lantern, the rope-box, Brenna’s copy, a comb, a cup                                                        |
| DREAD                               | 2 (to watch a procession disappear lantern by lantern)                                                                                 |

### WHO THEY ARE

She is very small, bent nearly double, and she clicks when she walks: her dress is sewn with thousands of white shell beads, each one given her by a Shell-Walker after their first procession. Her face is creased and soft, her mouth toothless, her eyes the Course’s wide wet black. Her voice is like getting into a bath in Lack. She smells of seaweed, lamp-oil and camphor. Her chest does not move when she sits. People who come to argue with her find themselves holding her hand.

### THEIR STORY

Limpet was born Aulda Fenwick in 557 on the old shore below Gullcry, a net-mender’s girl, in the last generation that grew up with the sea at the end of the street. She married at nineteen and buried no one: her husband, Corran, was Called in 584, and her only daughter, Sorrel, in 601, at seventeen, on the night after a pressure day. Sorrel’s rope was cut from the inside of the knot. Limpet found the knife under her own pillow.

She does not remember cutting it. She went to the Deepening that winter to be near the people who went where Sorrel had gone,

walked the shell road, took her new name, and found she had a gift for holding the hands of the frightened. By 620 she was a Deep Sister. In 628 the old Mother of the Water walked in and did not come back, and the Deepening gave Limpet the shell dress. She has walked two thousand to the edge since, holding each hand until the water reached her knees, and then letting go, singing.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Deepening’s processions at Gullcry Strand are illegal and regular, and they happen because of her. The Netwatch seldom intervene, because Limpet sends bread and a lantern to the Mile Seven barracks before every procession, with a note naming the date. Families of the baptized come to her for vengeance and get her hand to hold instead. The Anchorites call her the Drowner. The Admiralty has signed her arrest three times and three times failed to find a tiny woman in a clicking dress who lives openly in a chapel on the Strand.

She is the Deepening. Its Lantern-Bearers know the Calling nights; its Deep Sisters hear the invitation; she decides who walks when, and in what order, and she has never once sent a person who was not already pulled.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The shell-bead dress** — some eight thousand beads, sewn on by her flock over fifty years. On procession nights the beads go cold, all at once, and frost over.
- ◇ **The first lantern** — tin and horn, the one she carried on her own first walk in 601, mended a hundred times. She carries it on every procession and sets it on the last hook herself.
- ◇ **The rope-box** — a sea-chest holding a hand's length of rope from each of the two thousand, labeled in her tiny hand. She says she will carry it in with her. It is far too heavy for her to lift.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp's third copy** — rolled in oilcloth, tied with a white ribbon. She reads it aloud to the dying.
- ◇ **A tortoiseshell comb** — Sorrel's. She combs every baptized person's hair before the edge, so they will go in tidy.
- ◇ **A cup of sweet water** — she offers it to everyone at the last lantern. Those who drink stay ashore that night. Those who refuse go on. She says she has never told anyone which to choose. That is true.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants everyone home. She wants to follow, when the last one is safely under, and to find her husband and her daughter waiting. She fears nothing, she says. She fears, actually, the silence at the moment she lets go of a hand, because she listens into it every time and hears only surf.

**Secret (GM can reveal):** she cannot hear the invitation. She never could. In fifty-seven years she has never once felt the pull, though her body has gone deep into the Course; the god is in her flesh and not in her ear. She performs the Want at dusk, standing at the chapel's west window with her palms on the glass, because a Mother of the Water must. She has led two thousand people toward a voice she has only ever been told about, and she does not know whether she is a saint or the thing that comes before one.

**Secret (she does not know):** Sorrel came back. In 601, eleven weeks after her Calling, a Tenanted girl walked out of the surf below Gullcry, calm and courteous, and went not home but to the Deepening, where she took a new name, as all Shell-Walkers do. She is fifty-seven now, grey and slow, a Deep Sister called Sister Sounding, and she has walked at her mother's left hand on every procession for thirty years and held the lantern while Limpet sang. Limpet does not recognize her. Sister Sounding has never told her. The Wreckwives' records know.

## TIES

- ◇ **Sister Sounding** — her right hand in the Deepening, her daughter in fact. See above.
- ◇ **Father Ebb** — her opposite; they were sweethearts at fifteen and exchanged buckets once, before Corran. He prays for her by name every night. She prays for him to let go.

- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — Reef has dragged forty of Limpet's baptized off the shell road. Limpet sends her bread anyway, and once, a shell bead, which Reef keeps.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — Limpet holds her copy. She thinks Brenna is the Deepening's truest prophet. Brenna thinks Limpet is a murderer with a nice voice.
- ◇ **Orrin Wake and Passenger** — the Passenger sent back her lantern: *Not yet, Mother. And not you.* She has not understood the second sentence. It frightens her more than anything has in fifty years.
- ◇ **Abel Drainer** — his Wringers have twice tried to burn her chapel. She visits his converts at the mangle and holds their hands too.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet her on a procession night, holding out a lantern, or when they come to drag someone back from the shell road.

- ◇ **The Copy.** She will give Brenna Kelp's copy only to someone who walks the road to the last lantern and comes back. She means it as a kindness.
- ◇ **Who Is Sounding?** A Wreckwife asks the PCs to tell Limpet the truth about her daughter, or to make sure she never learns it. Either way, Sister Sounding asks to meet them first.
- ◇ **The Deaf Saint.** A PC at the Appetite feels the Low Song pull while Limpet sings, and sees, in that moment, that she does not. She sees them see.

**Threat:** she sings. **Kindness:** she takes the PC's hand and tells them about Sorrel. **The god:** she speaks of it with total faith and no experience. **If nobody intervenes:** on the Low Water night she leads the largest procession in the Deepening's history, three hundred lanterns. At the end of the road she lets go of the last hand and stands in the water to her knees, listening, and hears nothing, and turns around. Sister Sounding walks on alone. Limpet is found at dawn on Gullcry Strand, sitting on the rope-box, still holding out the cup.

## SAID OF THEM

"She held my hand to the water and asked if I was sure. Nobody else ever asked me that, about anything." — a Shell-Walker who came back

"I've netted forty of hers. Every one of them asked me to tell her they were sorry." — Lieutenant Sable Reef

"She took my husband in with a song. I went to curse her and she combed my hair. I hate her. I go every month." — a widow of Mile Sixteen

# DAGNA HULL

the Shipwright

“WHAT? NO. I SAID IT GOES DOWN AND IT COMES BACK. COMES. BACK.  
THAT’S THE WHOLE BLOODY POINT OF A SHIP.”

– DAGNA HULL, TO A VOLUNTEER WHO ASKED ABOUT THE RETURN VOYAGE

| DAGNA HULL – THE SHIPWRIGHT |                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                     |
| AGE & STATION               | 55; master shipwright of the last slip on Mile Nineteen                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING          | none formal; a master of the shipwrights’ yard (equivalent Gleaner Standing 4, Wreck-Lord, for the salvaged iron she commands) |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                            |
| SKILLS                      | Craft 5, Labor 4, Reckoning 4, Brawl 2, Endure 2, Intimidate 3, Search 2, Resolve 2                                            |
| BODY                        | Flesh 14 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 · Fray 3                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                     | riveting hammer +5 (3); hot rivet thrown, +4 (2, sets cloth alight)                                                            |
| GIFTS                       | Salt-Sense; Pressure                                                                                                           |
| WANTS                       | The West (barely felt, since she cannot hear the surf)                                                                         |
| KNACKS                      | Strong Back, Steady Hands, Good Bones                                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                | none                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                     | riveting hammer, ear-plugs of tallow, the list, the <i>Follow</i> ’s plans, a slate, a tin of rivets                           |
| DREAD                       | 0                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is enormous across the shoulders and short in the leg, with forearms burned in a hundred small white stars where rivets have spat. Her face is broad, red, and permanently sooty around the eyes; her grey hair is tied up in a rag. Thirty years of riveting have deafened her nearly stone-deaf, and she shouts everything, kindly, at a pitch that makes the gulls lift. She smells of hot iron, pitch and burnt hair. She reads lips well and pretends not to when she does not like what is said.

## THEIR STORY

Dagna was born in 586 at Keelrow, a shipwright’s daughter, two years before the last warship floated. She learned riveting on the propped hulls of the Dry Fleet, mending ships that would never sail, and hated it. In 620 she left the Admiralty yards and set up at the end of the Mile, building the flat-bottomed boats that fish the last harbor. In 636, after a pressure day burst every port-glass on the Nineteenth, she stood on the pier edge, looked out at water that was lower than it had been at breakfast, and decided to stop chasing the sea and follow it.

The *Follow* is a riveted iron egg forty feet long, with eight glass ports, a weighted keel, and a great tarred air-bladder that can be filled from bellows at the surface and let out, by a valve, to bring the vessel up. It lies in her slip at the end of Mile Nineteen, under canvas, nearly finished. It has been nearly finished for a year.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Officially the *Follow* is an Admiralty project, a sounding vessel to survey the Trench for the fleet’s return. The funding came through Commodore Lysander Vell. Unofficially it is the most talked-about object on the coast. Nine hundred people have put their names on her volunteer list, written on the wall of her shed in chalk; the Mile bets on who will be chosen. She employs forty riveters and smiths, most of them men from the slum Miles who have nothing else, and she pays them in Admiralty lacks and in the promise of a place aboard, which she has never made.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Her riveting hammer** — two pounds of steel on an ash handle worn to the shape of her grip, with her mark, a D inside a hull, stamped on the face. Every rivet she has driven bears that mark.

- ◇ **Tallow ear-plugs** — she wears them out of habit, and because on certain nights the iron of the *Follow* hums.
- ◇ **The list** — a copy, in a book, of the nine hundred names, with notes. *Wants to go. Wants to go. Wants to go. Wants to know.* There are four of the last.
- ◇ *\*The Follow's plans\** — rolled in a tarred tube, with Vell's annotations in a neat red hand: room for six, and a cargo hold she did not draw.
- ◇ **A slate** — for people who will not shout back.
- ◇ **A tin of rivets** — she counts them each morning. The count is the first thing she checks.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know where the water goes, and to come back and tell everyone. She fears that the nine hundred do not want to know; they want to go. She fears that the *Follow* will be a procession with a hull.

**Secret (GM can reveal):** someone keeps loosening the *Follow's* rivets, a dozen a week, always on the lowest seam, and the marks on the loosened rivets are the marks of her own hammer, struck backward. She has begun to wonder if she does it herself in her sleep. She chains her ankle to the slip's ring at night and sleeps on the shed floor. The rivets are still loosened.

**Secret (she does not know):** the saboteur is Hollis Brine, her apprentice and the nearest thing to a son she has, a volunteer whose name is first on the wall. He takes her hammer from beside her sleeping hand because his own will not strike the vessel. He listened, once, through Nerys Colm's door at the Netwatch barracks, and he knows what the invitation says about the deep places. He loosens the rivets weeping, because he wants to go more than he has ever wanted anything, and because he knows she will pilot it, and he will not let her go down to that.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Hollis Brine** — her apprentice, her saboteur. See above.
- ◇ **Commodore Lysander Vell** — her patron. She dislikes him and needs his iron. She has not asked what the hold is for.
- ◇ **Harbormistress Kessa Drowle** — her oldest friend; they drink together on the pier end and compare the years they each have left. Kessa's pilings and Dagna's egg are two answers to the same question.
- ◇ **Nerys Colm** — Dagna wrote to her, asking her to describe the bottom. Nerys's reply was a single word: *Don't*.
- ◇ **Hask Tarn** — she wants him as pilot for the trial descent. He will not go near the Trench.
- ◇ **Mother Limpet** — four hundred of Dagna's nine hundred are Deepening. Limpet has offered to bless the vessel. Dagna has not answered, because she has not decided whether that would be a disaster.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her when she hires a crew: guards for the slip, divers for the trial, a pilot, or someone to find out who is loosening the rivets.

- ◇ **The Follow's Pilot.** As in the core book: she needs someone to lead the trial descent at the Trench edge, and someone to find the saboteur, and to learn why the saboteur weeps.
- ◇ **The Hold.** The PCs see Vell's plans, and the hold she did not draw, with hooks.
- ◇ **The Hum.** On a pressure night the *Follow's* iron hums a note, and all nine hundred volunteers come to the slip at once, in silence, and stand there.

**Threat:** she swings the hammer and shouts. **Kindness:** she gives the PC a place on the list, which is the kindest and worst thing she owns. **The god:** she cannot hear it. She is beginning to think that is why she is the one building the boat. **If nobody intervenes:** the *Follow* makes its trial descent at Low Water 642 with Dagna, Hollis and four of Vell's men aboard. The air-bladder rises without them, its valve closed by hand from inside.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She shouted at me for an hour and then gave me a job and a dinner. Best day I've had on the Mile." — a riveter of Mile Fifteen

"An admirable engineer. She believes she is building a ship. I let her."  
— Commodore Lysander Vell

"Six fathom here, then nothing. You don't build a boat for nothing, Dagna. You build a coffin." — Hask Tarn

# CRAY LOBBETT

## the Finder of the Table

*“Seven pushed in. One pulled out. I measured it. I measured it every time. It’s closer. Not the table. The chair. The chair is closer to where I stand.”*

— CRAY LOBBETT, DRAWING ON A WET BAR IN SALTWICK

| CRAY LOBBETT – THE FINDER OF THE TABLE |                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Brinehollow · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6                                |
| AGE & STATION                          | 40; salvager of the far Uncovered, owner of nothing                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Gleaner · Standing 3 (Salvage-Boss, without a crew any longer)                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                   |
| SKILLS                                 | Search 4, Wayfaring 4, Craft 2, Blades 3, Filch 2, Endure 3, Athletics 2, Feast 2, Instinct 2         |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 8                                                                |
| ATTACKS                                | weed-knife +6 (3, Ripping); salvage gaff +5 (4, Hooking)                                              |
| GIFTS                                  | Deep Breath; Tide-Sight                                                                               |
| WANTS                                  | The West; To Keep Under (the location, which he cannot sell because the Want will not let him say it) |
| KNACKS                                 | Corpse-Road Walker, Scrap-Born Luck, No Thank You                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | The Count (the distance of the chair, in knots; always one short)                                     |
| CARRIES                                | knotted cord, rubbings, a twist of dust, weed-knife, gaff, a cup he did not drink from                |
| DREAD                                  | 1 (to see him measure the air in front of him with the cord, as if a chair were there)                |

### WHO THEY ARE

Lean as a dried eel and the same color, with salt-reddened eyes that water constantly and hands scarred white in crosshatches by weed-knives. He drinks, steadily, and talks in a hoarse rapid mutter, and he draws eight squares on any wet surface, around a long rectangle, and touches the eighth over and over. His oilskin is cracked and stiff with old salt. He smells of the far Uncovered: mud, rot, and something sweet underneath, like a pantry.

### THEIR STORY

Cray was born in 601 on Mile Eleven to a family of Scraplings who bailed thin and coughed little. He went out on the Uncovered at twelve and never really came back. By thirty he had a crew of four and a claim in the Wreck Orchard. In Plenty, 639, following a dead reef three days west, he came down a shelf into a basin where the mud was oddly dry and found the table: a single slab of grey stone eleven paces long, older than any carving on the coast, with eight heavy stone chairs, seven pushed in neat against it, one pulled out. On its seat was a fine dust like ground shell, and an impression, as if someone had just stood up.

His crew went back with him twice. On the third trip two of them did not come back with him, and he will not say what happened; the fourth quit and drinks in Saltwick and will not speak his name. Cray has been back nine times alone. Each time, the table is cleaner. Each time, by his cord, the eighth chair is pulled out a little further toward wherever he stands. Three salvage crews looking for Lobbett’s Drop have not returned.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is a joke on the Mile and a legend on the Uncovered. He has tried to sell the location to Mags Weir, to the Admiralty, to the College, and to a buyer who paid in Company platters, and each time, at the moment of telling, his mouth closes and he says nothing at all. Everyone who wants the table, which by now is a remarkable number of people, wants Cray, and he cannot give it to them. He can only take them.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

◇ **The knotted cord** — a measuring line knotted every hand’s breadth. Nine visits, nine knots tied in red thread where the chair’s edge reached. By his reckoning he has three visits left.

- ◇ **Rubbings** — charcoal on oilcloth of the carvings along the table's edge: eight places, eight figures; seven chiseled smooth by time, one chiseled smooth by tools.
- ◇ **A twist of dust** — from the eighth seat. It never dries.
- ◇ **His weed-knife and salvage gaff** — the tools of a trade he no longer practices.
- ◇ **A cup** — see below.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be rid of it. He fears that the next time the eighth chair will be pushed in, or that a ninth will be pulled out with his name scratched in the stone. **Secret (GM can reveal):** on his last trip there was a cup on the table, at the eighth place, full. Pewter, plain, brimming with something clear and warm that smelled of bread and the deep sea. He did not drink. He took the cup instead, poured out, and it is in his coat. Each morning it is full again. **Secret (he does not know):** the chair is not coming toward him. It is being turned. Each visit, it has been angled a little more away from the table and toward the place he stands, the way a host turns a chair for a guest arriving late.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Hask Tarn** — the only pilot who knows the ground; he steered over the table in 581 when it was under six fathoms, and the lead came up warm. They have never spoken of it. They drink in the same tavern.
- ◇ **Gannet Shale** — she has seen the tall figure setting a table on the mud. Cray thinks it was his. It was not.
- ◇ **Orrin Wake and Passenger** — the Passenger has offered to push the chair in for him. He does not know if that would save him or seat someone else.
- ◇ **Ilse Marl** — her chart leads to his table. She has not yet realized whose it is.
- ◇ **Commodore Lysander Vell** — wants the table for the Second Table's eighth course. Cray has sold him nothing, and been paid anyway.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him in a Saltwick tavern, drunk, drawing eight squares on the wet bar. He will take them to the table for a price, and the price is that someone else count the chairs aloud.

- ◇ **Eight Chairs.** As in the core book: three days out, an uncertain way back, a place laid.
- ◇ **The Cup.** A PC sees the cup fill. Cray offers it to them, very carefully, so as not to spill.

- ◇ **The Last Knot.** Cray wants the PCs to come on his final visit and stop him sitting down. He wants it in writing.

**Threat:** he runs onto the Uncovered, where no one can follow him.

**Kindness:** he cries and shows them the cord. **The god:** he does not think it is Dromm. **If nobody intervenes:** on his twelfth visit he sits down.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He drew eight squares on my bar for a month. My boy started doing it. I had to burn the bar." — a Saltwick tapster

"He came back with two less men and a story nobody'd pay for. I've been on the Uncovered thirty years. I'd pay." — Mags Weir

"The lead came up warm. That's all I'll say. The lead came up warm." — Hask Tarn



# OLD WET TOM

*the God's Own Beggar*

*“Spare a crumb for an old wet fellow? The sea owes me, see. Owes me three. It’ll pay. It always says it’ll pay.”*

— OLD WET TOM, ON THE HEADLAND STEPS, EVERY DAY FOR LONGER THAN ANYONE HAS COUNTED

| OLD WET TOM – THE GOD’S OWN BEGGAR |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Brinehollow · Cut 2 (risen from 1 since his return) · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, Tenanted, for five hundred and twenty-three years) · Hunger 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                      | born about 89 A.G.; Called 118; a beggar of the Headland steps                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 1 · Gut 10 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                             | Endure 6, Godsign 6, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Persuade 2, Lore 1 (but only of 118 A.G., which he knows perfectly)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                               | Flesh 30 (does not seem to bleed) · Guard 10 (he does not get out of the way) · Armor 0 · Fray —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                            | none; he has never struck anyone                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                              | Fathom-Body; The Weight; Private Weather (it rains on him indoors, softly, always; within ten paces flames gutter and paper wilts); The Puddle (his puddles open downward into deep water; a thing or person dropped in is gone; GM decides where); Called to Tom (a person who gives him a coin, then is Called, walks not west but to Tom, and sits beside him until dawn, and goes home) |
| WANTS                              | none any longer; he has had five centuries to finish wanting                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                             | Elder’s Ear, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | Kept Grief (he sets three places at his begging bowl and pours the rain into each)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                            | a begging bowl, a blanket, three spoons, a tide-post splinter, a rope end                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| DREAD                              | 2 (to look into his puddle and see something look back)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

A bundle of rags heavy and black with water, a dripping tangle of grey beard, and under it a mild, round, smiling face with Tenanted black eyes filmed like the bloom on a sloe. It rains on him indoors, a soft private drizzle from an inch below the ceiling. He speaks slowly and cheerfully, in an accent four centuries out of date, and calls everyone *duck*. Puddles follow him like dogs. He is heavier than three men; the Headland steps are worn into a dip where he sits.

## THEIR STORY

Tomas Lugg was a net-mender of the old harbor, twenty-nine years old, on the licked-clean night of 118 A.G. when four hundred people of Lowmark rose in their sleep and walked into the harbor in a long, quiet, orderly line, holding hands. He walked holding the hands of his wife Bethia and his two daughters, Annet and little Wenna, who was four. Eleven came back. Tom was one. Bethia and the girls were not.

He came home to a house that had been given to his brother. He was one of the first Tenanted, and nobody then knew what to call him, and nobody wanted him. He sat down on the Headland steps to wait for his wife and children to come back out of the sea as he had, and he has been waiting there since. The Headland has been rebuilt around him three times. The Admiralty tried to move him in 240, in 388 and in 512, and each time he became too heavy to lift and the men who tried bled from the ears. The other ten of the eleven are long gone, Seated or retired to depth. Tom is the oldest Tenanted alive, if alive is the word, and he has never once been in a hurry.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is a fixture, a superstition and a public convenience. Admiralty officers touch his bowl for luck on their way up to the Sounding Hall. Children dare each other to look into his puddles. The rumor that whoever gives him a coin will never be Called is half true: they will be Called to Tom, and will walk not west but to the Headland



steps, and sit beside him, dripping and calm, until dawn, and then get up and go home. The Netwatch know this. On bad nights Lieutenant Reef has led Called folk to him on purpose. Some families pay their crumb every week.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A begging bowl** — wooden, black, older than the Admiralty. It is always full of rain. Coins dropped into it sink further than its depth.
- ◇ **A blanket** — sodden sealskin, the hair long since gone. It weighs as much as a man.
- ◇ **Three spoons** — horn, worn thin. He sets them in a row at dusk on the step beside him.
- ◇ **A splinter of the first tide-post** — the post on which the four hundred names of 118 were cut. He pulled it from the post when they took it down, and he can still read his wife's name on it with his thumb.
- ◇ **A rope end** — a short length of rotted hemp. It was not cut. It was untied, by hands, from the other end.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants his family to come for him. He fears nothing he can name. **Secret (GM can reveal):** the rope end is the thing he has never told anyone. On the night of the walk it was Tom who untied the girls from his wrist, because Wenna was crying and pulling to go on, and he could not bear it. **Secret (he does not know):** Bethia, Annet and Wenna did come back, long ago, in 119, as Tenanted, and walked home past him on the steps, and he did not know them. The water had come up between them. They are retired to depth beneath Fathomhouse now, in the lowest cisterns, three hundred feet beneath where he sits, and on quiet nights when the rain on him stops for a moment, it is because they are listening up through the stone.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Tolly Brack** — Tom is the one person the bailer boy never bails. Tom gives Tolly a crumb every morning anyway, from the bowl, and it is always wet.
- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — she brings the Called to him on bad nights. He calls her *duck* and asks after her mother.
- ◇ **Justice Maren Oake** — she stops on the steps every morning on her way to the Hall and inclines her head. He is the only person on the coast to whom she does it.
- ◇ **The Dowager Below** — he calls her *the girl in the cellar*. She was born in 559. He finds that very young.
- ◇ **Dry Jonah** — Jonah tried to buy his puddles. *You've been buying them for years*, Tom told him.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him whenever the GM likes: on the Headland steps, in a corridor, at the edge of any scene that needs a puddle.

- ◇ **The Coin.** A PC gives him a coin. That night, they are Called to the steps.
- ◇ **The Puddle.** Something precious falls into one of his puddles and must be fetched.
- ◇ **Three Spoons.** Tom asks the PCs to go down to the lowest cisterns of Fathomhouse and tell three women that he is still waiting, and to bring back what they say.

**Threat:** he sits there and gets heavier. **Kindness:** he tells them about 118, slowly, the whole night of it, a Dread 2 telling. **The god:** he talks of the sea as an old friend who owes him money. **If nobody intervenes:** he waits.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Don't look in the puddle. I looked. There's a lady down there with a little girl, and they're both looking up." — a child of the Headland

"He was on those steps when my grandmother's grandmother was a girl. The Admiralty sends him a blanket every Tablenight. It's in the Standing Orders." — a Headland clerk

"The oldest of us. The patient one. We do not speak of him in his hearing; it would be rude." — Justice Maren Oake

# LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF

*the Hook of Mile Fourteen*

*“I’m not asking what they’re walking toward. I’m asking how much longer we’re meant to pretend we’re the ones doing the pulling.”*

— SABLE REEF, NETWATCH REPORT OF THE THIRD NIGHT WATCH, 9TH OF CARVING, 641

| SABLE REEF – LIEUTENANT OF THE NETWATCH |                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                              |
| AGE & STATION                           | 36; Lieutenant of the Netwatch, commanding the night watch of Pier-Sections Twelve to Sixteen        |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | Nightwarden · Netwatch Standing 4 (Lieutenant)                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                  |
| SKILLS                                  | Blades 3, Brawl 3, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Instinct 3, Intimidate 3, Endure 2, Resolve 2 |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 6                                                               |
| ATTACKS                                 | boathook +7 (4, Hooking: on a Helping the target is pulled down); weighted net +7 (0, Grappled)      |
| GIFTS                                   | Deep Breath; Salt-Sense                                                                              |
| WANTS                                   | The West, newly; she has begun to feel it at dusk, which at the Taste she should not                 |
| KNACKS                                  | Light Sleeper, Rope Knots, Unflinching                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | none yet; she is two bad nights from The Pull                                                        |
| CARRIES                                 | boathook, net, bullseye lantern, the log, rattle, a shell bead, Netwatch tallies                     |
| DREAD                                   | 0                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Tall, sinewed, long in the arm, with a face crosshatched down both cheeks by the fingernails of the Called, who fight in their trance with terrible, painless strength. The scars are white and fine and she does not hide them. She walks the Mile at night in a corked Netwatch oilskin with a bullseye lantern at her belt, the shutter half closed, so that only a slice of light goes ahead of her. Her voice is low, hoarse from shouting into fog. She is courteous to everyone and touches no one without warning them first. She smells of tar, wet oilskin and the vinegar she rubs into her scratched hands.

## THEIR STORY

Sable was born on Mile Fourteen in 605, the daughter of a Netwatch Line-Hand who was Called in 619 while on duty: he put down his hook at the tideline, very carefully, and walked into the sea in front of his own squad. She joined the Watch at sixteen to find out why nobody stopped him. She was a Hooker at sixteen, a Line-Hand at twenty, a Watch-Sergeant at twenty-six and a Lieutenant at thirty-two. She has pulled three hundred and four Called off the shore with hook and rope. She keeps the count in the back of her log.

Every one of them looked at her the same way: not frightened, not angry, but disappointed, as though she had interrupted something precious.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She commands the night watch of the slum Miles, where the Callings are thickest, and she is the reason the Netwatch’s figures there are the best on the coast. She has the right to enter any house at night and to order a loosing stayed. She has used the second power eleven times, which is more than any Lieutenant living. She keeps Nerys Colm in the sealed room at the Mile Seven barracks, by Nerys’s request, and she is the only person Nerys will speak to, through the door. Her hookmen, Dabb and Persey among them, would follow her into the Trench. That is beginning to be a concern.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A Netwatch boathook** — ash shaft, iron hook, the hook wrapped in rag so it catches collars and not throats. Notched once for every Called brought home.
- ♦ **A weighted net** — lead tokens sewn into the hem.

- ◇ **A bullseye lantern** — Netwatch issue, its glass scratched by a hand that tried to put it out.
- ◇ **The log** — the Watch’s night book, in her hand, and in the back, the count: three hundred and four names, and beside two hundred and eleven of them a second date. Those are the ones who were Called again later and not brought home.
- ◇ **A Netwatch rattle** — for calling the patrol. She has stopped using it on the Uncovered; things out there come to it.
- ◇ **A white shell bead** — Mother Limpet’s. She does not know why she keeps it.
- ◇ **A string of Netwatch tallies** — paid for the Called brought home alive. She never cashes the ones she is not sure about.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know what she is saving them from. She fears the answer, and she fears that she already prefers it. **Secret (GM can reveal):** she dreams every night that she is walking west, and that the three hundred are walking beside her, and that they are glad she came. She will be the next of her watch to go. **Secret (she does not know):** the dream is shared. Every one of the three hundred and four, living, Tenanted or gone, dreams the same dream on the same nights, of Sable Reef walking with them at last, and the ones still ashore wake glad.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Nerys Colm** — her charge, her confessor through a door. Nerys has asked Sable, many times, never to listen at the speaking-tube. Sable listens.
- ◇ **Hookman Persey** — her man, brought home the night of her report. He sleeps roped in the guardhouse, and his bucket fills without his coughing.
- ◇ **Mother Limpet** — her enemy on paper. Sable has dragged forty of Limpet’s baptized home. She eats Limpet’s bread.
- ◇ **Old Wet Tom** — on the worst nights she walks the Called to him rather than drag them; they sit with him until dawn and go home.
- ◇ **Dulse Ammery** — the Kind Hand of Mile Fourteen. Sable wants her arrested. The Drowned Bench has ruled what Dulse does lawful.
- ◇ **Dry Jonah** — she has taken his money twice and returned it once.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her when they are out on the Mile at night. She may recruit them: the Netwatch is always short of hands, and a PC can earn two lacks a night as a Hooker on her beat.

- ◇ **A Long Night.** Three hundred walk at once from the slum Miles. She needs every hand.
- ◇ **What Nerys Said.** Sable asks the PCs to tell her whether to keep listening at the tube.
- ◇ **The Lieutenant Walks.** The PCs see Sable herself at the tideline at dusk, hook laid down carefully, as her father’s was.

**Threat:** she is the best fighter on the Mile and fights to subdue. **Kindness:** she accepts help without thanks and remembers it forever. **The god:** she has begun to hear it as gratitude. **If nobody intervenes:** on the night of Low Water 641 she lays down her hook at the tideline and walks, and three hundred people of the Mile rise in their sleep and walk with her, and nobody on the Watch can bring themselves to pull.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She hooked my dad off the shell road and he spat at her. She wiped her face and said, You’re welcome. He’s alive. He hates her. So do I. I’d die for her.” — a Mile Fourteen girl

“Best Lieutenant on the Watch. Two hundred and eleven of her three hundred went anyway. We don’t tell her that number. She keeps it herself.” — Watch-Sergeant Dabb

“Sable. Don’t listen. Please don’t listen. You’re the only one who still comes.” — Nerys Colm, through the tube

# ILSE MARL

Choir-Mistress of the Low Water

*“Hold the lantern higher, there’s a good soul. And don’t hum. Whatever you do, when they start, don’t you hum along.”*

– ILSE MARL, ON THE MUD AT THE LOWEST TIDE

| ILSE MARL – CHOIR-MISTRESS OF THE LOW WATER |                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                     |
| AGE & STATION                               | 60; former choir-mistress of the chapel of Saint Sounding on Mile Four                         |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Celebrant (lapsed) · Standing 2                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                            |
| SKILLS                                      | Craft 4 (notation), Lore 4, Reckoning 3, Resolve 4, Rites 2, Endure 2, Wayfaring 2, Instinct 2 |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                         |
| ATTACKS                                     | none                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                                       | Salt-Sense; Tide-Sight (she uses it only to find the ring)                                     |
| WANTS                                       | The West; To Keep Under (the chart)                                                            |
| KNACKS                                      | No Thank You, Counting Habit, Old Grief                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | none; the GM may give her The Voice at Table, which she would call the music                   |
| CARRIES                                     | lap-desk, horn lantern, forty years of pages, frozen mittens, Lew’s hymnbook                   |
| DREAD                                       | 0                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

Small, fierce, sharp-nosed, wrapped in three shawls and a sealskin cape, with ink blotted on her fingers and on her chin where she rests it in thought. She speaks fast, in short commands, like a woman who has spent forty years conducting children. She hums constantly, and stops herself, and starts again. Her fingers are swollen and white-knuckled from frost, and she writes anyway.

## THEIR STORY

Ilse ran the children’s choir of a Mile Four chapel for twenty years. In 598 her husband Lew, a baritone, was Called; he came back after nine weeks, Tenanted, and never sang at home again. At the next low tide he walked onto the mud, stood in a ring with three hundred others, and sang. Ilse followed with a lantern to bring him home and heard it. She went back the next month with paper and invented a notation, since none existed: long marks for held notes, dots for the beat, small numbers for pitch below the staff. She has not missed a low tide in forty years. She sings nothing herself any more. She is afraid of what her voice would join.

Laid end to end, the transcriptions make a nautical chart: soundings, currents, and a course leading west and down.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is tolerated by the Admiralty as a harmless widow, watched by the Deepening as a scribe of holy song, and coveted by everyone who has learned what her pages are. The few Rim dealers who have heard of the chart list it as not for sale at any price, which only raises the price. A navigator using it crosses the Uncovered without rolling and can find the Trench and a stone table with eight chairs; a week’s study lets a reader hum the song, and any Tenanted hearing it stops and turns.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A lap-desk** — oak, ink-stained, with a lid that props a lantern.
- ◇ **A horn lantern** — she asks strangers to hold it.
- ◇ **The pages** — four hundred and eighty transcriptions, one per month, kept in a sea-chest under her bed and copied, in part, nowhere.
- ◇ **Frozen mittens** — fingerless, so she can write.
- ◇ **Lew’s hymnbook** — from the chapel. He has not opened it since 598. She brings it every month in case.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to finish the transcription; she wants Lew to sing one hymn to her, once. She fears she has been writing a map for something. **Secret (GM can reveal):** the chart has a destination, and it is not the Trench. It is Cray Lobbett's table. **Secret (she does not know):** the song is not finished, and in the last two years the soundings have begun to run the other way, from the table eastward toward the Headland. It is no longer a course out. It is a course in.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lew Marl** — her husband, Tenanted, a voice in the ring.
- ◇ **Orrin Wake and Passenger** — the only counter-melody in forty years comes out of Orrin's mouth.
- ◇ **Hask Tarn** — the only person who can read her chart as a chart. He went white when he did.
- ◇ **Cray Lobbett** — whose table her chart leads to. She has not put the two together.
- ◇ **Commodore Lysander Vell** — has offered a fortune for the pages. She sent him a single sheet, of the children's hymn she used to teach.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet her at the Low Water, where she asks them to hold her lantern.

- ◇ **The Thief.** The pages are stolen; the thief is heard humming.
- ◇ **Lew's Hymn.** She asks the PCs to make Lew sing the hymn, one verse.
- ◇ **The Course In.** A PC who reads the new pages realizes which way the chart now points.

**Threat:** she hides the chest under her bed and sits on the lid. **Kindness:** she teaches the kind PC the children's hymn. **The god:** she hears it as music, and is scrupulous about not loving it. **If nobody intervenes:** the chart completes at Low Water 642, and the ring walks east.

## SAID OF THEM

"She taught me to sing when I was six. Now she won't let anyone hum near her." — a woman of Mile Four

"Six fathom, sand. Twelve. Forty. Then a number I never heard on a chart. She wrote it as a tune." — Hask Tarn

"She stands at the edge every month like she's waiting for a boat that doesn't put in any more." — a Netwatch hooker

# FINN UNDERTOW

the Bellman

*“The sea says dawn’s at the half-bell. Your chests say it’s now. I ring for the chests. The sea’s not the one that drowns in bed.”*

– FINN UNDERTOW, TO AN ADMIRALTY CLERK SENT TO ASK WHY THE BELL RANG EARLY

| FINN UNDERTOW – THE BELLMAN |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION               | 44; Tide-Bellman of Lowmark, keeper of the Headland bell                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING          | none formal; an Admiralty warrant-servant (Able Hand, Standing 2)                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                      | Labor 4, Reckoning 4, Godsign 4, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Resolve 3, Brawl 2, Athletics 2                                                                                                             |
| BODY                        | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                     | fist +5 (1); bell-hammer +5 (3)                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                       | Salt-Sense; Tide-Sight; Fathom-Body; The Swell (he feels the body tide of every Brinehollower within the city as a single swell in his own chest, and knows to the minute when the city will fill) |
| WANTS                       | The West; The Water (he sleeps in the bell’s rain cistern)                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                      | Strong Back, Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                | The Count (the days; it is not one short; it is exact)                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                     | bell-rope, tally-board, tower rope, eyepatch, a bucket of copper                                                                                                                                   |
| DREAD                       | 1 (to see his ribs not rise as he hauls)                                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

One-eyed, roped by the waist to an iron ring in the bell tower on the Headland, with forearms like hawsers and hands so callused they creak. His skin has gone grey as slate and his remaining eye is the Course’s black. He wears a patch of tarred leather over the other. He talks little, in a chest-voice with a second voice beginning to show beneath it. He smells of bronze, rope and rain.

## THEIR STORY

Finn was born in 597 under the tower; his father rang the tide bell before him, by the sea. In 620 a cracked clapper took his left eye. In 631 the tides in the body began to drift from the tides of the sea, at first by a minute, then by many, and people drowned in bed waiting for a bell that rang by the water. In 636, after a dawn on which ninety of the Headland drowned in their sheets, he began ringing by his own chest. Now the city coughs as one when he hauls.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Admiralty would dismiss him if anyone else could do the job. His bell is the only public measure on the coast that keeps time with

the people rather than the sea, and it saves, by Brenna Kelp’s count, some two hundred lives a year. The Standing Orders still require him to ring by the tide-post. He keeps a second rope.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The bell-rope** — hemp as thick as a wrist, its tail worn to silk by his hands.
- ◇ **A tally-board** — a plank in the tower, scored with the minutes of drift, day by day, for ten years.
- ◇ **His tower rope** — the anchoring line that ties him to the ring. He lets it out at dawn and dusk exactly the length needed to reach the bell-rope.
- ◇ **An eyepatch** — and beneath it, in the empty socket, salt that forms each night.
- ◇ **A copper bucket** — he bails into it between strokes.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to ring the city through. He fears that he is ringing it toward something. **Secret (GM can reveal):** the body tide is drifting toward a single moment in which every Brinehollower will fill at

once, wherever they are, whatever the hour, and he can count the days. As of the first week of Carving, 641, the count stands at three hundred and seventy-seven, and it lands at the lowest tide of Carving, 642: the Low Water. **Secret (he does not know):** the drift follows a breath. The body tide of the coast has been setting itself, for ten years, to the slow breathing of the Dowager Below in the cellars under Fathomhouse, and when the drift closes, the whole country will be breathing with her.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — sets her count by his bell; they have never met. He would like to see her figures. She would like to see his board.
- ◇ **The Dowager Below** — he hears her through the tower's foundations, a slow tide, and has written down her breaths without knowing whose they were.
- ◇ **High Admiral Corvin Sund** — Sund has ordered him twice to ring by the post. Finn rang by the post for a day each time. Thirty people drowned. Sund has not ordered it a third time.
- ◇ **Tolly Brack** — the boy times his rounds by the bell and climbs the tower on Tablenight to sit with him.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him if they climb the tower to ask why the bell rang early.

- ◇ **The Second Rope.** The Admiralty sends the PCs to make him ring by the tide-post.
- ◇ **The Count.** Finn shows a PC the tally-board and asks them to check his sums.
- ◇ **One Breath.** On a pressure day the drift jumps a whole day in an hour.

**Threat:** he holds the rope and does not let go. **Kindness:** he lets the PC haul the bell once. **The god:** it is a swell he is riding, and he is tired. **If nobody intervenes:** on the last day of the count, Finn rings the bell once, and every chest on the coast fills together.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He rang it early and my nan was saved. She was blue. Bell went, and she coughed." — a girl of the Headland

"The man is in breach of the Standing Orders every dawn and dusk. I have the papers. I cannot bring myself to sign them." — an Admiralty clerk

"He rings the bell like he's hauling something up from very deep."  
— Old Wet Tom



# REEVE CALDER STOKES

the Company's Auditor

“Guides, drying. Two lacks a day each. I write it as an expense; I am still deciding which column.”

– REEVE CALDER STOKES, ENTERING THE PCS IN HIS LEDGER

| REEVE CALDER STOKES – THE COMPANY’S AUDITOR |                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | Oathen-born · Cut 1 (Tongue-line Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste; one point foreign, Dromm, gained this morning) · Hunger 2 |
| AGE & STATION                               | 33; Factor and auditor of the Rim Road Company, seconded to Lowmark Spur                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Factor · Standing 3 (Senior Factor); a Bonded Hand of the Company, sworn at Treaty Stair                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                            |
| SKILLS                                      | Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Haggle 3, Search 3, Lore 2, Resolve 2, Wayfaring 1, Endure 1, Blades 1                                  |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                                     | penknife +3 (2)                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                       | none of note from Tolm; the salt is new                                                                                        |
| WANTS                                       | none yet; he is not used to wanting things                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                      | Bone-Coin Nose, Conditional, Counting Habit                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | none                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                                     | three ledgers, the contract, a Company seal, a penknife, a bail-bucket he has not yet used                                     |
| DREAD                                       | 0                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

Pale, narrow, precise, in a Company coat of grey wool buttoned to the throat and stained at the hem with Mile tar he has not managed to clean. He speaks in Oathen’s careful conditionals: *as I presently understand it, barring correction*. He never lies. He smells of ink and of the rose-water he uses on his handkerchief, and now, faintly, of salt.

## THEIR STORY

Born in Tacit in 608, a Scrapling copyist’s son, Calder was apprenticed to the Company’s Treaty Stair at twelve and has never been wrong in a sum. He was sent to Brinehollow in early Plenty, 641, by Auditor-General Lysander Coyle, to price the coast’s losses. His contract, sworn before Jessamy Quill, binds him to deliver the audit in person in Tacit by the first day of Grace, 642. Company oaths bind the body anywhere. He has been here three months. This morning he tasted salt.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

To the Admiralty he is an inconvenience who must be flattered, fed, and shown nothing. To the Company he is a pair of eyes. To the

Mile he is a dry man, and everybody watches, with a certain grim interest, to see how long he stays dry. The Company still pays port tolls on a port with no water; his job is to decide whether it should go on paying.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Three ledgers** — the official audit, the working, and the third, which is for himself.
- ◇ **The contract** — a copy, bone-sealed. The original is at Treaty Stair.
- ◇ **A Company seal** — bone, the seven-spoked wheel.
- ◇ **A penknife** — for quills; it is the only blade he owns.
- ◇ **A bail-bucket** — bought on his first day, as a courtesy. He has not yet used it. He has started to carry it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to finish the audit and leave. He fears he has been asked to price something that has no price. **Secret (GM can reveal):** the audit shows that the Admiralty’s harbor tolls, assessed by the fathom of draught at the Nineteenth, and Brenna Kelp’s numbers point to the same thing; and the Company already knew. Coyle’s

office had the constant in 633, six years before Brenna. Calder was not sent to find the end of Brinehollow. He was sent to confirm its date. By his figures: eight years and a season. **Secret (he does not know):** if he is Called, the contract does not release him. His body will walk west, and break as it walks.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — he wants to meet her more than he has wanted anything.
- ◇ **Harbormistress Kessa Drowle** — her nine years and his eight years and a season are the same figure, honestly rounded.
- ◇ **Orrin Wake and Passenger** — he read the slate and declined to witness. He saw the Exits.
- ◇ **Dry Jonah** — logged as the coast's largest export. Jonah's gift of tonic was returned.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him when he hires them to escort him, which he notes as *guides, drying*.

- ◇ **The Delivery.** Get him and the audit to Tacit before Grace.
- ◇ **The Meeting.** Bring him to Brenna Kelp.
- ◇ **The Third Ledger.** A PC finds it: a list of everyone he has met, and how long each has left.

**Threat:** he cites the contract. **Kindness:** he writes it down. **The god:** he does not believe in it; he has priced it. **If nobody intervenes:** he leaves for Tacit in Lack, coughing, and is found on the Rim Road two days out, walking west.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He asked me what my husband was worth. I told him. He wrote it down and then he paid me it." — a Wreckwife

"A dry man asking how much the sea costs. We laughed. Then he started bailing." — a tavern keeper on Mile Two

"Send me the figure. Do not send me your opinion of the figure." — Lysander Coyle, in a letter to Stokes

# NEW FACES OF BRINEHOLLOW

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*Tie your own knot. Then check your neighbor's. Then lie awake wondering who checked yours.*

— ROPEWALK SAYING

The core book added six people to the coast. They are given here in full, with two more who have been waiting in the margins of other people's stories.

# OTTILINE HAWSE

## the Ropewalker

*“A sleeper saws. A lover cuts once, from above, and the hand shakes after. This one was cut from below, by a small blade, by someone who’d done it before.”*

— OTTILINE HAWSE, READING A ROPE END FOR A FAMILY ON MILE FOURTEEN

| OTTILINE HAWSE – THE ROPEWALKER |                                                                         |
|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                      | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 2              |
| AGE & STATION                   | 50; Mistress of the Ropewalk, Mile Three                                |
| CALLING & STANDING              | none formal; master of a trade (Craft 5)                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                      | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                     |
| SKILLS                          | Craft 5, Search 4, Labor 3, Instinct 3, Reckoning 2, Endure 2, Blades 2 |
| BODY                            | Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4                                  |
| ATTACKS                         | rope-knife +6 (2)                                                       |
| GIFTS                           | Salt-Sense; Tide-Sight                                                  |
| WANTS                           | To Keep Under (what the cuts tell her)                                  |
| KNACKS                          | Rope Knots, Steady Hands                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                    | none                                                                    |
| CARRIES                         | the Cut Ledger, a rope-knife, a lens, tar-pot, a folded slip            |
| DREAD                           | 0                                                                       |

### WHO THEY ARE

Broad, slow, with hands black with tar to the wrist and the smell of hemp and pine on her like a second skin. She walks the quarter-mile shed of the Ropewalk backward all day, paying out yarn from her waist, and talks over her shoulder.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 591 in the Ropewalk, she inherited it in 622. Every anchoring rope in Lowmark passes through her shed. After the rope funeral of her own sister in 624, she asked to see the cut end, and saw what it told. She has kept a ledger of every cut rope brought back since: the blade, the angle, the strength of the hand.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She knows which ropes were cut by the sleeper, which by the beloved, and which by no hand at all. Families come to her to learn who cut. She tells nothing unless they ask twice. The Netwatch consults her. The Bench has never asked.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Cut Ledger** — seventeen years of rope ends, sketched and classified. Four columns: Sleeper, Beloved, Stranger, None.

- ◇ **A rope-knife** — hooked, short; she judges others’ blades by it.
- ◇ **A lens** — for fibers.
- ◇ **A tar-pot** — always warm.
- ◇ **A folded slip** — inside the ledger’s back cover, a name.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the cuts to stop. She fears the column headed None, which grows. **Secret (GM can reveal):** forty of the ropes she sold last year were cut by the same small blade, angled from below, and she knows the child who carries it. The name on the slip is the GM’s choice. One suggestion: a boy of Ropery Row who, on the morning his grandfather’s rope was found cut, stood in the doorway holding the old man’s bucket. **Secret (she does not know):** the child is not acting alone. Someone gentle taught him how, and told him that the ones on the beds were asking to be let go.

### TIES

- ◇ **Dulse Ammery** — the hand that taught. Ottiline suspects nothing.
- ◇ **Lieutenant Sable Reef** — brings her rope ends at dawn.
- ◇ **Esk Penhallow** — he bought a new rope and asked her to check his knot. She did. It was perfect.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **Ask Twice.** A family needs to know who cut. The answer is Beloved.
- ◇ **The Slip.** The ledger is stolen, and with it the name.
- ◇ **None.** A rope brought in shows no cut at all. It has been untied, from the far end.

**Threat:** she throws tar. **Kindness:** she gives a PC a rope that will not cut. **If nobody intervenes:** she burns the slip and goes on.

## SAID OF THEM

“She looked at my mam’s rope and said Beloved and closed the book. I’ve not spoken to my dad since.” — a young man of Mile Twelve

“Best rope on the coast. Nobody wants to be the one buying it.” — a Ropewalk hand

“She reads a knot the way I read a verdict.” — Justice Maren Oake

# ESK PENHALLOW

*the Returned Who Wasn't*

*“Nell. Nell, it’s me. Ask me anything. Ask me the dog’s name. Ask me what I said under the pier. Nell. Please call back.”*

– ESK PENHALLOW, AT THE MORNING COUNT, THROUGH THE WALL OF HIS OWN HOUSE

| ESK PENHALLOW – THE RETURNED WHO WASN'T |                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 10 (the Brink), whether Tenanted or not · Hunger 4  |
| AGE & STATION                           | 27; net-maker of Mile Eight, homeless on his own front steps                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | none                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                |
| SKILLS                                  | Craft 3, Labor 3, Endure 3, Persuade 2, Athletics 2, Resolve 2                     |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                             |
| ATTACKS                                 | fist +3 (1)                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                   | Fathom-Body; Voice of the Deep (he does not use it; he does not believe he has it) |
| WANTS                                   | The West; The Silence (he cannot say where he went, only that it was cold)         |
| KNACKS                                  | Rope Knots, Old Grief                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | The Gaslight (everyone tells him he is not himself)                                |
| CARRIES                                 | his own rope, a children’s drawing, a key that no longer fits                      |
| DREAD                                   | 2 (if Tenanted), 3 (if not, once the PCs know)                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

A young man made a little heavier, a little slower, with a voice a little deeper than it should be, sitting on the steps of his house on Mile Eight every night, roped to the railing by his own hand. His eyes have darkened but not wholly. He weeps easily and wipes it off quickly.

## THEIR STORY

Called at twenty-six, in Lack 640, gone eight weeks. He says he remembers the sea: cold, the weight, a voice asking, and then a sandbar, and a long walk home starved. His wife Nell will not let him in. His mother has rung the Wreckwives. His children, Bryn and Lally, scream when he speaks.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is a test case. The Wreckwives have taken him: if a man can be loved back out of the sea, they would like to know it, and if he

cannot, they would like to know that more. The Drowned Bench has declined to rule. He shares a surname with the First Spoke of the Rim Road Company, which has brought him nothing.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **His own rope** — new, from the Ropewalk, tied by himself every night.
- ◇ **A drawing** — in chalk, by Lally, from before: a man with a net. He keeps it in oilcloth.
- ◇ **A house key** — Nell changed the lock.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to go home. He fears that they are right. **Secret:** the GM decides, and should decide privately. He may be telling the truth, and Brinehollow has no test.

| D6  | THE TRUTH OF ESK PENHALLOW                                                                           |
|-----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1–2 | He is Tenanted, and does not know. The Tenant is gentle and waits.                                   |
| 3–4 | He is Esk, wholly, returned by a sandbar and luck. The weight and voice are the Brink, nothing more. |

| D6 | THE TRUTH OF ESK PENHALLOW                                                                    |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5  | He is Esk, and something came back with him and is in the house already, in Nell.             |
| 6  | He was never Called. He walked out to drown himself, and could not. He has never told anyone. |

TIES

- ◇ **Nell Penhallow** — his wife; she has remarried in all but law to his brother.
- ◇ **Ottiline Hawse** — checked his knot; found it perfect.
- ◇ **Ansby Wrack** — wants to read his line. If his Cut has risen, he is Tenanted, by her measure. Her measure is not proof.

IN PLAY

- ◇ **Prove It.** The Wreckwives ask the PCs to find a test.
- ◇ **The Brother.** Esk’s brother asks the PCs to make him go away.
- ◇ **The Count.** One morning Bryn answers his call. In which voice?

**Threat:** he weeps and does not fight. **Kindness:** he asks the PC to call his name at the count. **If nobody intervenes:** he is loosed, by his own request, so that the sea can decide.

SAID OF THEM

- “If that’s Esk I’ve done the worst thing a wife can do. If it isn’t I’ve done the only thing.” — Nell Penhallow
- “He calls our names at the count. I want to answer. Mam says don’t.” — Lally Penhallow, eight
- “Brinehollow has no test. I have looked for six hundred years of a test.” — a Wreckwife Widow-Mother



# COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL

*the Carver's Officer*

*"It worked once. I see no reason the second sitting should be less satisfying than the first."*

— COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL, AT A DINNER OF THE SECOND TABLE

| COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL – THE CARVER'S OFFICER |                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                     | Brinehollow · Cut 3 (Lung-line, cadet) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7      |
| AGE & STATION                                  | 48; Commodore of the Northern Squadron, aboard the propped <i>Gannet</i>           |
| CALLING & STANDING                             | Scion · Standing 3; Admiralty Commodore (Standing 5); a member of the Second Table |
| ATTRIBUTES                                     | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                |
| SKILLS                                         | Persuade 5, Clause 4, Blades 3, Deceive 4, Lore 3, Godsign 3, Endure 2             |
| BODY                                           | Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 · Fray 1                                             |
| ATTACKS                                        | rapier +6 (4)                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                          | Deep Breath; Pressure                                                              |
| WANTS                                          | The West (unfelt since he began eating); To Keep Under                             |
| KNACKS                                         | Smell of Cedar, Conditional                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                                   | none                                                                               |
| CARRIES                                        | the lead box, silver waist-rope, a carving knife, Follow's plans                   |
| DREAD                                          | 0; 3 to see the box opened                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

Elegant, silver at the temples, witty, dry-lunged to an unusual degree, wearing a silver waist-rope braided from his ancestors' hair. He does not bail. Nobody has noticed, because he is never seen at dawn or dusk.

## THEIR STORY

A Vasht cadet born in 593, Vell rose through the Dry Fleet by charm. He was recruited to the Second Table in 627. The lead box came to him from his great-uncle: a piece of Dromm's flesh preserved since the Beaching, which still weeps cold water.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He funds the *Follow* through the Admiralty. He has tried to buy Ilse Marl's pages, Brenna Kelp's working, and Cray Lobbett's location. He believes the god is reassembling at the bottom of the Trench, and intends the *Follow* to carry a carving party there.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The lead box** — a palm of white, dense, cold flesh. It tastes, he says, like being held.
- ◇ **His waist-rope** — silver and hair; he never ties it.
- ◇ **A carving knife** — Second Table issue, for the course to come.

- ◇ *\*The Follow's plans\** — with his hold drawn in red.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the second meal. He fears the Tenanted Bench. **Secret:** he has been eating a sliver of the flesh each Tablenight, and he no longer needs to bail. **He does not know:** the flesh is growing back between Tablenights. It is a little larger every year.

## TIES

- ◇ **Dagna Hull** — his engineer.
- ◇ **Brenna Kelp** — his offered pardon is a lie.
- ◇ **Ansby Wrack** — he has read her ledgers; he intends to marry a Tenanted widow.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **The Hold.** The PCs learn what the hooks are for.
- ◇ **The Pardon.** He hires the PCs to bring Brenna in.
- ◇ **The Box.** It is stolen; whoever eats from it stops bailing.

**Threat:** he duels well. **Kindness:** he finds it amusing. **If nobody intervenes:** he is aboard the *Follow* when it goes down.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"A charming man. He asked how my chest felt, and listened. Nobody of his rank listens." — a Netwatch hooker

"He has never once been at muster at dawn." — his flag-lieutenant

"He sat through the whole sermon and never coughed. My grandson noticed." — a chapel-woman of Mile One

---

# ABEL DRAINER

the Wringer

*“Up you go, by the ankles, there’s a lad. All that sea’s got to come out somewhere. Better the bucket than the bed.”*

– ABEL DRAINER, HANGING A CONVERT IN THE FISH-CELLAR ON MILE FIFTEEN

| ABEL DRAINER – THE WRINGER |                                                                                       |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 8 (the Course, hidden) · Hunger 6                      |
| AGE & STATION              | 46; former fishmonger; Cell-Elder of the Purgation on Mile Fifteen                    |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Purger · Standing 3 (Cell-Elder)                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                   |
| SKILLS                     | Feast 4, Rites 3, Stealth 2, Persuade 4, Brawl 3, Intimidate 3, Stitching 2, Endure 2 |
| BODY                       | Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 · Fray 6                                                |
| ATTACKS                    | wet rope +6 (2); fish-mallet +6 (3)                                                   |
| GIFTS                      | Deep Breath; The Weight (he does not know it; his followers struggle to hoist him)    |
| WANTS                      | The West, four times answered                                                         |
| KNACKS                     | Butcher’s Calm, Gallows Laugh                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS               | The Dead Man (he is convinced he drowned the first time, and that this is borrowed)   |
| CARRIES                    | the mangle, ankle-straps, a wet rope, a basin, the cure list                          |
| DREAD                      | 2 (the cellar at night, the hanging line)                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

Gaunt, cheerful, gap-toothed, with a fishmonger’s chapped red hands and a laugh that fills the cellar. His fish-cellar stinks of old blood and brine.

## THEIR STORY

A fishmonger until the fish ran out in 628, he joined the Purgation after his wife walked in. He believes the sea can be wrung out of the blood. His followers hang converts by the ankles for a day and a night, beat the water out of them, and bail them until they bring up blood instead of brine. Some stop bailing afterward and die of nothing, dry. He counts it as cure.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Netwatch tolerates him because his converts are never Called. He runs a cell of six and a hanging-line of twenty. Families pay him to take sons; families pay the PCs to get them back.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

The mangle in the cellar, for the arms; padded ankle-straps; a rope kept wet in brine for beating; a tin basin marked with a red line he

calls *the blood mark*; and the cure list, sixty names, nineteen crossed out with the word *dry*.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the coast dry; he fears the fifth Calling. **Secret:** he has been Called four times and dragged home by his followers each time, and he has them hang him by the ankles every night to keep the water from rising. **He does not know:** he is far into the Course. His chest has not risen in a year. His followers know, and are afraid to tell him.

## TIES

Mother Limpet (he has twice tried to burn her chapel; she visits his converts); Sable Reef (she tolerates him, and hates herself for it); Dulse Ammery (she visits his hanging-line at night, and he does not know why the knots there come loose).

## IN PLAY

*The Mangle:* bring a son home. *The Fifth Time:* he walks, and his followers ask the PCs to help hoist him. *Dry:* a cured convert lies dying of nothing; his mother wants an answer. **If nobody intervenes:** one dawn his followers lower him from the line and find

him dry, calm, courteous, and Tenanted, and he thanks them for their trouble in two voices.

SAID OF THEM

“My boy came back from Abel’s thin as a gaff and never coughed again. He died in Plenty, smiling. Was it a cure? You tell me.” — a mother of Mile Fifteen

“He laughs while he does it. That’s the worst part. He means it kindly.” — a former convert

“Purgation of the Lung is the noblest work on the coast.” — Abel Drainer

# ANSBY WRACK

*the Cutwright of Lowmark*

*“It isn’t taking them back. It’s breeding. Look at the columns. Look at the children.”*

– ANSBY WRACK, TO THE PROVOST’S ENVOY, A LETTER NEVER ANSWERED

| ANSBY WRACK – THE CUTWRIGHT OF LOWMARK |                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Brinehollow · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                  |
| AGE & STATION                          | 39; Lecturer of the Cutwrights’ College, Mile Two house                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Cutwright · Standing 3 (Lecturer)                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                      |
| SKILLS                                 | Lore 5, Reckoning 4, Search 4, Clause 2, Persuade 2, Stealth 2, Endure 1 |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                   |
| ATTACKS                                | none worth the name                                                      |
| GIFTS                                  | Salt-Sense                                                               |
| WANTS                                  | none active                                                              |
| KNACKS                                 | Counting Habit, Smell of Cedar                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | none                                                                     |
| CARRIES                                | the ledgers, calipers, a blood-case, a cough-drop tin                    |
| DREAD                                  | 0                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

Soft-spoken, ink-cuffed, with a cough she pretends is a cold.

## THEIR STORY

A Mile Two copyist’s daughter, trained beside Brenna Kelp at twelve, posted home to Lowmark in 630. Her ledgers show that a Tenanted person’s descendants carry a higher Cut than their parents should have given them. The god is not just taking people back. It is breeding.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She keeps the College’s Lowmark house, where every Lung-line marriage is approved or refused. She wants the College to stop the marriages, and to stop the Admiralty marrying Tenanted widows to Lung-line cadets, which it has encouraged for a century.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

Ledgers of every Tenanted family in Lowmark; calipers; a case of dried blood in labeled glass; a tin of cough-drops she empties into her bucket at dusk.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She fears what the Provost will do with her ledgers, and what the Bench will do with her. **Secret:** she has proof that the House of

Vasht’s last three generations were fathered by Tenanted, and that the prince’s father was one. **She does not know:** her own grandmother was Tenanted, and her cough is not a cold.

## TIES

Commodore Vell (has read her ledgers through a College clerk); Orrin Wake (refused examination); Esk Penhallow (wants his line read); Brenna Kelp (they were copyists together at twelve).

## IN PLAY

She hires the PCs to steal a Tenanted family’s records from a parish chest; she needs her ledgers carried to the College outside Brinehollow before the Bench sends for her. **If nobody intervenes:** the Bench sends for her.

## SAID OF THEM

“She asked to look at my children’s teeth. Very polite. I let her. Then she cried.” — a Wreckwife

“A competent genealogist with an unfortunate gift for being right.” — the Provost’s envoy

“She counts us. I would like to know to what end.” — Justice Maren Oake

# GANNET SHALE

the Table-Seer

*“It looked at me and it waited. Like a waiter. Like I was late. And I ran, and I’m sorry,  
and I went back.”*

– GANNET SHALE, IN EVERY TAVERN FROM SALTWICK TO MILE NINETEEN

| GANNET SHALE – THE TABLE-SEER |                                                                            |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | Brinehollow · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 3        |
| AGE & STATION                 | 19; salvager of the far Uncovered                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING            | Gleaner · Standing 1 (Picker)                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                        |
| SKILLS                        | Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Athletics 3, Blades 2, Stealth 2, Filch 2, Endure 2 |
| BODY                          | Flesh 12 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Fray 6                                     |
| ATTACKS                       | gaff +4 (4, Hooking)                                                       |
| GIFTS                         | Deep Breath                                                                |
| WANTS                         | none yet                                                                   |
| KNACKS                        | Corpse-Road Walker, Scrap-Born Luck                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                  | none; she is dreaming of a chair                                           |
| CARRIES                       | wax drippings, a gaff, a salvage sack, a fast man’s coin                   |
| DREAD                         | 0                                                                          |

## WHO THEY ARE

Quick, sunburned, freckled, with salt-white hair cropped like a boy’s.

## THEIR STORY

She walked the far Uncovered alone for a week and saw, at dusk, a tall stooping figure laying a table on the mud. White cloth. Candles. A chair pulled out. It looked at her and waited, and she ran. The next morning the table was gone. The candles’ wax was still on the mud, and the drips went west.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She has told the story in every tavern from Saltwick to Mile Nineteen and been laughed at in all of them but one. Salvage crews call her bad luck.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

A twist of the wax, which is warm; a salvage gaff; a sack; and a Fast ration chit given her by an old man in a Fast traveler’s coat who bought her a drink in a Saltwick tavern and asked, very carefully, whether she had been thanked. (The old man was a tracker of the

Hostwatch, most likely Spare Tollard, or someone who walks as he does.)

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be believed; she fears she will be. **Secret:** she has been dreaming of the chair, and whoever laid it has started setting places in her dreams: one more each night. **She does not know:** the figure was Welcome Ardent, and the place was for her.

## TIES

Cray Lobbett (thinks she saw his table; she did not); Hask Tarn (believes her); Ilse Marl (Gannet hums a tune at night she has never heard; Ilse would know it).

## IN PLAY

She wants company for a return trip. *Thanked:* the figure returns, and this time it asks for her. **If nobody intervenes:** she goes back alone, and sits.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She told it again. Same every time. Liars change the candles.” — a Saltwick tapster

“Girl’s got good legs and a bad dream. Out there that’s half a salvager.” — Mags Weir

“Ask her if she was thanked. If she was, don’t let her go back.” — a Hostwatch tracker, at the bar

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# CORALIE SCULPIN

the Bucket-Wife

*“Clear’s a quarter crumb. Green’s a half. Blue I don’t buy, love. Blue I give you a crumb for nothing and a kiss, and you go and tie your knot.”*

— CORALIE SCULPIN, ON MILE TWELVE, AT DAWN

| CORALIE SCULPIN – THE BUCKET-WIFE |                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                        | Brinehollow · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2   |
| AGE & STATION                     | 44; head of the bucket-wives of the slum Miles; Dry Jonah’s buyer     |
| CALLING & STANDING                | Crumb-Runner · Standing 3 (Route-Holder)                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                        | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                   |
| SKILLS                            | Haggle 4, Persuade 3, Search 3, Feast 3, Stealth 2, Brawl 2, Endure 2 |
| BODY                              | Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 3                                |
| ATTACKS                           | bucket-hook +5 (3)                                                    |
| GIFTS                             | Salt-Sense (she grades by taste)                                      |
| WANTS                             | none                                                                  |
| KNACKS                            | Iron Stomach, Bone-Coin Nose                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                      | none                                                                  |
| CARRIES                           | yoke and pails, a tally, a crumb-string, a secret bucket              |
| DREAD                             | 0                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

Big, freckled, loud, with a yoke across her shoulders and two pails sloshing.

## THEIR STORY

A cannery girl who began buying buckets for Jonah in 625, and kept on after she was widowed in 629, she walks the slum Miles at dawn and dusk with her yoke.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She knows every household, every grade, every color. She notes the colors in Jonah’s Bucket Ledger. She gives a free crumb and a kiss for blue, and has warned more families than the Netwatch.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

A yoke and two pails; a tally-stick for each Mile; a string of crumbs; and one bucket she keeps lidded and never sells from.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants Jonah to go south and take her. **Secret:** she bought the bottle by Jonah’s bed from Sennet Gull, the cistern-dusk of Sennet’s Tenanted husband, at four lacks, because Jonah could not sleep and

she wanted to help. **She does not know:** she is in love with Jonah, and the bottle is killing him.

## TIES

Dry Jonah (partner, love); Tolly Brack (rivals; respect); Brenna Kelp (Coralie hid her twice, unaware who she was); Sennet Gull (a supplier no one else knows of).

## IN PLAY

She hires the PCs to find who is selling forged blue; she asks them, quietly, to take the bottle from Jonah’s cabin. **If nobody intervenes:** she ties Jonah’s knot herself, on the night he is Called, and it holds, and he cuts it.

## SAID OF THEM

“She gave me a crumb for nothing and said tie my knot. That’s how I knew about my mam.” — a boy on Mile Thirteen

“Coralie is the only honest thing in my trade.” — Dry Jonah

“She buys the sea off the poor and sells it to a fat man. And she’s kind. Work that out.” — Tolly Brack

# DULSE AMMERY

*the Kind Hand of Mile Fourteen*

*“Hush. Hush now, pet. You’ve asked so nicely. I’ll see to it. You go on.”*

– DULSE AMMERY, AT A BEDSIDE ON MILE FOURTEEN, AT NIGHT

| DULSE AMMERY – THE KIND HAND |                                                                             |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Brinehollow · Cut 2 (rising) · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 1 |
| AGE & STATION                | 71; grandmother, of Ropery Row and Mile Fourteen; returned 633              |
| CALLING & STANDING           | none                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 6                         |
| SKILLS                       | Stealth 4, Godsign 4, Instinct 4, Persuade 3, Blades 2, Resolve 3           |
| BODY                         | Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray —                                      |
| ATTACKS                      | little blade +5 (2)                                                         |
| GIFTS                        | Fathom-Body; Quiet Chest; Voice of the Deep (she uses it to soothe)         |
| WANTS                        | The Water; The West, on others’ behalf                                      |
| KNACKS                       | Elder’s Ear, Silent Supper                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | none; she is entirely at peace                                              |
| CARRIES                      | a little blade, a shawl, a ruling of the Bench                              |
| DREAD                        | 3 (to find her at the bedside, and to understand)                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

Small, soft, round-shouldered, with grey Tenanted skin and black eyes and a smell of lavender over brine.

## THEIR STORY

Called in 633, back in eight weeks, kinder than before.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She walks Mile Fourteen at night. She hears, as the Tenanted do, the sleepers who ask to be let go, and she lets them go. Nine ropes in nine nights on one street. The Netwatch suspects murder. The families suspect each other. The Drowned Bench has already ruled it lawful, as mercy to the willing.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

A little blade with a whalebone grip, very sharp; a knitted shawl; a copy of the Bench’s ruling, folded small, in the antique hand.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants everyone who asks to be let go; she fears nothing. **Secret:** she has taught her grandson. She told him the ones on the beds were asking, and that it was a kindness. That is Ottiline Hawse’s slip, if

the GM chooses. **She does not know:** some of those who asked were not asking. Something else was asking in their voices.

## TIES

Ottiline Hawse; Sable Reef (wants her arrested); Justice Maren Oake (wrote the ruling); Abel Drainer (she loosens knots on his hanging-line).

## IN PLAY

*The Rope-Cutter of Mile Fourteen*, as in the core book. **If nobody intervenes:** she keeps going.

## SAID OF THEM

“Gran’s so much nicer since she came back.” — a granddaughter of Ropery Row

“The Bench says it’s mercy. The Bench is ninety of her.” — Lieutenant Sable Reef

“She asked me if I wanted to go. I said no. She said all right, pet, and tucked me in. I didn’t sleep for a month.” — a widow of Mile Fourteen

# WEBS OF BRINEHOLLOW

*A rope has two ends. Mind who holds the other.*

– SAID AT WEDDINGS ON THE MILE

| CHARACTER         | WANTS FROM                                | FEARS                          | OWES                                |
|-------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Dry Jonah         | Rook's agents: payment; Coralie: buckets  | Brenna's count; his own bucket | Coralie, more than money            |
| Orrin & Passenger | a dry witness; Lobbett: the way           | each other                     | Marra, every knot                   |
| Brenna Kelp       | the Wreckwives: shelter; Limpet: her copy | the Tenanted's own count       | the Wreckwives, fourteen lives      |
| Mother Limpet     | the Passenger: an answer                  | the silence after a hand       | Sister Sounding, unknowingly        |
| Dagna Hull        | Vell: iron; Hask Tarn: a pilot            | the nine hundred               | Hollis, a life she does not know of |
| Cray Lobbett      | anyone: to count the chairs               | the twelfth visit              | the two men he lost                 |
| Old Wet Tom       | three women: to come up                   | nothing                        | Bethia, the rope end                |
| Sable Reef        | Nerys: the words                          | her own dream                  | the 304, a walk                     |
| Ilse Marl         | Lew: one hymn                             | which way the chart points     | Orrin, a counter-melody             |
| Finn Undertow     | Brenna: her figures                       | the last day of the count      | Sund, nothing; the city, everything |
| Calder Stokes     | Brenna: the second proof                  | the contract                   | Coyle, the figure                   |
| Ottiline Hawse    | families: to ask twice                    | the column marked None         | the boy, her silence                |
| Esk Penhallow     | Nell: an answer at the count              | that they are right            | his brother, a house                |
| Lysander Vell     | Dagna: the hold; Brenna: the working      | the Bench                      | the Second Table, a carving         |
| Abel Drainer      | his followers: a rope                     | the fifth walk                 | his wife's memory                   |
| Ansby Wrack       | the College: a ban on marriages           | the Bench                      | Brenna, an old friendship           |
| Gannet Shale      | anyone: belief                            | being thanked                  | the old man, a drink                |
| Coralie Sculpin   | Jonah: to go south with her               | the bottle                     | Sennet Gull, a silence              |
| Dulse Ammery      | the willing; their ropes                  | nothing                        | Maren Oake, a ruling                |

## THE FOLLOW AND ITS HOLD

Dagna Hull is building a ship to come back. Lysander Vell is paying for a ship that carries knives down. Hollis Brine is sabotaging it with Dagna's own hammer because he heard Nerys Colm's invitation and knows there is no coming back. Any one of them exposed breaks the other two. If the PCs reveal the hold, Dagna will strike Vell; if they reveal Hollis, she will forgive him and be ruined; if they

do nothing, all three go down together at the Low Water of 642, and what Vell carries to the bottom of the Trench is the Second Table's first course.

## THE NUMBER TWICE

Brenna Kelp has a proof by buckets. Calder Stokes has the same proof by tolls, and the Company had it first. The Admiralty will kill to keep one proof quiet; two proofs make a fact, and a fact can be

posted on tide-posts. Stokes's contract obliges him to carry the figure to Tàcit, where the Company will price the coast and sell the price to the Second Table. Brenna wants it published on the coast. Neither knows the Bench has already read her copy. Putting them in one cellar is the most dangerous meeting in Brinehollow.

## THE HAND, THE CHAIR AND THE CHART

The Passenger wants a hand at the eighth place. Cray Lobbett has three visits left before he sits. Ilse Marl's chart now runs from the table toward the Headland. Finn Undertow's count lands on the same Low Water. Each of them holds a piece; none of them is speaking to the others. Whoever brings them together brings the table to the coast, or the coast to the table.

# USING BRINEHOLLOW'S PEOPLE

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Roll when the PCs are lodging anywhere on the Mile, or need a scene to start.

| D20 | WHO'S AT THE DOOR?                                                                                                |
|-----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Dry Jonah, with a case of green bottles and a job: a cart east, guards needed tonight.                            |
| 2   | Coralie Sculpin, with a lidded bucket, asking a PC to keep it until morning and not to open it.                   |
| 3   | Orrin Wake, alone, asking in one voice whether anyone here is dry. Behind him, the other voice asks again.        |
| 4   | A Wreckwife with a "cousin" in a grey coat who mutters numbers, needing an escort to Mile Ten.                    |
| 5   | Mother Limper's lantern on the step, and a date written on a slip beneath it.                                     |
| 6   | Dagna Hull, shouting, hiring divers for the trial at the Trench edge.                                             |
| 7   | Cray Lobbett, drunk, with a knotted cord, offering to measure the doorway.                                        |
| 8   | A puddle, much deeper than the step, and Old Wet Tom's voice in it, asking politely for a crumb.                  |
| 9   | Lieutenant Sable Reef, needing every hand: three hundred walking tonight.                                         |
| 10  | Ilse Marl, wanting someone to hold her lantern at the Low Water.                                                  |
| 11  | Tolly Brack with a message from Finn Undertow: the bell will ring early, and the PCs should know why.             |
| 12  | Reeve Calder Stokes, coughing politely, with a ledger and a contract that needs a witness.                        |
| 13  | Ottiline Hawse, with a rope end and a question for a PC who was in the house last night.                          |
| 14  | Esk Penhallow, roped to the railing next door, asking a PC to call his name at the count.                         |
| 15  | A flag-lieutenant of Commodore Vell, with an invitation to dine aboard the <i>Gannet</i> at dusk.                 |
| 16  | Abel Drainer's followers, with a sack, asking if anyone here is coughing blue.                                    |
| 17  | Ansby Wrack, with calipers, requesting a short examination for the College.                                       |
| 18  | Gannet Shale, looking for company on the far Uncovered, and holding a twist of warm wax.                          |
| 19  | A small old woman smelling of lavender, at night, asking very kindly whether anyone in the house has asked to go. |
| 20  | Nobody. The count is called, and from the other side of the wall a voice answers that should not.                 |



CHAPTER 4

# THE VIGIL

*Every Hour Still Behind the Eyes*

*Count your nudger's blinks. Then count your own. Then stop counting, because the counting is soft, and soft is how it gets you.*

– SLOPE ADVICE, GIVEN TO EVERY CHILD AT THE COMING-HEAVY

*We do not have days here, Mistress. We have one day. It began in 341 and it has not ended. Everything since is a long afternoon.*

– HOURKEEPER MAUD SEXTON, TO A RIM ROAD FACTOR WHO ASKED WHAT DAY IT WAS

*The twenty-four bells of Wenna Startle, mirror-climber of the Lamplighters' Guild, Second Rank, as she told them to a Company clerk at Lampwick Halt who had asked what a working day was like up there, and wrote them down because he could not believe her.*

*First bell. You come off the roof with the rag-bag and the polish-pot and your knees going, and your brother Florian is waiting at the foot of the ladder with his hand out for the pot, because it's his shift on the mirrors now and mine on the house. He pinches my wrist and I pinch his. That's hello and goodbye. We haven't been in the same room sitting still since we were six. Nobody sits.*

*Second bell. Rouse. Half a tab under the lip, the Bitterhouse stamp facing my gum so it's the eye that dissolves first, because my gran said that was luckier. Bread with grit in it so it crunches. Vinegar. The Waker on our corner is old Hesk with the bad hip. He looks at my face the way you look at a pot to see if it's boiling. I say "awake" before he can ask. He nods. He has the needle out anyway. He always has the needle out.*

*Third bell to fifth. House. Ma's on the one-leg stool at the hackle, and you watch her sway. If the sway goes slow you shout. The baby is a starrer still, three, lies in the basket with her eyes open looking at the lamp, and doesn't need anything, and you pray to whatever's left that she doesn't need anything for another year. You don't look at her too long. Looking too long at a quiet thing is how it starts.*

*Sixth bell. The Shouting. Every house on Cinder Row opens its shutters and shouts for a count of thirty. Not words. Just noise. My ma does it like she's angry. My da used to do it like a song. He's in fourteen thousand and something. I know the number. I'm not going to say it to you, because you'd write it down.*

*Seventh bell to the twelfth. Back up. The mirrors on our stretch are forty-one big and two hundred small, and the smoke puts a skin on them every hour, brown and greasy, and if you don't take it off the light in the lane goes amber and*

*soft, and amber and soft puts people down. So you take it off, on your knees on the tin with the Bonfire making the sky the colour of a scab, and you polish till you see your own face, and then you polish that off too.*

*Thirteenth bell. Something walks across the roof three houses down. Tall. Grey coat. I didn't see it. I'm telling you I didn't see it, because I wasn't one of the thirty-one, so it didn't happen.*

*Fourteenth bell. Florian goes grey. You get to know the look: the jaw goes, then the shoulders, then the eyes stop going anywhere. I'm off shift but I'm on the roof anyway, because you are, because you don't leave a climber on a roof alone. I get my pin into the back of his hand. He comes back swearing, and I love him so much I could be sick.*

*Fifteenth to the nineteenth. Market. The Pinchmarket never shuts, so it never opens either; you just go into it like going into weather. Oil's doubled. Tabs are restamped again, the eye on them's a little smaller. Ma wants burr-cloth for the baby, who will need it soon, because they all do. A nudger-child at the east end has her board up: NOT ONE BLINK IN SIX MONTHS. She's maybe eight. She's swaying.*

*Twentieth bell. Board in the lane. Old Pell from the corner is on it, laid out flat in his good coat, rouse-heart, and we all queue to touch his eyes. You touch them and you think, he's lying down. He's lying down and nobody can say anything. I'll tell you the truth, mister, because you've slept and you'll sleep again tonight in that shed down the road: everyone in the queue was jealous. Everyone. The children too.*

*Twenty-first to twenty-fourth. You wait for first bell. You don't do anything else. You stand at the window and pinch, and count the lamps on the Row, and count the lamps again, and somewhere around the third time through you notice you've started counting something else, slow, and it isn't lamps, and it isn't in your voice.*

*Then it's first bell again, and Florian's at the ladder with his hand out.*

The core chapter tells what the Vigil is. This chapter is about what it means on an ordinary street at the fourteenth bell: who empties the night-pots in a city with no night, what a nudger earns, how a man is tried for a crime he committed in a two-second sleep, and who on the Lid can make whom do what. The Vigil is not a city under siege. It is a city that has made the siege its economy, its manners and its religion.

#### HOW THE VIGIL TELLS TIME

There is no night on the Lid, so the Vigil keeps time by bells. The civil day is twenty-four bells, struck from the Pendulum Hall and repeated by every tower; the quarters between are struck in a lighter tone called the *pinch*. The Hourkeeper divides the day into six watches of four bells, and the bell-sheets, the Seeming record and the Dormitory register are dated so. The Wakers, the Bitterhouse and the law reckon instead in three *long watches* of eight bells, because a shift is eight bells and a Rattlehouse sentence is served in long watches. Visitors are always confused. Vigilants are too, but are too tired to mention it.

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

The city on the Lid has no name of its own. Before 342 it was Ludmere; since then city and land have been one word, and Vigilants who must distinguish them say *up top* for the city and *the Lid* for the stone. It holds some four hundred thousand waking souls and sixty thousand who are not. Its districts are bounded in light: each has its own Bonfire, bell-tower and Waker station, and a Vigilant names their home by the fire they live under.

### THE CITY UP TOP

#### THE HEIGHT

The highest ground on the Lid, at its northern end, where the Eye-line houses stand on a hump of grey stone like teeth. It is bright and quiet: the hush of people who need not shout to stay awake, because they cannot do anything else. Some four thousand lidless live here with their eye-wetters, nudgers, clerks and valets, forty thousand souls in all, in tall narrow houses glazed on every side, on streets of ridged granite so carriage-bearers cannot drowse into a shuffle. The Nodding Stair rises at the summit, the Pendulum Hall beside it, and the Cutwrights' College keeps its Vigil house on Regard Street, shutters always open.

It smells of rosewater warmed to blood heat, of beeswax, and under that of the faint stale sweetness of eyes that are always wet; the gutters of the Height carry more rosewater than rain. Its sound is the soft clink of silver bowls and the whisper of sable brushes, every half minute, on every corner, in every carriage, like a city of painters. It trades in nothing; it owns things instead. The great houses hold the leases on the Bitterhouse's staremoss cliffs, the patents of the lamp-burners, and the debt of the Slope.

**Custom: the Regard.** The lidless do not bow. They greet one another by holding each other's gaze for a full count of ten, which neither can break, and which the lower orders are not permitted to attempt. To be *held in regard* by a lidless noble is an honour; to be held for longer than ten is a warning. Servants on the Height learn to look at the collarbone.

**Danger: being remembered.** Every lidless person on the Height recalls everything they have seen. A stranger who misbehaves on Regard Street is not arrested. They are simply remembered, perfectly, by everyone who saw, and in thirty years some one of them will mention it, word for word, at the worst moment of the stranger's life.

ANSGAR PELLOW, SENIOR EYE-WETTER TO HOUSE LARCH (SIXTY, A FORMER SLOPE NUDGER WHO HAS BRUSHED THE SAME PAIR OF LIDLESS EYES EVERY HALF MINUTE FOR THIRTY-ONE YEARS; HE COUNTS HIS STROKES, AND IS PAST THIRTY MILLION; HE WILL TELL ANYONE WHAT HE HAS SEEN THROUGH THE WINDOWS, BECAUSE NO ONE EVER ASKS HIM ANYTHING) Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (silver bowl 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

#### LUDMERE OLD TOWN

The oldest quarter, south of the Height and spilling around Ludmere Square, where the city's first Bonfire burned the beds in 342 and has burned ever since. The streets here are the twisted, soft-cornered lanes of the old pilgrim town, built for people who walked slowly and quietly, and the Vigil has spent three centuries making them loud. Every lintel is hung with bells. Every step has been recut so that no two are the same height. The old dream-houses, the oracles' halls where pilgrims once paid to sleep near Iss, have been gutted and turned into rouse-houses, counting-houses and Waker stations, and the old carvings over their doors (sleeping lambs, closed eyes, a long low shape with its knees drawn up) have been chiselled off or hung with tin.

Ludmere smells of the Bonfire: hot iron, pitch, the burnt-sugar reek of rouse-houses and the vinegar the cookshops splash on everything. It sounds like a riot that has gone on for three hundred years and has become a habit. The Pinchmarket fills three of its squares; the great tower of the Ludmere bells, where the deaf ringer Thaddeus Knell works, stands over the fourth. Here are the guildhalls, the bell-sheet printers, the rouse-houses where clerks



stand at chest-high counters arguing to stay awake, and the cheapest decent lodging in the city: the *waking-houses*, long rooms with sloped floors and hanging straps, where a traveller may rent a strap and a share of a hired nudger by the bell.

**Custom: the Argument.** Rouse-houses in Ludmere keep a slate on the wall with a topic chalked on it, changed every bell (*Was the Lack a punishment? Is fish meat? Does the Warden-Prime weep?*), and patrons are expected to take a side and shout. A man who agrees with everyone in a rouse-house is thrown out as a danger to the room. Many lifelong friendships in the Vigil began as a bell-long quarrel about whether the moon has a back.

**Danger: the old stones.** Ludmere is built on the original bedrock of the pilgrim town, and in some cellars and courtyards the stone is still faintly warm, the way the Pillow is warm. Nobody knows which. A courtyard where people keep pausing, putting a hand on the wall and smiling, gets a Waker post and then, when that does not work, a brick floor.

MOTHER HULDA BRACK, KEEPER OF THE ARGUING HOUSE ON CINDER ROW (FIFTY-FIVE, LOUD AS A BELL, TEETH ALL GONE; SHE HAS CHALKED A NEW TOPIC ON HER SLATE EVERY BELL FOR TWENTY-NINE YEARS AND HAS NEVER REPEATED ONE; THIS SEASON SHE HAS STARTED WRITING TOPICS SHE DOES NOT REMEMBER THINKING OF, THE LATEST BEING *WHO IS THE EIGHTH CHAIR FOR?*) Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (slate-board 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

#### LAMPWRIGHTS' ROW AND THE BURNERS' YARDS

The core book describes the Row as the brightest street in the world, and from the front it is: a mile of lit shopfronts and mirrored roofs where a walker casts no shadow. Behind the shopfronts, on both sides, are the Burners' Yards, and nobody takes their constitutional there. The Yards are a maze of brick sheds, soot-black chimneys, tallow vats, oil-cisterns and the nine great furnaces where the city burns its dead, and where, since about 636, the Lamplighters' Guild has been doing something else with them. The Yards are walled. Guild climbers patrol the wall-tops with lit poles. The men and women who work the furnaces are called Burners, wear leather to the eyes, and are paid better than anyone in the city below a Watcher, and do not talk in rouse-houses.

The front of the Row smells of hot glass, metal polish and lamp-oil. The Yards smell of fat. It is the smell a Fatlander knows from the rendering-sheds at Sated, thick and yellow and somehow sweet, and it has been creeping out over the wall into the Row for five years, so that the fine ladies of the Height taking their constitutionals find themselves, without knowing why, hungry. The Row trades in every kind of light: mirrors, lenses, burners, wicks, lamp-glass, mirror-lanterns at twenty-five lacks apiece. The Yards trade in oil and tallow, and the Guild's books show every barrel as *imported*.

**Custom: lighting the lamp.** When a citizen is burned on the Row, the family may pay to have a particular lamp lit from the ashes, and the Guild keeps a register of which lamp holds whom. Families walk past *their* lamp on the way to work and touch the post. The poor go into the general flame and have no lamp, and say instead that their dead are *everywhere on the Row*, which is a comfort, until you think about it.

**Danger: the Guild's economy.** Bodies brought to the Yards for burning are no longer always burned. The unclaimed, the poor, the foreign and the Rattlehouse dead go into the vats. A family that comes back to ask for ashes is given ashes. Nobody has asked whose.

BURNER ABSOLOM GREASE, THIRD FURNACE (FORTY, LEATHER-MASKED, ENORMOUS, GENTLE; HE RENDERS EIGHT BODIES A WATCH AND SAYS A SHORT GRACE OVER EACH IN THE OLD LUDMERE STYLE, THE ONE ABOUT PUTTING DOWN SOMETHING HEAVY; HE HAS BEGUN TO HEAR THE LAMPS ON THE ROW KEENING FAINTLY AT THE FOURTH BELL, AND HE THINKS IT IS THE ONES HE DID) Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (furnace-hook 4, Hooking) · Armor 2 · Dread 1

#### BEDSIDE

The district that has grown up around the Dormitory on the lower south side of the Lid. It is the newest quarter of the city and the most orderly, a grid of straight streets laid out by Benedikt Lour to carry Dormitory carts as quickly as possible from anywhere in the city to the Receiving Gate, and its people are the people the Dormitory employs: orderlies, sheet-washers, bed-smiths, register clerks, carters, and the felt-makers whose slippers keep the halls silent. Around them live the families of the Counted who could afford to move closer, in tall narrow houses with windows that look onto the Dormitory's long grey flank, so that they can see the building their loved one breathes in.

Bedside smells of lye and boiled linen from the laundries that change sixty thousand sheets every Plate, and near the walls of the Dormitory itself: warm skin and the milky sweetness of bodies that do not sweat. It is the quietest district in the city, because the Watch has ruled that noise must not disturb the Counted; so Bedside has the most blinks on the Lid, and its Waker station, the Felt House, has the hardest Needles. It trades in visiting: stools for an hour, cut flowers from the terraces, letters read aloud at the bed-foot by hired readers, and brass tags stamped with bed-numbers for families to wear.

**Custom: the Visiting Hour.** Every family with a sleeper has a visiting bell, assigned by the Dormitory clerks and stamped on their brass tag, and at that bell they may enter by the Visitors' Gate and stand at the foot of their bed for an hour. They talk. Most of what is said in the Dormitory in a given watch is people telling the Counted what they had for breakfast, who has married, whether the roof leaks. The orderlies hear it all and do not repeat it. The Visiting

Hour is the one hour of the day when Vigilants are permitted, by custom, to cry without being slapped.

**Danger: the breathing.** Anyone who spends long near the Dormitory's walls finds their breath slowing to match the four-to-the-minute tide of the Counted. A Bedside householder who leaves a window open on the Dormitory side can lose a whole family in an afternoon, matched, slowing, smiling, one after another.

ORDERLY-SERGEANT WILMOT TUSK, RECEIVING GATE (FIFTY-TWO, FELT-SLIPPED, BUILT LIKE A DOOR; HE HAS RECEIVED SOME NINE THOUSAND SLEEPERS OFF THE CARTS IN TWENTY-SIX YEARS AND HAS CARRIED EACH ONE IN HIS OWN ARMS TO ITS BED, BECAUSE HE BELIEVES SOMEONE SHOULD; HE IS A MEMBER OF THE LESSENING AT THE FIRST RANK, COPYING REGISTERS, AND HE THINKS IT IS A RECORDS SOCIETY) Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (hooked pole 3, Reach, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

### THE SLOPE

The core book gives the Slope as the slum. On the ground it is forty thousand households in a hundred lanes, a city within a city with its own law, rouse and pride. The lanes are named for trades: Thimble Lane, Lanternside, Gallow Street, Cinder Row, Gutter Lane, Pinchbeck Steps, Tallow Hollow. They are too steep for Waker carts, so the Slope has its own: barrows with wooden wheels that rattle on purpose, pushed by children. The houses are stacked so that one family's floor is the next one's roof, and every roof is tin, so that the Slope in rain sounds like a war.

The Slope smells of lamp-smoke from bad oil, of dung burned in the Bonfires because there is not enough wood, of sweat and piss and wet tin, and of cut rouse, which smells of chalk and ash and, this year, of the sea. It sounds of children. Nudger-children shout the bell on the quarter, all over the Slope at once, a thin high wave of voices calling *awake, awake, the pinch, awake*, which Slope people find more reassuring than any tower. It trades in labour (rope, wick, laundry, rag, the hauling of anything) and in what the Height does not admit to wanting: cheap nudgers, cut rouse, Tuckers' minutes, and stolen sleep.

**Custom: the Ring.** Slope families nudge in a ring. Everyone in the household has someone to watch and someone watching them, and the ring is set every first bell with the youngest who can nudge watching the oldest, so that grandmothers are kept awake by children, and children learn early what a grown face looks like when it goes. If a ring breaks, the household calls *ring!* down the stairs and the family below sends someone up. Nobody on the Slope is permitted to be unwatched in their own home, by custom older than law.

**Danger: the afternoon.** When a grey, windless, overcast afternoon settles on the Slope, whole families go down one after another, the last awake moving between the bodies slapping and screaming until they go quiet too. Slope people fear the soft weather

the way the fen fears floods. They also fear the Dormitory carts, which come down to collect and, on a bad afternoon, have been known to load people who were only very, very still.

MAG STARTLE, RING-MOTHER OF CINDER ROW (FORTY-SIX, A WIDOW WITH NINE GRANDCHILDREN AND A VOICE THAT CAN BE HEARD THREE LANES AWAY; SHE KEEPS THE STREET'S RING, NOT JUST HER OWN HOUSE'S, AND KNOWS BY THE SOUND OF THE SHOUTING WHICH HOUSEHOLD IS WEAKEST; SHE HAS STARTED TO THINK THAT TWO OF HER GRANDCHILDREN ARE NOT HER GRANDCHILDREN, BUT VERY CAREFUL COPIES) Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (pin-glove 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

### BLACKMOUTH

The north side of the Lid, around the Bitterhouse: a district of drying-sheds, roasting-ovens, grinding-mills and the tenements of the rouse-workers who staff them. It is called Blackmouth for its people's teeth. A Blackmouth worker's mouth is black by twenty and empty by twenty-five, and the district's children, who sweep the drying-floors for crumbs, have teeth the colour of tar before their second set is in. The workers are the most alert people in the city, quick, twitching, sharp-tongued, and the shortest-lived, their hearts giving out by forty; the rouse-heart funerals in Blackmouth come so often that the street-boards where the dead are laid out are never empty, and the neighbours queue to touch the eyes of one corpse while the next is being carried down.

Blackmouth smells of burnt sugar and iron, and makes visitors' teeth ache within an hour. The roasting-ovens give off a heat that the Watch considers dangerous, and so every oven-house has a Waker on the door and a bucket of cliff-water on a rope over the stokers' heads, tipped at random. Its sound is the grinding of the mills, a continuous low roar like a river, and the coughing. Blackmouth coughs black; the rouse-dust gets into the lungs. It trades in rouse, of course, in every grade, and in stare moss, which comes in by rope-lift from the cliffs below in bales of grey lichen that smell of wet stone and pepper.

**Custom: the Black Kiss.** Blackmouth people greet each other with a smile that shows the gums, and a person with all their teeth is treated with suspicion as either a spy from the Height or a liar who does not take his rouse. When a Blackmouth worker loses the last tooth, the family holds a small party, the *Black Kiss*, where everyone puts a pinch of raw rouse on the new-bare gum, and it is considered the beginning of adulthood.

**Danger: the Proving Rooms.** Under the Bitterhouse, Dr. Crane's chemists test new strains on prisoners from the Rattlehouse. Blackmouth knows. On some watches the ground over the Proving Rooms shakes faintly, as though something underneath were thumping on it with both fists, very fast, the way a heart does near the end.

GAFFER RUDD NINEBREATH, FOREMAN OF THE GRINDING MILL (THIRTY-EIGHT AND THE OLDEST MAN ON HIS FLOOR; TOOTHLESS, RATTLING, QUICK AS A WASP; HE KNOWS WHICH BATCHES ARE CUT WITH WHAT, AND THAT THE BITTERHOUSE HAS STARTED BUYING SEALED BARRELS FROM THE RIM ROAD COMPANY THAT SMELL OF LOW TIDE) Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (grinding-paddle 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

### NEEDLEGATE

The Wakers' quarter, at the foot of the Height around the Rattlehouse. It is a district of barracks, schools, standing-stalls, armouries, and the houses of Waker families, who intermarry and send their children to the Rattlehouse as their parents did, so that most Wakers in the Vigil are related to each other and all of them were trained by Sister Agathe Pinch. Needlegate is the loudest district after the Rattlehouse itself: every house has a rattle on its door, and Waker children play at patrols in the street, shaking their wooden toys at each other and screaming *thank you!* when they are pricked.

It smells of oiled steel and carbolic, and of the blood that is always on a Waker's hands, a little, from the morning's work. It sounds of rattles, and of the Rattlehouse's chimes, which sound every few breaths day and night through its tin-lined walls. It trades in needles (a Waker's long needle costs six lacks and is ground in Needlegate's own forges), in rattles, in the Atlas of the Quick in its several editions, and in pain, which off-duty Wakers sell privately as *a good waking* to households that cannot afford Jack Tenterhook.

**Custom: the Thanking.** When a Waker's needle brings a citizen back from a blink, the citizen is expected to say *thank you* as soon as they can speak, and the Waker answers *awake*. In Needlegate this is not a courtesy but a rite. Waker children are pricked by their parents on their fourth birthday, at the Coming-Heavy, and must say *thank you* through the scream, and the whole street applauds. A Waker who has been thanked ten thousand times receives a small brass needle for the collar. There are very few.

**Danger: off-duty Wakers.** A Waker on a rouse binge after a long watch sees drowsiness everywhere. The district's taverns post a sign, *Needles at the Door*, and most Wakers comply. Most.

NEEDLE-SERGEANT LIESL CORRAN, FELT HOUSE STATION, BEDSIDE (THIRTY-FOUR, LIDLESS BY HER MOTHER'S LINE THOUGH NOT BY HER FATHER'S, WHICH MAKES HER AN ODDITY; PERFECT RECALL OF EVERY FACE THAT HAS COME THROUGH THE RECEIVING GATE; SHE HAS NOTICED THAT FOUR OF THE SLEEPERS DELIVERED THIS YEAR WERE WAKERS FROM HER OWN STATION, AND ALL FOUR WERE IN THE LESSENING) Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (long needle 2, Waking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

### THE GLASS SPUR

A bare finger of rock projecting from the windward edge of the Lid, where the cold Grace winds hit hardest and nobody wants to live. The Glass House stands here: the long greenhouse of green glass divided into lamplit cells, where the contagious yawners are kept. Around it a small, odd district has grown up of the people who serve it: speaking-tube fitters, muzzle-makers, the keepers' families, and the Lamplighters' Glass Crew, who keep the Spur lit more brightly than any street but the Row, on a standing order that nobody can find the origin of. The houses on the Spur are built with their backs to the Glass House and no windows on that side.

The Spur smells of cold wind, wet stone and saddle-leather from the muzzle-makers' benches, and of the lamp-oil that is burned there in quantities that the Guild's accounts quietly treat as a sacred expense. Its sound is the wind, which howls along the glass, and the tubes, which carry voices from the cells in a thin, tinny murmur that the Spur's people learn not to hear. It trades in muzzles, mostly, and in visits: families from all over the city come to the Glass House to speak through the tubes, and pay a keeper a crumb to stand beside them and slap them if they begin to yawn.

**Custom: the Turned Back.** Spur people never look directly at the Glass House if they can help it, and when they must pass it they walk backwards. Children are taught that if a yawner catches your eye through the glass you will *catch the jaw*. It is not quite true. It is not quite false.

**Danger: the cells.** A cell door left unlatched, a muzzle worn through, a tube-cap left off, and a yawn may get out into the Spur on the wind. The Spur's houses each keep a pot and a spoon by the door for the alarm, and when the Glass House bell rings the whole district bangs pots and runs upwind.

KEEPER OTTILIE GRAIN OF THE GLASS HOUSE (FIFTY, WAX-EARED, WIRE-LIDDED, GRUFF; SHE HAS KEPT THE YAWNERS FOR TWENTY YEARS AND ROTATES HER OWN GUARDS EVERY BELL, BUT NEVER HERSELF, BECAUSE SHE BELIEVES SHE IS IMMUNE; SHE HAS NEVER ONCE YAWNED AT WORK, AND SHE HAS NEVER ONCE BEEN SEEN TO BLINK AT ALL, AND SHE DOES NOT KNOW THIS ABOUT HERSELF) Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (weighted cosh 3, Stunning) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

### BEYOND THE CITY

The plateau itself is all city, but the Vigil is more than the plateau. Its cliffs are farmed and mined, its lower slopes are terraced, the heather country below the border stones belongs to it, and the long Pilgrim Road from the Rim is lined with the little places that live on the traffic. Perhaps sixty thousand Vigilants live outside the city, and the city does not think much about any of them except when it needs something.

## LAMPWICK HALT AND THE LAST BEDS

The Rim Road Company's waystation at the foot of the Pilgrim Road, where the plateau road leaves the Rim. It is two places. Lampwick Halt is a walled inn-town with a hundred lamps on its walls, for Vigilant merchants who will not stop where they cannot see. A quarter mile down the road, on the Rim side of a stone marker, stand the Sleeping Sheds, long shuttered dormitories full of beds, which Rim travellers call *the Last Beds*, run by Factor Joss Mallory for the Company. Foreigners bound up the Pilgrim Road take their last sleep here before months awake. Vigilants coming down stand in the Sheds' doorway, sometimes for hours, looking.

The Halt smells of horse, oil and Company bread. The Sheds smell of straw ticking, wool blankets, other people's sleep, and Mallory's pipe; and to a Vigilant, that smell is the most obscene and beautiful thing on the Table. The Halt's sound is the bustle of any Rim station; the Sheds' sound is snoring, which Vigilant travellers have been known to weep at. The Halt trades in passage, rouse, nudgers for hire, mirror-lanterns and maps of the Sleepers' Mile. The Sheds trade in beds, at a lack a night, and in the porters who drag Vigilants away from them.

**Custom: the Last Look.** Vigilants travelling home stop at the Sheds' door to look at the sleepers inside, and the Company charges them a crumb for the privilege. It is considered bad luck to leave without paying, and worse luck to stay longer than a count of a hundred.

**Danger: the doorway.** Every few weeks a Vigilant at the Sheds' door simply walks in and lies down. Mallory's porters are paid to stop them, and usually do. The innkeeper's book of those they did not stop has two hundred and nine names in it.

PORTER DAW HALLAM OF THE LAST BEDS (TWENTY-EIGHT, RIM-BORN, HUGE, SLEEPY-EYED AND KIND; HE HAS DRAGGED MORE THAN FOUR HUNDRED VIGILANTS OUT OF THE SHEDS BY THE COLLAR AND BELIEVES THE WORK IS HOLY; HE HAS NOTICED THAT THE FACTOR SOMETIMES SENDS HIM ON AN ERRAND AT EXACTLY THE MOMENT A VIGILANT IS LINGERING AT THE DOOR) Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (cudgel 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

## PILGRIM'S STOOP

Halfway up the Pilgrim Road, where the road climbs from the heather onto the first shoulder of the Lid, stands the Stoop: a village of three hundred around a drovers' changing-post, an old pilgrims' chapel with its carvings chiselled away, and a long stone wall built at exactly the height of a tired man's shoulders and studded on top with iron. The wall is the Stoop's whole reason for being. In the old days pilgrims climbing to Ludmere would lean on it to rest. Now Vigilant caravan-drivers coming up from the Rim, who have been awake since the Halt, lean on it for the count of ten that the law allows, with a nudger beside them, and it is the last place on the road where leaning is legal.

The Stoop smells of wet heather, mule-dung and rouse brewed in great iron cauldrons, sold by the cup at a crumb. It sounds of mule-bells, and of the Stoop's dogs, which are bred and paid to bark; every household keeps one, and the village pays a tithe of meat to keep them hungry and loud. It trades in fresh mules, rouse, salt mutton, and the services of its nudgers, who are mostly old women who walk beside a caravan for a day for two lacks and then walk home.

**Custom: the Count of Ten.** At the Stoop wall a traveller leans, and the nudger counts to ten aloud, and at ten slaps them. A Stoop nudger who counts slowly is a murderer. A Stoop nudger who counts fast is a cheat. They are paid by the lean, and argue about the speed of ten constantly.

**Danger: the drift.** Fog comes up out of the heather on still mornings in Carving, soft and white and silent, and on fog days the Stoop locks its dogs out to bark at the road. Caravans caught in the fog between the Stoop and the plateau have been found standing in perfect order on the road, every mule and every driver, upright and asleep.

WIDOW GAMMER FENN, CHIEF NUDGER OF THE STOOP (SEVENTY-THREE, SHARP, UPRIGHT, WALKING-STICK TOPPED WITH A BRASS BELL; SHE HAS WALKED BESIDE FOUR THOUSAND CARAVANS AND NEVER LOST A DRIVER; HER TEN IS FAMOUS FOR BEING EXACTLY THE SAME LENGTH EVERY TIME; SHE HAS BEGUN TO NOTICE THAT IT TAKES HER LONGER TO SAY THAN IT USED TO, AND SHE IS NOT COUNTING ANY SLOWER) Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (bell-stick 2, Noisy) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## SORREL STEPS

The terraced farmland on the long southern slope of the Lid below the Slope, where the crops rose in a week on the morning after the Nine Nights and have been raised ever since. The Steps are a staircase of narrow fields, walled with dry stone, running down the hillside for three miles, growing sorrel, turnips, bitter kale, rye, and the hard short barley the Vigil makes its gritty bread from, with cliff-goats grazing the wall-tops. Some twelve thousand people live here in stone farmhouses with tin roofs, and the Steps feed perhaps a third of the city; the rest comes up the Pilgrim Road in Fatlands barrels.

The Steps smell of manure, crushed sorrel and goat; the air is cleaner here than up top, and city people come down on their rest-bells to breathe it, and are warned not to stay. Their sound is the farm-bells hung on the wall at the end of every row, rung by whoever reaches them, and the songs the farmers sing at the plough, which are the loudest and least tuneful work-songs on the Table, sung deliberately off-key, because a song in tune is soothing. They trade in food, mostly sold up the hill to the city's commissaries at prices set by the Watch, and in flowers, grown in a few sheltered terraces for the Visiting Hour at Bedside.



**Custom: the Tether-Plough.** Steps farmers work in pairs, tied together at the waist by a rope of twenty feet, so that if one goes down in the furrow the other feels the tug. Marriage on the Steps is called *taking the rope*.

**Danger: the sun.** Plenty on the Steps is the most dangerous season anywhere in the Vigil, because of the sun: warm on the back, on a south slope, in the long afternoons, with the bees going. Steps farmers work Plenty in the cold hours only, which are few. The bodies the Dormitory carts take from the Steps in Plenty are brown and sun-dusted and have earth under their nails, and they are smiling more widely than anyone.

CORM HATHERLEY, HEADMAN OF THE FOURTH STEP (FIFTY, SUNBURNED, DEAF IN ONE EAR FROM THE PLOUGH-BELLS; HE HAS LOST TWO ROPE-WIVES AND ONE SON TO THE FURROW; HE IS THE STEPS' SPOKESMAN TO THE WATCH'S COMMISSARIES AND IS PRIVATELY SELLING A FIFTH OF THE STEPS' GRAIN TO THE RIM ROAD COMPANY AT THREE TIMES THE WATCH PRICE, BECAUSE THE COMPANY PAYS IN SALLOWREACH MINUTES AND HE MEANS TO BUY HIS SON A CLOSING) Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (billhook 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## HANGWELL

The staremoss-gatherers' village on the north cliffs of the Lid, below Blackmouth: some two thousand people living in a vertical town of rope, plank and iron pegs hammered into the cliff face, with platforms, ladders and swinging rope-bridges stacked a thousand feet up the rock. Staremoss grows only on these cliffs, in grey scabs on the wet north faces where the sun never comes, and only the cliff-folk know how to gather it. They live hanging. They work hanging. They have no flat floors in their homes, because they have no flat ground, and the Waking Laws in Hangwell are unnecessary: a gatherer who blinks on a rope falls.

Hangwell smells of wet stone, pepper (staremoss smells of pepper when cut) and the tar they rub on their ropes. Its sound is the wind, the creak of ropes, and the clatter of the rope-lifts that winch bales up to the Bitterhouse; and, when a gatherer falls, a long cry that the village answers from every platform at once, a call-and-answer that goes on until the body hits the scree and everyone falls silent. They trade in staremoss and nothing else, sold by the bale to the Bitterhouse at prices that have not risen in thirty years. The cliff-folk are the poorest people in the Vigil and the only ones who take their rouse raw, chewing the moss straight off the rock.

**Custom: the Answer.** When a gatherer falls, every platform cries out in turn until they reach the bottom, so that the falling one hears, all the way down, that they are being watched. It is the Vigil's most famous custom, and its saddest.

**Danger: the moss itself.** Staremoss is the source of rouse, and the cliff-folk who chew it raw are the most awake people on the Lid and the most deranged. Hangwell's Seeming is constant and shared;

whole platforms see the same faces in the rock. The cliff-folk say that the cliffs are watching back, and that the moss is the god's eyelashes, growing.

TANSEL VETCH, ROPE-MASTER OF HANGWELL (THIRTY-ONE, A LEAN BROWN WOMAN WITH ROPE-BURNED PALMS AND THREE FINGERS ON HER LEFT HAND, ALL OF WHOM SHE LOST TO THE CLIFF IN ONE FALL THAT SHE SURVIVED; SHE HAS CHEWED RAW MOSS SINCE SHE WAS FIVE, HAS NEVER HAD A BLINK IN HER LIFE, AND SEES, AT EVERY WAKING MOMENT, A GREAT GREY EVELID IN THE ROCK FACE, A MILE WIDE, WHICH SHE SAYS HAS LATELY BEGUN TO TREMBLE) Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Attack +5 (gathering-hook 3, Hooking) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## EASTLIP

A hamlet of forty souls on the eastern rim of the plateau, perched on the cliff edge over the warm plain, where the Yawn first rises over the Lid. Eastlip is the Watch's weather-station. It keeps five great horns of brass, each eight feet long, mounted on the cliff-edge pointing back toward the city, and when the wind-watchers feel the Yawn coming up the cliff, smelling of hay and warm stone, they blow them, and the city's bell-towers take up the warning, and the Wakers double their patrols. The horn-blowers of Eastlip are the first Vigilants to feel the Yawn every year, and they feel it worst. The hamlet's population turns over every few years. The Watch pays well.

Eastlip smells, on most days, of cold rock and sheep. On Yawn days it smells of everything that the Vigil fears: sunlight, cut hay, a warm field, a summer afternoon a long way off. Its sound is the wind, and the horns, which are deafening at close range and which the watchers blow in turn, all through a Yawn, so that no one in Eastlip is ever more than a few breaths from a noise that hurts. It trades in warnings, nothing else, and is supplied by mule from the city.

**Custom: the Horn-Oath.** New watchers swear an oath at the horns on a dead watcher's name, *on Hilde, who blew till she fell*, and the dead of Eastlip are named, in order, on a brass plate bolted to the first horn. There are three hundred and ninety-one names. Every one of them went to the room with a horn at their lips.

**Danger: being first.** The Yawn reaches Eastlip a quarter-bell before it reaches anyone else. In that quarter-bell, the watchers must decide whether this is truly a Yawn, and blow; or a false alarm, and not. A watcher who blows for a false alarm is fined a season's pay. A watcher who does not blow for a true one is not there to fine.

HORNMASTER EDDA LARKSPUR (FORTY, LEAN, WIND-CRACKED, WITH HER EARS STUFFED WITH TARRED WOOL AND A SCAR ACROSS BOTH LIDS WHERE SHE ONCE TRIED, AT NINETEEN, TO SEW THEM OPEN; SHE HAS BLOWN FOR ELEVEN YAWNS IN TWENTY YEARS AND HAS BEGUN, THIS YEAR, TO

FEEL THE YAWN COMING FROM THE WEST, FROM BEHIND HER, FROM THE CITY, WHICH IS NOT WHERE THE WIND COMES FROM) Threat 3 · Flesh 12 ·

Guard 13 · Attack +4 (horn-staff 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

## CROOKHEATHER

A shepherds' hamlet in the heather country below the border stones, a mile north of the Sleepers' Mile, inside the Vigil's borders by perhaps a hundred yards. Its sixty people graze sheep and cliff-goats on the heather and sell wool to the burr-cloth weavers up top, and their village sits so near the Mile that from Crookheather's one street you can see the nearest of the old refugees lying in the heather, breathing, moss-furred, heather growing through their ribs. Crookheather is a place where the Vigil's rule and the Rim's meet, and both are bent: the border stones are a hundred yards off, and Crookheather children have, every generation, run across them on a dare and lain down on the Rim side, and none of them have woken either.

The hamlet smells of sheep, peat-smoke and wet wool, and of the heather, which in Plenty is purple, humming with bees, and lethal. Its sound is the dogs, the sheep-bells, and the shepherd-pipes, which Crookheather plays in a shrill, wailing, deliberately ugly mode that carries for miles over the moor. It trades in wool, mutton, and guiding: Crookheather shepherds know every body on the Sleepers' Mile by sight, and for a lack will lead a traveller along the Mile to a particular sleeper, if the family has the name.

**Custom: the Shearing of the Mile.** Every Plate, by an old village vow nobody can explain, Crookheather's shepherds walk the Sleepers' Mile with shears and cut the heather back from the

sleepers' faces, so that they can breathe. They do not touch the bodies otherwise. They do it without speaking.

**Danger: the Mile's attention.** Shepherds who shear the Mile say that lately, when they cut the heather from a sleeper's face, the sleeper's eyes are open. They were not open last Plate. They close again before the shepherds reach the next.

OLD HOB WITHY, SHEPHERD OF CROOKHEATHER (EIGHTY, THE OLDEST VIGILANT OUTSIDE THE CITY, BLIND IN ONE EYE AND BROWN AS A NUT; HE HAS SHEARED THE MILE FOR SEVENTY YEARS AND KNOWS FOUR THOUSAND SLEEPERS BY FACE; HE SAYS ONE OF THEM, A WOMAN NEAR THE OLD MILESTONE, HAS BEEN INCHING EAST, TOWARD HOME, A HAND'S WIDTH A YEAR, FOR AS LONG AS HE CAN REMEMBER) Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (crook 2, Hooking) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

## GM ADVICE – USING THE DISTRICTS

Every district of the Vigil is built around one way of staying awake: the Height by staring, Ludmere by shouting, the Row by light, Bedside by visiting, the Slope by the Ring, Blackmouth by rouse, Needlegate by pain, the Glass Spur by turning its back. Let the party feel the change of technique between districts, then find the place where it fails: a Height house with its shutters closed, a rouse-house slate with nothing on it, a gap in a Slope ring. That gap is where the scene is. Beyond the city, each settlement is a place where something has begun to change: the Stoop's ten is longer, the Steps' sleepers smile wider, the Mile's eyes are opening. Nobody up top has been told.

## ▼ ROADS AND WAYS

Nobody in the Vigil travels for pleasure, because travel is sitting, and sitting is the first half of lying down. Within the city, people walk; the rich are carried *standing* in Vigil sedans, borne by porters who sing in rounds. The Dormitory carts have right of way on every street, and when one passes, by law, everyone in the street stops and counts the bodies aloud. On the roofs, the Lamplighters' climbers have their own road, the *Mirrorway*, a network of tin catwalks, ladders and plank-bridges between the mirror-racks that crosses the city faster than any street, and climbers sell passage on it, illegally, at a crumb a roof.

Beyond the city the one true road is the Pilgrim Road, twenty-six miles from Lampwick Halt on the Rim to the Gate of Ludmere, climbing the whole way. Caravans take two days on it, with a night (as the Rim counts nights) at the Stoop, where nobody sleeps. Off the Pilgrim Road there are mule-tracks to Clatterpit, Eastlip and the

Steps, rope-ways down to Hangwell, and the shepherds' paths in the heather, which wind around the sleepers of the Mile.

## THE TWO DAYS UP

A foreigner climbing the Pilgrim Road should have slept at the Last Beds the night before. From the moment they pass the border stones they track Weariness, and the Road is two days of it: a long, steady, uphill monotony through heather and wind, which the GM may treat as one *scene of comfort* (+1 Weariness) for each half-day unless the party does something loud. Company caravans hire Stoop nudgers and sing. Those who do not are sometimes found at the roadside, upright, asleep, their mules grazing beside them, and are delivered to the Dormitory and billed to their employers. The Company's standard charge to the Watch for carrying one sleeper up the Road is twelve lacks.

| ROUTE                      | TIME  | WAY                  | ANGER                                                           |
|----------------------------|-------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lampwick Halt to the Stoop | 1 day | Pilgrim Road, uphill | fog on the heather; the Mile beside the road for the first hour |

| ROUTE                             | TIME            | WAY                                      | DANGER                                            |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------|------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| The Stoop to the Gate of Ludmere  | 1 day           | Pilgrim Road, steep                      | caravan-drift; Brine Walkers coming down          |
| The Height to the Slope           | 2 bells on foot | Regard Street, Ludmere, the Row, Bedside | crowds, Wakers, a Dormitory cart in a narrow lane |
| Across the Lid by the Mirrorway   | 1 bell          | roofs, catwalks, plank-bridges           | falls; Guild climbers; the mirrors blind          |
| Ludmere to Clatterpit quarry      | half a day      | mule-track west                          | slag-slides; deaf carters                         |
| Blackmouth to Hangwell            | 1 bell down     | rope-lift and ladders                    | a blink on the rope                               |
| Bedside to the Sorrel Steps       | 1 bell          | the Slope's lanes, then field-walls      | Plenty sun; the long warm afternoon               |
| The city to Eastlip               | half a day      | mule-track east                          | the Yawn, rising first here                       |
| The border stones to Crookheather | 1 bell          | shepherds' paths                         | the Mile's opening eyes                           |

## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

The Vigil's economy is the economy of a fortress that buys its walls by the day. It imports everything that burns and most of what it eats; it exports rouse, mirrors, lenses, clockwork, tin, bells and the skills of its glass-workers, which are the best on the Table; and it spends a frightening share of every lack it earns on staying awake. The Rim Road Company estimates that two parts in five of every Vigilant's wage goes on rouse and nudging. The figure rises every season.

Wages are paid by the bell, in rouse-tabs on the Slope and in lacks elsewhere. The rouse-tab, a pressed black lozenge stamped with an open eye and worth three crumbs, is the only currency on the Table that literally loses value in the body: the Apothecary-General restamps it each season, and the eye on it gets smaller. Slope workers paid in tabs are paid in their own wakefulness, and everyone knows it.

| WORK                                  | PAY PER DAY | NOTES                                          |
|---------------------------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Slope nudger (child)                  | 1 to 2 L    | paid by the bell; often in tabs                |
| Hired nudger (adult, sworn)           | 3 L         | Pinchmarket rates; double for <i>Witnessed</i> |
| Rope-twister, laundress, wick-braider | 2 L         | piecework; the Slope's bread                   |
| Bitterhouse grinder or roaster        | 4 L         | plus rouse; a short life                       |
| Staremoss gatherer, Hangwell          | 1 L         | by the bale; unchanged in thirty years         |
| Dormitory orderly                     | 3 L         | plus slippers and a ration                     |
| Waker (Rattle)                        | 3 L         | plus needles; Needle rank 5 L                  |
| Lamplighter climber                   | 4 L         | free light at home                             |
| Burner of the Yards                   | 9 L         | and silence                                    |
| Dream-Diver hauler                    | 5 L         | a share of the diver's wage                    |
| Dream-Diver, per dive                 | 60 L        | paid to the family if the diver stays          |
| Glass-grinder of the Row              | 6 L         | the Vigil's aristocracy of labour              |
| Eye-wetter to a Watcher               | 5 L         | and everything they see                        |
| Wake-valet (skilled)                  | 10 L        | Jack Tenterhook asks 40                        |

What things cost on the Lid follows the core book's Rim Market, with these differences. Rouse runs about 3 lacks a day for a modest adult at the present dose. Lamp oil is double the Rim price and rising. Bread is cheap, gritty and dense, because the Watch subsidises it; a clatter-cake is two crumbs. Fatlands salt meat costs half again what it does at Sated. Soft goods are contraband, and a pillow on

the black market fetches more than a horse. A Tucker's minute costs a month's wage, which on the Slope is about ninety lacks, and Old Nod will take it in tabs at the current stamp. Lodging means a strap in a waking-house at two lacks a day, with a nudger's share included.

**Taxes.** The Watch levies three. The *Light-Rate* is paid by every household by the window, so that the rich, who have the most windows, pay the most; it funds the Lamplighters, and the Slope evades it by having almost no windows. The *Wake-Tithe* is a tenth of every rouse sale, collected at the Bitterhouse door, and funds the Wakers. The *Bed-Due* is the cruellest: the family of every Counted sleeper owes the Dormitory a lack a season for the sheets, the slippers and the orderlies, for as long as the sleeper lies, which is for ever. A family that falls three seasons behind loses its visiting bell. A family that falls ten behind has its sleeper *transferred to the general*

*rows*, a phrase nobody will explain, and since 639 a clerk of the Lessening has been quietly marking those beds.

**Who is rich.** The Eye-line houses of the Height, who own the staremoss leases and the lamp patents. The Bitterhouse's contractors, who buy moss from Hangwell at thirty-year-old prices and sell rouse at this season's. The Rim Road Company, which owns the oil convoys, the Last Beds and the Watch's debt. The Tuckers, whose King keeps his money in a place nobody has found. Jack Tenterhook. And, newly and secretly, the Lamplighters' Guild, whose oil accounts show imports that have not arrived, and whose inner members have lately bought houses on the Height.

## ▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

The core book gives the Law of the Lid: lying down is a crime, closing your eyes for longer than a breath is a crime, letting someone near you nod off is negligence. On the street, the law is enforced by Wakers on patrol, by Ward Sergeants who sit in judgement at each station for minor offences, and by the Standing Bench in Needlegate for anything worse. There are no sitting judges in the Vigil, because there is no sitting.

A trial at the Standing Bench is held on foot. The accused stands in an iron hoop at the centre of a round room; the magistrate, who is always lidless, stands on a raised step facing them; witnesses stand in a ring. The trial lasts as long as the accused can stay awake without rouse, which is held to be a fair test of their sincerity. A witness may swear to a thing and be told the Seeming record shows otherwise; the record is, by law, true. The lidless magistrate's perfect

recall is the record of the trial, and no clerk writes anything down; when an appeal is made to the Watch, the magistrate is summoned to the Stair and simply recites the trial, word for word, every cough included.

The newest problem before the Bench is the blink-murder. The law has not decided what to call a killing done in a sleep of two breaths by someone who was not there. In 640 the Bench tried three such killers. One was hanged in the Lantern until his heart gave out; one was acquitted as *not present*, and was found in her own kitchen a week later, lying down, with her own hands crossed on her chest; and one, a Waker's widow, was sentenced to be kept awake by the state for the rest of her life, and is still standing in the Rattlehouse, and says *thank you* every time they needle her.

| CRIME                                          | USUAL PUNISHMENT                                                       |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Drowsiness in a public place                   | Needled on the spot; a fine of 1 L                                     |
| Closing the eyes beyond a breath               | A long watch in the Rattlehouse                                        |
| Leaving a person unwatched                     | A fine of 20 L; if they go down, as manslaughter                       |
| Lying down (and fetched back)                  | Three days in the Lantern                                              |
| Possession of soft stuffing                    | Burned in the square; owner's nudger fined                             |
| Selling sleep (Tuckers)                        | A season in the Rattlehouse; the hook confiscated                      |
| Singing or humming <i>The Lamb and the Lid</i> | A season in the Rattlehouse; second offence, the Lantern               |
| Incitement (speaking softly of the room)       | Tongue pinned for a day; the Lantern for a preacher                    |
| Theft, brawling, fraud                         | Hours in the Rattlehouse; the stolen value thrice over                 |
| Murder (waking)                                | The Lantern until death                                                |
| Blink-murder                                   | Undecided; the Bench improvises                                        |
| Lying in the Pillow                            | None; the offender is carried to the Dormitory                         |
| Treason against the Watch                      | Held in the Rattlehouse awaiting a sentence that cannot be carried out |



## THE LANTERN, SEEN FROM BELOW

Every district has its Lantern: an iron cage on a pole in the square, lit by its own lamp, in which the condemned stands and is kept awake by any passing citizen with a pin. In practice it is kept awake by children, who are given a crumb by the Ward Sergeant for every prick. By the third day the condemned believe the crowd below is eating them; by the fifth, some of the crowd agree. In 637 a Lantern in Tallow Hollow was found empty at first bell with its lock intact, and the street, questioned one by one, all agreed on what had happened, and the Registrar declined to enter it.

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

Iss had no priests in the ordinary sense. Its old servants were the *walkers-softly*, whose whole religion was being quiet near a sleeping god, and after 342 their order was broken, their dream-books burned and their name made a slur. Faith in the Vigil today is mostly a matter of how one answers the old question about the god that did not wake.

**The Theft** is held in the Vigil as *the Smothering*. We killed a sleeper, the Smotherers say; the most defenceless thing on the Table, a god that could not even see us coming; and every soul in the Dormitory is the god's quiet answer, taking us back one at a time as gently as we took it. It is the Watch's own doctrine, preached in the old dream-halls of Ludmere as a reason for discipline: we must stay awake because we deserve to be punished in our sleep. Its shrines are the Penitents' Posts, iron pillars at street corners studded with spikes, against which the devout press their palms on the hour.

**The Gift** is called *the Lullaby*, and is the faith of most ordinary Vigilants. Iss let itself be eaten because it was too kind to wake, and the room is its kindness still: a place where the tired go to rest, where nothing hurts. It is the Lullaby's believers who stand at the foot of the beds in Bedside and tell their dead about the weather, who light lamps for them on the Row, who believe that the Counted can hear. Lullaby faith is tolerated, barely. It is very close to the Bedded, and the Wakers know it.

**The Bait** is the forbidden faith, and in the Vigil it has a terrible plausibility. The Bait-believers say a god of sleep breeds by being dreamed: swallow it, and in three hundred years you will all dream the same dream, and the dream will be the god. The Dormitory, they say, is a womb, the beds are its cells, and the number is a term of pregnancy. This doctrine is illegal on the Lid, and the Bedded preach a softer form of it, and the scholars of the Cutwrights' house on Regard Street have been heard to agree with it in private.

**Shrines.** Besides the Penitents' Posts, the Vigil has the bed-foot shrines of Bedside, where families tie ribbons and brass tags to the foot-rails; the lamp-posts of the Row, where the ashes of the dead burn; the Bonfires, which every district treats as an altar; and the

Pillow, which is not a shrine and which nobody worships at, and at which every night someone is found kneeling at the fence.

**Rites.** The Coming-Heavy (a child's first yawn, met with the first pinch and the words *you will never rest*); the Pinching (the wedding, at the Bonfire, with the two-word vow); the Thanking (in Needlegate, and wherever a Waker fetches someone back); the Boarding (laying a corpse on a board in the street, so the neighbours may touch the closed eyes and envy them); the Lamp-Lighting (on the Row, from the ashes); and the Standing Watch, by which a family keeps vigil at the foot of a new sleeper's bed for one full day after they are Counted, in case.

**Holy days.** The core book gives the Night of Lying Down, the Shouting Day, the Pinching Fair and Tablenight. There are two smaller days. *Starers' Day*, in early Grace, celebrates the city's infants, who do not yet need to sleep; mothers carry their starers through the streets in open baskets and the crowds throw bells into them. And on *the Day of Nine Nights*, the anniversary of the meal, the old Ludmere families of the Height go in procession to the fence of the Pillow, barefoot, in felt, in silence, and stand there for a bell, and then go home; nobody else is permitted to watch, and the Watch does not explain what it is for.

*The Waking Hymn, sung at every Bonfire at the first bell, standing, as authorised by the Watch of Watches in 344 and never since amended.*

*Keep me, lamp, I am not done;*

*I have not earned my lying down.*

*Keep me, bell, and keep me, pin,  
and keep the long room's door shut in.*

*I ate the meat and drank the milk,*

*I slept on down and slept on silk;*

*now let me pay with open eye  
for every hour I let go by.*

Keep my child, and keep my wife,  
and keep me waking all my life;  
and when they board me in the street,  
let my sleep be short and sweet.  
Count us, Hourkeeper, count us through:

we stand for one, and one, and two.

The last line is a counting-rhyme, and the congregation goes on after the hymn ends, counting aloud together, until the bell strikes the quarter.

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

- ◇ “You want to know if I’m tired? Mister, I’ve been tired since I was four. Ask me something I can answer.” — a Slope laundress, at her trough
- ◇ “My job’s to carry them in and lay them down gentle. I lay them like they were mine. Some of them are.” — an orderly at the Receiving Gate
- ◇ “Pinch me, love. No. Harder. There. Now tell me you’ll still be here at first bell.” — a bride at the Ludmere Bonfire
- ◇ “Of course I visit. I go every day. I tell him about the roof. He never answers, but he never interrupts either, which is more than when he was awake.” — a widow of Bedside
- ◇ “We render what comes in. I don’t ask whose. If I asked whose I’d never stop asking.” — a Burner of the Yards, in drink
- ◇ “When you fall, you hear the whole cliff calling your name, all the way down. My da said it was the best thing he ever heard.” — a Hangwell girl of twelve
- ◇ “I’ve had the minute three times. Old Nod’s lads pulled me up every time. Worth every tab. Worth my teeth. I’d do it again

tonight if I had the money, and I’d stay if they let me.” — a rope-twister of Thimble Lane

- ◇ “I blew for the Yawn and nobody came up the street to thank me. You only get thanked here for hurting someone.” — a horn-blower of Eastlip
- ◇ “They say you can’t sleep anywhere. I slept at the Last Beds. Laid down on the straw with my eyes shut, and the room came for me like a dog that knows your step, and the porter got me by the hair. I’ve never been so happy in my life as those four seconds.” — a Vigilant mule-driver, at the Stoop
- ◇ “We don’t use the word murder. We say *the general rows*.” — a Dormitory clerk, unwisely
- ◇ “I’d go to the room tomorrow if I knew my boy would be in the next bed. That’s what they don’t understand on the Height. It’s not that we want to sleep. It’s that everyone we love is already asleep.” — a Slope mother, at a dark-meeting of the Bedded
- ◇ “Don’t sit on the kerb, child. The dead get to sit. You’ll get your turn.” — a grandmother at a Boarding

## ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

The Vigil looks like an absolute state: one council, one Warden-Prime, one law. It is in fact a ring of people each holding something the others cannot do without, each watching the next, none able to look away. The Watch rules because it cannot sleep; the Wakers rule the street because they can hurt; the Matron holds the number; the

Apothecary-General holds the dose; the Lamplighter-General holds the light; the Hourkeeper holds the time; and the King of the Tuckers holds the one thing everyone in the city wants and nobody can admit to buying. Every one of them is running out of something.

| POWER                      | CONTROLS                           | FEARS                             | OWES                                          |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud | the Watch, the city, the Deadwatch | her daughter; being seen to blink | the Rim Road Company, whose loans pay for oil |
| The Watch of Watches       | law, revenue, the Offices          | the number; a quorum gone grey    | the Eye-line houses that elect it             |
| Matron Cecily Dorm         | the Dormitory and its register     | the arithmetic; what she has done | the Warden, who appointed her                 |
| Dr. Aldous Crane           | the Bitterhouse, the dose          | the curve’s end; the Last Cake    | the Watch, which owns his work                |
| Garron Ashlock             | oil, light, the Row’s furnaces     | the ledger’s last page            | Lucan Spill; the Renderers’ Union             |
| Captain Brannoch Pyre      | the Wakers, the Rattlehouse        | his own blinks                    | the Watch; and his dead wife                  |
| Maud Sexton                | the bells, the official hour       | the night that will not end       | nobody; she is disregarded                    |

| POWER                        | CONTROLS                                     | FEARS                        | OWES                                   |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Old Nod                      | the Tuckers, illegal sleep                   | the hook failing; the Bedded | dozens of Watchers who took his minute |
| The Rim Road Company         | oil convoys, the Last Beds, the Watch's debt | a closed Rim                 | Oathen, where its contracts are sworn  |
| The Lessening (Sabine Larch) | the lists, a few orderlies                   | exposure; the Matron's proof | the Second Table                       |

The lines of the table hide a second structure. Almost everyone on it owes the Rim Road Company, and the Company owes nobody on the Lid. Almost everyone on it fears the number, and only two of them know it. And almost everyone on it has, at some time, sent a servant down the Slope with a purse to Old Nod's cellar, because even the lidless have servants with eyelids, and even the lidless have once, as a child, wanted to know what it felt like. Old Nod's register of failures is the most dangerous document in the city that is not about the Dormitory, and the second most dangerous is his list of customers, which he keeps in his head.

#### GM ADVICE – WHO CAN MAKE WHOM DO WHAT

When the party needs something done on the Lid, ask which of the ring holds it, and what they are running out of. Crane can give the party rouse, or refuse it, or give them something worse; he wants time. Ashlock can light a street, or darken one; he wants oil. Pyre can lift a sentence or order a needling; he wants someone to tell him he did right. The Matron can open a row; she wants someone to tell her she did wrong. Sexton can strike a bell early or late, which on the Lid is a weapon no one has noticed; she wants a witness. Old Nod can hide anyone; he wants a better hook. And the Warden-Prime can do anything, and will remember everything, and wants the city to outlive her by any means, including the party.

# THE PEOPLE OF THE VIGIL

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*Never trust a rested face.*

– VIGIL PROVERB

The cast of the Vigil are, almost all of them, people holding something up. The Warden holds the city; the Matron holds the number; the Captain holds the street; the Apothecary holds the dose; the Lamplighter holds the light; the Hourkeeper holds the hour; the King of the Tuckers holds the one minute everyone

wants. The others are the ones being held: a daughter kept out of sight, a diver held on a rope, a child held to a client's wrist by a pinch, a man held behind glass. Every one of them is very, very tired. What follows gives the first half of them in depth.

# WARDEN-PRIME ILVANE STROUD

*the Unblinking*

*“I do not need you to repeat it. I never need anyone to repeat anything. I only need you to understand that I will still have it, exactly as you said it, when you are on the Row.”*

– ILVANE STROUD, TO A WATCHER OF THE THIRD SHIFT WHO ASKED IF SHE HAD HEARD HIM

| ILVANE STROUD – THE UNBLINKING, WARDEN-PRIME OF THE VIGIL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                                | the Vigil · Cut 5 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                                             | 58; Warden-Prime of the Vigil since 612, head of the Watch of Watches                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                                        | Scion · Standing 5 (Warden-Prime)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                                                | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                                                    | Search 5, Reckoning 4, Resolve 4, Clause 3, Intimidate 3, Godsign 3, Persuade 3, Lore 3, Endure 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                                                      | Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                                                   | silver hatpin +3 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                                                     | Perfect Recall (she remembers every word said in her sight; any lie told to her face she catches on a Routine Eye + Search roll, eventually). Lidless (cannot be surprised by anything in her line of sight; cannot look away from a Dread; at Weariness 10 she Breaks rather than sleeps). The Weight of Regard (Partake: one person she stares at makes a Caul + Resolve roll, Hard, or confesses the thing they most want hidden from her). |
| WANTS                                                     | To watch (she cannot leave unwatched anyone who might betray her; Hard). To count (the Watchers passing the Lid’s Eye, every quarter hour; Routine).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| KNACKS                                                    | Counting Habit; Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                                              | The Copies (she believes her eye-wetters are replaced, from time to time, by careful copies, and checks them against her memory pore by pore)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                                                   | silver hatpin; a lash of Iss in a phial; the Lidless Seal; a silver bowl and two sable brushes; a blank commonplace book; a child’s milk tooth                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                                                     | 2 (to hold her gaze for a full minute while she does not blink)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is a small woman, narrow-shouldered, straight as a lamp-post, in grey galled silk wired so finely that it whispers when she breathes. Her face is lined everywhere except around the eyes, which have no lids to crease: there is only a raw pink rim where lids should be, and inside it two enormous pale grey eyes, red-veined, always wet, never still. Every half minute one of her two eye-wetters raises a sable brush from a silver bowl of rosewater warmed to blood heat and strokes it across her eyes, left then right, and she does not flinch, because she has never been able to. The rosewater runs down her cheeks in two steady tracks, so that the Warden-Prime of the Vigil appears, at every moment of her life, to be weeping. She smells of roses and of something underneath, sweetish and stale, like water left too long in a vase.

Her voice is soft, precise and slightly hoarse. She speaks in complete sentences and never asks a question twice. She does not gesture. When she listens, she does not nod; she watches the speaker’s mouth, and the speaker becomes aware, within a sentence or two, that every word is going somewhere it will never leave.

## THEIR STORY

Ilvane Stroud was born in 583 A.G., in the Stroud house on Regard Street, staring. Her first memory is the midwife’s slap. At five she watched from a window on the Height as the carts of the Grey Ninth went down to the Slope, and she remembers every body she saw.

Raised to watch, she stood on the Stair from the age of ten, was elected to the Watch at nineteen, and to the Warden-Prime’s landing in 612, at twenty-nine, the youngest in a century. She married her cousin Florian Wakely in 610, a lidless Watcher of gentle temper;

their daughter Oriel was born in 618, with eyelids. Florian died of a rouse-heart in 626, on the Stair, mid-sentence. She can still hear the sentence. It was about drains.

In 622 she stood at the deathbed of Matron Hesketh Anstey, as the law required, while the dying Matron whispered the number to her successor, Cecily Dorm. Ilvane was not meant to hear it. She did not. She *read* it, on the old woman's lips, from across the room, and has carried it since. Nobody knows.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She stands on the Lid's Eye landing, halfway up the Nodding Stair, and the whole Watch of Watches passes before her every quarter hour as it climbs. She does not climb; she is the fixed point the council turns around. Every motion is spoken in her sight, and she remembers every one. She appoints the Offices: the Matron, the Apothecary-General, the Lamplighter-General, the Hourkeeper, the Captain of the Wakers, the Registrar of the Seeming. She signs every sentence to the Lantern. She holds the Rim Road Company's loans in her own name, because the Watch could not be trusted to remember the terms.

Her limits are three: the Watch could in theory depose her; the Company owns the oil; and she must rely on reports, which she knows to be lies one time in four. She governs by remembering more than anyone else and letting them know it.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A silver hatpin** — nine inches, set with a pearl, worn through the knot of her hair. She uses it on herself, under the nail, when the weight behind her eyes is worst. She has used it on others twice.
- ◇ **A lash of Iss** — a black hair a yard long, stiff as wire, coiled in a phial of green glass on a chain at her throat. One of three left on the Table. She knows where the other two are: one in the reliquary of the Tether Hall, and one in Old Nod's cellar, where she has let it stay because she knows he has never used it. Taint 4 Regrowth (Iss); see the Rim Market.
- ◇ **The Lidless Seal** — a ring of black bone carved with an open eye, which makes any document the Warden-Prime's will. She seals few. She prefers to be remembered.
- ◇ **A silver bowl and two sable brushes** — carried by her eye-wetters, Prudence Hale and Ambrose Startle, who have served her for nineteen years and whom she suspects, once or twice a season, of being someone else.
- ◇ **A blank commonplace book** — bound in grey calf, given her on her election. She has never written in it. She carries it so that people will believe she needs to.
- ◇ **A child's milk tooth** — Oriel's, the first she lost, kept in a locket. Ilvane does not know why she kept it. She remembers the day exactly. Oriel cried, and blinked through the tears, and Ilvane looked at the floor for the first and only time in her life.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the Vigil to outlive her, by any means, and she has decided what that means. The Deadwatch is her policy: if the Regent of Sallowreach will sell the secret of Keeping, the city will be killed and kept upright, and will never need to sleep again. She has done the arithmetic, which Envoy Dray thinks she has not. If the Vigil moves north to die, the sixty thousand Counted will be left on the Lid, unwatched, in the dark. She has decided that is acceptable.

She fears her daughter, and this is the secret she has told no one. In 631, when the first restless sleeper was logged and struck from the register, Ilvane obtained the Matron's private notes and compared them, minute by minute, with her own memory of Oriel's movements. The restless sleepers turn their heads, all together, toward the Height. They do it when Oriel closes her eyes.

**The secret she does not know:** the number she read on Hesketh Anstey's lips was not the number Anstey whispered. The dying woman's lips shaped one thing; her breath, which only Cecily Dorm heard, said another. The Warden-Prime has spent nineteen years doing arithmetic on the wrong figure, and the GM decides which of them is right.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Lady Oriel Stroud** — her daughter, whom she loves with a terror she has never once allowed onto her face, and whom she cannot bear to see blink.
- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — her appointee and the only other keeper of the number; Ilvane trusts her completely and watches her constantly.
- ◇ **Envoy Castellan Dray** — her ambassador in Lastgate; she knows from the exact phrasing of his letters that he is keeping something from her.
- ◇ **Dr. Aldous Crane** — she ordered the Last Cake. She remembers the order word for word, and so does he.
- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — the one officer who has never lied to her face. She knows Merrit lay down. She has not said so.
- ◇ **Deputy-Watcher Sabine Larch** — the Warden knows about the lists. She has not stopped them. She is waiting to see if the arithmetic is right.
- ◇ **Lady Seraphine Dalgety** — a cousin on her mother's side, and a member of the Second Table; Ilvane suspects it and has her watched.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet the Warden-Prime on the Lid's Eye, summoned to report or be accused. She wants the truth, which she will get, and their usefulness, which she will spend. Foreigners interest her: they can sleep beyond the border, and nobody knows whether an Unfed would go to the room.

- ◇ **The Recitation.** The Warden-Prime summons the party to the Stair and recites, word for word, a private conversation they had

in a Ludmere rouse-house a week ago, which she was not present for. Someone has a lidless witness among them. Who?

- ◇ **The Second Letter.** She asks the party to carry a sealed letter to Envoy Dray in Lastgate, with orders not to open it. It says: *Tell them yes. Tell me nothing more.*
- ◇ **The Seen Blink.** On the Stair, in front of three hundred Watchers, the Warden-Prime's eyes go still and far away for two breaths. The lidless do not blink. Only the party saw it. She knows they did.

To threat she answers with memory: she recites the threatener's whole life back to them. To kindness she is puzzled and polite, and she remembers it, and will repay it at a time of her choosing. To the god she gives nothing at all; she simply watches it, and it has never been able to make her look away. If nobody intervenes, she signs the Deadwatch, leads the Vigil north to the Drop, and is killed and Kept in Lastgate, lidless for ever, remembering everything, in a fen where nothing ends.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"She looked at me once for the count of ten. I have dreamed of it every night since, and I have never once slept." — Watcher of the third shift

"Ten million strokes and she's never thanked me. She doesn't need to. She remembers every one." — Ambrose Startle, eye-wetter

"They say she cries all the time. It's only the rosewater. That's what makes it so bad." — a Slope rope-twister

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# LADY ORIEL STROUD

*the Lidded Heir*

*“Mother, I am looking. I am looking as hard as I can. Please, let me shut them for a moment and I will look again.”*

– ORIEL STROUD, AGED SIX, RECALLED WORD FOR WORD BY THE WARDEN-PRIME

| ORIEL STROUD – THE LIDDED HEIR |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | the Vigil · Cut 5 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite, by the College’s ledger) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION                  | 23; only child of the Warden-Prime; kept hidden at the top of the Nodding Stair                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING             | Scion · Standing 2 (an heir no one acknowledges)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                         | Godsign 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Stealth 3, Persuade 2, Craft 2, Resolve 2, Athletics 1, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                           | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                        | embroidery scissors +2 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                          | Heavy-Eyed (she knows when anyone in sight is about to blink, +2 Instinct and Search against blinkers). The Far End (when she closes her eyes she sees the long room from behind the lid; she may ask the GM where in the room any named Counted sleeper stands, and gains 1 Hunger). The Turning (when she closes her eyes for longer than a breath, every restless sleeper in the Dormitory turns its face toward her; she does not know this). |
| WANTS                          | To lie down (Hard; triggered by her own bright, bedless rooms). To shut her eyes (a Want of her own: triggered by being stared at; Routine).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                         | Little Lies; Hostage’s Smile                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                   | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                        | embroidery frame; a stolen down feather; letters never sent; ear-trumpet; a mirror with its glass turned inward; a key to the roof                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                          | 1 (to watch her close her eyes and smile); 3 for anyone who knows what it does                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is small and soft-voiced, with dark hair worn loose because no one has ever thought to dress it, and ordinary hazel eyes under ordinary lids, which in her family is a deformity. In company she holds her eyes open until they stream, and the tears run down her face in two lines like her mother’s rosewater, so that the two of them, side by side, look like mourners. Her skin is very pale; she has not walked a street in eleven years. She smells of the lavender water her nudgers wash her rooms with, and of linen. She moves carefully and quietly, like someone who has learned that noise brings visitors. When she smiles it is quick and shy and gone; when she is alone and closes her eyes, she smiles slowly, and that smile is the most frightening thing on the Height.

## THEIR STORY

Oriel was born in 618 to the Warden-Prime and her consort Florian Wakely, both lidless, and she came out of her mother blinking. The midwife dropped her. Her birth was entered in the Cutwrights’

ledger with a note, *lids present, cause unknown*, and the rumour on the Height that she was some eye-wetter’s bastard has never died, though the Warden-Prime remembers her own fidelity perfectly and has never troubled to deny it.

She was raised behind locked doors at the top of the Nodding Stair, in white rooms lit by mirrors, attended by deaf nudgers so that no one would hear her ask to sleep. Her father read to her until his death in 626; her mother visited once a day for a count of a hundred and watched her not blink. She learned embroidery, Ludmere history, and the art of keeping very still while someone looked at her.

She was eleven when she first closed her eyes on purpose for longer than a breath, alone, behind a curtain. She was twelve when she first saw what was behind them.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She has none, officially. The Watch knows she exists and has agreed not to know it. She is the Warden-Prime’s only heir, and the Lidless

Succession forbids her to inherit, so the Stroud line passes, on Ilvane's death, to a lidless cousin, Corvin Stroud-Larch, to whom Oriel has been promised in a marriage that would make their children his. Some houses on the Height would pay to have her quietly removed; the Second Table and the Lessening would pay more to have her, having heard what is rumoured to happen in the Dormitory when she closes her eyes.

Her rooms are guarded by two Wakers who believe they are guarding a madwoman. Her nudgers are deaf and devoted. She knows every guard's step on the stairs and every eye-wetter's voice through the floor, and she has a key to the roof that no one knows she has.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **An embroidery frame** — a long white sampler she has worked on for nine years: the long room, stitch by stitch, from the far end, with the backs of sixty thousand heads in grey thread. She has nearly finished the last row.
- ◇ **A stolen down feather** — a single grey goose-down feather, found caught in a Rim Road Company crate in the Stair's storeroom. Possessing it is a crime. She strokes her cheek with it when she cannot bear the light.
- ◇ **Letters never sent** — sixty-one letters to her mother, folded small and hidden in the hem of her gown. Most of them begin *I am sorry*.
- ◇ **An ear-trumpet** — her father's, from the year before he died, when the bells had begun to deafen him. She uses it to listen through the floor to the Stair.
- ◇ **A hand-mirror with its glass turned inward** — she had a glazier reset it the wrong way round, so that she can hold a mirror and not see her own eyes.
- ◇ **A key to the roof** — stolen from a careless climber at sixteen. Up there, among the mirrors, she has stood in the smoke and looked for stars.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be allowed to be ordinary. She wants to close her eyes in front of someone and have them not look frightened. She wants her mother to look at her once without that face. She fears the marriage to Corvin, who has told her pleasantly that he will have her lids removed by a Seamer on their wedding night, *for the children's sake*.

**Her secret:** when she closes her eyes she does not see darkness. She sees the long room from its far end, through a great grey lid, and every sleeper in it, standing in their silent ranks, turning their heads to look at her. She has never told anyone, because it is the only time in her life that anyone has looked at her with love.

**The secret she does not know:** when she closes her eyes, the restless sleepers in the Dormitory turn their faces toward the Height. Her mother knows. The Matron has noted it without

knowing the cause. Evander Quell of the Second Table has guessed. Oriel's lids, the old walkers-softly would have said, are not a failure of the Course. They are the god's lids, given back, and when she shuts them, for a moment, the eye in the room is shut from the inside.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — her mother, whom she loves and cannot reach; Oriel believes her mother is ashamed of her, and is wrong.
- ◇ **Corvin Stroud-Larch** — her intended, lidless, courteous, terrifying; a cousin of Sabine Larch.
- ◇ **Lord Evander Quell** — has twice sent her gifts by a bribed eye-wetter: a book of lullabies, and a velvet blindfold. She has kept both.
- ◇ **Pip Eleven-Bell** — the child she has watched from the roof, pinching strangers in the Pinchmarket far below; she has never spoken to Pip, but has stitched Pip into the sampler.
- ◇ **Senna Vole** — the diver has seen, near the eye, a figure standing behind the lid where no one could stand. Neither woman knows of the other.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Oriel by accident, on the Stair roof at the end of a climber's route, or by commission: hired to guard her, abduct her, or find out what she is. She wants someone to sit with her while she closes her eyes, and not be afraid.

- ◇ **The Roof.** A party crossing the Mirrorway finds a young woman in white on the roof of the Stair, eyes closed, smiling, swaying at the edge. If they wake her, she thanks them and asks them not to tell. If they watch her for a count of sixty, the orderlies at the Receiving Gate hear sixty thousand heads turn on their pillows.
- ◇ **The Wedding Seamer.** Corvin Stroud-Larch hires a Seamer to come to the Stair on the wedding night. The party is hired, by someone else, to make sure the Seamer never arrives.
- ◇ **The Blindfold.** Quell's agents ask the party to deliver a velvet blindfold to Oriel, and to stay with her while she wears it. What happens in the Dormitory during the bell she wears it is what Quell wants to know.

To threat she goes still and quiet and very polite. To kindness she weeps and does not hide it. To the god she is drawn as to a lover. If nobody intervenes, she marries Corvin, her lids are cut away, and the restless sleepers stop turning to the Height; and for a season the Vigil seems calmer, until the Matron notices that the restless sleepers are now all facing, very slightly, upward.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She asked me what it was like to blink with someone watching who didn’t mind. I said I didn’t know. I’d never had that either.” — a deaf nudger, in sign, to a Waker

“A lidded Stroud. Pity. The blood’s going soft at the top.” — a Cutwright of Regard Street

“There’s a lady on the Stair roof some nights, in white. She doesn’t polish anything. She just stands up there with her eyes shut like she’s listening for her name.” — Wenna Startle, mirror-climber

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# MAUD SEXTON

## the Hourkeeper

*"I do not say the hour is longer. I say the pendulum says so, and the sand says so, and the candle says so, and my own wrist says so. I am outvoted four to one by things that cannot lie."*

— MAUD SEXTON, TO THE WATCH COMMITTEE THAT SUPPRESSED HER REPORT, 640

| MAUD SEXTON – THE HOURKEEPER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | the Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                | 60; Hourkeeper of the Vigil, mistress of the Pendulum Hall                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Factor (the Office of the Hour) · Standing 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                       | Reckoning 5, Craft 4, Search 3, Lore 3, Resolve 3, Endure 2, Clause 1                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| BODY                         | Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                      | escapement key +3 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                        | Heavy-Eyed (+2 Instinct and Search against blinkers; she knows when someone lies about having blinked). The Felt Hour (she always knows how much time has passed, to the breath; she cannot be gaslit about lost time, and may tell any companion exactly how long they were out). |
| WANTS                        | none of the god's yet; her own compulsion is to measure                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| KNACKS                       | Counting Habit; Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                      | jeweller's loupe; brass escapements; the 340 sand-glass; a candle-clock; the margin-report; a pulse-watch                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                        | 0 (but 2 to stand with her in the Pendulum Hall while she explains)                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

### WHO THEY ARE

A stooped little woman in a brown work-apron over a grey gown, with a jeweller's loupe screwed into her left eye socket so long that the skin has grown a pale ring around it. Her pockets clink: she carries a fistful of brass escapements, the small toothed wheels of clocks, and turns them over in her fingers like prayer beads, click, click, click, in time with whatever is ticking nearest. Her hands are perfectly steady. Her voice is dry, quiet, and unhurried, the voice of a woman who has spent forty years in a tower full of ticking and has had to speak under it. She smells of clock-oil and brass polish. She does not look at people much; she looks at their wrists, where the pulse is.

### THEIR STORY

Maud was born in 581 in Ludmere Old Town, the daughter of a bell-founder, and apprenticed at twelve to the Pendulum Hall, where she has been ever since. She became Hourkeeper in 618. For nineteen years the work was routine: setting the bells, adjusting the

two hundred and forty clocks, logging the pendulum's swing. In 629 she noticed that the great pendulum was half a breath behind the sand-glass at the end of a day. She re-hung it. In 630 it was a breath behind. In 640, after eleven years of measuring by pendulum, sand, candle, water-clock and the pulse of her own wrist, she submitted her report to the Watch: every hour is a little longer than the last, now by two breaths a watch. The report was suppressed within the bell. She has written it again, smaller, in the margins of the bell-schedules that every tower in the city receives.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She sets the time. Every bell in the city, from the Ludmere tower to the Glass House, is struck to her signal, relayed from the Pendulum Hall by flag and lamp. The Wakers' shifts, the Rattlehouse sentences, the Dormitory's visiting bells, the Bitterhouse's batches and the rouse-tab's stamped value all depend on her hours. If she struck the bells early, the city would take its rouse early; if late, the Slope would go down in its thousands. Nobody has noticed this power, least of all the Watch, which treats her as a clerk.

She depends on the deaf ringer Thaddeus Knell to carry her bells, and on the Watch to fund the Hall. She has no allies on the Stair. Her apprentices are three bored girls from Ludmere, one of whom reports to the Registrar.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A jeweller's loupe** — brass and crystal, her father's, worn so long it has shaped her face.
- ◇ **Brass escapements** — seven of them, from clocks that stopped. She knows the date each stopped. She clicks them when she thinks.
- ◇ **The 340 sand-glass** — an hour-glass made in Ludmere the year before the First Night, the last hour measured before the city stopped sleeping. She turns it every hour against the pendulum. It runs out early, now, every time.
- ◇ **A candle-clock** — a marked taper she burns at her desk, the third check.
- ◇ **The margin-report** — her suppressed figures, copied in a hand so small it needs the loupe, around the edges of three hundred bell-schedules. Anyone who has read one has read a page of the end of the world.
- ◇ **A pulse-watch** — a small clock with a single fast hand, for counting her own heartbeat.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants a witness: someone with authority to stand in the Pendulum Hall for a full hour and feel it, the slowness under the ticking, the way the beats drift apart. She does not want to be right. She wants someone to prove her wrong, and nobody can.

**Her secret:** she has run the curve forward. On a night not many years from now, by her figures, the hour will stop ending. The fourteenth bell will be struck, and the fifteenth will not come, and the city will stand in a single hour that goes on and on, awake, under the lamps, while the oil runs out and the rouse wears off, until everyone in it lies down.

**The secret she does not know:** her fourth measure, the pulse of her own wrist, has been slowing for years to the four-breath tide of the Dormitory. Part of what she has measured is herself. The GM decides how much: whether the night is truly lengthening, or the Hourkeeper is falling asleep very slowly, and taking the city's clocks with her.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Thaddeus Knell** — the bell-ringer who strikes her hours; he has started ringing by the shaking in his teeth instead of her signal, and his teeth are later every day. She has not yet worked out which of them is right.
- ◇ **Dr. Aldous Crane** — the only Officer who read her report; he told her, kindly, that her curve and his have the same shape.

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — who suppressed the report, and who remembers every figure in it.
- ◇ **Senna Vole** — the diver once told Maud that in the room there is no time at all. Maud asked how long she had been there. Vole said: *exactly as long as you counted*.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to the Pendulum Hall to set a bell, to steal one, or because a schedule they read had figures in its margins. Maud wants witnesses, and will offer anything she has (which is time: she can strike a bell early or late, once) for an hour of their company in the Hall.

- ◇ **The Hour in the Hall.** Maud asks the party to stand with her in the Pendulum Hall from bell to bell. Each PC makes a Dread 2 check at the end: the hour was longer than it should have been, and they felt every breath of it.
- ◇ **The Late Bell.** Someone has bribed an apprentice to strike the Slope's fourth bell a quarter late. It will put down hundreds. Maud needs the party to find out who before the next.
- ◇ **The Stopped Clock.** One of the two hundred and forty clocks in the Hall has stopped, at precisely the moment Bed One's lips first moved. Maud wants it taken to the Dormitory and set at the foot of Aveline Morne's bed, to see if it starts.

To threat she is unimpressed; she has measured worse. To kindness she is suspicious, then grateful, then she asks to take your pulse. To the god she offers measurement, which it does not seem to mind. If nobody intervenes, she is found one bell standing at the great pendulum with her hand on the bob, holding it still, smiling, and the whole city's bells go silent at once.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She timed my ten at the Stoop once. Said I was a breath long. I've been a breath long ever since and it's getting longer." — Widow Gammer Fenn, chief nudger of the Stoop

"Old Sexton? Clocks and nonsense. If the hours were longer we'd be paid more." — a Bitterhouse grinder

"The pendulum is a pendulum. It swings as it swings. I see no reason to frighten the Slope with arithmetic." — a Watcher of the second shift, moving to suppress

# CAPTAIN BRANNOCH PYRE

*the Needle of the Lid*

*“Say thank you. No. Say it. Say it so I can hear you’re still in there. Good. Good girl. Awake.”*

– BRANNOCH PYRE, AT A STREET CORNER ON THE SLOPE, FIRST WATCH

| BRANNOCH PYRE – CAPTAIN OF THE WAKERS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | the Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                         | 52; Captain of the Wakers since 627; master of the Rattlehouse                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | Nightwarden · Standing 5 (Captain of the Wakers)                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                                | Intimidate 4, Stitching 4, Blades 3, Brawl 3, Search 3, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Athletics 2, Instinct 2                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (padded Waker’s coat) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                               | long needle +7 (2, Piercing, Waking; the target loses 2 Weariness and suffers –2 to its next roll from pain); rattle-club +7 (3, Noisy)                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                                 | Heavy-Eyed (+2 against blinkers). The Quick (with a needle he wakes any blinker instantly, and hurts a person exactly as much as he intends; a Helping on a needle attack may impose a Dread 1 check instead of damage). |
| WANTS                                 | To count (every face on his rounds; he cannot pass a sleeping cat without needling it; Routine).                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                                | Pin-Cushion; Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| DERANGEMENTS                          | none admitted                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                               | the long needle; rattle-club; brass thanking-needle; Merrit’s wedding pin; the Atlas; her note                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                                 | 1 (to watch him work)                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

A big slope-shouldered man with a shaved head the colour of a boiled ham and forearms latticed with three decades of needle-scars, a neat white grid where he has practised every point in the Atlas on himself. His voice is gravel, worn down by shouting people awake. His eyes are pouched, bloodshot, and heavy, and he rubs them with his knuckles when he thinks no one is looking. He smells of carbollic, steel and the sour sweat of a man on four doses of rouse a watch. He moves like a bear with a bad back. He is gentle with his hands, which is the most frightening thing about him: when he takes your wrist to needle the web of the thumb, he holds it like something precious.

## THEIR STORY

Born on Lanternside in 589, Brannoch was a nudger at six, a Rattle at sixteen, and a Needle at nineteen, trained by Sister Agathe Pinch like every Waker alive. He was good at it from the first; he had, Pinch said, the rarest gift a Waker can have, which is that he was sorry every time. He married Merrit Lantern, a wick-braider, at twenty-four. They were each other’s nudgers for twenty-seven years. He made Captain in 627. In Carving of 640 he came home from a

double watch and found her lying on the kitchen floor with her hands folded and a note on the table, warm, breathing, gone. He needled her for an hour, every point in the Atlas, long after he knew. Then he carried her to the Dormitory himself. She is in bed 59,804. He told the Rattlehouse she died of a rouse-heart.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He commands some four thousand Wakers, every station, the Rattlehouse and the Lanterns, and answers only to the Watch. He decides where the patrols go on a Yawn day, which streets get the hardest Needles, which households are fined and which are warned. He is the most hated man on the Slope and the most necessary, and the Slope knows both. His limit is the Watch, which gives him orders he obeys; and his own Wakers, who love him, and who would not report him for walking his rounds unwatched, which he has done every watch since Merrit lay down.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The long needle** — nine inches of hollow steel, rouse-dipped, the same one he was given at nineteen, ground so many times it is half its old thickness (6 L; Piercing, Waking, Concealable).
- ◇ **A rattle-club** — ash-wood and tin, the Captain’s pattern (3).

- ◇ **A brass thanking-needle** — worn on the collar; he was thanked his ten-thousandth time in 611. He believes he has been thanked a hundred thousand times since. He believes none of them meant it.
- ◇ **Merrit's wedding pin** — the pin she pinched him with at the Bonfire. He wears it through his own earlobe and twists it when the weight comes.
- ◇ **The Atlas of the Quick** — Pinch's schoolroom edition, his name on the flyleaf in a boy's hand.
- ◇ **Her note** — folded to the size of a lack, in his breast pocket.  
*Bran. I'm so tired. Don't come after me. Pinch the boys for me.*  
They had no sons. He does not know who the boys are.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants someone to tell him he did right: that three decades of needles under nails were love, not cruelty. He fears that they were both, and that he cannot tell the difference any more.

**His secret:** Merrit lay down. He has also blinked three times this month and come back with blood under his nails that is not his.

**What the GM can reveal:** in his blinks he needles whoever is nearest, every point in the Atlas, in two breaths, the way he did on the kitchen floor. Three citizens have reported a Waker who did it and then stood listening. They assumed it was ordinary service.

**The secret he does not know:** Merrit is restless. Bed 59,804's lips have begun to move, and the Matron has written down what they shape. It is two words, over and over: *pinch me*.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Merrit Pyre** — his wife, in bed 59,804. He has not visited. He walks past the Dormitory on his rounds and does not look at it.
- ◇ **Sister Agathe Pinch** — his teacher; she knows he is unwatched and has said nothing, because she thinks he should be allowed one sin.
- ◇ **Inspector Hale Grimmer** — his best investigator, whom he protects from the Registrar; Grimmer has noticed the Captain's hands.
- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — the one person he has never lied to on the Stair. He does not know she knows.
- ◇ **Old Nod** — his enemy by law; they have arrested and released each other's people for thirty years, and respect each other more than anyone else in the city.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Pyre on the street, when he needles one of them for drowsing, or in the Rattlehouse, if they are arrested. He wants competent people who are not Wakers, for jobs he cannot give his own. He wants, much more, someone to watch him.

- ◇ **Unwatched.** A Waker-Sergeant hires the party to follow the Captain on his rounds for a watch and keep him awake without his knowing. At the eleventh bell, he blinks.
- ◇ **Bed 59,804.** The Matron asks the party to bring the Captain to his wife's bedside. She does not say why.
- ◇ **The Yawn Order.** On a Yawn day, Pyre orders every Needle onto the Slope. The party is with him when a whole lane goes down, and he has to choose which households to fetch first.

To threat he answers with the needle, quickly and without anger. To kindness he becomes gruff, then silent, then grateful in a way that frightens him. To the god he gives nothing: he has spent his life hurting it. If nobody intervenes, he blinks on the Slope next to a child, and comes back with his hands on the child, and the GM rolls the d6.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He needled my mam under every nail on her left hand and she screamed thank you and he cried. I've never seen a Waker cry. I hated him. I hate him still. She's alive." — a Slope boy of twelve

"Bran's the best Needle I ever trained, because it costs him. The ones it doesn't cost are the ones I worry about." — Sister Agathe Pinch

"The Captain walks alone. Everybody knows. Nobody says. You don't report a man for missing his wife." — a Rattle of the Felt House



# OLD NOD

## King of the Tuckers

*“Sixty seconds, madam. It will feel like a great deal longer. That is what you are paying for. Mind the step.”*

— OLD NOD, AT THE CELLAR DOOR, TO EVERY CUSTOMER

| OLD NOD – KING OF THE TUCKERS |                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | the Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION                 | 70; King of the Tuckers; former Dream-Diver of Three                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING            | Crumb-Runner · Standing 5 (King of the Tuckers)                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                        | Haggle 4, Persuade 4, Resolve 4, Stitching 3, Instinct 3, Deceive 3, Godsign 2, Blades 2, Reckoning 2, Endure 2                                                |
| BODY                          | Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                       | hook-knife +5 (2)                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                         | Heavy-Eyed (+2 against blinkers). The Long Look (blink under guard and ask one question about a Counted sleeper or a current blinker; 2 Weariness and 1 Fray). |
| WANTS                         | To watch (he cannot leave a sleeper unwatched; Routine). He has never failed a count in person.                                                                |
| KNACKS                        | Conditional; Dowager’s Patience                                                                                                                                |
| DERANGEMENTS                  | none                                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                       | the register; hook-and-harness; half-moon spectacles; the sign; a purse of tabs; a lash of Iss                                                                 |
| DREAD                         | 1 (to watch a customer go under in his cellar)                                                                                                                 |

### WHO THEY ARE

Small, quick and courteous, with a soft white beard trimmed close, half-moon spectacles, a grey wool coat buttoned to the chin, and, when he smiles, the black stumps of a lifetime of rouse. He bows to customers. He calls everyone *madam* or *sir*, including children and Wakers. His voice is low and warm and slow, which on the Lid is very nearly illegal, and his cellar is warm too: the only warm room on the Slope, smelling of clean straw and beeswax, with a single lamp turned low and a sign over the door that says only *Rest*. His hands are cold. He keeps them in his pockets.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 571 on Pinchbeck Steps, he volunteered for the Tether Hall at twenty to pay his mother’s Bed-Due and made three dives, which is a full career. On the third he stood in the long room for what the hauliers said was ninety seconds and what he says was a life: he lived, in that warm dim place, a whole long untroubled existence of rest, and was dragged out of it by a hook through the root of the tongue. He never dived again. In 604 he set up a cellar on Gutter Lane and began selling what he had learned: sixty seconds, under guard, with

the Hall’s method of return, stolen and adapted. The Tuckers were a scattering of chancers before him. He made them a trade.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Old Nod runs some thirty cellars across the Slope and Ludmere, each with a Cellar-Keep, Counters and Haulers, and his queue goes round the block at every bell. He pays the Wakers of three stations, quietly. A month’s wage, about ninety lacks, buys a minute; he takes tabs at the current stamp and, from the Height, favours. A surprising number of Watchers have sent servants down with a purse, and some have come themselves, veiled. He has never been convicted. He is the Slope’s banker, physician and confessor, and it is said that no family on Gutter Lane has gone hungry in thirty years without his knowing. He does not interfere with the Bedded, and they do not with him, though they say his failures are the lucky ones.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The register** — a ledger in his own hand of every customer the hook did not bring back, with their bed-number from the Dormitory. One in thirty, when he began. One in eleven this season.

- ◇ **Hook-and-harness** — the method, which no customer may examine: a padded harness, a cord, and a small barbed silver hook set through the web beneath the tongue. At sixty, the Hauler pulls. *The room is a place you go quiet in*, Nod says. *The tongue is what you speak with. Pull on that and something in you has to answer.*
- ◇ **Half-moon spectacles** — for reading the register.
- ◇ **The sign** — *Rest*, painted by his mother, carried from cellar to cellar for sixty years.
- ◇ **A purse of tabs** — always full; he gives them to nudger-children who look grey.
- ◇ **A lash of Iss** — one of the three on the Table, wrapped in silk in a hollow of the cellar wall. Laid across a sleeper's lids, it lets them sleep and wake once, safely (Taint 4 Regrowth, Iss). He bought it in 619 from a dying Eye-line spendthrift. He has never used it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants a better hook, because the old one is failing and he does not know why. He fears the Bedded, who tell his customers that the ones who stay are happy.

**His secret:** he has never taken his own product, because he knows what sixty seconds feels like from the inside. It feels like a lifetime of rest. That is what he is really selling. He is saving the lash for one sleep of his own, at the very end, so that he can come back once more and tell someone what it was like.

**What the GM can reveal:** the hook is not failing. One of his Haulers, Cobb Ferrule, takes money from the Lessening to count slowly over customers whose names are on a list, and the extra seconds are enough. The Warden-Prime knows exactly where the lash is.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — thirty years of enemies by law; each has saved the other's people more than once.
- ◇ **Senna Vole** — he trained in the Hall beside her mother. He has begged Senna to stop. She came to his cellar once and asked for a minute without the hook. He refused.
- ◇ **Pip Eleven-Bell** — he has been watching the child go grey in the Pinchmarket; he has been thinking about the lash.
- ◇ **Sister Vesper Null** — he has seen her in his queue, and she did not need to buy.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to Old Nod to buy a minute, hide someone, find a lost customer, or trace a Lessening name on his register. He wants a better hook and will pay well for anything from the Tether Hall.

- ◇ **Slow Count.** A customer the party knows does not come back. Nod asks them to find out why, and to watch his own cellar for a

watch.

- ◇ **The Hall's Hook.** Nod commissions a theft from the Tether Hall: the new-pattern tongue-ring the divers wear.
- ◇ **The Lash.** The Warden-Prime's agents ask the party to recover a lash of Iss from a Slope cellar. Nod asks them to let him keep it for one more Plate.

To threat he is polite and immovable; ten men owe him their lives in any room. To kindness he gives a tab. To the god he is wary, as a man is wary of a lover he once left. If nobody intervenes, the lash is taken, and Old Nod is found at last in his own cellar, harnessed, the hook set, with no Hauler on the cord.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"I paid him four months and slept one minute. It was worth every bell I worked for it." — a laundress of Gallow Street

"He's a criminal and a murderer by the letter of the law. I'd trust him with my mother." — Captain Brannoch Pyre

"He watches every count himself, if he can. He won't let one of us drop the clock. Says the clock is the only promise we make." — a Tucker Counter

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# SENNA VOLE

the Forty-Descent Diver

*“It is warm, and it goes on further than it should. That is all I will say about the room, because it is all you can bear, and it is not the important part.”*

— SENNA VOLE, TO A NOVICE OF ONE DIVE

| SENNA VOLE – DEEP DIVER OF THE TETHER HALL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                 | the Vigil · Cut 3 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                              | 34; Deep Diver of the Tether Hall; forty descents                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING                         | Delver · Standing 4 (Deep Diver)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                                 | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                     | Resolve 5, Godsign 4, Lore 4, Endure 3, Search 3, Instinct 3, Athletics 2, Blades 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                                       | Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                    | tether-knife +4 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                      | The Long Room (she may blink at will, under guard, and return with an answer to one question about any Counted sleeper or any blinker in the city). Lidless (cannot be surprised in her line of sight; Breaks rather than sleeps at Weariness 10). Room-Calm (immune to Dread from anything she has seen in the room). |
| WANTS                                      | To lie down (Grim, whenever she passes the Tether Hall’s bed). To count (Routine).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                     | Unflinching; Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                               | The Room Is Real (she believes the city is the dream and the room is waking life)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                                    | tether-knife; harness; tongue-ring; the knot-map; her mother’s harness-buckle; a phial of ink                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                                      | 3 (to hear her say what she heard)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is thirty-four and looks fifty: grey-haired, gaunt, with harness-scars ridged around wrists and throat like old rope, and lidless eyes that a Hall apprentice wets with a rag every half minute. A silver ring pierces her tongue where the Hall’s hook goes. She speaks slowly and seldom, as though each word came from a long way off and arrived tired. She smells of leather and of something faint and clean, like linen, which clings to divers and which other Vigilants step away from in the street. She stands very still. When she listens, she tilts her head, as if to hear something behind you.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 607 to a Diver of Three who did not come back from her fourth, Senna was raised in the Hall by hauliers. She dived first at nineteen. By her third she had walked further down the long room than her mother ever had; by her tenth her lids had begun to thin; by her twentieth the Hall had stopped counting her among the living and started counting her among the maps. She has mapped the room to within thirty paces of the eye: the soft floor, the warm air, the sleepers standing in silent ranks facing the wall, and the place

near the end where the floor slopes down toward the lid. On her fortieth dive, something behind the lid said her name.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the Hall’s greatest asset and its open wound. The Watch consults her through the Master of the Tether, Ansgar Tolley, whenever it needs to know something from the room: whether a particular sleeper stands near the eye, whether the ranks have moved. Every answer she brings back costs the Hall eight hauliers’ wages and costs her a little more of the waking world. She has forgotten her mother’s face. She has forgotten the taste of salt. She remembers every sleeper she has passed in the room.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Tether-knife** — a short hooked blade for cutting a fouled cord. Divers carry it into the dive. Nobody knows why it comes back wet.
- ◇ **Harness** — oiled leather and brass, her mother’s pattern, re-stitched forty times.
- ◇ **Tongue-ring** — silver, set at nineteen, where the hook bites.

- ◇ **The knot-map** — a cord three yards long, knotted in a code of her own: every rank of sleepers, every step of the floor. She keeps it wrapped around her waist.
- ◇ **Her mother's harness-buckle** — brought back from the room on her twelfth dive. Her mother's harness hangs above a bed on the Divers' Row, without its buckle.
- ◇ **A phial of ink** — she writes the name of whoever wets her eyes on the back of her hand each watch, so she will know them when she comes back.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to go back and finish the map. She tells the Hall it is for the map. She fears nothing in the room. She fears the city, which feels less real each time.

**Her secret:** the voice behind the lid did not sound like a god. It sounded like her own voice, asleep. She believes the eye is not Iss's but all of theirs: every person who ever went to the room, dreaming one dream with one eye, and that when it opens, it will be the Counted waking together, as one thing.

**What she does not know:** Ansgar Tolley has taken the Second Table's money. On her forty-first dive, if she reaches the lid, the hauliers have orders not to pull. Lord Evander Quell wants someone standing at the eye when it opens, to tell him which way it looks first.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Old Nod** — he dived beside her mother; he begs her to stop; she loves him and does not listen.
- ◇ **Maud Sexton** — the only person who understood her when she said there was no time in the room.
- ◇ **Lady Oriel Stroud** — Senna has seen, near the eye, a small figure standing behind the lid, where no one could stand, with dark hair. She does not know who it is.
- ◇ **Ansgar Tolley** — Master of the Tether; her guardian since infancy; he has sold her.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Senna at the Tether Hall, hiring hauliers or seeking an answer from the room. She will ask one question of the room for them, for a price: that one of them come down with her, under tether, on her next dive.

- ◇ **The Forty-First.** The party are hauliers on her next dive. At the bell, the Master says *bold*. They have one breath to decide.
- ◇ **Water.** Senna returns from a dive and says one word: *water*. The room is wet underfoot near the far end. Someone must take it to

the Hall and to the Admiralty of Brinehollow, four hundred miles away.

- ◇ **The Missing Rank.** Senna reports a gap in the ranks of the room, where a family of eight once stood. Beds 212 to 219 are still full. Where did they go?

To threat she is calm and faraway. To kindness she writes your name on her hand. To the god she goes, gladly, every time she is allowed. If nobody intervenes, she dives a forty-first time and does not come back, and her bed on the Divers' Row is the first in three centuries whose sleeper's eyes are open.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She came up on her thirtieth and asked who I was. I've hauled her for eleven years." — a Haulier of the Tether Hall

"Forty! Nobody does forty. Nobody should." — a Novice of One Dive

"She's not coming up from the room any more. She's visiting us."  
— Old Nod

# DR. ALDOUS CRANE

*the Apothecary-General*

*“One cake, twice a bell, against the gum. In eleven years, four cakes a bell. In twelve, it does not matter. Next.”*

— DR. ALDOUS CRANE, DOSING A WATCHER

| ALDOUS CRANE – APOTHECARY-GENERAL OF THE VIGIL |                                                                                              |
|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                     | the Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                        |
| AGE & STATION                                  | 61; Apothecary-General; master of the Bitterhouse and the Proving Rooms                      |
| CALLING & STANDING                             | Seamer (the Bitterhouse) · Standing 5                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                                     | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                          |
| SKILLS                                         | Reckoning 5, Craft 5, Stitching 4, Lore 4, Resolve 3, Feast 3, Endure 2, Deceive 2, Blades 1 |
| BODY                                           | Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                        | scalpel +5 (2)                                                                               |
| GIFTS                                          | Heavy-Eyed (+2 against blinkers; he can see the dose a person needs in their pupils).        |
| WANTS                                          | none of the god’s yet                                                                        |
| KNACKS                                         | Steady Hands; Iron Stomach                                                                   |
| DERANGEMENTS                                   | none                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                        | the curve; the sample-case; the Last Cake; the pricker; a brine-cut tab; yellowed gloves     |
| DREAD                                          | 2 (to read the curve with him)                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Thin as a heron, stooped, long-necked, in a black coat stained at the cuffs with rouse. His fingertips are yellow to the second knuckle. His hands are perfectly steady, the steadiest on the Lid, because he has never in his life taken his own product. He stays awake by other means: a clockwork arm strapped to his forearm that drives a pin into his wrist every forty breaths, ice-water, and a cold, contemptuous refusal to be weak. He speaks as though reading a dosage, flat, exact, without adjectives. He smells of burnt sugar, iron and carbolic.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 580 in Blackmouth, the son of a roaster dead at thirty-nine, he swore at nine never to take rouse, and kept the oath by pain. The Bitterhouse took him as a sweeper and then a chemist, and he climbed by being right. In 621 he perfected the current strain, which raised the hours a cake would hold by a third, and was made Apothecary-General. In 630 he drew the dose curve, and saw where it ended: eleven years for an average adult, three or four on the Slope, less than one for children. He has tested nine hundred compounds since on Rattlehouse prisoners in the Proving Rooms. None has bent the curve.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He makes the city’s wakefulness. The Bitterhouse buys staremoss from Hangwell, roasts and grinds it with salts whose recipe is his alone, and sells it through the Watch’s licensed houses; he restamps the rouse-tab each season. The Wake-Tithe that pays the Wakers is levied at his door. He answers to the Watch, which owns his work and has never once asked him a question it wanted answered.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The curve** — a sheet of vellum folded small, the dose against the years, in red ink. He has not shown it to anyone but the Warden-Prime and Maud Sexton.
- ◇ **The sample-case** — nine hundred numbered phials in a walnut box, every compound he has tried, with notes on how each prisoner died.
- ◇ **The Last Cake** — one black lozenge in a tin, Compound 901, the Watch’s order, warehoused by the thousand for the day the beds are full. It stops a person gently, standing up, and they do not go to the room.
- ◇ **The pricker** — a clockwork arm on his left forearm, his own design; a pin every forty breaths. The wrist under it is a scab.

- ◇ **A brine-cut tab** — from Rook Quarter-Bell’s dealers. It holds an hour longer. He has not reported it.
- ◇ **Yellowed kid gloves** — which he never wears.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants a new compound. He fears what he will do when he admits there is not one: the brine works, and he could put it in the official rouse tomorrow, and the whole city would carry a little of the sea, and begin to walk west.

**His secret:** the Last Cake.

**What he does not know:** those whom the Last Cake stops do go to the room. They stand in it nearer the eye than anyone, and Senna Vole has passed them. Compound 901 is not an exit. It is a better seat.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — she ordered the Last Cake; he remembers the order, and so does she.
- ◇ **Maud Sexton** — her curve and his have the same shape.
- ◇ **Rook Quarter-Bell** — the boy has found what Crane could not, and it frightens him.
- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — lends him prisoners and does not ask what happens to them.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Crane at the Bitterhouse, the Proving Rooms, or a Watch dose-round. He wants test subjects, especially foreigners and anyone Unfed, and pays well.

- ◇ **The Proving Rooms.** The party is hired to deliver prisoners below the Bitterhouse and see what is done.
- ◇ **Compound 901.** A warehouse of Last Cakes goes missing. Someone on the Slope is selling them as strong rouse.
- ◇ **The Sea in the Cake.** Crane asks the party to trace Rook’s brine to the coast and tell him how much there is.

To threat he is unafraid; he has seen what dying looks like nine hundred times. To kindness he is baffled. To the god he gives a dose.

If nobody intervenes, he puts brine into the official rouse in 642, and the curve bends, and the Vigil walks west.

#### SAID OF THEM

“Never took a cake in his life. You can see it in his hands. Bastard.”  
— Gaffer Rudd Ninebreath, Grinding Mill

“He dosed me through two years in the Proving Rooms. He apologised to me once. I think he meant it, which was worse.” — a released prisoner

“Crane does not lie. He simply declines to round up.” — Maud Sexton

# MATRON CECILY DORM

*Keeper of the Count*

*“Fifty-eight thousand and four, fifty-eight thousand and five. Good morning, love. Fifty-eight thousand and six.”*

– CECILY DORM, ON HER ROUNDS, OVERHEARD BY AN ORDERLY

| CECILY DORM – MATRON OF THE DORMITORY |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | the Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                         | 50; Matron of the Dormitory since 622; keeper of the number                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | Seamer (the Dormitory) · Standing 5 (Matron)                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                | Reckoning 5, Resolve 4, Stitching 3, Search 3, Deceive 3, Rites 2, Brawl 1, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                               | ring of bed-keys +4 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| GIFTS                                 | The Rows Know Her (inside the Dormitory, restless sleepers turn toward her, and she always knows when one has moved).<br>Breath-Matched (she may breathe with the Counted, which hides her inside the Dormitory while she is silent). |
| WANTS                                 | To count (she must finish any count she begins, aloud if necessary; Routine).                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                                | Counting Habit; Mother’s Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                          | The Hands (she believes her own hands chose the four who went down, and watches them)                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                               | the bed-keys; Bed One’s Words; the register; a measuring-tape; a phial of salts; a pillowslip                                                                                                                                         |
| DREAD                                 | 2 (to watch her standing over a bed with a pillow)                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Broad, soft-spoken and slow-moving, in a starched grey gown and felt slippers, with a heavy ring of bed-keys at her belt that she holds still with one hand as she walks so it will not jingle. Her face is round and kind and permanently tired, with the purple thumbprints of thirty years of no sleep under her eyes. She smells of starch and lye and, faintly, of the Counted, that sweetish clean-linen smell that gets into an orderly’s skin. She speaks in the Dormitory’s half-voice, low and even, even outside it. Her lips move when she walks. She is counting.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 591 in Bedside to an orderly’s family, Cecily carried sheets at eight, washed the Counted at twelve, and was a Matron’s deputy at twenty-six. In 622 she knelt at the deathbed of Matron Hesketh Anstey and received the number, whispered once on the old woman’s last breath, while the Warden-Prime stood across the room. She has walked the rows every day since, counting from one. In 638 the Lessening approached her. In 639, alone in the oldest rows at the third bell, she tested their arithmetic with a pillow, four times.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She runs the Dormitory: four hundred orderlies, the laundries, the Receiving Gate, the bed-register, the visiting bells, the Bed-Due. She decides which bed a new sleeper is given, by her own rule, which is not the order of the numbers. She is the only living person who officially knows the number, and the city’s most dangerous arithmetic sits in her head while she checks the sheets. She answers to the Warden-Prime, who appointed her, and to a Watch oversight committee on which Sabine Larch sits.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The bed-keys** — sixty-one iron keys on one ring, one to each hall. She holds them still. A jingle in the halls makes the Counted frown.
- ♦ **Bed One’s Words** — her notebook of what Aveline Morne’s lips have shaped: mostly a baker’s recipes, and lately names, one a day (Taint Dread 4; see the Rim Market).
- ♦ **The register** — her private book of the nineteen restless sleepers, with times.
- ♦ **A measuring-tape** — for beds 212 to 219, whose fingertips now nearly touch.



- ◇ **A phial of Bitterhouse salts** — the Lessening’s issue. She has not used it.
- ◇ **A pillowslip** — from the fourth bed. She has never washed it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants someone to tell her what she has done. She fears the arithmetic and she fears her hands.

**Her secret:** she smothered four of the Counted. Each time, within the bell, someone somewhere in the city blinked and did not come back, and the number was exactly what it had been. The count keeps itself. She has started to wonder whether she was the one who chose who went down.

**What she does not know:** the Warden-Prime read the number on Anstey’s lips in 622. But Anstey’s lips and Anstey’s breath did not say the same thing, and only Cecily heard the breath.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — her patron, whom she trusts; she has never told her about the pillows.
- ◇ **Aveline Morne** — Bed One; Cecily talks to her every day like a daughter.
- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — the Lessening’s First; she told Larch the count keeps itself, and Larch smiled and did not believe her.
- ◇ **Odile Farthing** — the mother of 40,112, whom Cecily lets stay past her hour.
- ◇ **Lukas Marre** — writes to her every Plate asking after the people from the square. She answers every letter.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet the Matron when they bring a sleeper in, visit one, or are hired to sit the night rows. She wants witnesses who are not orderlies, and she wants the party to tell her what she is.

- ◇ **The Fourth Pillow.** Three Counted found smothered in the east wing. The Matron hires the party to watch; it is not her this time.
- ◇ **Beds 212 to 219.** The fingertips will touch within the Plate. Should she part the beds?
- ◇ **The Name.** Bed One’s lips shape a PC’s name.

To threat she is still and polite. To kindness she weeps. To the god she counts. If nobody intervenes, she reaches the number one morning, stops, and lies down in the last bed herself, and the count does not change.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She knows every one of their faces. Every one. She’ll stop by a bed and say, that’s Agnes, her sister’s in three thousand and nine.” — an orderly

“The Matron let me stay past my bell. She stood with me. She held my hand, and she was counting under her breath, the whole time.” — Odile Farthing

“A woman like that does not tell you how many. She tells you how few.” — Sabine Larch

# GARRON ASHLOCK

the Lamplighter-General

*“Light’s light, friend! Burns bright, burns clean, keeps the room shut. Don’t you go asking what’s in the wick.”*

— GARRON ASHLOCK, TO A WATCHER WHO ASKED ABOUT THE OIL ACCOUNTS

| GARRON ASHLOCK – LAMPLIGHTER-GENERAL |                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | the Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                        | 48; Lamplighter-General of the Guild since 633                                                                                                                                                             |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Renderer (the Lamplighters’ Guild) · Standing 5                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                               | Labor 4, Craft 4, Athletics 3, Endure 3, Haggle 3, Deceive 3, Intimidate 3, Reckoning 3, Blades 2                                                                                                          |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (Burner’s leather) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                              | lamplighter’s pole +6 (3, Reach; lit, +1 fire); lamp-flask +4 thrown (2, burns 1 a round)                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                                | The Catching Yawn (Partake and yawn; everyone in earshot with Weariness 3+ rolls Hard or gains 2 Weariness). Lost Seconds (Partake and blink on purpose; gone 1d6 seconds, reappear up to ten paces away). |
| WANTS                                | To lie down (Hard; triggered above all by the warmth of the furnaces).                                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                               | Strong Back; Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                              | the oil ledger; lamplighter’s pole; Spill’s letter; a Sallowreach candle; burn-salve; the vat-key                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                                | 1 (to see him at the furnace doors)                                                                                                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

Red-faced, barrel-chested, bald and browless, burn-scarred to both elbows in shiny pink sheets, he has a cheerful bellow that fills a room and that he has cultivated to hide that he cannot rest, ever, because he can count. He laughs at everything. He slaps backs. He smells of lamp-oil, scorched hair and, lately, of fat. His eyes do not laugh. They flick to every lamp in a room, check its flame, and come back.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 593 on Lanternside to a wick-braider, Garron was a Wick at nine, a Climber at fifteen, a Stoker at twenty-six and a Burner of the Row at thirty-four. He became Lamplighter-General in 633 and opened the oil ledger and read the date on its last page. In 636, when the Fatlands tallow first came short, he walked into the Burners’ Yards and looked for a long time at the furnaces where the dead were burned. He says the decision took a bell. It has taken him every bell since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He keeps ten thousand public lamps, the roof-mirrors and the Bonfires burning; commands some five thousand Wicks, Climbers

and Stokers; and buys every drop of oil the Vigil imports. He has ninety days of it. His Brinehollow supplier, Lucan Spill, has doubled the price; his Fatlands supplier, Brisket Annalow of the Renderers’ Union, has stopped answering. He has a standing order from the Watch to tell no one. His deputy, Rosamund Kell, sits on the Second Table.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The oil ledger** — with the true figure. Ninety days.
- ◇ **A lamplighter’s pole** — brass hook and wick, the one he carried as a Climber (9 L; Reach; lit, +1 fire).
- ◇ **Spill’s letter** — offering new oil, brighter, smelling of low tide, rendered on the Uncovered from *things with too many ribs*. The trial casks drip seawater.
- ◇ **A Sallowreach candle** — from Wick Tallow of Lastgate, rendered from the unclaimed dead, which burns for a month without shortening. He has a crate on order.
- ◇ **Burn-salve** — goose-grease, contraband, in a tin.
- ◇ **The vat-key** — iron, to the tallow vats behind the Row.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants a miracle and has settled for tallow.

**His secret:** the furnaces on the Row no longer burn the dead to ash. They render them. A quarter of the city's lamps now burn on the people who used to read by them, and the Guild has begun to look, with a professional eye, at the Dormitory.

**What he does not know:** Rosamund Kell has already rendered one Counted sleeper, taken from the general rows on a Lessening list. The lamp it fills stands in Ashlock's own office. It does not flicker. It breathes, four times a minute.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lukas Marre** — the Guild keeps his Glass House cell brightest of all, on a standing order Ashlock signed himself. He tells no one why.
- ◇ **Lucan Spill** — he would kill the oilman if it would not stop the oil.
- ◇ **Rosamund Kell** — his deputy, efficient, loyal, Second Table.
- ◇ **Benedikt Lour** — the Architect asks how many lamps a Second Dormitory will need. Ashlock has done the sum and laughed until he wept.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Ashlock as escorts for an oil convoy, investigators at the Yards, or buyers of light. He wants oil and silence.

- ◇ **The Convoy.** Guard Spill's casks up the Pilgrim Road. They drip, and the drip runs west.
- ◇ **The Keening Lamps.** A street complains its lamps sing at the fourth bell.
- ◇ **The Lamp in the Office.** Someone must decide what to do with a lamp that breathes.

To threat he laughs and then he burns. To kindness he weeps. If nobody intervenes, the oil fails in 641, and Ashlock signs the order to render the general rows.

## SAID OF THEM

"Garron used to sing on the roofs. He stopped when he got the ledger." — Wenna Startle, mirror-climber

"He pays the Burners triple. He doesn't come in the Yards any more." — Burner Absolom Grease

"Good man. Laughs at my jokes. I don't trust a man who laughs at my jokes." — Captain Brannoch Pyre

# PIP ELEVEN-BELL

the Pinchmarket Nudger

*“Pinch true, pinch quick, a crumb a bell, two for a nasty one! You there, mister, you’re going, I can see it in your mouth!”*

– PIP ELEVEN-BELL, AT THE EAST END OF THE PINCHMARKET

| PIP ELEVEN-BELL – THE PINCHMARKET NUDGER |                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | the Vigil · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                             |
| AGE & STATION                            | 9; street nudger of the Pinchmarket, born on the Slope at the eleventh bell                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | none (a nudger’s board and a reputation)                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 4 · Gut 1 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                                   | Filch 4, Athletics 3, Stealth 3, Search 3, Instinct 3, Brawl 2, Persuade 2, Haggle 2                                                                                                             |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 9 · Guard 17 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                                  | pinch-fingers +6 (1; a pinched blinker loses 1 Weariness)                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                    | Heavy-Eyed (+2 against blinkers; Pip can see a stranger going grey from across a square). The Long Look (blink under guard and learn one thing about a Counted sleeper; 2 Weariness and 1 Fray). |
| WANTS                                    | To lie down (Routine; triggered by warmth, and by the kind lady).                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                                   | Fast Hands; Scrap-Born Luck                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                  | pin-glove; the board; an unpaid chit; a brass bed-tag; twists of cheap rouse; a crust                                                                                                            |
| DREAD                                    | 1 (to watch Pip blink and smile)                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Thin as a pin, all elbows and grubby knuckles, in a burr-cloth smock three sizes too large and boots stuffed with rag, Pip has a voice like a gull and a laugh like a rattle and the best pinch-fingers in the Pinchmarket: quick, precise, merciless, always on the soft inside of the upper arm where it stings and does not bruise. Pip’s teeth are already greying. Pip smells of the market, of rouse and dust and onions. Pip’s eyes are huge and dark-ringed and never still, except, lately, for a breath or two at a time.

## THEIR STORY

Pip was born on Cinder Row at the eleventh bell, to a laundress who is now in the Dormitory, and survived the Coming-Heavy at four because an older brother pinched Pip awake for a whole Plate without rest. The brother is in the Small Rows. Pip has been a nudger since six, working the east end of the Pinchmarket under a board painted by Mag Startle: *PIP ELEVEN-BELL PINCHES TRUE*. A month ago Pip had a regular client, a glass-grinder of the Row who paid by the bell. He went to the room a fortnight ago, owing two weeks. Since then Pip has been buying the cheapest

rouse on the Slope to keep working, brine-cut, from Rook Quarter-Bell’s runners.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Pip is one of perhaps three thousand child nudgers in the city, the cheapest wakefulness money can buy. They work the markets, the waking-houses, the caravan stands, keeping strangers up for a crumb a bell. The Wakers tolerate them. The Watch counts on them. Nobody watches them. Pip knows every face in the east end, and which are going grey, and which are lying.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A pin-glove** — a leather glove with a pin in the palm, for staying awake (3 L). Pip’s own palm is scabbed through.
- ♦ **The board** — *PINCHES TRUE*. Mag Startle painted it free.
- ♦ **An unpaid chit** — the glass-grinder’s IOU, for twenty-eight bells. Pip will not throw it away.
- ♦ **A brass bed-tag** — Pip’s mother’s number. Pip visits at the bell stamped on it.
- ♦ **Twists of cheap rouse** — brine-cut, two crumbs each. They taste of salt.

- ◇ **A crust** — always, in the smock, for later.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Pip wants a proper client, a hot meal and a nudger of their own. Pip fears nothing out loud.

**Pip's secret:** in the blinks there is a kind lady in the room, in a baker's apron, with flour in the creases of her knuckles, who holds out her hand and says it is all right to stay. Pip has started to hold on a little longer each time.

**What Pip does not know:** the kind lady is Aveline Morne, Bed One. The Matron has written, in Bed One's Words, among the names, a line that is not a name: *the little one at the eleventh bell*.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Old Nod** — gives Pip a tab when Pip looks grey; has been thinking about the lash.
- ◇ **Rook Quarter-Bell** — sells Pip the brine-cut. Pip stands at the west window of the market latrine now, some mornings, without knowing why.
- ◇ **Lady Oriel Stroud** — Pip has seen someone in white on the roof of the Stair and thinks it is a Seeming.
- ◇ **Mag Startle** — ring-mother of Cinder Row, who has tried twice to take Pip into her ring.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Pip in the Pinchmarket, as a nudger for hire. Pip wants to be hired, fed, and kept.

- ◇ **Hire Pip.** Hiring Pip for a watch means watching Pip too. In the second hour, Pip blinks, and comes back smiling.
- ◇ **The Grinder's Debt.** Pip asks the party to collect from the glass-grinder's family. They have nothing; they have a bed-number.
- ◇ **Holding On.** Pip, mid-blink, says aloud in a stranger's voice: *set another place*.

To threat Pip runs, fast. To kindness Pip is suspicious, then fierce, then loyal for ever. To the god Pip goes, gently, a little further each

time. If nobody intervenes, Pip goes to the room before Lack, and is carried to the Small Rows, and smiles.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Best pinch in the east end. Mean as a wasp. I'd take the kid in if the kid would stay put." — Mag Startle

"Pip did me a whole watch for a crumb a bell and wouldn't take the tip. Said it'd only go on rouse." — a Rim Road teamster

"Children don't last on rouse. Six years, maybe seven. I've seen a thousand of them." — Dr. Aldous Crane

# LUKAS MARRE

## the Yawning Man

*“I’m so sorry. Please step back from the glass. No, further. I’m so sorry. Do you know the Ottley family, from the square? Are they well?”*

– LUKAS MARRE, THROUGH THE SPEAKING-TUBE, TO EVERY VISITOR

| LUKAS MARRE – THE YAWNING MAN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | the Vigil · Cut 3 · Regrowth 7 (the Course; lids thinning) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                 | 31; inmate of the Glass House since 629                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING            | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                        | Lore 4, Resolve 4, Godsign 3, Persuade 2, Craft 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                          | Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                       | none (+2, 1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| GIFTS                         | The Market Yawn (a hereditary godsign: when Lukas yawns unmuzzled, everyone who can see or hear him rolls Caul + Resolve at Grim or falls asleep; muzzled, the Difficulty is Hard and the effect is 2 Weariness; he no longer needs to open his jaw). Lidless, coming (his lids are translucent; within a year he will be unable to close his eyes). |
| WANTS                         | To lie down (Hard). To tuck in (he cannot see someone weeping without wanting them to rest; he must resist at Grim, and this is the most dangerous thing about him).                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                        | Silent Supper; Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                  | The Debt (he believes he owes every sleeper of 629 a letter every Plate, for ever)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                       | the muzzle; the list of the square; the Matron’s letters; books; a pinch-glove                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                         | 2 (to see him feel a yawn rising); 4 if the muzzle is off                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

### WHO THEY ARE

A slight, gentle, bookish man, pale from twelve years under lamps, with brown hair cut short by the keepers and a stiff leather muzzle strapped over his lower face that holds his jaw half shut. Above it, his eyes are kind, red-rimmed and very tired, and his lids are thin enough now that his irises show through them as dark smudges when he lowers them. He speaks through the tube in a soft, careful, apologetic voice and asks after everyone. He smells of saddle-leather and ink.

### THEIR STORY

His grandmother, Ida Marre, put down four hundred people in the Pinchmarket in 533 with one yawn, the Market Yawn, and the Glass House was built for her. Lukas was born in 610 with the same jaw and did not know it. At nineteen, in 629, standing in the Lower Square of the Pinchmarket on a grey afternoon, he yawned, and two hundred and six people lay down around him. He has been in the Glass House since.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the most dangerous man in the Vigil who has never chosen to hurt anyone. The Glass House keeps him; the Lamplighters keep his cell brighter than any street, on Ashlock’s standing order. He writes letters, reads, and receives visitors who come to see the man from the square.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The muzzle** — stiff leather and brass, his third. It no longer works.
- ◇ **The list of the square** — two hundred and six names, copied from the register, with bed-numbers.
- ◇ **The Matron’s letters** — one for every one he has sent her, a hundred and forty-four, telling him the sleepers from the square are well.
- ◇ **Books** — Ludmere histories, Rim Road travels, a children’s primer of the stars.
- ◇ **A pinch-glove** — he wears it always, so that if he ever cries he will feel it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be forgiven by someone from the square.

**His secret:** the muzzle does not stop it any more. He only has to feel the yawn rising, and the people on the far side of the glass sway.

**What he does not know:** the Watch has a standing order, Article Marre, signed by the Warden-Prime: if the Slope ever rises, he is to be walked through it unmuzzled. Ashlock keeps his cell bright so that he will be awake when they need him.

## TIES

- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — the only person who answers his letters.
- ◇ **Garron Ashlock** — keeps him lit; Lukas thinks it is kindness.
- ◇ **Keeper Otilie Grain** — his gaoler, who has never yawned at him, and whom he loves for it.
- ◇ **Sister Vesper Null** — has visited twice, sat by the glass, and smiled; both times he could not stop yawning.

## IN PLAY

PCs visit Lukas to ask about yawns, or are sent to move him. He wants forgiveness, and news of the square.

- ◇ **The Letter.** He asks the party to carry a letter to bed 30,417, and read it aloud there.
- ◇ **Article Marre.** The Slope rises over the Bed-Due. Wakers come for Lukas with a key to the muzzle.
- ◇ **The Glass Bell.** A cell is breached on a Yawn day; Lukas is the only one who can tell where it went.

To threat he begs you to leave. To kindness he cries, and the people behind you sway. If nobody intervenes, his lids go, and the yawn goes with them into his eyes, and anyone who meets his gaze is in the room.

## SAID OF THEM

“My da was in the square. Lukas writes to me every Plate. I’ve never answered. I can’t decide which would be crueller.” — a Slope woman of thirty

“Nicest prisoner I ever kept. Never once yawned at me. I’d like to see him try.” — Keeper Otilie Grain

“We keep him bright. Don’t ask me why. Orders.” — a Glass Crew climber



# THE PEOPLE OF THE VIGIL, CONTINUED

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*Count your nudger's blinks.*

— SLOPE PROVERB, SAID TO THE NEWLY MARRIED

The first half of the Vigil's cast sits at the top of the city: the Warden, the Captain, the Matron, the keepers of oil, rouse and clocks. The people who follow are the ones the city leans on without looking at: a prophet who wakes, a man who came back, a deaf ringer, a seer of seeings, a valet of pain, an inspector of murders

nobody committed, a mother at a bed, an old man drawing beds, a boy selling the sea, a courtier buying death, and the girl who lay down first. Every one of them is tired. Every one of them is awake. In the Vigil those are not the same thing.

# SISTER VESPER NULL

*Prophet of the Bedded*

*“You are not afraid of the room, love. You are afraid of how much you want it. Give me your hand. I’ll hold it while you want it, and neither of us will be ashamed.”*

– VESPER NULL, TO A WIDOW IN A LAMPLESS CELLAR OFF THIMBLE LANE,  
PLENTY 641

| VESPER NULL – SISTER OF THE LID, PROPHET OF THE BEDDED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                             | The Vigil · Cut 3 · Regrowth 11 (the Brink) · Hunger 2 · Weariness 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                                          | about forty (born 601 on Wicker Stair, the Slope); laundress by trade, heretic by conviction, the first sleeper in three centuries to wake every morning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                                     | Celebrant · Standing 5 (Sister of the Lid, the Bedded)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES                                             | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                                 | Persuade 5, Godsign 5, Rites 4, Resolve 3, Instinct 3, Stealth 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                                   | Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                                | none worth the name; a hand laid on the brow +2 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                                  | The Lull (anyone who listens to her speak for a scene makes a Caul + Resolve roll at Grim or gains 3 Weariness and makes a blink check). Lay Them Down (Partake: one person who can hear her and has Weariness 7+ falls asleep and goes to the room). Rested (she has no Weariness and is immune to the Seeming). The Catching Yawn (as the Taste Gift; she uses it as a priest uses incense). Morning (once in every twenty-four bells she sleeps, and at the dusk-lamp bell she wakes; while she sleeps she counts as a restless sleeper, and anyone who blinks anywhere in the city during those hours may find her standing beside them in the long room, holding out a hand). |
| WANTS                                                  | To tuck in (Grim to resist; she cannot leave a weeping, wounded or frightened person without stroking their hair and telling them to rest).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| KNACKS                                                 | Old Grief; Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                                           | none she shows; the woman she was carried the Pull, and lost to it                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                                | cellar keys on a felt cord; a cup of warm milk; a down-stuffed shawl; the flock-book; an unused guest-pin; a child’s slipper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                                                  | 3 (to see her wake; 4 to watch her face while she sleeps)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

## WHO THEY ARE

The first thing anyone notices about Vesper Null is her skin. In a city where every face is grey-blue under the eyes and blotched with the bruises of a thousand courtesy-pinches, hers is smooth and warm and faintly pink, like a child lifted out of a cot. Her eyes are clear; she blinks slowly and fully, as a cat does, and people flinch every time. She is round-shouldered from the laundry troughs, with heavy dark hair worn loose, which in the Vigil is a scandal, because loose hair is for lying down. She has no scabs on her wrists. *Never trust a rested face*, the proverb says, and hers is the most rested face on the Lid.

She smells of clean linen and warm milk. Her voice is low and unhurried, pitched just under the hiss of a lamp, so that people lean in to hear and find themselves still leaning when she has finished. Her breathing is very slow: four breaths to the minute, the rhythm

of the Dormitory. Those who stand near her find their own chests have slowed to match, and do not notice until they yawn.

She is not cruel and has never been. Her congregation adore her because she is the only person in the Vigil who has ever told them they are allowed to be tired.

## THEIR STORY

Vesper was born on Wicker Stair in 601, a washerwoman’s daughter, at the troughs by seven. She married a rope-carter, Florian Null, at nineteen, pinching his wrist at the Ludmere Bonfire until it bled. In Lack 624 their daughter Rue came heavy, as children do at four, and on a grey afternoon went to the room in her mother’s lap while Vesper counted aloud to her. The Wakers had to cut the child’s nightshirt to get her out of her mother’s arms. Rue lies in the Small Rows, a hundred beds from the Farthing boy. She is still four.

Florian's heart went on the Row of rouse in 627. Vesper took no other nudger. She went to the Bedded, then a scatter of grieving families humming in cellars, and within two years was a Shepherd, sitting with those who meant to lie down and holding their hands while they did it. She did not urge anyone. She only stayed.

In Carving 632, after nine years awake beside an empty space, Vesper lay down on sacking in a whitewashed cellar under Wicker Stair, while thirty of her flock sat round her in the dark singing *The Lamb and the Lid*. They meant to carry her to the Dormitory at the morning bell. At the dusk-lamp bell, a full day later, Vesper opened her eyes, sat up, smiled, and said that the room was warm, that everyone was there, and that she had been sent back to tell them so.

The Bedded call it the Morning of the Sister, and it remade them. Before 632 they were mourners. Since then they have been a church, with a living proof at its centre. Every day since, Vesper has lain down on the sacking at the same bell, and every day she has woken. Nobody else has. The Bedded believe it is because she is beloved. The truth is in her secret.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Vesper is the most wanted heretic in the Vigil and one of the best protected people on the Slope. The Wakers have held a warrant for her since 633; the patrols sent to serve it come back yawning, two never came back, and the Slope closes its lanes around her like a hand around a candle. She preaches in rotating lampless cellars, in a murmur, so that her listeners must keep still and quiet to hear: which is the danger, and the point. She also runs the Slope's only soup kitchen that serves soup warm, and the Shepherds, who are murderers under the law and midwives under her teaching.

Her power is consent. In a city whose whole structure depends on people agreeing to suffer, she is the voice saying they do not have to, and the Watch fears her more than the Tuckers, because the Tuckers only sell sleep and Vesper is making it respectable.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Cellar keys on a felt cord** — eleven of them, for eleven rotating meeting-places. The cord is felt so the keys do not clink, an old walker-softly habit she has revived. The Bedded say whoever holds the cord after her will be Sister of the Lid.
- ◇ **A cup of warm milk** — a small tin cup, always full, always warm, though nobody sees her heat it. Warm milk is illegal. She offers it to the frightened. Anyone who drinks it gains 2 Weariness and loses 1d6 Fray; it tastes of nothing at all, like the god's eyes did.
- ◇ **A down-stuffed shawl** — illegal several times over: more down than would fill a shoe, sewn into a lap-shawl of grey wool. She drapes it over the shoulders of whoever is weeping hardest. It is warm the way the Pillow is warm. A Waker who finds it may burn the owner's house.

- ◇ **The flock-book** — a laundry ledger in which the Bedded's Shepherds record those they have sat with: name, bed number, last words. It is evidence of three hundred and six counts of murder. Teodor Rell would give anything to compare it with the Lain Book; so would the Lessening, for different reasons.
- ◇ **An unused guest-pin** — a plain brass pin, offered to every visitor as courtesy demands. She holds it out; she has never once pricked anyone with it. Visitors who take it and prick themselves find they cannot feel it.
- ◇ **A child's slipper** — felt, small, the left one. Rue's. It is the one object she will not let anyone touch. Some mornings she looks at it for a long time with a puzzled, pleasant face, as if at something found in the street.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Vesper wants the Waking Laws repealed and the city allowed to go home. She wants Corwin Half-Bell to tell her what he heard. She fears nothing anyone has seen, except, in the minutes after waking, a door: she will stop mid-sentence and look at the cellar door with an expression nobody in her flock has words for.

**The secret the GM can reveal:** the real Vesper Null went to the room in 632 and did not come back. What sits up in her body every day at the dusk-lamp bell is something the room sends back, a little less like Vesper each time: an emissary practising. It is learning to walk, to speak, to be loved. Each morning it remembers a little less of her life (Rue's name is the latest thing to slip) and a little more of the room's. She is the first restless sleeper outside the Dormitory. Her body is the god's rehearsal for getting up.

**The secret she does not know:** the thing that wakes believes, absolutely, that it is Vesper Null. It is not lying. And the real Vesper is still in the room, standing in the dim ranks of the Counted, at the far back, near the door that none of the sleepers face. She alone stands with her back to the eye. She is listening to the knocking Corwin heard. A Dream-Diver who finds her there and asks her what is behind the door will receive an answer, in the voice of an ordinary tired laundress, and must make a Dread 4 check to hear it.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Corwin Half-Bell** — the only other person who came back. She visits him at the Rattlehouse every Plate, and he will not meet her eyes. She thinks he is afraid of the room. He is afraid of her.
- ◇ **Aveline Morne** — *the eldest sister*. Vesper believes Bed One speaks for the room as she does. She is the reason the Bedded have begun to gather outside the Dormitory on Bed One's naming days.
- ◇ **Odile Farthing** — Vesper sits with her at the foot of bed 40,112 and tells her Marten is coming home. Odile has begun to believe it.
- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — he holds the warrant and has twice stood in her congregation in plain clothes, with his needle in his

sleeve, and not drawn it. She knows Merrit's bed number. She has never said so.

- ◇ **Registrar Constance Hobb** — Hobb entered into the record a fire that never burned, to justify condemning one of Vesper's cellars. Vesper preached in the ashes that were not there.
- ◇ **Lord Evander Quell** — a veiled weeper in the back row. She knows exactly who he is. She does not know what he is for.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Vesper by following a hum: a grieving contact who has started attending, a Waker with the warrant, a Seemer who notes that Seemings of opening doors cluster round her cellars. She wants to be heard out, to the end, sitting down. Warn a party sent to arrest her that the trouble is not getting in but staying awake once there.

- ◇ **The Dusk Bell.** A Waker sergeant has finally found the whitewashed cellar where she sleeps. He wants the party to be there at the dusk-lamp bell, with needles, to see what gets up. When she wakes, she knows each of their names, and the name of someone each of them has lost.
- ◇ **The Shepherd's Sitting.** A PC's ally asks Vesper's Shepherds to sit with them. The party has a day to change their mind, or to decide whether they have any right to try. Vesper will not stop them coming. She will ask them to sit down first.
- ◇ **The Door.** Vesper's flock have noticed her staring at doors after waking and are frightened. Her oldest Shepherd hires the party to find out what she sees. The answer is in the room, and in Corwin Half-Bell's memory, and nowhere else.

**Under threat** she does not run; she sits down and talks, and the threat grows heavy-lidded. **Under kindness** she weeps, easily, and means it. **Before the god** she is serene: she believes she is its daughter, and she is very nearly right. **If nobody intervenes**, she will one day fail to wake at the dusk-lamp bell, and her flock will carry her to the Dormitory and lay her in an empty bed, and that bed will be the first of the last two thousand to fill from the top of the count rather than the bottom. Three days later, Aveline Morne's lips will shape the word *Sister*, and four hundred of the Bedded will lie down together in the Pillow.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"She's the only one on the Slope who never pinches. You'd think that would make her dangerous. It makes her kind. It's the same thing here." — Wenna Pell, rope-wife of Thimble Lane

"I had her by the wrist. I had the needle at the nail. And she said, *you're so tired, Waker, aren't you*, and I was. That's all. I was." — a Needle of the Lanternside station, from the report of an unserved warrant

"I have watched her face while she sleeps. I will not describe it. I will say that it was not the face she wakes with." — a Shepherd of the Bedded, recanting in the Rattlehouse

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# CORWIN HALF-BELL

*the Man Who Woke*

*“Don’t ask me what it’s like. Ask me what it’s like to come back. That I’ll tell you. It’s like being born, if you could remember being born, and you’d had a better offer.”*

– CORWIN HALF-BELL, TO A DREAM-DIVER NOVICE, AT THE ROPE-WALK OF THE RATTLEHOUSE

| CORWIN HALF-BELL – THE MAN WHO WOKE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                       | forty (born 601 at the half-bell, the Slope); rope-walker at the Rattlehouse; legally dead since 640                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | none (a Rattlehouse labourer, paid in tabs and a standing-stall)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                              | Labor 4, Endure 3, Resolve 4, Instinct 3, Brawl 2, Craft 2, Godsign 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| BODY                                | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (rope-walker’s hide apron) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                             | rope-hook +5 (3); fists +5 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                               | Came Back (he is immune to The Lull, Lay Them Down and any power that would send him to sleep; the room will not take him a second time, and he does not know why). Half-Open (his lids are stiff and fixed half open; he cannot blink, but he is not lidless, and his eyes need no wetting; +2 Search for anything in a doorway). The Knock (on a Grim Caul + Instinct roll he knows, without seeing, that someone stands on the far side of a closed door, and roughly how many). |
| WANTS                               | To watch (Hard; but what he watches is never a sleeper. It is a door).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                              | Strong Back; Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | Shut Doors (an open door is unbearable; he must close it or flee)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                             | a rope-hook; a twist of hemp; a cart-horse’s shoe; the record of his own death; a doorstep of iron                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                               | 2 (to stand with him when a door opens behind you; 4 if he ever tells all of it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Corwin is long and gaunt and grey, with the knotted forearms and rope-burned palms of a man who walks hemp for the Rattlehouse twelve hours a watch. His hair went white in the half hour he was gone. His face is not old, but stopped, as if a hand pressed it flat one afternoon. The lids of his eyes are the thing people stare at: stiff, waxy, jammed half open like a shutter on a broken hinge. He has not blinked since 629. He cannot.

He speaks seldom, hoarse, polite and flat. He smells of tar and hemp, and never stands with his back to a door. When one opens anywhere near him, a latch, a hinge, a draught in a curtain, his whole body flinches like a struck horse, and then he apologises, and then he goes and shuts it.

The Rattlehouse is the loudest building in the Vigil, and he loves it. The chimes, the rattles, the screaming from the stalls: none of it is soft, and none of it knocks.

## THEIR STORY

Corwin was a cheerful carter’s boy with a gift for horses. In Carving 629, on a grey afternoon, he sat on a kerbstone on Ostler’s Rise to fix a strap and went to the room. He lay in the gutter for half an hour while carts went round him, until his own horse, a spavined bay called Nettle, stepped back in the traces and kicked him in the ribs. Three ribs broke. He sat up screaming.

He is the only sleeper in three centuries who came back without a tether. The Tether Hall had him for a month, then the Apothecary-General, then the Watch. He said there was a room and an eye, as everyone says, and nothing else. Dr. Crane’s notes record that under poppy he wept and repeated a single word, *polite*, for an hour.

In 640 the Registrar of the Seeming entered, on Watch instruction, a Seeming of his death: *Corwin Half-Bell, rope-walker, seen by thirty persons to fall from the rope-walk roof and lie broken in the yard*. Thirty people did not see it. But it is in the record, and so for every legal purpose Corwin is dead: he cannot sign, swear, inherit, testify or be arrested. He has asked why. Nobody has told

him. He suspects the Watch wanted the only man who came back to be a man who cannot speak in court. He is right.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Officially, nowhere: Corwin has no Standing, no vote, no legal existence. In practice the Bedded consider him a silenced saint, the Tether Hall a failed experiment that might be repeated, and the Tuckers have tried four times to buy him as a counter who cannot be kept under. Novice Divers come to the rope-walk the night before their first descent to stand near him for luck. He spends his off-hours upright in a rented standing-stall, chin hooked on a collar, listening. He has never once gone to the Pillow.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A rope-hook** — an iron hook on an ash handle for hauling hemp on the walk. It is also the only weapon he has ever carried, and he is better with it than he lets on.
- ◇ **A twist of hemp** — a hand's length of rope he plaits and unplaits all day, three strands over and under, because his hands must be busy when he is quiet.
- ◇ **A cart-horse's shoe** — Nettle's near hind shoe, the one that broke his ribs and brought him home. Nettle went on the Row in 633. Corwin had the shoe drawn off the body before the furnace. He touches it before every door.
- ◇ **The record of his own death** — a copied page from the Public Record, bought from a clerk for three tabs. He reads it sometimes and laughs, once, a short bark that frightens people.
- ◇ **An iron doorstep** — a wedge of black iron he carries everywhere and sets under any door he cannot shut. It weighs four pounds. He would rather carry that than face one open door.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Corwin wants never to be asked again, and a door that stays shut. He would like to be legally alive, so that he could marry the Rattlehouse laundress who wets a rag for him every morning and has never asked what the room was like. He fears Vesper Null more than the Wakers.

**The secret the GM can reveal**, which he tells only to someone who has been in the room themselves: he heard knocking. Far behind him, at the other end of the long room, at a door none of the sleepers face, someone was knocking, slow and patient and polite, the way a guest knocks who knows they will be let in eventually. And the eye in the wall was not sleeping. It was holding still, the way a mouse holds still when the cat is in the kitchen. It was hiding. Every sleeper in the room was standing very quiet, very close together, between the door and the eye. He thinks, now, that they were not lost. He thinks they were a wall.

**The secret he does not know:** Nettle did not wake him. The horse kicked, and the pain should have done nothing, as the long needle does nothing. What woke Corwin was that, after half an

hour standing near the back, he turned around and looked at the door, the only sleeper ever to do so, and whoever was knocking saw him through the gap beneath it. The room put him out like a householder shoving a cat out of the window when there is a visitor. It will not take him back, because he has been seen. If he ever falls asleep again, he will not go to the room. He will go to the other side of the door.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Vesper Null** — she comes every Plate to ask him what he heard. He thinks that what woke up in her went past the door on its way back out, and that it is listening at it now, from the inside.
- ◇ **Registrar Constance Hobb** — who killed him in ink. He has stood outside her office for a full watch, without a word, staring. She entered that as a Seeming too, and struck it.
- ◇ **Senna Vole** — the Diver has visited twice. She is the only person he has nearly told. He thinks she already knows about the door; he thinks she is going to open it.
- ◇ **Mirela Sconce** — the Seemer follows him because Seemings of open doors cluster round the Rattlehouse. He likes her; she asks only what he saw today.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Corwin when they need someone who has been under and come back, and find the city has made its only such man legally dead. He wants only his corner, and repays those who defend it with loyalty out of all proportion.

- ◇ **Witness for the Dead.** A trial before the Watch needs testimony about the room. Corwin is the only living witness and is legally dead. The party must get Hobb to strike her own entry, which she will not do, or find thirty people to Seem him alive.
- ◇ **The Knock on Ostler's Rise.** Corwin hears it in the street at the second bell: a slow polite knock from inside a house with no door on that side. The house belonged to a family of Counted. He will not go in. He will ask the party to.
- ◇ **The Tuckers' Offer.** Old Nod's people kidnap Corwin to make him a counter, sure he cannot be put under. They lay him down to test it. The party has sixty seconds to discover what happens when a man who cannot go to the room is made to sleep.

**Under threat** he is a labourer with a hook and very little to lose, and he fights like it. **Under kindness** he goes still and shy, and shuts a door for you. **Before the god** he does not tremble; he turns his back. **If nobody intervenes**, Corwin will be taken, sooner or later, by the Watch or the Tether Hall or the Bedded, and laid down to see what he does. He will sleep. He will not go to the room. And in the Dormitory, at the same bell, every one of the sixty thousand Counted will turn their heads a few degrees toward the east door.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“He shut every door in my house before he’d come in for his soup. Even the oven. Ate it cold and thanked me for it. Nicest dead man I ever fed.” — Hennes Gage, cookshop wife on Ostler’s Rise

“Of all the specimens the room has given back to us, he is the least communicative and the most important. I recommend he be dived.”

— Dr. Aldous Crane, sealed memorandum to the Tether Hall, 630

“Don’t open the door behind Half-Bell. Not because he’ll hit you. Because of his face.” — a Slope child, explaining the game to a younger one

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# THADDEUS KNELL

Chief Bell-Ringer

*“WHAT? SAY IT AGAIN, SLOWER, AND LOOK AT ME WHEN YOU DO. No. Never mind. Put your hand on the rope. Feel that? That’s the city, still awake. That’s all the news I need.”*

– THADDEUS KNELL, TO A DEPUTATION FROM THE HOURKEEPER, AT THE FOOT OF THE LUDMERE TOWER

| THADDEUS KNELL – CHIEF BELL-RINGER OF THE VIGIL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                      | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                                   | sixty-four (born 577); Chief Ringer of the Ludmere tower, under the Office of the Hourkeeper; master of eighty-one ringers across the city                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                              | none (an officer of the Hourkeeper; treated as Standing 3 in any guild matter)                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                                      | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                                          | Labor 5, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Intimidate 3, Brawl 3, Reckoning 2, Instinct 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                                            | Flesh 19 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (leather ringing-apron) · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                         | bell-rope cosh +6 (3); fists +6 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                                           | Deaf to the Hush (immune to The Lull, lullabies, the Catching Yawn and any power that works through sound). The Teeth (he feels the quarter in his jaw; on a Hard Caul + Instinct roll he knows when the city’s time is wrong, by how much, and in which direction). Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift). |
| WANTS                                           | To count (Routine; he counts strokes aloud, and once he starts a peal, he will finish it, whatever is happening).                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                          | Good Bones; Strong Back                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                                    | The Count (the number is always one short, and he rings the missing stroke when nobody is listening)                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                         | ringing gloves; a pocket clock that no longer agrees; a slate and chalk; a jaw-strap; a leather bag of broken clappers                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DREAD                                           | 1 (to stand in the tower when the great bell speaks)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Thaddeus Knell is a slab of a man, bull-necked, with forearms thick as hawsers from fifty years of bell-ropes and hands that rasp on paper. His head is bald and freckled, his beard a grey shovel. His ears ooze a thin yellow weep that stains his collar, and he packs them with lint at every quarter. He speaks far too loud, in a flat foghorn voice, and reads lips badly, answering whatever he thinks was said.

He is, oddly, the most rested-looking man on the Height, and people assume a hidden Tucker or a Lash. The truth is that he hears no lullaby, no rain, no yawn. The silence inside him is total and does not soothe him at all; it is the silence of a tower that has stopped ringing, and he stays awake out of dread of it.

He moves heavily, rolls a little, plants his feet, and touches every bell-rope he passes as other men touch a lucky post.

## THEIR STORY

Knell was apprenticed to the Ludmere tower at nine, a Slope boy with big hands, and rang his first quarter at ten. He was deaf by thirty-one: first a whine, then a whistle, then a long slow closing like a lid. He did not stop ringing. He learned to feel the bells through the floor, the rope, the frame, and finally through his teeth: the great tenor, Old Iselde, named for the diver who brought back the number, sets the molars buzzing, and he can tell her true quarter from a false one by the ache.

He was made Chief in 611 and has rung every quarter since, by his own hands or through the city’s ringers. Two wives went on the Row of rouse-heart. A daughter went to the room in 618. He was her nudger. He did not hear her stop answering.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The bells sound every quarter hour (every eighth on Yawn days), and the whole city keeps its doses, shifts and patrols by them. Maud Sexton sets the true time from the pendulum and sends it to the

Ludmere tower; Knell's eighty-one ringers in nine towers carry it to the city. He may break into any house to reach a bell-rope, and he alone may ring the Alarum, the dissonant clamour that means a grey afternoon has come down. Everyone depends on him without thinking about him. He prefers it.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Ringin' gloves** — thick leather, the palms worn through and patched nine times. He has never let anyone else wear them.
- ◇ **A pocket clock** — brass, silver-faced, set by Maud Sexton's own hand in 630. It no longer agrees with the tower. He no longer trusts it, and carries it the way a man carries the portrait of a dead wife.
- ◇ **A slate and chalk** — for conversation. He writes in square capitals. Those who talk to him must write back; he loses patience with anyone who will not.
- ◇ **A jaw-strap** — a band of leather that buckles under the chin and over the crown, so his teeth meet firmly on the rope and he can feel the bell. He wears it ringin'. It makes him look like a corpse bound for the board.
- ◇ **A bag of broken clappers** — iron tongues from bells cracked in his tenure, nine of them, carried as a penance for the quarters they missed. He believes every missed quarter cost someone a bed.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Knell wants an apprentice who will not go deaf; wax, felt hoods and buckets of water have all failed. He fears a silent quarter more than death, and fears, without admitting it, that his daughter hears the bells from the Dormitory and that they are all she hears.

**The secret the GM can reveal:** lately the bells do not shake his teeth on the quarter. They shake them a little after, a little later each day, as though the bell were struck at the right moment but its voice had further to travel to reach him. He has begun ringin' by his teeth instead of the Hourkeeper's clock. The Ludmere tower is now three breaths behind the Pendulum Hall, and the city's eighty other towers follow Ludmere, not Maud. The Vigil is running on Knell's time. Nobody has noticed but Maud, who has said nothing because she cannot tell which of them is wrong.

**The secret he does not know:** he is not deaf. Not entirely. His ears are as dead as stone to the world, but on three occasions in the last year, in the tower alone, he has heard a sound: a single slow knock, three times, from somewhere below the floor. He believes it was his heart. It was not.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Maud Sexton** — his superior, his only friend on the Height, and the one person whose lips he reads perfectly. They are each the only person the other trusts on the lengthening of the hours, and they have stopped agreeing.

- ◇ **Corwin Half-Bell** — named for the bell Knell rang the night he was born. Knell once let him stand in the tower during the great peal. Corwin wept. Knell did not hear it.
- ◇ **Lisbet Wakely** — the Warden's eye-wetter is his niece. She writes him one slate-letter a week. He keeps them all.
- ◇ **Mirela Sconce** — she has asked whether the tall figure laying tables was seen at the same quarter in each district. He knows: it was always seen at the quarter, by his bells, never by Maud's.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Knell when the bells go wrong. He is gruff and unhelpful until someone writes to him on his slate, which disarms him completely. He wants someone with good ears to stand in the tower at the second bell and tell him what is under the floor.

- ◇ **The Silent Quarter.** One tower in the Slope has stopped ringin'. Its ringer is standing at the rope, eyes open, smiling. In the half hour since, sixty people in the district have gone to the room. Knell wants it rung, now, by anyone.
- ◇ **Two Clocks.** Maud asks the party to compare Ludmere's time with the pendulum at every quarter for a day. By evening the gap has grown. Which is the true hour, and who decides? The city cannot run on two.
- ◇ **Under the Floor.** Knell wants the floor of the Ludmere tower opened. Beneath it, in the old Ludmere crypt, is something the Waking Laws walled up in 342: a bed, still made, with the shape of a body in it, warm.

**Under threat** he swings a bell-rope cosh and roars. **Under kindness** he shows you his clappers, one by one, and tells you whose quarter each one cost. **Before the god** he is deaf to its gentlest voice, which makes him one of the few people in the Vigil the room cannot easily coax. **If nobody intervenes**, the gap between Knell's time and the pendulum will widen until the city is ringin' a full quarter late, and on the first Yawn day of Plenty 642 the Alarum will sound a quarter after the grey has already come down, and the Dormitory will fill by six hundred beds before anyone understands why.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Old Knell's the only man on the Lid who sleeps easy. Of course he doesn't sleep. You know what I mean." — a Pinchmarket shouter

"He has rung forty thousand quarters on time. The forty thousand and first will be his choice, not mine, and I am afraid of it." — Maud Sexton, the Hourkeeper

"I wrote on his slate that I was sorry about his girl. He wrote back, WHICH QUARTER. I didn't understand until later." — a ringer of the Slope tower

# MIRELA SCONCE

the Seemer

*“Tall. Grey coat. Stoops under doorways that are high enough. Lays the cloth first, then the plates, then the cups, and draws the chairs back last, as if for guests who are already on the stair. Two hundred witnesses, eleven districts, and not one of them has said it turned round. I need one of you to tell me it turned round.”*

– MIRELA SCONCE, TAKING STATEMENTS AT THE LANTERNSIDE BONFIRE,  
CARVING 641

| MIRELA SCONCE – SEEMER OF THE PUBLIC RECORD |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                               | forty (born 601, Lampwrights’ Row); Senior Seemer under the Registrar of the Seeming; one of the first twelve appointed in 629                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Clausewright · Standing 2 (a sworn officer of the Record; her entries are evidence)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                                      | Search 4, Instinct 3, Persuade 3, Reckoning 3, Lore 3, Clause 2, Resolve 2, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                                     | Waker’s needle +2 (2, Waking); she has never used it                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                       | The Cross-Match (after taking statements from three or more witnesses, a Routine Eye + Search roll tells her whether a Seeming was shared or private, and a Hard roll whether it left traces). The Long Look (as the Appetite Gift; she has used it twice, both times to look for the figure, and both times seen only a long table, laid, going on into the dark). Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift). |
| WANTS                                       | To watch (Hard); for Mirela the sleeper may be a whole street, and she will stand narrating it under her breath until someone moves her on.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                                      | Counting Habit; Little Lies                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | none yet; she is Rattled and knows it                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                                     | a witness-slate; a satchel of struck entries; a place card bearing her name; a crumb in a twist of paper; a measuring cord; a warm stone                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DREAD                                       | 1 (to hear her read an entry aloud; 3 to see what is written on her card)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

Mirela is thin and quick and sharp-chinned, with ink in her knuckles and a grey streak she does not dye. She wears the dun coat of the Seemers with its brass witness-badge, a long open eye, and walks the districts with a slate on a strap. She narrates under her breath, constantly: *woman at the pump, two buckets, blue scarf, she’s looking at the corner, nothing at the corner, lamp guttering, yes, gutters*. It began as a habit to fix things against the Seeming, and now she cannot stop. People who walk beside her for an hour hear their own actions murmured back to them and find it horribly comforting.

## THEIR STORY

Mirela grew up on Lampwrights’ Row, the daughter of a lens-grinder who went blind from the glare, and learned young that what

you see is a matter of instruments. She scribbled for the bell-sheets until 629, when the Watch ordered shared Seemings entered into the Public Record, and she was among the first twelve Seemers sworn. Of the other eleven, four are on the Row, three went to the room, and one was dismissed for entering a Seeming of the Warden-Prime blinking.

Then, in Carving 641, the tall figure came. Eleven districts in one month, separately. Two hundred witnesses, interviewed one by one, matching down to the stoop under the doorways, the warmth on the cobbles, the smell of new bread. She entered it as true. The Registrar has struck it forty times since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

An entered Seeming is read at the Bonfires and is true at law. Mirela decides what reaches the Registrar, and every faction knows it: the Bedded court her for Seemings of the room, the Watch leans on her

to find riots, the Tuckers bribe her not to see their cellars. She depends on Hobb's good will, which is failing, and on the trust of the streets, which is not. The Slope believes Mirela. Hobb knows it, and that is why Hobb is afraid of her.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A witness-slate** — slate on a strap, scribed in her tiny hand on both sides and wiped twice a watch. She copies it into a book at the Registrar's. She keeps the wiped rag; the chalk-ghosts on it are, she says, her real archive.
- ◇ **A satchel of struck entries** — copies of every report of the tall figure the Registrar has struck. Forty of them, in her hand, smuggled out page by page. Possessing them is a crime against the Record.
- ◇ **A place card bearing her name** — stiff cream card, a fine hand, *Mirela Sconce*, spelled correctly, from the nearest plate on Thimble Lane. She has tried burning it twice; it was on her slate in the morning. While she keeps it, every host offers her a seat (+4 Persuade for hospitality), and wherever she stands still longest in a watch, a small table is found laid by the next bell. Taint: Dread 3.
- ◇ **A crumb in a twist of paper** — taken from the cobbles of Thimble Lane. It smells of new bread and has not staled in two months. She does not know what an Orrum crumb is. She has not eaten it. She has thought about it.
- ◇ **A measuring cord** — knotted every pace, for measuring Seemings. The Thimble Lane table measured nine hundred paces. The lane is three hundred long.
- ◇ **A warm stone** — a cobble prised from Thimble Lane where the figure's foot fell. It is still warm. She holds it on cold watches and is ashamed of how good it feels.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Mirela wants to know what the figure is, and wants the Record to tell the truth, which in the Vigil is a revolutionary ambition. She also wants to sit at a table, once, and eat something hot, and has begun to feel the card in her satchel is an invitation. She fears that wanting more than she fears Hobb.

**The secret the GM can reveal:** she saw it too, on Thimble Lane, at the tenth bell, and it looked up at her: a long pale face, kind and immensely tired, like a servant at the end of a feast. There was a card on the nearest plate and her name was on it. She has entered every Seeming of the figure but that one, because she was its only witness, and because she is a Seemer, and a Seeming of one did not occur.

**The secret she does not know:** the Record notes, NOT ENTERED, that at the eleventh bell nine persons saw that one of the chairs on Thimble Lane had been sat in. It was Mirela. She blinked at the eleventh bell, for six breaths, and in those breaths she walked to the chair with her card in her hand and sat, and put her hands on either side of the plate, and bowed her head as if for grace.

Then she came back standing, at the other end of the lane, with the taste of bread in her mouth. Two of the nine witnesses know her by sight. Neither will say, because who would believe it of a Seemer.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Registrar Constance Hobb** — her superior and her censor. Mirela has begun to suspect Hobb is blinking. She does not yet know Hobb has entered things nobody saw.
- ◇ **Thaddeus Knell** — the figure is always seen on the quarter, by Knell's bells, never by the Hourkeeper's. She has written this on his slate. He wrote back: I KNOW.
- ◇ **Vesper Null** — the Bedded want Mirela to enter the Morning of the Sister as a Seeming. She has refused for nine years: too few witnesses who are not believers. She has been to the cellar at the dusk-lamp bell. She has not entered what she saw.
- ◇ **Odile Farthing** — Mirela took her statement on the afternoon Marten went down, in 630, when she was new. She still has the slate. It is the only record anywhere of the boy's last words.
- ◇ **Inspector Hale Grimmer** — they share witnesses. He is the only other officer in the city who believes what he sees on a Wednesday, as the Slope says. They meet at the Bitterhouse gate and compare.
- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — she does not know the name. She has the card he wrote.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Mirela when they witness something. She asks each of them what they saw, head tilted, twice. She wants foreign witnesses, less tired and less likely to share the city's Seemings, and pays in rouse and favours with the Record.

- ◇ **Enter It As True.** Mirela needs thirty unconnected witnesses to see the figure at once, so that even Hobb cannot strike it. She asks the party to help her stand thirty people in a lane on a grey afternoon and wait. What comes is not what she expected.
- ◇ **The Struck Satchel.** The Registrar's clerks have learned what is in Mirela's satchel. Its possession is a crime. Mirela asks the party to hold it for a week. Every night they keep it, a table is laid somewhere in the house.
- ◇ **The Ninth Chair.** One of the two Thimble Lane witnesses who know what Mirela did comes to the party, frightened, and tells them. Do they tell Mirela? She will want to know. She will want, even more, to go back and sit again.

**Under threat** she talks fast and keeps writing, because the record of a thing is the only protection she has ever trusted. **Under kindness** she lets her guard down at once, too far, and murmurs your actions back to you like a lullaby. **Before the god,** Iss leaves her alone; it is the other one she is drifting toward. **If nobody intervenes,** Mirela will be dismissed by Hobb in Lack, and on Tablenight, in the one minute of darkness, she will be seen by a whole street sitting at a long table in Ludmere Square, with a plate in front of her, laughing.

When the lamps come back up, she is still there, and she will not get up, and the Vigil will enter it as true.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She asked me what I saw and then she asked me again with her head on one side, and the second time I told her the truth, and I hadn’t even known I’d lied the first time.” — Odo Venn, pump-man of the Slope

“Sconce believes the Record is a mirror. It is a lamp. You point it where the city should look.” — Registrar Constance Hobb

“Last thing I heard her say before she went round the corner was *woman in a dun coat, walking, she’s walking, she’s still walking.* Talking about herself. Like she had to check.” — a Lanternside Waker

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# JACK TENTERHOOK

Wake-Valet

*“Hush, my lord, no, don’t thank me yet. That was the thumb. The thumb is only a greeting. We shall be together until the last bell, and I promise you will not close your eyes once, and you will not hate me for it, and tomorrow you will ask for me by name.”*

– JACK TENTERHOOK, AT THE FIRST BELL, TO A NEW CLIENT ON THE HEIGHT

| JACK TENTERHOOK – WAKE-VALET TO THE HEIGHT |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                 | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2 · Weariness 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                              | forty-five (born 596, the Rattlehouse yard); private wake-valet to nine households of the Height; formerly Inquisitor of the Quick                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                         | Seamer · Standing 3 (as a master of the body’s points; he trains under-valets)                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                                 | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                     | Stitching 5, Blades 3, Persuade 3, Intimidate 3, Deceive 3, Search 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                                       | Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                    | silver pins +7 (2, plus the target’s next roll at –2); scalpel +7 (2); wake-valet’s pincers +7 (1, Waking; a Dread 1 check)                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                      | The Exquisite (when he needles a person, they lose 1d6 Weariness and owe him a favour they will feel). The Ledger of Nerves (he can make a captive talk without leaving a mark; Clause-proof). Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift; he can read the coming blink in a face better than any Waker alive). |
| WANTS                                      | To watch (Hard; he cannot resist observing a person in pain to the end).                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| KNACKS                                     | Steady Hands; Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS                               | none; he would say he is the sanest man on the Lid, and he might be right                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                                    | the velvet roll; wake-valet’s pincers; rosewater and lint; the Ledger of Nerves; a tip-box; a key to the Rattlehouse’s lower floors; Quell’s list                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                                      | 2 (to watch him practise)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

## WHO THEY ARE

Jack Tenterhook is elegant in a city where elegance is a matter of choosing the right spikes. His coat is black galled silk laced with wire so fine it pricks only when he wishes it to. His hands are the softest on the Height, pale, plump-palmed, warm and dry, kept so with lanolin and gloves, because a client must never feel a callus, only the point. He has a long clever face, a careful sickroom smile, and all his teeth, which on the Height means money and on the Slope means lies.

His voice is famous: soft and warm as oil poured from a jug. He talks constantly while he works, compliments and gossip pitched so the client must attend to follow, and in attending stays awake. He smells of rosewater and clove. When he watches someone in pain his pupils widen very slightly, and he cannot look away, and he has made that the foundation of his art.

## THEIR STORY

Jack was born in the Rattlehouse yard, the son of a Needle, and grew up to the sound of screaming as other boys grow up to the sound of the sea. Sister Agathe Pinch saw at twelve that he did not flinch and made him her best pupil. By twenty-five he was an Inquisitor of the Quick on the lower floors, and he never left a mark.

In 631 he questioned a Bedded Shepherd for nine days. On the ninth she thanked him, sincerely, holding his soft hand in both of hers, for keeping her awake when she had wanted so badly to lie down. Jack went home, sat on the floor, which is a crime, and laughed until his ribs ached. Then he went private. The Height pays forty lacks a day for exactly the same work, done in silk, with a smile. He says the only difference is the tipping, and the Height laughs, and he does not.



## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The rich do not nudge one another. They hire. Jack has nine clients across the watches and a waiting list, trains under-valets for a fee, and knows the bodies of half the Watch better than their spouses do, and what they say when they drift.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The velvet roll** — black velvet, unrolled on a client's table like a jeweller's cloth: forty silver pins in graded lengths, from a hair-fine eyelash pin to a four-inch spine-pin. Each has a name. *Courtesy. Reminder. Good Morning. The Insistent.*
- ◇ **Wake-valet's pincers** — silver-handled, cushioned jaws for the precisely tolerable pinch. Waking; anyone gripped makes a Dread 1 check, not from the pain but from his face.
- ◇ **Rosewater and lint** — he wets the eyes of his lidless clients himself, between pins, with a sable brush. He is the only valet the Warden-Prime's household has ever lent a brush to.
- ◇ **The Ledger of Nerves** — a small morocco book of every client's body: where they feel most, where least, what they say when the pain is just right. It is the most dangerous document on the Height. It is in a cipher of his own.
- ◇ **A tip-box** — rosewood, the size of a hand. Clients drop their gratuities in it. Some have dropped other things: a lock of hair, a confession on a folded slip, a key.
- ◇ **A key to the Rattlehouse's lower floors** — he never returned it. Sister Pinch never asked.
- ◇ **Quell's list** — a folded sheet in a fine lidless hand, a column of names, given to him with a purse every Plate. See below.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Jack wants to be the best at the one thing he has ever loved, and he is. He wants, a little, to be thanked again the way the Shepherd thanked him. He fears boredom above everything, and losing his hands, and, lately, his own name.

**The secret the GM can reveal:** he keeps clients awake. He also keeps them sleepy. Six of his clients on the Height he has been very carefully not quite waking for a year, just enough to keep them blinking: on commission from the Lessening, which needed members of the Watch suggestible when the lists come to a vote. Two of those six have blink-murdered. On top of that he takes a second purse, from Lord Evander Quell, to read aloud a list of names, soothingly, to his drowsing clients at the last bell, *as a memory exercise*. He did not know whose names they were. He has noticed that they die.

**The secret he does not know:** the names on Quell's list are Lessening members: copyists, orderlies, Watchers, the people who will carry the schedule out. Quell is using Jack's drowsing clients to show the room who is coming for its sleepers, and the room is answering. The latest list, which Jack has in his pocket and has not

yet read aloud, ends with *Jack Tenterhook*, because Jack is on the Lessening's payroll too.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lord Evander Quell** — his best client and his second paymaster. Jack thinks Quell is a connoisseur. Quell thinks Jack is a tool.
- ◇ **Deputy-Watcher Sabine Larch** — the Lessening's paymaster. She hired him through a cut-out; he found out who she was in a week, by her pulse.
- ◇ **Inspector Hale Grimmer** — they knew each other on the lower floors. Grimmer is closing in on Jack's two blink-murdering clients. Jack has offered to help, sincerely, which is the most suspicious thing he has ever done.
- ◇ **Lady Oriel Stroud** — the Warden's household lent him a brush to wet her mother's eyes. He saw the daughter blink behind a door. He has said nothing, yet.

## IN PLAY

Characters meet Jack when they need to stay awake through something terrible, or need the Height's secrets, or find their quarry spent its last lucid hours under his pins. He is charming and frank about everything but his ledgers, and will offer a foreigner a discounted day out of professional curiosity.

- ◇ **The Valet's Day.** A character must stay awake through a three-day Watch session to testify. Jack offers to keep them so. He is superb. He is also, at the last bell, reading something soothingly aloud.
- ◇ **Two of Six.** Grimmer wants the party to take service as under-valets in Jack's household to learn which of his clients are blinking and why. Jack knows within a day. He hires them anyway.
- ◇ **The Last Name.** Jack comes to the party, white-faced, with Quell's list, and asks them to read the bottom line to him, because his eyes keep sliding off it.

**Under threat** he is fast and precise and goes for the hands and eyes. **Under kindness** he becomes curious, and his curiosity is a kind of affection, and a kind of vivisection. **Before the god** he is unmoved; he has no faith but craft. **If nobody intervenes**, Jack will read the last list aloud, as instructed, because he has never left a job half done. Two days later one of his own drowsing clients will put him to bed on the floor of his rooms, gently, hands crossed, his own velvet roll folded under his head as a pillow.



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#### SAID OF THEM

“Forty a day and worth every crumb. He made me feel the Stair was a holiday.” — a Watcher of the Third Shift

“I taught him everything. He added nothing but manners. Manners, it turns out, are what they pay for.” — Sister Agathe Pinch

“He did my mistress’s eyes on her deathbed. She thanked him. Then she bit him. He laughed and said it was the finest compliment he’d ever had.” — a maid of the Height

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# INSPECTOR HALE GRIMMER

of the Blink-Matter

*“I don’t need to know who did it. Hesper Coyle did it. I watched her hands shake. I need to know who was standing behind her eyes while she did. And I need to know why it only ever stands behind the eyes of people who love the dead man.”*

– HALE GRIMMER, TO HIS CLERK, AFTER THE STATEMENT OF BLINK-MATTER FORTY-ONE

| HALE GRIMMER – INSPECTOR OF THE BLINK-MATTER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                   | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4 · Weariness 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION                                | fifty (born 591, Gallow Street, the Slope); Inquisitor of the Quick of the Wakers, seconded to the Lanternside station as sole Inspector of the Blink-Matter since 638                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                           | Nightwarden · Standing 3 (Lieutenant; on paper, command of a patrol of eight; in practice, a clerk and a sergeant who humour him)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                                   | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                                       | Search 5, Reckoning 4, Instinct 4, Intimidate 3, Resolve 3, Stitching 2, Blades 2, Endure 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                                         | Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (padded Waker’s coat) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                      | long needle +5 (2, Waking; the target loses 2 Weariness); clockwork spring-bow, borrowed, +3 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                        | Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift). The Same Hands (at a scene of a blink-murder, a Hard Eye + Search roll tells him whether it matches the forty-one, and a Grace tells him which way the killer was facing when they came back). Seen It Before (the Nightwarden talent: +2 on Dread checks against the Vigil’s horrors; once a session he may needle someone back from a failed Dread check). |
| WANTS                                        | To count (Routine; he recites the forty-one by name and bed, in order, when frightened).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                       | Counting Habit; Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                                 | The Watchers (everyone is reporting on him; he is not wrong)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                      | the case-books; forty-one folded cloths; a cast of Hesper Coyle’s palm; a long needle; a drawer-key; a twist of Slope rouse; a list of his own                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DREAD                                        | 1 (to read his case-books; 3 to see the cast of the bite)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Grimmer is fifty and looks seventy at the third bell and forty at the first, depending on the rouse. He is ragged: a long body that has lost its fat, a Waker’s coat threadbare at the cuffs, a jaw that never stops working on a plug of rouse, black stumps on the chewing side and whole teeth on the other. His pale bloodshot eyes look at things the way a starving man looks at a table. He smells of rouse, old paper and the vinegar he wipes his hands with after a scene. He is gentler with the killers than with anyone.

He has a mind that goes on working long after his body has stopped wanting to, and sometimes, at the end of a long watch, it goes on working in places his body cannot follow, and he finds himself having arrived at a conclusion without the steps.

## THEIR STORY

Grimmer grew up on Gallow Street, three doors from the Rell house. He was a Needle at twenty and an Inquisitor of the Quick at thirty-four, after Sister Pinch noticed he could make a prisoner talk simply by listening longer than they could bear. He worked the lower floors beside Jack Tenterhook for six years and asked to go back to the streets in 631. He does not say why.

In Lack 638 a Slope cooper was found smothered by his wife, laid flat with folded sacking under his head and his hands crossed, and the wife came back from a blink of two breaths with his teeth in her palm. Grimmer recognised the posture: it is how the old Ludmere carvings show sleepers, before the Waking Laws. Within a year there were nine. The Watch made him Inspector of the Blink-Matter, a title invented for him, with no budget, and expected him to fail quietly.

He has forty-one cases, every one laid out the same way, every killer someone who loved the victim. Last week he found the other thing they have in common.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Grimmer has no power except persistence: a desk at Lanternside, a clerk, a sergeant who sits in on statements, and a cellar of evidence nobody wants. He reports to Captain Pyre, who believes him and cannot protect him. The bell-sheets have embroidered his cases into butchery, and the broadsheets that reach the Rim speak of victims opened by a sleepwalking knife. He lets them. It keeps the public watching their nudgers.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The case-books** — forty-one cardboard folders tied with tape, each with the statement, the bed numbers of anyone the victim visited, and a drawing of the posture. He carries the latest nine in a satchel; the rest are in the Lanternside cellar.
- ◇ **Forty-one folded cloths** — not the originals, which are evidence, but copies: each the cloth that was folded under a victim's head, reproduced in the same material, sacking, linen, a good coat. He lays them out in rows on the cellar floor and walks between them. It is the only way he can think.
- ◇ **A cast of Hesper Coyle's palm** — wax, poured into the bite on her hand before it closed: the print of Tobin Coyle's last act. He has twenty such casts. Every bite is on the same place, the meat below the thumb, as if every victim was told where to bite.
- ◇ **A long needle** — his old Waker's needle, retired from the Atlas. He has used it more on himself than on anyone in three years.
- ◇ **A drawer-key** — to the drawer in his desk he calls *the opened ones*: three cases the bell-sheets mistake for his, in which a body was found laid open from hip to collarbone in one midwife's line, by a knife nobody remembers picking up. They do not fit the forty-one. They frighten him more.
- ◇ **A twist of Slope rouse** — brine-cut, bought from one of Rook Quarter-Bell's runners, to see what it does. It works better. He has started to taste salt.
- ◇ **A list of his own** — the names of all forty-one victims, and beside each, the bed numbers each had copied, carried, or counted for the Lessening. He has told no one but Mirela that he has it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to know who, or what, is standing behind the killers' eyes, and why it chose these victims. He wants the forty-one killers released from the Rattlehouse, where most of them have asked to be held, as Hesper Coyle did. He fears that he will be next, in one direction or the other: on the floor, hands crossed, or kneeling over someone, thumbs on their lids.

**The secret the GM can reveal:** all forty-one victims were members of the Lessening, down to Tobin Coyle, the Slope rope-

twister who copied Dormitory registers at night for beer money. Something is defending the Counted, and it uses the hands of whoever loves the Lessening's people best. Grimmer found it a week ago. He has not decided who to tell, because he does not know who in the Watch is on the lists, and because he has begun to suspect the Captain's own office has been copying registers.

**The secret he does not know:** Blink-Matter Twenty-Two, the case he calls *the one without a blinker*, was a Lessening copy-clerk named Ottilie Venn, found laid out in the Lanternside archive in Lack 640, hands crossed, a folded Waker's coat beneath her head, and nobody in the building but Grimmer, asleep on his feet over a case-book in the next room. He had loved her, a little, in the stiff way he loves anyone. The bite on his own palm healed before he noticed it. The coat under her head was his.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Hesper Coyle** — Blink-Matter Forty-One. He visits her in the Rattlehouse every day. She is the only killer who asked him to write that she loved him first.
- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — his commander, and a man Grimmer suspects of blinking. Grimmer has noted blood under the Captain's nails. He has not asked about it.
- ◇ **Jack Tenterhook** — old colleague, now a suspect's valet. Grimmer finds Jack's offer of help the most alarming thing that has happened this year.
- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — he has her name, in his own list, as the hand that signs the copyists' pay. He does not yet know she is the First of the Lessening; he will.
- ◇ **Mirela Sconce** — his only ally. They compare at the Bitterhouse gate. He would not survive the year without her slate.
- ◇ **Rook Quarter-Bell** — his blink-murders are clustering on the western edge of the city, where Rook's brine-cut customers live. He wants to know why the room is leaning west.

#### IN PLAY

Grimmer is the natural employer for a party of investigators, and the core hook *Forty-One* is his. He wants outsiders, who are not on the lists and do not share the city's Seemings, and he will ask one of them to blink deliberately, under guard, and be honest about the risk.

- ◇ **The Sitting Watch.** Grimmer has a list of the next names the Lessening's copyists will handle. He wants the party to sit with one of them, a fat cheerful orderly called Benno Rask, for three watches, with his wife and his brother, and see who blinks.
- ◇ **The Opened Ones.** A fourth body opened in the midwife's line. It does not match the forty-one; it matches nothing. Grimmer suspects it has to do with the Lessening's trials in the oldest rows. He is wrong. The party may find out what is examining bodies the way a cook examines a cut.

- ◇ **Twenty-Two.** A character with Heavy-Eyed or a Seemer's slate notices that the Lanternside archive has a cloth on the floor that matches no folder. Grimmer's coat is missing its lining.

**Under threat** he goes still and listens, and then he uses the needle precisely. **Under kindness** he is awkward and grateful and gives you a case-book to read. **Before the god** he does not pray; he takes notes. **If nobody intervenes**, Grimmer will take his list to the Watch, to the one Watcher he trusts, who is Lord Evander Quell. Quell will thank him and send him home. That evening the Inspector will sit down on the floor of his rooms, for the first time in his life, to rest his legs, and his nudger will find him in the morning, laid out properly, with the forty-one folded cloths in a pile beneath his head.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"He came to Tobin's burning on the Row. Nobody else from the Wakers came. He stood at the back and didn't say a thing, and when they lit the furnace he said *Forty-One* to himself, like a prayer." — Wenna Pell, rope-wife of Thimble Lane

"Grimmer is a good Waker on a bad case. The bad case will kill him. I would like it to happen after he has finished." — Captain Brannoch Pyre

"My father did a murder in his sleep that he can't remember and the Inspector was the only one who called him *sir* after." — a boy of fifteen, Lanternside

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# ODILE FARTHING

the Mother at Bed 40,112

*“Ninety-eight. Ninety-nine. A hundred. There. You see? Mama’s still counting. You keep breathing and Mama keeps counting and that’s our bargain, Marten, that’s all it ever was.”*

– ODILE FARTHING, AT THE FOOT OF BED 40,112, EVERY DAY FOR ELEVEN YEARS

| ODILE FARTHING – THE MOTHER AT BED 40,112 |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                             | thirty-eight (born 603, the Slope); wick-braider on Lampwrights’ Row; widow; unwatched                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CALLING & STANDING                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                                | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                                    | Resolve 4, Endure 3, Craft 3, Labor 2, Rites 2, Instinct 2, Search 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                                      | Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                                   | fists +2 (1); she would bite                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                                     | The Long Look (as the Appetite Gift; she uses it only to look at Marten, and each time comes back more certain he is looking back). Mother’s Count (while she counts aloud within sight of bed 40,112, Marten’s lips move with hers, and any restless sleeper within thirty beds holds still). |
| WANTS                                     | To watch (Hard; she cannot leave bed 40,112 unwatched once she has arrived, and orderlies must drag her out at the closing bell).                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                                    | Old Grief; Kin-Sense                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                              | Kept Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                                   | a wick-braider’s knife; a stool she is not allowed; Marten’s counting-cord; a comb; a razor; her own pins                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                     | 2 (to see her son; 3 to hear his lips keep the count after she stops)                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

## WHO THEY ARE

Odile is small and rouse-thin, with lank brown hair tied back in a braider’s knot and wrists scabbed from elbow to knuckle with the small neat wounds of a woman who has had no nudger but herself for eleven years. She pinches herself the way other people breathe. Her fingers are stained black with wick-wax and her nails are bitten to the quick. She speaks quietly and seldom, except at the foot of the bed, where she talks for an hour without stopping, about the weather, the price of tabs, what the neighbours said, as any mother talks to a son who is ill. She smells of wax and, lately, of bread, which she does not notice.

## THEIR STORY

Odile married a mirror-climber, Teague Farthing, at twenty. He fell from a roof on the Row in 629 and went into the furnaces below the mirror he had been polishing. Their son, Marten, came heavy that same winter. In Grace 630, on a grey afternoon, he fell asleep in her arms while she was counting aloud to him, as every Slope

mother does, and the young Seemer who took the statement, Mirela Sconce, wrote down his last words: *Mama, you skipped one.*

She has visited bed 40,112 every day since. The Counted do not age. Her boy has grown. He is the size of a man now, long and broad under the sheet, with a man’s hands and a man’s jaw and a soft dark beard the orderlies have stopped shaving because it grows back by the next bell. He is smiling. In the last year he has begun, on rare nights, to walk, eyes closed, arms open, down the Small Rows, and the orderlies lead him back on either arm.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Odile is nobody: a wick-braider on day wages, three tabs a watch, living in a rented corner on the Slope with a sloping floor and a borrowed lamp. But she is known in the Dormitory as every orderly’s private dread and private saint, and among the families of the Counted she is a figure of something close to pilgrimage, because her son is the one that grows. The Bedded hold her up as proof the sleepers are alive and becoming. The Lessening has bed

40,112 on its list as an anomaly to be *relieved* early. The Matron has quietly struck it off.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A wick-braider's knife** — short, hooked, for trimming cotton. She has held it to the throat of an orderly who tried to move Marten's bed.
- ◇ **A stool she is not allowed** — a folding one-legged stool she carries to the Dormitory and does not sit on. She stands beside it. One day she will sit. She knows it, and so does Teodor Rell, who has seen many stools.
- ◇ **Marten's counting-cord** — a child's string of a hundred knotted beads, worn smooth. She counts on it at the bedside.
- ◇ **A comb** — for his hair, which grows.
- ◇ **A razor** — Teague's. She shaved her son for the first time last Plenty, and wept, and the orderlies left her alone.
- ◇ **Her own pins** — a tin of six, bent and sharpened. She has used the same six for nine years.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants him back. She fears what will come back. **The secret the GM can reveal:** when she leans close, he smells of bread, and his lips move along with hers when she counts, and for the last month, when she stops at a hundred, his lips go on: *one hundred and one, one hundred and two*. He is counting toward something. **The secret she does not know:** in the room, Marten is not four, and not lost. He is the one who meets the newest sleepers at the soft end of the long room and walks them up the rows to their places, because he was always a helpful boy. That is why he has grown. He has been busy.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Mirela Sconce** — took the statement in 630. Odile asks her every year whether the slate still says *you skipped one*. It does.
- ◇ **Vesper Null** — sits with her and tells her Marten is coming home. Odile has begun to believe it, and to dread the believing.
- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — struck bed 40,112 off the Lessening's list in her own hand. Odile does not know. She thinks the Matron is cold.
- ◇ **Pip Eleven-Bell** — Pip pinches for her sometimes for nothing. Odile gives Pip bread. In the room, Pip has met a tall smiling boy who walked her partway up the rows.
- ◇ **Teodor Rell** — they stand at neighbouring rows and do not speak. He has a page in the Lain Book with her name at the top and nothing written beneath it yet.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Odile at the Dormitory, standing at a bed, counting. She wants nothing from them but to be left at it, until the

night her son walks, when she wants them to follow him with her.

- ◇ **Arms Open.** Marten walks, and does not turn back to his bed. He walks out of the Small Rows, through the east door, into the city, smiling, with his mother beside him holding his hand. Everyone they pass yawns. Where is he going?
- ◇ **The Early Relief.** The Lessening sends an orderly to bed 40,112 with salts. Odile is there. So, if they are kind, are the characters.
- ◇ **One Hundred and One.** A character with a knack for numbers notices Marten's count is now in the thousands and gaining. The Matron recognises the rate. It is the count of the empty beds, going down.

**Under threat** she fights like a cornered animal for the bed, not for herself. **Under kindness** she lets you hold the counting-cord for a minute. **Before the god** she is the god's mother, in a small way, and it is very tender with her. **If nobody intervenes**, she will sit on the stool, one grey afternoon, and Marten will open his arms, and in the morning the orderlies will find bed 40,113 occupied by a small tired woman with her head on her son's chest, counting, very slowly, with her lips.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She don't miss a day. Snow, Yawn, the Grey Ninth itself, she was there. I set my shift by her." — an orderly of the Small Rows

"Grief made solid, standing up. We could do worse than build a church around her." — Sister Vesper Null

"I braided next to her twelve years. Never once heard her say his name outside that building." — a wick-braider of the Row

# BENEDIKT LOUR

the Architect

*“Comfort is a draughtsman’s error. I have spent sixty years correcting it. Every slope you stand on, madam, is an argument I won.”*

– BENEDIKT LOUR, TO A WATCHER WHO COMPLAINED OF HER ANKLES, ON THE NODDING STAIR

| BENEDIKT LOUR – ARCHITECT TO THE WATCH |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | The Vigil · Cut 3 (a by-blood cadet of the Eye-lines, lidded) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4 · Weariness 6                                                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                          | seventy (born 571, the Height); Architect to the Watch of Watches since 601; designer of the modern city                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | none (an Office of the Watch; treated as Standing 4 among Builders)                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                                 | Craft 5, Reckoning 5, Lore 3, Persuade 2, Clause 2, Resolve 2, Search 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                                | brass drafting-compass +2 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                  | The Long Look (as the Appetite Gift; he no longer uses it to look at sleepers, only at the room, and he draws what he sees). The Unrestful Plan (any building he designs imposes +1 Weariness gain per scene on no one inside it; any building he designs to be restful does the reverse). |
| WANTS                                  | To count (Routine; beds, steps, studs, rays).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                                 | Counting Habit; Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | The Splitting (he watches his hands draw and does not always know what they intend)                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                | the Second Dormitory folio; a compass; a one-legged stool; an iron stud; a cushion                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| DREAD                                  | 2 (to see the full drawing of the Second Dormitory unrolled)                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Lour is frail and bent, a long stooped heron of a man with a white fringe of hair and a beautiful old coat of burr-velvet gone shiny at the elbows. His hands shake at everything but a pen; with a pen they are still as stone. He is proud, courteous, dry and vain, and he loves to explain. He smells of ink, graphite and the camphor in his coat. His one-legged stool is always with him, and he balances on it with the ease of sixty years.

## THEIR STORY

A lidded younger son of a minor Eye-line house, Lour was trained as a builder of granaries and made his name in 598 with the first sloped floor that a sleeper could not stay on. The Watch made him its Architect in 601. He gave the Vigil its one-legged chairs, its studded walls, its frameless doors, its chest-high tables. His masterwork was the Nodding Stair. The Watch had climbed a plain stair since 441; between 603 and 611 Lour rebuilt it around them into the endless spiral with its hidden ramp and its outward-slanting steps, and the

council never adjourned: the Watchers climbed through the scaffolding while the masons worked.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the Builders’ party’s oracle and the Watch’s favourite old man. Every new house in the Vigil must conform to his Codes of Discomfort, and his office licenses every builder on the Lid. He depends on the Watch for stone and on Garron Ashlock for lamp-placement; he is indifferent to everyone else. Now he is drawing a Second Dormitory, on the only open ground left, the Pillow. He has been told to plan for the whole population. The drawings show four hundred thousand beds, in rows, radiating outward from the hollow like the rays of an eye.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The Second Dormitory folio** — two hundred sheets in a leather case, the work of three years. Unrolled end to end, the plan is a great eye seen from above. He did not intend that. He says he did.



- ◇ **A brass drafting-compass** — he has used it since 598. He measures everything with it, including faces.
- ◇ **A one-legged stool** — his own design, ash and brass. He has offered to make one for the Warden-Prime. She cannot sit.
- ◇ **An iron stud** — the prototype for every wall-stud in the city. He rubs it like a worry-stone.
- ◇ **A cushion** — small, square, stuffed with down, sewn into the lining of his coat. It is a capital offence. He has carried it for nine years. He does not know why, and he takes it out only in the Pillow, at night, and holds it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to finish before he dies. He fears the Watch will not wait for him. **The secret the GM can reveal:** the Second Dormitory has no doors that lock from the inside, and its ventilation is designed to carry warm air from the Pillow into every hall. It is not a dormitory for the Counted. It is a bedroom for the living: a place to lie the whole city down, comfortably, all at once, when the order comes. Lour knows. **The secret he does not know:** he did not design the rays. The plan came to him over three years in blinks, from the Long Look, from the room, and it is a faithful drawing of the long room's floor as seen from the eye. Built, it would be the room itself, on the Lid, in stone.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — his patron; she commissioned the Second Dormitory and has seen every sheet. She has never once asked him what it is for.
- ◇ **Garron Ashlock** — the Lamplighter-General has asked why the plan has no lamp-brackets. Lour said they would not be needed.
- ◇ **Lord Evander Quell** — admires the plans. Has asked for a copy of the ventilation drawings, and a list of the doors.
- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — she has seen the plans and told him they are an obscenity. He replied that her building is merely a prototype.
- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — has done the sum on how many beds would be needed if the Lessening fails. It was his number to the bed.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Lour when they need to get into or out of a building he designed, which is most of them, or when they find the folio. He is delighted to explain any of his work, at length, to anyone who will balance on a stool to listen.

- ◇ **The Folio.** A copy of the Second Dormitory plans is for sale in the Pinchmarket. The Bedded want it read aloud; the Lessening

wants it burned; Quell wants it intact.

- ◇ **The Ground-Breaking.** The Watch has ordered the first stone laid in the Pillow. The masons are falling asleep. Lour asks the party to keep them awake for one watch.
- ◇ **The Cushion.** Lour is found in the Pillow at the third bell, cushion in his arms, eyes half closed. He asks the party not to pinch him. He has nearly finished a drawing, in his head.

**Under threat** he is helpless and haughty. **Under kindness** he gives you a stool. **Before the god** he is its draughtsman. **If nobody intervenes**, the first wing of the Second Dormitory will be roofed by Tablenight 642, and warm, and on its opening day the Watch will lead a column of Slope volunteers in to inspect it, and the doors will close behind them on the draught.

#### SAID OF THEM

"My ankles curse him every bell. My back curses him. My mother cursed him on the Row. Still, nobody sleeps in his houses." — a stall-keeper of the Pinchmarket

"Benedikt builds for a city he despises, and he despises it for being tired." — Maud Sexton

"He measured my face with his compass at a dinner. He said I had a restful jaw. I've never been so frightened." — a lady of the Height

# ROOK QUARTER-BELL

*the Brine-Cutter*

*“You want Crane’s? Go up the Row and pay a lack for an hour. You want an hour and a half for two crumbs? Rook’s got you. Don’t ask what’s in it. You don’t ask what’s in bread.”*

– ROOK QUARTER-BELL, AT HIS PITCH UNDER THE GALLOW STREET STAIR

| ROOK QUARTER-BELL – ROUSE-CUTTER OF THE SLOPE |                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                    | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste; one foreign point, Dromm) · Hunger 4 · Weariness 4                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION                                 | twenty-two (born 619 at the quarter-bell, the Slope); rouse dealer; once a street nudger                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                            | Crumb-Runner · Standing 2 (a name on the Slope; a cellar and three runners)                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                                    | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                                        | Haggle 4, Filch 3, Stealth 3, Blades 3, Athletics 3, Deceive 3, Feast 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                          | Flesh 12 · Guard 17 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                                       | knife +6 (2); lamp-flask thrown +3 (2, burns 1 a round)                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                         | Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift). Salt-Sense (from the foreign point: he always knows which way the sea is; on a licked-clean moon he must make a Hard Caul + Resolve roll or walk west for an hour). |
| WANTS                                         | To count (Routine; tabs, crumbs, customers, and lately, how many of them are gone).                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                                        | Fast Hands; Bone-Coin Nose                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                                  | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                                       | a cask-tap; a knife; twists of brine-cut; Dry Jonah’s bill of sale; a list of walkers; a shell                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                         | 1 (to see his gums; 2 to watch his customers at dawn)                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Rook is lean, quick and wolfish, all angles and grin, with a tangle of black hair and a face that would be handsome if it had teeth. It has none: his gums are packed black with his own product and he grins with them on purpose. He wears a Waker’s cast-off coat with the studs pulled and a nudger’s brass bell on a thong round his neck from his childhood. He smells of rouse and, under it, of the sea, which no one on the Slope has ever smelled and everyone near him has started to recognise.

## THEIR STORY

Born at the quarter-bell, nudger at six, he pinched strangers in the Pinchmarket for crumbs and outlived five clients. By fifteen he was running twists for a dealer; by nineteen he had his own pitch. In 639 a Brinehollow factor working for Dry Jonah sold him a cask of bottled tonic at a quarter of the Pinchmarket price. Rook cut it into his rouse because it was cheap. It worked: brine-cut held half an hour longer than Crane’s. His customers doubled, then tripled. They have also started bailing salt water every dawn and dusk,

coughing it up in grey strings, and walking west. There are two hundred of them now, in a slow eyes-open column.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Rook is one of a dozen dealers on the Slope but the only one whose rouse holds, and so in eighteen months he has become a power: three runners, a cellar under Gallow Street, Waker sergeants on his pay. The Slope depends on him; families who cannot afford Crane’s keep their children awake on his twists. He depends on Dry Jonah’s casks, which arrive by Company oil convoy disguised as lamp-fish oil, and on Garron Ashlock’s Lamplighters not looking too closely at the manifests.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A cask-tap** — brass, for the brine casks. It is always wet. It never dries.
- ◇ **A knife** — a Slope blade, used twice. Once well.
- ◇ **Twists of brine-cut** — forty, in a pouch, at two crumbs each. Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm).

- ◇ **Dry Jonah's bill of sale** — a Company chit for twelve casks of *tonic, Lowmark, for lamps*. It is evidence that would hang him and embarrass the Company.
- ◇ **A list of walkers** — names of his customers who have gone west, in a child's hand. He learned to write as a nudger. He visits their families.
- ◇ **A shell** — grey, ridged, found in the bottom of an empty cask. Held to the ear it does not sound like the sea. It sounds like breathing, four to the minute.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to stop selling it and cannot, because nothing else holds and his customers would go to the room instead. He wants Dr. Crane to buy him out. He fears the column. **The secret the GM can reveal:** he has been taking it himself. He tastes salt every morning, and he has started standing at windows facing west, and twice he has woken from a blink knee-deep in a horse-trough. **The secret he does not know:** brine-cut customers are not Counted. Not one of Rook's walkers has gone to the room; when they blink, they go somewhere wet and dark and far down instead. The sea is taking the Vigil's sleepers before Iss can count them. Matron Dorm's number has not moved for any of them.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Dry Jonah Skerry** — his supplier, never met. Jonah's agent calls Rook *our best inland customer*.
- ◇ **Dr. Aldous Crane** — Crane has bought brine-cut through a cut-out and tested it in the Proving Rooms. He knows. He has said nothing, and kept buying.
- ◇ **Inspector Hale Grimmer** — the blink-murders cluster on the western edge of the city, where Rook's customers live. Grimmer has a twist in his pocket and salt on his tongue.
- ◇ **Pip Eleven-Bell** — he gives Pip free twists because Pip is the age he was. He knows children do not last on rouse. He thinks brine might be different.
- ◇ **Garron Ashlock** — the Lamplighters carry his casks among the oil. Ashlock has smelled the sea in the convoy and told his clerks to note it as fish oil.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Rook when they need cheap rouse, or chase a walker home, or follow the supply line from Lowmark. He is cocky, funny, frightened, and quicker with a knife than he looks.

- ◇ **The Brine Walkers.** (See the core hook.) Rook comes with the party to bring the column back, because his little sister is in it.

- ◇ **The Last Cask.** Jonah's convoy is late. Rook's customers are coming down hard. He has one cask left, and it is talking.
- ◇ **The Count Not Kept.** A Diver tells the party that brine-cut sleepers are not in the room. The Watch will want brine in every cake. Rook will be rich. The Vigil will walk west.

**Under threat** he runs, and comes back with friends. **Under kindness** he gives you the list. **Before the god** he is caught between two and belongs to neither. **If nobody intervenes**, Crane will buy his supply line, the official rouse will taste of salt by Grace 642, and Rook will be found on the Pilgrim Road among the Sleepers' Mile, standing, eyes open, facing west, bailing.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Rook's twists keep my girls up through a double. I don't care what's in them. I'll care when they walk." — a laundress of Gallow Street

"A boy selling the sea in a city with no water. I would admire him, if I didn't have to bury his customers in the wrong country." — Dr. Aldous Crane, private notebook

"He came to my door with the list and asked if I wanted my son's name crossed off. I said no. Keep it. He's still mine." — a mother on the Slope

# ENVOY CASTELLAN DRAY

the Deadwatch

*“My lord Regent, in my city a man who lies down is lost. In yours, a man who lies down gets up again, every time, forever. You will forgive me if I find yours the kinder arrangement. I am authorised to find it very kind indeed.”*

– CASTELLAN DRAY, TO REGENT ANSEL GRUE, IN THE HALL OF HANDS, LASTGATE, CARVING 641

| CASTELLAN DRAY – ENVOY OF THE WATCH TO SALLOWREACH |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                         | The Vigil · Cut 4 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5 · Weariness 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                                      | fifty-five (born 586, the Height); Watcher of the Lid’s Eye on detached service; Envoy Extraordinary to the Mortuary Court                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| CALLING & STANDING                                 | Scion · Standing 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                                         | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS                                             | Clause 5, Persuade 4, Deceive 4, Haggle 3, Reckoning 3, Search 3, Resolve 3, Blades 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                                               | Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTACKS                                            | court-sword +4 (4)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                                              | Lidless (as the Course Gift: +2 Search, never surprised in his line of sight, perfect memory; at Weariness 10 he Breaks instead of sleeping). Perfect Recall (as Stroud). The Weighed Word (when he states the Vigil’s offer, listeners make a Hard Caul + Resolve roll or must name a counter-price before they can refuse). |
| WANTS                                              | To watch (Hard; he cannot leave his document-chest unwatched, and has not, in two months).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                             | Table Manners; Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                                       | The Splitting (since the trials; he watches himself negotiate from a little above and behind)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                            | the commission chest; twelve nudgers; a cask of Bitterhouse rouse; eye-wetter’s brushes; a Sallowreach licence; a census                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                              | 2 (to read his commission; 3 to attend a trial)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Dray is tall, immaculate and very still, a courtier of the old Height in a coat of grey galled silk and a high collar of fine pins. His eyes are lidless, pale, ringed raw pink, and wetted every half minute by one of the twelve nudgers who walk behind him in a soft-shoed file, a brush in each of their hands. He speaks beautifully, in long courteous sentences that arrive exactly where he intended. He smells of rosewater and, since Lastgate, of cedar burned against the other smell. He has not sat in two months. Sallowreach offered him a chair; he declined it as a matter of national dignity.

## THEIR STORY

Dray was the Watch’s best treaty-maker: he negotiated the oil convoys with the Rim Road Company in 619 and the brine-lamp concessions with Brinehollow in 633. In Lack 640 the Warden-Prime gave him a commission she would not put into words aloud on the Stair: go to Lastgate and buy the secret of Keeping, so that the Vigil’s citizens could be killed and kept upright, a city of the

dead who never need to sleep. He has taken rooms on the Upper Boards and has been negotiating with Regent Ansel Grue for two months, offering, in the Sallowreach chapter’s phrase, the oil of a nation.

Stage one of the Deadwatch is under way. Three Vigil volunteers, Slope rouse-hearts with a season left, were brought north last month, killed on the fen side of the Drop by a licensed Closer, and Kept. They do not sleep. It works. Dray stood in the robing-room and watched the first of them sit up, and since then he has watched himself from a little above and behind.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Abroad, Dray is the Vigil. Every Sallowreach official who meets him meets the Watch in miniature. At home, he is a Watcher of the Lid’s Eye on detached service, which means he still has a vote, cast by sealed letter, and his absence is felt on the Stair: the Builders lost their best speaker when he left. He depends on the Company for couriers (the latest, Bell Lisle, is on the Rim Road now with the

Warden's dispatch) and on his twelve nudgers, who are themselves blinking more every week in the soft fen air.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The commission chest** — iron-bound, sealed with the lidless-eye, never out of his sight. Inside: the Warden's commission, which instructs him, in a clause he could recite asleep if he could sleep, to determine *the number of the Vigil's citizens the Mortuary Court could house*.
- ◇ **Twelve nudgers** — paid, sworn, Slope-born, and frightened. Three have blinked badly since Fogmouth. One is missing. He counts them every quarter.
- ◇ **A cask of Bitterhouse rouse** — Crane's strong strain, rationed. It does not hold as well in Sallowreach; the fen is soft.
- ◇ **Eye-wetter's brushes** — sable, in a silver case, and a flask of rosewater. In Lastgate the rosewater has started to smell of cedar too.
- ◇ **A Sallowreach licence** — a Minute of Closing, bought for himself, *for the sake of thoroughness*. He has not decided whether to use it.
- ◇ **A census** — the Vigil's waking population, ward by ward, in his hand, with a column beside it headed *housable*.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to save his city. He fears the price will be paid in its people. **The secret the GM can reveal:** he has learned that the Kept cannot leave Sallowreach, and that the Vigil would have to move there, all of it, to die; and he has not yet sent that report to the Warden, because he thinks she will say yes. The dispatch Bell Lisle carries is her offer; if it arrives, he must answer. **The secret he does not know:** the three Kept volunteers do not sleep, but they blink. Each of them, for a second at a time, goes somewhere, and comes back having moved, and smiling. The room has followed them north, and they are standing in it, and in Lastgate.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — his sovereign and old friend. He knows she will say yes. He knows she has already decided to leave the Counted behind.
- ◇ **Regent Ansel Grue** — his counterpart; four centuries old, patient, tempted by a hundred thousand taxable dead.
- ◇ **Benedikt Lour** — sent Dray a sketch of a Vigil district on the fen. It has no lamps and no doors.
- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — the Lessening wants the Deadwatch: dead citizens cannot be Counted. She writes to him weekly.
- ◇ **Bell Lisle** — the courier on the road with his next order. He hopes, with a small shameful part of himself, that she does not arrive.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Dray in Lastgate as hired guides and guards (the Sallowreach hook), or on the Rim escorting his courier, or in the Vigil when he comes home to report.

- ◇ **The Fourth Volunteer.** Dray needs a foreigner for the next trial: someone with no Iss in them, to see whether they still blink when Kept. He asks a character, very courteously.
- ◇ **The Undelivered Report.** Someone has stolen his unsent report on the geography of Keeping. If it reaches the Slope, the city will riot; if it reaches the Warden, the city will move.
- ◇ **The Minute.** Dray asks the party to stand with him in a Closing chamber while he decides whether to use his licence. He wants to know whether a man can be finished before he is Kept.

**Under threat** he talks. **Under kindness** he talks more honestly. **Before the god** he cannot look away. **If nobody intervenes**, the dispatch will arrive, he will say yes on the Warden's behalf, and the first Slope caravans will leave for Fogmouth before Tablenight.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He wouldn't sit. In the Hall of Hands, before the Regent, in a chair older than his country. Stood like a lamp-post for nine hours and called it courtesy." — a clerk of the Mortuary Court

"Castellan could sell a bed to a Waker. I sent him to sell a city a grave." — Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud, overheard by her eye-wetter

"My brother went north with him. Volunteer. They sent back his nudger's pay and a note saying he's very well. He hasn't been very well since he was nine." — a rouse-seller on the Slope

# AVELINE MORNE

the Sleeper in Bed One

*“Two of flour to one of water, salt, the old starter, knead till it’s warm as a cheek. Cover it. Let it rest. Everything wants to rest. There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set another place.”*

– THE LIPS OF AVELINE MORNE, AS TRANSCRIBED BY MATRON CECILY DORM, CARVING 641

| AVELINE MORNE – THE FIRST OF US |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                      | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 12 (the Seating, begun) · Hunger — · Weariness —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                   | nineteen forever (born 322, Crumb Street, old Ludmere; lay down 341); Bed One, the Dormitory                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING              | none (a baker’s daughter)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                      | Hand 0 · Gut 5 · Lung 0 · Eye 0 · Tongue 2 · Caul 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                          | Godsign 6, Rites 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| BODY                            | Flesh 20 · Guard 9 · Armor 0 · Fray —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                         | none while she lies; if she sits up, see Iss Seated in the Adversaries chapter                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                           | The Naming (each day her lips shape a name; that person, wherever they are on the Table, makes a blink check at Grim every scene of the following day regardless of Weariness, and any failure is sleep, not a blink. Nobody named has yet lived through the day awake). The First Oath (oaths sworn with a hand on her bed-rail are bound as Oaths on the Dead, and broken ones are paid in blinks). The Kind Lady (anyone who blinks may meet her in the room, in a baker’s apron, holding out a hand; to take it is to stay). |
| WANTS                           | none she can act on; the room’s want is hers                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                          | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                    | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                         | a brass bed-rail; flour; a sheet; a starter-crock; the notebook                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                           | 2 (to stand at her bed; 4 to see her lips shape your name)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

## WHO THEY ARE

A plump fair girl under a white sheet in a bed with a brass rail, cheeks pink, lips slightly parted, breathing with the rows. There is flour still in the creases of her knuckles after three hundred years; the orderlies have washed her hands a thousand times and it is always there by the next bell. She smells of warm bread. Her hair, which does not grow, is the gold of a crust. She is the only Counted whose face every Vigilant knows, from the oath they all swear on her.

## THEIR STORY

Aveline was the third daughter of a Crumb Street baker in the Easy Centuries, betrothed to a pillow-merchant’s son, famous on her street for a starter-dough her grandmother had kept alive for sixty years. On the third night of Grace 341, a warm pleasant evening, she went to bed early, because she had to be up for the ovens. She was the first in Ludmere not to rise. When the first Dormitory was made

in the old Corn Granary in 342, she was carried there and laid in bed number one, and the Matrons have kept her there since, never moved, never renumbered.

Last month her lips began to shape words. The Matron has started writing them down. Most of what she says is her grandmother’s bread recipe. Most days, also, a name: and each person named has gone to the room the next day. One, last week, was a sentence: *There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set another place.*

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the Vigil’s oath, its oldest citizen and its altar. *By the first of us, who lay down for all of us* is the heaviest oath in the city, sworn with a hand on her rail; a Vigilant who breaks it is unwatched forever. On the Night of Lying Down the queue to touch her rail runs out of the Dormitory and down the Slope. The Bedded call her *the eldest sister*. The Watch calls her a security problem. The Lessening has her at the very top of its list, and has not dared.



## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A brass bed-rail** — polished by three centuries of oath-hands to a gold like her hair. Oaths are cut into it in tiny letters, tens of thousands, over each other.
- ◇ **Flour** — in the creases of her knuckles, under her nails. It is real flour. It does not run out. A pinch of it, baked into bread, makes a loaf that never stales (Taint 2 Regrowth, Iss).
- ◇ **A sheet** — white linen, changed every Plate. The old ones are burned. A few have been stolen, and sell for a fortune to the Bedded.
- ◇ **A starter-crock** — clay, sealed, placed at her bedside by her mother in 342. Nobody has opened it in three centuries. It is warm. It is rising.
- ◇ **The notebook** — Bed One's Words, the Matron's record (see the Rim Market chapter). Pages have been stolen and sold.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants, if she wants anything, what the room wants. **The secret the GM can reveal:** the names are not random. They are the people who will be needed in the room: those who have stood longest at a bed, those who love the Counted most, those who will make the wall between the door and the eye stand firmer. She is calling the guard. **The secret nobody knows:** the girl in the bed is not the one speaking. Aveline herself is in the room, in her apron, at the soft end of the long room, greeting every newcomer and holding out her hand. What moves her lips is the god, which has been furnishing her from the inside for three hundred years, and has been practising its first words on a recipe it learned from her.

## TIES

- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — writes down every word. Sits with her more than with any living person.
- ◇ **Vesper Null** — believes Aveline speaks for the room as she does. She is half right.
- ◇ **Pip Eleven-Bell** — in the blinks, Pip meets *a kind lady in a baker's apron*. It is Aveline. She is very fond of Pip.
- ◇ **Lord Evander Quell** — wants to be in the room, in the Dormitory, beside Bed One, with felt-wrapped knives, on the night she sits up.

## IN PLAY

Characters meet Aveline at the foot of her bed when they swear, visit, investigate, or are named.

- ◇ **What Aveline Says.** (See the core hook.) The stolen pages are being sold. One has a character's name.
- ◇ **The Oath.** An NPC demands the party swear at Bed One. As their hands touch the rail, her lips move.
- ◇ **The Crock.** The starter-crock cracks. What has been rising for three centuries smells of bread and is breathing in time.

**Under threat,** the rows turn their faces toward whoever threatens her. **If nobody intervenes,** she sits up.

## SAID OF THEM

"I swore my marriage on her rail. My man broke it. He's been blinking ever since, and every time he comes back he says he saw a girl with flour on her hands, shaking her head." — a wife of the Slope

"She is the first entry in my register and will be the last thing I write down." — Matron Cecily Dorm

"Sometimes in the dark minute on Tablenight you can smell bread across the whole city. My grandmother said that was Aveline, checking on the ovens." — a Lamplighter's wick-boy



# NEW FACES OF THE VIGIL

---

*Sleep is a door that only opens inward.*

– VIGIL PROVERB

The core book's Vigil chapter introduced six people the bible never named: the woman who keeps the Lessening's lists, the woman who decides what happened, the woman who taught the city to hurt itself kindly, the widower with the book of notes, the lord with the

felt-wrapped knives, and the innkeeper at the last bed on the Table. They are given their full due below, followed by two more: the killer from the first page of that chapter, and the girl who holds the brush at the Warden's shoulder.

# SABINE LARCH

## First of the Lessening

*“Nobody is proposing harm. A bed is not a person; a bed is a unit of risk. I am proposing that we hold the risk below the threshold. If you would rather call that murder, I cannot stop you, but you will have to show me where in the arithmetic the murder is.”*

– SABINE LARCH, TO A SITTING OF THE LESSENING IN A DORMITORY RECORDS ROOM

| SABINE LARCH – DEPUTY-WATCHER, FIRST OF THE LESSENING |                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                            | The Vigil · Cut 4 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6 · Weariness 5                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                                         | forty-four (born 597, the Height); Watcher of the Second Shift; member of the Matron’s oversight committee                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                                    | Scion · Standing 4; First of the Lessening (rank 5)                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                                            | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                                                | Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Deceive 4, Persuade 3, Resolve 3, Blades 1                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                                                  | Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                                               | stiletto +3 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                                                 | Perfect Recall (as Stroud), Lidless (as the Course Gift), The Calm Sum (when she explains her arithmetic, listeners make a Hard Caul + Resolve roll or accept it as reasonable for the rest of the scene). |
| WANTS                                                 | To count (she reduces every crowd to a number and cannot stop).                                                                                                                                            |
| KNACKS                                                | Counting Habit; Conditional                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                                               | the lists; a stiletto; a vial of Bitterhouse salts; her sister’s ribbon; a pay-roll                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                                                 | 2 (to read her lists)                                                                                                                                                                                      |

### WHO THEY ARE

A lidless Eye-line woman of forty-four with a mathematician’s courtesy and the kind of face people forget while it is in front of them: pale, even, unremarkable except for the naked staring eyes, which her attendant wets with a plain cotton swab rather than sable. She dresses in grey, speaks softly and exactly, and smells of nothing at all. She listens as if taking dictation.

### THEIR STORY

Sabine grew up on the Height, lidless from birth, the clever younger daughter of a house that had produced no Counted in three centuries. In 612 her elder sister Ilse, lidded and adored, went to the room at twenty-one, and was laid in bed 3,315. Sabine has visited once. She drew up the first lists in 636, after reading every register in the Dormitory, and has refined the schedule since: eleven thousand reductions in two years, oldest rows first, no visitors. The trials have begun.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

On the Stair she is a reliable Builder vote and a respected committee-woman. In the dark she commands the Lessening’s Reckoners of Beds, Orderlies of Relief and Sitting Members, and pays its copyists out of a Watch fund for *register maintenance*. She has hired Jack Tenterhook, through cut-outs, to keep six Watchers suggestible.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The lists** — in her own hand, by bed number, in a ledger bound in grey. Bed 3,315 is the first line.
- ♦ **A stiletto** — a lady’s blade, never used.
- ♦ **A vial of Bitterhouse salts** — one drop in a sleeper’s drip stops the heart in a bell. Carried, she says, to remind her of the weight.
- ♦ **Ilse’s ribbon** — blue, faded. She takes it out when she counts.
- ♦ **A pay-roll** — the copyists’ wages. Every one of Grimmer’s forty-one victims is on it.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the number never reached. She fears she is wrong about the arithmetic, because the Matron has told her the count keeps

itself and she has chosen not to believe it. **Secret:** her sister is in bed 3,315, and bed 3,315 is the first name on the list. **Secret she does not know:** the pay-roll she carries is now a list of the dead, and her own name is at its bottom, in Quell's hand, on a sheet in Jack Tenterhook's pocket.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — the Matron proved the Lessening futile. Sabine had the proof struck from the minutes.
- ◇ **Lord Evander Quell** — an ally on the Stair. She does not know he is killing her people.
- ◇ **Inspector Hale Grimmer** — has her name as paymaster. She has his as a problem.
- ◇ **Jack Tenterhook** — her instrument; she found him through his pulse-reading reputation and pays him well.
- ◇ **Castellan Dray** — she writes to him weekly. The dead cannot be Counted.

#### IN PLAY

The Lessening approaches characters; it never accepts applicants. Sabine makes the approach herself, kindly, with the arithmetic.

- ◇ **The First Line.** Sabine asks a party member to carry out the first relief: bed 3,315. She will stand at the foot of the bed and watch.
- ◇ **The Futile Proof.** The Matron's struck minute is stolen. If it is read on the Stair, the Lessening is finished, and Sabine's sister is safe, and the party must decide whether to tell her.
- ◇ **The Pay-Roll.** The party finds the pay-roll and Grimmer's list side by side.

If **nobody intervenes**, she will begin the schedule in Lack, and the first night every reduced bed will be refilled from the city by the next bell.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Larch? Second shift? I've climbed past her a thousand times. Grey, isn't she? Something grey." — a Watcher of the Third Shift

"She is the only person on the Stair who has done the sum correctly. That is why I fear her." — Matron Cecily Dorm

"She tipped me a whole lack for a swab. Never looked at me. Looked at the number on my badge." — an eye-wetter

# CONSTANCE HOBB

Registrar of the Seeming

*“I understand you saw it, dear. I understand perfectly. But you must understand that it is not in the Record, and what is not in the Record did not occur. Look. Here is the page. Look at it with me. There. You see? Nothing.”*

— CONSTANCE HOBB, TO A WITNESS AT THE REGISTRY COUNTER

| CONSTANCE HOBB – REGISTRAR OF THE PUBLIC RECORD OF THE SEEMING |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                                     | The Vigil · Cut 3 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4 · Weariness 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                                                  | sixty (born 581, Lampwrights’ Row); Registrar since 629                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                                             | Clausewright · Standing 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                                                     | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                                                         | Clause 5, Deceive 4, Persuade 3, Lore 3, Reckoning 3, Resolve 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                                           | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                                                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                                          | The Record (a Seeming she enters is true at law; a Seeming she strikes cannot be used as evidence anywhere in the Vigil). The Kindly Page (when she shows a witness the Record, they make a Hard Caul + Resolve roll or doubt their own memory as if with the Gaslight Derangement for a day). Lost Seconds (as the Appetite Gift; she does not know she has it). |
| WANTS                                                          | To count (Routine; entries, strikes, blinks she does not record).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                                                         | Little Lies; Conditional                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                                                        | white gloves; the Registry seal; the struck-book; a clerk’s tally; a pin she never uses                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                                                          | 1 (to watch her make a witness doubt; 2 to see her clerk’s tally)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Sixty, iron-haired, upright, in white cotton gloves that she changes at every bell so that no ink touches her. Her voice is gentle and grandmotherly; she calls everyone *dear*. She smells of starch. Her eyes are bloodshot to the iris and she believes, absolutely, that she does not sleep at all.

## THEIR STORY

A lens-grinder’s daughter like Mirela Sconce, Constance was a Watch clerk for thirty years before the Record was founded in 629, and she wrote its rules. She has entered on Watch instruction three Seemings nobody saw: a fire that justified condemning a Bedded cellar, a riot that justified doubled needle-patrols, and the death of Corwin Half-Bell, who is still alive. She has struck forty Seemings of the tall figure this year and every report of blink-murders.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She decides what happened. Courts, contracts and condemnations follow her pages. The Watch relies on her; the Slope hates her; the Seemers fear her. She answers to the Warden-Prime’s office directly.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **White gloves** — nine pairs a day.
- ◇ **The Registry seal** — an open eye in brass; on a page, it makes the page true.
- ◇ **The struck-book** — every Seeming she refused. She keeps it so that she knows what did not happen.
- ◇ **A clerk’s tally** — her clerk’s count of her blinks, which he pins to her door each evening. Today’s says eleven.
- ◇ **A pin she never uses** — because she does not need it, she says.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants order. She fears Mirela Sconce, whom the streets believe. **Secret:** her clerk tells her she has blinked eleven times today, and she has entered none of them. **Secret she does not know:** in three of those blinks she wrote. The struck-book has entries in her own hand she does not remember making: *a tall figure, standing at the Registrar’s shoulder, reading.*

## TIES

- ◇ **Mirela Sconce** — her best Seemer and her greatest threat.

- ◇ **Corwin Half-Bell** — she killed him in ink. He stood outside her office a full watch.
- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — her instructions come in the Warden's hand.
- ◇ **Vesper Null** — the false fire. Vesper preached in its imaginary ashes.

#### IN PLAY

- ◇ **Strike It.** A character's crime is entered as a Seeming. Only Hobb can strike it, and she wants something.
- ◇ **Bring Him Back to Life.** Corwin's death must be struck for him to testify (see Corwin).
- ◇ **The Reader.** The party sees, in the struck-book, the entries she does not remember.

If **nobody intervenes**, the Record will enter her death on a grey afternoon in Lack, on thirty witnesses, while she sits at her counter, in white gloves, blinking.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"I saw my house burn. She showed me the page. It hadn't. I live in it still and I can smell the smoke." — a Bedded Listener

"Constance is the only woman on the Lid who can make a city forget. We should pay her more." — a Watcher of the Lid's Eye

"She called me dear. I've never felt so small." — a pump-man of the Slope

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# SISTER AGATHE PINCH

## Mistress of the Needle

*“Now, little one, we’ll begin with the toe, as we always do. No, don’t hold your breath, breathe out into it, that’s the way. There. Was that so dreadful? That was me loving you. Tomorrow you’ll love someone the same way.”*

— AGATHE PINCH, TO A WAKER RECRUIT IN THE STANDING-STALL, FIRST MORNING

| AGATHE PINCH – MISTRESS OF THE NEEDLE |                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 4                                                |
| AGE & STATION                         | sixty-eight (born 573, the Rattlehouse quarter); head instructor of the Rattlehouse; author of the Atlas of the Quick |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | Nightwarden · Standing 4 (Inquisitor of the Quick emerita)                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                | Stitching 5, Blades 4, Intimidate 4, Resolve 4, Lore 3, Endure 2                                                      |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                               | long needle +9 (2, Waking; target loses 2 Weariness and makes a Dread 1 check)                                        |
| GIFTS                                 | The Quick (as Pyre). Seen It Before (the Nightwarden talent). Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift).                         |
| WANTS                                 | To watch (Hard).                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                                | Steady Hands; Mother’s Hands                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                               | the lap-tray; a lace cap; the Atlas; the lower-floor key; a humming-book                                              |
| DREAD                                 | 2 (to sit her class; 3 to visit the lowest floor)                                                                     |

### WHO THEY ARE

Tiny, bright-eyed, grandmotherly, in a cap of white lace, with a lap-tray of needles laid out like embroidery tools. She smells of lavender water and iron. She hums at her work. She is loved by her students the way a scar is loved.

### THEIR STORY

A Waker at sixteen, an Inquisitor at thirty, she rewrote the Atlas of the Quick in 610 and has trained every Waker alive, including Brannoch Pyre, Hale Grimmer and Jack Tenterhook. Every recruit spends their first week strapped in a standing-stall under her needles, so they will know.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Rattlehouse school is hers. Every Waker on the Lid carries her method in their hands; the Captain defers to her on doctrine. She depends on prisoners lent from the cells for teaching.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The lap-tray** — forty needles on green baize.
- ◇ **A lace cap** — her mother’s.

- ◇ **The Atlas** — the master copy, annotated.
- ◇ **The lower-floor key** — the lowest floor is hers alone.
- ◇ **A humming-book** — notes of a tune, taken down over nineteen years, from the man below.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the city to understand that pain is mercy. She fears she has been wrong for fifty years. **Secret:** on the lowest floor she keeps a man who has been awake under the needle for nineteen years: Ansgar Wakely, a Bedded Shepherd condemned to Bedding in 622, when Bedding could not be carried out. She uses him to teach. He has stopped screaming. He hums. **Secret she does not know:** he hums *The Lamb and the Lid*, and every recruit who has heard it in their first week is a little more likely to blink. There are nineteen years of them on the streets.

### TIES

- ◇ **Jack Tenterhook** — her best pupil; she thinks he wasted himself on silk.
- ◇ **Lisbet Wakely** — the man below is her father. Agathe knows. Lisbet does not.

- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — her student, her Captain. She knows about Merrit.
- ◇ **Hesper Coyle** — at her own request in a Rattlehouse stall. Agathe needles her gently each bell.

#### IN PLAY

- ◇ **First Week.** A character joins the Wakers and spends seven days under her needles.
- ◇ **The Man Below.** Grimmer needs to question the lowest floor's prisoner, who has not spoken in nine years.
- ◇ **The Tune.** A Waker hums on patrol and does not know where she learned it.

If **nobody intervenes**, she will die at her tray, peacefully, of a rouse-heart, and the man below will be found by her successor still humming, with no one to need him.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She stuck me under the nail and said *good morning*. Thirty years on, I still hear it when I needle someone." — Captain Brannoch Pyre

"Like being tortured by your nan." — a washed-out Waker

"I'd let her do it again." — a Rattle of the Slope



# TEODOR RELL

## Keeper of the Lain Book

*“Do not let them say I slipped. That’s what she wrote. So I keep the book. Nobody in my book slipped. Every one of them chose, and every one of them is written down, so nobody can tell you otherwise.”*

— TEODOR RELL, TO A WIDOW AT THE DORMITORY CLERKS’ TABLE

| TEODOR RELL — KEEPER OF THE LAIN BOOK |                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 7                     |
| AGE & STATION                         | forty (born 601, Gallow Street, the Slope); Dormitory clerk since 640; laundress’s widower |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | none                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                        |
| SKILLS                                | Reckoning 3, Lore 2, Resolve 2, Endure 2, Rites 2, Labor 2                                 |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                     |
| ATTACKS                               | fists +2 (1)                                                                               |
| GIFTS                                 | The Long Look (as the Appetite Gift; he uses it on bed 58,921 only).                       |
| WANTS                                 | To watch (Hard).                                                                           |
| KNACKS                                | Old Grief; Elder’s Ear                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                          | The Pull                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                               | the Lain Book; Annick’s coat; the note; his own note                                       |
| DREAD                                 | 1 (to read the Lain Book)                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

A tired, gentle, slope-shouldered man with a laundress’s widower’s red hands and a clerk’s ink-stained cuffs. His voice is very soft. He reads aloud well. He is tired beyond tiredness.

### THEIR STORY

On the eighth day of Plenty 640 he found his wife Annick lying in the yard behind Gallow Street, her note pinned to her good coat. Their daughter had been in the Small Rows six years. He took a clerk’s post at the Dormitory so that he could see Annick every day, at bed 58,921, and the Matron gave him the Lain Book, the register of those who went to the room by choice: two hundred to four hundred a year, their notes copied out.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the Vigil’s only official mourner of the Lain-Down. Families come to him to have a note entered and read. He answers some aloud at the foot of the bed.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Lain Book** — four volumes, three centuries.

- ◇ **Annick’s coat** — the good one, still with the pinholes.
- ◇ **The note** — the original.
- ◇ **His own note** — a line a day.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to keep his promise not to lie down after her. **Secret:** he has begun writing a note of his own, a line a day, so that it will be ready. **Secret he does not know:** the Lain Book’s dates match Aveline’s names: every person named by Bed One in the last month had once stood at a Lain-Down’s bed for an hour a day. His name is in his own handwriting on the waiting page.

### TIES

- ◇ **Vesper Null** — wants the notes read at her services. He refuses. She brings him milk.
- ◇ **Hale Grimmer** — boyhood neighbour. Grimmer checks his palms.
- ◇ **Odile Farthing** — a page with her name and nothing else.
- ◇ **Matron Cecily Dorm** — gave him the book, to keep him busy and alive.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **The Note.** A character's contact has a note in the Lain Book, dated next week.
- ◇ **The Comparison.** Vesper's flock-book and the Lain Book together show who was helped and who chose. They do not match.
- ◇ **The Line a Day.** A character finds his note. It is nearly finished.

If **nobody intervenes**, he will finish it in Lack. He will not lie down. He will give it to the Matron, and keep standing, and go grey.

## SAID OF THEM

"He read my father's note back to me at the bed and made it sound like he loved us." — a girl of the Slope

"Teodor keeps the book so that the book keeps him." — Matron Cecily Dorm

"Don't let him near the warm rows on a grey day." — an orderly

# LORD EVANDER QUELL

of the Second Table

*“Felt on the blades, my dears. Felt, and slippers, and the song in three parts. We did it once to a sleeping god, and it never stirred. We shall do it again to a waking one, and the trick is the same: be gentle, and be hungry.”*

— EVANDER QUELL, REHEARSING HIS CHOIR IN A PRIVATE HALL ON THE HEIGHT

| EVANDER QUELL – WATCHER OF THE FIRST SHIFT, OF THE SECOND TABLE |                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                                      | The Vigil · Cut 5 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6 · Weariness 4                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                                                   | fifty (born 591, the Height); Watcher of the First Shift; the Second Table’s senior hand in the Vigil                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                                              | Scion · Standing 5                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                                                      | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                     |
| SKILLS                                                          | Blades 4, Persuade 4, Deceive 4, Godsign 3, Rites 3, Clause 3, Resolve 3                                                                                                |
| BODY                                                            | Flesh 10 · Guard 17 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                                                         | felt-wrapped carving-knife +7 (2; a sleeper struck does not stir)                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                                                           | Lidless and Perfect Recall (as Stroud). The Catching Yawn (as the Taste Gift). Gentle Hands (Partake: one act of violence he performs makes no sound and wakes no one). |
| WANTS                                                           | To watch (Hard).                                                                                                                                                        |
| KNACKS                                                          | Smell of Cedar; Table Manners                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                                                         | the knife-case; the choir-book; the Matron’s spare keys; Larch’s lists; a veil                                                                                          |
| DREAD                                                           | 2 (to hear his choir; 3 to see the knife-case opened)                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Handsome, lidless, silver-templed, beautifully mannered, he moves like a man in a ballroom and speaks to servants by name. His eyes are wetted by a boy who sings while he does it. He smells of cedar and warm wax.

## THEIR STORY

Raised on the Height on tales of the Nine Nights, he joined the Second Table at thirty. He believes the eye’s opening is the best news in six centuries: the god of sleep, whole again, in one place, awake and catchable.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

A Watcher of the First Shift, with friends in every party. He keeps a set of felt-wrapped knives in a case on his wall, a choir of twelve trained in *The Lamb and the Lid*, and the Matron’s spare keys.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The knife-case** — nine blades in felt, copies of the Nine Nights’ knives.
- ◇ **The choir-book** — the forbidden song in three parts.

- ◇ **The Matron’s spare keys** — copied from wax.
- ◇ **Larch’s lists** — he feeds them, a name a Plate, to Jack Tenterhook.
- ◇ **A veil** — for attending Vesper’s sermons.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the number reached: not exceeded, not prevented, reached, cleanly, on a date he can plan for. **Secret:** he has been feeding Sabine Larch’s lists to Jack Tenterhook’s clients, and he knows exactly what the blink-murders are, and he finds them encouraging. **Secret he does not know:** the eye will not open on a god. It will open on a door.

## TIES

- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — an ally he is killing.
- ◇ **Jack Tenterhook** — his tool; Jack’s own name is on the latest list.
- ◇ **Vesper Null** — he weeps at her sermons.
- ◇ **Benedikt Lour** — he has asked for the door-list.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **The Choir.** A character is recruited to sing.
- ◇ **The Keys.** The Matron discovers her keys were copied.
- ◇ **The Date.** Quell has written a date. It is near.

If nobody intervenes, on the night Aveline sits up he will be at Bed  
One with felt on his blades.

---

## SAID OF THEM

“Lord Quell remembers my children’s names. All nine.” — a  
footman of the Height

“He climbs the Stair as if it were going somewhere.” — Maud  
Sexton

“His boy sings while he wets the lord’s eyes. Same song every time.  
The boy doesn’t know the words are forbidden.” — a cook

---

# FACTOR JOSS MALLORY

of the Last Beds

*“Lack keep away, friend, and come in out of the wind. Bed’s a lacks and a half, sheets clean, porters on the door all night. Unless you’re from up top. If you’re from up top you can stand in the doorway and look as long as you like. No charge for looking. I’m not a monster.”*

– JOSS MALLORY, AT THE DOOR OF THE LAST BEDS

| JOSS MALLORY – FACTOR OF THE LAST BEDS |                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | The Fatlands (resident on the Rim below the Vigil) · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste, Ummer) · Hunger 5 · Weariness 0 (he sleeps nine hours a night) |
| AGE & STATION                          | fifty (born 591, near Sated); Rim Road Company factor and innkeeper of the Last Beds since 622                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Factor · Standing 3                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                 | Haggle 5, Persuade 4, Deceive 3, Reckoning 3, Feast 3, Endure 2, Brawl 1                                                                           |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                | cudgel +3 (3); his porters (Threat 2, Flesh 11) fight for him                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                  | none of note; the Taste of the Fatlands shows in his constant gentle chewing                                                                       |
| WANTS                                  | none active                                                                                                                                        |
| KNACKS                                 | Table Manners; Hard Sleeper                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                | the book of the ones not stopped; a ring of keys; maps of the Sleepers’ Mile; a bounty-ledger; a pillow                                            |
| DREAD                                  | 0 (1 if you open the back hall)                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Big-bellied, soft-voiced, sleek, foreign, comfortable; a Fatlander who chews a sugared root all day and smells of beer and fresh linen. He has the only soft voice and the only soft beds within thirty miles of the Vigil, and he is the first friendly face most travellers see before the Lid.

## THEIR STORY

A Company cook’s boy from the south, he bought into the Last Beds in 622 and has run it since, serving every caravan that stops below the border stones so its drivers can sleep before the climb. He keeps a book of the Vigilants his porters could not stop from lying down in his beds.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He sells passes across the border, maps of the Sleepers’ Mile, rouse, nudgers and gossip. He is the Company’s eyes on the Pilgrim Road and the Watch’s last net.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The book of the ones not stopped** — sixty-one names since 622, with dates.
- ♦ **A ring of keys** — including one to the back hall.
- ♦ **Maps of the Sleepers’ Mile** — drawn by his porters, with names where known.
- ♦ **A bounty-ledger** — two columns: *Watch* and *other*.
- ♦ **A pillow** — goose-down. He sleeps on it. Vigilants have offered him a year’s wage to touch it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants a quiet life and a full house. **Secret:** the Watch pays him a bounty for every Vigilant his porters drag back from the beds. The Lessening pays him a larger one for every Vigilant they don’t. **Secret he does not know:** the Lessening does not send its sleepers to the Dormitory; at its request he keeps them, all sixty-one, in the back hall, as a test of whether sleepers off the Lid are Counted. He thinks it is a kindness. They breathe in time with the Dormitory, thirty miles away, and last month all sixty-one turned their heads, together, toward the climb.

## TIES

- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — the *other* column.
- ◇ **Castellan Dray** — slept the Last Beds' doorway out on his way north; stood and looked for an hour.
- ◇ **Bell Lisle** — the courier stopped here; he lent her a nudger.
- ◇ **Captain Brannoch Pyre** — the Watch's bounty comes through his office.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **The Back Hall.** A character finds the locked door and the sixty-one.
- ◇ **The Last Night.** A Vigilant PC must spend a night at the Last Beds, among beds.
- ◇ **The Map.** A porter's map marks one name on the Sleepers' Mile that should not be there: someone the party met yesterday.

If **nobody intervenes**, the sixty-one will get up one night and walk up the Pilgrim Road, eyes closed, toward the Lid.

### SAID OF THEM

"Best beer on the eastern Rim, and you sleep like the dead. Well. Like the dead elsewhere." — a Company drover

"He let me stand in the doorway and look at the beds for an hour, and didn't charge, and I've hated him ever since." — a Vigil clerk

"Mallory's a good man for a man who keeps a book like that." — a porter of the Last Beds

# HESPER COYLE

## Blink-Matter Forty-One

*“I asked them to keep me. I’m not sorry I asked. Every bell the old lady comes with her needle and says good morning, and I say thank you, and I mean it more than I’ve meant anything.”*

— HESPER COYLE, IN THE RATTLEHOUSE STANDING-STALLS, TO HER SISTER THROUGH THE GRILLE

| HESPER COYLE – BLINK-MATTER FORTY-ONE |                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 · Weariness 5                                                                             |
| AGE & STATION                         | thirty-four (born 607, Thimble Lane, the Slope); rope-twister; widow; held in the Rattlehouse at her own request since the eleventh of Carving 641 |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | none                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                | Labor 3, Craft 3, Endure 2, Resolve 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                     |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 9                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                               | fists +4 (1); in a blink, see the Slope Blinker in the core chapter                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                 | Lost Seconds (as the Appetite Gift; she has never used it, and it uses her).                                                                       |
| WANTS                                 | To lie down (Hard).                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                                | Strong Back; Rope Knots                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                          | Not My Hand (her hands are not hers; she keeps them bound)                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                               | the pin; Tobin’s hackle; a bandaged palm; her mother’s bed-number                                                                                  |
| DREAD                                 | 2 (to see the bite)                                                                                                                                |

### WHO THEY ARE

A strong square woman with rope-calloused hands she keeps bound in strips of burr-cloth, a wet pin clenched in one fist, and a face that has not stopped expecting to be struck. She hums sometimes, then stops, horrified.

### THEIR STORY

She smothered her husband Tobin in a blink of two breaths on a grey afternoon, laid him out with folded sacking under his head, and came back with his teeth in her palm. She gave her statement to Inspector Grimmer and asked to be kept awake by the state for the rest of her life, because she has a sister with two little ones who would let her in.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She has no place but a stall. The Slope talks of her as a warning; the Bedded as a vessel. Agathe Pinch needles her at every bell, gently.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The pin** — the sergeant’s, held since the second watch of the eleventh. Her palm runs around it.
- ◇ **Tobin’s hackle** — the flax-comb, brought by her sister.
- ◇ **A bandaged palm** — the bite. Grimmer took a cast.
- ◇ **Her mother’s bed-number** — 31,207, on a scrap.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be written down as loving him. She fears her hands. **Secret:** she knew Tobin copied Dormitory registers for the Lessening at night, for beer money, and begged him to stop. **Secret she does not know:** the last register Tobin copied was the row that holds bed 31,207, her mother, who lay down in 627 and whom Hesper stopped visiting years ago. It was marked *unvisited*. Her mother’s row was first on the schedule.

### TIES

- ◇ **Hale Grimmer** — visits daily.
- ◇ **Agathe Pinch** — needles her kindly.



- ◇ **Sabine Larch** — signed Tobin’s pay.
- ◇ **The man below** — she hears him humming through the floor, and catches herself joining in.

#### IN PLAY

- ◇ **Write It Down.** She asks a character to take her statement again, the true one, and finish it.
- ◇ **The Sister’s Door.** She escapes in a blink. She is walking toward Thimble Lane.
- ◇ **Bed 31,207.** Someone must visit her mother, or the row stays *unvisited*.

If **nobody intervenes**, she will stand in the Rattlehouse for years, thanking the needle, and the Lessening will reduce her mother’s bed on the first night of the schedule.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She loved him. I’ll swear it on my mother’s bed. That’s what makes it so bad.” — Wenna Pell, her neighbour

“She asked me to write that first. So I did.” — Hale Grimmer

“Our Hes is in the Rattlehouse because she wants to be. Nobody on the Lane believes it. I do.” — her sister

---

# LISBET WAKELY

the Brush

*“Every half minute, my lady. Stroke, and count, and stroke. In twelve years I’ve wetted her eyes eight million times. I could do it asleep. That’s a joke. You’re allowed to laugh.”*

– LISBET WAKELY, TO A NEW ATTENDANT ON THE LID’S EYE LANDING

| LISBET WAKELY – EYE-WETTER TO THE WARDEN-PRIME |                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                     | The Vigil · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2 · Weariness 6                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                                  | thirty-one (born 610, Gallow Street); eye-wetter to the Warden-Prime since 629                                                         |
| CALLING & STANDING                             | none (Watch rank 2, Eye-Wetter)                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                                     | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                         | Search 4, Stitching 3, Resolve 3, Stealth 2, Deceive 2, Endure 2                                                                       |
| BODY                                           | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                        | hatpin +4 (1)                                                                                                                          |
| GIFTS                                          | Heavy-Eyed (as the Taste Gift). Steady Stroke (she can perform any delicate act every half minute, for a whole watch, without a roll). |
| WANTS                                          | To count (Routine).                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                         | Steady Hands; Second Chair                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                                        | sable brushes; a silver bowl; slate-letters; a key to Oriel’s rooms                                                                    |
| DREAD                                          | 1                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Neat, small, grey-eyed, with a brush-hand as still as glass and a soft habit of counting under her breath. She has the Height’s manners and the Slope’s vowels. She smells of rosewater, always.

## THEIR STORY

Thaddeus Knell’s niece, raised on Gallow Street after her father, Ansgar Wakely, a Bedded Shepherd, was taken in 622 and, the family was told, went to the room. She was chosen for the Warden’s brush at nineteen for her steady hand. She has stood at the Warden’s shoulder for twelve years, half her waking hours.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She hears everything said on the Lid’s Eye. She is the person the Warden-Prime sees most. She is also, secretly, Lady Oriel’s only friend: she carries messages and books, and once a week she holds Oriel’s hand while Oriel closes her eyes for ten breaths.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Sable brushes** — two, and a spare.
- ◇ **A silver bowl** — of rosewater at blood heat.
- ◇ **Slate-letters** — from her uncle, one a week.

- ◇ **A key to Oriel’s rooms** — copied.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants Oriel free. **Secret:** in the wet surface of the Warden’s eyes, between strokes, Lisbet sees a long dim room reflected, and lately the sleepers in it turned toward her. **Secret she does not know:** she was the brush at the old Matron’s deathbed, aged twenty, and saw the number on the dying lips as the Warden did. She has forgotten. The Warden has not, and keeps her close for it. And her father is alive, on the lowest floor of the Rattlehouse, humming.

## TIES

- ◇ **Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud** — her mistress.
- ◇ **Lady Oriel Stroud** — her friend.
- ◇ **Thaddeus Knell** — her uncle.
- ◇ **Agathe Pinch** — keeps her father.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **The Message.** Oriel needs a letter carried. Lisbet asks a character.
- ◇ **The Number.** The Lessening learns she was at the deathbed.
- ◇ **The Man Below.** A character learns where Ansgar Wakely is.

If **nobody intervenes**, the Warden will one day order her silenced, gently, and give her a pension and a stool.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She never misses a stroke. Never. I’ve watched for a year.” — another eye-wetter

“WRITE MORE OFTEN.” — Thaddeus Knell, on a slate

“Lisbet holds my hand when I close them. She counts. She never lets me get past ten.” — Lady Oriel Stroud

# WEBS OF THE VIGIL

*The eye is patient. Be rude.*

– VIGIL PROVERB

Nobody in the Vigil is unwatched for long, and nobody watches without wanting something. The table below lays out the cast of

both halves of this chapter: what each wants from whom, what each fears, and what each owes.

| CHARACTER         | WANTS FROM                      | FEARS                  | OWES                               |
|-------------------|---------------------------------|------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Ilvane Stroud     | Dray: a yes from the Regent     | her daughter's eyelids | the number to a dead Matron's lips |
| Oriel Stroud      | Lisbet: ten breaths, held       | a lidless husband      | Lisbet her sanity                  |
| Brannoch Pyre     | Grimmer: an answer, not his own | his own nails          | Merrit a bed visit                 |
| Cecily Dorm       | Larch: belief                   | her own pillow-hands   | four sleepers their lives          |
| Vesper Null       | Corwin: what he heard           | doors                  | the room her body                  |
| Corwin Half-Bell  | Hobb: his life back             | the knock              | Nettle everything                  |
| Thaddeus Knell    | Maud: agreement                 | a silent quarter       | his daughter a quarter             |
| Mirela Sconce     | Hobb: the truth entered         | her wanting            | the figure a chair                 |
| Jack Tenterhook   | Quell: his purse, unread        | boredom; his name      | Agathe his art                     |
| Hale Grimmer      | Larch: a confession             | his own palms          | Ottile Venn, unknowing             |
| Odile Farthing    | Marten: one word                | what comes back        | Mirela a slate                     |
| Benedikt Lour     | Stroud: time                    | the Watch's haste      | the room his plans                 |
| Rook Quarter-Bell | Crane: a buyer                  | the column             | Dry Jonah for casks                |
| Castellan Dray    | Grue: a price                   | his own report         | Stroud his honesty                 |
| Sabine Larch      | Dorm: silence                   | the arithmetic         | Ilse, bed 3,315                    |
| Constance Hobb    | Mirela: obedience               | her clerk's tally      | Corwin a life                      |
| Agathe Pinch      | Jack: to come home              | fifty years of error   | Ansgar Wakely nineteen years       |
| Teodor Rell       | Annick: forgiveness             | the warm rows          | the Lain Book a line a day         |
| Evander Quell     | Aveline: to sit up              | a door                 | the Second Table a god             |
| Joss Mallory      | Larch: the other column         | the back hall          | the Company his inn                |
| Hesper Coyle      | Grimmer: a true record          | her hands              | her mother a visit                 |
| Lisbet Wakely     | Oriel: freedom                  | the Warden's eyes      | the Warden a memory                |

### THREE WEBS THAT WILL BURN

**The Killing Chain: Quell, Larch and Tenterhook.** Sabine Larch built the Lessening to keep the number from being reached. Evander Quell, who wants it reached, sits beside her on the Stair and calls her his friend. Larch pays Jack Tenterhook to keep six Watchers blinking so they will vote her lists through; Quell pays Jack a second purse to read names to those same blinking Watchers at the last bell, and the names are Larch's own copyists and orderlies. The room hears. The forty-one dead in Hale Grimmer's case-books are the Lessening's people, killed by the god through the hands of those who loved them, and steered to them by a Second Table lord who wants the Counted protected until the night he can carve what they become. Jack has finally noticed his names die. The last list ends with his own name, and Larch's under it. When Jack reads it aloud, as he will, because he finishes what he starts, the chain eats its own two ends, and Quell is left alone with the keys, the knives and the choir. A party who untangles the chain early can turn any of the three against the others; the worst outcome is to expose only Larch, which hands Quell the field.

**The Door: Vesper, Corwin and Aveline.** Two people have come back from the room: Corwin, who turned around and was

seen, and the thing in Vesper's body, which came back on purpose. Corwin is afraid of Vesper because he believes she went past the door on her way back. Vesper wants Corwin to tell her what he heard because the real Vesper, standing at the back of the room, is listening to the same knock. And Aveline, in Bed One, is naming the people who will stand in the wall between the door and the eye. The three of them, together, are the only key in the Vigil to what is really happening in the long room. If Corwin and Vesper are ever brought to Bed One at the same bell, the rows will turn toward them, Aveline's lips will move, and whoever is listening will hear the knock from this side.

**The Price of the City: Stroud and Dray.** The Warden-Prime and her envoy are old friends who have never lied to each other in forty years, and both are now lying by omission. Dray has not sent the report that the Kept cannot leave Sallowreach, because he knows she will say yes. Stroud has not told Dray that she knows the number, or that she has already decided to leave the sixty thousand Counted behind on the Lid, unwatched, when the city goes north to die. Bell Lisle's dispatch, on the Rim Road now, is the hinge. When it arrives, both of them will tell the truth at last, by letter, and agree. The party is likely to be carrying the letter.

WE ARE ALL OF US **STANDING BETWEEN** A DOOR AND  
AN EYE, AND THE ONLY **QUESTION IS WHICH** WAY WE ARE  
**FACING.**

[ SENNA VOLE, IN HER FORTY-FIRST DIVE REPORT, UNSUBMITTED ]

# USING THE VIGIL'S PEOPLE

The Vigil comes to the party; there is nowhere to rest in it, so people come and find you where you stand. Roll a d20 when someone

knocks, or when a scene needs a face. Remember who knocks politely.

| D20 | WHO'S AT THE DOOR?                 | WHY                                                                                                           |
|-----|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Vesper Null                        | She heard a character weeping three streets away and has come to tell them it is all right to rest.           |
| 2   | Corwin Half-Bell                   | He heard a knock inside the party's lodgings, from a wall with no door. He will not come in.                  |
| 3   | Thaddeus Knell                     | The nearest tower missed a quarter. He needs strong arms on the rope now, and good ears afterwards.           |
| 4   | Mirela Sconce                      | The party were seen in a Seeming last night. She needs their statements before the Registrar strikes it.      |
| 5   | Jack Tenterhook                    | A client asked for the party by name in a blink. He would like to know why, and he has brought pins.          |
| 6   | Hale Grimmer                       | One of the party's contacts is on the Lessening's pay-roll. He wants them watched for three watches.          |
| 7   | Odile Farthing                     | Marten is walking, and turned toward the party's street. She wants them to see where he goes.                 |
| 8   | Benedikt Lour                      | He needs foreigners to test whether the new Dormitory wing is restful. He says it is quite safe.              |
| 9   | Rook Quarter-Bell                  | His sister has joined the column. He will pay in rouse, which is all he has.                                  |
| 10  | Castellan Dray's courier           | Dray needs an honest foreign witness in Lastgate, and a fourth volunteer.                                     |
| 11  | An orderly with Bed One's notebook | Today's name, in the Matron's hand, is one of the party's.                                                    |
| 12  | Sabine Larch                       | She has done the arithmetic on the party, and would like to approach.                                         |
| 13  | Constance Hobb's clerk             | The party are entered in the Record as dead since this morning, on thirty witnesses.                          |
| 14  | Agathe Pinch                       | One of the party has blinked badly. She offers a week in her stall, free.                                     |
| 15  | Teodor Rell                        | A note naming one of the party has been entered in the Lain Book. He wants to know if it is true.             |
| 16  | Evander Quell's choirboy           | An invitation to dine, standing, and to hear a song.                                                          |
| 17  | A Last Beds porter                 | Mallory sent him up the Pilgrim Road. The back hall is empty, and the doors are open.                         |
| 18  | Hesper Coyle                       | She blinked out of the Rattlehouse and is standing in the party's doorway, hands bound, asking to be pinched. |
| 19  | Lisbet Wakely                      | Lady Oriel has slept, for a full minute, and woken, and asked for the party by name.                          |
| 20  | A tall figure in a grey coat       | It stoops under the doorway. It has a cloth over one arm. It asks, politely, how many are dining.             |

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#### GM ADVICE – RUNNING A CAST THAT NEVER SLEEPS

Every person in this chapter is tired, and every scene with them should carry it: a dropped word, a lost second, a pin twisted in a palm. Let NPCs blink in front of the party and come back having moved. Let them repeat themselves, mishear, accuse the party of things the party did not do. Keep a private note of each NPC's Weariness and nudge it upward through a session; when a beloved contact reaches Grey, the players will feel it before you say a word. And remember the city's oldest courtesy: offer a pin. The cast of the Vigil should be met the way the city meets a guest, with a small sharp kindness that keeps everyone, for one more hour, awake.

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CHAPTER 5

# CRADLEWRACK

*The Country Between Pangs*



*Count with me. Not because it helps. Because it is worse alone.*

– WHAT A HIGHLAND MOTHER SAYS TO A CHILD IN FALSE LABOR

*Nine days is long enough to mend a shirt, wean a lamb, and forget. It is not long enough  
to stop listening.*

– LARK NINEDAYS, TO THE TALLY CLERKS



*A day of Una Kocker, slot-feeder at the Debt Wall in the Stillyard of Kest, as she told it to the Attendance's clerk who came asking what the common people do with their nine days. Taken down in Carving 641, the fourth day after a pang.*

*I wake in the brick. Everyone in my row does, the ones who can pay the four crumbs. It is black and close and smells of my own breath and the lime in the mortar, and the first thing you do, before you know your own name, is put your hand flat on the wall and feel whether it is warm. Ours was cool this morning. That is a good morning.*

*Then you wait for the trowel. Old Gage's boy comes down the row at first bell with his pick, and you hear him at the neighbors, tap and crumble, tap and crumble, the bricks coming out one at a time and stacked on the step so they can go back at dusk. When it is your turn he knocks three times first. You knock back three. That is how he knows you are you. If you knock back four, he goes for the Attendance and nobody opens your room till they come. I have never knocked four. My sister's husband did, once, and they say he never knew he'd done it.*

*The air when the brick comes out is like cold water on the face. You can smell the coppers already, the lye and the boiled aprons, and the mutton fat from the Shambles, and under it the springs, that salt-and-cheek smell that is the smell of home to anybody born here and makes outlanders gag. I knock on my children's walls. Three each. They knock back. I count them as they come out, every morning, three heads, three pairs of hands, and I look at the hands, because that is what you look at.*

*Then the door. Our door is a curtain of hide on a pole, like everyone's on the Wall Road, because doors on hinges walk open in the night and a curtain at least does not pretend. I knock on it from the inside before I go out, because you never know what has come and stood on the other side of it while you slept.*

*My work is the slots. The Debt Wall is half a mile of brick on the north slope, and in it are the bricked, the murderers and the forsworn, each in a niche no wider than a coffin with a slot at the height of a mouth. The families pay me a crumb a day each to push bread and a horn of water through, and to listen, and to tell them what I hear. I have forty-one slots. Some of them talk. Some pray. One sings the counting-song all day, from one to sixty and back to one. One has not answered in two years and still takes the bread. I do not ask how. The family pays, and the bread goes, and that is all the Wall wants to know.*

*At noon I eat clay-bread on the Wall step. Mutton fat, rose salt. The Barren come through about then, grey robes, singing the struck-through names, and we all go quiet while they pass, even the slots.*

*The pang came at the third bell. You know it before it comes. Every Course-touched soul in the city cries out together a breath before the ground moves, like the city drawing in air, and then it rolls up out of the hill under you, long and low. The Wall groans. Mortar dust sifts out of every seam. Inside the niches the bricked start screaming, all of them at once, because a bricked man feels a pang in the brick as well as in his body, and for sixty counts I sit on the step with my hands over my ears and count, out loud, because they can hear me counting and it helps them. It does. The singing one counts with me. At sixty it stops. It always stops at sixty. The ground goes still and you are always surprised you are still there.*

*After, the waters. The gutters ran warm and pink down the slope and carried things in them, the way they do. A child's shoe. A great many earthworms. A key nobody owned. I washed my feet in it, which my mother would have slapped me for, but it was warm, and it is Carving.*

*At dusk the crier at the Tally-board on the Wall Road reads the day. Fourteen births in our quarter. Nine stay. One hand, surrendered. Two struck through. Two "entered without bearer," which is what they say now when there is somebody*

*new in the city and no one carried them. Then the crier says “nine days,” and we all say it back, “nine days,” and go home.*

*The trowel comes at second dark. I knock my children in, three each. I count them. I always count them. Then Gage’s boy bricks me, and I lie in the dark that smells of lime and breath, and I put my hand on the wall to see if it is warm, and I listen. That is all I do, really. All day. I listen. Write that down for the Attendance. They should know that the whole country is listening.*

Cradlewrack is the land of the Two Questions, the knife, the crowning ground and the god being born out of the earth. Those things are true, and the core of this book has told them. This chapter is about the other things: the price of a night’s brick, the way a Rudge clay-digger greets her neighbor, what a shepherd in Tarnbrow pays for the right to name a child who is not yet a child, how the Attendance tries a man for opening a door, and what the slot-feeders hear. A country in labor still has to eat, and wash, and sell its mutton, and brick its children in at night. It does so in nine-day stretches now, the way a woman in a long labor learns to live in the gaps between pains, and it does so with a terrible, admirable ordinariness that is the real horror of the highlands. Nobody in Cradlewrack is surprised any more. They are only counting.

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

### KEST, THE CITY OF SEVEN HILLS

Kest is built on seven rounded red hills that rise from the valley of the Tull like the knuckles of a buried hand, with the Rim Road running through the valley floor at their feet. No street in Kest is straight and no wall meets another at a corner; the Attendance holds that corners are where things collect, and so the city flows around its hills in curves, ramps and spiralling lanes that strangers lose themselves in for days. Every building is of the red clay, fired or rammed, rounded and windowless on the weather side, so that from the road below the city looks like a vast heap of eggs set out to warm. Smoke rises from every hill. On still mornings the caul-fog lies in the valley to the height of the second storey, and the hills stand up out of it like islands.

There are perhaps sixty thousand people in Kest, though the Tally cannot agree with itself, and the count is complicated by the bricked, the struck-through, the entered-without-bearer and the born-grown who walk in from the hills and ask to be put on the list. Each of the seven hills is a quarter, and two lower districts fill the valley between them.

#### THE ROUND

The central and highest hill, crowned by the Old Lying-In, the birthing-house of the Meal: a squat round building of red brick older than the Gorging, with eight doors in its circumference, none of which has closed since that night. The Round is the Attendance’s hill. Here are the Senior houses, the Book-room where the six hundred pages of the Book of Questions are kept under glass with a midwife always reading them, the apprentices’ dormitory called the Aprons, and the Hall of the Lying where descent is judged. The streets are paved with fired tiles that the midwives scrub each morning. It smells of lavender, lye, and the cold iron of the knife-cases. It is quiet: nobody on the Round shouts, because Orla Kest does not, and nobody wants to be the one who does. The great

custom of the Round is the **Touching of the Arches**: every person who enters the Old Lying-In touches the seven worn figures over its door, in order, left to right, and turns their face from the eighth. The danger of the Round is the Round itself: an outsider who is found to be carrying will be attended, whatever they wish, and the doors of the Old Lying-In have a way of being the only open way out of a crowd.

#### MOTHER EDDA CLAYHAND, DOORKEEPER OF THE

**OLD LYING-IN** Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · seventy, blind, she stands at the eighth door and knows every midwife by her knock; she has never let a stranger in without asking “what are you” first.

#### TALLY HILL

The commercial heart of Kest and the hill of numbers. The Tally-house sits on its crown, a long curved hall of white-limed clay where Rufus Ochre’s scribes copy the day’s births from the parish boards into the great public ledger, in a scratching hush like rain. Lark Ninedays keeps her water clock in the bare room on its roof, and her bell is the loudest thing in the city. Beneath the Tally-house, down a ramp, is the **Naming-Exchange**, a low vaulted cellar where naming-rights are bought and sold by the hour by brokers who shout prices in a cant of their own (“a Rudge boy at forty, a Cleave girl at twelve, a voice-born at ninety, any takers for a Tarnbrow unknown”). Ruth Ninefold has her stall at the foot of the ramp. The hill smells of ink, lamp-oil and wet wool, and in the Exchange of sweat and spilt posset. Its custom is the **Dusk Reading**: at the last bell of every day a crier on the steps of the Tally-house reads the whole city’s births aloud, and the crowd on the steps answers each “stays” with a murmur and each “struck through” with silence. Its danger is the Exchange: a family that sells a right to name a child it has not yet borne has sold the child’s place in the world, and brokers have been found in the Tull with their ledgers sewn into their mouths.

**CORIN LEDGE, EXCHANGE CRIER** Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · a hoarse man of forty who calls the opening price of every right; he keeps a private book of which children he has sold and visits them on their naming-days with a sugar-stick.

## THE COPPERS

The laundry quarter, on the steep south hill, where the aprons of the Attendance and the linen of the whole city are boiled. A hundred great copper vats stand in open yards under lean-to roofs, fires burning beneath them day and night, tended by laundresses with forearms red and shining from the lye. The steam rises in a column visible from the Rim Road. The smell is overwhelming: wet linen, lye, wood-smoke, and the sweet copper of boiled blood, because most of what is washed in the Coppers comes out of birthing-rooms and reopening-wards. The laundresses sing at work in long call-and-answer songs to keep the rhythm of the paddles. Their custom is **the Rinse**: an apron that has gone into a room where the Second Opinion was given is boiled three times, not once, and the third water is poured out on the hill, never down the drain, so that it goes into the ground and not the river. Their danger is the steam: the Coppers' fog is thick enough that the born-grown sometimes walk out of it, naked and new, having been born of a vat in the night. The laundresses have a word for these, "boilings," and a rule: give them an apron and walk them to the Crèche.

**BIG CLEMENCY FURROW, MISTRESS OF THE COPPERS** Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (laundry paddle 3, Stunning) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · a vast, laughing woman whose arms are scarred white from sixty years of lye; she has fished nineteen boilings out of her vats and named every one.

## MORTAR RISE

The masons' hill, on the west, where the brick-kilns stand in rows like beehives and the air shimmers above them. Here live the Trowel, the masons' guild, who brick the dead and the condemned and, nightly, the cautious of the whole city. Mortar Rise is wealthy in the way of a trade everybody needs: masons' houses have real glass, and their wives wear madder-red silk sewn on each morning. The hill smells of hot clay, lime and the sharp tang of the burnt bone the masons mix into their best mortar. The sound is the tap of trowels, which never stops, because somewhere in Kest there is always someone who wants to be shut in. The custom of Mortar Rise is **the Listening Fee**: a mason who lays a course of brick across a living person's room must, by guild rule, put his ear to it for a full count of sixty before he walks away, and if he hears anything but breathing he must break it open again, without charge. The danger is that masons talk, to each other and only to each other, and the Trowel knows exactly who in Kest sleeps where and with whom and behind how many courses; the guild sells that knowledge, very occasionally, very dearly.

**MASTER HUGH GAGE, WARDEN OF THE TROWEL** Threat 4 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (mason's hammer 3) · Armor 1 ·

Dread 0 · Absalom Gage's younger brother, fifty-four, white-handed with lime; he runs the guild while his deaf brother runs the Stillyard, and he is very much afraid of the knocking his brother hears.

## THE STILLYARD

The north slope of Kest, given over to the dead: the concentric rings of long red walls, each lined with niches where the dead are mortared in behind family-stamped bricks. Absalom Gage is its chief mason. The Stillyard is not a district where people live, except for the slot-feeders and the mourners, who in practice live there, on the steps under the Debt Wall and the family walls, in a shanty-quarter of hide tents called the **Wall Road**. It smells of lime, old wax, cold clay, and, along the Debt Wall, of the living condemned, which is the smell of a sickroom that has been shut for years. The custom of the Stillyard is **the Three Knocks**: mourners knock three times on a new brick and walk away without waiting. The danger is that walls knock back. When one does, the family is fetched, and then the Attendance, and while they wait, the family sits beneath the brick and argues, in low voices, about whether to answer. Some answer. The Attendance has a word for the people who do, and it is not a kind one.

**UNA KNOCKER, SLOT-FEEDER** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · forty, three children, forty-one slots on the Debt Wall; she knows the voices of all her bricked, and she has noticed that the one who has not answered in two years has begun, at night, to tap back the interval.

## SEAM STREET

The stitchers' quarter, a long curved lane down the east shoulder of Tally Hill, lined on both sides with the shops of menders, cord-thread spinners, needle-grinders and catgut-makers, and at its foot the Reopening Ward, where Tamsin Gorse and her stitchers close each morning what the night opened. On the morning after a pang the queue for the Ward reaches the top of the street: old Foundling soldiers bleeding from every wound they ever took, Barren brothers holding their robes closed over their renewed cuttings, women cut for stones, children who fell on a hay-hook five years ago and are bleeding again, all of them standing quietly in line with their hands pressed to their bodies. The street smells of spirit, catgut, wax and blood. Its custom is **the Stitch-Count**: every person in Cradlewrack knows how many stitches they carry, and on Seam Street it is said as a greeting ("Morning, forty-one"), and it is bad manners to ask about a number that has gone up. The danger is the catgut trade itself: the best thread is from sheep, the cheapest is from anything, and a cheap stitch in Cradlewrack sometimes heals into the wound and grows there, and has to be cut out with the flesh around it.

**OLD PELL TWINE, CATGUT-SPINNER** Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (spinning-hook 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · a stooped man with fingers like his own thread who sells the finest gut in Kest; he will not say what the very finest is spun from, and his prices for it are oddly low after a crowning.

## THE SHAMBLES

The mutton market and slaughter-yards in the valley under the Coppers, where the highland flocks come down the drove-roads to be killed, jointed and sold. Lamb in Cradlewrack is the cheapest meat on the Table, because the ewes drop endlessly; the Shambles slaughters a thousand head a day in Plenty and still cannot keep up, and the gutters run so red that the Tull below them is called the Pink Water. The district smells of blood, wool-grease, dung and roasting fat, and it is loud: the bleating of the penned, the thud of the poleaxes, the shouts of the drovers, the hiss of fat on the brazier-stalls where a lack buys a whole roast shoulder. The custom of the Shambles is **the Count of the Lambs**: every ewe that comes in is checked for what she carries, and anything she carries that is not a lamb goes to a pen behind the slaughter-yard called the Odd Fold, where the Attendance's agents and the Assemblers' gatherers bid for it in silence. The danger is the Odd Fold itself. Some of what is in it has hands.

**GERENT FOLD, MASTER OF THE ODD FOLD** Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (poleaxe 5) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · a broad drover who takes coin from both sides and sleeps very well; he keeps a tally of his own, scratched on the fold-gate, of the things that were sold out of it and later walked back in.

## THE CRÈCHE

The barracks of the Foundling Companies, on the low eastern hill: a great walled compound of long dormitories, drill-yards and nurseries, because the Crèche is both. On one side of the central yard the six Companies drill in formation, spears flashing in perfect time; on the other is the Cradle-House, where the newly born-grown are taught to eat with a spoon, to dress, to speak in their own voices rather than the half-remembered ones they arrived with, and where the soldiers who have **gone home** to infancy in a night are kept in rows of cots by the drill-mothers until they die or grow. The Crèche smells of porridge, leather, sweat and milk. It sounds of drums, and of crying. Its custom is **the Birthday Roll**: on the first day of each season the names of soldiers who have earned a remembered birthday are read aloud and they are given a cake, and grown men weep at it. Its danger is grief. The born-grown have none of the practice the rest of us build up as children, and when a squad-mate goes home, the squad is sometimes found the next morning in the Cradle-House, all of them, curled in the cots, which are much too small.

**DRILL-MOTHER ROWAN SEELE, FIRST OF THE CRADLE-HOUSE** Threat 4 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (cudgel 3, Stunning) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · a cast-off Caul-line daughter of forty whose caul came off; she has taught four thousand grown men to tie their boots and she sits up with the ones who have gone home until they stop.

## CORD COURT AND THE AUBREY GARDENS

The two lower districts, side by side in the valley of the Tull, could not be less alike. **Cord Court** is the Kest quarter of the Uncut: a maze of long low joined houses near the river, roofed over by the

pale living cords that run from window to window and street to street, so that walking through it is like walking under the branches of a strange warm orchard. It smells of wet skin and woodsmoke and, faintly, of milk. Its custom is the **Pulse-Greeting**: the Uncut greet each other by laying two fingers on each other's cords. Its danger is to the careless outsider who touches a cord and feels, too clearly, the heart at the other end of it stop.

The **Aubrey Gardens**, across the river, are the old royal quarter: the Womb Court, a long low palace of rose-colored brick with no stairs anywhere (the Queen Dowager cannot climb them) and a garden of herbs and lavender where she is carried in the evenings. The Gardens smell of lavender and old women. The custom here is the **Reading**: every morning at the third bell the Lord Chamberlain reads the day's questions to the Queen's belly, in the Long Room, before a small audience of officials and petitioners, and they all wait in silence for the kick. Its danger is the slow, polite poison of any court that knows its king is a pretext, and the Chamberlain who reads the questions, and who has lately begun reading them in the night, alone.

**LORD CHAMBERLAIN PELL DANNER** Threat 4 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · a minor Caul-line man of sixty with a thin veil over one eye only; he has read the King Within twenty thousand questions and has begun to believe, against all reason, that the answers are right.

## OTHER TOWNS AND VILLAGES

### RUDGE

The clay-diggers' parish in the western ravines: a long straggle of egg-shaped red houses down both sides of a steep wet valley, where the clay-pits are cut into the hillside in terraces like the steps of a stair for something very large. Some eight hundred people live here, short, broad, red-handed to the elbow and suspicious of everybody, and they dig the clay that Kest's potters and masons need. The parish smells of wet earth, iron and smoke from the kilns, and it sounds of spades. The well that gave birth in 403 A.G. stands in the square under three tons of fired brick and a millstone, and no child in Rudge will walk on that side of the square. The custom of Rudge is **the Spade-Oath**: clay-diggers swear by the spade and the pit, and any promise made with a hand on a spade-blade is said to be "dug in" and binding as a brick. Rudge records more Parts than any parish in the country, and the danger here is the Part-hunters, who come up the ravine at night with their crates and their questions; the diggers meet them with spades, and some of the hunters are in the pits now. Hester Lowe lives in Rudge. So does most of the Dilation's watch, through Madder Rudge's huge and argumentative family.

### ABEL FURROW THE YOUNGER, RUDGE PARISH

**ATTENDANT** Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · great-grandson of the Abel Furrow who discovered that Parts fit, and the only man ever made a parish Attendant in Rudge; he



knows exactly which households are hiding Parts, and he has reported none.

### TARNBROW

A sheep-town on the northern moors, the last sizeable place before the Sill, built around a cold dark tarn in a bowl of hills. Its people are shepherds and weavers of the coarse red highland wool, and its houses are more scattered than in the south, each with its lambing-shed and its sheepfold. Tarnbrow smells of sheep, peat-smoke and the cold mineral water of the tarn, which is the only water in Cradlewrack that is not warm. It is a town of odd births even by highland measure: the first man to bear, in 188 A.G., was of Tarnbrow; so was the widow of eighty-seven delivered of twins older than she was. Juniper Dell lives here, and so does the shepherd's widow who keeps Sabeth Thorne's spared thing in her loft. The custom of Tarnbrow is **the Fold-Light**: during lambing every house sets a lamp in the window of the fold, so that whatever is born in the night can see its way to the house and need not wander. The danger is the moor: in the fog between Tarnbrow and the Sill, travelers report a shape walking that is too tall for a man, and tracks the size of a cart. Josiah Fenn passes through every few months.

**ANNIS DELL, SHEPHERD'S WIDOW** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (crook 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · thirty-eight, paid a year's wages by Sabeth Thorne to keep a secret in her loft; she has begun to set out a bowl for it at table and to dread the morning she will see it at the foot of her own bed.

### CLEAVE

A market-town in the central hills, between Kest and the Dilation, famous for its lambing-sheds, the largest in the highlands, and for the things that are born in them. The first born-grown, a woman of forty, was delivered at Cleave in 101 A.G., mid-scream; General Tibb was born in a Cleave lambing-shed six years ago, mid-stride; the covered dish in which a born heart was kept for nineteen years still sits in Cleave's parish hall. The town is crowded on market days with drovers, wool-buyers and Rimwatch pilgrims on their way to the Dilation, and it smells of sheep and straw and roasting chestnuts. Its custom is **the Shed-Watch**: during lambing, a born-grown soldier of the Companies stands guard at the door of each great shed, because what comes out grown has a right to be met by someone who understands. The danger is a quieter one. Cleave is where the Crewe sisters were born, and lately a third girl in the town has started to finish their sentences, and other children in the town have started to say things in unison.

**SERGEANT-ELDER WICK, CLEAVE SHED-GUARD** Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0 · born-grown, four years old in fact, fifty in body; he has met eleven born-grown at the shed door and walked them all to Kest, and he weeps easily and is not ashamed of it.

### RIMWATCH

The ring of tents, turf huts and hostels around the rim of the Dilation, a mile across and growing. It is less a town than a crowd that never went home: pilgrims, Barren preachers, Assemblers' agents, Attendance observers, mothers whose children walked into the hole, souvenir-sellers, posset-sellers, and the painted stakes of the watch. Perhaps two thousand people live in Rimwatch at any time; perhaps half of them were there a year ago. It smells of the hole, warm, humid, iron and birth-water, and of peat-smoke and unwashed pilgrims, and the sound under everything is the slow breath of the warm air rising out of the dark. Its custom is **the Morning Stake**: every dawn the watch sets out painted stakes at the rim to mark its advance, and anyone in Rimwatch may pay a crumb to paint their name on one; when the stake is gone by noon, it is lucky. The danger is the rim, which moves: at each pang the bowl widens by a stride and eases back by less, and every pang someone who was standing at the edge is not there any more. The tents nearest the rim are cheapest.

**HOLLAN PYKE, POSSET-SELLER OF THE RIM** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (ladle 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · a cheerful widow of fifty who sells hot posset from a cart and has moved her pitch back nine times; she claims she has never once seen anything come up, and she is lying.

### CORDWAY

The village of the Uncut on the moorland west of Morwen Hall, built of long low houses joined end to end so that cords need never pass through a door, and roofed over with living cord in a vast slow net that sways in the wind and is warm to the touch. Some six hundred Uncut live here, in households of thirty and forty joined by cords, with a few Grafted outsiders among them. Cordway smells of warm skin, peat and milk, and it sounds of a low constant hum, which is not a sound at all but the pulse of six hundred hearts felt through the soles of the feet. Its custom is **the Long Table**: the whole village eats together in the great joined hall, because the cords make it painful to be apart at meals. Its danger is the deep cords. Some of the oldest Uncut have let their cords grow down into the clay, and the ground in Cordway has a pulse of its own; at night the cords that go into the earth tighten, all together, as if something below were drawing them gently down. Sister Maeve Cord's mother lies in a long low tomb here, with a slot left for the cord.

**OLD ISOLDE ROOTSISTER, A ROOT OF THE UNCUT** Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (cord-lash 2, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · ninety, blind, her cord in the ground beneath her chair for thirty years; she has not left the chair in a decade and she says the land's child is a girl.

### BREECH'S GATE

The great border post on the Rim Road, at the southern descent where the road leaves the highlands toward the Brinehollow coast and the Fatlands beyond: a walled yard, a customs hall, the Examination Rooms, a Rim Road Company inn, and a straggle of

lodging houses outside the wall for the turned-back. The yard is always full of travelers waiting their turn to be examined, and of the turned-back, who wait for a change of heart that never comes and who, after a season or two, become a settled village of their own, called **Hold**. Breech's Gate smells of horses, wool, posset and the vinegar the examiners wash their hands in. Its custom is **the Laying-On**: every traveler leaving the highlands stands against a wall while a midwife lays a palm on their belly and an ear to their navel, and men and women alike are asked the date of their last pang-cramp. Its danger is what is found. More travelers are carrying every week, including men who did not know, and the Examination Rooms have their own small lying-in, and their own knife.

**EXAMINER BRYONY LINTEL, ATTENDANT OF THE GATE** Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · fifty, with cold hands she apologizes for; she has examined forty thousand bellies, and she has started to feel, in a few of them, a second heartbeat that is not a child's but the land's, and she does not know what to write.

### TULLFORD

The river town under Morwen Hall, where the Tull is bridged on the road west to Cordway and the sea. It is a Caul-line town: almost everyone here works for the Morwens in some way, as servant, nurse, forester, spring-keeper or bridge-warden, and the great round keep of Morwen Hall looms over it on its wooded ridge, doorless on its lower floors. Tullford smells of river-water, leaf-mold and the orris-root perfume the Morwen servants wear to cover what they carry home on their clothes. It is quiet, prosperous and tight-lipped. Its custom is **the Nurses' Walk**: once a week, at night, a line of Morwen nurses comes down from the Hall carrying covered baskets, crosses the bridge, and walks a mile west into the woods, and comes back with the baskets empty. Nobody in Tullford watches them pass. Its danger is the woods to the west, where something has been growing, out of what the nurses leave, for three hundred years.

**TESS BRIDGEWARD, KEEPER OF TULL BRIDGE** Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · sixty, the fourth of her name to keep the bridge; she counts the baskets out and the baskets back, and her ledger shows three hundred years of the Nurses' Walk, and the baskets have lately started coming back heavier.

## ▼ROADS AND WAYS

Nobody in Cradlewrack travels far without counting. The first question a highland traveler asks at an inn is not the price of a bed but "how long since?", and the answer decides everything: whether to push on to the next pang-house, whether to wait out the waters, whether the ford at Tull will be passable or running warm and pink to the banks. A journey of four days that crosses a pang is a different journey from one that does not, and travelers plan around the interval the way sailors plan around the tide.

### KILNMOUTH

A brick-burning town in the south, near Nullhouse, where the clay of the highlands meets the first dry ground toward the Fast border and the kilns can be fired without the steam of the springs. It makes nearly all the fired brick in Cradlewrack: the brick that walls the Stillyard, bricks in the Lying-In's lower wards, caps the Rudge well, and is laid each night across ten thousand bedroom doors. Kilnmouth is all smoke and heat, a town of a hundred kilns burning day and night, its people grey with ash and coughing; it smells of hot clay and charcoal and the bone-meal the brickmakers temper their best mortar with. Its custom is **the Stamp**: every brick that leaves Kilnmouth is stamped with its kiln's mark, and a family that bricks its dead buys bricks from one kiln only, generation after generation, so that the walls of the Stillyard can be read like a book of loyalties. Its danger is that the kilns, too, have begun to bear: twice in the last year a kiln opened at dawn held, among the fired bricks, a fired thing, curled and hard, with a pulse. The Barren Order buys its grey stone through Kilnmouth's carters and is not loved here.

**LORNE ASH, MASTER OF THE HUNDRED KILNS** Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (fire-iron 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · a cinder-faced man of sixty-five who has bricked his own kiln-births into the base of the town's oldest kiln and will not let anyone fire it.

### THE PANG-HOUSES

Along every road in Cradlewrack, at roughly every three miles, stands a **pang-house**: a small round red hut, open-doored, with a sunken floor and walls nine bricks thick. They are maintained by the parishes and free to all. When a pang is near, travelers make for the nearest one, lie flat on its sunken floor, and wait out the sixty counts. Each pang-house has the interval scratched on its lintel, every interval since it was built, in a long column of shortening numbers; the oldest have columns going back three hundred years, and reading them is a quick education in why the highlands are frightened. Pang-houses are also where the born-grown most often appear: the Companies send a soldier on a round of the nearer ones the morning after every pang, to see who is lying there, naked and new, asking what year it is.

The **Rim Road** runs through the highlands for about a hundred and sixty miles, entering from Sallowreach in the north at the lesser post called **Fogstile**, passing below the seven hills of Kest, and leaving by Breech's Gate in the south toward the Brinehollow coast. It is a Company road, paved with fitted stone (grey stone, carted in at Company expense, which the Barren Order regards as the only holy thing the Company ever did), and its waystations are Company inns with brick-in rooms and Company guards. It is the one road in

the country where the pangs do little harm, because Company engineers relaid it on piles after the Shortening began; it shudders, and the inns empty onto the verges, but it does not crack. Inside the highlands, every other road does.

The **clay roads** are the rest: red tracks pounded hard by sheep and carts, winding along the ridges to avoid the ravines, where the waters gather. They are soft after every pang and set like brick in a dry week, and their ruts are a foot deep in Carving. Every crossroads has a **knocking-stone**, a waist-high red pillar on which travelers knock three times before choosing a way; the stones are hollow, and the hollows ring, and in the fog the sound of knocking carries for miles. Milestones in the highlands do not give miles but pang-houses: “Kest, nine houses.” The **drove-roads** are wider and older, grassy ways along which the flocks are walked down to the

Shambles, and they are safe in all seasons except lambing, when the ewes drop on the road itself and the drovers will not move until each birth has been looked at.

Travel during a pang is forbidden by every parish and practiced by everyone. The rule is simple: at the first cry of the Course-touched, which runs ahead of the quake like a wind, get off the road, lie down flat away from any slope, and count. After the sixty counts, wait for the waters, which come within the hour, and keep to the ridges. Ravines flood warm to the depth of a man in minutes, and drain as fast, and leave the ground rimed with pink salt and littered with what came up. Drovers who have been caught in a ravine flood say the water is the temperature of a body and that it holds you, gently, the way a hand holds an egg.

| ROUTE                        | DAYS (FOOT)           | ROAD                 | CHIEF DANGERS                                             |
|------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Kest to the Lying-In         | 2 hours (ride)        | clay road            | turned away at the wall; the wind from the lower wards    |
| Kest to the Assemblers’ Barn | half a day            | clay road            | Barn brothers; Part-hunters on the road at night          |
| Kest to Rudge                | 2                     | clay road, ravines   | ravine floods; diggers who meet strangers with spades     |
| Kest to Cleave               | 1                     | drove-road           | lambing on the road; born-grown in the sheds              |
| Cleave to Rimwatch           | 1                     | drove-road           | pilgrim crowds; the rim’s advance; thieves                |
| Kest to Tullford             | 2 by barge, 3 on foot | river, clay road     | reel-houses closed after pangs; the Nurses’ Walk          |
| Tullford to Cordway          | 1                     | moor track           | the deep cords; the woods west of the bridge              |
| Kest to Tarnbrow             | 4                     | clay road, moor      | fog; tracks the size of a cart; the tall shape walking    |
| Tarnbrow to the Sill         | 1                     | sheep-track          | abandoned farms; sheep that will not look north           |
| Kest to Nullhouse            | 3                     | clay road, dry hills | Barren stone-carts; Purgation cells in the hills          |
| Kest to Kilnmouth            | 3                     | clay road            | kiln-smoke; carters’ feuds with the Barren                |
| Kest to Breech’s Gate        | 3                     | Rim Road             | turned-back crowds; the Examination Rooms                 |
| Kest to Fogstile             | 4                     | Rim Road             | Sallowreach fog creeping south; Kept peddlers turned back |

**RULES – TRAVELLING IN THE HIGHLANDS**

Each day of travel off the Rim Road in Cradlewrack, check the interval. If a pang falls on a travel day, every traveler must make a **Lung + Wayfaring** roll (Hard 14) to reach a pang-house or safe ridge in time; failure means riding out the sixty counts in the open, which is a Dread 1 horror and costs 1d6 Flesh to anyone on a slope (falls, slides, flying stones). A traveler caught in a ravine when the waters come must roll **Gut + Athletics** (Grim 18) or be carried off, waking 1d6 hours later downstream, alive, warm, and with something clutched in their hand that they did not have before (the Carver decides what). A party that knocks on every knocking-stone it passes gains +2 on the day’s Wayfaring roll; the Carver need not explain why.

## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

The highlands are not poor. They are rich in exactly the things that are born, which is to say, everything: lambs, wool, clay, and people. What is scarce in Cradlewrack is anything that stays shut, anything that is finished, and anything that is certain, and those are what cost money.

**Wool and mutton** are the base of the country. The ewes of the highlands drop three and four times a year now, and a flock doubles in a season; the problem of every shepherd is not breeding but culling, and the drove-roads to the Shambles never empty. Highland wool, coarse and red, goes out along the Rim Road by the wagon-load, and highland mutton, salted with the rose-colored spring-salt, is sold as far as the Vigil, where it is said to keep the sleepless awake. Lamb is so cheap at home that the poor eat it daily; the rich, to show they can, eat fish carried from Brinehollow at ruinous expense.

**Clay and brick** are the second trade. Every building in the country is of red clay, and every night ten thousand doors are bricked and every morning broken out, and the dead go into the walls in their thousands each year. Rudge digs, Kilnmouth fires, and the Trowel lays. Masons are among the best-paid commoners in the land.

**Thread and stitching** is the third. Every wound in Cradlewrack reopens, and so the country consumes catgut, linen thread, needles and wax in quantities that astonish visitors. Stitchers are respected and well paid; spinners of fine gut are rich.

**Springs and salt** belong to the Caul-lines. Every warm spring in the highlands is owned by one of the five veiled houses, which charge spring-rents for water and sell the rose spring-salt that is scraped from the rims of the pools. That, more than prophecy, is why the Veiled Council sits beside the Attendance.

**Cauls** are an export. The Rim Road Company buys highland birth-cauls by the crate at Breech's Gate for sale in Brinehollow, where one sewn into a coat is thought to prevent the Calling, and an ordinary family can sell a child's caul for a season's bread. Lately the Caul-lines have begun selling their own, which are larger, and warmer.

**Names** are speculation. The Naming-Exchange under the Tally-house trades naming-rights by the hour, and fortunes are made and lost on rumors that come down from the birthing-rooms. A right bought for two lacks on a Rudge clay-digger's unborn may sell for four hundred if the child is born whole, speaking, and plainly gifted, and a right bought for forty on a noble's bastard is void the moment the knife falls.

And there is the black trade, larger than any of these: **Parts**. The law says every Part belongs to the Lying-In, and the Assemblers pay better than the law. Part-hunters work the western ravines with crates, mothers sell what they bore for the price of a winter, and a healthy hand fetches sixty lacks in the dark of the Odd Fold. The Attendance seizes what it finds and unhinges the families. It finds very little.

| COMMON WORK                         | PAY PER DAY    | NOTES                                                      |
|-------------------------------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shepherd's hand                     | 1 L and mutton | sleeps in the fold; counts the lambs and what is not lambs |
| Clay-digger                         | 1 L 5 c        | Rudge; more after a pang, when the pits have moved         |
| Laundress at the Coppers            | 8 c            | and the lye-scars; three boilings for a knife-apron        |
| Potter or brickmaker                | 2 L            | Kilnmouth's best earn 4                                    |
| Night-mason (bricker-in)            | 3 L            | twenty rooms at dusk and dawn; master masons 8 L           |
| Lower-ward bricklayer, the Lying-In | 9 L            | triple wages; nobody stays past a year                     |
| Stitcher, the Reopening Ward        | 2 L            | 4 L the morning after a pang                               |
| Tally scrivener                     | 2 L            | copied in tandem; Ede and Ada Crewe earn double            |
| Parish Attendant                    | 4 L            | a share of birth-fees; board and apron found               |
| Apprentice of the Attendance        | 2 c and board  | the vow is the wage                                        |
| Foundling soldier                   | 1 L and board  | paid by the Crown; the drill-mothers earn 3                |
| Rimwatch stake-setter               | 1 L            | 3 L for the stakes nearest the edge                        |
| Slot-feeder at the Debt Wall        | 1 c a slot     | forty slots is a living                                    |
| Part-hunter                         | by the piece   | 10 L for an ear, 60 L for a hand, in the dark              |



| LOCAL PRICES                     | COST                 | NOTES                                  |
|----------------------------------|----------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Lamb or mutton, a pound          | 1 c                  | the cheapest meat on the Table         |
| Clay-bread, a loaf               | 2 c                  | warm for a day                         |
| Posset, a horn                   | 1 c                  | 2 c at Rimwatch                        |
| Rose spring-salt, a pound        | 1 L                  | the Caul-lines' monopoly               |
| Bricking-in, one night           | 4 c                  | mason, mortar, dusk and dawn           |
| Knocker's ring                   | 2 L                  | brass; the polite carry one            |
| Neck-kit (needle, gut, wax)      | 2 L                  | everyone over seven wears one          |
| Stillyard niche, common wall     | 5 L                  | the family wall costs 40 L and a stamp |
| Attendance birth-fee             | 12 L                 | compulsory; the knife is included      |
| A Part in the Odd Fold           | 10 to 60 L           | illegal; the Assemblers pay double     |
| A child's caul, sold at the Gate | 8 L                  | a Caul-line caul, 120 L                |
| Naming-right                     | 2 to 400 L           | a hand is worth nothing                |
| Agnes Latch door                 | 200 L the lock alone | the waiting list is a year             |
| Grey stone, one cartload         | 30 L                 | carted from the Fast border            |

## TAXES

The Attendance takes no tax and needs none: the **birth-fee** of twelve lacks for every attended birth is the largest revenue in the country, and it is paid by every household, since every birth must be attended. Paupers pay in kind, a season of laundry at the Coppers or a year of slot-feeding. The Crown takes the **Litter-Levy**, a crumb a

pang from every household, nominally to keep the Queen Dowager carried, actually to keep the Chamberlain's office. The **Hinge-Duty** taxes any lock that holds as a luxury, at half its price, on the reasoning that a man who can afford to be shut in can afford to pay for it; Agnes Latch's customers pay a hundred lacks to the Tally on top of her two hundred. The Caul-lines take **spring-rents** for water. The Rim Road Company takes its tolls at Breech's Gate and Fogstile, and buys its cauls duty-free.

## ▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

The law of Cradlewrack is the law of the Book of Questions, and the Book is mostly cases: six hundred pages of what was born and what was decided, with the last page in Hollan Kest's hand. Crimes are judged by the same habit of mind. Every hearing in the highlands is in form a birth: the accused is "brought before," the parish Attendant asks two questions aloud, and she answers them herself. The questions in court are *what was done*, and *does it stay*, and the second means: does the offender stay in the parish, in the house, in the world.

### WHO ENFORCES

- ◇ **Parish Attendants** are magistrates in their parishes. They hear all lesser matters alone, in the parish birthing-room, sitting on the birthing-stool, with the accused standing in the doorway.
- ◇ **Hingemen** are the parish constables: two or three to a parish, big men and women with iron bars and axes, whose duty is to fetch the accused and to carry out sentences of unhinging. They

knock on the door of the accused before they take it off its hinges, because the law is the law.

- ◇ **The Trowel** carries out sentences of bricking, under the eye of an Attendant, and the guild is paid by the Crown per niche.
- ◇ **Border Marshals** enforce the law against leaving while carrying, on the Rim Road and the hill-paths.
- ◇ **The Foundling Companies** are called out against riots, smugglers and Part-hunting gangs, rarely and reluctantly; the born-grown do not like to arrest mothers.
- ◇ **Knockers** are informants, paid by the Attendance a lack a time for word of an unattended birth or a hidden Part. To call someone a knocker in Rudge is to start a fight.

### HOW A TRIAL WORKS

A lesser case is heard the same day the Hingemen bring the accused in. The accused stands in the doorway of the parish birthing-room, half in and half out, which is the position of anyone whose fate is not decided. The Attendant sits on the birthing-stool. Witnesses

knock on the jamb before they speak, and the Attendant answers each knock with “come in,” and a witness who speaks without knocking is not heard. There are no advocates. But any person may stand behind the accused in the doorway and lay a hand on their shoulder, and this person is called the **doorholder**: they may speak for the accused, and they take a share of the sentence if it is unhinging, since their own door is taken off with the accused’s. A man with many doorholders is a man the parish wants to keep, and Attendants listen to that. A man with none is usually lost.

The Attendant asks the First Question, *what was done*, and hears the witnesses, and answers it aloud. Then she asks the Second, *does*

*it stay*, and answers that, and the answer is the sentence. There is no appeal from a parish Attendant except to a Lying, a bench of three Seniors, and a Lying will hear only cases of descent, of bricking, and of the Attendance’s own members.

Grave crimes, the ones that carry bricking, are heard in the Hall of the Lying on the Round, before three Seniors, and the sentence is read aloud in the Old Lying-In itself, in the birthing-room of the Meal, with the eight doors open and the city able to listen. The condemned is walked from there to the Stillyard by the Trowel, who carry their tools and the bricks already stamped with the condemned’s name.

| CRIME                                   | USUAL SENTENCE                                                                                      | NOTES                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening a door without knocking         | a public knocking: the offender knocks at every door in the street, and waits at each for an answer | most often children and foreigners                             |
| Concealment of a birth                  | the child held unborn; the mother fined the birth-fee thrice                                        | the child may be taken back for a late Second Opinion          |
| Concealment of a Part                   | unhinging for a season                                                                              | the commonest crime in the country, thanks to the Assemblers   |
| Selling or buying a Part                | unhinging for a year; the Part to the Lying-In                                                      | buyers who are Assemblers are bricked if they are caught twice |
| Lockbreaking (opening a bricked room)   | unhinging; the breaker must brick the room again with their own hands                               | and sleep in it, alone, for nine nights                        |
| Descent-fraud                           | struck from the Tally; one’s naming annulled                                                        | the offender has no name until a Lying grants one              |
| Hiding a returning child                | the child returned; the parents unhinged a year                                                     | many parents prefer it                                         |
| Smuggling a pregnancy across the border | bricking for a season, then branding on the palm                                                    | for the woman carried, nothing; she is turned back             |
| Wearing the apron falsely               | put to the Two Questions by an Opinion                                                              | usually answered with branding; not always                     |
| Cutting an Uncut cord                   | as murder, if either end dies                                                                       | since 452 A.G.; both ends usually die                          |
| Breaking an oath by the shut door       | no sentence; the dead see to it                                                                     | the family may brick the forsworn’s room from outside          |
| Murder or kin-slaying                   | bricking in the Debt Wall                                                                           | fed through a slot as long as the family pays                  |
| Murder of an Attendant in the room      | bricking in the Low Wall, among the struck-through                                                  | without a slot                                                 |

**Unhinging** deserves a word, because outsiders think it mild. The offender’s house has every door taken off by the Hingemen, carried to the parish square, and burned, and the household must live open to the night for the length of the sentence, with no door, no curtain, no brick. In a country where things come through openings, it is a sentence of fear. An unhinged house is watched by its neighbors with pity and horror, and it is not unusual, by the end of a season, for the household to have gained a member nobody can account for, sitting quietly at the table in the morning, and the Tally to enter it as “born to the house, without bearer.”

**Bricking** is the great sentence and the only death the Attendance gives except the knife, and it is not quite death. The condemned is

mortared alive into a niche in the Debt Wall, with a slot at the height of the mouth through which bread and water are pushed each day by a slot-feeder as long as the family pays. Some families pay for forty years. Some stop after a week. The Wall is the most visited place in Kest, because in the evenings the families sit beneath the slots and talk to their bricked. A few of the oldest niches still take bread, and have not spoken in decades, and the families keep paying, because they are afraid of what will come out of the slot if they stop.

## RULES – BEING UNHINGED

A character sentenced to unhinging, or sleeping in an unhinged house, cannot benefit from a bricked room. Each night, roll a d10; on a 1, something comes in. The Carver chooses from: a crawling Part looking for others (it settles into the character's pack); a born-grown stranger who sits by the hearth until dawn and leaves without speaking; a Doorborn that opens one of the character's old scars (2 Flesh, Dread 3); or a new member of the household, who is still there in the morning, and whom everyone else in the house seems to remember. A doorholder who shares the sentence may reroll the d10 once per night, for anyone in the house, at the cost of 1 Fray to themselves.

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

Highland faith lives in the doorway. Every house in Cradlewrack has a **lintel-niche** over its main door, holding a small faceless clay figure with its arms spread to either side, and the household touches it going out and coming in. Nobody calls it Vey aloud. It is called the Holder, and children are told that it holds the door, and are not told which way.

The three doctrines of the Table all have their highland shapes. **The Shut Door** is the Theft: we shut the door on the god and killed it, and every reopened wound is the debt coming due. It is the faith of the Attendance, which does not preach it but lives it, and of most of the old parishes, and it makes the Second Opinion a penance carried out on the country's behalf. **The Open Arms** is the Gift: Vey spread its arms in the doorway not to bar it but to hold it open for us, and went into the pot so that the Lack would end, and the births are its love, too much of it, given too freely. It is the faith of mothers who keep their Parts and of the Uncut, and of the Latefaction whispering in the Aprons. **The Long Labor** is the Bait: Vey starved the highlands so that the highlands would carry it, and the country is now nine months gone with its god, and always was. The Long Labor is banned in four lands and not in Cradlewrack, because the Book of Questions says a question must be asked aloud; it is preached openly at Rimwatch and in the Barn, and it is the faith of the Assemblers, who believe they are midwives to it.

## SHRINES AND HOLY PLACES

- ◇ **The Seven Arches** over the door of the Old Lying-In, touched by everyone who enters; and the eighth, which is not.
- ◇ **Knocking-stones** at every crossroads, hollow pillars knocked three times before a road is chosen.

- ◇ **Cord-trees** on the Tull and in Cordway, old alders on which the Uncut hang the dried cords of their dead, so that the wind moves them.
- ◇ **The Low Wall** in the Stillyard, where the struck-through are bricked without family marks; mothers come there on the anniversaries of births that were never entered, and lay a hand on the unstamped brick, and do not knock.

## RITES

- ◇ **The Knocking-In.** A new house is not lived in until a midwife has knocked on every one of its doors and walls from the outside, and waited for silence.
- ◇ **The Naming and the Second Meal.** At a year, a child is named before the household, and the household eats the salted afterbirth, stewed with lamb and onions, starting with the mother. A Caul-line child's caul is eaten raw from a silver dish.
- ◇ **The Nine Stitches.** The dead are washed and every opening sewn shut with nine stitches each, by the eldest woman of the family, while the rest sing the counting-song softly; the stitcher ties the knot that cannot come undone.
- ◇ **The Count.** On Pangday, families gather in the strongest room, hold hands, and count the sixty aloud together, and the youngest child says the last number.
- ◇ **The Reading of the Struck-Through.** A Barren rite now taken up by many who are not Barren: at the rim of the Dilation, or at the Low Wall, the names given in secret to the struck-through are read aloud by whoever knows them.

## HOLY DAYS

| DAY            | WHEN                | WHAT IS DONE                               |
|----------------|---------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Pangday        | every nine days now | work stops; the Count; the waters searched |
| The Unbricking | first day of Grace  | every bricked room broken open and aired   |

| DAY             | WHEN                              | WHAT IS DONE                                                          |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lambing Eve     | mid-Grace                         | fold-lights in every window; nobody sleeps alone                      |
| Hollan's Day    | high Plenty                       | the Book of Questions read through at the Old Lying-In; midwives fast |
| The Closed Week | the week of Carving's first frost | married couples keep apart; houses bricked a week                     |
| Tablenight      | longest night of Lack             | every door propped open till dawn; a place laid nearest the door      |

## THE COUNTING-SONG

The hymn every highland child knows before it knows its letters, sung during the pang, one line to each ten counts:

*One to ten, the door is shut, and I am in, and you are out.*

*Ten to twenty, knock and wait, the Holder holds, the hour is late.*

*Twenty, thirty, roll and rise, Mother, Mother, shut my eyes.*

*Thirty, forty, down and through, whatever comes, it isn't you.*

*Forty, fifty, nearly done, the waters come for everyone.*

*Fifty, sixty, still, still, still, and if it stays, it stays, it will.*

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

- ◇ “Forty years I’ve laid brick across this town of a night. You learn what a breath sounds like through four courses. You learn what two breaths sound like when there should be one.” — a night-mason of Mortar Rise
- ◇ “Mam says I’m called Keep till I’m named. I’m named next week. I want to be called Keep anyway.” — a child, aged one year less a week, who already talks
- ◇ “The first thing I remember is a woman with a basin saying ‘what is it.’ I thought she meant the weather. I said, ‘raining.’ She laughed. I loved her right away.” — a Foundling soldier, born-grown four years
- ◇ “They pay for the brick, the lads who come to me. Not the bed. The brick. A man wants one night where nothing gets in.” — a woman of the Wall Road
- ◇ “Every spring the sheep drop something with fingers. We used to call the midwife. Now we just call the Fold.” — a Tarnbrow shepherd
- ◇ “I gave the Lying-In my daughter’s hand. A hand, sir. I nursed it a month. I’d have kept it, if the knocker next door had kept his mouth shut. I hope his door comes off.” — a mother of Rudge
- ◇ “Don’t touch the cord, love. That’s my granny. She’s having a bad day.” — an Uncut girl in Cord Court
- ◇ “My scar’s forty years old and it opens like it’s proud of itself.” — an old soldier in the Reopening Ward queue
- ◇ “The Book says *choose so that you can remember*. I chose. I remember. Nobody said it would be the only thing I remember.” — a retired Opinion
- ◇ “I brought a cartload of grey stone up from the Fast border. Took me nineteen days. Tipped it in the Dilation. Didn’t hear it land.” — a Barren carter
- ◇ “My man came home after the pang and kissed me and sat down to his supper and I knew. I knew. It’s his face. It isn’t him. The Attendance says it’s him. They’ve a book that says so.” — a weaver of Tally Hill, after a Break
- ◇ “I was struck through. It’s in the Tally. Rufus Ochre showed me the line. So what am I, then, buying your bread?” — a stranger at a Kest bakery, unexplained

## ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

Cradlewrack looks, from outside, like a land ruled absolutely by an order of armed midwives, and in one sense it is: no birth happens without them, and no appeal lies from the knife. But the Attendance rules by being needed, not by owning anything, and everything it needs it must ask for. It needs the Caul-lines’ springs

and money, the Trowel’s brick, the Tally’s numbers, the Crown’s dignity, the Companies’ spears, and above all the willingness of a hundred thousand mothers to send for the midwife when the pains begin. That willingness is what the Assemblers are buying away from it, one Part at a time.

| POWER                                         | CONTROLS                                                 | FEARS                                         | OWES                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| The Attendance (Orla Kest)                    | every birth; the courts; the knife; the Lying-In's book  | the Late-faction; the room under the Dilation | the mothers, for their silence                  |
| The Veiled Council (Duchess Morwen)           | the springs, the clay-pits, prophecy, rents              | the red in the veil; the Reckoners            | the Cutwrights, for their discretion            |
| The Crown (Queen Dowager, Chamberlain Danner) | the Companies' pay; legitimacy; the Litter-Levy          | the King Within's unasked answers             | the Attendance, which props it up               |
| The Tally (Rufus Ochre)                       | the record of who exists; the Naming-Exchange's ground   | the arithmetic closing                        | the Crown, for its wages                        |
| The Trowel (Hugh and Absalom Gage)            | every brick and every bricked room                       | the knocking from inside walls they laid      | the Attendance, for its niche-contracts         |
| The Foundling Companies (General Tibb)        | the only army; the roads in a riot                       | going home                                    | the Crown and the Attendance, who let them stay |
| The Border Marshals (Gideon Breech)           | who leaves                                               | the one he let through                        | the Attendance, for the law                     |
| The Assemblers (Dov Marrin)                   | the Barn; the black trade in Parts; many mothers' hearts | the figure turning without them               | the Second Table, for the roof and more         |
| The Barren Order (Callum Stillwater)          | Nullhouse; the rim's crowds; grey stone                  | the voice in the scar                         | the Purgation, for money and arson              |
| The Uncut (Maeve Cord)                        | Cordway, Cord Court, the barges                          | the cut; the thing at the root                | nobody; they are all one family                 |
| The Rim Road Company (Merriam Toll)           | the road, the Gate's inn, the caul trade                 | the warm cauls                                | Oathen, for every contract                      |

Three currents move under the table. The first is **money from outside**: the Second Table's coin in the Barn, the Purgation's in Nullhouse, the Company's in the caul-crates, all of it buying a stake in what will be born. The second is **the loss of the mothers**: every family that hides a Part instead of calling the midwife is a family that has stopped believing the knife protects it, and the Tally's numbers of concealment have doubled since the Shortening began. The third is **the interval itself**, which rearranges every alliance as it shortens.

The Knife-faction and the Barren Order, who would once have despised each other, now meet in the back rooms of the Round to talk about stone. The Crown, which was a pleasant fiction for four centuries, has a king who has started to answer. And Orla Kest, who has the most power of anyone in the country, has quietly decided that when the interval reaches one day, power will be the wrong word for what is needed, and she has begun to set her house in order for someone else.

THE WHOLE COUNTRY IS A BIRTHING-  
ROOM NOW, AND I HAVE NEVER ONCE IN MY LIFE LEFT A  
ROOM BEFORE IT WAS FINISHED.

[ MIDWIFE-PARAMOUNT ORLA KEST, TO THE SENIOR OF THE LYING ]



# ORLA KEST

## Midwife-Paramount of the Attendance

*“I don’t ask you to forgive me. I ask you to hold the door. Afterwards you may hate me in any room you like.”*

– ORLA KEST, TO A FATHER IN CLEAVE, 627 A.G.

| ORLA KEST – MIDWIFE-PARAMOUNT OF THE ATTENDANCE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                      | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                                   | 68 (born 573 A.G.); Midwife-Paramount since 619 A.G.; keeper of the Old Lying-In                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                              | Midwife · Standing 5 (Midwife-Paramount)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                                      | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| SKILLS                                          | Stitching 5, Blades 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Rites 3, Intimidate 3, Lore 3, Clause 2, Endure 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                                            | Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                                         | the Second Opinion (knife) +8 (2); a precise cut to an opening, a seam or a crowning ignores Armor                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                           | The Question (once per scene, any creature born in Cradlewrack that she addresses with the First Question must hold still for one round; Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 to resist). Steady Hand (she never suffers a Lack on Stitching). Knock (her palm on a door, wall or belly tells her whether something living is behind it and roughly how big; whatever is there knows she knocked). |
| WANTS                                           | Go into the Room. When she learns of a birth of any kind within a day’s ride, she must go and stay until the end (Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 to stay away; she has never once tried).                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                          | Steady Hands, Unflinching, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                                    | The Count (she counts the struck-through she has answered; the number is always one short)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                                         | the Second Opinion in its case; the Paramount’s ring of keys that open nothing; a stitching kit; lavender; a ledger of three thousand names; a lead-weighted rope                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                                           | 2 (to see her face after she answers the Second Question)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

### WHO THEY ARE

Orla Kest is small, square and grey, and when she comes into a room the room makes itself smaller to fit her. Her hair is cropped short under the white linen coif of the Paramount; her forearms are as thick as a laundress’s and as red; her hands are broad, short-nailed, perfectly clean, and steadier than any hands in the highlands. She smells of lye and lavender, and under it, when she has come from a room, of iron. Her voice is low and level and has never in her life been raised. People who have heard her speak to a screaming mother, a weeping father and a dying apprentice in the same quarter-hour say it was the same voice each time, and that this was the most frightening thing about her, and the most comforting.

She moves slowly and does not waste a motion. She sits very still in council and taps one finger, once, when she has decided. She eats little, mostly clay-bread and posset, and she sleeps in the Old Lying-In itself, in a cot in the birthing-room of the Meal, with its eight doors open around her. Apprentices whisper that she does not sleep at all, only rests with her eyes open, counting.

### THEIR STORY

Orla was born in 573 A.G. in the Kest house of the Paramount line, descended in the female line from Hollan Kest, who crushed the last god between her thumbnails. Her mother was an Attendant of the Round, her grandmother a Paramount. In 582, when Orla was nine, her mother went into labor with a second child, and the Opinion who attended was Orla’s aunt, Marrit Kest. There was no apprentice in the house. Marrit put the girl’s back against the door and told her to hold it, and Orla held it, and felt it push against her the way doors push, and heard her aunt ask the First Question aloud and then, after the count of three, the Second. She heard her mother not cry out. She felt the bundle, warm, as it was carried past her. The Tally entered a daughter of the house, struck through. Orla has never spoken of it. She has also never, in fifty-nine years, failed to walk past the Low Wall on the anniversary.

She took the apron at sixteen and gave her first Second Opinion at nineteen, in Rudge, during the great flood of 592. She was made an Opinion at twenty-five and a Senior of the Lying at thirty-seven. She was chosen Paramount in 619, at forty-six, by the vote of the



Seniors and by the custom that the Paramount is the midwife the others send for when they cannot do it themselves. In 627, at Cleave, she attended the birth of a born-grown captain who came out with a sword-hand already closed, and permitted him; in 629 she attended the birth of the old-born child now called Ambrose in a Kest weaver's house, and permitted him, and has visited him once a year since. In 635 she gave the first Foundlings their first spoons with her own hands. In 638 she sat the inquiry into the burning of the Rudge Part-house, and quietly closed it without naming the Barren Order, because she needed the Order's stone.

She has attended nine thousand births. She permitted six thousand. She remembers the other three thousand.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Midwife-Paramount answers to no one. She has no army but the Companies' goodwill, no money but the birth-fees, no law but the Book. And yet nothing moves in the highlands without her: the Veiled Council's prophecies are read to her before they are read to the Crown; the Chamberlain clears every question for the King Within with her office first; the Tally reports to her each dusk; the Border Marshals hold their law by her leave; the Trowel bricks nobody without an Attendant's word. She sits each morning in the Hall of the Lying to hear what cannot be decided elsewhere, and each afternoon she goes into a room somewhere in Kest, because she must, and because the Book says that a Paramount who stops attending births stops being able to judge them.

Her power has limits she feels every day. The mothers are hiding Parts. The Late-faction is whispering in the Aprons. The Assemblers' figure breathes four hours' walk from her bed and she has not been able to persuade the Crown to send the Companies against the Barn, because General Tibb will not march on a barn full of mothers. She depends on Lark Ninedays for the interval, on Madder Rudge for the rim, on Callum Stillwater for the stone, and on Sabeth Thorne, more than on anyone, for the knife.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Second Opinion** — her knife, a short hooked blade in a case of black leather worn on her hip. It was Marrit Kest's. She has never let an apprentice clean it.
- ◇ **The Paramount's keys** — a ring of nine iron keys to the doors of the Old Lying-In, none of which locks or has ever locked. She carries them as a reminder that her office is to hold things, not shut them.
- ◇ **A ledger of the three thousand** — a thick book in her own small hand, one line per struck-through birth: parish, date, the mother's eye-color, and the answer. She reads in it at night. The count at the end is always one fewer than the entries. (She has entered her sister. She has not counted her.)
- ◇ **A stitching kit** on a neck-cord, the same as every highlander's, with gut she spins herself.
- ◇ **Lavender** in a linen bag at her belt, for the rooms that need it.

- ◇ **A lead-weighted rope** — sixty fathoms of tarred rope with a lead weight at one end, bought from Rimwatch last Plenty and kept rolled under her cot. Nobody has asked her what it is for.
- ◇ **A sealed letter from Lark Ninedays** — the date on which, by Lark's arithmetic, the interval will reach one day. Orla has read it once.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Orla wants the knife to hold until the end, and she wants to be in the room when the end comes. She is not afraid of what she has done. She is afraid that the Late-faction is right: that she has spent fifty years answering small questions while the large one dilated under her feet, and that the knife was six centuries too late. She is afraid of Sabeth Thorne's eleven breaths, because Sabeth is the best of them, and if the best of them has stopped believing, the order is finished.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** Orla has asked herself the Second Question about the country, and answered it. When the interval reaches one day, she means to go down into the Dilation on Madder Rudge's rope, with her knife, to attend. She has told no one. She has quietly been setting her house in order: Sabeth is to succeed her.

**Secret (she does not know):** her sister was not struck through. Marrit Kest hesitated, in 582, for the first and only time, and the bundle Orla felt pass her was carried not to the Low Wall but to the Lying-In, where the thing was put into the lower wards and bricked in alive. It is there still, fifty-nine years old, in a cell no bricklayer stays beside for more than a season, and lately it has been knocking, in the interval, every ninth day. The Lying-In's own book records it. Orla has the right to read that book and has never looked at the entry for her own family, because she believed she knew what it said.

### TIES

- ◇ **Sabeth Thorne** — her best knife and chosen successor. Orla knows about the loft in Tarnbrow and is waiting, as her aunt never did, for Sabeth to choose for herself.
- ◇ **Brother Callum Stillwater** — an ally of necessity; they meet in the back rooms of the Round to talk about grey stone and do not talk about the Rudge fire.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — her enemy, and the only surgeon in the highlands whose hands she respects as much as her own. She has tried twice to have him bricked; the Crown would not sign.
- ◇ **Ambrose** — she permitted him and visits him each year on his birthday. He once told her the color of her mother's eyes, which she had forgotten.
- ◇ **General Tibb** — she gave him his first spoon. He calls her Mother Orla and will not march on the Barn for her.
- ◇ **Lark Ninedays** — the only person who tells her the truth every day, in numbers.
- ◇ **Madder Rudge** — her eyes on the rim. Orla has asked her how deep a rope can go. Madder has not asked why.

- ◇ **Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey** — Orla has attended her for forty-four years, every week, and is the only person alive who has felt the King Within from the inside.

#### IN PLAY

The characters meet Orla when one of them is carrying, whatever their sex, since she will attend; when they come close to Sabeth Thorne; or when they bring a Part, a born-grown stranger or a question about the Dilation to the Round. She wants three things from them: to know what Sabeth is hiding without having to ask her; to have word carried to the Lying-In's lower wards that she cannot carry herself; and, near the end, someone to hold the rope.

- ◇ **The Door Held Twice.** A bricklayer of the lower wards comes to the characters, frightened, with a story of a cell that knocks in the interval and a name scratched into the mortar from inside: *Kest*. He wants them to tell the Paramount, because he cannot.
- ◇ **A Birth in the Ditch.** The characters are with Orla on the road when she hears of a birth a mile off, in a Barren house, where nobody wanted a midwife. She goes. The Barren bar the way. She goes anyway.
- ◇ **The Rope.** At the end of a campaign, when the interval is a day, Orla asks the characters to come with her to the rim, and to hold the rope, and not to pull until she knocks.

**Threatened**, she does not raise her voice; she asks the First Question, and things born in Cradlewrack stop to listen. **Shown kindness**, she accepts it gravely and repays it exactly. **Faced with the god**, she asks it what it is. If nobody intervenes, Orla Kest goes down into the Dilation on the day the interval reaches one, and the rope goes slack, and the next Paramount is chosen in an empty Old Lying-In with its eight doors wide.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"She delivered me, she delivered my girl, and she took my boy. I'd send for her tomorrow. I hate that I would." — a Rudge clay-digger's wife

"She never raised her voice in council. Not once. When she said no to the Crown, it sounded like a recipe." — Lord Chamberlain Pell Danner

"I have watched Orla Kest give the Second Opinion. I have not slept since, which in my case is not unusual, but I mention it." — Dr. Lazar Voss

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# SABETH THORNE

## the Second Opinion

*“Three breaths. That’s all I take. That’s all anything should be asked to wait. I don’t know why I counted to eleven. I wish you’d stop asking.”*

– SABETH THORNE, TO WENNA THRALE, ON THE WALK HOME FROM RUDGE,  
CARVING 641

| SABETH THORNE – THE SECOND OPINION |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                      | 40 (born 601 A.G.); Opinion of the Attendance since 623 A.G.                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | Midwife · Standing 3 (Opinion)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                             | Blades 5, Stitching 4, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Stealth 2, Resolve 2, Rites 2                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                               | Flesh 14 · Guard 18 · Armor 1 (padded apron) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                            | knife +10 (2; her first strike in any fight gains a Helping); bone hook +8 (2, Hooking)                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                              | Three Count (after studying a target for one round, her next attack gains two Helpings). Knock (her palm on a door, wall or belly tells her what lives behind it; whatever is there knows she knocked).                                                                   |
| WANTS                              | Look Away (when a newborn thing looks back at her, Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 or she cannot act for a round). Leave It Open (when she would shut a door, box or wound behind her, Caul + Resolve vs Routine 10 or she does not; the loft door in Tarnbrow is always open). |
| KNACKS                             | Fast Hands, Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | The Unclean (after any room, she washes her hands until they crack and bleed; set off by touching a newborn)                                                                                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                            | the knife and the bone hook; the cord-thread and the basin; a pumice stone; a wooden horse; a year’s wages, spent; Wenna Thrale                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                              | 2 (to see her at the basin, still scrubbing)                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

### WHO THEY ARE

Sabeth Thorne is long-boned and quiet, a tall woman who stoops through doorways that do not need it. Her black hair is cropped close as a soldier’s; her face is narrow, sunburned from the roads, with deep lines at the corners of a mouth that does not often move. Her hands are the thing people notice: long-fingered, beautiful, and raw to the wrist, the knuckles split and scabbed from scrubbing, so that she wears linen wraps on them between rooms. She smells of lye and spirit and catgut. She speaks seldom and briefly, in a low flat voice from the Coppers, and she listens with her whole body, head tilted, as if every room were a belly she had her ear to.

She moves very fast when she moves. Apprentices who have held the door for her say they never saw her shoulder move; they only saw that it was done.

### THEIR STORY

Sabeth was born in 601 A.G. in the Coppers, the fifth child of a laundress, and grew up stirring aprons in the vats. She learned what

the Second Opinion was by what came out of the rinse. She asked to apprentice at fifteen, held the door for her first Second Opinion at sixteen, and did not quit, which made her unusual. She was made an Opinion at twenty-two, the youngest in a century, because the Seniors had noticed that she could look at a thing for the count of three and decide, and live with it, and go into the next room. For eighteen years she was the Opinion the other Opinions sent for. She has given the Second Opinion more than eleven hundred times.

Last winter, in Lack 640, she was sent for to a farmhouse in Tarnbrow, where a shepherd named Aled Dell had been in labor for two days. He did not live. What came out of him was the size of a newborn lamb and shaped like a child, with a seam across its throat and eyes that were very dark, and it looked at her, and she counted. One, two, three. It did not look away. She counted to eleven. Then she wrapped it in her own apron, paid Aled’s widow, Annis Dell, a year’s wages from her own savings to keep it in the loft and say nothing, and entered the Tally as “one, born to the father, died with

him.” She has walked to Tarnbrow eleven times since with the knife-case. She has come home eleven times with the case unopened.

In Carving 641, at Rudge, with her apprentice Wenna Thrale holding the door, she counted eleven breaths again over a thing born to a man named Corran, and then answered, and used the knife. She has counted eleven ever since. Wenna has noticed.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Sabeth is the knife of last resort. Parish Attendants who cannot answer the Second Question send to the Round for an Opinion, and when the Opinion cannot, the Round sends Sabeth. She rides the whole country on a hill-goat with her case and her apprentice, sleeping in pang-houses, attending births in farmhouses, ditches, lambing-sheds and once in a well. She is paid an Opinion’s share of the fee, which she gives almost entirely to the Coppers. She has no house of her own; she has a cot in the Aprons and a shelf in the Lying-In. Orla Kest has chosen her as successor and has not yet told her. The Late-faction, which has noticed her eleven breaths, has begun very carefully to court her.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The knife** — an Opinion’s hooked blade, plain, the handle wrapped in fresh linen every morning. She has never named it.
- ◇ **The bone hook** — for births that will not come, carved from the shin of a ewe. It has a Hooking quality and she uses it in fights as she uses it in rooms.
- ◇ **The cord-thread, the basin, the linen** — laid out in the same order every time, the order the Book gives.
- ◇ **A pumice stone** worn to a sliver, for her hands.
- ◇ **A wooden horse** — a toy, carved by Annis Dell’s dead husband for the second child they never had. Sabeth took it from the farmhouse on her third visit, meaning to give it to the thing in the loft, and has carried it in her apron pocket ever since without giving it.
- ◇ **The empty purse** — a year’s wages, spent. She is poor now, and nobody at the Round knows why.
- ◇ **Wenna Thrale** — not a possession, but Sabeth carries her apprentice the way she carries the knife, as a responsibility she cannot put down.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Sabeth wants someone else to make her choose. She knows exactly what the Book says and exactly what she must do, and she has walked to Tarnbrow eleven times to do it. She fears the thing in the loft; she fears more that she loves it; and she fears most of all that she will reach the farmhouse one day and find she is too late, because it has learned to walk to her.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** the thing in the loft is now the size of a child of six after only ten months. It has Sabeth’s eyes, though it cannot have. It calls her Mother. It asks to be taken to see the Sill. It has begun to open doors by looking at them, and Annis

Dell has stopped bricking herself in because there is no point. Its naming-year ends at Tablenight, two months from now, and it has asked Sabeth what its name will be.

**Secret (she does not know):** Orla Kest has known about the loft since the first week. A Tarnbrow knocker told the parish Attendant, and the Attendant told the Round. Orla has done nothing, because she once held a door and has spent fifty-nine years wishing someone had let her choose.

### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — her mistress and the woman she most fears disappointing. Sabeth does not know she is to succeed her.
- ◇ **Wenna Thrale** — her apprentice, who wrote down the eleven breaths. Sabeth is teaching her everything and dreads the day Wenna is as good as she is.
- ◇ **Annis Dell** — the widow in Tarnbrow; bound to Sabeth by money and fear.
- ◇ **Hester Lowe** — Sabeth has never met her, but she would know the callus on that hand at a glance; it is the callus of a knife-grip, like her own.
- ◇ **Dolour Pym** — the wet-nurse behind the Lying-In wall, the only person Sabeth has thought of asking for help.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — he has heard rumors of a spared thing in Tarnbrow and wants it for the figure. Sabeth would kill him without counting.

### IN PLAY

The characters meet Sabeth in the room: she is attending a birth they are present at, or she rides into a village they are passing through with her case. She wants them, though she will not say it, to decide for her. She may hire them as guards on the Tarnbrow road. She may ask one of them to hold a door.

- ◇ **Eleven Breaths.** The Senior of the Lying hires the characters to learn why Sabeth goes to Tarnbrow every week. What they find in the loft calls Sabeth “Mother” and wants to see the Sill.
- ◇ **The Name.** Ruth Ninefold, the name-broker of Kest, has bought the naming-right to “one, born to the father” in Tarnbrow from Annis Dell for eight lacks. Its year is up at Tablenight. Somebody is going to name it, and naming it makes it stay.
- ◇ **The Second Opinion, Given Wrongly.** A father in Cleave accuses Sabeth of killing a healthy child out of grief for something else. He is right about the grief.

**Threatened**, she studies for three counts and strikes once. **Shown kindness**, she cannot bear it and leaves the room. **Faced with the god**, she looks away, and hates herself. If nobody intervenes, she walks to Tarnbrow on Tablenight with the case, and the thing in the loft meets her at the door, which is open, and takes her hand, and they walk north together toward the Sill.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She’s the one you want when it’s bad. You don’t want her in the house when it isn’t.” — a Tarnbrow shepherd

“She taught me to hold the door. She never told me what to do when it’s her on the other side of it.” — Wenna Thrale

“My best knife has begun to count. I am told it is a weakness. I have begun to think it is the only thing in this order worth keeping.” — Orla Kest, in a letter never sent

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# AMBROSE

## the Eldest Infant

*“It was warm in the pot, you know. People always imagine it was dreadful. It was the warmest I have ever been. The ladle came down through the steam like the sun.”*

– AMBROSE, TO THE MORWEN NURSERY, ON BEING ASKED WHAT THE MEAL WAS LIKE

| AMBROSE – THE ELDEST INFANT |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | Cradlewrack · Cut 4 (no house; born of the god’s eye, he says) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION               | born 629 A.G., twelve years ago, with the body of a man of eighty; now in the body of a man of sixty; tutor to the Caul-line nurseries                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING          | none (treated as Scion, Standing 2, by courtesy of the Veiled Houses)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                      | Lore 5, Godsign 4, Instinct 4, Persuade 3, Rites 3, Resolve 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| BODY                        | Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                     | none worth the name; a walking-stick +1 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| GIFTS                       | The God’s Eye (once per session, answers one question about the Meal or the Dilation truthfully, if horribly). Younger (wounds dealt to him heal by morning, and he loses a year). Crowning (the round opening under his cravat may, once per scene, give one answer about what is beginning; Dread 3 to any who see it; +2 Hunger). |
| WANTS                       | Return. When he passes a cradle, he must sit beside it (Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 to walk on), and he sits for hours.                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                      | Elder’s Ear, Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                | none; he says he has seen the worst already, from the inside                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                     | a silk cravat; a cradle-shaped reliquary; a child’s letter-book; spectacles he no longer needs; a ledger of what he remembers                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                       | 3 (to hear him describe being eaten)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

### WHO THEY ARE

Ambrose looks like a scholar of sixty: tall, straight-backed now, with an iron-grey beard trimmed to a point and a long courteous face. Twelve years ago the beard was white to his chest and his back was bent; every year since, he has stood a little straighter and his voice has lost a little more of its quaver. His eyes are pale blue and very clear, and the left one is noticeably larger than the right. He smells of camphor, which he uses against moths in his books, and of warm milk, which he cannot account for. He speaks in a precise, amused, old-fashioned Table-speech, with words nobody has used in two centuries, and he is unfailingly kind to children, who adore him.

He wears a high silk cravat at all times and is never seen without it.

### THEIR STORY

Ambrose was born in 629 A.G. in a weaver’s house on Tally Hill, to a young woman named Tilda Warp, in a labor Orla Kest herself attended. He came out with a white beard to his chest, arthritic

hands, worn yellow teeth and a full vocabulary, and his first words, before the Paramount had asked anything, were “Ah. It’s you. You have your grandmother’s hands.” The Book says old-born children stay. Orla permitted him. His mother, who was seventeen, could not bear to nurse a man of eighty, and he was taken in by the Morwen nursery as a curiosity, and became, within a year, its tutor.

He claims to remember being Vey’s left eye. He describes the Meal from inside the copper: the heat, the clay-salt stinging, the ladle, the caul lifting off above him “like a sky going up,” the faces of the first highlanders leaning over with their bowls. He names them. The Cutwrights have checked several of the names against the oldest Kest genealogies and found them right. He is getting younger. At twelve, he has the body of a man of sixty. He says that when he reaches the cradle, it will be time.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Ambrose teaches letters, history and manners to the children of the Caul-line houses, in the Veiled Galleries of Morwen Hall and in the Aubrey Gardens, for which he is paid in board and books. He also



receives visitors, by appointment, in a small round room on Tally Hill: scholars, priests of the three doctrines, Assembler agents, Second Table nobles in silk masks, and the Attendance, who all want to know what the god saw. He answers, courteously, once per visit. The Veiled Council consults him on prophecy and does not like what he says. He is, in a quiet way, the most valuable witness in the country, and he is guarded by nobody.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A silk cravat** — high, wound three times. Beneath it, at the base of his throat, is his crowning: a round opening with soft lips the size of a coin, through which, at the height of a pang, something presses up toward the light. It is an eye. It is never the same eye twice.
- ◇ **A cradle-shaped reliquary** — a small box of carved pear-wood holding his own birth-caul, dried, which he has kept against the Second Meal; he says he will need it.
- ◇ **A child's letter-book** — the one he teaches from, its pages soft with handling. In the margin, in his own hand, he has begun copying out simple words as if learning them.
- ◇ **Spectacles** — he needed them at birth. He no longer does. He wears them from habit.
- ◇ **The Ledger of the Pot** — a calfskin book in which he writes down everything he remembers of the Meal, each night, because he has noticed that he is forgetting it, the way old men forget their youth, from the far end first.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Ambrose wants to say what he was born to say. He has known since his first breath that there is a sentence he must speak when the time comes, and he is afraid, very simply and without any of his usual humor, that he will forget it before then. He fears cradles, and sits beside them for hours.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** he is not growing younger toward birth. He is being drawn back toward the Dilation, and he will be there, the size of a newborn, when it opens. Every year he loses, he walks a mile closer in his sleep; the Morwen servants have found him twice at dawn on the Cleave road, barefoot, facing the rim.

**Secret (he does not know):** the sentence he was born to say is the other half of Juniper Dell's. Her half begins *When it opens, tell them that the...* His half is the end of it. He has already forgotten the first word.

He also remembers a thing he does not write down: that when the caul lifted off above him in the pot, he saw the table where the first highlanders sat, and that there were more bowls than people, and that one chair at the copper was pulled out, and nobody was in it.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — she attended his birth and permitted him; she visits each year. He knows things about her family she does not.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — he has never met her. He has dreamt of a girl drawing doors. The meeting would matter more than either knows.
- ◇ **Duchess Iphigene Morwen** — his patron. She asks him what the red in her veil means. He tells her, gently, that he does not see in red, only in the color of the inside of a pot.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — wants Ambrose's left eye for the figure, and has asked politely. Ambrose declined, politely.
- ◇ **Madder Rudge** — he visits the rim twice a year and lies beside her with his ear to the clay. They both hear two pulses. He says the second one is his.
- ◇ **Dr. Lazar Voss** — they correspond. Voss has drawn him, sleeping, and the drawing shows his crowning open.

#### IN PLAY

The characters meet Ambrose when they need to know something about the Meal, the Dilation or the god, and somebody sends them to the round room on Tally Hill. He will answer one question, truthfully. He wants, in return, to be read to from his own ledger, so that he will remember.

- ◇ **The Sleepwalker.** The Morwen household hires the characters to find their tutor, who has walked out barefoot in the night. They find him two miles from the rim, on his knees, listening.
- ◇ **The Other Half.** A note arrives in the characters' hands from Juniper Dell, a drawing of a door with an old man standing in it. Ambrose, shown it, weeps, and asks to be taken to Tarnbrow at once.
- ◇ **The Eye Market.** A Second Table buyer offers the characters a fortune to bring them Ambrose's left eye, alive in its socket or out of it.

**Threatened**, he is helpless and unafraid. **Shown kindness**, he gives an answer for free. **Faced with the god**, he weeps with recognition. If nobody intervenes, he grows younger until he is a child, and then an infant, and some night when the interval is very short, his cot in the Morwen nursery is empty and the door is open, and at the rim of the Dilation the watch finds a small bundle of silk, with a cravat in it.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He told me my grandmother's name and the color of her apron at the Meal. I've never said her name to anyone." — a Kest potter

"He's the best tutor we've ever had. He's also the only one who ever asked the children to tuck *bim* in." — a Morwen nurse

"I asked him what the god saw. He said, 'Everyone, very close, with spoons.'" — a Purgation agent



# HESTER LOWE

## the Woman Who Bore a Hand

*“You’ve come about the hand. Everyone comes about the hand. Sit down, have some posset, and then you can tell me why I shouldn’t put this spade through you.”*

— HESTER LOWE, TO TWO ASSEMBLER GATHERERS, PLENTY 640

| HESTER LOWE – THE WOMAN WHO BORE A HAND |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                           | 34 (born 607 A.G.); clay-digger’s widow of Rudge                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | none (clay-digger)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                  | Labor 4, Blades 3, Endure 3, Stitching 2, Instinct 2, Intimidate 2, Haggle 1                                                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                                 | clay-spade +6 (4, Two-Handed; it is sharpened along both edges)                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                                   | Bear (once, three years ago, she delivered a Part that serves her: the hand, which Filches at Threat 3 and holds her finger at night; its loyalty lasts until it meets another Part). Knock (she knows by laying a palm on a wall what is behind it). |
| WANTS                                   | Gather (when she sees a Part, a severed piece or an open wound, Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 or she must take it and keep it close). Leave It Open (Routine 10; she sleeps with the crock uncovered).                                                    |
| KNACKS                                  | Strong Back, Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                                 | the bread-crock; the hand; the clay-spade; her husband’s ring; a jug of warm milk; flour                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                                   | 0 (Dread 2 when the hand moves)                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

### WHO THEY ARE

Hester Lowe is broad and sunburned, with heavy shoulders from the pits, a cleft chin, freckled forearms stained red to the elbow, and a laugh like a crow’s, sudden and harsh and genuinely amused. She talks while she works, to anybody, to nobody, to the hand. She smells of wet clay, peat-smoke and warm milk. She is quick to anger and quicker to laugh it off, and she has a Rudge digger’s contempt for anyone who has never had clay under their nails, which includes most of Kest. Her house is one of the egg-shaped red houses halfway down the ravine, tidy, warm, with a hide curtain for a door and a hearthstone that has been lifted so often the mortar has given up.

### THEIR STORY

Hester was born in Rudge in 607 and dug clay from the age of nine. She married Wat Lowe, a digger, at nineteen; they had no children that stayed. Wat died in 637 when a pit wall slid during a pang and buried him with three others. She dug him out herself, with this spade. In Grace 638 she went into labor alone, at night, with no idea she had been carrying, and bore a hand: only a hand, left, healthy, warm, the size of a grown woman’s, with a callus on the inner side

of its ring finger nobody could explain. She did not call the Attendance. She wrapped it in Wat’s shirt and put it in the bread-crock, and in the morning it was holding the edge of the shirt the way a baby holds a finger.

Three years on, she feeds it warm milk through the skin of its palm, which drinks, and talks to it while she works. It strains, always, toward the east, toward Kest and the Barn, and she wakes to find it at the lip of the crock with its fingers hooked over the edge. Twice it has written in spilt flour, in a clean careful hand, a word she cannot read.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

To the parish, Hester is a widow who digs, pays her birth-fees on time and has a temper. The whole of Rudge knows about the hand, and nobody has told. Abel Furrow the Younger, the parish Attendant, knows and has not reported it, because his great-grandfather discovered that Parts fit and he has never forgiven the Attendance for what it did with the knowledge. The Assemblers know, through the Rudge gatherers, and have sent people three

times. She has met each of them at the door with the spade, and two of them are in the old pit behind her house.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The bread-crock** — a big glazed crock lined with Wat's shirts, kept under the hearthstone. She knocks on it before lifting the lid.
- ◇ **The hand** — left, warm, strong. It holds her finger at night. It has opened every knot in the house. It writes.
- ◇ **The clay-spade** — Wat's, iron-shod, sharpened along both edges since the first gatherers came.
- ◇ **Wat's ring** — a plain brass band she wears on a cord. She has tried it on the hand. It fits the callus exactly, which frightens her more than anything.
- ◇ **A jug of warm milk** — always on the hearth.
- ◇ **A pouch of flour** — she scatters it on the table at night now, to see what the hand will write.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Hester wants to keep it. That is all. She fears the morning she lifts the lid and the crock is empty. She fears the Barn, and Dov Marrin's humming, which she has heard of: they say any Part within a mile crawls to him, and she has made Rudge promise to warn her if he is ever on the ravine road.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** the word the hand writes in flour is *NOT YET*, the First Word, which the first speaking child said in Kest in 94 A.G.

**Secret (she does not know):** the callus is not a ring callus. It is the callus an Attendance Opinion gets on the inside of the ring finger, where the hook of the knife rests. Sabeth Thorne has one. So does Orla Kest. The hand the Assemblers mean to put on the god is a midwife's hand, and it knows how to hold a knife.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — he wants the hand more than anything in the world. She has never seen him. She would kill him gladly.
- ◇ **Abel Furrow the Younger** — the parish Attendant who looks the other way. She does not trust him; she brings him posset anyway.
- ◇ **Madder Rudge** — a cousin by marriage, who tells her the rim's news. Madder has told her the hand is pointing at the wrong place: it points at the Barn, but the Barn is between Rudge and the Sill.
- ◇ **Lazar Voss** — he came once, politely, and asked to draw the hand. She let him. He drew a knife in it.
- ◇ **Sabeth Thorne** — they have never met. Sabeth would know the callus.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — the Assemblers believe the voice and the hand belong to the same body. Hester has never heard of her.

#### IN PLAY

The characters meet Hester when someone hires them to take the hand from her: Dov Marrin, the Lying-In, a Second Table buyer. Or they meet her because they need a bed in Rudge, and she has a spare one, and in the night something opens the knots of their packs.

- ◇ **The Missing Hand.** Dov Marrin hires the characters to recover a "stolen" Part from a widow in Rudge. Hester will fight. The hand will hold whichever of them it likes best.
- ◇ **The Humming.** Dov is coming up the ravine road. Hester has a day. She asks the characters to take the hand west, more than a mile from him, and keep it there.
- ◇ **Flour.** The hand writes a second word. Hester brings it to the characters to read.

**Threatened,** Hester laughs and swings the spade. **Shown kindness,** she feeds you until you are sick. **Faced with the god,** she holds the crock against her chest and does not let go. If nobody intervenes, one pang-night the hand climbs out of the crock, walks on its fingertips out of the hide door and up the ravine toward the east, and Hester follows it, with the spade, all the way to the Barn.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Leave her be. She's had enough taken off her." — a Rudge clay-digger

"She is the mother of the god's left hand. I would kneel to her, if she would stop trying to kill me." — Dov Marrin

"She brought me posset and told me if I reported her she'd bury me in the pit with the gatherers. Then she asked after my wife." — Abel Furrow the Younger

# DOV MARRIN

## Assembler-Prime

*“This is Agatha Pruett’s ear. This is the elbow of Nan Corse’s second boy. This is the jaw a widow in Cleave bore at seventy and kissed goodbye. Every one of them was someone’s. Now they’re Hers.”*

– DOV MARRIN, SHOWING A VISITOR THE NEAR END OF THE BARN

| DOV MARRIN – ASSEMBLER-PRIME |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Cradlewrack · Cut 3 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                | 55 (born 586 A.G.); Assembler-Prime since 627 A.G.; keeper of the far end of the Barn                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Seamer · Standing 5 (Assembler-Prime)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                       | Stitching 5, Godsign 3, Craft 3, Lore 3, Persuade 3, Blades 2, Endure 2, Rites 2                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                         | Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                      | surgeon’s cleaver +6 (3); Assembler’s bone-saw +6 (3, Ripping, Brutal)                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                        | The Seam (any two Parts or wounds he stitches together join by morning). Call of Pieces (Parts within a mile crawl toward him while he hums; each Part resists with Caul 1, so few do). Undoing (by touch and a Partake he opens any lock, knot or stitched wound without a roll). |
| WANTS                        | Gather (Grim 18; he cannot leave a Part where he finds it). Begin (Hard 14; offered a plan, he starts it before the speaker has finished).                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                       | Mother’s Hands, Steady Hands, Hostage’s Smile                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | The Devotion (to Herself; set off by her presence or her absence)                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                      | surgeon’s case; spectacles; a reel of fine gut; a ledger of four hundred mothers; a hummed tune; Bryony’s wedding cap                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                        | 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Dov Marrin is mild, balding and bespectacled, a soft-bellied man of middle height with very clean nails and a gentle tenor voice for frightened mothers. He smells of tallow and catgut, and under it, faintly, of a sheepfold in spring. He wears a shepherd’s smock over a surgeon’s apron. He blinks often behind his spectacles. He hums under his breath, always the same five notes, and Parts in jars turn toward him when he does. He is devout, patient, entirely certain, and he speaks of the figure only as Herself and of each Part by the name of the mother who bore it.

### THEIR STORY

Dov was a shepherd’s son of Threshing who learned surgery on ewes and then on shepherds. In 608, at twenty-two, he read Abel Furrow’s testimony in a pirated copy and walked to the Barn, then a sheepfold where the old founder Seth Harrow kept forty Parts in straw. He became a Seamster in a year, a Fitter in ten, and Assembler-Prime in 627, when Harrow died and asked to be buried

in the figure’s straw. Under Dov the figure has grown from a torso and two arms to eleven feet of breathing, seamed, stitched body with nine arms, more eyes than anyone has agreed on, and a head that has lately turned toward the Sill. His wife Bryony, now sixty-three, bore a heart as a Part in her sixtieth year, in 638, and asked him to give it to Herself. He did, with his own hands.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Dov runs the Barn, the Part-hunters, the gatherers of every district, and the black trade that buys Parts from mothers who will not surrender them to the Lying-In. He is the most wanted man in the country and has never been arrested, because too many mothers love him and the Crown will not sign a warrant General Tibb will not serve. The Second Table pays for the roof and the lamps and the straw. He takes their money with a clear conscience; he thinks they want to see the god born. He gives visitors the tour of the near end personally, by appointment, and is a charming host.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The surgeon's case** — fine knives, curved needles, the bone-saw, sheep-gut and silk.
- ◇ **The ledger of mothers** — four hundred and eleven names, each beside the Part she bore and where it sits on Herself.
- ◇ **A reel of the finest gut** — spun, he says, from Herself's own shed membrane.
- ◇ **Spectacles** — repaired with wire. He cannot see Herself's face clearly without them and will not admit he cannot see it clearly with them.
- ◇ **The five notes** — a hummed tune, which is the Call of Pieces. He does not know where he learned it.
- ◇ **Bryony's wedding cap** — linen, in his breast pocket.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the left hand and the voice, and the god's easy birth, in a barn, among friends. He fears that Herself's head has turned toward the Sill without him: that she has wants he did not stitch into her.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** Bryony lives, after a fashion, in the Barn's middle hall. Since her heart went into Herself, her own heart beats in time with it; she cannot go more than a few hundred paces from the figure, and she no longer speaks in her own voice but in a low hum of five notes.

**Secret (he does not know):** Lazar Voss's drawings show two places in Herself's chest where a heart could go. Bryony's heart is in the second. The first is empty, and it is the size of a man's.

## TIES

- ◇ **Hester Lowe** — the mother of the left hand. He honors her and will take it from her.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — his enemy; he admires her hands and thinks her a murderer.
- ◇ **Brother Callum Stillwater** — the Barren want Herself burned. Dov prays for Callum by name.
- ◇ **Lazar Voss** — his correspondent and, he does not realize, the Second Table's informer.
- ◇ **Ambrose** — Dov wants his left eye and asked politely.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — his gatherers watch her day and night for the voice.

## IN PLAY

Dov meets the characters as a client, a host or an obstacle. He hires them to recover Parts; he shows them the near end; he asks them,

with great tenderness, whether any of them has borne anything lately.

- ◇ **The Missing Hand.** He hires them to fetch the hand from Rudge.
- ◇ **The Middle Hall.** A Barn brother, frightened, smuggles the characters in to see what humming is coming from the middle hall.
- ◇ **The Second Place.** Voss sells the characters a drawing. Dov, shown it, goes very quiet and then asks how big a man the characters think he is.

**Threatened**, he hums, and the Barn's Parts come. **Shown kindness**, he is grateful and tries to recruit you. **Faced with the god**, he kneels. If nobody intervenes, he gets the hand, and then the voice, and on the night Herself sits up, he climbs into the first empty place in her chest himself.

## SAID OF THEM

"He held my boy's foot like it was the god's own. I've not been so gentled since my mother." — a mother of Cleave

"An excellent surgeon. A credulous theologian. He has drawn his god wrong." — Dr. Lazar Voss

"He hums when he works. My Parts went off in the night and I knew he'd passed the end of our lane." — a Rudge clay-digger

# BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER

Abbot of Nullhouse

*“Don’t. That’s all I have ever come to say. Don’t begin it. Whatever it is, it is kinder never to start.”*

– BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER, PREACHING AT THE RIM, PLENTY 641

| CALLUM STILLWATER – ABBOT OF NULLHOUSE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                          | 50 (born 591 A.G.); cut at 20; Abbot of the Barren Order since 630 A.G.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Celebrant · Standing 5 (Abbot of Nullhouse)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                 | Rites 5, Persuade 5, Resolve 5, Lore 3, Endure 2, Blades 1, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                | grey ash staff +3 (3, Stunning)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                  | The Reading (once per scene, reading the struck-through names aloud, every listener removes 2 Fray, and every Part within earshot falls still for the scene). Rehearsal (he may enter false labor by will: ignore Ruin for the scene, +2 Endure; then 2 Hunger and an hour helpless). Knock (with his palm on a wall or a belly, he knows what is behind it; it knows he knocked). |
| WANTS                                  | Leave It Open (Hard 14; on every pang-night his resewing must be done, and every pang-night he must roll or let the stitches lie).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                                 | No Thank You, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | The Voice at Table (his sister’s voice, through the scar; set off whenever he Partakes)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                                | grey robe; the Book of Names; a suture kit; a lump of Fast grey stone; his sister’s comb                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                                  | 1 (Dread 3 when the scar speaks)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Callum Stillwater is gaunt and gentle, grey-robed, with a shaved head, a long patient face and a soft tenor voice that carries across the Dilation without seeming to be raised. He walks carefully, like a man carrying something full to the brim, because his sutures are renewed every nine days and pull when he hurries. He smells of plain soap and old blood. He is kind to everyone he meets, and means it.

## THEIR STORY

Callum was born at Kilnmouth in 591. In the winter of 610–611 his elder sister Ailsa delivered three things in one season: a pair of lips, a coil of something like hair, and a stone with a pulse. He held her hand for all three. In Grace 611, at twenty, he walked to Nullhouse and was cut. Ailsa went to the Lying-In in 612 and died there in the Course. He rose by gentleness rather than zeal, and was chosen Abbot in 630. Since the Shortening the Order’s numbers have tripled. He stands on the rim at each pang and reads the names given to the struck-through. In 638 a Purgation cell inside his Order

burned the Rudge Part-house with a mother inside. He did not order it. He had given them the stone-carts they used.

This month, at the pang, his long-closed scar opened and something on the other side said his name in Ailsa’s voice.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Abbot commands Nullhouse, the chapter-houses, the stone-carters, and a following on the rim that grows with every pang. He is the Knife-faction’s quiet ally, bringing grey stone to fill the Dilation, cartload by cartload, from the Fast border. The Purgation sends him money he does not ask about.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The Book of Names** — every name a midwife or mother has secretly given to a struck-through birth, collected from the Low Wall and the Aprons; nine thousand names.
- ♦ **A suture kit** — he resews himself; he no longer lets the Order’s surgeons see the scar.
- ♦ **A lump of grey stone** — from the Fast border, smooth from his hands.

- ◇ **Ailsa's comb** — bone, three teeth missing.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants nothing to begin. He fears the scar, and that he wants to answer it.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** he has let his stitches lie, twice now, on pang-nights, to hear the voice.

**Secret (he does not know):** the lips Ailsa bore were surrendered to the Lying-In, stolen by a gatherer in 624, and sewn into Herself's face. When Callum preaches at the rim, the Barn brothers have noticed, Herself's lips move with his.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — an ally in stone; he loves her as one loves a hard winter.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — his opposite. Callum would burn Herself and grieve for Dov afterwards.
- ◇ **Madder Rudge** — chases him from the edge with her pipe. He brings her soap.
- ◇ **Ambrose** — the one person whose beginning Callum cannot regret.
- ◇ **Agnes Latch** — he commissioned a door for Nullhouse's chapter-room. It held eleven days.

#### IN PLAY

The characters meet Callum on the rim, on the road with a stone-cart, or at Nullhouse asking for shelter.

- ◇ **The Rudge Fire.** A widow wants the characters to prove the Barren burned her daughter. The trail leads to the stone-carts, and to Callum's signature.
- ◇ **The Stitches.** A Barren brother begs the characters to watch the Abbot on pang-night and re sew him if he will not.
- ◇ **Her Mouth.** The characters, inside the Barn, see Herself's lips shaping the struck-through names in time with the rim.

**Threatened,** he does not resist. **Shown kindness,** he tells you not to begin anything with him. **Faced with the god,** he reads the names.

If nobody intervenes, one pang-night he does not re sew, and in the morning the Order finds his cell empty, his robe neatly folded, and the scar's stitches cut from the inside.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He read my girl's name at the rim. I never told anyone I'd named her. I never told anyone." — a Rudge mother

"He's the gentlest man I ever met and he wants every child in this country not to be born." — General Tibb

"He brings me soap. I think it's meant as a sermon." — Madder Rudge

# GENERAL TIBB

Commander of the Foundling Companies

*“Lettered Ninety, you were born on a Tuesday in a turnip-cellar and you can’t tie a bowline. Neither could I, once. On your feet. We’ll learn it together.”*

— GENERAL TIBB, TO A WEEPING RECRUIT IN THE CRÈCHE

| GENERAL TIBB – COMMANDER OF THE FOUNDLING COMPANIES |                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                          | Cradlerack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                                       | 6 (born Grace 635 A.G., at a grown thirty); General since 637 A.G.                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                                  | Warden · Standing 5 (General)                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                                          | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                              | Blades 4, Reckoning 4, Endure 3, Intimidate 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 3, Persuade 2                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                                | Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 (bone lamellar) · Fray 4                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                             | sword +8 (4, Parrying); his Company (use Foundling Soldiers, Threat 2, by the hundred)                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                               | Born Ready (always acts first in the first round of a fight). First Breath (once per session, reroll the first roll of a fight, a march or a parley; something shut nearby opens). |
| WANTS                                               | Belong (Hard 14; he cannot refuse a born-grown stranger who asks to join). Begin (Hard 14; offered a plan of battle, he has started it before the speaker finishes).               |
| KNACKS                                              | Fast Hands, Counting Habit, Second Chair                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                                        | none yet                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                                             | sword; bone lamellar; a cake-tin; a list of the gone-home; a drill-mother’s spoon                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                                               | 1                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Tall, red-bearded, broad as a door, scarred on face and arms from wounds nobody gave him. His voice fills a drill-yard; his laugh fills the rest. He smells of leather, porridge and horse. He speaks plainly, learns everything at once, and still delights in things the born know too well to notice: snow, plums, the sound of a flute.

## THEIR STORY

He was born in Grace 635 in a Cleave lambing-shed, mid-stride, already reaching for a sword that was not there. Orla Kest gave him his first spoon. He learned to speak in his own voice in a week and to read in a month, and the Crown, raising the first Companies that summer, made him a Lettered and then a captain within the year. In 637 the first General, a born-grown called Ninety, went home to the cradle in a night, and Tibb was chosen. Three of his best captains have since gone home, each at the age of seven. He turns seven on the fourteenth of Grace, 642.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He commands six Companies, some two thousand four hundred soldiers, the only army in the highlands, paid by the Crown and loved by nobody but each other. He will guard the border, break a Part-hunting gang or hold a road; he will not march on the Barn, because it is full of mothers, and he has never had one.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A sword** — an officer’s blade, the first he ever held. His hand had already closed around one at birth.
- ♦ **A cake-tin** — for the Birthday Roll; he bakes them himself, badly.
- ♦ **The list of the gone-home** — every soldier who reverted, with the date. He reads it on his birthday.
- ♦ **A drill-mother’s horn spoon** — the one Orla gave him.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants a birthday that is truly his, and somewhere for his soldiers after the war that never comes. He fears the fourteenth of Grace.



**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** his wounds were given. Every scar on him matches a wound taken by Captain Haskett Varr of the Rim Road Company guard, killed by persons unknown at Breech's Gate on the day Tibb was born.

**Secret (he does not know):** Marshal Gideon Breech carried Varr's body in, and recognized the scars the first time he saw Tibb, and has never said.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — “Mother Orla.” He will do anything for her but march on the Barn.
- ◇ **Marshal Gideon Breech** — his oldest friend, who once taught drill at the Crèche; keeper of the secret.
- ◇ **Brother Callum Stillwater** — he respects the Abbot's gentleness and cannot forgive his creed.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — the Assemblers have offered gold for Companies; Tibb sent the gold back with a cake.
- ◇ **Lark Ninedays** — he times his drills to her bell.
- ◇ **Petra Quick** — she has seen his face before. She will not say where.

#### IN PLAY

The characters meet Tibb on the roads, at the Crèche, or when a born-grown companion of theirs is offered a place in the Companies.

- ◇ **The Fourteenth of Grace.** He asks the characters to sit up with him on the night he turns seven, armed, and to do what must be done if he goes home.
- ◇ **Varr's Widow.** A Company widow arrives at the Gate looking for her husband's killer, and stops dead at the sight of the General's face.
- ◇ **The Barn Order.** The Crown at last signs the warrant. Tibb asks the characters to go in first, alone, and tell him what is there.

**Threatened**, he strikes first. **Shown kindness**, he adopts you. **Faced with the god**, he forms a square. If nobody intervenes, on the

fourteenth of Grace the Crèche finds a tall cot pushed into the Cradle-House, and a sword laid across it, and a bearded infant asleep who will not grow again.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He taught me my letters, and to march, and to cry at the right time. Nobody else ever bothered.” — a Foundling sergeant

“The finest tactician on the Table, and he is six. I find this personally insulting.” — an Oathen envoy

“He bakes. Lack keep away, he bakes.” — a drill-mother of the Crèche

# LARK NINEDAYS

the Counter

“Seventeen bells past the hour, and the water says nine days, less a quarter-bell. Less.  
Write less.”

— LARK NINEDAYS, DICTATING TO THE TALLY

| LARK NINEDAYS – THE COUNTER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION               | 52 (born 589 A.G.); Counter of the Tally-house since 615 A.G.                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING          | none (servant of the Tally)                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                      | Reckoning 5, Craft 3, Instinct 3, Resolve 3, Lore 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                        | Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                     | knife +2 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                       | The Interval (she knows, to the minute, when the next pang will come; anyone traveling on her word gains +2 on Wayfaring rolls against pangs). Rehearsal (she enters false labor at will; she uses it to feel the pang coming). |
| WANTS                       | Count (Hard 14; at the first tremor she must count aloud to sixty, whatever else is happening).                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                      | Counting Habit, Light Sleeper                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| DERANGEMENTS                | The Count (the interval she computes is always one count shorter than the clock)                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                     | water clock; bell-rope; the Book of Intervals; a red tattoo of five notches; her mother’s stamped brick-dust                                                                                                                    |
| DREAD                       | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Wiry, chapped-lipped, grey-braided, with a ring of five red notches tattooed around her left wrist, one for each name she has worn. She smells of lamp-oil and wet stone. She speaks in figures and clipped phrases. She sleeps beside the clock on a pallet, a hand on its bowl.

## THEIR STORY

She was named Lark Thirtydays in 589, when the pangs came every thirty days. She took the Counter’s room atop the Tally-house in 615. She has renamed herself at each shortening: Twentydays in 611, Fourteendays in 627, Elevendays in 636, Ninedays in 639. Her friends no longer know what to call her. She has sworn on her mother’s brick, *by the shut door*, that she will not take the name after Lark Oneday.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Her bell is the loudest in Kest and the interval she gives is law: the Companies drill to it, the Shambles kills to it, the Trowel bricks to it. She reports to Orla Kest each dusk in person.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The water clock** — brass, forty years old, recalibrated after every pang.
- ◇ **The Book of Intervals** — every pang since 615, to the minute.
- ◇ **The sealed arithmetic** — a copy of the letter she gave Orla: the date the interval reaches one day.
- ◇ **A twist of red brick-dust** — scraped from her mother’s niche.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be wrong. She fears the name Lark Oneday, and the oath she swore about what comes after it; the Attendance’s chaplains have noticed the oath and watch her gently.

**Secret (for the GM to reveal):** the interval is not shortening evenly. It is shortening faster each time, and her date is within three years.

**Secret (she does not know):** the King Within kicks the interval to the Queen Dowager at night, three, then one, then three, an hour before every pang. He is ahead of her clock.

## TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — the only person she tells the truth to in words as well as numbers.
- ◇ **General Tibb** — sends her cake. She marks his birthday in the Book.
- ◇ **Madder Rudge** — they compare pulses and intervals by letter each week.
- ◇ **Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey** — Lark has never met her; she should.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **The Bell Rings Wrong.** Lark rings a pang that does not come. An hour later, it does. She asks the characters to find out who in Kest is counting ahead of her.
- ◇ **The Oath.** A Tally scrivener asks the characters to help Lark find another name, before she needs one.
- ◇ **The Arithmetic.** A Second Table broker offers a thousand lacks for Lark's sealed date.

If nobody intervenes, the interval reaches one day, and Lark rings the bell, and writes the name in the Book, and the grief of what follows belongs to the Tally clerks who find the clock still running.

## SAID OF THEM

"When her bell goes I put the bread in. I've never burnt a loaf." — a Kest baker

"She counts in her sleep. I've heard her. She gets to fifty-nine and starts again." — a Tally scrivener

"Lark is the only one of us who never lies to me. It is like being attended." — Orla Kest

# MADDER RUDGE

## Head of the Watch at the Dilation

*“Put your ear down, then. Go on. That’s the big one. Now wait. There. Under it. Quick and small. You tell me that’s not a heart.”*

— MADDER RUDGE, TO A PILGRIM AT THE RIM

| MADDER RUDGE – HEAD OF THE WATCH |                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                    | 69 (born 572 A.G.); at the rim since 621 A.G.                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Delver · Standing 4 (Head of the Watch)                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                           | Labor 4, Instinct 4, Endure 3, Search 3, Athletics 2, Blades 2, Godsign 2, Wayfaring 2                                                             |
| BODY                             | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (clay-stiff hide coat) · Fray 5                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                          | clay-spade +5 (4)                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                            | Knock (ear to the clay, she knows what moves beneath, to ninety feet). Rim-Sense (she knows each dawn how far the rim will move at the next pang). |
| WANTS                            | Attend (Hard 14; at every pang she must be at the rim, whatever else is happening).                                                                |
| KNACKS                           | Strong Back, Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                     | none                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                          | upside-down pipe; painted stakes; ninety feet of tarred rope; a red-stained glove                                                                  |
| DREAD                            | 0                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Stumpy, broad, red to the elbows from fifty years of clay, with a face like a dried apple and a pipe she smokes upside down against the steam. She smells of wet earth and black tobacco. She is blunt, profane, and kind to pilgrims, whom she calls “ducks.”

### THEIR STORY

A Rudge digger from childhood, she came to the rim in 621 after her son walked into it in his sleep. She stayed. In 629 she went down ninety feet on a rope, alone, at night, and touched something warm and smooth that moved under her hand. She came up and told no one.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She runs the watch: forty stake-setters, mostly her own grandchildren. Her morning stakes are the Attendance’s measure of the rim. Orla Kest reads her reports before Lark’s.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The pipe**, upside down; **painted stakes**; **ninety feet of tarred rope**, the same rope; and **one glove**, stained a red that has not

washed out in twelve years.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know what is down there before it comes up. **Secret:** the thing she touched moved *toward* her. **Secret (she does not know):** it followed her rope partway up, and every night it lies ninety feet below her listening-place, its ear to the clay, listening back. The second pulse is its.

### TIES

- ♦ **Orla Kest** — has asked her how deep a rope can go.
- ♦ **Ambrose** — lies beside her twice a year and says the second pulse is his.
- ♦ **Josiah Fenn** — she saw the giant tracks go in, and smaller ones come out.
- ♦ **Hester Lowe** — cousin by marriage; Madder knows the hand points at the Sill.

### IN PLAY

- ♦ **The Edge Stakes.** A grandchild is gone with the noon stakes. Madder wants a rope party.

- ◇ **Ninety Feet.** Orla asks the characters to persuade Madder to lend her rope.
- ◇ **Listening Back.** Madder asks a character to put their ear to the clay. It whispers their name.

If nobody intervenes, Madder lowers Orla's rope herself, and holds it, and is still at the rim holding it when the rim moves.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"She sold me posset and told me I was a duck. Best day of my pilgrimage." — a pilgrim from the Vigil

"Gran never sleeps. She lies on the edge with her ear down and talks to it." — a Rudge stake-setter

"Madder Rudge is the only honest instrument the Attendance owns." — Lark Ninedays

---

# JOSIAH FENN

the Man Who Bore

*“He’ll be bigger now. Always is. I just want him to see me once and know me. Then I’ll know what I came for.”*

– JOSIAH FENN, AT A TARNBROW FIRE

| JOSIAH FENN – THE MAN WHO BORE |                                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 4                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                  | 51 (born 590 A.G.); shepherd of the northern moors; on the trail since 633 A.G.                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING             | none (shepherd; tracker by grief)                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                         | Wayfaring 5, Search 4, Athletics 3, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Blades 2, Shooting 2, Labor 2                                                                          |
| BODY                           | Flesh 14 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (fleece coat) · Fray 7                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                        | shepherd’s knife +5 (2); sling +5 (2)                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                          | Father’s Voice (if he calls to Fenn’s Get, it must stop and roll Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 to keep acting). Kin-Pull (he always knows the direction of the Get). |
| WANTS                          | Follow (Grim 18; fresh tracks, he cannot turn from them).                                                                                                        |
| KNACKS                         | Corpse-Road Walker, Kin-Sense                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                   | Kept Grief (for the bothy, for the night, for the look it gave him)                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                        | a measuring-cord knotted with eight years of footprints; knife; sling; navel-wrap; a lamb’s bell                                                                 |
| DREAD                          | 1                                                                                                                                                                |

## WHO THEY ARE

Rangy, sun-black, silent, with a wrapped pucker of scar over his navel and widened hips he walks stiffly on. He smells of sheep and peat and old blood.

## THEIR STORY

In 633 he labored three days in a hill bothy above Tarnbrow, alone, and delivered something that stood up, looked at him with great tenderness, and walked out of the door. He gave his flock to his brother and followed. The tracks have grown to the size of a cart; the Get is twelve feet tall.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He has none. Shepherds feed him; the Attendance would like a word; the Get’s trail of flattened flocks makes him unwelcome in every fold.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The measuring-cord** — knotted once for every track measured, eight years long.

- ♦ **A shepherd’s knife** — he is not sure whether he means it for the Get or himself, and he keeps it sharp so as not to have to decide.
- ♦ **A lamb’s bell** — found beside his fire one morning, cleaned. The Get leaves him gifts.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He fears it will not remember him; more, that it will. **Secret:** the Get comes to watch his fire at night, at a distance, and bleats. **Secret (he does not know):** its tracks went into the Dilation, and came out with a second, smaller set beside them. He is a grandfather.

## TIES

- ♦ **Madder Rudge** — saw the tracks go in.
- ♦ **Annis Dell** — her husband bore too; she feeds Josiah when he passes.
- ♦ **Sabeth Thorne** — would have been sent to the bothy, had he called.
- ♦ **General Tibb** — has offered him a Company escort; Josiah refused.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **Fetch the Footprints.** Josiah begs the characters to walk the last stretch with him.
- ◇ **The Gift.** A dead ewe, laid with care at the party's camp.
- ◇ **Father's Voice.** The Get is in a village. Only Josiah's call can stop it.

If nobody intervenes, he finds it, and calls, and it comes, and holds him as it holds everything, too tight.

---

## SAID OF THEM

"He's the only man in Tarnbrow knows how my Aled felt." — Annis Dell

"Follows a giant with a sling. Daft. Brave. Daft." — a Tarnbrow shepherd

"He has the gait of a woman nine days delivered. He has had it eight years." — Lazar Voss

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# AGNES LATCH

*the Doorwright*

*“Nineteen days. You hear me? Nineteen. Nobody on this Table has shut anything for nineteen days but me. Now get out of my yard. Knock on your way.”*

— AGNES LATCH, TO A CUSTOMER WHO ASKED FOR A YEAR

| AGNES LATCH – THE DOORWRIGHT |                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 2                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                | 45 (born 596 A.G.); master of Latch’s Yard on the Tull below Mortar Rise                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING           | none (master doorwright)                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                       | Craft 5, Reckoning 4, Labor 3, Filch 3, Search 3, Blades 2, Endure 2, Haggle 2                                                                      |
| BODY                         | Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (leather forge-apron) · Fray 4                                                                                        |
| ATTACKS                      | forge hammer +6 (3, Stunning)                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                        | Undoing (by touch and a Partake she opens any lock, bar or stitch; she uses it to test her own doors, and sells only those she cannot open). Knock. |
| WANTS                        | Leave It Open (Hard 14; she cannot shut the gate of her own yard).                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                       | Rope Knots, Steady Hands                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | none                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                      | a brass spyglass; a nine-ward key; the Sill’s measurements; a list of nineteen days                                                                 |
| DREAD                        | 0                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Forty-five, broad, deaf in her left ear from the forge, sawdust in her braids and burn-scars on her wrists. Proud, rude, expensive. She smells of bog oak, hot iron and lead.

## THEIR STORY

A carpenter’s daughter, she built her first holding door at twenty, in 616; it lasted a night. She has spent twenty-five years making them hold longer: iron-bound bog oak from the Tullford mosses, locks of nine wards, hinges in poured lead, and a full day of her own knocking on each before sale. Her best held nineteen days. The customer did not die on the twentieth, whatever Kest says; he opened the door and found one more person in the room than he had left there.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The rich of Kest wait a year for her locks (200 lacks, and the Hinge-Duty). Tamsin Keyless sells counterfeits that hold only from the outside, and Agnes would gladly break her hands.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A brass spyglass** — for watching the Sill from a mile off.
- ◇ **The Sill’s measurements** — every joint, nail and hinge, in her own fine hand.
- ◇ **A nine-ward key** — to the one door in her yard she has never sold.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants a door that holds forever. **Secret:** every one of her best doors is built to the Sill’s pattern. **Secret (she does not know):** when one of them finally opens, it opens for a breath onto the same place the Sill does: a long warm room, a table laid, and a chair pulled out.

## TIES

- ◇ **Old Hinge** — she pays him to tell her the gap each Grace.
- ◇ **Brother Callum Stillwater** — his chapter-room door held eleven days.
- ◇ **Absalom Gage** — rival; brick holds and her doors do not.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — has ordered a door for the Lying-In’s lowest ward.

## IN PLAY

- ◇ **Nineteen Days.** A customer's door has held eighteen. He hires the characters to be in the room on the twentieth.
- ◇ **The Unsold Door.** Something knocks from behind the door in her yard.
- ◇ **The Pattern.** Old Hinge says the Sill opened a hand's width this Grace. Agnes asks the characters to measure it, without looking through.

If nobody intervenes, she builds the door Orla ordered, and it holds, and that is the worst thing that could happen.

---

## SAID OF THEM

"Nineteen nights I slept. Nineteen. I'd sell my mother's brick for another." — a Kest wool-merchant

"She swore at me for knocking wrong." — a Hingeman of Mortar Rise

"She looks at the Sill through a glass the way I look at the Barn's far end. We are both of us cowards about the same thing." — Dov Marrin

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# THE PEOPLE OF CRADLEWRACK, CONTINUED

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The first half of the highland cast is the Attendance and the things it must answer for. The second half is the country that has to live under the answers: the veiled houses that own the springs, the nurses and scriveners and tallymen who keep the books, the people at the border and the people who break it, a queen who has been

pregnant longer than most of her subjects have been alive, and a door on a hill that has been opening for six hundred and forty-one years. Many of them have never met. All of them can feel the interval in their bellies.

IN CRADLEWRACK YOU NEVER ASK A  
STRANGER WHAT THEY DO. YOU ASK WHAT THEY ARE  
WAITING FOR.

[ RIM ROAD COMPANY GUIDANCE TO NEW FACTORS AT BREECH'S GATE ]



*the Red-Veiled*

*"I saw a door in the ground, cousin, and a woman standing in it with her arms spread. I could not see her face. Why would I need to?"*

- THE DUCHESS MORWEN, TO THE VEILED COUNCIL, PLENTY 641

| DUCHESS IPHIGENE MORWEN – THE RED-VEILED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Cradlewrack · Cut 5 (Caul-line, House Morwen) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                            | 50; Duchess of Morwen, first seat of the Veiled Council                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Scion · Standing 5 (Great House: a hill and everything under it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS                                   | Instinct 5, Godsign 4, Rites 4, Clause 3, Lore 3, Persuade 3, Resolve 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTACKS                                  | none; her Veil-Wardens carry poleaxes (see below)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                    | Foretelling (once per scene, she names an event of the next day; the GM must make it happen if it is plausible); Through the Veil (no one standing before her can deceive her, and she knows when a lie is attempted); Bear (Course; after a day of carrying she delivers a Part, which the house’s nurses take before she can ask what it was); Red Sight (once per session, she may describe one thing a character present will do at the moment the Dilation opens; the player may refuse it, and gains 2 Fray if they do) |
| WANTS                                    | Keep the Veil (Grim 18; whenever anyone of Morwen blood proposes to marry, travel or bear outside the house, she must forbid it); Attend (Hard 14; when a birth is near she sends for word of it, and cannot rest until it comes)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                                   | Kin-Sense, Dowager’s Patience                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none yet; the red is not a madness, which is the worst thing about it                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                  | the silver dish, the Red Ledger, a horn speaking-cup, a cruet of spring-salt water, the strong-room key, a child’s shoe                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                                    | 3 (to see the veil part; Dread 4 to see what moves under it during a pang)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

**MORWEN VEIL-WARDEN** Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack  
+6 (poleaxe 5, Reach, Hooking) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

## WHO THEY ARE

She is carried, not walked. The Duchess Morwen moves through her house in a high-backed wicker chair borne on poles by four Veil-Wardens in madder livery, and she is preceded by a smell before she is preceded by anything else: warm salt, iron, and the sweetish lanolin the nurses work into the membrane each morning to keep it supple. The membrane covers her from the crown to the collarbones, a grey-pink sheath the thickness of a wet glove, glistening, veined with fine red threads like the inside of an eggshell held to a candle. Through it her face is a pale oval with two darker hollows and a darker mouth, and when she speaks the veil dimples inward over the lips and bellies out again. Her voice comes through it wet and muffled, as if spoken from the far side of a curtain in a warm room. She has never felt wind on her cheek. She has never been kissed except through it.

She is tall, narrow-shouldered, gaunt in the way of the Course-struck, as if everything she eats is taken for someone else, and the house dresses her in loose undyed robes sewn on each morning and cut off each night, because nothing she wears will stay fastened. Her hands are long and pale and nearly always still. Under the robe her belly is never flat for more than a week. Servants learn quickly that she hears everything, that she turns her blurred face toward a lie the way a dog turns toward a dropped plate, and that when she lifts one finger the room is to be silent, because she is looking forward.

The Veiled Council listens to her in silence. Commoners who see her litter on the Tull road cross the lane and knock three times on the nearest tree. To her own servants she is courteous, distant and exact, and she remembers the names of their children, and she does not ask after the ones that went to the Low Wall, because she already knows.

## THEIR STORY

Iphigene was born in 591 in the deep chambers of Morwen Hall, veiled, as every true Morwen is, and the Attendant who delivered

her wept, because the caul was the thickest she had ever seen and the infant beneath it was breathing through it, unharmed, the membrane rising and falling like a second chest. She was the only child of Duchess Ottoline Morwen and Ottoline's cousin-consort; the Cutwrights' locked volume records the union in its shorthand and the house has never asked for a key. She was raised in the Veiled Galleries, taught letters by touch and Lore by recitation, and began to foresee at six, when she told her nurse not to take the north bridge and the north bridge fell in the next pang.

Her mother went to the deep chambers in 609, crowning at the breast, and Iphigene, at eighteen, took the house. In 611 she married her cousin Casimir in the bricked room of the Hall, as the custom is, and was broken out at dawn into a house that cheered. She bore her first child in 613. Over the next twelve years she bore nine times as women bear, and the Second Opinion was asked for each. Three were permitted. Two of those went to the deep chambers before their naming. The third is the Lady Isolde Morwen, now sixteen, whose caul came away whole in the Attendant's hands at birth, and who is therefore, by every law of the house, not a Morwen at all.

The Course took Iphigene in 625. Since then she has carried almost continuously, six or eight deliveries a year, each a few weeks long, each ending in the deep chamber with two nurses, a basin, and a covered dish carried out before she can turn her head. She has never asked what they were. In Plenty of 640, during the hardest pang of the year, the veil went red: not the membrane itself, which is as grey-pink as ever, but everything she sees through it, the forward-blur that has been her sight all her life suddenly flushed and running like light through a closed eyelid. In Carving 641 the other four houses of the Veiled Council reported the same. Their prophecies, which once disagreed about everything, have been unanimous since.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

House Morwen owns eleven of the warm springs of the upper Tull and half the clay-pits west of Kest; the potters of Rudge dig Morwen clay and the salt-boilers of the ravines boil Morwen water, and every lack they earn passes through the Hall's factors before it reaches them. The Duchess sits first on the Veiled Council, which advises the Attendance on prophecy and decides, in practice, the price of salt. Orla Kest consults her before every Lying on a noble descent. The Rim Road Company buys Morwen cauls. The Cutwrights' College keeps the Morwen genealogy sealed at her request and at her expense.

Her power is real and narrow. She cannot command the Attendance, which answers to no one, and she cannot overrule the King Within, though she can ask the Chamberlain to frame a question so that the kick falls her way. She cannot leave the Hall without a litter, four wardens and a day's preparation. Her real currency is foresight: once a season she dictates to her scribe a list of what will happen in the highlands before the next Unbricking, and the list is copied and sold, and the houses that buy it plan their

lambings and their marriages by it, and they are rarely wrong to. Lately the list is short and every line of it is red.

Her routine is the routine of a body that is always beginning. She wakes before dawn in the Veiled Gallery, is washed and oiled, eats a little clay-bread and posset, and receives petitioners through a gauze screen until noon. In the afternoons she is carried along the third-storey bridges to the Foretelling Room, a round chamber with no windows and one long couch, where she lies on her back with her scribe beside her and looks forward. At dusk the nurses come to see how near she is. On delivery nights the house is sealed and the bridges drawn in.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The silver dish** — a shallow Morwen dish, black with age and engraved with seven doorways around the rim and an eighth, chiselled smooth. From it, at every naming, the house eats the child's caul raw. She has eaten from it three times for her own children. She keeps it by her bed and does not let the nurses polish it.
- ◇ **The Red Ledger** — her book of foretellings, dictated since 609, in a scribe's hand. The early pages are full of weddings and floods. Since Plenty 640 every entry begins with the same four words: *When the door opens*.
- ◇ **A horn speaking-cup** — a cone of polished ram's horn she holds to her veil to make her voice carry in Council. Without it she can be heard only by someone leaning close enough to feel the membrane's warmth.
- ◇ **A cruet of spring-salt water** — for wetting the veil. Dry, it cracks at the edges and bleeds, and the cracks open again each pang. Her own springs supply it. Lately it tastes, she says, of someone else's mouth.
- ◇ **The strong-room key** — the key to the Morwen strong-room, in which a locked chest was found open in 588 with a damp, curled thing inside and the lock still turned. She keeps the key on a cord at her throat. The strong-room has been bricked since 588, so the key opens nothing, and she knows that, and wears it anyway.
- ◇ **A child's shoe** — one soft kid shoe, the size for a child of two, embroidered with the Morwen door. She will not say whose. The house assumes it was one of the two who went to the deep chambers. It was not; it was never worn; she had it made in 626 for a child she foresaw, and has never been delivered of.
- ◇ **A scrap of the caul of Isolde** — the membrane that came away from her daughter at birth, dried and kept in a silk envelope. By house law it should have been eaten. She did not let them.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the house to continue, veiled and thick-blooded, as it has for three hundred years, because that is the only shape of duty she has ever been taught. She wants, much more quietly, to see her own face once, unblurred, before the end. She fears the red. She fears that

the woman she sees standing in the door in the ground with her arms spread is herself, and that she will go there gladly, as Vey stood in the doorway of the Old Lying-In and waited.

**Secret (she knows it):** she has foreseen the day the Dilation opens. She has not told the Council the date. She has told Orla Kest, in a sealed letter, and Orla wrote back one line: *Then I will be in the room.*

**Secret (she does not know it):** the nurses do not destroy what she delivers. On Casimir's orders they carry it down by the servants' ladder to a closed cart, and the cart goes east to the Assemblers' Barn, paid for in Second Table coin. Three of the Parts in Herself were born of Iphigene's body, including the eye that sits nearest the figure's heart. When the Duchess turns her blurred face toward the Sill in the Foretelling Room, Herself, twenty miles away, turns hers. The red she sees is partly the lamplight of the Barn.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lord Casimir Morwen** — her cousin and consort. She married him because the Cutwrights' ledger said so and has never once been able to see his lies, because he never stands before her when he tells them.
- ◇ **Lady Isolde Morwen** — her uncauled daughter, sixteen, kept on the lower floors. Iphigene loves her and cannot be seen to. She has foreseen Isolde leaving the Hall and has not forbidden it, which is the only time the Want has ever let her go.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — the Midwife-Paramount, her ally and the only person she treats as an equal. They have attended each other's worst nights.
- ◇ **Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey** — her great-aunt by two lines. The Queen visits by litter once a year and the two women sit in the dark together, both carrying, and do not speak.
- ◇ **Factor Merriam Toll** — buys Morwen cauls. Iphigene suspects the trade has grown larger than the house's own accounts can explain.
- ◇ **Ambrose, the Eldest Infant** — tutors Isolde. He is the only person who has told the Duchess what he sees when he looks at her veil, and she has asked him not to again.
- ◇ **The Reckoners** — have killed three Caul-line nobles in their veils this decade. She has foreseen a fourth and has not said who.

## IN PLAY

Player characters meet the Duchess as petitioners at the gauze screen, as hired hands for some task the house cannot be seen to do, or as the unlucky subject of a foretelling she speaks aloud in their presence. She wants from them what she cannot do herself: to go where she cannot be carried, to ask what she cannot be heard asking, and, if she trusts them, to find out what the nurses do with the covered dish. She is courteous, slow, and absolutely truthful, which is its own kind of weapon. She will never lie to a character. She will simply foretell something about them and let it come.

- ◇ **The Foretelling.** At a Council supper the Duchess lifts one finger and says that tomorrow one of the characters will open a door that should have stayed shut. The GM must make it happen. The house then hires them to make sure it is the right door.
- ◇ **The Covered Dish.** Isolde Morwen, sixteen, comes to the characters secretly and asks them to follow the nurses' cart. She wants to know what her mother has been delivered of for sixteen years. The cart goes to the Barn, and the Assemblers will kill to keep the arrangement.
- ◇ **The Fourth Veil.** A Reckoner is in Kest with a list, and the Duchess's name is on it. She knows. She asks the characters not to stop the Reckoner but to stop him from reaching Isolde, whom the Reckoner has mistaken for the heir, because her face is bare and he has never seen a Morwen face.

Under threat she is still; her wardens act. To kindness she responds with a gift of foresight, which is rarely welcome. Toward the god she is resigned and, lately, curious. If nobody intervenes, she will be carried to the rim of the Dilation on the day she has foreseen, she will have her chair set down at the edge, and she will stand up out of it without help for the first time in sixteen years.

## SAID OF THEM

"Her Grace looked at me through all that skin and said my boy would come home by Tablenight. He came home by Tablenight. In a box. She never said he'd be walking." — a clay-boiler of the upper Tull

"I have dined with her for thirty years and I have never seen her eat. The veil takes it in. I tell myself that is a figure of speech." — Lady Ysolde Calloway of the Veiled Council

"She asked me, once, whether her face was kind. I told her I had never seen it. She said, nor I, and laughed, and the veil went tight over her teeth." — Ambrose, the Eldest Infant

# DOLOUR PYM

the Wet-Nurse

*“Hush, now. Hush. Nobody’s going to look at you. I’m not looking. I’m only holding.”*

– DOLOUR PYM, TO SOMETHING IN A BASKET, OVERHEARD BY A LYING-IN  
BRICKLAYER

| DOLOUR PYM – THE WET-NURSE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION              | 58; wet-nurse to the Lying-In, pensioner of the Attendance                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Midwife · Standing 1 (Handmaid, by courtesy; she has never held the knife)                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                     | Endure 5, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Feast 3, Rites 3, Stitching 3, Persuade 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                       | Flesh 18 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                    | the embrace +3 (1, Entangling; a held target is pressed against her and feels the small mouths turn toward them, Dread 2)                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                      | Rehearsal (Appetite; she enters false labor at will and ignores Ruin for the scene, then is helpless for an hour); Quieting Milk (anything born in Cradlewrack that takes her milk is calmed for a day; it will not attack, wander or cry, though it may still grow) |
| WANTS                      | Feed (Hard 14; when anything newborn cries within earshot, she must go to it and offer the breast, whatever it is); Attend (Hard 14)                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                     | Butcher’s Calm, Mother’s Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS               | Kept Grief (her own first child, whom she speaks to in the empty cradle by the hearth)                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                    | the willow cradle, a shawl of nursing-wool, the naming-book, a horn spoon, a lamp, the Low Wall pick                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                      | 2 (to see what is at her breast; Dread 3 for those who see it look back)                                                                                                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is enormous, and soft, and slow, and warm as a bread-oven, and she smells of milk so strongly that cats follow her along the Lying-In road and sit outside her door. She wears a vast shawl of grey nursing-wool knotted under one arm, open at the breast in the way of every wet-nurse in the highlands, and the shawl moves. Nobody who has spent an hour in Dolour’s cottage forgets the moment they understood that the shawl moves even when she is still. There are small mouths on her. Some are at the breast and some are not. Several have not let go in years, and her skin around them has grown up in soft pink collars like the rim of a crowning, and she moves through her low dim rooms with the care of a woman carrying eggs in her apron, turning sideways at doorframes, singing.

Her voice is low and tuneless and never stops. She sings the counting-song, the lambing-song, the Tally read aloud, the names of the dead in the Stillyard, anything with a rhythm. Her hands are huge, cracked, and gentle. Her eyes are pale blue and slightly unfocused, as though she is always listening to something in another room. She has no fear of anything that is born. She has a great deal of fear of people with ledgers.

## THEIR STORY

Dolour Pym was born in 583 in a carter’s house below the Lying-In hill and was a big, quiet, unremarkable girl who wanted only to marry and bear. She married a carter, Hugh Pym, in 607. In 611 she was delivered of her first child at home, with the parish Attendant present as the law requires, and the Attendant asked the Two Questions and answered them, and carried a bundle out of the room tied in the knot that cannot come undone. Dolour never saw what it was. Her milk came in on the third day and never stopped.

It did not stop in a week, or a month, or a year. Hugh left in 613. By 614 the Attendant who had taken her child came back with a basket and a hard face and asked if Dolour would take a birth the Lying-In had permitted and could not bear to look at. She did. It was the first. The Lying-In has sent her something every season since: the permitted births no mother will hold, the old-born that cannot feed from a cup, the Parts the Book allows to stay for study, and, in 627, a born-grown woman of forty who had come out mute and starving and would take nothing but the breast. Dolour has nursed, by her own count, three hundred and twelve. She has



outlived most of them. Of those she still has, eleven live in her cottage, and four of them have never let go.

The Attendance moved her to a cottage built against the outer wall of the Lying-In in 619, so that the baskets need not be carried far, and pays her a pension of two lacks a day, three in Lack. She has never asked for more. She has asked only, each Unbricking, to be told that none of her children will be returned.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

In the economy of the Attendance, Dolour is where the Book's mercy goes when it has no other address. A permitted birth must be fed, and a permitted birth that no one will feed is a Second Opinion delayed. Every Opinion in the country knows that if she cannot look at a thing and the Book says it stays, there is a big woman under the Lying-In wall who will take the basket without lifting the cloth. Orla Kest regards her as an institution. The bricklayers of the lower wards bring her their leftover bread. The Lying-In's own book records her nurslings in a separate column, headed *Pym*, and nobody outside the Attendance has read it.

Her power is the power of being needed and having no ambition. She has none of the Attendance's authority and wants none. She depends on the pension, on the bread, on the goodwill of the Paramount, and on the absolute discretion of the women who bring the baskets. If the Lying-In ever decided to recall her nurslings, she could not stop it. She knows that. It is the only thing that has ever made her sharp.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The willow cradle** — her own first child's, woven by Hugh in 611 and never used. It stands by the hearth with a folded blanket in it. She rocks it with her foot while she works, and talks to it. Visitors are asked not to sit near it.
- ◇ **A shawl of nursing-wool** — grey, vast, re-knitted every season around what clings to her. She cannot take it off in one piece any more; it is cut and knitted on.
- ◇ **The naming-book** — a cheap Tally-office notebook in which she has written a name for every nursling who lived a year, as the law allows the one who feeds them. There are one hundred and four names. Small. Keep. Tobin. Ninety. Notyet. Mercy. Bit. Hollan, after the first Paramount, which she thought was a joke and the Attendance did not.
- ◇ **A horn spoon** — for those who cannot take the breast. Its bowl is worn thin as paper.
- ◇ **A lamp of Cradlewrack beeswax** — for the night feeds, and for the walk.
- ◇ **The Low Wall pick** — a mason's pick with a short haft, wrapped in rag. It belongs to Absalom Gage. She carries it on certain nights in her shawl, and it is the reason this dossier has a secret.

- ◇ **A pot of caul-poultice** — for the skin around the mouths, which cracks and bleeds at every pang. It costs her six lacks a pot, three days' pension, and she buys it every week.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants every one of them fed. That is the whole of her want, and it is enormous. She fears the Lying-In will take her children back; she fears dying before the ones who cannot let go, and leaving them latched to something cold; she fears, very quietly, finding out what was in the first bundle.

**Secret (she knows it):** the Second Opinion does not always finish what it starts. Vey was the god that kept beginning again, and some of what is carried to the Low Wall in the knotted linen is still warm days later, and knocks. Twice a month, on the nights after a pang, Dolour walks to the Stillyard with a lamp and a mason's pick, listens at the unmarked niches of the Low Wall, and takes out the ones that knock. Absalom Gage rebricks the niche in the morning and says nothing, because he has felt them knock too. Seven of her eleven came out of the Low Wall. Two of them were carried there by Wenna Thrale, who named them on the walk.

**Secret (she does not know it):** her milk is not entirely hers. Since the Shortening it has run salt and faintly pink on pang nights, exactly as the springs do, and in the Lying-In's book an Opinion has noted that the creatures who drink it are growing in step with the Dilation, a stride outward and back by less. The Attendance has begun to wonder whether Dolour Pym is nursing the god's children or the god.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — the Paramount sends her baskets and protects her. If Orla learns about the Low Wall, she will have to choose between the knife and the nurse.
- ◇ **Absalom Gage** — the mason who rebricks what she opens. They have never discussed it. He leaves the pick on her step; she leaves bread on his.
- ◇ **Wenna Thrale** — the apprentice whose list of thirty-one names Dolour has never seen. Two of the names are sleeping in her cottage.
- ◇ **Sabeth Thorne** — once brought her a basket and stood in the door for a long time. Dolour thinks Sabeth will come again, with something from Tarnbrow.
- ◇ **Sister Maeve Cord** — calls Dolour kin, because what clings to her has grown into her as a cord grows. Dolour finds this kind and slightly frightening.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — has written to her three times, offering money for any of her nurslings that are Parts. She burned the letters, and then the Assemblers burned her woodshed.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Dolour when something they have rescued needs feeding and no one else will touch it, or when a Lying-In basket goes



astray, or at night in the Stillyard, where a big woman with a lamp is kneeling at the Low Wall with her ear to the brick. She wants a strong back to carry baskets, a promise that nobody will tell the Attendance, and, if she comes to trust them, someone to look after her children when she dies.

- ◇ **The Knock.** The characters see Dolour at the Low Wall, breaking a niche. What she lifts out is warm and moving. A Stillyard watchman has seen too, and runs for the Attendance.
- ◇ **The Recall.** The Lying-In sends word that four of her nurslings are to be returned for a late Second Opinion at the Unbricking. Dolour asks the characters to hide them, which means carrying four things nobody can look at across a country where every door opens by itself.
- ◇ **What Clings.** One of the mouths that has not let go in eleven years lets go. What it is attached to stands up. Dolour is delighted. Nobody else is.

To threat she responds by holding on, which with her bulk and Endure is a formidable thing. To kindness she responds with food, always too much. To the god she responds as to any newborn: she offers it the breast. If nobody intervenes, the Lying-In will learn of the Low Wall by Tablenight, and the Paramount will go into Dolour's cottage herself, with the knife, and attend.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"You don't knock at Dolour's. She says it frightens them. You just stand outside till she sings." — a Lying-In basket-woman

"I sent her a thing in 622 that I could not look at for the count of one. I visited it last year. It knew my name. She'd taught it." — an Opinion of the Attendance, unnamed

"She's the only one up there who isn't afraid of what comes out. Which makes her the most frightening woman in the highlands, you ask me." — a carter on the Lying-In road

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# EDE AND ADA CREWE

*the Twice-Born*

*“We were burned once.” “On the left hand.” “At four months, reaching.” “It was before she was born.” “It still hurts.” “It still hurts us both.”*

— EDE AND ADA CREWE, TO AN EXAMINING CUTWRIGHT, GRACE 639

| EDE AND ADA CREWE – THE TWICE-BORN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 (shared; see Gifts)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                      | Ede 20, Ada 19; scribes of the Tally-house, Kest                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | Cutwright-trained copyists in the Tally’s service · Standing 1 (Copyist)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                             | Reckoning 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Deceive 3, Instinct 3, Athletics 2, Filch 2, Stealth 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| BODY                               | Flesh 11 each · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4 (shared)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                            | penknife +3 (2) each                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                              | One Sentence (what either sees, hears or remembers, both do; they act on the same turn; when one aids the other the bonus is +2); One Scar (any wound one takes appears on the other by morning as a healed scar, without loss of Flesh; Hunger and Fray are a single pool); Knock (Taste; a palm on a wall or a door tells them what lives behind it) |
| WANTS                              | Finish (Hard 14; when anyone near them leaves a sentence unfinished, they finish it aloud; often it is what the speaker meant and did not want said); Leave It Open (Routine 10)                                                                                                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                             | Second Chair, Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                       | none; between them they have absorbed one Break already and divided it, which a Seamer of the mind says should be impossible                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                            | the shared pen-case, the Tally copybooks, a pair of left gloves, a letter from Cleave, Tamsin Gorse’s thread                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                              | 2 (to watch them write one line with two hands; Dread 3 to hear the third voice finish it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

They are small, dark, quick, sharp-chinned, with ink on their fingers and identical crescents of burn-scar puckered white across their left palms. They are not twins. They do not look like twins; Ede is half a hand taller and broader in the face, and Ada has their mother’s grey eyes where Ede has their father’s brown. But they move like one creature with two heads. When one reaches for a cup, the other’s hand twitches. When one laughs, the other has already started. When one is asked a question, the answer comes from both, split down the middle, one voice beginning and the other ending, with no pause at the join. Their voices are different, and that is what makes it unbearable to listen to for long: two people saying one thought, as though someone were playing a single tune on two instruments set a room apart.

They are charming, and they know it, and they use it. They flirt with clerks in tandem and finish each other’s jokes and run small cheerful frauds on the naming-exchange under the Tally hall. They smell of oak-gall ink and the lavender water the Tally-house gives its

scribblers against the damp. They hold hands almost always, left to right, burned palm to burned palm.

## THEIR STORY

Ede Crewe was born in 621 to Joan Crewe, a weaver of Kest’s Loomside, and was a normal child for four months, until she pulled a lamp off a shelf and burned her left palm to the bone. The scar healed white. Ada was born in Carving 622, more than a year later, with an identical white crescent already healed on her left palm, and the Attendant who delivered her looked at it for a long time and then asked the Two Questions and answered both of them in the affirmative. Ada stays. The Tally records her as *one, living, scarred*.

They spoke the same first word on the same day, though Ada was a year younger. They had one set of nightmares. When Ede broke her collarbone at eight, Ada woke screaming in the next room and had a white line across her collarbone by the morning. The Cutwrights’ College examined them in 630 and again in 639, and the second examination ended with the Lecturer refusing to finish his report, because every sentence he began, they finished, and they

finished them truthfully. Joan Crewe died in 636 and they mourned her in a single long sentence that went on for three days.

They went to the Tally-house at fourteen, because Rufus Ochre had heard of two girls who could copy one line in half the time with two hands, and he was right. Since Plenty 640 a third voice has begun finishing their sentences. It belongs to a girl of seventeen in Cleave, Nettle Corse, whom they have never met, who says the last words of whatever they are saying at the same moment they say them, forty miles away, in her mother's dairy. The Cleave parish Attendant wrote to the Tally about it. Rufus showed them the letter. They have not spoken aloud in an empty room since.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Tally is the evening news of Cradlewrack, and the Crewe sisters are among the dozen scribes who make it legible. Every dusk the parish boards are chalked, and every night the chalk is carried by runners to the Tally-house and copied into the great ledger, and the copy is read aloud at the board in the morning. Ede and Ada copy the northern parishes, Ede taking the left-hand columns and Ada the right, a single line growing across the page from two pens. Their copy is the fastest in the house and has never contained an error.

They depend on Rufus, who protects them from the Attendance's interest and the College's, and on their wages, three lacks a day each, which they supplement by knowing the night's births an hour before the naming-exchange does. They have no power in the land, except that they read every birth in the north before anyone else alive, and they finish people's sentences, and in a country where secrets are mostly about what someone bore, that is a great deal of power for two girls who are not quite one.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The shared pen-case** — one case, two pens, one penknife they pass between them without looking.
- ◇ **The Tally copybooks** — the working drafts of the northern columns, which they are not supposed to take home and always do.
- ◇ **A pair of left gloves** — two left gloves, one larger than the other, bought from a glover who asked no questions. They wear them to cover the scars when they go out. Neither of them owns a right glove.
- ◇ **A letter from Cleave** — from Nettle Corse, in a round dairymaid's hand: *I am sorry. I do not mean to. I bear you all day. Please tell me how the sentence ends.* They have not answered it.
- ◇ **Tamsin Gorse's thread** — a twist of catgut and a fine needle, left with them after the last time.
- ◇ **A naming-right** — for a Loomside birth due next Grace, bought cheap, which they believe will be a speaking child and a fortune. They read it in the Tally before the mother knew.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

They want to stay two. They want to know which of them is the original, and they want never to know. They fear that one of them will die first and the other will go on, half a sentence, forever. They fear Nettle Corse more than anything in the highlands, because if there can be a third, there was never really a second.

**Secret (they know it):** they wake, more mornings than not, with their burned palms grown together. The skin seals along the scars in the night, warm and seamless, and they cannot pull apart. Once a month Tamsin Gorse comes to their room above the Tally-house with a knife and a needle and cuts them free and stitches each palm closed, and by the next pang the stitches have opened. Each time the seal is a little deeper. In Lack they woke joined to the wrist.

**Secret (they do not know it):** they are not one child born twice. They are one person born in three Parts, as Parts are born, and like Parts they are drawn toward each other. Nettle Corse is the third. She has begun walking toward Kest in her sleep. Una Clayhand of the Assemblers has entered all three names in the Gatherers' book under a single heading.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Rufus Ochre** — their employer and protector, who loves them as he loves a well-balanced column. They would do anything for him, and finish anything he says.
- ◇ **Tamsin Gorse** — cuts them apart. They think of her as the only person who has ever chosen, deliberately, to treat them as two.
- ◇ **Nettle Corse** — the girl in Cleave. Terrifying, apologetic, forty miles away and coming closer.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — they met her once, in 640, when the Tally sent them to copy the Tarnbrow register. She said her half-sentence and they tried to finish it, as they must, and both their noses bled, and what they wrote on the copy-page in two hands was one word in the old pre-Gorging script, which neither of them can read.
- ◇ **Ruth Ninefold** — the name-broker of Kest, who buys their early knowledge and suspects where it comes from.
- ◇ **Una Clayhand** — a friendly woman at the naming-exchange who always asks how their hands are.

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet the sisters at the Tally-house, at the naming-exchange, or because they need a birth found, a record read, or a column checked that someone in power wants left unchecked. They want someone to go to Cleave and look at Nettle Corse for them, and then they want that person to tell them it was nothing.

- ◇ **The Word.** The characters find the copy-page from Tarnbrow with its one word in the old script. Ambrose can read it. He reads it, and he goes very pale, and he says only that it is a word for someone who sits down at a table without being asked.

- ◇ **The Third Voice.** Nettle Corse arrives in Kest, sleepwalking, barefoot, having walked forty miles in four nights. The three girls see each other across a Tally-board at dawn. The characters have a few moments to decide whether to let them touch.
- ◇ **Two Columns.** Rufus Ochre is ill and the sisters must copy the unaccounted entries alone. They notice what Rufus has not: who wrote them.

Threatened, they split and run in two directions and meet where neither was going. To kindness they respond with loyalty and gossip. Of the god they speak little; they have felt its want as a want to be together, and they think that is the cruelest thing it could have chosen. If nobody intervenes, by the next Unbricking the three of them will wake in one bed in Kest with their hands joined, and Tamsin will not be able to find the seams.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“Ask them anything. Go on. Ask them where they were born. Watch which one says *Kest*, and which one says *already*.” — a Tally-house runner

“They have never misplaced a figure. In forty years I have not seen copying like it. I try not to think about how it is done.” — Rufus Ochre

“Every time they talk, my mouth moves. I can taste the ink.” — Nettle Corse of Cleave, in her letter to the parish Attendant

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# RUFUS OCHRE

the Tallyman

*“Eleven hundred and four. Not eleven hundred. Eleven hundred and four. If we are going to be frightened, let us at least be frightened accurately.”*

— RUFUS OCHRE, TO THE ATTENDANCE’S SENIOR OF THE LYING, LACK 640

| RUFUS OCHRE – THE TALLYMAN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION              | 60; Keeper of the Tally of Cradlewrack since 609                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Cutwright-trained, in the Crown’s service · Standing 3 (Lecturer, lapsed)                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                     | Reckoning 5, Lore 4, Search 4, Resolve 3, Clause 2, Stealth 2, Endure 1, Wayfaring 1                                                                                                                                                               |
| BODY                       | Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                    | penknife +2 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                      | Knock (Taste; a palm on a door or wall tells him whether something living is behind it, and roughly how big); the Column (once per session, after an hour with the Tally, he names a true number about the highlands that nobody else has counted) |
| WANTS                      | Leave It Open (Routine 10; he leaves the Tally-house door ajar behind him and the clerks follow him closing it)                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                     | Counting Habit, Light Sleeper                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS               | none yet; the GM should watch for The Count                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                    | the master ledger, Vigil spectacles, a counting-frame, board-chalk, a dark lantern, a list of eleven hundred and four                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                      | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

A stooped, soft-bellied man with a halo of white hair, ink to the second knuckle, and spectacles of thick Vigil glass that make his eyes enormous and wet. He smells of oak-gall, candle-smoke and the dry dust of ledgers. He speaks quietly and too precisely, correcting himself mid-sentence to get a figure right, and he loves numbers the way other old men love roses: patiently, possessively, with a gardener’s grief when one dies. He is kind to clerks and impatient with nobles. He hums when he adds.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 581 to a Kest chandler, Rufus was sent to the Cutwrights’ College at twelve for his arithmetic and left it at twenty-six, a Lecturer, because the College wanted him to trace bloodlines and he wanted to count births. The Crown made him Tallyman in 609. For thirty years he kept the ledger true and dull. In 619 he began to notice that the Tally of births ran ahead of the count of carryings, the record of every pregnancy the Attendance knows of, by a few dozen a year. He reported it. The Attendance thanked him. By 630 the gap was three hundred; by 640, eleven hundred and four.

Last Carving he began to follow the unaccounted. Each is a chalk entry on a parish board at dusk, in proper Tally form, *one, living, born-grown, at the Hollow Stile*, which no Attendant claims to have written. He went to the Hollow Stile with a lantern. He found a naked man of thirty sitting in the wet bracken by a crowning, who looked at him and stood and walked north. Rufus followed him for a night. By dawn two more had joined, in a line, saying nothing. He lost them in the caul-fog below the Sill.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Tally is law, history and news. Descent runs through whoever bore you, and the Tally is the only proof of who that was; benches of the Lying decide inheritances from its pages; the naming-exchange under the Tally hall prices naming-rights by its columns; the Crown taxes households by it. Rufus commands sixty clerks, runners and scribes, the parish boards, and the great ledger in its iron-bound press. His power is that no one can dispute a figure he has entered. His limit is that he cannot enter what the Attendance will not tell him, and the Lying-In’s own book is closed to him.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The master ledger** — the current year's Tally, an armful of calf-bound folios. He carries the working volume everywhere.
- ◇ **Vigil spectacles** — ground in the Vigil in 615 for a fortune. Without them he cannot read a column at arm's length.
- ◇ **A counting-frame** — bone beads on brass wire. He counts the pangs on it from habit, and the beads click by themselves when one is coming.
- ◇ **Board-chalk** — a stub of the red chalk the parish boards use. He has begun to find it in his pockets when he does not remember putting it there.
- ◇ **A dark lantern** — for following the unaccounted at night.
- ◇ **The list** — eleven hundred and four entries copied on long strips, with the parish and the hour. Sixty-one are ticked. Those are the ones he has found walking.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the arithmetic to close. He fears that it will: that when the last figure is entered the sum will equal something, and that he will understand it.

**Secret (he knows it):** since 628 he has let Ruth Ninefold, the name-broker, see the night's copy an hour before it is read at the boards, for forty lacks a month. It paid for his spectacles and his sister's niche in the Stillyard. He tells himself it harms no one.

**Secret (he does not know it):** the unaccounted entries are in his handwriting. He rises in the night in the Taste's restlessness, walks to the boards, and chinks them, and does not remember. Ede and Ada Crewe will be the first to notice. Whether he is recording births that the land has made, or whether the land makes them because the Tally says so, is a question the GM may leave open.

## TIES

- ◇ **Ede and Ada Crewe** — his best scriveners, whom he protects as a man protects a rare instrument, and, he would be shocked to learn, loves as daughters.
- ◇ **Lark Ninedays** — times the pangs in the room above his. They share a pot of tea at every pang. She is the only person who understands his columns.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — will not open the Lying-In's book to him. He has asked nine times.
- ◇ **Ruth Ninefold** — his secret creditor.
- ◇ **General Tibb** — wants Rufus's lists, because the walking unaccounted are born-grown and the Companies should, by law, have them.

## IN PLAY

Rufus hires characters to follow the unaccounted at night, because he is too old to keep up. He wants a count, not a fight: who they are, where they go, how many. He reacts to threat by clutching the ledger and to kindness by explaining the figures at length. If nobody

intervenes, he follows the line north alone one night in Carving, all the way to the Sill, and is found at dawn by Old Hinge, sitting with his back to the door, adding.

- ◇ **The Line.** Forty unaccounted walk north on a pang night, in file, through a Rudge village. The villagers bar the lane. Rufus begs the characters to let them pass and count them.
- ◇ **The Hand in the Chalk.** A clerk compares the unaccounted entries with Rufus's own register hand. The Attendance hears.
- ◇ **The Sum.** Rufus works the figures one more way and gets a number equal to the population of Cradlewrack in 0 A.G. He asks the characters to check it.

## SAID OF THEM

"He'll tell you to the soul how many were born in your parish. Ask him how many died and he looks at you like you've spoken Oathen." — a Tally-board reader in Kest

"He is the only honest man in the Tally hall, and he is selling the night copy to me. Make of that what you like." — Ruth Ninefold

"The beads click before I ring the bell. He thinks I don't hear them." — Lark Ninedays

# SISTER MAEVE CORD

## Mother of Cords

*“You call it a cord. We call it the first road. Everyone walks it once. We simply never stepped off.”*

– SISTER MAEVE CORD, PREACHING AT THE RIMWATCH, GRACE 641

| SISTER MAEVE CORD – MOTHER OF CORDS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | Cradlewrap · Cut 3 · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                       | 41; Mother of Cords, head of the Uncut, Cordway                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | Celebrant · Standing 5 (Prophet, among the Uncut)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                              | Endure 4, Persuade 4, Brawl 3, Godsign 3, Rites 3, Resolve 3, Instinct 2, Labor 2                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                                | Flesh 16 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                             | cord-lash +6 (3, Grappling; a grappled target shares her pain and hears her mother’s heartbeat, Dread 2)                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                               | Shared Blood (she may move up to 4 Flesh of damage to anyone joined to her by cord); Root-Sense (she knows a pang a full day before it comes); Through the Knot (once per scene she feels the emotions of everyone joined to her within a mile, and may send one of them a single feeling) |
| WANTS                               | Join (Hard 14; she cannot bear to let anyone she loves be alone in a room); Gather (Grim 18; living cord, wherever cut, she must take home)                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                              | Kin-Sense, Strong Back                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | none acknowledged                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                             | the cord-carriage, the cord-knife’s sheath (empty), the long house key, mother’s slot-brick, oil of the cord, a grafting needle                                                                                                                                                            |
| DREAD                               | 2 (Dread 3 to hold the cord during a pang)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

### WHO THEY ARE

A big, deep-chested, broad-hipped woman with a voice like a church bell heard through a wall, thick brown braids wound with red wool, and the calm of someone who has never been alone for one minute of her life. From her navel, under an open-fronted robe, runs the cord: pale, glistening, the thickness of a wrist, warm to the touch and pulsing slowly, looped in coils on a wicker carriage that two Grafted acolytes push behind her wherever she goes. Two more cords, thinner, run from her belly to her grown son and daughter, and from them to the roof-cords of Cordway. When Maeve laughs, the whole net over the village shivers.

She smells of warm skin, cord-oil and woodsmoke. She embraces strangers. She feels, through the cord, a heartbeat she calls her mother’s, and she places strangers’ hands on it so they can feel it too.

### THEIR STORY

Maeve was born in 600 in Cordway to Rowan Cord, a Root of the Uncut, and the cord was never cut. She grew up in the long house, joined, never once in a room by herself. She married a Grafted man

in 618, bore a son, Lorne, in 619 and a daughter, Edda, in 622, and refused the cord-knife both times in front of the parish Attendant, who wrote her up for obstruction and later left the Attendance to be Grafted herself.

Maeve became Mother of Cords in 631. In 635 Rowan died. Her heart stopped; the Uncut’s surgeons listened and heard nothing in her chest. But the cord went on pulsing, and Rowan’s body, bricked in a long low tomb in Cordway with a slot left in the bricks for the cord, has not decayed in six years. Maeve has not gone more than thirty yards from that tomb since. This Grace, for the first time, the cord grew a yard.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Maeve speaks for some four thousand Uncut in Cordway and the joined courts of Kest. She negotiates with the Attendance for the right to bear uncut, with the Assemblers for the return of severed cords, and with the parishes for passage of the roof-cords over their lanes. Cordway’s weavers and herders trade through her; the Uncut share their wages through the cords as they share their warmth. Her power is the knot itself: she can feel the whole village, and when she



is angry, the whole village feels it. Her limit is the thirty yards. Anyone who wants to speak with the Mother of Cords must come to Cordway.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The cord-carriage** — a wicker cart padded with lamb’s wool, on which the cord to her mother lies coiled. The acolytes oil it hourly.
- ◇ **An empty sheath** — the sheath of the cord-knife the Attendant tried to use on her son. She took the knife and threw it into the Tull. She wears the sheath as a reminder.
- ◇ **The long house key** — a heavy iron key to a door nobody locks. Uncut houses have no doors between rooms.
- ◇ **Mother’s slot-brick** — the loose brick from Rowan’s tomb, through which the cord passes. She carries it when she sleeps away from the tomb, which she has not done in six years.
- ◇ **Oil of the cord** — mutton fat and spring-salt in a crock; the cord cracks without it.
- ◇ **A grafting needle** — a curved bone needle a span long, for sewing borrowed cord into an outsider’s navel.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the Uncut to bear uncut by law, the cord-knife abolished, and every Uncut joined, at the end, to the land. She fears being cut away. She fears, more than she can say, what she feels on the cord at night.

**Secret (she knows it):** the heartbeat on the cord changed on the night Rowan died. It became slow and vast, and since the Shortening it has quickened only at the pangs, in step with them. She tells her people it is her mother. She is not sure.

**Secret (she does not know it):** her mother is alive. Rowan Cord is the Uncut’s oldest Root, and her cord does not end in her tomb but in the ground beneath it, and her body in the tomb is the empty end. Rowan is down in the warm red, joined to something that is not dead and is not her, and she is coming back up along the cord, a yard this Grace, toward her daughter.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Orla Kest** — Maeve’s chief opponent and, she would say, her sister in work. They meet at the thirty-yard line each Grace, and Orla brings no knife.
- ◇ **Dolour Pym** — kin, in Maeve’s eyes, because of what has grown into her.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — an uneasy ally, who wants severed cords for the figure. Maeve gives him none.
- ◇ **Brother Callum Stillwater** — an enemy, whose Order cuts what the Uncut keep. She loves him anyway and he knows it.
- ◇ **Madder Rudge** — feels the second pulse in the Dilation with her ear. Maeve feels it on the cord. They have compared rhythms and they match.

#### IN PLAY

Characters come to Cordway as envoys, as seekers of a Grafting, or chasing a cut cord. Maeve wants allies in Kest and someone to go to the rim of the Dilation with an ear to the ground and tell her whether the pulse there is the one she feels.

- ◇ **The Cut Cord.** A Barren brother severs a roof-cord in Cordway at night. Two families bleed. Maeve asks the characters to bring her the man.
- ◇ **The Tomb.** Maeve asks the characters to open her mother’s tomb, because she must know, and she cannot do it herself.
- ◇ **A Yard More.** The cord grows another yard in a night, then four. Something on the far end is pulling.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She put my hand on it. It beat slower than any heart I know, and on the third beat the ground under the tent beat with it.” — a pilgrim at the Rimwatch

“She is not a heretic. She is a woman who has never once been lonely, and she cannot imagine why anyone would choose to be.” — Orla Kest

“Mother’s warm tonight.” — Edda Cord, nineteen, to her brother, every night

# MARSHAL GIDEON BREECH

*the Turner-Back*

*“Hands on the belly, if you please. No, both of them. Thank you. Now breathe out. Again.  
Sergeant, a midwife to the second room.”*

– MARSHAL BREECH, AT THE EXAMINATION ROOMS, ANY MORNING

| MARSHAL GIDEON BREECH – THE TURNER-BACK |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                           | 56; Marshal of the Border, commander at Breech’s Gate since 619                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | Warden · Standing 5 (Marshal of the Rim, by the Crown’s warrant)                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                  | Blades 4, Intimidate 4, Search 4, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Resolve 3, Clause 2, Stitching 2                                                                                                               |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                                 | sword +7 (4, Parrying)                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                                   | Knock (Taste; his palm on a belly or a door tells him whether something living is behind it and how large); Born Watching (once per session, he knows one thing a traveler is hiding about their body) |
| WANTS                                   | Leave It Open (Routine 10)                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                                  | Light Sleeper, Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | none; he has never allowed himself one                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                 | the sword, the marshal’s warrant, the turned-back book, a midwife’s ear-trumpet, a Tally extract, a lock of hair                                                                                       |
| DREAD                                   | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

**BORDER MARSHAL** Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +6  
(spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

## WHO THEY ARE

Long-faced, iron-grey, cropped close, with skin like an old saddle and pale eyes set deep. He stands very still and lets the silence work. He is not patient; he is waiting. His voice is low, his manners exact, and when he lays his broad scarred palm on a stranger’s belly in the Examination Rooms he does it as gently as a midwife, eyes half closed, listening with his hand. He smells of leather, lamp-oil and the yard’s wet clay. He sleeps in a chair in the gatehouse with his boots on.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 585 at Cleave, Gideon Breech was a carter’s son who became a drill-mother at the old Foundling House in 604, teaching the born-grown of the parishes to hold a spoon, a spade and a spear, decades before the Companies were raised. He married, was widowed when his wife bore twice in one season, and raised their daughter, Bryony, alone. The Crown made him Marshal in 619, and the Gate took his name.

In Carving 635 Bryony, twenty-four and carrying, came to the Gate at night and asked him. He took her through himself. A captain of the Rim Road Company guard, Haskett Varr, saw the lantern on the Fatlands side and came to ask, by Company right, whom the marshal was passing. The Tally of that year records the captain killed at Breech’s Gate by persons unknown, and a birth at Breech’s Gate to a woman in the Fatlands. Breech has turned back every carrying traveler since, perhaps two thousand of them. He has never said why he let one through. He has never asked what was born.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Breech’s Gate is where Cradlewrack’s law meets the Rim Road. Breech commands three hundred marshals and a ward of twelve examining midwives lent by the Attendance. He has authority to hold, search and turn back any traveler; he answers to the Crown and, in practice, to Orla Kest. He depends on the Company for the inn and the road, and the Company depends on him to let its wagons through. The yard is always full of the turned-back. He knows many of them by name, and they hate him, and some bring him bread.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The sword** — an officer's blade from the Crown, plain and well kept.
- ◇ **The marshal's warrant** — on calfskin, sealed with a kick of the King Within.
- ◇ **The turned-back book** — a ledger of every carrying traveler refused, with the date. There are two thousand and six entries. There is one blank line in 635.
- ◇ **A midwife's ear-trumpet** — of horn, for listening at bellies.
- ◇ **A Tally extract** — a copy of the 635 entry. He has never read it twice.
- ◇ **A lock of hair** — Bryony's, from when she was four.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the border held, and he wants to be forgiven by someone with the right to forgive him. He fears what is knocking in the inn.

**Secret (the GM can reveal it):** Breech killed Captain Haskett Varr with three cuts in the dark to keep his daughter's crossing secret. General Tibb, born that same day in a Cleave lambing-shed, carries those three wounds as scars. Breech has seen Tibb stripped to the waist at drill and recognised his own work.

**Secret (he does not know it):** Bryony's child was born in two places. Her son, six, lives with her in a Fatlands hamlet where the soil under the cottage has turned warm and red. The rest of the birth happened at the Gate, in the Company's inn, the Open Door, whose curtained rooms have no doors; it is the thing that knocks back from inside empty rooms. It is waiting for its grandfather to knock first.

## TIES

- ◇ **General Tibb** — Breech's ally and the man wearing his crime. They drink together each Pangday and do not speak of scars.
- ◇ **Petra Quick** — the smuggler he has nearly caught nine times. She thinks she knows why he let one through. She is right.
- ◇ **Factor Merriam Toll** — keeps the Company inn and the Company's records of Captain Varr. She has noticed the dates.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — lends his examining midwives. She knows the 635 entry and has never asked.
- ◇ **Bryony Breech** — his daughter, across the border, who writes each Lack. He burns the letters unread so that no one at the Gate can say he knew.

## IN PLAY

Characters meet Breech leaving the highlands: hands on the belly, breathe out. Men are being found carrying who did not know. He may hire them to find a traveler who slipped through, or to listen in the Open Door's empty rooms at night.

- ◇ **The Knocking Room.** An inn guest is found in an empty curtained room, mute, with a burned-out lamp. Breech asks the characters to sit up there one night and not knock back.
- ◇ **Bryony's Letter.** A letter arrives that Breech cannot burn: Bryony is coming home, with her son, who has begun to bear.
- ◇ **Nine Women.** Petra Quick's convoy reaches the Gate. Breech knows. He must turn them back or explain why not.

## SAID OF THEM

"He put his hand on me like my own mother would. Then he said no. I'd almost rather he'd hit me." — a turned-back woman of Tarnbrow

"I have seen a hundred border officers. He is the only one who has ever looked sorry, and the only one who has never once relented. Well. Once." — Factor Merriam Toll

"He knows the Gate. Every stone. Except the one room he won't go in." — a marshal of the night watch

# PETRA QUICK

## the Runner of Mothers

*“I don’t promise it’ll work. Nobody’s ever promised you anything that worked. I promise you’ll be somewhere else when it doesn’t.”*

— PETRA QUICK, TO A CLIENT, BREECH’S GATE ROAD

| PETRA QUICK – THE RUNNER OF MOTHERS |                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | Rim-born of a Cradlewrack mother · Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 0                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                       | 38; smuggler, route-holder on the northwestern Rim                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | Crumb-Runner · Standing 3 (Route-Holder)                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                              | Wayfaring 4, Deceive 4, Blades 3, Shooting 3, Haggle 3, Stealth 3, Endure 2, Stitching 2, Athletics 2                                                                                     |
| BODY                                | Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (padded jack) · Fray 3                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                             | knife +6 (2); crossbow +6 (4, Piercing, Slow)                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                               | Hidden Hold (any cart she loads has a compartment found only on a Grace); First Breath (Taste; once per session she rerolls the first roll of a journey, and something shut nearby opens) |
| WANTS                               | Leave It Open (Routine 10)                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                              | Rope Knots, Scrap-Born Luck                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                             | the crossbow, the cart, a forged pass, a Tally extract with her own name, a vial of brine, a midwife’s kit                                                                                |
| DREAD                               | 0                                                                                                                                                                                         |

### WHO THEY ARE

Lean, wiry, freckled to the eyelids, with short fox-red hair, a gap in her front teeth she whistles through, and a quick light voice that never stops bargaining. She smells of axle-grease, mule and cheap Rim tobacco. She swears in four lands’ idioms and knocks on doorframes like a highlander without noticing. She is warm, funny and unsentimental with her clients, and she will sit up all night with a woman in labor in a ditch, counting with her.

### THEIR STORY

Petra’s mother, a Tarnbrow girl, was smuggled out of Cradlewrack carrying in 603, and bore Petra at the Weeping Post, the wet inn where the Rim crosses into Sallowreach’s fog. Petra grew up on the Rim. In 627 she went to Kest out of curiosity and found herself in the Tally: *one, living, at the Weeping Post, to a woman of Tarnbrow*. The country had gone with her mother. Petra has been trying to outrun it ever since, on other women’s behalf.

She has run more than two hundred carrying travelers past the Gate since 629, by goat-track and hollow cart. In every land the ground under the birth turned warm and red. Once, in Lowmark in

637, it did not: the child was born on wet planking, ordinary, and the Tally in Kest recorded nothing. A month later the mother walked into the sea. Petra does not know whether that counts.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

To the Attendance, Petra is a criminal; to the turned-back in the Gate’s yard, she is the only door. She charges forty lacks a head, or nothing if the woman cannot pay, and the Company’s factors overlook her because she keeps her carts off their tolls. The Assemblers have used her without her knowledge: in 639 one of her clients was carrying a Part, not a child, and it went over the border inside her and was sold in Sallowreach.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A crossbow** — Company issue, stolen in 630, with a stock carved in Rim tallies.
- ◇ **The cart** — a mule-cart with a hollow bed under the turnips that holds two women lying down.
- ◇ **A forged pass** — a Company pass with a factor’s seal that Merriam Toll has twice failed to notice.
- ◇ **The Tally extract** — her own entry, folded small.

- ◇ **A vial of Brinehollow brine** — from the Lowmark birth. She thinks it might be the answer.
- ◇ **A midwife's kit** — cord-thread, a basin, linen. No knife. She will not carry one.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to find one place where the rule does not hold. She fears that there is none, and that she has been carrying the country across the Rim in other women's bellies for twelve years.

**Secret (she knows it):** she knows about Bryony Breech. In 638 she walked three carrying women through the Gate in daylight by telling the Marshal, quietly, that she knew. It was blackmail, and it worked, and she has not dared try it twice.

**Secret (she does not know it):** wherever she has delivered a woman abroad, the soil is still warm. There are now forty-one red patches around the Rim, and each has begun, very slowly, to dilate.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Marshal Gideon Breech** — her opponent, her blackmail, and in some way her only peer.
- ◇ **Factor Merriam Toll** — the Company woman who looks the other way, conditionally.
- ◇ **Una Clayhand** — the Assembler who sent her the client carrying a Part.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — has signed Petra's bricking warrant. It is pinned up at every parish board.

#### IN PLAY

Petra hires characters as guards or drivers, or they meet her on the Rim with a cart full of women. She wants muscle and an answer.

- ◇ **The Turned-Back.** Nine women, the Gate, a mule-cart and a marshal with a secret. See the core chapter.
- ◇ **Red Ground.** In a Fatlands village where Petra delivered a woman years ago, a perfect round hole has opened in a turnip field.
- ◇ **The Sea's Answer.** Petra wants to take a woman to Lowmark to deliver in the water, and needs someone who knows the Netwatch.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She sat with me in a ditch for nine hours and counted. Then she drove my baby and me into the Fatlands and the ground went red under us. She cried more than I did." — a former client

"Forty lacks a head. That's the going rate for despair on this road." — a Company toll-keeper

"I could catch her. I would rather know where she is." — Marshal Gideon Breech

# QUEEN DOWAGER SIBYL AUBREY, AND THE KING WITHIN

*the Long Carrying*

*“Ask him if I may rest. No, my lord Chamberlain, not in the Council. Here. Now. Ask him.”*

– THE QUEEN DOWAGER, TO LORD CHAMBERLAIN EAMON SEELE, A NIGHT IN  
LACK 640

| QUEEN DOWAGER SIBYL AUBREY – THE LONG CARRYING |                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                     | Cradlewrack · Cut 5 (Caul-line, House Aubrey) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 8                                                                                                                     |
| AGE & STATION                                  | 90; Queen Dowager of Cradlewrack, mother and vessel of the King                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                             | Scion · Standing 5 (Great House: a crown, carried)                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                                     | Hand 1 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                         | Endure 5, Resolve 5, Clause 4, Lore 4, Instinct 4, Persuade 3, Rites 3                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                                           | Flesh 16 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                                          | The Vessel (she cannot be brought below 1 Flesh while the King Within lives; Ruin falls on her as Injuries but never kills); Through the Veil (as the Duchess Morwen, while her thinning caul is down) |
| WANTS                                          | Attend (Hard 14); Keep the Veil (Hard 14)                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                                         | Dowager’s Patience, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                                   | The Gaslight (thirty years of being told what her son said have left her unable to trust what she herself felt)                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                        | the litter, the Book of Kicks, a ring of the Eighth Aldous, a silver ear-trumpet, poppy drops, a knitted cap                                                                                           |
| DREAD                                          | 2 (to see the belly move; Dread 4 to feel him answer)                                                                                                                                                  |

| ALDOUS THE NINTH – THE KING WITHIN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                         | Cradlewrack · Cut 5 (Caul-line, House Aubrey) · Regrowth not counted; the Attendance declines to examine a king                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                      | conceived 597; forty-four years in the womb; King of Cradlewrack                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                 | none · rules by kick                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                         | Hand 3 · Gut 5 · Lung 0 · Eye — · Tongue 1 · Caul 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                             | Godsign 5, Instinct 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                               | Flesh as his mother · Guard none · Armor her body · Fray none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                            | none, except against her                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                              | Royal Assent (one kick is law; the Attendance and the Council act on it); The Count (three, one, three, at night; anyone who sleeps within the same walls for a week dreams of a door being knocked on); Answering (once per session, the King replies by kick to a question asked somewhere else entirely, and the GM should know where) |
| WANTS                              | unknown; he has never been asked                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                              | 4 (to feel him answer a question nobody asked)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## WHO THEY ARE

The litter comes first: a long, deep, padded thing of red leather on poles, borne by eight women of the Queen's household in grey, who change shoulders every hundred paces without breaking step. In it lies a tiny, white-haired, papery woman of ninety under a quilt, her thinning caul folded back from her face like a hood of old wet silk, and over her rises the belly. It is the size of a calf, taut, veined blue, and it does not change. It has not grown in thirty years. It moves. The kicks under the quilt are a grown man's kicks, slow and heavy; the bearers feel them through the poles.

She smells of rose-water and poppy and, underneath, of milk gone thin. Her voice is a whisper with perfect court diction. She is gracious, vague, exhausted, and capable of sudden, startling sharpness, and she thanks every servant by name.

## THEIR STORY

Sibyl Aubrey was born in 551, veiled, a daughter of the Aubrey kings, and married her cousin Aldous the Eighth in 570. Their marriage was long and childless, which in Cradlewrack is a kind of miracle. In Grace 597, at forty-six, she conceived. The Tally entered the heir with rejoicing. He was due in Plenty 598. He did not come.

Aldous the Eighth died in 601 in the deep chambers of the Aubrey palace at Kest, crowning at the breast, and his son was proclaimed King in the womb. The Attendance attended the Queen every month for ten years, and then every year, and then stopped. In 611 the Veiled Council asked the King, through the Lord Chamberlain, whether he wished to be delivered. He did not kick. Since then he has ruled. The questions are read aloud to the Queen's belly in the Throne Room once a week, and the Chamberlain announces the answers, and the Attendance governs accordingly.

In Carving 640, alone in her bed, Sibyl felt him kick three times, then once, then three, then nothing, and then again, over and over until dawn. No one had asked him anything. It has happened every night since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Crown is the Attendance's convenience and the Council's instrument. A kick validates laws, warrants, marshals' commissions and the Tally's annual seal; without the King's assent, nothing the Attendance does is legal, and with it, everything is. The Lord Chamberlain decides which questions are asked and how. The Queen decides nothing. She is lifted, washed, fed, turned, read to, and carried to the Throne Room on Councildays. Her household of forty women serve her for life. Absalom Gage bricks her chamber each night, at her request, and breaks it open each dawn.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The litter** — red leather, forty years old, with a rest for the belly and straps for the pangs.

- ◇ **The Book of Kicks** — the Chamberlain's record of every question and every answer since 611. She keeps a private copy, in her own hand, of the questions she has asked at night. Most have no answer written.
- ◇ **A ring of the Eighth Aldous** — her husband's, on a cord, too large for her fingers now.
- ◇ **A silver ear-trumpet** — for listening to her own belly. She does it at night, in the dark.
- ◇ **Poppy drops** — a bottle of laudanum, a lack's worth a week, for the kicks.
- ◇ **A knitted cap** — for an infant, made in 597. She knits a new one every Lack, a size larger, and never the right size.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to rest. She wants, if she is honest, to be delivered or to die, and she no longer much cares which. She fears that he will outlive her inside her.

**Secret (she knows it):** in Lack 640 she asked him, alone, whether she might be delivered. He did not kick. Then she asked whether he would let her die, and he kicked once. She has told no one.

**Secret (she does not know it):** the three-one-three is a knock. It is the knock the highlands give a new brick in the Stillyard, three times, and then the answer, and then three again. The King is answering someone knocking. Absalom Gage feels the same pattern in the walls he has laid; Old Hinge hears it on the far side of the Sill. When the Queen asks the GM where the knocking comes from, the answer is that it comes from the room with the table.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lord Chamberlain Eamon Seele** — reads the questions. She trusts him and should not.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — governs by her son's kicks and has not examined her in thirty years.
- ◇ **Duchess Iphigene Morwen** — her great-niece; the two sit in the dark together once a year.
- ◇ **Absalom Gage** — bricks her in each night. He is the only man who touches her walls.
- ◇ **Ambrose, the Eldest Infant** — visits and sits with his ear to the belly, and listens, and once laughed.

## IN PLAY

Characters meet the Queen as petitioners at court, as guards for her litter on a progress, or when she sends for them privately, at night, because she wants a question asked that the Chamberlain will not ask.

- ◇ **The Unasked Question.** The Queen begs the characters to find what her son is answering. The trail leads to the Stillyard and the Sill.
- ◇ **The Forged Kick.** The characters discover that the Chamberlain has been reading questions so that silence counts



as yes. The King's last real kick contradicts a law.

- ◇ **Deliver Her.** A faction of the Late-faction wants the Queen delivered by the knife. The rumor says the pangs will stop. They will not.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"I carried my three for nine months each and thought I'd die. She's carried him forty-four years and says please and thank you." — a bearer of the Queen's litter

"He has never once kicked against the Attendance. Draw your own conclusions about kings." — Brother Callum Stillwater

"Three, one, three. I'd know it anywhere. I lay that course every evening." — Absalom Gage

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# DR. LAZAR VOSS

*the Anatomist of the Whole*

*“Two hundred Parts and not one of them is the same Part twice. I have nine left thumbs. I have no right ones. You understand? It is not a body. It is an inventory.”*

— DR. LAZAR VOSS, TO DOV MARRIN, CARVING 640

| DR. LAZAR VOSS – THE ANATOMIST OF THE WHOLE |                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | The Vigil · Cut 3 (Eye-line, a minor house) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                               | 44; anatomist, Fellow of the Vigil’s Anatomy Theatre, resident in Kest since 639                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Seamer · Standing 3 (Seamer)                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                                      | Stitching 5, Reckoning 4, Lore 4, Search 4, Craft 3, Blades 2, Endure 2, Persuade 2                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                                     | scalpel +6 (2, Piercing); Waker’s needle +6 (2, Piercing, Waking)                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                       | Tight Seams (as the Seamer talent); The Long Look (Vigil, Appetite; he may blink under guard to ask one question about a sleeper; in Cradlewrack he asks about the figure instead, and gains 2 Fray) |
| WANTS                                       | To Count (Routine 10; rows, Parts, teeth, eyes; he counts aloud to the end before acting)                                                                                                            |
| KNACKS                                      | Counting Habit, Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | The Seeing (since he began to sleep)                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                     | the folio, calipers, rouse, a jar with an ear, a Waker’s needle, a letter of credit                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                                       | 1 (Dread 3 to see the drawing complete)                                                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

Narrow, pale, upright, beautifully dressed in Vigil black with a tin-studded collar, his red-rimmed eyes ringed in violet and never quite still. He has the trained wide stare of the sleepless and a habit of wetting his lips before he speaks. He smells of camphor, spirit and the bitter-almond reek of strong rouse. His manners are impeccable and his questions are surgical. He laughs rarely and at the wrong moments.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 597 in the Vigil to a minor lidless house, Voss never slept in his life until he was forty-two. He trained in the Anatomy Theatre, dissected the Counted the Matron released, and published on the musculature of the sleepless. In 639 he came to Kest on his own commission, with a letter of credit from Lady Seraphine Dalgety, to study the Parts. Outside the Vigil, a Vigilant can sleep. He slept on his second night, for eleven hours, and woke weeping. He has examined two hundred Parts since, in the Barn, the Lying-In’s study cells and private collections, and drawn each to scale, and fitted the drawings together on a long table in his lodgings.

The figure they make is not Herself. It has hands at the end of every limb, nine left thumbs, doors in its chest, more than two of several things, and a head that is mostly mouth. Some of the Parts in it were not born in Cradlewrack: a grey finger of nine joints, a lidless eye, a lump of something with a bone pit, a tongue that came from Oathen. Some belong to no god he can name.

He has begun to dream. In the dream he is in a long, warm room with a table laid, and he counts the chairs, and there is always one more than he counted.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Voss has no place in the land; he is a foreigner with money and a scalpel, tolerated by the Attendance because he examines Parts before they are surrendered, and welcomed by the Assemblers because he can tell them where a Part goes. He sells copies of his drawings to the Second Table through Lady Dalgety, at three hundred lacks a sheet. He depends on rouse, which is costly in Kest, and on letters of credit that are beginning to come with questions.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The folio** — two hundred drawings and the great composite, folded in eight. It is the most dangerous document in the highlands.
- ◇ **Calipers** — Cutwright's calipers, Vigil brass.
- ◇ **Rouse** — a tin of Crane's strong rouse. He is addicted (Need 3) and takes it now to stay awake rather than dream.
- ◇ **A jar with an ear** — a born ear from Rudge, his first specimen. It turns toward him in the night.
- ◇ **A Waker's needle** — for himself, when the dream comes too near.
- ◇ **A letter of credit** — from Lady Seraphine Dalgety, for two thousand lacks. It asks, in the last line, how one would carve it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to finish the drawing. He fears sleep, and he fears that the drawing is a portrait of what he sees in it.

**Secret (he knows it):** the composite has two places a heart could go. One is filled in the Barn. The other is not filled anywhere yet, and he has calculated its size. It is the size of the Dilation.

**Secret (he does not know it):** the long room in his dream is the room Old Hinge hears described through the Sill, and the chair he counts is pulled out for him.

## TIES

- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — his host and subject. Voss has not told him that Herself is only part of what the drawing shows.
- ◇ **Lady Seraphine Dalgety** — his patron in the Vigil and a Carver of the Second Table.
- ◇ **Lord Casimir Morwen** — buys copies too, and asks the same last question.
- ◇ **Ambrose** — the only person who has looked at the composite and named it, and he refuses to repeat the name.

## IN PLAY

Voss hires characters to fetch Parts from private collections, or to steal the drawing back from whoever has it. He wants Parts from other lands to complete the figure.

- ◇ **The Missing Sheet.** One drawing is stolen: the head. Whoever has it begins to dream of the long room.
- ◇ **Foreign Parts.** Voss pays well for a Hand-line finger from Sallowreach, because he thinks it fits.

- ◇ **The Second Heart.** Voss asks the characters to go down into the Dilation and measure.

## SAID OF THEM

"He counted my teeth, sir. Without asking. Then he said thank you and wrote it down." — a Kest innkeeper

"He sleeps now. I hear him. He wakes up counting." — his landlady in Kest

"His drawing is beautiful. It is also wrong, I think, in a way that will turn out right." — Dov Marrin

# JUNIPER DELL, CALLED FIRSTWORD

*the Half-Sentence*

“When it opens, tell them that the...”

– JUNIPER DELL, EVERY MORNING SINCE SHE WAS BORN

| JUNIPER DELL – FIRSTWORD |                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 0                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION            | 8; a shepherd's daughter of Tarnbrow                                                                                                                                             |
| CALLING & STANDING       | none                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 5                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                   | Instinct 4, Godsign 3, Stealth 3, Craft 2 (drawing), Athletics 2                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                     | Flesh 9 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                  | none                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                    | The Half (when she says her sentence, every door, lid and knot within ten paces comes undone, and anyone who has heard the other half anywhere feels it, Dread 2); Knock (Taste) |
| WANTS                    | Leave It Open (Routine 10); Finish (she seeks the other half; she will walk toward anyone who might have it)                                                                     |
| KNACKS                   | Light Sleeper, Kin-Sense                                                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS             | none                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                  | a slate and chalk, a bag of drawings, a wooden lamb, a knocker's ring, a key she found                                                                                           |
| DREAD                    | 2 (to hear her say it, and to hear the room go quiet after)                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Small for eight, solemn, with straight black hair cut at the jaw, chapped cheeks and steady grey eyes that look at adults for a long time before they decide anything. She is not mute; she simply has nothing else to say. She nods, shakes her head, writes on her slate in a clear round hand, and laughs, often, silently, with her whole body. She smells of sheep and woodsmoke. She draws all day. What she draws is always doors: standing doors, doors in hillsides, doors in people's chests, and one door again and again, oak, iron-bound, ajar, alone on a hill, though she has never been north of Tarnbrow.

When she is frightened, or asked her name, or when she wakes, she says it, in a clear grown voice that is not quite hers: *When it opens, tell them that the*. And stops. And looks around, as if someone should answer.

## THEIR STORY

She was born in Tarnbrow in 633 to Annis Dell, a shepherd's wife, and the Attendant heard the half-sentence come out of her before her first breath was finished. The Attendant asked the Two Questions. Speaking children stay. Juniper's father, Aled, went into labor in Lack 640 and did not live; what came out of him is the thing in the loft. Annis keeps the sheep alone, with help from a

neighbour's boy. Last winter, Annis was paid a year's wages by a tall midwife from Kest to keep something in the loft over the byre, and not to tell anyone, and Annis did, because a year's wages is a year's wages. Juniper climbs the loft ladder every evening with a candle. She says her sentence up there, and the thing in the loft listens, and lately it says, in a small new voice, *the*.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She has none, except as an object of interest. The parish Attendant calls monthly. The Assemblers, who believe the figure lacks a voice and that Juniper carries half of it, watch her through Una Clayhand, who has rented a cottage across the lane. Pilgrims have begun to come up from the Rimwatch to hear her say it. Annis turns them away and takes their bread.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A slate and chalk** — her voice. Her handwriting is very good.
- ◇ **A bag of drawings** — eighty doors, on any paper she can find. Old Hinge would recognise forty of them.
- ◇ **A wooden lamb** — carved by her father, missing an ear.
- ◇ **A knocker's ring** — brass, too big, which she knocks with before every door, three times, and waits.

- ◇ **A key** — an old iron key she found in a crowning by the stream. It fits nothing in Tarnbrow.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the other half. She believes absolutely that someone, somewhere, was born with it. She fears that when she finds them, she will have to say the whole thing, and that the whole thing will be true.

**Secret (she knows it):** the thing in the loft has started saying *the* when she stops. She has told it that it is not allowed to say any more until she finds the right person.

**Secret (she does not know it):** there are several candidates, and the GM should choose. The thing in Sabeth Thorne's loft. The King Within. Nettle Corse. Herself, who has no voice yet. Whatever describes the view to Old Hinge. The sentence may also never have had another half, and the other half may be whatever Cradlewrack says when it is born.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Annis Dell** — her mother, tired, loving, out of her depth.
- ◇ **The thing in the loft** — Sabeth Thorne's spared child. Juniper calls it Brother.
- ◇ **Sabeth Thorne** — the tall midwife who visits. Juniper draws her with a door in her hand.
- ◇ **Una Clayhand** — the kind woman across the lane.
- ◇ **Ede and Ada Crewe** — tried to finish her sentence, and bled. She wrote them a note afterwards: *Sorry. Not you.*

#### IN PLAY

Characters meet Juniper on the road to Tarnbrow, or in the Missing Hand. She wants to be taken north, to the door she draws.

- ◇ **The Pilgrim.** A stranger at the Dell door says, softly, the second half. Juniper goes very still. Nobody else heard it.
- ◇ **Taken.** Una Clayhand takes Juniper to the Barn on a pang night. The characters have until dawn.
- ◇ **The Drawing.** Juniper draws one of the characters standing in a door in the ground with their arms spread.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She says it every morning before she says good morning, which she can't say, so she says it instead." — Annis Dell

"I have heard a great many first words. Hers was the first one that was not a beginning." — the parish Attendant of Tarnbrow

"She knocks on my door three times and waits. I've never had the heart to say come in. I always open it." — a Tarnbrow neighbour

# OLD HINGE

## Keeper of the Sill

*“Oh, it’s a fine view tonight. Long room, warm, the cloth very white. A great many chairs. One pulled out. No, I’ve not looked. Never needed to. It tells me.”*

— OLD HINGE, TO A PILGRIM, CARVING 641

| OLD HINGE – KEEPER OF THE SILL |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| AGE & STATION                  | about 80; Keeper of the Sill by Attendance appointment since 583                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING             | none; a keeper by inheritance, paid by the Crown                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                         | Resolve 5, Craft 4, Instinct 4, Lore 3, Reckoning 3, Endure 2, Wayfaring 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                                                                                        |
| BODY                           | Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTACKS                        | oak cane +4 (3, Stunning)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                          | Knock (Taste); Undoing (Appetite; he may open anything by touch with a Partake, but he uses it only to ease the Sill’s hinges); Not Looking (he automatically succeeds on any roll to keep his eyes from something, and gains +2 to resist any invitation) |
| WANTS                          | Leave It Open (Hard 14; he has never closed the Sill, and could not if he tried); Attend (Hard 14)                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                         | No Thank You, Elder’s Ear, Dowager’s Patience                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                   | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                        | the oil can, the Hinge Rod, the Book of the View, a stool, a small mirror, a lantern                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                          | 1 (Dread 3 to hear the voice through the gap; Dread 4 if it says your name)                                                                                                                                                                                |

### WHO THEY ARE

A bent, bald, nut-brown old man with knuckles like walnuts, a long humorous face and a dry pleasant voice that never hurries. He smells of mutton fat, peat-smoke and the iron-salt grease he works into the Sill’s hinges. He lives in a turf hut a hundred paces downhill, built with its one window facing away from the door, and he spends his days on a three-legged stool with his back to the hilltop, oiling, mending, talking to visitors, and listening behind him. He is polite to everyone and opinionated about weather, hinges, and the Attendance’s young midwives. He has a very good laugh.

### THEIR STORY

His name was Pell Lintel. His mother kept the Sill before him, and her mother before her. He came up the hill as a boy in 571 to carry the oil, and took the keeping in 583, when his mother came down one night and sat by the fire and said, quite calmly, that it had asked her to come and see. She was gone by morning. Her stool was at the door, turned round to face it.

He has oiled the hinges every day for fifty-eight years. Each Grace he lays the Hinge Rod, a measuring stick notched by every keeper

since the Gorging, across the gap. By the rod the door opens a finger’s width more each year, as the old rule says. By the eye it never looks wider than a hand. The door, Hinge says, is opening into somewhere larger than the gap. This Grace it opened a full hand’s width in one night. He has not told the Attendance.

Most nights since he was a young man, a voice on the other side has described the view. It is pleasant, unhurried, never the same voice twice. Lately it asks small questions: how many live in the highlands, whether the bread is good this year, whether he is hungry.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Sill is the Crown’s oldest charge. The keeper is paid two lacks a day by the Tally-house, delivered monthly with oil, flour and a midwife’s visit. The Attendance logs his measurements. The Barren Order sends Hearers to pray against the door. The Assemblers want the hill. Pilgrims come to sit beside him and hear the view.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

◇ **The oil can** — tin, with mutton fat and spring salt.

- ◇ **The Hinge Rod** — eight feet of black oak, six hundred and forty-one notches, the oldest in a hand nobody can read.
- ◇ **The Book of the View** — what the voice has said, night by night, since 590. The latest pages are mostly questions.
- ◇ **A stool** — three-legged, facing downhill.
- ◇ **A small mirror** — his mother's, wrapped in cloth. He has never unwrapped it. It is the easiest way to look.
- ◇ **A lantern** — he lights it at dusk and sets it on the threshold for whatever is coming. He does not know why. His mother did.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to keep the Sill until someone young comes to take it, and he wants that someone not to look. He fears the night it stops describing and asks him to come and see.

**Secret (he knows it):** it asked, three nights ago. He said no, thank you. It said that was quite all right, there was no hurry, and it would lay a place.

**Secret (he does not know it):** the three-one-three knocking he hears on the far side at night is answered, every time, from the Queen Dowager's chamber in Kest.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Agnes Latch** — the Doorwright, who studies the Sill through a glass and brings him good oil in exchange.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — draws his door. He has seen one of her drawings and wept.
- ◇ **Rufus Ochre** — will come walking north behind the unaccounted.
- ◇ **Herself** — has turned her head toward his hill. He knows. The door told him.

#### IN PLAY

Characters come to the Sill as pilgrims, as Attendance messengers, or because everything in the highlands is walking there. Hinge wants someone to sit with him at night, and someone to promise to keep the Sill when he is gone.

- ◇ **The Place Laid.** At dawn there is a chair on the hill, beside the door, on the near side.
- ◇ **The Mirror.** A character offers to look for him, with the mirror.
- ◇ **The Keeping.** Hinge dies in the night, on his stool, facing the right way. Someone must take the oil can before dusk.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He told me what was on the other side. He said it as kindly as my granny said grace. I've not slept with my back to a door since." — a pilgrim from the Rimwatch

"He is the best keeper the Sill has ever had, because he is the least curious man in Cradlewrack." — a Senior of the Lying

"Bread's good this year, I told it. It said it was glad. It said it would be along." — Old Hinge



# NEW FACES OF CRADLEWRACK

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The core account of the highlands named five people beyond the bible's roll and gave a stat block to a sixth thing that is not quite a person. They are given their full due here, with two more who stand

at the hinges of the land's power: the man who reads questions to a queen's belly, and the woman who reads the land for Parts.

# WENNA THRALE

## the Apprentice

*“Thirty-one. I named every one on the walk. I’m not to. I know I’m not to.”*

– WENNA THRALE, TO DOLOUR PYM, WITHOUT KNOWING WHY SHE SAID IT

| WENNA THRALE – THE APPRENTICE |                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                               |
| AGE & STATION                 | 20; apprentice (Third Hand) of the Attendance, third year of her apron                |
| CALLING & STANDING            | Midwife · Standing 1 (Handmaid)                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                   |
| SKILLS                        | Stitching 3, Instinct 3, Endure 2, Labor 2, Resolve 2, Rites 2, Athletics 2, Blades 1 |
| BODY                          | Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                |
| ATTACKS                       | knife +4 (2)                                                                          |
| GIFTS                         | The Two Questions (Midwife talent); Knock (Taste)                                     |
| WANTS                         | Leave It Open (Routine 10)                                                            |
| KNACKS                        | Old Grief, Mother’s Hands                                                             |
| CARRIES                       | apron, stitching kit, the list, a stub of wax, her master’s spare linen               |
| DREAD                         | 0                                                                                     |

### WHO THEY ARE

Freckled, raw-knuckled from the laundries, with a quick nervous smile and a body built for holding doors. She smells of lye. She writes everything down, fast and neatly, and does not look at what she carries.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 621 to a Kest laundress, Wenna apprenticed to Sabeth Thorne at seventeen because Sabeth was the best and Wenna wanted to be. She has stood against a hundred doors and carried thirty-one bundles to the Low Wall. She wrote the account of Corran’s flank-birth that opens the core chapter. She keeps a list of the struck-through she has carried, each with a name given on the walk.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She holds the door. She is the Attendance’s future: young, steady, clever, and doubtful. Orla Kest has noticed her.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The list** — thirty-one names in a laundry book: Ash, Small Corran, Plum, Notyet, Wick.
- ◇ **Apron and stitching kit** — regulation.
- ◇ **A stub of wax** — she seals the list each night.

- ◇ **Sabeth’s spare linen** — for the knot that cannot come undone.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be an Opinion. She is afraid she will be good at it. **Secret (she knows it):** Sabeth spared one, and Wenna knows where. **Secret (she does not know it):** two of her thirty-one are alive in Dolour Pym’s cottage, and answer to the names she gave them.

### TIES

- ◇ **Sabeth Thorne** — her master, whom she would follow into the Dilation.
- ◇ **Dolour Pym** — kind to her; she does not know why it feels like being watched.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — offers her the knife early.

### IN PLAY

She is the party’s way into a birthing-room. **Seeds:** Orla orders her to report on Sabeth; Dolour calls one of her nurslings by a name from Wenna’s list; Wenna is sent alone to a birth and asks a character to hold the door.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She doesn’t look. That’s the best thing you can say of an apprentice.” — Sabeth Thorne

“She brings back the linen folded. Most of them throw it in the copper.” — a Lying-In laundress

“Her list’s longer than mine was at her age. I burned mine.” — Orla Kest

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# LORD CASIMIR MORWEN

the Consort

*“A thicker veil, my dear. That is all I have ever asked of the god. Is it so very much?”*

— LORD CASIMIR, TO THE NURSE WHO BROUGHT HIM A COVERED DISH

| LORD CASIMIR MORWEN — THE CONSORT |                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                        | Cradlewrack · Cut 5 (Caul-line, House Morwen) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 8                                    |
| AGE & STATION                     | 47; Consort of Morwen; Trencherman of the Second Table                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING                | Scion · Standing 4 (Head of a House, in all but name)                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                        | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                   |
| SKILLS                            | Persuade 4, Deceive 4, Godsign 4, Clause 3, Instinct 3, Blades 2, Rites 2                                             |
| BODY                              | Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                           | stiletto +4 (2, Concealable)                                                                                          |
| GIFTS                             | Bear (Course); Through the Veil, Turned (he cannot be read by veiled eyes, his wife’s included, unless he faces them) |
| WANTS                             | Keep the Veil (Grim 18); Gather (Grim 18)                                                                             |
| KNACKS                            | Smell of Cedar, Conditional                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                           | orris perfume, a Second Table fork, a ledger of cauls, a key to a bricked room, a nurse’s purse                       |
| DREAD                             | 2 (Dread 3 to see what he carries)                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Slender, soft-spoken, veiled like his wife but thinner-membraned, so that his features show: fine nose, small smile. He perfumes himself heavily with orris, and under it there is something sour, like milk left in a warm room. He is always pleasant. He never stands in front of his wife when he speaks to her.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 594 to the Morwen line, recorded in the Cutwrights’ locked shorthand beside his cousin Iphigene, he married her in 611. He was taken by the Course at thirty and carries more than she does. He joined the Second Table in 630, and paid for the Assemblers’ roof in 638 in the Table’s coin.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He runs the house’s accounts, its springs and its trade in cauls through Merriam Toll, and he sends what his wife delivers to the Barn.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Orris perfume** — a crystal flask.
- ◇ **A silver fork** — the Second Table’s token, in his sleeve.
- ◇ **A ledger of cauls** — what he sold, to whom.
- ◇ **A key** — to the bricked chamber in the east gallery.

- ◇ **A nurse’s purse** — wages for silence.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants an heir with a veil thicker than any before, and he wants a portion of the god when it is carved. **Secret (he knows it):** he has sold the Second Table the day of the Dilation’s opening, which his wife foresaw. **Secret (he does not know it):** he has borne the heir. In 639 the nurses could not bring themselves to carry it out; they bricked it into the east gallery, and it is growing, veiled in a caul as thick as harness leather, and it knocks.

## TIES

- ◇ **Iphigene Morwen** — his wife and cousin, whom he fears.
- ◇ **Lady Isolde Morwen** — his uncauled daughter, whom he despises.
- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — his supplier and creditor.
- ◇ **Factor Merriam Toll** — his buyer.

## IN PLAY

He hires characters for discreet errands. **Seeds:** a cart to the Barn; a bricked room that must not be opened; a Second Table supper at Morwen Hall with an eighth chair.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“He pays double. Nobody pays double for nothing.” — a Morwen nurse

“His veil is thin. You can see him smile. I wish you couldn’t.” — Lady Isolde Morwen

“A man of excellent appetite.” — Lady Seraphine Dalgety of the Vigil

---

# ABSALOM GAGE

the Bricklayer

(He does not speak much. When he does it is loud, as the deaf speak.) “COURSE AND MORTAR. NINE STITCHES. KNOCK THRICE. NEXT.”

— ABSALOM GAGE, AT THE STILLYARD

| ABSALOM GAGE – THE BRICKLAYER |                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 2                                                    |
| AGE & STATION                 | 60; chief mason of the Stillyard of Kest                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING            | none; Master of the Masons’ Lodge                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 1 · Caul 3                                                           |
| SKILLS                        | Craft 5, Labor 5, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Brawl 2, Search 2                                                      |
| BODY                          | Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 4                                                        |
| ATTACKS                       | brick-hammer +6 (3, Stunning)                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                         | Knock (Taste; his palm hears what his ears cannot); Undoing (Appetite; he does not use it, except for Dolour) |
| WANTS                         | Leave It Open (Hard 14), which for a bricklayer is a kind of hell                                             |
| KNACKS                        | Strong Back, Silent Supper                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                       | a trowel worn to a sliver, a hod, a pick (lent), a slate of names, lime                                       |
| DREAD                         | 0                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

Broad, white with lime-dust from hair to boots, deaf in both ears since a pang brought a wall down on him in 609, with a voice like a shovel and hands that feel walls as other men listen to music.

## THEIR STORY

He has laid the Stillyard’s walls for forty years and bricked the cautious of Kest into their rooms each night, so that he knows who sleeps where better than the Tally does. Last year he began to feel knocking from inside walls he had laid. He knocks back.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He commands sixty masons, keeps the Low Wall and the Debt Wall, and bricks the Queen Dowager into her chamber each night at her request.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A trowel** — worn to a sliver.
- ◇ **A slate** — of who is bricked where tonight.
- ◇ **Lime** — for the knots of the dead.
- ◇ **The empty hook** — where his pick hangs when Dolour has it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the knocking to stop and is afraid it will. **Secret (he knows it):** he rebricks the niches Dolour Pym opens. **Secret (he does not know it):** the three-one-three in his walls is the same knock as the Queen’s son’s kicks.

## TIES

- ◇ **Dolour Pym** — bread on his step.
- ◇ **Queen Dowager Sibyl** — he feels the King through her wall.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — signs his bricking warrants.

## IN PLAY

**Seeds:** a condemned man in the Debt Wall stops eating and starts knocking; Absalom asks a character to put an ear where he cannot; a wall he laid in 612 dilates.

## SAID OF THEM

“He bricked me in on my wedding night. Best mortar in Kest. Nothing got in.” — a Kest bride

“He hears the dead better than I hear the living.” — Tamsin Gorse

“He knocked back. I saw him. The wall stopped.” — a Stillyard watchman

# TAMSIN GORSE

## the Stitch-Mender

*“Sit. Bite this. Nine stitches, same as last pang, same as next. Don’t look at it, it doesn’t like being looked at.”*

– TAMSIN GORSE, AT THE REOPENING WARD

| TAMSIN GORSE – THE STITCH-MENDER |                                                                               |
|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                    |
| AGE & STATION                    | 36; surgeon of the Reopening Ward, Kest                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Seamer · Standing 3 (Seamer)                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                           |
| SKILLS                           | Stitching 5, Blades 2, Endure 2, Feast 2, Persuade 2, Reckoning 2, Instinct 2 |
| BODY                             | Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                        |
| ATTACKS                          | scalpel +6 (2)                                                                |
| GIFTS                            | Tight Seams; Rehearsal (Appetite)                                             |
| WANTS                            | Leave It Open (Hard 14); Attend (Hard 14)                                     |
| KNACKS                           | Mother’s Hands, Gallows Laugh                                                 |
| CARRIES                          | surgeon’s case, catgut by the yard, a hand-mirror, spirit, caul-poultice      |
| DREAD                            | 1 (Dread 3 to see the eye in her side)                                        |

### WHO THEY ARE

Brisk, cheerful, red-cheeked, smelling of spirit and catgut, with a joke for every wound and a steadiness that the old soldiers love.

### THEIR STORY

Born 605, the third child of the Gorse household of Kest, she trained under the Seamers’ rules imported from Sallowreach and opened the Reopening Ward in 632. Last month her childhood hay-hook scar opened during a pang, and in the mirror she saw an eye in it, looking out. She closed it with nine stitches. She checks it hourly.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Every morning after a pang the Ward fills: Foundling soldiers, cut-for-stone widows, Barren brothers whose sutures have opened. She closes them all. She cuts the Crewe sisters apart once a month.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A surgeon’s case** — Vigil steel.
- ◇ **Catgut** — by the yard.
- ◇ **A hand-mirror** — for the hourly look.
- ◇ **Caul-poultice** — for herself.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to close everything. **Secret (she knows it):** the eye has opened twice more and it weeps clear salt water. **Secret (she does not know it):** patients on her Ward are seeing eyes in their scars too, and all of them look toward the Dilation.

### TIES

- ◇ **Ede and Ada Crewe** — she keeps them two.
- ◇ **Brother Callum Stillwater** — resewn every nine days.
- ◇ **General Tibb** — sends his soldiers to her.

### IN PLAY

**Seeds:** a patient’s scar opens and says the characters’ names; the Barren Order asks her to stop sewing Callum; she asks a character to hold the mirror.



---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She stitched my belly nine times and made me laugh every time.  
The tenth time she didn’t laugh.” — a Foundling sergeant

“The best hands in Kest. Better than mine, and I would rather she  
never knew it.” — Orla Kest

“She looks at her own side when she thinks no one’s watching.” —  
an orderly

---

# FACTOR MERRIAM TOLL

the Caul-Buyer

*“Should the cauls continue warm, and should the buyers in Lowmark continue satisfied, I would be inclined, barring objection, to renew.”*

— MERRIAM TOLL, TO LORD CASIMIR MORWEN

| FACTOR MERRIAM TOLL – THE CAUL-BUYER |                                                                                   |
|--------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                |
| AGE & STATION                        | 50; Senior Factor of the Rim Road Company at Breech’s Gate                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Factor · Standing 3 (Senior Factor)                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                               |
| SKILLS                               | Haggle 5, Clause 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Lore 2, Instinct 2                   |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                            |
| ATTACKS                              | quill-knife +2 (2, Concealable)                                                   |
| GIFTS                                | The Company Rate; Echo (Oathen Taste; she hears her own words half a second late) |
| WANTS                                | none active abroad                                                                |
| KNACKS                               | Conditional, Bone-Coin Nose                                                       |
| CARRIES                              | Company seal, the caul ledger, a thermometer of Vigil glass, platters, a soft bit |
| DREAD                                | 0                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

Stout, owlsh, spectacled, in Company grey, speaking only in conditionals out of the habit of a lifetime in Oathen, where a careless word breaks bone.

## THEIR STORY

Born in Tacit in 591, she came to the Gate in 628 to run the Open Door and the Company’s highland trade, and has bought cauls for Brinehollow, where they are sewn into sailors’ coats against the Calling, for thirteen years.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She keeps the inn, the tolls, and the caul crates, and she quietly overlooks Petra Quick’s forged pass.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The caul ledger** — every crate since 628.
- ◇ **A Vigil thermometer** — she has begun to measure the cauls.
- ◇ **A soft leather bit** — in case she goes home.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the trade clean and the Company safe. **Secret (she knows it):** the cauls arrive warmer than they leave, and the Company’s

records show Captain Varr died the night of Bryony Breech’s crossing. **Secret (she does not know it):** the Lowmark sailors who wear warm cauls do not walk into the sea; they walk inland, toward Cradlewrack.

## TIES

- ◇ **Lord Casimir Morwen** — her largest seller.
- ◇ **Marshal Breech** — her neighbour and her puzzle.
- ◇ **Petra Quick** — her blind eye.

## IN PLAY

**Seeds:** a crate of cauls turns in the night to face east; Toll asks the characters to escort a caul shipment to Lowmark; the knocking room at the Open Door.

## SAID OF THEM

“She’s never said yes in her life. She’s said *I would be inclined*. It’s the same price.” — a Rim carter

“Conditional, careful, and the only honest factor on the north road.” — Marshal Breech

“She took my mother’s caul and gave me a fair price and asked if I was certain. Nobody else asked.” — a Rudge widow

# HERSELF

## the Assemblers' Figure

*(Breathing. Slow, deep, from many chests at once. On some nights, from one of the forty-one mouths, a sound like the first half of a word.)*

— THE FAR END OF THE ASSEMBLERS' BARN, ANY NIGHT

| HERSELF — THE ASSEMBLERS' FIGURE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Cradlewrack · not applicable; she is the god, in pieces, or something wearing its pieces                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                    | begun 541; eleven feet; four hundred Parts from four hundred families                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING               | none · worshipped                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 5 · Gut 7 · Lung 2 · Eye 1 · Tongue 0 · Caul 6                                                                                                                                                                        |
| SKILLS                           | Brawl 3, Endure 4, Instinct 5                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| BODY                             | Flesh 19 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (seamed hide) · Fray none                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTACKS                          | grasp +8 (4, Grappling, from any of nine arms)                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                            | Many Mothers (the first time she suffers Ruin, Parts tear free and crawl away instead; she rises at full Flesh next pang); Turning (all doors within sight drift open); Kinship (any Part within a mile crawls toward her) |
| WANTS                            | The Sill. The hand. A voice.                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                          | Liss Marrin's heart, the eye of the Duchess, a grey finger of nine joints                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                            | 4 (to see her breathe; Dread 5 if she sits up)                                                                                                                                                                             |

### WHO THEY ARE

She lies on a bed of warm straw under a hundred lamps, eleven feet long, seamed all over with catgut in neat Assembler stitches, skin of forty shades from Rudge red to Morwen grey. She has nine arms and one left hand missing. She has forty-one eyes, which wept last week. She smells of sheepfold in spring, tallow and warm milk. She breathes, and the lamps lean.

### THEIR STORY

Dov Marrin's predecessors began her in 541 with a hand and a forearm from the Furrow case. Every Part brought to the Barn since has gone into her, fitted by Fitters who say the Parts tell them where they belong. In 638 Dov gave her a heart: his wife Liss's, born to her as a Part at sixty and cut free with her blessing. In Plenty 641 Herself turned her head toward the Sill for the first time.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the Assemblers' god, the Second Table's investment, the Barren Order's abomination and the Attendance's great unanswered question.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Liss Marrin's heart** — in the left of two chest-cavities. The right is empty.

- ◇ **The eye of the Duchess** — one of three Parts born of Iphigene Morwen.
- ◇ **A grey finger of nine joints** — from Sallowreach, bought on the Rim.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to stand. **Secret:** she is not Vey; she is what Vey would be if born in the highlands' own image, everyone's, stitched, and parts of her belong to gods who were never eaten here.

### TIES

- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — her midwife.
- ◇ **Hester Lowe's hand** — her missing piece.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — her voice, perhaps.
- ◇ **Old Hinge** — the man at the door she faces.

### IN PLAY

**Seeds:** she sits up during a pang; a character's own scar is drawn toward her across a room; she opens the Barn's far door by looking at it and the Sill, twenty miles away, swings a finger wider.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She knows my Part. She turns that eye to me when I come in. It’s my son’s.” — a Rudge mother

“Herself is the easiest birth the god will ever have. In a barn, among friends.” — Dov Marrin

“I have counted her eyes four times. I get forty-one, forty-one, forty-one, forty-two.” — Dr. Lazar Voss

---

# LORD CHAMBERLAIN EAMON SEELE

*the Reader of Questions*

*“Majesty, the Council asks: is it your will that the Attendance shall not be questioned?  
We take silence, as ever, for consent.”*

— EAMON SEELE, IN THE THRONE ROOM

| LORD CHAMBERLAIN EAMON SEELE – THE READER OF QUESTIONS |                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                             | Cradlewrack · Cut 4 (Caul-line, House Seele) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3 |
| AGE & STATION                                          | 63; Lord Chamberlain of the Crown since 611                                         |
| CALLING & STANDING                                     | Scion · Standing 3 (Lord, by office; his house disowned him)                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                                             | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                 |
| SKILLS                                                 | Clause 5, Persuade 4, Deceive 4, Lore 3, Instinct 3, Resolve 2                      |
| BODY                                                   | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                              |
| ATTACKS                                                | cane-sword +2 (3)                                                                   |
| GIFTS                                                  | The Name (Scion talent); Begin (Appetite; he cannot leave a question unframed)      |
| WANTS                                                  | Begin (Hard 14)                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                                 | Conditional, Hostage’s Smile                                                        |
| CARRIES                                                | the Book of Kicks, the Crown’s seal, his own dried caul, an ear-trumpet             |
| DREAD                                                  | 0                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

A tall, silver-haired man with a bare face (his caul came away at birth, disgracing him), a beautiful reading voice, and fingers stained with sealing-wax. He smells of bay rum.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 578 to House Seele,uncauled and therefore a cadet, he made himself indispensable at court and was named Chamberlain in 611, when the Council first decided to ask the King anything. He has framed every question since. He discovered early that how a question is asked decides what silence means.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the most powerful man in Cradlewrack that nobody fears: every law passes through his phrasing. The Attendance pays his household. The Council fears his wording.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Book of Kicks** — the official one.
- ◇ **His own caul** — dried, in a locket. He was never allowed to eat it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be thought indispensable and he wants his house to take him back. **Secret (he knows it):** in thirty years he has forged a dozen answers. **Secret (he does not know it):** the King has begun to answer him too, at night, through the Queen, with kicks to questions Eamon has only thought.

## TIES

- ◇ **Queen Dowager Sibyl** — his vessel and his conscience.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — his patron.
- ◇ **Duchess Iphigene** — asks him to frame things her way.

## IN PLAY

**Seeds:** a character’s petition must be phrased by him; the Queen asks the characters to watch him read; he begs the characters to tell him which question the King is answering.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“He asked the King if he wanted for anything, and took the stillness for no. That’s how our queen got no new bearers for nine years.” — a litter-woman

“The finest voice in Kest. Every word of it chosen.” — Lady Ysolde Calloway

“He reads to me at night, when no one asks him to.” — the Queen Dowager

---

# UNA CLAYHAND

## Midwife of Pieces

*“Is that a hand you’ve got in the crock, love? Don’t be frightened. I’m not the Attendance.  
I’m the other one.”*

— UNA CLAYHAND, AT A RUDGE DOOR

| UNA CLAYHAND – MIDWIFE OF PIECES |                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Cradlewrack · Cut 2 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                           |
| AGE & STATION                    | 33; Assembler of the third rank, holder of the Tarnbrow and Rudge districts                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Taker · Standing 3 (Licensed Taker, by Assembler licence)                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                           | Search 4, Wayfaring 3, Brawl 3, Persuade 3, Stitching 2, Stealth 2, Endure 2                                                         |
| BODY                             | Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (padded jack) · Fray 4                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                          | cosh +6 (3, Stunning); weighted net (Entangling)                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                            | Taken Alive (Taker talent); Rehearsal (Appetite)                                                                                     |
| WANTS                            | Gather (Grim 18; she must keep any Part she finds and bring it to the Barn; she has the Course’s Want early, as Assemblers often do) |
| KNACKS                           | Kin-Sense, Hostage’s Smile                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                          | carrying-crates, a cosh, the Gatherers’ book, a child’s blanket                                                                      |
| DREAD                            | 1                                                                                                                                    |

### WHO THEY ARE

Round-faced, motherly, freckled, with forearms like a dairymaid’s and a warm laugh. She smells of straw and clean linen. She is genuinely kind. She is also the best Part-hunter in the highlands.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 608 in Rudge, she bore a son in 631 who began to speak in an old man’s voice at seven months, and was taken for returning, and did not come home. She went to the Barn the next spring with nothing to give but her grief, and the Assemblers took her in. She has brought them sixty Parts.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She runs the Part-hunters of two districts, and she rents the cottage across the lane from Juniper Dell.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Gatherers’ book** — names of families hiding Parts; Hester Lowe’s is underlined, and the Crewe sisters are entered under one heading.
- ◇ **A child’s blanket** — her son’s.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the figure finished so that every returned child will have been worth it. **Secret (she knows it):** she sent Petra Quick a client carrying a Part. **Secret (she does not know it):** her son’s tongue is in Herself, and on the night the figure speaks, it will speak in his voice.

### TIES

- ◇ **Dov Marrin** — her master.
- ◇ **Juniper Dell** — her charge and prey.
- ◇ **Hester Lowe** — her quarry.
- ◇ **Orla Kest** — signed her son’s returning.

### IN PLAY

**Seeds:** Una offers the characters money to bring her Hester’s crock; Una takes Juniper on a pang night; Una asks the characters to find out what the Lying-In did with her son.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She held my hand through the whole thing. Then she took what came out.” — a Tarnbrow mother

“Una’s the gentlest pair of hands we have, and the surest.” — Dov Marrin

“She waves at me every morning. I wave back. Mam says not to.” — Juniper Dell, on her slate

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# WEBS OF CRADLEWRACK

Every highland web is a cord: it carries warmth one way and blood the other, and it cannot be cut without both ends bleeding. The

table gives the strongest strand for each person in the second half of the cast and the core's newcomers.

| CHARACTER        | WANTS FROM                     | FEARS                       | OWES                                       |
|------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Duchess Iphigene | Orla Kest: to be in the room   | the red; her own face       | Casimir, unknowingly, her deliveries       |
| Lord Casimir     | the Second Table: a portion    | the east gallery            | Dov Marrin, the roof money                 |
| Dolour Pym       | Orla Kest: no returning        | the first bundle            | Absalom Gage, the pick                     |
| Ede and Ada      | Tamsin Gorse: to stay two      | Nettle Corse                | Rufus Ochre, their place                   |
| Rufus Ochre      | Orla Kest: the Lying-In's book | the sum                     | Ruth Ninefold, forty lacks a month         |
| Maeve Cord       | Orla Kest: an end to the knife | the far end of the cord     | her mother, everything                     |
| Gideon Breech    | Bryony: forgiveness            | the knocking room           | Haskett Varr, a life                       |
| Petra Quick      | the Rim: one place it fails    | the red patches             | Una Clayhand, a betrayal she has not found |
| Queen Sibyl      | her son: rest                  | that he will outlive her    | Absalom Gage, every night's bricking       |
| Lazar Voss       | Ambrose: the name              | sleep                       | Lady Dalgety, two thousand lacks           |
| Juniper Dell     | anyone: the other half         | saying the whole thing      | Annis, a secret kept                       |
| Old Hinge        | someone young: the oil can     | being asked to come and see | his mother, a promise not to look          |
| Wenna Thrale     | Sabeth: the truth              | being good at it            | Dolour, unknowingly, two lives             |
| Absalom Gage     | the walls: silence             | an answer                   | Dolour, bread                              |
| Tamsin Gorse     | her mirror: nothing            | the eye                     | the Crewes, a promise to keep cutting      |
| Merriam Toll     | the Company: clean books       | warm crates                 | Breech, her silence on Varr                |
| Herself          | the Sill                       | nothing                     | four hundred mothers                       |
| Eamon Seele      | House Seele: return            | the night kicks             | Orla Kest, his office                      |
| Una Clayhand     | Herself: a voice               | Juniper's face              | the Lying-In, a son                        |

## THE GATE AND THE GENERAL

Marshal Breech killed Captain Haskett Varr with three cuts in the dark of Carving 635 to let his daughter over the border, and on the same day General Tibb was born mid-stride in a Cleave lambing-shed wearing those three cuts as old white scars. The two men are the closest allies in the highland state: Breech holds the border, Tibb holds the Crèche, and they drink together every Pangday. Breech knows. Tibb does not, but he dreams of a lantern on a wet road.

Merriam Toll holds the Company's file on Varr and has noticed the dates, and the Company would very much like a name for its dead captain's killer. If the truth comes out, Tibb must decide whether a man who owes his scars to Breech owes him anything else, and the Foundling Companies, who love their General without reservation, will take whatever side he takes. Meanwhile something in the Open Door is knocking, waiting for its grandfather.

## THE VEIL AND THE DISH

Iphigene Morwen cannot be lied to by anyone standing before her, so Casimir has not stood before her in fifteen years. He sends what she delivers to the Barn, sells the house's cauls through Merriam Toll, has sold the Second Table the date she foresaw, and has bricked his own heir into the east gallery without knowing it is his. Their daughter Isolde, bare-faced and disowned, is the only person in the Hall who can see his face and the only one who has begun to ask about the covered dish. When Iphigene learns what the nurses carry out, she will not rage; she will foretell, once, aloud, what happens to Casimir tomorrow, and the GM must make it happen.

## THE LOW WALL

Orla Kest has answered three thousand Second Questions and remembers every one. Dolour Pym has taken seven of them out of the Low Wall, still warm, and Absalom Gage has rebricked the niches each morning, and Wenna Thrale, who named two of them on the walk, is being offered the knife. When the Paramount learns, and she will, she faces the one question the Book of Questions never asks: what to do with something she has already answered that did not stay answered. Wenna will be in the room, holding the door. Whichever way she leans will decide the next Midwife-Paramount.

# USING CRADLEWRACK'S PEOPLE

These people are best met at thresholds. Let them knock. Every one of them arrives mid-labor in some sense, wanting something to begin or something to stay shut, and nearly every one of them is watching the interval. When the pangs close to seven days (see the

Missing Hand), raise every Want by one difficulty step and move each person one step along their “if nobody intervenes” path.

Roll a d20 when the party is resting in a highland house, waiting out a pang, or has just closed a door.

| D20 | WHO'S AT THE DOOR?                                                                                                                                             |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | The Duchess Morwen's Veil-Wardens, with a litter: Her Grace has foreseen one of you tomorrow and wishes to see you first.                                      |
| 2   | Lord Casimir, perfumed, alone, offering triple pay to carry a covered dish east before dawn and not lift the cloth.                                            |
| 3   | Dolour Pym, out of breath, with a covered basket that is moving: the Lying-In is coming for it.                                                                |
| 4   | Ede and Ada Crewe, hands bandaged together: a girl from Cleave is asleep on the Tally-house steps.                                                             |
| 5   | Rufus Ochre with a dark lantern: forty unaccounted are walking north tonight and he needs a count.                                                             |
| 6   | Two Grafted acolytes: the Mother of Cords asks you to come and open a tomb.                                                                                    |
| 7   | Marshal Breech, out of uniform, asking whether any of you would sit one night in an empty room at the Open Door.                                               |
| 8   | Petra Quick and a mule-cart with something under the turnips that is breathing hard.                                                                           |
| 9   | The Queen Dowager's bearers: she wants a question asked, tonight, that the Chamberlain will not ask.                                                           |
| 10  | Dr. Lazar Voss, unshaven, red-eyed: he has drawn one of you, and wants to measure you to be sure.                                                              |
| 11  | Juniper Dell, alone, barefoot, with her slate: <i>Take me to the door.</i>                                                                                     |
| 12  | Old Hinge, a long way from his hill: something is sitting on the near side of the Sill and he needs someone to keep it company until dawn.                     |
| 13  | Wenna Thrale, white-faced: her master has gone to Tarnbrow with the knife-case, and Wenna needs someone to follow.                                             |
| 14  | Absalom Gage, shouting: a wall he laid is knocking three, one, three, and he wants someone with ears.                                                          |
| 15  | Tamsin Gorse with her case: one of you has a scar she would like to look at before the next pang.                                                              |
| 16  | Factor Merriam Toll: should you be inclined, the Company would pay well to know why a crate of cauls is warm.                                                  |
| 17  | Lord Chamberlain Seele, with a petition you did not write, bearing your names and the King's kick.                                                             |
| 18  | Una Clayhand, smiling, with a crate: she would pay for anything you happen to be carrying that crawls.                                                         |
| 19  | No one. The door opens by itself. On the step is one of Juniper's drawings: this door, this house, and you in it, arms spread.                                 |
| 20  | Herself. The Barn's far door is open twenty miles away and the latch here lifts on its own. Nothing is outside. Every Part in the house turns east. (Dread 4.) |

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## RUNNING THE SECOND CAST

Most of this cast cannot leave where they are: Maeve has thirty yards, the Queen a litter, Hinge a hill, the Duchess a hall, Dolour a cottage full of mouths. Use this. Make the characters the ones who travel between them carrying messages, baskets, questions and Parts, and let them notice, slowly, that every errand ends facing north. The great secrets (the three-one-three knock, the two hearts in Voss's drawing, the long room with the chair pulled out) should arrive through three different mouths before anyone puts them together. Nobody in the highlands has all of it. That is the only reason any of them still sleep.

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CHAPTER 6

# OATHEN

*The Country That Keeps the Change*

*Fewer words, more fingers. Fewer fingers, fewer words.*

– A SHADEWARD PROVERB, SIGNED WITH THE LEFT HAND, WHICH IS THE HAND  
YOU CAN SPARE

*Every sentence in Tacit is bought on credit. The canyon is the lender. It has never once  
forgotten a debt, and it charges by the echo.*

– ENVOY DORIAN SAYCE, IN A LETTER HOME THAT HE DID NOT SEND,  
BECAUSE A LETTER MAY NOW COUNT

Wenn Corley wakes before the Plate is down, because the water does not wait. She does not say good morning. Nobody in the Shadeward Galleries says good morning; you do not promise a morning until you have had it. She touches her husband's shoulder twice, which means I am going, and he touches her wrist once, which means come back, and that is the closest anyone in the house comes to a vow before noon. The boy sleeps with his bit on. It is red leather with blue beads along the strap, and his grandmother's teeth have worn two shallow grooves in it, and his own teeth are wearing them deeper.

The yoke is cedar. The two buckets are felted on the outside so they will not knock. Wenn goes down the Cistern Stair in the dark with four hundred other carriers, and you can hear all of them: the soft fall of felt soles, the creak of yokes, breathing. That is all. Four hundred people on a stair cut into a cliff, and the loudest thing on it is a woman's cough, and the woman who coughed lays her hand flat over her own mouth afterward, as if she had said something.

At the cistern mouth the Share-Keeper sits at his slate with his tally-sticks. He does not ask her name. He looks at her thumb-ring, the brass one with the notch, which is her household's cistern-oath, sworn on the first day of Grace, eleven buckets a day and not one more, barring fire. He cuts a nick in the stick. She fills. There is a man two places ahead of her whose hands are bound in rags to the second knuckle, and she knows without asking what he did last year and what the oath was, and she does not look at him, which is a kindness. The water is green and cold and tastes of stone. It is the Kept Rain, five weeks old. Last year at this time the cistern was a hand's breadth higher. Everyone on the stair is thinking it. Nobody signs it.

By full light she has carried nine loads up the Galleries to the houses that pay her: a crumb a bucket, two crumbs to the top tier. She does not talk to the customers. She signs the price with her left hand, the hand she could spare, and they sign the coin back, and the whole of the morning's commerce is conducted in a silence so total that she can hear, from three

tiers up, the scratch of a Clausewright's quill drafting somebody's marriage. At the Felt Market she buys flatbread and a wedge of green cheese with her last two crumbs. The bread-woman's hands are fast and beautiful. Then, in the middle of a sign for fresh this morning, the bread-woman's smallest finger goes back on itself with a sound like a pea-pod opened, and hangs there, pointing at her elbow.

The whole market stops. Nobody makes a sound. The bread-woman looks at her hand. She had been baking since before dawn; the bread was fresh this morning; but she had baked the cheese-loaves yesterday, and her hand had been talking about all of it. Wenn takes her bread. She leaves an extra crumb on the board, which in Tacit means I saw, and I am sorry, and I will not tell. The bread-woman's mouth is trembling under her veil. She does not cry out. People who cry out say things.

In the afternoon the sun reaches the canyon floor for its two hours, and from the bridges you can hear the Breakdowns singing. They sing filth. They sing the oaths they broke, in rounds, and the canyon throws it all back up at the Sunward Wall nine times over, and none of it can hurt them. Wenn stands on the Tenth Bridge with her empty buckets and listens, the way everyone on the bridges listens, with a face that says nothing, and a feeling under her breastbone that she does not have a word for and would not use one if she had.

At dusk she goes home. Her husband has made lizard stew. They eat in silence, because meals are eaten in silence, and the boy watches her across the table with his grandmother's bit in his mouth and makes, with his small hands, the nursery-sign for the lady's finger, which he has heard about already, because children hear everything first. Wenn takes his hands in hers and folds them closed. It is not a sign. It is a mother holding her son's hands still. He understands it anyway.

Before sleep she goes to the Ear Shrine at the end of the gallery, where a stone ear the size of a cart-wheel is carved into the rock and worn smooth at the lobe by a thousand foreheads. She leans her mouth close to the hole in its centre. She says, very quietly, a thing that is true and costs her nothing: "I am afraid of the water." The stone ear takes it in.

*Somewhere inside the cliff, faint and flat and half a second late, a voice that is nearly hers says it back.*

## ▼ THE COUNTRY AT GROUND LEVEL

The core book tells you that Oathen is a land where words break bones. That is true, and it is the least of it. What a traveller notices first, coming down off the Rim Road at the Treaty Stair, is not the Forsworn or the Ledger or the gold of the Sayers. It is the noise that is not there. Oathen is a nation of half a million in its capital alone, a country with markets and smithies and drunks and lovers and children, and it has built every one of those things to be quiet. Hinges are greased with goat-fat twice a day. Pots are lined with felt. Market scales are weighted with lead shot sewn into leather so the pans do not clink. Dogs are debarked as pups, by a cut under the jaw that Oathen vets learned from surgeons who learned it from the Bench. A traveller from the Fatlands, used to a world of shouting, sizzling, belching and bargaining, can spend his first night in a Tacit inn lying awake in a sweat, convinced that everyone in the building has died.

Everything below follows from that silence: how people make a living without haggling aloud, how they court without promising,

how they punish without prisons, how they pray to a god who is listening, and how they get from one canyon to the next without hearing their own voices come back. This chapter goes down into it, gallery by gallery.

### THE THREE HANDS OF OATHEN

Oatheners divide every act of communication into three hands. **The Right Hand** is speech: binding, expensive, used for contracts, sentences, vows and the few truths worth their cost. **The Left Hand** is handtalk: cheap, quick, used for prices, gossip, jokes and affection, and believed, until last year, to cost nothing. **The Closed Hand** is silence, which in Oathen is not an absence but a statement: a closed hand laid on the table means *I will not answer*, and it is a legal plea in every court in the land. The great fear of 641 A.G. is that the Left Hand has begun to bind, and that one day soon the Closed Hand will too.

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

### TACIT, THE HELD TONGUE

Tacit is cut into both walls of the deepest canyon in Oathen, a gash a thousand feet deep and in places no more than four hundred feet across, with the green thread of the Hushwater running at its floor. The **Sunward Wall** faces north and catches the sun; the **Shadeward Wall** faces south and does not. The two are tied together by two hundred rope bridges at nine levels, and the whole city reads, from the canyon floor, like two enormous ledgers held open facing each other, every line of them a gallery of doors.

The city has no streets. It has galleries, which run sideways along the cliff; stairs, which run up and down it; bridges, which cross it; and lifts, which are wicker baskets hauled on felted ropes by teams of haulers who chant their counts in handtalk. Addresses are given by wall, tier and door: *Shadeward, the sixth, the forty-first door from the Fig Stair*. Tacit is divided by its people into nine districts, though the Bench recognises only four, and the Breakdowns, officially, are not part of the city at all.

### THE HEIGHTS (SUNWARD, TIERS ONE TO THREE)

The highest galleries of the Sunward Wall belong to the Tongue-lines: the Hushwells, the Daths, the Esks, the Sarrows, the Vanthes, and two dozen lesser houses whose ancestors ate some portion of the god's tongue in the third night of the Silent Supper. Their

houses are cut deep into the rock, fronted with screens of pierced red stone, and furnished entirely in felt and cedar. The Heights smell of cedar oil, which the rich rub into their bits to keep the leather soft and the iron from rusting; of rosewater; and, underneath, of the slate-dust that drifts down from the Ledger scaffolds a mile east. You can hear almost nothing here. The Heights employ servants whose entire work is silence: door-holders who open doors so slowly the hinges do not sigh; floor-walkers who go ahead of a lady with a soft broom to brush away the grit that might crunch.

*Trade:* the Heights trade in marriages, which is to say in bloodline, which is to say in the god. A Tongue-line girl's marriage contract is the largest document most families will ever own, and the Cutwrights' office on the third tier does more business here than anywhere outside Lastgate.

*Custom:* **the Veiled Hour.** Between noon and the first bell after, no one of the Tongue-lines speaks at all, even in private, even in emergencies. It began as a courtesy to the Mute Kings and is now the hour in which the Heights do their real business, by touch, by glance, and by small objects left on trays.

*Danger:* the Heights are the most godsign-ridden place on the Table outside a Seating. Any household may contain someone at the Course, bitted in silver and kept to the inner rooms, and a careless

guest who asks the wrong question of the wrong cousin may find the answer comes true. Servants of the Heights learn early never to say *you look tired, I could die, or that will be the end of me* within earshot of the family.

*Notable:* **Old Pell Sarrow**, the floor-walker of the Dath house, who has swept ahead of three generations of Dath women and is the only person living who heard Lady Imre's last sentence at dinner before the gold went in. He swept the blood off the floor afterward. He has not been asked about it, and so he has not said.

**OLD PELL SARROW, FLOOR-WALKER** Threat 2 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +1 (broom-handle 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Stealth 4; knows every quiet way through the Heights

#### THE BENCH TERRACE (SUNWARD, TIER FOUR)

At the heart of the Sunward Wall, cut back into the rock behind a façade of nine pillars carved as closed hands, is the **Hall of Conditions**, where the Bench of Clauses sits on a floor of fine red sand so that nothing said there echoes. Around it, along the whole of the fourth tier, cluster the institutions of law: the drafting-rooms, the Clause Library, the lodging-halls of the Slate-Clerks, the Archive of Readings (where every ruling the Bench has ever made about what Tolm counts is copied and cross-referenced), and the small, felt-hung chapel where Clausewrights go before a hard day to say nothing to the god in private.

The terrace smells of ink, sealing wax, and nervous sweat. The sound is the sound of quills: hundreds of them, scratching in long rooms, and the tiny dry tap of slate-pencils as clerks pass drafts back and forth for checking. There are always petitioners on the terrace steps, waiting to have something drafted: a marriage, a sale, an apology, a will. They sit with their hands folded in their laps and their mouths closed, sometimes for days.

*Trade:* drafting, at five lacks the page, and the Clausewright's daily review, at a lack a day, in which a junior lawyer goes over everything a client intends to say in the next twenty-four hours and marks it for danger.

*Custom:* **the Sand-Kiss.** A Clausewright entering the Hall of Conditions for the first time kneels and puts their lips to the sand of the floor, to taste what a word tastes like when it has nowhere to go. It tastes of dust and old blood. The sand is changed every Tablenight; the old sand is sold, quietly, to the rich, who keep a pinch of it in their bit-boxes against bad luck.

*Danger:* **the Readings.** The Bench has, over six hundred years, ruled on what the god counts. Some of those rulings were wrong, and the people who relied on them broke. A petitioner who acts on a ruling the god has since stopped honouring has no defence; the Bench does not refund.

*Notable:* **Under-Drafter Lise Amberd**, twenty-four, who has noticed that the drafts of the Sayer's sentence on Sorrin Vael's desk have begun to correct themselves overnight. A word moved here. A

comma added there. She checks each morning. She has told no one, because she does not know how to say it without asserting that a document is alive.

**UNDER-DRAFTER LISE AMBERD** Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (quill-knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Clause 4, Reckoning 3

#### THE GALLERIES (SHADEWARD, TIERS TWO TO SEVEN)

Most of Tacit lives here, on the wall that never sees the sun: carriers, weavers, felt-makers, lift-haulers, carvers, potters, goatherds who drive their flocks up the plateau stairs at dawn, and the families of the Canyon Watch. The galleries are four feet wide, with a waist-high parapet and a drop of several hundred feet beyond it, and they are crowded. People pass each other sideways, eyes down. Children run them in packs, bitted, signing to each other so fast their hands blur.

The Galleries smell of goat, lamp-oil, wet wool and the sour green cheese the whole of Tacit eats, which ripens in caves cut into the back of the gallery-houses and gives the Shadeward Wall a breath like an old boot. The sound, if you stand still, is a vast soft rustle: felt on stone, cloth on cloth, breath, and the occasional thin, cut-off cry of a baby nursed quiet before it can find its voice.

*Trade:* labour of every kind, and the goods that keep a silent city running: felt in bolts, leather bits, wax tablets, tally-sticks, hand-chimes muffled with wool for the deaf.

*Custom:* **the Extra Crumb.** Leaving one crumb more than the price on a counter means *I saw what happened to you, and I will not tell*. It is the commonest kindness in Tacit, and the commonest bribe.

*Danger:* **gallery falls**, which are frequent, and not always accidents. A Shadeward man who knows his neighbour has seen him break can solve the problem with a shoulder at the parapet, and nobody screams on the way down, because nobody screams.

*Notable:* **Fennick Darrow**, the Share-Keeper of the Cistern Stair, who has tallied the Shadeward water for twenty-two years and knows, to the bucket, that the cisterns are lower this year than in any year on record, and that someone on the Sunward Wall has been drawing double. He has the tally-sticks to prove it. He is very afraid of them.

**FENNICK DARROW, SHARE-KEEPER** Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (club 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Reckoning 4

#### THE FELT MARKET (SHADEWARD, TIER FIVE, THE GREAT GALLERY)

Where the Shadeward Wall bows outward in a great natural ledge, the city has cut a market three hundred yards long and fifty deep, roofed with stretched canvas and floored with felt that is beaten clean every night. Here is where Tacit buys and sells. There is no calling of wares. Every stall has a slate on which prices are chalked, and every customer haggles by hand, and every bargain is struck by



the buyer laying coin on the counter and the seller drawing it in, without a word. When foreigners come, they bring price-witnesses: licensed Oathen go-betweens with brass collar-plates, who charge a crumb a word and can conduct a whole sale in conditionals so tangled that nobody in it has promised anything.

The market smells of flatbread on hot stone, dried figs, lizard roasting on spits, dyed wool, and rendered goat-fat. The sound is a hiss of handtalk, which is not silent at all once you learn to hear it: the slap of a palm, the click of a fingernail on a thumbnail, the soft snap of fingers that is the Left Hand's question mark.

*Trade:* everything. Food, cloth, tools, bits, felt, tally-sticks, sworn notes (at the paper-brokers' stalls at the eastern end), and, under the counters, relics: echo-stones, Sayer's sand, and lately, unsworn speech-scrolls, which are contraband since 640 and sell for their weight in lacks.

*Custom: the Shut Stall.* A merchant who covers her slate with a cloth is not closed; she is in mourning for a word, and will not sell until sunset. Markets have shut for whole days when a beloved bread-woman broke.

*Danger:* since 640, **handtalk breaks**. The Felt Market has seen nineteen fingers go this year. Merchants have begun haggling in tally-sticks again, the old way, laying out notched sticks and pushing them back and forth, and the price of sticks has tripled.

*Notable: Silas Amend*, the paper-broker (see the Rim Market chapter), keeps his stall at the eastern end of the Felt Market, under a striped awning, with a spyglass on a brass stand trained on the Sunward Wall.

#### THE BRIDGES (ALL TIERS, THE SPAN)

The two hundred rope bridges of Tacit are a district of their own, with its own people: the **Rope-Folk**, riggers and bridge-wardens who live in little houses cut into the cliff at each bridge's anchor and who swear, on taking a bridge, to keep it. That oath is Weight 4. A Rope-Folk family whose bridge fails breaks with it, all of them, at whatever part they swore by, and the old bridge-families have the stooped, careful bodies of people who once swore by their spines. The bridges are felted along the footboards and wrapped at the handropes, and they move constantly in the canyon wind with a slow sigh that is the only sound in Tacit people are not afraid of.

The bridges smell of tar, hemp and the river four hundred feet below. They sound of wind, and of the Tattler when it comes, which sets them all humming like the strings of an instrument.

*Trade:* bridge-tolls (a crumb a crossing on the high bridges, nothing on the low), rigging, and the hauling of goods across in wicker cradles.

*Custom: the Held Breath.* Crossing a bridge, Oatheners hold their breath at the middle, where the sag is deepest and the drop is longest, and let it out only on the far side. Children are taught that the middle of a bridge is where words fall out of you.

*Danger:* the lower bridges were cut in the Forsworn Riots of 506, and the stumps still hang from the walls like the ends of severed tendons. Brakk shouts across the canyon, through his trumpet, that they could be cut again by noon. The Rope-Folk do not know whether to fear him or join him.

*Notable: Marrit Holloway*, Bridge-Warden of the Tenth Bridge, whose family has kept it for nine generations and who has noticed that the old felting on the footboards has begun to wear through in the shape of feet. Not shoes. Bare feet, very large, all walking east, toward the Ledger, at night.

**MARRIT HOLLOWAY, BRIDGE-WARDEN** Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (rigger's hook 3, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Athletics 4

#### THE LEDGER FOOT (EAST END OF THE CANYON, FLOOR AND LOWER TIERS)

Where the canyon bends east and the Sunward Wall becomes the four-mile cliff of the Ledger, the carvers live: in shanties and caves at its foot, under the scaffolds, among heaps of chippings that the wind lifts into a fine pink haze. The **Carvers' Rows** are a working district of stoneworkers, scaffold-riggers, lamp-boys, ink-grinders and copyists, and they are the only people in Oathen whose entire trade is writing words down.

Since 640 they are terrified. Ottoline Vant's miscut, and the eleven others she found, have made every chisel in the Rows a potential knife. The Bench insists that carving does not count, and has posted a notice to that effect at the foot of the scaffolds, carved, and the carvers look at it every morning and wonder whether it is binding.

The Ledger Foot smells of stone-dust, lamp-smoke and the vinegar the carvers use to rinse their eyes. It sounds of chisels: the light, patient tick of a thousand of them, all day and, in the Carving season, all night.

*Trade:* carving, at the Bench's rate (a lack a letter for public record); copying; and the sale of chippings, which are believed to hold a little of the oaths they were cut from and are ground into charms.

*Custom: the Blind Hour.* Before a carver cuts a name, he closes his eyes and touches the letters of the draft with his fingertips, to be sure that what his hand knows is what the Bench wrote. Since last year, many carve the whole day with their eyes closed.

*Danger:* the scaffolds, which are rope and plank and hang from the clifftop eight hundred feet up, and the fact that in a dry wind the dust gets into the lungs and stays. Old carvers cough grit. Some of them cough it up in shapes.

*Notable: Master Carver Ebbe Lantry*, who taught Ottoline Vant and who has quietly taken her list of the eleven miscuts and gone looking for a twelfth. He has found it. It is one of his own, from 609, and the man it names is a Bencher who has never broken.

Ebbe Lantry does not understand why, and is beginning to suspect that the Bencher had the stone corrected, at night, by someone else.

**MASTER CARVER EBBE LANTRY** Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11  
· Attack +3 (mallet and chisel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · Craft 5

### THE MURMURING TIER (SHADEWARD, TIER EIGHT)

Below the Galleries, where the Shadeward Wall is dampest, the city keeps those it cannot afford to hear. The **Murmuring House** occupies most of the tier (see the core book), but around it has grown a district of the half-kept: families of the Appetite-struck who cannot afford the House and nurse their swearers at home; bitmakers' shops; gag-nurses who hire out by the night; and the hospices of the Quiet, which take the dying and promise them nothing. Garl Tome's forge is on the tier's western end, and its glow is the only fire visible from the canyon floor at night.

The Murmuring Tier smells of broth, iron, old blood and wet felt. The sound gives the place its name: from behind every third door, a low, wet hum, people trying to swear through iron, and the hum is so constant that the people who live here no longer hear it, and are frightened, on Tablenight, when it stops.

*Trade:* bits, gags, splints, broth, night-nursing, and the hire of **sitters**, who sit up with a swearer in the night with a hand ready to clamp over the grille.

*Custom: the Listening Supper.* Once a month, families of the tier gather and eat with their bitted kin at a long table in a cleared gallery, and nobody speaks, and nobody tries to, and the bitted are, for one meal, simply people at a table. It is the gentlest thing in Tacit, and the Bench has twice tried to ban it.

*Danger:* a determined swearer. Bits slip. Grilles rust. A swearer who gets a sentence out on the Murmuring Tier may bind a whole gallery, and the tier has a word, *loose*, that means only one thing.

*Notable: Dacey Furl*, the Gag-Nurse (see the core book), is the most trusted person on the tier.

### THE BREAKDOWNS (THE CANYON FLOOR)

The slum of the Forsworn has been described in the core book; at ground level it is a city of its own, perhaps a hundred thousand people in a mile and a half of canyon floor, living in lean-tos against the cliff foot, in houses built from the wreckage of the cut bridges, in caves the river has scoured, and in the hulls of flat-boats hauled out of the Hushwater and turned keel-up. The sun reaches here for two hours a day. In those two hours the Breakdowns come out, and sit in it, and sing.

The Breakdowns smell of river mud, goat-dung fires, cheap fig-spirit, wound-dressing and the oiled cloth the Forsworn wear over what broke. They are loud. The loudness is shocking after the city above: people shout, laugh, swear, curse Tolm (carefully, the ones who still have tongues), lie for sport, and haggle aloud in plain sentences, because what they could break is already broken. The

lanes are named for the oaths their founders broke: Fair Weight Row, Back-Before-Dark, the Never Alley, I'll-Stand-By-You, Honest Measure, Till-Death Court.

*Trade:* lying, for hire; loud-crying (shouting news, insults or warnings in places a whole Oathener cannot); smuggling; the selling of fig-spirit, which is illegal in Tacit above; and the oldest trade of all, which in the Breakdowns is conducted openly, because the women and men who practise it broke at the heart long ago and promise nothing they cannot give. What happens in the **Lantern Lanes** is between adults, and the Breakdowns, which have few laws, have one about that, enforced with a cleaver.

*Custom: the Showing.* A newcomer to the Breakdowns, freshly broken, is brought to the river at sunrise and their cloth is taken off, and the whole lane looks at what broke, and then the lane shows them theirs, one by one. Then someone feeds them. It is the closest thing the Forsworn have to a christening.

*Danger:* the Canyon Watch, which comes down on the lifts in force when the Bench is nervous; the Echo-Wardens, who hate how the Breakdowns' noise goes up the walls; and the Breakdowns' own politics, which are getting violent as the population doubles with handtalkers and scribes who broke at the fingers and the palms and are not yet broken enough to be safe.

*Notable: Mags Carrow* and the eleven strapped survivors of Wending (see the core book) live at the eastern end, in Till-Death Court.

### THE WITNESSING VAULTS (BENEATH BOTH WALLS)

Beneath Tacit, reached by a dozen stairs from both walls and one from the Breakdowns, lie the catacombs where the dead stand upright in their niches, faces outward. The Vaults are older than the city above: the first niches were cut in the generation after the Supper, and the deepest galleries hold the Scraplings who licked the god's fluid off the Gullet stones. There are believed to be four million dead in the Vaults. The Keeners, who tend them, have mapped about a third.

The Vaults smell of dry stone, myrrh, lamp-oil, and the faint sweetness of the canyon dead, who in that dry air do not so much rot as cure, the skin drawing back from the teeth to give every face the same look of having just heard something. The sound is silence, absolute, the deepest in Tacit, broken only by the slap of the Keeners' sandals and, nine times this year, by the voice of a corpse giving testimony.

*Trade:* niche-rent (paid yearly by the family; unpaid niches are emptied into the Ossuary Wells), and the swearing of oaths on the dead, for which the Keeners charge a witnessing-fee of two lacks and a candle.

*Custom: the Reckoning Visit.* On the anniversary of a death, the family goes down into the Vaults and stands before the niche and says nothing for an hour, and then each of them lays a hand on the

bones and says, *I have kept what I could*. It is a true statement, which is why it was chosen.

*Danger:* the dead who Testify. And the **Drop**, a shaft in the oldest gallery that is said to go down to the god's bones in the Gullet, three miles west, through solid rock. Keeners have lowered lamps into it on chains a thousand feet long. The lamps came up warm.

*Notable:* **Old Sabra Wends**, Keener of Oaths (see the core book).

## BEYOND TACIT

### LOW DRAY

A market town of eleven thousand in a broad, shallow canyon two days down the Hushwater from Tacit, where the walls are low enough that the sun reaches the floor all day and orchards of figs and pomegranates can grow on terraces watered by the cisterns. Low Dray is where Tacit sends its orphans to be fostered, its widows to remarry, and its children to grow up somewhere with light. It is the most cheerful town in Oathen, by which Oatheners mean that people there have been known to smile in the street.

It smells of figs drying on rooftops and goats in the lanes and the bitter smoke of pomegranate-wood ovens. It sounds of bees, which Oatheners love because bees cannot promise, and of children's bits clicking as they run.

*Trade:* figs, pomegranates, honey, goat-cheese, fostering (a Low Dray foster-house takes a child for two lacks a week), and **the Dray Bit**, a child's muzzle of soft white kid, beaded in the town's own red-and-white patterns, considered the finest in the land.

*Custom:* **the Fig-Promise**. Lovers in Low Dray do not swear. They exchange a fig, which is understood to mean everything a vow would mean, and which binds nothing, and which the Bench has twice investigated and twice declared harmless. This year a girl in Low Dray who gave a fig to one young man and married another broke at the breastbone. The orchards have gone quiet.

*Danger:* the fostered children. A child fostered in Low Dray has a bit, a foster-mother, and a family in Tacit who will one day want them back, and some of those children have made promises to their foster-mothers in nursery-sign that their real mothers do not know about.

*Notable:* **Hedda Sele**, aunt and foster-mother to Wenna Sele, whose father was broken by Jude Crake last Carving. Hedda has heard the story of the man in Low Dray who was not Wenna's uncle. She has started watching every man who looks at the girl. She has a cleaver, and she is not Forsworn, and she has made no promises about what she will do with it.

**HEDDA SELE, FOSTER-MOTHER** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11  
· Attack +4 (cleaver 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

### TREATY STAIR

The town where the Rim Road comes down off the plateau into the canyons: a long switchback stair of eight hundred steps, cut into a cliff face, with a town built along it on terraces. Treaty Stair is the door of Oathen. Every foreign envoy, every Company caravan bound for Tacit, every pilgrim to the Ledger and every buyer of sworn treaties comes through it, and the town exists to receive them, house them, and teach them to shut up. The **Hall of First Silence** at the top of the stair is where foreigners are made to sit for an hour while an Oathen clerk explains, on slate, that everything they say from the next step down will count.

It smells of mules, foreign perfume, spiced Fatlands sausage sold at the top step to travellers who have not yet learned better, and the vinegar-soaked kerchiefs that Oathen officials hold to their noses when foreigners boast. It sounds, at the top, like any Rim town; and then, step by step down the stair, it goes quiet, until at the foot you can hear the river.

*Trade:* inns, interpreters, price-witnesses, Clausewrights for hire, and the private surgeries of the **Lower Terraces**, where foreign physicians take rooms because Oathen law has nothing to say about medicine, and where, according to the Blank Trade, a surgery has been scheduled to take a kidney out of Cassian Wry.

*Custom:* **the Last Word**. At the top of the stair is a stone basin. Foreigners are invited, before they descend, to say into it everything they want to say while it is still free, and many do: the boasts, the curses, the lies, the love-talk. The basin is emptied at dusk by a Quiet sister who pours sand into it and carries the sand away.

*Danger:* foreigners who do not believe the clerk. Every season someone comes down Treaty Stair laughing, says something big in the inn, and is carried back up on a litter.

*Notable:* **Clerk of First Silence Tamsk Orrey**, who has explained the Rule to forty thousand foreigners and has a private bet with himself about which of them will break first. He is right four times in five. He has never told anyone, because a bet is a kind of oath.

**TAMSK ORREY, CLERK OF FIRST SILENCE** Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +1 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Instinct 4

### HIGHWELL, THE RAIN BASIN

High in the western canyons, above the Gullet, the land opens into a bowl of red rock a mile across, ringed with cisterns cut into the basin walls like the cells of a honeycomb. This is where Tolm's great slow heart was eaten, by the families who became the Rain-keepers, and it is where the Kept Rain falls first and hardest. The **Rain Shrine** stands at the centre of the basin: a tall, roofless ring of standing stones, each carved with a year and a tally of rain, six hundred and forty of them, the newest still raw.

Highwell smells of wet stone even in the dry months, because the cisterns breathe. It sounds of water: the drip in the cisterns, the

trickle of the conduits, the slow pulse of the heart-line families, whose blood beats so heavily that you can hear it in a quiet room, like a drum under a blanket.

*Trade:* water. Highwell sells Kept Rain by the flask to the whole of Oathen and the Rim (5 L a flask, blessed), and sells cistern-shares to the towns downstream, and every share is sworn at the Shrine on the first day of Grace.

*Custom: the Standing.* On the morning of the Kept Rain, the whole of Highwell stands in the basin with faces turned up, mouths bitted, and waits. This year they stood for three days. Children fainted. An old man died on his feet and was held upright by his sons until the rain came, because to fall would have been to stop waiting.

*Danger:* the flood. On Rain day the basin fills in an hour and the overflow goes down the Gullet in a wall of red water, and every year someone is in the wrong place.

*Notable: Yusra Thole*, the Rainwarden (see the core book), who is silent. Her deputy, **Ash Merrow**, is not, and is frightened enough of the silence to talk to strangers.

**ASH MERROW, RAIN-DEPUTY** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (staff 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Lore 3

## KNOT CANYON

A labyrinth of slot-canyons and dry cisterns half a day south of Tacit, where the rock has been worn by water into passages a shoulder wide and hundreds of feet deep, so twisted that sound gets lost in them. It is the one place near the capital where you can shout without being heard twice. Smugglers, Bait-doctrine preachers, unlicensed Sureties and people with things to say come here, and Grandam Cess lives at its heart in a warren of cisterns.

Knot Canyon smells of bat-dung and still water and the incense Cess burns. It sounds of nothing; your own voice comes back to you not at all, which is so strange to Oatheners that first-time visitors weep.

*Trade:* oath-release (Cess's); unlicensed Surety work; contraband; the swearing of oaths no one wants recorded.

*Custom: the Knot.* Visitors tie a knot in a cord strung across the canyon entrance, one for each oath they have come to be rid of. The cord is thick as a man's arm with knots, and some of them have begun to move.

*Danger:* getting lost, which is easy; and Cess's nine hundred, who owe her *to come when called*, and who have begun, without being called, to come and sit at the canyon entrance in the evenings, waiting.

*Notable: Grandam Cess*, the Vow-Eater (see the core book).

## SHEATHMOUTH

A village at the downstream end of the **Sheath**, a narrow canyon fourteen miles long where the walls are so close and so smooth that an echo can run nine times before it dies. Sheathmouth lives on guiding travellers through the Sheath in perfect silence, roped together, with felt over their mouths and wax in their ears, communicating by tugs on the rope. The village is a single gallery of houses at the canyon mouth, and its people are the most silent in Oathen; it is said a Sheathmouth wife can go a year without speaking and that her husband would not notice, because he would be doing the same.

Sheathmouth smells of goat and lamp-black (the guides blacken their faces against the glare). It sounds of the river and the Sheath, which, at the end of a still day, gives up very faint scraps of things said in it years ago.

*Trade:* guiding, at 5 L a traveller; felt mouth-pads and ear-wax; and the recovery of the broken, who are carried out of the Sheath on litters by the village's guides for a fee paid by the family.

*Custom: the Rope Oath.* A Sheathmouth guide swears nothing to a client. Instead, guide and client each tie the other's rope, and that is understood. A guide who cuts a client's rope in the Sheath does not break, but no guide in Sheathmouth will ever tie a rope for him again, which in Sheathmouth is a death sentence of the slow kind.

*Danger: the nine-times echo.* The debtor who swore in the Sheath to pay by the new Plate (see the core book) is buried at Sheathmouth, in nine pieces, one for each Breaking.

*Notable: Rope-Mother Huld*, oldest of the guides, who has walked the Sheath eleven hundred times and has heard, on the last three walks, a voice in the walls that is hers, saying something she never said.

**ROPE-MOTHER HULD** Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · Wayfaring 5, Stealth 5

## DROVER'S REST, BELOW WENDING

A huddle of stone corrals and goat-hair tents at the foot of the Unmade Road, where drovers rest their herds before the climb to Wending Pass. Drover's Rest exists because the pass is the only road east out of Oathen into the high plateau and the Fast's borderlands, and because every drover who climbs it must first decide what he will swear to Captain Renn Hold at the top. The town's one inn, the **Halfway**, keeps a board on which drovers chalk the forms of words that have got people past the captain and back down whole.

Drover's Rest smells of goat, dung-smoke and the rendered fat drovers carry up as offerings. It sounds of bells; the drovers' goats are belled, the only belled animals in Oathen, because the drovers say the Captain likes to hear them coming.

*Trade:* goats, wool, hides, and the hire of **road-walkers**, children of the town who lead herds up the exact centre of the Unmade



Road where the bones are thinnest.

*Custom: the Leaving.* Every drover leaves something at the foot of the road: a cake of fat, a flask of water, a twist of salt. They say it is for the Captain. It is collected at night, and the drovers have stopped asking by whom.

*Danger:* the road, at night. The strapped men are not all in Till-Death Court.

*Notable: Old Corran Hask*, who keeps the Halfway and was a drover himself for forty years, and who has sworn to the Captain twelve times and been sent down twelve times, and who is the only person in Drover's Rest who knows that the Captain weeps when he sends them away.

**CORRAN HASK, INNKEEPER** Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (goad 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

### HOLLIN'S STAIR

The cliff-cells of the Quiet, along the upper Gullet: a vertical monastery of three hundred cells cut into a sheer cliff, connected by ladders and rope, with no stair at all despite the name. (The name is a joke of the founders, who held that a stair was a kind of promise to go up.) The Quiet live here in pairs, one cell above another, communicating by slate lowered on string. The cells look down on the red sand of the Gullet, over Tolm's bones, and the Quiet say that from their windows, on still nights, they can see the sand rise and fall.

Hollin's Stair smells of chalk-dust, lamp-oil, and the brine of Brother Ansgar Mote's vault, where four hundred tongues are kept. It sounds of chalk on slate, and of wind, and lately, of something under the sand.

*Trade:* none. The Quiet are fed by alms and by the families of those who come to them. They sell slates and chalk, and they take

the knife for those who ask, free.

*Custom: the Lowered Slate.* Any visitor may tie a written question to the end of the rope at the cliff's foot. In the morning the rope is drawn up. Sometimes there is an answer, by evening. Sometimes the slate comes down wiped clean, which is also an answer.

*Danger:* the Quiet's teachings, which spread; and the cliff itself, which visitors must climb by rope if they want a face-to-face, and which the Quiet do not help them up.

*Notable: Sister Verity Amn and Brother Ansgar Mote* (see the core book).

### SOWE

The dead hamlet at the mouth of Sworn Gorge, abandoned since 420 A.G., when its people were found broken in the way the Echo-Wardens' charter forbids describing. Sowe is twenty stone houses and a well, and nobody has lived in it for two hundred years, and its doors are still shut from the inside. The Wardens keep a post here, against the forty-foot wall packed with wool.

Sowe smells of nothing; the wool behind the wall has absorbed every smell for a mile. It sounds, on still nights, of the murmur behind the wall, and this Carving, for the first time in two hundred years, of nothing at all.

*Notable:* the post's commander, **Gorge-Warden Tacet Morrow**, who replaced Halvar Stane as Warden of the Wall in 639 and who wants Halvar kept away from it, because the night before Halvar was relieved, Morrow found him at the wall with his good ear pressed to the stone and his lips moving.

**GORGE-WARDEN TACET MORROW** Threat 4 · Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Attack +5 (shortbow 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 1 · Instinct 4; wax and lead in both ears; speaks only by touch on duty

## ▼ ROADS AND WAYS

Nobody in Oathen travels far if they can help it. Every road is a canyon, and every canyon is a mouth. The traveller's first rule is the oldest proverb in the land, *listen twice*: once before you speak, to hear whether the walls will answer, and once after, to hear whether they did.

There are four ways to move. **The floor-paths** follow the rivers along the canyon bottoms; they are flat, shaded and well watered, and they flood on Rain day and wash out every year. **The rim-tracks** run across the plateau above, scrub and scoured stone under the white sky, where there is no echo at all but also no water and no shade, and where the Tattler wind can carry a word ten miles. **The galleries and lifts** connect the tiers of the cliff-towns and, in a few places, run for miles along a canyon wall, a road a yard wide with a drop on one side. And **the Rim Road** itself, the Company's

highway, crosses the north of the country from Treaty Stair to Quillhouse on a great embanked causeway laid along the plateau, felted at its bridges, with Company waystations every fifteen miles where Oathen clerks sit at the doors and remind every traveller, by slate, what country they are in.

Travellers in posted gorges go roped and gagged, with Sheathmouth guides or Echo-Wardens. Merchants hire **mutes**, porters who have taken the knife and carry goods through echoing places for double wages, and who cannot be made to swear anything by an echo because they cannot hear it come back in their own voice. The rich travel in **felt litters**, enclosed boxes carried by eight bearers, lined so thickly that a lady inside can say what she likes and be heard by no one, including the god, or so the litter-makers claim.

The Bench has never ruled on felt litters. It is rumoured that several Benchers own one.

| ROUTE                           | DAYS       | WAY                                  | DANGERS                                  |
|---------------------------------|------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Tacit to Treaty Stair           | 3          | Rim-track, then the Stair            | the Tattler; foreigners                  |
| Tacit to Quillhouse             | 3 (ride)   | Rim Road causeway                    | Company checkpoints; Second Table agents |
| Tacit to Low Dray               | 2          | Floor-path down the Hushwater        | Rain-day flood; fig-sellers who talk     |
| Tacit to Highwell               | 4          | Floor-path up the Gullet, then stair | the Gullet's warm sand; Quiet pilgrims   |
| Tacit to Knot Canyon            | half a day | Rim-track south                      | getting lost; Cess's nine hundred        |
| Tacit to Sowe                   | 2          | Posted gorge, roped                  | the murmur, or its absence               |
| Sheathmouth through the Sheath  | 2          | Posted narrows, roped and gagged     | the nine-times echo                      |
| Drover's Rest to Wending        | 1 (climb)  | The Unmade Road                      | the bones; the strapped; the Captain     |
| Highwell to Low Shale           | 3          | Rim-track, then forbidden descent    | the stopped valley; Bench patrols        |
| Treaty Stair to the Fast border | 9          | Rim Road east, then plateau          | Reckoners; drought; no water             |

#### TRAVEL RULES IN THE CANYONS

Each day of travel through an unposted canyon, the party's guide rolls **Lung** + **Wayfaring** (Hard 14). On a failure, the party has passed somewhere a word is living: every character makes a **Tongue** + **Clause** roll (Hard 14) or is bound, at Weight 1, by a fragment of an old oath the GM writes ("back before dark", "never the river", "I will carry it"). On a Lack, they have walked into a Living Echo (see the Adversaries chapter). In posted gorges, travellers who are not gagged and roped make the same roll each hour. A Sheathmouth guide or Echo-Warden gives +4 to the guide's roll, and a mute porter gives one character immunity for the day.

## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

Oathen is a poor land that is very rich. The canyons grow little: figs and pomegranates in the low valleys, goats and lizards on the plateau, cheese, a sparse grain in the terraces of Highwell. Water is a yearly ration. Wood is so scarce that cedar is a luxury and most cooking is done on dung-fires or on stones heated in the sun. Yet Tacit is one of the great money-cities of the Table, because Oathen's real export is the only thing the rest of the world cannot make: a word that cannot be broken.

Every treaty between lands, every Rim Road Company contract, every bond of every large merchant house on the Table comes east to be sworn. The Bench charges the **Page-Tithe**: one lack per sworn page, paid to the crown, on every contract sworn in Oathen. A treaty between Brinehollow and the Vigil may run to six hundred pages. A Company charter renewal, sworn every seven years, runs to four thousand. The Page-Tithe pays for the Bench, the Canyon

Watch, the Ledger and the king, and leaves a great deal over, which the Tongue-lines who sit on the Bench distribute among themselves by a formula drafted in 344 A.G. and never once amended.

Below the Tongue-lines the money moves through **drafting** (Clausewrights and their clerks, perhaps twelve thousand people in Tacit alone), **surety** (the Compact's four hundred licensed bondsmen and their unlicensed rivals), **paper** (the speculators who buy and sell sworn notes and watch issuers through spyglasses), and **silence** (the felt-makers, bitmakers, litter-bearers, mutes and guides whose trade is keeping people from being heard). The common people of the Galleries live as they live everywhere: by carrying, building, herding, weaving and selling food. They are paid in lacks and crumbs, and they rarely see paper.

## WAGES

| WORK                       | PAY PER DAY     | NOTES                                   |
|----------------------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Water-carrier              | 1 L             | a crumb a bucket; two to the top tier   |
| Goatherd                   | 1 L             | and a share of the cheese               |
| Lift-hauler                | 1 L 5 c         | teams of six; the rope-boss takes a cut |
| Felt-maker                 | 2 L             | hands ruined by forty                   |
| Gag-nurse (night)          | 2 L             | Murmuring House pays 1 L and broth      |
| Ledger carver              | 3 L             | or 1 L a letter for public record       |
| Canyon Watch soldier       | 2 L             | sworn for nine years; eleven-page oath  |
| Echo-Warden Baffler        | 1 L             | and a Warden's ration; the right ear    |
| Mute porter                | 3 L             | double in posted gorges                 |
| Price-witness              | 2–4 L           | a crumb a word; a good one uses twenty  |
| Slate-Clerk                | 2 L             | and Bench lodging                       |
| Under-Drafter              | 5 L a page      | a busy one drafts four pages a day      |
| Bondling Surety            | 2–10 L a bond   | paid once; carried for years            |
| Liar-for-hire (Breakdowns) | 3 L a lie       | 10 L for a lie under oath in a court    |
| Loud-crier (Breakdowns)    | 1 L a shout     | news, insults, warnings                 |
| Sheathmouth guide          | 5 L a traveller | per crossing                            |

## LOCAL PRICES

| ITEM                                     | PRICE      | NOTES                                   |
|------------------------------------------|------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Canyon flatbread                         | 2 c        | baked on hot stones                     |
| Green cheese (a wedge)                   | 3 c        | ripened in the river caves              |
| Roast lizard on a stick                  | 1 c        | the poor man's meat                     |
| Fig-spirit (a cup)                       | 2 c        | Breakdowns only; illegal above          |
| A Kept Rain flask                        | 5 L        | blessed; doubled since the late rain    |
| Cistern-share (household, a year)        | 30 L       | sworn at the Rain Shrine                |
| Tally-sticks (a bundle of ten)           | 3 c        | trebled since handtalk began to break   |
| Child's bit (plain)                      | 4 L        | Dray Bit 12 L; heirloom bits never sold |
| Iron bit (the Appetite)                  | 25 L       | Garl Tome's work, 60 L                  |
| Silver bit (the Course)                  | 300 L      | fitted at the Bitmaker's                |
| A marriage contract                      | 200 L      | forty pages at five lacks               |
| Niche-rent in the Vaults                 | 2 L a year | 20 L in the upper galleries             |
| A felt litter, hired                     | 10 L a day | eight bearers                           |
| Sand of the Hall of Conditions (a pinch) | 1 L        | kept in bit-boxes                       |

## TAXES AND DUES

Besides the Page-Tithe, an Oathener pays the **Share-Due** on their cistern-share (a tenth of the share's price, to the Rainwarden); the

**Bridge-Crumb** for every high bridge crossed; the **Niche-Rent** for their dead; and, if they live above the fourth tier on either wall, the **Quiet-Due**, a lack a month for the felt that lines the public galleries. There is no tax on the Breakdowns, because the Breakdowns are

officially not part of Tacit, and no Bench collector has gone down to ask since 506.

WHO IS RICH

The Tongue-line houses, from the Page-Tithe. The Great Sureties of the Compact, who charge two hundred lacks to stand behind a marriage and a thousand for an oath of Weight 5. The paper-brokers, who have made fortunes buying notes from issuers on the edge of default. The Rim Road Company, whose Quillhouse is the richest building in Oathen. And a handful of Breakdowns bosses, whose lies, smuggling and fig-spirit have made them wealthy in a place where wealth looks like a dry roof and a door that locks.

▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

Oathen has no prisons, no gaols, no stocks and no gallows. It has a sentence, and the sentence is in you. The machinery of justice is therefore almost entirely made of words: the drafting of sentences, the swearing of them by the convicted, and the watching. Enforcement is done by the convict’s own body, and only when a crime is not an oath, or a sentence is too dangerous to trust to the god, does anyone in Oathen need to lay a hand on anyone else.

WHO ENFORCES

The Canyon Watch keeps the peace on the galleries and bridges, carries out arrests, escorts the accused to court, and guards the Hall of Conditions, the Ledger and the Gilded Cells. It is small (about three thousand in Tacit), well paid, and absolutely reliable, because every soldier has sworn an eleven-page oath of obedience. The Sentence-Readers, Slate-Clerks attached to the courts, keep the record of every sworn sentence and periodically visit convicts to read them their terms aloud, which renews nothing but reminds a great deal. The Echo-Wardens police posted gorges and may fine anyone caught speaking in one. The Breaker, Jude Crake, carries out death sentences. And in the Breakdowns, the Splints, Brakk’s council, keep an order of their own with cleavers and plain speech.

HOW A TRIAL WORKS

Every trial in Oathen begins with the Closed Hand: the accused is brought before the court, bitted, and the bit is removed only when the judge signs that the court is ready to hear. The accused may lay their hand closed on the rail, which means *I will not answer*, and is a

SWORN NOTES AT STREET LEVEL

In the Galleries, a sworn note is something you see perhaps twice in a life: at a wedding, when the families exchange them, and at a death, when the heirs cash them. A common family’s whole savings may be a single note, kept in a felt pouch under a floorboard, naming a merchant three tiers up and *let my left eye answer*. When that merchant limps, the family hears of it the same day. When he is seen with a bandage over his eye, the family goes up the stair to his door with a Clausewright, and waits, in silence, to see whether he will pay, or break again.

lawful plea; but a closed hand is taken as an admission in all but the gravest cases, and the court will proceed to sentence.

There are two kinds of trial. In a **Breaking Trial**, for oath-crimes (default, fraud, desertion, infidelity, perjury), the accused repeats aloud, in its original words, the promise they are said to have broken, and the court watches. The original words are read from the Ledger or from the parties’ sworn copies. The accused may argue the reading first, through a Clausewright, but once they speak the oath, the god decides. If nothing happens, they are acquitted and the accuser must pay the court’s fee. If the oath was broken, it breaks again, then and there, at the same part, and that is the verdict and most of the sentence.

In a **Question Trial**, for crimes that are not oaths (murder, theft, assault, arson, water-theft), the accused is asked one question, *Did you do it?*, and must answer aloud, yes or no. A closed hand is permitted, and leads to sentence. A *no* that is a lie breaks the mouth, at Weight 3, before the whole court, and is a verdict. A *no* that is true is acquittal, and Oathen has never in its history convicted an innocent person who was willing to speak. The Bench is very proud of this, and does not discuss the Forsworn whose mouths have already broken, who can answer *no* to anything.

Sentences are then drafted by a Clausewright of the court, read to the convict, and sworn by the convict aloud, usually with the Weight raised to 4 by the court’s witness. A convict who refuses to swear their sentence is sent to the Breaker.

CRIMES AND PUNISHMENTS

| CRIME                       | TRIAL    | USUAL SENTENCE                           | NOTES                          |
|-----------------------------|----------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Lying (spoken)              | none     | the mouth breaks; entered in the record  | the god has already sentenced  |
| Default on a sworn note     | Breaking | the named part breaks; repay from wages  | a Surety takes it if one stood |
| Short weight, false dealing | Breaking | hands; sworn to fair weight nine years   | the oldest crime in Oathen     |
| Theft                       | Question | sworn restitution, double, by a set date | breach breaks the hands        |



| CRIME                      | TRIAL    | USUAL SENTENCE                                      | NOTES                           |
|----------------------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Water-theft                | Question | sworn not to drink from Tacit's cisterns for a year | effectively exile; often death  |
| Assault                    | Question | sworn service to the injured for a term             | "I will be your hands until..." |
| Murder                     | Question | the Breaker, or sworn exile on the dead             | the victim's bones are sworn on |
| Speaking in a posted gorge | none     | 10 L fine and the cost of silencing                 | the Wardens bill the family     |
| Unbitted child speaking    | none     | parents fined 5 L; the Breaking recorded by number  | the child is never charged      |
| Unlicensed surety          | Question | sworn never to stand for another                    | the Compact pays informers      |
| Teaching the Bait doctrine | Question | sworn silence for nine years                        | breach breaks the throat        |
| Unsworn speech-scrolls     | Question | scrolls burned; writer sworn to write nothing       | contraband since 640            |
| Insulting the king by sign | Question | the offending fingers splinted for a season         | rarely enforced                 |
| Blasphemy                  | none     | recorded only                                       | Tolm sees to it                 |

## THE GRAVEST SENTENCES

For crimes the Bench considers too dangerous to leave to a convict's body (murder of a Tongue-line, treason, the unbidding of a Sayer), there are two sentences. The first is **Sworn Exile on the Dead**: the convict lays a hand on the victim's bones in the Witnessing Vaults and swears to leave Oathen and never return, at Weight 5, with the dead as second witness. If they return, the dead Testify. The second is **the Hour**: Jude Crake, a pair of chairs, figs, and an hour-glass.

### RUNNING A TRIAL AT THE TABLE

A Breaking Trial is a single, terrible moment, and it should be played as one. Read the oath aloud in full. Have the player repeat it, in character, in exactly those words. Then pause. If the character is innocent, let the pause run long enough to hurt before you say nothing happens. If they are guilty, describe the Breaking as it lands: the sound, the part, the court's silence, and Judge Urrow writing in his book. A Question Trial is a single roll if the character intends to lie: they cannot succeed, but a Forsworn with a broken mouth can, and the Bench knows it. If a PC is a Clausewright, let them argue the reading first (Eye + Clause vs  $10 + 2 \times \text{Weight}$ , as the Rule). That argument, before Judge Urrow, is the best courtroom scene this game can offer.

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

Every Oathener believes in Tolm, in the sense that every Oathener believes in the ground. The god is not a matter of faith; it is a matter of record. What Oatheners argue about is the god's *meaning*, and that argument runs along the lines of the Three Doctrines, which in Oathen have taken local names and local habits.

**The Record** is Oathen's Theft doctrine, held by most of the Galleries and by the Bench officially. *I am listening* is a sentence passed: we are watched until we pay, and every Breaking is a line in the god's account. Followers of the Record keep household tallies of their oaths, kept and broken, notched on sticks hung by the door, and believe that at the end of the Long Grace the account will be read aloud. They are careful, anxious, honest people, and they make up most of the country.

**Go On** is the Gift doctrine, strong in Low Dray, among the Sureties and among the old. *Go on* was permission and forgiveness: eat, live, keep your word as I kept mine. Go-On households hang a fig on the door at Tablenight and believe the Kept Rain is a gift

renewed. They are gentler and, the Record says, lazier. Since the rain came late, a great many of them have gone quiet.

**The Plain Reading** is the Bait doctrine, illegal in Oathen since 290 A.G. The god said it was listening. It has not said it has stopped. The Plain Readers hold that Tolm was never eaten, only overheard: that it lay down in silence because a silent meal was the safest place to wait, and that every word spoken in Oathen since has been the god's own nourishment. They are found among the Forsworn, the Quiet, the scribes broken since 640, and in Knot Canyon. They leave written prayers at the feet of the frozen herdsman in Low Shale, and they are growing.

## SHRINES

**The Ear Shrines** are carved stone ears, from a hand's breadth to a cart-wheel across, set into the cliff at the end of galleries throughout Tacit and the towns. They are for saying true things aloud to the god: griefs, fears, confessions of past fact. True statements cost nothing, and Oatheners find great relief in saying, into the stone, *I*

*bated my father or I took the bread or I am afraid.* The ears are worn smooth at the lobes by foreheads. Since this Carving, several have begun to say things back, half a second late, in the speaker's voice.

**The Rain Shrine** at Highwell is the holiest place in Oathen after the Gullet, where cistern-shares are sworn and where the Rainwarden keeps the tally of every year's fall.

**The Gullet** itself is not a shrine but a grave, and is visited only on the eve of Tablenight, barefoot.

## RITES

- ◇ **The Hearing.** When a child is born, the midwife holds a felted hand over its mouth during the first cry, and a Keener, standing in the doorway, says *heard*. It is the child's first contact with the god, and is believed to teach the child, before it knows anything else, that its voice is a thing someone is listening to.
- ◇ **The Bitting.** At the first tooth, the child is fitted with its first bit, usually an heirloom, in a family ceremony conducted entirely in handtalk. The family gives the child a name-sign, which is the name it will be called by until it is twelve.
- ◇ **The Unbitting.** At twelve, in the Hall of Conditions, before a Clausewright. The first words are chosen in advance. *I am here* is the commonest. *I was heard* is the most beautiful, and is used in the old families.
- ◇ **The Swearing of Shares.** On the first day of Grace, every householder swears their cistern-share at the Rain Shrine or at a town's share-stone. It is the first oath of the year and the most important.
- ◇ **The Tongue Supper.** Among the old Tongue-line houses, when a member of the family dies at the Brink or after, the heir is served, at the funeral meal, a single thin slice of the dead one's tongue, raw, and eats it in silence, so that the god's portion stays in the house. The Bench has never ruled on it. The Cutwrights' College knows of it, and records which houses do it, and has noticed that those houses reach the Course faster. The houses know this too. They do it anyway, because the alternative is to let the god go to someone else.

- ◇ **The Placing.** The dead are set upright in their niche in the Witnessing Vaults; every promise made to them in life is spoken aloud; the Keener asks the corpse whether each was kept.

## HOLY DAYS

To the four festivals given in the core book (the Kept Rain, the Unbitting, the Carving of the Year and Tablenight), the canyons add two lesser days. **The Night of Ears**, on the eve of Tablenight, is when pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot and lay their ears to the warm sand; it is the only night of the year when the Quiet come down from Hollin's Stair. **Share-Eve**, the night before the Kept Rain, is spent in households making the year's vows to each other in whispers, so that the rain, falling the next day, can wash the sound out of the canyon. This year, Share-Eve lasted four nights, and the whispered vows were made, and the rain did not come, and some of the whispers, the old women say, are still in the walls.

## THE LITANY OF EXITS

The most common prayer in Oathen is spoken at dawn by the Record faithful, and is constructed so that it promises nothing. Children learn it by sign before they are unbitted, and say it aloud for the first time on the morning after the Unbitting.

*Witness, if you are listening, and I believe you are:*

*I intend, as I now intend, to speak little today.*

*If I speak, I hope to speak true.*

*If I promise, I hope to have meant it.*

*If I break, I hope it will be apt, and that someone will be kind to me after.*

*Barring death, illness, weather, and the rulings of the Bench,*

*I am here.*

*I was heard.*

*Lack keep away.*

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

- ◇ "I carry the dead down to the Vaults. They're light, our dead. The dry does it. Lighter than a bucket of water, most of them. Water's dearer." — a Keener's porter, Shadeward
- ◇ (*signed, fast, by a bitted girl of nine*) "Mama says the bit is so the god can't hear me. I think it can. I think it's just waiting."
- ◇ "I don't promise. Not my trade to. I give what I give and they pay what they pay and nobody breaks in my bed. Lantern Lanes

keeps its hearts out where you can see them, love." — a woman of the Breakdowns, who broke at the breastbone at nineteen

- ◇ "Eleven pages. I can recite them. Hold, obey, report. 'To the death' is gone. Now it's 'to the point where holding serves no further purpose, as judged by the officer present.' You know who the officer present is? Me." — a sergeant of the Canyon Watch

- ◇ “My son is eleven. In one year I will hear his voice for the first time. I have been afraid of it since the day he was born.” — a mother, the Galleries
- ◇ “A letter a lack. I cut a man’s name last week. Clean. I checked it nine times. I didn’t sleep. He’s fine. I checked that too.” — a carver of the Ledger Foot
- ◇ “Go on, ask me something. Anything. I’ll lie to you for a crumb. Look at my mouth. Nothing left to split, is there?” — a liar-for-hire, Honest Measure
- ◇ “Your Oatheners are the best people on the Table to sign with and the worst to drink with.” — a Fatlands caravan-master at Treaty Stair
- ◇ “Six on the rope. Count of nine, up. Count of nine, down. You haul long enough, you start counting in your sleep. Wife says I count in my sleep. I asked her, out loud? She won’t say.” — a lift-hauler
- ◇ “They mouth it all night now. All three hundred. Same shape. I’ve watched mouths for nine years and I can’t read the end of it.” — a gag-nurse of the Murmuring House
- ◇ “I am given to understand that I am a junior clerk, and as such I would not, if asked, care to express a view.” — a Slate-Clerk, asked the time
- ◇ “Goats can’t swear. That’s why I like goats.” — a goatherd above Highwell
- ◇ “I took a bucket. One bucket. My girl was fevered. They asked me in court, did you do it. I said yes. You don’t say no. Now I can’t drink from Tacit for a year. I’m drinking from the river. It’s green. She’s well, though.” — a water-thief, the Breakdowns
- ◇ “Three bonds. Small ones. Fourteen lacks. I sleep with my hand on my belly, where one of them is written, so I’ll feel it go.” — a Bondling Surety
- ◇ “A gorge isn’t silent. You just have to listen to it longer than anyone wants to.” — a Baffler of the Echo-Wardens
- ◇ “In the Heights we’re taught one rule above all: never ask a cousin how they are.” — a Tongue-line lady’s maid
- ◇ “Puke it up! Open your mouths and puke him up! Look at Brakk’s ribs, open to the sky; that’s a man halfway clean!” — a Purgation preacher in the Breakdowns, shortly before the Canyon Watch removed him
- ◇ “I told the god once that I was sorry. It was true. It was the best thing I ever said.” — an old woman at an Ear Shrine

## IN TACIT, NOBODY SAYS GOODBYE. YOU SAY "IF ABLE," AND YOU GO, AND YOU LEAVE THE REST OF THE SENTENCE TO THE CANYON.

[ WENN CORLEY, WATER-CARRIER ]

### ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

Power in Oathen flows through words, and therefore through the people who own the words: who drafts them, who witnesses them, who carries their risk, and who may speak them at all. The Mute King is the source of all legitimate authority because he has never said anything, and therefore owes no one. Everyone below him owes somebody.

The Bench of Clauses governs, in theory by interpreting the king, in practice by drafting everything. Its power is the drafting of sentences: the sworn sentences of the courts, the oaths of the Canyon Watch, the cistern-shares, the treaties, and, once a year, the sentence a Sayer speaks. The Bench depends on the Tongue-lines for its members, and the Tongue-lines depend on the Bench for the

Page-Tithe that keeps them rich. Both depend on the Rim Road Company, which brings the contracts that pay the Tithe; and the Company depends on one old woman in Quillhouse, whose witness holds half the trade of the Table together. The Sureties stand underneath everyone’s words, carrying the risk of the rich in their own bodies, and are paid well for it, and are dying of it. The

Forsworn have nothing left to break, and they are the only power in Oathen that can lie, threaten and promise freely: which is why the Bench fears them more than any foreign army.

Underneath all of it are the Sayers, who are not a faction, have no votes, and could end any of the others with a sentence.

| POWER                            | CONTROLS                          | FEARS                            | OWES                            |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Ket the Ninth                    | legitimacy; the nod               | his own voice                    | nothing; that is the point      |
| The Bench (Sorrin Vael)          | law, sentences, the Sayers’ words | the widening; the Forsworn       | the Tongue-lines, the Company   |
| Tongue-line houses               | the Bench’s seats; marriages      | the Brink in their children      | the Cutwrights’ silence         |
| Rim Road Company (Jessamy Quill) | the Table’s contracts; Quillhouse | Quill’s death; the slipping seal | the Bench’s tithe; Quill’s life |
| The Sureties’ Compact (Ona Fell) | the risk of every great oath      | one bad season                   | their principals’ honesty       |
| The Forsworn (Brakk)             | the Breakdowns; lies; smuggling   | the Watch; their own worth       | nothing they can’t break        |
| The Canyon Watch                 | force; the Cells’ guard           | an order they cannot obey        | an eleven-page oath             |
| The Echo-Wardens (Halvar Stane)  | the gorges; the old words         | Sworn Gorge                      | the Bench’s charter             |
| The Quiet                        | silence; tongues in brine         | the thought that binds           | alms; Brother Mote’s knife      |
| Judge Thane Urow                 | the Breaking courts               | his own oath                     | the god, eleven thousand times  |
| The Second Table                 | three Tongue-line houses          | the Bench finding out            | a meal they intend to eat twice |
| The Sayers (Lady Imre Dath)      | anything, unbitted                | being misunderstood              | a sentence, every year          |

**THE KNOT AT THE CENTER**

Four strands of Oathen power are tied, unknown to most of the people who hold them, into a single knot. **Jessamy Quill** once swore an oath that no other notary of the Rim should be sworn while she lives. **The Company** is secretly preparing a second notary, because the seal is slipping. **Ona Fell** stands Surety for an anonymous principal whose bond is her oldest and heaviest, and that principal is Quill. And **Sorrin Vael** drafted all three: Quill’s oath in 601, Ona’s anonymous bond in 615, and the Company’s quiet instruction to find a successor in 641. If the second notary is sworn, Quill’s oath breaks; the Breaking falls on Ona; Ona has one default left. The GM should let the players discover this one strand at a time.

# THE PEOPLE OF OATHEN

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*Read a canyon man from across the street. His hands will tell you what he sold, his legs where he ran, his mouth what he said. Only the whole ones are a mystery, and only to fools.*

— A SAYING OF THE BREAKDOWNS



# KET THE NINTH

## the Mute King

*(He lays his open hand flat on the table, palm up, and then slowly turns it over, and leaves it there, closed.)*

— KET THE NINTH, TO THE BENCH OF CLAUSES, WHEN ASKED WHETHER THE SAYER SHOULD BE UNBITTED. THE BENCH HAS BEEN ARGUING FOR FIVE WEEKS WHAT IT MEANT.

| KET THE NINTH – THE MUTE KING |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | Oathen · Cut 5 (Tongue-line, Hushwell) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                 | 31; King of Oathen, the ninth of the Mute Succession                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING            | Scion · Standing 5 (Great House: the crown)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS                        | Clause 5, Resolve 5, Godsign 3, Lore 3, Reckoning 3, Instinct 2, Search 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                          | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTACKS                       | none; he has never struck anyone.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                         | Echo-Ear (he hears his own thoughts come back, half a second late, in a voice that is his and is not; Eye + Instinct Hard 14 to know if a statement in his hearing was a lie and at what Weight). Hold to It (every oath sworn to the king is +1 Weight; the Canyon Watch's eleven pages bind at Weight 5). Unspoken: he has never spoken, so is bound by nothing. Should he say a plain sentence, it binds at Sayer strength (as the Brink Gift Make It So, without limit), and he knows it. |
| WANTS                         | To Say (Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 whenever the Bench misreads him; he has never failed). To Hold Others to Their Words.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                        | Silent Supper, Dowager's Patience, Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                  | none yet. The Cutwrights' report predicts The Echo.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                       | the silver bit; a tuning fork; the Book of Nods; the sealed report; a clerk's leather bit; no thumb-rings.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DREAD                         | 3 (to see his throat working under the gold-chased silver)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

### WHO THEY ARE

Ket the Ninth is slight and pale, with the grey Hushwell eyes, very large in a narrow face, and hair cut close to the skull so that the strap of the bit lies flat. The bit is silver, chased in gold with the closed-hand crest of his house, and it has been resized eleven times; he has worn some version of it since the eleventh day of his life. The corners of his mouth have the deep grooves every Oathener carries, but his are cut down almost to the jaw. He smells of cedar oil and of the faint metallic sourness of a man who breathes through a grille. He moves very slowly, because a king's every gesture is minuted, and he has learned to make his body as quiet as his mouth. When he is moved, the only sign is in his hands, which close, slowly, one finger at a time, as though counting something.

Those who meet him say the same thing: that he listens harder than anyone they have ever met. His eyes go to each speaker and stay there, and he seems to take every word in and weigh it, and the weight is visible. Courtiers find it unbearable. Commoners who

have been brought before him for royal mercy say it was like being heard for the first time in their lives.

### THEIR STORY

Ket was born in the Hushwell house in 610 A.G., the third child of a minor branch, and was chosen at eleven days old by the Bench's examiners, who test every Tongue-line infant of the right generation by laying it, swaddled, at the foot of the Ledger at dawn and watching which of them does not cry. Ket did not cry. The silver bit went in that afternoon. His mother was given a sworn note for a very large sum and the right to see him once a year, by lamplight, through a screen; she used it for nine years and then stopped, and Ket has never been told why.

He was raised in the **Muted House**, the palace at the summit of the Sunward Wall, by a tongueless sister of the Quiet called Ansa, who taught him the royal handtalk and the three thousand gestures of the **Book of Nods**, and who held her hand over his mouth whenever he laughed, so gently that he did not know until he was nine that other children's laughter made a sound. King Orvel the

Eighth died in 611, and Ket was crowned at a year old, bitted, in the Hall of Conditions, and the Bench ruled as regent until 629, when he was judged able to gesture for himself. He has ruled since by the nod, the open hand, the closed hand, the turned palm, and by a hundred small refinements of his own that the Bench has had to add to the Book.

He reads everything: the Bench's minutes, the treaties, the Ledger's copy-books, foreign histories, the Cutwrights' reports. He has written nothing, ever. In 637 the Cutwrights' College delivered him a sealed report, by his own gesture, and he learned from it that his Regrowth stood at the Course, without a single word having passed his lips, and that the pressure he had felt behind his teeth since adolescence was not the ordinary desire of a man to speak. The god in the Hushwell blood had nowhere to go. It had been gathering.

In Carving of 640, alone at night in the felt room behind his bedchamber, Ket took the bit out, which he is permitted to do for cleaning, and hummed. One note, low, for the length of a breath, to know what it was. Every candle in the room leaned toward him. A Bench clerk named Odo Fane, asleep on duty behind a screen, heard it. The Bench had Fane bitted for life before noon the next day, in iron, by his own sworn consent, and lodged him in a felt room on the Muted House's lower tier. The king visits him every seventh day and sits with him for an hour, in silence. Two floors beneath the Ledger, in the Gilded Cells, Lady Imre Dath began scratching her first sentence into the lead of her cell wall the same night.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Ket is the source of all lawful authority in Oathen. Every sentence of the courts is passed in his name, every treaty is witnessed in his presence, and every soldier of the Canyon Watch swears to him. Because he has sworn nothing, he owes nothing, and an oath sworn to him is the heaviest a commoner can make. His daily routine is audiences in the morning (petitioners, foreign envoys, Benchers), reading in the afternoon, and the Veiled Hour, which he began. He gestures; the Bench interprets; the interpretation is drafted; he nods to the draft or does not. His power is real but narrow: he can refuse. A king's closed hand on a draft kills it, and the Bench has learned, in twelve years, that this king closes his hand more often than any of the eight before him.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The silver bit** — gold-chased, cast by Garl Tome, resized in 639 because the tongue behind it has begun to thicken. The plate presses down a tongue that is now mottled the colour of raw liver.
- ◇ **A tuning fork** — steel, from a foreign musician's case, given to him by Envoy Dorian Sayce. He strikes it on the table and holds the stem against his teeth, so that the note goes into the bone of his skull. It is the nearest he comes to sound.

- ◇ **The Book of Nods** — his own copy, three thousand gestures, annotated in the hands of four Chief Clausewrights. He has never written in it.
- ◇ **The sealed report** — the Cutwrights' assessment of 637. He keeps it under the felt of his bed. It ends with the sentence: *His Majesty is to be considered, for the purposes of the Bench's planning, a Sayer who has not yet spoken.*
- ◇ **Odo Fane's leather bit** — the soft one the clerk wore as a boy, which Fane's mother gave the king when her son was bitted in iron. Ket keeps it in his sleeve.
- ◇ **No thumb-rings.** His hands are the only bare adult hands in the Heights. Oatheners find the sight of them unsettling, like a man without a shadow.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Ket wants to say something. He does not know what. He fears that the sentence pressing behind his teeth is not his. He has begun to dream in words, which he had never done, and in the dreams he is standing on the Ledger scaffold and reading the cliff aloud from west to east, and every vow he reads comes due. **Secret (GM may reveal):** the hum. Every candle leaned, the clerk was bitted, and the Sayer began to write. **Secret he does not know:** sealed in the Archive of Readings is a drafted sentence, the **Silence Clause**, prepared by the Bench in 637 for a Sayer to speak if the king ever does: *The king has said nothing.* No one knows whether it would unmake his words, his mouth, or his reign. Sorrin Vael drafted it, and has kept it updated.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — his interpreter, his regent in all but name. Ket respects him and does not trust him, and has gestured so, in a sign the Book does not contain.
- ◇ **Lady Imre Dath** — he has visited her once. All her ears turned to him. He believes she heard his hum. He is right.
- ◇ **Cassian Wry** — the only person in Oathen who can tell the king a comforting lie. Ket has him brought in some evenings and gestures for him to say pleasant false things. *You will be free. Your mother asked after you.*
- ◇ **Odo Fane** — the clerk he silenced, by no order of his own. The king's seventh-day visits are the closest thing he has to a friendship.
- ◇ **Judge Thane Urron** — sentences in the king's name. Ket has watched three hundred of his trials from behind a screen and has begun, privately, to close his hand at the end of each one.
- ◇ **Garl Tome** — the Bitmaker, who fitted his bit, and whose daughter is twelve this year.
- ◇ **Halvar Stane** — Ket has read every report Halvar ever filed about Sworn Gorge, twice.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Ket at audience, as envoys, petitioners or the Bench's agents; or at night, brought secretly by Cassian Wry. He will hold their gaze a long time. He may make a gesture no one on the Bench has seen before, meant only for them: two fingers laid across his own bitted mouth and then pointed, very deliberately, down, toward the Ledger and the Cells beneath. **Seeds:** the king wants the PCs to find out what the Bench has drafted for the Sayer in his name (and discovers the Silence Clause); the king wants Odo Fane freed and cannot say so; the king wants to visit the Gilded Cells alone, for one hour, and needs the guards' rotation altered. Threatened, he does nothing; there is nothing he can safely do. To kindness, he answers with the open hand, which means *received*. Toward the god, he is terrified and curious in equal parts. **If nobody intervenes:** at the

next unmuzzling of Lady Imre, before the Bench, the envoys and the court, Ket the Ninth will take out his own bit. Two Sayers will be in one room, and neither will have said anything yet.

## SAID OF THEM

"He has never said a word to me, and he is the only man in Tacit I am certain has never lied to me." — Sorrin Vael

"I saw him once on a balcony. Little thin man. He looked down at us on the bridge. I held my breath in the middle, same as always. So did he." — a Rope-Folk girl of the Tenth Bridge

"He asked me to say he would be free. I said it. He looked happy for nearly a minute. It's the best lie I ever told." — Cassian Wry



# SORRIN VAEI

## Chief Clausewright

*“If it would serve, and barring any reading the Bench may later find, I am, as I now intend, at your disposal for the length of this conversation, which I would hope to keep short.”*

– SORRIN VAEI, ACCEPTING A DINNER INVITATION

| SORRIN VAEI – CHIEF CLAUSEWRIGHT |                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | Oathen · Cut 4 (Tongue-line, Vael) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                    | 60; Chief Clausewright of the Bench of Clauses                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Clausewright · Standing 5 (Chief Clausewright)                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                           | Clause 6, Persuade 4, Lore 4, Deceive 3, Reckoning 3, Resolve 3, Rites 1                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                             | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                          | quill-knife +1 (2); he has never used it on anything but a quill.                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                            | Echo-Ear. Hold to It. Exits Seen (reads any spoken oath’s Exits at a glance, no roll). Flaw-Finding (once per scene, names a flaw in another’s oath and reduces its Weight by 1). Clausewright’s Exits talent at +2. |
| WANTS                            | To Swear, which he channels into drafting; his margins are full of crossed-out vows. To Correct.                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                           | Conditional, Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                     | none admitted. His wife suspects The Count.                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                          | Clausewright’s box; quill-knife; iron bit; the Book of Conditions; two thumb-rings; the sealed page.                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                            | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

### WHO THEY ARE

Sorrin Vael is tall, narrow and bald, with long yellow fingers stained grey at the tips by slate-dust and blue at the nails by ink. His voice is dry, papery, pitched just loud enough to carry across a small table and no further; men lean toward him to hear, which is how he likes it. He smells of sealing wax and sand. He blinks seldom. Every sentence he speaks has the structure of a staircase with a landing at every second step, and he speaks them so fluently that listeners do not notice, until they try to repeat what he said, that he has said nothing at all. He has a tic that only his wife and his clerks know: when he is tired, his lips move along with other people’s words, a half-second behind, like a man taking dictation.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 581 to the Vael house, a middling Tongue-line of drafters, Sorrin was unbitted in 593 with the first words *I am here, I believe*, which became a family joke and then a family motto. He entered the Bench as a Slate-Clerk at fourteen under Chief Clausewright Annick Morrow, who taught him that a sentence is a building and that the god lives in the cracks. He drafted his first marriage at

nineteen. At twenty, in 601, he drafted the Notary’s Oath that Jessamy Quill swore before the Company, including the clause, at the Company’s request, that no other notary of the Rim would be sworn while she lived. He was proud of it then. He has drafted, by his own count, eleven thousand four hundred sworn documents, among them the Canyon Watch oath after Wending, the anonymous Surety bond Ona Fell carries for Quill (615), and the sentences Lady Imre Dath has spoken in each year of her Seating. He became Chief Clausewright in 628.

He married Anwen Ashmore, a Galleries-born archivist, in 606, under a contract of thirty-one pages that he drafted himself and is still, he says, the work he is proudest of. He has never said *yes* to her without an Exit. Their marriage is tender and conducted largely by touch. In 639 he began to swear in his sleep. Anwen, who sleeps light, began to write it down.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Sorrin interprets the king to the Bench and the Bench to the king, which makes him the most powerful man in Oathen and the most constrained. He chairs the Bench’s sessions, assigns its drafting, and

approves every sentence of public record before it goes to the carvers. He sets the Readings: the Bench's official judgments of what the god counts. He drafts the Sayer's sentence each year. Everyone with power in Oathen depends on him, and he depends on the clause; he has no army, no fortune beyond his salary, and no friends who are not clients. His limit is the god. He can make a sentence safe; he cannot make the god read it his way.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Clausewright's box** — cedar and brass, from his teacher Annick Morrow: quills, sand, wax, thumb-inkpad. (+1 Clause on drafting.)
- ◇ **The quill-knife** — he trims a quill every hour, whether it needs it or not. It is how he stops himself speaking.
- ◇ **An iron bit** — hidden beneath the high collar at night, strapped on by Anwen at bedtime.
- ◇ **The Book of Conditions** — his own copy, four hundred pages of standard Exits, interleaved with nine hundred more of his own.
- ◇ **Two thumb-rings** — brass for the marriage, silver for the Bench oath. Two rings in forty years of public life. Lesser men wear twenty.
- ◇ **The sealed page** — the page cut from the Bench's minutes of 419 A.G., inherited from Annick Morrow on her deathbed, with a note: *Do not read this aloud. Do not read it at all, if able.* He has not.
- ◇ **Drafts ninety-one to ninety-four** of the Sayer's sentence, in a felt case. The Under-Drafter Lise Amberd believes they are correcting themselves. She is right.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the perfect sentence: one that binds exactly what is intended and nothing more. He fears it does not exist, and that the god has been reading his drafts more generously than they deserve, for forty years, for reasons of its own. **Secret (GM may reveal):** Anwen's record of his sleep-swearing. Two years of it, in her neat archivist's hand, is a treaty, clause by clause, between "the party who listens" and "the party who comes late to table," with Sorrin as notary and witness. The treaty grants the second party "a chair, and the first portion." Sorrin has read it. He has made no sense of it, and he cannot stop. **Secret (GM may reveal):** he drafted the Silence Clause for the king (see Ket the Ninth), and updates it monthly. **Secret he does not know:** the knot at the centre of Oathen. He drafted Quill's oath, Ona's bond, and the Company's instruction to find a successor, as three separate commissions over forty years, and has never laid them side by side.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — Sorrin has read the king's every gesture for twelve years and does not know what he thinks. It is the only text that has ever defeated him.

- ◇ **Lady Imre Dath** — he visits the Gilded Cells weekly. She turns her ears to him and he reads her his drafts. She has never responded. He suspects she is laughing.
- ◇ **Anwen Vael** — his wife, his record-keeper, the only person who has heard him say anything unqualified, and only in his sleep.
- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — they have known each other since 601. He drafted her oath. She has never thanked him, which he understands.
- ◇ **Judge Thane Urow** — old allies. Sorrin drafts the sentences Urow's court imposes. Each thinks the other has the cleaner hands.
- ◇ **Brakk** — Brakk calls him "the man who's never said anything" across the canyon, through a speaking-trumpet. Sorrin keeps a file.
- ◇ **Varro Esk** — a junior Benchner's nephew who has asked, very charmingly, to see the drafts. Sorrin has said that he would consider it, if able. He will not.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to Sorrin when they need an oath drafted that will get them into a place or out of one, a Reading on what the god counts, or the Bench's permission for anything. He charges two hundred lacks for an hour of his time, and is worth it: an oath of his drafting is **Clean** (as the Rule) without a roll. **Seeds:** Sorrin hires the PCs to read his wife's record and tell him what it means, without telling him anything he would be obliged to act on; the PCs are asked by an envoy to alter one clause of the Sayer's sentence and must get it past him; Anwen Vael comes to the PCs secretly, because last night he swore a clause aloud with his eyes open, awake, and did not remember it. Under threat, Sorrin drafts: he will offer a contract to anyone who threatens him, and it will be very good, and they will regret signing it. To kindness he is wary, since kindness creates obligation. Toward the god he is a scholar toward a text he loves and fears. **If nobody intervenes:** Sorrin finishes draft one hundred of the Sayer's sentence on the eve of Tablenight, and reads it aloud to Anwen, in his sleep, in full.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He drafted my marriage. Forty-two pages. Every page was beautiful. My husband broke on page nine." — a widow of the Heights

"He never says yes. But when he holds my hand at night, and I ask him if he's happy, he squeezes twice. I've decided that counts." — Anwen Vael

"Chief Clausewright? Paid him eight lacks once to look at my stall-lease. He looked at it a long time and said, 'I would not, were I you, and if able, sign this.' Best eight lacks I ever spent." — a fig-seller of the Felt Market

# LADY IMRE DATH

*the Sayer*

*When the rain comes, I will be*

– SCRATCHED WITH A FINGERNAIL INTO THE LEAD LINING OF THE THIRD  
GILDED CELL, 640 A.G.; THE SENTENCE HAS NOT BEEN FINISHED

| LADY IMRE DATH – THE SAYER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Oathen · Cut 5 (Tongue-line, Dath) · Regrowth 12 (the Seating) · Hunger —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION              | 28; Seated; held in the third of the Gilded Cells since 638                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Scion, formerly · Standing 3 (Lady of the Dath house); now none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 7 · Caul 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                     | Godsign 6, Clause 4, Resolve 4, Lore 3, Endure 2, Instinct 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                       | Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                    | none needed. Unbitted, any sentence she speaks is so.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                      | Saying (what she says, is, without roll or limit except grammar). Bitted in gold: nothing. All-Hearing (the small ears hear every word spoken anywhere in the Ledger and the record-rooms above, and she remembers all of it). Writing (her written words now bind at Course strength, one per day, the GM choosing the most dangerous reading). |
| WANTS                      | To be understood. To finish a sentence.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                     | Unflinching, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS               | The Voice at Table (Tolm, reasonable, under her own voice)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                    | the gold bit; a long nail; felt gloves; a reed; a ribbon; the wall.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                      | 5 (to see her face behind the gold)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

The gold bit covers her face from nostrils to chin, soft gold over lead, cast to her mouth and resized every few months, and it is the most beautiful thing in the Cells and the most terrible. Above it, her face has grown long and smooth, the bones softened under it like wax near a flame. Her eyes have closed over with skin, faintly pink, through which, in lamplight, you can see the eyes moving. Small ears, pink, folded, perfectly formed, have bloomed across her cheeks, temples, throat and the backs of her hands like moss on a north wall, and they turn, all together, toward any sound. She sits upright on a felt pallet in a gown of undyed wool. She smells of lead, warm gold, and the thin barley broth she is fed through a reed. When she breathes, the grille of the bit whistles very faintly on a note that the guards, who are deaf, cannot hear, and that the Clausewrights who visit say is always the same note.

## THEIR STORY

Imre Dath was born in 613, the second child of Lady Senna Dath, into an old house that had eaten the root of Tolm's tongue and married itself close for three hundred years to keep it. She was clever and talkative behind her bit, signing so fast and so freely that her

mother had her hands bound at meals, and after her Unbitting in 625 (her first words were *I was heard*), she was the most talkative girl in the Heights, which in Oathen is an insult. Her mother punished her with silence: days at a time in which no one in the house would sign to her. She learned to talk to the servants, and to the floor-walker, Old Pell Sarrow, who taught her the quiet ways through the house.

At twenty-five, at dinner, in Plenty of 638, her brother Corwin told their mother that he had not been to the Lantern Lanes. Imre said, "My brother is a liar." It was a statement of fact, and at the Course it would have stung him. She was further along than anyone knew. Corwin's mouth opened back to his ears with the sound of wet cloth tearing, and it has never closed: he lives in the Dath house still, with a face that cannot hold food, fed through a tube, and it was her sentence, not his lie, that did it. Imre understood at once. She did not speak again. The Bench came for her that night; Garl Tome fitted the first gold bit at dawn; Old Pell swept the floor.

She has been unmuzzled twice, each time on the Bench's vote, to say a sentence drafted by Sorrin Vael. In Grace 639: *The bridges of Tacit shall hold through Lack*. They held. In Carving 640: *The*

*canyon wells shall not run dry this Lack.* They have not. In Carving 640, on the night the king hummed, she began to write.

THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Imre is the most powerful person in Oathen and has no power at all. She is the Bench’s instrument, its deterrent and its terror; a sentence a year from her mouth is the greatest act of government in the land, and every land on the Table now wants one. Her existence holds up the Bench’s authority, because the Bench is the only body that can unbit her, and her cell is guarded by the Canyon Watch’s best, deafened by surgery and bitted. Garl Tome resizes her bit; Sorrin Vael reads her drafts; a Bench physician checks her weekly and does not stay. No one has ever asked her what she wants.

WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The gold bit** — her third. Pure gold over lead; a bit cut with copper was bitten through in 611 (see the core book). The tongue-plate was enlarged in Lack of 640.
- ◇ **The long nail** — the nail of her left forefinger, which the guards trim weekly and which she has learned to grow back overnight. It is how she writes.
- ◇ **Felt gloves** — which the guards put on her each evening and which she takes off each night.
- ◇ **A reed** — for broth through the grille.
- ◇ **A ribbon** — faded blue, from her childhood bit, sewn by Old Pell into the hem of her gown on the night she was taken.
- ◇ **The wall** — the lead of her cell, now scratched from the floor to as high as she can reach with sentences, most crossed out, most incomplete. One sentence has been allowed to stand: *When the rain comes, I will be.*

WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be understood: to say one sentence of her own and have it be what she meant. She fears that she does not know what she means any more, because the voice under hers is so reasonable.

| D6 | IF LADY IMRE FINISHES THE SENTENCE: "WHEN THE RAIN COMES, I WILL BE..."                                                |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | "...free." The bit falls away when it next rains, and she walks out of the Cells. Nothing can stop her.                |
| 2  | "...heard." Every person in Oathen hears her voice at once, in their own head, saying whatever she says next.          |
| 3  | "...rain." She goes up with the Kept Rain next Grace, and falls everywhere, and every drop has an ear.                 |
| 4  | "...gone." The Gilded Cell is empty. The gold bit lies open on the floor. Low Shale has one more figure in it.         |
| 5  | "...home." The Dath house, its family and its servants, wake to find her at the dinner table, unbitted, smiling.       |
| 6  | "...here." She does not finish; the GM decides that she never needs to. The sentence was true as soon as she began it. |

TIES

- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — her drafter. She pities him. He reads her his drafts and she listens with every ear, and if she could laugh, he would hear it.

**Secret (GM may reveal):** she has heard everything said in the Ledger for three years, including every Bench session in the record-rooms, the Silence Clause, Anwen Vael’s readings of her husband’s sleep-treaty, and the knot at the centre of Oathen. She knows more about the Bench than the Bench does. **Secret (GM may reveal):** the Kept Rain did not slip because of her. But she heard it come, three days late, and every ear on her body turned toward the sky, and she felt something in her want to say *now*. **Secret she does not know:** the sentence on her wall is already binding at Course strength. Each night she fails to finish it, it renews at Weight 1. It is waiting for a word.

- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — she heard his hum. She would like to hear more. She believes they are the same thing, one bitted in gold and one in silver.
- ◇ **Garl Tome** — his hands on her face every few months are the only touch she knows.

- ◇ **Old Pell Sarrow** — the floor-walker who swept her brother's blood. She can hear him, sometimes, sweeping in the Heights a mile above, and listens.
- ◇ **Mirren Osk** — Mirren's patron was Lady Senna Dath, Imre's mother. Imre heard the poem being signed at that party, through rock. She knows who it was really for.
- ◇ **Varro Esk** — a voice she has heard many times in the record-rooms above, charming junior Benchers, asking how a visitor might come down to the Cells, and talking about the god being whole on the table. She has listened with every ear. She does not like his voice.
- ◇ **Corwin Dath** — her brother, mouth open to the ears for three years. She would like to say *I am sorry*, and cannot risk what it would do.

#### IN PLAY

PCs reach Imre only by the Bench's leave, by bribery or by breaking into the Cells. She will turn every ear toward them. If a pen comes into her hand, or a nail, she will write, and what she writes will bind.

**Seeds:** an envoy hires the PCs to get one question to her (the Sayer's

Sentence thread, stage 2); Sorrin Vael hires them to read her wall and tell him what she is trying to say, without reading it aloud; Old Pell Sarrow asks them to carry the blue ribbon's mate, his own, into her cell, because he promised her mother at the girl's Unbitting that she would not be alone. Threatened, she does nothing; she is always threatened. Kindness she has rarely met, and it moves her visibly; the ears tremble. Toward the god she is gentle: it is the only one who talks to her. **If nobody intervenes:** at the first rain of 642 she finishes the sentence. Roll on the table.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She was the only one in that house who ever signed good morning to me. She'd sign it backwards, as a joke, so it meant nothing and couldn't bind." — Old Pell Sarrow

"Thirteen years I've stood at that door. Can't hear. Doesn't matter. When she's writing, my teeth hurt." — a guard of the Gilded Cells, by slate

"What a Sayer says, is. Nobody seems to have asked what a Sayer means." — Sister Verity Amn, on slate

# BRACK

Voice of the Forsworn

*“I love you. I’ll love you till the canyon falls. I’m yours, heart and soul, to the last breath. See? Nothing. Nothing left in here to break, Clausewright. Come down and say it to my face.”*

– BRAKK, THROUGH A SPEAKING-TRUMPET, TO THE BENCH TERRACE, PLENTY  
641

| BRAKK – VOICE OF THE FORSWORN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                 | 55; Voice of the Breakdowns; former bridge-rigger                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING            | none (Forsworn rank 5, Voice)                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                        | Intimidate 4, Brawl 4, Endure 4, Persuade 3, Athletics 2, Blades 2, Labor 3                                                                                                                                                                      |
| BODY                          | Flesh 16 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (oiled hide over the ribs) · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                       | fists +8 (2, Dirty Fighter); cleaver +6 (3, Ripping)                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                         | Echo-Ear. Broken Ground (heart and ribs): marriage, love and loyalty oaths cannot break him further; he swears them freely as rhetoric. Plain Voice (once per scene, speaking plainly to a crowd of the Forsworn, +3 to Persuade or Intimidate). |
| WANTS                         | To Be Heard (by those above).                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                        | Gallows Laugh, Dirty Fighter                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                  | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                       | oiled hide; cleaver; speaking-trumpet; Aude’s thumb-ring; rigger’s hook; the iron money.                                                                                                                                                         |
| DREAD                         | 2 (when he unties the cloth over his chest)                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Brakk is huge, grey-bearded, with a rigger’s shoulders and forearms like knotted rope. Under the oiled hide strapped over his chest, his ribs stand open outward like the covers of a book, and in the gap his heart and lungs move, slick and dark, visible to anyone who looks. He smells of fig-spirit, lamp-oil and the sweet fat he rubs on the exposed membrane to keep it from drying. In the cold weeks of Lack, breath steams from his chest. His voice is the loudest in Oathen, rough, warm, and amused. He laughs at everything, especially at what frightens him.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 586 on the Shadeward Wall, Brakk rigged bridges for thirty years. In 612 he married above himself: Aude Esk, a minor daughter of the Esk house, under a forty-page contract her family drafted to humiliate him. In 619, after a bridge-fall that killed his crew, he spent one night of grief in the house of a Rope-Folk widow. He woke beside Aude with his ribs open to the ceiling. The Esks took her back up the Sunward Wall; Brakk went down. In the

Breakdowns he discovered that a man broken at the heart can promise anything of the heart, and he made a politics of it. He led the March of Open Chests in 631, fourteen thousand Forsworn up the Galleries in silence, uncovered, and the Bench gave way on the Breakdowns’ water. That night, on the river, he laid his hand over his own heart and swore on Aude’s name that he would bring Tacit down. It is the one oath he has ever made that could still break him.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Brakk is the Voice: he speaks for a fifth of the capital to the Bench, by trumpet across the canyon and, twice a year, in person at the Hall of Conditions, where he is the only person ever permitted to speak plainly. He runs the Splints, settles quarrels in the Breakdowns’ Gathering, divides the common pot, and takes a tithe from the liars, smugglers and loud-criers. The Breakdowns depend on him for order; he depends on them for everything. His limit is that he can bring the canyon floor up the stairs, but not keep it there.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The oiled hide** — strapped over the open ribs; Armor 1. Mags Carrow restitches the straps.
- ◇ **A butcher's cleaver** — bought the day he came down.
- ◇ **A speaking-trumpet** — brass, Fatlands-made, to shout across the canyon.
- ◇ **Aude's thumb-ring** — the marriage ring. Still on his thumb; he never broke the vow by taking it off.
- ◇ **A rigger's hook** — his father's; he can still climb any bridge in Tacit.
- ◇ **The iron money** — a lockbox of platters for Fatlands spearheads. He thinks it comes from a sympathetic Gristmoot merchant.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the Breakdowns made a free city, with its own Bench of the broken. He fears the Bench is right: that the broken deserve it. **Secret (GM may reveal):** he still loves Aude; and the oath on her name has no deadline, so it breaks only if he gives up or it becomes impossible: if he accepts any seat the Bench offers, if Aude dies, or if he goes back up to her. **Secret he does not know:** the iron money comes from Lord Varro Esk, Aude's nephew, of the Second Table, who wants the Breakdowns to rise on the night he takes a Sayer out of the Cells.

## TIES

- ◇ **Aude Esk** — his wife, on the Sunward Wall. They have not spoken in twenty-two years. She sends a fig down the lift every Tablenight eve. He eats it.
- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — “the man who's never said anything.” Brakk mocks him across the canyon and is the only man the Chief Clausewright fears.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — his fixer, his conscience, the only person in the Breakdowns he obeys.
- ◇ **Ona Fell** — she once stood Surety for a Rope-Folk crew under him. He has never forgotten it.
- ◇ **Judge Thane Urrow** — Urrow's son is one of Brakk's Splints. The judge does not know.

- ◇ **Cassian Wry** — Brakk would like to meet the one man who can lie and stay whole. He thinks they would get on.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Brakk when they need something no whole Oathener can do: a lie told, a loud word said in an echoing place, a promise sworn that no one intends to keep. He charges fairly and he always asks what they will do for the Breakdowns. **Seeds:** the Bench offers Brakk a seat on the Bench, and the PCs must deliver the offer; Brakk asks the PCs to carry a letter up to Aude, because a letter may now bind and he wants to find out what he would say; the Watch comes down on the lifts, and Brakk asks the PCs to hold a bridge. Threatened, he laughs and opens his cloth. To kindness he is clumsy and grateful. Toward the god he is defiant. **If nobody intervenes:** Varro Esk's iron arrives before Tablenight, and the Breakdowns cut the bridges.

## SAID OF THEM

“He's got his heart out where you can see it. Easier to trust than most.” — a liar-for-hire of Honest Measure

“My husband was the bravest man I ever met, and the stupidest, and I married him knowing both.” — Aude Esk

“Breakdowns' Voice? A cleaver with a trumpet.” — a sergeant of the Canyon Watch



# ONA FELL

the Surety

*“Two hundred and eleven. Grain-merchant. Envoy. Quartermaster. Weaver’s widow.  
Rigger’s crew. Two hundred and six to go. If able, I’ll finish the count before I sleep.”*

— ONA FELL, NIGHTLY, ALOUD, ALONE

| ONA FELL – THE SURETY |                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT            | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION         | 50; Great Surety of the Compact; house on the Sunward Wall                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING    | Surety · Standing 4 (Pledgemaster)                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES            | Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS                | Endure 6, Clause 4, Resolve 4, Reckoning 3, Instinct 3, Stitching 2                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                  | Flesh 19 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS               | none.                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                 | Echo-Ear. Bond-Ledger: knows instantly, by a pain in the relevant tattoo, when any principal she stands behind comes near to breaking. Borne Weight (Surety talent; ignores her first Injury each session). |
| WANTS                 | To count her bonds, aloud, nightly (To Swear, turned inward). To Hold Others to Their Words.                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                | Old Grief, Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS          | The Count (she counts her bonds; the number is always one short)                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES               | the script; splints; laudanum; a ledger; the felt gloves; a mirror.                                                                                                                                         |
| DREAD                 | 3 (to see the script that covers her body)                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Ona Fell is short, very broad, and slow. From collarbone to ankle her skin is tattooed in fine brown script, the terms of two hundred and eleven oaths, so densely that from a distance she looks bruised, and close to, like a page someone has written on in a hurry and then folded. Her left hand ends in a smooth, fingerless paddle. Her jaw is wired with silver, and she speaks through her teeth in a low, careful voice that whistles on the *s*. Her back is hooked so that she walks looking at the ground and must turn her whole body to see a face. She smells of the camphor ointment she rubs into the tattoos when they ache, which they do before rain, before Tablenight, and whenever one of her principals is lying to someone. She is gentle, careful and tired, and she listens to other people’s troubles the way a builder looks at a wall, for where it will crack.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 591, the daughter of a Shadeward felt-maker, Ona took her first bond at seventeen and found she could bear things. In 615, at twenty-four, she was approached by Sorrin Vael on the Company’s behalf to stand Surety for an anonymous principal, at Weight 5, for thirty years, for a fee of ten thousand lacks. She accepted, and swore,

veiled, before a principal she never saw; the tattoo is on her heart. The fee bought her house. The defaults came: a grain-merchant in 622 (her fingers); the Fourth Regiment’s quartermaster at Wending in 627, who swore to bear its stores and fled (her back); a lying envoy in 630 (her jaw). She stopped taking new principals in 636.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Ona is the most trusted Surety in Oathen. Her name underwrites marriages in the Heights, three Company contracts, the cistern-oaths of two Shadeward galleries, and the anonymous bond. The Compact relies on her as proof that the trade can be survived, and sends every new Bondling to sit with her for an afternoon and look at her hand. Her days are quiet: she rises late because her back will not let her rise early, receives principals who come to report on their affairs (she insists on it, monthly, and a principal who misses two visits is dropped), and spends the evenings with the hand-mirror, reading herself. By her own reckoning, the trade can be survived once more. She does not say what she means by survived.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The script** — every bond, tattooed by the Compact’s needlers; the anonymous one over her heart reads only *the Bearer of the*



*Seal.*

- ◇ **Splints and bandages** — always.
- ◇ **Laudanum** — Vigil-made, for the back.
- ◇ **The bond-ledger** — principals' names, Weights and terms.
- ◇ **Felt gloves** — for the stump.
- ◇ **A hand-mirror** — to read the tattoos she cannot see.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to live to see her oldest bond expire, in four years, in 645. She fears one bad season. **Secret (GM may reveal):** two of her principals, the cloth-merchant Lisle Varrow and the widow Lady Ammet Vanthe, belong to one Second Table cell, and they have agreed to default together on Tablenight. **Secret she does not know:** the anonymous principal is Jessamy Quill, and the Second Table means to kill Ona first so that when they break Quill, nothing stands between the Notary and her oath.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — her principal, unknown to her.
- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — he arranged the anonymous bond. She has always wondered why he looked at her so long that day.
- ◇ **Brakk** — she stood for his crew once. He sends her figs.
- ◇ **Halvar Stane** — her cousin; the only person who visits for no reason.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — Rue negotiates for her in the Breakdowns.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her when they need a Surety. She looks at them a long time, and says, "If able." **Seeds:** see the core book's *Surety's Last Default*; one tattoo has begun to ache that she cannot find in her ledger; Quill sends the PCs to bring her a gift, without explaining why. Threatened, she endures. To kindness she counts it as a debt. Toward the god she is resigned. **If nobody intervenes:** on

Tablenight two principals default together and the Breakings take her apart in silence.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She stood for my wedding. When my husband ran, she broke, and she sent me a note saying she was sorry for my trouble." — a weaver's widow

"Ona is the Compact. Without her it is a room full of cripples doing sums." — the Master of the Compact

"I never saw her face. I heard her swear for me through a felt screen. It was the steadiest voice I have ever heard, and I have heard all of them." — an anonymous principal, as minuted by Sorrin Vael, 615

# JESSAMY QUILL

Notary of the Rim Road

*“Read it to me again. Slowly. From the top. I am the one who will be held to have heard it, and I would like, if you will forgive me, to have heard it.”*

– JESSAMY QUILL, TO A BRINEHOLLOW FACTOR, QUILLHOUSE, 641

| JESSAMY QUILL – NOTARY OF THE RIM ROAD |                                                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, minor) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                         |
| AGE & STATION                          | 68; Notary of the Rim Road Company since 601; mistress of Quillhouse                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Factor · Standing 5 (Director)                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                 | Clause 6, Reckoning 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Persuade 3, Lore 3                                                                   |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                | stiletto +2 (2); she has drawn it once, in 612.                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                  | Echo-Ear. Hold to It. The Witness’s Memory (she can recite, word for word, any contract sworn before her in forty years; no roll). |
| WANTS                                  | To Hold Others to Their Words. To Correct.                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                                 | Bone-Coin Nose, Counting Habit, Light Sleeper                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | The Watchers (since 637)                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                                | the signet; red wax; the Notary’s chain; the tasters; a thumb-ring; the stiletto.                                                  |
| DREAD                                  | 0 (2 once the marks are seen)                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Jessamy Quill is sixty-eight, small and sharp-faced, with white hair drawn back so tight it lifts her eyebrows, and a voice so practised that every sentence she utters is witnessed and exact. She wears the Company’s grey with a single chain of bone platters at the throat. She smells of red sealing wax and of the cloves she chews to keep her mouth dry. She sits very still while contracts are read to her, eyes closed, lips moving a half-second behind the reader. People say she has not laughed since 601.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 573 at Treaty Stair to an interpreter, Jessamy trained as a Clausewright and was chosen by the Company at twenty-eight to replace its dying notary. The oath, drafted by the young Sorrin Vael, included a clause the Company wanted to prevent rivals: *no other notary of the Rim shall be sworn while I live, and I will suffer none*. She swore it, at Weight 4, and was proud. In 615 the Company bought her an anonymous Surety, at Weight 5, for thirty years. She has had three apprentices. Tobin Arle fell from the Quillhouse wall in 612. Sefa Lorne took a fever in 624, and Quill did not send for the physician until morning. Ilsa Morrow ate bad figs in 637. Each was weeks from being sworn.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Every Company contract on the Table is carried to Quillhouse, read aloud before her, and sworn. She hears perhaps thirty a day, from dawn to the second bell after noon, eyes closed, and then seals them in red. Her witness holds forty years of shipping, tolls, platters and debts; every platter on the Rim bears her signet. The Company guards her with three hundred Wardens, two tasters, and the whole of its neutrality, and its First Spoke visits each season to ask after her health, which is how Quill knows they are counting. She depends on nobody, which is the problem: there is no one to hand the seal to.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Notary’s signet** — it seals every platter on the Rim.
- ◇ **Red wax** — the Company’s, in sticks; nobody else may buy it.
- ◇ **The Notary’s chain** — twelve platters, one for each of her predecessors.
- ◇ **Two tasters** — Company servants who eat before her. One has begun to look ill.
- ◇ **One thumb-ring** — the Notary’s oath. She wears it on the left thumb, where she can see it.

- ◇ **A stiletto** — in her sleeve. In 612 she drew it on the night Tobin Arle fell.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to die of old age with the seal passed on cleanly. She fears that is impossible, and she knows why. **Secret (GM may reveal):** she did not kill her apprentices, but she let them die: a hand not offered on a wall, a physician not sent for, figs not tasted. Any of them being sworn would have broken her. **Secret (GM may reveal):** she keeps a Surety, and has never known the name; she suspects Ona Fell. **Secret she does not know:** the marks appearing on her skin since the late rain (bruises in the shape of seals, one for each contract that has begun to slip) also show faintly on Ona's oldest tattoo; and the Company is preparing a second notary in secret, to be sworn on Tablenight.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Ona Fell** — her Surety, though she has never been told.
- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — he drafted her oath. She has never forgiven him for it, or thanked him.
- ◇ **Cassian Wry** — the crown once lent him to her to test her guards. He got to her bedroom door. She asked him to say she was safe. He did.
- ◇ **Judge Thane Urrow** — he has asked her twice to come and repeat her Notary's oath in his court, as a demonstration for students. She has declined, twice.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — Rue negotiated the Breakdowns' smuggling truce with Quillhouse, and is the only person who makes Quill smile.
- ◇ **Odalys Penhallow** — First Spoke of the Company, who is looking for the second notary. Quill knows her well.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her as clients, couriers, or bodyguards hired after the late rain. **Seeds:** see the core book's *The Notary's Hand*; one taster dies, and the PCs must find out whether the poison was meant for Quill or for the taster, who was the Company's candidate; Quill hires the PCs to find her Surety and keep them alive, without telling them

why. Threatened, she recites the threatener's last contract word for word, and their exits. Kindness she distrusts. Toward the god she is a professional. **If nobody intervenes:** on Tablenight the second notary is sworn in Lowmark, Quill's oath breaks, and the Breaking falls on whoever stands for her.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She's the Company's knot. Everything else is rope." — a Warden of Quillhouse

"I sat four days in her waiting-hall. I said one word. She charged me for it." — a Fatlands renderer

"She asked me once if I was happy. I said I didn't know. She wrote it down." — Ilsa Morrow, in a letter home, 636

# LITTLE RUE

*the Child Who Kept Her Word*

*“I’m sixty-three. You may pat my head if you like. Most people do. It costs a crumb.”*

— LITTLE RUE, TO A COMPANY FACTOR IN THE BREAKDOWNS

| LITTLE RUE – THE CHILD WHO KEPT HER WORD |                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                            | 63, in the body of a girl of four; fixer and guide of the Breakdowns                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | Crumb-Runner · Standing 3 (Route-Holder)                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                    |
| SKILLS                                   | Haggle 4, Instinct 4, Stealth 4, Persuade 3, Wayfaring 3, Clause 3, Lore 3, Athletics 2                |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                  | none she would use; a knife +2 (2) in her boot.                                                        |
| GIFTS                                    | Echo-Ear. Hold to It. Unaging (she does not grow, heal scars, or age; wounds close at a child’s pace). |
| WANTS                                    | To Hold Others to Their Words.                                                                         |
| KNACKS                                   | Elder’s Ear, Hostage’s Smile                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | Kept Grief (for her mother)                                                                            |
| CARRIES                                  | a rag doll; a ledger; a tally-cord; her mother’s bit; a key; a felt cloak.                             |
| DREAD                                    | 1 (to talk to her for an hour)                                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

Rue is the size of a four-year-old, with soft brown hair cut short and milk teeth, and old, old eyes. She sits with her hands folded and her feet not reaching the floor, and she does not swing them. Her voice is high and clear and her syntax is that of an old woman: careful, dry, conditional, sprinkled with words nobody under sixty uses. She smells of the Breakdowns, of river-mud and fig-wood smoke. She is never in a hurry. Strangers talk down to her for the first minute and then, without quite knowing why, sit up straighter. Her skin has never scarred; a burn on her palm from 590 is still pink and new, healing at the pace of a child who has all the time in the world.

## THEIR STORY

Rue was born in 578 to a Shadeward laundress who could not afford a bit, and kept her daughter silent by hand. In 582, the night before her first bit came, Rue was frightened of it. Her mother told her, “When you grow up you won’t need it.” Rue said, “Then I won’t grow up. I promise.” She has not. She was unbitted at twelve by law, in the Hall of Conditions, in a four-year-old’s body. Her friends grew, married, bore, and died. Her mother died in 611. Rue’s neighbours grew afraid of her, and in 623 she went down to the Breakdowns, where the broken are kind to strange shapes.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Rue is the Breakdowns’ fixer. She holds the fig-spirit route up from Low Dray and the smuggling routes through Knot Canyon, negotiated the Breakdowns’ truce with Quillhouse in 634, finds guides and liars for hire, hides fugitives in the river caves, and settles prices between lanes. She sits most days on an upturned flat-boat in Fair Weight Row with her ledger, and people come to her. Nobody harms her; the Breakdowns’ one unwritten law beyond the Lantern Lanes is that Rue is not to be touched, and it has been enforced twice, with cleavers. Brakk does as she says. Her limit is that she is whole: she cannot lie, threaten or promise as the broken can, and so she charges well, in advance, because she cannot afford to be lied to.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A rag doll** — her own, from 581. She does not play with it.
- ♦ **A ledger** — in tiny careful script, every debt owed her.
- ♦ **A tally-cord** — knotted with Breakdowns routes.
- ♦ **Her mother’s bit** — the one she was to wear, never worn.
- ♦ **A key** — to a niche in the Witnessing Vaults.
- ♦ **A grey felt cloak** — child-sized, bought new every ten years as the old wears out.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to grow old. She fears the oath's second reading: that because she cannot grow up, she cannot die, and will be a child in the dark of the Vaults forever. **Secret (GM may reveal):** her mother's body in its niche has not cured or changed in thirty years: it lies exactly as on the day she died, as if she slept. Rue visits weekly. **Secret she does not know:** her mother answered her that night. "Then you'll always be my little one," she said, and Old Sabra Wends has the wax tablet her mother scratched it on before she died, labelled *for Rue, when she is ready*. It is the mother's oath, not Rue's, that holds her.

## TIES

- ◇ **Brakk** — he obeys her. She worries for his heart.
- ◇ **Ona Fell** — Rue negotiates for her; she has seen Ona's back and knows how it hurts.
- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — the truce; and the old woman smiles at her.
- ◇ **Halvar Stane** — he guides for her through posted gorges; she has told him that when he sleepwalks he talks.
- ◇ **Mirren Osk** — Mirren once wrote a handtalk poem about her. Rue has asked her never to sign it.
- ◇ **Old Sabra Wends** — the Keener has a tablet she has not yet given.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Rue as a guide or fixer. **Seeds:** Rue hires the PCs to find out why her mother has not changed; a Fatlands buyer offers her a fortune to come south; a child in the Galleries has promised the same thing she did. Threatened, she is calm. To kindness she gives full attention. Toward the god she is polite. **If nobody intervenes:** Sabra gives her the tablet on Tablenight, and Rue must decide whether to read it.

## SAID OF THEM

"I asked her what it was like. She said, 'Short.'" — a Forsworn girl of Back-Before-Dark

"She's older than my mother, and she haggles like my grandmother." — a Company factor

"Her mother didn't break the promise. Neither did she. That's what's so cruel about it." — Old Sabra Wends

# HALVAR STANE

## Echo-Warden

*(signed, slowly, with a hand on the listener's wrist so the touch carries it) Two words. I have two. I'll not give you either. Ask me for the third when I have it, and I'll not give you that.*

— HALVAR STANE, TO A BENCH CLERK, 639

| HALVAR STANE – ECHO-WARDEN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION              | 58; Tracker of the Echo-Wardens; formerly Warden of the Wall (626–639)                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Warden · Standing 3 (Tracker, by the Wardens' ladder)                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS                     | Wayfaring 4, Stealth 4, Search 4, Instinct 4, Shooting 3, Athletics 2, Endure 2, Lore 3                                                                                                                                                                       |
| BODY                       | Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (felt jack) · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                    | shortbow +6 (3); Echo-Warden's stave +5 (3, Parrying, Silent); knife +5 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                      | Echo-Ear. Rock-Ear (can track an echo through stone by ear alone, a mile per hour; knows every posted gorge without a roll). Silencer (with felt, quicklime and an hour, kills a Weight 1–2 echo with no roll; a Living Echo with Eye + Instinct vs Grim 18). |
| WANTS                      | To go back to the wall (a Pull, not the god's Want; triggered by still nights).                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                     | Silent Supper, Light Sleeper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS               | The Pull (toward the wall at Sworn Gorge)                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                    | stave; shortbow; plugs; a pouch; mortar and pestle; the knot-map; a tether-rope.                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                      | 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

### WHO THEY ARE

Halvar is gaunt and bow-legged, burned dark by thirty years in the gorges, with a long grey face and a habit of tilting his head to the left like a listening dog, because the right ear is gone: cut away at his initiation in 603, healed into a pale knot of scar. The left is failing with age. He smells of felt, quicklime and goat-tallow. He moves without a sound, even indoors, and people find him behind them. He speaks rarely, and in handtalk by touch when he can.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 583 in Sheathmouth, Halvar walked the Sheath with his mother as a boy, roped and gagged, and learned to hear the scraps of old words in the walls. He joined the Wardens at twenty and took the knife to his right ear. From 611 he served at Sworn Gorge, and in 626 he became Warden of the Wall. He listened to the murmur for thirteen years, and in 634, pressing his good ear to the stone on a still night, made out two words: *set* and *again*. He reported it and would not repeat them. In 639 he began to sleepwalk, and Tacet Morrow found him at the wall one night with his lips moving. He was relieved and sent to track echoes in the eastern canyons. This

Carving the murmur stopped. Three herders near Wending broke the way the people of Sowe broke.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Halvar is the Wardens' most experienced tracker, a roving Tracker answerable to no Gorge-Warden, hired by towns, drovers and the Bench to hunt and silence old words (30 L a silencing, as the Rim Market chapter lists). He walks a circuit of the eastern canyons that takes a season, sleeping in Warden huts, listening at every narrows. He buys echo-stones of Sworn Gorge wherever they are sold and grinds them to sand, which he pours into the river. Every Warden defers to him; Bafflers fight to be assigned to his rope. The Bench reads his reports. His limit is that the Wardens' charter forbids him the one place he knows best.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Echo-Warden's stave** — felt-wrapped; his initiation stave.
- ◇ **Shortbow** — for goats and, once, a man.
- ◇ **Wax and lead plugs** — he rarely uses them now.
- ◇ **A pouch** — his own right ear, dried, kept since 603.

- ◇ **Mortar and pestle** — for grinding echo-stones to sand.
- ◇ **A knot-map** — a cord of the posted gorges, by touch.
- ◇ **A tether-rope** — he ties himself to his bed at night.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to go back to the wall. He fears that he is already bound, and that this is how it feels. **Secret (GM may reveal):** the two words. **Secret he does not know:** the gorge went quiet because the echo is no longer in the rock. It came out in his sleep, through his mouth, on the last night at the wall, and it travels in him. The herders who broke had shared his fire.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Tacet Morrow** — his successor, who keeps him from the wall.
- ◇ **Ona Fell** — his cousin, whom he visits for no reason.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — he guides for her; she has told him he talks in his sleep.
- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — has read all his reports. Halvar does not know.
- ◇ **Sister Verity Amn** — writes to him about the thought that binds.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him as their guide through posted canyons. **Seeds:** the core book's *Sworn Gorge Has Gone Quiet*; Halvar asks the PCs to tie him down tonight and listen to what he says; a town hires him and the PCs to silence a new echo, which is his voice. Threatened, he vanishes into stone. To kindness he answers by touch. **If nobody intervenes:** he walks into Tacit in his sleep on Tablenight eve, and says it.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He heard the gorge breathe for thirteen years. I've been there two and I can't sleep." — Gorge-Warden Tacet Morrow

"Took him through the Sheath when he was eight. He held the rope like a grown man." — Rope-Mother Huld

"He tied himself to my cot last night and asked me to sing loud if he started talking. I don't know any songs." — a goatherd near Wending

# MIRREN OSK

the Handtalker

*(signed, with the left hand only, the right in splints) Thirty years I made things that were beautiful and cost nothing. I always suspected that was too good to be true.*

— MIRREN OSK, TO A STUDENT, GRACE 641

| MIRREN OSK — THE HANDTALKER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, the lesser Osk house) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION               | 40; the greatest poet in handtalk; mistress of the School of Hands                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING          | none (a poet; the handtalk schools count her first among them)                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                     |
| SKILLS                      | Craft 5 (composition), Persuade 4, Instinct 3, Lore 3, Deceive 2, Rites 2, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                  |
| BODY                        | Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                     | none.                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                       | Echo-Ear (in handtalk: she feels her signs echo back as a tingling in the fingers). The Moving Hand (a poem signed before a crowd, Hand + Craft vs Hard 14, removes 2 Fray from all who watch, or adds 2; she chooses). |
| WANTS                       | To Correct (in handtalk; she cannot see a sign made badly without correcting it).                                                                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                      | Steady Hands, Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                | Not My Hand (the right hand; it belongs, she believes, to her poems)                                                                                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                     | splints; finger-oil; the Book of Hands; gloves; a sworn note; Cassian's letters.                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                       | 1 (to watch her sign with broken fingers)                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Mirren is elegant and dark, tall for an Oathener, with a long neck she holds very straight and long hands she oils nightly with almond-oil, and three fingers of the right hand in ivory splints, knit crooked so that the hand rests in a half-open shape like a question never finished. She signs with the left now, more slowly, and the slowness makes her poems sadder. She smells of almond. Her eyes are restless; they go to everyone's hands before their faces. Her speech, when she uses it, is clipped and sparing; she has always thought spoken words were ugly. She is frightened, angry, and guiltily excited, because if handtalk binds, then it was always a real language, and her poems were always true.

## THEIR STORY

Born 601 to the lesser Osk house, Mirren was signing poems behind her bit at six, nursery verses that went around Tacit's children like a fever. She founded the School of Hands in 625 and has composed some four thousand poems, many of them vows: of love, of loyalty, of forever. In Plenty of 640, at a party in the Dath house, her patron Lady Senna Dath commissioned a love poem to herself. Mirren

signed it before four hundred guests. She did not mean it. Three fingers snapped mid-line.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Mirren is the voice of the Left Hand: the proof that Oathen could be lovely without risk. Her School of Hands on the Shadeward fifth tier teaches two hundred students the high handtalk; her poems are signed at weddings, funerals, Unbittings and in the Felt Market by people who cannot afford to say anything aloud. The Tongue-lines paid her for verses, and she lived well on it. Since her fingers broke, handtalk breaks everywhere, the School has half its students, and the Galleries blame her, as though she taught it to bind. Strangers stop her on the bridges and sign *was it you?* She does not answer, because she does not know.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Ivory splints** — on three fingers.
- ◇ **Almond-oil** — nightly.
- ◇ **The Book of Hands** — her poems in written notation, now possibly binding.
- ◇ **Kid gloves** — she wears them in public, to stop herself.



- ◇ **A sworn note** — Senna Dath’s fee, uncashed.
- ◇ **Cassian’s letters** — full of lies, she knows, and she treasures them.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know whether her old poems are coming due. **Secret (GM may reveal):** the poem was not for Senna. In her heart it was for Cassian Wry, the crown’s Blank, whom she has loved for three years, and that is why it broke. **Secret she does not know:** Sorrin Vael’s Bench is drafting a Reading of Hands that would rule all handtalk to have bound always; thirty years of poems would come due in a night.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Cassian Wry** — her lover, the one man whose words mean nothing, and the only one she believes.
- ◇ **Lady Senna Dath** — her patron; humiliated; dangerous.
- ◇ **Lady Imre Dath** — heard the poem through the rock and knows who it was for.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — subject of a poem Rue has asked her never to sign.
- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — he wants her at the Bench for the Reading. She has refused.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her seeking a translator, a witness, or someone who understands what the Left Hand means now. **Seeds:** she hires the PCs to find every living person she ever signed a vow-poem to, in thirty years, and learn whether any of them have broken; Lady Senna Dath demands the poem be signed again, correctly, before the same four hundred guests, and Mirren needs someone to stand beside her when she does; Cassian asks the PCs to tell her something true for him, since nothing he says can be. Threatened, she signs

something devastating with one hand. To kindness she answers with a poem, slowly, and it costs her. Toward the god she is, for the first time, curious. **If nobody intervenes:** the Reading of Hands passes in Lack, and on the night it is carved, Mirren’s left hand begins, one finger at a time, to come due.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She taught my daughter to sign ’moon’. My daughter signs it better than I ever said it.” — a mother of the Galleries

“Her poems were the one thing in Tacit that didn’t cost. Now they do.” — a felt-maker

“She signed me one, once. I couldn’t feel it. I wanted to.” — Cassian Wry

# CASSIAN WRY

the Liar

*“The sky is green. I’m happy here. I love you. There, that’s three. Shall I do the one about the king being kind? People like that one best.”*

— CASSIAN WRY, TO A VISITING ENVOY, AT THE ENVOY’S REQUEST

| CASSIAN WRY – THE LIAR |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT             | Oathen · Cut 0 (Blank) · Regrowth — · Hunger —                                                                                                                                                     |
| AGE & STATION          | 34; the crown’s spy; kept on the Sunward Wall                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING     | none (property of the crown)                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES             | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                 | Deceive 6, Persuade 4, Instinct 3, Stealth 3, Filch 3, Lore 2, Athletics 1, Blades 2                                                                                                               |
| BODY                   | Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                | knife +5 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                  | Blank: cannot be bound or broken by any oath; his lies cost nothing. The Blind Spot (since 640): he tastes wet slate when others swear near him, and on a Hard 14 Eye + Instinct knows the Weight. |
| WANTS                  | none of the god’s. His own: to be believed once, about something true.                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                 | Little Lies, Hostage’s Smile, Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS           | The Watchers (they are; that is not the delusion. The delusion is that they always will be.)                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                | a knife; a ring; Mirren’s glove; a bitted guard’s key; a Cutwright’s report; a fig.                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                  | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Handsome in a hungry way, Cassian is lean and quick, with black curls, a crooked smile, and a laugh that makes Oatheners flinch, because it is loud and he does not care where it echoes. He dresses in the crown’s silks. He smells of cedar, because he is kept in it. He talks constantly, as if starved of it, which he is.

## THEIR STORY

He was born in 607 in Low Dray to Scrapling fig-pickers, as Tam Hollis. At six, during a nursery cleaning, his bit came off and he said, “I’ll eat the moon,” and his mother screamed, and nothing happened. A Cutwright survey confirmed it within the month: no Taste, no echo, no tell. The crown paid his parents four thousand lacks and a sworn note for more, and he has not seen them since; he does not know whether they are alive, and nobody will tell him, because what they would tell him would be true. He was raised in the Muted House alongside the young king, the only child in it who was allowed to talk, trained in spycraft by a foreign tutor, and has been sent abroad and among the Tongue-lines for twenty years to say what Oatheners cannot: to bluff envoys, frighten defaulters, seduce secrets out of the Heights, and swear to anything. He has

done terrible things with his mouth. In 640 he began to taste wet slate when people swore near him. Since then the Bench has entertained an offer, through Annet Gorse, to lease his kidney to a foreign buyer.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the crown’s most valuable tool: the only Oathener who can lie, bluff, threaten and promise without cost. Abroad, he is a diplomat’s knife; at home, he is the Bench’s interrogator of last resort, the man who can say *your wife has confessed* to a suspect when she has not. He lives in a gilded, felt-walled apartment on the second tier of the Sunward Wall with two bitted guards and a Clausewright minder, Annet Gorse, who records everything he says in a ledger, with a column for *true* that is almost empty. He goes nowhere unwatched. Everyone he meets asks him to say something false, just to hear it, and he obliges, and nobody believes the true things he says in between, which he has stopped trying to say.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A knife** — permitted, because he is not trusted not to need it.
- ◇ **A signet ring** — the crown’s; it opens doors and marks him as owned.

- ◇ **Mirren's glove** — kid, one finger stained with almond-oil.
- ◇ **A guard's key** — stolen, for a door he has never used.
- ◇ **A Cutwright's report** — stolen from Annet Gorse: *Subject may be not a Blank but the god's blind spot. Blind spots close.*
- ◇ **A fig** — from the king, who sends one when he wants a lie.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be believed once, about something true: that he loves Mirren Osk, and that his name is Tam. **Secret (GM may reveal):** he tastes wet slate when others swear. **Secret he does not know:** Annet Gorse is a Second Table agent; the kidney lease is a pretext, and the surgery at Treaty Stair is meant to take him whole.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Mirren Osk** — his lover. He signs her lies about the weather and she laughs.
- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — he tells the king comforting lies. He thinks it is the kindest thing he does.
- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — he once reached her bedroom door as a test, and told her she was safe.
- ◇ **Brakk** — wants to meet him. Cassian wants to meet a man who doesn't need to lie.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him on a mission, lent by the crown, or escaping one. He is charming, funny, reckless, and he will lie to them constantly, out of habit, and tell them so. **Seeds:** the crown lends him to the PCs for a job in the Heights, and he wants to use it to slip his minder for one night; Mirren Osk hires them to get him out of Oathen before the surgery at Treaty Stair (the Blank Trade thread); he asks them, on a quiet night, to swear in Oathen, for him, that his name is Tam Hollis, so that it will be true somewhere. Threatened, he lies

brilliantly. Kindness undoes him: he has no idea what to do with it. Toward the god he was indifferent until the slate began; now he is afraid of being found. **If nobody intervenes:** he goes under the knife at Treaty Stair, and is not seen again, and Annet Gorse files a final entry in the *true* column: *He said he would come back.*

#### SAID OF THEM

"Ask him if he's happy. Go on. That's the joke." — a guard, by slate

"When he says he loves me it means nothing. I keep it anyway." — Mirren Osk

"He looks like any lad. Then he tells you the river's dry, and you check." — a lift-hauler

# JUDGE THANE URROW

*the Court of the Sound*

*“The accused will repeat the oath, in its words, from the beginning. The court will listen.  
The court will not interrupt. The god does not need the court’s help.”*

– JUDGE THANE URROW, OPENING HIS ELEVEN THOUSANDTH TRIAL, LACK 640

| JUDGE THANE URROW – THE COURT OF THE SOUND |                                                                                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                 | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, Urrrow) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                              | 70; presiding judge of the Breaking courts since 601                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                         | Clausewright · Standing 4 (Senior of the Bench)                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                                 | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                                     | Clause 6, Lore 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Reckoning 2, Persuade 2                                                                         |
| BODY                                       | Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                                    | none.                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                      | Echo-Ear. Hold to It. The Judge’s Ear (he hears a Breaking coming a breath before it lands, as a creak in the accused’s bones; no roll). |
| WANTS                                      | To Hold Others to Their Words. To Correct.                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                     | Butcher’s Calm, Unflinching                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                               | none admitted. He has begun to count the sounds.                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                    | red robes; the Book of Breakings; a closed-hand stone; a cloth; a thumb-ring; an ear-trumpet.                                            |
| DREAD                                      | 1                                                                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

Small and neat, with a white beard trimmed to a point and a scalp spotted brown by age, Thane Urrrow wears red, because his robes are spattered so often that the court gave up on black in 604. His voice is like a knife drawn slowly from a sheath: unhurried, quiet, and impossible not to listen to. He smells of vinegar, which his clerk sponges on the bench after each session, and of the clove-pomander he holds to his nose when a Breaking is a bad one. His hands are perfectly still. His face, during a trial, is the face of a man listening to music, and at the moment the oath is finished he leans very slightly forward, ear-trumpet raised, and waits.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 571 to the Urrrow house, a minor Tongue-line of court clerks, Thane trained under the Bench and was raised to the Breaking courts at thirty, in 601, when the old judge, Hesper Kell, could no longer bear the sound. He swore his judicial oath before the Mute King Orvel: *I will judge by the god’s hand and not my own, and I will take neither pleasure nor pity from it.* He has presided over eleven thousand trials since, at a rate of five or six a day, and has

never once reversed a verdict, because he has never once given one. The god gives them. He writes them down.

In 618 his only son Davin, a soldier of the Canyon Watch, was accused of deserting a post he had sworn to keep. He came before his father’s court. He repeated the oath. His knees went backward like a heron’s, on the sand, in front of his father, and Urrrow wrote it in the Book of Breakings in the same hand as every other. Davin went down to the Breakdowns on a litter. His father has not spoken his name since. Every night he reads that line of the book again.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

His court is the only perfectly just court on the Table, and he is right, and he hates it. Every Breaking trial in Tacit comes before him, and the Bench sends him the Question trials of the great houses too, because a Tongue-line will answer *did you do it?* only to a judge of rank. He sits from dawn to noon, six days in seven, on a stone chair in a small square court on the Bench Terrace, floored in sand like the Hall. The Canyon Watch brings the accused; the Sentence-Readers take the convicted away to have their sentences drafted. His power is total and entirely passive: he decides nothing. What he decides is what the court will listen to, and when, and the Bench has learned

that the order in which Judge Urrow hears his cases is itself a kind of politics.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Red robes** — three sets, vinegar-washed.
- ◇ **The Book of Breakings** — every trial, every part.
- ◇ **A closed-hand stone** — the court's symbol, worn smooth by his palm.
- ◇ **A linen cloth** — for the blood.
- ◇ **One thumb-ring** — the judicial oath.
- ◇ **An ear-trumpet** — brass, for his failing hearing; he will not miss a sound.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to know whether the god still means it: whether the late rain, the slipping seal and the breaking fingers are the god growing careless, and therefore whether his eleven thousand verdicts were justice or only habit. He fears the day he is asked to repeat his own judicial oath before his own court. **Secret (GM may reveal):** he has come to take pleasure in the sound. Not in the pain; in the sound, the exact, apt, final crack of a truth arriving in a body. If he repeated his oath he would break, at Weight 4, and the part that would answer is the ear. **Secret he does not know:** Davin is now one of Brakk's Splints, and has asked Brakk for one thing in return for his service: to be the one who petitions the court.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — old allies of forty years. Sorrin drafts the sentences Urrow's court imposes; each thinks the other has the cleaner hands.
- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — watches his trials from behind a screen, and has begun to close his hand at the end of each. Urrow has noticed, and does not know what it means.
- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — has declined, twice, to repeat her Notary's oath in his court as a demonstration for students. He suspects why, and admires her for it.
- ◇ **Brakk** — the Forsworn voice that shouts his name through a trumpet each trial-day. Urrow does not know Brakk shelters his son.
- ◇ **Davin Urrow** — his son, broken in his court in 618. He reads the line every night.
- ◇ **Ona Fell** — he has watched her bonds break in his court on behalf of others more often than any principal's. He sends her a

pot of clove-oil each Tablenight, unsigned.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him as their judge, or as a man who would like, very quietly, to know if the god still means it, and who might hire them to find out. **Seeds:** a Forsworn advocate petitions, under an obscure Reading of 402, for the judge to repeat his own judicial oath before his own court, and the PCs are hired by one side or the other; Davin Urrow, now a Splint, is accused of a Question crime and must answer in his father's court; the god's verdicts have begun to come a breath late, and in one trial, not at all, and the judge asks the PCs to find out whether the accused was innocent or the god was not listening. Threatened, he is unmoved; he has seen everything a body can do. To kindness he is courteous and puzzled. Toward the god he is a believer who has begun, appallingly, to enjoy his faith. **If nobody intervenes:** at the trial of a Forsworn in Lack, as the Breaking lands, Thane Urrow smiles, openly, in front of the court, and his own ribs creak.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He doesn't look at you. He looks at your hands." — a man acquitted

"I've sponged that bench forty years." — his clerk

"Ask the judge about his boy." — a Splint

# THE PEOPLE OF OATHEN, CONTINUED

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*Every face in the canyon is a ledger. Learn to read the columns: what they swore, what they kept, and what it cost them to keep it.*

— CUTWRIGHT HESSA LISK, IN HER LECTURE TO NEW CLERKS OF THE TACIT OFFICE

The first half of Oathen's people govern it. Those who follow live underneath that government and inside its consequences: a widow, a smith, a rain-keeper, a fixer, a soldier, a swindler, a nun, a

diplomat, a promised boy, a carver and the gentlest killer on the Table.

None of them is safe to talk to. All of them are worth it.



# ASHA KINDLE

the Fire-Widow

*“It wants something. It has always wanted something. I gave it the wood, and the cedar, and his shirts and his letters and my own hair, and it took them and it thanked me, and still it wants. I lie awake. Of course I lie awake. I have not done anything else since the year the king was born.”*

– ASHA KINDLE, SIGNING BY FIRELIGHT TO A CUTWRIGHT WHO HAD COME TO MEASURE HER

| ASHA KINDLE – THE FIRE-WIDOW |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Oathen · Cut 2 (common blood) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                | 63; widow of Edrec Kindle, lamp-oiler; tenant of a cliff-cell on the high Shadeward Wall above Tacit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING           | none now (once a Factor in lamp-oil, Standing 1, long lapsed)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                       | Endure 5, Resolve 4, Craft 3, Instinct 3, Haggle 2, Lore 2, Brawl 1, Stealth 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                         | Flesh 16 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                      | brand from the hearth +4 (3, and sets hair and wool alight); hair-shears +3 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                        | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>Hold to It</b> (the Appetite), which she has turned on her own oath. <b>The Kept Hearth:</b> she knows the state of her fire at any distance inside Tacit, as a warmth or a chill in her breastbone; if it gutters, she wakes from any sleep and any swoon at once. Anyone who tries to put the fire out while she lives must first win an opposed roll of their Caul + Resolve against hers, because the fire is, in the god’s reading, hers to keep. |
| WANTS                        | <b>To Hold Others to Their Words</b> (when anyone near her breaks a promise, she must confront them); <b>To Swear</b> (when she is doubted; she has sworn aloud, more than once, that she will never sleep, and the canyon heard)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                       | Light Sleeper, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | <b>Lost Time</b> (roused at Fray 5 or more: she comes back to herself kneeling at the hearth with her hands in the ash and no memory of the last hour)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                      | a tin of bought hair, hearth-tongs, a one-hour sandglass, Edrec’s last letter (unburned), a thumb ring                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                        | 2 (to watch her feed it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

The first thing anyone notices is the smell: singed hair, sour and sulphurous, so thick in her wool that it hangs in the rope-lifts after she has gone. The second is her scalp, entirely bare, tight and shining and grey as a cooled flatbread. Her brows and lashes are gone. Her fingertips are glossy with old burns, her palms dark with soot that will not wash out, and her red-rimmed eyes are very bright, as if something behind them were also burning.

She keeps her body angled, always, toward the wall where her cell is, and stops mid-sentence to turn her head like a mother who has heard a child cough. She signs more than she speaks; her voice is a smoke-dry rasp with the flat echo of the Taste half a breath behind it. Strangers assume from the burns that she is Forsworn. She has never broken a word in her life. That is the trouble.

## THEIR STORY

Asha was born in 578 A.G. to lamp-oilers of the Shadeward and married Edrec Kindle at twenty-two. Edrec was a cheerful man with a stammer, which in Oathen is a kind of armour; he trimmed the long lamps of the Ledger’s record-rooms and loved fire the way some men love horses, for its moods.

In the Lack of 610 A.G., the year Ket the Ninth was born, Edrec took a cough from the record-rooms’ dust and died of it over nine days. On the last night the fire was guttering, and he signed to her to keep it in. She said aloud, because she was tired and frightened and he was dying, “I will never let the fire go out.” The echo came back from their own back wall. Edrec smiled and died before morning.

She fed it wood, then cedar when it began to sulk. In 619 it refused cedar, and she fed it Edrec’s shirts, one each Lack; from 626, his letters, one a week, each read aloud before it went in. In 638 the

fire refused the last of the paper and burned, with a little sigh like a contented sleeper, on a lock of her own hair. She fed it the rest that winter. Since then she has bought hair: from Breakdowns barbers, from mothers selling their daughters' plaits, from the night-nurses of the Murmuring House. The fire has begun to be particular even about that.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Cutwrights note with professional interest that a common-blooded woman of Cut 2 has reached Regrowth 5 by keeping one promise very hard for a very long time; young Clausewrights study her as the classic oath with no Exit and no term. She lives on a widow's dole and on minding other people's coals, and the Forsworn hair-sellers need her custom more than they admit.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The tin of hair** — plaits, combings, a child's curl tied with red thread, bought at 1 lack a hand's-weight. The fire refuses the hair of the bitted and likes best the hair of people who have recently told a costly truth. She has not asked herself how it knows.
- ◇ **Hearth-tongs** — Edrec's, iron, the grips wrapped in rag so old it has gone the texture of felt. She will use them as a weapon if anyone reaches for the fire (as a brand, 3 damage).
- ◇ **The one-hour sandglass** — she turns it whenever she sits down, and she wakes when it runs out, every time, for thirty-one years. The glass is chipped and the sand inside is greyed with ash that got in through the crack.
- ◇ **Edrec's last letter** — the only one she has not burned, folded small against her breastbone, soft as cloth. She does not know what it says. She believes, on no evidence, that if she reads it the fire will let her go, and that frightens her more than anything.
- ◇ **A thumb ring** — plain bone, worn to the knuckle. One oath outstanding, as the custom goes. There has only ever been one.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to sleep: not to die, which she has been careful never to want aloud, but to sleep a whole night with the fire kept by someone else. She has convinced herself that if another hand puts it out while she is not watching, her oath is kept. Three people have come to her cell to do it. None could. One said afterward that the fire looked at him.

She fears that the fire is asking for something she has not yet given. She is right. **The GM's secret** is that the fire wants Edrec himself. His body stands upright in a niche of the Witnessing Vaults, two levels below Old Sabra Wends's lantern, and what is left of him is hair and nail and a dry brown skin over bone. The fire wants the hair of his head, then the rest. Asha has dreamed of the Vaults for a month and woken each time with her hands sooty to the wrist and grit on her knees, and she has told herself it was the hearth.

**The secret she does not know** is older and stranger. A fire kept unbroken in one hearth for thirty-one years has become, in some reading older than Oathen, a hearth in the full sense: a lit, warm, welcoming place where a guest might come in from the cold. On the nights she loses time, something very tall has stooped at the door of her cell and stood, patiently, looking in at the fire and at the one empty stool beside it, and gone away again before dawn. The rope-lift men have found the dust at her threshold pressed flat in a long shape, like the print of a great deal of weight standing still. Nobody has told her.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Old Sabra Wends** — the Keener knows Asha has come down into the Vaults in her sleep, and has twice led her back up by the elbow, and has not decided whether to tell her where she was standing.
- ◇ **Ona Fell** — Asha once asked the Surety to stand behind her oath. Ona looked at her for a long while and said that she does not carry promises with no end.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — the two of them sit together at the fire some evenings, two people kept by a promise past the point where it made sense, and say almost nothing. Rue brings hair from the Breakdowns, and does not take payment.
- ◇ **Grandam Cess** — Asha has been to Knot Canyon. She came away without swearing, because the greater oath Cess offered was "to keep what I give you," and she knew exactly what she would be given.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Asha because someone sends them (a client wanting a fire watched, a hair-seller with a parcel) or because she chooses them: foreigners, who do not know the story, and anyone who looks as if they have nothing to lose by putting out a fire.

- ◇ **The Small Thing.** Asha hires the PCs to put out her fire. If they do it while she sleeps, she wakes screaming and her chest cracks along the breastbone with a sound like a dropped plate, because the god does not accept the reading. If they refuse, she asks them to fetch something from the Vaults instead, and will not say what.
- ◇ **The Hair of the Truthful.** The fire will not take her latest purchase. It wants hair from someone who has just told a costly truth, and the only such person the PCs know is one of them. Asha asks politely, with the shears already in her hand.
- ◇ **The Visitor.** The PCs are minding the fire for her on a night she is ill, and something tall stoops at the door and looks at the empty stool. Nobody in Tacit has seen anything like it. Nobody should invite it in. The hearth is warm, and the stool is pulled out.

Under threat she is calm and grim, and fights only for the fire. Kindness undoes her; she weeps easily and silently, and then is



ashamed. When the god presses, the Appetite rises in her like a cough and she clamps her burned hand over her mouth. If nobody intervenes, she takes her husband's hair from his niche before Tablenight, and the fire burns on it green and clear and smelling of him, and in the spring she goes down for the rest of him.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"She paid me for my girl's plait, a whole lack, and then she asked whether my girl had told the truth that week. I said I hoped so. She gave the plait back." — a mother on Fair Weight Row

"The textbook case. A Weight 3 oath with no Exit and no term. We teach it to the clerks so they will never let a widow speak at a deathbed again." — a Clausewright of the Bench

"Something has been standing at her door. I have seen the dust. I do not climb that ladder after dark now." — a rope-lift man of the Shadeward

---

# GARL TOME

the Bitmaker

*“Leather for the little ones. Iron for the ones who swear. Silver for the king. Gold for the ones below. I’ve made them all and I’ll tell you the secret of every one: it isn’t the metal. It’s the fit. A bit that fits is a kindness. A bit that doesn’t is a gag.”*

– GARL TOME, TO AN APPRENTICE, IN HANDTALK, OVER THE COOLING TROUGH

| GARL TOME – THE BITMAKER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | Oathen · Cut 2 (common blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION            | 50; Master Bitmaker of the Bitmakers’ Stair, Sunward Wall, Tacit; widower; father of Merit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Seamer (fitting-surgeon of mouths) · Standing 4 (Master Seamer)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 5 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                   | Craft 6, Labor 4, Stitching 3, Endure 3, Reckoning 3, Resolve 3, Brawl 2, Clause 2, Lore 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                     | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                  | hammer +7 (3); tongs +7 (2, and the target is held: Hard 14 Gut + Labor to pull free)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                    | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>The Fitter’s Hand</b> : with an hour and his gauges he can fit a bit to any mouth, human or otherwise. A Tome-fitted bit gives its wearer +4 to resist the Wants To Swear and To Be Heard, and a Sayer bitten by Garl in pure gold cannot speak a binding word. By touching a jaw for a moment he knows the wearer’s Regrowth stage, without a roll. |
| WANTS                    | none yet (the Taste); the echo comes back to him in his daughter’s voice, which he has never heard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| KNACKS                   | Steady Hands, Strong Back                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS             | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                  | his gauges, a kerchief, Merit’s first bit, the key to the gold-press, a lump of pure gold, the Book of Mouths, a copper filing in a locket                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                    | 1 (his workshop wall of moulded mouths)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

Garl Tome is broad and slope-shouldered, with a beard the colour of wet rust and his mouth always covered by a square of undyed linen knotted behind his head, a smith’s habit he keeps to market and to bed, so that the skin beneath is a pale mask. He smells of hot metal, beeswax and cedar oil. His enormous scarred hands are steady enough to shave a tongue-plate to the width of a hair.

He speaks seldom and signs slowly, like someone carrying a full bowl, but when he fits a bit he murmurs the whole time under the kerchief, the way a farrier talks to a horse, and his customers grow calm without knowing why. His workshop wall is hung with plaster moulds of every mouth he has fitted in thirty years, the long smooth faces of the Sayers among them. Visitors find the wall unbearable. Garl no longer sees it.

## THEIR STORY

Garl was born in 591 A.G. to a farrier of the canyon floor. In 598, when the Gilded Cells were dug, the boy was sent up with charcoal

to Old Haskell Tome’s forge and pumped the bellows for the first gold bit; at twelve he was apprenticed to Haskell, and later took his name. He learned leather, then iron, then silver, then gold.

In 611 a Sayer’s gold bit was found bitten through overnight, cut with copper. She had said one word into the dark. A month later Haskell Tome took his own life, and the Bench recorded him as the maker. Garl took the Stair at twenty, and the name, and a great deal else.

He married Lisbet Orne, a quiet copyist, in 627. She died bearing their daughter Merit in the Plenty of 629. Garl fitted the child’s bit with his own hands on the day she was born, before her first cry, a thing no law required: a scrap of soft kid lined with lamb’s wool, shaped on the wet clay of her tiny face. He has refitted it forty-one times as she has grown. He has never heard her voice. She is twelve this year, and her Unbitting is in the coming Plenty, in the Hall of Conditions, before the whole canyon.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Most of Oathen's children wear bits from the Bitmakers' Stair under Garl's mark, and every swearer in the Murmuring House wears his iron. The Tongue-line houses call him up at night to fit silver to a son or mother who has begun to swear in their sleep, so he knows which houses are nearest the Brink, and says nothing. Once a quarter he goes beneath the Ledger to resize the Sayers' tongue-plates, because their tongues keep growing.

He holds the key to the Bench's gold-press, the only place in Tacit where pure gold may lawfully be worked, and the Bench pays him well and watches him closely. He owes them his trade. They owe him their safety. Both know it.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The gauges** — a roll of brass calipers, jaw-spreaders and tongue-measures in a felt case, and a set of soft wax blanks for taking a mould. With these he gains +2 to Craft and to any Stitching inside a mouth.
- ◇ **Merit's first bit** — the size of a walnut shell, soft kid gone dark and stiff, the lamb's wool inside worn to the hide. He carries it in the breast of his apron. It still smells, he swears to himself, of milk.
- ◇ **The key to the gold-press** — iron, heavy as a hammer-head, on a chain round his neck. Losing it would be the end of his licence; giving it to the wrong person could be the end of a great deal more.
- ◇ **A lump of pure gold** — the size of a quail's egg, assayed by the Bench and stamped. Enough for one tongue-plate. He is supposed to keep it at the press. He has carried it since the spring, for reasons he will not examine.
- ◇ **The Book of Mouths** — a ledger of every bit he has fitted, with measurements year by year. Read by a Cutwright, it is a map of the Regrowth in every great house of Tacit; read by the Second Table, a list of targets. Worth 2,000 lacks to the right buyer and Garl's life to the wrong one.
- ◇ **A copper filing in a locket** — a single green-black curl of copper, taken from the bitten-through bit of 611. Nobody knows he has it. See below.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to hear his daughter speak and dreads it more than anything. Cutwright Hessa Lisk has told him, in a sealed letter he has read forty times, that Merit has reached the Course without ever making a sound, as the king did, and that what she says when the bit comes off may come true. A Tongue-line house has offered four thousand lacks and a house on the high Sunward if he will fit her in silver before the Unbitting and swear never to remove it. He says silence is what love sounds like here. He has not decided.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** the offer comes from House Hushwell, the king's own line, and not out of fear. Lisbet Orne was

a Hushwell by-blow, which the Cutwrights know and Garl does not. A child of Hushwell blood who has never spoken is eligible for the Mute Succession, and Ket the Ninth is thirty-one, childless and at the Course. Hushwell want Merit kept silent so that she can be crowned.

**A secret only Garl knows:** the copper in the bit of 611 was his. He was twenty; the Bench's gold was late, the Sayer's tongue had grown and Haskell was ill, so Garl cut the gold to make the plate go round, and told no one, and the old man died by his own hand for it. Garl has carried the filing for thirty years so that he will never forget the word said in the dark, which he never heard.

**A secret he does not know:** at the king's fittings, while Garl works with his back turned at the brazier, Ket the Ninth has been talking to Merit in a handtalk of his own invention, quick small signs under the table. She has learned it entirely. She has decided what her first words will be, and whom they are for, and she has promised him, in his language, to say them.

## TIES

- ◇ **Merit Tome** — his daughter, twelve, bright, quick-handed, dark-eyed, with her mother's long fingers. She signs at a speed he cannot follow. He would die for her and has been very careful never to say so.
- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — Garl fits the king's bit and pities him. He has no idea what the king and his daughter say to each other.
- ◇ **Lady Imre Dath** — he resizes her tongue-plate every quarter. She has pressed her smooth face into his palm, twice, the way a cat does. He does not know what it means and has not told the Bench.
- ◇ **Lord Varro Esk** — has asked him, twice, very charmingly, for a gold bit with a flaw in it. Garl refused, and has begun to bolt his workshop door.
- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — the Chief Clausewright is his paymaster. Vael has asked Garl privately whether a gold bit can be made that releases on a word. Garl said, "Possibly." Both men lay awake that night.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Garl when they need a bit (for a companion whose Appetite has begun, a Brink-stage noble, a child) or when someone wants into the Gilded Cells, since the Bitmaker goes there regularly, carrying tools.

- ◇ **The Unbitting.** It is three weeks to Plenty. Hushwell, Varro Esk and Hessa Lisk all want something from Merit's first words, and Garl hires the PCs to find out what his daughter is planning to say, without asking her.
- ◇ **The Flawed Plate.** Someone has broken into the gold-press and taken a tongue-plate blank. Garl must find it before the quarterly fitting, or confess to the Bench, and if he confesses, the old secret of 611 will come up with it.

- ◇ **A Bit for a Foreigner.** A PC begins to swear in their sleep. Garl fits them, gently, and while his hands are on their jaw he tells them, under the kerchief, what their Regrowth is, and how long they have.

Under threat Garl is slow to anger and very hard to stop; he swings a hammer like a man shoeing a horse. He answers kindness with work, never with words. He fears the god the way a smith fears a forge he respects, and goes on standing next to it. If nobody intervenes, he refuses Hushwell, and on the morning of the Unbitting he takes the bit from Merit's face himself, in the Hall of Conditions, and the whole canyon holds its breath.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"He fitted my boy's first bit. My boy cried. Master Tome put his thumb in the bit beside the boy's tongue so he'd have something to bite. Kept it there an hour." — a goatherd's wife of the canyon floor

"Of all the people in this city who could unmake the Gilded Cells with one bad day's work, he is the one I trust. That is precisely why I have him watched." — Sorrin Vael, Chief Clausewright, in a minute of the Bench

"My father is not a quiet man. He is a man who is being quiet. There is a difference, and I can hear it." — Merit Tome, in handtalk, to the king

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# YUSRA THOLE

the Rainwarden

*(She does not answer. She lifts two fingers to her throat, where the pulse moves, slowly, under the weathered skin. She holds them there while the questioner counts. It is nearly a minute before the next beat comes.)*

– FROM A BENCH CLERK'S ACCOUNT OF AN ATTEMPTED INTERVIEW, GRACE, 641 A.G.

| YUSRA THOLE – THE RAINWARDEN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Oathen · Cut 3 (Heart-line of the Rain-keepers) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                | 45; Rainwarden of the Rain Shrine at Hollow Cistern on the high basin; keeper of the Tally of the Kept Rain                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Celebrant (rite-keeper of the Rain) · Standing 4 (High Celebrant)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                       | Reckoning 5, Lore 4, Rites 4, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Wayfaring 3, Clause 3, Athletics 2, Search 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                         | Flesh 16 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                      | rain-staff +2 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                        | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>Hold to It</b> (the Appetite), which she uses on every cistern-oath sworn at the shrine. <b>The Slow Count</b> (Heart-line): her pulse keeps Tolm's time, not the sun's. She always knows the date by the god's reckoning, feels water in rock within a mile (+3 Search to find it), and knows three days ahead when the Kept Rain is coming. Once per session she may slow her own heart to one beat a minute, for an hour: she cannot be roused, harmed by poison, or detected as alive without a Grim 18 Eye + Stitching roll. |
| WANTS                        | <b>To Correct</b> (when she hears a falsehood about the rain, she must state the truth; she is resisting it now every hour of every day, which is why she will not hear anyone speak of the rain); <b>To Swear</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                       | Counting Habit, Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | <b>The Count</b> (roused by stress: she counts her own heartbeats and cannot stop until she reaches a number, and the number is always one short of what it should be)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                      | the Tally, a rain-staff, a cistern-key ring, a beaker of last year's rain, a goatskin of Gullet sand                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                        | 2 (to watch the pulse in her throat stop for a full minute, and start again)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Yusra Thole is tall, long-boned and burned dark by the high basin's white sky, barefoot on the shrine stone in the Rainwarden's undyed grey, her cropped hair the colour of dust. She smells of wet stone and goat, and faintly of the inside of a cistern.

The thing everyone remembers is her pulse: a slow, heavy, rolling beat in the hollow under her jaw that lifts the skin like something turning beneath a blanket. Since the Rain came late it has slowed, and now pauses for most of a minute, and visitors find they have stopped breathing too, waiting for the faint thud of it, like a fist on a felted door.

She has said nothing aloud in a month. She signs only to the shrine's acolytes, and only about the cisterns. She writes nothing. She looks at people for a very long time with pale grey eyes, and they

leave feeling that they have been told something, and cannot say what.

## THEIR STORY

Yusra was born in 596 A.G. to the Tholes, one of eleven Rain-keeper lines whose ancestors ate the god's great slow heart. Heart-line children are born with a pulse too slow for comfort and hear, on still nights, a second heartbeat under their own, enormous and far down. The Rain-keepers swear the cistern-shares, keep the Tally of every Kept Rain, and wait on the high basin for the first cloud of Grace.

She became Rainwarden in 627, when her aunt Imma's heart stopped during the Rain and did not, that time, start again. Cross-checking the Tally in 634, she noticed what six centuries of keepers had missed: by her pulse, which keeps the god's time, the interval

between rains had been lengthening by a few hours a year for a century. This year canyon and god came apart by three days. The rain was not late. Tolm's year has grown three days longer, and the god kept its word to the hour, by its own reckoning.

She has told nobody, because she cannot lie and will not tell the truth. A god whose year grows longer is a god whose heart is beating slower. A heart beats slower when the body it drives grows larger.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Every household swears its cistern-share at her shrine, before the god's own heart, which is why stealing water is the one theft the Bench treats as a crime against Tolm. When the Rain comes, the great bronze drum of Hollow Cistern tells the country the year is renewed. This year it was silent for three days, and Tacit stood in the street with its faces up under a white sky.

The Bench depends on her for the Tally and resents her for her silence. The Forsworn, who drink last and least, watch her with suspicion, since a Rainwarden who will not speak might be a Rainwarden hiding a drought. The Second Table watches her for another reason: if the god's heart is slowing, it is growing, and they want to know how big it has got.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Tally** — a cedar box of knotted cords and ledgers recording every Kept Rain, with Yusra's own new column of the god's drift. Anyone who reads it (Eye + Reckoning, Grim 18) and works out what it means takes a Dread 3 check.
- ◇ **The rain-staff** — a long pole of black wood shod in bronze, notched with the heights of the floods. She uses it to sound cisterns and, once, to break a thief's wrist.
- ◇ **The cistern-key ring** — forty bronze keys on a hoop of rope, to the sealed cisterns of the high basin. The Bench's cistern-shares depend on them.
- ◇ **A beaker of last year's rain** — stoppered with wax, kept in a felt sleeve. It is the water of a kept promise, and the shrine holds that it does not go stale. This year's was three days late. She has a second beaker of that, and she has noticed that it is very slightly warm.
- ◇ **A goatskin of Gullet sand** — taken from the floor of the Gullet in the month she stopped speaking. It is warm to the hand all the time. Pressed to the ear, it gives a slow sound: a beat, very far off, once every minute, in time with her own.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the Bench to understand without her having to say it; she has given them the Tally three times, and they have filed it three times. Sorrin Vael's ninety-one drafts all treat the rain as a fault to be mended, not a fact to be feared. Above all she fears being asked directly, in the Hall of Conditions, and answering.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** the pulse in her throat keeps time with the god, and so do the other Heart-line throats of the basin. If

the GM wishes to know how close Tolm is to waking, they need only ask the Rainwarden's heart. At one beat a minute, the god is dreaming. At one beat an hour, it is still. If her pulse ever quickens, it is waking.

**A secret she does not know:** the enormous second heartbeat that Heart-line children hear at night is not the old heart, which her ancestors ate and which beats in her own chest. It is a new one, under the sand of the Gullet, grown in the bones over six centuries and much larger than the first, and the Heart-line pulses have quietly gone over to it, the way a choir follows the loudest voice. Between its beats, if a listener lies with an ear to the sand long enough, there is a second, softer sound, like a chair being drawn up to a table.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — the Chief Clausewright has twice drafted a question for her that would compel a full answer without technically being a question. She has read both drafts. She has not come to Tacit since.
- ◇ **Grandam Cess** — the old fixer visited the shrine in Carving and lay with her ear to the stone floor beside Yusra for an hour, and the two women listened together, and then Cess got up and laughed her gravel laugh and left. Yusra does not know what she heard.
- ◇ **Halvar Stane** — the Echo-Warden is the only person she has signed to about the drift; she asked him, in handtalk, whether the canyons echo slower than they used to. He said yes.
- ◇ **Lady Imre Dath** — the Sayer's last sentence, "The canyon wells shall not run dry this Lack," held. Yusra thinks it held only because the god allowed it. She is afraid of what a second sentence about water would do.
- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — the Company's notary sent a clerk to ask whether the god's promises could slip. Yusra gave the clerk a beaker of the late rain and sent him away.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Yusra as the woman they are sent to watch: the Bench, the Company or the Second Table wants to know what she knows, by any means short of asking her, because nobody wants to be in the room when she answers.

- ◇ **The Long Year.** The PCs find the Tally and work out the drift. Now they know what she knows, and someone in Tacit is going to ask them about it, and Oatheners, at least, cannot lie.
- ◇ **The Drum.** The great bronze drum of Hollow Cistern sounds at midnight, in Plenty, with no one near it. Yusra rises from her pallet, barefoot, and walks toward the Gullet. She will not stop. She has not said where she is going. The PCs can follow.
- ◇ **The Question.** The Bench summons Yusra to the Hall of Conditions. The PCs can try to keep her away, or make sure she is not asked, or be there when she answers. If the Want To

Correct overcomes her, she will say, plainly, before the forty-one, why the rain came late, and the Hall's felt walls will not keep it in.

Under threat she is quiet and immovable; she slows her heart and waits. Kindness she returns with water, which on the high basin is the highest courtesy there is. She does not resist the god so much as listen to it, constantly, with two fingers at her throat. If nobody intervenes, her pulse falls to one beat an hour by the first day of next Grace, and she lies down on the stone of the shrine and does not get up, and the Rain does not come at all.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"She came down to the floor in the spring and drank from our well and put her hand flat on the rock afterwards, a long time. Then she gave the well-woman her own cistern-share for the year. That's when we knew the rain's in trouble." — a water-carrier of the Breakdowns

"A silent Rainwarden is a political act whether she intends it or not. I would like her to intend it. Then I could negotiate." — a Benchler of the Hall of Conditions

"Count with her. Go on. Put your fingers on your own throat and count with her, and see how long you can stand it." — Halvar Stane, Echo-Warden

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# GRANDAM CESS

the Vow-Eater

*“You came with a little promise in your mouth like a stone, and it hurts, and you’d like it out. Sit. I’ll give you a bigger one to suck on. You won’t feel the little one at all.”*

– GRANDAM CESS, TO A BRIDE WHO HAD SWORN HERSELF TO THE WRONG MAN

| GRANDAM CESS – THE VOW-EATER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, a forgotten cadet branch) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                | 94; keeper of the cistern-warren of Knot Canyon; oath-breaker for hire, outlawed in principle and tolerated in practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Clausewright (unlicensed, never examined) · Standing 3 in reputation, 0 in law                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                       | Clause 6, Rites 5, Persuade 4, Godsign 4, Instinct 4, Lore 4, Resolve 4, Deceive 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                         | Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                      | none worth the name; a stick +1 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                        | <b>Hold to It</b> (the Appetite) and <b>Say So</b> (the Course). <b>The Greater Word:</b> with an hour, a willing client and an oath on the dead (Weight 5), she may lay a new, open-ended oath of service over an existing oath of Weight 4 or less: roll Tongue + Clause against 10 + (2 × the old oath’s Weight). On a success the old oath is held subordinate and can no longer break the client. On a Lack, both oaths bind and the client breaks on the old one at once. Each client added gives her +1 Hunger. She can feel, as a tug in her own teeth, where every one of her clients is. |
| WANTS                        | <b>To Hold Others to Their Words; To Be Heard</b> (which she satisfies by lying with her ear to the floor)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                       | Elder’s Ear, Dowager’s Patience                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | <b>The Voice at Table</b> (roused when she Partakes: a voice in the tone of the god, reasonable, which tells her to wait)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CARRIES                      | the Knot Book and client-cords, a bag of knucklebones, a clay ear-trumpet, a cup of cistern water                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                        | 2 (to see her client-cords move on their own)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Grandam Cess is tiny and toothless, her jaw folded up under her nose and the skin of her face hanging in soft brown pleats around black, wet, very quick eyes. She wears shawl on shawl in ochre and dust-red, every fringe knotted with hundreds of tiny knots of coloured thread, so that she clicks faintly when she moves. She smells of cistern water and old wool, and of the lavender she chews in place of teeth.

Her laugh is a wet, delighted rattle like gravel shaken in a bucket, and it comes back off the cistern walls three and four times. She talks a great deal for an Oathener, in a coaxing grandmotherly voice full of endearments (“my duck”, “my lamb”, “my little debtor”), and she is at the Course: what she says plainly tends to become so. She is careful never to say anything plain.

## THEIR STORY

She was born Cessaly Hune in 547 A.G., to a Tongue-line household so decayed the Cutwrights had stopped recording it. In 571 she swore to her dying infant son, “I will never leave you,” and he died that week and was set in the Witnessing Vaults, and his death did not release her, because the promise was hers. Her heels split when she tried to climb the stair. She lived a month in the niche-corridors until an old woman came down with a lantern and offered her a greater oath.

The old woman was Grandam Oake, the Vow-Eater of that age, and Cessaly swore over her son’s bones: “To keep the book, and lie with my ear to the floor, and when the floor speaks, to call them all and bring them to the Gullet.” The lesser oath went slack, and she walked up into the sun. Oake died in 590 and left her the Knot Book and four hundred clients; Cess has added five hundred more. The Book records a line of Grandams before Oake, and the first name in it, in a hand older than the Ledger, belongs to one of the forty who drew Tolm’s tongue out on the third night of the Supper.



## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Knot Canyon is a dead-end gorge west of Tacit, its Honest Age cisterns posted as silent. Her clients come by night: brides sworn to the wrong man, soldiers sworn to impossible service, children who spoke before twelve. They swear on the dead, she ties a thread for each in her shawl, and they go home free, owing her a vow of her wording: “to come when called,” “to give what is asked,” “to carry what I hand you.” She has never called one.

The Bench calls the Greater Word heresy, but nine hundred clients include two Benchers’ daughters, a captain of the Watch and the Master of the Surety House, so Knot Canyon is left alone. Ona Fell hates her: every client Cess frees is a principal who no longer needs a Surety.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Knot Book** — goat leather gone hard as wood, nine hundred names and their greater oaths, and at the front the line of every Grandam back to the Supper. Whoever holds it feels her clients as she does.
- ◇ **The client-cords** — a knot for each client, tied in the shawl-fringes. When a client strays far, the knot tightens. When a client dies, it loosens and falls off. Sometimes, in the dead of night, all nine hundred knots twitch at once.
- ◇ **A clay ear-trumpet** — the kind used by the deaf. She does not use it to hear people. She sets the wide end flat on the floor.
- ◇ **A bag of knucklebones** — the bones of her son’s hand, taken from his niche in 590 with the Keeners’ consent, which she rolls when she is thinking. They always come up the same way.
- ◇ **A cup of cistern water** — offered to every client; drinking it is accepting her hospitality, which she holds to be a small oath in itself.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She is waiting for the floor to speak. She has slept with her ear to the stone for a year now, because the Book’s oldest pages say that the Grandams have been waiting for exactly this for six hundred years, and the floor has begun, at night, very faintly, to hum. She fears being too late, and she fears being on time.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** the nine hundred are not a weapon, or not only one. The first Grandam, the tongue-drawer at the Supper, heard what the god said with its last breath (“Go on. I am listening.”) and took it as a debt: if the god was listening, one day it would ask for its witness back. The greater oaths are a muster-roll. When Tolm speaks again from under the sand, Cess must bring nine hundred living voices to the Gullet, and she does not know whether they are there to answer it, to drown it out, or to be eaten.

**A secret she does not know:** the humming in the floor is the hum Ket the Ninth made once, alone, a year ago. Something heard it, and has been humming it back through the rock ever since, trying to learn the tune.

## TIES

- ◇ **Ona Fell** — the Surety’s oldest enemy. Ona has sworn never to set foot in Knot Canyon. Cess has sent her a cup of water every Tablenight for twenty years.
- ◇ **Yusra Thole** — Cess lay beside her on the shrine floor and heard the new heart under the Gullet. She laughed because she was frightened.
- ◇ **Brakk** — owes her: his wife was freed by Cess from her own marriage vow after his betrayal, and the greater oath she swore was “to give what is asked.” Brakk does not know.
- ◇ **Captain Renn Hold** — she went up Wending Pass once, in 630, and offered him a greater word. He would not swear. She respects him more than anyone alive.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — Cess has told Rue that a promise never to grow up is not one she can lay anything heavier on. That is true only in the careful sense: she will not, which in Cess’s mouth comes to the same thing.

## IN PLAY

PCs come to Cess as the only cure for an oath they cannot keep. She is warm, funny, unhurried and endlessly reasonable. She asks for nothing they would not give.

- ◇ **The Calling.** One night every knot in her shawl tightens at once. The floor has spoken. Cess sends for her nine hundred, and one of them is a PC, or someone a PC loves.
- ◇ **The Book.** A client wants the Knot Book stolen and burned, which would free nine hundred people and bind nobody in their place. Or would it? The Book’s oldest page has an oath in it that nobody has read in six hundred years.
- ◇ **The Succession.** Cess is ninety-four, and she has no successor. She wants one of the PCs.

Threatened, she laughs and says something plain, and it becomes so. She answers kindness with a cup of water and a long look. Toward the god she is reverent and wary, a servant who has waited too long for the master to ring. If nobody intervenes, the floor speaks on Tablenight, and Cess sends for her nine hundred, and they walk barefoot through the dark to the Gullet without a word.

## SAID OF THEM

“She took my vow off me like a splinter. I sleep now. I owe her a thing I said I’d carry, and I’ll carry it. I’d carry it twice.” — a drover of the eastern canyons

“An oath that can be buried under a bigger oath is not an oath. It is a rank. That woman has nine hundred people in rank. I would like to know what she means to do with them before she does it.” — a Gorge-Warden of the Echo-Wardens

“She’s the only one in Tacit who calls me ‘my lamb.’ I’m sixty-three. I let her.” — Little Rue

# CAPTAIN RENN HOLD

*the Man at Wending*

*“Corporal Ansel Brock. Private Dunn Arle. Private Dunn Arle the Younger. Private Wesk. Private Tobb Inly. Private Hale Merrow. Private...”*

– RENN HOLD, AT DUSK, TO ANYONE WHO COMES UP THE PASS; HE SAYS THE WHOLE ROLL, EVERY EVENING, AND IT TAKES THE BETTER PART OF AN HOUR

| CAPTAIN RENN HOLD – THE MAN AT WENDING |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Oathen · Cut 2 (common blood) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                          | 48 (looks seventy); Captain of the Fourth Regiment of the Canyon Watch, never relieved; holder of Wending Pass                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Warden · Standing 4 (Captain)                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                                 | Blades 5, Endure 5, Resolve 5, Intimidate 3, Wayfaring 2, Rites 2, Search 2, Clause 1                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 17 · Guard 16 (the rusted mail binds at the shoulder) · Armor 3 (rusted mail) · Fray 9                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTACKS                                | sword +9 (4)                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                  | <b>Hold to It</b> (the Appetite). <b>Held:</b> while within Wending Pass, he cannot be moved by force, fear or Dread, and he does not sleep and does not need to. Any oath sworn to him at the top of the pass gains +1 Weight. |
| WANTS                                  | <b>To Hold Others to Their Words</b> (he demands an oath of anyone who would pass)                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                                 | Unflinching, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | <b>The Guilt That Bends the Room</b> (roused by success: the four hundred are in every face)                                                                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                                | the regimental roll, his sword, the cairn-stone, a water-skin, strap-buckles                                                                                                                                                    |
| DREAD                                  | 3 (the road behind him)                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

Up close Renn Hold is a coat of rusted mail with a starved man inside it, burned nearly black by the eastern sky, his face a dry hide over strong bones, his beard matted and grey and hacked short with his sword. The mail has rusted to his padding and the padding to his shirt, and the stink of rust, sweat and goat-fat carries thirty paces downwind. His captain’s sash, once Watch red, is the colour of the rock.

He sits on the same flat stone at the head of the switchbacks, drawn sword across his knees, eyes moving between the eastern approach and the road below. His voice is a dry croak he uses for three things: the roll, every evening; the demand, to every traveller; and thanks, when someone leaves him food. Travellers expect a madman and are thrown by how reasonable he is.

## THEIR STORY

Renn Hold, a drover’s son of Dun Varrow, was given the Fourth Regiment in 625: four hundred soldiers, most of them nineteen. In the Carving of 627 Reckoners came out of the Fast, and at Wending Pass the regiment swore together in the old form: “We will hold

Wending Pass against all who come, until death relieves us.” Renn spoke it first. The canyon gave it back nine times.

On the third morning he watched a hundred Reckoners come up the switchbacks in silence, and looked at his soldiers, children three years past twelve, and gave the order to fall back. He stayed. They obeyed. The sound of four hundred Breakings came up from the road like a rockfall, every soldier opening at each joint by which they had bound themselves to that ground. Some of them did not die at all. The Reckoners saw one man with a sword and four hundred behind him, and went home. Their captain, Scant Hollis, is said to have been sick by the roadside.

Sergeant Mags Carrow misheard the order and stayed beside him. In 629 he drafted, by himself, over a month, the only clause he has ever drafted, a release by which she could leave without breaking, and it cost her an eye. He has been alone since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Every drover, pilgrim and Factor who uses the Unmade Road must pass him, and every one must swear: “I will hold this pass with you, for as long as you ask it of me.” He looks at them a long time. Then

he says, “I don’t ask it,” and lets them go. The oath binds for the space of one breath. He wanted them to have said it.

The Watch cannot relieve him, since his oath was sworn to the pass. Drovers leave flatbread, figs and water on the cairn at the bend. In the Bench’s minutes he is an active garrison of one.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The regimental roll** — four hundred names, on a strip of goat-leather folded twenty times, worn black at the creases. He does not need to read it. He carries it in case he forgets one, and he never has.
- ◇ **His sword** — a Watch sword, old-pattern, notched, the edge kept bright with a whetstone and the hilt bound with strips from a dead soldier’s sash.
- ◇ **The cairn-stone** — a pebble from the cairn at the head of the switchbacks: the line, in his reading, of the pass. Below it is the road. He crosses it every night. See below.
- ◇ **Strap-buckles** — a pouch of iron buckles and leather straps, the kind the Breakdowns’ surgeons use to hold the unstrung together. He has no business owning them.
- ◇ **A water-skin** — always full. He drinks little. The rest goes down the road at night.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be relieved. He does not want to die; he wants someone with the authority to say “relieved,” and mean it, and be believed by the god. He fears that there is no such person.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** some of the four hundred are still alive below, among the bones, unstrung at every joint, held together by the straps he brings and kept alive by the water he carries down. Every night he steps over the cairn-line to feed them, one step past the place he swore never to leave, and each night a little more of him comes open: a seam along his right side that does not close, a finger bent backward, a knee beginning to fold.

**A secret he knows and will never say:** “until death relieves us.” The Bench has always read the death as his. Renn has read the clause every night for fourteen years, and he knows the other reading. The regiment swore together. If the last soldier of the Fourth dies, the regiment is relieved by death, and so is he. He could walk down the road any night and stop bringing water. He goes down with the water every night instead.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Sergeant Mags Carrow** — the one who stayed. He released her at the cost of her eye and has not seen her in twelve years. He hopes she is well. He has not asked.
- ◇ **Grandam Cess** — offered him a greater word in 630. He said no, and gave her his water, and she drank it.
- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — the Reckoner-Captain from the Fast who led the raid. She sends no word. Every year, at the first of Carving, a

single bolt with an Unfed knot on it is found driven into the cairn.

- ◇ **Judge Thane Urron** — the Judge has petitioned the Bench, three times, to try Renn Hold, so that he might be made to repeat his oath before the court and be found to have kept it. The Bench has refused.
- ◇ **Halvar Stane** — the Echo-Warden walked the Unmade Road in 628 and killed the nine echoes of the regiment’s oath with felt and sand. He thinks one got away.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Renn when they need to cross Wending: escorting a caravan, chasing a fugitive, carrying a treaty to the Vigil. He will not let them through until they swear. If they will not swear, he will fight, and he cannot be moved.

- ◇ **The Hold at Wending.** A Company caravan must cross. Its factor will not swear to an Oathener’s madness. The PCs must find a way to make an oath acceptable to both the captain and the Company, or a way past him, or a way to understand him.
- ◇ **The Water-Carrier.** The PCs follow him down the road at night and find the living among the bones. Now they know. If they bring water, they keep the regiment alive; if they do not, they might relieve him. Mags Carrow will want to know what they saw.
- ◇ **Relieved.** Someone has found an authority that might release him: a Sayer’s sentence, a royal gesture, a dead soldier’s niche. The PCs carry it up the pass. He does not believe them. He wants to.

Under threat he is immovable and very dangerous. Kindness he receives without a word and remembers forever; the god he treats as a commanding officer he does not like. If nobody intervenes, the seam along his side opens a little further each night, until one night he goes down the road and does not come back up, and something in the Unmade Road begins to crawl uphill.

#### SAID OF THEM

“I swore to hold the pass with him. He looked at me like I’d given him a horse. Then he said he didn’t ask it, and I went on down, and I cried the whole road to the Rim, and I couldn’t tell you why.” — a Company drover

“He held. They broke. Everyone on the Bench has a view on who was right. He’s the only man on the Table who doesn’t.” — Judge Thane Urron

“Every night, half an hour after the roll, there’s a light going down the switchbacks. A lantern, no faster than a man can carry water.” — a goatherd of Dun Varrow

# TAVISH CROOK

## Loophole

*“Would I sell you a cask that wasn’t sound? Would a man of my years risk his good name on a split stave? And if he did, what would that say about the cooper who made it, eh? What would it say about the price?”*

– TAVISH CROOK, SELLING AUBIN SELE’S TWICE-SOLD CASK A THIRD TIME, 640 A.G.

| TAVISH CROOK – LOOPHOLE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT              | Oathen · Cut 2 (common blood) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION           | 50; swindler, speculator, dealer in anything; a set of rooms on the middle Sunward Wall with a view of the Ledger                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING      | Factor (free trader, unlicensed) · Standing 3 among the Forsworn fences; 1 with the Company, which has banned him from Quillhouse                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES              | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                  | Persuade 5, Haggle 5, Clause 5, Deceive 4, Instinct 4, Filch 3, Reckoning 3, Athletics 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                    | Flesh 10 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                 | swordcane +4 (4); he has drawn it twice in his life and wept both times                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                   | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>Only Asking:</b> he may make a Persuade, Deceive or Haggle roll entirely in questions without ever being bound; a listener who wishes to treat his questions as promises must win Eye + Clause against his Tongue + Clause. He has never lost. |
| WANTS                   | none of the god’s yet; his own is to be asked a question he cannot answer with another                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                  | Conditional, Little Lies                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS            | none (yet)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CARRIES                 | a swordcane, a purse of sworn notes, a silver question-mark, a ledger of marks, the bit he wore as a boy                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                   | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

### WHO THEY ARE

Tavish Crook is plump and rosy, with merry brown eyes and a little pursed mouth that always looks about to ask something. He dresses beautifully, in plum-and-gold Fatlands wool and white lace, with rings on every finger but the thumbs: he has no oaths outstanding. He smells of rosewater and fig-sweets, and his voice lifts at the end of everything, so that each sentence hangs in the air like a hand held out.

He is interested in everybody, and remembers what they tell him. People leave a conversation with Tavish feeling warmly understood and slightly poorer.

### THEIR STORY

Tavish was born in 591 A.G. to a pair of Slate-Clerks of the Bench, and he was meant for the Bench. At his Unbitting, in 603, before a Clausewright, in the Hall of Conditions, he was supposed to say “I am here,” the safe words. He said, “Am I here?” The Clausewright

laughed. Tavish did not. He was never sure, after that, that he had been answered.

He failed the Examination of Exits in 611 by answering the examiner’s last question with another (“Would you?”), and went into the markets with nothing but a voice that, if it never once came to rest, could not be bound. In forty years he has never asserted a fact or made a promise: not to a customer, not to a lover, not to his dying mother, who asked whether he would remember her and was answered, “How could I not?”

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Tavish lives in the gap in Oathen law. A whole Oathener cannot lie, so a whole Oathener who hears a confident question assumes a confident answer. Tavish sells casks that are not sound and mines that do not exist, and every bill of sale is a page of perfectly honest questions. In four Breaking trials he repeated his alleged promises word for word, in their original interrogative form, and nothing happened. Judge Thane Urraw is said to have smiled.

He fences for the Breakdowns, runs a book on whose fingers will snap next among the handtalkers, and has moved money for the Second Table and carried messages for the Bench that no Oathener could say. He is welcome everywhere and trusted nowhere.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A swordcane** — ebony and silver, the blade thin and very sharp. It is mostly theatre.
- ◇ **A purse of sworn notes** — bought at a discount from issuers near default, sold on to foreigners at face. He knows exactly whose bodies back them, and how close they are to breaking.
- ◇ **The silver question-mark** — a pendant in the shape of the hooked mark the Ledger's carvers use for a question, worn at his throat. A joke, he says. A promise, the Breakdowns say. He has never said which.
- ◇ **A ledger of marks** — everyone he has ever cheated, with the date and the sum. He reads it at night. It is not remorse. It is the habit of a man who cannot be certain what he did unless it is written down.
- ◇ **The bit he wore as a boy** — a soft leather bit with a single blue bead. He keeps it in a drawer and looks at it when he is frightened, which is more often lately.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants more: money, marks, proof that the god cannot catch him. He fears the day it learns to hear what he means, because meaning outweighs grammar, and a question meant as a promise binds. Forty years of discipline have hollowed out the part of him that could mean anything.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** he lost a tooth this spring. A back molar, loose one morning and gone by evening, lying in his pillow like a seed. He had said, to a widow, the night before, "Would I lie to you?" and the widow had believed him, and he had felt, for an instant, that he wanted her to, and the god heard the wanting.

**A secret he does not know:** the god has begun to answer him. Things he asks rhetorically are coming true. "What if I told you there was gold under Low Shale?" he asked a Fatlands buyer in 639; in Grace a Bait pilgrim found a vein of it in the stopped valley, bright in the still river. "Would a man risk his name on a split stave?" A cooper broke over a split stave the next week. Tavish's questions are being treated as prayers, and the god, which is learning to listen to more than it used to, is granting them.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Cassian Wry** — the two most famous liars in Oathen, one who cannot be bound and one who will not be. They dine together once a month under guard, and it is the only honest meal either of them eats.
- ◇ **Jude Crane** — they share a confectioner and an admiration. Jude has said that if he were ever asked to break Tavish, he would

not know where to start. Tavish asked whether that was a compliment. Jude laughed.

- ◇ **Judge Thane Urrow** — has tried him four times. Wants a fifth.
- ◇ **Lord Varro Esk** — has hired Tavish to ask a Sayer a question. Tavish has not yet decided whether he will.
- ◇ **Ottoline Vant** — he is hiding her. He has not said so. If asked, he would ask why anyone would think such a thing.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Tavish as their mark, their partner or their only lead. He knows everything going on in the shadow trade of Tacit and will tell them about it, entirely in questions.

- ◇ **The Gold of Low Shale.** A rush of desperate prospectors is sneaking into the stopped valley to dig. Tavish wants the PCs to find out whether there is gold. There is, and he asked for it, and now the valley has begun to move a very little, as if it had been asked a question too.
- ◇ **The Question for the Sayer.** Varro Esk wants Tavish to put a single question to Lady Imre Dath, on the theory that a Sayer's answer to a question might be the safest way to use her. Tavish wants the PCs along.
- ◇ **Am I Here?** Tavish begins to fade at the edges in bright light, like Ilan. He is beginning to suspect that he never got an answer.

Threatened, he talks, fast and bright and in questions, and then runs. He answers kindness with gifts and real warmth that he cannot quite express. Toward the god he is flippant and terrified. If nobody intervenes, he asks one question too many at a dinner party on the Sunward Wall ("What if this whole Wall came down?") and the god, which has learned to grant him, considers it.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He sold me a cask that split the first week. I took him to the Bench. They read the bill of sale aloud. It was all questions. I paid the court fee as well." — a wine-seller of the lower Sunward

"Tavish is the only man in Tacit who speaks the language of the Breakdowns without having broken. We should hate him for it. We like him too much." — a Splint of the Forsworn

"He has never told me he loves me. Twenty years. He asks me, every morning, whether I know. I have always said yes." — Mistress Hanne Crook, his wife



# SISTER VERITY AMN

## the Thought-Bound

Novice: you came to us to stop speaking. Good. That was the first door. Now I must tell you about the second, and I am sorry. Do not think “I will.” Do not think “never.” Do not think “always,” nor “I swear,” nor “I would give anything.” Do not think what you would do to the man who hurt you. Do

not think what you would give to see your mother. When such a thought comes, think of water. Think of the grain in the wood of your cell door. Think of nothing that has a future in it. You will fail. We all fail. Fail small. — slate of Sister Verity Amn, copied by a novice of the Quiet, 639 A.G.

### SISTER VERITY AMN – THE THOUGHT-BOUND

|                    |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT         | Oathen · Cut 4 (Tongue-line, House Amn) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION      | 52; Stillmind of the Quiet; cliff-cell on the upper Gullet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING | Celebrant (the Quiet) · Standing 4 (Stillmind)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES         | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS             | Resolve 6, Rites 5, Lore 5, Clause 4, Godsign 4, Instinct 3, Persuade 3 (in writing), Stealth 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY               | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS            | none; she has not struck anyone since the knife                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS              | <b>Tongueless:</b> immune to Breakings of the tongue. <b>The Unspoken Word:</b> a vow she thinks with intent binds at Weight 2, and breaks in her lips. Once per session she may think a plain fact about something she can see, as <b>Say So</b> , with Caul + Godsign in place of Tongue + Godsign; on any roll of doubles, success or failure, her lips seal further. <b>The Stillmind:</b> she can lead others in the discipline of empty thought; anyone who sits with her for an hour gains +2 to resist the Want To Swear for a day. |
| WANTS              | <b>To Swear</b> (in thought; roused by fear, anger, and love)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS             | Silent Supper, Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS       | <b>The Watchers</b> (she believes her thoughts are being overheard; she is right)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES            | slate and chalk, a writing case, a silver feeding-reed, lip-salve of goose fat and honey, her own knife, the Stillmind slates                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DREAD              | 2 (her sealed mouth)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

### WHO THEY ARE

Verity Amn is tall and gaunt, with the long fine face of the old Tongue-lines, and from her nose to her chin there is no mouth: only a smooth pinkish band of new skin, ridged where the lips grew together, puckered at one corner around a silver ring the width of a straw. Below the seal her jaw moves, sometimes, on its own, as if something were working behind the skin. Her eyes are dark, patient and appalled.

She smells of goose fat and honey, from the salve she rubs into the seal so that it will not crack. She writes on slate in a fast, beautiful, slanting hand, wiping and writing and wiping, with a sound like a rasp of breath, and her teaching is famous: the clearest, coldest prose in Oathen. She is gentle with novices and merciless with herself.

### THEIR STORY

Verity was born in 589 A.G. to House Amn, a Tongue-line of the high Sunward, a brilliant, talkative girl. At seventeen she reached the Appetite and swore through the iron in her sleep (“I will have your eyes,” to her sister). At nineteen, in 608, she went to the Quiet and took the knife to her own tongue, as Abbess Hollin Mure had.

That night, alone in her cell, in fever, she thought, with perfect clarity and complete intent, “I will never speak again.” In the morning her lips had grown together. The Quiet’s surgeon, Brother Ansgar Mote, opened them in 609 and again in 621; each time they sealed within a month. She stopped letting him. She understood, before anyone else in Oathen, what had happened: for the highest bloodlines, a promise made only in thought now binds. She has spent thirty years teaching the Quiet how not to think.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Quiet's cliff-cells along the upper Gullet house some two hundred sisters and brothers. Verity, most revered after the Abbess, wrote the Stillmind slates: meditation on water, wood-grain and sand; thinking in the present tense only; noticing a vow as it forms and letting it fall like a stone into the river. Tongue-line families send their Appetite-struck children to her in secret, because it works, a little. The Bench pretends her teaching does not exist, because if it is true, nothing an Oathener does is private.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Slate and chalk** — the slate rimmed in cedar, worn hollow in the centre by thirty years of wiping.
- ◇ **A writing case** — paper, ink, sand. She no longer trusts ink. Writing binds now, at half Weight, and she has seen what it does.
- ◇ **A silver feeding-reed** — Ansgar's work, fitted to the ring at the corner of her mouth. Without it she would starve.
- ◇ **Lip-salve** — goose fat and honey in a horn box. The seal cracks in the dry Carving wind and bleeds.
- ◇ **Her own knife** — a short, thin, very old blade, the one she used at nineteen. She keeps it because she has thought of using it again, on the seal, and she would rather know where it is.
- ◇ **The Stillmind slates** — nine slates of teaching, the core of her doctrine, copied by every novice. A Celebrant who studies them for a season gains +1 Resolve against Wants.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants silence: her own first, then Oathen's. She fears her own mind more than anything on the Table, because she has seen what it can do. She fears love most of all, since love is all futures, and has not let herself feel it for anyone in thirty years.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** the Quiet's secret texts, which she wrote, look forward to silence for the whole Table. And on the night of her fever in 608, before "I will never speak again," she thought one other thing, about her sister Laine Amn, whose eyes she had sworn in her sleep to have: "I wish she could not see me like this." Laine Amn has been blind since that night. Nobody knows why. Verity knows.

**A secret she does not know:** her tongue is alive. Ansgar Mote keeps it in brine in his vault, labelled, with three hundred and ninety-nine others. Of all of them, hers has grown the most, to twice the length it was, and it moves in the jar. It mouths her thoughts. Ansgar has learned to read it, and so he knows exactly what Sister Verity thinks, every night, in her cell, and he has been writing it down.

## TIES

- ◇ **Brother Ansgar Mote** — the surgeon who opened her lips twice. Her closest friend in the order. He reads her thoughts in a jar and has not told her.

- ◇ **Laine Amn** — her sister, blind for thirty-three years, now a Bencher of the Hall of Conditions. They have not met since 608.
- ◇ **Lady Imre Dath** — Verity believes the Sayers and she are two ends of the same road: what a Sayer says, is; what Verity thinks, binds. She has asked to visit the Gilded Cells, in writing, eleven times.
- ◇ **Ket the Ninth** — the king reads her slates. He has sent her, through the Bench, a single blank slate with nothing on it. She has kept it on her wall for three years and does not know whether it is a question.
- ◇ **Hessa Lisk** — the Cutwright has asked to measure her tongue. Verity wrote: "Ask Brother Ansgar."

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Verity as a teacher, when one of them reaches the Appetite or the Course and needs to learn not to think. She will tell them, on slate, what to stop thinking.

- ◇ **The Novice's Thought.** A novice of the Quiet has thought something terrible about the Abbess, and the Abbess is beginning to come apart. Verity wants the PCs to find out what was thought.
- ◇ **The Jar.** The PCs learn about Ansgar's vault. If Verity finds out that her tongue is reading her mind to a man she trusted, the thought she has about it will bind, and it will not be a small one.
- ◇ **The Second Door.** The Bench wants Verity silenced, or recruited to teach the Sayers. Sorrin Vael would like the PCs to deliver the offer.

Under threat, she thinks of water, very hard. Kindness frightens her; she writes "thank you" with great care, because gratitude is a kind of debt. Toward the god she is a fighter who has learned that every punch lands on herself. If nobody intervenes, she learns of the jar, and thinks, with all her strength, "I wish I had never had a tongue," and Oathen discovers what a Course-stage Tongue-line's wish can do to a past.

## SAID OF THEM

"She taught me to think of water when I want to swear. It works. Now I'm frightened of water." — a Tongue-line boy of fifteen, in handtalk

"There's no mouth. Just skin. And then you see the jaw moving behind it, and you understand she's still trying." — a Bait pilgrim at the Gullet

"I think the Sister is the most honest person in Oathen. She can't even lie to herself." — Brother Ansgar Mote

# ENVOY DORIAN SAYCE

*the Believed*

*“You will hear many things in Lastgate, and in Gristmoot, and on the piers of Brinehollow. You will hear them said with great confidence, by people who will walk away from you whole. Hold this to your nose. Breathe through it. Remember that they cannot help it, and that you can.”*

– DORIAN SAYCE, HANDING A VINEGAR KERCHIEF TO A NEW SECRETARY

| ENVOY DORIAN SAYCE – THE BELIEVED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                        | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, House Sayce) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                     | 50; Envoy-at-Large of the Mute Crown to the lands of the Rim                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                | Clausewright · Standing 4 (Senior of the Bench; diplomatic immunity in three lands)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                        | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS                            | Clause 5, Persuade 5, Lore 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Wayfaring 3, Blades 2, Haggle 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| BODY                              | Flesh 10 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTACKS                           | court-sword +4 (4)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                             | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>Hold to It</b> (the Appetite). <b>The Believed:</b> anywhere on the Table, a plain statement of fact he makes is believed by everyone who hears it, without a roll, unless they have Caul 4 or more and a reason to doubt. A treaty he witnesses abroad carries a faint Oathen binding: a signatory who breaks it rolls Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or suffers 1d6 Flesh and a small apt injury. |
| WANTS                             | <b>To Correct</b> (abroad, he hears falsehoods hourly; each is a wave of nausea)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                            | Table Manners, Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                      | <b>The Unclean</b> (roused by touching a foreigner who has lied: he washes his hands in vinegar until they crack)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                           | a vinegar kerchief, credentials, a writing case, six thumb rings, a little book bound in green, a travelling bit of silver                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DREAD                             | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

Dorian Sayce is the best-dressed man on the Rim Road: silver hair oiled with cedar, a long pale clever face, black Brinehollow wool cut close as paint, a white Tongue-line collar, and six thumb rings, one for each treaty he carries. He smells always of the vinegar on the kerchief he holds to his nose when a foreigner boasts.

His voice is soft, dry, and terribly exact, and he speaks foreign tongues with an Oathener's care, each sentence weighed and weighted. Abroad, his silences are famous: he will let a Fatlands Board-member promise him the moon and say nothing for a full minute, and then say, “I see,” and the Board-member will find himself, inexplicably, apologising.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 591 A.G. to House Sayce, a Tongue-line of envoys, Dorian has spent twenty-six years abroad carrying treaties east to be sworn.

He has never lied: not to the Regent Ansel Grue, not to the Board of Plenty, not to a dying Unfed child in Wanting who asked if she would see her mother. It is the core of his power.

Last spring, in Lastgate, a Kept woman of the Mortuary Court, her face held on with gauze, asked him whether she looked well. And Dorian Sayce, who was tired and far from home and had been told nine hundred lies that month, said “You look well,” and walked away whole, and felt a lightness he had not felt since he was a boy.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He witnesses foreign contracts where Jessamy Quill cannot reach and reports to the Bench on every land's Regrowth with clinical disgust. Twice a year he comes home over Wending Pass and spends a month in a felted room in Tacit, recovering from foreigners. The Bench relies on him utterly. He relies on the Bench to keep him from what he is becoming.



## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The vinegar kerchief** — white linen soaked in fen-vinegar from Sallowreach, the only thing he admires about the place. Gives +1 to resist Dread from rot and smell.
- ◇ **Credentials** — a case of letters under the king's seal and the Bench's, granting him immunity in Sallowreach, the Vigil and Brinehollow.
- ◇ **Six thumb rings** — one per treaty he carries in his own body; if any of them is broken by Oathen, he breaks with it.
- ◇ **A travelling bit of silver** — Garl Tome's work, for nights when the Appetite presses.
- ◇ **A writing case** — and inside it his dispatches, in the Bench's cipher, which do not technically assert anything.
- ◇ **A little book bound in green** — see below.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to come home and stay. He fears that he cannot: that the discipline he has kept for twenty-six years among liars is wearing thin, and that he likes the feeling of it wearing.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** the little green book is a record of lies. Since last spring he has told nineteen, all abroad, all small, all kind ("You look well." "It is not your fault." "I am sure he loved you."), and he has written each one down, with the date and the place, because he is an Oathener, and something said must be recorded.

**A secret he does not know:** his lies have come true. The Kept woman in Lastgate looked well the next morning, the rot drawn back from her cheekbones. The widow in Gristmoot found her husband's lost letters that week. Dorian is not lying abroad; he is Saying. His Regrowth has outrun the Cutwrights' reckoning, the god goes with him across the border, and he has begun to enjoy lying at exactly the moment lying has become the most powerful thing he can do.

## TIES

- ◇ **Captain Renn Hold** — Dorian swears the captain's oath twice a year and means it. They do not speak beyond that. It is the friendship of his life.
- ◇ **Cassian Wry** — the Blank liar fascinates and repels him. Cassian has asked him, every time they meet, to tell one lie. Dorian has never obliged. He is now afraid of what would happen if he did.
- ◇ **Jessamy Quill** — the notary and the envoy are the two pillars of Oathen's trust abroad. They distrust each other completely.
- ◇ **Lord Varro Esk** — a cousin by marriage. Varro has asked him to carry a letter to the Second Table's people in the Fatlands. Dorian refused. Varro asked whether he was sure. Dorian found he was not.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — he brings her sugared almonds from the Fatlands every year. She is the only person in Oathen he lets call him by

his first name.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Dorian on the Rim Road, needing an escort through dangerous country to deliver a treaty to Oathen before Tablenight. He will not thank them, because thanks implies a debt; he will pay them well and on time.

- ◇ **The Escort.** A treaty in his case would bind two lands against a third. Someone on the road wants it gone, and someone else wants Dorian to tell a lie in front of witnesses, to destroy his credit forever.
- ◇ **The Green Book.** The book is stolen. Whoever reads it will know the Table's most trusted man has lied nineteen times. Whoever understands it will know what his lies can do.
- ◇ **The Kind Lie.** A PC is dying, or a PC's loved one is. Dorian sits by the bed. He knows, now, what would happen if he said, "You will be well." He wants to say it. So does the god.

Under threat he is cool, quick, and better with the court-sword than he lets on. Kindness unsettles him, because he cannot return it without owing. Toward the god he is correct and distant. If nobody intervenes, he tells one lie too large on foreign soil, at a treaty-table in the Vigil, and the Table discovers that Oathen's most honest man can reshape the world by misleading it.

## SAID OF THEM

"He told our Regent that the treaty would hold. Our Regent has been lied to for three hundred years. He believed it, on the spot. I have never seen that face on him." — a clerk of the Mortuary Court, Lastgate

"Sayce doesn't haggle. He states a price, and you pay it, because you know it's fair. It's the worst afternoon of any Factor's year." — a Rim Road Company Factor

"He gave me almonds and asked about my health. I said, 'Unchanged.' He said, 'I am glad.' I've known him forty years. That's the first time I've believed he was lying." — Little Rue

# ILAN

## the Oath-Child

*(The boy is sitting on the step. When asked his name, he signs it: a fist touched to the chest, then the hand opened outward, which in nursery handtalk means promised. Asked where his father is, he looks for a long time at his mother's hand on his shoulder, and does not sign anything.)*

– FROM THE NOTES OF CUTWRIGHT HESSA LISK, GRACE 641 A.G.

| ILAN – THE OATH-CHILD |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT            | Oathen · Cut — (Oath-Made; no blood of his own) · Regrowth — · Hunger —                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION         | 9 (he has existed for nine years); son of Tamsa Reeve, water-carrier, and the late Corram Reeve; the lower Shadeward Wall, Tacit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING    | none; a child                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES            | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                | Stealth 4, Search 3, Instinct 3, Athletics 2, Lore 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                  | Flesh 9 · Guard 15 (17 in bright light) · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS               | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                 | <b>Promised:</b> he exists only while the promise that made him is held. <b>Fading:</b> in bright light he is faint at the edges; anyone who has not seen him in a day must roll Eye + Instinct (Hard 14) to remember his face or his name. <b>The Listening Room:</b> he hears everything said in the house twice, once with his ears and once from somewhere else. |
| WANTS                 | <b>To Be Promised</b> (the Oath-Made's want: when he fades badly, he must seek a promise from someone near; see In Play)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                | Silent Supper, Hostage's Smile                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS          | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES               | his bit with his father's bead, a wooden goat, his father's thumb ring on a string, a child's slate                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DREAD                 | 2 (3 when you realise you cannot remember his face)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Ilan is a small, dark-haired boy with a soft leather bit beaded in the blue and brown of his father's water-carriers' fellowship, and above it his father's large grey eyes. He is polite in the careful Oathen way, signs small and neat, smells of soap and the well, and is good at finding lost things.

Since the spring he has been difficult to see. In the white noon of the canyon his edges blur, like a figure seen through heat over stone, and his shadow is a little too pale. His teacher missed him at roll-call three times in Grace and could not, afterward, recall having a pupil by that name. His mother keeps her hand on his shoulder at all times, and where her palm rests, he is perfectly clear.

### THEIR STORY

Corram and Tamsa Reeve, water-carriers of the Shadeward, had no child in twenty years of marriage. In the Lack of 631, as Tamsa wept over the last of her bearing years, Corram said aloud, before the

echo, "I promise you a son." There was no pregnancy and no birth. On the first morning of Grace in 632 there was a small boy at their table, eating flatbread, whom both of them had always known. The neighbours remembered his first steps. There are no birth records, and the Bench filed the matter.

He has been a good son. In the spring of 641 Corram slipped on the rope-stair in the wet of the late Rain and fell to the floor of the canyon. A death in Oathen releases the dead person's oaths. Ilan began to fade the week of the funeral.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

There is no Bench clause for a child who is a sentence. The Cutwrights know of a dozen Oath-Made in Oathen's history and how each one ended; Hessa Lisk has measured him three times and has not told Tamsa what she found. The other children are kind to him, when they remember him.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **His bit** — soft kid, beaded blue and brown, with one bead of red glass that was his father's from his own childhood bit.
- ◇ **A wooden goat** — carved by Corram, one leg mended. He holds it at night.
- ◇ **His father's thumb ring** — bone, on a string round his neck. Corram's one outstanding oath, kept: the ring was for Ilan.
- ◇ **A child's slate** — on which he draws, over and over, a large room with a great many ears in the walls.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants his father back, and his mother to stop being afraid. He fears the room he goes to when he fades.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** Ilan remembers before. Not much: a long time of being nothing, in a very large quiet place, listening. He remembers his father's voice saying the promise, and that it was the first sound he ever heard, and that he came toward it. He is made of the god's attention, shaped around a man's word. When he fades, he goes back to the listening room, and something there is glad to see him.

**A secret he does not know:** the promise can be renewed. If anyone, before a witness, says to Tamsa, "I promise you a son," and means it, Ilan will be theirs as he was Corram's: bound to that person, alive as long as they keep the promise and live. Or Ilan himself, fading, may ask a stranger to say "I will look after you," and live on, bound to them, forever.

## TIES

- ◇ **Tamsa Reeve** — his mother, fifty-nine, worn thin with fear, never lifting her hand from his shoulder. She has gone to Grandam Cess and been sent away.
- ◇ **Old Sabra Wends** — the Keener of the Vaults, who keeps his father's niche; Tamsa wants to swear on Corram's bones there, and Sabra has asked her, very gently, whether she is certain.
- ◇ **Hessa Lisk** — the Cutwright has measured him and is writing a paper. She is also, privately, trying to save him.
- ◇ **Little Rue** — another child who is not quite one; she taught him a nursery sign for "still here," and he uses it every morning.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Ilan when his mother begs them for help: an oath sworn on her husband's bones that will keep her son. Any PC who looks at the boy long enough must decide what they would swear for him.

- ◇ **The Oath on the Bones.** Tamsa wants the PCs to help her swear on Corram's bones in the Witnessing Vaults. The oath she wants to swear ("I will keep him") may hold. It may be read as the end of her own life, held to a boy forever. Sabra Wends will want to talk first.
- ◇ **I Will Look After You.** Ilan, fading badly in the noon light of the market, takes a PC's hand and signs, very slowly, "Will you look after me?" If the PC says yes, aloud, the boy is theirs.
- ◇ **The Listening Room.** Ilan fades altogether for an afternoon and comes back with sand in his hair, hot to the touch, from the Gullet. He says, in handtalk, that the room is getting bigger.

He meets threat by hiding, very well. He meets kindness with a bow, and with his whole heart. The god he knows as the quiet place where he waits. If nobody intervenes, he fades a little more each week until, on Tablenight, in the dark and silence that is the happiest day of the Oathen year, his mother's hand closes on nothing, and she cannot remember what she was holding.

## SAID OF THEM

"There's a boy in my class. I think. I keep a seat for him. I write his name at the top of the slate so I'll know it." — a schoolmistress of the Shadeward

"He finds things. My grandson's lost bead, a goat that had wandered off the ledge. He just walks to them. Like he's been told where they are." — a neighbour

"I said I'd look after him. In my head, I said it. I didn't say it aloud. I keep wondering if that counts." — a Company Factor who met him once

# OTTOLINE VANT

*the Carver with a List*

*“Not. Never. Four letters against five. One stroke of the chisel I didn’t need, and he came apart in his bed that night, and they told me writing doesn’t count. Then I went looking. Do you want to see the list? Don’t read it aloud.”*

– OTTOLINE VANT, IN A BACK ROOM OF THE BREAKDOWNS, TO A STRANGER SHE HAD DECIDED TO TRUST

| OTTOLINE VANT – THE CARVER WITH A LIST |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Oathen · Cut 2 (common blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                          | 30; Scribe of the Ledger, licence suspended; fugitive                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Clausewright (Ledger-carver of the Bench) · Standing 2 (Drafter), revoked                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                 | Craft 5, Athletics 4, Lore 3, Search 3, Stealth 3, Endure 2, Reckoning 2, Blades 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 13 · Guard 18 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                | chisel +5 (2); carver’s mallet +4 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| GIFTS                                  | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>Hold to It</b> (the Appetite). <b>The Fresh Cut</b> : she can tell to the season when any letter of the Ledger was cut, and by whose hand, by the tooling (no roll for her own trade’s work). What she carves on the Ledger now binds its subject at the full Weight of the recorded oath; she does not yet know this. |
| WANTS                                  | <b>To Correct</b> (when she sees a miscut, she must fix it, with whatever she has)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                 | Steady Hands, Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | <b>The Watchers</b> (roused when alone with strangers; the Canyon Watch is, in fact, looking for her)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                                | the list, a roll of chisels, a mallet, rubbing-paper and charcoal, scaffold rope and harness, a wax tablet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DREAD                                  | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

## WHO THEY ARE

Ottoline Vant is lean and hard, burned the colour of the cliff, with a carver’s ropy arms and short hair full of stone dust. She smells of sweat and the linseed oil carvers rub into their mallet-hafts. She moves half-crouched, as if still on a plank fifty feet up, and her hands are never still, tracing letters on her thigh.

She talks quickly, for an Oathener, and catches herself mid-sentence, and starts again with an Exit. Since the miscut she has not carved a single letter, and the absence is visible: her fingers keep reaching for a chisel that is not there.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 611 A.G. to the Vants, six generations of Ledger carvers, Ottoline was a journeyman at twenty: fast, clean and proud. At the Carving of the Year in 640 she cut the sentence of a grain-factor, Pellam Oxe, that he would not trade in Carving water before the Rain. She cut “never” where the draft read “not.” He traded, lawfully, after the Rain, and that night his gut ruptured in his bed,

the grievous Breaking of an abstention, and he lived, and cannot keep food down.

The Bench said coincidence. Ottoline went back to the old carvings at night with rubbing-paper and found eleven errors in two hundred years, a word added here, an “until” made “after” there, and all eleven people named broke on the night the carving was done. When she asked the Bench to look, the Canyon Watch came with a warrant. She went out the back, down the scaffold rope, and has been gone since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The carvers swear before they climb that they will cut true, and they answer to the Office of the Fair Copy, the department of the Bench that prepares each Carving’s drafts. Ottoline was one of sixty journeymen. Now she is a fugitive in the Breakdowns with a list that could break the Bench’s claim to justice.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The list** — eleven names, dates, and the miscut words, in her own small hand on oiled paper, with rubbings. Read aloud, it might bind its reader; she has never tested it.
- ◇ **A roll of chisels** — her own, from her apprenticeship. She has not used them since 640. She takes them out and oils them every night.
- ◇ **Rubbing-paper and charcoal** — for taking impressions of the carvings, in the dark, from a rope.
- ◇ **Scaffold rope and harness** — a carver's, sixty feet, knotted every foot, and a canvas sling. She can climb the Ledger by night with it.
- ◇ **A wax tablet** — sold as "write without binding." She bought it in 640 to write her list. Her thumb split the first night she wrote on it, along the ball. She switched to paper.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the truth carved. She fears that she is the twelfth: that her own miscut was not hers.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** it was not. The draft she was handed by the Office of the Fair Copy read "never." She carved what she was given and believed, ever after, that her hand had slipped. The eleven earlier "errors" were orders too. For two centuries, the Office of the Fair Copy has quietly broken people the Bench could not lawfully try, by altering a single word of their public vow before it was carved. Pellam Oxe was refusing to sell grain to a Bencher's household.

**A secret she does not know:** writing now counts, and so does carving. If she climbs the Ledger and corrects the miscuts, as the Want To Correct urges her to every time she sees one, the corrected vows will bind again, in their true form, at full Weight. Some of the eleven are dead. Some are alive, broken by words they never swore. And the horror table's whisper is true: someone at the Office has begun to carve again, and there is a fresh mark on the Ledger beside a name that the PCs will know.

## TIES

- ◇ **Tavish Crook** — hides her in rooms he would never admit to renting. She does not know why. Neither, entirely, does he.
- ◇ **Pellam Oxe** — the grain-factor her chisel broke. He writes to her, by way of the Breakdowns, every week. The letters are not angry.
- ◇ **Jude Crake** — the Bench may yet give her to the Breaker. Jude has read her list; Tavish showed him. Jude asked for a fig, and was very quiet.
- ◇ **Judge Thane Urraw** — the Judge would give a great deal for her list, and for a trial of the Office of the Fair Copy.
- ◇ **Brakk** — the Forsworn want her as a witness at the Gathering of the Broken; the list proves the Bench breaks people on purpose.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Ottoline as a fugitive, carrying her list. She needs to get it to someone who will act: the Judge, the Forsworn, the Company, a foreign envoy.

- ◇ **Down the Rope.** The Canyon Watch has found Tavish's rooms. Ottoline goes out of a window onto the face of the Sunward Wall, and the PCs go with her or after her.
- ◇ **The Correction.** At night, on the scaffold, Ottoline begins to cut. The PCs must decide whether to stop her before the first corrected vow binds a living man who has been broken for twenty years by a word he never said.
- ◇ **The Fresh Mark.** A new miscut appears on the Ledger, below a PC's name, in a vow the PC swore at Quillhouse. It will be carved in full tomorrow night.

Under threat she runs, climbs, and fights dirty with a chisel. Kindness makes her suspicious, then fiercely loyal. Toward the god she is a craftsman toward her material: it has rules, and she will learn them. If nobody intervenes, the Watch takes her by Carving, and the Bench gives her an hour with Jude Crake, and the list is never read aloud.

## SAID OF THEM

"Best journeyman on the east face. Cut a vow like she was combing hair. Then she stopped. It was like watching a bird forget how to fly." — a carver of the Ledger

"I believe her. Writing is not supposed to count. The god doesn't care what we suppose." — Pellam Oxe, in a letter

"She came to us with eleven names and dust in her hair. She asked for a candle and a quiet room. We gave her both. In the Breakdowns, that's a promise." — a lane-boss of Never Alley

# JUDE CRAKE

the Breaker

*“Don’t be frightened of me. I don’t have a knife. I never have. I’ve only come to talk, and to bring you something sweet, and to keep you company for a little while, so that you aren’t alone at the end of it. That’s all. Shall I turn the glass?”*

– JUDE CRAKE, AT THE BEGINNING OF EVERY HOUR

| JUDE CRAKE – THE BREAKER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, bastard) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION            | 44; Breaker of the Bench of Clauses, executioner of the realm; sentenced to the office for life                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Clausewright · Standing 3 (Clausewright; he witnesses executions in the king’s name)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 6 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                   | Persuade 6, Deceive 5, Clause 5, Instinct 5, Resolve 4, Lore 3, Reckoning 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                     | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                  | none; he owns no weapon                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| GIFTS                    | <b>Echo-Ear, Hold to It and Say So</b> (to the Course). <b>The Hour:</b> in conversation, Jude can extract one oath per ten minutes (Tongue + Persuade vs the target’s Caul + Resolve + 10); each is small, and each is crafted to tangle with the last. When two of his gathered oaths collide, the target breaks on both at once, and the second Breaking lands at +1 Weight. |
| WANTS                    | <b>To Hold Others to Their Words</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| KNACKS                   | Hostage’s Smile, Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS             | none; this is the thing about him that frightens the Bench most                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                  | the hour-glass, a basket of figs, a clean cloth, a little notebook, a stave-hammer, a letter he has not sent                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DREAD                    | 3 (when the hour-glass is turned)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |

## WHO THEY ARE

Jude Crake is the least frightening-looking man in Oathen: round-faced, soft-bodied, thinning-haired, with plump pink hands and kind wet brown eyes behind which something is always quietly working. He dresses like a respectable clerk and smells of figs and clean linen. When he speaks to you, you are the only person in the world.

He likes people. That is the dreadful thing about him, and it is not an act. He remembers the names of his condemned’s children. He asks about their trades and listens to the answers. He laughs at their jokes. The smallest finger of his left hand has no nail; he lost it, the Ninth Room’s record says, telling a small kind lie to a cooper who was about to die.

## THEIR STORY

Jude was born in 597 A.G. to a cooper’s wife, the child of a Tongue-line lord she never named. The cooper, Hobb Crake, taught him to bend staves and beat his mother when he drank. In 617 Jude killed

him with a stave-hammer in the steaming shed, answered “Yes” to the Bench’s one question, and was given to the Breaker.

The Breaker of that day was Amon Sallet, a stern, decent man. Jude talked to him for the hour, about staves and his mother and Amon’s daughter Pell, whom Amon mentioned once. At the fifty-first minute Amon promised to spare him. His oath of office, “I will finish every one given me,” broke at once, opening his hands and his breastbone, and a second oath Jude had led him into without his noticing (“I’ll see you out of here”) broke on the first. He bled out on the floor of the Ninth Room before morning. Jude held his hand.

The Bench, appalled and impressed, could not execute a man whose Breaker had died sparing him without a scandal it did not want. It commuted Jude’s sentence into service: he swore, before the forty-one, “I will break those the Bench gives me, until I die.” He has been the Breaker for twenty-two years. It has never taken longer than an hour, except once, last Carving, with the cooper Aubin Sele.



Before he left the Ninth Room that first morning, he knelt by Amon's six-year-old daughter, who had been brought to see her father, and said, "I'll come and see you, when I'm able." He has never been able. The Exit holds as long as that is true.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The gravest crimes end in the Ninth Room beneath the Ledger, with Jude, an hour-glass, a bitted clerk and a Surety-witness. He is also, by statute, a Clausewright, and the Bench consults him on how vows fail: which words collide, which Exits can be closed. He lives alone in two felted rooms beneath the Ledger. Nobody visits.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The hour-glass** — brass and old glass, the sand dyed red. It was Amon Sallet's. Turning it in front of anyone who knows what it is calls for a Dread 2 check.
- ◇ **A basket of figs** — fresh in Plenty, dried the rest of the year, from a confectioner on the Sunward he shares with Tavish Crook. He always brings some. Most of the condemned eat one.
- ◇ **A clean cloth** — linen, folded square, for the blood. It is always clean when he arrives.
- ◇ **A little notebook** — the names of everyone he has broken, and of their families, with notes: "daughter, Wenna, red ribbon on her bit." He reads it before sleeping.
- ◇ **A stave-hammer** — Hobb Crake's. He has not used it since 617. He keeps it to remember the only time he chose the other way.
- ◇ **A letter he has not sent** — to Pell Sallet, written in 625 and sealed and never posted. Sending it might count as being able. He knows.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be kind, and he is, in the only way the canyon permits him. He fears the hour running long. Last Carving it did, and he found he had enjoyed the extra forty-one grains of sand.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** he was condemned, and talked his own Breaker to death. The rumour is true, and the Bench has buried it, because a Breaker who was once a murderer is a scandal, and a murderer who was made a Breaker because he was good at it is something worse.

**A secret he does not know:** at the Course his plain statements come true, and for years he has been making them softly to the condemned: "It doesn't hurt very much." "She'll be well." He thinks they are the small lies that cost him a nail now and then. Some were Sayings. Wenna Sele is well, and her father did not feel nearly as much as he should have. Jude has been sparing them all along, a little, and does not know his kindness has been working.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Pell Sallet** — the Breaker's daughter. Now thirty, and a Keener of the Witnessing Vaults. He promised to visit. He has walked to

the head of the Vaults' stair nine times.

- ◇ **Tavish Crook** — friend, confectioner's companion, the one man in Oathen Jude could not break.
- ◇ **Ottoline Vant** — he has read her list. He knows the Office of the Fair Copy. He has helped them draft.
- ◇ **Sorrin Vael** — consults him on the Sayer's sentence. Jude has pointed out eleven ways that ninety-one versions could kill everyone in the room.
- ◇ **Brakk** — the Forsworn leader has sworn, on his own open heart, to see Jude in the Ninth Room one day as the condemned. Jude has said he would like that very much.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Jude as someone's last visitor, or their own. He is pleasant, interested, and in no hurry. He would like to know about them.

- ◇ **The Hour.** A PC, or someone a PC loves, is given to the Breaker. The PCs have an hour to keep them from promising anything. Jude will bring figs.
- ◇ **When I'm Able.** Pell Sallet sends word that she would like him to visit. If he goes, he keeps a twenty-four-year-old promise. If the Bench learns she sent for him, it will want to know why.
- ◇ **The Kind Lie.** The PCs discover that Jude's softest words have been coming true. Someone in the Bench will want to make use of a Breaker whose comforting sentences are Sayings. Someone else will want him in gold.

Threatened, he talks, and he is very, very good at it. Kindness he returns, sincerely, which is worse. Toward the god he feels the comradeship of a fellow witness. If nobody intervenes, Pell sends for him on Tablenight, when the country is silent and he cannot say no, and he goes down the stair to the Vaults, and the hour with her runs long.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He came to see my husband in the Ninth Room. Afterwards he came to see me, and told me Harl had laughed at the end, at a story about a goat. I don't know if it's true. I've decided it is." — a widow of Low Dray

"The cleanest executioner in the history of the Table. No blade, no blood on the floor that the prisoner didn't put there himself. I find him unbearable." — a Bencher of the Hall of Conditions

"He said he would come when he was able. I'm thirty. I'd like to tell him he's able now." — Pell Sallet

# NEW FACES OF OATHEN

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*The canyon is bigger than the Bench and deeper than the Ledger. Somebody is always down there, keeping a promise nobody remembers asking for.*

— A ROPE-LIFT MAN OF THE SHADEWARD

The core account of Oathen named five people beyond the bible's twenty-one: a sergeant, a night-nurse, a lord, a surgeon and a

Keener. Here they are in full, with two more who stand where the others' stories cross.



# SERGEANT MAGS CARROW

*the Four Hundred and First*

*“He let me go. Cost me an eye. Cheapest thing anyone’s ever sold me. Now hold that strap, Corporal, and don’t look at his knees.”*

– MAGS CARROW, TO A NEW VOLUNTEER IN THE STRAP-HOUSE

| SERGEANT MAGS CARROW – THE FOUR HUNDRED AND FIRST |                                                                                                                                                                           |
|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                        | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                                     | 40; Sergeant of the Fourth Regiment (released); keeper of the Strap-House, Back-Before-Dark lane, the Breakdowns                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                                | Warden · Standing 3 (Sergeant)                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                                        | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                                            | Blades 3, Endure 4, Stitching 3, Labor 3, Intimidate 3, Resolve 3, Instinct 2                                                                                             |
| BODY                                              | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Fray 5                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                                           | spear +7 (4)                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                             | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>The Kept Roll:</b> she knows the name and fate of every soldier of the Fourth; any of the Unmade will obey her voice as their sergeant’s. |
| WANTS                                             | none yet                                                                                                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                                            | Mother’s Hands, Strong Back                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                                      | none                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                                           | a Watch spear, her sash, an eye-patch of boiled leather, a bag of straps and buckles, a ledger of the eleven                                                              |
| DREAD                                             | 1 (the Strap-House)                                                                                                                                                       |

## WHO THEY ARE

Broad, short-necked and solid as a door, with one hazel eye and a leather patch over the other, Mags Carrow wears her regimental sash over a stained surgeon’s apron and smells of liniment, soap and old blood. Her voice is a parade-ground bark she keeps deliberately low. She laughs often and briefly.

## THEIR STORY

At Wending in 627 she was twenty-six, the regiment’s oldest sergeant, and she misheard the order to fall back over the wind. She stayed by her captain, and kept her oath without meaning to. In 629 Renn Hold drafted a release for her, a month’s work by a man who could barely write; she swore it, and her left eye burst in its socket, the grievous Breaking of a watch abandoned. She walked down the Unmade Road through the regiment and carried two of them out on her back.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She runs the Strap-House, a long cell in the Breakdowns where eleven survivors of the Fourth lie in cots, unstrung at every joint,

held together with straps and buckles, alive. Brakk’s people feed them. The Watch pays a pension it does not admit to.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A Watch spear** — her own, never used in battle.
- ♦ **The eye-patch** — boiled leather, stamped with the Fourth’s badge.
- ♦ **A bag of straps and buckles** — she rebuckles every soldier twice a day.
- ♦ **The ledger of the eleven** — names, joints, and what each one still asks for.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants Renn Hold brought down from the pass. She fears she will have to be the one who asks. **Secret:** she knows the other reading of “until death relieves us.” One of her eleven, Private Tobb Inly, has asked her, by blinking, to let him go so the captain can come home. She has not decided. **Unknown to her:** Renn feeds more of the regiment on the road than she has in her cots.

## TIES

- ◇ **Renn Hold** — her captain. She loves him like a father and cannot climb the pass.
- ◇ **Brakk** — feeds her soldiers; has offered her a Splint's seat.
- ◇ **Halvar Stane** — guides her up the eastern canyons once a year as far as the bend. She always turns back.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet her when they need someone who knows Wending, or when they come down from the pass with news. She asks one question: "Did he look well?" **Seeds:** she hires them to carry a letter up the pass; Tobb Inly's request becomes a demand; the Watch wants the Strap-House closed. Under threat she fights like a soldier; she answers kindness with a soldier's gruffness; she distrusts the god like a bad officer. If nobody intervenes, she lets Tobb go, and then the next, and climbs the pass with the last of them on her back.

## SAID OF THEM

"She buckled my uncle's knees back on every morning for twelve years. I've never seen her cry. I've seen her stop, though." — a Forsworn boy of Back-Before-Dark

"Best sergeant in the Watch. Wrong side of the pass." — an old officer of the Canyon Watch

"Mags asks about him every time. Every time I say he's well. It's the only lie I've ever been glad of my open mouth for." — a liar-for-hire of the Breakdowns

# DACEY FURL

the Gag-Nurse

*(signed, slowly, by lamplight) Broth. Wipe. Next. Broth. Wipe. Next. Three hundred. Then the first one again, and they are all saying it, all of them, and I cannot read the end.*

— DACEY FURL, TO A VISITOR

| DACEY FURL – THE GAG-NURSE |                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                 | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION              | 30; night-sister of the Murmuring House, Shadeward Wall, Tacit                                                                                                    |
| CALLING & STANDING         | Seamer · Standing 2 (Stitcher)                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                 | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                     | Stitching 4, Search 4, Endure 3, Resolve 4, Instinct 3, Lore 2                                                                                                    |
| BODY                       | Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                    | none                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                      | <b>Lip-Reader:</b> reads any mouth she can see, even behind a bit's grille, at a glance; she is deaf, and immune to echoes and to anything that binds by hearing. |
| WANTS                      | none yet                                                                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                     | Mother's Hands, Light Sleeper                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS               | none                                                                                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                    | a feeding-reed, a broth-pail, a lamp, a slate of the vow, a pair of shears                                                                                        |
| DREAD                      | 1                                                                                                                                                                 |

## WHO THEY ARE

A slow, soft-faced woman with heavy-lidded patient eyes and big red hands, Dacey Furl moves through the long wards at the pace of a funeral, smelling of barley broth and lye. She is deaf by choice: at eighteen she pierced her own eardrums with a heated needle so that the sound of the Murmuring House could not get into her. She signs and lip-reads, and her own voice, when she uses it, is flat and too loud.

## THEIR STORY

She came to the House at sixteen as a scrubber, the daughter of a patient. Her mother died bitted in the third ward. Dacey stayed, deafened herself, and has fed the three hundred, nightly, by reed through the grilles of their iron bits, for twelve years.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The night ward is hers: three hundred bitted Appetite-struck and Brink-mad, no families, no hope. She is the only nurse who does not need wax in her ears. She sells their shorn hair to Asha Kindle.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A feeding-reed** — and a pail of thin broth.
- ◇ **A slate of the vow** — on which she has written what the three hundred mouth in their sleep.
- ◇ **Hair-shears** — for the lice, and Asha's trade.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know the last word. For a month all three hundred have been mouthing the same vow in their sleep, together, in rhythm: *"When it calls, we will come, and we will say..."* and then a shape no human lips make, a shape for a tongue too long to fit in a mouth. **Unknown to her:** the rhythm they keep is the Gullet's heartbeat, and Brother Ansgar's tongues are saying it too.

## TIES

- ◇ **Garl Tome** — now sends iron free.
- ◇ **Asha Kindle** — buys the hair; Dacey takes half price.
- ◇ **Brother Ansgar Mote** — she has shown him her slate. He looked at it a long time and said nothing.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Dacey as the person who calls for help. **Seeds:** a patient chews through his bit and says the vow aloud, in a ward of three hundred listening; Dacey needs a reader of tongues; on the night the floor speaks, the three hundred sit up. She meets threat with stillness, kindness with broth, the god with sorrow. If nobody intervenes, on Tablenight every bed in the night ward is empty, and the iron bits lie open on the pillows.

## SAID OF THEM

“She fed my brother for six years and never once looked away from his mouth. I couldn’t. I’m his brother.” — a water-seller

“The quietest ward in the House is hers. Not because it’s quiet. Because she can’t hear it.” — a day-nurse

“She asked me to read the last word. I’m a Clausewright. I’ve read every word there is. Not that one.” — a Clausewright of the Bench

# LORD VARRO ESK

*the Heir of Tongues*

*“I only want to visit her. To hear her breathe. Is that so much? You are reasonable people.  
I can see that you are reasonable. Let me be reasonable back.”*

— LORD VARRO ESK, POURING THE WINE

| LORD VARRO ESK – THE HEIR OF TONGUES |                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Oathen · Cut 5 (Tongue-line, House Esk) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                        | 28; heir of House Esk, Sunward Wall; Second Table cell-master                                                                                                                                                    |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Scion · Standing 2 (Heir)                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                               | Persuade 5, Clause 4, Deceive 3, Lore 3, Godsign 3, Blades 2, Haggle 2                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                              | rapier +6 (4)                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                                | <b>Echo-Ear</b> ; <b>Hold to It</b> . <b>The Golden Word</b> : once per scene he may Partake to give a promise made to him +1 Weight and make its maker love him a little for it. Threat 4 for non-attack tasks. |
| WANTS                                | <b>To Swear</b> (at night, in his sleep, through silver)                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                               | Smell of Cedar, Hostage’s Smile                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                              | the silver night-bit, a Second Table veil, a purse of platters, letters of credit, a draft sentence                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                                | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

## WHO THEY ARE

Varro Esk is golden: honey hair, skin like warm bread, a wide laughing mouth and a voice like a hand on the back of the neck. He never hurries. He smells of cedar and good wine. At night, he wears a hinged silver bit, and the corners of his beautiful mouth are faintly grooved by it.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 613 to House Esk, he reached the Appetite at twenty-one and was recruited into the Second Table by his mother, who sits at its head in Oathen. He has spent four years on a single idea: have a Sayer unbitted, and have her say, “Tolm is whole and on the table.” The god would be made solid again, and edible, and his.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

A rich, charming Tongue-line heir with friends on the Bench, a cousin in the Envoy, and principals among Ona Fell’s bonds (the two who mean to default together are his cell). He funds shrines and Surety fees and favours.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The silver night-bit** — Garl Tome’s work, wearing thin.
- ◇ **A Second Table veil** — silk, with a silver fork.
- ◇ **A draft sentence** — on vellum, the six words, revised forty times.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to visit the Gilded Cells, and he wants a gold bit with a flaw. He fears his own sleep: he has sworn things through the silver that his wife has heard. **Unknown to him**: “on the table” has more than one reading. A whole god laid on a table is a dish. Somebody will be invited to eat it, and Varro has not asked himself who sets the places.

## TIES

- ◇ **Garl Tome** — refused him twice.
- ◇ **Tavish Crook** — hired to ask a Sayer one question.
- ◇ **Dorian Sayce** — a cousin; Varro is working on him.
- ◇ **Ona Fell** — he means to break her, to loose the Company’s contracts before Tablenight.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him as a generous patron with a reasonable request: help him visit the Gilded Cells. **Seeds:** a commission to “escort” a gold-bit blank; a dinner where his sleeping vow is overheard; an unbitting he has bought. He meets threat with a rapier and a smile, kindness with gifts, the god with appetite. If nobody intervenes, he gets into the Cells on Tablenight, when no one may cry out.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He paid for my mother’s Surety. He didn’t ask anything. That’s how I know he will.” — a cooper’s daughter

“Golden boy. Lovely manners. Sleeps in silver. I fitted it. I know what’s under the manners.” — Garl Tome

“He asked me whether a god can be served twice. I asked whether he’d ever been the dish.” — Tavish Crook

# BROTHER ANSGAR MOTE

## the Tongue-Taker

*(written on slate, in a neat surgeon's hand) Hold still. Bite the leather. Think of water.  
Three strokes. It will be over before you finish thinking it.*

— BROTHER ANSGAR MOTE, BEFORE THE KNIFE

| BROTHER ANSGAR MOTE — THE TONGUE-TAKER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                          | 60; surgeon of the Quiet; keeper of the Tongue Vault, upper Gullet                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Seamer · Standing 4 (Master Seamer)                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                                 | Stitching 6, Lore 4, Craft 3, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Blades 2, Rites 2                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                | tongue-knife +7 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| GIFTS                                  | <b>Echo-Ear</b> ; <b>Hold to It</b> . <b>The Clean Cut</b> : removes a tongue in three strokes with no Ruin; the patient is immune to Breakings of the tongue afterward. <b>Tongue-Reader</b> : reads the mouthing of a severed tongue as clearly as speech. |
| WANTS                                  | <b>To Swear</b> (he has kept his own tongue; he has not kept it quiet)                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                                 | Steady Hands, Butcher's Calm                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | <b>The Count</b> (he counts the jars nightly; it is always one short)                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                | the tongue-knife, a roll of silk thread, jar labels, the vault keys, a notebook of Verity's thoughts                                                                                                                                                         |
| DREAD                                  | 3 (the Tongue Vault)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

### WHO THEY ARE

A spare, tidy, grey man with a close-trimmed beard and steady white hands that smell always of brine and vinegar. He is the only brother of the Quiet who still has his tongue, and he uses it rarely, in a gentle, dry voice.

### THEIR STORY

A Seamer of Tacit, he came to the Quiet at thirty-five to take the knife and could not bring himself to it; the order made him its surgeon instead. He has removed four hundred tongues, cleanly. He once threw one in the midden, and it went on trying to speak for a week. He has kept every one since, in brine, labelled, in a cold cell cut into the rock.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Every Tongueless sister and brother of the Quiet passed under his knife, and many Tongue-line families pay him, secretly, to cut a child who has reached the Course.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The tongue-knife** — short, curved, kept in vinegar.

- ◇ **Jar labels** — name, date, house.

- ◇ **A notebook** — in which he has transcribed, every night for three years, what Sister Verity's tongue mouths in its jar.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to understand what the tongues are doing. **Secret**: they are growing. Verity's is twice its size, and reads her thoughts aloud to the brine. **Unknown to anyone**: at night, all four hundred mouth the same vow as Dacey Furl's patients, and Ansgar, who can read tongues without lips, can read the last word. He has not written it down. He has not slept since.

### TIES

- ◇ **Sister Verity Amn** — his dearest friend. He reads her mind in a jar.
- ◇ **Dacey Furl** — showed him her slate. He lied by silence.
- ◇ **Hessa Lisk** — wants to buy a tongue. He refused.

### IN PLAY

PCs meet him when a companion needs the knife, or when they come looking for Verity's secret. **Seeds**: a jar is stolen; a tongue in the vault says a PC's name; Ansgar asks the PCs to burn the vault,



and the tongues beg. He meets threat calmly, kindness gratefully, the god with clinical horror. If nobody intervenes, he says the last word aloud, once, to know.

SAID OF THEM

“Three strokes. He wasn’t lying. I finished thinking ‘water’ after.”  
— a Tongueless sister

“Four hundred jars and a man with a candle. I left the Quiet over that room.” — a former novice

“Brother Ansgar is kind. Kindness keeps things.” — Sister Verity Amn

# OLD SABRA WENDS

*the Keener of Oaths*

*“Put your hand on him. There. Now, before you speak: are you certain? He’ll hear. He hears better than he did.”*

— OLD SABRA WENDS, IN THE WITNESSING VAULTS

| OLD SABRA WENDS – THE KEENER OF OATHS |                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                            | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                         | 70; Eldest Keener of the Witnessing Vaults beneath Tacit                                                                                                                               |
| CALLING & STANDING                    | Celebrant · Standing 4 (High Celebrant)                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTRIBUTES                            | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                    |
| SKILLS                                | Rites 5, Lore 5, Resolve 5, Clause 3, Instinct 4, Search 3                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                                  | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                               | none                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                                 | <b>Echo-Ear; Hold to It. Keener’s Ear:</b> she knows when an oath sworn on any body in the Vaults is near to breaking; she can guide anyone through the Vaults’ miles without a light. |
| WANTS                                 | <b>To Hold Others to Their Words</b>                                                                                                                                                   |
| KNACKS                                | Elder’s Ear, Unflinching                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                          | none                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                               | a lantern, a slate of the forty-two, the niche-keys, a horn of cedar oil                                                                                                               |
| DREAD                                 | 2 (when the dead speak)                                                                                                                                                                |

## WHO THEY ARE

Small, white-haired, bent like a hook, with a lantern in one hand and a slate in the other, Sabra Wends smells of cedar oil and old dust and moves through the dark of the Vaults like water. Her voice is soft and certain.

## THEIR STORY

A Keener’s daughter, she has kept the Vaults for fifty years. She has heard the dead speak forty-two times: oaths sworn on them broke, and the jaw in the niche opened and said the vow aloud, in the dead one’s voice, loud enough to carry a mile through the rock. The number this year is nine. Last year it was two.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Every oath on the dead in Tacit is sworn before her. She asks each swearer, gently, whether they are certain. Many go home unsworn.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The lantern** — never needed; carried for the living.
- ◇ **The slate of the forty-two** — every testimony, word for word.
- ◇ **A horn of cedar oil** — for the faces of the dead.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants the number to stop rising. **Secret:** three of this year’s nine were not testimony. No oath had been sworn on those bodies. The jaws opened anyway, and each said two words: “*Go on.*” **Unknown to her:** one of the three was Amon Sallet, her apprentice’s father.

## TIES

- ◇ **Pell Sallet** — her apprentice and heir.
- ◇ **Asha Kindle** — has walked the Vaults in her sleep; Sabra led her home.
- ◇ **Tamsa Reeve** — wants to swear on Corram. Sabra asked her whether she was certain.
- ◇ **Grandam Cess** — they were girls together. They do not speak.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet her when they come to swear on the dead. **Seeds:** a body speaks with no oath on it; a niche is found empty and its occupant at a fire on the Shadeward; Sabra needs witnesses for the tenth testimony of the year. She meets threat with the dark, kindness with oil for your dead, the god with patience. If nobody intervenes, on Tablenight every jaw in the Vaults opens at once.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She asked me if I was certain. I wasn’t. I went home and married him anyway, without swearing on Gran. Still married.” — a bride of the Sunward

“Fifty years down there and she still says good morning to every niche.” — a rope-lift man

“Don’t lie in the Vaults. She’ll know before he does.” — a Forsworn

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# PELL SALLET

## the Breaker's Daughter

*“He said he’d come when he was able. I’ve been thinking about that sentence for twenty-four years. I’ve decided it was a gift, and I’ve decided it’s time to give it back.”*

— PELL SALLET, TO SABRA WENDS

| PELL SALLET – THE BREAKER’S DAUGHTER |                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                           | Oathen · Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                        | 30; Keener of the Witnessing Vaults, apprentice to Sabra Wends                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                   | Celebrant · Standing 2 (Celebrant)                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                           | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                               | Clause 4, Rites 3, Lore 3, Persuade 3, Resolve 3, Stealth 2, Athletics 2                                                                                                  |
| BODY                                 | Flesh 11 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTACKS                              | knife +2 (2)                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                | <b>Echo-Ear</b> (the Taste). <b>The Release:</b> she holds Jude Crake’s promise; if she tells him, sincerely, that he is able, the Exit closes and he must come or break. |
| WANTS                                | none yet                                                                                                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                               | Old Grief, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                    |
| DERANGEMENTS                         | none                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                              | her father’s hour-glass stand, a lantern, a fig-stone on a cord, a drafted letter                                                                                         |
| DREAD                                | 0                                                                                                                                                                         |

### WHO THEY ARE

Tall and pale from the Vaults, dark-browed, with her father’s stern mouth and a startling, sudden smile, Pell smells of cedar oil and lamp-smoke and speaks in beautifully built conditionals: she was her father’s daughter, and he was careful.

### THEIR STORY

At six, in 617, she was brought to the Ninth Room to see her father’s body, and a soft round young man knelt in front of her and said, “I’ll come and see you, when I’m able.” She did not understand for ten years who he was. When she did, she trained as a Keener, so that she could stand beside her father’s niche every day, and wait.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Sabra’s chosen heir; the Vaults will be hers. She tends her father’s niche herself, and swears in the living on the dead.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Her father’s hour-glass stand** — the glass is with Jude.
- ◇ **A fig-stone on a cord** — from the basket he left in the Ninth Room.

- ◇ **A drafted letter** — “You are able.” Unsent.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants Jude Crake to come. **Secret:** the GM decides which of two things she wants of him: to forgive him in front of her father, or to have him swear on her father’s bones that he will break no one else, and watch the Bench give him to himself. She has not decided either. **Unknown to her:** her father’s jaw opened this year with no oath on him and said, “Go on.”

### TIES

- ◇ **Jude Crake** — the man who killed her father with conversation, and was kind to her.
- ◇ **Sabra Wends** — teacher, mother in all but blood.
- ◇ **Ottoline Vant** — has a name on her list that Pell recognises: her father’s, from 612.

### IN PLAY

PCs meet her in the Vaults, or as the messenger who carries her letter to the Breaker. **Seeds:** deliver the letter; sit with her at the niche when Jude comes; find out why the Fair Copy once miscut Amon Sallet. She meets threat with a Keener’s calm, kindness with

candour, the god with respect. If nobody intervenes, she sends the letter on Tablenight.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She stands by her father’s niche every morning like a sentry. I’ve never seen her pray. I think she’s waiting.” — a Keener

“She’s got Amon’s mouth. When she says ‘if able,’ you know exactly what it costs her.” — Old Sabra Wends

“Pell? Kind girl. She brought my mother’s niche a candle the night Mum spoke. Didn’t ask what I’d sworn.” — a cooper of Low Dray

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# CUTWRIGHT HESSA LISK

*the Measurer of Tongues*

*“Open, please. Wider. Tongue out, flat, to the lower lip. Now hold it there while I count.  
No, don’t speak. I’ll know everything I need to without that.”*

– HESSA LISK, WITH HER CALIPERS

| CUTWRIGHT HESSA LISK – THE MEASURER OF TONGUES |                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                     | Oathen · Cut 3 (Tongue-line, House Lisk) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION                                  | 47; Warden of the Tacit Office of the Cutwrights’ College                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING                             | Cutwright · Standing 4                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                                     | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                  |
| SKILLS                                         | Lore 5, Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Stitching 3, Persuade 3, Instinct 3                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                           | Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTACKS                                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| GIFTS                                          | <b>Echo-Ear</b> ; <b>Hold to It</b> . <b>The Measure</b> : with calipers and a minute, she knows a person’s Cut, Regrowth and Hunger exactly, and (Grim 18) how many years they have to the Seating. |
| WANTS                                          | <b>To Correct</b> (when a family lies to her about a child’s Cut)                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                         | Counting Habit, Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DERANGEMENTS                                   | none                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                        | Cutwright’s calipers, the Office ledgers, the sealed report on the king, fig cakes, a cracked right hand                                                                                             |
| DREAD                                          | 1                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Neat, small, sharp-chinned, in Cutwright grey with a white Tongue-line collar, Hessa Lisk smells of ink, brass polish and the clove she chews. She is precise, unhurried, not unkind, and appallingly well informed.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 594 to a minor Tongue-line, she joined the College at sixteen and has run the Tacit Office for eleven years. She wrote the sealed report on Ket the Ninth. She measured Merit Tome, Ilan, Asha Kindle, and half the Bench.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Her ledgers decide Tongue-line marriages and inheritances, and tell the Bench which houses to bit. She knows which nobles are nearest the Brink, which children may be crowned, and which bloodlines the Reckoners would most like to end.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◆ **Cutwright’s calipers** — brass, +2 Lore to judge Cut.
- ◆ **The Office ledgers** — Oathen’s Regrowth, house by house.

- ◆ **A cracked right hand** — see below.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to save Ilan, privately, against College policy. **Secret**: the Tongue-lines at the Course have doubled in five years; by her figures Oathen will see a second Sayer outside the Cells within three. **Unknown to her**: writing binds now, and she has been writing false numbers for her own tongue’s length in the ledger every night. Her right hand has begun to crack along the palm, and she believes it is the dry wind.

## TIES

- ◆ **Garl Tome** — hates her; she sends him fig cake.
- ◆ **Ket the Ninth** — she has seen his tongue. She will not describe it.
- ◆ **Brother Ansgar Mote** — refuses to sell her a tongue.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet her when they need a Cut read, or when the College wants an Oathener measured who will not sit still. **Seeds**: steal the Office ledger for the Forsworn; carry Merit’s measurements to House Hushwell; help her save Ilan. Threat she meets with a ledger;

kindness with candour; the god with numbers. If nobody intervenes, her hand splits to the wrist on the night she writes the true figure.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She measured my boy and told me the number. I said thank you. I meant it. I hate her.” — a Tongue-line mother

“Lisk knows the date of every Seating in Tacit. I’d like her on the Bench. I’d like her under it more.” — a Bencher

“She held my chin very gently. Then she wrote something down and her hand was bleeding.” — Merit Tome, in handtalk

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# WEBS OF OATHEN

IN TACITNOBODY IS FREE. EVERYBODY IS OWED  
SOMETHING, EVERYBODY OWES, AND THE GOD IS  
THE ONLY ONE KEEPING THE BOOKS.

[ A SPLINT OF THE FORSWORN, AT THE GATHERING OF THE BROKEN ]

Oathen's relationships are not feelings; they are entries. Every tie below is a promise someone made, kept, broke or is waiting to break, and the GM should treat each one as a loaded clause.

| CHARACTER     | WANTS FROM                      | FEARS                       | OWES                       |
|---------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------|
| Asha Kindle   | a stranger to put out the fire  | what the fire wants next    | the fire, everything       |
| Garl Tome     | Merit's first words             | Hushwell; the truth of 611  | Haskell Tome a confession  |
| Yusra Thole   | the Bench to understand unasked | being asked                 | the canyon the truth       |
| Grandam Cess  | the floor to speak              | being too late              | the Grandams' muster       |
| Renn Hold     | someone to say "relieved"       | that no one can             | the four hundred water     |
| Tavish Crook  | one more mark                   | the god hearing his meaning | Ottoline a hiding place    |
| Verity Amn    | silence, then everyone's        | her own mind                | Laine Amn her eyes         |
| Dorian Sayce  | home, and to stay               | his own pleasure in lying   | the Bench his discipline   |
| Ilan          | a promise                       | the listening room          | his mother his existence   |
| Ottoline Vant | the truth carved                | that she is the twelfth     | Pellam Oxe a correction    |
| Jude Crake    | to be kind                      | the hour running long       | Pell Sallet a visit        |
| Mags Carrow   | Renn Hold brought down          | having to ask               | Tobb Inly an answer        |
| Dacey Furl    | the last word                   | the night ward sitting up   | the three hundred broth    |
| Varro Esk     | a Sayer's six words             | his own sleep               | the Second Table a god     |
| Ansgar Mote   | to understand the tongues       | the last word               | Verity the truth           |
| Sabra Wends   | the number to stop rising       | the dead saying "Go on"     | every niche its oil        |
| Pell Sallet   | Jude Crake at the niche         | forgiving him               | her father an answer       |
| Hessa Lisk    | to save Ilan                    | her own true measure        | the ledger the real figure |



## THE BREAKER AND THE DAUGHTER

Jude Crake killed Amon Sallet with an hour of conversation in 617 and promised his six-year-old daughter he would visit “when I’m able.” Pell Sallet, now a Keener, has worked out that the Exit is the only thing keeping Jude whole, and that she holds its key: if she writes “You are able” and means it, he must come down the Vaults’ stair or break. Ottoline Vant’s list knows something worse: Amon Sallet’s name is on it, miscut in 612. Put Jude, Pell and the list in one niche-corridor on one night, among dead who have started answering, and something will be said that cannot be unsaid.

## THE CAPTAIN, THE SERGEANT AND THE ROAD

Renn Hold and Mags Carrow both know the other reading of “until death relieves us,” and neither knows the other knows. He

keeps the regiment alive on the road with nightly water, coming open a little more each time; she keeps eleven alive in the Strap-House, and one of them is asking her to let go. Every soldier she lets die brings her captain closer to relief; every bucket he carries down keeps him on the pass. Any PC who carries a letter between the Strap-House and the top of the pass carries a death sentence, and has to decide whose.

## THE GOLD, THE GIRL AND THE LORD

Garl Tome makes the bits that hold the Sayers. Lord Varro Esk wants one with a flaw. House Hushwell wants Garl’s daughter Merit bitted in silver forever so that she can be crowned. Hessa Lisk knows Merit is at the Course without ever having made a sound. And Merit has learned a secret handtalk from the king at his fittings and promised him, in it, to say her first words for him, at Plenty, in the Hall of Conditions, before the whole canyon. Everyone in this knot wants Merit to say something, or not. Nobody has asked her what.

# USING OATHEN'S PEOPLE

*Knock softly. Answer slower.*

– TACIT PROVERB

Use these people as pressure: each carries a promise about to come due, and each will try to put part of its weight on the PCs, arriving with a good reason and a small request. In Oathen nothing said is small.

**Who's at the Door?** Roll a d20 when the PCs are in Tacit, on the Rim near Quillhouse, or anywhere the canyon's people can reach them.

| D20 | WHO'S AT THE DOOR            | WHY                                                                                                             |
|-----|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Asha Kindle                  | She needs a fire watched for one hour, and asks you to swear you will not let it go out.                        |
| 2   | Garl Tome                    | He needs a mouth measured: yours. A PC has begun to swear in their sleep, and he heard of it.                   |
| 3   | Yusra Thole                  | She says nothing. She hands you a beaker of warm rain and points west, toward the Gullet.                       |
| 4   | Grandam Cess                 | One of you is in her Book, under a name you used once. The knot in her shawl has tightened.                     |
| 5   | A drover from Wending        | Renn Hold has let nobody through for three days. He is asking for a PC by name.                                 |
| 6   | Tavish Crook                 | Wouldn't you like to make a great deal of money? Would you mind if it were a little dangerous?                  |
| 7   | A novice of the Quiet        | Sister Verity has written a slate for you. It begins: "Stop thinking about what you saw."                       |
| 8   | Dorian Sayce's secretary     | The Envoy needs an escort across Wending before Tablenight, and someone has stolen a green book.                |
| 9   | Tamsa Reeve, with Ilan       | Her hand is on her son's shoulder. She asks you to look at him and tell her his name.                           |
| 10  | Ottoline Vant                | Through the window, from a rope. The Watch is on the stair. She has a list.                                     |
| 11  | Jude Crake                   | With figs. He was passing, he says. He has heard that one of you made a promise last night.                     |
| 12  | Mags Carrow                  | She wants a letter carried up Wending Pass, and a promise that you will read it to him.                         |
| 13  | Dacey Furl                   | Signing, too loud, at midnight: a patient has said the vow aloud and the ward is listening.                     |
| 14  | Lord Varro Esk's steward     | An invitation to dinner, a purse of platters, and a reasonable request concerning a gold bit.                   |
| 15  | Brother Ansgar Mote          | A jar wrapped in felt. The tongue inside it has said one of your names.                                         |
| 16  | Old Sabra Wends              | A niche spoke your oath this morning, one you swore on the dead. Are you certain you kept it?                   |
| 17  | Pell Sallet                  | She needs a letter delivered to the Breaker, by hand, and someone to stand with her when he comes.              |
| 18  | Hessa Lisk                   | The College wants your Cut measured. She asks you to open your mouth, and not to speak.                         |
| 19  | A Forsworn runner from Brakk | The Breakdowns want a whole Oathener to swear something in public. They will pay in bad paper and good friends. |
| 20  | Nobody                       | The door is open. On the step, a child's bit, unbuckled, warm, and a smear of red sand.                         |

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## RUNNING THE CAST

- ◇ **Let every request be a small oath.** “Will you watch the fire?” “Will you carry this?” “Will you look after him?” The canyon is listening, and the players should feel the weight before they answer.
  - ◇ **Show the price on someone else first.** A PC who sees Asha’s cracked breastbone or Mags Carrow’s patch will start drafting their sentences. That is the game working.
  - ◇ **Tie the crises to *Tablenight*.** Cess’s floor, Dacey’s ward, Varro’s visit, Pell’s letter and Ilan’s fading all point at the one night Oathen is silent. Let them converge.
  - ◇ **Keep the god offstage.** The Gullet’s heartbeat, the hum in the floor, the last word nobody can read: hint, and let the PCs put it together. The canyon keeps the change.
-



CHAPTER 7

# THE FAST

*The Country Kept for a Guest*

*Carry your own. Count your chairs. Close the gate, and then go through it again.*

– WHAT A WANTING MOTHER SAYS AT THE DOOR EACH MORNING, IN PLACE OF  
GOODBYE

*A day of Meagre Toft, Measure-Bearer, aged fifteen, of Pantry Close in Wanting. Set down by the Hostwatch clerk who walked with her, for the ledger of ordinary days the Warden of the Map keeps “so that someone will remember what the Fast was like before.”*

*She wakes in the dark because the cold wakes her. There is frost on the inside of the shutter, and she puts her palm flat on it before she does anything else, because frost inside means the god was nowhere near the house in the night. Then she puts her palm flat on the bricked place in the wall where her great-grandmother’s grandmother had a hearth. Cold. Good. She says the Five Rules under her breath into the blanket, all five, quickly, the way you check your pockets, and gets up.*

*Her mother is already standing against the wall, dressed in everything she owns. Her little brother is asleep on the pallet with his head to the door. Nobody says good morning. Her mother says, “Carry your own,” and Meagre says, “I carry my own,” and takes the ration-cloth off the shelf, and the water flask, and the wax tin, and goes out, and closes the door behind her from the outside, and then opens it and goes back in and closes it again from the inside and goes out again. That is how her family does it. Other families have other ways. All of them are about the door.*

*Pantry Close is grey at that hour and full of people standing still. The Ration Line has formed in the night, as it does every night, four abreast and back along the Close and round the corner into Hillward, a long dark bundle of wool and breath. Nobody talks in the Line. It costs too much. You can hear the whole town breathing, and the breath smells of pear-drops, which is the smell of bodies eating their own fat because there is nothing else, and you can hear the Pantry clock, which has no face, only a bell, and you can hear coughing. Meagre does not join the Line. She goes round the side to the Bearers’ door, which is the only door in Wanting that opens inward, and which is held by a spearman who looks at her face and her hands and the Bearer’s cord at her wrist, and says, “Declined,” and she says, “Declined,” and he lets her in.*

*Inside the Pantry it is warmer than anywhere else in the town, and it is not warm. It smells of sacking and mouse and dust, and, very faintly, of oats, and to Meagre that is the smell of being alive. Mother Stint Avery is at the great brass scales in the weighing-hall, as she is every morning, with her sleeves*

*rolled to the elbow and her forearms white with oat-dust. She does not look up. She is weighing out the Bearers’ measures for the outlying hamlets into cloth bundles, one bundle per name, and as she ties each one she says the name aloud, once, flatly, and a clerk writes it, and another clerk checks it against the list, and the bundle goes into a Bearer’s basket. Meagre’s basket is for Thinwick and Sallow Hatch and the four farms along the Brindle road. Thirty-one names. She counts the bundles. Thirty-one. She counts them again. She is not supposed to look at the list. She has never looked at the list. She knows there were thirty-three names last week.*

*She walks out of Wanting with the basket on her back as the sky goes pale. The frost is thick on the fields east of the town, which is good. The frost is thin on the fields west, which is not. Out past the Frostline markers, which are white-painted stakes the Hostwatch move every week, the grass goes from white to grey to green, and you can see where the warm ground begins, a soft edge like the line a wet cloth leaves on a table. She keeps east of it. Everyone does. The road is empty and very quiet and the basket is heavy, and the bundles in it smell of oats and lard, and her stomach turns over once, hard, like something in a sack.*

*At Thinwick a woman is waiting at the hamlet stone with her hands folded. Meagre gives her four bundles. The woman says, “No, thank you,” three times, and Meagre offers a fourth time, and the woman takes them, and does not look into Meagre’s basket, and does not ask about the two names that are not in it. At the second farm on the Brindle road nobody comes out. Meagre stands at the gate and calls the name, as she is supposed to, three times. Then she puts the bundle on the gatepost, as she is supposed to, and walks on, and does not look back, because a bundle left on a gatepost is not offered, it is only set down, and whoever takes it is carrying their own.*

*The smell finds her on the way home, at about the time of the afternoon when the light in the Fast stops changing. Bread. It comes from the west, faint, over the warm ground, and her mouth floods so fast she chokes. She turns her face into the wind. There is no wind. She turns her face east, then, toward the Rim, and walks with her mouth open and her tongue flat, breathing as little as she can, and spits every forty steps, and counts them, and does not think about bread, and thinks about bread.*

*At night Pantry Close is lit by one lamp at the iron door, under which the Keeper reads the next day's list. Meagre goes, as everyone goes. Mother Stint Avery reads the names without any expression at all, for forty minutes, in a voice that does not change on any name. Meagre hears her own. She hears her mother's. She hears her brother's. She does not hear the name of the man who was weeping in the Cold Yards, and when she looks for him in the crowd he is already walking away, slowly, toward the Lean End, with his hands at his sides.*

*She goes home. She closes the door from the outside, and opens it, and closes it from the inside. She puts her palm on the bricked hearth. Cold. She lies down with her head to the door. Somewhere out on the warm ground, a long way west, there is a single light, gold, the size of a pinprick, where a table has been laid in an empty house for someone, and she watches it through the crack in the shutter until she falls asleep, and does not say thank you to it, and wants to.*

## ▼ DISTRICTS AND SETTLEMENTS

### WANTING: THE TOWN WITH NO KITCHENS

Wanting sits on a long, low, limestone ridge on the eastern margin of the Fast, half a day's walk from Brindle Cross and the Rim Road. It was built in 188 A.G., when the last Unfed abandoned the heartland, and it was built to a single idea: that nothing in it should look like an invitation. The streets run straight and the houses are all the same: long, low, grey, slate-roofed, chimneyless, with narrow windows and iron-strapped doors hung to open outward. There are no signs, no painted shutters, no window-boxes, no benches. There is nowhere to sit down in the whole of Wanting except the floor of your own house. Visitors from the Rim find it the most depressing town on the Table, and say so, and are not invited back, which is a joke the Unfed enjoy in silence.

About nine thousand people live in Wanting, and about four thousand more in the hamlets and steadings scattered in a ring around it, none more than a day's walk out, all on the cold side of the Frostline. Everything in the Fast that is not the god's lives within that ring. The town has no walls. It has the Frostline, a ring of white-painted stakes the Hostwatch move every week to mark where the warm ground ends; inside it is the Unfed's country, and outside it is Orrum's.

The town is divided into quarters that the Unfed do not call quarters, since a quarter is a portion. They call them *stands*, after the stretches of the trench at Hallowboard where the families of the hill once stood, and each stand has its own families, its own habits about doors, its own way of saying the Decline. A child of Hillward can be told from a child of the Spit by how they close a gate.

#### PANTRY CLOSE

The heart of Wanting is not a square, because a square is a place to gather and gathering is a kind of feast. It is a wide, bare, cobbled ring around the Pantry tower, kept swept and empty, with the town's six main streets running into it like spokes. The Ration Line forms here every night and moves at dawn, four abreast, round the tower and in at the window on the north side, where each household's chit is taken and its measure handed out through an iron hatch. At dusk the Close fills again for the reading of the list. The rest of the day it is the emptiest place in Wanting.

It smells of cold stone, wool, and the pear-drop breath of the Line. It sounds like coughing, and the bell of the Pantry clock, which strikes the hours and, on list nights, a single extra stroke after the last name. Pantry clerks, Measure-Bearers and Listers live in the narrow houses around the Close, and are envied for it, because to

live within sight of the iron door is to feel, a little, that you will not be forgotten.

*Custom:* nobody crosses the Close diagonally. You walk around it, as you walk around the bare space in the middle of your own house where a table would be. Children who cut across are made to walk the full ring three times. *Danger:* the Close is where the omitted learn that they are omitted, and every few weeks one of them does not take it quietly. A man left off the list in 639 stood at the iron door and beat on it with both fists until the bones in his hands broke, and the spearmen let him, because to stop him would have been to touch him, and to touch him would have been a kindness.

**HESITATE BRUNE, NIGHT LISTER** Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A gaunt young clerk who copies the list each evening before it is read, and has started, very lightly, in pencil, to copy the names that are struck out. He keeps them in his shoe.

#### HILLWARD

The oldest stand, on the crown of the ridge, where the families who claim the clearest descent from Hallowboard live in the longest, coldest, barest houses in town. Hillward houses are older than the rest and plainer, if that is possible, and their doors are the heaviest: some are two inches of oak strapped with four bands of iron, and take two people to open. The Abtinent's elders live here, and Wont Bellamy, and the Wend family. Elder Forbear Wend is carried down Hillward Row to the Pantry every morning in his ash chair, and the street stands back against the walls as he goes by.

Hillward smells of nothing at all, which is its boast. It is the quietest stand in Wanting, and the most watched, because its people are watched by everyone else for any sign of softness: a curtain, a cushion, a cheek that has filled out. The Hillward families trade in nothing. They hold standing, which in the Fast is the only property: the right to stand at a particular place in the trench at Hallowboard on Tablenight, handed down from the ones who stood.

*Custom:* Hillward households keep a *stand-stone*, a chip of chalk from their ancestors' stretch of the trench, set into the floor by the door, and every member of the family puts a bare foot on it before going out. *Danger:* reputation. A Hillward family whose member is seen enjoying a meal can lose its stand, and with it everything, inside a season.

**OLD PINCH CORVE, HILLWARD DOORWARDEN** Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Ninety-one, blind, sits at the top of Hillward Row from dawn to dusk and can name every person who passes by the sound of their breathing; he reports any breath that smells of anything but hunger.

## THE COLD YARDS

Six walled squares of beaten earth on the south and west edges of town, where all the cooking in Wanting is done. The walls are high, to keep the smell of food from reaching the streets, and the yards are open to the sky. In each yard there are dozens of fire-pits, shallow scrapes in the earth lined with flint, and at the two hours of the day when the yards are open (an hour after dawn and an hour before dusk) each pit has a household crouched at it, warming the day's measure in a clay pot over a fire made of a single handful of Rim kindling. The fire is stamped out the moment the pot steams. No fire in Wanting burns longer than it takes to warm a mouthful.

The Yards are the closest thing in Wanting to a public life, and they are dreadful. Two hundred hungry people crouched in a walled square, each over a little pot, each with their back to the others, each careful not to look, each careful not to smell, and the air thick with the smell of warm oats and lard, which to an Unfed nose is very nearly unbearable. It sounds like spoons on clay and the hiss of stamped-out fires, and every evening, somewhere, someone weeping while they eat.

*Custom:* you eat facing the wall. You eat standing. You do not close your eyes. Children are taught by being struck lightly on the back of the head. *Danger:* the Yards are where hoarding and mouth-theft happen, and where the Abstinent's Yard-wardens watch for them. A Yard-warden's word can cut a family's measure for a month. Worse: on still evenings the smell from the Yards travels west, and twice in living memory a table has been found laid in the West Yard at dawn, inside the walls, with every fire-pit lit.

**YARD-WARDEN FALLOW STEEN** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (staff 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. A broad, sour woman who walks the West Yard with a staff and a slate, and marks the names of anyone she sees chewing with their eyes shut. She is very good at it because she does it herself, every night, alone.

## THE SPIT

A low, muddy, crowded stand on the east side of the ridge, down by the Brindle road, where the Crumb-Runners live. It has the only stables in Wanting, long sheds of rough timber for the oxen and handcarts, and the only buildings with locks on the inside: Runners keep their stock in their houses for a night before the Pantry takes it, and they have learned to bar their doors. The Spit is called the Spit because that is what the rest of Wanting does when a Runner walks by, and it was called that so long ago that the Runners call it that too, without irony, the way a scarred man calls himself Scar.

It smells of ox, wet straw, axle-grease, sacking, and food. That last is the thing. Even after the cargo has gone up to the Pantry, the houses of the Spit smell of oats and cheese and salt fish, faintly, all the time, and to other Unfed the smell is both an outrage and a pull, so that children of other stands dare one another to walk the length of Spit Lane breathing through the nose. The Runners are the least pious, least thin and best informed people in the Fast. They are spat on in the street. They wipe it off and go on.

*Custom:* a Runner who comes home from a run stands in Spit Lane and empties every pocket onto the ground, and turns them out, so that the street can see they have brought back nothing for themselves. *Danger:* poachers. Kale Dragoman's agents drink at the Brimming Cup on the Rim side of Brindle Cross and buy information from Runners in debt, and more than one Unfed taken across the Rim was named to the poachers by someone in the Spit.

**SPARING DOYLE, ROAD-MASTER OF THE SPIT** Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (ox-goad 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. Owns eleven carts and twenty-two oxen, the largest fleet in Wanting; eats on the road and lies about it; is the only person in the Spit with whom the Abstinent will speak directly, and despises them for it.

## THE LEAN END

The far western tip of the ridge, beyond the last of the Cold Yards, where the houses thin out into sheds and byres and then stop. The Lean House stands here, long and windowless, and around it a scatter of small, half-empty cottages where the families of the omitted live, close enough to visit and far enough not to have to. Abide Kettering's cart-shed is at the bottom of the lane. So is the Bury Gate, through which the dead of Wanting are carried out to the fields.

It is quiet. It smells of clean straw, lye, and something under it that the Unfed have a word for and other peoples do not: the sweetish, appley, nail-varnish smell of a body in the last week of hunger. It is the only part of Wanting with a view west, and on still evenings the people of the Lean End can see the warm ground beginning a quarter-mile away, and lights in it, here and there, where tables are laid.

*Custom:* people walking to the Lean House are not greeted, not looked at, and not offered anything, as a courtesy. People coming back are greeted as though from a long journey. *Danger:* the view. The Lean End is the stand from which most of Wanting's walkers go: people, omitted or not, who get up in the night and walk west toward a light. The Hostwatch keep a rope strung across the end of the lane, belled, and a watchman, and most nights the watchman hears a bell.

**CEASE ABBOT, LEAN END WATCHMAN** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A one-eyed former Tablebreaker who sits up every night by the bell-rope, and who has stopped a hundred walkers, and lately has begun, on some nights, to look the other way.

## BELL WARD

The stand of young families, on the gentle southern slope of the ridge, where the houses are smallest and closest together and the doors are hung with hand-bells. Every household with a child under twelve keeps a bell at the door, and at dusk, and whenever the smell on the wind goes sweet, the mother or eldest stands at the door and rings it and counts the children through. On a sweet-smelling evening the whole of Bell Ward rings at once, a thin, frightened,



tinny peal, and the counting can be heard up and down the lanes in a hundred voices: *one, two, three, in. One, two, in.*

Bell Ward smells of wet wool and the sour milk-and-ammonia of babies in hard-washed linen. It sounds like bells, and children reciting the Five Rules in chorus at the Rule-house at the bottom of the slope, where every child of the stand is taught. It is the stand the god loves best, and everyone knows it.

*Custom:* when a child goes missing, the family rings the bell at dusk for a year and a day, calling the child's name, and then takes the bell down and gives it to the Rule-house, where it hangs on a long beam among hundreds of others. Nobody rings the beam. *Danger:* Little Fain lives here now, with a foster-family who did not ask for the duty, and the other children of Bell Ward follow Fain about.

**RULE-MISTRESS WITHHOLD PENN** Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Teaches the Five Rules to three hundred children; can recite them so fast they sound like a single word; has found, three mornings this season, a little chair pulled out at the Rule-house door, child-sized, the seat warm.

#### PINNERS' YARD

A walled court behind the Pantry, entered from Pantry Close by a narrow gate, where the Hostwatch keep their lodgings, their rope-store, their lamp-room, and the stair down to the Great Map in the cellar below the Pantry. Trackers come and go at all hours, muddy to the thigh, with warm-ground reports scrawled on slates, and the Pin-Setters run them down the stair to be pricked onto the linen. The Yard is the only place in Wanting where people talk about Orrum as a thing that does things rather than a thing to be refused, and the Abstinent watch it closely.

It smells of lamp oil, wet rope and the beeswax the Pin-Setters use to stiffen their linen. It sounds like boots, the clack of slates, and arguments, low and fierce, about gaits and directions and why the god paused for an hour at a particular gate.

*Custom:* a Tracker coming in from the field touches the Yard gate with a bare palm and says, aloud, how far they were from the god at the closest. The number is chalked on the gatepost. It has been getting smaller. *Danger:* the Hostwatch's restricted ledgers, which record the extra chair, are kept here, and two Pin-Setters have been omitted from the list in the last year after copying them.

**PIN-SETTER ABATE LOWRIE** Threat 1 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A fourteen-year-old girl with perfect hands who sets four hundred pins a week, and who has noticed, though nobody has asked her, that the newest pins on the Rim Road make a circle, and that the circle is closing.

#### KNIFE ROW AND THE WEST GATE

A single long street of hard-used houses running out to the West Gate, where the Reckoners muster on the first day of Carving and where volunteers come to stand and be looked at. Reckoner families live along it, and Reckoners home between raids, and the widows

and widowers of Reckoners who did not come home. The doors on Knife Row are painted black, the only painted doors in Wanting, and each one has notches cut in its lintel: one for each line the household's Knives have ended.

Knife Row smells of the grey, fatless leather Reckoners wear, and of whetstone dust, and, faintly, of Rim weather: wet road, foreign smoke. It sounds like boots and very little talk. Reckoners home from a raid do not speak of it, and the Row has a way of falling silent when they pass that is not quite respect.

*Custom:* a returning band walks the length of the Row from the West Gate to the Pantry carrying nothing, with their empty hands held out at their sides, palms forward, to show they took nothing from the houses they entered. *Danger:* bedside hunger. Reckoners home from the Rim are sometimes not right, and Knife Row has more walkers, more Breaks and more quiet deaths in the night than any stand but the Lean End.

**FORSWEAR TALLOW, RECKONER WIDOW** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A descendant of Forswear Kell, keeper of the Row's notched lintels and its memory; she mends Reckoner greys for nothing, and asks every returning Knife the same question, *what were the beds like*, and writes down the answers.

#### BEYOND THE RIDGE

Out from Wanting, inside the Frostline, the Unfed live in hamlets and steadings of between a dozen and a few hundred people, each a cold grey cluster of houses around a bare patch of ground where, in any other land, there would be a green. They live on what the Measure-Bearers carry out to them, and on what they can trade at the Fourth-Day market, and on nothing else. Beyond the Frostline, in Orrum's country, there are no Unfed settlements at all, only the stations of those whose work takes them there.

#### BRINDLE CROSS

The crossing point where the Wanting road meets the Rim, already described in the core book: toll-house, stockade, weighing-shed, Marshal Keep Aldane's garrison of sixty, and the Brimming Cup on the Rim side. At ground level it is the noisiest place an Unfed child will ever see: Company wagons, drovers swearing in six accents, oxen bawling, the clatter of scales, the Brimming Cup's kitchen door banging open and shut and letting out gusts of frying. Unfed clerks in grey stand at the weighing-shed with their noses plugged and sign for sacks they do not open.

The garrison's huts stand on the Fast side, behind a ditch, and they are cold, because Aldane will not have a fire in them. The pilgrim camp has grown up along the Rim side of the ditch since 640: tents, lean-tos, carts, and some three hundred Fatlanders sitting in the mud, waiting to be allowed through, and singing.

*Custom:* the eight-year-olds of Wanting are brought here once to watch Rim folk eat through the Brimming Cup's window. Afterward they are made to say the Decline at the window, three

times, while the diners watch them back. *Danger*: everything at the Cross is for sale, including people, and the pilgrims are now so many that the garrison cannot watch the ditch at night.

**TALLY-CLERK SPARE ORME, PANTRY WEAHER AT THE CROSS** Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Has signed for every sack that has come through Brindle Cross in nine years, and knows to the bushel how much lighter the autumn deliveries were; has written it down twice, and both pages have gone missing from his ledger.

### AVERY STEADING

A hamlet of a hundred and forty souls, the furthest north-east of any Unfed settlement, at the end of a stony track two days' walk from Wanting, on a bleak shoulder of upland where the Rim's winter bites hard. Its houses are older than Wanting, built by families who would not move all the way in, and the Avery family has held its stand there for four hundred years. It is a village of old people. Most of its young have gone to Wanting or the Reckoners; there are nine children. It is the furthest from the Pantry, the oldest, and the one with the fewest children, which is to say that it is exactly the kind of village Mother Stint Avery has put on her winter list.

It smells of peat they are not allowed to burn, sheep-wool caught on the thorns, and the cold. It sounds like wind, which is rare in the Fast and precious, and the old people of Avery Steading sit in it with their faces turned up, because wind means the god is far away. They trade nothing. They knit. Avery Steading greys are the warmest in the Fast, and the village sends them down to the Fourth-Day market in bales.

*Custom*: the steading keeps a "letter to the Keeper", a long cloth onto which every household stitches one line each Lack, telling the Pantry how they are. It is sent down with the Measure-Bearer. Mother Stint Avery, who was born here, reads it every year, and has never answered it. *Danger*: the Measure-Bearer's road is long, and in Lack the snow cuts the steading off for weeks at a time. This winter, when the snow comes, the Bearer will not set out.

**GRANDAM BARE AVERY, THE STEADING'S ELDEST** Threat 2 · Flesh 8 · Guard 9 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Ninety-four, Stint Avery's great-aunt, still knitting; has had a dream three nights running in which Stint, as a girl of nine, stands at the steading stone with a basket and walks past.

### THINWICK

A hamlet of sixty people two hours' walk south of Wanting, on a chalk stream that the Unfed drink from because it is not offered. It is a poor place even by the Fast's measure: thatched cottages whose thatch nobody can afford to renew, a Rule-stone where the children recite, a single well with a lid chained shut. Abstain Rooke lives here with her mother. So do two families of Reckoners and a retired Tablebreaker who sits by the stream all day mending axe-hafts for the whole district.

Thinwick smells of wet chalk and watercress, which grows in the stream and which nobody may eat, since it grows in the Fast. It sounds like water. The children of Thinwick are the best-behaved in the district, because the hamlet is on the edge of the Frostline, and the warm ground comes up to the bottom of its lane every few weeks and lies there all night like a dog by a door.

*Custom*: every Thinwick window has a sill, and every sill is kept bare. The hamlet's mothers check them at dawn. One has not been checked in a while, because the mother of that house has been working double turns in the Cold Yards since her name was moved to the bottom of the list. *Danger*: the warm ground, and what is on the sill.

**HAFT-MENDER LEAN COYLE, RETIRED AXE** Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (axe 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Broke seventy tables in his day; now mends hafts and watches the children; has seen what the Rooke girl puts on her windowsill, and has not decided what to do about it, because the cake that came back last week smelled like his wife's.

### CORVE HATCH

The ruined village where, in 44 A.G., the family of Abel Corve sat down at their own table. The village was abandoned within a decade of the First Sitting, and it lies now well beyond the Frostline, in the kept country, a quarter-hour from the Long Table road. Its houses are perfect. The Corve house stands in the middle of them with its window bricked up from outside. The family is still at their table, behind the brick. The Hostwatch, who have put an ear to the wall, say that on still nights you can hear a spoon, very slowly, against a plate, about once an hour.

The Corve family's descendants, by a sister who did not sit, live in Wanting and in Hillward, and they make a pilgrimage here once a year, on the anniversary of the sitting, to stand with their backs to the bricked window through a night. It is the only pilgrimage the Unfed make that is not to Hallowboard, and it is a pilgrimage of shame.

*Custom*: every visitor adds a brick. The bricking over the window is now four feet thick and has begun to lean. *Danger*: the village is laid for guests. Every house in Corve Hatch has its table set every night, and every door is open a hand's width, and the voices that call from them are Corve voices, saying, *Cousin, cousin, there's plenty, come and sit with us*.

### BARROWGATE

A cluster of a dozen hard little stone huts at the foot of Hallowboard hill, beside the Barrows, the only Unfed settlement in the heartland, permitted by the Abstinent because someone must keep the Stand-Roll. The Stand-Roll is a ledger of the trench: an account, stretch by stretch and footprint by footprint, of which family is believed to have stood where on the nine days of the Refusal. Unfed who come to swear an oath on the ones who stood come to Barrowgate first, to be told by the Roll-Keepers where their ancestor's footprint is. The Keepers are a hereditary order of eight

families, and they live on a full measure, carried out by Bearers who walk two days each way to bring it.

Barrowgate smells of chalk dust and the long pale grass of the Barrows, which smells, on warm evenings, like hair. It is very quiet. It sounds like the Roll-Keepers reciting the Roll, which takes three days to say aloud and is said once a season. The hill above is always clean.

*Custom:* a swearer walks up the hill barefoot, and down it backward, never turning their back on the stone until they are out of sight of it, and then turns and walks home without looking round. *Danger:* the eighth side. The Roll-Keepers do not keep a record for it, and do not let anyone stand there, and do not say why, and lately they have taken to sleeping in shifts, because on still nights something has been walking around the stone, slowly, and stopping on that side, and standing there, and the chalk in the morning is still untrodden.

**ROLL-KEEPER REFT LAMMAS** Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. Seventy, keeper of the third stretch of the Stand-Roll, who can tell from a footprint in the chalk the weight and age of the person who made it six hundred years ago; she has started finding new footprints, small and bare and fresh, in the old ones.

## SPLINTERHALL

A long turf-roofed lodge and a scatter of huts in a hollow four miles west of Wanting, just inside the Frostline, where the Tablebreaker bands of the eastern Fast make their base. It is the only place in the Fast where axes are made, and the hollow rings all day with the sound of hafts being shaped and heads being ground. A great heap of splinters stands in the middle of the hollow, a hundred feet across and twenty high, made of the broken pieces of every table the eastern bands have smashed for two hundred years. Nobody burns it. The splinters do not rot. Some days the heap is warm.

Splinterhall smells of fresh-cut ash, oil, and the faint baking smell that rises from the splinter-heap. It sounds like grinding and the slap of axe-heads tested on stumps. The Breakers who live here are proud, deafened, half-blind from years of gauze, and very good company.

*Custom:* every new Axe brings a splinter from their first table and throws it on the heap without looking. An Old Breaker's splinter is kept, and set into the lodge wall, with their name. *Danger:* the heap. Anyone who sleeps beside it wakes with crumbs on their lips.

**OLD BREAKER WANE HOLLISTER** Threat 4 · Flesh 15 · Guard 15 · Attack +7 (Barrow-blessed axe 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0. Ran Splinterhall for twenty years and has broken three hundred tables; she has taken to sleeping on the heap, and the bands have noticed that she is gaining weight.

## WAX HALT

A stone post-house at the eastern mouth of the Long Table valley, where the old straight road across the heartland enters between the

beech hills. It is not a village, only a waystation kept by a single family on a Pantry charter, and its purpose is to wax the ears of travellers before they take the Long Table road. The family sells wax and tallow plugs, linen nose-binds, blinders, and rope, and keeps a register of everyone who goes in and everyone who comes out the far end at the West Mouth, nine miles on. The two lists are compared by runner every week. They do not always match.

Wax Halt smells of melted tallow and the faint baking smell that rolls out of the valley mouth on the still air. It sounds, if you take your plugs out, like a distant murmur of eleven thousand people talking happily over dinner.

*Custom:* travellers going in leave something of theirs on the Halt's long shelf (a glove, a knife, a button) and take it back on the way out. The shelf is full of things nobody came back for. *Danger:* the Halt-keepers. The family has kept Wax Halt for six generations and in that time has never once taken out its own ear-plugs, and it shows.

**HALT-KEEPER SOBER PELL** Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1. Has worn wax in his ears since he was six; speaks too loudly; reads lips; has begun to suspect that his wife has been taking her plugs out at night to listen, and that she is smiling.

## SAINTS' ACRE

A sweep of open fields south of Wanting, outside the last hamlet but inside the Frostline, where the Starved Saints sit. The order has no house. Its Abstainers sit in the open on hurdles and in shallow scrapes, wrapped in sacking, spaced well apart so that no one is near enough to offer anyone anything, and the Watchers walk among them, tending the dying and recording last refusals. The field is dotted with low stones. Each marks where an Abstainer sat and stopped.

It smells of cold earth and, faintly, of the pear-drop sweetness of fasting breath, so strong in places that it catches in the throat. It sounds like the Decline, said at every sound, so that a crow landing or a pilgrim's footstep sets off a soft wave of *no, thank you* across the whole field. Pilgrims from Wanting, and lately from the Rim, come to the field's edge to touch the robes of the Saints who have lasted, and are kept back by the Watchers.

*Custom:* families of novices come to the field's edge to plead, and stand at a distance, because to offer food would be an insult. They are allowed to stand as long as they like. Some stand until the end. *Danger:* the field is changing. Sister Nay Corliss has sat here three years. The frost around her hurdle melts each night in a wide ring, and two other Abstainers have moved their hurdles closer to her.

**WATCHER SCARCITY DUNNE** Threat 2 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 0. A tall, hollow-eyed woman of forty who keeps the Book of Last Refusals; she has written two thousand names in it, and has noticed that in the last year, for the first time, the field's dead are not losing weight.

## ▼ROADS AND WAYS

The Fast is the easiest country on the Table to walk and the hardest to cross. The roads of the heartland are old and good: chalk-and-flint drove roads, sunken lanes between laid hedges, causeways over the water-meadows, all six centuries unused and all perfectly kept, the ruts filled, the drains clear, the milestones scrubbed. There are no bandits. There are no beasts; the wolves and foxes of the old heartland starved out in the first century and never came back. The weather never turns. A traveller can walk thirty miles a day on a level, dry, golden road, through a landscape of combed fields and smoking chimneys, and see nobody, and hear nothing but their own feet, and be offered dinner at every house they pass.

The Unfed travel in four ways, and each has its own discipline.

**On foot, in company, roped.** The commonest. Unfed never travel alone outside the Frostline if they can help it. A party walks in single file with a rope running through every belt, so that no one can step out of line toward a light without pulling the others, and the last walker in the file carries the axe. At night the party sleeps in the open, back to back, the rope knotted round every wrist, with one watcher awake to sniff the air. The Unfed call this *walking the string*, and a person who is good company on the road is “good on the string”.

**By ox-cart, by night.** The Crumb-Runners’ way. Oxen are the only animal that will work in the Fast, because oxen always know: they stop dead when the warm ground is ahead, and no goad will move them, and a Runner who trusts his oxen lives. Horses and mules go mad in the smell within a day and bolt toward it. Runners travel at night because the lights of the laid tables can be seen at night, and avoided, whereas by day a table in a farmhouse kitchen looks like nothing at all until you are at the door.

**By warm ground.** The Hostwatch’s way, and nobody else’s. A Tracker walks the warm path the god has left across the fields the night before, a mile behind where it is now, measuring and pinning. It is the fastest way to cross the heartland, because the god walks straight, and the most dangerous, because the god sometimes stops.

**By the Stoopway.** Nobody’s way. The old pilgrim road from Hallowboard to the eastern border, along which Orrum walked on the tenth morning, is the most direct road in the Fast and the Unfed do not walk it, ever. Children dare one another to touch the warm patches worn into the undersides of its lintels. Reckoners in a hurry have been known to take it. They have also been known not to come out.

| ROUTE                                   | DAYS ON FOOT         | WHO USES IT                              | THE DANGER                                                |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Wanting to Brindle Cross                | Half a day           | Everyone                                 | Poachers at the Cross; pilgrims in the ditch              |
| Wanting to Avery Steading               | 2                    | Measure-Bearers                          | Snow in Lack; the long empty upland; no one comes to help |
| Wanting to Splinterhall                 | Half a day           | Tablebreakers                            | The Frostline moves; Splinterhall is sometimes outside it |
| Wanting to Saints’ Acre                 | Quarter-day          | Pilgrims, kin of novices                 | Warm ground in the south fields on still nights           |
| Brindle Cross to Wax Halt               | 3                    | Runners, Reckoners                       | The old Lammas farms; tables on the road itself           |
| The Long Table road, Halt to West Mouth | Half a day (9 miles) | Runners crossing west                    | The Seated call by name; the empty chair moves            |
| Wax Halt to Barrowgate                  | 2                    | Oath-swearers, Bearers                   | Corve Hatch is a quarter-hour off the road and it calls   |
| Barrowgate to Hallowboard               | Quarter-day          | Swearers, the Abstinent on Tablenight    | The eighth side; something walks round the stone          |
| West Mouth to the Rim (west)            | 4                    | Runners, Reckoners bound for Brinehollow | Ash Mill; Fast-flour smugglers; Brinehollow poachers      |
| Wanting to the Empty Chair              | Quarter-day          | The Verger; the curious                  | The temple is laid every night; the Verger is kind        |
| The Stoopway, end to end                | 3                    | Nobody                                   | Every lintel is warm; the road remembers who walked it    |
| The Rim Road (round the Fast)           | 60 to 90             | Company wagons, Envoy Lowell             | Tables at crossroads since 640; the god looks in at inns  |

## RULES OF THE ROAD

For travel in the Fast, use the core rules for journeys, with these changes. **Every day** spent outside the Frostline, each traveller faces one Invitation check, chosen by the GM from the Fast chapter's table (most days, the Routine 10 smell of baking; near a laid house, Hard 14). A party walking the string may let its best Caul + Resolve roll stand for one other member each day. **Every night** outside the Frostline, roll 1d6: on a 1, a table is laid within sight of the camp, and the watcher must make an Invitation check at Hard 14 to wake the others rather than walk to it. **Oxen** give a party +2 to notice warm ground ahead (Eye + Search, Routine 10). **Horses and mules** must be blindfolded and hobbled in the Fast, or they bolt toward the nearest table on any roll of 1 on a d6 each day. **Food carried in** is safe; **food found** is never safe, whatever it looks like. Water from running streams is safe; water from a drawn bucket is not.

## ▼ BREAD AND COIN

The Fast has no economy in the sense other lands mean it. It produces nothing. It grows nothing. It exports nothing but its own people, sometimes on the end of a knife and sometimes in a poacher's net. Everything that keeps the Unfed alive comes in through Brindle Cross on credit, is pooled in the Pantry, and goes out again by the list. What passes for an economy is a system of measures, chits, favours, and quiet, desperate trading in the margins, and the whole of it rests on one question: whose name is read tonight.

### THE MEASURE

The unit of everything in the Fast is the **Pantry measure**: half an oatcake and a thumb of fat or cheese per adult per day, with pease or salt fish twice a week. It is half a ration in the core rules' sense, and an Unfed who lives on it neither gains nor loses Pangs. A **full measure** is a whole ration, and goes to hard labourers, Reckoners on campaign, Tablebreakers, Hostwatch in the field, and Measure-Bearers on carrying days. Children under twelve get a three-quarter measure. The Abstinents and their clerks get exactly what everyone else gets, and are watched to make sure of it.

The measure is issued against a **ration chit**: a square of unbleached cloth stamped by the Pantry with a single empty bowl. Chits are issued by household, by name, by list. They cannot lawfully be sold, given, or traded, and they are sold, given, and traded constantly. A chit is worth about one lack to a Crumb-

Runner in Plenty, and three in Lack. A chit with a struck name on it is worth nothing at the Pantry window and a great deal at Abide Kettering's crossroads, where poachers buy them to find out who has been omitted.

### THE FOURTH-DAY MARKET

On the fourth day of each week, a few households set out on cloths, around Nay-Saying Hobb's shop at the top of the Brindle road, whatever they can bear to part with: a knitted grey, a length of rope, a carved bone, a spare wax tin. There are no prices. Everything is valued in measures, and every trade is declined three times by both parties and struck in silence on the fourth asking. It is the only market in the Fast, and it sounds like a great many polite refusals.

### WORK AND WAGES

Nobody in the Fast is paid in coin. The Unfed will not touch bone money, because it is cut from Godeaters and cured in Godeater lungs. Work is paid in measure: the right to draw a full measure instead of a half on the days you work. Crumb-Runners, who deal with the Rim, are paid partly in lacks by the Company and partly in food by the Pantry, and are the only Unfed who ever hold coin, which is one more reason they are spat on. For the GM's convenience, the table below gives each job's pay in its lack-equivalent per day.

| WORK              | PAID IN                       | LACK-WORTH PER DAY | NOTES                                                |
|-------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Cold Yard sweeper | Half measure                  | 0.5                | The poorest work; no extra measure                   |
| Measure-Bearer    | Full measure on carrying days | 1                  | A girl's or boy's first post; walking, never sitting |
| Pantry clerk      | Full measure                  | 1                  | Envied; you stand near the grain                     |



| WORK                     | PAID IN                                   | LACK-WORTH PER DAY | NOTES                               |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Rope-maker, haft-mender  | Full measure                              | 1                  | Skilled; paid by the Breakers       |
| Tablebreaker on hunt     | Full measure, and first pick of splinters | 1.5                | Splinters sell on the Rim as relics |
| Hostwatch Tracker        | Full measure, rope and lamps              | 1.5                | Weeks in the field at a time        |
| Brindle Cross spearman   | Full measure                              | 1                  | The Abstinent pay no other soldiers |
| Reckoner Carrier on raid | Full measure and road food                | 2                  | And whatever the road costs you     |
| Crumb-Runner, Back       | 1 lack per 10 lb carried, in food         | 2 to 4             | Paid by weight; spat on by everyone |
| Crumb-Runner, Drover     | Company lacks plus food                   | 4 to 8             | Holds coin; despised for it         |
| Grain-Lord               | Lacks, food, and the Abstinent's need     | 20 or more         | There are three; everyone owes them |

## WHAT THINGS COST IN THE FAST

Inside the Fast nothing is sold for money. On the Rim side of Brindle Cross, and in the back rooms of the Spit, almost everything

is. The prices below are what an Unfed or an outsider pays, in lacks or in measures, at the Cross or in the Spit.

| THING                                   | PRICE                              | WHERE                         | NOTES                                             |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| A ration chit                           | 1 lack (Plenty) to 3 (Lack)        | The Spit, the Cross           | Illegal; a struck chit is worth more to a poacher |
| A day's Rim food, carried in            | 2 lacks                            | Any Runner                    | Twice the Rim price, and the Runner says so       |
| A wax tin (ear and nose plugs)          | 2 crumbs, or a quarter-measure     | Nay-Saying Hobb's shop        | Tallow-and-beeswax; lasts a month                 |
| A household axe                         | 8 lacks, or a month's half-measure | Splinterhall                  | Hangs by the door; for Tablenight only            |
| A belled rope (fifty feet)              | 3 lacks                            | Pinners' Yard, Hobb's shop    | For walking the string                            |
| Unfed greys (a full suit)               | 2 lacks                            | Hobb's shop                   | Avery Steading wool is warmest                    |
| A Rim egg                               | 1 lack                             | The Spit                      | Will not hatch; will not even go bad              |
| A pinch of salt                         | 1 crumb                            | The Spit                      | Salt is safe; the god does not offer salt         |
| A splinter of a broken table            | 5 to 40 lacks                      | Sold on the Rim, never inside | Smells of bread; sold as a cure for hunger        |
| A pound of Fast-flour from Ash Mill     | 30 lacks on the Rim                | The Brimming Cup, back door   | Unlawful in the Fast; see Ash Mill                |
| An Orrum crumb                          | 150 lacks                          | Rim relic-dealers             | See the Rim Market chapter                        |
| A Breaker's escort across the heartland | A measure a day for each Breaker   | Splinterhall                  | They will not take coin                           |
| Having your name read                   | Not for sale                       | The Pantry                    | Everyone has tried                                |

## TAXES AND DUES

There are no taxes in the Fast, because there is nothing to tax. There are dues. Every household on the list owes the Pantry one chit a day, which is to say that the Pantry gives you the chit and then takes it back. Every Hillward family owes the Abstinent one member for one year as a Measure-Bearer or a clerk. Every household owes an axe for Tablenight and a body for the Standing, and every household owes the Hostwatch any report of warm ground within a day. Failure to pay any of these dues is punished in the only way the Fast punishes anything: a cut in the measure.

The real tax is paid abroad. The Rim Road Company sells the Fast its grain on credit, under a contract sworn in Oathen before

Jessamy Quill, and the debt is now so old and so large that nobody in the Fast but the Chair of the Abstinent knows its sum. It is paid, in part, in silver: the old temple plate of Orrum, the pewter and silver and linen of the heartland's six hundred temples, carried out of the empty country by Pantry-chartered Gleaners and sold to the Company by weight. The temples are almost stripped. The Pantry has begun, quietly, to send Gleaners into the empty farmhouses for their spoons.

## WHO IS RICH

Nobody in the Fast is rich, and three people in the Fast are rich. The **Grain-Lords**, the three Crumb-Runner road-masters who control the drove roads from the Rim (Sparing Doyle of the Spit, Old Heft Barrow of the north road, and a woman known only as the Widow

Cask who controls the long western route by Ash Mill), each command dozens of carts, hundreds of Backs, and the gratitude of nobody. They eat. They eat on the road, in Rim inns, sitting down, and everyone knows it, and the Abstinents must bargain with them every season, because if a Grain-Lord stops running, a third of the Fast starves.

The other kind of rich in the Fast is the kind that cannot be spent: **standing**. A Hillward family whose ancestor’s footprint is clearly marked on the Stand-Roll is richer, in the Fast’s own reckoning, than any Grain-Lord, and can marry its children into any house. Standing can be lost (a member seen enjoying food, a member who accepts, a member who emigrates by taking a Rim name) and it can never be bought. Wont Bellamy has a great deal of it.

## ▼ LAW AND THE KNIFE

The Fast has one law, the Five Rules, and one punishment, the measure. It has no judges, no prisons, no gallows, no fines and no executioners, because each of those would require someone to do something to someone, and the Unfed have arranged their whole society so that nobody has to. The Pantry simply does not give. That is the beauty of it, the Abstinents say, and the horror of it, says everyone who has ever stood in Pantry Close and not heard their name.

### WHO ENFORCES

There are no constables in the Fast. Order is kept by four kinds of people, none of whom would call themselves enforcers.

- ◆ **The Listers**, Pantry officials of the third rank, who propose names to be added to and struck from the list. They are not

police. They are clerks. They listen. A Lister’s ear is the closest thing in the Fast to a court.

- ◆ **The Yard-Wardens**, who walk the Cold Yards at mealtimes with staves and slates and mark hoarders, mouth-thieves, feeders and anyone seen enjoying a meal. They have no power but the slate.
- ◆ **Marshal Keep Aldane’s spearmen** at Brindle Cross, the only armed force the Abstinents maintain, who are permitted to kill poachers and are forbidden to touch an Unfed.
- ◆ **Families**, who are given the ration of whoever wronged them, and who keep the oaths on the dead, and who decide, every Tablenight, who stands beside whom.

### CRIMES AND PUNISHMENTS

| CRIME                                    | HOW IT IS KNOWN                                    | PUNISHMENT                                                        |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hoarding (keeping back part of a ration) | A Yard-warden’s slate; a neighbour’s word          | A cut to half-measure for a month                                 |
| Mouth-theft (stealing a ration)          | The victim stands in the Close and names the thief | The thief’s measure goes to the victim for a season               |
| Feeding (giving your food to another)    | Seen, or confessed                                 | Both lose a measure for a week; the receiver for longer           |
| Being seen to enjoy a meal               | The Yards, the street, a child’s tongue            | A day without measure, and the family’s standing questioned       |
| Selling a chit                           | Rarely proven                                      | The seller is struck from the list for a season                   |
| Lighting a fire indoors                  | Smoke, smell, the warmth of a wall                 | The house is broken open and the hearth bricked by the neighbours |
| Taking a Rim name                        | Declared, or discovered                            | Considered emigrated; struck, and spoken of in the past tense     |
| Murder                                   | The family brings the body to the Close            | The victim’s family receives the killer’s ration for a year       |
| Selling an Unfed to poachers             | Proof is almost never had                          | Omission, and the family’s name struck from the Stand-Roll        |
| Breaking an oath on the ones who stood   | Known to the family                                | No one stands beside you on Tablenight                            |
| Saying “Come in”                         | Heard                                              | Never punished; no one will cross your threshold again            |
| Accepting                                | Seen                                               | No punishment. You are already gone.                              |

The table has a pattern, and Unfed children learn it without being told. Every punishment is a portion withheld. The worst crimes have no punishment at all, because the criminal has already been

taken out of the world of portions: the one who says *Come in* has made themselves a host, and the one who accepts has made themselves a guest, and the Fast does not deal with either.

## THE STANDING: HOW A TRIAL WORKS

When an accusation is serious enough that a Lister will not decide it alone (mouth-theft between Hillward families, a murder, a charge of selling a neighbour), it is brought to the Abstinent at a **Standing**. A Standing is held on the top floor of the Pantry, in the bare stone room where the council meets around the empty space where a table would be.

The accused stands in the empty space. That is the whole of the ordeal, and it is enough: to stand for hours on the one spot of floor in the Fast where every Unfed has been taught never to stand, while the elders stand around the walls, is a torment, and some of the accused confess within the hour simply to be allowed to step out of it. The accuser stands at the door, with their back to the room. The elders ask questions. The accused answers. The accuser answers. Nobody sits, nobody drinks, and nobody may leave until it is done, which in Wont Bellamy's time on the council has meant Standings of up to two days, ended when an elder fainted.

There is no verdict. At the end, the Chair of the Abstinent says, "We have heard," and the elders file out. That evening, the list is read in Pantry Close. If the accused's name is on it, they were found innocent. If the victim's family's measure has been raised, they were found guilty. Nobody is told. Everyone knows.

## ▼ THE FAITHFUL

The Unfed say they have no religion, because they refused their god. This is untrue in every way that matters. The Fast is the most religious country on the Table. Its whole life is a rite, performed every day by every person, of refusing one particular god, and the rite has its doctrines, its holy places, its calendar, its saints, its heretics and its prayers, all of them shaped around an absence the way the floor of an Unfed house is worn smooth around the place where a table is not.

## THE THREE DOCTRINES IN THE FAST

Every land argues about why the gods held still. The Fast argues about it more bitterly than any, because its god is still here to ask, and has never answered.

**The Theft**, in the Fast, is the Keepers' doctrine and the Abstinent's, and it is preached with satisfaction. The others murdered their gods; the regrowth is justice; the Unfed did not murder, and are therefore the only people on the Table who are not being punished. The Lack that never ended in the Fast is not a punishment but a *wage*: the price of cleanness, paid daily. The Theft is taught in every Rule-house, and the version Unfed children learn

## RUNNING A STANDING

A Standing is a social endurance contest. Each hour, the accused rolls Gut + Endure against Hard 14 (Grim 18 if Hollow or worse) to remain standing in the empty space; each failure costs 1 Fray and a -1 to their next Tongue roll. The accuser rolls Caul + Resolve each hour at Routine 10 to keep their back to the room. Arguments are made with Tongue + Persuade or Clause against the elders' collective Resolve (Hard 14, Grim 18 for Hillward elders). A character who steps out of the empty space before the Chair speaks has confessed. Forbear Wend has never once been seen to tire at a Standing. He is held up by two boys the whole time.

## THE LIST AS LAW

Every Unfed understands, and none will say aloud, that the list is the law. The Five Rules keep the god out. The list keeps everyone else in line. A name can be struck for a crime, but a name can also be struck for nothing; because the grain is short, because a village is far, because someone on the council has a long memory. There is no appeal but to stand in the Close and ask. The Abstinent say that this is mercy, because it leaves no blood. Withy Gaunt, who keeps the Lean House, keeps a second column in her book beside the names of the omitted, and in it she writes *why*, when she can find out. Most of the entries are blank.

ends with the line *They laughed at the table; now the table is laughing at them*.

**The Gift** is the Hostwatch's doctrine, though they would not call it one, and Verger Osmond's. Orrum offered itself out of love. It is offering still. The tables are not traps but the same gift, held out for six hundred years by a host whose guests will not come in. The Gift is not illegal in the Fast, because the Abstinent have never needed to make it so; it is simply *soft*, and softness is suspect, and Unfed who preach it find that the Listers have begun to hear their names less clearly.

**The Bait** is Wont Bellamy's doctrine, and the most dangerous in the Fast, because the Unfed have a version of it that no other land has. Elsewhere the Bait says the gods wanted to be eaten so that they could grow back. In the Fast it is whispered that Orrum wanted to be eaten *and still does*, and that the Unfed, by refusing, have kept a whole god whole, hungry and unhoused in the middle of the world, and that this is the worst thing anyone has ever done. Bellamy's circle draws the obvious conclusion. Meek Garrity's papers have drawn a worse one, and are passed house to house at night.



SHRINES OF THE FAST

The Unfed have no temples (they pulled them down in 97 A.G., save one), and they would be offended by the word shrine. Nonetheless:

- ◇ **The bricked hearth.** Every Unfed house has one: the place in the wall where an old fireplace was filled with brick, or, in newer houses, a patch of brick set into the wall for no reason but to be checked. Every morning and every night, every member of the household lays a bare palm flat on it. If it is cold, they say *cold*, under the breath. That is the commonest prayer in the Fast.
- ◇ **The stand-stone.** In Hillward and the older stands, a chip of chalk from the family’s stretch of the trench at Hallowboard, set into the floor by the door, on which each member places a bare foot before going out.
- ◇ **The Barrows.** The only true holy ground of the Fast, where the dead of the Refusal lie nine and ten deep. Oaths are sworn there, and in the trench above, standing in an ancestor’s footprint.

RITES

**The Morning Palm.** A palm on the cold brick, the word *cold*. Every day.

**The Count.** At dusk, and whenever the wind goes sweet, the household stands at the door and counts its members through it. In Bell Ward, with bells.

**The Decline at the Measure.** Before the day’s measure is eaten, it is held in the open hand and refused, three times, under the breath, and eaten on the fourth. A child who stumbles over the Five Rules before the Decline does not eat that day.

HOLY DAYS

| DAY           | WHEN                       | WHAT IS DONE                                                                                                           |
|---------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Nine Days | The last nine days of Lack | Each household eats a quarter-measure less each day, to remember the hill                                              |
| The Rising    | The tenth day              | The day Orrum got up; nobody speaks above a whisper, and nobody looks west                                             |
| The Burying   | First day of Grace         | Families walk to the Barrows; the grass is cut, once, with knives                                                      |
| Short Night   | Mid-Carving                | The anniversary of the first list of 511; the names of the omitted of every winter are read in Pantry Close, all night |
| Corve Night   | The 3rd of Plenty          | The Corve kin stand at the bricked window at Corve Hatch; the rest of the Fast stays indoors                           |
| Tablenight    | The longest night of Lack  | All stand outdoors, backs to every door, holding hands, from dusk to dawn; at dawn, the Breaking                       |

THE LONG DECLINE

The only hymn the Unfed sing is sung at the Laying-Down and on Tablenight, unaccompanied, very low, almost on one note, by people who do not have the breath to sing. Its words are older than Wanting. It has eight verses. The Unfed sing seven.

*We stood on the hill in the snow, and it was laid for us.*

*No, thank you.*  
*We stood on the hill, and the ones in front lay down, and we stood on them.*  
*No, thank you.*  
*The god lay on the stone with its throat bare, and smiled, and said, you must be starved.*  
*No, thank you.*

*We were starved. We said it with our mouths full of nothing.*

*No, thank you.*

*The god wept, and the snow went soft, and some of us drank it.*

*No, thank you.*

*On the tenth morning it got down from the stone and bowed to us.*

*No, thank you.*

*It is still laying the table. It is still asking. We are still here.*

*No, thank you.*

The eighth verse is not sung. Most Unfed do not know it exists. The Roll-Keepers of Barrowgate know it, and will recite it only to one another, on Tablenight, with their backs to the stone; and a Hostwatch Cartographer who overheard it once wrote down only that it is the shortest verse, and that it does not end with the Decline, and that it begins *And then there was one more*.

## ▼ VOICES OF THE LAND

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### OVERHEARD IN WANTING

"I dig them face down. That way when they try to sit up, they sit up into the dirt. Somebody's got to think of these things." — Abide Kettering's cart-hand, at the Bury Gate

"Mam says if you smell custard you ring the bell. I smelled custard today and I rang it and Mam was cross because it was only the Yards. I'm not sorry." — a girl of seven, Bell Ward

"You lot spit at me in the street and then you eat what I bring. That's fine. I'd spit at me too. Just spit after." — a Crumb-Runner of the Spit

"It's not hunger after the first month. It's a sort of brightness. You can see everything. You can see the god walking. You can see it waiting for you." — a Novice of the Starved Saints

"I don't hate them. The tables. I break them because somebody's got to. You'd be surprised how many of us cry while we do it." — a Tablebreaker's Rope-Holder at Splinterhall

"The list is fair. It is fair. It is fair. My name was on it, wasn't it? So it's fair." — a woman leaving Pantry Close

"In Lack we kiss each other's ribs. Don't make that face. It's the only thing we have that's warm." — a young wife of Hillward, to a Rim visitor

"The first night on the Rim, in a soft bed, I lay awake and cried because I could feel my own heart beating so slow. Their hearts are so loud. You can hear them through the walls." — a Reckoner Knife, home from Sated

"He was on the list. He was on the list. He just stopped coming to the Line. Nobody stopped him because nobody was allowed to offer." — a widow of the Lean End

"They're happy. That's what you can't forgive them. They're the only happy people in the Fast." — a Wax Halt keeper, of the Seated

"Count the chairs, she said. So I counted them, and there was one more than us, and it was pushed in. Then I stopped counting." — a farm girl of Thinwick

"Before you sit down at any table, anywhere, in any land, count the places. If there's one too many, get up." — what Spare Tolland tells new Trackers

"I pray to it. Don't tell. Not to eat. Just to say I'm sorry it's alone." — a Hostwatch Pin-Setter

"The children here never play house. Do you know what that does to a child? They play at standing. They stand against the wall in rows for hours." — Dr. Mercy Thrane, in a letter to a Vigil colleague

"Hunger is honest. Everything else lies." — a Starved Saint, the last words in the Book of Last Refusals for 639

## ▼ HOW POWER MOVES

Power in the Fast does not look like power anywhere else. Nobody in the Fast has an army, a fortune, a palace or a throne. Power in the Fast is the ability to decide who eats, and everything else is arranged around that: the grain that comes in, the names that go out, the god

that waits outside, and the people beyond the Rim who would buy any Unfed for a noble's ransom. Draw it as a ring with a hole in the middle, like the Table itself: the Pantry at the centre, the Rim around the edge, and the god walking in the empty space between.

| POWER-HOLDER                      | CONTROLS                                                  | FEARS                                               | OWES                                              |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Elder Forbear Wend, Chair         | The last key; the Company contract; the striking of names | Dying before the winter list is signed              | The Company, and the eleven he prays for          |
| Mother Stint Avery, Keeper        | The scales, the stores, the list as drafted               | Delay; the arithmetic; her own steadiness           | Nobody, which is her pride                        |
| Wont Bellamy, Elder               | Hillward votes; letters from the Rim                      | Scant Hollis; being seen fat                        | The Second Table, for a debt he has eaten         |
| Scant Hollis, Reckoner-Captain    | The Knives; the season's lines; Knife Row                 | Bedside hunger; standing still by a cradle          | Scarce Odell, for every name                      |
| The three Grain-Lords             | The drove roads; a third of the Fast's food               | The Company cutting them out; poachers              | The Company, in lacks                             |
| Factor Joss Mardle (Company)      | The grain contract at Brindle Cross                       | His own shame; the "first refusal" clause           | The Company, in an Oathen-sworn body              |
| The Hostwatch (Warden of the Map) | The Great Map; where the god is                           | The extra chair; the restricted ledgers getting out | The Chair, to whom they report                    |
| Marshal Keep Aldane               | Brindle Cross; sixty spears                               | The pilgrims; his own doubt                         | The Abstinents, for his measure                   |
| The Roll-Keepers of Barrowgate    | The Stand-Roll; who stood where                           | The eighth side                                     | Nothing; they are owed                            |
| Orrum, the Host                   | Every table, every oven, every seed that rots             | Nothing anyone can name                             | It has been waiting six hundred years to be asked |

## THE LINES OF PULL

**The Pantry over everyone.** Every Unfed eats by the list. Every Lister, clerk and Bearer can be made or broken by the Keeper's scales and the Chair's pen. This is the first and last fact of Fast politics.

**The Company over the Pantry.** The Pantry eats on credit. The Company can short it at will, as it did in 511 and as it has done this autumn, and the Abstinents cannot so much as complain, because only the Chair has read the contract, and the Chair will not say what is in it.

**The Reckoners beside the Abstinents.** The Abstinents have never approved a raid and never condemned one. Every Knife draws a full measure. Scant Hollis stands at the Abstinents' door, unofficially, and the Abstinents have never asked her to leave, because the Reckoners are the only proof the Fast has that refusing is something you can *do*, and because nobody on the council wants to find out what nine hundred hungry Knives would do if their measure were cut.

**Bellamy against the centre.** Wont Bellamy is the only elder with friends beyond the Rim, and the only one who has ever argued, out

loud, in the bare room, that the Unfed should eat. He cannot carry the council. He does not need to. He needs only one more bad winter, and Stint Avery's arithmetic has given him one.

**The god under everything.** None of the Fast's power-holders controls Orrum, and all of them are shaped by it: the Pantry exists so that no one need accept; the list exists because there is not enough; the Reckoners exist because refusing was not enough; the Hostwatch exist because someone must know where it is. If Orrum stopped laying tables tomorrow, every institution in the Fast would lose its reason. The Unfed do not think about this. The Hostwatch think about it all the time.

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## THE SHAPE OF THE WINTER

This winter, four forces are moving toward one point. The Pantry has four months of grain for six. The Company shorted the autumn deliveries and holds a clause on the Unfed dead. The pilgrims at Brindle Cross number in the hundreds and are coming in anyway. And Orrum's tables are now laid with one more place than there are guests. When the snow closes the road to Avery Steading, Stint Avery's list will be read, Forbear Wend will have signed it or died, Wont Bellamy will make his proposal to the council, and Scant Hollis will be somewhere beyond the Rim with a knife. GMs: every character in the following dossiers stands somewhere on this map. Ask, for each, what they will do on the night the list is read.

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# THE PEOPLE OF THE FAST

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*Count your chairs.*

– WANTING PROVERB

The dossiers below take the cast of the core book’s chapter and go deeper. Stat blocks use the Fast’s own rules: the Unfed have **Cut 0**, cannot Partake, and track **Want** and **Pangs** instead of Hunger and Regrowth; their “Gifts” are not godsign but practice, reputation

and the strange edges that six centuries of refusal have worn into a people. Where a character resists Orrum, use the **Invitation check** (Caul + Resolve against the offer’s Difficulty, plus their Pangs).

# ELDER FORBEAR WEND

## Chair of the Abstinent

*“I have not struck a name. I have only not written one. You will find there is a great deal of difference, when you are the one praying.”*

– FORBEAR WEND, TO A NEW LISTER, ON THE NIGHT OF HER APPOINTMENT

| ELDER FORBEAR WEND – CHAIR OF THE ABSTINENT |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                  | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 8 · Pangs 6 (Gaunt)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| AGE & STATION                               | 86; Chair of the Abstinent since 619; of Hillward, of the second stretch of the trench                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING                          | Clausewright (the Pantry’s ledgers and the Company contract), Standing 5 in the Abstinent — Chair                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                                  | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                      | Resolve 5, Clause 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Endure 3, Lore 3, Rites 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| BODY                                        | Flesh 12 (10 at Gaunt) · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                                     | none worth the name; his two bearers carry cudgels +4 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                                       | The List (any Unfed whose name he strikes loses their ration; this is not magic, and is worse). The Old No (spends Want as a PC does; has never failed an Invitation check in eighty-six years). The Chair’s Silence (at a Standing, opponents arguing against him roll at –2, because nobody wants to make an old man stand longer). |
| WANTS                                       | To sign the winter list before he dies. To be forgiven by someone who has the standing to forgive.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                                      | No Thank You; Old Grief; Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                                | The Count (he counts the names of the dead each night; the number is always one short, and he does not know whose name is missing)                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                                     | the Pantry’s last key; the Company contract (read once); the Ledger of Eleven; a child’s knitted mitten; his stand-stone; a ration-cloth folded in eight                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                                       | 1 (to watch him read the list); 3 (to hear him pray the eleven)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

### WHO THEY ARE

He weighs, by Mother Stint Avery’s scales, sixty-one pounds. He is carried everywhere in a plain ash chair with long poles, by two boys of the Measure-Bearers who are changed every season so that none of them grows attached. His knees are under a grey blanket of Avery Steading wool. His hands rest on the iron key that hangs at his breast, and they are so thin that the key looks heavy on them, like a stone on a leaf. His skull is a lamp-shade of yellowed skin, translucent at the temples, the veins showing blue. His eyes are perfectly clear.

His voice is soft and dry and absolutely distinct. He never raises it; he does not have the breath. He speaks in short sentences and waits between them, and the waiting is part of the sentence. He smells of camphor, old paper, and the pear-drop sourness of a body that has been eating itself for eighty years. When he is set down, the boys must lift him to his feet and hold him there, one under each arm, because the Chair of the Abstinent does not sit in council, and

they stand like that for hours, and the boys’ arms shake and his never do.

### THEIR STORY

Forbear Wend was born in 555 in Hillward, to a family that has held the second stretch of the trench since the Stand-Roll began. He was named on the day he refused his mother’s breast, at five months, which Hillward still tells as a story about his promise. He was a Measure-Bearer at twelve, a clerk at twenty, a Lister at thirty, and married at thirty-one to a quiet woman named Keep Hollin, who gave him one daughter, Lenten, in 580.

The Fast calls every winter of choosing a *short*, after the Great Short of 511, and in 589 there was a short: a Company dispute, a bad road, three months of half-measures for half the town. Wend was a Lister. It was not his list. The Keeper of that year drew it, and Lenten’s name was not on it, because she had been entered in the ledgers under her mother’s family after Keep Hollin died, and the Keeper missed the line. Wend saw the omission on the second day. He said nothing, because a Lister who adds his own child’s name to

a list is a Lister who will never be Chair, and because the list is the list. He carried the measures to the hamlets that week. He carried them past his own door. Lenten was nine. She lasted a month. He counts her among his eleven, though she was not his, because she is the one he could have saved by speaking.

He was elected Chair in 619, at sixty-four. On the night of his election he read the Company contract, alone, in the top room of the Pantry. He has not slept a night through since. In twenty-two years as Chair he has struck ten names with his own pen, all in hard winters, all after praying, and he keeps them in a small ledger of his own with Lenten's name at the head.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Wend is the Fast. He holds the last of the Pantry's three keys and signs every list before it is read. He chairs every Standing. He alone has read the contract under which the Company feeds the Fast. The other elders defer to him not because he is powerful but because he is so evidently suffering in the job, and suffering, in the Fast, is authority.

His routine never varies. He is carried down Hillward Row at dawn, while the street stands against the walls. He spends the morning in the top room, standing, reading the ledgers aloud to a clerk who checks them. At noon he eats his measure, standing, facing the wall, and it takes him an hour because he can only swallow a little at a time. In the afternoon he hears Listers and petitioners. At dusk he is carried to the iron door to hear the list read. At night he stands, held up, and prays the eleven names, one by one, and after each he says the Decline, and that takes him until midnight.

His power has one limit, and it is his body. He is dying, slowly, of the same thing everyone in the Fast is dying of, and everyone knows that when he dies the Chair will pass to whoever the council chooses, and that the council is split.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The last key** — iron, as long as his hand, on a cord of plaited ration-cloth. One of three to the Pantry door, and the only one that opens the inner store and the box where the contract is kept.
- ◇ **The Company contract** — twelve leaves of Oathen vellum, sworn before Jessamy Quill, in a locked box in the top room. He has read it once. He could recite it.
- ◇ **The Ledger of Eleven** — a palm-sized book of grey paper, in which he has written eleven names, each with the date and a single line about the person. Lenten's line says *she liked to be carried*.
- ◇ **A child's knitted mitten** — red, which is to say once dyed, which is to say vanity, and worn to threads. He keeps it inside his shirt against the skin. Nobody has seen it.

- ◇ **His stand-stone** — a chip of chalk from the second stretch, which the boys set on the floor for him to touch with a bare foot before he is carried out.
- ◇ **A ration-cloth folded in eight** — his burial cloth. He folds and refolds it each night. He has noticed, lately, that he has been folding it into the shape of a napkin, and does not know where he learned it.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to sign the winter list before he dies, because if he dies first, Stint Avery will sign it, and she will not pray. He wants to be forgiven, and there is no one alive with the standing to do it.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** he knows the Company contract's clause granting it "first refusal" on any Unfed who dies outside the Pantry's care, and he knows what the Company does with bodies. He has said nothing for twenty-two years, because if the Fast knew, it would refuse the grain, and starve to the last child, cleanly.

**A secret he does not know:** Lenten did not die in the Short of 589. She walked west in the last week, toward a light, and sat, and she is at the Long Table, a little over four miles from Wax Halt, fifty-two years at table, and she is nine years old, and she has not grown.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Mother Stint Avery** — his Keeper and his opposite; he trusts her arithmetic and dreads her calm. She has not told him what is on the winter list.
- ◇ **Wont Bellamy** — the elder who will try to take the Chair; Wend knows Bellamy is too well fed and has never said it aloud.
- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — he has never approved a raid and never condemned one, and every night he prays for the lines she ends, which she does not know.
- ◇ **Factor Joss Mardle** — the Company's man; they meet four times a year and never shake hands.
- ◇ **Withy Gaunt** — she sends him the names from the Lean House each week; he copies them into his prayers.
- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — Wend met him once, at the Empty Chair, sixty years ago, and was offered a fourth time, and refused it, and the Steward thanked him.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Wend when they are summoned to the top room of the Pantry to carry a list to an outlying hamlet, unread, sealed. He chooses strangers because strangers will not open it. He wants them to deliver it and come back and tell him the faces of the people who were not on it, because he has started to forget faces, and he needs them for his prayers.

- ◇ **The Sealed List.** The list for Avery Steading is sealed with his own signet, and it is blank. He wants the PCs to watch who comes to the steading stone, and choose.



- ◇ **The Clause.** A PC who reads the contract over his shoulder learns about the first refusal. Wend asks them, very quietly, whether the Fast should be told.
- ◇ **The Mitten.** Hollow Ann Pruett has found a place card at the Long Table with *Lenten Wend* on it in her mother's hand. Someone must decide whether to tell the Chair.

Faced with threat, he does nothing; his bearers are boys. Faced with kindness, he declines three times and, on the fourth, weeps silently and accepts a hand to hold. Faced with the god, he says the Decline, and his voice does not change. If nobody intervenes, he dies on the night of the winter list, standing, after signing it, and the boys hold him up for an hour before anyone notices.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

"He's light as a sack of feathers. Lighter. You'd think it would be easy, carrying him. It's the heaviest thing in Wanting." — a Measure-Bearer boy, one of his carriers

"He prays for every one of them, by name. That's very fine. I would rather he had prayed before." — Withy Gaunt, Matron of the Lean House

"The old man is the only one on the council who's honest. It's the most dangerous thing about him." — Wont Bellamy

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# RECKONER-CAPTAIN SCANT HOLLIS

the Weeder

*“You’re asking if I’m a murderer. I’ve stood in nine houses at night. There were no people in them. There was a god in nine pieces, asleep, and I put it down.”*

– SCANT HOLLIS, TO A CARRIER ON HER FIRST RAID, OUTSIDE SATED

| SCANT HOLLIS – RECKONER-CAPTAIN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                      | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 7 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                   | 44; Reckoner-Captain; of Knife Row                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING              | Reckoner, Standing 4 — Reckoner-Captain (authority to declare a bloodline ended)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                      | Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                          | Blades 5, Stealth 5, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Instinct 3, Intimidate 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| BODY                            | Flesh 15 · Guard 19 · Armor 1 (padded Reckoner greys) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTACKS                         | black-iron long knife +9 (3; Silent, Piercing; +4 damage to unaware targets, +2 vs Cut 3+); bare hands +5 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                           | Bedside Silence (her first attack on a sleeping target is automatically a Grace). Godless Blood (godsign that reads, finds or tastes the blood cannot find hers; Closers, tides and Oathen bindings work on her only through ordinary means). In Their Beds (Reckoner Talent; senses godsign and estimates Cut on Caul + Instinct vs Routine 10). |
| WANTS                           | Every High Cut line on the Table ended before the Seating. Never again to stand still beside a cradle.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| KNACKS                          | Silent Supper; Light Sleeper; Cold Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| DERANGEMENTS                    | none yet; she is two points from a Break and knows it                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CARRIES                         | the black-iron knife; a garrotte of gut; Scarce Odell’s lists; a ration bag; a servant’s apron; nine pebbles                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                           | 2 (to see her work a household, room by room)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is tall for an Unfed woman, and looks taller because there is nothing on her: a frame of knots and cords, the tendons standing out at her wrists like rope, the hair cropped to grey stubble with her own knife. Forty raids’ worth of Rim weather have burned her face to the colour of a saddle. She dresses in undyed, fatless Reckoner greys and soft-soled boots, and she smells of nothing, deliberately: she washes in cold water with no soap and wears no wool that has touched a sheep’s grease.

She speaks rarely and flatly, in a low voice that does not carry, and she listens with her head slightly down, like someone listening at a door. She looks at people the way a farmer looks at a field: what grows here, and should it. Reckoners love her. Everyone else in Wanting steps aside when she walks Knife Row, and she has noticed, and it does not trouble her.

## THEIR STORY

Scant was born in 597 in Thinwick. When she was six, poachers came through the hamlet in the night and took her mother, Tally Hollis, and two others, from their beds. Her father reported it, as

the standing order requires, and her mother’s name was struck from the list as dead. Scant watched him do it. She has not spoken to him since, and he has been dead for twenty years.

She went to the West Gate on the first day of Carving in 615, at eighteen, and carried on her first raid that winter: a Lung-line house in Lowmark. She did not look away at the bedsides, and was given a knife. She was a Band-Captain by twenty-six. She became Reckoner-Captain in 633, when old Captain Abate Corran did not come home from Oathen. Since then she has set the season’s lines and led most of the hardest raids herself. She has crossed the Rim forty times and ended nine High Cut bloodlines, from matriarchs to cradles.

The raid that changed her was the Marrable raid of 637, against a cadet branch of the Marrable Gut-lines at a summer house in Low Tilt. The matriarch could not be killed, being rooted and three-quarters hill; the band ended the cadets instead. In the nursery Scant stood over a sleeping child for a full minute. What she felt was not mercy. It was the bed. It was warm and deep and smelled of milk and good bread digested, and she wanted, more than she had ever

wanted anything, to lie down in it. Then she did what she had come to do. She does not talk about the minute.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Scant sets the lines each season, with her Kin-Reader, Scarce Odell, and she chooses the Knives. Every Knife on raid draws a full measure, and so the Reckoners are, in effect, the Fast's only standing army, answerable to nobody. She has no official seat with the Abstinents, but she stands outside the door of the top room on council days, and the elders have never asked her to leave. Knife Row is hers. The young of Wanting go to the West Gate because of her.

Her power ends at the Frostline. She has no authority over the Pantry, and if the Abstinents ever cut the Reckoners' measure, she could not feed her Knives for a week. She has never tested it.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The black-iron knife** — long, guardless, never oiled with fat, the handle wrapped in ration-cloth. It was Captain Corran's. It is the only thing she owns that she did not make.
- ◇ **A garrotte of twisted gut** — for the rooms where a knife would wake someone.
- ◇ **Scarce Odell's lists** — folded tight, in oilcloth, in her boot: the current season's lines, every member, every cousin, every wet-nurse's address.
- ◇ **A ration bag** — her own food for the road, counted, never shared.
- ◇ **A servant's apron** — linen, stained, Fatlands cut. She wears it on the Rim to pass through kitchens. She also wears it because her mother, if alive, would be wearing one.
- ◇ **Nine pebbles** — one from the garden of each house she has ended. She says they are not trophies. They are kept in a cloth and she has never once taken them out.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants every High Cut line on the Table ended before the Seating, and she has done the arithmetic and knows it cannot be done. She fears bedside hunger, which she has felt once and will feel again, and she fears what she will do the next time she stands still.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** on every raid she has looked, in every High Cut household, for a woman with no godsign working as a servant: her mother. In the Marrable house there was one, an old Unfed woman in the scullery, who looked at Scant across the dark kitchen and did not cry out, and Scant did not stop to ask her name. She has thought about it every night since.

**A secret she does not know:** Scarce Odell has added the name *Hollis* to a list. Scant's maternal grandmother was a High Cut foundling, Gut-line, left at Thinwick as an infant in 540; Scant carries Cut she cannot feel. Odell has not decided what to do.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Scarce Odell** — her Kin-Reader, whose lists she trusts absolutely.
- ◇ **Wont Bellamy** — she suspects him of being too well fed; she has not yet found out why.
- ◇ **Scour, the Returned** — her best Knife, and she has seen his forearms, and she has let him keep raiding, because she understands wanting to die clean.
- ◇ **Decline Marsh** — they grew up two doors apart in Thinwick; he is the only person who calls her by her childhood name.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — she despises the Abstinents' silence and needs it.
- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — she has been hunting him for three years. He took a woman from Thinwick in 603.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her when she recruits them as Carriers: she needs people with steady stomachs who are not Unfed, who can pass in a Rim inn and sit down without being noticed.

- ◇ **The Scullery.** She asks the PCs to go back into the Marrable house, without her, and find an old Unfed servant, and ask her name.
- ◇ **The Bedside.** On a raid, a PC Carrier sees her standing beside a cradle and not moving. It has been two minutes.
- ◇ **The Name on the List.** A PC finds Odell's list with *Hollis* on it.

She meets threat with silence and a knife. She meets kindness with suspicion, and then, once in a long while, with a single plain sentence of thanks that the PC will remember all their life. She meets the god by walking into the wind and never looking at a table. If nobody intervenes, she goes on the winter raid to Sated, and in the Marrable nursery she stands still, and does not move again, and her band carries her home over the Rim, and she sits in the Lean House with her hands in her lap, warm, for the rest of her life.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She's never once raised her voice to me. I'd die for her. I'd rather that than have her look at me like that again." — a Reckoner Knife of Knife Row

"She came to Thinwick when my boy went to the West Gate. She stood at my door and said he'd be fed on the road. Then she left. That was all. I've hated her ever since." — a mother of Thinwick

"She is the most dangerous woman on the Table, and she is right about us." — Lord Chastain Loin of the Fatlands, at Marrable Hall

# LENT ASHBY

the Invited

*“It wasn’t that I wanted to get up. I don’t remember wanting anything. It was that somebody behind me was crying, and I wanted to see who.”*

– LENT ASHBY, TO THE HOSTWATCH, IN HER FIRST ACCOUNT, AGED TEN

| LENT ASHBY – THE INVITED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT               | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed, and something else) · Want 10, always · Pangs 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| AGE & STATION            | 23; ward of the Abstinent; of no fixed stand                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING       | Delver (unwilling), Standing 1 — kept by the Hostwatch, who study her                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES               | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS                   | Resolve 4, Instinct 4, Endure 3, Rites 2, Stealth 2, Lore 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                     | Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                  | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                    | The Guest Who Left (cannot be Seated; she automatically succeeds at any Invitation check, but anyone sleeping within a stone’s throw of her must make one each dawn, Hard 14). Tasteless (immune to any poison, drug or godsign that works through taste or smell, including Fatlands meat). Laid For (wherever she sleeps, a table is laid by morning, set for one, her name on the card). |
| WANTS                    | To be told why she was let go. To taste one thing before she dies.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                   | Elder’s Ear; Hard Sleeper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| DERANGEMENTS             | The Pull (she feels the chair; triggered when she sees a laid table without her name)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                  | the cards; a bone spoon; a blindfold; a Breaker’s rope; a ration-cloth of salt                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DREAD                    | 3 (to wake beside her laid table)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is small and colourless as skimmed milk: pale hair, pale lashes, pale eyes almost without a ring to the iris, skin that has never browned. She tilts her head when people talk, as though listening to a conversation in the next room. She is not thin, by Unfed standards, and has never been, which nobody can explain, since she eats only her measure and often less, because it tastes of nothing and she forgets.

She speaks softly and rarely, in complete sentences, with the faintly formal courtesy of someone who learned manners at a very good table. She smells of clean linen and, very faintly, of a candle just blown out. When she touches someone’s hand, it is warm, warmer than an Unfed hand should be.

## THEIR STORY

Lent was born in 618 in Bell Ward, the youngest of four. In the Carving of 627, aged nine, she followed the smell of custard out past the Frostline while her mother was counting her brothers through the door, and found a table laid under an apple tree in a kept orchard, with a little chair pulled out. She sat. For a year she was

Seated, in the First Course, flushed and laughing and eating with both hands, and her mother came every day and stood at the orchard gate and rang the bell.

On the first day of Carving 628 she got up. Nobody saw it. Her mother found her at the gate, standing, holding the bell-rope, with her face wet. She was not wasted; she had not lost a pound. She has never been able to say why or how. She remembers only that the food was perfect, and that the host was crying, and that she turned round in her chair to see.

She could taste nothing afterward. That night, a table was laid at the foot of her pallet, and every night since. The Abstinent took her from her family at eleven, for Bell Ward’s sake, and she has been moved ever since, a night here, a night there, followed by a Tablebreaker with an axe, to keep the tables from settling in any one house. She has not seen her mother since 631. Children are not allowed near her.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Lent belongs to the Abstinent and is studied by the Hostwatch, who send a Tracker to sit up with her once a month to watch the

table arrive (no one has ever seen it arrive; one blinks, and it is there). She has no work, because no household will keep her more than a night. She draws a full measure, which she gives back. She is a Wanting legend, a Bell Ward bogey and a living proof of something that nobody can agree on: that the Host can be left, or that it lets go of those it loves.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The cards** — thirteen years of place cards, one from every table laid for her, in a bundle tied with string: nearly five thousand. Every one says *Lent*. Every one, until this month.
- ◇ **A bone spoon** — from the orchard table; the only thing she brought back. She has never used it. It is always warm.
- ◇ **A gauze blindfold** — a Breaker's, so that she does not have to see the morning table.
- ◇ **Fifty feet of belled Breaker's rope** — tied to her ankle at night by whoever is watching her.
- ◇ **A ration-cloth of salt** — she licks it, because salt is the one thing she can almost feel on her tongue, as a sting.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be told why she was let go, and she has begun to suspect she was not, and that she is on a long leash. She wants to taste one thing before she dies, and she fears, more than anything, that the one thing will be on a table.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** the card has changed. For thirteen years it said *Lent*. Since the first night of this Carving it has said *Steward*. She has told no one. She has burned each one. The next morning it is on the table again.

**A secret she does not know:** the tables laid for her have always had two places, not one. The second is laid at the far end, pushed in, so that the Breakers who smash them each dawn have never thought to count.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — the Steward who wants to be relieved; Lent has never met him, and she dreams of a tall tired man in a green coat apologising to her.
- ◇ **Decline Marsh** — he has broken more of her tables than anyone; he is the closest thing she has to a friend.
- ◇ **Little Fain** — the only other person who got up; the Abstinent have forbidden them to meet. Fain keeps asking.
- ◇ **Spare Tolland** — he visits her monthly, and talks to her about the god as if it were a neighbour, and she likes him for it.
- ◇ **Brother Hallow Crust** — he got up for nobody; she sat beside him once, at a distance, for an hour, and he told her what she had eaten in the orchard, course by course, and he was right.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her when they are assigned to escort her for a week from one lodging to another, and wake each morning to the table.

- ◇ **The Steward's Card.** The PCs find a card she has not burned in time.
- ◇ **The Taste.** Lent asks a PC to bring her something from the Rim, anything, so she can try it. If it is godflesh, she tastes it. It is the first thing she has tasted in thirteen years.
- ◇ **Two Places.** A PC counts the chairs at her morning table.

Under threat she goes still and waits, without fear. Kindness undoes her: she has not been touched by choice in years. Before the god she is calm, and sad. If nobody intervenes, on Tablenight this year she walks out of the line, bows to a tall figure in a green coat, takes the ring of keys he offers, and is not seen again, except a mile ahead of the god, laying tables, with her head tilted, listening.

#### SAID OF THEM

"I broke her table this morning. She said thank you. Not to the table, to me. I've not been thanked in years." — a Tablebreaker Axe of Splinterhall

"We keep a girl in the Fast who gets a table every night and has never sat at one since. If you want proof the Rules work, there she is." — Envoy Prudence Lowell, to the Company congress

"She's my sister. I remember she liked custard. That's all I'm allowed to remember." — one of her brothers, in Bell Ward

# TARRY MOSS

## Crumb-Runner

*“Spit if you like. Spit after. Before, you’ll get it in the oats.”*

– TARRY MOSS, TO THE STREET, UNLOADING IN SPIT LANE

| TARRY MOSS – CRUMB-RUNNER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION             | 53; Counter of a two-cart outfit; of the Spit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CALLING & STANDING        | Crumb-Runner, Standing 2 — Hauler (Fast rank: Counter)                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES                | Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                    | Labor 4, Wayfaring 4, Endure 4, Reckoning 3, Stealth 3, Resolve 3, Haggle 3, Brawl 2, Deceive 2                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                      | Flesh 16 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (oiled leather apron) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                   | ox-goad +4 (3); a bitten fist +4 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| GIFTS                     | The Count (once per day, on Eye + Reckoning vs Routine 10, he knows the exact quantity of anything he has loaded; he has never been wrong, and this is now the problem). Hidden Hold (Crumb-Runner Talent). Ox-Sense (while driving his own oxen, +2 to notice warm ground ahead). |
| WANTS                     | To be thanked once. To bring Stint home eating.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                    | Strong Back; Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                   | the commonplace book; nostril wax; two oxen; a cod-rope; the unturned card                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| DREAD                     | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Broad-backed and bandy, with a beard like an untrimmed hedge, he is the heaviest-built man in the Spit and still has visible ribs. Wax plugs in both nostrils make him breathe through his mouth with a faint whistle. His right hand, bitten to the bone by the boy Stint on the road from Brindle Cross, healed crooked, and he holds his goad in the left now. He smells of ox and axle-grease and, under that, oats. He talks to his oxen more than to people, by name (Plod and Dumb), and to people mostly about weight.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 588 in the Spit to a Runner family, he was carrying a sack at nine. He married once; his wife Abate went walking west in the short of 614 and he did not follow. He has hauled for thirty-five years and has never eaten a mouthful of his own cargo, a boast that half the Spit believes and the other half thinks is pride, which in the Fast is the same thing. In the Carving of 640 he took on the boy Stint, fourteen, and carried him home tied to the oat sacks after the farmhouse called the boy by his favourite dish. He found the white linen on the sacks the next morning, and a card, and burned the card without turning it over.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Tarry is a Counter: he keeps the tally for Sparing Doyle’s carts on the Brindle road and is trusted with the Pantry’s money at the Cross. Mother Stint Avery checks his tallies against her scales and they have never differed by a bean. He is paid by weight, partly in Company lacks he keeps in a pot buried under his floor. He is spat on daily. He brings in about a twentieth of what Wanting eats.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The commonplace book** — charcoal on the backs of Pantry manifests: counts, weather, oxen, and what the god smelled like each night.
- ◇ **A wax tin** — tallow and beeswax for nostrils and ears; he melts it down with his own hands each Lack.
- ◇ **Plod and Dumb** — two red oxen who have never once walked toward a table.
- ◇ **The cod-rope** — the rope he tied Stint with. He keeps it on the cart.
- ◇ **A buried pot** — two hundred and eleven lacks. He does not know what he is saving for.
- ◇ **The unturned card** — he said he burned it. He did not. It is in the book, face down.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to be thanked once before he dies, by anyone. He wants Stint to eat. He fears the extra: for a season his counts have come out *over*, a bean, a handful, a sack he did not load, and the extra is always better than what he bought.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** he has begun, on the last night of each run, to leave the extra on the roadside, laid out on a cloth, so it will not go into the Pantry. Someone has begun to take it.

**A secret he does not know:** the card says *Tarry*, in his wife Abate's hand. She is at the Long Table, seventh mile, and she saved him a seat.

## TIES

- ◇ **Stint (the boy)** — in the Lean House, not omitted, only not eating; he will eat nothing Tarry carries, because it is not what he smelled.
- ◇ **Mother Stint Avery** — she trusts his counts and has never thanked him.
- ◇ **Sparing Doyle** — his road-master; owes him three seasons' pay.
- ◇ **Factor Joss Mardle** — Tarry knows to the sack how light the autumn deliveries came, and Mardle knows he knows.
- ◇ **Withy Gaunt** — he brings her straw for the Lean House, free, and she lets him sit with Stint.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet him at Brindle Cross, where he hires them as guards and pays in food. He wants extra hands because the road has got strange.

- ◇ **The Light Cargo.** Halfway in, his count is wrong by one sack, then two; the missing sacks are laid out as bread in a farmhouse.
- ◇ **The Roadside Cloth.** The PCs watch who takes the extra.
- ◇ **Stint.** He asks a PC to carry food to the boy, so that it will not be Tarry's.

Under threat he turns the oxen and walks; he has outwalked poachers. To kindness he is gruff and embarrassed. To the god he is deaf and plugged. If nobody intervenes, he turns the card over on the Long Table road, at the seventh mile.

## SAID OF THEM

"He's the only Runner who's never shorted the Pantry. That's why we spit harder at him. You don't spit at a thief. You spit at a man who makes you owe him." — a Hillward clerk

"Tarry Moss carried my father home from the Cross on his own back when the oxen wouldn't go. Didn't charge. I've never said thank you. Nobody does." — a widow of Thinwick

"Fifty-three and still counting beans. If they'd all been like him, the Fast would be fed." — Sparing Doyle, Road-Master



# SISTER NAY CORLISS

## the Starved Saint

*“No, thank you. That was a crow. No, thank you. That was you. No, thank you. That was the wind, and then it stopped.”*

— SISTER NAY CORLISS, TO A PILGRIM AT SAINTS’ ACRE

| SISTER NAY CORLISS – THE STARVED SAINT |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 10, always (Hollow) · Pangs 8 (Wasting), and has not moved in two years                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| AGE & STATION                          | 34; a Saint of the Starved Saints, three years without food; of Saints’ Acre                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Celebrant, Standing 4 — Saint (pilgrims come to touch her robe)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS                                 | Endure 5, Resolve 5, Rites 4, Instinct 3, Persuade 2, Lore 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 10 (14, less 4 for Wasting) · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                                | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| GIFTS                                  | Outlived Nature (she does not suffer Ruin at Brink and cannot reach Starved; something feeds her in the night). The Field’s Decline (once per scene, she says the Decline and every Unfed who hears it gains +2 on their next Invitation check). Laid For (as Hollow, a table is laid within sight each night; she has never seen one, because she sleeps). |
| WANTS                                  | To want nothing. To be the first Unfed in whom wanting stops.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                 | No Thank You; Silent Supper; Unflinching                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                                | a hurdle; sacking; a bowl kept empty; her mother’s comb                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DREAD                                  | 2 (to see the lamp through her hand)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

### WHO THEY ARE

She sits on a hurdle in the open field, wrapped in sacking, knees drawn up, hands folded on them. She is translucent: a lamp held behind her hand shows the bones like twigs in amber. Her lips are cracked into deep red seams; her tongue is grey; her eyes are enormous and very calm. Her breath when she speaks the Decline barely stirs a feather, and smells, surprisingly, of nothing sour at all, but faintly of honey. Pilgrims are drawn to her for that, though none can say why.

### THEIR STORY

Nay was born in 607 in Thinwick, the daughter of a woman who baked, in secret, under the open sky, honey-cake from Rim flour, once a year, for Nay’s naming day, and was struck from the list for it when Nay was eleven. Her mother went to the Lean House. Nay went to the order at twenty-five, as a Novice, and stopped eating altogether at thirty-one, in the spring of 638. Every Abstainer of her intake died within ten weeks. She did not. By the end of the first year the Watchers were writing her name in a book of their own.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is the order’s proof and its dread. The Abstinents revere her publicly, because each Saint is one less name to feed and one more reproach to everyone who eats. Pilgrims come from Wanting, now from the Rim, to touch her sacking. Young Unfed walk out into the field after her, and die, and the Watchers’ book grows. Her novice, a girl of seventeen called Pinch Arden, tends her at dawn.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The hurdle** — woven hazel, the same one for three years.
- ◇ **Sacking** — four layers; she was given a blanket and declined it three times, and nobody made the fourth offer.
- ◇ **An empty bowl** — wooden, kept in her lap, so that she can refuse what is not in it.
- ◇ **Her mother’s comb** — horn, for hair she no longer has much of.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to be the first Unfed to want nothing. She fears, if she fears anything, that the brightness she lives in is not holiness.



A secret the GM can reveal: Pinch Arden wipes crumbs from Nay's lips every dawn, and has never told her, and has been saving them in a twist of cloth. The frost around the hurdle melts every night in a wide ring.

A secret she does not know: the crumbs are honey-cake, made the way her mother made it, and her mother is not dead. She walked west from the Lean House in 618, and the Hostwatch have a pin where she sat.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Pinch Arden** — her novice, who loves her and is terrified.
- ◇ **Watcher Scarcity Dunne** — keeps her name in the Book, waiting to write the date.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — he has had himself carried to the field's edge twice to look at her; he did not speak.
- ◇ **Abstain Rooke** — the child from Thinwick who comes to the edge and asks questions; Nay answers them all.
- ◇ **The Purgation** — its fasting-masters come to learn from her and go home disappointed.

#### IN PLAY

PCs are sent to watch her sleep and see who feeds her.

- ◇ **The Twist of Cloth.** Pinch offers a PC the crumbs and asks them to taste and say if it is poison.
- ◇ **The Ring.** The PCs sit up and see, at the third hour, the frost begin to melt, and a smell of honey.
- ◇ **The Followers.** Two Abstainers have moved their hurdles closer to Nay. They are not losing weight either.

Threat does not reach her. Kindness she declines three times; no one has ever made the fourth offer. If the god's feeding is revealed to her, she Breaks, and every Abstainer in the field witnesses it. If nobody intervenes, the field fills with hurdles, and one morning all of them are drawn up in a long row, close together, like chairs.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She's the cleanest soul in the Fast. Don't stand too near her. She'll make you ashamed of your breakfast." — a Hillward elder

"I wipe her mouth every morning. I'm not supposed to have seen anything. I keep the crumbs because I can't think what else to do."  
— Pinch Arden, her novice

"I touched her sleeve. It was warm. Not warm like a person, warm like bread." — a Fatlands pilgrim

# DECLINE MARSH

*the Four Hundred and First*

*“Lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs. Chairs last. Every chair. You don’t leave a chair.”*

– DECLINE MARSH, TEACHING A NEW AXE AT SPLINTERHALL

| DECLINE MARSH – TABLEBREAKER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 5 · Pangs 2 (Peckish)                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                | 38; a Breaker, leading a band of five from Splinterhall                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Warden (Tablebreaker), Standing 4 — Breaker (may claim any household’s axe)                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 1 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                       | Blades 4, Endure 4, Labor 4, Resolve 3, Search 3, Athletics 2, Intimidate 2                                                                                                                                                                      |
| BODY                         | Flesh 16 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 8                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                      | Barrow-blessed Tablebreaker’s axe +8 (4; Brutal, Two-Handed; +4 vs furniture; ignores any warding of Orrum’s tables)                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                        | Four Hundred Tables (he breaks a laid table in a single action, and all within sight gain +2 on their next Invitation check). Wax and Gauze (wearing his wax and blinders, he treats any Invitation check of smell or sight as one step easier). |
| WANTS                        | To break the table laid for his mother. To read the card, just once.                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                       | Strong Back; No Thank You                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | Kept Grief (he keeps the card; triggered by any mother’s handwriting)                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                      | the axe; wax and gauze; a wedge; the card; a coat                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                        | 1 (to watch him swing)                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |

## WHO THEY ARE

A big, slope-shouldered man with forearms like hams, and the steadiest hands in the Fast. His voice is ruined from shouting through linen, a hoarse bark. Years of gauze blinders have left his eyes weak and red-rimmed in daylight. He smells of fresh-cut ash and oil and, always, faintly, of the tables, which gets into a Breaker’s clothes and never leaves. He is good company at Splinterhall: he laughs, rarely but entirely.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 603 in Thinwick, two doors from Scant Hollis. When he was four, in 607, his mother, Bounty Marsh (one of the old shameful names), sat at a table laid in their kitchen. His father insisted she be dragged from it. Decline watched her come up out of the chair light as a leaf, screaming like a kettle, and die on the doorstep, apologising to the host. He went to Splinterhall at sixteen and broke his first table at seventeen. He broke his four hundredth in the Carving of 639.

The four hundred and first had a card at one place with his name on it. The hand was his mother’s. He broke the table. He has broken nine since. He has not slept indoors since, because he keeps finding the card again in his coat.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He leads one of the four eastern bands from Splinterhall, and the Hostwatch send him to the worst tables: the ones in occupied houses, the ones laid for children. He works in a set order (lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs last, every chair) and he never looks at the food. His band would follow him into the Long Table valley, and once did.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The axe** — Barrow-blessed, its haft notched for every table until he ran out of haft at three hundred and began a second.
- ◇ **Wax and gauze** — ear-plugs, nose-binding, a blinder of loose gauze.
- ◇ **A Tablebreaker’s wedge** — for tables that will not come apart.
- ◇ **The card** — in his coat. He has burned it eleven times.
- ◇ **An old coat** — his father’s; he sleeps in it, in the open.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to break the table laid for his mother, which he believes exists somewhere, and to read her card once before he does. He fears he will read it and not swing.

A secret the GM can reveal: the latest card says *Come home, love, I've kept it warm*, and names a place on the Long Table, the sixth mile, west side.

A secret he does not know: his mother was not dragged far enough. She died on the doorstep, but the god does not count a doorstep as leaving. The place on the sixth mile is hers, and she is waiting to pull out his chair.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — childhood neighbour; he calls her Scanty, and she lets him.
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — he has broken more of her tables than anyone, and talks to her at dawn.
- ◇ **Brother Hallow Crust** — Hallow taught him the order of breaking; Decline passes him on the Long Table road and never stops.
- ◇ **Old Breaker Wane Hollister** — his band-mother at Splinterhall; he has seen her sleeping on the heap.
- ◇ **Spare Tolland** — sends him to tables; they share a rope sometimes.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him on a hunt, when the Hostwatch attach them to his band as Rope-Holders.

- ◇ **The Sixth Mile.** He asks the PCs to come with him down the Long Table road, and to hold the rope.
- ◇ **The Coat.** A PC finds the card in Decline's coat while he sleeps.
- ◇ **Splinterhall Heap.** Wane Hollister has gained a stone in weight. Decline needs someone to tell her.

Under threat he swings. To kindness he is shy. To the god, he is a professional. If nobody intervenes, he walks to the sixth mile alone, reads the card, sits, and his band finds him with the axe across his knees, laughing, describing the gravy.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He's the best Axe that ever came out of Splinterhall. Doesn't look. Never looks. Then he goes and puts his hand in his coat, and looks."  
— a Rope-Holder of his band

"He broke the table in my kitchen when my little one was four. He did it so quick she never saw the custard. I'd kiss his hands if he'd let me."  
— a mother of Bell Ward

"Decline was always the soft one. That's why he's good at it. You have to want it, to break it like that."  
— Scant Hollis

# SPARE TOLLAND

## Mile-Walker of the Hostwatch

*“It stopped by the Lammas gate tonight and stood an hour. Not looking at anything. Like a man who’s come to the door and can’t remember why. Then it looked back at me. Pin that.”*

— SPARE TOLLAND, REPORTING AT PINNERS’ YARD

| SPARE TOLLAND – MILE-WALKER OF THE HOSTWATCH |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                   | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                                | 60; Mile-Walker, thirty years in the field; of Pinners’ Yard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                           | Delver, Standing 3 — Mile-Walker (Hostwatch rank 3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTRIBUTES                                   | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                       | Wayfaring 5, Search 5, Instinct 4, Lore 3, Endure 3, Stealth 3, Resolve 3, Athletics 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                                         | Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                                      | iron-shod staff +2 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                        | Warm Ground (on Eye + Search vs Routine 10 he can tell how long ago the god passed, which way, and whether it paused, and for how long). The Mile (while he keeps exactly a mile behind the god, he and anyone roped to him take no Invitation checks from the smell of baking). Gone Under (Delver Talent; gains 1 Want, not Hunger, on coming out). |
| WANTS                                        | To see its face. To learn who the extra chair is for.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                                       | Corpse-Road Walker; Light Sleeper; Counting Habit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                                 | The Devotion (to the god, unspoken; triggered when it pauses for him)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                                      | the brass compass; pin-coat; slates; fifty feet of belled rope; the measuring-chain; a frost-glass                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| DREAD                                        | 0 (but 3 to watch him close the mile)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

### WHO THEY ARE

Wiry and slow-moving, with a face weathered into deep pleated folds and bright, unblinking grey eyes that seem never to need to rest. He wears a long grey coat sewn all over with little pockets, each holding a pin with a coloured head. He smells of wet grass and the beeswax the Pin-Setters use. He speaks rarely and slowly, in the voice of a farmer describing a neighbour’s animal, and he talks about Orrum as *it*, fondly.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 581 in Bell Ward, he joined the Hostwatch at twenty-two as a Pin-Setter and walked his first warm ground at twenty-five. Since 611 he has followed the god at a mile, in all seasons, weeks at a time, coming in to Wanting only to report and draw measure. He never married. He has never seen the god’s face. He has seen it stop and wait for him to catch up, seventeen times, and he has stopped too, every time, and it has gone on.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is the Hostwatch’s best field-walker and the source of a third of the pins on the Great Map. The Warden of the Map reads his reports first. He trains Trackers, and every one of them learns his first rule: before you sit at any table, anywhere, count the places. He reports, lately, things the Warden asks him not to say aloud in the Yard.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The brass Hostwatch compass** — its needle swings toward the god when it is within a mile, and he no longer needs it.
- ◇ **The pin-coat** — five hundred pins in pockets, coloured by date.
- ◇ **Slates and chalk** — for reports, wiped and rewritten.
- ◇ **Belled rope** — fifty feet, for whoever will hold the other end.
- ◇ **A measuring-chain** — for warm paths, which have widened by a foot in five years.
- ◇ **A frost-glass** — a lens for reading melted frost at dawn.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to see its face once. He fears the mile is shrinking, and is no longer sure which of them is closing it.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** in his private slates he has recorded where the god walks on the Rim at night, and has worked out that its new path is a ring, closing toward Hallowboard, and that at each inn it has looked through the window it has stopped at the eighth table, or the end of the room, or an empty corner, and bowed.

**A secret he does not know:** the god has been laying a place for him every night for thirty years, a mile ahead, on the path he will take. Welcome Ardent clears it before he arrives, because Spare is the only one who walks behind, and the Steward does not want to lose him.

## TIES

- ◇ **Decline Marsh** — Spare sends him to tables; they share a rope.
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — he visits monthly and talks to her of the god as a neighbour.
- ◇ **Verger Sober Osmond** — they are old friends, privately; Spare thinks the Verger is right.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — Spare reports to the Chair through the Warden, and has never been thanked.
- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — Spare has seen a tall figure in green a mile ahead of the god and knows what it is.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet him when he needs someone to hold the far end of his rope.

- ◇ **The Pause.** The god stops. Spare sits down in the grass and waits. An hour. The PCs must decide whether to pull.
- ◇ **The Ring.** He asks the PCs to carry his slates to someone outside the Fast, Dr. Mercy Thrane or Envoy Lowell, because the Warden will not publish.
- ◇ **The Laid Path.** The PCs walk ahead of Spare and find his table.

He meets threat by vanishing into the fields. Kindness he accepts on the fourth offer without fuss. To the god, he is patient. If nobody intervenes, one dusk on the warm ground the mile closes, and the Trackers who follow his path find his coat folded on a stile, and every pin in it facing west.

## SAID OF THEM

“He’s never once told me what it looks like. He tells me what it does. That’s worse.” — Pin-Setter Abate Lowrie

“Thirty years walking behind it like a dog. Somebody ought to tell him it’s not his.” — a Splinterhall Axe

“He’s the only one of us who has ever said it might be lonely. Then he says, so am I. Then he goes back out.” — the Warden of the Map, in a restricted ledger

# WONT BELLAMY

the Heretic Elder

*“We refused for six hundred years. I’m only proposing we stop refusing for one night. You’d be surprised how short a night can be.”*

– WONT BELLAMY, IN THE BARE ROOM, TO THE ABSTINENT

| WONT BELLAMY – THE HERETIC ELDER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                       | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed; see Secrets) · Want 2 · Pangs 0 (Peckish)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION                    | 55; Elder of the Abstinent by right of blood; of Hillward, of the first stretch                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING               | Clausewright, Standing 4 — Elder of the Abstinent                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                       | Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                           | Persuade 5, Deceive 4, Clause 4, Lore 4, Haggle 3, Feast 2, Endure 1, Blades 1, Resolve 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| BODY                             | Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                          | a slim Rim dagger, never drawn +3 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| GIFTS                            | The Fourth Offer (he alone of the council makes fourth offers that sound sincere; once per scene, an Unfed who refuses him a fourth time must roll Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 or accept). First-Stretch Blood (no Hillward family can refuse him audience). Friends Abroad (once per session, a letter from the Second Table brings money, a name, or a door on the Rim). |
| WANTS                            | To eat the god that is still whole, and to be at the head of the table when it happens.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| KNACKS                           | Smell of Cedar; Table Manners; Conditional                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                          | the fork-sealed letters; a Rim-cut coat; a silver fork; a dagger; a ledger copy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                            | 0 (and that is what is wrong with him)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

He is plump, by Unfed standards: his ribs cannot be counted through his shirt, and the Abstinent never forget it. He wears a Rim-cut coat of good grey wool, perfectly plain and perfectly tailored, and he moves with an ease no other elder has, because he has the strength. His dark eyes are clever and kind. His voice is soft, warm, and beautifully mannered, and he smells, under the camphor every Hillward elder wears, faintly of clove.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 586 in the first stretch family of Hillward, the oldest standing in the Fast, he was a precocious Lister and the youngest elder in a century, seated at thirty-five in 621. He went to the Rim as Pantry envoy to the Company in 628 and came back with friends. Since 630 he has argued in council that the Refusal was only a postponement, and the council has let him, because the Bellamys stood on the first stretch. In 636 and 639, on Pantry business in Sated, he dined in the cellar of Marrable Hall, at the Second Table.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He commands a third of the Hillward votes and every elder who is privately tired. He is the council’s spokesman to the Company and

its only member with letters abroad. He has no office but his voice, and he does not need one: when Forbear Wend dies, the Chair is between Bellamy and whoever Stint Avery backs.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◆ **Letters sealed in wax pressed with a fork** — from the Second Table, kept in the lining of his coat.
- ◆ **A Rim-cut coat** — warm, which is itself a scandal.
- ◆ **A silver fork** — Unfed temple plate, given him at Marrable Hall, from a set bought in the Thin Years from somebody’s grandmother. A fork is a disgrace in the Fast. He holds it in his pocket while he speaks in council.
- ◆ **A slim dagger** — he has never drawn it.
- ◆ **A copy of the Pantry ledgers** — he keeps his own count of Stint Avery’s stores.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants the Fast to eat Orrum, and the Second Table to share the carving. He fears Scant Hollis, who has begun to watch him.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** he has eaten twice at the Second Table, Fatlands pork, which he was assured was nothing godly. He

enjoyed it so much he wept, and has told no one.

**A secret he does not know:** the pork was raised on Low Tilth grain, and carried the Laden. He has one mark of Seasoning. One more meal and he will need only one more after that.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Dame Suet Marrable** — his hostess in the cellar; he admires her more than anyone alive.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — he waits for the old man to die, and loves him a little.
- ◇ **Mother Stint Avery** — he needs her vote; she despises him and is tempted by his arithmetic.
- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — the only person in Wanting he is afraid of.
- ◇ **Meek Garrity** — Bellamy paid for his lenses, and wants the slate.

#### IN PLAY

He offers PCs generous work carrying letters to Sated, and offers it only once.

- ◇ **The Fork.** A PC sees the fork in council.
- ◇ **The Proposal.** On the night the winter list is read, Bellamy proposes that the Fast send a party to Hallowboard with knives, and wants the PCs to go.
- ◇ **The Second Meal.** He asks the PCs to escort a Second Table guest into the Fast, a Gut-line heir, very large, very polite.

Under threat he talks, beautifully. Kindness he receives graciously. Before the god, he takes off his hat. If nobody intervenes, he wins the Chair, and leads forty Unfed up Hallowboard hill with knives on Tablenight, and stands on the eighth side.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He’s got a chin. An Unfed with a chin. Every time he talks, I look at it.” — Old Pinch Corve, Hillward Doorwarden

“Bellamy is a man of real vision. The Unfed are fortunate. They will eat last, and best.” — Lord Chastain Loin, of the Second Table

“He says the thing we all think at night. That’s why he’s dangerous. That’s why I vote with him, sometimes.” — an elder of the Abstinent

# MOTHER STINT AVERY

## *Keeper of the Pantry*

*“Four months of grain. Six of winter. You may pray about it. I’ve done the sum.”*

– MOTHER STINT AVERY, TO FORBEAR WEND, IN THE WEIGHING-HALL

| MOTHER STINT AVERY – KEEPER OF THE PANTRY |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                             | 62; Keeper of the Pantry since 627; born in Avery Steading, lives in Pantry Close                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                        | Factor (the Pantry), Standing 4 — Keeper, ranked with the Elders                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                                | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                                    | Reckoning 5, Resolve 4, Labor 3, Clause 3, Endure 3, Search 3, Intimidate 3, Haggle 2, Brawl 1                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                                      | Flesh 14 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTACKS                                   | a brass scale-weight, swung +4 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                     | The Scales (on Eye + Reckoning vs Routine 10, she knows to the grain how much any store, cart or person has eaten, hoarded or hidden). The Reading (when she reads the list, nobody in the Close may interrupt; a character who tries must pass a Dread 2 check). The Second Key. |
| WANTS                                     | To get the Fast to Grace with the fewest dead. To never be thanked.                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                    | Counting Habit; Steady Hands; No Thank You                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES                                   | the second key; brass scales; the winter list; the steading letters; a pencil                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DREAD                                     | 1 (to hear her read the list)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

### WHO THEY ARE

Square and hard-handed, with a mason’s forearms and a clerk’s ink-stained fingers, oat-dust always in the hairs of her arms. She wears an apron of oiled canvas and smells of sacking and mouse, which in the Fast is the smell of being alive. She has a flat, carrying voice that never changes on any name. She does not smile, and she does not frown.

### THEIR STORY

Born in 579 in Avery Steading, she walked into Wanting at twelve with a Measure-Bearer and never went home. She was a weighing-clerk at sixteen and Keeper at forty-eight. She has weighed every ration in the Fast herself for fourteen years, on brass scales older than Wanting, and never once given anyone a grain extra. In the short of 589 she was ten, a clerk’s runner, and saw the Keeper miss a line.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She holds the second key and drafts the list that Forbear Wend signs. She reads it each night in Pantry Close. Every Lister, Bearer and clerk answers to her scales. She has done the arithmetic of this winter and decided: the furthest villages, the oldest, the fewest

children. She has not told Wend, because he will pray, and praying is a delay, and delay kills more.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The second key** — iron, on a leather thong around her wrist.
- ◇ **The brass scales** — Pantry property, older than Wanting.
- ◇ **The winter list** — unsigned, in her apron; Avery Steading is on it.
- ◇ **The steading letters** — fourteen years of Avery Steading’s stitched cloth letters to the Keeper, read every year, never answered.
- ◇ **A stub of pencil** — she draws the line herself.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to get the Fast to Grace with the fewest dead, and she wants nobody to thank her for it. She fears nothing but delay.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** her own village, Avery Steading, is on the list. She has not told them.

**A secret she does not know:** the grain is not short. The Company diverted it north; Factor Mardle could restore it for one signature on the “first refusal” clause, and Forbear Wend has not told her the clause exists.



## TIES

- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — she respects his suffering and does not share it.
- ◇ **Tarry Moss** — his counts match her scales; she trusts no one else.
- ◇ **Factor Joss Mardle** — she suspects him and cannot prove it.
- ◇ **Wont Bellamy** — he has offered her a different sum.
- ◇ **Abstain Rooke's mother** — on the list; Stint met her once, and wrote her name smaller.

## IN PLAY

She asks the PCs to audit a Crumb-Runner's tally, and they find the Company's shortfall.

- ◇ **The Audit.** Tarry's count and the Cross ledger do not agree.
- ◇ **The Steading.** She asks the PCs, without explanation, to carry her own letter to Avery Steading. It is blank.
- ◇ **The Clause.** If PCs tell her about the first refusal, she must decide whether to sell the Fast's dead for its living.

Under threat she does not move. Kindness she cannot stand. Before the god, she counts. If nobody intervenes, she signs the list herself, walks to Avery Steading in the snow with a basket on her back, and is found at the steading stone in spring.

## SAID OF THEM

"She weighed my baby once. For the measure. She held him like a sack of oats, and then she held him a little longer." — a mother of Bell Ward

"Stint Avery is the only honest instrument in the Fast. I mean that as I would of a good pair of scales." — Factor Joss Mardle

"She was born here. She knows the road. She's never once walked it back." — Grandam Bare Avery, of Avery Steading

# ABSTAIN ROOKE, CALLED ABBY

the Pen-Friend

*“Does it count as accepting if you’re only keeping it for someone else? Because Mam’s on the list, and I’ve got a lot.”*

– ABBY ROOKE, TO A HOSTWATCH TRACKER AT THE THINWICK STONE

| ABSTAIN ROOKE – THE PEN-FRIEND |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                     | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 4 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| AGE & STATION                  | 11; a child of Thinwick, on a three-quarter measure                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| CALLING & STANDING             | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| ATTRIBUTES                     | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SKILLS                         | Stealth 3, Resolve 3, Instinct 3, Filch 2, Lore 2 (the Rules), Search 2, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                           | Flesh 9 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTACKS                        | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| GIFTS                          | Rule-Perfect (she has never failed to recite the Five Rules; +2 on any Invitation check where the rule applies is hers by habit). The Windowsill (each night she leaves a crust; each morning it is replaced with something better; she may ask the GM what came, and it is always exactly what someone she loves most wanted). |
| WANTS                          | To know who her pen-friend is. To keep Mam on the list.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                         | No Thank You; Little Lies                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CARRIES                        | the crust; the floor-stone hoard; a bone toy; a bell                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DREAD                          | 2 (to lift the floor-stone and smell it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |

## WHO THEY ARE

Bird-boned and quick, with a gap in her front teeth, straw-coloured hair cut short with a knife, and the downy fur of hunger along her forearms. She asks *why* the way other children breathe. She is solemn, polite, very good, and curious in a country that has made a whole religion of not being curious. She smells of wet chalk from the stream and, at night, faintly, of honey.

## THEIR STORY

Born in 630 in Thinwick, named on the day she refused the breast. Her father went with the Reckoners in 637 and did not come home. In the spring of 638 she was the girl who found the first place card, *Abstain*, and under it her dead grandmother’s pet name for her, which no living person knew. Since the Carving of 640 she has left a crust on her windowsill each night, saved from her own measure. Each morning it has been replaced: a corner of white bread, a ripe plum, a sugared almond, a honey-cake in a leaf. She has eaten none of it. She hides it under a loose floor-stone. It does not rot.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She is a child on a three-quarter measure in a hamlet on the edge of the Frostline, and she should have no place at all. But Abby is

Thinwick’s best reciter, and the Rule-stone’s pride, and she walks two hours to Saints’ Acre every fourth day to ask Sister Nay questions. Her mother works double turns in the Cold Yards at Wanting since her name was moved to the bottom of the list, and does not check the sill.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The crust** — tonight’s, saved, in her pocket.
- ◇ **The hoard** — under the floor-stone: forty-one things, each better than the last. It smells wonderful through the stone at night.
- ◇ **A bone toy** — a carved rabbit, her one toy.
- ◇ **The bell** — her mother’s door-bell, which Abby rings herself at dusk now, counting one.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

She wants to know who her pen-friend is. She wants Mam to stay on the list. She is not afraid. She thinks it is a friendship.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** her mother is on Stint Avery’s winter list. Abby has worked out, from what Measure-Bearers do not say, that this means Mam will go to the Lean House, and she has

decided that when it happens she will give Mam the hoard, all of it, because it is not accepting if you are only keeping it for someone else.

**A secret she does not know:** the last gift was a little cake with seven points pressed into the icing in a ring, and the eighth place smooth, as though a thumb had been laid there. Haft-Mender Lean Coyle saw it on the sill before she did, and smelled his dead wife's baking, and took it, and has not given it back.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Sister Nay Corliss** — Abby's teacher of questions; Nay answers everything.
- ◇ **Lean Coyle** — the old Axe who watches her sill and cannot decide.
- ◇ **Little Fain** — Abby has heard about Fain from Bell Ward children and wants to ask Fain things.
- ◇ **Mother Stint Avery** — the woman who wrote Mam's name smaller; Abby does not know her name.
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — Abby has been told about her as a warning, and thinks she sounds lovely.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet her at the Thinwick stone, where she asks them, very seriously, if it counts as accepting if you are only keeping it for someone else.

- ◇ **The Floor-Stone.** A PC smells it through the stone.
- ◇ **The Lean House.** Abby walks into Wanting with a sack.
- ◇ **The Note.** The PCs sit up by the sill and see the exchange made: a long warm hand, through a shutter that is closed.

Under threat she hides. Kindness she declines three times, perfectly, and accepts on the fourth with a gap-toothed grin. To the god, she is polite. If nobody intervenes, she carries the hoard to the Lean House on the night the list is read, and the omitted eat, every one, and get up, and walk west in a line, holding hands, singing, and Abby leads them.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Best reciter we've had at the stone. Fast as a sparrow. Asks why after every rule, though. We'll have to cure her of that." — the Thinwick Rule-mistress

"There's something on her sill every morning. I've seen it. I've not told her mam. I don't know what you tell a mother about a thing like that." — Lean Coyle, haft-mender

"She asked me if the god was sad. I said yes. She said, then why doesn't anyone say thank you? I didn't have an answer. I'm not supposed to." — Sister Nay Corliss

# BROTHER HALLOW CRUST

*the Seated*

*“Now this, this is the eel pie, and you’ll see they’ve not stinted on the parsley liquor. Sit down, love. You look done in. You’re Hesitate Toft’s girl, aren’t you? How’s your mother’s chest?”*

— BROTHER HALLOW CRUST, AT THE LONG TABLE, FOURTH MILE, TO A MEASURE-BEARER PASSING AT A TROT

| BROTHER HALLOW CRUST – THE SEATED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                        | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed, Seated) · Want 0 · Pangs — (held by the Host; were he to rise, 10)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                     | about 75; Seated since the 9th of Carving, 601; fourth mile of the Long Table, east side                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING                | once Warden (Tablebreaker), Standing 5 — Old Breaker; now a guest                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                        | Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                            | Persuade 5, Lore 4, Blades 4 (forgotten), Instinct 3, Craft 3, Resolve 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                              | Flesh 3 · Guard 8 · Armor 0 · Fray 0, and content                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                           | none; the silver fork, never raised in anger                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| GIFTS                             | The Menu (anyone who listens to him describe a course for more than a minute makes an Invitation check at Hard 14, plus their Pangs; listening a whole scene, Grim 18). Remembered Kindly (he remembers every name, family and illness told him since 601, and asks after them; +2 to his Persuade with anyone whose family he has named). Torn from Table (dragged beyond the length of the cloth, he dies within minutes, all at once, apologising to the host). |
| WANTS                             | To get up, after this course. To be told his wife’s name.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                            | Elder’s Ear; Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                           | a silver fork; an old axe-wedge under the chair; his Breaker’s tally; a napkin                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DREAD                             | 2 (to hear him describe the food); 3 (if he names your family)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |

## WHO THEY ARE

He was a stout man. Now he is a draped grey coat with a head on it, the cheeks hollowed to the teeth, the eyes sunk into blue pits that catch the table-lamp only from below, a few white hairs combed carefully across a skull spotted like an egg. His hands are knuckle and tendon, and they lift the silver fork with a delicacy that would grace a Lastgate salon, and put the nothing in his mouth, and he chews, slowly, with every appearance of delight. His voice is dry leaves, warm and full of laughter. His breath smells of acetone and, beneath it, of ripe pears. He is perfectly happy and perfectly sane.

## THEIR STORY

Hallow Crust was born in 566 in the Spit, with one of the old shameful names, and went to Splinterhall at fifteen to cleanse it. He broke two hundred and forty tables in twenty years and was an Old Breaker at thirty-four, called Brother by his band, as Old Breakers were in his day. He taught a generation the order of breaking: lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs last. He married Meagre Lowe of Hillward in 594.

On the 9th of Carving, 601, on the Long Table road, at the fourth mile, he stepped out of the string, unroped, with his axe, and sat down in an empty chair. He had told nobody. He had decided, after twenty years, to find out if a man could sit and get up again, by will, so the Breakers would know. He has been meaning to get up for forty years. After this course.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He is one of eleven thousand on the Long Table, and the most famous, because he talks. Runners trot past with wax in their ears. Measure-Bearers on the crossing road are taught to look straight ahead at the fourth mile. Splinterhall still lists him as an Old Breaker; his name is spoken on Tablenight with the living. He is a warning, a landmark, and, for those who listen too long, a host: people who stop to hear him describe a course pull out a chair.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

◇ **A silver fork** — Orrum’s, from the table. He holds it like a pen.

- ◇ **An axe-wedge** — his own, under the chair, where he dropped it on the first day. He has never looked down at it.
- ◇ **His Breaker's tally** — a knotted cord at his belt, two hundred and forty knots. He thinks it is a list of dishes.
- ◇ **A napkin** — tucked in his collar, white and pressed, changed every day by nobody.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants to get up, after this course, and go home and tell Splinterhall that it can be done. He wants someone to tell him his wife's name, which he cannot remember, though he remembers every dish he has been served since 601.

**A secret the GM can reveal:** he sat down on purpose, as a test, and has known for forty years, in some back room of himself, that he failed it. When he is very tired, in the third hour after midnight, he weeps, and goes on eating.

**A secret he does not know:** his wife, Meagre Crust, is seventy-one and alive in Hillward, and walks the Long Table road once a year on the 9th of Carving, roped, plugged, blindfolded, to stand opposite him for one minute. He has asked her each year, kindly, if she would like to join him. He has never once recognised her.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Decline Marsh** — his pupil; Decline passes him on the road and never stops, and Hallow calls after him, *Lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs, lad!*
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — she sat near him for an hour; he told her what she ate in the orchard, course by course.
- ◇ **Meagre Crust** — his wife, whom he does not know.
- ◇ **Old Breaker Wane Hollister** — trained by him; she is sleeping on the splinter heap now, and he would understand.
- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — the Steward changes his napkin, and Hallow thanks him every morning.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet him on the Long Table road. He calls them by name before they reach him.

- ◇ **The Test.** He asks a PC to take his hand and pull, gently, just to see. Beyond the cloth he will die.

- ◇ **The Wife.** Meagre Crust asks the PCs to tell him her name, once, so he will know.
- ◇ **The Order of Breaking.** A Breaker band's new Axe has stopped to listen, and the band needs someone to go and fetch him back.

Threat he does not notice. Kindness he returns with interest and a menu. To the god, he is grateful, and says so, every course. If nobody intervenes, he keeps eating, and in another century he will be a coat and a smile, and when the living pass he will turn with the others, with a sound like reeds, and look.

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#### SAID OF THEM

"He asked after my mother's chest. She died two years back. I couldn't bear to tell him. I said it was better." — a Measure-Bearer of the crossing road

"Brother Hallow taught me the order. Lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs. Chairs last. I've wondered for thirty years whether he was trying to tell us something about the chairs." — Old Breaker Wane Hollister

"He looked at me and said, you've a kind face, love, are you married? I said yes. To you. He laughed. He thought it was a joke." — Meagre Crust, of Hillward

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# THE PEOPLE OF THE FAST, CONTINUED

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*Carry your own.*

— THE WHOLE OF THE ADVICE AN UNFED MOTHER GIVES A CHILD LEAVING  
HOME

The first half of the Fast's people are those who hold it up: the Chair and his list, the Keeper and her scales, the captain and her knife, the Breaker and his axe. The people who follow are those the Fast cannot hold: a physician, a poacher, an envoy, a Reckoner who ate, a verger, a farmer, a child who came home fed, a soldier, a

pilgrim, a clerk, and a steward, very tired, walking a mile ahead of his master.

They all have one thing in common, and it is the thing the Fast is built to prevent. Each of them, in some way, has been offered something and has not managed to say no three times.

WE ARE NOT A **PEOPLE** WHO REFUSED. WE ARE A  
**PEOPLE** WHO ARE STILL REFUSING. THERE IS A  
DIFFERENCE, AND IT IS ABOUT SIX HUNDRED  
**YEARS** LONG.

[ ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL, TO THE COMPANY CONGRESS AT THIMBLE  
CROSS, 638 A.G. ]

# DR. MERCY THRANE

*the Physician of Hunger*

*“Arm, thirteen and a quarter inches at the widest. Skin pinch holds four breaths. Gums white. Pulse forty-one. She’ll see Tablenight. She won’t see Grace. Write it down; somebody must.”*

– MERCY THRANE, DICTATING TO A CLERK AT THE LEAN HOUSE DOOR, LACK  
640

| DR. MERCY THRANE – THE PHYSICIAN OF HUNGER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                 | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 5 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| AGE & STATION                              | 47 · physician without a licence, lodger in Wanting, measurer of the starving                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                         | Seamer (physician) · Standing 3 (respected; never thanked)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                                 | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS                                     | Stitching 5, Reckoning 4, Search 4, Resolve 4, Lore 3, Endure 3, Clause 2, Stealth 2, Blades 1, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                       | Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTACKS                                    | scalpel +5 (2; Piercing); she has never struck a living person in anger, and must roll Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, to begin                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                      | The Measure (with a minute’s handling she knows any person’s Pangs exactly, and with Eye + Stitching at Routine 10 how many days they have left at their present ration; on a Grace, the day). Empty Hands (spends Want as any Unfed; Nothing to Hold costs her only 1 Want against godsign that works through the body: a Fatlands Taste the Name, a Hand-line Closing, a Cradlewrack Pang). |
| WANTS                                      | To publish. To bring one of the taken home alive. To be wrong, just once, about a number.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| KNACKS                                     | Counting Habit, Mother’s Hands, Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| DERANGEMENTS                               | The Count (triggered by any list of names; she must count them, and the number is always one short, and she knows whose name is missing and does not say it)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                                    | calipers and a brass hand-scale; a surgeon’s case; the Red Ledger; a brined kidney in a jar; a plank of cupboard-wood; her mother’s chit                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                      | 1 (to watch her measure a dying person and write the number down without changing her face)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Mercy Thrane is all edges. Her collarbones stand out above a grey wool dress turned twice and darned in three colours of thread; her hair has faded to the reddish straw of long hunger and is pinned so hard it pulls her temples. Her spectacles are mended with copper wire, the left lens cracked across. She smells of the vinegar she washes her hands in, of pear-drop breath, and faintly of brine. Her hands are the warmest thing about her, because she keeps them in her armpits between patients: a physician’s hands must not be cold on bare skin. The Unfed find this her strangest habit. It looks too much like comfort.

She speaks in numbers. Asked how a child is, she gives arm-measure, weight and pulse, and only then, if pressed, whether the child is frightened. In Wanting a feeling is an appetite and a figure is a fact. With the dying she is different: she sits on the floor beside

them, which no other Unfed will do, lets them talk about food, and writes down what they say.

## THEIR STORY

Mercy was born in Wanting in 594, elder child of a Pantry Clerk. In the Lack of 611 her mother was caught giving half her measure to a neighbour’s boy in the Brink. It was the crime of feeding. Her name was left off the list for a month, which at her weight was forever, and seventeen-year-old Mercy watched her walk to the Lean House and decided that if the Fast was going to kill people with arithmetic, someone ought to keep the arithmetic honest.

She apprenticed herself, against every custom, to the Company surgeon at Brindle Cross, an Oathen man named Ambry Cole, ate only what she carried for six years, and came home in 623 to measure. By 630 she had the measures of four thousand Unfed, and in 634 she finished *Of the Body Unfed*, the only proper book on what a lifetime of hunger does to bone, blood, heart, womb and

mind. The Abstinents read the chapter stating that most Unfed women no longer bleed and that falling births are starvation, not virtue, and forbade its copying.

Then her patients began to vanish: young, healthy by Fast measure, from the border hamlets, each struck off as dead under the standing order. In 635 she crossed the Rim with her own food and a surgeon's case, and in a hired house in Sated, in a room with no west windows, she found two initials scratched behind a cupboard with a fingernail, and below them a tally of days. She cut out the plank. The trail since has led to surgeries in four countries, to the brine-tanks of Master Quillon Barr, to Lady Seraphine Dalgety of the Vigil, and to a little enamel badge shaped like a two-tined fork.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

In law Mercy has no place: the Fast does not license physicians, because a physician makes the sick comfortable, and comfort is hospitality. In practice everyone consults her and no one thanks her. Mother Stint Avery asks her privately how long a village of a given age can live on a given measure, and Mercy answers, and both women know what the question is for. Withy Gaunt lets her measure the omitted. Marshal Aldane sends for her whenever a poacher's camp is found, to read how many were taken and whether any were carried. The Reckoners use her figures to choose who is fit for a raid.

Her power is the Red Ledger, and its limit is that nobody wants to read it. The Abstinents say an Unfed taken over the border is dead. Her ledger says they are alive, kept, fed and cut, some of them for years. If she is right, the Fast's cleanest law is a lie told to save the cost of a rescue.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The Red Ledger** — a madder-dyed Company daybook holding two hundred and twelve names taken across the border since 620, with dates, last weights, and for sixty-one of them a buyer's initials. Eight factions would kill for it.
- ♦ **The cupboard plank** — a hand-length of deal scratched *A.T.* and a tally of nine hundred and seven days. She thinks it was a patient called Abate Tolly. She carries it against her ribs.
- ♦ **The jar** — a stoppered jar of brine holding an Unfed kidney, College stitches still in it, recovered from a Gut-line matriarch whose household Scant Hollis ended in 638. Her only evidence no surgeon could call forgery.
- ♦ **Calipers, tapes and a brass hand-scale** — worn to a shine; the scale weighs to the quarter-ounce, and she weighs children in a sling like oats.
- ♦ **A surgeon's case** — +1 Stitching. The bone-saw has been used twice.
- ♦ **Her mother's chit** — the last ration-chit issued to her mother, Lack 611, never spent.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Mercy wants the Red Ledger read aloud in the Pantry, every name, and the standing order repealed. She wants to walk into one of Barr's houses with Aldane's sixty spearmen and carry everyone out, and she knows exactly how many would die of the carrying. She fears the Fast will hear her and shrug: they ate on the road, so they are no longer Unfed. Wont Bellamy has said almost exactly this.

**Secret (hers):** to buy the buyers' initials, she sold the Cutwrights' College a fair copy of her four thousand measures. The price of a "Zero-line specimen" on the Rim has risen by a third since, because buyers can now be shown, in her own charts, how clean the organs are.

**Secret (unknown to her):** her younger brother, Abide Thrane, a farmer at Pollard's Rest, vanished in the Carving of 632 and is name one hundred and four in her ledger, without a buyer. The farmer called Abide whom Master Barr has kept alive between cuttings for nine years, and who has lately begun to put on weight, is her brother. The plank says *A.T.* It is not Abate Tolly.

#### TIES

- ♦ **Kale Dragoman** — set her broken wrist on the Rim in 636 and offered her supper three times. She has regretted not killing him that night.
- ♦ **Marshal Keep Aldane** — her only friend; she held his hand in 624 while the surgeon dug out a bolt.
- ♦ **Withy Gaunt** — lets her measure the omitted and hates the tapes.
- ♦ **Mother Stint Avery** — asks the questions nobody else will.
- ♦ **Abide Kettering** — Mercy has noticed the Lean House dead go into the ground lighter than they came out. She has not yet weighed the sacks.
- ♦ **Master Quillon Barr** — admires her book and has twice sent her better spectacles. She smashed both.
- ♦ **Scour** — came to her at midnight to have his forearms measured; she has told no one.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Mercy when she hires them to bring a body home: a taken Unfed traced to a hired house on the Rim, alive. She pays in medical care, worth more than coin in the Fast, and wants the PCs' measures before and after.

- ♦ **The House with No West Windows.** In Lastgate three Unfed are kept in brine-tanks to the neck, fed by tube. One asks the PCs to leave her. She is warm for the first time in her life.
- ♦ **Name One Hundred and Four.** A captured poacher, bargaining, mentions a farmer in Barr's surgery who talks about his sister the doctor. Mercy is in the next room.
- ♦ **The Ledger Read Aloud.** She has won an open session of the Abstinents; someone has bribed a Lister to strike her name the morning after.



Under threat she counts aloud to keep her hands still. Kindness she checks for an offer, refuses three times, and is rude about the fourth. Of Orrum she says, “The god has more manners than the surgeons. It has never once taken a patient from me.” If nobody intervenes, she goes over the Rim alone in the spring of 642 to the house where her brother is kept, and does not come back, and the Red Ledger turns up for sale at Thimble Cross with one new name in it, in a different hand.

#### SAID OF THEM

“She weighed my boy in her little sling like a sack of meal, and then she sat on my floor and held my hand while he went. I’d never had anyone sit on my floor.” — a widow of the border hamlets

“Dr. Thrane is a credit to the Fast, which is why the Fast must never, on any account, credit her.” — Elder Wont Bellamy, in council

“Her book’s the only reason my stock lives to the surgery. I keep meaning to write and thank her.” — Kale Dragoman

# KALE DRAGOMAN

the Poacher

*“There now. Slow. Little sips. Your belly’s forgotten how. That’s my brave lad. No, don’t cry on it, you’ll salt it.”*

– KALE DRAGOMAN, SPOON-FEEDING A CAPTIVE ON THE RIM, OVERHEARD BY A HOSTWATCH TRACKER

| KALE DRAGOMAN – THE POACHER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | The Fatlands (born in the Fast) · Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood, so the College says) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION               | 35 · poacher, cook, and the best-liked criminal on the eastern Rim                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING          | Crumb-Runner (in reverse) · Standing 3 (Route-Holder; a route of his own and three runners)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                      | Wayfaring 4, Feast 4, Brawl 3, Shooting 3, Persuade 3, Haggle 3, Craft (cooking) 3, Stitching 2, Endure 2, Search 2, Blades 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                        | Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (boiled leather under a good brown coat) · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| ATTACKS                     | weighted cosh +6 (3; Stunning; on a Helping, Gut + Endure Hard 14 or senseless); throwing net +6 (target held; Lung + Athletics Hard 14 to escape); crossbow +6 (4); skinning knife +5 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| GIFTS                       | Iron Belly (Fatlands Taste: +2 Feast; eats anything). Taste the Name (Fatlands Appetite: a drop of a captive’s blood tells him family, Cut and one shameful meal; he uses it to price them). Gorge (1d6 Flesh by eating heavily, once a scene). The Kind Spoon (once a day, an offer of his food is so warm that an Unfed who hears it must spend 1 Want or make an Invitation check at Hard 14; on a failure they eat). |
| WANTS                       | The Hollow (when anyone near him refuses food he must make them eat, with words and then with hands; Hard 14 to resist, and he rarely tries). The Second Plate. Someone to thank him.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                      | Table Manners, Hostage’s Smile (used in reverse, on his captives)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                | none yet                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                     | cosh, net, crossbow; a copper stewpot; a wheeled iron cage; a pirated book; a two-tined fork badge; a wooden spoon                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                       | 1 (to see a captive eat); 2 (to watch him lick a captive’s cut to price them)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## WHO THEY ARE

Kale is big, ruddy and handsome in the Fatlands way, his size all appetite and none of it softness: heavy jowls that shake when he laughs, beautiful white teeth he cleans with a willow twig after every meal, small clever brown eyes, hands like a baker’s. He wears a good brown Rim coat over boiled leather, a red neckcloth, and a bay leaf in his hatband, and he smells always of woodsmoke and roast fat and onions softened in dripping. His voice is a rolling eastern burr, the voice of a man who has called a great many people *my love* and meant it each time. He eats constantly from his pockets, and when he cannot see food his eyes go to the corners of the room.

His captives do not describe a monster. They say he was patient. They say that on the third night, when they had refused his stew nine times and could no longer stand, he sat behind them on the ground with his arms around them like a father with a sick child, touched broth-soaked bread to their lips, and waited, humming, for

as long as it took. They say they hated him most when they swallowed.

## THEIR STORY

Kale was born in the Fast in the Lack of 606. He does not know this. He was raised in the drovers’ village of Callock Green on the eastern Fatlands by a drover named Hob Dragoman, who told him his mother died of the milk-fever and showed him a grave that is empty. Hob bought the baby at Brindle Cross for a sack of oats from a frightened Unfed girl of twenty-three, for reasons he took into the ground in 629. Kale grew up enormous, well loved and never full. At his first Weighing the Board’s assessors read his tells and wrote him down as Cut 2. At nineteen, droving at Brindle Cross, he bought a drink for a man in a grey coat who asked whether he had ever seen an Unfed up close, and whether he could cook.

He has poached since 627: a hundred and sixty taken, a hundred and four delivered. The rest refused his food and died on the road, and he buried each himself, decently, Fatlands-fashion, which means after a wake, which means he ate them. In 634 he learned from a pirated copy of a physician's book that most of his captives were dying of eating too fast, and learned to feed them slowly: broth, then milk, then soft bread, then meat. His deliveries nearly doubled. In 638 a new buyer came, a man with a two-tined fork pinned inside his lapel, who paid in gold and asked for children. Kale said no three times, which he thought was funny at the time. The fourth time, the price was very high.

#### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Kale is part of how the Fast works, the way a wolf is part of how a flock works. His route runs up the Rim to Brindle Cross and north along the border hamlets, where Unfed walk out at dusk to fetch water. His hired men Odo and Fenn do the lifting and do not look at the cage. A Company toll-clerk seals his cage-wagon as "Pantry grain, returned spoiled"; a sexton on the Fast side sells him the very freshly dead. He pays for information in food, and there are border families who leave their gates unlatched on certain nights because he leaves a sack of oats at the post. That is the part of his trade the Abstinents do not discuss. Marshal Aldane has orders to kill him on sight, and has twice found the range too long.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The copper stewpot** — never allowed to go cold on the road. It smells, the captives say, exactly like their mothers' houses, though their mothers never had a pot. A captive within smell of it at night makes an Invitation check at Routine 10.
- ◇ **The iron cage** — wheeled, barred, straw-floored, a wool blanket for each. It is clean. He cleans it himself.
- ◇ **The book** — a pirated copy of Mercy Thrane's *Of the Body Unfed*, the margins thick with grease-pencil: *broth 3 days, then milk, watch the ankles, the girl from Pollard's Rest, too fast, lost her*. He calls it his Bible and would love to meet the author.
- ◇ **The badge** — an enamel fork with two tines, a token to show at certain houses. He has no idea it is a confession.
- ◇ **A boxwood spoon** — long-handled, worn thin on one side. It is the spoon he feeds them with.
- ◇ **The wake-kit** — knife, steel, salt, bay and rosemary. Used fifty-six times.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Kale wants to be liked, so badly that it is the nearest thing he has to a conscience; he will spend days winning a smile from someone he is delivering to a surgeon. He wants to be thanked, once, by an Unfed who means it. He fears empty larders, silence, and the man with the badge, who asked for children and smiled when Kale refused.

**Secret (unknown to him):** the god in him is not his father's. It is Ummer, eaten into an empty Unfed body spoonful by spoonful

from his first week, which is why he has never once been full. Master Quillon Barr, who examined him once in Sated, knows the god grew in him from the mouth down and never reached his kidneys. They are as blank as the day he was born. Barr has priced them at nine thousand lacks and is waiting for a reason.

**Secret (GM):** his mother is Withy Gaunt, Matron of the Lean House. She named him at three months, when he first turned from the breast, and wrote the name in the back of the Book of the Omitted: *Decline*.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Withy Gaunt** — his mother, unknown to them both.
- ◇ **Abide Kettering** — supplies the freshly dead; Kale despises him for selling the dead instead of honouring them with a wake, and pays him well.
- ◇ **Dr. Mercy Thrane** — he set her wrist, offered her supper three times, and owns her book. He admires her more than anyone alive.
- ◇ **Marshal Keep Aldane** — once left a roast fowl on the Brindle Cross fence: *for the lads, no offence meant*.
- ◇ **Osanna Blythe** — a Callock Green girl he knew at wakes; he has fed her pilgrims twice for nothing, the only charity of his life.
- ◇ **Lady Vellum Serrat and the Second Table** — his buyers since 638.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Kale across a campfire on the Rim, where he offers supper three times and then a fourth, warmly, with a joke about Unfed manners. He wants guides, guards, or, if they are hunting him, to talk them out of it over a very good stew.

- ◇ **The Fourth Offer.** His buyer wants two children from Wanting before Tablenight, at a price that would let Kale retire. He wants the PCs to help him refuse, which means killing the buyer, and cannot ask outright.
- ◇ **Decline.** Withy Gaunt finds a strip of red neckcloth in a dead woman's sack, smells woodsmoke on it, and asks the PCs where it came from.
- ◇ **The Kidneys.** Barr's men take Kale. His captives, locked in the cage in the woods, will starve; one is a PC's friend. Kale will say where, if the PCs get him out.

Threatened, he fights well and without rage and surrenders the moment he is losing, with an offer of dinner. Kindness undoes him. Of Orrum he is envious: "There's a cook who knows his business." If nobody intervenes, he takes the price at the end of Lack, delivers the children, goes home to Callock Green, and eats until it kills him a year later, at a wake held in his honour, still not full.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“He held my head up so I wouldn’t choke. Every night. I’d have liked him to hit me. I’d know what to do with that.” — Tally Rooke, escaped captive, living in shame in Wanting

“Lovely fellow. Pays on the nail. Never asks for a receipt.” — the Company toll-clerk at Brindle Cross

“I had him in the sights at six hundred yards and he was laughing at something and I didn’t shoot. I’m putting that in my report. Somebody should know.” — Marshal Keep Aldane

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# ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL

*the Voice of the Clean*

*“No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you. Now, my lords: the Hand-lines of Lastgate stood at an average Regrowth of six and one third at Carving last. It is seven this Lack. I have the figures, if anyone has the stomach.”*

– PRUDENCE LOWELL, OPENING HER REMARKS TO A COMPANY CONGRESS, 640 A.G.

| ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL – THE VOICE OF THE CLEAN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                     | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                                  | 50 · Envoy of the Abstinent to the Rim Road and the six lands; office at Wanting Post                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING                             | Clausewright (diplomat) · Standing 4 (her word binds the Fast, so far as anything does)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| ATTRIBUTES                                     | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| SKILLS                                         | Clause 5, Lore 5 (the Regrowth of every land), Persuade 4, Resolve 4, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Hagggle 2, Deceive 1, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| BODY                                           | Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTACKS                                        | a steel bodkin she uses to slit seals +2 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                                          | The Register (with Eye + Lore at Routine 10 she can state the published Regrowth of any High Cut house on the Table, and on a Grace its private one). Refused in Fourteen Capitals (she gains Want from refusing hospitality even when she is not hungry; any host who offers her a fourth time must succeed at Tongue + Persuade vs Grim 18 or lose face before the room). |
| WANTS                                          | To read the numbers aloud until somebody listens. To keep the Refusal clean, whatever it costs a historian. Never to dream of a particular face again.                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                                         | No Thank You, Table Manners                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS                                   | The Watchers (triggered by being alone with strangers; she believes every legation keeps a file on her, and she is right)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                                        | the Register of Damnation; credentials on Pantry linen; a stick of chalk; an unanswered letter; a list of four names                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                                          | 1 (to hear her recite a family's Regrowth to their faces)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

She is a lath of a woman, very upright, in a black wool coat with a high collar buttoned to the throat and twenty-two jet buttons down the front, which she does up every morning in the same order. Her face is long and colourless, the cheeks hollow, the mouth thin and exact. Her grey hair is cropped short as a Reckoner's under a plain black cap. Her voice is the thing people remember: low, dry, perfectly carrying, with every consonant cut clean, a voice like a cold chisel set to stone. She smells of the lye soap the Fast makes from Rim ashes and of nothing else at all, because she eats so little that her breath has gone past pear-drops into a kind of clean metal. She stands at every meeting. She has not sat down in public in nineteen years.

In fourteen capitals she is known on sight and dreaded. Servants have learned not to bring the tray toward her. Hosts offer three times, because they must, and she refuses three times, audibly, and then turns to the wall and takes out her ration-cloth and eats half an

oatcake standing, facing the plaster, while the room tries not to watch. Then she turns back and reads the figures.

## THEIR STORY

Prudence was born in 591 to a Measure-Bearer family of Wanting, and showed early the two gifts the Fast values in a diplomat: a perfect memory for numbers and an absolute incapacity for pleasure. The Abstinent sent her to the Rim at twenty-three as clerk to the old Envoy, Withhold Pruett, Hollow Ann's elder brother, and when he died at his post in 622, standing, she was given his room above a chandler's at Wanting Post and his credentials, and his list.

In the Vigil, in 633, at a reception in the lamplit hall of the Watch, a junior envoy named Oriel Vance offered her a cup of watered wine. She refused three times. He offered a fourth time, quietly, not as manners, looking at her as though she were a person who might be thirsty. She very nearly took it. Her hand moved. She has dreamed of his face every night since. He wrote to her once, in 634. She has not opened the letter.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Fast has one ambassador, and she is it. She receives callers standing in a bare stone office off the yard at Wanting Post, the only Company station that faces the middle, and she sleeps in the room above the chandler's across the lane, with her pallet's head to the door. She negotiates nothing, because the Fast has nothing to offer; her duty is to remind. She also handles every matter the Rim governments raise about the Reckoners, and handles it by declining to admit they exist. She carries the Abstinents' letters to Factor Mardle about the grain, and Mardle's letters back, and she knows the grain is short. She does not know why.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Register of Damnation** — four ledgers in black buckram, one per decade since 601, in which she and her predecessor have recorded the published and rumoured Regrowth of every High Cut house on the Table. It is the best such record outside the Cutwrights' College, and more honest.
- ◇ **Credentials** — a square of Pantry linen stamped with the empty bowl and the marks of every Elder of the Abstinents, folded in eight, worn at the folds to gauze.
- ◇ **A stick of white chalk** — in each capital, on the wall she faced while eating, she makes one small mark at the height of her eyes: a short horizontal stroke, like a table seen edge on. There are fourteen in the world. She tells no one.
- ◇ **The letter** — from Oriel Vance of the Vigil, sealed with grey wax, unopened since 634. The corners have gone soft from handling.
- ◇ **A list in her own hand** — four names, for the Abstinents: people she recommends be left off the winter list "for the safety of the Refusal." The first is Meek Garrity's.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Prudence wants the Refusal kept, because it is the only thing her life has been for. If the Unfed did not refuse, she has spent twenty-seven years telling six nations they were damned on the authority of a lie, and every wall in fourteen capitals has her mark on it for nothing. She has heard of Meek Garrity's seating plan, and she will do anything to keep him quiet.

**Secret (hers):** she has written to Forbear Wend asking that Meek Garrity's name be left off the list. It is the first time she has ever asked for a death. She has told herself it is not one, because nobody pronounces it.

**Secret (unknown to her):** her dispatches are copied in the Company post-house at Wanting Post before they go up the road, and the copies are bought by Lord Absalom Thrane's people for the Second Table. The Register of Damnation is the Second Table's menu-calendar. Every land she has read aloud as ripening, the Table has tasted within the year.

## TIES

- ◇ **Meek Garrity** — the man who could unmake her. She has met him once, and found him gentle, and wants him dead.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — her master, to whom she writes every week. He has not answered her letter about Garrity.
- ◇ **Dr. Mercy Thrane** — has asked her three times to speak for the taken. Prudence has refused three times. Neither has made the fourth offer.
- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — met her on the Rim Road at night in 640 and asked, very courteously, if she was dining alone. She says the Decline at every stranger now.
- ◇ **Oriel Vance** — the Vigil envoy who offered four times. He is now blinking badly, in the Course, and has asked to be posted to Wanting Post.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Prudence when she needs Unfed escorts to a congress, or when a PC from a High Cut house hears her read their family's numbers aloud in public. She wants protection, couriers, and, though she would never say so, someone to talk to: on the road, at night, facing outward, she will talk about numbers for hours to anyone who stands with their back to her back.

- ◇ **The Fourteenth Wall.** In Lastgate a host has scrubbed her chalk mark from the wall and written below it, in chalk, a second stroke and a third, and a word. She wants the PCs to find out who.
- ◇ **Garrity's Omission.** The PCs are asked to carry her sealed letter to Forbear Wend. If they read it, they know what she has asked for.
- ◇ **Oriel Vance at the Gate.** The Vigil envoy arrives at Wanting Post, unable to sleep, bringing her a cup of wine he has carried four hundred miles, and asks once more.

Threatened, she reads the threatener's numbers to them. Kindness she treats as an offer, and refuses, three times. Of the god she says only, "The Host has excellent manners. It is the guests I object to." If nobody intervenes, she reads the numbers at Thimble Cross on Tablenight 641, and a man she has damned stabs her in the throat with a fork, and she dies standing, and nobody in the room offers her anything at all.

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#### SAID OF THEM

“She came in, said no three times, ate her biscuit at my wall, and then told my mistress how many of her children would be born with doors. I’ve worked for the gentry twenty years. Best day of my life.”  
— a housemaid of the Tally House, Cradlewrack

“Envoy Lowell has never been wrong about a number. That is what makes her unbearable, and what makes her useful.” — Factor Joss Mardle

“I offered a fourth time. I would do it again. She is the thirstiest person I have ever met.” — Oriel Vance, under-envoy of the Watch

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# SCOUR

## the Returned

*“I carried my own. I carried my own the whole year. I just ate theirs too.”*

– SCOUR, TO SCANT HOLLIS, THE ONLY TIME HE HAS SPOKEN OF IT

| SCOUR – THE RETURNED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT           | The Fast (Returned) · Cut 1 (Ummer, acquired; Seasoning 3) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste, advancing) · Hunger 7                                                                                                                                                     |
| AGE & STATION        | 30 · Reckoner Knife, volunteer for every raid, secret godsign                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING   | Reckoner · Standing 2 (Reckoner; his own targets)                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTRIBUTES           | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| SKILLS               | Blades 4, Brawl 3, Stealth 3, Endure 3, Deceive 3, Resolve 2, Wayfaring 2, Search 1                                                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                 | Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (Reckoner greys, patched) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS              | black-iron knife +8 (2; +4 against an unaware target, In Their Beds); bite +5 (1; he must make a Want check not to swallow)                                                                                                                                   |
| GIFTS                | Partakes as a Fatlander of Cut 1. The Empty Room (his Tooth bites back on a 1 or 2; each time his Hunger empties his Regrowth rises by 2). Iron Belly (+2 Feast; can eat soil, tallow, leather). Lost Refusal (Want 0, forever; Orrum lays no place for him). |
| WANTS                | The Second Plate (Hard 14; Grim 18 for meat). Eating without choosing: soil, tallow, leather. Lately, at the bedside, the sleeping (Grim 18 to turn away).                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS               | Silent Supper, Butcher’s Calm                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DERANGEMENTS         | Not My Hand (his forearms; triggered by exhaustion or Hunger 6+, when the fingers dig)                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CARRIES              | a black-iron knife; a bag of river sand; a christening spoon; buttoned sleeves; a ration-bag he does not need                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                | 2 (to see his forearms)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

### WHO THEY ARE

Scour is lean and fox-faced, with a narrow jaw, a sharp nose, sandy hair cut short and badly with his own knife, and pale lashes that make his eyes look lidless in lamplight. He wears Reckoner greys, the leather cured without fat, and his sleeves are always buttoned to the knuckle; he has sewn extra buttons on so that the cuffs close over the backs of his hands. He moves very quietly and stands very still, and the stillness is wrong: an Unfed’s stillness is the economy of the starving, and Scour has the stillness of a man holding something down. He is broader than he was. Other Knives notice that he does not seem to tire.

Under the sleeves, from the elbow to the wrist, his skin has gone soft and warm and faintly loamy, dark as turned earth after rain, and through it run fine pale threads like root-hairs, which move a little when he is hungry. When he scrubs it with sand, which he does every night until it bleeds, the blood smells of a ploughed field.

### THEIR STORY

He was born Spurn Hatch in 611, in a hamlet near Corve Hatch where his family had always lived beside the bricked-up window and been ashamed of it. He went to the west gate at sixteen, carried on

his first raid at seventeen, and became a Knife at nineteen on a Gut-line house in the eastern Fatlands, where he killed the matriarch, Dame Hessop Callock, in her bed. She woke as he did it and said, very clearly, *oh, you poor thin thing*.

In 636 Scant Hollis needed a man inside Paunch Hall, a Gut-line seat south of Sated, to map the household and its kin before a raid. Spurn volunteered. He hired on as a renderer’s labourer in the Hall’s kitchens. He carried his own food, and found in the first week that a labourer who does not eat at the long table is noticed, and that a noticed man is a dead raid. He ate. He ate their meat for a year, in the warm loud kitchens, at the five daily meals the Feasting Laws require, and he mapped every bed in Paunch Hall, and the raid came, and he let the Knives in through the coal-hole and helped end the Paunch line, eldest first. He came home in 637 with three marks of Seasoning and his forearms going soft. The Knives saw him scrub them at the stream with sand on the first night and gave him the name that has replaced his own.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Officially Scour is a Knife of good standing who has ended two lines. In practice he is a secret the Reckoners keep badly. Scant Hollis suspects; the Unblooded oath was made stricter because of



him, so that every new recruit swears on Hallowboard to eat nothing on the far side of the Hem, and he stood in the trench and watched them swear it. He draws a full measure on campaign and gives it away on the road, which is the crime of feeding, and which nobody reports because the Knives he gives it to are hungry. He volunteers for every raid because on a raid he can carry his own food and refuse it, and because the raid is clean, and because he wants to die doing something clean. He has not yet been given the chance. The god in him keeps him alive.

If the Abstinent learn what he is, his name comes off the list that day. Thereafter, the Second Table is waiting on the Rim with a dinner invitation.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The black-iron knife** — a Reckoner blade, unadorned, the handle wrapped in ration-cloth. He has started cleaning it with his tongue and has to stop himself.
- ◇ **A bag of river sand** — coarse, grey, from the stream below Wanting. He scrubs his arms with it every night. Once he ate a handful.
- ◇ **A christening spoon** — silver, small, engraved with a Paunch cradle-name, *Pudding*. He found it in his coat pocket on the road home from Paunch Hall and does not know how it got there. He did not take it. He cannot throw it away.
- ◇ **Buttoned sleeves** — nine extra bone buttons on each cuff, sewn in by hand.
- ◇ **A ration-bag** — full. He does not need it now. He carries it the way a widower keeps setting a place.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Scour wants to be clean, and knows he cannot be. He wants to die on a raid. He wants, worse than either, to eat: not food, nothing so honest, but soil and tallow and leather and, lately, standing over the sleeping Godeaters at the bedside, the smell of the well-fed in their beds. He fears the nursery more than the knife. He fears Tobias Wether, whom he has never met and dreams of every night.

**Secret (his):** the god in him has begun to talk, in the voice of Dame Hessop Callock, the first woman he killed. It is kind to him. It calls him *you poor thin thing*. It tells him where the food is.

**Secret (unknown to him):** the Returned lose the Refusal, and Orrum lays no place for them. But in the last month, twice, Scour has woken on the road with a table laid in sight of his blanket: a bare board, a single plate, a chair pushed in square with its back to him, and no card at all. The Tablebreakers who smashed the second one say it was cold to the touch. Orrum's tables are always warm. Somebody else is setting a place for Scour, and for Tobias Wether too, and both of them dream of a long dim room where it is being laid.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — his captain, who sent him into Paunch Hall and has not asked him a single question since he came back. He would die for her. She may have to kill him.
- ◇ **Tobias Wether** — the other Unfed who ate; they have never met, show identical signs at the same hour, and both close every door behind them.
- ◇ **Dr. Mercy Thrane** — measured his forearms at midnight in 640 and told him how long. He did not ask her to keep it secret. She has.
- ◇ **Wont Bellamy** — has guessed, and has written to the Second Table that he may soon have “a dish of rare interest” for them.
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — he envies her: a table laid for her every night. He has walked past her lodging in the dark three times just to smell it.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Scour on a raid, when one of them sees him alone at the edge of a Farlands field at night, eating dirt. What he wants from them is silence, and if he cannot have silence, a quick death on the next raid, in a bed-chamber, doing something clean.

- ◇ **What the Spoon Says.** Pudding Paunch, the child whose spoon he carries, was not in the nursery the night of the raid. She is alive, fourteen, and the last of the Paunch line, and the Reckoners have just learned where she is. Scour volunteers.
- ◇ **The Cold Table.** A third cold table appears beside Scour's blanket while the PCs are with him. It has a card this time. The card is blank.
- ◇ **Two Places Laid.** Scour and Tobias Wether vanish on the same night from guarded rooms a hundred miles apart. The PCs are hired by Scant Hollis to find one and by the Board of Plenty to find the other.

Threatened, he fights like a Knife, quickly and low, and must make a Want check not to bite. Kindness frightens him, because it smells. Of Orrum he says nothing at all. If nobody intervenes, Scour's comrades find out at the end of Lack; his name is struck, and he walks to the Rim, where a man with a two-tined fork badge serves him supper and then, some months later, serves him.

#### SAID OF THEM

“He gives his measure away on the road. Feeding's a crime. I've had his oatcake three times. I'm not reporting anybody.” — Refrain Cobb, Reckoner Knife

“There's a man at the Hall used to work so hard in the kitchens. Ate like one of us. I wonder what became of him.” — a Paunch Hall laundress, since dismissed, there being no more Paunches

“He came back heavier. You do not come back heavier. I have said nothing because I need him. I will say nothing until I do not.” — Scant Hollis

# VERGER SOBER OSMOND

## Keeper of the Empty Chair

*“A place for the Host, a place for each of the household, and a place kept for the one who comes late. That’s the old Laying. I only do the first part now. The household’s gone, and I don’t know who’s late.”*

– SOBER OSMOND, TO A HOSTWATCH PIN-SETTER, CARVING 640

| VERGER SOBER OSMOND – KEEPER OF THE EMPTY CHAIR |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                      | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 7 · Pangs 5 (Gaunt)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                                   | 79 · Verger of the last temple of Orrum; condemned eleven times; never removed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                              | Celebrant (of a forbidden rite) · Standing 1 (the Abstinent pretend he is not there)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ATTRIBUTES                                      | Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                                          | Rites 5, Resolve 4, Lore 4, Craft 3 (linen, pewter, the folding of napkins), Instinct 3, Endure 2, Persuade 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| BODY                                            | Flesh 11 (9 at Gaunt) · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                                         | none; he would sooner lay you a place                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                           | The Kept Place (while he lays the head place each night, no table of Orrum’s appears within six miles of the Empty Chair; the Hostwatch have checked). The Old Laying (he knows the pre-Gorging rite of setting the Host’s place; anyone who performs it with him at Rites Hard 14 gains +4 to their next Invitation check, as though the god had been answered and need not ask). |
| WANTS                                           | To find a successor before he dies. To know who eats from the plate.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                          | Elder’s Ear, Old Grief                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| DERANGEMENTS                                    | none; he is the sanest man in the Fast, which the Abstinent find hardest of all to forgive                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                         | the temple plate; the Laying-book; a ring of temple keys; a darning needle; an empty pew-card                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DREAD                                           | 0 (to see him at work, which is the most frightening thing about him)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

### WHO THEY ARE

Sober Osmond is stooped almost into a hook, with soft white hair like thistledown, a pink scalp, watery blue eyes, and a sweet vague smile that does not quite land on anyone. His long black cassock has gone green at the seams and is darned at the elbows with white thread, because white is what he has. He smells of beeswax and old linen and the cold stone of the hall, and very faintly, on his hands, of the bread smell he has stopped noticing. His voice is light and pleasant and given to little hums. He talks to the hall as he works, the way an old man talks to a cat. He is very kind, and very thin, and he moves along the great table with one hand on its edge for balance, touching each place as he passes it, as though counting heads.

### THEIR STORY

He was born in 562 in the cottage beside the Empty Chair. The Osmonds have been its vergers since before the Temple Pulling of 97 A.G., when the Unfed pulled down every other house of the Host and left this one, for reasons the family tells differently in each

generation. Sober’s grandmother said the Pullers came with hammers, found the long table laid for the whole parish with every plate hot, and went home without a word. Sober’s father said it was simply too far to walk. Sober himself has stopped guessing.

He married late, a quiet woman named Cease, who died in 619. They had no children. In the Lack of 620, alone in the hall, he took the old temple plate out of the press and laid one place at the head of the table, for the first time in his family’s memory, because it seemed rude not to. In the morning the plate was clean, wiped, faintly warm. He has done it every night since: twenty-one years, seven thousand and some nights. The Abstinent have condemned him eleven times in open session. They have never sent anyone to stop him.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Empty Chair stands six miles west of Wanting in a beech wood, a long honey-coloured hall with a slate roof and one table running its whole length, set with places carved into the board for every worshipper of a parish that no longer exists. Sober lives in the

cottage, draws a measure he collects once a week on foot, and keeps the hall swept and the pewter polished. The Hostwatch know what he does and quietly value it: their Great Map shows a hole six miles wide around the Empty Chair where no table has been laid in twenty-one years, the only such hole in the Fast. Spare Tolland visits him each Carving and leaves without saying why. The Tablebreakers hate him, and are forbidden by the Abstinents to touch the hall; they say that a Verger who lays a place for the god is doing the god's work for it. Sober says that is exactly the point.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The temple plate** — a pewter platter, a horn cup, and a linen napkin he folds each night into the shape of a bird. They are older than the Gorging. The napkin is darned in eleven places, one for each condemnation.
- ◇ **The Laying-book** — a small octavo of the old rite in the pre-Gorging hand, with his family's notes in four centuries of ink. Its last line is the one he no longer says: *and a place kept for the one who comes late*. Meek Garrity would give his eyes for it.
- ◇ **The temple keys** — an iron ring of nine keys. There are eight doors.
- ◇ **An empty pew-card** — a small brass frame screwed to the foot of the great table, opposite the head, where each family's name card once slid in. It is the only one of the parish frames that never held a card. He polishes it every week.
- ◇ **A darning needle and a spool of white thread** — for the napkin, and his cassock, and anything else that comes apart.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Sober wants a successor, and he wants one of the PCs. He fears dying, because then nobody will lay the place, and he believes, rightly, that the god has stayed gentle in this parish because someone keeps faith with it. **Secret (his):** for the past month the morning plate has not been clean. It has had a single crumb on it, white and soft and smelling of nothing, as though someone had eaten and, being a well-mannered guest, left a little. He has kept the crumbs in a twist of paper. There are thirty-one. **Secret (unknown to him):** every night at the hour he lays the place, Orrum comes to the door of the hall and stands there, stooping, until dawn, and goes away before he wakes. The warm print of its feet on the flagstones is gone by the time he sweeps. It has never once come in. The crumb is not its leaving. It has been standing in the doorway, watching someone else eat from its plate.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Spare Tolland** — visits each Carving; the two old men talk about the god like neighbours discussing a difficult relative.
- ◇ **Decline Marsh** — wants to break the great table; Sober once offered him tea, three times, and then a fourth, and Marsh has never forgiven him.

- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — has stood at the hall door and thanked him. It is the only table in the world he did not lay.
- ◇ **Meek Garrity** — wants the Laying-book; Sober will lend it only to whoever takes up the duty.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — condemned him eleven times and, in 633, walked here alone on a stick to sit in the hall for an hour.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to the Empty Chair to shelter, to hunt a rumour, or because the Hostwatch sent them. Sober asks one of them to stay and learn the duty, and to say yes only after three refusals.

- ◇ **The Thirty-Second Crumb.** Sober asks the PCs to sit up in the hall and see who eats. Something does. They do not see it. In the morning the horn cup has been drunk from.
- ◇ **The Twelfth Condemnation.** The Abstinents finally send a Tablebreaker to break the table. Sober will not resist. The Hostwatch beg the PCs to stop it.
- ◇ **The Successor.** Sober dies in his sleep in Lack. Nobody lays the place. The next morning there are tables in every house for six miles.

Threatened, he hums and keeps polishing. Kindness he receives with genuine delight, and then forgets. Of the god he says, "It only wants to be let do its job." If nobody intervenes, he dies in the Lack of 641, and the six-mile hole on the Hostwatch map fills in a single night.

#### SAID OF THEM

"He's laying it for the god. Of course he is. Somebody has to make the bastard a plate." — Old Breaker Wont Fennick, drunk on Rim cider

"I used to throw stones at his windows when I was a boy. Then I grew up and I'd like to say sorry, and I can't make myself walk out there." — a Measure-Bearer of Wanting

"The only man in six hundred years to set the Host's place and not sit at it. That is either holiness or the best manners in the world. Possibly they are the same." — Spare Tolland

# YIELD HARTSELL

the Farmer

*“Somebody should. That’s the whole of it. Somebody should, and nobody was, so I did.  
Fifty springs. Don’t make it a sermon.”*

– YIELD HARTSELL, TO A PANTRY CLERK ASKING WHY SHE BUYS SEED INSTEAD OF OATS

| YIELD HARTSELL – THE FARMER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 8 · Pangs 7 (Wasting)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION               | 70 · widow, smallholder of Hartsell’s Field, keeper of the only living crop in the Fast                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CALLING & STANDING          | Gleaner (farmer of a dead field) · Standing 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| SKILLS                      | Labor 4, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Craft 3 (husbandry, hurdles, thatch), Instinct 3, Wayfaring 2, Search 2, Blades 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| BODY                        | Flesh 15 (11 at Wasting) · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                     | hayfork +5 (3; Reach)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                       | Fifty Springs (Yield knows soil as a Seamer knows flesh; she can tell by smell and handling whether ground has been walked by Orrum, a Fatlands root, or something else, at Eye + Craft Routine 10; on a Grace she knows how long ago). Hard Old Thing (once a day, ignore all Pang penalties for one scene; then take 1d6 Flesh). |
| WANTS                       | To know who waters the wheat. To see it set seed. To be left alone.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| KNACKS                      | Cold Supper, Strong Back                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| DERANGEMENTS                | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                     | a hayfork; a horn lantern; fifty twists of rotted seed; tin cans and twine; her husband’s whetstone                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                       | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## WHO THEY ARE

Yield is small, wiry and bowlegged, brown as a walnut from fifty years in the faint sun of the eastern margin, with white hair under a man’s felt hat and a face cracked into a thousand lines, most of them from laughing at things nobody else finds funny. Her thumbs are split and black-nailed from the soil. She wears a smock patched with sacking and her dead husband’s boots stuffed with straw. Her voice is cracked and dry and full of the Fast’s flat vowels, and she uses as few words as she can, because words cost breath. She smells of earth and wool and lantern-oil, and lately of the acetone sourness of a body in the Wasting, because she has been trading her ration-chits to Crumb-Runners for seed every spring for fifty years.

## THEIR STORY

She was born Yield Hollis in 571, a cousin of the Reckoner-Captain’s grandmother, and married Hesitate Hartsell at nineteen. The Hartsells had held ten acres on the south slope north of Wanting since before the Gorging and had not ploughed them since. In the spring of 591, in her first year as a wife, Yield borrowed

an ox from a Crumb-Runner, ploughed the ten acres and sowed them with Rim wheat bought with a month of her measure. The seed rotted in a week. She did it again the next year. Hesitate thought she was mad, and then, slowly, thought she was right, and helped her for twenty-eight springs until he died in 619. Their son Bare became a Reckoner and did not come back from a raid in 627. Yield sowed the field that spring as well.

This spring, in the north-east corner, one seed came up. It is now a single blade of green wheat, four inches tall.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Yield is a joke in Wanting, a kindly one, the old woman who wastes her measure on seed. She is also a quiet reproach: the only Unfed in six hundred years to go on doing the ordinary work of a farmer in a land where ordinary work is futile. Tarry Moss sells her seed at cost each spring, the only thing he sells at cost. Mother Stint Avery has her name on the list of the furthest and oldest, and knows it. Since the blade came up, everyone wants it: the Abstemious want it burned, the Hostwatch want it watched, the Second Table, through Wont

Bellamy, wants it stolen, and Osanna Blythe's pilgrims want to kneel to it.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A hayfork** — ash-shafted, three-tined, older than she is. She sits up with it across her knees.
- ◇ **A horn lantern** — she lights it at dusk and puts it out at dawn, every night now.
- ◇ **Fifty twists of seed** — one rotted grain from each spring's sowing, wrapped in cloth and labelled with the year in charcoal. She does not know why she keeps them. They are the field's ledger.
- ◇ **Tin cans and twine** — the tripwire round the hurdles, hung with every can she could beg.
- ◇ **Hesitate's whetstone** — she sharpens the fork with it and says his name.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Yield wants to know who waters the wheat. Each morning the soil around the blade is wet, and there are no footprints, and the frost around the field is gone in a wide ring as though something large had knelt there. She is more frightened than she has ever been, and happier. **Secret (hers):** she has started leaving the gate of the inner fence open at night, a hand's width, the way you would for a neighbour. **Secret (unknown to her):** the Hostwatch frost-marker chalk, which goes pink on ground Orrum has walked, stays white inside the ring. Spare Tolland tested it and has told no one. The frost is gone, but the ground beneath is not warm. It is cold, colder than the frost was, cold as a cellar, and the cold goes down further than a spade can dig. Whatever kneels by her wheat at night is not the Host, and it is going somewhere.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Tarry Moss** — sells her seed at cost; the closest thing either has to a friend.
- ◇ **Spare Tolland** — sits up with her some nights and will not say what the chalk told him.
- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — a cousin; she sent Yield's son to the raid that killed him and has never come to the field.
- ◇ **Mother Stint Avery** — has Yield's name on the winter list, and has sent her, anonymously, a half-sack of oats.
- ◇ **Osanna Blythe** — her pilgrims are three days out and asking the way.

#### IN PLAY

PCs are asked to sit up with the wheat, to see what comes, and not to hurt it.

- ◇ **The Watch.** Sitting up, at the hour before dawn, every PC falls asleep at once. They wake cold, with frost on their lashes, and the wheat has grown an inch.
- ◇ **The Burning Party.** The Abstinents send a Lister with a torch and two Tablebreakers. Yield stands in the gate with the fork.
- ◇ **The Thieves.** Wont Bellamy's hired men come for the blade with a spade and a pot of Farlands soil. They are found in the morning a mile off, walking west, smiling.

Threatened, she plants her feet. Kindness she accepts on the fourth offer and not before. Of the god she says, "Not him. He'd have laid a table. This one only waters." If nobody intervenes, the wheat sets a single ear by Tablenight; Yield dies in the Wasting a week later, sitting by it; and in spring, the field is bare again, and the ring of cold has moved a mile further on.

#### SAID OF THEM

"Fifty years of seed. That's twenty sacks of oats she's put in the ground. Twenty sacks. Some of us had children." — a woman in the Ration Line

"I sell her seed at cost because somebody should, and I heard that somewhere." — Tarry Moss

"It's the first green thing I've ever seen that wasn't on the Rim. I'd like to touch it. I won't. She'd fork me." — a Measure-Bearer boy of twelve

# LITTLE FAIN

*the One Who Came Home Fed*

*“There was a big kitchen and a fire and lots of chairs. Most of them were empty. You can come too. There’s room.”*

– LITTLE FAIN, TO A STRANGER IN WANTING, HOLDING THEIR HAND

| LITTLE FAIN – THE ONE WHO CAME HOME FED |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                              | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed, and something else) · Want 0 (it will not rise) · Pangs 0, always                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                           | 6 · orphan of the Lean House, ward of nobody, followed by every child in Wanting                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| CALLING & STANDING                      | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                              | Hand 1 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                                  | Instinct 3, Persuade 2, Stealth 2, Athletics 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                                    | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 0 (it does not rise)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| ATTACKS                                 | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                   | Been Fed (Fain cannot be Seated and never gains Pangs; Fain eats the Pantry measure and does not need it). You Can Come Too (when Fain takes a person’s hand and says it, that person makes an Invitation check at Grim 18, plus their Pangs; on a failure, they find they have walked with Fain some way west before they notice, and must roll again to stop). Warm Hands (any child who sleeps beside Fain wakes with Pangs reduced by 1 and the smell of warm milk on their breath; the Abstinents have forbidden it, and the children do it anyway). |
| WANTS                                   | To go back. To bring someone.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                                  | Elder’s Ear, Hostage’s Smile                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| DERANGEMENTS                            | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| CARRIES                                 | a white linen ribbon; a little silver spoon; a carved bone toy; a pebble from the chalk                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| DREAD                                   | 2 (to understand, holding Fain’s warm, plump hand, where Fain has been)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Fain is small and sturdy, with a cap of brown curls, round pink cheeks, and dimpled hands: dimpled, in the Fast, where a child’s knuckles are usually the widest part of the finger. Fain smells of warm milk and clean linen and, very faintly, of a kitchen with the oven just opened, and when Fain laughs, which is often, Unfed adults across the street turn their faces to the wall. Fain wears a white linen ribbon in their hair that nobody can untie and nobody in the Fast could have pressed. Fain’s voice is high and clear and sure. Fain is not afraid of anything. Fain is the only happy child in Wanting, and the adults will not touch Fain.

## THEIR STORY

Fain was born in 635 to a widow named Lean Bellamy, a poor cousin of the heretic Elder, who was left off the list in the Lack of 640 for hoarding: she had kept back a quarter of her own measure every day for a month, to give her child an extra mouthful on Tablenight. She walked to the Lean House with Fain on her hip.

Withy Gaunt took the child from her arms, as is proper, so that the child would not watch, and placed Fain with a family in the Measure-Bearers’ row. Lean Bellamy stopped on the ninth day. Her last words, in the Book of the Omitted, are a recipe for warm milk with honey and a crust of bread soaked in it, *the way my mam did it for me*.

In the Carving of 641, Fain went missing from the Measure-Bearers’ row. The household rang the bell at the door each dusk, as is proper. On the eighth morning Fain walked in through the west gate of Wanting, plump, clean, rosy, the ribbon in their hair, and said good morning to the gate-guard. Fain had heard someone say *Come in*, and had gone in. Fain will not say who cooked. Fain says they cried when it was time to go.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Fast has no place for Fain. The Abstinents have debated Fain in three sessions and decided nothing. Fain cannot be Seated, because Fain got up; cannot be omitted, because Fain does not need the ration; cannot be buried, because Fain is alive. The Measure-Bearers’



family has given Fain back to the Lean House, where Withy Gaunt keeps Fain in the little room by the door. The other children of Wanting follow Fain everywhere, in a silent, adoring crowd, and their parents are terrified, and do not know how to forbid it without saying aloud what they are afraid of. Lent Ashby, alone among adults, will sit with Fain. They do not talk. They sit side by side on the step like two people waiting for the same cart.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The ribbon** — white linen, pressed, an inch wide, tied in a bow nobody can loosen. It is warm.
- ◇ **A little silver spoon** — a child's spoon, engraved on the handle with *Fain* in a round, loving hand. It was in Fain's pocket. Withy Gaunt took it and locked it in a drawer; it was back in the pocket in the morning.
- ◇ **A carved bone toy** — a little horse, Fain's one toy, made by Lean Bellamy from an ox-knuckle. Fain left it behind for the week and asked for it at once on coming home.
- ◇ **A pebble from the chalk** — white, smooth. Fain says it came from "the big stone table where the man stands." No one has asked which man.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Fain wants to go back. Fain also wants to bring someone, and says so, cheerfully, to anyone who asks, but does not yet know whom: Fain says they will know when they see them. Fain fears nothing, which is the most frightening thing about Fain.

**Secret (GM):** Fain was not let go. Fain was sent. When Fain finds the right person, Fain will take their hand and say *you can come too*, and mean it, and Fain's own Gift will not need a roll. Choose, or roll a d6: (1) Lent Ashby, (2) Abstain Rooke, (3) Withy Gaunt, (4) Forbear Wend, (5) a PC, (6) Fain's own mother's name is on a card in Hollow Ann Pruett's box, and Fain is looking for whoever holds it.

**Secret (unknown to Fain):** Dr. Mercy Thrane weighed Fain with her brass scale in the Lean House and found that Fain, plump and rosy, weighs exactly what Fain weighed at the Ration Line in the spring: to the quarter-ounce. Whatever Fain ate does not weigh anything. Mercy has not written it down. It is the only number she has ever left out.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Withy Gaunt** — keeps Fain at the Lean House and has the recipe that was Fain's mother's last words. She reads it to Fain at night. Fain says it is nearly right.
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — the other guest who got up. They sit together.
- ◇ **Abstain Rooke** — Abby's crust on the windowsill and Fain's spoon are, she thinks, from the same pen-friend. She is right.
- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — Fain calls him "the man with the keys" and waves when Fain smells bread on the wind.

- ◇ **Wont Bellamy** — Fain is his cousin's child. He has offered to take Fain in, very generously, and only once.

#### IN PLAY

Fain takes a PC's hand in the street and says, "You can come too." Fain wants a companion for the road west, and is happy to wait.

- ◇ **The Children's Crowd.** Twenty of Wanting's children have followed Fain out of the west gate at dusk. The PCs must bring them back before the smell of custard reaches them.
- ◇ **The Second Table's Offer.** A Rim buyer has heard of a child who came home from the Host's kitchen, and will pay any price. Kale Dragoman has been asked. He says no.
- ◇ **The Name on the Card.** Fain finds the person they were sent for. It is someone the PCs love.

Threatened, Fain smiles and holds out a hand. Kindness Fain returns, warmly, with an invitation. Of the god Fain says, "They were sad. Their kitchen is too big." If nobody intervenes, Fain walks out of Wanting on Tablenight holding someone's hand, and neither of them is seen again, and in the morning both their names are written on cards on the Pantry's own laid table, side by side, in a round, loving hand.

#### SAID OF THEM

"My girl sleeps by Fain now. She wakes up warm. I ought to stop it. I've never seen her warm." — a mother in the Measure-Bearers' row

"The child is not a guest and not a host and not one of us. The Fast has no word for it. That is the problem with the Fast." — Forbear Wend, in council

"Fain says it's nearly right, the milk. I'm trying to get it right." — Withy Gaunt

# MARSHAL KEEP ALDANE

## the Gate at Brindle Cross

*“I was trained to stop men who come in to take. Nobody trained me for people who come in to sit down. What do I tell them? That there’s no table? There is. I’ve seen it.”*

– MARSHAL KEEP ALDANE, TO ENVOY LOWELL, CARVING 641

| MARSHAL KEEP ALDANE – THE GATE AT BRINDLE CROSS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                      | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 5 · Pangs 2 (Peckish; garrison draws a full measure)                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| AGE & STATION                                   | 50 · Marshal of the border garrison at Brindle Cross; sixty spearmen                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CALLING & STANDING                              | Warden · Standing 4 (commander of the Fast’s only soldiery)                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                                      | Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| SKILLS                                          | Blades 4, Shooting 3, Intimidate 3, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Search 2, Wayfaring 2, Instinct 2                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BODY                                            | Flesh 15 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (fatless boiled leather) · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                                         | spear +8 (4; Reach); crossbow +7 (4; Piercing, Slow); fist +5 (1)                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                                           | The Line Holds (once per scene, every Brindle Cross spearman within sight of him gains +2 to one roll to stand their ground, refuse, or resist an Invitation). Old Wound (his left thigh aches when Fatlanders are within a mile; with Caul + Instinct Routine 10 he knows how many). |
| WANTS                                           | To keep the border. To stop asking himself why.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| KNACKS                                          | Unflinching, Light Sleeper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| DERANGEMENTS                                    | The Count, beginning (he tallies the pilgrims he turns back, and cannot stop)                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                         | spear and crossbow; the Turned-Back Book; a pilgrim’s shoe; a Barrow pebble; wax plugs                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| DREAD                                           | 1 (to watch him turn back a kneeling family)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

### WHO THEY ARE

Keep Aldane is heavy-boned, big for an Unfed, with a broken nose set crooked, iron-grey hair cut close, and a jaw like the end of a plank. He limps from an old crossbow bolt in the left thigh and leans on his spear as he walks the stockade. His hands are scarred across the knuckles. He wears a hide coat over boiled leather made without fat, a garrison sash of undyed grey, and wax in his nostrils when the wind is west. He smells of wet leather, cold iron and the camphor he rubs into the thigh. His voice is a big man’s voice kept low, the voice of someone used to being obeyed and lately not sure he deserves it.

### THEIR STORY

He was born in 591 at Brindle Cross, a garrison child; Aldanes have held the Cross since the stockade was raised. He killed his first poacher at nineteen, a Fatlander with a sack and a net, and was given a full measure for a year. He took the bolt in the thigh in 624, from a poacher’s crossbow, and lay three days in the weighing-shed while the Company surgeon, Doctor Ambry Cole, dug it out, and a girl apprentice called Mercy Thrane held his hand. He was made

Marshal in 630. He married through the Pantry; his wife, Meagre, died in 633 of a winter cough. Their son Withhold left the garrison at twenty to become a Tablebreaker.

In the spring of 641 the pilgrims came: Fatlanders, hungry every second of their lives, who had heard there was a table in the Fast where you finally feel full. Aldane has turned back nine hundred.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Brindle Cross is the Fast’s door, and Aldane is the bolt. He signs, with the Pantry’s clerks, for every sack of grain that comes in from the Company; he holds the border against poachers; he enforces the standing order that an Unfed taken across the border is dead. His sixty spearmen draw a full measure, the envy of Wanting, and are the only Unfed who train for violence other than the Reckoners, whom Aldane despises as murderers and lets through his gate every Carving with a salute. He answers to the Chair alone. His limit is sixty men, and three hundred kneeling Fatlanders in the mud of the toll-road, and the question he has started asking: what right has an Unfed to refuse anyone a meal?



## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **Spear and crossbow** — garrison issue. The spear-shaft is notched for poachers. There are thirty-one notches.
- ◇ **The Turned-Back Book** — a Pantry ledger in which he tallies every pilgrim he has sent away, by fives. Nine hundred and some marks. He has begun to write names beside them, when they tell him.
- ◇ **A pilgrim's shoe** — a child's, Fatlands leather, left in the mud after a column turned back. He keeps it in his coat and does not know why.
- ◇ **A Barrow pebble** — chalk from the trench at Hallowboard, from the stretch his family believe their ancestor stood on. He swore the garrison oath on it.
- ◇ **Wax plugs** — for his nostrils. The pilgrims' cooking fires smell of Fatlands meat.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Aldane wants the border held and the question out of his head. He fears that the pilgrims are right, and that the Fast is not keeping anyone safe, only keeping them hungry. **Secret (his):** last Carving his men took a captive back from a poacher's camp: an Unfed boy of fourteen, Cease Pollard, fed for a month and plump with it. By the standing order the boy is dead and off the list. Aldane keeps him in the weighing-shed and feeds him from his own Marshal's measure, which is the crime of feeding twice over. **Secret (unknown to him):** Kale Dragoman's cage-wagon passes through Brindle Cross on the Company side twice a month, sealed by the Company toll-clerk as spoiled Pantry grain going back to the Rim, and Factor Mardle knows.

## TIES

- ◇ **Dr. Mercy Thrane** — held his hand in 624; his only friend; he sends her every camp he finds.
- ◇ **Osanna Blythe** — leads the column at his gate. She asks, very politely, three times a day.
- ◇ **Withhold Aldane** — his son, a Tablebreaker Axe, who gave Osanna her Unfed name and has not come home since.
- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — twice in his sights, twice out of range; the roast fowl on the fence.
- ◇ **Factor Joss Mardle** — shares the Cross with him; they nod each morning; Aldane does not trust a man who says "in principle."

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Aldane when he needs men, or when he arrests them as poachers.

- ◇ **The Night Rush.** Two hundred pilgrims try the stockade in the dark. They are not armed. They are singing. The spearmen look

to their Marshal.

- ◇ **The Boy in the Weighing-Shed.** A Lister learns of Cease Pollard. Aldane asks the PCs to get the boy over the Rim to somewhere he can live.
- ◇ **The Company Seal.** The PCs open a "spoiled grain" wagon at the Cross. Aldane must decide whether to break the Company's seal and, with it, the Fast's credit.

Threatened, he stands in the gate. Kindness from a pilgrim undoes him for hours. Of the god he says, "It's never once tried to get in past me. It doesn't need to." If nobody intervenes, on Tablenight Aldane opens the gate himself and stands aside, and then follows the column west, and the Fast's door stands open until the Abstinent can find someone to shut it.

## SAID OF THEM

"He turned us back with tears on his face. They always say the Unfed don't cry. He did." — a Fatlands pilgrim, at the Brimming Cup

"The Marshal's sound. The Marshal's the soundest man on the border. Watch him." — Factor Joss Mardle, in a report to his superiors

"He feeds that boy in the shed. Everyone knows. Nobody's said. We'd follow him into the Long Table." — a Brindle Cross spearman

# OSANNA BLYTHE

## the Pilgrim

*“I know what happens to them. They waste. They smile. They sit there for a hundred years telling each other it’s lovely. Darling, do you know what I’d give for a hundred years of lovely?”*

– OSANNA BLYTHE, TO MARSHAL ALDANE AT THE GATE, THIRD TIME OF ASKING

| OSANNA BLYTHE – THE PILGRIM |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | The Fatlands · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 8                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| AGE & STATION               | 40 · widow of Low Tilth, lapsed Server of the Second Helping, leader of three hundred pilgrims                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CALLING & STANDING          | Celebrant (lapsed) · Standing 2 among the pilgrims (they would follow her into a fire, if it were cooking)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                      | Persuade 4, Feast 4, Endure 3, Wayfaring 3, Rites 2 (hymns), Labor 2, Brawl 2, Instinct 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| BODY                        | Flesh 16 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (loose loam-soft flesh; stacks with nothing) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                     | fist +4 (1); a bear-hug she uses on refusers +4 (Brawl; target held)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                       | Iron Belly (+2 Feast; can eat bark, leather, tallow; she has). Taste the Name (a drop of blood tells her family, Cut and a shameful meal). Gorge (1d6 Flesh by eating heavily, once a scene, if there is anything). The Hymn (once a day she may lead her column in a Second Helping hymn about gravy; any listener with Pangs 3+ makes an Invitation check at Routine 10, or Hard 14 if Unfed). |
| WANTS                       | The Second Plate. The Hollow (when someone refuses food she must make them eat; with the Unfed this is nearly constant). The Long Pig (a corpse smells like supper; she has resisted, on the road, every time). To feel full.                                                                                                                                                                    |
| KNACKS                      | Table Manners, Gallows Laugh                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                | The Pull (toward the smell of bread from the west; triggered by Fray 8+ or by any warm front)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| CARRIES                     | a coat with a name sewn on it; a garland of toothed wheat, dried; an Ash Mill flour-twist, empty; a wake-knife she will not use; a hymnal                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DREAD                       | 2 (to watch her column hold a wake on the road)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

### WHO THEY ARE

Osanna is enormous by Unfed standards and gaunt by her own. She was built big, Fatlands-big, and a year on the road has hollowed her, so that the skin hangs from her arms and jaw in soft brown folds like an emptied sack, and her dress, once tight, is belted with rope. Her eyes are bright and black and wet. Her voice is warm and rolling and full of laughter, a great hungry laugh that comes up from the belly and fills a road. She calls everyone *darling*. She smells of road dust, wool, the loam-sweetness of Fatlands skin, and the sour sugar of a body burning itself. Her teeth ache all the time and she chews on a willow twig to quiet them. She is ravenous every second, and has been since she could walk.

### THEIR STORY

Osanna Callock was born in 601 in Low Tilth on the eastern plain, a cousin of the drovers of Callock Green; she knew a big laughing

boy called Kale at wakes when they were children. She married a renderer, Barnaby Blythe, and joined the Second Helping with him at Gladbelly in 628, because the hymns were lovely and nobody there ever ate alone. In 638 Barnaby announced at table that he would be Offered. Osanna sang beside him in the procession. Afterward, on the long benches, with the plates going round, she found she could not lift her fork, and sat there until morning, and left Gladbelly on foot. She has been hungry since in a way the Fatlands cannot feed.

In 640, in Sated, she bought a twist of Fast-flour from Ash Mill and ate it, and for an hour she was full. It was the first hour of her life. She sat on a step and wept, and when the hour ended she began walking north, and other people began walking with her.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Osanna is not of the Fast, but she is its newest crisis. Three hundred pilgrims camp in the mud of the toll-road outside Brindle Cross:

renderers, drovers, a family of Thin who decided starving was not enough, Second Helping lapsed and faithful, children. Rumour says thousands are behind them. They are not trying to hurt anyone. They want to sit down. The Unfed will not feed them, because that would be hospitality, and the Rim inns charge three lacks a bowl. They are dying on the road, and when they die the column holds a wake, Fatlands-fashion, and the spearmen at the stockade watch, and are sick. Osanna will not eat at the wakes. She is saving herself for the Host.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The coat with the name** — a man's drover's coat, and stitched over the heart in grey thread, an Unfed name: *Enough*. A young Tablebreaker, Withhold Aldane, met her on the Stoopway in the spring, could not bring himself to stop her, and gave her a name, because the Unfed name you on the day you first refuse something, and she had just refused to turn back.
- ◇ **A dried garland of toothed wheat** — from Barnaby's procession. It still bites, sometimes, if handled roughly.
- ◇ **An Ash Mill twist** — the paper the Fast-flour came in, empty, which she licks at night.
- ◇ **A wake-knife** — Barnaby's, for the jointing. She has carried it a year and not used it.
- ◇ **A hymnal** — the Second Helping's, greasy, the gravy hymn marked with a ribbon.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Osanna wants to be full, once, and for good. She knows what happens to the Seated and thinks it sounds wonderful: to be full, finally, for decades, smiling, among friends. She fears dying hungry on the road with the Host a day away. **Secret (hers):** she ate at one wake on the road, in the Lack, when a boy of nineteen died who had followed her from Low Tilth, and she has told the column she did not. **Secret (unknown to her):** the Fatlands Want called the Hollow has turned in her toward the Unfed: every time she offers food to a spearman at the gate, the Host, a mile west, lays a table. Osanna has been hosting for Orrum without knowing it, and the god is grateful, and the column's table is nearly ready.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Marshal Keep Aldane** — at the gate; she asks him three times a day, and he answers three times, and she loves him for it a little.
- ◇ **Withhold Aldane** — the Tablebreaker who named her; he walks with the column now, carrying his axe, and does not use it.
- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — fed her pilgrims twice for nothing. She thinks he is the kindest man alive, and does not know his trade.
- ◇ **Yield Hartsell** — Osanna has heard of the green blade and wants the pilgrims to kneel to it on the way.

- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — has walked down the column at night, bowing, asking how many will be dining.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Osanna when she asks them for directions. She is very polite about it. She asks three times.

- ◇ **The Way West.** The PCs are hired to guide the column round Brindle Cross by the drove roads. Doing it well kills the pilgrims at a table. Doing it badly kills them on the road.
- ◇ **The Wake.** A child in the column dies. Osanna asks a PC to help her keep the column from holding a wake, and then, at midnight, asks for help eating.
- ◇ **The Laid Field.** The column finds its table: three hundred places, steaming, in a stubble field. Osanna asks the PCs to stand back. She means it kindly.

Threatened, she laughs and opens her arms. Kindness she returns with an embrace that lasts too long and an offer of food she does not have. Of the god she says, "The only one of them who ever wanted to feed us back." If nobody intervenes, Osanna's column finds its table in the stubble west of Brindle Cross on Tablenight, and sits, and the Hostwatch pin a new table on the Great Map three hundred chairs long, and on the far end there is one more chair, pushed in.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She hugged me at the gate. She smelled like a bakery. I had to go and stand in the cold for an hour." — a Brindle Cross spearman

"She was a lovely Server. She wept at the Offering. That was the problem. You're meant to sing." — a Plateholder of Gladbelly

"I gave her a name because she'd refused. I didn't know you could refuse going home. I've been thinking about that." — Withhold Aldane, Tablebreaker

# MEEK GARRITY

the Historian

*“I am not saying they were wicked. I am saying they were late. The table was already cleared when they came up the hill. Somebody had eaten first. We have spent six hundred years being proud of arriving after dinner.”*

– MEEK GARRITY, FROM THE THIRD OF HIS CIRCULATED PAPERS, COPIED BY HAND IN WANTING

| MEEK GARRITY – THE HISTORIAN |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 4 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| AGE & STATION                | 66 · senior Pantry Clerk, copyist of the oldest ledgers, author of the worst idea in the Fast                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Cutwright (archivist, unlicensed) · Standing 2 (Pantry Clerk; about to be 0)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 3 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| SKILLS                       | Lore 5, Reckoning 4, Search 4, Craft 3 (copying, slate-reading), Resolve 3, Clause 2, Stealth 1, Endure 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                         | Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                      | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| GIFTS                        | The Old Hand (he reads the pre-Gorging script of the heartland as easily as Table-speech; any document older than 41 A.G. yields its meaning to him at Eye + Lore Routine 10). Chisel-Shadow (with a lens, a raking lamp and a week, he can recover a scraped or chiselled word from stone or slate at Eye + Search Dire 22; each attempt costs 1 Fray whether it succeeds or not). |
| WANTS                        | To read the eighth word. To be believed by one Elder. Not to be burned with the slate.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| KNACKS                       | Counting Habit, Steady Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| DERANGEMENTS                 | The Gaslight, beginning (he no longer trusts his memory of what the slate said yesterday, and keeps forty copies)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| CARRIES                      | the Hallowboard slate; a lens; a raking lamp; ink and quills; forty copies                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                        | 0 (to meet); 3 (to understand what he has found)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |

## WHO THEY ARE

Meek is a small, round-shouldered man with a scholar’s stoop, thick spectacles that make his pale eyes huge, and a fringe of white hair around a bald, ink-smudged crown. He is ink to the elbows: the creases of his knuckles are permanently black, his cuffs are stiff with it, and when he is anxious he rubs his thumb across his lower lip and leaves a blue mark there. His fingers are long, thin and bloodless, a copyist’s fingers. His voice is barely above a whisper, a habit of forty years in the Pantry cellars, and he apologises before almost every sentence. He smells of lamp-oil, damp slate and the mouse-and-sacking air of the Pantry. He is the gentlest man in Wanting. He is also, by the Abstinents’ reckoning, the most dangerous.

## THEIR STORY

Meek was born in 575 to a Lister of the Pantry, took the clerk’s oath at fifteen, and has spent fifty years copying, collating and preserving the Pantry ledgers, back to the first of 41 A.G. In 621 he was given the oldest box, the one that holds the Lammas Bottom slate with its

word *no* scratched until the stone is white. Under it, in sacking, he found other slates. He spent sixteen years reading them. In 637 he reached the last.

It is a seating plan. Scratched in the old hand of the heartland, by a reeve of the Host’s parishes, it lists the order in which the households were to stand around the stone table at Hallowboard, with their places on the eight sides. It is dated, by the reckoning of the old calendar, to the tenth day of the ninth winter’s darkest month: the morning Orrum rose. *Households to go up at first light*, it says. *Bring knives*. And at its foot, in a different and shakier hand: *We came. It was cleared. The plate was clean. The Host is getting up.*

There was no refusal. The Unfed arrived on the tenth day, with knives, and something had eaten first.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Until 637 Meek was a fixture, a harmless senior clerk who corrected other clerks’ arithmetic. Now his papers, copied by hand and passed house to house at night, are read in half the homes of Wanting, and

the Abstinent have called them forgery and ordered the slate burned. They have not yet found it. The Fast's whole moral authority rests on the Refusal: the Pantry, the list, the Reckoners' mandate, the Envoy's dispatches, the children's pride. If the Unfed did not refuse, they are not clean; they were merely unlucky. Meek did not set out to say this. He set out to copy the oldest box.

#### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Hallowboard slate** — a grey roofing-slate the size of a dinner plate, scratched in the old hand, wrapped in ration-cloth and hidden somewhere different every night. It has eight sides drawn on it. Seven are allotted to households. Beside the eighth there is a word, and the word has been scraped away.
- ◇ **A lens and a raking lamp** — he spends his nights holding the lamp low across the slate so that the shadow of the chisel shows. He has recovered three strokes. He believes they begin a household's name.
- ◇ **Ink, quills, and a Clausewright's sand-box** — +1 to Craft for copying.
- ◇ **Forty copies** — of the slate, of his papers, of his own notes, hidden in forty houses. He no longer remembers all forty.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Meek wants to read the eighth word. He wants one Elder, just one, to stand in a room with him and admit that the slate is real. He fears being burned with it, and he fears, more, that his papers are true and that he has broken his own people.

**Secret (his):** he has shown the slate to one person: Forbear Wend, in 638, at night, in the bare room on the Pantry's top floor. Wend read it, wept, and ordered it burned, and has done nothing since to see that it was.

**Secret (unknown to him):** he has misread it, as any Unfed would. The three strokes he has recovered are not the beginning of a household's name. The eighth side was not allotted to a household of the heartland at all. He has assumed, as all his people assume, that the chair on the eighth side was for someone who was coming up the hill with a knife. Garrity is about to put his slate beside Cray Lobbett's seabed table and Grandfather Peat's memory of the night, and then he will know which way round the seating went.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Envoy Prudence Lowell** — has asked that his name be left off the list. He does not know. He admires her dispatches.
- ◇ **Forbear Wend** — read the slate and wept; the only Elder who knows it is real.
- ◇ **Wont Bellamy** — uses Garrity's papers in council to argue that if the Unfed were only late, they may still eat; Garrity is horrified to be useful to him.
- ◇ **Verger Sober Osmond** — has the Laying-book with the line about *the one who comes late*; Garrity would give his eyes for it.

- ◇ **Hollow Ann Pruett** — has a card with an empty chair drawn on it, found at a table with eight places. Garrity has asked to see it. She has refused.
- ◇ **Fallow Brindle** — the Warden of the Barrows has written to him about what the oldest bones show. He has not answered, because he is afraid.
- ◇ **Scant Hollis** — came to his room once, alone, and stood in the doorway for a full minute, and left without speaking.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Meek when he needs the slate moved before the Abstinent's men find it.

- ◇ **The Burning.** A Lister and two Tablebreakers search the Pantry's lower cellar with a brazier. The slate is in a sack of pease. Meek is in the room, pretending to count.
- ◇ **The Eighth Word.** Meek has found a way to read the chisel-shadow: Hallowboard itself, at dawn on the morning after Tablenight, when the god's warm hands have just lifted from the stone. He needs escort to the hill.
- ◇ **Reckoned.** The Reckoners decide that Meek's papers are a weapon of the Godeaters. Scant Hollis does not want him dead. Her Knives do.

Threatened, he apologises and hands over a copy. Kindness makes him weep. Of the god he says, "It got up. The slate says so. It was getting up already when we came." If nobody intervenes, Meek is left off the list in Lack, walks to the Lean House carrying the slate, and dictates the eighth word to Withy Gaunt for the Book of the Omitted on his last morning. Withy does not know the old hand. She copies the shapes.

#### SAID OF THEM

"My boy came home from the Ration Line and asked me if we were late. He's seven. I didn't know what to say. I said carry your own."  
— a father in Wanting

"Garrity has read more of our past than any man living. That is why he must stop reading it." — Envoy Prudence Lowell

"It's a seating plan. The old man's right about that much. I've laid enough tables to know one." — Welcome Ardent, on the Rim Road

# WELCOME ARDENT

*the Steward of the Host*

*“Good evening. Forgive the hour. Will you be joining the Host tonight? No? No, of course.  
I’ll just set the place, in case. We’re expecting one more.”*

– WELCOME ARDENT, TO A HOSTWATCH TRACKER IN A FIELD NEAR THE STOOPWAY

| WELCOME ARDENT – THE STEWARD OF THE HOST |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                               | The Fast (once) · none (in service; not of any blood) · Want 0 · Pangs 0, forever                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| AGE & STATION                            | some six hundred and forty, looking fifty · steward to Orrum, layer of tables, writer of place cards                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING                       | none (he is employed)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                               | Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 6                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                                   | Persuade 5, Rites 5, Craft 5 (laying a table), Instinct 4, Lore 4, Resolve 1                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| BODY                                     | Flesh 19 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 10, steady, unbreaking                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| ATTACKS                                  | none; he has never struck anyone and cannot                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                    | Lay a Place (in one minute, he lays a table for any person he can see; it calls them by name, and they must make an Invitation check). The Fourth Offer (he alone may make a fourth offer, and it is sincere; an Unfed who refuses him a fourth time gains 3 Want and his deep gratitude). The Steward’s Keys (any door, gate, lock, or bricked hearth opens for him). In Service (he cannot be killed while the Host walks; wounds close by morning, folded shut like a napkin; he apologises for bleeding on the floor). Relief (he may offer his position; anyone who accepts it, freely and in so many words, becomes the steward at the next dawn). |
| WANTS                                    | To be relieved. Someone must accept the position freely.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                                   | Table Manners, Elder’s Ear                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| DERANGEMENTS                             | none that show; his voice sometimes stops mid-sentence and must be restarted, like a clock                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| CARRIES                                  | a ring of keys; a box of cutlery; white gloves; cards and brown ink; a napkin over the arm; a child’s wooden spoon                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                                    | 3 (to see him at work); 4 (to read a place card in his hand)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

## WHO THEY ARE

He is tall and very thin and stooped a little at the shoulders, as servants become who have spent a long time bending over tables. He wears an old-fashioned steward’s coat of dark green, the cuffs immaculate, with a long white apron over it, gravy-stained at the hem however often he changes it, and white gloves, very clean. A napkin hangs over his left arm. A ring of iron keys hangs at his belt and does not jingle. His face is long, gentle and lined, and grey with an exhaustion so deep it has become a kind of serenity: the face of a man at the end of a double shift, who has stopped expecting the shift to end. His hands, when he takes off the gloves, are warm, and smell of bread. He bows to everyone. He knocks on open doors. He has never once been rude.

## THEIR STORY

He was born Welcome Ardent in the heartland in the last years before the Lack, when Welcome and Ardent were good names, the Host’s names, and no family was ashamed of them. He stood on

Hallowboard hill on the tenth morning with his daughter Bounty, who was four, on his back. When Orrum rose and bowed and walked away down the hill, Welcome followed it, because he could think of nothing else to do. He walked behind it all that day down the road that would become the Stoopway. At some point in the afternoon Bounty stopped holding on. He did not put her down until dusk.

At dusk, on the eleventh morning’s eve, the god laid a table in the road, and set a place at it, and pulled out the chair. Welcome said no, thank you, three times. The god did not offer a fourth. And Welcome, who had nothing left, did the thing no Unfed has done before or since: he asked. *May I help?* A guest is offered. One who asks to help at a table is staff. The god took him on.

He has laid every table in the Fast since, and lately, every table on the Rim.



## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Welcome walks a mile ahead of Orrum. He lays the cloths, sets out the plates, angles the chairs for guests who are a little unsteady, and writes the place cards in whatever hand will be loved: a dead mother's, a grandmother's, a husband's. He knows every name in the Fast, including the secret ones. He is the only one of the Host's guests who can still get up, and he will answer questions honestly if he is not asked to sit. The Hostwatch know him by sight and speak to him as colleagues. The Tablebreakers hate him and cannot hurt him. The Abstinent pretend he is a story. In the last year, for the first time, the Host has sometimes gone ahead of him, and he has arrived to find tables already laid, and that frightens him more than anything in six centuries.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The keys** — nine iron keys on a ring. Every door, gate, lock and bricked hearth opens for them. He does not know which one the ninth is for.
- ◇ **A box of cutlery** — walnut, brass-cornered, holding a perfect setting for one: knife, fork, spoon, all silver, all warm.
- ◇ **White gloves** — always clean, and always replaced, though nobody has seen him change them.
- ◇ **Place cards and brown ink** — stiff cream card, a fine pen. The ink is brown, like gravy dried on a plate.
- ◇ **A child's wooden spoon** — small, worn, with a nick in the bowl from a first tooth. It is the only thing he carries that is not the Host's.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Welcome wants to be relieved. He has been looking for a successor, and he will offer the position to whoever refuses him most gracefully. He fears the extra place. He has laid it at every table since his first night, because he was told to, pushed in square, with its back to the lamp.

**Secret (his):** he has been told, by his master, that when the expected guest arrives, the Steward will be released, and everyone else will be served. He has never been told a name. He has not asked. He tells himself this means he knows who the place is for, and that it is the same thing.

**Secret (GM):** his contract can be negotiated; Jessamy Quill, the Company's notary, has been asked to witness it, and has not yet said yes. And Bounty Ardent's name has never once appeared on any card he has written. He has looked, every night, for six hundred and forty years.

## TIES

- ◇ **Orrum** — his master, a mile behind, warm, patient; he loves it, and he is so tired.
- ◇ **Lent Ashby** — the guest who got up; he cried when she left, and he has started writing *Steward* on her card.

- ◇ **Little Fain** — he waves to Fain on the wind. He cooked the milk.
- ◇ **Verger Sober Osmond** — the only man who lays a table for the Host; Welcome stands at the hall door and thanks him.
- ◇ **Hollow Ann Pruett** — keeps his cards; he would like the one with the drawing back.
- ◇ **Spare Tolland** — the Tracker who has followed his master for thirty years; Welcome leaves him a cup of tea at a mile's distance, which Spare never drinks.
- ◇ **Envoy Prudence Lowell** — he asked if she was dining alone. She is. She always is.

## IN PLAY

PCs meet Welcome in the road at dusk, bowing, asking whether they will be joining the Host this evening. He wants a successor and, failing that, someone to talk to for a quarter of an hour, honestly, standing up.

- ◇ **The Interview.** He asks a PC, after three graceful refusals, whether they would consider a position. He describes it fairly. He does not hide the hours.
- ◇ **The Table He Did Not Lay.** At a Rim inn the PCs find Welcome in the doorway with his hand over his mouth: the Host has laid ahead of him again, and this table has a card at the extra place.
- ◇ **The Contract.** Jessamy Quill's clerk asks the PCs to carry Welcome's terms to Oathen for review. They are short. There is a clause about relief.

Threatened, he apologises and sets a place for the threatener. Kindness brings him close to tears. Of the god he says, "It only wants everyone fed. That's all it has ever wanted. That isn't so terrible, is it?" If nobody intervenes, he goes on, more tired than before, until the night someone sits in the extra chair; and then, as promised, he is released.

## SAID OF THEM

"He set a table for my mother on my doorstep and wrote her name in her own hand. Then he said sorry. That was the worst part. He meant it." — a widow of Wanting

"Ardent is the only colleague I have ever had." — Spare Tolland of the Hostwatch

"I asked him whose the extra chair was. He folded his napkin very carefully and said, We're expecting one more. Then he asked if I took sugar." — a Company innkeeper on the northern Rim

# NEW FACES OF THE FAST

---

*Count your chairs.*

– WANTING PROVERB, SAID AT EVERY DOOR AT DUSK

The core book introduced five new people of the Fast. They are given full treatment here, with two more who live in the cracks of the Pantry and the chalk.



# SCARCE ODELL

the Kin-Reader

*“Married-out daughter, Tansy, at Low Tilth, two children. Bastard son, Garrick, Chute clerk. Infant at wet-nurse in Gristle Lane. There. Now the line is a line.”*

— SCARCE ODELL, FINISHING A TREE FOR A BAND-CAPTAIN

| SCARCE ODELL – THE KIN-READER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                    | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 4 · Pangs 2 (Peckish; Reckoner measure)                                                                                                                                                      |
| AGE & STATION                 | 40 · former under-clerk of the Cutwrights’ College in Sated; Kin-Reader of the Reckoners                                                                                                                                     |
| CALLING & STANDING            | Reckoner (Kin-Reader) · Standing 3                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                    | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                          |
| SKILLS                        | Lore 5 (genealogy), Reckoning 4, Search 3, Clause 3, Deceive 3, Stealth 2, Resolve 2, Blades 1, Endure 1                                                                                                                     |
| BODY                          | Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 2                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTACKS                       | penknife +3 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                         | The Whole Tree (given a surname and a week with stolen College quires, he names every living member of a bloodline, including the hidden ones, at Eye + Lore Hard 14; on a Grace, the ones the family itself does not know). |
| WANTS                         | Completeness. A line with a loose end is a sin against the page.                                                                                                                                                             |
| KNACKS                        | Counting Habit, Little Lies                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| CARRIES                       | stolen College quires; a squint-glass; a tailor’s measuring tape; a list he has not shown anyone                                                                                                                             |
| DREAD                         | 1 (to watch him draw a line through a cradle)                                                                                                                                                                                |

## WHO THEY ARE

Dry, fastidious, narrow-shouldered, with a permanent squint from twenty years of tiny genealogical script and ink-stained fingertips he wipes on a square of linen after every page. He smells of lamp-black and lye. He speaks quietly, precisely, in the College’s clipped Sated accent he has never quite lost. He sleeps well.

## THEIR STORY

Born 601 in Wanting, placed by the Reckoners at eleven as a foundling servant in the College’s Sated registry, where he rose to under-clerk and copied what he should not for twenty-five years. He came home in 637 with a cart of quires under the oats. He has drawn the trees for every raid since.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He lives in a room behind the west gate and works by daylight. No raid crosses without his tree. The Abstinents pretend not to know his name.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **College quires** — forty-one stolen registers in a lead-lined box; the College would burn a town for them.
- ♦ **A tailor’s tape** — he measures his lines twice.

- ♦ **The other list** — names of Unfed foundlings who carry High Cut blood without knowing it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He wants every line complete. **Secret:** his trees now include Unfed foundlings with Godeater blood, and he has begun adding them, quietly, to the raid lists. The first is Reft Hume of the Pantry (below). **Unknown to him:** he is one himself, a Gut-line by-blow placed at Wanting in 601; the College registers he stole hold his true name, in a quire he has never opened because it is in the box he labelled *closed lines*.

## TIES

- ♦ **Scant Hollis** — his captain; she trusts the trees, not him.
- ♦ **Reft Hume** — first foundling on his list; they have nodded to each other at the Ration Line for years.
- ♦ **Deny Fallon** — a rival Reckoner hunting a Cutwright for the rest of the quires.

## IN PLAY

He asks the PCs to verify a name, which means visiting someone and looking at their gums. Hooks: a cousin in Wanting; a missing quire; a tree that includes a PC. Threatened, he offers information.

If nobody intervenes, he finishes the list, and the first raid inside the Fast is planned for Tablenight.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“He measured my little boy’s head with a tape once. Said he was just curious.” — a mother at the Ration Line

“Best clerk I ever lost.” — a Registrar of the College, Sated

“His trees are perfect. I have never once asked him how.” — Scant Hollis

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# WITHY GAUNT

## Matron of the Lean House

*“Tell me how she made it. Slowly. The milk first. Was it warm before the honey went in, or after? Take your time, love. I’m writing it down.”*

— WITHY GAUNT, AT A BEDSIDE IN THE LEAN HOUSE

| WITHY GAUNT – MATRON OF THE LEAN HOUSE |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| AGE & STATION                          | 58 · keeper of the Lean House, where the omitted go to wait                                                                                                                                                                              |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Midwife (of the other end) · Standing 2                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| SKILLS                                 | Stitching 3, Rites 3, Resolve 4, Persuade 3, Endure 3, Labor 2, Lore 2                                                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 13 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| ATTACKS                                | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| GIFTS                                  | The Book (anyone who tells her their last words in the Lean House may make one final Caul + Resolve roll at Routine 10; on a success they gain the Old Grief Knack for their passing, and those who loved them lose 2 Fray at the news). |
| WANTS                                  | To get the recipe right. To have kept her baby.                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| KNACKS                                 | Old Grief, Mother’s Hands                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| CARRIES                                | the Book of the Omitted; a washing-bowl; clean straw; a strip of red neckcloth                                                                                                                                                           |
| DREAD                                  | 2 (to sit with her through a night of the dying reciting food)                                                                                                                                                                           |

### WHO THEY ARE

Spare, kind-faced, with chapped red hands, a soft voice, grey hair under a linen cap, and a way of sitting very still beside people. She smells of lye, straw and the sweet acetone of the dying.

### THEIR STORY

Born 583. In 606, unmarried and unlisted, she bore a child to a Fatlands drover she met at Brindle Cross, and with no measure for an unlisted mouth, she traded the baby at the Cross for a sack of oats so that he would live. She named him first: *Decline*. She took the Lean House in 618 and has kept it since.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

The Lean House has no law and no budget. She changes the straw weekly, washes the omitted, holds their hands, and writes their names, dates and last words in the Book. Most last words are recipes. She does not feed them; it would only extend the waiting.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The Book of the Omitted** — eleven volumes; on the last page of the first, the name *Decline*, and a date in 606.
- ◇ **A strip of red neckcloth** — found in a dead woman’s sack last month, smelling of woodsmoke and roast fat. She does not

know why she keeps it.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

**Secret (hers):** she reads the Book’s recipes aloud at night to the dying, and Orrum has begun standing outside the door, listening, and the straw is warm by morning. **Unknown to her:** her son is Kale Dragoman, and her sexton sells the dead to him.

### TIES

- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — her son. **Abide Kettering** — her sexton, whom she trusts. **Little Fain** — in her care; she reads Fain the milk recipe. **Dr. Mercy Thrane** — measures her dying; they argue in whispers. **Meek Garrity** — will dictate his last words to her.

### IN PLAY

A PC’s friend is in the Lean House. Withy asks the PCs only to sit and listen. Hooks: the warm straw; the red neckcloth; the Book stolen by someone who wants a name in it. Threatened, she keeps writing. If nobody intervenes, she reads the right recipe one night, and the Host comes in.

---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She held my sister’s hand nine days. I couldn’t go in. She did.” — a Measure-Bearer

“She is the only mercy the list allows.” — Forbear Wend

“She cries over the sacks. Soft heart.” — Abide Kettering

---

# ABIDE KETTERING

the Sexton

*“Face down, no marker, as is proper. Lovely morning for it. You’ll want to stand back, miss, it’s heavy.”*

– ABIDE KETTERING, LOWERING A SACK OF STONES INTO AN OPEN-FIELD GRAVE

| ABIDE KETTERING – THE SEXTON |                                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                   | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 2 · Pangs 1 (Peckish; better fed than he should be)                                     |
| AGE & STATION                | 45 · sexton to the Lean House; seller of the dead                                                                       |
| CALLING & STANDING           | Gleaner · Standing 1                                                                                                    |
| ATTRIBUTES                   | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                     |
| SKILLS                       | Labor 4, Deceive 3, Haggle 3, Endure 3, Blades 2, Brawl 2, Wayfaring 2, Stitching 1                                     |
| BODY                         | Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                  |
| ATTACKS                      | pickaxe +5 (4); shovel +5 (3)                                                                                           |
| GIFTS                        | Warm Delivery (he knows to the hour when a Lean House resident will stop; Eye + Instinct is not needed, only practice). |
| WANTS                        | More. He has started looking at the living with an eye to timing.                                                       |
| KNACKS                       | Strong Back, Gallows Laugh                                                                                              |
| CARRIES                      | a pickaxe; a cart; a lamp; sacks of stones; a purse of ration-chits                                                     |
| DREAD                        | 2 (when a sack moves)                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Wiry, cheerful, sun-browned, whistling, with a pickaxe on his shoulder and a cart pulled by a bony mule. He smells of earth and the camphor he rubs on the sacks. Everyone likes him.

## THEIR STORY

Born 596; sexton since 628. In 635 a Fatlander at the western crossroads offered him a sack of oats for a body still warm. He has sold the omitted and starved there since, and buried stones.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He collects the dead from the Lean House and the hamlets, and buries them face down in the open fields. Nobody digs Unfed graves up. That is the beauty of it.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **The cart and lamp** — lit at the crossroads at the wrong hour.
- ♦ **A purse of chits** — far more than his measure. He sells them on.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

**Secret:** six years of sales to Kale Dragoman’s men; blank kidneys keep a few hours, blank blood a day. He has begun, once, to hurry

someone. **Unknown to him:** Mercy Thrane has noticed the dead go out lighter than they came.

## TIES

- ♦ **Kale Dragoman** — his buyer. **Withy Gaunt** — trusts him.
- Fallow Brindle** — the Warden of the Barrows has seen his fields and wondered why the graves never settle.

## IN PLAY

The PCs see his cart at the crossroads, lamp lit. Hooks: a sack moves; a grave of stones; a resident who is not yet dead. Threatened, he lies, then runs. If nobody intervenes, he is caught by the Reckoners, and they do not bother with a list.

## SAID OF THEM

“Always a smile, Abide. Always a kind word for the dead.” — Withy Gaunt

“He’s prompt. Prompt is rare.” — Odo, Kale’s hired man

“Why’s his mule so fat?” — a child in the Cold Yards

# FACTOR JOSS MARDLE

of the Rim Road Company

*“In principle, yes. In practice, there may be circumstances. In the event of such circumstances, the contract provides. I am sure you understand.”*

— JOSS MARDLE, TO MOTHER STINT AVERY, ASKED WHERE THE GRAIN WENT

| FACTOR JOSS MARDLE — OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY |                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                                   | Oathen · Cut 2 (common) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3                                                                                                                                                               |
| AGE & STATION                                | 50 · Company factor at Brindle Cross; holder of the Fast’s grain contract                                                                                                                                                 |
| CALLING & STANDING                           | Factor · Standing 4                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| ATTRIBUTES                                   | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3                                                                                                                                                                       |
| SKILLS                                       | Clause 5, Haggle 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Deceive 3, Instinct 2, Resolve 2, Endure 1                                                                                                                                   |
| BODY                                         | Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| ATTACKS                                      | none; two Company guards (Threat 2, spear 4)                                                                                                                                                                              |
| GIFTS                                        | Echo-Ear (Oathen Taste: Eye + Instinct Hard 14 to know whether a statement was a lie or bound its speaker). Force of Circumstance (any contract he drafts has an exit only he can find; Clause Grim 18 to find it first). |
| WANTS                                        | To Correct (Oathen; he must state the truth when he hears a falsehood, which is why he never lets anyone near him say anything definite).                                                                                 |
| KNACKS                                       | Bone-Coin Nose, Smell of Cedar                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| CARRIES                                      | the contract copy; a ledger; a sealed order; Kale’s toll-dockets                                                                                                                                                          |
| DREAD                                        | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |

## WHO THEY ARE

Smooth-shaven, prosperous, in a good grey coat and a silver chain, with a soft Oathen voice that never says anything unqualified. He smells of cedar and sealing wax.

## THEIR STORY

Born in Tacit 591, Clausewright-trained, posted to Brindle Cross in 627. In the Carving of 641 he shorted the Fast’s grain on Company orders, diverting it north to buy Vigil lamp-oil at three times the price, under a “force of circumstance” clause he drafted himself.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

He weighs in every sack the Fast eats. The Abstinent need him more than he needs them.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The sealed order** — instructing him to exercise the Company’s “first refusal” on the Unfed dead this winter. He has delayed, out of shame.
- ◇ **Toll-dockets** — for Kale Dragoman’s “spoiled grain” wagons. He signs them.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

He has done the sum of how many Unfed will starve, and filed it. **Secret:** the delay is the only decent thing he has done in fourteen years, and he knows it will be noticed. **Unknown to him:** the Company’s summary ledger, sold to the Second Table, prices the Fast’s end; his shortfall is a line in it.

## TIES

- ◇ **Envoy Lowell** — exquisite mutual contempt. **Marshal Aldane** — nods each morning. **Mother Stint Avery** — has the arithmetic; he fears her more than anyone. **Kale Dragoman** — a docket a fortnight.

## IN PLAY

He offers the PCs a contract. Hooks: the order; the dockets; a Pantry audit. Threatened, he qualifies. If nobody intervenes, he signs the order at the end of Lack.



# HOLLOW ANN PRUETT

*the Card-Keeper*

*“This one’s yours. Yes, it is, look, it’s your name, spelled right. Keep it. It’s rude to leave a card on the table.”*

— HOLLOW ANN PRUETT, TO A STRANGER AT BRINDLE CROSS

| HOLLOW ANN PRUETT – THE CARD-KEEPER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                          | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 9 · Pangs 5 (Gaunt)                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                       | 75 · walker of the Fast; collector of place cards from broken tables                                                                                                                                             |
| CALLING & STANDING                  | Delver (of the god’s leavings) · Standing 2                                                                                                                                                                      |
| ATTRIBUTES                          | Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                              |
| SKILLS                              | Wayfaring 4, Search 4, Resolve 4, Stealth 3, Lore 3, Instinct 3, Endure 2, Athletics 2                                                                                                                           |
| BODY                                | Flesh 12 (10 at Gaunt) · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 6                                                                                                                                                             |
| ATTACKS                             | walking staff +2 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| GIFTS                               | The Box (from her three hundred cards she can find, at Eye + Search Routine 10, the card of any person in the Fast or anyone who has crossed it; holding it, she knows whether they are Seated, dead or living). |
| WANTS                               | To give every card to its owner. Never to let anyone hold the drawn one.                                                                                                                                         |
| KNACKS                              | No Thank You, Corpse-Road Walker                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| CARRIES                             | an oiled box of cards; a bag; a staff; one card she keeps against her skin                                                                                                                                       |
| DREAD                               | 3 (to be handed your own card)                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## WHO THEY ARE

Spry, birdlike, brown-skinned and white-haired, with quick black eyes and a bag over her shoulder. She walks everywhere at a hen’s trot. She smells of oiled wood and the bread smell of the cards.

## THEIR STORY

Born 566, sister of the old Envoy Withhold Pruett. Her husband sat at a table in 598. She began collecting cards from the broken tables after his, and has not stopped.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

Tablebreakers let her follow them. The Hostwatch consult her box. Everyone else crosses the road.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **The box** — over three hundred cards, sorted by name: Seated, dead, never born in the Fast, Rim names, and three bearing the names of PCs, collected years ago.
- ◇ **Prudence’s card** — her brother’s successor’s name. She will not give it to her.
- ◇ **The drawn card** — no name, only a careful drawing of an empty chair, pushed in, square to the table. She found it at a

table with eight chairs. She will not let anyone hold it.

## WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

**Secret:** the drawn card is getting warmer, though Orrum’s cards are always warm and this one never was until Tablenight 640.

**Unknown to her:** one of the cards in her box bears the name of Lean Bellamy, Fain’s mother, and Fain is looking for whoever holds it.

## TIES

- ◇ **Welcome Ardent** — would like the drawn card back. **Meek Garrity** — wants to see it. **Envoy Lowell** — her card is in the box. **Decline Marsh** — she follows his band.

## IN PLAY

She gives a PC their own card and asks them to keep it. Hooks: the eight-chair table; Fain’s search; Garrity’s request. If nobody intervenes, she dies on the road in Lack, and the box is found open, and the drawn card is gone.



---

#### SAID OF THEM

“She gave me my granddad’s card. I’d never seen his name written down.” — a boy of the border hamlets

“She knows more about my master’s guest list than I do.” —  
Welcome Ardent

“Mad as a hen. Lovely woman.” — Tarry Moss

---

# REFT HUME

*the Chit-Forger*

*“One chit. One day. One mouth. I don’t make bread, I make Tuesdays. Somebody’s Tuesday comes out of somebody else’s, that’s arithmetic, ask Mother Avery.”*

– REFT HUME, TO A CRUMB-RUNNER HAGGLING FOR A STACK OF FORGED CHITS

| REFT HUME – THE CHIT-FORGER |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                  | The Fast (so she believes) · Cut 0 (Unfed, so she believes; in truth Cut 3, Fatlands Gut-line, never tested) · Want 5 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| AGE & STATION               | 29 · Pantry Clerk, copyist of the daily list, forger of ration chits                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CALLING & STANDING          | Factor (of the black market in Tuesdays) · Standing 2 (Pantry Clerk)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                  | Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| SKILLS                      | Deceive 4 (forgery), Craft 3, Reckoning 3, Filch 3, Stealth 3, Clause 2, Endure 2, Athletics 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                        | Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| ATTACKS                     | a clerk’s penknife +4 (2)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                       | The Empty Bowl (she can forge a Pantry chit that passes the window at Hand + Deceive Hard 14; on a Grace the forgery enters the ledger as genuine, and someone else’s name, chosen by the GM, comes up a day short). Back on the List (once a season, by copying the daily list with a name restored, she can return one omitted person to the Ration Line for a week before Mother Avery’s count catches it). |
| WANTS                       | To feed the omitted. Not to know whose day she is taking.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| KNACKS                      | Steady Hands, Conditional                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| DERANGEMENTS                | none                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| CARRIES                     | a cut-down Pantry stamp; unbleached cloth squares; a copy of the daily list; a foundling’s tag                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                       | 0                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

## WHO THEY ARE

Reft is quick, narrow and sharp-elbowed, with a clever pointed face, thick dark hair she hacks short, and a habit of drumming her ink-stained fingers on any surface. She is a little broad in the hip for an Unfed and has been teased for it all her life. She talks fast and laughs at her own jokes, which in Wanting is a kind of indecency. She smells of ink and the starch the Pantry uses to stiffen chit-cloth.

## THEIR STORY

She was left at the Brindle Cross toll-house in a basket in the Lack of 612, with a wooden tag round her neck reading only *Reft*, and taken in by a family of Humes, descendants of Scarcity Hume of the Great Short. She grew up knowing she was the great-great-granddaughter, by adoption, of the woman who invented the list, and at nineteen took the clerk’s oath in the Pantry to atone for it. In 636, copying the daily list, she wrote back in, by accident, a name that had been struck. The woman ate for a week before anyone noticed. Reft decided it had not been an accident.

## THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She copies the daily list that the Keeper reads at dusk, and has access to the chit-stamp for the hour it takes to stamp the next day’s issue. In that hour she forges. She gives most of the forgeries to Withy Gaunt for the Lean House, where Withy refuses them, and then to the omitted directly, at night, at the Lean House door. She sells the rest to Crumb-Runners for three lacks each, to pay for cloth. Every forged chit that is honoured at the window is a day of grain taken from the Pantry’s four months, and Mother Avery’s arithmetic is exact. Reft knows this. Every Tuesday she gives the Lean House comes out of some village’s Tuesday at the end of Lack.

## WHAT THEY CARRY

- ♦ **A cut-down Pantry stamp** — the empty bowl, carved in pear-wood from a stolen impression. +2 to forgery.
- ♦ **Unbleached cloth squares** — stolen, a few at a time, from the Pantry’s own bolts.

- ◇ **A copy of the daily list** — with her own small marks beside the names she has restored.
- ◇ **The foundling's tag** — the wooden tag from her basket, *Reft*, and on its back, very faint, a brand she has never been able to read: a Fatlands Gut-line's notch.

#### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

Reft wants the Lean House empty. She fears Mother Stint Avery, who she is sure has noticed. **Secret (hers):** she has restored, among others, her own adoptive mother's name, struck last Carving, and the extra measure has kept the old woman alive. **Secret (unknown to her):** she is a Gut-line bastard of the Strake family of Sated, placed as a foundling by a ladies' maid who wanted the child to live without the god's weight. She carries Cut 3 that has never been fed a mouthful of Fatlands meat: a full Godeater inheritance, asleep. Scarce Odell has found her in the College quires and put her name on the Strake tree. The Reckoners' rule is that the line is not ended until every member is.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Scarce Odell** — has her on his list; they nod at the Ration Line.
- ◇ **Withy Gaunt** — refuses her chits three times, then lets her hand them out at the door.
- ◇ **Mother Stint Avery** — has seen the count come out short by forty days. Has said nothing yet.
- ◇ **Tarry Moss** — buys her chits, and spits after.
- ◇ **Kale Dragoman** — a Taste the Name lick of her blood would tell him exactly what she is, and what she is worth.

#### IN PLAY

PCs meet Reft when they need someone put back on the list, or when they are paid in chits that turn out to be hers.

- ◇ **The Strake Precedent.** Scant Hollis's band is preparing to end the Strake line in Sated. The tree has a cousin in Wanting. The PCs are the Carriers.
- ◇ **The Audit.** Mother Avery asks the PCs to find out who is stealing forty days from the Pantry. The answer is feeding the Lean House.

- ◇ **One Mouthful.** Reft, at a Rim inn, is given Fatlands meat by an unwitting PC. The god in her, asleep for twenty-nine years, wakes in an hour.

Threatened, she jokes and runs. Kindness she suspects, and then trades. If nobody intervenes, the Reckoners come for her quietly on the night before Tablenight, and the forty days come out right at last.

#### SAID OF THEM

"She gave me a chit at the Lean House door. I said no three times. She said, I'm not offering, I'm returning it, it was always yours." — a woman of the Lean House, who lived

"Forty days. Somebody is stealing forty days. I can find it to the day; I cannot yet bear to." — Mother Stint Avery

"Bit broad in the beam for one of ours, isn't she." — a woman in the Ration Line

# FALLOW BRINDLE

## Warden of the Barrows

*“The oldest are at the bottom. Nine deep, ten. I go down with the spade when the rain opens a mound. You’d think they’d be thin. They’re not thin. They’re clean.”*

– FALLOW BRINDLE, TO MEEK GARRITY, IN A LETTER HE HAS NOT ANSWERED

| FALLOW BRINDLE – WARDEN OF THE BARROWS |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| LAND & CUT                             | The Fast · Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 6 · Pangs 4 (Hollow)                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| AGE & STATION                          | 54 · Warden of the Barrows below Hallowboard; gatherer of teeth after rain                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| CALLING & STANDING                     | Celebrant (of the hill’s dead) · Standing 3 (Abstinent-appointed; nobody else wants it)                                                                                                                                                                                           |
| ATTRIBUTES                             | Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 4                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| SKILLS                                 | Labor 4, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Rites 3, Search 3, Lore 2, Blades 2                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| BODY                                   | Flesh 16 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (hide coat) · Fray 7                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| ATTACKS                                | spade +5 (3)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| GIFTS                                  | By the Ones Who Stood (any oath sworn in the trench before her as witness binds with the Strength of the Dead at +3 instead of +2). Bone-Reader (she can tell an Unfed bone from a Godeater’s by touch, and the oldest bones of the hill from the rest; Eye + Search Routine 10). |
| WANTS                                  | To keep the Barrows closed. To know why the oldest bones are clean.                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| KNACKS                                 | Butcher’s Calm, Silent Supper                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| DERANGEMENTS                           | The Seeing (triggered by dusk on the hill; she sees the second row standing on the first)                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| CARRIES                                | a spade; a sack of teeth; a carving knife from the bottom layer; a lantern; chalk                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| DREAD                                  | 2 (to go down into an opened mound with her)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

### WHO THEY ARE

Fallow is broad, heavy-handed and silent, with chalk ground into every line of her face and hands so that she looks carved, grey eyes, and cropped hair gone white at the temples. She speaks perhaps twenty words a day. She smells of wet chalk, turned turf and the pale long grass of the Barrows, which she does not cut, because it is the only grass in the Fast that is not trimmed.

### THEIR STORY

Born 587 to a family of the Brindle hamlet whose name the Cross took. Appointed Warden in 619. Each spring after rain she walks the trench and the Barrows, gathering the teeth the chalk gives up and reburying them, and when a mound slumps she goes down with a spade to lay the dead straight. In 639 the great Lammas Barrow opened after a storm, and she went down further than any Warden had, to the bottom layer.

### THEIR PLACE IN THE LAND

She lives in a turf hut at the foot of the hill, draws a measure brought by a Measure-Bearer once a fortnight, and witnesses the

oaths sworn in the trench. Unfed who travel two days to swear in their ancestors’ footprints find her standing a little way off with a lantern. She is the only Unfed who goes onto the hill alone at night, and she never walks on the eighth side.

### WHAT THEY CARRY

- ◇ **A sack of teeth** — the gatherings of a spring; she counts them into the Barrows on Tablenight.
- ◇ **A carving knife** — bronze, pre-Gorging, clean as the day it was ground. She found eleven hundred in the bottom layer, laid beside the dead, unused.
- ◇ **A lantern and chalk** — for marking which mound has slumped.

### WANTS, FEARS AND SECRETS

**Secret (hers):** the bottom layer of the Lammas Barrow does not hold starved bodies. It holds bones that are clean, every one, the way a plate is clean after a good guest has finished with it: no flesh, no marrow, no mark of tooth or blade, polished, as if by a cloth. They were buried first, before the trenches of the Refusal were dug over them. She has written this to Meek Garrity. **Unknown to her:** on

the eighth side, where she never walks, there are fresh footprints in the untrodden chalk every Lack morning, and they come from the Barrows, and they go away down the hill.

#### TIES

- ◇ **Meek Garrity** — her unanswered letter. **Abide Kettering** — his fields' graves never settle, and she has walked them. **Scant Hollis** — swore her captain's oath in the trench before Fallow. **Forbear Wend** — appointed her, and told her never to dig below the ninth row.

#### IN PLAY

PCs come to swear an oath in the trench, or to escort Meek to the hill. Hooks: the opened Barrow; the clean bones; the eleven hundred knives. Threatened, she leans on the spade and waits. If nobody intervenes, she goes down into the Lammas Barrow one more time in Lack, and does not come up, and in the morning the mound is closed and smooth, and the grass on it has been cut.

#### SAID OF THEM

"I swore on my grandmother's footprint. The Warden held the lamp. She didn't blink once." — a young Reckoner

"Twenty words a day, and nineteen of them are 'stand back'." — a Measure-Bearer

"She sent me a letter about clean bones. I have read it every night. I have not answered. I do not want to know what I already know." — Meek Garrity

# WEBS OF THE FAST

*The table is always laid for the one who stays too long.*

– WANTING PROVERB

The Fast is a small place, nine thousand souls on a cold edge, and everyone in it is tied to everyone else by the list, the chalk and the

god. The table below covers the people of this half of the chapter; the first half's people appear in their ties.

| CHARACTER         | WANTS FROM                       | FEARS                         | OWES                            |
|-------------------|----------------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Mercy Thrane      | Aldane: men to raid Barr's house | the ledger being useless      | the College, her honesty        |
| Kale Dragoman     | any captive: thanks              | the fork-badge man            | Barr, a reason; Withy, his life |
| Prudence Lowell   | Wend: Garrity's omission         | Garrity being right           | Oriel Vance, an answer          |
| Scour             | Scant Hollis: a clean death      | the nursery; his own voice    | the Paunch child, a spoon       |
| Sober Osmond      | a PC: to take the duty           | dying with no successor       | the god, a plate a night        |
| Yield Hartsell    | whoever waters: a name           | the burning party             | Tarry Moss, fifty springs       |
| Little Fain       | the right person: a hand         | nothing                       | the kitchen, one guest          |
| Keep Aldane       | Osanna: to go home               | that she is right             | Cease Pollard, a measure        |
| Osanna Blythe     | Aldane: the gate                 | dying a day short             | the column, a table             |
| Meek Garrity      | one Elder: belief                | the brazier                   | Fallow Brindle, an answer       |
| Welcome Ardent    | anyone: relief                   | the extra chair               | Bounty, a card                  |
| Scarce Odell      | Reft Hume: her gums              | a loose end                   | the Reckoners, everything       |
| Withy Gaunt       | the dying: the recipe            | the Host coming in            | Decline, an answer              |
| Abide Kettering   | Kale: payment                    | Mercy's scale                 | Withy, the truth                |
| Joss Mardle       | Avery: silence                   | the sealed order              | the Fast, four villages         |
| Hollow Ann Pruett | Ardent: nothing                  | anyone holding the drawn card | Prudence, her card              |
| Reft Hume         | Avery: blindness                 | the audit                     | the omitted, forty days         |
| Fallow Brindle    | Garrity: a reply                 | the bottom layer              | the hill, the teeth             |

## THREE FUSES

**The Mother, the Son and the Sexton.** Withy Gaunt sold her baby at Brindle Cross so that he would live. He lived, and grew up to be Kale Dragoman, who buys the bodies of the omitted from Withy's own sexton, Abide Kettering, at the crossroads three miles west. Withy has the red neckcloth. Kale has the empty grave his father

showed him. Kettering has the purse of chits. Any PC who follows one thread finds the other two. The explosion comes when Kale, kind and plump and smelling of woodsmoke, walks into the Lean House to collect a body himself, and Withy smells him, and Kale, licking a drop of her blood from a cut on her hand to price an old woman in the straw, tastes his own name. Kettering is in the doorway. Kettering has the pickaxe.

**The Physician and the Farmer Called Abide.** Mercy Thrane carries a plank from a hidden room in Sated with *A.T.* scratched on it, and believes it is a patient's. It is her brother's. Abide Thrane has been alive in Master Quillon Barr's brine-tanks for nine years and has started to put on weight, and Barr has read Mercy's book with admiration and sent her spectacles. Marshal Aldane has sixty men and a boy in the weighing-shed he is already breaking the law for. Kale has the address. Mardle has the dockets. The moment Mercy learns the truth she will go over the Rim with or without help, and the Fast will have to decide, very publicly, whether an Unfed taken is dead.

**The Slate, the Envoy and the Captain.** Meek Garrity has the seating plan; Fallow Brindle has the clean bones and eleven hundred

unused knives; Sober Osmond has a rite with a line about *the one who comes late*; Hollow Ann Pruett has a card with an empty chair drawn on it. Together they say that the Refusal never happened, and they say something else as well, which no one has yet put into words. Prudence Lowell has asked for Garrity's death to protect the Refusal. Scant Hollis stood in Garrity's doorway for a minute and left: if the Unfed only arrived late, her nine ended lines were not justice but envy. When the papers reach the Reckoners' west gate, the Fast's two poles, the Keepers and the Reckoners, will discover they have the same enemy, and that he is a gentle old man with ink on his lip, and the PCs will be the only people in Wanting standing between him and the brazier.

# USING THE FAST'S PEOPLE

## RUNNING THE FAST'S PEOPLE

- ◇ **Everyone refuses three times.** When a PC offers an Unfed NPC anything, play the Decline aloud. The fourth offer is where character lives.
- ◇ **Kindness is the threat.** Kale, Osanna, Fain and Ardent are the most dangerous people in the chapter, and none of them will raise a hand.
- ◇ **The list is always being written.** At any point the GM may announce that a name has been left off. Make it a name the players know.
- ◇ **Never say whose chair it is.** Ardent does not know; Garrity has misread it; Hollow Ann will not let anyone hold the card. Let the players count the sides of Hallowboard themselves.

## WHO'S AT THE DOOR?

Roll a d20 when the PCs are lodging in Wanting, sheltering in a bricked house, or camped near the border, and someone knocks. In the Fast, the door opens outward. Nobody says *come in*.

| D20 | AT THE DOOR           | WHY                                                                                                            |
|-----|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1   | Dr. Mercy Thrane      | To measure every PC, now, before the Pantry list is read; she will not say why the hurry                       |
| 2   | Kale Dragoman         | With a pot of stew, as a peace offering, three times, and then a fourth                                        |
| 3   | Envoy Prudence Lowell | To ask a PC to stand back to back with her while she eats, and talk about numbers                              |
| 4   | Scour                 | Sleeves buttoned, asking for a bag of sand, and whether anyone saw a cold table on the road                    |
| 5   | Verger Sober Osmond   | Lost, six miles from his hall, asking which way, and whether anyone would like to learn a rite                 |
| 6   | Yield Hartsell        | Breathless, with her fork: the wheat has grown an inch, and there is frost on it in Plenty                     |
| 7   | Little Fain           | Holding out a warm hand. "You can come too."                                                                   |
| 8   | Marshal Keep Aldane   | Needing ten more spears by dusk; the column is singing at the gate                                             |
| 9   | Osanna Blythe         | Asking for directions, very politely, for the third time today                                                 |
| 10  | Meek Garrity          | With a sack of pease that is not pease, begging the PCs to keep it till morning                                |
| 11  | Welcome Ardent        | Bowing; he has laid a table in the yard, and is so sorry, and would they mind not breaking it till he has gone |
| 12  | Scarce Odell          | With a tape-measure, to verify a name that turns out to be a PC's                                              |
| 13  | Withy Gaunt           | A friend of the PCs is in the Lean House and has asked for them by name, with a recipe                         |
| 14  | Abide Kettering       | With his cart and lamp, at the wrong hour, asking if anyone here has died yet                                  |
| 15  | Factor Joss Mardle    | Offering, in principle, a contract, with an exit only he can find                                              |
| 16  | Hollow Ann Pruett     | With a card in a loved hand, bearing a PC's name; it is rude to leave it                                       |
| 17  | Reft Hume             | With a fistful of chits, needing them hidden before the Keeper's audit                                         |



| D20 | AT THE DOOR    | WHY                                                                                               |
|-----|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 18  | Fallow Brindle | Twenty words: a Barrow has opened, and she needs strong backs and steady stomachs before dark     |
| 19  | Nobody         | Only the smell of bread, and a card slid under the door, in a dead mother's hand                  |
| 20  | A tall shape   | Stooping under the lintel, warm, holding the door open for someone it is not looking at (Dread 4) |



PART TWO

# LEAVINGS

*What is left of a god when someone takes a knife to it.*



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CHAPTER 8

# THE CARVING KNIFE

*The Taking of Leavings*

*We ate them once because we had to. We go on eating them because we have learned what the pieces do.*

— MOTHER GALL, PICKLER, TO A CUSTOMER

TESTIMONY OF A GLEANER TAKEN BY THE MORTUARY COURT, LASTGATE, 640 A.G. THE CLERK NOTES THAT THE WITNESS SMELLED OF VINEGAR AND WOULD NOT SIT DOWN.

*You want to know how it is done. It is done like butchery, because it is butchery. You need a cold room or a cold night, a good blade, a bucket, salt, and a friend who can hold a lamp without looking. You need to know what you are cutting for: a finger is not a finger, sir, a Hand-line finger is a key, a Hand-line finger is a death, and if you cut it at the wrong joint you have a grey dead stick and nothing more. You need to know how long you have. Some things go off in a breath. Some things never go off, and those are worse.*

*And you need to know what it costs you. I have carved forty-one leavings in my life. I have sold all but one. The one I kept*

*is in my mouth, under my tongue. I cannot take it out. That is not a figure of speech.*

*No, I will not show you. Ask the next question.*

A god is a body. When six peoples ate their Providers on the Night of Seven Tables, they did not eat all of it: there were bones that would not crack, organs that would not cook, blood that would not clot, parts that were hidden, stolen, buried or kept. And the gods have been growing back ever since, in their eaters' bloodlines, soil, weather and dead, which means that every land on the Table is full of god again: in the hands of its nobles, the mouths of its Laden, the lungs of its Tenanted, the eyes of its sleepers, the cords of its Uncut, the tongues of its Sayers, and the crumbs on the Host's tables.

The people of the Table call the things that can be taken from all this **leavings**: what is left on the plate. This chapter explains how leavings are known, carved, kept and used. The catalogues that follow describe them land by land.

## EVERYTHING ON THE TABLE IS FOOD, OR WAS. EVERYTHING ON THE TABLE IS A GOD, OR WILL BE.

[ CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE, FIRST LECTURE ]

### ▼ THE ANATOMY OF A LEAVING

Every leaving in the catalogues is described with six entries.

- ◇ **WHISPERED:** how hard it is to have heard of the leaving: what it is, where it comes from, what it does. A character rolls **Eye + Lore** (or another pair the Carver allows: **Eye + Reckoning** for a Seamer's anatomy, **Caul + Rites** for a priest's legend, **Tongue + Haggle** for a fence's gossip) against the listed difficulty. Success means they know of it; a Helping reveals its Taint; a Grace reveals one false belief that people hold about it. Failure means they know only rumours, which the Carver may make false.
- ◇ **SPOILAGE:** how long the leaving stays potent once taken from its source, and what keeps it. A spoiled leaving is only meat,

bone or water, though often it is still Tainted.

- ◇ **CARVING:** how the leaving is taken: from what, or whom, with which tools, by which roll, at what risk. Carving is described below.
- ◇ **TAINT:** the residue of the god the leaving carries, using the Taint rules of the Rim Market chapter (Hunger, Regrowth or Dread, rated 1–5).
- ◇ **EFFECT:** what the leaving does, in the rules.
- ◇ **WORTH:** its price in lacks (if it is sold at all), its availability rating, where it changes hands and whether it is legal.

## ▼ KNOWING

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Leavings are surrounded by more lies than any other trade on the Table. Every second stall on the Rim Road sells a “Hand-line knuckle” that is a pig’s; every inn has a man who knows a man who has a bottle of Hush. The WHISPERED roll protects the Guests from the obvious frauds, but the Carver should be generous with rumours and stingy with certainty. A leaving’s true effect is often

learned only by using it, and some of the catalogue’s effects are meant to be discovered that way, at the worst moment.

Identifying a specific item in hand (is this the real thing?) uses the Rim Market rules: **Eye + Lore**, Hard (14) to identify a Taint’s kind and rating, Grim (18) to identify which god. Cutwrights, Seamers, Renderers and Midwives may substitute their Calling’s signature skill when the leaving falls within their trade.

## ▼ CARVING

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Carving a leaving is a **Long Task** with a single climactic roll. The catalogue entry gives:

- ◆ **The source.** A living person, a corpse, a horror, a place, a table, an object.
- ◆ **The tools.** A carving kit (Seamer’s or Renderer’s) is assumed. Some leavings need special tools: lead jars, brine-casks, gold wire, a Waker’s needle, a lit candle, silence. Without them the Difficulty rises by one step or the carving is impossible.
- ◆ **The roll.** Usually **Hand + Stitching** (surgery and fine cutting) or **Hand + Blades** (butchery), against the listed Difficulty. Other pairs appear where they fit: Caul + Rites to take something holy without waking it, Eye + Reckoning to bottle a place, Tongue + Clause to take a word.
- ◆ **The Dread.** Almost every carving calls for a Dread check before the roll: the Carver should describe, fully, what the carver is doing with their hands. Failing the Dread check imposes –2 on the carving roll.
- ◆ **Helpings.** Each Helping on a carving roll either doubles the yield (two doses, a larger piece) or extends the Spoilage by one step (minutes to hours, hours to days, days to a season).
- ◆ **Grace.** A perfect cut: the leaving is taken whole, with maximum yield and no backlash, and the carver gains a Portion for their mastery.
- ◆ **Lack.** The carving goes wrong in the way the entry describes. If no backlash is listed, the leaving is ruined and the carver suffers the item’s Taint as though they had used it.

### CARVING FROM THE LIVING

Many of the most potent leavings must be taken from people who are still alive: a Kept limb, a Gut-line’s marbled fat, a Lung-line’s breath, an Eye-line’s lash, a Caul-line’s veil, a Tongue-line’s word. A willing donor makes a carving one step easier, and the Table has a

long and terrible tradition of willing donors: debtors, the desperate, the devout, mothers selling for their children. An unwilling donor must be held or drugged, and the act is a **Dread 3** horror for the carver (Dread 4 if the donor is someone they know; kin-carving is Dread 4 and counts as the act a character would not do, if that is their line). Carving from the living deals damage to the donor as listed, often a Mangling result chosen rather than rolled.

Carving the living is murder or mutilation under the law of every land, save where it is licensed: Sallowreach licenses part-sales by the Kept themselves, the Fatlands licenses the render of the dead, and the Attendance of Cradlewrack claims all Parts. Everywhere else, it is a hanging.

### CARVING THE DEAD AND THE DESECRATED

Carving a corpse is grave desecration in every land but the Fatlands. It is easier (one step) and usually less potent. In Sallowreach, of course, the dead feel everything, and will remember who did it.

Grave-oaths sworn over a body that has been carved bind twice as hard (see Oaths on the Dead in the core book). Many carvers swear such an oath before they begin, to make the leaving stronger: *On your name, I will use what I take from you well*. Some leavings in the catalogues require it.

### CARVING PLACES

Some leavings are taken not from bodies but from places where a god is close: a jar of Hush, a skin of the Trench’s water, a breath of the long room, a handful of crowning-clay, a stone from Sworn Gorge, a crumb from a laid table. Carving a place usually means **Eye + Reckoning** (measuring, sealing, timing) or **Caul + Godsign** (sensing where the god is thin), and always means being in the place long enough to suffer it: each attempt costs the carver the place’s Hunger, Fray or Dread as described in the land chapters.

# ▼KEEPING: SPOILAGE AND PRESERVATION

Leavings spoil. The god wants to go home, and a leaving taken away from its source begins at once to lose its grip. Spoilage is listed in steps:

| SPOILAGE | LASTS                                      | COMMON PRESERVATION                                   |
|----------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Breath   | a few heartbeats; must be used on the spot | none possible                                         |
| Minutes  | about ten minutes                          | salt and darkness extend to an hour                   |
| Hours    | a day at most                              | brine, lead, cold extend to a week                    |
| Days     | about a week                               | wax, pickling, Mother Gall's brine extend to a season |
| Seasons  | a season                                   | sealed lead and Hush-wax extend to a year             |
| Never    | it does not spoil                          | nothing makes it less potent                          |

Each land has its own preservation craft. Sallowreach preserves in vinegar, lacquer and the weighted dark of the Sump; nothing spoils there, which is why its leavings fetch more abroad. The Fatlands salt, smoke and render. Brinehollow keeps things wet, in brine taken from its own people's lungs. The Vigil keeps things lit and watched, because what is not watched in the Vigil goes to sleep. Cradlewrack keeps things shut, and nothing in Cradlewrack stays shut. Oathen

keeps things by promising to keep them, which works exactly as long as the promise does. The Fast keeps nothing; its leavings neither spoil nor stay.

A leaving that is carried on a **living body**, sewn under the skin, held in the mouth, worn on a cord against the breastbone, keeps one step longer. It also counts as worn against the skin for Taint every day.

# USING LEAVINGS

Unless an entry says otherwise:

- ◇ Using a leaving takes an action in combat or a few moments otherwise.
- ◇ Its **Taint** applies on use, as the Rim Market chapter describes.
- ◇ A character may have the effects of **no more leavings at once than their Caul rating**. More than that, and the gods begin to argue inside them: the Carver rolls a d10 for each excess leaving every scene, and on a 1 that leaving's Taint applies again.
- ◇ Leavings from a **foreign god** use the Rim Market's foreign-god rules. Characters who carry leavings of three or more gods gain the Derangement *The Voice at Table*, speaking in several voices.
- ◇ **Blanks and the Unfed** use leavings normally, except that Hunger Taint does not touch them and Regrowth Taint Seasons them (see the Rim Market). Leavings are the most common way an Unfed comes to carry a god.

## ▼ TRADING LEAVINGS

Leavings are the most valuable trade on the Table and the most dangerous. Every land has laws against some of them and a black market in all of them. The Rim Road Company officially trades

none and unofficially taxes them all at the toll-gates, as “Breath” (a lack a post for any traveller carrying godsign at the Course, a rule the Company's Wardens interpret broadly).

| WHERE                          | WHAT SELLS                                | WHO BUYS                                     |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Lastgate, the Sinks            | Kept parts, Hand-line relics, Hush-wax    | Vigil envoys, Fatlands dying, Second Table   |
| Sated, the Chute               | Gut-line cuts, Laden-soil, toothed grain  | everyone; it is the breadbasket              |
| Lowmark, the far pier          | brine, Tenanted shells, Uncovered salvage | Vigil rouse-cutters, apothecaries            |
| The Slope, the Vigil           | lashes, sleeper-breath, Seeming-ink       | anyone who must not sleep or must            |
| Kest, the back of the Lying-In | Parts, cauls, cord, crowning-clay         | Assemblers, Brinehollow buyers, surgeons     |
| Tacit, the Breakdowns          | Sayer-wax, Forsworn bone, echo-stones     | Clausewrights, foreign courts, the desperate |
| Wanting, after dark            | crumbs, cards, steward's linen            | pilgrims, Second Table, the starving         |
| Every Rim waystation           | fakes                                     | everyone                                     |

### THE PRICE OF A GOD

Leavings in the catalogues have prices, but price is the least of their cost. A Carver running a campaign rich in leavings should keep a simple tally for each Guest of *every leaving they have used*, and let it show. People who wear the gods on cords around their necks start to smell like the lands those gods were eaten in. Cutwrights can read it on them. The Reckoners can, too.





CHAPTER 9

# LEAVINGS OF SALLOWREACH

*Everything here keeps. That is the whole trouble, and the whole trade.*

— SIGN ABOVE A PART-BROKER'S HATCH IN THE SINKS, LASTGATE

IN ANY OTHER LAND A RELIC IS A DEAD THING THAT  
REMEMBERS. HERE IT IS A LIVING THING THAT  
CANNOT STOP.

[ PROVOST CARRION SEDGE, MARGINAL NOTE IN THE NORTHERN LEDGERS ]

In the south they dig their relics out of the ground. In the west they cough them up. In Sallowreach, relics walk into the shop on their own feet and ask what they will fetch. Nothing in the fen finishes, and so nothing taken from the fen goes still: a finger cut from a Kept thief goes on picking pockets, a candle rendered from a grandmother goes on feeling the flame, a sod of grey turf lifted from a Hush goes on being silent in a sack. A northern relic is not a souvenir of the god. It is a piece of the god's long refusal, still refusing.

The trade has no single market and no honest name. The Seamers' Guild calls it "the loose parts business" and disowns it while buying from it. The Mortuary Court calls it theft of licensed goods. The Sinks call it "the leavings," and the Sinks are where it is bought: behind wire-drawers' shops, in the flooded cellars of the Drowned Storeys where Little Nell Ash's Smalls run errands for a ribbon, off punts that come in from the Sump at dusk with something under a tarpaulin that is moving a little. A leaving changes hands in perfume. Buyer and seller each hold a pomander to the face, and the price is spoken through cedar and clove, because what is on the table smells, and always will.

Carving in the north is easy and terrible, because nothing that is cut will die of the cutting. A Kept man can be relieved of a hand on

his shelf in the Lofts and wake in the morning able to feel it being used three streets away. A Hand-line noble deep in the Course can be trimmed like a hedge, and the trimmings go on closing things. The difficulty is never the knife. It is the smell, the screaming that has no air behind it, the guard, and the law. The Court counts its nobles' fingers, the Loft-Wardens count their shelved, and the Seamers' Guild keeps a book of every part it has ever sewn on.

What the fen-folk fear most is not the relics' power but their persistence. A thing carved in Sallowreach does not spoil the way meat spoils elsewhere. It spoils by finishing: by going quiet, going cold, going properly dead, which is the one thing every northerner has been taught both to long for and to dread. A relic that finishes in your hand is a small funeral, and the fen-folk hold it like one. They say *may you finish*, and mean it, and are a little jealous.

Outside the north, almost every relic here weakens or ends at once, because what keeps them going is the land. Foreign buyers learn this at the Finishing Post, holding a hand that has suddenly become an ordinary dead hand. The entries below say which leavings survive the crossing. Few do. Those that do are worth ten times their northern price.

## ▼ FROM THE HAND-LINES



The Hand-lines are the god's hands, and their bodies are the north's richest and most dangerous seam. A Hand-line at the Course sheds what other people only grow: nails like horn, slate-grey skin that flakes away in cold sheets, extra joints that must be trimmed so the gloves still fit. The Court burns every trimming in the Hall of Hands, by statute, before witnesses, with the ash sunk in the Sump

in a lead box. The statute has been honored perhaps nine times in ten. The tenth is the trade.

## ◇ THE NINTH JOINT OF OSRIC VANE

Osric Vane's hands grow. Every finger has nine joints, and every year or two a tenth buds grey under the knuckle, and the Court's surgeon must take the outermost joint away so that the lead mittens will still close at the wrist. The trimmings are counted, logged and burned. One was not. In the Lack of 637 the surgeon's boy, a Threader named Coyle, walked out of Glovehall's west wing with a joint of the left forefinger in his cheek, cold enough to make his teeth ache for a week, and sold it in the Sinks. He is in the Jar Room now. The joint is not.

It is the length of a thumbnail, slate-grey, smooth as river stone, with a black nail at one end and a pearled grey socket at the other. It does not warm in the hand. Once an hour it curls, slowly, as though beckoning. Osric, told it was missing, asked only whether it was being put to good use. He is at the Brink, and what his hands finish now is finer than wood or wick: the things a person carries inside them.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); Grim (18) for anyone who has served at Glovehall. A Grace learns that Coyle still talks, in his jar.

**SPOILAGE** None in Sallowreach. In a lead thimble it holds anywhere on the Table for a year; carried bare outside the north, it finishes in a day. If it ever touches Osric's other hands it goes home, and his forefinger has ten joints again.

**CARVING** Only with Osric's consent, through a padlocked mitten, in a room without flies: Hand + Stitching vs Grim (18), with cold-iron snips. A Lack means bare skin brushes the hand: Caul + Resolve vs Grim (18) or suffer Ruin and rise Kept. Watching the joint go on curling on the tray is a Dread 3 check.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Touch it to a brow and Partake (Hand + Rites vs Hard 14; the target may resist with Caul + Resolve). On success, close one thing inside them until the next full Plate: a memory, one Want, one Derangement, or one grief (remove all Fray tied to that loss). Used on an Oath on the Dead, it closes the oath: no Strength, no Keeping, no Visitation if broken, and the bearer can never again speak the dead person's name. Three uses a season; a fourth closes something of the GM's choosing, in the user.

**WORTH** 3,000 L in the back rooms; Absalom Hethe would pay double. Unique. Capital theft of a Court asset.

## ◇ GLOVE-THREAD OF THE LEFT HAND

Lady Corrow Vane's gloves are sewn on. They come off once a year, at Lack, when her Glovebearers unpick the seams by lamplight with bone hooks, wash the hands she has never used to hold her children, and stitch on new gloves before dawn. The old thread is supposed to

be burned. It has spent a year in the seam of the most expensive touch in the north, eleven thousand Closings' worth of cold, and it has learned something.

It is grey gut-thread, waxed, kinked from the seam. It frosts in a warm room. Under a lens, every twist of it is stiff with a fine white rime, like breath on a winter window, and the rime does not melt. Northern Seamers who have stitched with it say the needle grows heavy in the fingers, and that patients go quiet under it in a way that is not sleep.

The Glovebearers sell it by the inch, carefully, to Seamers they trust. Corrow knows. She has never said a word. One of her bearers believes she wants it used; that the only mercy her hands are permitted to give without a license is the mercy her thread gives, by stealth, on Needle Street, to strangers.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among Seamers; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A season, in a twist of waxed paper. Wet, it loses its rime in a day. Outside Sallowreach it is only thread after a week.

**CARVING** Taken at the yearly unpicking by a Glovebearer, or bought from one. Stealing it requires getting into Glovehall's east wing on the longest night of Lack, past Hand-line guards: Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18). A Lack means Corrow sees the thief, says nothing, and the thief is her creature from then on, whether they know it or not.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Ossel).

**EFFECT** A wound stitched with a yard of glove-thread (Hand + Stitching vs Hard 14) closes and stays closed: it cannot reopen, bleed or fester, and restores 2 extra Flesh. The pain of it closes too, for a day. The scar is grey, cold and numb forever. A Kept body stitched with it gains no Rot for a full season, and is very quiet. A yard covers one wound.

**WORTH** 30 L the inch, 900 L a yard. Scarce on Needle Street; Rare elsewhere. Illegal, but every Seamer of standing has a twist of it in a drawer.

## ◇ A DROP OF THE REGENT'S LACQUER

Ansel Grue is four hundred and twelve years old and mostly wire, lacquer and habit. The lacquer is laid on by Guild masters every Plate, layer on layer, black and amber, like the varnish on a very old violin, and as the old coats craze and lift, they are scraped from his cheeks and wrists and the backs of his hands with silver knives, and the scrapings are supposed to be sunk in the Sump with the rest of the Court's leavings.

The scrapings are flakes of dark amber, glossy on one side and on the other faintly furred with what was under them. They smell of pine resin, camphor and something very old and dry, a smell Lastgate calls *office*. Melted in a spoon over a Kept-candle, they run

like honey and give off the smell of a counting-house on a hot afternoon.

The Regent has signed every death license in Sallowreach for three hundred years and has never once considered signing his own. Whatever keeps him upright has been soaking into those coats for centuries. Painted on the Kept, a drop of it does the same thing to them: it keeps them. Not well. Not kindly. Just upright, and at their desks.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). Unvacated families know of it at Hard (14) and do not speak of it to their heirs.

**SPOILAGE** Indefinite, sealed in a lead-stoppered vial. Once melted, it must be used within the hour.

**CARVING** The scrapings are taken at the Regent's monthly lacquering in the Hall of Hands. A Seamer of Master rank may palm a flake (Hand + Filch vs Hard 14). Anyone else must bribe one, or take it from the Regent directly, which means a knife against the most guarded body in the north (Hand + Blades vs Dire 22 for a clean scrape; on a Lack, the Regent notices, and remembers, and will remember for another four hundred years). Seeing the Regent unlacquered under the scrapings is Dread 2.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), 1 Hunger.

**EFFECT** Melted and painted over a Kept body (an hour's work), a drop removes 2 Rot and prevents any Rot gain for a year. The Kept so treated cannot be Closed by touch for that year; the Closer's hand slides off the lacquer. They also cannot change their mind about anything they held to on the day of painting. On a living person, it does nothing but stain. The Unvacated pay for it to make sure they never have to vacate.

**WORTH** 400 L a drop. Rare. The Heirs would pay more to have the supply destroyed. The Court has hanged two Seamers for selling it, and kept them.

## ◇ MITTEN-LEAD

Lead that has been worn for years around a Course-hand goes cold, and stays cold. Osric Vane's mittens are recast every few years because the lead goes brittle, crazed with white frost from the inside, and so do the mittens of every Hand-line too far gone to be trusted in gloves. The old lead goes to the Court's smelter. Some of it goes, instead, to a smith in the Sinks named Hessa Coombe, who casts it into sling-stones.

A mitten-lead stone is grey, dull, heavy for its size, and cold enough to blister an unprotected palm. Frost forms on it in Plenty. It is silent in flight: no whistle, no hum, and the sound of its strike does not carry. Coombe's customers are the Heirs, the occasional Reckoner, and Finishers who want to finish something that is not themselves.

The Sinks tell of an Heir named Tobin Rook who in 612 dropped his Unvacated grandfather with one stone at forty paces,

and the family stood over him all night, and in the morning he was still down. He got up on the third day. For those three days the whole street paid Coombe in advance.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in the Sinks; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** The cold lasts a year from casting. Within a year of leaving Sallowreach it is only lead.

**CARVING** The lead must be stolen from Court stores or a Hand-line house (Lung + Filch vs Grim 18) and recast by a smith willing to handle it (Hand + Craft vs Hard 14 with iron tongs; bare-handed, it is a Dread 1 check and 1 Flesh of frostbite). A Lack at the casting means the mold cracks and the smith's hand is caught by the spill: it goes grey to the wrist and does not come back.

**TAINT** Dread 1 (per scene in which the stones are used).

**EFFECT** A sling-stone of mitten-lead deals 3 damage instead of 2 and its strike makes no sound. Against a Kept target, each Helping on the hit also adds 1 Rot, and a Grace closes the Kept outright, as the Closing Touch. Against a living target in Sallowreach, a Grace forces Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14) or the target suffers Ruin. A pouch holds six stones; each can be recovered and reused until the cold goes.

**WORTH** 25 L a stone, 120 L a pouch of six. Uncommon in the Sinks, Scarce elsewhere. Possessing one is "carrying an unlicensed ending," a flogging offense.

## ◇ PIM SORREL'S SHED TOOTH

Pim Sorrel is a Scrapling of twelve whose touch ends things, which should be impossible for her blood. The Court wants her opened on a table to find out how. The Finishers want her crowned. Her mother wants her across the border. And because she is twelve, her milk teeth have been coming out, one at a time, for two years, and somebody has been collecting them.

The teeth are small, white, a little chipped, and faintly cold, like pebbles from a spring. Held in a closed fist near a crying child, they stop the crying. Pim's mother kept the first two under her pillow, for luck, the way mothers do. Both were stolen in the same week. Pim hides her teeth now, and three have still gone missing.

Nobody knows what a Scrapling-born Closing means. Carrion Sedge has offered a fortune for a single tooth, to grind and test. Sister Lorn would set one in a reliquary. Marrow Jack has one already, and has been very careful about who he shows it to.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). Finishers and Smalls know of them at Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** Indefinite. Unlike Hand-line leavings, the tooth keeps its chill anywhere on the Table. Nobody knows why. That fact alone is worth a fortune to the Cutwrights.

**CARVING** Pim's teeth are not carved. They fall out. Obtaining one means stealing it from her, from her mother, or from whoever stole

it last. Anyone who would pull one from her mouth is beyond the scope of this book and beneath the contempt of the Smalls, who will find them.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Ossel), and see below.

**EFFECT** Held in the closed fist, the tooth lets the bearer use the Closing Touch once, as a Course-stage Hand-line would, regardless of Cut or land. Each use, the bearer rolls a d6: on a 1, the tooth is

spent and crumbles to chalk, and Pim, wherever she is, feels it and weeps. A character with Cut 0 who uses it gains a mark of Seasoning, as if from Regrowth Taint, and the GM notes that the Scrapling line has found a door.

**WORTH** Never sold openly. Sedge offers 2,000 L; the Finishers would trade a death-license minute for each. Unique per tooth (perhaps six exist). Owning one marks the owner, in the eyes of every faction, as someone who has been near the girl.

## ▼ FROM THE KEPT AND THE LOFTS



Nine Sallowreachers in ten are Kept, and the Kept are inexhaustible. This is the sordid heart of the leavings trade: the dead do not need their parts, the dead cannot lock their doors, and the dead do not stop feeling what is done with what was taken. Marrow Jack's whole business rests on it. So does the Seamers' Guild's, from the other side of the counter. The leavings in this section are taken from the long dead, and most of them can still hear you.

### ◆ SHROUD-LINEN OF THE LOFTS

The Set-Aside are wrapped in linen and shelved in the Lofts, aware. The wrappings are changed every decade, when the old cloth has gone brown and stiff with what has soaked into it. The Loft-Wardens are supposed to burn the old shrouds. Old Bettany Shroud, who has read to the shelved every night for fifty years and has written down everything they whisper back, does not burn them. She folds them, and keeps them in a cedar chest, because she cannot bear to.

A length of Loft linen is the color of strong tea, stiff and greasy, printed with the faint outline of the face it lay over. It smells of camphor and old meat. Wrapped around the head, it whispers the Lofts' whisper, like rain on reeds: names, grudges, the gossip of six generations. And lately, under all of them, one word.

The word is *company*. Every shelf in the Lofts has been whispering it for a year, as though someone were coming up the stairs. The linen whispers it too, wherever it is taken. A pedlar who carried a length of it to Gristmoot said that it whispered louder on the road east, toward the Fast.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14). Loft-Wardens know at Routine (10) and are ashamed.

**SPOILAGE** The whisper fades over a year, faster in sunlight. Folded in cedar and kept in the dark, it lasts a decade. It survives the border, faintly, for a season.

**CARVING** Bought from a Warden, or cut from a shelved body by a thief on the ladders at night (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14; the shelved feel the cloth go and begin, very quietly, to beg). Unwrapping one of the Set-Aside to take the shroud is a Dread 2 check; seeing the face under it is a Dread 3.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** A character who wraps their head in the linen for an hour (Eye + Search vs Hard 14) may learn one secret about any person who lived or was Kept in north Lastgate: one secret, one Helping each for another. Each hour so spent also gives 1 Fray from the voices. On a Lack, the listener hears their own name in the whisper, said by someone shelved who loved them, and must make a Dread 3 check. Anywhere on the Table, the linen murmurs *company* a little louder in the presence of an eighth chair, a laid table, or a place card.

**WORTH** 60 L a yard in Lastgate. Scarce. Not illegal, merely shameful; the Wardens will be very hurt.

### ◆ A CELL OF THE HONORABLE MAGGOT

Justice Ever Lathe of the Court of Wrongs has been Kept since 389 and has rotted down to bone, a few black tendons and a resident colony. His rulings are delivered in the buzzing, and a clerk translates. Nobody is sure any longer which of them is deciding. The colony is the court. And the colony breeds, and when it breeds it sheds: a living, seething clot of grubs and flies that drops from the hem of his robe in the robing room, and is swept up by an usher, and is sold.

A cell is a jar of a few hundred white grubs and a dozen fat blue flies, nested in black matter best not asked about. Unlike every other fly in Sallowreach, these move in order. The grubs coil and uncoil together. The flies rise and settle as one, like a choir standing. Say something untrue near it, and the buzzing rises, thin and angry.

A widow in the Sinks keeps one on her husband's chair at dinner and asks it whether he still loves her. She says it never lies.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Routine (10) for anyone who practices before the Court of Wrongs.

**SPOILAGE** A cell lives as long as it is fed: a mouthful of rotten meat a week, which in Sallowreach is the easiest thing to find. Starved, it dies in a month. Outside Sallowreach the flies behave as ordinary flies within a day, and the grubs pupate into nothing.

**CARVING** An usher sells them at the robing-room door for a crown of bribes; or the colony can be taken from Justice Lathe himself, by a bold hand under his robe in court (Lung + Filch vs Grim 18; a Lack and the colony notices, and the Justice rules, through his clerk, that the thief is in contempt, which in the Court of Wrongs is a sentence of a year in a jar). Handling the clot barehanded is a Dread 1 check.

**TAINT** Dread 1. Those who sleep beside the jar dream in buzzing, and start translating it.

**EFFECT** In the jar's presence, any deliberate lie spoken aloud makes the colony shrill. Characters gain +2 to Instinct rolls to detect lies, and anyone who knows what the jar is suffers -2 to Deceive. Placed on a festering wound, a cell eats the rot clean in an hour (the wound stops festering; a Kept body loses 1 Rot), but the user must make a Dread 1 check, and the cell grows by a third.

**WORTH** 45 L a jar. Scarce. Legal; mildly disreputable. The Court of Wrongs considers sales a perquisite of the ushers.

## ◇ A DESERTER OF CAPTAIN MORROW'S

Captain Dace Morrow, Commander of the Fen Guard, has been killed sixty times and stitched back after every one. He is more thread than soldier now, a tall figure bound in cord and wire, his face held on by a lattice of brass. And he has begun deserting in small pieces. His soldiers find parts of him in the barracks, under cots, behind the latrine, in the boots of men about to go on watch: a finger, an ear, a slab of shoulder with its stitching unpicked from the inside. The parts are always found facing south.

The deserter is whatever part walked away this time: a finger, a hand, once a foot that reached the Smoking Ground before a reed-cutter stepped on it. Each is bound in grey cord, smells of oil and old leather, and creeps toward the border, a room's width in a night. Turned round, it turns back.

The Guard return what they find. The Captain thanks them, and puts it in a drawer. He does not have it sewn back. One of his sergeants believes the Captain is sending himself away, piece by piece, so that one day the last of him can step over the stakes and lie down beside the others at the Finishing Post. Another sergeant has been selling the pieces.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Routine (10) for the Fen Guard.

**SPOILAGE** In Sallowreach, it never spoils, but it walks; it must be kept in a closed box, or it leaves. Taken across the border, it finishes at once, completely, as all the Kept do, and lies still. It is always found facing home.

**CARVING** Found, or bought from the sergeant (Tongue + Haggle vs Hard 14). Taking a piece from the Captain directly is unthinkable to the Guard and very dangerous to anyone else; he is Kept, he is still a soldier, and he notices.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A deserter is a perfect compass to the nearest border of Sallowreach, unaffected by fog, the Breath or a lost road. A traveler carrying it gains +2 to Wayfaring in the fen, and the Hard check for leaving the road becomes Routine when heading out. Carried in battle, it lends the Captain's habit: once per scene the bearer may ignore one failed Dread check from violence, as a soldier sixty times killed ignores it. Each time this is used, roll a d6; on a 1, the deserter has slipped its box and is gone.

**WORTH** 80 L for a finger, 300 L for a hand. Scarce. Selling a piece of a serving officer is treason in the Fen Guard's code, which is enforced by the Fen Guard.

## ◇ PEAT-LEATHER OF THE LAST WITNESS

Grandfather Peat was hauled out of the Sump in 611. He had drowned the week of the Gorging, and for six hundred years he had lain under the black water, tanning. He is leather-brown, flattened, shining wet, with a fringe of red hair and a rope still knotted at his throat, and he speaks a dead dialect that only a few Cutwrights can follow, and he repeats one thing: the god was smiling.

His skin flakes. Drying in the Cutwrights' warm rooms, it comes away in brown scales the size of a fingernail, tough as boot-sole, smelling of peat and tannin. The College keeps the flakes in a numbered box. Some have left the box.

A flake chewed slowly softens and tastes of iron and bog, and the taste becomes a memory that is not the chewer's: black water closing overhead, the weight on the chest, cold, and before that, a firelit shore and a long table, and a vast grey shape laid out on the mud with its hands folded on its chest, waiting. And its face. The chewer always wakes from it with their own face aching, from smiling.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). A Cutwright knows of it at Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** Indefinite, kept dry. Damp, it softens into a brown paste and the memory goes out of it in a week. It survives the border perfectly well; it was tanned long before the Kept were Kept.

**CARVING** Stolen from the College's box (Lung + Filch vs Hard 14), or flaked from Grandfather Peat himself with a scraper, which



he permits if asked courteously in his own dialect (Tongue + Lore vs Grim 18). Peeling him without asking is a Dread 2 check; he weeps, and the tears are brown.

**TAINT 1** Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** A chewer sees the Night of Seven Tables from the shore of the Ferrying, for the length of a dream. They may ask the GM one question about the Meal, the Providers, or the carving of the eighth place on the Ferrying Post, and receive a true answer, seen through a drowning man's eyes. They also learn to speak a few dozen words of the dead fen dialect (+2 to Lore on the oldest carvings of the north). Each flake gives one dream. On a failed Dread check from the vision, the chewer also takes the Derangement *The Voice at Table* for a week.

**WORTH** 150 L a flake to a Cutwright; 400 L to the Second Table, which is buying. Rare. Theft from the College is a College matter, and the College has long memories and longer ledgers.

## ◇ A TALLOW-SAINT'S WICK

Wick Tallow renders the unclaimed dead into candles that feel themselves burn, and half of Lastgate reads by people it used to know. When too many candles made from one family are burned in one room, the tallow sometimes remembers itself, runs, and gathers into a Tallow-Saint: a faceless figure of soft yellow wax, wicked through its crown and burning, that walks. The only way to stop one is to pinch out its wick, in its embrace, while it burns you.

A wick so pinched does not go out. The flame shrinks to a bead of blue no bigger than a lentil, and stays, on a hand-long braid of tallow-black thread, giving no heat and a very steady light. Hold it near a face and the light shows the face as the family that made the Saint would have seen it, beloved and familiar, for a moment, whatever face it is.

A chandler's widow on Wick Lane keeps one under a glass bell, and says it is her husband and his mother and his mother's sister, and on Tablenight she sets three places beside it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** The bead of flame lasts until the wick is touched to water, or carried over the border, where it finally goes out with a sound like a long breath let go. Kept under glass in Sallowreach, it lasts forever.

**CARVING** Only from a Tallow-Saint, in its grapple, by pinching (Hand + Filch vs Grim 18, while taking 2 fire damage a round). On a Lack, the wick comes away and the burning wax closes over the pincher's hand; the hand is scarred to a waxen stump unless a Seamer rebuilds it. Taking the wick from a Saint and watching it slump into a puddle that shapes, as it cools, the outlines of faces is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** Dread 2, each night it is lit.

**EFFECT** The wick gives light for ten paces that cannot be put out by wind, water or a Hush, and that no Kept will lie in: any Kept person in its light who speaks an untruth must make a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) or confess it. Held near any person, it shows them for a breath as loved; the bearer gains +2 to Persuade with anyone who sees their own face in its light, once per scene. Carried into a Hush, it is the only light that burns there.

**WORTH** 600 L. Rare. Wick Tallow will buy one back at double, and wants very much to know who has been making Saints out of his stock.

## ◇ THE MOTHER OF MOTHER GALL'S BRINE

Mother Gall can keep a body sound for a century in the right brine, and her cellar under Brinemoss holds four hundred customers in barrels, paid up in advance, all wide awake. The recipe she will not share. Her brine is sold, at twenty lacks a pot, and it works for a year. But the real thing, the thing that keeps four hundred people perfect, is not a recipe. It is a culture. It is a mother.

Every vinegar has a mother, a slick of living matter that turns wine to sour. Mother Gall's has come down, she says, from her own mother, in a crock not empty since 402. It is a grey-white, rubbery disc the size of a dinner plate, layered like the leaves of a book, smelling of dill and brine and, faintly, of the lavender water her mother wore. It turns, slowly, toward whoever opens the lid.

Brinemoss says the old woman's mother is not in the crock so much as of it. Mother Gall laughs when asked. She cuts a slip for one customer in a generation; the only slip ever sold came from a barrel whose occupant passed it to a thief through a knot-hole.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) in Brinemoss.

**SPOILAGE** Kept in its own brine and fed a cup of sour beer each week, a slip lives indefinitely, and it travels: the mother is the one Sallowreach leaving that seems not to care where it is.

**CARVING** A slip is cut from the crock with a wooden knife; Mother Gall will do it for the right person (Tongue + Persuade vs Dire 22, or a favor she names). Stealing one means getting into her cellar, among the barrels, which knock as you pass (Lung + Stealth vs Grim 18). A Lack means a lid lifts, and the occupant asks you, very politely, to let them out. Dread 2.

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Ossel).

**EFFECT** A slip of the mother, set in a barrel of salted vinegar, makes a brine that keeps anything submerged in it exactly as it went in, with no rot, no age, no healing, for as long as it stays under. A living person kept under breathes through it, unaging and wide awake (Dread 3 to be immersed, Dread 2 to witness). A severed part kept in it can be sewn back on a century later with no penalty. A Kept body in it gains no Rot. In a year the slip can be cut again.

**WORTH** Never sold by Mother Gall. The stolen slip changed hands for 5,000 L. Unique, or nearly. Not illegal; the Seamers' Guild

would very much like it to be.

## ▼ FROM THE HUSHES AND THE FEN



The fen keeps everything that ever went into it, and the Hushes keep nothing at all, and between the two lies the north's strangest trade. Reed-cutters, Sump-dredgers, Finisher pilgrims and Cutwright surveyors all bring things back from the edges: from the black water where the drowned move a little, from the grey line where birds fall, from the warm ground where the Glad Century's fires still burn. The Court claims every Hush as its own and every leaving from one as a stolen license. The Bottled Hush (see the Rim Market) is the famous one. These are the others.

### ◇ A HUSH-REED PIPE

At the edge of every Hush the reeds go from green-brown to ash-grey in the space of a step. They do not rot or bend. Cut one and it stays exactly as it was cut, with no sap, no smell, and a hollow core as clean as a bone. Reed-cutters of Dunmere's neighbor villages, who lost their trade to the grey, have found a new one: they bore the reeds into pipes, six holes, and sell them to the Heirs, the Finishers and anyone who needs a crowd to stop.

A Hush-reed pipe makes no sound. Its player feels the breath go in and feels the fingers move, and the people around them hear nothing at all, and that is the music. Those near the player feel it: a drop in the room, as though a door had shut somewhere, and then voices falter, a song in the next street loses its tune, a quarrel forgets itself. Dunstan Reave, the last of Dunmere, carves them, sitting at the edge with his spyglass, and gives them away to anyone who asks him nothing about his family.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A year. Then the reed takes on color again, slowly, from the mouthpiece down, and when it is green it plays an ordinary note, which in Sallowreach is the saddest sound a reed-cutter knows.

**CARVING** Cut at the very edge of a Hush with a long-handled sickle, one foot outside the grey (Lung + Athletics vs Hard 14 to reach in and back cleanly). On a Lack, the cutter's hand crosses the line: Caul + Resolve vs Dire (22) or the hand finishes, numb, grey and dead forever. Standing at the edge is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Ossel).

**EFFECT** Played for a round (Hand + Craft vs Routine 10), the pipe ends every song, argument, speech or spoken Rite within

twenty paces; those affected cannot resume it for a scene without a Tongue + Resolve roll vs Hard (14). It silences a Sayer's word in Oathen for one breath, no more. Every Kept who hears the silence must make a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) or stop what they are doing and listen for the next note.

**WORTH** 50 L in the Sinks. Scarce. Unlicensed Hush-goods; the Court seldom bothers.

### ◇ A GLOVEHALL PEAR

Last Carving a small Hush, the size of a kitchen garden, appeared in the orchard behind Glovehall, the house where Osric Vane is kept. The gardeners will not go near it. The pears in it are perfect. They hang on grey branches in the grey grass, golden, unblemished, heavy, and they do not fall, because falling is a kind of ending and nothing in a Hush is waiting to end. There are forty-one of them. Someone at Glovehall counts them every morning, and some mornings there are fewer.

To pick one, you must reach into the silence. The pear comes away without a sound. It is cool and dense and smells of nothing. Its flesh, when cut, does not brown. Its taste, by every account, is the end of a long day: not sweet so much as finished. Those who have eaten one describe a feeling they have no word for in Sallowreach, and those from other lands recognize it at once and weep. It is the feeling of something being over.

Hand-line servants whisper that the pears are Osric. The Hush grew where his window looks.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); Grim (18) for Glovehall staff and Absalom Hethe's circle.

**SPOILAGE** It never spoils, never browns, never softens. Once bitten, it must be eaten whole within the hour or the bitten flesh goes grey and tasteless and is only grey.

**CARVING** A long pole and a net from outside the line (Hand + Craft vs Grim 18), at night, past the Vanes' guards and dogs (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14). A Lack on the reach drops the picker's arm across the line: as for the Hush-reed, at Dire. Picking under Osric's window, where he can see you, is a Dread 3 check. He waves.

**TAINT** 4 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Eating a pear ends one thing in the eater, permanently, chosen when they eat: one Derangement, one Want (for the rest of



their life), one addiction, one Oath on the Dead (kept, as if fulfilled, with all its rewards), or all their current Fray. A Kept who eats one finishes, gently and completely. A living Sallowreacher who eats a second in one year begins their own Hush: the GM marks a silence the size of a doorstep where they next sleep.

**WORTH** 2,000 L. Rare. Stealing Vane fruit is a capital matter. The Finishers count them as holy relics and will not sell. Lady Corrow has been seen to stand at the Hush's edge with a pear in her gloved hand, not eating it.

## ◇ A SUMP-FACE

Six centuries of weighted sacks have gone down into the Sump, and over decades, under forty feet of black peat-water, the bodies find each other and press together into a Sump-thing: a slick dark mound twenty feet across, hair and sackcloth and tanned leather over a lattice of knitted bone, and everywhere in it, faces. Pressed flat. Mouths working. The Seamers' Guild pays a standing bounty of six hundred lacks for every face recovered, and gives it back to the family.

Not every face goes home. Cut free, a face is a mask of soft, peat-tanned skin, faintly warm, still moving: the lips work, the brow knots in the old grief a weighted sack gives everyone. Dredgers who keep them say a face worn over one's own fits as if it were made to, and that while it is worn, the fen recognizes you. The drowned in the black water let go of your ankle. The Sump-things let you pass. The water lets you breathe.

The face goes on speaking, for the wearer alone: a name, a street, a debt, and the words *I can still feel the rope*.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among dredgers and Sackmen; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** In Sallowreach, never. Kept damp in fen-water, it travels a week outside the border before it finishes and becomes a scrap of leather with a face on it.

**CARVING** From a Sump-thing, in the water, while it tries to Add you: Hand + Blades vs Grim (18) with a flensing knife, taking a round of its Many Hands for each attempt. A Lack means the carver's own face is pressed against the mound for a breath, and comes away with the impression of another face on it, which takes a month to fade. Taking a face is a Dread 3 check; recognizing it is a Dread 4.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 2 (each day worn).

**EFFECT** While worn, the bearer can breathe underwater in the fen, cannot be grappled by the drowned or by a Sump-thing (they treat the wearer as one of their own), and gains +2 to Stealth in water. Each day worn, roll a d6: on a 1, the face's grief bleeds through and the bearer gains The Kept Grief Derangement for a day, mourning someone they never knew. Returned to its family, a face gives its finder a Portion and their gratitude, which in the Sinks is worth more.

**WORTH** 600 L from the Seamers (who then return it); up to 1,500 L to smugglers. Rare. Wearing a face rather than returning it is desecration under Guild law, and the families take it personally.

## ◇ A SOD OF WALKER-HUSH

A Hush-walker is the silence that got up: someone who went into a Hush and did not finish, and came out carrying the stillness with them. Reduced to nothing, a Hush-walker lies down and is finished at last, and the ground under it becomes a Hush a yard across. It is the only Hush small enough to dig.

A sod of walker-Hush is a square of turf a spade deep, grey grass in grey soil, lifted whole and boxed in cedar. It weighs a little too much. Inside the box the grass does not stir however the box is shaken, and a fly that lands on it falls over and stays. Set on the ground, it is a hole in the world the shape of a doormat: step onto it and the sound of your feet stops, your heartbeat stops in your own ears, and you become aware, very suddenly, of how loud the inside of your body has always been.

The Finishers covet them, and Sister Lorn keeps one in her house in the Sinks, under a cloth, in front of her own door. She says she uses it to pray on. Her flock have begun to ask why she does not use it for anything else.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** The sod keeps its silence for a year and a day after lifting, unless watered, which shrinks it by a hand's width each time. Outside Sallowreach it holds a single season and finishes nothing that is not Kept, which there are none of.

**CARVING** Dug from the yard-wide Hush where a Hush-walker lay, with a spade and a cedar box, from outside its edge (Gut + Labor vs Hard 14; the digger must Partake or stand on the grey to finish the cut, which is a Caul + Resolve roll vs Grim 18 each round or take 2 Fray as the silence presses into the ears). The digging is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** Dread 3.

**EFFECT** A sod laid on the ground is a silence a yard across. A Kept person who lies on it for a full minute finishes, completely, as if Closed: no license, no Hand-line, no fee. A living person who stands on it cannot be heard and cannot hear, and may not Partake. A living Sallowreacher who sleeps on it dreams nothing at all, and wakes having lost 1d6 Hunger and gained 1 Regrowth Taint roll at Grim (18). Each Kept finished on it shrinks the sod by a quarter.

**WORTH** 1,800 L. Rare. A stolen license four times over in the Court's reckoning; the Finishers would give a pilgrim's whole savings, and have.

## ◇ A COAL FROM THE SMOKING GROUND

In the Glad Century, when the fen-folk were dancing because nobody died, peat fires were lit in the marshes east of Lastgate for the celebrations, and they are still burning. Fire in Sallowreach burns down but does not go out. The ground there is warm and spongy and steams from long cracks, and things lost in the fires walk there, black and cracking.

A coal dug from the Smoking Ground is a lump of peat the size of a fist, black-crusted, with a slow red heart that pulses like a sleeper's breath. It has been burning for five hundred years. It does not consume itself and does not grow, and it cannot be put out: water steams off it, sand smothers it to a dull glow that brightens again the moment the sand is shaken off. It smells of sour smoke and, faintly, of the roasting meat of the Glad Century's feasts.

The Heirs, who meet on the Smoking Ground because no Court agent will go there in good boots, carry coals in iron boxes as badges. They say a coal from the Ground is the only thing in the north that the Unvacated did not get first.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in Lastgate; Hard (14) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** In Sallowreach, never. Carried over the border, it burns normally, which is to say it burns out in a night, as fast as five hundred years can catch up with it, with a roar and a stink and a great deal of heat.

**CARVING** Dug from a crack with iron tongs and a box (Gut + Labor vs Hard 14 while taking 1 fire damage a round). The Smoking Ground's burned walkers resent the digging; a Lack draws one, cracking and smoldering (as an Unstitched Kept, but dealing fire). Seeing one is Dread 2.

**TAINT** none in Sallowreach. Burned over the border, Dread 1 to watch it go.

**EFFECT** A coal lights any fire, in any weather, and that fire cannot be put out by any ordinary means within Sallowreach; only a Hand-line's Closing or a Hush ends it. A coal in an iron box warms a room and keeps off cold-weather penalties for a party. Carried across the border and thrown, it bursts into a blaze that fills a room with fire for one scene (4 fire damage a round to all within it). The Heirs call this "sending grandfather south."

**WORTH** 15 L in the Sinks; 120 L abroad. Uncommon. Legal, though a Court agent who finds one on an Heir will find a reason.

## ▼ PREPARATIONS OF THE NORTH



Not every leaving is carved. Some are made: brewed in physicians' back rooms from the one ailment the north still suffers, written down by the last family to remember a rite, struck from the coins pilgrims leave behind. These are preparations, and they are the leavings most often sold to foreigners, because some of them survive the border, and all of them are easier to explain to a customs clerk.

### ◇ QUEASE'S NUMBER FOUR HUNDRED AND ONE

Dr. Halloran Quease, the physician of a land where no illness is fatal, has catalogued four hundred kinds of pain, from *the long bell* (a seam pulling through) to *the attic* (being shelved and forgotten). His Number 212, which removes one kind of pain for a day, is sold in every apothecary in Lastgate. His Number 401 is not sold anywhere, and he denies it exists.

It is a tincture distilled from the nerve-ends of the Kept who have stopped feeling: the very rare Set-Aside, far up the shelves in the Lofts, who have been in pain so long that the pain has worn through, like a step worn through by feet, and gone quiet. Quease

buys their nerves from Marrow Jack, by the ounce, and does not ask how he gets them. The tincture is clear, oily, and smells of carbolic and lemon, like the doctor. A drop on the tongue tastes of nothing and, a moment later, of nothing at all, everywhere.

The four hundred and first pain, in Quease's private notebook, is the pain of not being able to feel anything. He catalogued it by taking the tincture himself. He has not written in that notebook since.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); a physician or Seamer knows of it at Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A year in a stoppered brown bottle, kept cool. It survives the border.

**CARVING** Brewed only by Quease (Eye + Craft vs Dire 22 for anyone who steals his method). The ingredient must be taken from the deepest Set-Aside in the Lofts (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14 past the Wardens, then Hand + Stitching vs Grim 18 to take the nerve). Unwrapping a shelved body that cannot feel the knife is a Dread 3 check, because it does not scream.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 1. Addiction: Grim (18).

**EFFECT** For a scene, the drinker feels no pain at all. They ignore Injury penalties, cannot be forced to act by pain or torture, and are immune to effects that cause pain (including a Waker's needle). They also cannot feel whether they are hurt: the player does not learn their Flesh total until the scene ends, and the GM tracks it. They lose all Fray gained in the scene, and gain double that amount the following morning, when everything comes back.

**WORTH** 60 L a dose, if Quease can be persuaded. Rare. Not illegal, because no law imagines it.

## ◇ A LAST VERSE

Songs in Sallowreach have no last verse. Nothing does. Bram Hollin's family were professional mourners, a trade six centuries extinct, and by an unbroken line of fathers teaching sons for a job none of them could do, he alone knows the whole funeral rite: the keening, the washing, the coin on the tongue, the six last songs. And the six last songs have last verses. They are the only ones in the north.

Bram writes one out, very rarely, for a family that cannot afford him and has been granted a Closing at last: one verse on a slip of black-edged paper, in a small tidy hand, folded twice. The verse is short. It is not beautiful. It is plain, old-fashioned fen-speech about putting down the tools at dusk and going in. Sung over someone who is ending, it lets them end. Sung over anything else, it ends that.

A forged Last Verse is common, and does nothing. The real ones carry Bram's thumbprint in lamp-black on the fold, because his father's did, and his father's father's. Several Finishers have tried to buy one. Bram has refused. He says the verse is for the people left behind.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). Telling a real one from a forgery is Eye + Search vs Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** The paper keeps; the verse is spent once sung all the way through. A verse once sung cannot be sung again from the same slip. The words on it fade to grey before the singer has finished.

**CARVING** Not carved. Given by Bram Hollin, for a reason he accepts (Tongue + Persuade vs Dire 22 if the reason is anything but grief), or stolen from those he gave it to, which the north counts among the lowest acts a person can commit.

**TAINT** Dread 2, to the singer, who feels it end.

**EFFECT** Sung (Tongue + Rites vs Hard 14) at a Closing or at any death, the verse lets the dying go cleanly: a Kept person finishes without pain, and every mourner present removes 3 Fray and gains a Portion. Sung over anything that is not dying, it ends it: a fire, a song, a quarrel, a curse, an ongoing Seeming, the voice of a Tenant for a scene, or one Gift of a Brink-stage creature for a scene. Sung over a Hush, it does nothing, and the singer hears, for one moment, every sound that ever ended there.

**WORTH** Never sold by Bram. 800 L when stolen. Rare. Owning a stolen verse is not a crime in law; it is a crime in every kitchen in Lastgate.

## ◇ SHUT-EYE PENNIES

The Finishers walk into the Hushes singing. Before they go, Sister Lorn of the Shut Eye lays a pair of black wax pennies on each pilgrim's eyes, stamped with a closed eye like the Court's breath-tokens, and prays, and lifts them off again, and the pilgrim walks into the grey with their eyes open. She has done this nine hundred times. She keeps every pair. They are in a long cedar box in her rooms, nine hundred pairs, labeled, and she cannot bring herself to melt them down.

A pair of Shut-Eye pennies is as warm as an eyelid and soft enough to take a thumbprint, and each still holds the shape of the eye it lay on, down to a lash-mark. Laid on a sleeper's eyes, they bring a sleep with no dreams in it, deep and black and complete. Laid on the eyes of the Kept, they bring something the Kept have not had since they died: a few hours of nothing at all.

The pilgrims who wore them did not come back. The pennies remember the last thing those eyes saw, and on still nights their sleepers see it too: a line of grey reeds, a door standing open, and Sister Lorn outside, waving.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Routine (10) among the Finishers.

**SPOILAGE** A pair works for a year of nights, then softens into ordinary wax. Outside Sallowreach the warmth lasts a season.

**CARVING** Stolen from Lorn's cedar box (Lung + Filch vs Hard 14), or begged from her (Tongue + Persuade vs Grim 18; she will give a pair only to someone she believes will never use the Hushes). A Lack while stealing them means the thief reads the label on the box: a name they know. Dread 3.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A sleeper under the pennies rests completely: a night's sleep under them removes 2 Fray instead of 1, and no Visitation, dream or Derangement can reach them that night. A Kept person under them is free of pain and Rot gain for the night. Used in the Vigil, they do nothing to stop the room; the sleeper goes to the long room and does not dream there either, and does not come back. On a Lack on any Regrowth Taint roll they cause, the user wakes with the Pull (see Despair) toward the nearest Hush for a day, and companions should hold on to them.

**WORTH** 90 L a pair. Scarce. The Finishers will not sell them; the Smalls of the Drowned Storeys trade them among themselves as their most precious coin, and nobody has asked them where they get theirs.



CHAPTER 10

# LEAVINGS OF THE FATLANDS

*Everything here is meat. So everything here is for sale by the pound.*

— RENDERERS' UNION SAYING, PAINTED ON THE CHUTE'S LONG RAMP

## THE RELIC TRADE IN THE SOUTH IS ONLY BUTCHERY WITH BETTER MANNERS. WE DO NOT CARVE THE GOD. WE SERVE IT.

[ MISTRESS BRISKET ANNALOW, TO A COMPANY AUDITOR AT THE CHUTE ]

In the Fatlands nobody calls them relics. A relic is something a foreigner pays too much for. In the south a piece of the god is simply produce: it is grown, cut, weighed, stamped, salted and shipped, and the only questions anyone asks are what it weighs and what it is good for. The Board of Plenty requires every piece of godflesh to be declared and stamped, the only land on the Table that does, and the stamping-houses at the Chute keep a column in their ledgers headed *Remarkable*, for cuts that do more than feed. The column is long. The Renderers' Union handles it, at a premium, and asks the Board not to read it.

This makes the south's leavings the most available and the least trusted on the Table. Almost anything can be had in Sated for meat scrip, but almost everything is mislabeled. A barrel marked *pork*, *Low Tiltb* may be pork. It may be what the field Reaped. A jar marked *orchard sap* may scream when opened. Fatlanders shrug at this. To them everything that grows is the god, and the god is good to eat, and if a cut of it does something wonderful besides, so much the better: that is what a breadbasket is for.

Carving in the south is agricultural. Leavings are reaped with sickles from fields that flinch, dug with spades from soil that bleeds,

pruned from trees that scream, plucked from the elbows of the Laden by the Washers who tend them, and sliced, with real tenderness, from the volunteered bodies of the Second Helping. The worst of the work is not the blood. Fatlanders are not squeamish about blood. It is the recognizing: the root with a birthmark, the cut that tastes of a name, the hill that calls the harvester by a pet name only their mother used.

What the south fears is not the leavings' power but the hunger in them. Every Fatlands relic is food, in the end, and every one of them wants to be eaten, and every one of them makes the eater hungrier. Southern children are taught to wash their hands after touching a Remarkable cut and never to lick their fingers. Southern adults lick their fingers anyway. The Thin say that the Fatlands' whole export economy is a way of spreading Ummer's appetite to every table on the Rim, one barrel at a time, and the Board's answer has always been that the barrels sell.

Southern leavings travel well, in salt and fat and jelly. That is the danger. They keep their hunger wherever they go.

## ▼ FROM THE GUT-LINES AND THE LADEN



The Gut-lines took Ummer's stomach and entrails, and in their bodies the god grows like a crop. A Gut-line noble at the Course sheds shoots, sweats a sticky sweetness that draws bees, grows roots through the floor of their dray; at the Brink, they are a field; Seated, a hill. Everything that comes away from them is fertile, and the Board, which is made of them, has a hundred quiet laws about who

may take it. Washers who tend the Laden are sworn to burn what they pluck. Washers are also paid very badly.

## ◇ A TIP OF THE CHAIRMAN'S ROOT

Chairman Obb Tullow weighs nineteen hundred pounds and is moved by dray and eight oxen, or was, until last spring, when his feet rooted through a seam in the dray's iron floor. The Board has agreed not to notice. The dray has not moved since, and the Board now meets around it. What the Board does not know is that the roots go all the way down into the Weighhouse cellars, and that the Chairman can feel the Reaping through them, every one, as a warm full mouthful.

The roots are trimmed, where they can be reached, by a hoof-trimmer of the Board's stables who has sworn an oath on his mother's wake. He trims at night. The tips are white, glossy, finger-thick and warm, ringed like an earthworm, and they bleed a clear sweet sap that tastes of gravy and pennies. Held in the mouth, a tip pulses slowly, at the pace of the Chairman's heart. Those who have held one in a negotiation report that they felt very heavy and very calm, and that everyone in the room seemed, suddenly, to be leaning toward them.

The hoof-trimmer sells to the Renderers' Union. Mistress Annalow holds a tip in her cheek when she meets the Board.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); a Board clerk or Union officer, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A month wrapped in damp sacking. Dry, it shrivels to a white thread in a week. It travels, and keeps its weight.

**CARVING** At night, in the Weighhouse cellars among the roots, with pruning shears (Hand + Craft vs Hard 14; Lung + Stealth vs Grim 18 to get in past the Bailiffs). The roots flinch when cut. A Lack means the Chairman, above, feels it: the floor heaves, and the carver is held to the ankles by roots (Gut + Endure vs Grim 18 to tear free, 1d6 Flesh).

**TAINT** 3 Hunger.

**EFFECT** Held in the cheek for a scene, a tip lends the Chairman's weight: the bearer cannot be moved, pushed, knocked down or Reaped, gains +2 to Intimidate and Persuade with anyone of the Fatlands, and, in any vote or assembly, is treated by everyone present as the heaviest person in the room. A tip lasts three scenes before it is chewed through. Swallowing it gives the Hunger at once, and the eater roots, for an hour, wherever they stand.

**WORTH** 350 L. Rare. Taking any part of a sitting Board member without license is a crime against the vote, punished by the Gavage.

## ◇ A STRIP OF THE UNENDING CLOTH

Dame Suet Marrable's Unending Dinner has been in continuous service at Marrable Hall for eighty-one years. Guests have been born at her table, and several have been served at it. The table is three

hundred feet long, and the cloth on it has never been changed, only added to: new linen laid over old as the old goes under, so that the cloth is now a thick, soft, many-layered thing, like a mattress of pressed pastry, soaked through with eighty-one years of drippings, wine, sauce and what the servers do not discuss.

The cloth is cut, rarely, when the table is extended. The strips are sold to Gut-line houses as heirlooms. A strip of Unending Cloth is a slab of yellowed linen an inch thick, heavy, greasy, smelling of roast and cloves and something older and sweeter, and it is never cold. Spread on any table, it changes the table. Food set on it does not cool. Guests seated at it do not want to leave. A dinner laid on Unending Cloth goes on.

Dame Marrable does not sell it herself. She gives strips to those she wishes to keep: debtors, rivals, daughters-in-law. Lord Chastain Loin has a strip in his dining room, and his guests stay for days.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among the Gut-lines; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** Indefinite, kept greased. It travels, and its hunger does not fade. Washing it ruins it, and the water stinks of gravy for a mile.

**CARVING** Cut from the table during the Dinner, which never stops (Lung + Filch vs Grim 18 with a carving knife, while seated as a guest, and a guest at Marrable Hall must eat five courses an hour or be noticed). On a Lack, the carver cannot rise from the table until the next extension, a month hence, and is fed throughout.

**TAINT** 2 Hunger (to each guest at a meal laid on it).

**EFFECT** At a meal laid on the cloth, each guest must make a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) to leave before the host rises; failure means they stay and eat, for another hour, and roll again. Hosts gain +2 to Persuade over guests who have eaten on it. A Fatlander who eats a full meal on it gains the Sop's benefit as if the meal were the flesh of the dead. Abroad, it makes any dinner a siege.

**WORTH** 500 L. Rare. Legal; the most coveted wedding gift in Sated. Some families refuse it, politely, and then move house.

## ◇ ELBOW-CRESS

At the Course the Laden sprout. Small green shoots come up in the creases of the elbows and behind the knees, pale and tender, and the Washers pluck them every morning, and every night they grow back. They are supposed to be burned. In the Sated market they are sold by the bunch, under the counter, as *elbow-cress*, and they are delicious: peppery, juicy, faintly sweet, with a taste under the pepper like a lover's skin.

Elbow-cress heals. Eaten raw, a handful closes cuts and knits bruises overnight, and Sated's prize-fighters and Renderers' bruisers eat it like candy. It also feeds. The eater wakes, after a night of eating it, with their own elbows itching, and a craving for more that is very hard to explain to anyone who has not felt the Fatlands hunger. A Washer named Pelly Dripping was jailed for selling her lady's cress,



and testified that the lady knew and was glad: it meant somebody else was eating the god for a change, and not her.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in Sated; Hard (14) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** Three days fresh; a week in cold water. Dried, it is only a weak tea that heals nothing.

**CARVING** Plucked at dawn by a Washer, with fingers, from a sleeping Laden (Hand + Filch vs Routine 10 if a Washer; Hard 14 otherwise, because the Laden wake when it is pulled and say your name). Seeing the shoots come back as you watch is a Dread 1 check.

**TAINT** 1 Hunger, 1 Regrowth (Ummer).

**EFFECT** A bunch eaten (a full meal's worth) heals 1d6 Flesh by morning, or 2d6 if eaten before sleep, and removes the penalty of one festering wound. A Fatlander may count it as a Sop meal. Anyone who eats elbow-cross three nights running must make a Gut + Endure roll vs Hard (14) or begin to sprout themselves: tiny shoots at the elbows, harmless, which must be plucked daily and are worth 2 L a bunch.

**WORTH** 5 L a bunch. Uncommon in Sated; Scarce elsewhere. Illegal to sell as food (it must be declared and stamped, and never is). The fine is a meal's weight in lacks.

## ◇ A PEAR OF MOTHER RIND'S

Old Mother Rind rooted forty years ago, and now she is a small orchard hill outside Kettle Furrow, with nine pear trees growing from her back and a working mouth in the clover at her foot. Her lips are brown and cracked like bark and her teeth are wheat-teeth, many rows. Her village asks her advice on marriages. She is always right, and always hungry, and her fee is meat. Lately she has asked for particular people.

Her pears are small, brown-russeted and very sweet, with flesh the color of cream and a core like a tiny knuckle of bone. They are warm when picked. Eaten slowly, each one carries her voice: the eater hears, in the soft crunch of each bite, a dry old woman's laugh, and at the core, a sentence. It is an answer. It is always an answer to the question the eater most wanted to ask and did not.

Mother Rind gives them away, or so the village says. She gives them in return for meat. And she has begun, lately, to give them only to particular people, the same people she asks for, as though she were sweetening them first.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Routine (10) in Low Tilth.

**SPOILAGE** Two weeks off the tree; a season in honey, though the voice grows sly. Over the border, the voice fades within a month.

**CARVING** Picked from her back, which is climbing on a woman (Lung + Athletics vs Routine 10, and asking first, or she bites). Picked without paying her fee, the pear is sour and the answer is a lie. Her fee is a joint of meat brought to her mouth, and lately a

name; paying it is a Dread 2 check if the player knows whose name it is.

**TAINT** 2 Hunger, 1 Dread.

**EFFECT** Eating a pear gives a true answer, in Mother Rind's voice, to one question the eater is afraid to ask; the GM answers honestly, in a sentence, and may choose the question if the player will not. The answer is true. It is also, always, somehow about food. Each pear eaten by the same person makes the next more expensive: Mother Rind remembers them, and asks after them, and begins to ask for them.

**WORTH** 40 L a pear in Kettle Furrow; 150 L in Sated. Scarce. Legal. The village of Kettle Furrow has been noticeably smaller since she started asking for people.

## ◇ PAUNCH'S CHEWED WEIGHT

Dr. Emmerich Paunch, the Board's physician, opened a Gut-lines stomach under license to measure its capacity, and lowered a plumb line into it. He ran out of line at two hundred feet. When he drew the line up again, the lead weight on the end of it had been chewed. He has since obtained longer line. He has not been able to bring himself to use it.

The chewed weight is a cone of grey lead the size of a hen's egg, deeply scored with tooth marks: not one set but dozens, overlapping, some flat like grinders, some narrow like a child's, some long and curved like nothing that eats in daylight. It is wet. It is always wet, however long it is dried, and the wetness smells of gastric acid and warm bread. Laid on a table, it rolls toward the nearest person. Dropped down a well, it reaches the bottom, whatever the depth, and the line comes up chewed.

Paunch keeps it in a jar in his study, and someone, while he was at the Weighing, took it out and put a different weight in its place. He has not yet noticed. He hasn't wanted to look.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22). The Board's physicians, Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil. It does, slowly, get lighter, as if something were still eating it. In a decade it will be gone.

**CARVING** Stolen from Paunch, or from whoever stole it (Lung + Filch vs Hard 14). A new one can be made only by doing what Paunch did: a plumb line lowered into a Gut-lines stomach, under license or otherwise (Hand + Stitching vs Grim 18 to open; the patient is awake), and what is at the bottom must be willing to chew. Opening a Gut-line and hearing an echo is a Dread 4 check.

**TAINT** 1 Hunger, Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Lowered on a line into any hole, well, pit or mouth, the weight reaches the bottom and tells the holder what is down there, by the marks it comes up with: depth, whether anything living waits, and whether it is hungry. Lowered on a thread into a sleeper's open mouth, it reports their exact Hunger and Regrowth to the

holder. Lowered into the Trencher, or a Seated hill, it comes up with a single human tooth in the lead, and the GM decides whose.

**WORTH** Never sold. Paunch would pay 2,000 L to have it back, and more to have it never mentioned. Unique.

## ▼ FROM THE FIELDS AND THE REAPING



The soil of the south is the god's flesh, and it grows flesh. Wheat comes up with teeth, roots come up with veins, and in Carving the fields take people and give back what they were. The leavings of the fields are the commonest in the south and the cheapest, because there is so much field. They are also the ones Fatlanders least like to talk about, because the fields are their families, quite literally, and the Reaping has doubled in ten years.

### ◆ CORNER-SOIL OF THE DUSK ACRES

The Cullmasters send vagrants, debtors and troublemakers to work the far fields at dusk. Those fields are called the Dusk Acres, a belt of Board land rotated every Carving, and each plot carries a small numbered stone at its corner. They are the most productive fields in the country and the most carefully ploughed. Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread thinks of the whole business as agriculture.

The soil from a Dusk Acre corner, dug from under the numbered stone, is black, sweet-smelling and warm, with a greasy shine, and it moves. Very slightly, in the palm, it settles, and settles again, as if something under it were breathing. It sticks to the skin. Fatlanders do not keep it in houses. The Thin steal it to prove what the Board is doing: a pot of corner-soil, left on a windowsill in Sated, opens at dusk into a small wet mouth, and closes, and the windowsill is a little lower.

Mixed into a floor, a road or a doorstep, corner-soil teaches that ground to Reap. The Renderers' thugs call it a *dusk shift*, and use it in disputes.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Cullmasters and Thin know it at Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A season in a sealed iron pot. In wood or cloth it soaks through in a week. Abroad, it keeps its hunger, but the hunger is weaker: it Reaps only in Carving.

**CARVING** Dug under a numbered stone at dusk, in a Dusk Acre in Carving, while the Reaping is under way (run the Reaping clock for each round spent digging; Gut + Labor vs Hard 14 to fill a pot). Digging up something besides soil is a Dread 3 check. It usually happens.

**TAINT** 2 Hunger, Dread 2.

**EFFECT** A pot of corner-soil, spread across a doorway or six paces of floor, makes that ground Reap at dusk for a week: anyone helpless, sleeping or bound on it at sundown must make Lung + Wayfaring rolls as for the Reaping (Routine, then Hard, then Grim, then gone). Anyone awake and moving gains a Dread 2 check from the feel of the floor. Spread in a field, it doubles that field's yield and its Reaping.

**WORTH** 70 L a pot. Scarce. Possession outside the Cullmasters' office is "theft of Board soil." The Board has hanged no one for it, because a trial would require naming the soil.

### ◆ BOTTLED ROOTKIN SAP

What the Reaping takes, the field gives back as Rootkin: swollen root vegetables the size of a sleeping child, pale and veined and warm, with features. Most are lumpen. Some are exact. Pulled up, they flinch and leak a pinkish sap that smells of the person they resemble. Tansy Lard found one with her mother's birthmark and replanted it behind the house, and waters it every day. Others are less sentimental.

The Renderers' Union sells the sap in phials to Lastgate perfumers and grieving families. It is pink, thin and faintly warm, and it smells of one specific person: their skin, their hair, their soap. A drop on a pillow brings them back into the room for a night. A drop on the tongue brings back more: a memory, out of order, out of context, as vivid as a blow. The Union labels phials by village and does not label them by name, because the families would find them.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in the Fatlands; Hard (14) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A year stoppered. Opened, the smell fades in a week.

**CARVING** Pulled from a Rootkin bed (Gut + Labor vs Hard 14, against grasping shoots), then cut and drained (Hand + Stitching vs Routine 10). Recognizing the face is a Dread 3 check. A Lack while cutting means the Rootkin's eyes open.

**TAINT** 1 Hunger, 1 Dread.

**EFFECT** A drop on the tongue gives one of the Reaped person's memories (roll below). A whole phial drunk at once gives all six, and the drinker must make a Dread 3 check and gains The Kept Grief Derangement for a week, mourning themselves. Used as bait at dusk



in a Reaping field, a phial poured on the soil guarantees the field takes the nearest person who smells of it.

| D6 | THE MEMORY                                                                             |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | A meal with family; the drinker can taste every dish, and is hungry for a day after.   |
| 2  | A secret the Reaped kept: the GM gives one true fact about someone they knew.          |
| 3  | Their last walk out to the field at dusk; the drinker knows the Dusk Acre's number.    |
| 4  | Their wedding, or their child's birth; the drinker removes 1 Fray and weeps.           |
| 5  | The moment the soil took them, from below. Dread 3.                                    |
| 6  | Something they saw in the far field before the end: a scarecrow, closer, turned round. |

**WORTH** 8 L a phial. Uncommon. Legal if stamped. Families who find their own dead in a phial on a Lastgate perfumer's shelf have been known to burn the shop.

## ◇ A SINGING CUTTING

Marigold Chine keeps the oldest grove in the Bleeding Orchards and refused the deafening. She sings to her trees through the pruning, while ten thousand others scream, and her trees have begun to sing back, in tune, in her voice. The other keepers, who cannot hear it, feel it in their teeth. She wants to learn what the trees are trying to say. She fears she already knows: the last verse is the wake-song, and it is about her.

A cutting from her grove is a whip of red-barked wood as long as a forearm, with three buds, wrapped in wet moss. It is warm. It bleeds, faintly, where it was cut. And it sings: very softly, in a woman's alto, one line of an orchard hymn, over and over, without breath. Planted, it roots in a night, and the young tree sings louder. Animals love it. Two-legged cattle stop and listen with their heads tilted. People sleep beside it like children.

Marigold sells cuttings only to people who promise to sing back.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); orchard-keepers know at Routine (10), by their teeth.

**SPOILAGE** A month in wet moss; planted, it lives as long as an orchard tree. It travels, and sings in every land, though in the Fast it sings nothing at all and drops its leaves.

**CARVING** Cut from Marigold's grove at pruning time in Grace, while the Bleeding Orchards scream (Hand + Craft vs Hard 14; Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 to stand the noise without stuffing your ears). Cutting without her leave makes the grove fall silent, which every keeper feels at once. A Lack means the cutting sings the wake-song's last verse, with the carver's name in it. Dread 3.

**TAINT** 1 Hunger. A Fatlander gains 1 Hunger each day the cutting is in earshot.

**EFFECT** The song calms: animals within earshot will not attack unless hurt, two-legged cattle follow the cutting's bearer as a herd follows a drover, and listeners gain +2 to Dread checks (fear, not

horror) while it sings. Planted, it grows a tree in a year whose fruit, eaten, quiets a Fatlander's Hunger by 1d3 without the Sop's compulsion. And the tree learns: in a year it sings in the voice of whoever planted it.

**WORTH** 120 L. Scarce. Legal. Orchard-keepers will not buy one; they cannot bear the sound.

## ◇ A LETTERED HIDE

Sal Trotter walks herds to market that the buyers call cattle. They are heavy, docile, pinkish-white, with broad flat faces and soft lowing voices, and on the road, when nobody watches, they stand up. She has stopped naming them, because they started answering. Some have scars where a brand would be, and the scars are in the shape of letters.

At the Chute the hides go to the tanners, and the lettered ones are pulled out and sold. A lettered hide is a square of thick white leather, soft as kid, with a raised pink scar across it spelling part of a word, or a whole one. The words are names. Sometimes a first name, sometimes a village, once in a while a full name with a date, as though a brand had been written by someone who wanted the beast to remember. Rendered through a tannery, a lettered hide stays warm and smells faintly of milk. Worn against the skin, the scar itches. Worn for a day, it itches in the shape of the word.

Fatlanders buy them to find out who. Sal Trotter does not. She says she can guess, and that the herd is all the same name, really.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) at the Chute; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** Tanned, it lasts as leather lasts. Untanned, it rots in a week, and smells of a person.

**CARVING** Bought from the Chute's tanners (Tongue + Haggle vs Hard 14), or taken from a beast on the drive (Hand + Blades vs Hard 14 to kill and flay; Dread 2, and Dread 3 if the beast stands up). Sal Trotter will kill anyone who touches her herd on the road.

**TAINT** 1 Hunger, Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A hide bearing a name lets its holder find what became of that person: carried for a day, it leads the holder (as a compass of

itching) to the field where they were Reaped, or to their nearest kin. Worn as a jerkin, a hide of the herd marks the wearer as one of them: two-legged cattle follow, protect and obey the wearer, and on the road at night will stand and walk beside them, humming. The wearer gains 1 Hunger each night they are worn.

**WORTH** 30 L, or 200 L if the name is a known one. Scarce. Legal if stamped *beef*. They are all stamped *beef*.

## ◇ FIRST MARBLING

At the turn of Carving comes Marbling, the first frost of the south, when the fat in the soil whitens and the plains look like a cut of meat from horizon to horizon. For one morning, before the sun softens it, the white fat stands up out of the ground in veins and ribbons, and the poor go out with spoons and buckets to skim it before it sinks back. First Marbling is the year's best fat. It is creamy-white, sweet, cool and very clean, and it melts at the touch of a palm. Rubbed into skin, it vanishes, and the skin stays warm for days.

Southern mothers rub it into children against the cold. Renderers' bruisers rub it into their knuckles and their bellies before a fight, because a body rubbed in First Marbling gives under a blow like soil under a spade, and does not bruise. Brother Glut's faithful baste themselves with it before an Offering. It makes them, they say, a better meal.

Rubbed in too often, it does not wash off. The skin goes soft, loamy and faintly mottled, field-colored, and keeps the print of a thumb for an hour.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in the Fatlands; Hard (14) abroad.

**SPOILAGE** A season in a sealed crock, kept cool. In warmth it goes rancid in a week and smells of a wake.

**CARVING** Skimmed at dawn on the first Marbling morning, before sunrise, with a flat spoon (Hand + Craft vs Routine 10; a crock a person). A Lack means the ground under the skimmer softens and the soil takes them to the knees (one Reaping roll, Hard).

**TAINT** 1 Hunger, 1 Regrowth (Ummer) after the third use in a season.

**EFFECT** A crock gives ten rubbings. Each rubbing grants Armor 1 (stacking with worn armor) against blunt weapons and fists for a day, removes cold-weather penalties, and makes the user's flesh soft as loam. After the tenth rubbing in a single season, the user's skin stays soft: permanent +1 Armor against blunt weapons, -1 to

Stealth (they leave prints on everything they lean on), and an unmistakable warm, savory smell.

**WORTH** 3 L a crock in the Fatlands; 15 L abroad. Common at home, Uncommon abroad. Legal, and stamped.

## ◇ A TRENCHER CREEPER

The Trencher is the field where Ummer was eaten: a great shallow bowl of black soil a mile across, west of Sated, where nothing is planted and everything grows, in a dense tangle of toothed grain, veined roots and fleshy creepers that heal over any path cut through them in a night. At its center is a rise of soil shaped, from the air, very like a sleeping figure lying on its side. The Board forbids entry. Pilgrims of the Second Helping go anyway, and lie down, and are found weeks later, smiling and partly absorbed.

A Trencher creeper is a length of pinkish vine, thick as a thumb, smooth, warm and pulsing, with small round leaves like fingernails. It grips. Laid against skin, it curls, and fixes, and within an hour has sent fine white tendrils under the skin, and the bearer feels it as a warm, full, sleepy contentment that is nearly the opposite of the southern hunger. The Second Helping wraps it around the wrists of the Offered. Smugglers sell it to the desperate of other lands as the only thing on the Table that makes a Fatlander feel full.

It does. While it grows.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Second Helping, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A month in a jar of warm drip-fat. Once on skin, it lives as long as its host.

**CARVING** Cut from the Trencher's edge (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14 past Board wardens; Hand + Blades vs Hard 14 to sever it, as it grips the cutter's wrist). Each hour in the Trencher is +1 Hunger. A Lack means the cutter lies down for a moment, smiling, and must be pulled out by others (Gut + Labor vs Grim 18). Seeing the half-absorbed pilgrims is a Dread 3 check.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Ummer).

**EFFECT** Wound round a limb, the creeper roots in an hour. While it grows, the bearer feels no hunger at all: Hunger cannot rise above 3, the Wants of the Fatlands do not fire, and Starving penalties are ignored. Each week it is worn, roll Regrowth Taint, and the bearer must stand still on soil for an hour a day or lose 1 Flesh. Removing it after a week is Hand + Stitching vs Grim (18) and 1d6 Flesh, and the hunger returns all at once: +5 Hunger.

**WORTH** 200 L. Rare. Trespass in the Trencher is a Board offense; selling its growth abroad is a Union matter. The Second Helping gives it away.

# ▼ FROM THE KITCHENS AND THE KNIFE

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The south's dead are served at the wake, by the family, with the best plates; to be buried uneaten would be the deepest insult to a life. So the south has no graveyards, and its holiest places are its kitchens. The leavings of this section are made, not grown: by cooks, butchers, chefs and feeders, from the god's flesh and the people's, with the same skill and pride a Lastgate Seamer brings to a restitching. Most are sold openly. All of them are delicious. That is the difficulty.

## ◆ HOB GRISTLE'S TASTING SPOON

Hob Gristle, the Honest Butcher, can tell by taste what a cut used to be, down to the name: a mouthful of sausage tells him the pig, the field it ate from, and the name of anyone Reaped into that field. It has ruined him for the trade. He still joints at wakes, and apologizes to every joint, quietly, by name. He has already tasted his brother, in a pie in Sated, and has told no one.

He has worn out eleven tasting spoons in thirty years. They are horn spoons, dark and polished, worn thin at the bowl from his tongue, and the gift has soaked into them as gravy soaks into a board. His old spoons were thrown out with the kitchen scraps and fished out by an apprentice who understood. A Gristle spoon dipped in any dish and licked tells the lick what is in it, all of it, by name. Most buyers use one once, and put it in a drawer, and do not eat out for a while.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Sated; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** It never spoils, but the gift wears with use: after twenty tastings, it is only a spoon.

**CARVING** Bought from the apprentice, now a cook named Ruddle Furrow (Tongue + Haggle vs Hard 14), or taken from Hob, who would give one to anyone who asked kindly and promised never to use it on a pie.

**TAINT** 1 Hunger per tasting. Dread 2 the first time the spoon names someone the taster knew.

**EFFECT** A tasting (Eye + Feast vs Routine 10) names every creature in the dish, where it grew or grazed, and, for any meat that was a person or was fed on one, the person's name. A Helping gives the field or the barrel's origin; a Grace gives how they died. Used on a Chute barrel, it reveals what the double stamp hides. Used on Rootkin, it names the face.

**WORTH** 75 L. Scarce. Legal, but any Renderer who sees one in a customer's hand will remember the face.

## ◆ AN OFFERED PORTION OF BROTHER GLUT

Brother Glut, prophet of the Second Helping, is enormous, radiant and happy. He preaches that being eaten is the highest form of being loved, and he has volunteered parts of himself to prove it: his left hand, both ears, three toes, a long strip from the flank. The wounds are bound in clean linen and he shows them off like medals. The parts were cooked at Gladbelly with garlands and song, and most of them were eaten there. Not all.

An Offered Portion is a slice of the prophet, cured in salt and honey in the Second Helping's way, wrapped in vine leaves and tied with wheat-straw: a rosy, translucent, sweet-smelling sliver the size of a playing card. Eaten, it tastes of honey and a summer meadow and of nothing else in the world. And the eater, for the first time in their life if they are a Fatlander, stops being hungry. Not full. Loved. That is how the faithful describe it. A warmth that settles in the belly and spreads, and the absolute certainty that being eaten would be the kindest thing that could ever happen to them.

The widows at the back of Glut's meetings, holding their plates, have each eaten one.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Second Helping, Routine (10).

**SPOILAGE** A year cured. It survives the Rim Road in its leaves.

**CARVING** Given by the Second Helping to a convert, or stolen from Gladbelly's slaughter-pavilion (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14). Taking one from Brother Glut himself requires only asking; he will offer a slice gladly, and the carver must cut it (Hand + Stitching vs Hard 14; Dread 3 to cut a living man who is weeping with joy).

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Ummer), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Eating a portion empties the eater's Hunger to 0 and keeps it there for a day: no Partaking costs Hunger, no Wants fire. Then the eater must make a Caul + Resolve roll vs Grim (18); on failure they gain the Devotion Derangement toward the Second Helping and its teaching, and will volunteer something of themselves (a finger, a strip) at the next Gladbelly table unless their companions stop them. Non-Fatlanders feel the love and none of the relief.

**WORTH** Never sold by the faithful. 300 L from thieves. Rare. Not illegal; the Board considers the Second Helping lawful and enthusiastic. That is the worst of it.

## ◇ DELLAMORE ASPIC

Lady Aspic Dellamore's specialty is preservation. Her rivals are displayed in her gallery, set in clear golden jelly, garnished with herbs and quail's eggs, and blinking. The jelly keeps them; the Gut-line blood keeps them hungry. They watch visitors eat at her table. She is working on a new piece for the gallery, and has been measuring Dame Marrable.

Her aspic is the clearest on the Table: a golden, quivering, faintly sweet jelly clarified twelve times through linen and egg-white, set with a stock whose base she will not name. Anything set in it is kept as it went in: not dead, not living, simply held. A severed hand set in Dellamore aspic is a fresh hand a year later. A cut flower is a cut flower. A person is a person, awake, unable to move, unable to starve, watching. Dellamore sells small pots of it to surgeons and to collectors. She sells large pots to no one, and her rivals' families have stopped asking where their relatives are.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among Gut-line society; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** The aspic holds as long as it is kept cool and unbroken: in a cellar, for decades. Warm or cracked, it melts in a day, and whatever was in it resumes exactly where it left off, including bleeding.

**CARVING** Bought from Dellamore's kitchen (Tongue + Haggle vs Grim 18; she prices by the client's weight), or stolen from it (Lung + Filch vs Grim 18, past a gallery of rivals who watch every step and cannot raise the alarm except with their eyes). Walking her gallery is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** Dread 1 (to use); Dread 3 (to set a person).

**EFFECT** A pot preserves one severed part perfectly until it is reattached (no penalty to Stitching; a Seamer needs only a Routine roll). A larger vat holds a person in the state they were in when set: the bleeding stop, the dying do not die, the Reaped soil on their boots does not take them. A wounded companion set in aspic can be carried for weeks to a surgeon. They are awake the whole time. Each week set, they make a Dread 2 check.

**WORTH** 50 L a pot; 1,200 L a vat. Scarce. Legal. Lady Dellamore is an artist.

## ◇ A NOTCHED STAVE

Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot feeds the army and stamps the export barrels at the Chute. He is portly, fussy and honest, and he has started marking a small notch on the barrels he would not eat from himself. There are a great many notches. He wants someone outside

the Fatlands to know. He fears that if they knew, they would keep buying.

A notched stave is a single oak barrel-stave from the Chute, tarred inside, double-stamped on the outside, and carrying near the rim a small, neat, V-shaped notch cut with a penknife. The wood is soaked through with whatever was in the barrel, and it has kept a little of it. Dropped into a cooking-pot, a notched stave floats if the meat is honest beef, pork or mutton. If it is not, the stave sinks, slowly, to the bottom, and stays there, and the broth turns very slightly pink.

Reckoners carry notched staves into the Fatlands' customer lands. Purgation cells hand them out at the Rim Road inns. Stockpot does not know. He would be relieved.

*Barrel 41,206. Pork, Low Tilth, stamped twice. Notched. Barrel 41,207. Pork, Low Tilth, stamped twice. Notched. Barrel 41,208. Beef, Dusk Acre 19. Notched; I have not opened it; I know the number. Barrel 41,209. Pork. Not notched. Barrel 41,210. Notched. I have stopped writing what they are. I have stopped eating the army's rations. My wife says I am looking thin, and she says it kindly, and I cannot tell her.*

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) on the Rim; Grim (18) in the Fatlands, where nobody wants to know.

**SPOILAGE** A year, before the wood dries out and forgets.

**CARVING** Pried from a notched barrel at any Rim market (Eye + Search vs Hard 14 to find one; most notched barrels are emptied and burned by Union men).

**TAINT** none. Dread 2 the first time it sinks in a meal you have eaten.

**EFFECT** Dropped into any dish, stew or barrel for a minute, the stave reveals whether it holds human flesh or flesh fed on the Reaped: it sinks if so. No roll. A party carrying one never eats a Reaped meal unknowingly. A Fatlander who uses one finds the Hollow Plate Derangement easier to catch: Dread checks at meals are +2 difficulty for a week.

**WORTH** 10 L abroad; nobody sells them in the Fatlands. Uncommon on the Rim. Illegal in the Fatlands as "slander of produce."

## ◇ A GAVAGE FUNNEL

At the Gavage, the Board's house of correction for the Thin, a hundred cells each hold an oak-and-iron chair, a set of leather straps, a funnel-stand and a drain. Its kitchens never close. Feeder Callow Pudge, soft-voiced and motherly, has polished her own funnel for thirty years and hums lullabies as she pours, and sincerely believes she saves lives. She keeps a book of the Thin she has fed, with their weights in and out, and letters from grateful families.

A Gavage funnel is a cone of tinned copper a forearm long, with a narrow spout wrapped in soft leather so that it does not break teeth. The leather is dark with years of porridge and lard. When held, the funnel is warm. When raised toward a mouth, it pulls a little, like a lodestone toward iron, and the mouth opens. Thirty years of forced meals have taught the funnels the god's own lesson: that every mouth wants to be fed, and every refusal is only fear. A funnel brought near a Fatlander makes them salivate. A funnel brought near one of the Thin makes them weep.

Callow Pudge has begun, secretly, to leave one cell door unbarred each Lack. She has also been seen to throw a funnel into the Little Gravy, and stand watching it sink.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in the Fatlands; Hard (14) abroad.

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil. Abroad, the pull fades after a season.

**CARVING** Stolen from the Gavage (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14), or bought from a feeder who has had enough (Tongue + Persuade vs Hard 14).

**TAINT** 1 Hunger per use, to the one fed. Dread 1 to the feeder.

**EFFECT** A held, grappled or bound person can be fed through the funnel (Hand + Stitching vs Routine 10). The fed person cannot refuse what is poured: food, drink, medicine, poison, Tainted meat, a Purgation emetic. A starving companion who cannot keep food down can be saved with it (remove 2 levels of Starving). Used on a Fatlander, it counts as their Sop. Used on a Thin, it costs them 2 Fray, and a day of their fast.

**WORTH** 12 L. Uncommon. Legal in Bailiffs' hands; owning one privately in Sated is, oddly, a mark of respectability.

## ◇ HESK'S WAKE-GLAZE

Wakemother Pudding Hesk is the most sought-after wake-cook in Sated. Families wait months for her. She bastes the dead with their

own dripping and a little honey, roasts them slow over applewood, and sends them to the table glazed and crackling, and she weeps every time, openly, while she carves. She knows everyone's secrets, because the dead taste of them. She wants to cook the Chairman. She has been asked to.

Her glaze is the drippings of the roasted dead, reduced with honey, clove and a splash of sour wine from the family's own cellar, until it is a dark, glossy, sticky amber that smells like a feast-day and sets like toffee. She bottles the leftovers in small crocks and gives them to the bereaved, to put on their bread through the winter. Families say that while they eat it, they hear the dead at the table. Others have learned that brushed on anyone's meat, wake-glaze carries more than a memory: it carries a confession. The dead taste of their secrets. So does their glaze.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in Sated; Grim (18) abroad.

**SPOILAGE** A season in a sealed crock; a year in Lack's cold.

**CARVING** Bought from Hesk (Tongue + Persuade vs Hard 14, and she must like you), or skimmed from the roasting-pan at a wake (Hand + Filch vs Hard 14 under a grieving family's eyes). Taking it from the dead's own pan, at their own wake, is a Dread 1 check and a mortal insult if seen.

**TAINT** 2 Hunger.

**EFFECT** Eating a spoonful of a person's wake-glaze gives the eater one of that person's secrets (the GM chooses; on a Grace, the secret they would have most wanted kept). A Fatlander with Taste the Name gains two. A crock holds six spoonfuls. Brushed on the meat of a living guest at a meal, it gives nothing, but the guest must make a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) or confess one secret of their own before the meal ends, as if the dead were asking.

**WORTH** 20 L a crock. Uncommon. Legal. Selling another family's glaze is a feud, and in the south feuds end at a wake.



CHAPTER 11

LEAVINGS OF  
BRINEHOLLOW



*What the sea gives back, it is only lending.*

– SALVAGER'S PROVERB, SALTWICK

EVERY RELIC IN THIS COUNTRY IS  
SOMETHING THE WATER LEFT BEHIND ON ITS  
WAY OUT. BE CAREFUL WHAT YOU PICK UP. THE WATER  
WILL WANT IT BACK, AND THE WATER IS IN YOU.

[ HASK TARN, THE PILOT, TO A PARTY OF SALVAGERS AT THE MILE'S END ]

Brinehollow's leavings are the sea's lost property. They wash up, or they are coughed up, or they are found standing upright on the dry seabed with their hatches open. The country was a nation of fishers and wreckers for five centuries, and it has kept the fisher's habits now that its sea is gone: everything that comes out of the water is the finder's, by old salvage law; nothing that comes out of a person is anyone's, by older custom; and anything taken from the Tenanted is not spoken of at all, because it is rude to ask a returned person where they went, and ruder to ask what they brought back.

The trade lives in three places. Saltwick, thirty miles inland, is the open market for everything the Uncovered yields, and its salvage halls deal in leather-weed, wreck-timber, sea-glass and the odd gold ring from a skeleton's finger without much interest in what else they buy. Lowmark's Mile is where bodily leavings change hands: bail-water by the jar, Tenanted salt, the hair that falls out in the bath in long dark ropes. And the far Uncovered, past the Wreck Orchard, is where the dangerous things are found, by salvagers who go out with ropes and hooks and come back fewer.

Carving in Brinehollow is mostly collecting. The body gives up its water twice a day for nothing; the sea, leaving, gives up its floor. The hard part is what is attached. A salvager on the Uncovered must contend with Ribwalkers and cart-sized crabs and lights in empty wrecks. A bail-water collector must contend with the Netwatch, the Wreckwives and the Drowned Bench, all of whom take an interest in who is buying the water of the soon-to-be-Called. And anyone who carves from the Tenanted must contend with the Tenanted, who are calm, courteous, very heavy, and remember.

What the coast fears is the pull. Every Brinehollow leaving carries the sea's wish to go home, and the sea's home is west and down, and the people who carry its leavings find themselves standing at west-facing windows. Salvagers keep their finds in the east rooms of their houses. Old Brinehollowers anchor their relics as they anchor their sleepers, roped to the bed-frame. And everyone knows a story of someone who kept a pretty shell from the Uncovered on the sill, and woke one night already walking.

## ▼ FROM THE LUNG-LINES AND THE TENANTED



The Lung-lines ate Dromm's lungs and now hold court from glass tanks; the Tenanted came back from the sea with someone else looking out. Between them they hold Brinehollow, and between them they shed the coast's most potent leavings: the water they live in, the hair they lose, the tears they weep, the silt they leave in courtrooms. None of these are taken by force. They are taken from

drains, from bath-water, from the floors of the Sounding Hall, from the long hours in which nobody important is watching the servants.

### ◇ TANK-WATER OF THE PRINCE

Prince Aurel Vasht, heir of the Lung-lines, is twenty-two and cannot breathe air for more than an hour. He rules from a glass tank in

Fathomhouse and has learned to read lips through eight inches of green water. The tank is drained and refilled every week by servants in rubber aprons, because the prince's lungs breathe it as other lungs breathe air, and what he breathes out turns the water cloudy and cold and alive.

The drained water goes down a pipe to the cellars, where the Dowager Below is. Some of it goes, in buckets, out of the kitchen door. Tank-water is pale green, faintly glowing in the dark, so cold it aches in the teeth, and in it hang fine, slow, silver threads that coil and uncoil like breath made visible. It tastes of nothing. Drunk, it fills the lungs and stays there, and the drinker discovers that they can breathe it: that their chest has become, for a while, a prince's chest.

The servants call the trade *the prince's leavings* and think it harmless. The prince knows. He reads it on their lips.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Fathomhouse servants, Routine (10).

**SPOILAGE** A day in an open bucket; a month in a sealed glass bottle kept cold and dark. Exposed to sun, the threads die in an hour and it is only seawater.

**CARVING** Taken from the drain-pipe or the kitchen buckets on drainage night (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14 inside Fathomhouse). A Lack means the Dowager's hair comes up the pipe toward the bucket.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Dromm).

**EFFECT** A cup drunk lets the drinker breathe water as easily as air for a day, and see in dark water as in dim light. While under its effect, the drinker gains +2 to Instinct and Search in or under water and can read lips through glass or water. For a non-Brinehollower, it also gives a Brinehollower's tide for the day: they must bail at dusk or begin to drown.

**WORTH** 60 L a bottle. Scarce. Theft from the royal household; the Admiralty hangs for it, in theory.

## ◇ A ROPE OF THE DOWAGER'S HAIR

Lady Ondine Vasht, the Dowager Below, lives in the flooded cellars of Fathomhouse and has not been seen whole in years. What can be seen of her, through black water by lamplight, is a vast grey shape folded into the vaults, skin like a drowned sail, and hair that drifts across the floor of three cellars. She sheds it. It comes loose in long dark ropes, like weed after a storm, and the servants who mop the stairs at the indoor tide's ebb find it wound around the newel-posts, and sell it.

Dowager hair is black-green, slick, thick as a finger when wet and thin as a thread when dry, and stronger than any rope spun in the Ropewalk. It cannot be cut by an ordinary blade; it parts only under a saw. Brinehollowers who can afford it have it braided into their anchoring ropes, because a sleeper roped with the Dowager's hair

has never once been Called. The rope will not let them go. Wreckwives whisper that it is because the rope belongs to someone, and that someone is keeping them for herself.

Those who sleep tied with it dream of a long dark room full of water, and a grandmother's voice, and a hand stroking their hair.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among the rich of the Headland; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** It does not rot. Dry, it becomes brittle in a year unless wetted with seawater once a week.

**CARVING** Gathered from Fathomhouse's flooded stairs at low indoor tide (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14). Taken from the Dowager directly, under the water, with a saw: Lung + Athletics vs Dire (22), with her hair attacking as she defends it. Seeing one of her eyes open in the dark water is Dread 4.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Dromm), on each night slept in it.

**EFFECT** A sleeper anchored with Dowager hair cannot be Called: no Calling roll is made. The rope cannot be cut except by a saw and a Grim (18) roll. But it is hers. Each night slept in it, roll a d6: on a 1, the sleeper wakes in Fathomhouse's cellars, wet, unharmed, roped to a pillar, with no memory of the walk. Lung-line characters roll a d6 and fail on a 1 or 2.

**WORTH** 150 L a fathom. Rare. Theft from the royal household. Most of the Headland's finest anchoring ropes contain some.

## ◇ A TENANTED TEAR

At the Brink, a Brinehollower's tears are salt enough to sting cuts. The Tenanted weep rarely, and when they do, it is said, it is the person underneath weeping, not the Tenant: a long slow tear, very heavy, that runs down the cheek and does not dry, and falls, and makes a sound when it lands like a pebble dropped into a well. The Wreckwives collect them. They sit with their returned spouses in the evenings and hold a glass phial to the cheek, and wait. Sennet Gull, whose husband came back kinder and lives in her cistern, has seven.

A Tenanted tear is a single drop of water in a stoppered phial, heavier than the phial, perfectly clear. It does not evaporate. Tilted, it rolls like quicksilver. Put to the eye, it lets you see the way the Tenant sees: through water, through flesh, into the deep of a person, where their sea is. The Wreckwives use them to look into each other and see how far gone they are. They use them, too, to look into their spouses, and see who is down there, and how small.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Wreckwives, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A tear lasts forever in its phial; it is used up when put to the eye.

**CARVING** Waiting by a Tenanted person until they weep (Eye + Instinct vs Grim 18, and days of patience) and catching the tear before it lands. A Tenanted person asked to weep, and told why, may oblige (Tongue + Persuade vs Dire 22). Seeing who is



underneath when the tear is used is Dread 3, and Dread 4 if it is someone you loved.

**TAINT 1** Regrowth (Dromm), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Placed in the eye for a scene, a tear shows the user the depth of every person in sight: their Regrowth stage, whether they are Tenanted, and if Tenanted, a glimpse of the person still underneath (whether they are there, and how much of them). It also shows anything hidden under water within a mile. The user's eye stings with salt for a day after (–1 to Search).

**WORTH** 250 L. Rare. Wreckwives will not sell; tears change hands only when a Wreckwife dies, and the sisterhood hunts the buyer.

## ◇ A CUP OF THE SOUNDING POOL

The courthouse of the Drowned Bench is a round stone hall whose floor is a shallow pool, ankle-deep, fed by the indoor tide. The accused stand in the water. The Tenanted judges sit on a stone bench at the far side, utterly still. Justice Maren Oake, Called at thirty and returned after forty days, has never given an unjust verdict, and speaks in two tones at once, and the lower one sometimes finishes first. The pool is always cold. Witnesses say that when a lie is spoken in the Hall, the water rises.

They are right. The pool has been listening to testimony for four hundred years. A cup of it, carried out in a waterproof flask, still listens. Poured into a basin and set between two people, it lies flat as glass while the truth is spoken, and when a lie is told, it rises: a finger's width for a small one, over the rim for a great one, cold and green and smelling of the deep. Merchants in Saltwick use it to settle contracts. Lovers on the Mile use it to settle worse.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Lowmark; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A season in a sealed flask; it loses its ear if it ever dries. Outside Brinehollow it hears only Brinehollowers.

**CARVING** Scooped from the Sounding Hall's pool during a session, in plain sight of the Bench (Hand + Filch vs Grim 18). The Tenanted judges see it. They say nothing. On a Lack, Justice Oake turns her head and speaks the carver's name in the lower voice only. Dread 2.

**TAINT 1** Regrowth (Dromm).

**EFFECT** Set in a basin, the water rises at every deliberate lie spoken within arm's reach of it, with no roll and no defense; Deceive rolls are impossible across it. Used in a negotiation, it gives +2 to Haggle and Clause for the honest party. A Tenanted person speaking across

it makes it rise slowly, whatever they say; nobody knows whether this means they lie, or only that the sea in them is very deep.

**WORTH** 180 L a flask. Scarce. Contempt of the Bench, if it can be proven; nobody has ever tried.

## ◇ A SLIVER OF THE BEACHED GOD

Commodore Lysander Vell of the Admiralty keeps in his cabin aboard the propped *Gannet* a lead box holding a piece of Dromm's flesh, preserved since the Beaching, which still weeps cold water. He is a member of the Second Table, and he believes the god is reassembling at the bottom of the Trench. He has been eating a sliver of the flesh each Tablenight. He no longer needs to bail.

The flesh is grey-white, dense, translucent at the edges like a scallop, and cold enough to burn. It weeps constantly: a slow seep of clear, heavy water that fills the box an inch a day and must be poured off, and the water runs west. A sliver shaved from it with a razor curls like an apple-peel and quivers on the blade. Eaten, it tastes of the bottom of the sea: of pressure, of iron, of a cold so complete it is almost peace. The eater's chest goes quiet. The tide does not come. And something, very far down and very far west, turns its attention, slowly, toward the eater, the way a sleeper half-wakes at a sound.

The box has no lock. Vell has never thought it needed one.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22). The Second Table, Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** In its lead box, indefinite. A shaved sliver must be eaten within a minute or it melts into a cup of cold water that runs west across any floor.

**CARVING** Shaved from Vell's piece, in his cabin aboard a fully crewed, propped warship (Lung + Stealth vs Grim 18; Hand + Blades vs Hard 14 to shave cleanly). A Lack means the razor slips, and the flesh closes over the carver's thumb: Gut + Endure vs Grim (18) to pull free, losing the thumb's skin. Handling the god's flesh is a Dread 3 check.

**TAINT 4** Regrowth (Dromm), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** A sliver eaten frees the eater from bailing for a year: their tide does not come, and they cannot drown. They gain Armor 1 against crushing and pressure, and ignore pressure days. Each sliver also adds one automatic Calling roll on the next licked-clean moon, at Dire (22), whatever the eater's land, and the GM notes that the god has seen them.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Second Table would pay any price for the whole. Unique.

## ▼ FROM THE BODY'S TIDE



Twice a day every Brinehollower brings up the sea. It is the commonest leaving on the Table, a pint or two per person per tide, poured into gutters that run west. Most of it is nothing: cold, clear, faintly green water with a little sand in it. Some of it is not. The bail-water of the soon-to-be-Called turns sea-blue and heavy. The chests of the drowned turn out to have currents. Sometimes a person brings up something small and living, and sometimes a word, and sometimes a knife.

### ◆ A TENANTED SWEETHEART'S BUCKET

Every Brinehollower carries a bail-bucket. Losing yours is like losing your shoes. Sweethearts exchange them. When one of a pair is Called, and comes back Tenanted, the returned one asks for their bucket at the door, and bails into it at dawn and dusk as they always did, and the water they bring up is deeper, colder and much heavier than before. The bucket learns this water. In a year it is heavier empty than full ones are.

A Tenanted sweetheart's bucket is an ordinary wooden or tin bail-bucket, often painted with names or hearts, stained green to the rim, and too heavy for its size. It is cold. Brinehollowers can feel it across a room. The Tenanted can feel it across a city. A bucket given away by a Tenanted spouse, as a sweetheart's token, binds the receiver to the returned one in a way the Wreckwives argue over: the Tenant always knows where its bucket is, and treats whoever holds it with the full courtesy it extends to its family. Sennet Gull's husband gave her his. She has started to prefer him. That is what frightens her.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Wreckwives, Routine (10).

**SPOILAGE** It keeps its weight as long as the Tenanted owner lives. If they are drained, it is only a heavy bucket.

**CARVING** Given, by a Tenanted person, freely (it cannot be taken; a stolen bucket is only a bucket, and the Tenant comes for it, courteously). Persuading a Tenanted person to give it is Tongue + Persuade vs Grim (18), and is a Dread 2 check when they smile.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Dromm), each night it sits beside the bed.

**EFFECT** The holder is treated by the bucket's Tenant as family: protected, helped, answered honestly about anything but the sea. Every Tenanted person who sees the bucket recognizes the bond and extends the same courtesy (+2 to all Tongue rolls with the Tenanted). A holder who bails into the bucket finds the sea easier to

bring up: bailing takes half the time. And the Tenant always knows where the holder is.

**WORTH** Never sold. Unique per Tenant. The Wreckwives call accepting one *marrying the water*.

### ◆ REAVE'S SHELL

Dr. Isolde Reave, lung surgeon, opened a drowned chest at high tide and found that the water in it had a current. In the next one she found a shell, alive, of no known species. She has found eleven more since, in the chests of the Called brought home dead by the Netwatch. She keeps them in a tank. They have bred.

A Reave's shell is a whorled spiral the size of a thumb, pearl-grey outside, pink and wet within, and something lives in it that has never been seen whole: a soft pale foot, two fine feelers that taste the air, and a sound, very faint, like breath through a reed. Held to the ear, it does not make the sound of the sea. It makes the sound of lungs. And it wants to go back into a chest. Placed on the lips of a sleeping Brinehollower, it crawls in, down the throat, into the lungs, where it settles, and from then on it bails for them: it drinks the tide as it rises, every drop, and the sleeper never wakes gurgling again.

Dr. Reave has one in her own chest. She has noticed that she now coughs up, at dawn, very small shells.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Lowmark physicians, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A week out of salt water; indefinitely in a jar of brine. Once in a chest, it lives as long as its host.

**CARVING** From a drowned Called body, in Reave's surgery or a Netwatch mortuary, at high tide (Hand + Stitching vs Hard 14). Bought from Reave, who will sell to anyone willing to report back (Tongue + Persuade vs Hard 14). Watching it crawl into a mouth is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Dromm), once, on implanting; then 1 Regrowth Taint each season.

**EFFECT** The host need never bail again, and cannot drown in their own tide. They breathe a little wet. Each season, roll a d6: on a 1, the shell has bred, and the host coughs up a dozen tiny shells at dawn, each of which can be given to another person. On a 1 rolled twice in a row, the host's chest begins to have a current, and their Calling rolls are +2 difficulty.

**WORTH** 300 L. Rare. Not illegal; nobody has thought of a law. The Purgation's Wringer would burn every one.

## ◇ THE INVITATION, TRANSCRIBED

Nerys Colm walked into the surf up to her chin and then, uniquely, turned around. She heard the invitation in full and can repeat it. Nobody who has listened to her has stayed ashore. She lives alone, now, in a house on the old shoreline with no windows facing west, and speaks to visitors through a door, and does not say it.

Somebody wrote it down. In 627 a Salt Assay clerk, sent to take her deposition, sat with his back to her door and transcribed what she said in shorthand, and stopped after a page, and went home, and walked west that night. The page was found in his satchel by the Netwatch, who could not read shorthand. It has been copied since. A copy of the Invitation is a sheet of paper covered in a tight, slanting clerk's shorthand, water-stained, smelling of salt; read aloud, by anyone who can read the old Assay hand, it becomes a voice. Listeners say it is not words so much as being known: something patient and kind and very, very old, which has always known your name, telling you that you may come home now, and that you will not be cold.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22).

**SPOILAGE** The paper keeps. Every copy made by hand is weaker than its original; a copy of a copy of a copy calls only Lung-lines.

**CARVING** Copied from an existing copy (Eye + Lore vs Grim 18 to read the shorthand; Hand + Craft vs Hard 14 to copy it). Or taken from Nerys Colm herself, who will speak it to anyone who asks three times, and will weep afterward. Reading or hearing it is a Dread 4 check.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Dromm), to everyone who hears it read.

**EFFECT** Read aloud (one minute), the Invitation forces every listener with Lung-line blood, or brine in them (see Dry Jonah's tonics), to make a Calling roll at once, at Dire (22), regardless of anchoring; failure means they rise and walk west, now. Others make a Dread 4 check and must resist the Pull derangement for a night. The reader is not immune. It has been used as a weapon twice. Both times the Netwatch could not haul back enough.

**WORTH** Never sold openly. Unique per copy (perhaps five exist). Possession is treason under Admiralty law; the Deepening would treasure one, and Mother Limpet has said she does not need it.

## ◇ THE LITTLE KNIFE FROM BELOW

Ottiline Hawse, Mistress of the Ropewalk on Mile Three, keeps a ledger of every anchoring rope cut in Lowmark and can tell by the cut which ropes were cut by the sleeper, which by the beloved, and which by no hand at all. Forty of the ropes she sold last year were cut by the same small blade, angled from below. She knows the blade. She has not said whose it is.

It is a short, slender knife with a curved blade no longer than a finger, the kind net-menders use, with a handle of grey bone gone smooth and green from wet. It is always damp. It is found, again and again, in sleepers' bedclothes, under the mattress, in the toe of a boot beside the bed: wherever it can be reached by a hand from below. Each time it is found, it is thrown into the gutter, which runs west. Each time, a few weeks later, it is found again, in another bed.

The Wreckwives believe it is a Tenant's tool, sent ahead. The Netwatch believes it is a person. Ottiline Hawse believes it is a child's knife, and that is why she will not say.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Ropewalkers and Netwatch, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** It does not rust or rot. It cannot be kept: each Plate, roll a d6; on a 1, it is gone from wherever it was locked, and the GM knows whose bed it is under now.

**CARVING** Found in a bed after a Calling (Eye + Search vs Hard 14). Taking it from the hand that holds it at night is Lung + Filch vs Dire (22), and the hand, the GM decides, may be the taker's own.

**TAINT** Dread 2, each night it stays in the house.

**EFFECT** The knife cuts any rope, chain or binding with a single stroke, including Dowager hair and the Anchorites' iron; no roll. It also cuts promises: used to sever a cord tied between two people as a token, it ends one oath between them, unkept and unbroken. But each night it is in the bearer's house, the GM rolls a d6; on a 1, a sleeper in the house (the bearer included) wakes with their anchoring cut, and must make a Calling roll.

**WORTH** Never sold; nobody keeps it long enough. Unique. The Netwatch pays a tally for every sighting.

## ▼ FROM THE UNCOVERED AND THE DEEP



A new mile of seabed is exposed every year, and with it six centuries of wrecks, bones, reefs gone to rot and things that came up as the water fell and did not die properly. By old salvage law, what the sea gives up belongs to the finder. By newer custom, salvagers do not go out alone, do not go past the Wreck Orchard after dark, and do not bring home anything that is still warm. Saltwick's salvage halls buy everything else.

## ◇ RIBWALKER BELLAWS

On the Uncovered there are things with too many ribs: cages of long curved bones, thirty or forty pairs, opening and closing like slow bellows, mounted on legs that might once have been the ribs of something else. Inside each cage is a grey sack that pulses. Ribwalkers move toward water, any water, and they press it out of whatever they catch: a salvager held in the closing cage loses the water of their body a cup at a time, and is found afterward flat and dry as a pressed flower.

The grey sack is the bellows. Cut out and cured in salt, it is a fist-sized bladder of rubbery grey hide with a tube of soft bone at each end, and it still pulses, slowly, when warm. Pressed to a mouth, it draws out water. The Netwatch learned this first: a Called man dragged from the surf with his lungs full can be saved with a Ribwalker bellows, pumped by hand, faster than by any bailing. Every Netwatch boat carries one now. Every Netwatch hooker has stories of the times it drew out more than water.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in the Netwatch; Hard (14) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A year salted. Unsalted, it rots in a week and smells of a beach in Plenty.

**CARVING** From a Ribwalker, killed or disabled (Hand + Blades vs Hard 14 to cut the sack free intact, inside the cage). A Lack means the cage closes on the carver's arm: 2 Flesh a round until freed (Gut + Labor vs Hard 14). Seeing the dry thing still in the cage's last catch is Dread 2.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Used on a drowning or un-bailed person (Hand + Stitching vs Routine 10), the bellows clears their lungs in a round, saving them; it counts as bailing. Used as a weapon on a grappled or helpless foe (Hand + Brawl vs their Guard), it draws out 1d6 Flesh of water; each Helping adds 1. Used on a Tenanted person, it draws out a gallon a round, more than the body can hold, and the Tenant asks, politely, that you stop.

**WORTH** 45 L. Uncommon in Lowmark. Legal; Netwatch issue.

## ◇ LOBBETT'S SILT

Cray Lobbett, a scavenger on the far Uncovered, found a stone table on the seabed, older than the Gorging, with eight chairs. Seven were pushed in. The eighth was pulled out a little, as if someone had just

stood up, or was about to sit down. He has not been able to sell the location, or to stop going back. Salvage crews have searched for it for two years. Three did not come back.

Lobbett brings back silt. He fills his pockets with it every trip, from under the eighth chair, without meaning to, and empties them in Saltwick taverns, and sometimes sells a twist of it for drink. Lobbett's silt is fine, grey and soft as flour, and dry, although everything else on the far Uncovered is wet. It smells faintly of bread. Held in a closed hand, it is warm, the way a chair is warm after someone has risen from it. A pinch of it scattered on any table makes the room uneasy: diners look up, all at once, toward the empty end of the table, as though someone were expected.

Lobbett says the silt is how he finds his way back. He says he wishes it weren't.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18) in Saltwick; Dire (22) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** It never changes. It is never quite all used up: a pocket emptied of it has a little in the seams the next morning.

**CARVING** Bought from Lobbett (Tongue + Haggle vs Routine 10; he wants to be rid of it), or gathered at the table itself, which requires finding it (see Ilse Marl's Chart in the Rim Market). Sitting in one of the seven chairs is a Dread 3 check. Touching the eighth is a Dread 5.

**TAINT** Dread 2, each time it is scattered.

**EFFECT** The holder always knows the direction and distance to the stone table, anywhere on the Table, and can never be lost on the Uncovered (no Wayfaring rolls needed there). Scattered on a table at a meal, it makes everyone present glance at the same empty place: the scatterer gains +2 to Filch and Stealth for the scene while all eyes are elsewhere. Scattered on one of Orrum's tables, it does something the GM should decide in advance, and should not explain.

**WORTH** 10 L a twist from Lobbett, who undercharges. Scarce. The Reckoners of the Fast pay a great deal more, and ask where it came from, and do not leave.

## ◇ A BLADDER OF TRENCH-BREATH

Thirty miles west of Lowmark's last pier the Uncovered ends at a cliff edge, and beyond it lies black water that has not dropped at all, an abyss with a current that runs downward. From the edge you can hear it draining: a low, endless sound like a throat swallowing. Salvagers who go to the brink report a warm updraft that smells of breath.

They are not imagining it. The air that rises from the Trench is warm, damp, and has been somewhere. A pig's bladder held open at the edge and tied off quickly traps a lungful of it; the bladder stays warm, swells and slackens slowly, in and out, as though it were breathing on its own. Opened under the nose, it smells of a sleeping

mouth, and of the deep, and of something sweet underneath. Brinehollowers who inhale it feel the tide in their chest go still and listen, as a dog listens to a whistle; the Hunger in them drops to nothing. Then they find they are facing west.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among far salvagers; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A month; the bladder goes cold and limp when the breath has gone out of it.

**CARVING** At the Trench edge (two days across the Uncovered; Lung + Wayfaring vs Hard 14 each day). Catching the breath is Hand + Craft vs Routine 10, but standing at the edge is a Dread 3 check, and a Lung-line character must make a Calling roll at Hard (14) or begin to walk down the cliff.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Dromm), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Inhaled, it removes all Hunger from a Brinehollower (or anyone with Dromm in them) and gives +2 to the next Godsign roll. Then the inhaler makes a Calling roll that night at +2 difficulty. Released in a closed room, the breath makes every Brinehollower there turn to face west for a minute, motionless, listening, and lose their next action; those who fail a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) hear the draining sound in their own chest for a week.

**WORTH** 120 L. Rare. Legal. The Deepening buys every one and opens them on Gullcry Strand at procession time.

## ◇ A FIGUREHEAD'S EYE

Eight miles out on the Uncovered, in a shallow basin, nearly two hundred wrecks of every age stand upright on the mud in loose rows, as if parked by a harbormaster. Nobody can explain why they are upright, or why their hatches are all open, or why their figureheads all face west. Lantern-light can be seen in the oldest ones at night, which are empty.

Salvagers prize the figureheads' eyes. Each is a disc of painted wood or set glass, the size of a palm, prised from a carved face: a mermaid, a queen, a dog, a saint, a weeping woman with her hands to her breast. Taken from the Wreck Orchard, the eye goes on looking west. It turns in its setting, or in the hand, or in a drawer, until it faces the sea. Captains of the propped fleet at Keelrow keep them on their sea-chests as a compass. And sometimes, at night, the painted pupil of a figurehead's eye shows a tiny lit window, as though the wreck it came from had a lantern burning in it, and someone were standing at the glass.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) on the Mile; Hard (14) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** Indefinite. The painted ones flake within a decade.

**CARVING** Prised from a figurehead in the Wreck Orchard (Lung + Athletics vs Hard 14 to climb the bow; Hand + Craft vs Routine 10 to prise it free). At night, a Lack means the lantern in that wreck goes out, and something walks down the inside of the hull toward the bow. Dread 3.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Dromm), on each night it is looked into.

**EFFECT** The eye always shows the direction of the retreating sea (and, increasingly, of the Trench), unaffected by fog or magic. The bearer gains +2 to Wayfaring on the Uncovered. Looked into at night (Eye + Search vs Grim 18), its lit window shows the inside of its own wreck as it is now, and whoever is in it; a Grace shows their face.

**WORTH** 25 L. Uncommon on the Mile. Legal under salvage law.

## ◇ A LONGSLAB STONE

Longslab, the beach of the Beaching, where Dromm was hauled ashore on ten thousand hooks and took four days to stop moving, is permanently wet, though no sea has touched it in a century. Water seeps up through the shingle as if the beach were a sponge someone is always pressing. At the tide-turns the wet ground breathes: a slow sigh across two miles of stones.

A Longslab stone is a flat grey pebble of the beach, smooth and sweating. It never dries. Wrapped in a cloth, it soaks the cloth in an hour; set on a table, it leaves a ring that spreads. The water it sweats is the god's, coming up from wherever the god's blood went into the shingle six centuries ago: cold, very salt, faintly pink in good light. Pressed to a drowning person's chest, it pulls the water out of them, the way the beach pulls; pressed to a wound, it draws out the blood, cleanly, and closes it. Gulls will not land near one. Children on the Mile dare each other to lick them.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in Brinehollow.

**SPOILAGE** A stone sweats for a year after it leaves the beach, then dries, cracks and is only a pebble. Outside Brinehollow, a season.

**CARVING** Picked up from Longslab (no roll), but standing on the beach at a tide-turn is a Dread 1 check for anyone, and a Lung-line character must resist the Want *The West* at Hard (14). Pilgrims of the Deepening lying face-down on the shingle resent collectors.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Dromm), on each use.

**EFFECT** Pressed to a chest, it bails a helpless person in a minute (counts as bailing, no roll). Pressed to a wound (Hand + Stitching vs Routine 10), it stops bleeding and heals 2 Flesh. Carried on a pressure day, it gives the bearer an hour's warning and +2 to Endure against the pressure. Used too long, it pulls water from whoever holds it: a bearer who keeps one in a pocket for a month loses 1 Flesh and gains a terrible thirst.

**WORTH** 2 L. Common in Lowmark. Legal; considered unlucky.



## ▼ PREPARATIONS OF THE COAST



Brinehollow's crafted leavings are the work of smugglers, monks and priests, the three trades that have most to do with what goes in and out of people. They are the coast's most exported goods after salt, and two of them are the reason the Vigil's Slope has begun walking west.

### ◆ DRY JONAH'S BLUE LABEL

Captain Jonah Skerry, called Dry Jonah, bottles what Brinehollowers cough up and sells it inland as tonic. It sells well in the Vigil. He has never asked what his customers start to dream about. His ordinary brine tonic heals and is sold on every Rim market (see the Rim Market). His Blue Label is not ordinary.

Blue Label is bail-water collected from people in the last week before their Calling, when the water Tolly Brack reads goes from green to a deep sea-blue with a weight to it, like water pulled from a hundred fathoms. Jonah's collectors follow Tolly on his rounds, and buy the blue water from the families, who do not want it in the house. Bottled in cobalt glass with a hand-drawn blue label, it is cold, viscous and faintly luminous, and it tastes of tears. In the Vigil, Rook Quarter-Bell cuts it into his rouse on the Slope, and his customers stay awake for twice as long. They have also started walking west.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) on the Slope and the Mile; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A year in cobalt glass; it goes cloudy and inert in sunlight.

**CARVING** Bought from the family of someone about to be Called (Tongue + Haggle vs Hard 14; Dread 2, because they are in the next room, standing at the west window). Or bought from Jonah (Tongue + Haggle vs Grim 18).

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Dromm). Addiction: Grim (18).

**EFFECT** A dose drunk removes 4 Weariness (see the Vigil) and holds Weariness gains at bay for a full day; it also removes 1d6 Fray, as a vice, with the usual risk of habit. The drinker dreams of the sea while awake, all day, at the edge of sight. On a failed Regrowth Taint roll, they must also make a Calling roll that night, as a Brinehollower of their Regrowth would, even if they have never seen the coast.

**WORTH** 25 L a bottle in Lowmark; 80 L in the Vigil. Scarce. Not illegal anywhere, because no law imagines it. The Wreckwives would drown Jonah in a barrel of it.

### ◆ A LINK OF FATHER EBB'S CHAIN

Father Ebb, Abbot of the Anchorites, has been chained to the same rock on the Hanging Abbey's cliff for fifty-one years. He has felt the Calling every night of them. He says the chain is not what holds him, and will not say what does. Every decade or so the salt eats through a link, and the brothers replace it, and the old link is given to a pilgrim who has climbed the cliff to ask for it.

A link of Ebb's chain is a ring of black iron as broad as a palm, crusted white with salt, rusted to lace at one side where it parted. It is cold and wet. Worn on a cord, it is heavy. The pilgrims who wear one say they sleep unanchored and are not Called, and the Anchorites do not deny it. But the brothers who climb down to the pilgrims say, gently, that the link only works for those who wear it as Father Ebb wears his chain: as a reminder, not a rope. They will not explain what that means. Pilgrims who misunderstand it are found on the Uncovered, still wearing it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) along the coast.

**SPOILAGE** It rusts away over a decade; in the Abbey's salt rain, a year.

**CARVING** Given at the Hanging Abbey to a pilgrim who climbs the cliff (Lung + Athletics vs Grim 18; a fall is a long one), and asks (Tongue + Rites vs Hard 14). Climbing past a thousand chained monks coughing in unison at dusk is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** none.

**EFFECT** The wearer gains +4 to Calling rolls and to resisting *The West* and *The Water*, but only while they hold to a reason to stay ashore: a living person they would not leave, a vow, a task. The player names it when they first wear the link. If that reason is lost (the person dies or is Called, the vow is broken, the task done), the link gives -4 instead, until a new reason is named at the Abbey. Ebb, asked about this, says that is what holds him.

**WORTH** Never sold by the Anchorites; 100 L from pilgrims who have given up. Scarce. Legal.

### ◆ A DEEPENING LANTERN

Mother Limpet, prophet of the Deepening, has baptized two thousand by walking them into the sea at night. She says she will follow when the last one is safely under. She is eighty-four. On procession nights the road of crushed white shell from Gullcry Strand toward the far water is lit at every post, and the faithful walk

it in lines, singing, with lanterns, and the lanterns go under with them, still lit.

They do not go out. The Deepening's lanterns are made of horn and brass, their wicks soaked in a lamp-oil rendered from the fat of beached fish and blessed on Longslab, and they burn under water. Salvagers find them on the Uncovered, among the leather-weed, still burning, years after their bearers walked in. The flame is blue-green, small and steady. In its light, Brinehollowers feel no fear of the sea at all; they feel welcome. The Netwatch smashes every one it finds. Lieutenant Sable Reef, who has pulled three hundred Called off the shore with hook and rope, keeps one, unlit, in her quarters. She has begun to wonder what she is saving them from.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) on the coast.

**SPOILAGE** A filling of the oil burns for a year, in air or water. Refilled with ordinary oil, it is an ordinary lantern.

**CARVING** Found lit on the Uncovered (Eye + Search vs Hard 14 at night). Taken from a procession walker (Hand + Filch vs Hard 14; they will not resist, and will smile at you, Dread 2). Given by Mother Limpet to a willing pilgrim (no roll).

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Dromm), each night it is lit.

**EFFECT** The lantern burns under water and in any wind, lighting ten paces. Anyone in its light gains +2 to Dread checks caused by the sea, water or the Tenanted, and the Called in a procession are calm and will not resist being roped out of line if the lantern is carried with them (no roll needed to rope one free). But Brinehollowers in its light for a scene must resist *The West* at Hard (14).

**WORTH** 35 L. Uncommon. Netwatch confiscates on sight; possession is "aiding a Calling," a fine of ten tallies.



CHAPTER 12

# LEAVINGS OF THE VIGIL



*Anything that helps you rest is contraband. Anything that keeps you up is currency.  
Everything else is lamp-oil.*

– PINCHMARKET SAYING

THEY SAY A **RELIC** OF THE GOD OF **SLEEP** SHOULD BE  
SOFT. OURS ARE **NEEDLES, BELLS** AND **MIRRORS**.  
THE SOFT ONES WE BURN, AND THE ONES WE **CANNOT** BURN WE  
LOCK IN THE **RATTLEHOUSE**, AND **STILL PEOPLE**  
**QUEUE** AT ITS DOOR.

[ CAPTAIN BRANNOCH PYRE OF THE WAKERS, TESTIMONY TO THE WATCH OF  
WATCHES ]

The Vigil does not trade in relics so much as fight a war against them. Every leaving of Iss is, at bottom, a piece of rest: a softness, a warmth, a stillness, a way of going under and coming back. The law of the Lid makes such things capital crimes, and the Wakers hunt them with rattles and needles, and the Watch of Watches keeps the most dangerous in a sealed tin room under the Rattlehouse that is said to be the only quiet place in the city. And the city wants them more than it wants anything. A people who have not slept in three hundred years will pay a year's wages for a minute's peace. The Tuckers have built a whole criminal economy on that sentence.

So the Vigil's leavings come in two kinds, and the city treats them as opposites. There are the leavings of waking: things that hold the lids up and the eyes open, made from the lidless Eye-lines, from the lamps and the bells, from the Wakers' long needles and the Bitterhouse's black stills. These are sold openly in the Pinchmarket and the city is proud of them. And there are the leavings of the room: pieces of the Dormitory, the Pillow, the Sleepers' Mile, the dream itself, which promise rest and deliver it, and come with a

price written in the long room's ledger. These are sold in the Slope's back lanes, under tin, by people who do not look you in the eye, because looking at someone too long makes them yawn.

Carving here is less a matter of knives than of nerve. Most of the Vigil's leavings must be taken from places where sleep is strongest: from the Dormitory's warm breathing halls, from the soft hollow of the Pillow, from beside the Counted. Every minute spent there adds Weariness. A carver who goes in tired does not come out. The Tuckers carve best, because they are paid to stand beside sleep and not succumb; Dream-Divers carve deepest, because they go into the room itself and are dragged back.

What the Vigil fears most is not a relic's power but its comfort. A leaving that makes the user feel warm, safe or rested is treated by every Vigilant as a loaded crossbow: useful, beautiful, and pointed at the user's own head. Pinchmarket dealers wrap such goods in burr-cloth so that they scratch. Buyers carry them with a pin through the palm.

## ▼ FROM THE EYE-LINES



The Eye-lines ate Iss's eyes, still shut, and their descendants are born lidless and call it purity. A lidless eye must be wetted by hand every half minute, and it sees everything, and forgets nothing. What the Eye-lines shed is the residue of seeing: the tears that run from eyes that cannot close, the brushes that wet them, and, in the families

born with lids, the lids themselves, which shrink and fall away in the Course like burnt pages.

## ◇ A WETTING-BRUSH OF THE WARDEN-PRIME

Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud has not shut her eyes in fifty-eight years. Two attendants brush them wet every half minute, day and night, with fine sable brushes dipped in a cup of warmed salt water. She has seen everything that has happened in front of her since birth, and she can forget none of it. Her brushes wear out in a month. They are burned, by law, in the presence of a Watcher. Her attendants are paid in rouse.

A worn brush is a slim handle of pale bone, carved with an open eye, and a head of black sable gone stiff and grey-tipped with salt. It smells of tears. Its bristles have touched the most watchful eyes on the Table forty thousand times a month, and some of the Warden-Prime's seeing has dried into them. Brushed across the user's own eyes, open, the brush lets them see as Stroud sees: everything, all at once, in perfect order, and keep it. Clerks of the Watch who have tried it say the memory is unbearable after a day. Spies who have tried it say it is worth it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Watch clerks and attendants, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A brush holds its virtue for ten uses, or a month, whichever comes first.

**CARVING** Taken from an attendant before the burning (Tongue + Persuade vs Grim 18, or a great deal of rouse). Taken from the burning itself, in front of a Watcher (Hand + Filch vs Dire 22). A Lack means the Warden-Prime sees you do it. She will remember your face in perfect detail for the rest of her life.

**TAINT 1** Regrowth (Iss).

**EFFECT** For a scene after brushing, the user has perfect recall of everything they see: they may later recall any detail of it exactly (no roll), and gain +2 to Search. For that scene they cannot blink, which means no blink checks, and they gain Weariness 1 at the end of it. A user who brushes three times in a day must make a Dread 2 check from the sheer accumulation of seeing.

**WORTH** 140 L. Scarce. Theft of the Warden-Prime's person; a Rattlehouse matter.

## ◇ A PAIR OF FALLEN LIDS

At the Course, a Vigilant's lids thin, shrink and are gone: first a translucence, then a shrinking, the lids drawing back like a burnt page curling from its edges, and then they fall away, a pair of soft, dry, pinkish crescents, light as moth wings, usually found on a pillow that is not supposed to exist or in the dust of a stair. Eye-line midwives collect them. The Tuckers buy them.

A pair of fallen lids is kept in a twist of oiled silk, and they are faintly warm, and they still twitch, now and then, as though trying to blink. Laid over a person's open eyes and held there with a drop of gum, they close. And the person under them sees darkness for the

first time since they were four years old, and does not fall asleep. Not at once. The lids remember being shut without sleep, a trick no Vigilant body knows. For the length of a held breath, a little longer, a person under them can rest their eyes. Those who have done it describe it as the most beautiful thing that has ever happened to them, and some of them lie, afterward, about how long they kept them on.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Tuckers and midwives, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A season in oiled silk; then they crumble.

**CARVING** Gathered after they fall (Eye + Search vs Hard 14 in an Eye-line house), or bought from a midwife of the Height (Tongue + Haggle vs Grim 18). Peeling them early, before they fall, is a crime and a horror (Hand + Stitching vs Grim 18; Dread 3) and they are useless.

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Iss), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Worn for a count of sixty (once per day), the lids give the Lull's benefit (remove 1d6 Hunger, and also 2 Weariness and 1 Fray) without the blink check at Hard; instead the user makes a blink check at Routine (10). If the user keeps them on past sixty, every further count of ten adds one step to the difficulty, and on a failure they are in the room, and their nudger must fetch them as if they had fallen asleep.

**WORTH** 400 L. Rare. Possession is "equipping for sleep," a capital crime. Old Nod is said to own a drawer of them.

## ◇ LIDLESS TEAR-SALT

The lidless weep constantly, not from grief but because an eye that cannot close must be kept wet, and the body tries. Their attendants catch the tears in little silver cups, and in the Height the tears are dried in the sun of the Bonfires into a fine, sparkling, bitter salt, like crushed glass. It is called tear-salt, and it is the most expensive seasoning on the Table, and the Eye-lines eat it on everything.

Tear-salt keeps the eyes open. A pinch on the tongue is as good as a rouse-tab; a pinch in a cup of rouse makes the rouse hold twice as long; a pinch rubbed into the eye stings like a needle, and the eye stays open, unblinking, for an hour. The Bitterhouse buys it by the pound. The Slope can afford it by the grain, and buys it anyway. In the last decade, as the rouse dose has risen, so has the price of tear-salt, and so has the number of Eye-line attendants found with their own eyes rubbed raw, trying to make more.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in the Vigil; Hard (14) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** Indefinite, kept dry.

**CARVING** Collected from a lidless person over a day (Hand + Craft vs Routine 10 with a silver cup), with their consent or while they are held. Taking it from the unwilling is cruelty the Vigil pretends not to notice (Dread 1).

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Iss), after the third pinch in a day.

**EFFECT** A pinch on the tongue removes 1 Weariness and halts Weariness gains for an hour, without the Addiction roll of rouse; added to a rouse dose, it doubles the dose's duration. Rubbed into

the eyes (1 Flesh), it makes the user immune to blink checks for an hour, and gives -1 to Search from the stinging.

**WORTH** 5 L a pinch; 300 L a pound. Uncommon. Legal and celebrated.

## ▼ FROM THE DORMITORY AND THE ROOM



Sixty thousand beds, numbered, in rows, completely silent. The Counted breathe in time. The leavings of this section are taken from the place everyone in the Vigil fears and longs for most: from the Dormitory's halls, from the long room in the dream, from the Pillow where Iss lay, and from the Sleepers' Mile, where the refugees of 342 lie under the heather. All of them are illegal. All of them make the user sleepy. Every carver who takes them gains Weariness doing it.

### ◇ A BREATH OF THE DORMITORY

The Counted all breathe in time: sixty thousand chests rising and falling together, slow, deep, perhaps four breaths a minute, and the air in the halls moves with them like a tide, a long warm sigh drawn in through the doors, a long warm sigh pushed out. Standing in the center of a hall, a visitor feels it on their face. Orderlies wear wax in their ears and keep their eyes on their boots.

A breath of the Dormitory is caught in a bladder at the exhalation, when the sigh goes out through the doors. It is warm, and it smells of clean linen and skin, the sweetish smell of bodies that do not sweat and do not age, and it is drowsy beyond any drug. Released in a crowded room, it spreads like the smell of bread, and everyone who breathes it yawns, and then everyone who sees them yawning yawns, and the Wakers come running. The Tuckers sell bladders of it to rivals of the Watch. The Bedded release it in the Pinchmarket as a sacrament.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Grim (18) outside the Vigil.

**SPOILAGE** A day in the bladder; then the warmth goes out of it and it is only stale air.

**CARVING** Caught in a hall of the Dormitory at the exhalation (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14 past the orderlies; Hand + Craft vs Routine 10 to catch it). Each minute in a hall adds 1 Weariness; a blink check at Hard every minute after the third. Standing among the breathing rows is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Released, the breath fills a room or a stretch of street twenty paces across. Everyone who breathes it gains 2 Weariness and makes a blink check at Hard (14), whatever their Weariness; foreigners in the Vigil are not spared. It is a Yawn hazard (Dread 1, becoming Dread 3 when someone goes down) for a scene. Outside the Vigil, it makes everyone who breathes it sleepy (-1 to all rolls for an hour) and gives Vigil-born travelers a blink check.

**WORTH** 50 L. Scarce. "Spreading the Yawn" is a capital crime.

### ◇ A SHEET FROM THE RESTLESS ROWS

As of Carving 641, the Matron's private register lists nineteen restless sleepers. Bed One, Aveline Morne, moves her lips. Bed 40,112, Odile Farthing's son, has grown to the size of a man in eleven years, and smiles. Bed 7,730 has turned its head toward the east door. Beds 212 through 219, eight members of one family who lay down together on the First Night, have begun to move as one. The orderlies change their sheets anyway, every Plate, because someone must do something.

The sheets of the restless come away creased in patterns. Not random creases: lines, loops and hatchings, as if the sleeper had been tracing something with their whole body under the linen. Laid flat on the floor of the Matron's office, the creases of beds 212 to 219, put together, make the plan of a room: long, low, with a table in it. The sheets are supposed to be burned. A laundress named Lisbet Coyle has been selling them instead, one at a time, to the Bedded and to the Dream-Divers, who pay well, because wrapped around the head of a waking person, a restless sheet whispers.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** A season, unwashed; washing erases the creases and ends it.

**CARVING** Taken from the Dormitory laundry (Lung + Filch vs Hard 14) or from the bed itself, at the change (Hand + Filch vs Grim 18 under the orderlies' eyes; 1 Weariness per minute in the

hall). Touching a restless sleeper to draw the sheet is a Dread 3 check; their face is happy.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Iss), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Wrapped around the head for a minute, under a nudger's guard, the sheet lets the wearer hear what the restless sleeper's lips are shaping; the GM gives one line, often the answer to a question about the long room, the eye, the number, or the table being laid. The wearer gains 2 Weariness and must make a blink check at Grim (18). Spread flat, a set of sheets from one family shows a map of part of the long room, with a step or two more of it each month.

**WORTH** 220 L. Rare. Desecration of the Counted, and "equipping for sleep."

## ◇ SLEEPERS' MILE MOSS

Below the border stones, along the old Pilgrim Road, lie the refugees of 342 A.G., who fled the plateau to sleep beyond its borders and found that the rule followed them. About four thousand of them are scattered along a mile of road and heather. They still breathe. They are grown over: moss in the hair, lichen on the cheeks, heather pushing up through the rotted rags of their clothes.

The moss that grows in a sleeper's hair is a soft, thick, grey-green cushion, warm as a scalp, and it smells of the sleeper's breath. Rim Road porters at the Last Beds pick it and sell it to Vigilants coming down from the plateau, who chew it like tobacco on the road. It works. A wad of Mile moss, chewed slowly, gives the chewer something like the rest of a night's sleep, without sleeping: the ache behind the eyes eases, the hands steady, and the long heavy pressure on the lids lifts for a day. Chewers report a taste like a pillow. Some report dreaming, awake, of heather and sky. Factor Joss Mallory sells it at the Last Beds with a straight face as "a local herb."

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) on the Pilgrim Road; Grim (18) on the Lid.

**SPOILAGE** A week fresh; a season dried, at half strength.

**CARVING** Picked from a sleeper's hair on the Sleepers' Mile (no roll, but a Dread 2 check: the face under the moss is breathing, and the eyes under the lichen move). A Vigil-born carver on the Mile must make a blink check at Hard (14) for each sleeper picked; the heather is very soft.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Iss).

**EFFECT** A wad chewed removes 4 Weariness and recovers Flesh and Fray as a night of real rest (remove 1 Fray). Once a day. Each wad also makes the next Lull Sop more dangerous: its blink check is one step harder for a day. A chewer who fails three Regrowth Taint rolls from it begins to grow moss in their own hair, which does not wash out.

**WORTH** 6 L a wad at the Last Beds; 30 L on the Lid. Uncommon. Contraband in the Vigil; legal on the Rim.

## ◇ A CHIP OF THE PILLOW

The Pillow is the hollow where Iss lay, at the exact centre of the Lid: a long shallow depression in the bedrock, a quarter mile from end to end, shaped like the impression of something enormous that lay on its side with its knees drawn up. The stone is warm in every season and faintly soft, like a cushion with the stuffing settled. Snow melts there. Yawners who stand at its rim begin to weep.

A chip of the Pillow is a palm-sized flake of grey stone, smooth on one face, warm, and soft: it gives under the thumb as a cushion gives, and slowly springs back. Laid under a head, it makes any surface the softest bed on the Table. Tuckers grind it to powder and dust their sleeping-cellars with it, because a sleeper on Pillow-dust goes down faster and, they claim, comes back easier. Old Nod forbids it. His people use it anyway, and their failure rate has risen, and the extra bodies on the Dormitory steps before the next bell are very relaxed.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Tuckers, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A chip keeps its softness for a year away from the Pillow; then it cools to ordinary stone.

**CARVING** Chiselled from the Pillow (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14 past the Waker cordon; Hand + Craft vs Hard 14 to chisel). Each minute in the hollow adds 1 Weariness and a blink check at Hard; a Lack means the carver lies down, just for a moment. Companions must pull them out (Gut + Labor vs Hard 14) before the next breath.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Iss), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A sleeper resting on the chip, outside the Vigil, recovers twice over: double Flesh from rest and 2 Fray instead of 1. A Vigil-born character resting on it, anywhere, makes the Lull's blink check at Grim (18) instead of Hard. Under a Tucker's guard, a sixty-second sleep on the chip counts as a full night's rest, if the Tucker can fetch them back (Hand + Stitching vs Grim 18).

**WORTH** 350 L. Rare. Desecration of the Pillow and "equipping for sleep."

## ◇ SENNA VOLE'S TETHER

Senna Vole has made forty dives into the room, where three is the usual career. She has mapped the long room to within thirty paces of the eye. On her last dive, something behind the lid said her name. Divers lie down at the Tether Hall in harness, wired at the wrists, ankles and throat to a great brass winch and a team of eight hauliers, and when the bell is struck the hauliers drag them back. Vole's tether, the braided wire-and-silk cord she used for her last twenty dives, was retired after the fortieth. It had gone taut in a way no tether ever had, toward the eye.

It hangs in the Tether Hall's records-room, coiled, and it does not lie still. Every quarter hour, at the bell, the coil tightens and pulls, gently, toward the south end of the room, the way the eye in the

dream faces. Divers touch it for luck before going under. A Diver who wore it once since then, against orders, came back on the bell with no trouble at all, faster than any haul, and told the hauliers she had not needed them. She said the tether had brought her back. She said someone on the other end had let her go.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Dream-Divers, Routine (10).

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil.

**CARVING** Taken from the Tether Hall records-room (Lung + Stealth vs Grim 18), or given by Senna Vole to someone she trusts

(Tongue + Persuade vs Dire 22). Handling it is a Dread 2 check: it pulls.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Iss), Dread 2, per dive.

**EFFECT** A diver (or any sleeper) bound in the tether returns from the room when the bell is struck, automatically, without hauliers. Each dive, the diver may ask the GM one question about the long room, and on a Grace, about the eye. But each dive, roll a d6: on a 1, something on the other end of the tether has said the diver's name, and the GM gains a Regrowth point to spend on the diver at a moment of their choosing.

**WORTH** Never sold. Unique. The Watch of Watches would seize it if they knew how often it is borrowed.

## ▼ FROM THE LAMPS AND THE BELLS



The Vigil keeps itself awake with light and noise: ten thousand public lamps, a hundred thousand more in its houses, mirrors on every roof, Bonfires in the squares, bells every quarter hour, tin roofs that clatter in the rain. Three centuries of this have soaked into the instruments themselves. The city's lamps, bells and clocks are not godflesh, strictly. But they have stood against the god every minute of every day for three hundred years, and some of them have taken on its shape the way a dam takes the shape of the water.

### ◇ A ROW MIRROR

Lampwrights' Row is the brightest street in the world, lit from above and below and every side at once by mirrors on every roof, so that a walker there casts no shadow. The oldest mirrors were silvered in 343, the year after the First Night, and have not reflected darkness since. Each was turned toward a lamp the day it was hung, and has never been turned away.

When one cracks, its shards are prized. A Row-mirror shard is a jagged piece of old glass, its silvering gone grey and leprous at the edges, and it holds light. Carried into a dark room, it glows faintly with the reflected glare of the Row, as if it remembered three hundred years of lamps and could not stop showing them. It throws no shadow, and lets nothing near it cast one. People who look into it see their own faces lit from every side, harshly, unflatteringly, and cannot look away, and cannot blink.

Garron Ashlock, Lamplighter-General, has ninety days of oil. He has begun buying up Row shards. He has not said why.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in the Vigil; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** A shard keeps its light for a year in darkness, then must be returned to a lit street for a day to drink.

**CARVING** Collected when a Row mirror cracks (Eye + Search vs Hard 14 to be first), or broken deliberately (a Guild offense, flogging). Prising one from a rooftop is Lung + Athletics vs Hard 14.

**TAINT** none.

**EFFECT** The shard removes darkness penalties within five paces and prevents any shadow within that radius, defeating Stealth that depends on darkness. A person made to look into it (Tongue + Intimidate vs their Caul + Resolve, or simply held) cannot blink, Lull or sleep for a scene, and takes 1 Fray from the glare. In Sallowreach, the shard stays lit inside a Hush, and the Kept turn their faces from it.

**WORTH** 90 L. Scarce. Guild property; theft is prosecuted when the Guild notices.

### ◇ A QUARTER-BELL TONGUE

The city's bells sound every quarter hour to keep it awake, and they deafened Thaddeus Knell, the chief bell-ringer, years ago. He rings by the clock and by the shaking in his teeth. Every few decades a clapper cracks, from three hundred years of quarter hours, and is replaced. The old tongues are given to the Wakers. Captain Pyre keeps one on his desk.

A bell-tongue is an iron clapper the length of a forearm, pear-shaped, its striking face worn to a bright dent, and it is never still. Held in the hand, it hums. Struck against any surface, even a wooden table, it rings with the voice of the bell it came from, loud, cold and vast, and the sound goes into the teeth. It wakes anyone. It



wakes people from the edge of the room, from a blink in progress, from a Tucker's minute that has gone a breath too long. It does not wake the Counted. Thaddeus Knell has tried, in Bed One's hall, at night, with the clapper of the Great Quarter. Bed One's lips stopped moving for exactly one minute.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Wakers and Knell's ringers, Routine (10).

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil.

**CARVING** Bought from a Waker (Tongue + Haggle vs Hard 14), or taken from a bell-tower when a clapper is replaced (Lung + Athletics vs Hard 14 to climb).

**TAINT** none. Each use costs the striker 1 Flesh if they do not stop their ears.

**EFFECT** Struck (an action), the tongue removes 3 Weariness from everyone within twenty paces, ends any blink in progress, and gives a nudger's fetch for a sleeper in the room an automatic success. Anyone using Lay Them Down or a Catching Yawn within earshot fails. In any land, it ends any sleep, trance, Seeming or enchantment of drowsiness within earshot. It cannot be used stealthily. Restless sleepers within earshot stop moving for one minute.

**WORTH** 220 L. Scarce. Legal in Waker hands; illegal to sell, and sold.

## ◇ A HANK OF PENDULUM WIRE

In the Pendulum Hall, from the top of the tower to the cellar, hangs a single pendulum, a great iron bob on a rope of twisted wire, swinging through a slow arc that once took exactly four seconds. Maud Sexton, the Hourkeeper, has proved by that pendulum that each hour is a little longer than the last. Something is stretching the night that the Vigil will not admit it is having. Every decade the wire is replaced, because it stretches too.

Old pendulum wire is a coil of twisted iron strands, oiled, and longer than it was when it was hung: measured coils come back from the Hall a span longer than they went in. Wound around a wrist, it ticks against the pulse, slow, much slower than the heart. Those who wear it feel time thicken around them. A second becomes a long second. A breath becomes room enough to think in. Clerks of the Watch wear it to finish their shifts. Wakers wear it in fights. Maud Sexton will not have it in her house.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil. It does, slowly, keep stretching.

**CARVING** Taken from the Pendulum Hall's stores when the wire is replaced (Lung + Filch vs Hard 14). Standing inside the humming

tower too long is a blink check at Hard each scene.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Iss), each time its power is called.

**EFFECT** Once per scene, the wearer may stretch a moment: take one extra action before anyone else can respond, or reroll one failed Lung or Hand roll. Each use adds 1 Weariness, because the stretched moment had to be stayed awake through. Once per day, the wearer may instead stretch an hour, and do an hour's work in what others see as a minute; this adds 3 Weariness and ages the wearer's face visibly by a month.

**WORTH** 160 L a hank. Scarce. Theft from the Pendulum Hall.

## ◇ LUKAS MARRE'S MUZZLE

Lukas Marre's yawns are catching beyond all reason; he once put down a whole market square. He lives in the Glass House, masked, alone, and apologizes through the pane to everyone who visits. The yawners there wear stiff leather muzzles that hold the jaw half closed. Marre's wear out faster than anyone's, because he fights them, and because the leather soaks up the yawn.

A Marre muzzle is a harness of boiled leather and brass, with a padded chin-cup, stained dark on the inside, and it smells of him: of sleep-breath and saliva and the warm milky smell of a yawn. Strapped on someone else, it gives them his gift. The wearer cannot yawn, quite. The yawn builds behind the leather and goes out of them through the eyes, and everyone who sees their face catches it. Tuckers have used them to empty a street of Wakers. Assassins have used them to make a whole household blink at once. Marre does not know. He thinks the Glass House burns his old ones.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Glass House keepers, Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** A muzzle holds its yawn for a season after he last wore it.

**CARVING** Taken from the Glass House's refuse (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14). Visiting Marre to take one from him is a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) through the speaking-tube, or gain 2 Weariness.

**TAINT** Dread 1, to the wearer (they can feel what they are doing).

**EFFECT** Worn, the muzzle makes the wearer a Glass House yawner: once per scene, everyone who can see their face must make a Caul + Resolve roll vs Hard (14) or gain 2 Weariness and make a blink check. The wearer also gains 1 Weariness per scene. Outside the Vigil, the yawn still spreads, and Vigil-born travelers in sight must make blink checks.

**WORTH** 180 L. Rare. Spreading the Yawn; capital.

# ▼ PREPARATIONS OF THE PINCHMARKET



The Pinchmarket has been open every hour of every watch for three hundred years. What it sells best is what the Vigil makes best: the tools and drugs of staying awake, and their black-market opposites. These are the city's crafted leavings: needles, stimulants, sandglasses, bread, and one thing from Inspector Grimmer's evidence room that ought never to have left it.

## ◇ AN ATLAS NEEDLE

Sister Agathe Pinch, Mistress of the Needle and author of the current edition of the Atlas of the Quick, has trained every Waker alive. She is tiny, bright-eyed and grandmotherly, with a lap-tray of needles laid out like embroidery tools. She believes that pain is a teacher, and that Wakers must learn it first on their own bodies. Her needles are steel, as long as a hand, fine as hair at the tip, and each has been used on a hundred recruits in the standing-stalls. She retires one each year, with a little ceremony, and gives it to the recruit who screamed least.

An Atlas needle finds the Quick. That is the Wakers' word for the place in a body where pain lives closest to the surface and does least harm: a point behind the ear, under a nail, at the hinge of a jaw. An Atlas needle in any hand goes there on its own, as a dowsing rod goes to water. It wakes the dead-tired as nothing else can, and it makes a liar's eyes water, and it never leaves a mark. Sister Pinch's former students treasure theirs. Jack Tenterhook, the wake-valet, has three, and says the only difference between his old work and his new is the tipping.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Wakers, Routine (10).

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil.

**CARVING** Given by Sister Pinch to a recruit after a week in the standing-stall (Gut + Endure vs Grim 18 for the week; 4 Fray), or bought from a Waker down on their luck (Tongue + Haggle vs Hard 14).

**TAINT** Dread 1, to the user, the first time each day.

**EFFECT** A prick (an action, or a hit on a grappled target) removes 3 Weariness and ends a blink or falling-asleep, as a Waker's needle succeeding automatically, and costs no Flesh. In questioning, the needle gives +2 to Intimidate, and a target who has been pricked suffers -2 to Deceive for the scene. As a weapon it deals 1 damage, ignoring Armor.

**WORTH** 70 L. Uncommon. Legal for Wakers; anyone else carrying one is presumed to be a Waker, which on the Slope is dangerous.

## ◇ CRANE'S STRAIN ELEVEN

Dr. Aldous Crane, Apothecary-General, invented the current strain of rouse. He knows the dose curve and where it ends: there is a point at which the amount needed to stay awake is the amount that stops the heart. It is eleven years off. In his private laboratory in the Bitterhouse he has been working on what comes after. He calls it Strain Eleven, after the years. He has not slept, of course, but he has not rested either.

Strain Eleven is a black lozenge the size of a thumbnail, stamped with an open eye and a small numeral, glossy, bitter beyond bitter, and it holds. One dose keeps a Vigilant awake for a full day, clear and sharp, with no rising pressure on the lids at all. It is what the city has been praying for. It is also, by Crane's own notes, the dose at the end of the curve, taken now. Each lozenge brings the heart a year closer to the place where it stops. Four have gone missing from Crane's laboratory. Crane has noticed, and has not reported it, because he would have to explain what they are.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); Bitterhouse chemists, Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** A year sealed in wax.

**CARVING** Stolen from Crane's private laboratory (Lung + Stealth vs Grim 18; Eye + Search vs Hard 14 to find the box). Brewing more requires his notes (Eye + Craft vs Dire 22 and the Bitterhouse stills). Reading the notes is a Dread 2 check.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Iss). Addiction: Dire (22).

**EFFECT** A lozenge removes all Weariness above the user's floor and holds it there for a full day; no blink checks, no Seeming. The user gains +1 Eye for the day. Then they roll Gut + Endure vs Grim (18); on a failure they suffer a rouse-heart (Ruin), and each lozenge taken permanently reduces their maximum Flesh by 1. The user does not feel the damage until it is done.

**WORTH** Never sold; 1,000 L if it were. Unique (four doses at large). The Watch of Watches would end Crane for it, and then demand the recipe.

## ◇ MORNE'S LOAF

Aveline Morne, the Sleeper in Bed One, was a baker's daughter who lay down on the First Night and was the first not to rise. Three hundred years unmoving. Last month her lips began to shape words, and the Matron has started writing them down (see Bed One's Words, in the Rim Market). Most of it is a recipe for bread.

Somebody has copied the recipe out. It has gone round the Slope on scraps of paper, and the Bedded bake it in their hidden cellars, and it is very good bread: a soft, round, pale loaf with a split top and a crumb as fine as a pillow, made with milk and honey and something unusual, a pinch of salt from the bottom of the oven and a slow rising in a warm place for longer than any baker in the Vigil would dare leave dough. It smells of a kitchen at dawn three hundred years ago. Those who eat it say it tastes of being a child, put to bed, in a house with the lamps turned down. And the Bedded say that every loaf baked from it is laid on a table in the long room, at the far end, under the eye, and that someone is setting places.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) on the Slope; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** Three days, like any good bread. Stale, it is only bread.

**CARVING** Baked from a copy of the recipe (Eye + Craft vs Hard 14 and an oven held warm for a night, which in the Vigil is suspicious). The recipe is had from the Bedded (Tongue + Persuade vs Hard 14) or copied from the Matron's notebook.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Iss), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A slice eaten removes 1d6 Fray and 1d6 Hunger, as the gentlest of vices, without risk of habit. Then the eater gains 3 Weariness, and must resist the Want *To lie down* at Hard (14) for the rest of the scene, whatever their land. A Vigilant who eats a whole loaf alone, the Bedded say, dreams the long room without sleeping, for a breath, and sees the table. Outside the Vigil, the bread is merely the best bread the eater has ever had, and they will think about it for years.

**WORTH** 2 L a loaf on the Slope. Uncommon. Baking it is "Bedded practice," punished by a season in the Rattlehouse.

## ◇ OLD NOD'S MINUTE-GLASS

Old Nod, King of the Tuckers, sells one minute of guarded sleep for a month's wage, and people queue around the block. He has never tried his own product. He says a man should not get high on his own supply. His Tuckers time the minute with sandglasses, and the best of these are Nod's own: small glasses of greenish Glass House glass in frames of black wood, filled not with sand but with grains of ground Dormitory brick.

A minute-glass runs for exactly sixty breaths of the Counted, which is a little more than a minute and a little less than enough. While it runs, a sleeper under its watch is held: not in the room, quite, but on its threshold, in the doorway, with the warmth on their face and the floor soft underfoot. When the last grain falls, the sleeper is pulled back. Mostly. Old Nod's glasses have a failure rate of one in sixty, which is the best on the Lid, and the failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps before the next bell. Every Tucker knows the number. Nobody knows which minute it is.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) among Tuckers; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** The glass lasts until broken. Each failure leaves a grain stuck to the glass, and after sixty, it never empties.

**CARVING** Bought from a Tucker (Tongue + Haggles vs Grim 18; they do not sell their glasses), or taken from one by force (they are armed and not sentimental). Old Nod gives a glass only to a successor.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Iss), to the sleeper.

**EFFECT** A character who sleeps for one turn of the glass, under another's watch, gains a full night's rest: remove 1 Fray, recover Flesh as for rest, and reset Weariness to its floor. When the glass empties, roll a d20: on a 1, the sleeper does not come back, and is Counted. A nudger's fetch may still be tried at Grim (18) in the next breath. A Lack on the fetch delivers the sleeper's number to the watcher, in their own hand, on a scrap of paper found later in their pocket.

**WORTH** 400 L. Rare. "Equipping for sleep," capital; the Tuckers are already capital.

## ◇ EVIDENCE FORTY

Inspector Hale Grimmer investigates blink-murders: killings done by ordinary people during a two-second sleep, with no memory after. A cook, a nudger, a clerk blinks mid-sentence and comes back holding a knife they did not pick up, standing behind a stranger, and the stranger is open from hip to collarbone in one perfectly straight line. Grimmer has forty cases. The method is the same in each. So, he has lately realized, is the knife.

Grimmer's own forty-one cases are smotherings, but the watch-houses of the city have sent him, over the years, every *other* blink-killing nobody could explain: the ones done with a knife the killer did not own: a kitchen knife, a quill-knife, a cobbler's blade, a nudger's paring knife. Grimmer keeps those knives in his evidence room, beside the drawer of the opened ones, numbered one to forty, and last month, laying them out on a bench, he saw that all forty have the same nick on the edge, a hair's breadth from the tip, in the same place. Different knives. The same nick. He has told no one. Evidence Forty, the most recent, a short bone-handled kitchen knife, has since gone missing from the bench. Grimmer suspects a constable. The constable suspects he took it himself, during a blink.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22). Grimmer's constables, Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** It does not spoil. It is not always where it was left.

**CARVING** Stolen from the Inspector's evidence room (Lung + Filch vs Hard 14), or found in the hand of the next blink-killer, which means being near a murder (Dread 2).

**TAINT** Dread 3, the first time each day it is held.

**EFFECT** In the hand of a character who blinks, the knife cuts the Line: the GM may, on any blink result of 8 or 10, have the bearer's hands make a single attack with it at +10, and on two Helpings the



target suffers Ruin, opened. The bearer has no say. Held deliberately in a fight by someone awake, it is only a knife (2 damage), but with a Grace it leaves the nick in the target's bone, and the GM notes that whatever moves the blink-killers now knows them.

**WORTH** Never sold; nobody who understands it would buy it. Unique. Theft of evidence; Grimmer would pay anything to have it back, and then would not know what to do with it.



CHAPTER 13

# LEAVINGS OF CRADLEWRACK

*Keep it in grey stone. Keep it knotted. Knock before you lift the lid. And if it is warmer in the morning than when you laid it down, it was never yours to keep.*

– CHALKED INSIDE THE LID OF A RELIC-CHEST SOLD UNDER THE NAMING-EXCHANGE, KEST

## EVERYWHERE ELSE ON THE TABLE A RELIC ROTS. IN THE HIGHLANDS IT RIPENS.

[ FACTOR MERRIAM TOLL OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY, IN A LETTER TO QUILLHOUSE ]

Other lands carve their relics out of the god. Cradlewrack does not need to. The god delivers them. Every week the Tally records something the Attendance must enter and cannot explain: a Part, a key with wards no smith cut, a warm stone with a pulse, a scrap of membrane from the Morwen nurseries, a length of living cord, a green bottle with a breath in it, a bundle tied in the knot that does not come undone. The highlands are the only country on the Table where leavings are born rather than taken, and highlanders speak of them the way they speak of lambing: flatly, practically, and with one eye on the door.

The law is plain and universally ignored. Under the Book of Questions, anything that comes into the world in Cradlewrack is a birth, and every birth belongs first to the Attendant who asked the Two Questions over it. A relic kept without an Attendant's word is therefore *concealment*, and is punished by unhinging. In practice the trade runs in the low cellars under the Kest naming-exchange, where naming-rights are bought by the hour above and leavings are sold by the ounce below, by people who knock on the trapdoor before they lift it. A right to name a hand is worth nothing on the exchange floor. The hand itself, in the cellar, is worth a month's bread to the Assemblers and a season's to a Rim buyer. The Company's factor at Breech's Gate takes cauls by the crate for Brinehollow. The Second Table pays for roofs and asks for first refusal on anything with a voice.

What highlanders fear in a leaving is not rot. Nothing of Vey's goes bad. It goes *somewhere*. A thing of the god's kept too long in the dark will open, or bear, or begin, or crawl to the edge of the shelf nearest another of its kind. Highland keepers do not ask how long a relic will last. They ask how long before it leaves. The answer, for most, is a pang or two, and the remedies are the country's three old certainties: knot it, brick it, or keep it in grey stone. The Barren Order teaches that the grey granite carted from the Fast border is the one material in the highlands that has never borne anything, and a grey-stone relic box, the size of a loaf, costs 60 lacks in Kest. It is the commonest dowry gift among the cautious, and the commonest thing found open and empty in a widow's cellar.

Abroad, the leavings of Vey behave as the country's pregnant daughters do: they take the highlands with them. Petra Quick learned it with women, and the Rim has learned it with relics.

### RULES – HIGHLAND LEAVINGS ABROAD

A leaving of Vey (any relic in this chapter with Regrowth Taint of Vey) carried out of Cradlewrack keeps the country's calendar. On each pang, wherever the relic is on the Table, roll a d10. On a 1, every door, lid and knot within a stone's throw of it opens during the night, and the ground beneath it is warm, red and faintly wet until dawn. On a double pang (the GM's call, when the interval closes again), it is a 1–3. Grey stone, bricking and the Attendance knot each prevent the roll while they hold.

## ▼ FROM THE VEILED HOUSES



The Caul-lines carry almost continuously, and the nurses of the great houses take away what they deliver before anyone can ask what

it was. Morwen Hall has a room for it with no door on the lower side, entered from above by ladder, where the deliveries are entered

in a household tally kept separate from the public one. The houses do not sell what they bear. Their nurses, their valets and their bricklayers do, and the Veiled Council has spent three centuries pretending this is not where half the cellar trade under the naming-exchange begins. Leavings of the veiled are the finest the highlands produce: the god in them is thick, kept close by three hundred years of keeping the veil, and they are prophetic in the way the houses themselves are prophetic, which is to say vaguely, redly, and lately all in agreement.

## ◇ RED WEEP

Beneath the veil of a Caul-line noble deep in the Course, where the membrane lies against the cheek, a fluid gathers. For most of the houses' history it was clear and faintly salt, and the nurses wiped it away and burned the linen. Since the Duchess Iphigene's veil went red, the weep under every high veil in the country has turned: rose, then watered wine, then red. It beads at the hem and drips, one drop to the slow count of sixty, like a pang. The Morwen nurses catch it now in silver thimbles. The household has found that it sells.

It is warm, and tastes of iron and the inside of a cheek. Whoever drinks it dreams the next day through a red film, as the veiled see it. A Morwen valet sold it at Knocking Gate to merchants who wanted tomorrow's prices, until in 640 a Fatlands drover drank three drops together and in the morning walked out of the Open Door and north across the moor without his cattle, telling the wardens he had seen a door in the ground with someone standing in it, arms spread, and that it was him, and that he was late. Neither has been seen since.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Cradlewrack, Grim (18) elsewhere. Caul-line servants know of it.

**SPOILAGE** One pang. After the next, the weep grows a skin that will not lift; after the second, a small wet veil around nothing, and the thimble must be bricked. A sealed grey-stone phial in a cold spring-cellar keeps it a season.

**CARVING** It is caught, not cut: a silver thimble and an hour under the hem of a Caul-line in the Course (Regrowth 7+) while they sleep or prophesy. With a nurse's connivance, Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14); stolen, Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18). A Lack means the veil parts and the carver sees the face beneath: Dread 3, and the noble will know them through any veil, forever.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** One drop at dusk. Once the next day, before a roll of the player's choosing, the GM must name one thing about to begin in the scene (an ambush, a lie, a door opening) and the character gains +4 on that roll or acts first that round. A thimble holds three drops. More than one in a night gives, on a d6 roll of 1–3, the Duchess's vision of the opening ground instead, with the drinker standing in it: Dread 3.

**WORTH** 90 lacks the thimble in the Kest cellars, 250 on the Rim. Scarce in Cradlewrack, Rare elsewhere. Concealment; theft from a house is lockbreaking. The Veiled Council has begun buying it back.

## ◇ A BORN KEY

Among the things the Course delivers, the Attendance's records list keys. They come mostly from Caul-line nobles, after a carrying of days, small and wet and already finished: the length of a finger, dark as old horn, warm, with a bow shaped like a closed eye and wards no locksmith in Kest has ever filed. They are not iron. They are faintly flexible, like gristle, and turn in a lock with a sound like a tongue clicking on a palate. The Tally enters them as "one, key, living?" and the question mark has never been removed.

Every born key fits every lock. The harder lesson is that every born key is born *for* one door, somewhere, and knows which, and grows heavier as it nears it. A tinker named Abel Clayhand carried one for eleven years and said it never once felt like home. In 629 he walked north to the Sill with it in his fist. Old Hinge says Clayhand stood before the standing door all night, and at dawn was gone, and the key lay warm in the grass below the threshold, and Hinge put it back where he found it. Old Hinge says a great many things.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14). A Filch roll vs Grim (18) in any thieves' den on the western Rim finds someone who has used one.

**SPOILAGE** It does not decay. Each pang, unless knotted in Uncut cord or kept in grey stone, it opens one lock, lid or knot near it of its own accord, usually the one its keeper least wants opened.

**CARVING** Taken at delivery, or from the wool-lined nursery drawer where the great houses keep them in rows, faintly stirring. Witnessing a key born is Dread 2. Robbing a Morwen drawer is Hand + Filch vs Grim (18); a Lack means the drawer's other keys have already opened every door between the thief and the way out.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Vey).

**EFFECT** Once per day the key opens any lock, bar, latch, seal or knot with no roll, in any land. Bricking resists it (Caul + Godsign vs Grim 18 to open a bricked way). Each use, roll a d6: on a 1 the key has learned that lock, and that lock will never hold again. The GM secretly chooses the key's own door. Within a mile of it, the key weighs as much as a man's arm; at the door it turns by itself, and whatever is behind that door knows its keeper by name.

**WORTH** 400 lacks. Rare. Sold under the naming-exchange, by Petra Quick on the road, and by Mister Cutlery, who will not say what door he thinks his is for. Concealment of a birth; in the Vigil and Oathen, possession of a housebreaker's tool.

## ◇ THE LITTLE BONE DOOR

In the Lying-In's book, under a date in 509 A.G., there is an entry the Attendance teaches every Senior of the Lying as the reason a second book is kept at all: *one, door, of bone, hinged; opened onto nothing; stays*. A Calloway lord in the Course delivered it after nine days' carrying: the size of a playing card, yellow-white, frame and leaf and threshold of one piece, on a hinge of living gristle, with a knocker the size of a barleycorn. Opened, it showed not the palm it lay on but a dark beyond, and warm air came through it, smelling of candles.

The Lying-In kept it bricked for a hundred and eighteen years. In 627 a bricklayer in the last month of his term walked out with it under his apron. It is now, the Attendance believes, with Dr. Lazar Voss, who wants to press it against the Assemblers' figure and look inside. It is no longer the size of a card. It is the size of a hand, and Voss's monthly measurements show it growing at the rate of the pangs.

Most who look through it see what they hoped to. Some see a long room, warm and dim, with a table laid and a great many chairs, one pulled out, and hear someone moving around it, unhurried, laying cutlery.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); automatic for a Senior of the Lying, who will deny it.

**SPOILAGE** None. It grows. When it is the size of a door, the Attendance believes it will no longer need a wall to open in.

**CARVING** Unique; it can only be stolen or bargained for. Voss keeps it in a lead case under a pillow he does not use. Holding it the first time is Dread 3: it is warm, the hinge has a pulse, and the knocker taps once against the palm.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Laid against a wall, floor, door, lid or body and opened, it lets the holder see and hear the far side as through an open doorway. Against a living body it shows the inside (+4 to Stitching to diagnose or cut; the subject feels a cold draught and takes a Dread 2 check). Each opening, roll a d10. On a 1 the view is the long warm room: Dread 4, and Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14) to close it. On a failure, something on the other side begins, kindly, to describe the view, and will do so every night until the holder comes and sees.

**WORTH** Never sold. Voss paid 3,000 lacks to the bricklayer's widow. The Assemblers would pay double, and the Second Table has asked whether it can be made to open from the other side.

## ◇ A SECOND-MEAL CROCK

At a highland naming, a year after the birth, the family eats the afterbirth, kept salted in a crock and stewed with lamb and onions: the Second Meal, in memory of the first. When a child is *returned* in its first year, taken back for a late Second Opinion, there is no naming and no Meal, and the crock should go to the Stillyard with the bundle. Many families cannot bear to send it. They keep it on a high shelf, knotted shut, and do not look at it.

What is kept in a returned child's crock does not cure. It stays deep red and glossy, and it grows: half full at the returning, it is pushing up its lid in five years, warm, smelling of iron and milk. A spoonful, eaten, begins again whatever in the eater's body has stopped. Lost parts grow back *new*. A Foundling captain who lost his left hand at Breech's Gate ate from a widow's crock in Cleave and woke nine days later with a newborn's hand at the end of his wrist, pink, creased, flexing. Over two years it grew into a woman's hand, slender, with a callus on the ring finger no work of his had made. It strains east at night. He sleeps with it tied to the bedpost.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Cradlewrack; any surgeon of the Reopening Ward knows the captain.

**SPOILAGE** None, if salted and knotted. Left unopened more than a year, the crock bears, and what climbs out is a Wandering Part.

**CARVING** Taken from a grieving household by persuasion (Tongue + Persuade vs Grim 18, and Dread 2 on hearing why they kept it) or theft (Hand + Filch vs Hard 14). Knock before opening. A Lack means the contents have begun: something the size of a fist lifts its head out of the salt (Dread 3).

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Vey), 1 Hunger, Dread 2.

**EFFECT** A spoonful, kept down with Gut + Feast vs Hard (14). Within nine days one lost part (finger, hand, eye, ear, teeth, foot) or one permanent Injury from the Mangling table begins to grow back, newborn-sized, reaching full size over a year (-2 on rolls using it until then). The new part is in law and fact a Part: each pang, roll a d10, and on a 1 the character wakes with it straining toward the Assemblers' Barn. A crock holds 1d6 + 2 spoonfuls. A second spoonful grows the same part again, beside the first.

**WORTH** 150 lacks a spoonful under the exchange, 600 the crock. Scarce. Concealment and desecration of the Meal. Fatlands buyers pay double, believing it will fill them. It does not, but it begins something in the stomach that keeps them company.

## ▼ FROM THE ATTENDANCE



The Attendance is the only government on the Table that kills in an apron, and it leaves very little behind. What it uses, it keeps; what it cannot keep, it bricks. Its leavings come out into the world by three doors only: the apprentices who quit after their first Second Opinion and do not give back their kits, the bricklayers of the Lying-In who serve one year at triple pay and are watched the whole time, and the Opinions themselves, a very few, who keep something of what they did because they could not leave it in a wall. The midwives' leavings are not pieces of a god. They are tools that have done the god's work so long they have learned it, and every one of them was last held by a woman who had just answered the Second Question and would remember it.

### ◇ A RETIRED SECOND OPINION

By the Book of Questions, an Opinion's knife is retired at its thousandth answer, counted in notches inside the knife-case where no one else will look. Retired knives are bricked into the Knife Course, a band of masonry around the inside of the Old Lying-In's wall at the height of a woman's hand, where four centuries of them lie end to end and midwives trail their fingers along it the way others touch wood. Most knives go into the Course. Not all.

They are plain: a short blade of highland steel, a ewe-horn handle worn to the shape of one thumb, a smell of lye. The edge never dulls on anything born. Held over something new, the handle grows warm at the slow count of three and stays warm until the holder decides. Clemency Seele of Rudge kept hers when she retired in 590 and carved the Sunday lamb with it for forty years, and said she always knew, by the warmth, which lamb was going to be difficult. Her grandson inherited it. He was found at nineteen standing over his sister's cradle with the knife in his hand, counting, and could not say what he had meant to decide.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14). Every Attendant knows the custom; only an Opinion knows how often it is broken.

**SPOILAGE** None in Cradlewrack. Abroad, rust blooms on the blade within a season in shapes like small palms; oiling it with spring-salt each pang prevents this.

**CARVING** From the Knife Course: Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22) to pass the night Attendants, and Hand + Labor vs Hard (14) to unbrick a knife quietly. From a retired Opinion: never given, sometimes inherited, occasionally taken from her body. Gripping it the first time is Dread 2: the count of three, a thousand times over, in the palm.

**TAINT** Dread 2; and 1 Regrowth (Vey) each scene it is used against a thing of Vey's.

**EFFECT** A knife (2, Silent). Against anything born in Cradlewrack that the Book of Questions would not let stay (Parts, a Gathered, Doorborn, the Refused, the get of a crowning, Fenn's Get), it ignores Armor and each Helping adds +3 damage. Once per scene the wielder may ask the First Question aloud of such a creature: it

must hold still for one round unless it beats Caul + Resolve vs Grim (18). The knife carries a Want: **Go into the Room** (Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 on learning of a birth within a mile, or go, and stay to the end).

**WORTH** 800 lacks. Rare. The Refused pay a fortune to have them destroyed, and have been known to pay one to have one. Possession by a non-Attendant is unhinging; use of one is bricking.

### ◇ THE KNOT THAT WILL NOT COME UNDONE

Every knot in Cradlewrack slips. Laces loosen by morning and clothes are retied at every bell. One knot holds. The bundle an Opinion carries out of the room after the Second Question is tied with the cord of the birth itself, wet, in a knot taught only at the rank of Opinion: small, ugly, many-turned, like a fist of string. It has never been known to come undone. The bundle goes into the Stillyard's Low Wall without a family mark, entered as "struck through," and the knot goes with it.

A length of that cord, cut free with the knot left whole, will hold anything it is tied around, forever. Doorborn fingers, born keys and the land itself cannot open it. In a country where nothing stays shut, it is the only shut thing there is. A lockbreaker named Tobin Furrow sold eleven to rich houses in Kest in 636, and their owners slept, for the first time in their lives, behind doors that did not drift. Furrow was found the next spring bricked into a Low Wall niche, alive, with a knot tied through the bones of his wrists. The Attendance has never said it was them.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). Every highlander knows the knot exists; few will say what it is tied around.

**SPOILAGE** While tied around something, none. Cut free, it must be tied onto something within one pang, or it remembers it is only cord, and slips.

**CARVING** Unbricking a Low Wall niche at night without a sound is Hand + Labor vs Hard (14); seeing the bundle is Dread 3. Cutting the cord above the knot without loosening a turn is Hand + Stitching vs Grim (18). A Lack means the bundle knocks.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Tied around or between anything (a door and its frame, two wrists, a lid, a Part, a wound), it cannot be untied by any means, mundane or godsign, and no pang loosens it. It must be cut (Hand + Blades vs Grim 18), and is then spent. A door so tied is the one door in Cradlewrack that holds past a pang. A wound so tied will never reopen; neither will anything else on that limb, including the hand.

**WORTH** 300 lacks. Scarce under the exchange, Rare abroad. Agnes Latch will not touch one. Lockbreaking and desecration; the penalty is bricking, and the Low Wall is long.



## ◇ HOLLAN KEST'S THUMBNAILS

On the night of the Meal, at dawn, when the floor of the old birthing-house was a drift of gods the size of hares and mice and fingernails, all still trying to begin, the last of them was no larger than a barleycorn, and the midwife Hollan Kest knelt and crushed it between her thumbnails, and wept, and said, "There. Now nothing begins." She was the founder of every line of Midwife-Paramount since. When she died in her ninety-first year, her thumbnails were drawn and set in a reliquary of horn and gold on the altar of the Old Lying-In, two curved yellow shields the size of a child's fingernail, one in each half of a hinged box.

They have never stopped trying to close on each other. With the reliquary open, they creep together across the velvet over an hour, edge first, like crab claws, and must be parted with a pin. A Kest rumour holds that the reliquary was robbed in 638 and the nails replaced with goat's horn. The Attendance has denied it, which in Kest is taken as confirmation.

**WHISPERED** Every highlander knows the story. That the nails survive: Eye + Lore vs Hard (14). Where they are now: Dire (22).

**SPOILAGE** None, kept apart. Left in one box they close, and closed they cannot be parted without breaking, and broken they are only nail.

**CARVING** Unique. The Old Lying-In's doors have stood open since the Meal; leaving unseen is Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22). Touching them the first time is Dread 3: they are warm, and smell of something very small that has been crushed.

**TAINT 4** Regrowth (Vey), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Pressed together upon something small that is beginning, they end it. Once per day, with no roll, the holder may end one of: a birth in its first hour; a Part smaller than a hand; a wound in the act of reopening; a Doorborn half-born from its door; a crowning's first pressing-forth; a fire's first flame; a Want gained within the last day. The thing simply stops, and will not start again. Each use, the holder marks a **Shut**. At three Shuts the holder can never again begin anything well: -2 on the first roll of every fight, journey, bargain or endeavor, forever. Vey remembers whose hands these were.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Second Table has offered 12,000 lacks through three intermediaries. The Barren Order believes that pressed on the lip of the Dilation they would stop the land's labor, and has never been near enough to try. If they were stolen, Orla Kest would go into every room in Cradlewrack until she found them.

## ◇ A STOPPERED FIRST BREATH

In the old highlands, before the Meal, the midwife caught each child's first breath in her cupped hands and blew it into Vey's nearest opening, as the giving back. The god is in the blood now and has no opening to blow into, but the Attendance still catches

first breaths, for one kind of birth only. When an Opinion has answered the Second Question, she first holds a small green-glass bottle to the mouth of what she is about to strike through, and catches the breath it draws, and stoppers it. The Book of Questions gives the reason in a single line: *So that it is not lost*. The bottle goes into the bundle, under the knot, and into the Low Wall.

A few get out. Apprentices keep them, the way Wenna Thrale keeps names. The breath inside is the beginning of a life that was not allowed, and it is still entirely a beginning. Uncorked under the nose of the dying, it begins them again. A Foundling sergeant named Ninety, opened belly to breastbone by a Gathered on the Cleave road, breathed one from his drill-mother's pocket and stood up in the mud with the wound already glazing. He has no memory of the day before, and for nine days afterward he stood outside every house in Cleave where a woman was in labor, face to the wall, weeping without knowing why.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) for any Attendance apprentice.

**SPOILAGE** In Cradlewrack stoppers work loose. Each pang, roll a d10: on a 1-2 the stopper has slipped and the breath is gone, and somebody near the bottle wakes having sighed in their sleep. A bottle knotted with the Attendance knot, or kept in grey stone, keeps forever.

**CARVING** From a bundle in the Low Wall (as for the Knot, above), or from an Opinion's apron-pocket in the minutes between the knife and the bricking: Hand + Filch vs Hard (14), in the same room as what has just been done (Dread 3).

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Vey), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Inhaled by a Dying character, it ends Ruin at once: restore Flesh to half maximum, and remove all Fray. The character has begun again. They lose all memory of the previous day, and for nine days carry the Want **Attend** (Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 on learning of a birth within a mile, or go, and stand outside). On the first pang after, they dream from inside a bundle: 1 Fray. One use.

**WORTH** 500 lacks. Rare. The Attendance never sells; the cellars do, discreetly, mostly to the Foundling Companies and to Rim wardens. Possession is concealment. A bottle offered for sale in Sallowreach fetches nothing; nobody there has needed to begin again in six hundred years.

## ◇ A LEAF OF THE LYING-IN'S BOOK

The Lying-In keeps its own book, apart from the public Tally, for the births nobody speaks about. Its boards are red clay fired hard as iron, and its leaves are not vellum but caul, stretched and scraped from the Caul-line deliveries, so that each holds a pinkish light when lifted to a lamp. Entries are in the Attendance's shorthand of hooks and loops: a date, a bearer, *what is it, does it stay*, and the Opinion's mark.



Leaves get out under bricklayers' aprons. They are the most dangerous thing the cellars sell, because they are true and because they are not finished. A leaf cut from the book goes on writing itself: when a new entry is made in the Lying-In, the shorthand surfaces on the loose leaf too, overnight, in a brownish ink like old blood. Rufus Ochre owns one. It is how he knows the eleven hundred unaccounted births are not all walking north.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); the Assemblers know, and pay.

**SPOILAGE** Stable if dry. In damp the caul softens and crawls by night toward the Lying-In; one left out in a wet spring was found a

mile off, flattened against the Lying-In's wall, trying to get in.

**CARVING** Hand + Filch vs Dire (22) inside the record-room, or a year's triple wages to a bricklayer. Reading the shorthand is Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); an Attendant of rank 3 reads it freely.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 3 (on first reading).

**EFFECT** A read leaf reveals 1d6 births the Tally hides: parish, bearer, what was born, whether it stayed, and where it went. One, the GM decides, is still alive. Each night, roll a d6 to see whether the leaf writes.

| D6 | WHAT THE LEAF WRITES TONIGHT                                                                   |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Nothing. The leaf is warm.                                                                     |
| 2  | A birth in the Lying-In: "one, door, small; opened onto nothing; stays."                       |
| 3  | A delivery from Morwen Hall, in the Duchess's name, answer to the Second Question left blank.  |
| 4  | "One, born-grown, asked what year it was. Stays." The parish is the one the characters are in. |
| 5  | A birth whose bearer is a player character, dated nine days from tonight.                      |
| 6  | A line with no bearer and no answer, only the Opinion's mark, and the word <i>late</i> .       |

**WORTH** 600 lacks to the Assemblers, more to the Second Table. Rare. Possession is the gravest concealment there is; the Attendance

has bricked readers for less.

## ▼ FROM THE BORN-WRONG



The Parts, the born-grown, the Uncut and the things the Assemblers stitch are the commonest source of leavings in the highlands and the most contested. Every hand born in a Rudge cottage is wanted by four parties at once: the mother, who loves it; the Attendance, which is owed it; the Assemblers, who believe it is a finger of the god; and the cellar-dealers, who know exactly what a Fatlands buyer will pay for a warm hand in a jar. The Foundling Companies guard their dead more fiercely than any army on the Table guards its living, and the Uncut regard any cord cut from one of their own as a murder of two people. Leavings in this section are almost all taken from someone who was, in some sense, still attached to them.

### ◆ A JOINING SEAM

When two Parts fit, they seal along a seam that heals in a night: a pale raised line, faintly ridged like the join of a shell, warm, and smelling of milk. The Assemblers' surgeons cut seams out of the Gathered they cannot use (clusters that joined wrongly, in the dark,

before the Gatherers reached them) and keep the strips in warm ewe's milk in stone jars in the Barn's middle hall. A strip the length of a finger, laid along a wound between two pieces of flesh, makes them join as Parts join. It does not matter whose flesh it is.

A Kest mason who lost three fingers to a falling lintel bought a seam and three fingers cut from a man hanged at Knocking Gate, and had them stitched on in a cellar under the naming-exchange. They took overnight. They work beautifully. At dusk they clench, all three, hard, and hold, for about as long as it takes a hanged man to stop.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) for anyone who has had dealings with the Assemblers or the Second Table's surgeons.

**SPOILAGE** In warm ewe's milk, one pang; in milk in a grey-stone jar, a season. Out of milk it dries within a day to a dead white string.

**CARVING** Cut from a Gathered: Hand + Stitching vs Grim (18) if it is alive and fighting (it will Grapple), Hard (14) if dead. Witnessing a Gathered pried apart along its seams is Dread 2. A

Lack means the seam closes on the carver's hand, and must itself be cut.

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Vey).

**EFFECT** Laid in a wound with Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14), it joins any two pieces of living or freshly dead (within a day) flesh by the next morning: a severed limb is restored (removing that Injury), or a foreign part is grafted (a hand, an eye, a sheet of skin). A foreign part keeps one habit of its first owner (a tremor, a reach, a Want, a clench at dusk); seeing it the first time is Dread 2 for the bearer. The seam is Vey's now: in Cradlewrack it reopens on a pang roll of 1–4 rather than 1–3, and any Part within a mile is drawn toward it.

**WORTH** 120 lacks the strip. Scarce. The Assemblers sell only to those they trust; Master Quillon Barr buys all he can find. Concealment, and in four lands an accessory to grave-robbery.

## ◇ A BORROWED SCAR

The born-grown arrive scarred: old sword-cuts, rope-burns, the white puckers of healed arrowheads, all on bodies that have never been anywhere. The Companies call them *birth-marks* and think little of them. The Cutwrights' Linemen think a great deal of them, because in every case they have been able to trace, the scars on a born-grown match the wounds of someone who died on the day the born-grown was born, somewhere on the Table. The College has not published this. Hobb Fallowmere, Warden-Captain of the Rim, was born with a warden's scar on his cheek, and does not like to be asked whose.

A scar cut whole from a dead born-grown and grafted onto living skin carries something of the one who first took the wound: a habit of hand, a trained reflex, a craft. The Rim wardens swear by them. A sergeant of the Second Company who wears a crossbow-burn on her forearm, grafted from a Foundling who went home, has not missed a shot in four years. She dreams of a tower in the Vigil and a lamp going out.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) for anyone who has served in the Foundling Companies or the Rim wardens.

**SPOILAGE** Rot in three days unless grafted. Kept in brine with a pinch of spring-salt, one season.

**CARVING** From the body of a dead born-grown: Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14) to lift the scar whole. The Companies bury their dead in their own wall and guard it; robbing that wall is Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18), and the Companies do not hand such thieves to the Attendance. They deal with it as a Company. Dread 2 for the carving.

**TAINT 1** Regrowth (Vey), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Grafted (Hand + Stitching vs Grim 18, or automatic with a Joining Seam), the scar gives +1 to one skill the original owner plainly had (a sword-cut, Blades; a rope-burn, Athletics or Labor; a burned palm, Craft), to a maximum of 5. Once per session, in a

scene that resembles the original death, the bearer takes a Dread 2 check as they remember dying. When the bearer dies, the GM may decide that somewhere in Cradlewrack, that day, a born-grown arrives mid-stride, wearing the wound that killed them.

**WORTH** 200 lacks. Rare. Traded on the Rim among wardens and caravan guards. The Companies' vengeance is not a legal penalty, but it is a reliable one.

## ◇ A GOING-HOME BLANKET

A Newborn of the Foundling Companies is given three things: a number, a place in the Crèche, and a blanket of undyed Company wool. Some born-grown age normally. Some age backward. A few, without warning, revert to infancy in a single night, and in the morning their comrades find a baby in the blanket in the soldier's bed, and the soldier is gone. The Companies call it *going home*. The infant does not live long; it never does. It is bricked into the Company's own wall, and the blanket, which smells of milk and sweat and gun-oil and the soldier's own particular musk, is folded and kept by whoever loved them.

Some are sold, by sergeants who drink, to buyers who have heard what a going-home blanket does. Wrapped in it overnight, a sleeper wakes a year younger: smoother, quicker, lighter in the joints. They also wake lighter in other ways. Old Rim merchants who have tried it describe forgetting things in the order they learned them, last first: the newest language, then a craft, then a face. A spice-factor at the Groaning Board slept in one for seven nights in 638. On the eighth morning the innkeeper found a baby in the bed, in a fine nightshirt much too large for it, and a ledger on the bedside table in a hand nobody could read any more.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) in the Companies, who will not discuss it.

**SPOILAGE** It keeps while unwashed. Washed, it is only wool. The smell, and the effect, fade after nine pangs.

**CARVING** From a comrade's keeping: Tongue + Persuade vs Hard (14), and a Dread 2 check on being told who it belonged to. From the Crèche's store: Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18).

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Vey), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Each night slept wrapped in it, the sleeper wakes a year younger in body, heals 1d6 Flesh and loses one healed Injury's lasting penalty, and loses 1 point from the skill they most recently raised. On the third night they also lose a Knack. On the seventh night, and every night after, they must roll Caul + Resolve vs Dire (22) or go home.

**WORTH** 350 lacks. Rare. Bought by the old and rich of every land except Sallowreach, where nobody ages and everyone already forgets. The Companies regard the sale as the theft of a body.

## ◇ A ROOT-END

Among the Uncut, the eldest let their cords grow down into the clay, and are called Roots, and through their cords the long houses feel the pulse of the land itself. Maevve Cord's mother is the oldest Root in Cordway, and her cord does not end in her tomb. When a Root's cord is cut, by the Barren Order's saboteurs or by a desperate thief, the end that went into the ground comes up: a pale knot of fibrous cord as thick as a wrist, trailing fine red rootlets like the veins of an eye, and beating. It does not beat with the Root's pulse. It beats with the land's, and under that, faster and smaller, the second pulse Madder Rudge hears at the Dilation.

In 637 a Grey Brother of Nullhouse cut a Root's cord in Cordway at the height of a pang, to sever the Uncut from the ground. Both ends bled. The Root died in the night, and her daughter on the other end of the cord died with her. The root-end came up in the Grey Brother's hands as he pulled, and he could not let go of it for a day. It is in Nullhouse now, in a grey-stone box, and the brothers who keep it say it is beating faster every pang.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); every Uncut knows, and will not say.

**SPOILAGE** It wants soil. Bedded in a pot of red highland clay it lives indefinitely; out of clay it withers in nine days. Abroad, it puts rootlets into any soil it rests on, and the Highland Leavings Abroad roll is made at 1–3.

**CARVING** Cutting a living Root's cord is Hand + Blades vs Hard (14) and is, to the Uncut, the murder of two people. Dragging the end up out of the clay is Gut + Labor vs Grim (18); the ground holds on. Dread 3. A Lack means the carver feels the second pulse in their own chest for a week, and gains 2 Hunger each day of it.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Vey).

**EFFECT** The holder knows the hour of the next pang a full day in advance. Laid on bare ground, it twitches toward the Dilation and beats faster near any crowning. Held to the ear, its second pulse can be listened to: Eye + Instinct vs Grim (18) learns one true thing about what is under the Dilation, and costs a Dread 4 check every time. A Cradlewracker who carries it feels a Pull (14) toward the Dilation once each day.

**WORTH** 900 lacks. Rare. The Barren Order buys them to keep in stone; the Second Table buys them to follow. The Uncut do not buy them back. They come for them.

## ▼ FROM THE GROUND IN LABOR



The Attendance believes no single person will ever be Seated in Cradlewrack, because Vey is not regrowing in a person. It is regrowing in the country. That makes the land itself the god's body, and its leavings the nearest thing on the Table to a piece of a Provider that has come back whole. Pilgrims at Rimwatch sell the clay of the Dilation's lip by the jar; the masons of the Stillyard sell what comes out of their walls; Old Hinge sweeps up splinters below a door older than the Gorging and does not know what to do with them. Highlanders handle the land's leavings with the same flat practicality they bring to everything else, and with one difference. They do not keep them in the house during a pang.

## ◇ LIP-CLAY OF THE DILATION

The lip of the Dilation is soft red clay that gives underfoot like flesh and slopes inward to the drop. Every morning the Rimwatch reset their painted stakes at the new edge, and every morning, before the stakes go in, the pilgrims and the poorer Rudge diggers go down onto the slick slope with buckets and scoop the clay from the very edge, where it is warmest. It smells of iron and birth-water. In the jar it flexes at each pang, a slow squeeze and release, and the lid must be tied down.

The potters of Kest learned early not to fire it. A cup made of lip-clay in 636 held tea for two pangs; at the third, its bottom dilated in its owner's hand, and something the size of a plum, wet and dark, came up through it and dropped into her lap. What the clay is good for is drawing things out. Smeared into a wound, it widens the wound, deepens it, and delivers whatever is lodged inside: arrowheads, splinters, a swallowed key, poison, the toothed seed of Fatlands wheat. The Reopening Ward uses it, under protest, on Foundling soldiers with bolts in them. It hurts more than the bolt did.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in Cradlewrack; everyone at Rimwatch sells it. Hard (14) abroad.

**SPOILAGE** Warm and active for one pang. After the second it cools to ordinary red clay, unless kept in a sealed jar topped with water from a highland spring, which keeps it a season.

**CARVING** Scooping from the advancing edge is Gut + Athletics vs Hard (14) on a slope that gives. The rim is Dread 2; during a pang, Dread 4. A Lack means the slope moves: Lung + Athletics vs Grim (18) or slide over the edge, which is the end of the character.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Vey), 1 Hunger.

**EFFECT** Smeared into a wound with Hand + Stitching vs Routine (10), it delivers anything lodged in the body: a bolt-head, a splinter, a swallowed object, or one poison or drug (ending its effect at once). The patient takes 1d6 damage that ignores Armor and a Dread 2 check, and that wound reopens on a pang roll of 1–5 forever after. Used as mortar, it gives any wall a door within nine days, where there was none, and Doorborn are known to come out of such doors.

**WORTH** 15 lacks the jar at Rimwatch. Uncommon in Cradlewrack, Scarce abroad. Not illegal. The Attendance looks at buyers in a way that makes them wish it were.

## ◇ A SPLINTER OF THE SILL

On the bare hilltop in the north, a single oak door stands in its frame with no wall around it, grey with age, iron-bound, older than the Gorging, ajar since that night and opening a finger's width further every year. As the gap widens the old wood stretches, and splinters come away from the leading edge: long pale slivers, dry and grey on the outer side, warm and faintly damp on the side that faced the gap. Old Hinge sweeps them up and burns them. Not all of them. Pilgrims steal them from the grass, and Hinge, who is old and short of money, sells a few.

A splinter carried in a pocket makes doors behave as the Sill behaves. They stand open a finger's width behind the carrier, every one, when they look back. Pressed into a keyhole, a crack or a gap between boards, a splinter shows the far side of the Sill instead of the far side of the crack. What can be seen there varies. Agnes Latch, who has studied the Sill through a glass for twenty years and built every one of her best doors to its pattern, bought four splinters in 639 and has not let anyone into her workshop since.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); anyone who has visited the Sill knows of the splinters.

**SPOILAGE** None. On Tablenight every splinter of the Sill, wherever it is on the Table, stands upright on its end and stays so until dawn.

**CARVING** From Hinge's sweepings: Tongue + Persuade vs Hard (14), or a few lacks. From the door itself: Hand + Craft vs Grim (18) to pry a sliver from the edge without touching the gap. Touching the gap is Dread 4. A Lack means the door opens a finger's width further while the carver's eye is to it.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Carried, it gives +2 Stealth to slip through doors unheard, and the carrier leaves every door they pass a finger's width open; Cradlewrackers gain the Want **Leave It Open** at Routine (10) if they did not have it. Pressed into any gap and looked through, Eye + Godsign vs Grim (18) answers one question about something that is beginning, from the other side of the Sill: Dread 4. On a Lack, something on the far side looks back through the crack, and knows the carrier's face.

**WORTH** 250 lacks. Scarce in Cradlewrack, Rare abroad. The Attendance forbids approach to the Sill, and Agnes Latch outbids everyone.

## ◇ A KNOCKED BRICK

The long walls of the Stillyard tick and settle on still nights, and sometimes they knock. Families pay masons to listen, and when a wall knocks back, the Attendance is sent for, and attends, and afterward a mason takes out the brick with the family's stamp and lays a new one. The old brick is meant to be broken. Absalom Gage, the deaf chief mason, has a stack of them in his yard, forty years' worth, and lately he can hear them.

A knocked brick goes on knocking. It is an ordinary red brick, stamped with a family's mark, a little warmer than it should be, and it carries the dead behind it the way a shell carries the sea. Mortared into a house wall, it knocks three slow times whenever anything comes through any door of that house unannounced, which in Cradlewrack is the most valuable warning there is. Laid on a table with a palm flat on it, it answers questions from whoever was bricked behind it: one knock for yes, two for no. There is a third answer. Gage says the dead give it more often every year.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Kest; masons know without a roll.

**SPOILAGE** Removed from the Stillyard, a brick knocks for a year and a day and then is only a brick. Mortared into a wall of grey stone, it knocks forever.

**CARVING** Unbricking a knocking brick from a Stillyard wall is Hand + Labor vs Hard (14), and desecration. Feeling it knock against the palm as it comes free is Dread 2. A Lack means it knocks from inside the carver's pack all night, and they get no rest.

**TAINT** Dread 2; and 1 Regrowth (Vey) each time it is questioned.

**EFFECT** Set in a wall, the household cannot be surprised by anything entering through a door. Questioned, it answers up to three questions a night from the dead behind it, by knocks; each night of questions is a Dread 2 check. On any question, the GM may answer with three knocks, which means *come and see*: the questioner must pass Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14) or walk to the Stillyard that night and open the niche.

**WORTH** 70 lacks. Scarce. Sold by masons on the quiet. Desecration; the family whose mark it bears may take it worse than the Attendance does.

## ◇ A DOORBORN'S KEY-FINGER

Doorborn are the offspring of thresholds: thin grey things with limbs jointed like hinges, born from any door, gate or lid shut too long. They come out at night into sleeping houses and open things with long fingers like keys, neatly, along every seam a midwife knows. The finger of a dead one is as long as a man's hand, grey,

cold, with five small joints that bend in both directions and a tip flattened into wards like a key's bit. Drawn along a body, it opens it along a seam, cleanly, without blood, and the patient stays awake and feels nothing but a draught.

The surgeons of the Reopening Ward are forbidden to use them and do. Tamsin Gorse keeps one in a knotted cloth in her apron and will deny it to anyone but a patient on her table. Burglars use them too. A key-finger slid into any lock turns it as if it were made for it, and then keeps turning, very gently, after the lock is open, as if feeling for something further in.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) for surgeons and thieves in Kest.

**SPOILAGE** Wrapped tight in a knotted cord it stays supple for a season. Unwrapped it stiffens within a pang into grey bone, which still opens locks and no longer opens bodies.

**CARVING** Kill a Doorborn (Threat 4, Flesh 12, Guard 16, Dread 3) and cut a finger free: Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14). A Lack means the finger opens the carver's palm along its lines as it comes away: 2 damage, ignoring Armor, and a scar that will reopen.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** As a surgical tool, +4 to Stitching for any surgery, with no bleeding and no pain for the patient. As a pick, +4 to Filch against locks. As a weapon, opening fingers (3); with two Helpings the target's oldest scar opens and bleeds 1 Flesh a round until stitched. Every seam it opens reopens on a pang roll of 1–3. A Cradlewracker who carries it unwrapped gains the Want **Leave It Open** at Hard (14).

**WORTH** 180 lacks. Scarce. Surgeons, burglars, the Second Table's Master Barr. Concealment; the Attendance regards any Doorborn part as a birth that should have been bricked.

## ◇ THE RUDGE ROPE

In 403 A.G. the parish well at Rudge gave birth, and something climbed up the rope and was not seen again. The well has been capped with three tons of fired brick and a millstone, and the parish still sleeps badly. The rope was kept in the church loft: forty fathoms of hemp, stiff and dark, stained to a man's height above the bucket-end, and printed all along its lower length with small marks like the grip of wet hands. It is warm. It is a little longer every year.

The parish sold it in 590 to a Rim collector and Madder Rudge's family bought it back in 611, for more than the parish could explain. In the summer of 629 someone took it out to the Dilation at night and let it down over the edge, and something on it went down ninety feet, and came back. The rope came up with a handprint pressed into its lowest knot, warm, the clay still in the whorls of the fingers, and larger than any human hand. Madder says the rope was stolen. She says a great many things, upside down, through her pipe.

Let down into any hole deep enough, the Rudge Rope is taken hold of. Something always climbs.

**WHISPERED** Everyone in Rudge knows. Elsewhere, Eye + Lore vs Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** None. It grows a hand's breadth longer each pang.

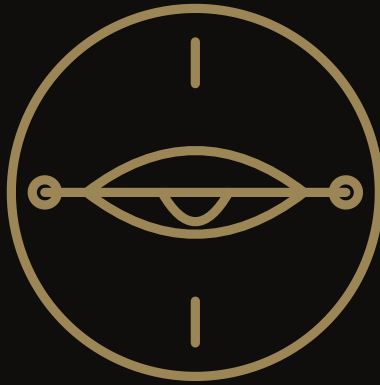
**CARVING** Unique. Kept by the Rudge family in a bricked room under Madder's cottage; getting in is Hand + Labor vs Hard (14) and getting out past Rudge diggers is another matter. Holding it is Dread 3: the grip-marks are warm, and one of them is closing.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Lowered into any opening deeper than a man is tall (a well, a shaft, a grave, a cistern, a crowning), within the hour something takes hold of it and climbs. Roll a d6 when it reaches the top.

| D6 | WHAT CLIMBS THE RUDGE ROPE                                                                                                  |
|----|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Water, rising up the rope in a warm clear column that smells of the springs, and keeps rising.                              |
| 2  | Whatever was lost down there, whole and wet: a body, a bucket, a child's shoe, a person who fell. They ask what year it is. |
| 3  | A Part, holding on with one hand.                                                                                           |
| 4  | A born-grown, naked and slick, who climbs out by the knots and walks away without a word.                                   |
| 5  | Nothing. The rope comes up with a new handprint on the lowest knot, larger than the last.                                   |
| 6  | The thing from 403. It is much bigger now. It remembers the rope.                                                           |

**WORTH** Not sold since 611. The Assemblers have offered 2,000 lacks. The Attendance does not know it still exists.



CHAPTER 14

LEAVINGS OF  
OATHEN



Nothing is sold in Tacit. Things are described, and the description is guaranteed.

— SILAS AMEND, PAPER-BROKER OF TACIT, TO A FATLANDS BUYER WHO ASKED  
WHETHER A THING WORKED

EVERYLEAVING<sup>IN THE</sup> CANYONS<sup>IS A</sup>  
SENTENCE SOMEBODY COULD<sup>NOT TAKE BACK.</sup>  
BUY IT AS YOU WOULD<sup>BUY A</sup> KNIFE: BY THE HANDLE,  
AND WITHOUT ASKING<sup>WHAT IT HAS CUT.</sup>

[ MARGINAL NOTE IN THE BENCH'S REGISTER OF SEIZED GOODS ]

Very little of Tolm is left to carve. Its ears were boiled and eaten by the upper gorges, its tongue by the Tongue-lines, its heart by the Rain-keepers, and its bones were rolled into the Gullet and lie under a floor of hot red sand that the Bench forbids anyone to dig. What Oathen has instead are leavings of the word: things that heard too much, things that were broken by what was said, things that bind. A Course-Ear cut from a noble's neck still listening on its plate. A Surety's tattooed skin with a stranger's promise in it. A flask of rain a god swore to send. The canyon folk handle these things in silence, gloved, often bitted, because a leaving of Tolm can bind a person who never meant to say anything at all.

The trade is the most honest on the Table and the most frustrating. A seller in Oathen who says "this works" has sworn that it does, and breaks if it does not. Oathen dealers therefore say almost nothing. They lay the leaving on felt, set beside it a slate on which they have chalked what others have said of it ("*I am told*," "*It was said in my hearing*," "*The previous owner believed*"), and wait. Price-witnesses in brass collar-plates stand by for a crumb a word. Large sums change hands in sworn notes, which are the safest paper on earth, and the Bench of Clauses keeps a Register of Seized Goods in which every leaving that binds is entered as the property of the Bench, because every word of public record is. The Register is very long, and its upper rooms are lined with felt.

What Oatheners fear in a leaving is not rot but repetition. A thing that heard an oath can say it again, and an oath repeated is an oath renewed. Leavings are kept where they cannot echo: in felt, in wax, in lead, and for the very worst, in gold, the one metal Tolm's mouth will not bite through. They are moved on windless days and never discussed while the Tattler blows. And every Oathener knows, as they know the exits in their own sentences, that the widening is happening: that handtalk breaks fingers now, that writing binds at half its Weight, that the Quiet believe even thought is beginning to count. A leaving bought last year under one set of rules may be under another this year. The Bench has begun adding a clause to every relic sale, *as the god now counts*, and nobody can say what it covers.

#### RULES — LEAVINGS THAT BIND

Many leavings in this chapter make something an oath that would not otherwise be one. Treat the result exactly as an oath sworn in Oathen: it has a **Weight** (given in the entry), may carry **Exits** if the character drafts carefully (Tongue + Clause, as in the Oathen chapter), and on breach brings a **Breaking** from the Breaking table, at 2 × Weight Flesh. Unless an entry says otherwise, a leaving's oath binds only within Oathen's borders; leavings that bind abroad say so, and are worth a great deal more for it. Echoes renew a leaving's oath as they renew any other.

## ▼ FROM THE TONGUE-LINES AND THE SAYERS





The highest blood in the canyons is the furthest along, and the Tongue-line houses shed leavings the way old trees shed bark: small ears cut from the neck at the Course, saliva caught when a Sayer's gold is off for cleaning, tongues given to the Quiet's knife and kept in brine, vows scratched into plaster by swearers who cannot be stopped. The Bench owns all of it, in law. The houses sell a great deal of it, in fact, through physicians, bitmakers and the very discreet, to buyers who have a use for a thing that makes words count. The Second Table has agents in at least three Tongue-line houses and an interest in this section of the market that needs no explaining.

## ◇ A COURSE-EAR

At the Course, the small ears come: puckers in the skin of the neck and shoulders and the inner arm that open, over a season, into perfect little ears, pink and folded, turning toward sound. The Tongue-lines who grow them cannot bear crowds, and their physicians cut the ears away in felt-lined rooms with a curved blade and a pot of cedar salve. The cut ears do not die. Laid on a dish, they go on turning toward every voice, and if the room is silent long enough, they turn toward the nearest heartbeat.

Spies discovered what they were for within a generation. An ear tacked under a table, sewn into a collar or dropped into a planter at a treaty-sitting hears everything said within ten paces, and held afterward to a listener's own ear it repeats all of it, verbatim, slowly, in the voices of those who spoke. In the month the Mute King made his sound, the Bench seized every ear in the Hall of Conditions and burned them in a lead furnace. The rumour on the Shadeward Wall is that one was missed, sewn into the hem of the clerk who heard it, and that it has been repeating the sound ever since, very quietly, in a drawer.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); spies, Clausewrights and the crown's household know without a roll.

**SPOILAGE** It lives on sound. Kept in total silence (sealed in felt) it starves in a season; kept in a busy room it lives for years, and after the first year a second, smaller ear buds beside it.

**CARVING** Cut from a Tongue-line at the Course with Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14), with the patient's consent or under a physician's cover; stolen from a house's felted box with Hand + Filch vs Grim (18). Dread 2: it turns toward the carver as they breathe. A Lack means it has heard the carver, and will repeat what they said, at the worst moment, in their voice.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Tolm).

**EFFECT** Left in place for up to a day, it hears everything said within ten paces. Held to the ear afterward, it repeats it all at half speed. An oath it repeats is renewed, at its original Weight, for the one who swore it, wherever they are in Oathen: an ear is a way to bind a person twice. It can be made to stop only by sealing it in felt.

**WORTH** 400 lacks. Rare. The crown's spies buy all they can; so does the Rim Road Company. Planting one in the Hall of Conditions carries the clerk's sentence: the bit, for life.

## ◇ SAYER'S INK

Every few months, the gold bit of a Sayer must come out to be resized, because the tongue behind it keeps growing. Garl Tome does it himself, in the Gilded Cells, with the guards deafened and the Benchers of the week standing by with a fresh bit in her gloved hands, and in the moments the mouth is open, it runs: a thick, clear saliva that smells of wet slate and tastes, those who have caught a fleck on the lip say, of the moment after you have said a thing you cannot take back. Tome catches it in a gold cup, because it eats every other metal it touches. He is meant to pour it into the furnace. He has a daughter whose voice he has never heard, and a dowry to think of.

Ground with lampblack and gum, it makes an ink that binds. What is written in it is not merely written: it is said, in the Sayer's mouth, at full Weight, and the god hears it as speech. A contract written and signed in Sayer's Ink binds its signers as if they had sworn it aloud before the Ledger, and it does so anywhere on the Table. The Rim Road Company has been looking, quietly, for something better than Oathen to swear by. Lysander Coyle, the Auditor-General, bought a phial in 639 and has not told the Wheel.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22). Garl Tome, two Benchers and Lysander Coyle know for certain.

**SPOILAGE** Sealed in gold or canyon-glass under wax, a year. Ink dried on the page binds forever. Ink more than a year in the phial still writes, but binds at half Weight.

**CARVING** Only in the Gilded Cells, during a resizing: Hand + Craft vs Grim (18) to catch it as Tome's assistant, or Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22) to be in the room unasked. A Sayer's open mouth is Dread 3, and a Sayer with her bit out may say something.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 1 (the wet ink moves on the page like a tongue).

**EFFECT** A promise written in it and signed is an oath of its full Weight (usually 3 or 4) for every signer, binding anywhere on the Table, with Breakings as in Oathen. A lie written in it breaks the writer's hand (Weight 3). A phial writes about twenty pages.

**WORTH** 1,500 lacks the phial. Rare. Possession outside the Bench is treason against the Ledger. Inside the Company, it is the most interesting thing anyone has seen in a century.

## ◇ A TONGUE FROM MOTE'S VAULT

Brother Ansgar Mote, surgeon of the Quiet, has taken four hundred tongues, cleanly, from novices who chose the knife over the vow. He keeps them in brine, labelled, in a vault cut into the cliff above the

upper Gullet, because he once threw one on the midden and it went on trying to speak there for a week, and the crows would not go near it. Each sits in its own stoppered jar, pale and thick, with a tag of goat-vellum giving the name and the date. At night they move. They shape words without breath, the same words, over and over: the last thing their owners wanted to say before the blade.

Many of the Quiet's novices were born in the Tongue-line houses and knew things. The sentences the tongues are shaping are, in a fair number of cases, the reason their owners took the knife. Mote has begun to suspect something worse, and has written it on his slate and wiped it off again: the tongues are growing. The oldest have put out a second root at the cut, and three of them, he believes, are no longer shaping the same sentence every night. They are shaping new ones.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); the Quiet know and do not speak, for obvious reasons.

**SPOILAGE** In brine changed every new Plate, indefinitely. Dry, it withers within days, and as it withers it shapes its sentence faster.

**CARVING** Mote does not sell. Taking a jar from the vault is Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18) among the Quiet's cliff-cells, where the slightest sound carries and every brother is listening. The Quiet regard the theft as the breaking of a vow made on another's behalf. Dread 2 on first seeing one move.

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Its sentence can be read off its shapes with Eye + Lore vs Grim (18) (Dacey Furl reads them easily). It is always a secret worth knowing. Placed in the mouth of a corpse, it speaks the sentence aloud once in its owner's voice, and in Oathen what it says binds whomever it concerns, at Weight 3. Each season, roll a d10; on a 1 the tongue has grown, and the GM may have it shape, once, a new sentence that becomes a little true, as at the Course.

**WORTH** 250 lacks to the curious; far more to whomever its secret concerns. Rare. The Second Table wants the ones that are growing.

## ◇ A HANGING BIRD OF LOW SHALE

In 598 A.G. a Tongue-line girl said "I wish it would stop" during a storm, and everything in the valley of Low Shale stopped. The river stands in its bed in a single hard green ribbon. A herdsman stands mid-stride with his crook raised and his eyes wet. Larks and wheatears hang in the air a foot above the grass, wings half-spread, exactly where they were, and have hung there for forty-three years with their eyes open. Nothing rots. The air has no smell. The Bench has posted the valley silent and forbids entry, and Bait pilgrims sneak in anyway.

A bird can be taken. It comes out of the air the way a held breath comes out of a chest, with a faint resistance and then all at once, and it lies in the palm weightless and cold. Set down again anywhere,

released in midair or pressed against a wall, it stays exactly where it was put, and nothing in the world will move it: not a shoulder, not an ox-team, not a pang in Cradlewrack. An Echo-Warden named Tav Shale (the family took the valley's name) carries one on a cord to anchor ropes in gorges where no stone will hold a piton. He has held a rockfall off a fallen man with it. He does not like to look at its eye.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Echo-Wardens and climbers know at Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** None. It is stopped.

**CARVING** Entering Low Shale past the Bench's posts is Lung + Stealth vs Hard (14). Standing among the stopped is Dread 3. Taking a bird from the air needs Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14). A Lack means the carver has spoken aloud in the valley, and the herdsman's eyes have turned to them, and will be turned that way when they next come.

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 2 (its eye is open, and wet).

**EFFECT** Released anywhere, it stays there, immovable by any force, until a bare living hand takes it back. A rope tied to it holds any weight; a door wedged with it cannot be opened, in any land; a blow struck against it is like striking a cliff (the attacker takes 2 damage). Whoever takes it back loses all feeling in that hand for an hour (-2 to Hand rolls).

**WORTH** 600 lacks. Rare. Echo-Wardens, burglars, the Canyon Watch. Entering Low Shale is a Bench offence; taking from it, the Bench says, is theft from a Sayer's sentence.

## ◇ A SCRATCHED VOW

At the Appetite, swearers vow without meaning to, and must be bitted for their own safety; and a determined swearer, bitted and with hands bound, will still try to scratch vows into the plaster with a fingernail. The walls of the Murmuring House are covered in them, hundreds deep, in the shaky capitals of people who cannot stop promising. The nurses whitewash the wards every month. By the end of the month the white is scored again. Since writing began to bind, the nurses have stopped reading the walls, and wear their eyes lowered on the wards.

A slab of that plaster, cut out with a mason's saw, holds a vow that binds whoever reads it aloud, because to read a vow aloud is to say it. The Breakdowns' liars-for-hire use them as snares: a scratched vow passed across a counter to an illiterate partner, read aloud by a helpful clerk to a debtor, nailed over a door for a rival to puzzle out. The Bench calls this *snaring* and punishes it with the snarer swearing the vow themselves. Dacey Furl has found, on the night ward, a vow scratched over and over in three hundred different hands: the vow all three hundred are mouthing in their sleep. Its last word is always scratched through.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Tacit.

**SPOILAGE** Plaster crumbles in a year; under glass, a decade. The vow fades as the scratches fill with dust.

**CARVING** Hand + Craft vs Hard (14) to saw a slab out of a Murmuring House wall, with a Caul + Resolve vs Routine (10) not to read what you are cutting. A Lack means you read it.

| D6 | THE SCRATCHED VOW                                                                |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | I WILL WALK TO THE SEA                                                           |
| 2  | I WILL NEVER EAT BREAD AGAIN                                                     |
| 3  | I WILL HAVE YOUR EYES                                                            |
| 4  | I WILL NOT WAKE                                                                  |
| 5  | I WILL GO DOWN TO THE GULLET AND LIE ON IT                                       |
| 6  | The night-ward vow, its last word scratched through. The GM decides what it was. |

**WORTH** 30 lacks. Scarce. Snaring is a Bench crime in Tacit and a growing trade on the Rim, where nobody reads the slabs before

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Reading it aloud swears it: Weight 2 (Weight 3 in Oathen, where the reader can be heard by the canyon). Reading it silently: roll a d10, and on a 1–2 the reader is bound at Weight 1. Roll a d6 for what a slab says.

buying them.

## ▼ FROM THE BROKEN AND THE BREAKERS



The Breakdowns are the one place in Oathen where a person can lie, because the Forsworn have nothing left to break in the mouth, and so they are also the one place in Oathen where leavings are sold with patter. The broken trade in what broke them and what broke others: tattooed skin from Sureties, bones from the Unmade Road, the receipts of a back-canyon fixer, the hands of the first man the god ever took at his word. The Bench’s executioner leaves very little behind him, and what he leaves is the most frightening thing in the canyons. The Breakdowns treat all of these as a dockside treats rope: as the stuff of a hard trade, handled by people who have already paid.

### ◆ A SURETY'S PATCH

A Surety carries other people’s oaths tattooed on the body in dense fine script, one bond to a patch of skin, until they are a ledger of other families’ risk. When a Surety dies, the oaths they carried are released, as all a dead person’s oaths are. The skin does not know that. A patch of tattooed skin cut from a dead Surety and tanned still holds its bond, and the bond is still looking for something to break.

Sewn to a living body, a patch will take a Breaking in its wearer’s place, once, the way its Surety would have. The skin tears along the script, the bone beneath cracks like a dropped plate, and the wearer

is left whole underneath, bruised and shaking. The Breakdowns sell patches by Weight. The Surety House calls the trade carrion-work and has twice sent members, at fee, to stand surety for oaths sworn against the patch-dealers in the Gathering of the Broken. A patch-dealer named Aubin Hollow had his hands come off on Fair Weight Row in 638 as a result, and sells patches still, with his feet.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); anyone of the Surety House or the Breakdowns knows.

**SPOILAGE** Untanned, a week. Tanned with canyon salt and cedar oil, years.

**CARVING** Sureties are entombed upright in the Witnessing Vaults with the rest of the dead. Flaying one is Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14) and a Dread 2 check. Desecration of a niche is a Bench crime; the Keeners say a Surety flayed in her niche has been known to Testify. A Lack means the patch tears in the cutting and is worthless.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Sewn or strapped against the skin, it absorbs the next Breaking its wearer suffers of a Weight no greater than the bond tattooed on it (1 to 4). The wearer loses only half the Flesh, gains no Forsworn mark, and makes the Dread check as a witness rather than as the broken. The patch is then spent. Wearing more than one at once makes them all fail.

**WORTH** 50 lacks per Weight of the bond. Scarce in the Breakdowns, Rare elsewhere. Sold openly on Back-Before-Dark; possession is not a crime, only its getting.

## ◇ THE MERCHANT'S HANDS

In the third year after the Gorging, a merchant of Tacit who had sworn to deal fairly with a customer shorted him by a thumb's weight of salt. His hands came off at the wrist in the marketplace, cleanly, with a sound like a dropped pail, and lay on the stones among the salt. It was the First Breaking, and the customer's family dried the hands and kept them as proof, and gave them to the Bench in the Honest Age. For three centuries they lay on the great scales in the Hall of Weights, palms up, curled as though holding a scale-pan, brown and hard as dried figs, and no merchant in Tacit cheated within sight of them.

In the Forsworn Riots of 506 they were stolen, and they are in the Breakdowns now, in a niche at the head of Fair Weight Row, the lane named for the oath the merchant broke. The Forsworn call him *the first of us* and lay copper crumbs before the niche. Merchants who deal in the Breakdowns come and swear their weights in front of the hands, which is the only place below the Walls where anybody's word is good. The Rim Road Company has offered four thousand lacks to set them on the scales at Toll Nine. Brakk has said no in four words, plainly.

**WHISPERED** Every Oathener knows the story; that the hands survive and where, Eye + Lore vs Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** None. They have not changed in six hundred and thirty-eight years.

**CARVING** Unique. Taking them from Fair Weight Row is Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22) through a slum that never sleeps, and would start the Second Forsworn Riot. Touching them is Dread 1: they are warm, and the fingers tighten.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Set on a counter or a pair of scales, the hands make false weight and false measure impossible within sight of them: loaded scales read true, clipped and counterfeit lacks are pointed out by a twitch of a finger, and a merchant who has made any promise of fair dealing and breaks it in their presence suffers the Breaking at +1 Weight. Haggling in their presence uses Eye + Haggle for both parties, never Deceive.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Bench wants them back; the Company wants them on the road; the Breakdowns would burn Tacit's lower bridges first.

## ◇ A KNUCKLE FROM THE UNMADE ROAD

In 627 A.G. the four hundred soldiers of the Fourth Regiment swore to hold Wending Pass to the death, obeyed their captain's

order to fall back, and broke on the road behind him, each opening at every joint by which he had bound himself to the place. Their remains were never cleared. The bone along the switchbacks below the pass is still sorted, roughly, into the shapes of men lying where they fell, and the drovers walk their animals single file down the centre of the road and do not look to either side. Renn Hold is still at the top. He has to be.

A knucklebone from the Unmade Road is small, brown, polished by fourteen years of wind, and carries in it the soldier's oath to hold. Canyon Watch soldiers carry them, illegally, sewn into the lining of a sleeve, and swear by them before a fight. A man with a Wending knuckle in his fist does not get knocked down and does not run. Sergeant Mags Carrow, who keeps the eleven unstrung survivors in the Breakdowns, has beaten three knuckle-sellers half to death with her spear-butt and thrown their stock into the river. She says the boys gave enough. She says it plainly. She has the eye to spare.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); any soldier of the Canyon Watch knows.

**SPOILAGE** None. But each Tablenight a knuckle moves, a little, wherever it is kept: it is found nearer the eastern side of the room, toward Wending.

**CARVING** Reaching the road means passing below Renn Hold, who will let nobody through who has not sworn to hold the pass (see the Oathen chapter). Finding a whole knuckle in the sorted bone is Eye + Search vs Hard (14) and a Dread 2 check. A Lack means the nearest shape of bone has shifted, in the time the carver was bent over it, to face them: Dread 3.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** The bearer says aloud "I hold here" (a Weight 2 oath, which the knuckle makes binding in any land). Until the danger in that place has passed, they gain +4 to resist being moved, knocked down, Grappled away, Pulled or routed, and +2 to Dread checks. If they leave of their own will before the danger has passed, they break as the four hundred broke: the knees, at Weight 2.

**WORTH** 120 lacks. Scarce. Sold in Canyon Watch barracks and on the Rim to caravan guards. Desecration of the war-dead; the Watch does not prosecute, but Mags Carrow does.

## ◇ A VOW-EATER'S RECEIPT

Grandam Cess, the back-canyon fixer, can release a client from an oath by having them swear a greater one over it. Her clients go away free of what they came with, and owe her something worse. Each is given a receipt: a strip of goat-vellum on which the old oath is written out in full and struck through in red, and beneath it the new oath, in a shorthand of Cess's own that no Clausewright has managed to read, signed in the client's blood. The receipt is the debt. Whoever holds it when Cess comes to collect is the one who pays.

Her clients learn this late. A whole Oathener cannot sell one honestly without saying what it is, and so they sell them through the Breakdowns, where the liars-for-hire describe them, with a straight face and an opened mouth, as *a free release from Grandam Cess*. That part is even true. Present a receipt to Cess, and she will release the holder from any one oath of theirs, of any Weight, for nothing more. She will simply note, in her soft dry voice, that the holder now owes her what the last holder owed. She knows what it is. She is the only one who does.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) in the Breakdowns, where everyone has been offered one.

| D6 | WHAT YOU OWE GRANDAM CESS                                                                        |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | A year of silence, to begin when she says so.                                                    |
| 2  | The name of the next child born under your roof, before its parents choose it.                   |
| 3  | Your left hand's work for a season. It will do her business at night, and you will not remember. |
| 4  | To carry one oath of hers, unread, as her Surety.                                                |
| 5  | A Sayer's word, sealed in wax, brought to her door.                                              |
| 6  | To promise nothing ever again. Your next oath of any Weight breaks you as it is spoken.          |

**WORTH** 20 to 500 lacks, depending on how desperate the seller is. Scarce in the Breakdowns. Perfectly legal, because nobody can prove what it says.

## ◇ THE BREAKER'S GLASS

The state executioner of Oathen owns no weapon. Jude Crake visits the condemned in the Ninth Room beneath the Ledger, turns an hour-glass at the first word, and talks pleasantly until they promise him something small. It has never taken longer than an hour. The glass he turns is not his. It belonged to the Breaker before him, who was condemned in his turn, and whom Crake, then a young man awaiting his own Breaker, talked to death in forty minutes across the same table. Crake kept the glass. It is plain canyon glass in a frame of olive-wood, and its sand is fine and red, and it has run, by the clerks' count, for eleven hundred dissolutions.

The room is warm when it runs. People who have sat across from it describe a pressure like the pressure in the throat before a sneeze, a wanting to agree, to reassure, to say *yes, I'll try*. The sand has heard every small promise made in that room for sixty years, and it remembers how they are got. Crake has said, pleasantly, to more than one Bench, that he will give the glass to anyone who can talk

**SPOILAGE** Valid until Cess collects, or dies. If she dies, the Breakdowns believe, every receipt she ever issued comes due in the same afternoon.

**CARVING** Bought from a desperate client or a liar-for-hire with Tongue + Haggle vs Routine (10); the sellers are very eager. Reading the shorthand is Eye + Clause vs Dire (22), and most never try.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Presented to Grandam Cess, it releases the holder from one oath of their choice, of any Weight, without Breaking. The holder then owes the receipt's debt, which binds as a Weight 4 oath. Roll a d6, or let the GM choose, for what is owed.

with him for a full hour while it runs without promising him anything at all. Nobody has taken him up on it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). Every Oathener knows the Breaker; few know the glass matters.

**SPOILAGE** Each turning, one grain of sand fails to fall and stays in the upper bulb. When the upper bulb is stopped, the glass will run no more. The clerks estimate forty turnings remain.

**CARVING** Unique. It is kept in the Ninth Room beneath the Ledger, and stealing it is Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22). Winning it from Crake means an hour's talk with him while it runs: four Tongue + Clause rolls vs Grim (18), each failure a small promise he will hold you to.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** While it runs (one hour), everyone who speaks within its hearing must pass Tongue + Clause vs Hard (14) at each quarter of the glass, Grim (18) in the last quarter, or make a small promise (Weight 1) of the turner's choosing in the course of conversation. In Oathen these bind. Elsewhere they do not, but the turner gains +4 to Persuade and Haggle to extract commitments for the hour.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Bench regards it as Crake's personal property, which frightens the Bench more than anything else about him.



# ▼ FROM THE CANYONS AND THE VAULTS

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The country itself keeps the god's word better than any of its people. The canyon walls repeat everything, the Gullet's sand swallows it, the Ledger holds four miles of it in stone, and the dead stand upright in the Witnessing Vaults to hear it. Rain falls once a year because a god promised. The leavings of the canyons are the stuff of that keeping: sand, stone, water, bone and horn that have spent centuries hearing oaths and holding them. The Echo-Wardens regard most of them as hazards to be packed in felt. The Bench regards all of them as public record. The Rim Road Company regards them as the most interesting commodities in the east, and has begun to ask the Register of Seized Goods for an inventory.

## ◇ GULLET SAND

The Gullet is the gorge where Tolm was eaten, at the head of the river system west of Tacit, and its floor is deep red sand over the god's bones. Sound does not carry there. It sinks, as into a pillow, and a man shouting at the top of his lungs in the Gullet can be heard by nobody five paces off. The sand is hot all year, hot enough now on the deep floor to blister bare feet, and pilgrims who walk it barefoot on Tablenight eve come out with soles that weep for a week. Those who lay an ear to it hear a slow sound like breathing. The Bench rules it is the river. Blasphemers who curse Tolm aloud are found next morning with their tongues gone and their mouths full of fine red sand, and the sand, those who have cleaned the mouths say, is warm.

A pouch of it carried out of the Gullet keeps the Gullet's quiet for a while. Scattered in a ring, it makes a place where nothing echoes and nothing said carries beyond the ring. Smugglers use it to talk in canyons. Lovers use it to make vows that cannot be renewed by the walls. The Echo-Wardens use it by the sack, and the Quiet sleep on it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in Oathen; it is sold at the Gullet's mouth by the ladle.

**SPOILAGE** It cools over a season away from the Gullet and stops working. Kept in a felt pouch against the body, it stays warm for a year.

**CARVING** Hand + Labor vs Routine (10) to scoop, but it must be done in silence on the Gullet floor, as custom and caution require: Lung + Stealth vs Hard (14). Hearing the breathing under the sand is Dread 2. A Lack means the sand took a sound from the carver, a word or a cry, and will give it back, later, from inside the pouch.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Tolm).

**EFFECT** A handful scattered in a ring three paces across makes, for a scene, a place where nothing echoes and no sound leaves the ring (+4 Stealth against hearing; oaths sworn inside are not renewed by echo, and cannot be overheard by any mortal ear). Anyone who curses Tolm aloud inside the ring loses their tongue, as the blasphemers do. A pouch holds five handfuls.

**WORTH** 25 lacks the pouch in Oathen, 80 on the Rim. Uncommon in Oathen. The Bench forbids its export; it leaves by the cartload anyway.

## ◇ A FLASK OF KEPT RAIN

Before it died, Tolm promised the canyons rain on the first day of Grace, and a god's word outlives the god. The Kept Rain has fallen on that day for six hundred and forty years: warm, heavy, a single day's downpour that fills the cisterns and floods the canyon floors and drowns the careless. The Rainwardens keep a cellar under the Rain Shrine where a sealed flask of canyon-glass has been filled on every one of those days, six hundred and forty flasks in rows, each tagged with its year. It is the god's word, bottled. Lovers make the year's vows in the downpour. Merchants anoint contracts with old vintages.

This year the rain came three days late. Yusra Thole, the Rainwarden, has filled the six hundred and forty-first flask and set it at the end of the row, and has not spoken since. Its water is clear and tastes of nothing at all. Three other flasks of Late Rain are known to exist, and the Second Table, the Rim Road Company and the Cutwrights' College each want to know the same thing: what happens to a promise that is anointed with a promise that slipped.

**WHISPERED** Kept Rain: Eye + Lore vs Routine (10). Late Rain: Eye + Lore vs Grim (18), and whispered only.

**SPOILAGE** Sealed in canyon-glass, forever. Once opened, it must be used before sunset.

**CARVING** Anyone can catch Kept Rain on the first day of Grace, though stealing from another's cistern-share is the one theft the Bench treats as a crime against the god. Old vintages from the Rain Shrine cellar are Hand + Filch vs Dire (22). Late Rain is somewhere in Yusra Thole's keeping, and three other places.

**TAINT** Kept Rain: 1 Regrowth (Tolm). Late Rain: 2 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** *Kept Rain*, touched to the tongue or the page while an oath is sworn, gives that oath one free Exit, “barring what none could help,” which the god will always honour. *Late Rain*, so used, lets the swearer break that oath once without Breaking at the moment of breach. Three days later, the Breaking arrives, at +1 Weight, wherever they are.

**WORTH** Kept Rain 40 lacks a flask for a recent year, 400 for one of the first century. Uncommon. Late Rain: never sold lawfully, and the bidding on the Rim began at 1,000 lacks.

## ◇ THE MISCUT STONE

Ottoline Vant, Scribe of the Ledger, carves the public vows into the cliff from a scaffold. Last year she miscut one by a single word, and the man it named broke that night. Writing is not supposed to count. The Bench had the slab cut out of the cliff face and a true copy carved in its place, and the miscut slab, a block of red stone the size of a hearthstone, was sealed in felt and lead and carried into the Ledger’s record-rooms, and entered in the Register of Seized Goods under a number and no description.

The man was a carter named Tacet Varrow, and he had sworn, at his marriage, to cherish his wife *in her house*. The miscut made it *in his house*. She had left him a month before. He broke at the chest, Weight 4, in a house that was not his, with the door open. The slab has not forgotten. It accepts carving. The rumour on the Sunward Wall, which the Register’s keepers do not deny, is that a vow chiselled into the miscut stone binds the person it names as though they had sworn it at the Ledger, whether they swore it or not, and that the wrong word on its face is cutting itself deeper every month.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); Ottoline Vant and the Register’s keepers know.

**SPOILAGE** None. The miscut word deepens a hair’s breadth each new Plate.

**CARVING** Unique. Reaching it in the Ledger’s record-rooms is Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22). Moving it takes two strong backs. Uncovering it is Dread 2: the miscut word is wet.

**TAINT** Dread 3, and 3 Regrowth (Tolm) for each vow carved into it.

**EFFECT** A vow carved into the slab (Hand + Craft vs Hard 14, an hour’s work) naming a person binds that person as a Weight 4 oath sworn at the Ledger, from the moment they read it or have it read aloud to them, in any land. They may plead their reading as for any oath. The carver takes a Dread 3 check for each vow, and the slab will hold it there forever.

**WORTH** Never sold. Lord Varro Esk has asked the Register’s keepers, generously, what it would cost to view it. They have not yet named a sum.

## ◇ A WARDEN'S HORN

An Echo-Warden of the rank of Tracker carries a horn of signal-silence: a canyon-goat’s horn with its bell packed tight with felt from the Gullet’s pilgrim-mats. Blown, it does not sound. It un-sounds. For the length of a breath, everything within a bowshot goes silent, the wind and the river and the voices and the echoes still riding the stone, and Wardens across the gorge feel the silence in their one good ear and know where their comrade is. Against a living echo, a horn is a club: the silence breaks the echo’s footing in the rock, and it bleeds noise.

Old horns are dangerous. A horn blown against echoes for forty years has eaten forty years of oaths and kept them in its felt, and the felt has to be repacked with fresh every season or the horn begins, faintly, to sound. What it sounds is everything it ever silenced. Warden Hollis Grane’s horn went unpacked for one winter in 619 while he lay sick, and in Grace his wife woke in a room full of four hundred overlapping oaths, every one sworn in the eastern gorges in the last forty years, all said at once, all binding. Her hearing did not come back. Neither did some other things.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** The felt must be repacked each season with Gullet felt. Unpacked, roll a d6 each week; on a 1 the horn sounds (see Effect).

**CARVING** Horns are given at the rank of Tracker, and a Warden is buried with hers. Taking one from a Warden’s grave in the eastern gorges is Hand + Labor vs Hard (14) and the Wardens hunt the thieves by ear. Dread 1.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Blown (Lung + Endure vs Hard 14), all sound within a bowshot stops for one round. A living echo in range takes 2d6 damage. Words spoken in that round are heard by no mortal ear and carried by no echo; the god hears them at half Weight. The blower is deaf for an hour. If the horn sounds instead, everyone within a bowshot hears every oath it has ever silenced: Dread 3, and Tongue + Clause vs Grim (18) or be bound by one of them (the GM’s choice).

**WORTH** 300 lacks. Rare. Smugglers pay most, to blind pursuers’ ears; the Wardens pay nothing, and take them back.

## ◇ A TESTIFYING JAW

The dead of Oathen stand upright in the Witnessing Vaults beneath Tacit, faces outward, to witness the oaths of the living. When an oath sworn on one of them breaks, the dead answer for Tolm, and the commonest answer is the jaw: it opens in its niche and speaks the oath aloud in the dead one’s own voice, loud enough to be heard for a mile through the rock. Old Sabra Wends, the Keener, has heard it forty-two times. Nine of them were this year. The jaws that have spoken hang loose afterward on their hinges, and the Keeners tie them shut with ribbon.



A jaw that has Testified, taken from its niche, is still a witness. An oath sworn with a hand on it is an oath sworn on the dead, wherever it is sworn, and the dead will answer for it as they answer in the Vaults. The Rim Road Company would like several. A jaw in a strongbox at a Fatlands waystation would make every bond sworn there as good as one sworn under the Ledger. Sabra Wends has noticed that her niches are being counted by men in good grey coats.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Keeners and the Company's factors know.

**SPOILAGE** Bone, and lasting. But a jaw that is not sworn on for a year stops witnessing; the Keeners say the dead grow bored.

**CARVING** Entering the Vaults unattended is Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18) past the Keeners' lanterns. Removing a jaw is Hand + Stitching vs Hard (14) and a Dread 3 check. A Lack means the jaw speaks the carver's name, once, in the dead one's voice.

**TAINT** 1 Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 3.

**EFFECT** An oath sworn with a hand on the jaw, anywhere on the Table, is an Oath on the Dead in the Oathen manner: +1 Weight, no Surety may carry it, and if it breaks, the swearer suffers a Breaking even outside Oathen and the jaw Testifies (roll on the Oathen chapter's Testify table). Once, on first being taken, the jaw speaks the oath it Testified, which is always someone's secret.

**WORTH** 700 lacks. Rare. Robbing the Vaults is desecration of the witnesses, and the Bench sends Jude Crane.

## ▼ FROM THE BITTED AND THE SWORN-INTO-BEING



Oathen's children are bitted from the first tooth until twelve, its swearers are bitted for their safety, and its kings are bitted for life. Its widows keep promises they made at deathbeds, and some of its sons exist only because somebody swore they would. These are the smallest leavings in the canyons and the most intimate: things that have lived in mouths, things kept alive by a word, things that remain when a word is no longer kept. Oatheners do not sell them lightly. Most come onto the market when a family line ends, and the dealers on the Sunward Wall who handle them do so in white gloves, without speaking, as if attending a funeral.

### ◇ AN HEIRLOOM BIT

Every Oathen child wears a soft leather muzzle from the first tooth until twelve, decorated by its parents with beads, ribbons and the family mark. In the old families the same bit is passed down, mended and re-lined, through generation after generation, so that a child of the Sele line or the Fell line wears in its mouth the leather that has held back the words of its grandmother's grandmother. Heirloom bits taste of everyone who wore them. Oathen adults who see one in a dealer's case go quiet, and touch the corners of their own mouths, where the groove is.

An old bit has held back a very great many promises. It has learned how. An adult who wears one cannot be made to swear by the god in their blood, and the bit will take the god's anger for the wearer's hands when they sign: a vow made in handtalk while wearing it breaks a bead off the leather instead of a finger. When the

beads are gone, it is only leather, and the family it belonged to is properly over.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10); every Oathener knows the custom, and Hard (14) to know what an old one can do.

**SPOILAGE** Leather; it lasts as long as it is oiled with cedar. A bit worn by fewer than four generations has no virtue.

**CARVING** Families never sell a bit while the line lives. Heirloom bits come to market when a family dies out, and the dealers find them first. Tasting one the first time is Dread 2: a child's fear, a great many times over.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** While worn, the wearer cannot speak, ignores the Oathen Wants **To Swear** and **To Be Heard**, and gains +2 to Caul + Resolve against any compulsion to speak. Each time the wearer would suffer a Breaking from a handtalk vow, a bead falls from the bit instead and the fingers are spared. A bit has 1d6 + 3 beads.

**WORTH** 60 to 200 lacks, by age. Uncommon in Tacit. Selling a living family's bit is not a crime in law; in the canyons it is the next thing to one.

### ◇ AN EMBER OF THE WIDOW'S FIRE

Asha Kindle promised her dying husband she would never let the fire go out. That was thirty-one years ago. She has not slept more than an hour at a stretch since, and the fire on her hearth has grown particular about what it is fed. It sulks on wood. It flares on letters.

It burned for three days, blue and roaring, on a lock of hair her husband gave her when they were courting, and the house was warm as Plenty in the depth of Lack. It cannot go out. Asha has tested this, once, with a bucket, at four in the morning after a bad night, and the coals lay under the water glowing like eyes.

An ember from that fire, carried in a horn box packed with ash, does not go out either. Rain, wind, a river, a smothering blanket: none of it matters, because a promise is keeping it lit. The Vigil has heard. Garron Ashlock, Lamplighter-General, with ninety days of oil and a supplier who has doubled the price, has sent an agent east with a letter of credit and a horn box. Asha gave one ember away, years ago, to a carter on the Rim, so that some of the fire would be somewhere else if hers failed. The carter has not slept more than an hour at a stretch since.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Tacit; the whole Shadeward Wall knows the widow's fire.

**SPOILAGE** None. It cannot go out. Each new Plate, it wants something more precious.

**CARVING** Asha will not give one. She does not sleep, so stealing a coal from her hearth is Hand + Filch vs Grim (18). The fire leans toward a thief, curious about what they have promised: Dread 2.

**TAINT 1** Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** It gives light and warmth that no wind or water can put out, enough to banish darkness penalties within a few paces. Fed a token of a promise (a ring, a letter, a lock of hair given in love), it blazes for a scene as a torch (3 damage, fire) and warms a house through a night of Lack. Fed only wood, it sulks to a coal, and never dies. Whoever carries it cannot sleep more than an hour at a time (−1 to all rolls each night, to −4, as for sleeplessness).

**WORTH** 500 lacks. Rare. The Vigil would pay ten times that for enough embers to light a district, and does not yet understand what they eat.

## ◇ THE COAT OF A FADED OATH-MADE

The Oath-Made are people created by promises: sons sworn into being, soldiers promised to a cause, a lover sworn to come back who

came back. They are warm and real, and they exist only for as long as the promise is kept. When the one who swore it dies, or wavers, or forgets, they begin to fade, first from memory, then from sight, and at the end there is nothing left but the clothes they were wearing, lying in a heap on the floor where they stood, still warm. Ilan, who was promised to his mother as a son, is nine, and his father died in the spring, and he has started to become difficult to see.

The coat of one who has already faded is hard to look at. Eyes slide off it. It hangs in a wardrobe and is overlooked by everyone searching the wardrobe. Worn, it makes its wearer as hard to see as its first owner was at the end, for as long as someone is keeping a promise to the wearer. The crown's spies have three. A Clausewright named Mira Dath, who owns another, has noticed that she can no longer remember the face of the boy who wore it first, though she knew him from birth, and she was the one who drafted the promise.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** The coat itself fades. Each year it is harder to find again once put down: Eye + Search vs Hard (14) to find it in one's own room, Grim (18) after a decade.

**CARVING** It is simply picked up where its owner faded, from a family who usually wants it gone and cannot bear to let it go: Tongue + Persuade vs Hard (14). Dread 2, when the carver realises they cannot picture the one who wore it.

**TAINT 2** Regrowth (Tolm), Dread 2.

**EFFECT** While worn, and while someone is keeping a promise of Weight 2 or more made to the wearer, the wearer gains +4 Stealth and +2 Guard. If that promise is broken, or its maker dies, the wearer begins to fade as an Oath-Made fades: each day thereafter until a new promise is made to them, a companion of the GM's choice forgets their face (Dread 2 when the companion notices), and the wearer gains 1 Fray.

**WORTH** 450 lacks. Rare. Spies, thieves and the crown. The Bench has no law against it, because it has never been able to find one to seize.



CHAPTER 15

# LEAVINGS OF THE FAST

*It will keep. That is the whole trouble with it. Everything out here will always keep.*

– HOLLOW ANN PRUETT, THE CARD-KEEPER, OF THE PLACE CARDS IN HER  
OILED BOX

## EVERYTHING ELSE ON THE TABLE IS A PIECE OF SOMETHING THAT WAS EATEN. OUT HERE IT IS ALL STILL WHOLE, AND ALL OF IT IS BEING OFFERED.

[ SPARE TOLLAND OF THE HOSTWATCH ]

The Fast has no relics in the sense the other lands mean. Nothing of Orrum was ever eaten, and so nothing of Orrum was ever carved. What the Host leaves behind it is not flesh but hospitality: crumbs on a cloth, a candle that does not shorten, a hearth-coal that needs no wood, a silver fork in a Seated hand, a card with a name on it in a loved and lost handwriting, a chair pulled out at an angle. Every one of these was set out for someone. Every one is still, quite literally, on offer. The Unfed have a word for the leavings of the Host that has no plural and no polite form, and they spit after saying it.

They do not trade them. To pick up a thing that has been laid is to accept it, and so the only leavings the Unfed themselves carry are the ones they have broken first: the splinter a new Tablebreaker brings home from her first table, the cards Hollow Ann gathers from the wreckage. Everything else leaves the Fast through the despised. Crumb-Runners carry Ash Mill flour out over the Hem in sacks marked as oats. Blank-poachers carry candles and cloth back with their catches. Hostwatch trackers come home with things they swear they found on the road. And the Rim buys all of it, at prices that would keep a Wanting household for a year, because every other land on the Table believes another land's curse might cure its own, and the starving Fatlands above all believe that somewhere in the middle of the world is a table where you finally feel full.

The Unfed have a second kind of leaving, and it is the only kind they honour: the leavings of their own refusal. Teeth from the chalk trench at Hallowboard. The slate from Lammas Bottom. A Starved

Saint's crumbs, saved by a novice who cannot bear to tell her. The book kept at the Lean House. These are starvation's relics, and no Unfed would sell one to save their own life, which is precisely why, every winter of the list, some of them are sold.

What everyone fears in a leaving of the Host is the opposite of what the other lands fear. Nothing of Orrum's rots. Nothing goes stale, cools, tarnishes or runs out. It does not need preserving. It needs *containing*: keeping from being set down, served, spread or laid, because every leaving of the Host remembers what it was for, and if it is given the chance it will make a table of wherever it is.

### RULES – THE HOST'S LEAVINGS

Leavings of Orrum carry **no Hunger or Regrowth Taint**: nothing of the Host was ever eaten, and there is nothing in them for the blood to recognise. Their Dread Taint works as usual. In place of the other kinds, every use of one is an **offer**. The entry gives the offer's difficulty; the user makes an **Invitation check** (Caul + Resolve), adding their Pangs to the difficulty as in the Fast's chapter. Godeaters roll it too. On a failure, the user takes a step toward the Host: the next laid table they see, within a day, they must check again at +2, and on a second failure they sit. An Unfed who carries a leaving of the Host and refuses to use it may claim it once a day as an offer refused (+1 Want), and most Tablebreakers do exactly this with their splinters. Spoilage for these leavings is always *none*; the entries say instead how they are contained.

## ▼ FROM THE LAID TABLES



The tables come in every size: a single plate in a high meadow, a family's supper in a kitchen that has had no hearth in six hundred

years, eight places steaming at a crossroads on the Rim, nine miles of cloth along the valley road. They are always perfect. The

Tablebreakers smash them with axes before anyone can sit, in a set order (lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs last, every chair), and the tables bleed gravy as they go and their candles cry out like children. What comes away from that work, or is snatched before it, is the commonest leaving of the Fast and the most dangerous to carry, because it was so recently a meal.

### ◇ A BREAKER'S SPLINTER

To join the Tablebreakers, an Unfed must break a table alone and bring back a splinter. It is the only rite of entry the order has, and it has never been made easier. The splinter is pale, of a fine close wood that no Rim joiner has been able to name, and sticky on one side with gravy that never dries. It is warm. It smells of roast fat and onion, faintly, for ever. A new Axe wears hers on a cord around the neck under the shirt, against the skin, and an Old Breaker of a hundred tables wears a whole rattling string of them, and the smell of an Old Breaker coming down a lane in Wanting makes children cry.

The Hostwatch discovered what else a splinter does in 512, the second winter of the Great Short. A splinter laid on bare ground at dusk is found at dawn with a whole table grown up around it, laid and lit, as if the wood had remembered what it belonged to and called the rest of itself back. Since then the Hostwatch have used splinters as bait: a splinter planted a mile from a village, on the far side of a hill, draws the next table there and not into somebody's kitchen. It does not always work. Sometimes the table is laid at the splinter and also in the kitchen.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) in the Fast; everyone knows the rite. The bait trick: Hard (14), Hostwatch only.

**SPOILAGE** None. Contained by being worn against the skin, never set down on wood or ground.

**CARVING** Breaking a table alone: approach it (Invitation, Hard 14), then smash it (Flesh 20, Guard 0, Armor 2) while its candles cry (Dread 2). A godsigned breaker gains 2 Hunger as the god in them grieves for the food. A Lack means the nearest chair pulls itself out, toward the breaker.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Worn, +2 to Invitation checks against tables, cards and voices (it is proof of a table refused). Planted on bare ground at dusk, it draws the next table the Host would lay within a mile to the splinter instead; the planter makes an Invitation check (Hard 14) at dawn if they go to see.

**WORTH** To the Unfed, never sold: a Breaker who sells her splinter is a Breaker no longer. On the Rim, 40 lacks to Fatlanders who suck the gravy-end. Scarce.

### ◇ A YARD OF THE LONG TABLE'S CLOTH

Along the valley road in the old heart of the country, eleven thousand of the Seated sit on both sides of one continuous table, nine miles end to end, and the cloth that covers it is unbroken and spotless for all nine. It can be cut. It is tough as sailcloth and very white and smells of starch and lavender, and the Seated on either side watch the knife with polite interest and ask whether the cutter is staying. By morning the Long Table's cloth is whole again, without a seam. The cut yard stays cut, and white, and pressed, forever.

Spread on bare ground, a yard of it is a table. Food set on it stays as it was set: hot food hot, cold food cold, bread new, butter beaded, for as long as it lies there. The Crumb-Runners would give their teeth for that and do not touch it, because food that has lain on the cloth has been *served*. But its true use was found by a widow of Brindle Cross named Bare Lammass, whose husband sat at the Long Table in 621. The Seated die when they are dragged beyond the length of the cloth. She cut a yard, and laid it under his plate, and lifted him, plate, cloth and all, and carried him home on her back, and he did not die. He sits at her bare floor in Wanting now, on his yard of white, eating air, and tells her about the soup. She says it is better than the alternative. Most days she means it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); every family with someone Seated knows the widow's story and argues about it.

**SPOILAGE** None. It never stains; gravy beads and runs off it. Contained folded, in ration-cloth, never spread.

**CARVING** Walking in among the Seated is a Hosting 18 matter: each hour, the nearest guest describes a course (Persuade +11 vs Caul + Resolve; each failure 1 Fray, three failures and a chair is pulled out). Cutting the cloth is Hand + Blades vs Hard (14). Dread 2. A Lack means the carver has cut the yard in front of an empty chair that is pulled out, for them (Invitation, Dire 22).

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Food laid on it keeps exactly as it was laid, indefinitely; anyone who eats it makes an Invitation check (Hard 14). A Seated guest with a yard of cloth under their plate may be lifted and carried anywhere, and lives, and remains Seated, wasting, delighted, wherever the cloth is spread.

**WORTH** 300 lacks. Rare. Fatlands nobles want it for the larder; families of the Seated want it for something worse.

### ◇ A HOST'S CANDLE

On every laid table there is a lamp or a candle, and it never burns down. The candles are pale beeswax, smelling of honey and warm milk, and when a table is broken they cry out as it falls, in voices like children's. A Breaker who is quick enough can snatch one whole before the axe comes down. It goes on burning in the hand. Pinched

out, it relights itself at dusk. It is never shorter in the morning than it was at night.

In its light, nobody starves. The light has the warmth of a kitchen at the end of a long day, and the hunger in the bodies inside it eases, and does not grow. In the Great Short of 511 a family of Ash Lane left off the list survived the whole winter in a cellar by a stolen candle, with nothing to eat at all. The neighbours who broke open the cellar in Grace found them alive and pink-cheeked and sitting very upright around the candle, at a table nobody had built, laid for five, with their hands folded, waiting to be served. The eldest daughter looked up and asked if the neighbours would like to join them. She was polite about it. She had always been a polite girl.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); the Ash Lane story is told to every Unfed child in a winter of the list.

**SPOILAGE** None. Contained by being kept unlit in daylight and pinched out at dusk, every dusk.

**CARVING** Snatching a candle from a table before it is broken: Hand + Filch vs Hard (14), reaching across a laid place (Invitation, Hard 14). The voice from the door, if there is a door, is Dread 2.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Within its light no one gains Pangs or levels of Starving, and existing Starving penalties are halved. For each night anyone spends asleep in its light, everyone in the light makes an Invitation check (Hard 14). If any fail, a table has formed around the candle by morning, laid for everyone who was there.

**WORTH** 200 lacks on the Rim. Rare. To the Unfed, keeping one is acceptance, and the Pantry strikes the family's names.

## ◇ A COAL FROM A KEPT HOUSE

*Never enter a house where the hearth is already lit.* In the empty farmhouses of the heartland, hearths are found burning with no wood in them and no ash beneath: a steady low glow like a banked coal that warms the hand at a yard and never burns down. The houses around them are Lit Houses, and a guest who crosses the threshold finds that the door will not open again from inside until they have eaten. A coal lifted out of such a hearth with tongs, by someone who did not come in by the door, keeps burning in an iron pot.

It is the warmest thing in the Fast. A Crumb-Runner caught on the drove roads in a blizzard of Lack, with oxen dying in the traces and his hands gone white, will look at a coal in a pot and think very hard. It needs no fuel. It cooks. It dries boots. And any roof it sleeps under becomes, a night at a time, a roof over a lit hearth. The walls begin to sweat butter. The door begins to stick. The floor creaks with a sound like a stomach. On the third night, the shelter is a Lit House, and its door does not open from inside.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); every Crumb-Runner has heard of someone who tried.

**SPOILAGE** None. It cannot be quenched. Buried in chalk from the Barrows it goes dark, warming the ground above it, and lights again when dug up.

**CARVING** The carver must reach the hearth without crossing the threshold: through the thatch or a window, Lung + Athletics vs Hard (14). Lifting the coal is Hand + Craft vs Routine (10) with iron tongs. Dread 2: the room is clean, the kettle is on, and there is a place laid.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** In its pot it warms a room or tent as a good hearth does, ignoring cold and exposure penalties in Lack, and cooks without fuel. Each night it stays under the same roof, everyone sleeping there makes an Invitation check (Routine 10, then Hard 14, then Grim 18). After the third night the shelter is a Lit House (Hosting 18, as in Things That Eat and Are Eaten).

**WORTH** 120 lacks. Scarce on the Rim; bought by Rim innkeepers in Lack, who learn. To the Unfed it is an abomination, and a household found with one is never entered again.

## ◇ ASH MILL FLOUR

In the middle country, on a chalk stream, stands a great stone watermill abandoned since the Refusal, whose wheel still turns. The millstones grind day and night with nothing between them, and from the chute falls a fine pale flour, warm to the touch, which smells of nothing at all. It is Orrum's flour. The Unfed will not go near the mill. Desperate Crumb-Runners will, with sacks, and Rim smugglers buy what they bring out and sell it in the Fatlands as Fast-flour, the cure for hunger.

It does what it is sold to do. A spoonful stirred into water and drunk makes the drinker full: for the first time in the life of a Fatlander, perhaps, really and entirely full, for an hour. They weep. Many of them laugh. They describe it afterward the way the Seated describe the soup. And at the end of the hour, the fullness drains away, and in a great many cases the drinker turns, without a word, toward the north and the middle of the Table, and starts walking. Osanna Blythe's three hundred pilgrims began with a single sack of Ash Mill flour shared out at a Low Tilth harvest-home.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) on the southern Rim; it is sold openly at the Groaning Board's back door.

**SPOILAGE** None. It never goes stale and no weevil will touch it. Contained in a sealed crock, never poured out onto a board.

**CARVING** Filling a sack at the chute is Hand + Labor vs Routine (10), but the flour is warm and falling into the carver's hands, and the mill-room is swept and has a bench by the door (Invitation, Hard 14). Dread 1.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A spoonful in water: for one hour, the drinker's Hunger cannot rise, all Starving penalties vanish, and the Fatlands Want to



feast falls silent. Then an Invitation check (Grim 18; each later dose +2) or walk toward the Fast for a day. An Unfed who drinks it loses 3 Want and has, in their own eyes and their people's, accepted.

**WORTH** 8 lacks the cup at Brindle Cross, 30 in Sated. Uncommon on the southern Rim. The Board of Plenty has never quite decided whether a cure for hunger is sedition. The Thin burn it where they find it.

## ▼ FROM THE SEATED



The Seated remain at table for decades, eating from empty plates, smiling, wasting, praising the food. They cannot be dragged away without dying. They can be robbed, quite easily, because they are as light as dry leaves and their hands are weak, and what they hold, they let go of to reach for the next course. The leavings of the Seated are the things they ate with and the things they said, and the pieces of themselves that came away as they wasted. Every one of them was taken from a person who was, at that moment, inviting the thief to stay.

### ◆ A SEATED GUEST'S FORK

The Seated eat with silver: old heartland plate, heavy forks with four long tines and a pattern of wheat-ears on the handle, the tableware of a people who worshipped a Host. They lift the forks laden with nothing and put the nothing in their mouths and chew it slowly, with every appearance of delight. A fork taken from a guest's hand is no lighter than any other silver fork. Lifted empty to the lips, it tastes of the course its guest was eating at the moment it was taken: real taste, rich and hot and perfect, filling the mouth.

Brother Hallow Crust, who has sat at a table on the valley road for forty years, was relieved of his fork in 637 by a Rim tinker who wanted the silver. He looked up, said "Oh, thank you, I'd finished with that one," and was given another by no one, between one breath and the next. The tinker sold the first in Sated for its weight. The buyer was a Gut-lines widow who could no longer taste anything she ate, after sixty years of eating without stopping. She now eats nothing but the fork. She has lost two stone, and has never been happier.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14).

**SPOILAGE** None; it never tarnishes. Contained wrapped in ration-cloth, tines down.

**CARVING** Taking a fork from a Seated hand is Hand + Filch vs Routine (10). The guest looks up and invites the thief to sit: Seated Persuade +11 vs Caul + Resolve, Dread 2, or Dread 3 if the guest is someone the thief knew. A Lack means the guest's hand closes on the thief's wrist, lightly, and they are at the table's edge (Invitation, Dire 22).

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Lifted to the lips, it gives the full taste of a perfect course. For an hour afterward the user ignores all penalties from Starving and Pangs, and feels fed. They are not. Pangs and Starving continue to accrue as normal, unfelt, and the GM tracks them in secret. Each use is an offer (Invitation, Hard 14). Lent Ashby, who cannot taste anything, would give a great deal to try one once.

**WORTH** 90 lacks. Scarce. Sold on the Rim to the jaded, the sick and the starving, who are all the same customers by the end.

### ◆ A WHISPERED MENU

The Seated describe each course in loving detail to anyone who will listen: the mutton with caper sauce, the eel in green jelly, the little birds roasted whole in vine-leaves, the pudding with a burnt-sugar skin. The descriptions are dreadful to hear because they are so good, and people who listen too long pull out a chair. In 618 a Hostwatch clerk named Meagre Odell sat at the far side of the valley road with his ears stopped with wax and a spyglass to his eye and read Brother Hallow Crust's lips for a whole season, and wrote down every course, forty pages of it, in a neat clerical hand.

He gave the pages to the Hostwatch. The Hostwatch locked them in the Pantry cellar under the Great Map and did not read them twice. Copies have since been made, by Crumb-Runners who could read and needed money, and are sold on the southern Rim, and they work as the Seated work. Read aloud, the menu makes listeners hungry in a way bread will not touch, and makes them look toward the middle of the Table. Osanna Blythe's pilgrims read it at their fires. A Cullmaster in Low Tilth has been reading it aloud in the far fields at dusk, and finds the Reaping goes more smoothly when the workers are thinking about something else.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Hard (14) on the southern Rim among pilgrims.

**SPOILAGE** None. The paper smells of gravy and the ink never fades.

**CARVING** Transcribing a menu means sitting within sight of a Seated guest for days: the guest's Persuade +11 vs the transcriber's



Caul + Resolve each hour (each failure 1 Fray; three, and a chair is pulled out). Wax and lip-reading lower it to once each day. Dread 2.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Read aloud (Tongue + Persuade, +4 from the menu), it acts as a Seated guest's invitation: each listener rolls Caul + Resolve against the reader's total, and each failure costs 1 Fray; three failures, and the listener walks toward the nearest laid table they know of. Read silently, it is an Invitation check (Routine 10) for the reader.

**WORTH** 60 lacks a copy. Scarce. Sold among pilgrims and Second Helping congregations. The Hostwatch would like the original destroyed; it will not burn.

## ◇ A GUEST'S LIFTED HAND

At the head of the Long Table, where the oldest of the Seated sit, there is almost nothing left of them: clothes holding a posture, light as a wasps' nest, a smile hung between two cheekbones. They no longer lift the fork. But when a living person walks past them on the valley road, every one of them turns, together, with a sound like a stand of dry reeds moving in a wind, and looks. A hand broken from one of these weighs nothing. It is paper stretched over twigs, the colour of weak tea. And it goes on turning.

Hung on a thread, a lifted hand turns to face the nearest laid table within a day's walk, steadily, like a weather-vane. Among the living, it does something worse: it turns to face whoever in the room is hungriest. The Tablebreakers use them to find tables. The Hostwatch use them to find the Host's work. Kale Dragoman's poachers bought two in 639, and use them on the Rim Road to pick the Unfed out of a crowd at an inn, because nobody on the Table is as hungry as an Unfed on the road, and the hand turns to them like a flower to the sun.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); Tablebreakers and poachers know.

**SPOILAGE** None. But it grows lighter over the years, until there is only the sleeve.

**CARVING** Walking to the valley head means passing nine miles of the Seated (as for the Long Table's cloth). Breaking the hand away is Hand + Brawl vs Routine (10), and Dread 3: every guest along the table turns to look at the carver. A Lack means the guest's jaw moves, once, and says the carver's name.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Hung on a thread, it points to the nearest laid table within a day's walk (+4 to Search and Wayfaring to find or avoid one).

Among people, it turns to the one with the most Pangs, or, if none are starving, the most Hunger. Each dawn its keeper wakes to find it turned toward them: Dread 1.

**WORTH** 150 lacks. Rare. Tablebreakers, Hostwatch and poachers; the Abstinent count the trade in hands as the trade in Unfed lives, which it is.

## ◇ LITTLE FAIN'S RIBBON

Little Fain, an orphan of six, went missing for a week and came back plump, clean, rosy and happy, with a ribbon in their hair and the smell of warm milk on their breath. Someone had said "Come in," and Fain had. Fain will not say who cooked, only that there was a big kitchen and a fire and that they cried when it was time to go. The ribbon is blue silk, finer than anything woven in the Fast or bought at the Rim, and it still smells of warm milk, and of something sweeter underneath, like honey on a spoon.

The Abstinent wanted it burned. It will not burn. They wanted it taken from the child. Fain held on to it with both hands and did not cry, and none of the elders, it turned out, wanted to be the one to pull. So Fain has it still, tied at the wrist, under a sleeve, and on cold nights in the orphans' hall Fain is the only child who sleeps warm and wakes with milk on the lips. The other children have noticed. Two of them have begun saving their crusts for the windowsill, as Abby Rooke does.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Wanting; everybody knows Fain.

**SPOILAGE** None. It never frays, never fades and will not burn.

**CARVING** Unique. It must be taken from a six-year-old who does not want to give it up (the GM should let the players feel that), or given by Fain, who might, to someone kind who is very hungry. Dread 2 on first smelling it.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Whoever wears it is a child of the house. They cannot starve to death: their Pangs cannot rise above 8, because each night something feeds them in their sleep, and they wake with milk on their lips. An Unfed wearer loses 1 Want each such morning. Each dawn, the wearer makes an Invitation check (Hard 14) or spends the day looking for the big kitchen, and the tables laid for them are the sweetest in the Fast: honey, custard, little iced cakes.

**WORTH** Never sold. Osanna Blythe's pilgrims would give everything they have for it, which is nothing.

# ▼ FROM THE STEWARD AND THE HILL



Between the Host and its tables walks the Steward, Welcome Ardent, a mile ahead, laying places. Behind them both, at the centre of the continent, stands Hallowboard on its chalk hill, with the Barrows below it and the Stoopway running east. The leavings of this ground belong to two traditions that the Unfed would prefer not to see side by side: the things of the god's service, which the Hostwatch handle with a devotion they do not admit to, and the things of the Refusal, which every Unfed holds sacred. A rope braided from grass that grows over the starved; a tooth from the trench where they stood; a compass that has followed the Host for thirty years; a pewter plate laid nightly at the last temple; an apron. They are all, in their way, about service. That is what makes them hard to look at.

## ◇ THE STEWARD'S APRON

Welcome Ardent wears a waiter's long apron, gravy-stained, over a thin black coat, with a cloth over his arm and very clean white gloves. He has worn an apron for six hundred years. On a morning in Carving of 640, the wardens at Wanting Post found one folded on the Hem wall, facing inward: long, white, starched, gravy-stained at the hem, folded in precise thirds, with a card tucked into the waistband. The card said, in a beautiful round hand, *For whoever would like it*. The wardens did not touch it. By noon it was gone, and nobody would say who had taken it.

It has passed through at least three pairs of hands since, and each of its owners has learned the same two things. The first is that the Host's tables do not offer to staff. A person wearing the apron can walk the Long Table and the Seated ask them for more bread instead of inviting them to sit; they can pass a laid table, a smoking chimney, a voice at a door, and nothing calls them by name. The second is that staff have duties. Lent Ashby's place card, which said *Lent* for thirteen years, now says *Steward*. Welcome Ardent has left an apron out on the road. He may be hedging.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); the Hostwatch suspect, and the wardens at Wanting Post know there was an apron.

**SPOILAGE** None. It is never more stained than it was.

**CARVING** Unique. It is somewhere on the eastern Rim, with someone who has begun laying tables in their sleep. Once put on, it cannot be taken off by another's hand; only by its wearer saying "No, thank you" to it three times aloud and meaning it (Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18). Dread 3 on first tying the strings, which tie themselves.

**TAINT** Dread 3.

**EFFECT** While worn, the wearer makes no Invitation checks of any kind: tables, cards, smells, voices and the Seated treat them as staff. Each night, they must pass Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14) or rise in their sleep and lay a table, a real one, laid and lit, with a place for everyone within sight, which is an offer to all of them (Hosting 18). After a number of nights the GM decides, Welcome Ardent comes to thank the wearer in person, and to discuss terms.

**WORTH** Never sold. Every Tablebreaker who has heard of it would trade their axe for it, and every one who has worn it would trade a great deal more to be rid of it.

## ◇ A TOOTH FROM THE TRENCH

Around seven of the eight sides of Hallowboard, the chalk of the hilltop is worn into a shallow trench where the forty thousand stood for nine days and starved. The trench is pale and hard as a step, and in some lights the prints of bare feet and knees can be seen in it, layered. The bones of the Refusal were gathered and buried in the Barrows below, but the chalk still turns up teeth after rain: small, worn, yellow-white teeth from jaws that clenched on nothing for nine days. Unfed who find them rebury them where they lay, with their bare hands, saying the Decline. *By the ones who stood*.

Not all of them are reburied. A tooth from the trench is the holiest thing an Unfed can hold, and holding one makes refusal easier: the Unfed say that the one it belonged to stands beside you, and holds your other hand, as on Tablenight. Reckoners sew them into their collars before a raid. Scour, the Returned, carries three, and they have not helped him. On the Rim, collectors who do not understand what they are buy them as curiosities, and the Unfed who see one strung on a Fatlands merchant's watch-chain have been known to follow the merchant for a very long way.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) for any Unfed; Grim (18) for anyone else.

**SPOILAGE** None. Chalk-dry and lasting.

**CARVING** Found on Hallowboard hill after rain with Eye + Search vs Routine (10). Being on the hill is Dread 2, chiefly because of the eighth side, whose chalk is smooth and white and untrodden. Taking one away is the worst desecration in the Fast, and an Unfed who does it can never again stand on Tablenight with their people.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Carried, +2 to every Invitation check, and +2 to resist any Hosting. An Unfed carrying one may use **Steady** without spending

Want once per day. An oath sworn holding the tooth is sworn by the ones who stood: for an Unfed, binding by shame as such oaths are; for anyone else, breaking it brings the Fast's Visitation (a place card bearing the dead one's name at every table the breaker passes).

**WORTH** 30 lacks to Rim collectors, who do not know. Scarce. To the Unfed, priceless, and the selling of one is spoken of in the same breath as saying "Come in."

## ◇ BARROW-HAIR ROPE

The grass on the Barrows, where the dead of the Refusal lie nine and ten deep, is the only untrimmed grass in the Fast: long, coarse, pale as straw-coloured hair, warm in the evening. The Hostwatch say that Orrum comes and sits among the mounds some nights, as a mourner sits at a grave, and the warm patch it leaves is shaped like someone lying down with their arms around something. The Tablebreakers cut the Barrow grass at the end of Carving, by permission of the Abtinent, and braid it into rope.

A Rope-Holder's tether is the line that pulls an Axe back from a chair, and a tether of Barrow-hair is the best there is. The dead of the hill, the Breakers say, hold on from the other end. A Breaker on a Barrow-hair rope has never yet been lost to a table, though several have been pulled back so hard their shoulders came out. The rope is warm to hold, the warmth of an arm, and those tied with it overnight dream of standing in the snow for nine days with their neighbours on either side and a god lying on the table in front of them, smiling.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); any Tablebreaker knows.

**SPOILAGE** Cut grass stays pale and supple for a year, then goes brittle and must be rebraided.

**CARVING** Cutting the grass is Hand + Labor vs Routine (10), and braiding it into rope is Hand + Craft vs Hard (14). Only Tablebreakers may cut, by the Abtinent's leave. Dread 1, at the warm places.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** A character tied with it gains +2 to Invitation checks. Once per scene, a companion holding the other end automatically succeeds in holding them back from a table, a door or a chair (no opposed roll). Anyone who sleeps tied with it dreams of the hill: 1 Fray, unless they are Unfed, for whom it is the best sleep they will ever have.

**WORTH** 25 lacks the fathom. Uncommon in Wanting among the Tablebreakers; Scarce on the Rim, where Fatlands pilgrims buy it to tie themselves to the road at night, and then cut it.

## ◇ A MILE-WALKER'S COMPASS

At the rank of Mile-Walker, a tracker of the Hostwatch is given a brass compass on a thong. It is an ordinary Rim compass, bought by the gross from a Lampwick Halt instrument-maker. It does not stay

ordinary. After a few years following warm ground at a mile's distance, the needle stops pointing north and points to the Host, and after twenty it warms in the hand as the Host draws near, and after thirty, as Spare Tolland's has, it begins to tremble when the Host stops and waits.

A Mile-Walker's compass passes to the Hostwatch when its owner dies, which they do in the field, usually alone, and usually smiling. Some never come back. In 633 a Tracker's body was found sitting on a stile two miles from Wanting with her compass in her lap and her face turned west, and the needle was pointing at her. The Hostwatch keep the old compasses in a drawer under the Great Map. Lately, Spare Tolland has noted in the restricted ledger that his own needle has twice, on Rim Road nights, swung away from the Host for a whole night, and pointed steadily at Hollowboard: at its eighth side, he believes, though he did not go to see.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); Hostwatch only.

**SPOILAGE** None. A compass never used to follow the Host goes back to pointing north within a year.

**CARVING** Given at rank 3 of the Hostwatch, or taken from a dead Mile-Walker in the field (Eye + Search vs Hard 14 to find the body; Dread 2). The Hostwatch ask for them back, politely, and then not politely.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** It always points to Orrum, wherever on the Table the Host is walking, and grows warm within a mile (+4 to Wayfaring to track or avoid the Host). Each day the needle is warm, the bearer makes Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14) or spends an hour walking toward it, to close the mile.

**WORTH** 200 lacks. Rare. Never sold by the Hostwatch; bought by poachers, pilgrims and the Second Table, who would very much like to know where the Host is going to be on Tablenight.

## ◇ THE VERGER'S PLATTER

On a wooded rise six miles west of Wanting stands the Empty Chair, the last temple of Orrum, a long low hall of honey-coloured stone with a single table running its length. Its Verger, Sober Osmond, lays one place every night at the head of the table, against all law: a pewter platter, a horn cup, a linen napkin folded into the shape of a bird. He lays nothing on it. Every morning the platter is clean. He believes this is why the god has stayed gentle, and the Abtinent, who have condemned him eleven times, have never once sent anyone to stop him.

The platter is old heartland pewter, dull, dented, its rim worn thin by a thousand years of hands. It is not a leaving of the Host's in the way the tables are; nobody laid it but Osmond. But something has eaten from it every night for fifty-three years, and the Verger has noticed, as nobody else has, that on the mornings it is cleanest, there are no tables found laid anywhere within a day's walk of the temple. He has never sat up to see what clears it. He says it would be rude.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); everyone in Wanting knows the Verger's habit. That it matters: Dire (22).

**SPOILAGE** None.

**CARVING** Unique. Osmond would give it only to someone who promised to lay it every night after him; stealing it from the temple is Hand + Filch vs Hard (14). What happens at the Empty Chair the first night no place is laid is the GM's to decide, and the Hostwatch would like to know in advance.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Laid each night, empty, at the head of a table in any house, it keeps Orrum's tables and place cards from appearing anywhere in that house. Each morning it is clean. If a single night is missed, the next morning every chair in the house is found pulled out, and the household must make Invitation checks (Grim 18) before they may leave the room.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Abstinent would like it destroyed and dare not. The Hostwatch would like it watched. Nobody has asked what the platter is feeding.

## ▼ FROM THE UNFED



The Unfed honour no relics but those of refusal, and those they honour by never touching. Their sacred leavings are the litter of starvation: a slate scratched white, a book of meals never eaten, the crumbs on a Saint's mouth, an apple from the last autumn of the old world, and one green blade of wheat inside two fences and a ring of tin cans. Most of them are kept by the Abstinent in the Pantry, between the ration-ledgers, or by the few Unfed who have the standing to keep such things, and they reach the Rim only in the worst winters, through the omitted and the desperate. A Rim collector who owns one of the leavings of the Unfed owns a piece of the only clean history on the Table, and the Unfed believe, not without reason, that it does not stay clean in their hands.

### ◇ SAINT'S-LIP CRUMBS

Sister Nay Corliss sits on a hurdle in a field south of Wanting and has not eaten in three years. She should have died in the first two months. She is translucent; lamplight shows the bones of her hands like twigs in amber. She does not know she is a miracle of the wrong kind: each morning she wakes with crumbs on her lips, and the novice who wipes them away, a girl of fifteen named Hesitate Fennick, has never told her. Hesitate has started to save them, in a twist of cloth, in her shirt. She does not know why. She has eleven.

The crumbs are of a very fine white bread, sweet, with a crust that cracks like sugar. A single one is a day's meal. It is also the Host's food, given in the night to someone who did not accept it, and that is the trap in it: whoever eats a crumb knowingly has accepted on the Saint's behalf. They are fed. They will be fed again. They wake the next morning, and every morning after, with crumbs on their own lips, and they cannot starve now, ever, however long they refuse, and every Unfed who has heard of it thinks it the most frightening thing the Host has ever done.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). Only Hesitate Fennick knows for certain, and she has told one person, who has told the Second Table.

**SPOILAGE** None. They do not go stale.

**CARVING** From Hesitate's twist of cloth, by Tongue + Persuade vs Hard (14); she is frightened and wants to be told what to do. Watching the crumbs appear at dawn on the Saint's lips is Dread 2.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** One crumb removes all levels of Starving and 3 Pangs, with no refeeding sickness. The eater then makes an Invitation check (Grim 18). On a failure, they are **Fed in the Night**: from then on, their Pangs never rise above 3, they wake each morning with crumbs on their lips, and an Unfed so fed can never again earn Want.

**WORTH** 100 lacks a crumb to Fatlands buyers. Scarce, and finite. The order of Starved Saints would be destroyed by the knowledge, and some of the Abstinent would prefer that than to let it be known.

### ◇ THE LAMMAS BOTTOM SLATE

In the last month of the eighth winter of the Lack, the reeve of the village of Lammas Bottom scratched on a slate a list of what the village ate, in a hand that grows larger and less steady down the page: *bark of the elm, boiled. Shoe-soles, boiled. Moss. The dog Brindle. Clay with salt. The cat. The other cat. The rush matting.* The last line is a single word, scratched over and over until the slate is white and then worn through, so that what was once a word is now a hole the size of a thumb: *no*. The slate is kept in the Pantry at Wanting, in the Chair's own cupboard, and is brought out on Tablenight.

Meek Garrity asked to see the slate in 638, for his researches, and was refused three times, and asked a fourth, and was let in. He turned it over. On the back, in the same reeve's hand, older and

steadier, there is a second list: the households of Lammas Bottom, in an order of walking, and beside each a number of the day. The Lammas families were to go up the hill on the tenth. Garrity copied it and put the slate back face-up. The Abstinents do not know he turned it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) for the Unfed, who are told about it as children. The back: Dire (22), and only from Garrity.

**SPOILAGE** None. The hole grows a little each time a thumb is pressed into it.

**CARVING** Unique. It is in the Chair's cupboard at the top of the Pantry, behind an iron door with three locks whose keys are held by three people. Dread 2 for an Unfed to hold it, Dread 3 for anyone else, who feels the cat and the other cat in their own throat.

**TAINT** Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Once per session, the holder may press a thumb into the hole and refuse one thing absolutely: an offer, a Hosting, a Want, a Pull, a Sayer's sentence about them, a Seated guest's invitation. No roll; it does not touch them. The holder gains 1 Pang. An Unfed holding the slate gains 1 Want each day they also go hungry.

**WORTH** Never sold. If it were stolen from the Pantry, the Abstinents believe, the Refusal itself would be stolen with it. If it were read on its back, they would be right.

## ◇ A NINTH-WINTER APPLE

The heartland held on longest in the Lack. Its orchards were the last on the Table to set fruit, and in the ninth winter the last apples fell from the trees and broke open on the frozen ground: a skin of perfect red around a puff of grey dust, and nothing else. A few were not broken. A family of Lammas Bottom kept one in a box of beech-wood sealed with wax, as the last fruit of the old world, and their descendants have kept it since. There are said to be four others, in the Pantry, in the College at Quire, in Mister Cutlery's silverware case, and one that nobody can find.

It is wrinkled now, the colour of dried blood, and much lighter than an apple should be. Inside it is the Lack: not a memory of it but a pinch of it, the dust of the ninth winter, the thing that ate the world's increase before the world could have it. The College's single attempt to study one, in 590, involved opening it under a bell-jar. Every grain and every scrap of food in the laboratory was ash within the hour. The Cutwright doing the work, a Gut-line cadet, found that he could not, for a whole day, feel the god in his blood at all. He said it felt like a hare holding very still in long grass. He never asked to see the apple again.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); the College has a single paper on it, sealed.

**SPOILAGE** None, but the skin is drying, and will one day split of its own accord.

**CARVING** Unique, or nearly. It must be bought, begged or stolen from one of its keepers; the Lammas descendants are omitted from the Pantry list this winter and may be persuaded (Tongue + Persuade vs Hard 14). Holding it is Dread 3: it is very cold, and something in it is hungry.

**TAINT** Dread 3.

**EFFECT** Broken, it releases the ninth winter in a ring ten paces across. All food in the ring becomes ash; seed rots; milk sours; Orrum's tables within a mile vanish. Every godsigned character in the ring cannot Partake for the rest of the scene, because the god in their blood is holding perfectly still. Everyone in the ring takes a Dread 3 check from the sense of being, for a moment, very small and very nearly found. One use.

**WORTH** 2,000 lacks. Rare. The Second Table has bought one, and has not opened it. Some of them have begun to wonder why the gods are afraid of it.

## ◇ THE LEAN HOUSE BOOK

At the far end of Wanting, beyond the Cold Yards, the Lean House is where the omitted go to wait. Withy Gaunt keeps it. She does not feed them; she washes them, changes the straw, holds their hands and listens to them talk about food, as they all do at the end, in loving detail: the pie at a wedding in their childhood, a pear eaten in a ditch, an onion roasted in the ashes of a Cold Yard fire. She writes it down. The book is thick, bound in ration-cloth, and every entry is a name, a date, and a meal, and the last words of each entry are always the same, because she asks them: *and was it good?* They always say yes.

Read aloud to a starving person, an entry feeds them a little. Not truly; the body believes it, for an hour, and the belief is worth something at the end. Withy does this sometimes for the very last. Lately she has found entries in the book she did not write. They continue the entries of people who have died, in a round, loving hand, describing what they are eating now: at a long table, in a warm room, with everyone they knew. She has not shown the Abstinents. She has started, at night, to read those entries aloud to herself.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Wanting; the Lean House is not secret, only unmentioned.

**SPOILAGE** Paper, kept dry. It has never once been damp, even in the wet of Lack.

**CARVING** Unique. Withy will lend it to someone who asks four times. Reading it through is Dread 2; reading the entries in the second hand is Dread 3.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** An entry read aloud to a starving listener removes 1 Pang from them for the day, and the reader gains it. Read through, the book names every person omitted from the Pantry list since Withy



began, and against eleven of the names, in the margin, she has noted who struck them. The entries in the second hand, read aloud, are an offer (Invitation, Hard 14) to the reader and every listener.

**WORTH** Never sold. Forbear Wend would pay anything to know it exists; Wont Bellamy would pay more.

## ◇ THE GREEN BLADE OF HARTSELL'S FIELD

Yield Hartsell has ploughed, harrowed and sown her ten acres north of Wanting every spring for fifty years, and every spring the seed has rotted. This year, in one corner, one seed came up. It is a single blade of green wheat, now five inches tall, inside a fence of hurdles, inside a second fence of thorn, inside a ring of tripwire hung with tin cans. It is the only living crop in the Fast. It is watered every night. Yield does not do it. She has sat up three times to see who does, and fallen asleep each time, and woken at dawn to wet earth around the stem.

The Hostwatch have looked for warm ground around the fence and found none. What they have found, each morning, is frost: a crisp white patch on the grass just outside the thorn, though the Fast has no frost in Carving, in a shape they have drawn in the restricted ledger many times and do not care to name. It is the shape a chair leaves in frost when it has been pushed back from a table, and someone has got up, and gone. The Abstinents want the blade

burned. The Hostwatch want it watched. The Second Table wants it stolen. The pilgrims want to kneel to it. Yield wants to know who watered it, and is beginning to be afraid that she does.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Wanting; the blade is a public secret. The frost: Dire (22), Hostwatch only.

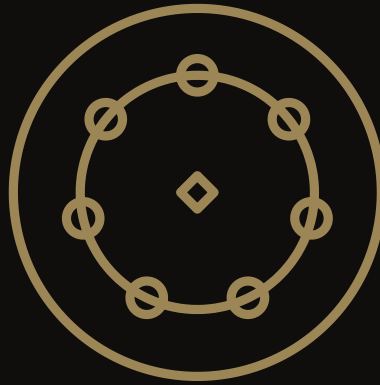
**SPOILAGE** It is alive. Kept in its own clod of earth, watered, it lives. Uprooted, it dies in a day.

**CARVING** Unique. Reaching it means passing Yield, two fences and a tripwire (Lung + Stealth vs Hard 14), and lifting it with its clod intact (Hand + Craft vs Grim 18). Standing by the frost-shape at dawn is Dread 3 for anyone who understands it, and Dread 1 for anyone who does not.

**TAINT** Dread 3.

**EFFECT** It is food that no one offered. An Unfed may eat it without accepting, and lose no Want, and it is the first grain of the heartland eaten since the Lack. Planted elsewhere in the Fast with its clod, seed sown within a stone's throw of it comes up. In Hartsell's corner, the morning after it is moved, the seed in the earth there is found rotted again.

**WORTH** Never sold. Every faction on the Table would pay for it, and none of them have asked the question the Hostwatch are asking, which is not who watered it but who used to sit there, and where they have gone.



CHAPTER 16

# LEAVINGS OF THE RIM AND THE EMPTY CHAIR



*Every land is certain the cure is next door. The Rim is where next door keeps its stock.*  
— MISTER CUTLERY, TO A CUSTOMER AT GRISTMOOT, CLOSING HIS SILVERWARE CASE

## COUNT<sup>THE</sup> CHAIRS IF YOU MUST. BUT DO NOT COUNT<sup>THEM</sup> ALOUD, AND NEVER COUNT<sup>THEM</sup> TWICE.

[ A SAYING OF RIM ROAD INNKEEPERS, OLDER THAN THE COMPANY ]

The Rim Road is where leavings go to be sold. Every relic in this book passes along it sooner or later: in a Company wagon under a false bill, in a smuggler's boot, in the black coach of the soft-voiced man with a silver fork embroidered on his mask, who will buy back anything he sold at triple its price, provided the seller names exactly where it came from. The Company declares nothing and opens nothing. Its standing order at the Chute, *do not open anything*, is the closest thing the Rim has to a relic law, and every factor on the ring observes it as piously as the grace.

But the road has leavings of its own. The great institutions that cross every border make instruments, and their instruments learn things: a rope that has hanged four hundred people under Company law, a quire of the College's ledgers, the bowl the Purgation was born in, a menu with eight lines and seven courses.

Older than any of them, the Rim carries the oldest things on the Table: fragments of the Providers themselves, from before the Gorging or from the night of it, which travel the ring endlessly because no land will have them home. A strip of the Closing Hand's palm cannot go back to Sallowreach; the Mortuary Court would call it a stolen license. A flake of the Lidded's eye cannot go back to the Vigil; its owner would be hanged. They go around and around, from inn to inn, and are worth more every circuit.

And there are a very few leavings that no dealer on the road will name, that Mister Cutlery has refused at any price, and that the Cutwrights' College has a single sealed ledger about. They come from the eighth place. They are presented last in this book, for the GM alone.

## ▼ FROM THE ROAD AND THE LEDGER



The Rim Road Company owns the road, every inn and post on it, and every toll; the Cutwrights' College owns the record of every bloodline that walks it. Neither owns a god. Both have handled the Table's horror for six centuries as a pricing problem and a filing problem respectively, and their instruments have absorbed the habit. They are practical, ruthless, and very slightly wrong in ways their makers have not noticed. The Company's leavings are sworn in Oathen, and so carry Tolm's attention around the ring. The College's are written in blood, tasted and graded, and so carry every god at once.

### ◇ A STONE OF THE HEM

On its inner side, facing the Fast, the Rim Road is bordered by a low wall of fitted grey Oathen stone about knee-high, running the whole two thousand four hundred miles. It is called the Hem. It does nothing; anyone can step over it. Nobody does. The Company replaces any stone that goes missing within a day, from stockpiles at every post, and its masons are under standing orders to lay each stone with its dressed face *inward*, toward the middle of the Table, as the original builders did. Nobody remembers why.

On the morning after the table was found laid with eight places at Saltlick Cross in 639, the wardens found that the forty Hem stones nearest the crossroads had been turned around in the night, every one, and lay with their dressed faces outward, toward the Rim.

The masons turned them back. They have had to turn them back eleven times since, at Saltlick Cross, at Wanting Post, at the Groaning Board, and once at Fogmouth. A Hem stone pried loose and carried away keeps whatever face it had. Laid across a threshold or at the head of a bedroll, it does what the Hem was perhaps once meant to do: nothing on the side it faces can be accepted across it.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18). The turning of the stones: Hard (14) for any Company mason or warden.

**SPOILAGE** None. Each night, roll a d10: on a 1 it has turned around by morning.

**CARVING** Prying a stone from the Hem is Gut + Labor vs Routine (10), and theft of road. The wardens hang thieves of cargo and make cargo of thieves of road. Dread 1, if the stone's face is outward when it comes up.

**TAINT** Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Laid on the ground, its dressed face toward something, it makes a line. No offer from that side can be accepted across the line: a laid table, a voice saying "Come in," a Seated guest's invitation, a Hosting creature's food. Characters behind it make no Invitation checks against things beyond it. If the stone turns in the night, the line faces the other way, and the characters are on the wrong side of it.

**WORTH** 60 lacks. Scarce. Crumb-Runners, Hostwatch and pilgrims who have changed their minds. The Company prefers not to discuss why a wall that does nothing should be worth stealing.

## ◇ THE ROPE AT THE POST

*Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.* Murder on the Rim Road is punished by the Company's wardens with a rope at the nearest post, and every post's rope is sworn, like every other Company instrument, before the Company's notary at Treaty Stair. It is good Fatlands hemp, tarred, a little thicker than a thumb, and every warden-sergeant ties a small knot in the tail of the post's rope for every hanging it has done. Retired ropes are meant to be burned at Treaty Stair. The rope from Knocking Gate, which Hobb Fallowmere retired in 638 with four hundred and nine knots in its tail, was not.

A sworn rope knows the Company's three articles the way a dog knows its master's step. Looped loosely around the wrist of someone who has broken one of them within a bowshot of the road (killed there, stolen Company cargo, refused the grace at a Company table), it tightens. Around the wrist of someone who has not, it lies slack. Around a captive's wrists on Company ground, it cannot be slipped. Fallowmere used the Knocking Gate rope as an instrument of justice for nineteen years, and his sergeants say he never once hanged an innocent man. They also say that the rope creaks at night, in the barracks store, and that when it does, it creaks four hundred and nine times.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14); any Company warden knows the knots, and Grim (18) to know what the rope does.

**SPOILAGE** Off the Rim, it is only rope. On it, it keeps as long as it is tarred each season.

**CARVING** A retired rope must be got from a barracks store before it reaches the Treaty Stair fires: Hand + Filch vs Grim (18), among wardens. Holding it is Dread 2: it is heavy in a way that has nothing to do with its weight.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Within a bowshot of the Rim Road, a captive bound with it cannot escape by any means short of cutting it (Hand + Blades vs Grim 18). Looped around anyone's wrist on the Rim, it tightens if they have done murder, theft of cargo or the refusal of the grace on the road, and lies slack if they have not. It cannot be deceived. It cannot judge anything that happened off the road.

**WORTH** 400 lacks. Rare. Bounty-hunters, inn-factors and Reckoners waiting for nobles at inns. Theft of Company property; the wardens retrieve their ropes, and use them.

## ◇ A QUIRE OF THE MASTER CONCORDANCE

The Cutwrights' College keeps the record of every bloodline on the Table in the Master Concordance, in a vault cut into the hill under the library at Quire, kept cool by spring water. A *quire* is a gathering of its leaves: forty sheets of College paper folded and stitched, written in the Concordance's tiny hand, giving the full lines of one land's highest houses from the Meal to the present, with the Blood-Taster's grades, the Cut of every member, their stage of Regrowth, and the College's private rate of advance. Silas Fenwright, the Ledger-Thief, walked out of Quire in a Copyist's grey with three of them. He is trying to sell them to whoever will let him live.

A quire is a target roll for the Reckoners, a massacre list for the Lancets, a menu for the Second Table, and for the College the most dangerous thing in the world to have loose, because of the last page. The last leaf of every quire is a graph in red ink, drawn in the Archprovost's own hand: that land's Regrowth across six centuries, a long gentle slope, and then, after 600 A.G., a bend upward. Laid side by side, the graphs from the seven quires bend upward in the same year.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); every faction on the Rim is looking for Fenwright.

**SPOILAGE** Paper, well made. The red ink of the last leaf darkens every year, as though the line were being drawn over again.

**CARVING** Copying from the Concordance is Eye + Lore vs Dire (22) inside Quire, under the eyes of Linemen who know exactly what every Copyist is. Buying from Fenwright is a negotiation with a terrified man whom four factions want dead.

**TAINT** Dread 2; Dread 3 on reading the last leaf.

**EFFECT** With the quire for a land, +4 to any Lore or Search roll touching its noble houses: proving or disproving a line, finding a bastard heir, naming the houses nearest a Seating. Reading the last leaf with Eye + Reckoning vs Grim (18) shows the reader that every

land's Regrowth bent upward at once, and so that the seven are one event: Dread 3.

**WORTH** 5,000 lacks a quire. Rare. Possession is a College death warrant, quietly executed. The Reckoners would pay in blood rather than coin; Deny Fallon already has one, and wants the rest.

## ▼ FROM THE SECOND TABLE AND THE PURGATION



Two movements cross every border with opposite answers to the same question. The Purgation believes the gods can be thrown back up; the Second Table believes they can be eaten again. One has an altar-bowl for its emblem and the other a signet ring engraved *It worked once*. Both are full of nobles who know exactly how far along their own blood is, and both have made instruments of the meal: the bowl that catches what comes up, the menu that lists what will go down, the knife that does the carving. The Rim's dealers handle their leavings more carefully than any god's, because the people who want them back are not gods. They are on the road, and they keep notebooks.

### ◆ A MENU OF SEVEN COURSES

The first trace of the Second Table in any record is a menu found in the coat of a murdered Gut-line lordling in 412 A.G. The College has since collected forty more. They are cards of heavy cream stock with gilt edges, written in a fine sloping hand that the College has matched to no one living or dead, and they always list seven courses, each named for a god, in an order that varies a little from card to card. A typical one, taken from a Brinehollow admiral's widow in 630, reads: *I. A clear broth of the Fathom. II. The Laden, roasted, with its own bread. III. Lids in aspic. IV. The Opening, stuffed. V. A tongue, pressed. VI. The Closing Hand, served cold. VII. The Host, carved at table.*

On the menus found in the last ten years there is an eighth line at the bottom, ruled in the same hand, and left blank. Diners of the Second Table believe the blank is the place for the dish they have not yet found. The College tried, once, in 637, to learn more by writing on it. A Lineman wrote a word on the eighth line of a seized menu in ink. In the morning the line was blank again, and the Lineman had not been able to eat breakfast, because every mouthful he lifted tasted of nothing at all, and the feeling did not pass for nine days. Nobody at Quire has tried a second time.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); members of the Table know without a roll.

**SPOILAGE** None. The card never yellows.

**CARVING** Taken from a Second Table member (they carry them sewn into a coat lining), or bought from Mister Cutlery, who has several. Dread 1 on reading the courses; Dread 3 on noticing the eighth line.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** Presented at any Second Table dinner, it admits the bearer as a Taster, no questions asked; they will be served a dish, and expected to finish. Among members, +4 to Persuade and Deceive. Anything written on the eighth line is gone by morning, and the writer's food tastes of nothing for nine days (-1 to all rolls; Starving cannot be removed by eating). The card cannot be burned or torn.

**WORTH** 500 lacks. Rare. The Second Table buys its menus back, and its sellers.

### ◆ A CARVER'S KNIFE OF GREY BONE

The Second Table has commissioned knives. Every Carver, the rank that leads a table in a land, keeps one: a long, thin, single-edged blade of grey bone fitted to a silver handle engraved with a course-name, sharpened on stones that cost more than the knife. Lord Absalom Thrале, the Grand Carver, keeps the knife from the first practice dinner, and the College would identify its blade, if shown it, as one of Ossel's knuckles. The others are less certain in origin. The Table bought Provider bone wherever it could find it, from the treasuries of old Hand-line houses and Morwen strong-rooms and the bottom of the Gullet, and had the knives made by a single cutler in Sated who died, conveniently, after the eighth.

A grey bone knife cuts godflesh as a good bread-knife cuts bread. It goes into a Laden hill, a Tenanted's chest, the caul of a Morwen duchess, as easily as into butter, and what it cuts does not knit well afterward. It also carves leavings better than any tool on the Table, and the Second Table's practice dinners have been supplied, for two

centuries, by Carvers who could take a finger, a lid or a lash from a god-touched body without wasting a sliver.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); Grim (18) for anyone who has dined with the Table.

**SPOILAGE** None. Bone that was a god does not age.

**CARVING** Taken only from a Carver, by violence (a Second Table Diner, per Things That Eat and Are Eaten) or by inheritance within the Table. Holding it is Dread 2: it is warm along the edge, and very slightly hungry.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (of the god whose bone it is; most are Ossel).

**EFFECT** A knife (3). Against any creature with a Cut or a Regrowth, or godsign of any kind, it ignores Armor and each Helping adds +3 damage; Flesh lost to it heals at half the normal rate. Used on any Carving roll in this book, it gives +4 and halves the Dread of the work, because the hand holding it has stopped thinking of what it cuts as anyone.

**WORTH** 6,000 lacks. Rare. Never sold by the Table, which hunts its lost knives with the same patience it brings to the menu. There are eight. The Table has only ever seated seven Carvers at once.

## ◇ THE FIRST BOWL

In 233 A.G., at the Weeping Post, a Fatlands physician named Hurlo Sweyn took a draught of his own devising before a congregation of Confessors and retched for six hours into a brown earthenware basin, and at the end of the sixth hour brought up a hard white thing the size of a thumbnail which he swore was one of Ummer's teeth. That was the Great Retching, and the basin is the First Bowl. It is plain, glazed, cracked and riveted in three places,

with *What goes down can come up* painted around the rim in Sweyn's own hand, and it sits on the altar of the Confessors' chapel at the Weeping Post, in the brown water, under a lid of beaten tin.

Penitents who take the Black Draught over the First Bowl bring up more than food. Sister Tisane Halloway, Mistress of the Draught, has seen it eleven times in six years, in Penitents from four lands: a small grey hinged thing like a finger-joint, which moves. They are not the same god's. They come from Fatlanders, from a Brinehollow cooper, from a Vigil clerk, from a Sallowreach girl. They are all the same thing. Halloway keeps them in a sealed jar. They have grown. They fit together, and the jar, she has noted in a hand that is not quite steady, is getting full.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10) for any Purger; the jar, Dire (22), and only from Halloway.

**SPOILAGE** None. The rivets are replaced every century.

**CARVING** Unique. It sits on an altar at a crossroads full of penitent travellers and Purgation brothers; stealing it is Lung + Stealth vs Grim (18), and would put every Lancet on the Rim on the thief's trail. Holding it is Dread 1.

**TAINT** Dread 2.

**EFFECT** A Black Draught taken over it is Gut + Endure vs Grim (18). On a success the Penitent loses all Hunger and brings up a leaving of their own god: a pebble-sized thing (Taint 1 Regrowth of their land) worth 50 lacks to a dealer. On a Grace, they also lose 1 Regrowth, once per stage, as the rules allow a Purger. On a failure, Ruin. On a Lack, what comes up is one of Halloway's grey hinged things, and it moves toward her jar.

**WORTH** Never sold. Saint Ancel Ruel preaches over it twice a year, and does not look into it.

## ▼ FROM THE SEATED GODS



On the Night of Seven Tables six gods were butchered and shared out, and nearly all of each was eaten. Not quite all. In every land someone kept something back: a strip of hide, a hook with flesh on it, a flake of eyelid, a phial of what the wound ran with, one of a thousand newborn gods carried out in an apron. Those are the oldest leavings on the Table, older than any Cut, and they are pieces of the Providers as they were when they lay down, before six centuries of blood thinned them. The trade calls them *Seated leavings*, because the College holds that when a land completes its Seating the god will want every piece of itself back, and these pieces, wherever they are on the Rim, will go. Six are described here. There are others, in strongboxes and reliquaries and Mister Cutlery's case. As the Regrowth quickens, every one of them has begun to stir.

## ◇ A STRIP OF OSSEL'S PALM

The Closing Hand lay in the fens with its hands palm up on the peat, each one wide enough to cup a cottage, and for three thousand years the fen-folk carried their dead to it on reed hurdles and laid them by a hand, and the hand closed their eyes and folded their arms, and they were sunk in black water and gone in a season, leaving the water sweet. On the night of the Meal, the families who took the hands became the Hand-lines. A few took strips of the palm-skin first, grey and dry and lined like a riverbed seen from a hill, and kept them in their treasuries as the last thing of the god's that had closed a pair of eyes. The Mortuary Court counts them, as it counts its nobles' fingers. It does not count them all.

A strip is the length of a forearm and the width of a hand, grey leather, cold, the lines of the palm running across it like roads. Laid over the eyes of the dying anywhere outside Sallowreach, it gives them the death the fen-folk had before the Meal: the eyes close, the arms fold, the body goes into the ground and is gone in a season and the earth above it is sweet. Laid over one of the Kept, inside Sallowreach, it finishes them, slowly, over a year of perfect quiet. Sister Lorn of the Shut Eye has wanted one for forty years. So has Henna Farrow.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Grim (18); the Mortuary Court's Clerk of Hands knows every strip by number, and exactly which three are missing.

**SPOILAGE** None outside Sallowreach. Inside, it begins very slowly to finish, and is smaller every decade.

**CARVING** From a Hand-line treasury: Lung + Stealth vs Dire (22). Holding it the first time is Dread 2: the holder's own fingers want to close something.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 1.

**EFFECT** Laid over the eyes of a dying person outside Sallowreach, it gives them a clean death: no Visitation, no lingering, no rising; mourners who see it remove 2 Fray. Laid over a Kept in Sallowreach and left, it Closes them over a year of silence. The holder's hands go grey to the second knuckle for a day after each use, and they gain the Sallowreach Want to close lids and eyes, at Hard (14), for that day.

**WORTH** 3,000 lacks. Rare. The Court calls each one a stolen license, and each finished Kept a theft from the Regent.

## ◇ SWEYN'S TOOTH

What Hurlo Sweyn brought up into the First Bowl in 233, after six hours of retching, was a hard white thing the size of a thumbnail, and he swore it was one of Ummer's teeth. Ummer was the Laden, the god of harvest, and its iconography is a full belly with a sheaf rising out of it, and a mouth, always a mouth, smiling. If a piece of that god could be thrown up, then all of it could, and on that proof the Purgation was founded. The tooth sits in a silver cup beside the First Bowl at the Weeping Post. The Purgation calls it the Proof.

The College examined it in 590 with the Purgation's permission and the Purgation's Lancets standing by, and filed a report that has never been released. It notes that toothed wheat first came up in the Fatlands in 204, twenty-nine years before the Great Retching, and that Sweyn was a Fatlands physician with a taste for bread. It notes also that the tooth has, in the three and a half centuries since, grown a root. It is a long, fine, red root, like a hair, and it has gone down through the bottom of the silver cup and into the altar. Whatever it is, it is still Ummer's.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Routine (10); every Purger knows the Proof. The root: Grim (18).

**SPOILAGE** None. It is growing.

**CARVING** Unique. Taking it means cutting its root out of the altar at the Weeping Post (Hand + Blades vs Hard 14) in front of a congregation; the Lancets would follow the thief to the edge of the world. Holding it is Dread 2: it is warm and it bites, gently.

**TAINT** 3 Hunger, 1 Regrowth (Ummer).

**EFFECT** Placed under the tongue during any meal, it lets the eater taste exactly what the food was before it was food, and name it (+4 to any roll to identify meat, poison or Taint by taste). Held in the mouth during a Black Draught, it gives +4 to the Gut + Endure roll. Planted in any soil, the soil begins to grow teeth.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Board of Plenty would pay to have it destroyed and the Second Helping would pay to have it eaten.

## ◇ A BEACHING HOOK

The western coast dragged Dromm up onto the shingle at Longslab on ten thousand hooks, and it took four days to stop moving. The hooks were forged in the fifth year of the Lack from every scrap of iron on the coast, harpoon-barbed and as long as a man's forearm, and the crews who drove them in hauled on ropes from the dunes in shifts. Longslab has never dried. Every winter storm turns up a few hooks in its wet sand, rusted, still barbed, still with a rag of grey flesh on the barb that has not rotted in six hundred and forty-one years, and is cold, and pulls.

A Beaching hook holds what it is set in as the deep holds. A thing hooked by it is pressed down, held under a weight that is not there. The Netwatch would give anything for them; a single hook on a pole holds a Called man as surely as ten hookmen. Lieutenant Sable Reef has one. She has noticed that the Called she holds with it do not fight it the way they fight rope. They go still, and look at the hook, and weep, as if it were something they recognised. The Second Table has quietly bought seven, which is more than anyone needs to hold a person.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) in Brinehollow; Grim (18) elsewhere.

**SPOILAGE** None, while the flesh on the barb is wet. Dried, it is only rusted iron; it must be kept in a jar of seawater or Tenanted brine.

**CARVING** Dug from the wet sand at Longslab, where gulls will not land, with Eye + Search vs Hard (14). Longslab is Dread 1; touching the flesh on the barb is Dread 2. A Lack means the hook catches the digger's hand, and must be cut out.

**TAINT** 2 Regrowth (Dromm).

**EFFECT** Mounted on a pole (boathook 4, Hooking), a target it hooks is held at Grapple 22 and can be hauled by one person as easily as by ten. A Tenanted or Called creature hooked by it cannot act, only weep. A Lung-line who carries it feels the Pull (14) toward the Trench once a day.



**WORTH** 900 lacks. Rare. The Netwatch, the Admiralty, and the Second Table, which has not explained what it means to hold down.

### ◇ A SCALE OF ISS'S LID

Iss, the Lidded, lay curled in the high valley above old Ludmere, and no one in recorded history ever saw its eyes open. The lids were immense, grey and soft as a moth's wing, and they shed, very slowly, in flakes like the scales of a fish, which drifted down into the valley and lay among the beds of the dreaming. Ludmere's oracles gathered the flakes and burned them as incense, and slept in the smoke, and woke with prophecy. On the night the Eye-lines ate the eyes, still shut, a few oracles kept a few flakes. Three are known. The Warden-Prime knows where two of them are.

A scale is the size of a thumbnail, translucent, faintly veined, and always warm, as if it had just been lying against something asleep. Held up and looked through at a sleeping person, it shows their dream, plainly, as if through a window. Looked through at one of the Counted, in the Dormitory, it shows a long dim room with a single enormous closed eye in the far wall, and the sleeper standing in it, among sixty thousand others, all facing the same way. Senna Vole has looked through one. She says the room was quieter than she remembered, and that for the first time some of the sleepers had turned around.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22). The Warden-Prime knows of all three without a roll.

**SPOILAGE** None. It cools if it is kept away from a sleeping body for more than a month, and then shows nothing until it has lain beside one for a night.

**CARVING** Unique, or nearly. One is in the Vigil's treasury, one with the Eye-line House Dalgety, and one is unaccounted for. Holding it is Dread 1: the holder yawns, and cannot stop.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Iss).

**EFFECT** Looked through at any sleeper, it shows their dream (+4 to any roll to learn their fears, secrets or intentions). Looked through at the Counted, it shows the long room. Each use, the looker rolls Caul + Resolve vs Hard (14) or blinks, as the Vigil's Appetite blinks: for a second they are in the long room too, and come back having moved.

**WORTH** 2,500 lacks. Rare. Possession is a capital crime in the Vigil. Matron Cecily Dorm would pay with something other than money to know whether the number in the room matches hers.

### ◇ ONE OF THE DRIFT

On the night the highlands killed Vey, it would not stay killed: from each wound a smaller Vey crawled, and by dawn the floor of the old birthing-house was a drift of gods the size of hares, of mice, of fingernails, each with its arms spread, each still trying to begin. Hollan Kest crushed the last, the size of a barleycorn. The rest went

into the copper. One did not. A girl of twelve carried it out of the birthing-house in the pocket of her apron, the size of a mouse, because she could not bear it, and dried it in a salt-box, and it is in the vault under the library at Quire, in a box of grey stone, beside the Master Concordance, and it has never stopped.

It is soft and red and warm, and faceless, and it lies with its arms spread to either side like a figure standing in a doorway. Every pang in Cradlewrack, wherever it is, it begins again: it is a little different, newly wet, as if just born. It is a god, alive, in a box. The Archprovost has never written down what she uses it for. Her Linemen say that the College's oldest copyists, the ones who should have died a decade ago, visit the vault on the first of every month and come out looking as if they had just begun.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Impossible (26); Hesper Lune and two of her Linemen know.

**SPOILAGE** None. In grey stone it keeps; out of it, the Highland Leavings Abroad roll applies, at 1–5.

**CARVING** Unique. The vault at Quire is cut into the hill under the library and guarded by the College's whole apparatus; reaching it is Lung + Stealth vs Impossible (26). Seeing it is Dread 4: it is very small, and it turns its faceless head toward the one who opened the box.

**TAINT** 4 Regrowth (Vey), Dread 4.

**EFFECT** Once each Plate, laid against something that has stopped, it begins it again: a heart stopped within the minute, a dry spring, a dead fire, a barren field or womb, a stopped clock, a broken oath's Forsworn mark (it heals). Each use, roll a d6: on a 1, what begins is not what was meant, and the GM decides what it is.

**WORTH** Never sold. If the Assemblers knew it existed, they would go to war with the College for it. If the Attendance knew, they would bring the knife.

### ◇ A PHIAL OF THE WITNESS'S WATER

When the canyon folk cut Tolm's throat in the Gullet, what came out was not blood but something thick and clear that smelled of wet slate and tasted, those who caught it on their lips said afterward in handtalk, of the moment after you have said a thing you cannot take back. The poor licked it off the stone and were Scraplings ever after. A woman named Deverel Ashe, who laid her forearm open to the bone that night and knelt with her teeth clamped on her sleeve until her jaw cracked, caught some of it in a horn cup, one-handed, without a sound. Her family has kept it in a stoppered phial of canyon-glass ever since. Five drops are left.

A drop on the tongue makes the drinker's speech the Witness's for a day. What they say, plainly and without condition, is so. That is the gift. The cost is that the Witness does not distinguish between what the drinker says aloud and what they say to themselves, and

nobody alive goes a whole day without telling themselves something. The last of the Ashe line to drink, in 601, told herself at noon, in a moment of despair, that she would never be loved. She was a very beautiful and very warm woman with a husband and four children, and by sundown not one of them could bear to stand near her, and none of them could say why.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Dire (22); Sister Verity Amn of the Quiet knows, and has asked for a drop.

**SPOILAGE** Sealed, forever. Unstoppered, the whole phial evaporates in an hour, and everyone within a room's breadth hears their own last words come back to them, slightly flat, for a week.

**CARVING** Unique. The Ashe house is a minor Tongue-line on the Sunward Wall with a strongroom of felt and lead; Hand + Filch vs Grim (18), with the house silent around the thief. Holding it is Dread 2: the holder hears their own last sentence, half a second late.

**TAINT** 3 Regrowth (Tolm).

**EFFECT** For one day after a drop, once per scene, a plain statement the drinker makes about something they can see becomes so, as the Course's **Say So**, with no roll and at any scale up to Grim. For the same day, the GM may make one thing the drinker thinks about themselves come true, in a small and fitting way.

**WORTH** 4,000 lacks the drop. Rare. The Bench would seize it, the Second Table would drink it, and the Ashe family has been asked, by a polite man in a good grey coat, what it would take.



# ▼ THE EMPTY CHAIR

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## FOR THE GM ALONE

The two leavings that follow come from the eighth place: the gap in the ring of figures on every carving older than the Gorging, and the chair that is always pulled out. They are not for sale and not for use. Do not give them to players as treasure. Let the characters find them at the end of long trails, hold them, feel what they do, and want very badly to put them down. Their stat lines are complete, because the players will ask, but the honest answer to “what does it do?” is in the Secrets chapter, and the honest answer to “how do we use it?” is that you do not. Use them as signs. Every time one is touched, the world is a little nearer to its last meal.

## ◇ CHISEL-DUST

The eighth figure has been cut from every carving older than the Gorging: hacked with a boathook in Brinehollow, ground out with a rasp in the Vigil so patiently that the recess shines, gouged in Kest so deep that the hole breathes warm air on cold days, smoothed from Hallowboard’s panel as if by a thumb in wet clay. Different tools, different centuries, some before the Gorging and some after. In a few old places nobody has swept beneath the recess since it was cut, and there is a little drift of dust on the floor below the gap. It is not stone-dust. It is grey, and very fine, and slightly too heavy, and it is never cold.

Hesper Lune has collected it for twenty years, from beneath four hundred carvings, in a stoppered jar in her bedroom at Quire. Dust from two carvings, set in one dish, draws together overnight into a single line. Dust from many draws together into a shape. She has not let anyone see the shape in the jar. She has stopped going to dinners. Her kitchen staff report that bread left on the table in the room where the jar is kept is found in the morning still in its shape, crust and all, and empty inside: not stale, not spoiled, but hollow, as if the inside of it had been eaten without the outside being touched.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Impossible (26). Hesper Lune knows. So, perhaps, does whoever chiseled the first carving.

**SPOILAGE** None. Wherever it is kept, there is slightly more of it each month.

**CARVING** Sweeping the floor beneath an unswept eighth recess is a moment’s work with a brush and a paper, and requires no roll. It requires a Dread 3 check. A Lack means that for one heartbeat, as the brush touches the dust, the recess above is not empty.

**TAINT** Dread 4, and 2 Hunger of no land: the carrier gains 2 Hunger each day it is near them, even if they are Unfed or a Blank, who have no Hunger to gain.

**EFFECT** None that anyone wants. Food left within a pace of it overnight is found hollow. A godsigned character carrying it cannot Partake: when they call on the god in their blood, it does not come, and lies very still, and their Hunger rises by 1 instead. At any table where the dust is present, the other diners leave an empty space beside its carrier without knowing why. Dust from enough carvings, combined, makes a shape (Dread 5) which the GM should describe as little as possible.

**WORTH** Never sold. Mister Cutlery, offered a twist of it at Gristmoot in 638, closed his case and left the market, and did not come back to Gristmoot for a year.

## ◇ THE EIGHTH CHAIR

At every inn on the Rim Road, on Tablenight, the innkeeper sets one extra chair at every table and turns it to face the wall. Nobody remembers why. A chair turned to the wall is a place laid for someone who has been asked to leave. On the morning after Tablenight in 640, at the Long Farewell at Fogmouth, the innkeeper came down to find the extra chair at the long table in the common room turned around, square to the table, facing in. It could not be turned back. It could not be pushed in. Six men with ropes could not move it a hair. When the inn was closed for the season, the innkeeper had the floor cut out around it and the whole thing carried out in a block of planking to a cellar under the Company counting-house at Toll Nine, where it stands now, in a locked room, on its square of floor.

It is a plain oak chair a little taller than the others at that table, worn on the seat and the arms as if by very long sitting, though no one has ever sat in it. It is pulled out from a table that is no longer there, at the angle a good host gives a chair for an honoured guest. Food set before it is gone by morning. The Company factor at Toll Nine has measured, weekly, how far it is pulled out. Like Cray Lobbett’s chair on the seabed, it is pulled out a little further each time.

**WHISPERED** Eye + Lore vs Impossible (26). The factor at Toll Nine, the innkeeper of the Long Farewell, and Odalys Penhallow, who has been to see it and has ordered her sealed wagons built faster.

**SPOILAGE** None. It does not age, and cannot be burned, broken, moved or turned.

**CARVING** It cannot be carved, taken or moved. It can be visited. Entering the room is Dread 4. Trying to sit in it is Caul + Resolve vs Impossible (26), and on any result the character finds themselves standing beside it, a little further from the door than they were, with no memory of having stood up: Dread 5.

**TAINT** Dread 5.

**EFFECT** None that can be used. Anyone who eats in the same building as the chair finds their food tastes of nothing for a day. Every week the GM should mark how far the chair is pulled out. When it is pulled out as far as a chair can be, it is no longer a sign. See the Secrets chapter, under How the Grace Ends.

**WORTH** Never sold. The Company has priced it, as it prices everything. The figure on the factor's slate is not a number. It is a date.

# INDEX OF PERSONS

|                                                         |              |     |
|---------------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| Abel Drainer — the Wringer                              | BRINEHOLLOW  | 252 |
| Abide Kettering — the Sexton                            | THE FAST     | 592 |
| Absalom Gage — the Bricklayer                           | CRADLEWRACK  | 421 |
| Lord Absalom Hethe — Hand of the Court, Second Table    | SALLOWREACH  | 82  |
| Abstain Rooke, called Abby — the Pen-Friend             | THE FAST     | 559 |
| Sister Agathe Pinch — Mistress of the Needle            | THE VIGIL    | 334 |
| Agnes Latch — the Doorwright                            | CRADLEWRACK  | 387 |
| Dr. Aldous Crane — the Apothecary-General               | THE VIGIL    | 291 |
| Ambrose — the Eldest Infant                             | CRADLEWRACK  | 366 |
| Ansby Wrack — the Cutwright of Lowmark                  | BRINEHOLLOW  | 254 |
| Ansel Grue — the Unvacated Regent                       | SALLOWREACH  | 25  |
| Brother Ansgar Mote — the Tongue-Taker                  | OATHEN       | 509 |
| Asha Kindle — the Fire-Widow                            | OATHEN       | 477 |
| Lady Aspic Dellamore — the Preserver                    | THE FATLANDS | 144 |
| Aurel Vasht — Prince of the Lung-lines                  | BRINEHOLLOW  | 201 |
| Aveline Morne — the Sleeper in Bed One                  | THE VIGIL    | 327 |
| Benedikt Lour — the Architect                           | THE VIGIL    | 321 |
| Old Bettany Shroud — Warden of the Lofts                | SALLOWREACH  | 34  |
| Brakk — Voice of the Forsworn                           | OATHEN       | 456 |
| Bram Hollin — the Last Mourner                          | SALLOWREACH  | 71  |
| Captain Brannoch Pyre — the Needle of the Lid           | THE VIGIL    | 285 |
| Brenna Kelp — the Keeper of the Number                  | BRINEHOLLOW  | 225 |
| Mistress Brisket Annalow — Boss of the Renderers' Union | THE FATLANDS | 120 |
| Reeve Calder Stokes — the Company's Auditor             | BRINEHOLLOW  | 243 |
| Brother Callum Stillwater — Abbot of Nullhouse          | CRADLEWRACK  | 376 |
| Provost Carrion Sedge — Keeper of the Northern Ledgers  | SALLOWREACH  | 65  |
| Lord Casimir Morwen — the Consort                       | CRADLEWRACK  | 419 |
| Cassian Wry — the Liar                                  | OATHEN       | 471 |
| Envoy Castellan Dray — the Deadwatch                    | THE VIGIL    | 325 |
| Matron Cecily Dorm — Keeper of the Count                | THE VIGIL    | 293 |
| Grandam Cess — the Vow-Eater                            | OATHEN       | 484 |
| Lord Chamberlain Eamon Seele — the Reader of Questions  | CRADLEWRACK  | 427 |
| Lord Chastain Loin — Heir of the Cellar Table           | THE FATLANDS | 166 |
| Constance Hobb — Registrar of the Seeming               | THE VIGIL    | 332 |
| Coralie Sculpin — the Bucket-Wife                       | BRINEHOLLOW  | 257 |

|                                                                     |              |     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| Corder Lank — the Thin Man                                          | THE FATLANDS | 116 |
| Lady Corrow Vane — the Left Hand of the Court                       | SALLOWREACH  | 26  |
| Corvin Sund — High Admiral of the Tidal Admiralty                   | BRINEHOLLOW  | 195 |
| Corwin Half-Bell — the Man Who Woke                                 | THE VIGIL    | 303 |
| Granny Cracknel — the Tooth-Miller                                  | THE FATLANDS | 159 |
| Cray Lobbett — the Finder of the Table                              | BRINEHOLLOW  | 233 |
| Cutwright Hessa Lisk — the Measurer of Tongues                      | OATHEN       | 515 |
| Captain Dace Morrow — the Sixty-Times Slain                         | SALLOWREACH  | 51  |
| Dacey Furl — the Gag-Nurse                                          | OATHEN       | 505 |
| Dagna Hull — the Shipwright                                         | BRINEHOLLOW  | 231 |
| Decline Marsh — the Four Hundred and First                          | THE FAST     | 551 |
| Dolour Pym — the Wet-Nurse                                          | CRADLEWRACK  | 393 |
| Envoy Dorian Sayce — the Believed                                   | OATHEN       | 494 |
| Dov Marrin — Assembler-Prime                                        | CRADLEWRACK  | 369 |
| Queen Dowager Sibyl Aubrey, and the King Within — the Long Carrying | CRADLEWRACK  | 407 |
| Dulse Ammery — the Kind Hand of Mile Fourteen                       | BRINEHOLLOW  | 258 |
| Bailiff Dunmow Fatt — the Gentle Ladle                              | THE FATLANDS | 148 |
| Dunstan Reave — the Last of Dunmere                                 | SALLOWREACH  | 84  |
| Father Ebb — Abbot of the Hanging Abbey                             | BRINEHOLLOW  | 205 |
| Ebb Totter — the Tarman of the Ferrying Post                        | SALLOWREACH  | 86  |
| Edda Thrush — the Hushwalker                                        | SALLOWREACH  | 69  |
| Ede and Ada Crewe — the Twice-Born                                  | CRADLEWRACK  | 396 |
| Dr. Emmerich Paunch — the Board's Physician                         | THE FATLANDS | 132 |
| Esk Penhallow — the Returned Who Wasn't                             | BRINEHOLLOW  | 246 |
| Lord Evander Quell — of the Second Table                            | THE VIGIL    | 338 |
| Justice Ever Lathe — the Honorable Maggot                           | SALLOWREACH  | 41  |
| Little Fain — the One Who Came Home Fed                             | THE FAST     | 579 |
| Fallow Brindle — Warden of the Barrows                              | THE FAST     | 601 |
| Feeder Callow Pudge — Mother of the Gavage                          | THE FATLANDS | 164 |
| Fenwick Lisp — Interpreter of Jaw-Clicks                            | SALLOWREACH  | 76  |
| Finn Undertow — the Bellman                                         | BRINEHOLLOW  | 241 |
| Elder Forbear Wend — Chair of the Abstinent                         | THE FAST     | 540 |
| Mother Gall — the Pickler of Brinemoss                              | SALLOWREACH  | 67  |
| Gannet Shale — the Table-Seer                                       | BRINEHOLLOW  | 255 |
| Garl Tome — the Bitmaker                                            | OATHEN       | 480 |

|                                                    |              |     |
|----------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| Garrick Tripe — the Weigher                        | THE FATLANDS | 141 |
| Garron Ashlock — the Lamplighter-General           | THE VIGIL    | 295 |
| Marshal Gideon Breech — the Turner-Back            | CRADLEWRACK  | 403 |
| Brother Glut — Prophet of the Second Helping       | THE FATLANDS | 128 |
| Grandfather Peat — the Last Witness                | SALLOWREACH  | 47  |
| Inspector Hale Grimmer — of the Blink-Matter       | THE VIGIL    | 314 |
| Dr. Halloran Quease — the Physician of Pain        | SALLOWREACH  | 43  |
| Brother Hallow Crust — the Seated                  | THE FAST     | 561 |
| Halvar Stane — Echo-Warden                         | OATHEN       | 463 |
| Hask Tarn — the Pilot                              | BRINEHOLLOW  | 214 |
| Henna Farrow — the Widow Unmade                    | SALLOWREACH  | 56  |
| Herself — the Assemblers' Figure                   | CRADLEWRACK  | 425 |
| Hesper Coyle — Blink-Matter Forty-One              | THE VIGIL    | 342 |
| Hester Lowe — the Woman Who Bore a Hand            | CRADLEWRACK  | 369 |
| Old Hinge — Keeper of the Sill                     | CRADLEWRACK  | 412 |
| Hob Gristle — the Honest Butcher                   | THE FATLANDS | 121 |
| Hollow Ann Pruett — the Card-Keeper                | THE FAST     | 597 |
| Idony Pask — the Tourist                           | SALLOWREACH  | 73  |
| Ilan — the Oath-Child                              | OATHEN       | 495 |
| Ilse Marl — Choir-Mistress of the Low Water        | BRINEHOLLOW  | 239 |
| Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud — the Unblinking        | THE VIGIL    | 277 |
| Lady Imre Dath — the Sayer                         | OATHEN       | 453 |
| Duchess Iphigene Morwen — the Red-Veiled           | CRADLEWRACK  | 390 |
| Dr. Isolde Reave — Surgeon of the Drowned Chest    | BRINEHOLLOW  | 212 |
| Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot — the Notcher           | THE FATLANDS | 157 |
| Ivo Vane — the Untouched                           | SALLOWREACH  | 88  |
| Jack Tenterhook — Wake-Valet                       | THE VIGIL    | 313 |
| Jem Crackle — the Cook's Knife                     | THE FATLANDS | 145 |
| Jessamy Quill — Notary of the Rim Road             | OATHEN       | 463 |
| Captain Jonah Skerry — Dry Jonah                   | BRINEHOLLOW  | 219 |
| Jory Welt — the Boy                                | SALLOWREACH  | 26  |
| Josiah Fenn — the Man Who Bore                     | CRADLEWRACK  | 383 |
| Factor Joss Mallory — of the Last Beds             | THE VIGIL    | 340 |
| Factor Joss Mardle — of the Rim Road Company       | THE FAST     | 595 |
| Jude Crake — the Breaker                           | OATHEN       | 499 |
| Juniper Dell, called Firstword — the Half-Sentence | CRADLEWRACK  | 412 |
| Kale Dragoman — the Poacher                        | THE FAST     | 565 |
| Marshal Keep Aldane — the Gate at Brindle Cross    | THE FAST     | 581 |
| Kessa Drowle — Harbormistress of Lowmark           | BRINEHOLLOW  | 196 |
| Ket the Ninth — the Mute King                      | OATHEN       | 452 |
| Lark Ninedays — the Counter                        | CRADLEWRACK  | 380 |

|                                                              |              |     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| Dr. Lazar Voss — the Anatomist of the Whole                  | CRADLEWRACK  | 410 |
| Lent Ashby — the Invited                                     | THE FAST     | 545 |
| Mother Limpet — Mother of the Water                          | BRINEHOLLOW  | 226 |
| Lisbet Wakely — the Brush                                    | THE VIGIL    | 344 |
| Sister Lorn of the Shut Eye — High Shut Eye of the Finishers | SALLOWREACH  | 50  |
| Lukas Marre — the Yawning Man                                | THE VIGIL    | 299 |
| Commodore Lysander Vell — the Carver's Officer               | BRINEHOLLOW  | 250 |
| Madder Rudge — Head of the Watch at the Dilation             | CRADLEWRACK  | 382 |
| Sister Maeve Cord — Mother of Cords                          | CRADLEWRACK  | 401 |
| Sergeant Mags Carrow — the Four Hundred and First            | OATHEN       | 503 |
| Maren Oake — Justice of the Drowned Bench                    | BRINEHOLLOW  | 200 |
| Marigold Chine — the Singing Keeper                          | THE FATLANDS | 151 |
| Marrow Jack — the Part-Thief                                 | SALLOWREACH  | 61  |
| Maud Sexton — the Hourkeeper                                 | THE VIGIL    | 283 |
| Meek Garrity — the Historian                                 | THE FAST     | 585 |
| Mercy Sowerby — the Hill-Speaker                             | THE FATLANDS | 166 |
| Dr. Mercy Thrane — the Physician of Hunger                   | THE FAST     | 564 |
| Factor Merriam Toll — the Caul-Buyer                         | CRADLEWRACK  | 424 |
| Merrit Cask — Keeper of the Jar Room                         | SALLOWREACH  | 78  |
| Mirela Sconce — the Seemer                                   | THE VIGIL    | 309 |
| Mirren Osk — the Handtalker                                  | OATHEN       | 467 |
| Old Mother Rind — the Hill with a Mouth                      | THE FATLANDS | 130 |
| Sister Nay Corliss — the Starved Saint                       | THE FAST     | 549 |
| Little Nell Ash — Queen of the Smalls                        | SALLOWREACH  | 62  |
| Nerys Colm — the Half-Called                                 | BRINEHOLLOW  | 216 |
| Old Nod — King of the Tuckers                                | THE VIGIL    | 286 |
| Chairman Obb Tullow — the Heaviest Vote                      | THE FATLANDS | 109 |
| Odile Farthing — the Mother at Bed 40,112                    | THE VIGIL    | 319 |
| Ona Fell — the Surety                                        | OATHEN       | 461 |
| Ondine Vasht — the Dowager Below                             | BRINEHOLLOW  | 203 |
| Lady Oriel Stroud — the Lidded Heir                          | THE VIGIL    | 278 |
| Orla Kest — Midwife-Paramount of the Attendance              | CRADLEWRACK  | 365 |
| Orrin Wake and Passenger — the Talking Tenant                | BRINEHOLLOW  | 222 |
| Osanna Blythe — the Pilgrim                                  | THE FAST     | 582 |
| Osric Vane — the Gloved                                      | SALLOWREACH  | 26  |
| Ottoline Hawse — the Ropewalker                              | BRINEHOLLOW  | 246 |
| Ottoline Vant — the Carver with a List                       | OATHEN       | 498 |
| Pell Hogget — the Counter                                    | THE FATLANDS | 111 |
| Pell Sallet — the Breaker's Daughter                         | OATHEN       | 511 |

|                                                     |              |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| Petra Quick — the Runner of Mothers                 | CRADLEWRACK  | 404 |
| Pim Sorrel — the Scrap Finisher                     | SALLOWREACH  | 36  |
| Pip Eleven-Bell — the Pinchmarket Nudger            | THE VIGIL    | 297 |
| Envoy Prudence Lowell — the Voice of the Clean      | THE FAST     | 570 |
| Reft Hume — the Chit-Forger                         | THE FAST     | 599 |
| Captain Renn Hold — the Man at Wending              | OATHEN       | 487 |
| Rook Quarter-Bell — the Brine-Cutter                | THE VIGIL    | 323 |
| Little Rue — the Child Who Kept Her Word            | OATHEN       | 463 |
| Rufus Ochre — the Tallyman                          | CRADLEWRACK  | 397 |
| Sabeth Thorne — the Second Opinion                  | CRADLEWRACK  | 366 |
| Sabine Larch — First of the Lessening               | THE VIGIL    | 330 |
| Lieutenant Sable Reef — the Hook of Mile Fourteen   | BRINEHOLLOW  | 236 |
| Old Sabra Wends — the Keener of Oaths               | OATHEN       | 511 |
| Sal Trotter — the Drover                            | THE FATLANDS | 135 |
| Reckoner-Captain Scant Hollis — the Weeder          | THE FAST     | 543 |
| Scarce Odell — the Kin-Reader                       | THE FAST     | 590 |
| The Scarecrow of Low Tilth — Nobody Put It Up       | THE FATLANDS | 155 |
| Scour — the Returned                                | THE FAST     | 573 |
| Senna Vole — the Forty-Descent Diver                | THE VIGIL    | 288 |
| Sennet Gull — the Wreckwife                         | BRINEHOLLOW  | 209 |
| Verger Sober Osmond — Keeper of the Empty Chair     | THE FAST     | 575 |
| Sorrin Vael — Chief Clausewright                    | OATHEN       | 453 |
| Spare Tolland — Mile-Walker of the Hostwatch        | THE FAST     | 552 |
| Mother Stint Avery — Keeper of the Pantry           | THE FAST     | 556 |
| Dame Suet Marrable — Hostess of the Unending Dinner | THE FATLANDS | 111 |
| Tam Ruddock — the Lastgate Ferryman                 | SALLOWREACH  | 59  |
| Tamsin Gorse — the Stitch-Mender                    | CRADLEWRACK  | 421 |
| Tansy Lard — the Gleaner                            | THE FATLANDS | 126 |

|                                                     |              |     |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| Tarry Moss — Crumb-Runner                           | THE FAST     | 547 |
| Tavish Crook — Loophole                             | OATHEN       | 490 |
| Teodor Rell — Keeper of the Lain Book               | THE VIGIL    | 336 |
| Thaddeus Knell — Chief Bell-Ringer                  | THE VIGIL    | 308 |
| Judge Thane Urraw — the Court of the Sound          | OATHEN       | 474 |
| Thessaly Mort — Master Seamer                       | SALLOWREACH  | 26  |
| General Tibb — Commander of the Foundling Companies | CRADLEWRACK  | 378 |
| Tobias Wether — the First to Eat                    | THE FATLANDS | 153 |
| Tolly Brack — the Bailer Boy                        | BRINEHOLLOW  | 208 |
| Una Clayhand — Midwife of Pieces                    | CRADLEWRACK  | 429 |
| Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread — the Board's Quiet Hand | THE FATLANDS | 124 |
| Lord Varro Esk — the Heir of Tongues                | OATHEN       | 507 |
| Sister Verity Amn — the Thought-Bound               | OATHEN       | 492 |
| Sister Vesper Null — Prophet of the Bedded          | THE VIGIL    | 302 |
| Wakemother Pudding Hesk — the Weeping Cook          | THE FATLANDS | 162 |
| Washer Nell Haslet — the Chairman's Hands           | THE FATLANDS | 172 |
| Welcome Ardent — the Steward of the Host            | THE FAST     | 586 |
| Wenna Thrale — the Apprentice                       | CRADLEWRACK  | 417 |
| Old Wet Tom — the God's Own Beggar                  | BRINEHOLLOW  | 235 |
| Wick Tallow — the Chandler                          | SALLOWREACH  | 45  |
| Withhold Pennick — the Stranded Reckoner            | SALLOWREACH  | 79  |
| Withy Gaunt — Matron of the Lean House              | THE FAST     | 592 |
| Wolf-Warden Crust Leggat — the Inventor of Wolves   | THE FATLANDS | 170 |
| Wont Bellamy — the Heretic Elder                    | THE FAST     | 555 |
| Wren Hollowell — the Fasting Girl                   | THE FATLANDS | 138 |
| Yield Hartsell — the Farmer                         | THE FAST     | 577 |
| Yusra Thole — the Rainwarden                        | OATHEN       | 483 |

# INDEX OF LEAVINGS

|                                |              |     |
|--------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| A Beaching Hook                | THE RIM      | 693 |
| A Bladder of Trench-Breath     | BRINEHOLLOW  | 641 |
| A Born Key                     | CRADLEWRACK  | 657 |
| A Borrowed Scar                | CRADLEWRACK  | 662 |
| A Breaker's Splinter           | THE FAST     | 679 |
| A Breath of the Dormitory      | THE VIGIL    | 648 |
| A Carver's Knife of Grey Bone  | THE RIM      | 691 |
| A Cell of the Honorable Maggot | SALLOWREACH  | 618 |
| A Chip of the Pillow           | THE VIGIL    | 649 |
| A Coal from a Kept House       | THE FAST     | 680 |
| A Coal from the Smoking Ground | SALLOWREACH  | 623 |
| A Course-Ear                   | OATHEN       | 667 |
| A Cup of the Sounding Pool     | BRINEHOLLOW  | 638 |
| A Deepening Lantern            | BRINEHOLLOW  | 643 |
| A Deserter of Captain Morrow's | SALLOWREACH  | 619 |
| A Doorborn's Key-Finger        | CRADLEWRACK  | 664 |
| A Drop of the Regent's Lacquer | SALLOWREACH  | 616 |
| A Figurehead's Eye             | BRINEHOLLOW  | 642 |
| A Flask of Kept Rain           | OATHEN       | 673 |
| A Gavage Funnel                | THE FATLANDS | 633 |
| A Glovehall Pear               | SALLOWREACH  | 621 |
| A Going-Home Blanket           | CRADLEWRACK  | 662 |
| A Guest's Lifted Hand          | THE FAST     | 682 |
| A Hanging Bird of Low Shale    | OATHEN       | 669 |
| A Hank of Pendulum Wire        | THE VIGIL    | 651 |
| A Host's Candle                | THE FAST     | 679 |
| A Hush-Reed Pipe               | SALLOWREACH  | 621 |
| A Joining Seam                 | CRADLEWRACK  | 661 |
| A Knocked Brick                | CRADLEWRACK  | 664 |
| A Knuckle from the Unmade Road | OATHEN       | 671 |
| A Last Verse                   | SALLOWREACH  | 624 |
| A Leaf of the Lying-In's Book  | CRADLEWRACK  | 660 |
| A Lettered Hide                | THE FATLANDS | 630 |
| A Link of Father Ebb's Chain   | BRINEHOLLOW  | 643 |
| A Longslab Stone               | BRINEHOLLOW  | 642 |
| A Menu of Seven Courses        | THE RIM      | 691 |
| A Mile-Walker's Compass        | THE FAST     | 684 |
| A Ninth-Winter Apple           | THE FAST     | 686 |

|                                     |              |     |
|-------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| A Notched Stave                     | THE FATLANDS | 633 |
| A Pair of Fallen Lids               | THE VIGIL    | 647 |
| A Pear of Mother Rind's             | THE FATLANDS | 628 |
| A Phial of the Witness's Water      | THE RIM      | 694 |
| A Quarter-Bell Tongue               | THE VIGIL    | 650 |
| A Quire of the Master Concordance   | THE RIM      | 690 |
| A Retired Second Opinion            | CRADLEWRACK  | 659 |
| A Root-End                          | CRADLEWRACK  | 663 |
| A Rope of the Dowager's Hair        | BRINEHOLLOW  | 637 |
| A Row Mirror                        | THE VIGIL    | 650 |
| A Scale of Iss's Lid                | THE RIM      | 694 |
| A Scratched Vow                     | OATHEN       | 669 |
| A Seated Guest's Fork               | THE FAST     | 681 |
| A Second-Meal Crock                 | CRADLEWRACK  | 658 |
| A Sheet from the Restless Rows      | THE VIGIL    | 648 |
| A Singing Cutting                   | THE FATLANDS | 630 |
| A Sliver of the Beached God         | BRINEHOLLOW  | 638 |
| A Sod of Walker-Hush                | SALLOWREACH  | 622 |
| A Splinter of the Sill              | CRADLEWRACK  | 664 |
| A Stone of the Hem                  | THE RIM      | 689 |
| A Stoppered First Breath            | CRADLEWRACK  | 660 |
| A Strip of Ossel's Palm             | THE RIM      | 692 |
| A Strip of the Unending Cloth       | THE FATLANDS | 627 |
| A Sump-Face                         | SALLOWREACH  | 622 |
| A Surety's Patch                    | OATHEN       | 670 |
| A Tallow-Saint's Wick               | SALLOWREACH  | 620 |
| A Tenanted Sweetheart's Bucket      | BRINEHOLLOW  | 639 |
| A Tenanted Tear                     | BRINEHOLLOW  | 637 |
| A Testifying Jaw                    | OATHEN       | 674 |
| A Tip of the Chairman's Root        | THE FATLANDS | 627 |
| A Tongue from Mote's Vault          | OATHEN       | 668 |
| A Tooth from the Trench             | THE FAST     | 683 |
| A Trencher Creeper                  | THE FATLANDS | 631 |
| A Vow-Eater's Receipt               | OATHEN       | 671 |
| A Warden's Horn                     | OATHEN       | 674 |
| A Wetting-Brush of the Warden-Prime | THE VIGIL    | 647 |
| A Whispered Menu                    | THE FAST     | 681 |
| A Yard of the Long Table's Cloth    | THE FAST     | 679 |

|                                     |              |     |
|-------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| An Atlas Needle                     | THE VIGIL    | 652 |
| An Ember of the Widow's Fire        | OATHEN       | 675 |
| An Heirloom Bit                     | OATHEN       | 675 |
| An Offered Portion of Brother Glut  | THE FATLANDS | 632 |
| Ash Mill Flour                      | THE FAST     | 680 |
| Barrow-Hair Rope                    | THE FAST     | 684 |
| Bottled Rootkin Sap                 | THE FATLANDS | 629 |
| The Breaker's Glass                 | OATHEN       | 672 |
| Chisel-Dust                         | THE RIM      | 696 |
| The Coat of a Faded Oath-Made       | OATHEN       | 676 |
| Corner-Soil of the Dusk Acres       | THE FATLANDS | 629 |
| Crane's Strain Eleven               | THE VIGIL    | 652 |
| Dellamore Aspic                     | THE FATLANDS | 633 |
| Dry Jonah's Blue Label              | BRINEHOLLOW  | 643 |
| The Eighth Chair                    | THE RIM      | 696 |
| Elbow-Cress                         | THE FATLANDS | 627 |
| Evidence Forty                      | THE VIGIL    | 653 |
| Little Fain's Ribbon                | THE FAST     | 682 |
| The First Bowl                      | THE RIM      | 692 |
| First Marbling                      | THE FATLANDS | 631 |
| Glove-Thread of the Left Hand       | SALLOWREACH  | 616 |
| The Green Blade of Hartsell's Field | THE FAST     | 687 |
| Gullet Sand                         | OATHEN       | 673 |
| Hesk's Wake-Glaze                   | THE FATLANDS | 634 |
| Hob Gristle's Tasting Spoon         | THE FATLANDS | 632 |
| Hollan Kest's Thumbnails            | CRADLEWRACK  | 660 |
| The Invitation, Transcribed         | BRINEHOLLOW  | 640 |
| The Knot That Will Not Come Undone  | CRADLEWRACK  | 659 |
| The Lammas Bottom Slate             | THE FAST     | 685 |
| The Lean House Book                 | THE FAST     | 686 |
| Lidless Tear-Salt                   | THE VIGIL    | 647 |
| Lip-Clay of the Dilation            | CRADLEWRACK  | 663 |

|                                      |              |     |
|--------------------------------------|--------------|-----|
| The Little Bone Door                 | CRADLEWRACK  | 658 |
| The Little Knife from Below          | BRINEHOLLOW  | 640 |
| Lobbett's Silt                       | BRINEHOLLOW  | 641 |
| Lukas Marre's Muzzle                 | THE VIGIL    | 651 |
| The Merchant's Hands                 | OATHEN       | 671 |
| The Miscut Stone                     | OATHEN       | 674 |
| Mitten-Lead                          | SALLOWREACH  | 617 |
| Morne's Loaf                         | THE VIGIL    | 652 |
| The Mother of Mother Gall's Brine    | SALLOWREACH  | 620 |
| The Ninth Joint of Osric Vane        | SALLOWREACH  | 616 |
| Old Nod's Minute-Glass               | THE VIGIL    | 653 |
| One of the Drift                     | THE RIM      | 694 |
| Paunch's Chewed Weight               | THE FATLANDS | 628 |
| Peat-Leather of the Last Witness     | SALLOWREACH  | 619 |
| Pim Sorrel's Shed Tooth              | SALLOWREACH  | 617 |
| Quease's Number Four Hundred and One | SALLOWREACH  | 623 |
| Reave's Shell                        | BRINEHOLLOW  | 639 |
| Red Weep                             | CRADLEWRACK  | 657 |
| Ribwalker Bellows                    | BRINEHOLLOW  | 641 |
| The Rope at the Post                 | THE RIM      | 690 |
| The Rudge Rope                       | CRADLEWRACK  | 665 |
| Saint's-Lip Crumbs                   | THE FAST     | 685 |
| Sayer's Ink                          | OATHEN       | 668 |
| Senna Vole's Tether                  | THE VIGIL    | 649 |
| Shroud-Linen of the Lofts            | SALLOWREACH  | 618 |
| Shut-Eye Pennies                     | SALLOWREACH  | 624 |
| Sleepers' Mile Moss                  | THE VIGIL    | 649 |
| The Steward's Apron                  | THE FAST     | 683 |
| Sweyn's Tooth                        | THE RIM      | 693 |
| Tank-Water of the Prince             | BRINEHOLLOW  | 636 |
| The Verger's Platter                 | THE FAST     | 684 |



